HowToLiveBetter: The Best-Value Life Guide

# Less time, effort, and expense — more life, freedom, and money

Longevity | First aid | Money | Law | Safety net | Family | Skills

**690** tips  Grade-A evidence — **450**  **1841** primary-source links  Filter by value-for-effort

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# Preface

Covers longevity and disease prevention, accidents and first aid, saving money and managing it, fraud prevention and legal red lines, a safety net for unemployment, the risks of running your own business, building a platform and keeping it legal, love, marriage, and children, going abroad, and learning skills. 690 pieces of advice; each one states what it costs, what it buys back, and how hard the evidence is. Sources cite only journal papers and official documents.

## Questions this book tries to answer

| Question | Where to look |
|---|---|
| What can you do almost for free that still noticeably lowers your chance of dying early? | 1. Do Not Die Early |
| How many years of life exactly do smoking, alcohol, a sedentary life, and sleep loss take away? | 2. Don't Die Slowly |
| Not enough energy in a day, constantly interrupted — how do you fix it? | 3. Don't Waste Energy |
| Where does the time go, and how do you do fewer pointless things? | 4. Don't Waste Time |
| How should savings be kept so that interest, fees, and scams don't eat them? | 5. Don't Waste Money |
| Which supplements, checkup packages, and "IQ taxes" can you simply not buy? | 6. The Negative List |
| You lost your job, your wages are withheld, you have no money — what can you claim and where do you ask for help? | 7. How to Live When You Have No Money |
| Betrothal gifts, premarital property, large transfers during dating — who owns what in law? | 8. Don't Get Yourself Locked Up: Law and Property Safety |
| Someone reports you, accuses you, fabricates facts — what is the first step, and can you seek redress and compensation afterwards? | 8. Don't Get Yourself Locked Up: Law and Property Safety |
| Which "side jobs" and casual favors turn an ordinary person into a criminal defendant? | 9. Legal Red Lines |
| Should you court many people at once or commit to one, can long-distance work, what do you bring to register a marriage? | 10. Are Dating and Marriage Worth It |
| Writing which code, taking which jobs can get you a prison sentence? | 11. Red Lines for Techies |
| Before borrowing to open a shop or founding a company, what should you think through first? | 12. Starting Your Own Business |
| Someone collapses and stops breathing, heavy bleeding, fire, lost in the wild — what do you do first? | 13. Emergencies: What to Do First |
| Account stolen, phone lost — what is the first step? | 14. Accounts And Security |
| Deposit withheld, landlord evicting you, long-term rental operator collapsed — what do you do? | 15. Renting And Buying Housing |
| After a chronic disease diagnosis, how do you manage it long-term and spend less? | 16. Living With Chronic Disease |
| How should an elderly parent's guardianship, will, and money be arranged in advance? | 17. Elderly At Home |
| What can you claim when having a child, and how much time and money does it take? | 18. Is Having Kids Worth It |
| How are overtime pay and annual leave counted, how much compensation does a layoff owe you, how do you file and get paid for a workplace injury? | 19. Employment And Work Injury |
| The child is just born — which things matter most? | 20. Newborn |

| Question | Where to look |
|---|---|
| Which countries not to go to now, and how far does consular protection go when something happens? | 21. Travel And Abroad Safety |
| How not to get burned at KTV, internet cafés, escape rooms; and what works best when you're stressed? | 22. How To Relax |
| Learning welding, English, certificates — which ones really pay back? | 23. Which Skills To Learn |
| Same illness at a community clinic and a tier-III hospital — how different is the cost? | 24. Seeing The Doctor |
| Badly injured and rushing to a hospital — register and queue, or go to the ER triage desk? Afterwards, do you need a disability assessment, a disability certificate? | 24. Seeing The Doctor |
| A family member has died — what to do first, which money can be recovered, which fees can be waived? | 25. After Someone Dies |
| Building a website or platform that takes payments — which licenses, where to host servers? | 26. Building A Website Or Platform |
| Pregnant, about to give birth — when to do what, and which documents to arrange before discharge? | 27. Pregnancy And Birth |
| You want to lose weight or look better — which practices wreck your body? | 28. Do Not Ruin Health For Looks |
| A relative died, you were laid off, you got a serious diagnosis — what matters most in the first months? | 29. After A Major Blow |
| Once the child starts school, which physical and mental things cannot wait until after the exams? | 30. School-Age Kids |
| After eighteen, besides studying and working, which roads are open — and what are their thresholds? | 31. Paths After Eighteen |
| Studying abroad — how do you keep the visa unbroken, and will the diploma be recognized when you come home? | 32. Studying Abroad |
| You or a family member became disabled — which complications to prevent first, which subsidies can you claim, and what about school, work, and guardianship? | 33. Living With Disability |
| Cold meds, fever reducers, stomach meds you buy yourself — what not to combine, and what kids, pregnancy, and older adults must avoid? | 34. Avoid Serious Harm From Home Medicines |

## How to read this

- **To filter by conditions**: open the online search page; you can filter by keyword, chapter, and evidence grade, and combine three cost dimensions: whether it costs money, whether it takes time, whether it takes willpower. The data is read directly from the book/ text; fix the text and the search page changes with it.
- **To read in order**: items inside each section are ordered from highest to lowest value for the money; start with the first few items of each section.
- **If you can't read that string of numbers**: every item has an "In plain terms" line that translates the risk ratios and confidence intervals in the Benefit field into everyday statements like "about 20% lower chance of dying in the same period" or "a few days of detention, a fine of so much" — using only facts already in the original, without adding new numbers. That line alone is enough to decide; the Benefit field keeps all the raw numbers and confidence intervals so you can check for yourself.
- **Only the hardest conclusions**: on the search page check evidence grade A to keep only the 450 items with concrete numbers from meta-analyses or large trials.

- **Only the most worthwhile**: check "very high" value-for-money to get the 117 items that cost no money, no time, no willpower, and whose benefit lands in the largest tier. Stack one more "what it buys back" filter on top and you have the priority list under that measure.
- **Don't be alarmed by section titles that start with "Don't"**: a section title names the outcome that section tries to prevent (don't die early, don't waste time), not a blanket ban on every item under it. Item titles are the actual actions, always starting with a verb, each carrying its own "do this" or "don't do this" — both kinds live in the same section. For example, section 4 has both "Turn 'planning to do it' into 'at such an hour, in such a place, when X happens, do it'" and "Skip TV and rolling news". Read by item title, not by the tone of the section title.

Each piece of advice looks like this:

```
### 5. Switch your household salt to low-sodium (potassium) salt
- Cost: a few yuan more per bag
- In plain terms: in a randomized trial of 20,000 people, those who switched to low-
sodium salt had about a 12% lower chance of dying within five years and about 14%
fewer strokes. This comes from random assignment, which is more trustworthy than
observational data.
- Benefit: stroke down 14%, cardiovascular events down 13%, all-cause mortality down
12%
- Evidence grade: A
- Sources: Neal B, et al. (2021). NEJM. https://doi.org/10.1056/NEJMoa2105675
- Notes: contested. People with impaired kidney function or on potassium-sparing
diuretics should not use it. ...
```

## Four resources

This guide optimizes not just lifespan but four resources:

- **Lifespan**: live longer, die less often from things that were avoidable
- **Time and energy**: the time you are alive is not eaten by zero-return activities, and your daily attention and stamina are drained less
- **Money**: spend less money on nothing, put it where the payoff is certain
- **Personal freedom**: don't talk yourself into detention or jail by not knowing where a red line runs

Every piece of advice answers two questions: what it costs (money / time / energy / willpower), and what it buys back (all-cause mortality change / a specific cause of death down / time and energy saved / money saved / protection and personal freedom). Items are ordered by value for money, not by category: near-zero cost with large benefit goes first.

**Whose account the benefit lands on is tiered.** By the expected chance that the good comes back to you, from high to low: ① **you yourself**; ② **spouse and immediate family** (parents, children, grandparents, grandchildren); ③ **friends, colleagues, and other relatives** — a reciprocal relationship, what you give may come back later; ④ **strangers** — the lowest tier, but not zero: the chance of return is small, you don't know the other person's character, and there is the risk of being scammed, counter-accused, or retaliated against. Tiers are not merged into one number; when writing about tier ④, the benefits and the risks are written together.

Read the first-aid section with this in mind: of 38,227 out-of-hospital cardiac arrests in China, 79.2% happened at home — you learn compressions first of all to press on your own family. Rules like "do not go into the water yourself after a drowning person" and "don't step in to separate a fight" are self-protection rules: they guard against you turning from bystander into second casualty. Whether to act for a stranger is your own trade-off; the item spells out the liability disclaimer, the self-protective moves, and the risk surface, and does not decide for you that it must be done.

Mortality numbers, time/energy numbers, money numbers, and legal consequences are kept in separate measures and never converted across measures. The four resources correspond to the four "what it buys back" filters on the search page; they are not compared with each other.

## Evidence grades

Every piece of advice carries an evidence grade:

| Grade | Meaning |
|---|---|
| A | Quantifiable evidence from meta-analyses, large cohorts, or RCTs that gives concrete numbers (HR, RR, percent reduction) |
| B | Research-backed but hard to quantify, or evidence from small samples / a single study |
| C | Author experience or general consensus, no direct literature |

Of the 690 items in the book, 450 are grade A, 193 grade B, and 47 grade C; 75 items are marked as contested and 3 spots are marked TODO, pending verification. Contested A/B items are marked "contested" with the opposing evidence listed. All sources cite primary literature only (journal papers with a DOI or PubMed link, or reports from official bodies such as WHO, CDC, or the national statistics bureau), never second-hand retellings. Uncertain numbers are marked "to be verified".

## Value-for-money tiers

The evidence grade answers "can this number be trusted", not "is it worth doing". So every item also carries a benefit magnitude and a measure; the search page combines these with the three costs into one value-for-money tier:

| Dimension | Values | How it is set |
|---|---|---|
| Measure | Buys lifespan / buys money / buys time-energy / buys personal freedom | By what the item mainly buys back. **Measures are not compared with each other**: "all-cause mortality down 12%" and "save 500 yuan a year" are not on one ruler |
| Benefit magnitude | Large / medium / small | Mechanically applied from thresholds in the item's own Benefit field where possible: for lifespan, relative reduction (≥20% large, 10–20% medium, <10% or only surrogate endpoints small); for money, the amount (tens of thousands large, hundreds to thousands medium, tens of yuan small); for personal freedom, the consequence (avoiding criminal liability large, avoiding detention or administrative punishment medium, avoiding a civil dispute small); for time-energy, the saving (hours a day large, hours a week medium, one-off small) |
| Value for money | Very high / high / ordinary | Large benefit with all three costs zero = very high; large benefit with low costs, or medium benefit with zero costs = high; the rest = ordinary |

Of the 690 items in the book, 117 (17%) are very high, 310 (45%) high, and 263 (38%) ordinary. The middle tier is deliberately thick: the underlying benefit magnitude has only three levels, and slicing finer would be false precision.

**This tier is the author's judgment, not evidence** — essentially grade C, and orthogonal to the evidence grade. An item can be grade A but ordinary value (the shingles vaccine has a phase-III RCT at 97.2% efficacy, but two doses cost three to four thousand yuan and shingles is rarely fatal), and it can be grade C but very high value (sending your itinerary to family before going abroad). "Ordinary" does not mean "shouldn't be done" — every item in the book is advice worth taking; it only means you should weigh that spend yourself.

## Reading the numbers (glossary)

The text tries to speak plainly, but citing research requires a few statistical terms. Check this table when something is unclear; on the online search page, hovering over (or tapping) a dotted-underlined word also pops up an explanation.

Expand 41 terms (all-cause mortality, HR, RR, 95% CI, meta-analysis, BMI, LPR, deposit vs prepayment …)

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| All-cause mortality | The share of people dying from any cause over a period, regardless of cause. The book uses it to measure "how long people live". The original literature calls it all-cause mortality, abbreviated ACM |
| HR | Hazard ratio. The speed at which two groups hit an event (death, illness) over the same time. HR 0.87 means 13% lower than the control group; HR 1.21 means 21% higher |
| RR | Relative risk. The ratio of event probabilities between two groups; read like HR |
| OR | Odds ratio. The ratio of odds between two groups; close to RR when events are rare, exaggerates the difference when they are common |
| IRR | Incidence rate ratio; read like RR |
| RaR | Rate ratio (e.g. number of falls); read like RR |
| Standardized mortality ratio | SMR. Actual deaths in a group divided by the expected number computed from the mortality of the general population of the same age. 5.86 means 5.86 times the deaths of peers |
| Risk difference | The probability of an event in one group minus the other, directly giving "how many extra cases per thousand". Ratios only say how many times; the risk difference says how many more people in absolute terms |
| 95% CI | 95% confidence interval. The range where the true value most likely sits. If a ratio-type interval crosses 1, or a difference-type interval crosses 0, the difference may be pure chance and the text will say "not statistically significant" |
| RCT | Randomized controlled trial. People are randomly split into two groups, one gets the intervention, one does not, and outcomes are compared. The best evidence of causation |
| Meta-analysis | Pooling the results of multiple studies into one overall estimate |
| Cohort | Cohort study. A group of people is followed for years to see who has events. Shows association, cannot fully show causation |
| Observational | Observational study. Researchers only observe, do not intervene; results may be affected by confounding and reverse causation, so discount the numbers |
| Confounding | A third factor that affects both cause and result, making association look like causation. People who eat more vegetables also tend to exercise more |
| Reverse causation | Not A causing B, but B causing A. It is not that sleeping a lot makes people die early; it is that seriously ill people sleep a lot |
| d, g | Effect size. How many standard deviations apart two group means are. 0.2 is small, 0.5 medium, 0.8 large |
| r | Correlation coefficient. How strongly two things move together, from −1 to 1; 0.1 weak, 0.3 medium, 0.5 strong |
| MET | Unit of exercise intensity. 1 MET is sitting quietly; brisk walking is about 3 to 4 MET. MET·h is intensity times hours |
| GRADE | An international standard for grading evidence quality into high, moderate, low, and very low |

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Intention-to-screen analysis | Counting the effect by "who was invited" rather than "who actually went", which underestimates the effect on those who actually went |
| Pack-years | A unit of smoking amount. Packs per day times years of smoking; 30 pack-years is one pack a day for 30 years |
| BMI | Body mass index. Weight (kg) divided by height (m) squared |
| LDL | Low-density lipoprotein cholesterol, colloquially "bad cholesterol" |
| eGFR | Estimated glomerular filtration rate. A measure of how well the kidneys filter, in mL/min/1.73 $m^2$; the lower the number, the worse the kidney function, and chronic kidney disease is staged by it |
| HBsAg | Hepatitis B surface antigen; positive means infected with hepatitis B |
| HPV | Human papillomavirus; long-term infection with some types causes cervical cancer |
| LDCT | Low-dose chest CT, with about one-fifth to one-tenth the radiation of a regular CT |
| PM2.5 | Airborne particulate matter under 2.5 micrometers in diameter |
| NOVA | A food classification by degree of processing; "ultra-processed food" is its fourth category |
| LPR | Loan Prime Rate. China's benchmark lending rate, published on the 20th of each month; mortgage and private-lending caps both reference it |
| One-arbitration-final | The labor arbitration ruling takes effect directly; the employer cannot sue in court |
| Crude marriage rate, crude divorce rate | Marriages and divorces registered in the year per thousand people. Divorces divided by marriages is another measure, the divorce-to-marriage ratio; do not mix the two |
| AED | Automated external defibrillator. The red or yellow first-aid box common in public places; turn it on and follow the voice prompts, it decides by itself whether to shock |
| CPR | Cardiopulmonary resuscitation. Pressing hard on the chest during cardiac arrest to keep blood flowing |
| CCC | China Compulsory Certification. Products in the catalog may not leave the factory or be sold without this mark |
| ICP filing | The registration a website or app completes in the MIIT system before going live |
| Multi-Level Protection Scheme | China's cybersecurity classified protection system; protections are applied according to how important the system is |
| GPL | An open-source license. Build a product with its code and you generally must open-source your product when distributing |
| Non-compete | An agreement not to join a competitor for a period after leaving; the company must pay monthly compensation, capped at 2 years |
| Subscribed capital | The money promised when registering a company. Once promised it must actually be paid in within the statutory deadline; it is not just for show |
| Deposit vs prepayment | A statutory deposit (dingjin) carries a penalty: the holder who breaches returns double, capped at 20% of the contract; a prepayment (yudingjin) carries no penalty |

# 1. How to avoid premature death

This section covers three main topics: preventing deaths from accidents and injuries such as car crashes, fires, and poisonings; reviewing several vaccines and screening tests backed by strong evidence; and explaining which bodily warning signs should prompt a medical checkup. The figures listed under “Benefit” come from randomized controlled trials, long-term observational studies, or official statistics. The “Cost” column offers a rough estimate based on current market prices; it is meant only for relative comparison, not for formal citations.

All items here are grouped by theme, with their respective item numbers shown in parentheses.

**On the road**: Always wear a seatbelt (Item 1), wear a helmet (Item 2), avoid speeding and driving under the influence of alcohol (Item 9), and use proper child safety seats (Item 10).

**Fire, gas, and electricity at home**: Install smoke detectors (Item 3), replace gas hoses once they reach their expiration date (Item 4), never bring electric bicycles into stairwells or hallways (Item 6), keep fire extinguishers and first-aid kits handy (Item 26), and always use protective guards when operating angle grinders (Item 42).

**Accidents involving children, seniors, and outdoor activities**: Fit window guards to prevent falls (Item 11), keep young children under constant supervision near water (Item 12), encourage seniors over 60 to practice balance exercises (Item 13), never eat wild mushrooms (Item 5), avoid picking up unknown metal objects (Item 36), and always measure ice thickness before stepping onto frozen surfaces (Item 41).

**Vaccines**: Get tested for hepatitis B markers (Item 14), stay up to date with tetanus shots (Item 15), receive the HPV vaccine (Item 16), get an annual flu shot (Item 20), consider the shingles vaccine (Item 21), and get vaccinated against pneumococcal infections (Item 22).

**Screening and disease detection**: Regularly monitor blood pressure (Item 7) and fasting blood glucose levels (Item 8); undergo routine breast cancer screening (Item 17), cervical cancer screening (Item 18), and colorectal cancer screening (Item 19). Also consider testing for Helicobacter pylori infection (Item 23), low-dose chest CT scans (Item 24), bone density measurements (Item 39), and anti-osteoporosis medications (Item 40).

**Physical warning signs and sexual health**: Seek medical advice if blood appears in urine (Item 27); men experiencing erectile difficulties should first have their cardiovascular health checked (Item 28). Losing weight and quitting smoking can improve erectile function (Item 29). Always use condoms and never share needles (Item 30); get tested for HIV if needed (Item 31) and consider pre-exposure prophylaxis if at high risk (Item 38).

**Mental health crises**: If you ever have suicidal thoughts, call 12356 immediately (Item 25). It also helps to confide in someone you trust (Item 32). Avoid gambling when you're already in debt (Item 37). Finally, remember that surviving poisoning from pesticides or carbon monoxide often leaves lasting health problems (Items 33 and 34), and losing a kidney also carries significant long-term consequences (Item 35). You can also ask someone close to you directly whether they have thought about suicide (Item 43).

## 1. Always wear seat belts, both front and back

**Cost**. No cost at all. It only adds about 2 seconds to every trip.

**In plain terms**. Wearing a seat belt in the front seat cuts the risk of dying in a crash by roughly half. For drivers and passengers in light trucks, the reduction is about 60%. Among U.S. crash victims in 2022 whose seat belt use was documented, half were not wearing one.

**Benefit**. According to NHTSA estimates, seat belts lower the risk of fatal injury for front-seat occupants of cars by 45% and for those in light trucks by 60%. In 2022, half of the U.S. fatalities in passenger cars had no recorded seat belt use. The World Health Organization states that seat belts can reduce the risk of death inside a vehicle by up to 50%. WHO also estimates that in 2021, 248,099 people died in road crashes in China, which translates to 17.4 deaths per 100,000 people.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Seat belts must be worn in the back seat as well. In the same report, 60% of rear-seat occupants killed in crashes were not wearing belts. The 45% and 60% figures are NHTSA estimates derived from crash-database analysis (Kahane 2015), not from randomized trials. The Chinese death toll cited by WHO is a projection and is several times higher than official police statistics; the two figures cover different populations, so only the WHO estimate is used here.

## 2. Wearing a helmet and fastening the strap while riding motorcycles or e-bikes

**Cost**. A helmet costs between 100 and 300 yuan. It takes just 5 seconds to put on each time.

**In plain terms**. Wearing a helmet and fastening the strap properly reduces a motorcyclist's risk of dying in an accident by roughly 40%. The chance of suffering a head injury drops by about 70%. The strap must be tightened; a helmet that simply hangs loosely on the head does not count as being worn.

**Benefit**. Cochrane pooled data from multiple studies. For motorcyclists wearing helmets, the risk of death fell by 42%. The original odds ratio was 0.58, with a 95% confidence interval ranging from 0.50 to 0.68. Head injuries were reduced by 69% (odds ratio 0.31; 95% CI 0.25–0.38).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The helmet strap must be fastened securely. A helmet left hanging on the handlebars does not count as being worn. The figures above apply specifically to motorcycles. For e-bikes, no direct studies exist, but the mechanics of head injury in a crash remain the same.

## 3. Install smoke alarms; those heating with coal or gas in winter should also add a carbon monoxide alarm

**Cost**. A smoke alarm costs between 30 and 100 yuan. A carbon monoxide alarm costs between 50 and 150 yuan. After installation, the batteries need to be replaced once a year.

**In plain terms**. A properly functioning smoke alarm can cut the risk of dying in a home fire by roughly 60%. Forty percent of fire victims are asleep at the time, so they won't wake up just from the smell of smoke. For anyone heating their home with coal or gas during winter, adding a carbon monoxide alarm is essential. In China, 11,500 people died from carbon monoxide poisoning in 2018; 70% of those deaths occurred at home during the three winter months.

**Benefit**. A study in North Carolina examined homes that had experienced fires versus those that hadn't. It found that having a working smoke alarm lowered the death risk by about 60%. The odds ratio was 0.39, with a 95% confidence interval ranging from 0.18 to 0.83. Between 2018 and 2020, 24% of fatal residential fires in the U.S. happened in homes without smoke alarms, and 41% of victims were asleep when the fire started. In 2018, China reported 11,523 deaths from carbon monoxide poisoning; of these, 72.59% occurred at home in December, 67.42% in January, and 66.48% in February.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because only one study exists on smoke alarms; it compared past fire incidents in various homes rather than using a randomized trial design. No research has shown that carbon monoxide alarms reduce mortality rates. The reported benefits are inferred from the fact that most poisoning deaths happen at home during winter.

## 4. Replace gas hoses and stoves when they reach their expiration date; never modify the piping yourself, and you may decline any unsolicited sales pitches from gas companies

**Cost**. A compliant gas hose costs only a few dozen yuan. Stoves should be replaced every few years; during replacement, check whether they've passed their expiration date.

**In plain terms**. A compliant gas hose costs just a few dozen yuan. Replacing it when it expires is a user obligation clearly stated in the “Regulations on Urban Gas Management.” The same regulations explicitly forbid users from modifying piping or removing gas meters on their own. Additionally, the regulations state that gas companies cannot require customers to purchase specific products or services. Therefore, you may freely decline any sales pitches claiming that replacement is mandatory.

**Benefit**. The regulations designate “promptly replacing gas appliances and connecting hoses that have been phased out by the state or have exceeded their service life” as a user obligation; this means you must replace any stove or hose that has reached its expiration date or been discontinued. The same regulations also classify “unauthorized installation, modification, or removal of indoor gas facilities and metering devices” as prohibited actions, which includes any DIY attempts to alter piping or remove gas meters. Furthermore, the regulations explicitly forbid gas operators from mandating that users purchase particular products or accept specific services.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Some individuals pose as gas inspectors and, after performing a check, attempt to sell self-closing valves and alarms. However, Article 20, Clause 6 of the regulations bars gas companies from requiring you to buy their designated products; you may decline such offers or even file a complaint. If you detect a gas odor, first shut off the main gas valve; in the case of bottled gas, close the cylinder valve as well. Then open doors and windows to ventilate the area, but avoid using exhaust fans. Do not turn on or switch off any electrical appliances—including lights and range hoods—and refrain from using lighters. After that, leave the premises immediately and call the gas company's emergency line from a safe location. Carbon monoxide poisoning is a separate issue; refer to Section 13 for details.

## 5. Do not pick, buy, or eat wild mushrooms; any “folk tricks” for identification are useless

**Cost**. No expense involved. The hard part is giving up a seasonal delicacy.

**In plain terms**. In 2025 alone, there were 828 cases of mushroom poisoning across China, affecting 2,165 people, with 13 fatalities. That same year, 34 previously unknown poisonous mushroom species were identified. Myths such as using a silver needle to test for toxicity, assuming mushrooms safe if insects eat them, or that only brightly colored varieties are toxic are all false.

**Benefit**. The Chinese CDC investigated 828 mushroom poisoning cases in 2025 involving 2,165 individuals; the mortality rate was 0.6%. From 2019 to 2024, annual cases ranged from 276 to 676, with mortality rates between 0.87% and 2.86%. In 2025 alone, 138 poisonous mushroom species were identified, including 34 new ones never documented before as causing poisoning.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If you accidentally eat poisonous mushrooms, induce vomiting immediately and then go to the hospital with any remaining mushrooms or photos of them. There are several types of mushroom poisoning, and identifying the exact species is crucial for proper treatment. New poisonous species are discovered each year, so the assumption that “local people can recognize them” is unfounded. Claims such as silver needle testing, cooking with garlic, insect consumption indicating safety, or vivid colors signaling toxicity are all incorrect.

## 6. Electric bicycles must not be pushed into stairwells, elevators, or charged indoors

**Cost**. No direct cost. The tricky part is having to walk a few dozen meters each time to reach the designated charging stations downstairs.

**In plain terms**. Pushing an electric bike into a stairwell, elevator, or charging it at home is strictly prohibited under the Ministry of Emergency Management's regulations on fire safety in high-rise residential buildings. Those who violate the rules face fines of $500–$1,000 for individuals and $2,000–$10,000 for businesses. Even these fines are the least of the concerns — the real danger is that a fire could block your only escape route.

**Benefit**. The regulations explicitly forbid parking or charging electric bikes in public lobbies, hallways, stairwells, or near emergency exits of high-rise buildings. Noncompliance results in the same fines mentioned above.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Avoid buying modified batteries or generic chargers, and never leave a battery charging unattended overnight. Lithium-ion batteries can ignite within seconds of catching fire, producing highly toxic smoke. A fire in a stairwell essentially blocks your only way out. In 2021, there were 18,000 electric bike-related fires nationwide, causing 65 deaths; 3,782 of those occurred inside buildings, claiming 60 lives, most of whom were indoors. Following stricter enforcement in 2024, fire incidents dropped 42.2% year-on-year, with casualties falling by over 90% — exact figures for 2024 have not been released.

## 7. Measuring blood pressure and taking meds to reach target levels

**Cost**. An electronic sphygmomanometer costs 100–200 RMB. Each measurement takes 1 minute. Most antihypertensive drugs cost just a few to dozens of RMB per month. The hard part is keeping the medication regimen even when there are no symptoms.

**In plain terms**. For every 10 mmHg drop in blood pressure, the risk of major cardiovascular problems falls by 20%, stroke risk drops 27%, heart failure risk drops 28%, and overall mortality risk declines by 13%. Among Chinese adults aged 35–75, 44.7% have hypertension, but only 7.2% have their blood pressure under proper control.

**Benefit**. Data from 123 clinical trials involving over 610,000 participants shows that a 10 mmHg reduction in systolic blood pressure lowers the incidence of major cardiovascular events by roughly 20%. The relative risk is 0.80, with a 95% confidence interval of 0.77–0.83. Systolic blood pressure is the higher of the two readings taken during a measurement. Stroke risk drops by 27% (RR 0.73), heart failure risk drops by 28% (RR 0.72), and overall mortality drops by 13% (RR 0.87, 95% CI 0.84–0.91). A screening program in China involving 1.7 million adults aged 35–75 found that 44.7% had hypertension; of these, 44.7% were aware of their condition, 30.1% were receiving treatment, and only 7.2% had their blood pressure under control.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Start by getting your blood pressure measured at least once. Fewer than 1 in 10 Chinese adults with hypertension manage to keep their levels under control, so this single measurement is one of the most cost-effective actions you can take as outlined in this book. There is still some debate over what exact target level (130 or 140 mmHg) is ideal, but there is no dispute that knowing you have hypertension and taking steps to lower it is highly beneficial.

## 8. After age 35, anyone who is overweight should get a fasting blood glucose test; if the result is normal, repeat it every three years

**Cost**. A fasting blood glucose test costs just a few dozen yuan. Testing for glycated hemoglobin is a bit pricier, still only a few dozen yuan. All it takes is one blood draw at a clinic.

**In plain terms**. For just a few dozen yuan, a single blood test can detect prediabetes even when there are absolutely no symptoms at all. Official US screening guidelines recommend this test for anyone aged 35 to 70 who is overweight or obese. If the test comes back normal, they should repeat it every three years.

**Benefit**. The US Preventive Services Task Force is the official body that issues screening recommendations in the US. Its current guidance states that adults aged 35 to 70 who are overweight or obese — even with no symptoms at all — should be screened for prediabetes and type 2 diabetes. Overweight is defined as a BMI of 25 or higher, while obesity means a BMI of 30 or higher. This recommendation is rated as a Grade B. The Task Force also explicitly notes: “It is reasonable to screen adults with normal blood glucose levels for prediabetes every three years.”

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Having a prediabetes diagnosis does not mean you must start taking medication right away. Many people can fully reverse this condition simply by making lifestyle changes. In China, only a small fraction of adults are aware they have diabetes; most only find out after developing complications.

## 9. Don't speed or drive after drinking

**Cost**. There's no direct cost. Driving a bit slower adds just a few minutes to each trip. The hard part is drinking less at social gatherings.

**In plain terms**. On average, for every 1% increase in speed, the chance of a fatal crash rises by roughly 4%. There is no “safe” level of alcohol consumption when it comes to driving; even very low blood alcohol concentrations already raise the risk of accidents.

**Benefit**. According to the World Health Organization (WHO), a 1% rise in average speed translates to a 4% increase in the likelihood of fatal crashes. The risk of a fatal crash also climbs steadily as blood alcohol concentration rises, even at very low levels.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The 1% and 4% figures linking speed to fatalities come from accident modeling rather than controlled trials. For alcohol and driving, WHO only provides a general trend without specific numerical values. This section does not verify any original research on exactly how much drinking raises risk.

## 10. When riding in a car, use a car seat for children under 4, don't hold them in your arms

**Cost**. A seat costs between 300 and 2,000 yuan and lasts several years. It adds about one minute to each trip to buckle the child in.

**In plain terms**. For infants under one year old, using a car seat when riding cuts the risk of a fatal injury in a crash by roughly 70%. For children aged 1 to 4, the risk drops by about half. Holding a child in your arms provides no such protection; in a sudden stop you simply cannot keep them secure.

**Benefit**. According to the U.S. National Highway Traffic Safety Administration (NHTSA), car seats lower the risk of fatal injury for infants under one year old by 71% and for children aged 1 to 4 by 54%. The World Health Organization reports a similar 71% reduction in infant deaths.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Follow the manufacturer's instructions to install the seat correctly; a faulty installation offers no protection. Infants under one year must be placed rear-facing. These figures are based on official U.S. crash data.

## 11. Install window guards and balcony barriers if you have kids at home; screen windows do not count as protection

**Cost**. A set of window guards or child safety locks costs just a few dozen yuan to install, and the whole process takes only ten minutes.

**In plain terms**. These window guards cost only a few dozen yuan each. New York City once offered free window guards to high-risk households and provided on-site guidance; as a result, child fall incidents reported in one borough dropped by half over three years. Eventually, New York even passed a law requiring landlords to install such guards in rental units with kids under 10. Screen windows, however, can be easily pushed open — they do not provide any real protection.

**Benefit**. Since 1972, New York City has run a program called “Kids Can't Fly,” which distributes free window guards in high-risk neighborhoods and offers on-site safety guidance. Between 1973 and 1975, child fall incidents reported in the Bronx dropped by 50%. Following this success, New York updated its health code to make it mandatory for landlords to install window guards in all apartments housing kids under 10 years of age.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Avoid placing beds, sofas, boxes, or any other objects near windows or balconies that kids might climb onto. Screen windows only keep mosquitoes out; they can be easily pushed open, so never rely on them as a safety barrier. This protection is needed even on lower floors: most child falls recorded in U.S. data actually occur on the second floor or even lower.

## 12. Keep young children in sight near water; wear life jackets when boating or swimming

**Cost**. Life jackets cost between 50 and 200 yuan. Additionally, parents must dedicate constant attention to watching their children.

**In plain terms**. Wearing a life jacket while in the water cuts the risk of drowning to roughly half compared to not wearing one. Drowning remains the leading cause of death among children aged 1–14 in China. The drowning mortality rate in rural areas is roughly twice that in cities.

**Benefit**. Research using U.S. Coast Guard data compared similar groups of people. For individuals who fell overboard while boating recreationally, wearing a life jacket lowered their drowning risk by about half. The unadjusted RR was 0.51, with a 95% CI of 0.35–0.74. In China, the drowning mortality rate among people under 20 fell from 6.60 per 100,000 in 2013 to 3.28 per 100,000 in 2021; rural rates remained roughly twice those in cities. Drowning continues to be the top cause of death for children aged 1–14. In 2021, drowning accounted for 31.1% of all injury-related deaths among those aged 0–19, while road traffic injuries accounted for 27.9%.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The Grade A rating applies only to the protective effect of life jackets. The practice of keeping children within sight is widely accepted but only qualifies for a Grade C rating due to lack of randomized trials; no such trials are expected in the future. In China, drowning deaths occur most often in rural areas during summer months, and among males aged 15–19. For winter play on ice, see item 41 (measure outdoor ice thickness first).

## 13. Exercising balance and leg strength for people over 60, plus home modifications

**Cost**. Aim to practice balance exercises two to three times per week, each session lasting 30 minutes — activities like Tai Chi work well. Installing non-slip mats, handrails, and night lights in bathrooms and stairways costs anywhere from a few dozen to several hundred yuan. The real challenge is maintaining this routine over the long term.

**In plain terms**. Doing balance exercises such as Tai Chi two or three times weekly can cut the overall number of falls among older adults by roughly 23%. It also reduces the proportion of people who have fallen at least once by about 15%. Adding simple home modifications — like anti-slip mats and handrails — can lower fall rates by another 20% or so. Falls are the leading cause of injury-related deaths among Chinese seniors aged 65 and above; alarmingly, over half of all falls happen right at home.

**Benefit**. Cochrane analyzed 108 separate trials involving 23,407 participants. Collectively, these studies show that regular exercise lowers fall rates among older adults by 23%. The relative risk of falls dropped to 0.77, with a 95% confidence interval ranging from 0.71 to 0.83. The proportion of individuals experiencing at least one fall also fell by 15% (relative risk 0.85). Professional home safety assessments and modifications further reduced fall rates by roughly 20% (RR 0.81; 95% CI 0.68–0.97). Practicing Tai Chi specifically lowered fall risk by about 29% (RR 0.71). In China, falls remain the top cause of injury-related mortality for seniors over 65; data from 2018 indicates that 55.97% of all falls among this age group occur at home.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This recommendation applies to seniors aged 60 and above who live independently at home rather than in nursing homes. The studies referenced here focus on the total number of falls, not on actual mortality rates. It's important to note that the path from a fall to a hip fracture — and ultimately death — can be very short for older adults. For seniors pulled over while walking a dog, see Section 17, item 10 (older adults walking a dog).

## 14. Get tested for hepatitis B markers; if no antibodies, get vaccinated

**Cost**. The test costs just a few dozen yuan per person. For adults lacking antibodies, three doses of the hepatitis B vaccine cost between 100 and 300 yuan total, to be completed within six months.

**In plain terms**. The test itself is very inexpensive. In Qidong's 30-year follow-up study, infants who received the hepatitis B vaccine at birth had an 84% lower risk of developing primary liver cancer and a 72% lower rate of carrying the hepatitis B virus compared to unvaccinated peers. Adults found to have no antibodies should receive three vaccine doses over six months at a cost of roughly 100–300 yuan.

**Benefit**. This Qidong trial used group randomization rather than individual assignment and was tracked for three decades. Vaccination at birth cut primary liver cancer incidence by 84% (95% CI 23%–97%). The prevalence of hepatitis B surface antigen (HBsAg) fell by 72% (95% CI 68%–75%), reflecting a comparable drop in the proportion of people carrying the virus. Nationwide in China, HBsAg prevalence dropped 52% between 1992 and 2014, and fell 97% among children under five.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This recommendation applies to adults born before 1992 who never received the vaccine or whose antibodies have waned. The 84% cancer-risk reduction pertains only to those immunized at birth; adolescents vaccinated later saw only a 21% reduction in virus carriage. For adults, the main goal is preventing new infection, not achieving the same cancer-prevention benefit. Vaccination offers no protection to people already infected; they must see a hepatologist regularly. Infection is confirmed when the hepatitis B surface antigen (HBsAg) test result is positive.

## 15. If you get pricked by a nail or splinter, or if a wound gets dirty with soil, seek treatment the same day and ask whether a tetanus shot is needed

**Cost**. Seeing a doctor and having the wound treated typically costs a few dozen yuan. If a shot is recommended, the vaccine or immunoglobulin will add another few dozen to several hundred yuan.

**In plain terms**. Once tetanus sets in, about 1 out of every 10 people dies. The risk is highest for deep wounds or wounds contaminated with dirt. If a wound is dirty and it's been 5 years or more since your last tetanus shot, you'll need a booster. Getting treated the same day costs only a few dozen yuan — don't wait until the wound starts swelling.

**Benefit**. In the U.S., roughly 1 out of every 10 tetanus cases ends in death. Deep wounds and those exposed to dirt carry an even higher risk. China's 2024 treatment guidelines classify wounds into two categories. Wounds treated within 6 hours that aren't dirty and haven't been exposed to feces, animal saliva, or soil are considered low-risk. Wounds treated later, or those contaminated with such substances, as well as puncture wounds, avulsions, crush injuries, burns, frostbite, or wounds containing foreign bodies, are deemed high-risk. If you've received three or more tetanus shots and the most recent one was less than 5 years ago, no further dose is needed. For high-risk wounds, a booster is required if it's been 5–10 years since your last shot; after 10 years, a booster is mandatory regardless of risk level. If you've never completed the three-dose series or can't recall when you last got a shot, you'll need to finish the series and, for high-risk wounds, also receive passive immunization (an injection of immunoglobulin or antitoxin that delivers antibodies directly).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. At the hospital, let the doctor make the decision — don't guess on your own, and don't hesitate to ask questions. Not every wound requires a tetanus shot; the doctor will assess the wound category and your vaccination history before deciding. The idea that "one shot in childhood provides lifelong protection" is a myth. If a wound is dirty, a booster is needed after 5 years, so try to recall when you last received a tetanus shot before heading to the clinic.

## 16. The earlier women get the HPV vaccine, the better

**Cost**. Domestic bivalent vaccines cost around 300 RMB per dose, while imported 9-valent vaccines cost about 1300 RMB per dose. A total of 2–3 doses are needed, and each visit takes half a day.

**In plain terms**. Data from 1.67 million Swedish women show that those who received the HPV vaccine before age 17 have only about one-eighth the risk of developing invasive cervical cancer compared to unvaccinated women. For women vaccinated between 17 and 30, the risk is roughly half that of non-vaccinated peers. Therefore, getting vaccinated earlier offers the greatest benefit.

**Benefit**. Swedish research on 1.67 million women found that vaccinated individuals have a much lower incidence of invasive cervical cancer. Before age 17, vaccination reduces risk by roughly 88% (IRR 0.12, 95% CI 0.00–0.34). Vaccination between 17 and 30 still lowers risk by about 53% (IRR 0.47, 95% CI 0.27–0.75).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The greatest benefit is seen when vaccination occurs between ages 9 and 14. Even for women aged 17–30, risk is still reduced by more than half. After age 30, the protective effect gradually diminishes. Vaccinated women still need regular cervical cancer screening; the vaccine does not replace screening — see item 18 for screening guidelines for women over 30.

## 17. Breast cancer screening for women: mammograms every two years starting at age 40

**Cost**. A mammogram costs around 200–300 yuan each time. Many regions also offer free screening programs. Each screening takes about half a day.

**In plain terms**. For women aged 40 to 74, having a mammogram every two years is a clear recommendation in official US screening guidelines. For women over 75, and for those with dense breast tissue who need extra ultrasound or MRI scans, there is currently insufficient evidence to support such screening. If a health check package includes these extra tests at an extra charge, they are not necessary.

**Benefit**. The US Preventive Services Task Force is the official body that issues screening recommendations in the US. Its current recommendation reads: "We recommend screening mammography every two years for women aged 40 to 74." Mammography is exactly what we commonly call a mammogram. This recommendation is rated as a Grade B. For women over 75, and for those with dense breast tissue who need additional ultrasound or MRI scans, the Task Force has concluded that there is not enough evidence to support such screening.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The recommended starting age for screening varies by country. In China, some local guidelines and programs recommend starting at age 45. Women with a family history of breast cancer — such as parents, children or siblings who have had it — or those carrying BRCA mutations are at higher risk. They should consult a doctor individually to determine the right screening plan; the above recommendations do not apply to them.

## 18. For women over 30, HPV testing should be the first choice for cervical cancer screening

**Cost**. An HPV test costs between 100 and 300 yuan. Women with a negative result can get tested again only once every five years. The sampling process takes just a few minutes.

**In plain terms**. In that rural Indian trial, women who underwent just one HPV test in their lifetime had roughly half the risk of dying from cervical cancer and about 50% lower odds of being diagnosed with advanced-stage disease. At a cost of just 100–200 yuan per test, a negative result provides protection for five years.

**Benefit**. This trial in rural India used group-level rather than individual randomization, involving women aged 30–59. A single HPV test cut the risk of death from cervical cancer by roughly 48% (hazard ratio 0.52; 95% CI 0.33–0.83). It also reduced the likelihood of detecting late-stage disease by about 53% (HR 0.47; 95% CI 0.32–0.69).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Even women who have received the HPV vaccine still need screening, since the vaccine does not protect against all viral types. What makes this study unique is that it was a randomized screening trial with mortality as the primary outcome and only one round of testing performed.

## 19. Starting colorectal cancer screening at ages 45–50: use fecal immunochemical tests or colonoscopies

**Cost**. Fecal tests cost just a few dozen yuan and can be done every 1–2 years. Colonoscopies cost several hundred to over a thousand yuan; those with negative results only need one every 10 years. Preparing for a colonoscopy requires setting aside a full day for bowel cleansing.

**In plain terms**. Getting a low-cost fecal occult blood test every year or two lowers the chance of dying from colorectal cancer by roughly 16%. For people who've had at least one round of screening, this risk drops by about 25%. In the group invited to undergo a colonoscopy, the likelihood of developing colorectal cancer over the next decade fell from 1.20% to 0.98%.

**Benefit**. Cochrane pooled data from multiple studies showing that individuals undergoing fecal occult blood screening have a roughly 16% lower risk of dying from colorectal cancer. The original RR was 0.84, with a 95% CI ranging from 0.78 to 0.90. For those who've had at least one screening round, this risk reduction reaches 25% (RR 0.75). The NordICC randomized trial likewise found that among participants invited to get a colonoscopy, colorectal cancer incidence dropped from 1.20% to 0.98% over 10 years; its RR was 0.82, with a 95% CI of 0.70–0.93.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This topic remains debated. The NordICC trial tracked participants based on whether they were invited to get a colonoscopy; the difference in colorectal cancer mortality between groups was 0.28% versus 0.31% (RR 0.90, 95% CI 0.64–1.16), a gap well within statistical margins of error. This suggests earlier estimates of colonoscopy's mortality benefits may have been overstated, while evidence for fecal tests' impact on mortality is more robust. Most national guidelines recommend starting screening at ages 45–50; those with a family history of colorectal cancer should begin even earlier.

## 20. People with cardiovascular disease and older adults should get a flu shot each year

**Cost**. One shot costs 50 to 150 yuan. It should be given once each autumn.

**In plain terms**. In a trial involving people after a heart attack, the yearly death rate dropped from 4.9% to 2.9% after they received the flu vaccine. For people with cardiovascular disease and older adults, getting one shot each autumn for just 50 to 150 yuan can make a real difference.

**Benefit**. This trial included 2,571 participants after a myocardial infarction; neither doctors nor patients knew who got the vaccine or the placebo. Over 12 months, the overall death rate was 2.9% in the vaccine group versus 4.9% in the placebo group. The hazard ratio was 0.59, with a 95% confidence interval of 0.39 to 0.89. Cardiovascular death rates also showed a hazard ratio of 0.59. Another study pooled multiple trials and found that flu vaccination lowered the rate of major cardiovascular events to 3.6% from 5.4% in the control group; the relative risk was 0.66, with a 95% confidence interval of 0.53 to 0.83. Cardiovascular death risk showed a relative risk of 0.74, though this fell within the margin of error and was not statistically significant (95% CI 0.42 to 1.30).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This recommendation is somewhat controversial. The Grade A rating applies only to people with cardiovascular disease. For otherwise healthy older adults, a Cochrane review offers only limited evidence. Flu vaccination also lowered the seasonal flu infection rate from 6% to 2.4%. The review rated the evidence for infection outcomes as “low” quality and the evidence for mortality as “very low” quality. This review was published in 2018 by Demicheli V et al.

## 21. Getting the shingles vaccine after age 50

**Cost**. The recombinant shingles vaccine requires two doses, costing roughly 3,000 to 4,000 yuan in total. This expense must be paid out of pocket.

**In plain terms**. In Phase 3 trials, this vaccine proved 97% effective at preventing shingles across all age groups. The downside is that both doses cost several thousand yuan, all paid by the patient. In exchange, there's a 97% reduction in the likelihood of developing shingles.

**Benefit**. This Phase 3 trial involved 15,400 participants from 18 countries. Participants were randomly assigned to receive either the vaccine or a placebo, with follow-up lasting an average of 3.2 years. Over that time, 6 cases of shingles occurred in the vaccine group versus 210 in the placebo group. Expressed per 1,000 person-years, these figures translate to 0.3 versus 9.1 cases. One thousand person-years represents the number of cases observed in a group of 1,000 people over one year. The original report states, “The overall vaccine efficacy against shingles is 97.2% (95% CI 93.7–99.0, P<0.001).” Effectiveness ranged from 96.6% to 97.9% across all age brackets.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This option ranks low in terms of cost-effectiveness primarily due to its high price. While shingles itself rarely proves fatal, its most troublesome complication is post-herpetic neuralgia, which can persist for months or even years. After vaccination, a notable percentage of recipients experience pain at the injection site and fever. In particular, severe side effects (graded as Grade 3) occurred in 17.0% of vaccine recipients versus 3.2% of those given a placebo.

## 22. Pneumococcal vaccine for people over 65

**Cost**. Several hundred yuan. In some regions, it is provided free of charge for seniors.

**In plain terms**. In a trial involving 84,500 seniors, the 13-valent pneumococcal vaccine cut cases of pneumonia caused by strains it targets by roughly 46%, and reduced instances of the most severe invasive infections by 75%. However, it showed no effect on pneumonia cases caused by any other pathogens, so it won't prevent all types of pneumonia. The absolute confidence interval width is 95.2%.

**Benefit**. Researchers in the Netherlands randomly assigned 84,500 seniors over 65 to two groups for comparison. They used the 13-valent pneumococcal conjugate vaccine. Its effectiveness against pneumonia caused by strains it targets was 45.6%, with a 95% confidence interval of 21.8–62.5. This figure refers to the specific bacterial strains the vaccine can protect against. For the most dangerous form of pneumococcal disease, the effectiveness was 75.0% (95% CI 41.4–90.8). No protective effect was observed against pneumonia cases caused by any other pathogens.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This vaccine only protects against the specific bacterial strains it targets; it does not prevent all types of pneumonia. The 23-valent polysaccharide vaccine commonly used for seniors in China is a different formulation from the 13-valent conjugate vaccine used in this trial, so the effectiveness figures here cannot be directly applied to that vaccine.

## 23. Testing for Helicobacter pylori and eradicating it if positive

**Cost**. The carbon-13 or carbon-14 breath test costs 100 to 200 yuan. Eradicating the bacteria requires taking four different medications for two weeks; the medication cost for that period is 200 to 500 yuan. The main difficulty is ensuring the full two-week course of medication is taken on schedule.

**In plain terms**. A 22-year follow-up study conducted in Linqu, Shandong, showed that individuals who had Helicobacter pylori eradicated had roughly half the risk of developing gastric cancer and about 40% lower risk of dying from it. Testing costs just 100–200 yuan, while eradication requires a two-week medication regimen.

**Benefit**. This randomized trial in Linqu, Shandong, followed participants for 22 years. Those who underwent Helicobacter pylori eradication therapy saw their risk of gastric cancer drop by nearly half. The original odds ratio was 0.48, with a 95% confidence interval ranging from 0.32 to 0.71. Their risk of dying from gastric cancer also fell by roughly 38% (hazard ratio 0.62; 95% CI 0.39–0.99).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Reinfection can still occur after eradication, so it is advisable for all household members to be tested and treated together. This trial involved residents of an area with a high incidence of gastric cancer; people living in regions with lower incidence may gain considerably less benefit.

## 24. Heavy smokers should get a low-dose chest CT once a year

**Cost**. The test costs 200–400 yuan per session and takes just 10 minutes. You must also factor in follow-up tests after any false alarms, plus the anxiety that comes with waiting for results.

**In plain terms**. Eligible heavy smokers who get a low-dose CT once a year have a 20% lower risk of dying from lung cancer and a 6.7% lower overall risk of death compared to those who only get regular chest X-rays. The trade-offs are extra follow-up tests after any suspicious findings and the resulting worry during the waiting period.

**Benefit**. The NLST trial in the U.S. enrolled 53,454 participants aged 55–74 with at least 30 pack-years of smoking history and who had quit smoking no more than 15 years prior. Those who underwent low-dose CT had a 20.0% relative reduction in lung cancer deaths versus those who only got chest X-rays. The 95% confidence interval is 6.8–26.7. Overall mortality dropped by 6.7% relative to controls, with a 95% CI of 1.2–13.6.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This recommendation applies only to high-risk smokers. In the same study, 24.2% of CT recipients showed suspicious findings, yet 96.4% of those cases turned out to be false positives. For non-smokers, undergoing this test offers no benefit and only adds unnecessary anxiety.

## 25. Call 12356 if you're depressed or having suicidal thoughts; don't keep sleeping pills or pesticides at home

**Cost**. There's no cost involved. You just need to make one phone call. Plus, lock away any medications and keep pesticides out of the house.

**In plain terms**. Removing lethal items from easy reach is a proven way to cut suicide risk: after restricting access to painkillers, suicide rates linked to them dropped by 43%; installing barriers at locations where people often jump off cliffs cut rates by 86%. That's why it's a good idea to avoid storing sleeping pills and pesticides at home. If you're feeling overwhelmed, call 12356 — this national helpline is available at least 18 hours a day.

**Benefit**. A recent review of nearly a decade's worth of research confirms that limiting people's access to lethal means is an effective suicide prevention strategy. After controls on painkiller availability were put in place, suicide cases tied to these drugs fell by 43%. Installing protective barriers at common suicide hotspots reduced rates by 86% (the 95% confidence interval ranges from 79% to 91%). School-based cognitive intervention programs also lowered rates of attempted suicide by roughly 55% (OR 0.45, 95% CI 0.24–0.85). Antidepressant medications and psychotherapy are also key components of suicide prevention. Starting May 1, 2025, the 12356 helpline will be available nationwide in China, operating at least 18 hours each day.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The B rating is based on two factors: most evidence supporting restrictive measures comes from ecological studies that compare suicide rates before and after policy implementation; there is currently no direct evidence that the helpline itself reduces overall mortality rates. Suicidal impulses typically last only a few minutes to a few hours, so simply removing lethal items from immediate reach is a meaningful intervention on its own. Data on outcomes over longer time periods following suicide attempts, as well as information on long-term consequences for survivors, can be found in Item 32 of this section (“Tell someone close to you as soon as suicidal thoughts arise”).

## 26. Purchase fire extinguishers, fire blankets, escape respirators, and first-aid kits, then inspect them once a year

**Cost**. A set of fire extinguishers, fire blankets, one respirator per person, and a first-aid kit costs a few hundred yuan. You only need to buy it once; after that, it takes just 10 minutes each year to inspect the items.

**In plain terms**. Fire extinguishers, fire blankets, escape respirators, and first-aid kits are all included in the Emergency Management Department's list of 11 essential items for household emergency preparedness. The whole set costs a few hundred yuan, and you only need to buy it once. Studies of home safety programs that included on-site guidance found these measures cut injury rates by roughly 25%.

**Benefit**. The Emergency Management Department's “National Recommended List of Basic Household Emergency Supplies” contains 11 items in total. Among them, “fire extinguishers and fire blankets” are recommended for “putting out small fires at the initial stage”, and the list also notes that “fire blankets can be draped over the body to aid escape”. The “escape respirators” listed are “firefighting filtering self-rescue respirators designed for use during fire escapes”. “External medical supplies” refer to “hemostatic powder, adhesive bandages, gauze bandages, and other items used to treat wounds”. Cochrane analyzed 98 studies involving 2,605,044 participants in total. Home safety interventions lowered injury rates to an IRR of 0.89; the 95% confidence interval for this figure is 0.78 to 1.01. For interventions that included on-site guidance, injury rates dropped by around 25% (IRR 0.75, 95% CI 0.62 to 0.91).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This finding is somewhat controversial. The same Cochrane meta-analysis found that interventions that did not provide emergency supplies also lowered injury rates by roughly 20%. The original IRR for those interventions was 0.78, with a 95% confidence interval of 0.66 to 0.92. Providing emergency supplies alone did not yield better results than other measures. The main effect of these interventions comes from on-site education and home modifications, so the benefit of supplying emergency supplies is rated as “moderate”

rather than “significant”. When buying fire extinguishers, look for the CCC certification mark; for pre-pressurized extinguishers, make sure the pressure gauge needle points to the green zone. Fire blankets are often made of fiberglass: grab only the two pull tabs and do not touch the blanket surface with bare hands. Using one to smother a pan fire is also disputed: in 2014 a Dutch regulator tested 22 brands, and none put out the fire reliably when used the way an ordinary person would. For a pan fire, turn off the heat first and put a lid on the pan. Details on smoke alarms and carbon monoxide detectors are covered in section 3 of this chapter. Instructions for using tourniquets can be found in section 13, item 12. Guidance on how to select, store, and replace each item can be found in Home Emergency Supplies Checklist: What to Buy, Where to Put It, and How Often to Check.

## 27. Visible blood in urine — even if painless and gone by the next day — still warrants a check-up

**Cost**. A routine urine test costs just a few dozen yuan, while a urinary-system ultrasound runs around 100–200 yuan. If a doctor deems it necessary, a cystoscopy can be added at a cost of roughly 1,000 yuan.

**In plain terms**. Among people aged 60 and older, the chance of ultimately being diagnosed with bladder cancer after experiencing one episode of visible blood in urine is about 2.8%. For those aged 40–59, that figure is roughly 1.2%. These percentages may not seem very high, but they're high enough to justify getting checked — even if the bleeding stops the very next day.

**Benefit**. A UK study analyzed electronic medical records from primary-care clinics, comparing 4,915 patients diagnosed with bladder cancer against 21,718 controls. Among patients with visible blood in urine, the proportion ultimately found to have bladder cancer was 2.8% for those aged 60+, with a 95% confidence interval of 2.5–3.1. For ages 40–59, the figure was 1.2%, with a 95% CI of 0.6–2.3. This proportion is known as the positive predictive value. Blood visible only under a microscope also carries significance; the odds ratio is 20, with a 95% CI of 12–33. For those over 60, this figure is 1.6%, with a 95% CI of 1.2–2.1.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The absence of pain is a key clue. Blood in urine caused by kidney stones or infections usually comes with abdominal or flank pain, plus frequent, urgent, or painful urination. Cancer-related bleeding, however, often causes no discomfort at all and may disappear for a few days before returning — which is why many people overlook it. Taking anticoagulant medications is not a valid reason to skip testing. Blood in urine after intense exercise or during a woman's menstrual period can be re-evaluated before deciding on further checks. The benefit is rated “low” because it reflects only detection rates, not any measurable reduction in mortality resulting from early diagnosis.

## 28. If erectile dysfunction appears, check cardiovascular health first — don't treat it as a purely sexual issue

**Cost**. A doctor's visit costs just a few dozen yuan. Measuring blood pressure and running tests for blood sugar and cholesterol adds another hundred or so yuan. One trip to the hospital yields results after a few days.

**In plain terms**. Men with erectile dysfunction later develop cardiovascular disease at roughly 40% higher rates than other men, and heart attacks at about 60% higher rates. The younger a man is, the greater this difference becomes. This problem often shows up before any chest pain does. Therefore, it's wise to check blood pressure, blood sugar, and cholesterol levels rather than simply self-medicating.

**Benefit**. One meta-analysis combined data from 14 long-term studies involving 92,757 men, followed for an average of 6.1 years. Compared with men without erectile dysfunction, those with the condition faced higher risks as follows: overall cardiovascular events rose by roughly 44% (RR 1.44, 95% CI 1.27–1.63). Heart attacks increased by about 62% (RR 1.62, 95% CI 1.34–1.96). Cerebrovascular events rose by roughly 39% (RR 1.39, 95% CI 1.23–1.57). All-cause mortality went up by about 25% (RR 1.25, 95% CI 1.12–1.39). No significant difference appeared for cardiovascular-related deaths (RR 1.19, 95% CI 0.97–1.46). The risk elevation was greater in younger men and in those whose baseline cardiovascular risk was moderate. Studies that used

questionnaire-based diagnosis reported an RR of 1.61 (95% CI 1.38–1.86), while studies asking just one question gave an RR of 1.27 (95% CI 1.18–1.37).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These 14 studies tracked groups of men over time; they are not randomized controlled trials. Hence the "40% higher" figure reflects an association, not a proven cause-and-effect relationship. Occasional episodes do not count; the condition is considered present only when symptoms persist for three months or more. The tests recommended — blood pressure measurement, fasting blood-glucose testing, plus cholesterol checks, smoking status assessment, and waist-circumference measurement — are the same as those listed in sections 7 and 8 of this chapter. Avoid purchasing "male-enhancement" supplements online; legitimate medications for this purpose are prescription drugs, and their instructions list nitrates as a contraindication — meaning men already taking nitroglycerin or similar drugs must not use them, as doing so can cause a sudden drop in blood pressure. For ways to improve erectile function, see section 29 (weight loss and smoking cessation can help). The benefit is rated "moderate" rather than "large": the 44% figure represents the difference between two groups, not the actual reduction in mortality achieved by testing. It is also not "small"; unlike the situation described in section 27 (visible blood in urine), where detection alone is the benefit, here hypertension, diabetes, and abnormal cholesterol levels each have established treatments available.

## 29. Weight loss, quitting smoking, and controlling blood pressure and blood sugar can improve erectile function

**Cost**. There is no cost involved; in fact, it may even save money. The real challenge is staying consistent over time — eating healthily, exercising regularly, and quitting smoking.

**In plain terms**. Managing cardiovascular risk factors naturally leads to better erectile function. When multiple randomized trials are combined, questionnaire scores improve by an average of 2 to 3 points. This questionnaire has a maximum score of 25, with scores above 22 considered normal.

**Benefit**. One meta-analysis evaluated six randomized controlled trials involving 740 men. Interventions included lifestyle changes or medication to control cardiovascular risk factors, with follow-ups lasting at least six weeks. Overall, erectile function scores on the IIEF-5 questionnaire rose by an average of 2.66 points (95% CI: 1.86–3.47). When two trials using statins (143 participants) were excluded, the remaining four trials relying solely on lifestyle changes still showed an average improvement of 2.40 points (95% CI: 1.19–3.61). A total of 597 men participated in these four trials. The IIEF-5 consists of five questions scored from 5 to 25; scores between 22 and 25 indicate no erectile dysfunction, while scores of 5–7 indicate severe impairment.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These six trials used different interventions — some combined weight loss and exercise, while others used medication to control blood pressure and lipids. With only 740 participants overall, the results confirm a positive trend, though the exact degree of improvement varies per individual. The benefit is rated as "minor" because the outcome measured was solely questionnaire scores, not actual reductions in disease incidence. However, similar lifestyle changes have been shown to produce measurable health benefits elsewhere: quitting smoking (see Section 2, Item 1), maintaining a BMI between 20–25 through weight control (Section 2, Item 33), and managing blood pressure with medication when necessary (Section 7). Prescription medications are acceptable when prescribed by a doctor; caution is advised with over-the-counter "health supplements," which may contain unregulated amounts of active ingredients. For guidance on identifying safe products, see Section 28, Item 4.

## 30. Always use condoms during sex and never share needles

**Cost**. A single condom costs just one or two yuan. The challenge isn't the price, but making sure to use one every single time — and putting it on right from the start.

**In plain terms**. Using a condom every time throughout sex cuts the chance of HIV transmission between heterosexual partners by roughly 70% or more. “Most of the time” just isn't enough — that still leaves the risk nearly as high as not using one at all. Condoms also protect against syphilis, gonorrhea, and other STIs.

**Benefit**. One study pooled data from 25 separate studies involving 10,676 heterosexual couples in which one partner was HIV-positive and the other was not. Compared to couples who never used condoms, those who consistently used them saw their HIV transmission risk drop by about 71%. The reported relative risk was 0.29, with a 95% confidence interval of 0.20–0.43. When compared to couples who used condoms only intermittently, the risk was lower by roughly 77% (RR = 0.23; 95% CI 0.13–0.40). The authors concluded that although condoms are not perfect, “consistent use can reduce HIV transmission by more than 70%.” This same level of protection also applies to syphilis, gonorrhea, chlamydia, and other sexually transmitted infections.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The difference between “infrequent use” and “no use” is minimal; the whole benefit hinges on the phrase “every time, throughout.” Sharing needles is a separate, highly effective route of transmission that has nothing to do with sex — this includes drug injection, tattooing, and piercing. For people at high risk, pre-exposure prophylaxis (PrEP) offers another option: taking medication in advance to block infection. Pooled data from 18 studies show that when at least 70% of participants adhered to the regimen, PrEP cut HIV risk by about 70% compared to placebo (RR = 0.30; 95% CI 0.21–0.45). Trials with lower adherence rates showed no protective effect. PrEP is a prescription medication; consult an infectious-disease specialist or public-health clinic rather than ordering it online. Information on what to do after potential exposure can be found in Section 13.

## 31. If you've engaged in high-risk behavior, get tested for HIV — the Chinese CDC offers free testing with full confidentiality

**Cost**. There is no charge. You simply visit the Chinese CDC or a designated medical facility and provide a blood sample. The only real hurdle is mustering the courage to get tested at all.

**In plain terms**. Testing for HIV at the Chinese CDC costs nothing. According to the “National Measures for HIV Testing Management,” staff are prohibited from disclosing your name, address, or test results. A positive result does not mean a death sentence: people who adhere to treatment and keep their viral load undetectable cannot transmit the virus to sexual partners. One major study followed more than 700 couples through over 70,000 unprotected acts; there were zero transmissions between partners.

**Benefit**. Article 23 of the “Regulations on HIV/AIDS Prevention and Control” mandates that local health authorities designate medical institutions to provide free counseling and initial screening to anyone who voluntarily seeks testing. Early detection is far more than a psychological comfort — modern antiretroviral therapy can drive the virus down to undetectable levels. The World Health Organization states that individuals on such treatment with an undetectable viral load pose no risk of HIV transmission. The PARTNER study observed 782 same-sex couples (serodiscordant pairs) for a total of 1,593 person-years; despite 76,088 unprotected encounters, only 15 new infections occurred, and genetic analysis proved none originated from the partner. The same national measures also forbid any disclosure of patients' personal data or test outcomes.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The “window period” determines when a test becomes reliable. The Guangdong Provincial CDC reports that nucleic-acid tests can detect HIV after roughly one week, fourth-generation antigen-antibody tests after about two weeks, and third-generation antibody tests after three weeks. It is advisable to wait at least two weeks post-exposure and then retest after another two to four weeks; after three months, 99.99% of people can be certain they are not infected. A positive home-test result is not a diagnosis — confirmation must come from the Chinese CDC or a certified lab. Article 3 of the regulations guarantees that no one may discriminate against HIV-positive individuals or their families; their rights to marriage, employment, medical care, and education are protected by law. Article 38 also requires infected persons to inform any sexual

partners of their status. Screening for HIV, syphilis, and hepatitis B during pregnancy and related prevention measures are covered in Section 27.

## 32. As soon as suicidal thoughts arise, tell someone nearby and hand over those first few minutes

**Cost**. No cost involved. The hard part is actually speaking up at that moment and admitting you can't be alone for a few hours.

**In plain terms**. Among 82 people who attempted suicide, 47.6% reported that only 10 minutes or less passed from the first appearance of suicidal thoughts to the actual attempt. What they had to endure was not a lifetime of mental anguish, but just those few minutes. Of the same group, 76.8% had some contact with others during that time, though they did not voice their feelings. Looking ahead, about 2% of people who ended up in the hospital due to self-harm died by suicide within a year, while roughly 7% did so after nine years or more; the vast majority did not follow that path.

**Benefit**. Interviews conducted within three days of admission with those 82 individuals showed that 47.6% (39 people) stated the interval between the first emergence of suicidal thoughts and the actual attempt was no more than 10 minutes. Those whose process took longer displayed significantly higher scores on measures of suicidal intent. However, impulse scores showed no correlation with the duration of this period. Additionally, 76.8% (63 people) reported having some sort of interaction with a partner, family member, or friend during those minutes. The authors conclude that the window for intervention is usually very brief, leaving limited room for professionals to step in; thus, it is crucial to spread awareness of warning signs and basic intervention methods to ordinary people. Another systematic review compiled findings from 90 follow-up studies. For those seeking medical care after self-harm, the median rate of repeated self-harm without resulting in death was 16% after one year, while the suicide mortality rate at that point stood at 2%. After nine years or more of follow-up, roughly 7% had died by suicide.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B is assigned for two main reasons: the Deisenhammer study involved only 82 participants from a single hospital and relied on retrospective recollections; Owens's review aggregated median figures from 90 studies employing different methods, rather than producing a single combined statistic. That same review also emphasizes that the suicide risk among self-harm patients remains hundreds of times higher than in the general population. Consequently, the statement “the vast majority did not follow that path” describes the overall trajectory of this group, not a guarantee for any individual; appropriate medical care must still be sought. For advice on removing lethal means and contacting the helpline 12356, see item 25 in this section. Steps to take when feeling down are outlined in item 19 of Section 3. Long-term consequences following survival are discussed in item 33 of this section. If you suspect someone close to you is thinking about it, you can ask them directly; see item 43 in this section (asking someone who seems off). Finally, actions you can take if someone close to you expresses such thoughts are detailed in item 15 of Section 8.

## 33. Don't treat “survival” as a safety net: after ingesting paraquat or inhaling carbon monoxide, emergency care can save lives, but it rarely preserves lung or brain function

**Cost**. No cost involved. It simply helps you understand this reality up front.

**In plain terms**. There is no antidote for paraquat. Gastric lavage is not recommended, and neither hemofiltration nor dialysis alters its disease progression. Paraquat actively enters lung tissue against its concentration gradient, causing pneumonia and pulmonary fibrosis, while also damaging kidneys and liver. Among 257 cases treated at ten hospitals in Bangladesh, the mortality rate reached 43.2%. Carbon monoxide produces similar outcomes: six weeks after exposure, 46.1% of patients receiving normal oxygen still suffered cognitive impairment, compared to 25.0% of those receiving hyperbaric oxygen therapy. No treatment pathway yields a completely clean outcome; the most common result is lasting health complications.

**Benefit**. A systematic review on paraquat poisoning highlights its extremely high mortality rate, stemming from its intrinsic toxicity and lack of effective treatments. Paraquat is actively transported into lung tissue against its concentration gradient, resulting in pneumonia, pulmonary fibrosis, kidney and liver damage. The review explicitly advises against gastric lavage; hemofiltration and dialysis are unlikely to alter clinical outcomes. Evidence supporting corticosteroids or immunosuppressants remains weak. It also notes that mortality rates remain high across all centers despite varying treatment approaches. In Bangladesh, 257 out of 1,420 cases admitted to ten tertiary hospitals between 2013 and 2024 resulted in death (43.2%). Common symptoms included lower limb swelling due to acute kidney failure (71.2%), vomiting (65.8%) and abdominal pain (58.0%). Another randomized, double-blind trial involving 76 patients per group examined acute carbon monoxide poisoning; six weeks later, 25.0% of those receiving hyperbaric oxygen therapy and 46.1% of those receiving normal oxygen still had cognitive impairments (P=0.007; adjusted OR 0.45, 95% CI 0.22–0.92). A separate study of 73 patients found 30% developed cognitive impairments and 12% showed hyperintense signals in white matter on brain imaging. Since July 1, 2014, China has banned the registration and production of paraquat aqueous solutions; sales and usage ceased by July 1, 2016. As of September 26, 2020, soluble concentrate formulations are also prohibited nationwide. Official documents cite frequent suicide attempts involving paraquat as the primary reason for these strict controls.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B is assigned because these studies involve general poisoning patients rather than solely suicide attempt survivors; the carbon monoxide trial even included accidental poisoning cases. Consequently, observed complication rates cannot be directly interpreted as probabilities specific to suicide attempts. This entry does not compare mortality rates across different treatment methods nor recommend any specific actions. The sole certainty is that no treatment pathway guarantees a completely clean outcome. On-site management of carbon monoxide poisoning is detailed in Section 13, Item 19. For accidental ingestion of pesticides or medications, avoid inducing vomiting and seek medical help while bringing the container along (Section 13, Item 20). Finally, refrain from storing pesticides or sedatives at home (Section 13, Item 25).

## 34. Don't bet on “a few days of rest” after a fall from height: most patients admitted to a trauma ICU survive, though at a cost measured in years

**Cost**. No cost at all. It simply helps you see the full picture.

**In plain terms**. A trauma ICU in southern Xinjiang treated 289 patients who fell from heights. Only 5.5% died either in the hospital or within 30 days. The vast majority survived, but at a price: 47.1% suffered injuries to three or more body parts, 36% needed ventilators, and the median length of stay in the ICU was 8 days — with some patients remaining for as long as 132 days. The median fall height for this group was just 3 meters. Follow-up showed that 58% of those with serious injuries eventually returned to work.

**Benefit**. From April 2020 to July 2024, the same ICU recorded 289 cases of falls from heights; the average age of patients was 40.3 years. The median fall height was 3 meters; 26.6% fell from heights above 5 meters and 11.4% from heights above 10 meters. The median Injury Severity Score was 24, a higher score indicating more severe injuries; 63.3% of patients scored above 20. In addition to the multiple injuries, 18.3% suffered damage to four or more body parts. Mechanical ventilation was required for 36% of patients, with a median duration of 103.5 hours. The median ICU stay was 8 days, ranging from 1 day to 132 days. The in-hospital or 30-day mortality rate was 5.5% (16 out of 289). A German trauma center reported similar results: among 84 patients with an ISS of 25 or higher, 58% returned to work after follow-up. Age, length of ICU treatment, and self-reported health status were identified as predictive factors. Nationwide, the average cost per hospital stay in 2024 was 9,870 yuan, a 4.3% decrease from the previous year; total health expenditures reached 9,089.55 billion yuan, of which personal spending accounted for 2,500.75 billion yuan, or 27.5% of the total.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B is assigned because the fall-related data come from a single hospital's retrospective chart review without distinguishing between accidental and self-inflicted falls. The figure on return-to-work is based on only 84 patients in Germany; neither dataset can be taken as a reliable predictor of outcomes for any individual who falls from a height. The average national hospital cost is an overall figure, not specific to

fall injuries; it is included only to provide a baseline for comparison. No direct correlation between fall height and injury severity is presented, as the source only supplies the height distribution of this group. For information on pressure ulcers that often develop during prolonged bed rest, see Section 17, Item 8. Deep-vein thrombosis and pulmonary embolism are discussed in Section 13, Item 11 (sudden swelling of one leg). If suicidal thoughts arise, refer to Section 32 of this chapter. Details on paraquat poisoning are covered in Section 33 — remember that “being saved” does not guarantee a completely uncomplicated recovery. The timeline described here reflects the author's own experience: after falling from the fourth floor, he initially believed he would recover in a few weeks, but ended up hospitalized for a full year, undergoing multiple surgeries, wearing steel plates, and unable to sit up on his own for half a year; his family had to take on debt to cover the expenses.

## 35. Don't trade “losing one kidney is no big deal” for cash: the remaining kidney has to do the work of two, and 86% of kidney sellers later say their health got worse

**Cost**. No cost at all. It simply requires a clear look at the facts.

**In plain terms**. First, consider the best-case scenario: legitimate donors who pass rigorous screening and receive post-surgery follow-up. In U.S. data from nearly 96,000 donors, only 31 per 10,000 developed end-stage renal disease within 15 years after donation. Among equally healthy, eligible non-donors, that figure was just 4 per 10,000. On the other side, a study of 305 kidney sellers in India found that six years later, 86% reported poorer health, and three-quarters still carried debt. Legitimate donors get screening and monitoring; kidney sellers get none of that.

**Benefit**. U.S. researchers compared 96,217 living kidney donors with 20,024 similarly healthy non-donors drawn from the NHANES III survey. After 15 years, the estimated risk of developing end-stage renal disease (ESRD) was 30.8 per 10,000 donors (95% CI 24.3–38.5) versus 3.9 per 10,000 non-donors (95% CI 0.8–8.9; P<0.001). Over a lifetime, ESRD risk was 90 per 10,000 donors, 14 per 10,000 non-donors, and 326 per 10,000 in the general population. A Norwegian study of 1,901 donors (median follow-up 15.1 years) showed a 30% higher overall mortality (HR 1.30, 95% CI 1.11–1.52), a 40% higher cardiovascular mortality (HR 1.40, 95% CI 1.03–1.91), and roughly tenfold higher ESRD risk (HR 11.38, 95% CI 4.37–29.6). Among 3,698 U.S. donors, 11 developed ESRD — an incidence of 180 per million person-years, compared with 268 per million in the general population. Of those re-examined after an average of 12.2 years, 255 remained healthy, and 85.5% retained a glomerular filtration rate of at least 60 ml/min/1.73 m², the clinical lower limit of normal. Hypertension affected 32.1% and proteinuria 12.7%. In Chennai, India, 96% of 305 kidney sellers acted to pay debts; they received an average of $1,070. Six years post-surgery, family income fell by one-third (P<0.001), poverty rose, and three-quarters remained indebted; 86% said health worsened, and 79% would not recommend kidney selling to others. The absolute numbers from these studies are 32,621 donors, 24.9 years of follow-up, 302 ESRD cases, and 9.2 years of average follow-up after surgery.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy exists: Ibrahim's study used ordinary citizens as controls and found no difference in survival or ESRD risk between donors and non-donors. Muzaale and Mjøen compared donors to equally healthy, eligible non-donors and found markedly higher risks. The disagreement concerns the control group, not the donors themselves. All three studies agree that absolute risks remain low (30.8 per 10,000 over 15 years). Thus the key points are two: first, the remaining kidney does bear extra strain, as shown by higher rates of hypertension and proteinuria; second, these figures apply only to donors who undergo pre- and post-operative screening and medical care — conditions absent for illegal kidney sellers, whose outcomes differ sharply according to Indian follow-up data. Original studies provide only self-reported health decline, proteinuria, hypertension, and ESRD rates; no figures on bed-bound status are included here. Legal restrictions on organ sales, fines, and criminal penalties for relatives are detailed in Section 9, Article 22. Dialysis patients may use cross-regional settlement and long-term medication programs described in Section 16, Articles 1 and 2.

## 36. Don't pick up, disassemble, or sell unidentified metal parts; stay clear of areas marked with the clover symbol

**Cost**. No cost involved. If you see unfamiliar metal cylinders, lead containers, or parts removed from equipment, simply steer clear — don't pick them up, take them apart, or put them in your pocket.

**In plain terms**. Radiation has no smell, color, or temperature. Most radioactive sources look like ordinary pieces of metal, so “it looks harmless” is not a reliable indicator. The chance of an ordinary person encountering one is extremely low — fewer than one incident occurs per 10,000 sources each year. Yet when such an encounter does happen, the consequences are irreversible. In 1987, four people died in Brazil after dismantling a radiotherapy machine from an abandoned clinic.

**Benefit**. As of 2025, roughly 178,000 radioactive sources and 355,000 radiation devices are in use nationwide. The annual rate of radiation incidents involving sources remains below one per 10,000 sources. Classification is as follows: loss, theft, or uncontrolled release of Category I or II sources constitutes a major radiation incident; Category III is a relatively serious incident. Loss or theft of Category IV or V sources, or exposure exceeding annual dose limits, counts as a minor incident. Official example: In June 2020, a γ-ray inspection was performed during pipeline upgrades at a steel plant in Ningxia. A Category II iridium-192 source exposed three workers to radiation; one suffered third-degree acute skin damage, another had fourth-degree injuries on several fingers, and a third had first- to second-degree burns. All three received doses far above legal limits; both responsible firms had their radiation licenses revoked and were fined 70,000 yuan. International example: In 1987, 50.8 TBq of cesium-137 was removed from a radiotherapy machine in Goiânia, Brazil, after the device was dismantled; the source's protective casing was ruptured. About 112,000 people were screened; 249 showed internal or external contamination, 129 of whom required moderate to severe medical care. Four people ultimately died. (National and international statistics)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If you ever encounter such a source, move away, note its location, do not touch it, and call 110. Reporting is mandatory to environmental, police, and health authorities. Distance and time are the only effective safeguards; plastic bags or pockets offer no protection. Devices such as X-ray machines or CT scanners emit radiation only when powered; once turned off, they pose no residual risk. The real danger lies in the sealed radioactive source inside them. Radiotherapy machines, pipeline and boiler inspection devices, well-logging tools, and level gauges all contain such sources, which look identical to ordinary metal parts. Therefore, never try to identify a source — simply avoid picking up, selling, or taking home any unidentified equipment parts. Workers in scrap recycling, dismantling, hardware, and construction face higher risks; they should steer clear of any area marked with the clover warning symbol. Nuclear plant leaks represent a different type of incident, with an even lower probability of affecting the general public. The primary beneficiaries of these precautions are you and anyone else present at the scene.

## 37. When gambling leads to borrowing money and persistent low mood, call 12356 first and then hand over your bank cards and payment passwords to family members

**Cost**. No cost involved. Simply make one phone call and give your bank cards, payment passwords, and gambling apps to a family member. The hardest part is admitting that you've lost control over your gambling behavior.

**In plain terms**. Individuals who have sought treatment for gambling problems are 15 times more likely to die by suicide and 1.8 times more likely to die overall compared to their peers. Depression serves as a key warning sign for potential suicide. Therefore, if you find yourself gambling despite owing money and feeling persistently down, call 12356 right away.

**Benefit**. A nationwide Swedish registry study examined 2,099 individuals diagnosed with gambling disorder between 2005 and 2016. Gambling disorder is defined as an inability to control gambling habits, which negatively impacts daily life. Compared to the general Swedish population aged 20–74, these individuals

showed a 1.8-fold increase in overall mortality and a 15-fold increase in suicide mortality (these figures represent standardized mortality ratios). Over the follow-up period, 67 participants died, including 21 from suicide. Depression proved to be a reliable predictor of suicide risk. In a 2023 correction, researchers reported that the suicide risk was 12.1 times higher for men and 16.1 times higher for women. Starting May 1, 2025, China launched a nationwide mental health hotline at 12356, available at least 18 hours per day.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because only one study exists, and it includes only individuals who sought specialist care — a group with relatively severe conditions. Consequently, the 15-fold suicide risk increase cannot be generalized to all gamblers. Handing over financial control to family members is a widely practiced approach, though lacking direct research support; thus it receives a C grade. Legal boundaries regarding gambling are outlined in Section 9, Article 13 (prohibiting bookmaking and online gambling). Whether family members should repay gambling debts incurred by a spouse is discussed in Section 8, Article 44 (such debts do not qualify as joint marital obligations). For guidance on responding to suicidal thoughts, refer to Section 37, Article 32 (inform a trusted person immediately). The primary beneficiaries are the gamblers themselves; however, family members who notice warning signs can also encourage them to follow these steps.

## 38. Men who have sex with men at high risk of HIV infection can significantly lower their infection risk by taking pre-exposure prophylaxis from designated HIV clinics on schedule

**Cost**. This is a prescription medication, so in most places it must be paid for out of pocket. Prices range from several hundred to several thousand yuan. Before prescribing it, doctors must test for HIV, kidney function, and hepatitis B. Follow-up tests are required every three months. The main challenge is remembering to take the pills every day without fail.

**In plain terms**. People who aren't yet infected can take an antiviral drug called pre-exposure prophylaxis to protect themselves. Those who take it consistently cut their risk of infection by more than 70%. On the other hand, people who take it intermittently see almost no benefit. Because it's a prescription drug, a medical checkup is mandatory before obtaining it, and regular follow-ups are necessary thereafter.

**Benefit**. This medication is a fixed-dose combination of emtricitabine and tenofovir. In the iPrEx trial, 2,499 men who have sex with men and transgender women were assigned to either take this drug daily or receive a placebo. The group taking the medication saw a 44% reduction in infections (95% CI 15–63). Among participants whose blood tests confirmed they were taking the drug, the protective effect was even stronger. The UK's PROUD trial involved 544 men who have sex with men; those who started treatment immediately had an 86% lower infection rate compared to those who delayed treatment for a year (90% CI 64–96). France's IPERGAY trial evaluated on-demand dosing before and after sex; results showed an 86% drop in infections (95% CI 40–98). A meta-analysis compiled by WHO concluded that overall, the relative risk of infection dropped to 0.49 (0.33–0.73, roughly a 51% reduction). In trials where adherence exceeded 70%, the relative risk fell to 0.30 (0.21–0.45, about a 70% reduction); when adherence stayed below 40%, the relative risk was 0.95, essentially indicating no effect. In August 2020, China's National Medical Products Administration approved this drug for pre-exposure prophylaxis use in adults and adolescents weighing at least 35 kg (both domestically and internationally).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The participants in these trials were primarily men who have sex with men; therefore, they are the group most encouraged to seek this treatment. Others at high risk of infection can also consult doctors to determine suitability. Prior to prescribing, it is essential to confirm that patients are not already infected; taking the medication while infected can foster viral resistance. Self-test results cannot be used as a basis for prescription. For individuals with hepatitis B, discontinuing treatment may trigger a flare-up, so testing is mandatory beforehand. WHO currently recommends on-demand dosing only for men who have sex with men engaging in sex fewer than twice a week; the regimen involves taking two tablets 2–24 hours prior to sex, followed by one tablet 24 and 48 hours afterward. Women and hepatitis B carriers must adhere to daily

dosing. Trials involving on-demand dosing reported more gastrointestinal and kidney-related side effects than placebo groups; hence, regular medical checkups are indispensable. Since 2019, China has been piloting this program among men who have sex with men; official plans for 2024 emphasize “standardized implementation.” No nationwide free distribution program has been confirmed. Prospective patients should call local disease control centers to identify designated HIV clinics or STD/AIDS outpatient departments offering this treatment. Importantly, this medication does not protect against sexually transmitted infections such as syphilis or gonorrhea; condoms must still be used consistently, as noted in Section 30 of this chapter. In cases where exposure has already occurred, emergency post-exposure prophylaxis is available per Section 13, Item 38 (within 72 hours). Ultimately, this treatment safeguards both the individual and their sexual partners.

## 39. Women aged 65 and older should have a dual-energy X-ray absorptiometry (DXA) bone density test; postmenopausal women with osteoporosis risk factors need not wait until 65

**Cost**. A hospital DXA scan of the lumbar spine and hip takes a few minutes lying down. Out-of-pocket cost is usually 100–200 yuan, varying by region. Heel ultrasound at a checkup can screen but cannot diagnose.

**In plain terms**. Women aged 65 and older, and postmenopausal women with osteoporosis risk factors, should have bone density measured once. When screening starts with fracture-risk assessment and treats those at high risk, hip fractures fall by about 17%. That works out to about 5 fewer hip fractures per 1,000 people screened. Overall mortality did not change.

**Benefit**. The U.S. Preventive Services Task Force 2025 recommendation is osteoporosis screening for women aged 65 and older (Grade B). Postmenopausal women under 65 at high fracture risk by assessment should also be screened (Grade B). Evidence for men is insufficient; no recommendation. The evidence review for that guidance pooled 3 randomized trials with 42,009 older European women. Screening meant assessing fracture risk first, measuring bone density in those at high risk, and treating those found high risk. Hip fractures in the screening group were about 17% lower (RR 0.83, 95% CI 0.73 to 0.93). In absolute terms, screening avoided 5 hip fractures per 1,000 people. In the UK SCOOP trial of 12,483 women aged 70 to 85, hip fractures in the screening group were about 28% lower (HR 0.72, 95% CI 0.59 to 0.89); mortality did not differ. The Chinese Medical Association 2017 guideline recommends DXA for women aged 65 and older and men aged 70 and older, and earlier when osteoporosis risk factors are present. In a 2017–2018 national survey, osteoporosis prevalence among adults over 40 was 20.6% in women and 5.0% in men (China).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy: SCOOP's prespecified primary outcome was all osteoporotic fractures; the screening group did not show a clear reduction (HR 0.94, 95% CI 0.85 to 1.03)—only hip fractures fell. All three trials used "assess risk, then measure bone density"; none compared bone density testing alone. The evidence review also estimated 11.8% to 24.1% overdiagnosis—people who would never have fractured from this cause in their lifetime. For men, the U.S. says evidence is insufficient; China's guideline sets age 70—follow your doctor. This item is about whether bone can survive a fall; avoiding falls themselves is item 13 (balance and leg strength)—do both. After osteoporosis is found, see item 40 (treat with medication). Primary beneficiaries are you and your parents.

## 40. If you are diagnosed with osteoporosis, or have fractured from a minor fall, ask a doctor for osteoporosis medication and keep taking it—do not treat calcium supplements as a substitute

**Cost**. Prescription required; use continues for years. Common options include once-weekly oral drugs and once-yearly infusions. Bone density should be rechecked yearly at first, then every 1 to 2 years once stable. The hard part is continuing when you feel fine.

**In plain terms**. If osteoporosis is confirmed, or you have already fractured from a light fall, following a doctor's drug plan cuts hip fractures by about half and symptomatic spine fractures by a bit more than half. In older people who start yearly infusion within 90 days after hip-fracture surgery, new fractures over two years fall by about 35%. Calcium alone cannot replace these drugs.

**Benefit**. Fragility fracture means a fracture from minor trauma or everyday activity. The Chinese Medical Association 2017 guideline lists three groups for treatment: prior fragility fracture of spine or hip; bone density T-score −2.5 or lower regardless of prior fracture; or low bone mass plus fragility fracture of wrist, upper arm, or pelvis, or high calculated fracture risk. The guideline states: "There is currently insufficient evidence that calcium supplementation alone can replace other anti-osteoporosis drug therapy." Cochrane's 2025 update on alendronate in postmenopausal women with osteoporosis or prior fracture found hip fractures about 51% lower in the treated group (RR 0.49, 95% CI 0.25 to 0.96) and symptomatic vertebral fractures about 55% lower (RR 0.45, 95% CI 0.28 to 0.73). The HORIZON trial enrolled 2,127 people mean age 74.5 after hip-fracture surgery; yearly zoledronic acid starting within 90 days post-op, median follow-up 1.9 years. New fractures fell from 13.9% to 8.6% (about 35% relative reduction). Death fell from 13.3% to 9.6% (about 28% relative reduction). The guideline notes about 20% of people die from complications within one year after hip fracture. In the 2017–2018 national survey, only 1.4% of women and 0.3% of men with diagnosed osteoporosis or prior fracture were on medication (China).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy: A meta-analysis of 38 trials did not show these drugs lowering overall mortality (RR 0.98, 95% CI 0.91 to 1.05). Zoledronic acid alone was also not significant (RR 0.88, 95% CI 0.68 to 1.13). The authors concluded these drugs should be used to prevent fractures, not to cut death rates. Cochrane rated those fracture estimates low to moderate certainty. In women without prior fracture and lower risk, alendronate did not clearly reduce hip fractures (RR 0.76, 95% CI 0.43 to 1.32). Rare harms such as jaw osteonecrosis and atypical femur fracture may not show up in trials of a few years—keep follow-up visits and do not change dose on your own. Injection versus pills depends on the doctor. How to find osteoporosis is item 39 (bone density testing). Menopausal hormone therapy can also reduce fractures, but it is generally considered only when other drugs are unsuitable. For hormone use for hot flashes and night sweats, see Section 2, item 43 (assessing hormone therapy for hot flashes around menopause). Primary beneficiaries are you and your parents.

## 41. Drill holes to measure ice thickness before stepping onto it; don't go out if it's under 15 cm thick. Avoid ice over rivers and near ice-fishing holes

**Cost**. The easiest and cheapest option is to visit a properly managed public ice rink. If you must venture onto natural ice, bring an ice auger or ice chisel to measure thickness, plus a pair of rescue ice spikes — essentially two pointed spikes with handles that you can attach to your chest. Altogether, these items cost anywhere from a few dozen to a couple hundred yuan. You'll need to measure the ice at regular intervals, which takes extra time.

**In plain terms**. Official Chinese guidelines state that ice must be at least 15 cm thick before adults can safely skate on it. In the U.S. and Canada, the minimum threshold is 10 cm, but only for newly formed, transparent ice. White ice is only half as strong, so its thickness must be doubled to be considered safe. Even on the same body of water, ice can be 12 cm thick in one spot and just 2–3 cm a few steps away; therefore, you must measure it as you go.

**Benefit**. According to the China Meteorological Administration, ice must reach 15 cm thickness before adults can skate on it, and outdoor rinks must also meet this standard to open. The Beijing Municipal Water Authority adds that natural ice rinks must have 15 cm of ice, plus stable temperatures between −8°C and 1°C without strong winds for at least a week before they become safe. Natural ice often contains holes drilled by anglers, which rarely freeze shut again. Minnesota's Department of Natural Resources specifies that only transparent, newly formed ice under 4 inches (≈10 cm) thick is safe for walking or ice fishing; white ice formed after snow melts is only half as strong, so its thickness must be doubled. Ice thickness can vary

dramatically across a single water body — sometimes 12 cm in one area and just 2–3 cm a few feet away. Ice over flowing water is especially hazardous, particularly near streams, bridges, and culverts; shore ice is often thinner than ice farther out. The U.S. National Weather Service sets the same minimum threshold of 4 inches for walking, ice fishing, and skating. The Canadian Centre for Occupational Health and Safety cites the Canadian Red Cross: groups of skaters or walkers need at least 15 cm of ice, while larger gatherings require 20 cm. These are safety guidelines only; no studies have quantified how many lives they actually save (nationwide, in the U.S. and Canada).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. All official guidelines agree that no ice is 100% safe; reaching the minimum thickness is merely a baseline, not a guarantee. Early winter and late spring pose the greatest risks. If you fall through the ice, don't remove your clothes — trapped air in thick layers can help you stay afloat. Turn back toward the direction you came from; ice there is usually the sturdiest. Place your arms on the surface, drive the ice spikes in, and kick your legs to pull yourself up. Once out, don't stand up; roll flat away from the hole and seek warmth immediately — severe hypothermia requires medical care. If you see someone else fall in, do not rush to pull them out; follow the advice in Section 13, Item 25 (responding to drowning without entering the water): call for help, dial 110, then throw a pole or rope. The primary beneficiaries of these precautions are yourself and any children you bring ice skating.

## 42. Always attach the guard, wear goggles and a face shield, then grip the grinder firmly with both hands — never use a wood-cutting blade on it

**Cost**. A pair of goggles plus a face shield costs only a few dozen yuan. Each time you start the machine you should briefly check the guard and blade; before changing the blade, unplug the grinder — this adds just a minute or two to your routine. The real challenge is resisting the urge to skip these steps when you're in a hurry or to work with one hand.

**In plain terms**. Angle grinders spin at extremely high speeds; a broken blade can fly off and injure someone, and attaching a wood-cutting blade can cause sudden recoil. In China, two separate incidents involved workers who used wood-cutting blades without any guard — one suffered a severed femoral artery and the other a cut carotid artery, both resulting in death. Installing a guard, wearing goggles and a face shield, and holding the tool with both hands costs very little yet can prevent such tragedies.

**Benefit**. The Canadian Centre for Occupational Health and Safety and Queensland's safety authority recommend the following practices: inspect the guard and blade before each use, discarding any blade showing cracks, chips, or deformation; ensure the blade's maximum rated speed meets or exceeds the grinder's speed rating; match the blade's diameter and central hole to the machine; disconnect power before blade changes; secure the workpiece firmly; wear protective goggles under a face shield; grip both handles with both hands while keeping a stable stance; never use a cutting blade for grinding as this makes it more prone to breakage; wait until the blade has fully stopped before setting the grinder down; direct sparks and debris away from people and flammable materials. Queensland's guidelines also note that a cutting blade's edge should ideally travel at roughly 70 m/s. Installing a 356 mm blade on a 230 mm grinder can push that speed to 120 m/s, greatly increasing breakage risk. In February 2016, a worker in Canada died from internal injuries after being struck by debris from such a setup. Two Chinese accident reports describe similar tragedies: in 2019 a Harbin worker replaced the blade with a toothed one and cut wood without a guard, causing his femoral artery to be severed; in 2024 a Shenzhen worker used a grinder fitted with a wood-cutting blade, no guard, and no auxiliary handles, leading to a fatal carotid artery cut when the tool recoiled. National standards explicitly warn against attaching saw chains, carving blades, or toothed blades to grinders. South Korea's emergency-injury surveillance from 2011-2018 recorded 8,697 injuries from high-speed rotating tools, 4,603 of them involving grinders; 46.4 % affected hands and 23.0 % heads; compared with other similar tools, grinders carry roughly twice the risk of severe injury (OR 2.07, 95 % CI 1.88–2.29). A hospital in Mianyang, Sichuan, treated 36 patients with eye injuries from grinders over two years; ten still had best-corrected visual acuity below 0.05 even after surgery. In Turkey, 82 of 742 acute hand-forearm injuries treated in one year were caused by grinders; 44 % of those victims were retirees, not workers. A

Japanese trauma centre reported that nine of fifteen grinders-related injuries from 2017-2018 involved misuse such as attaching wood-cutting blades; two patients lost entire fingers and one lost part of a finger.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because the recommendations stem from safety-authority guidelines and accident investigations rather than quantitative studies showing exactly how many injuries they prevent. The injury-severity data merely illustrate how serious the outcomes can be, and they come from single hospitals or countries. The benefit level is judged “moderate” because, while the consequences can be death, blindness, or finger loss, they apply only to people who operate grinders. The Harbin worker's manual already warned against using toothed blades and required a guard; a hand saw would have been the proper tool for cutting wood. Loose clothing, dangling jewellery, and long hair must be secured to avoid being drawn into the machine. Grinding generates considerable dust and noise; proper respirators and ear protection are discussed in Section 19, Item 10. In case of a major vascular bleed, apply firm direct pressure as described in Section 13, Item 12. Ultimately, following these steps protects you and anyone nearby who might be helping.

## 43. Ask someone close to you who seems off, directly: “Have you thought about suicide?” Asking does not make the thoughts stronger

**Cost**. Free. One sentence, then some time to listen. The hard part is getting the words out: many people fear that asking will put the idea into someone's head.

**In plain terms**. The worry that mentioning suicide plants the thought has not shown up in research. When suicide questions were added to a questionnaire for high-school students, those asked did not feel worse, and no more of them reported thinking about suicide. Students who were already depressed felt less distressed after being asked, and students who had attempted suicide before were less likely to report suicidal thoughts.

**Benefit**. In New York State, 2,342 students in 6 high schools were randomly assigned by class to two groups. One group's questionnaire included suicide questions; the other group's did not. Distress did not differ between the groups right after completion or 2 days later (P = 0.66 and P = 0.41; a P above 0.05 means no detectable difference). Among those who reported suicidal thoughts at 2 days, 4.7% were in the asked group and 3.9% in the not-asked group, with no detectable difference (P = 0.49). Students with depressive symptoms were less distressed after being asked (P = 0.01). Students with a previous suicide attempt were less likely to have suicidal thoughts after being asked (P = 0.02). A 2022 meta-analysis assessed 17 studies and pooled 8 comparisons of “asked” versus “not asked”. After being asked, neither immediately nor later were suicidal thoughts and behaviors, non-suicidal self-harm, or psychological distress significantly increased. The strongest evidence is 8 randomized controlled trials, with low or unclear risk of bias. A 2014 literature review also states that no study found a significant increase in suicidal thoughts after asking

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because these studies only show that asking does no harm; none calculated how many suicide deaths asking prevents. The benefit is rated small for the same reason: there is no mortality figure, only the substitute endpoint “thoughts did not increase”. The studies mostly asked through questionnaires and research interviews, not family or friends asking face to face, so carrying the result over to face-to-face asking is an inference. If it turns out they have thought about it, do not walk away: stay with them, call 12356 together, and move medicines and pesticides out of reach; see item 25 in this section (call 12356 when having suicidal thoughts). If they say they will take others with them, or have already prepared the means, close relatives may take them straight to a hospital, or call 110; see item 15 in Section 8 (close relatives may take someone directly for medical care). From the thought appearing to acting often takes only a few dozen minutes; see item 32 in this section (tell one person nearby as soon as suicidal thoughts arise). The beneficiaries are mainly spouse and direct relatives; asking friends and colleagues works the same way.

# 2. Avoid a slow death

This section covers just two types of long-term health risks: those with a major impact on overall mortality and those backed by solid evidence. The items are listed in order of cost-effectiveness. A few entries are marked “randomized trials,” meaning participants were randomly assigned to different groups for comparison — this is the most reliable type of evidence. All other figures come from observational studies that only track people over time without any grouping. These studies produce risk ratios such as HR and RR, but they also contain two kinds of confounding factors: participants naturally differ from one another, and some already had health problems before the study began. Therefore these numbers only indicate general trends and approximate magnitudes; they do not guarantee that following these steps will bring about exactly those reductions.

The items in this section are grouped by topic, with item numbers shown in parentheses.

**Smoking, alcohol, and betel nut**: The earlier you quit smoking, the better (Item 1); avoid smoking at home or in the car (Item 2); get medication to help you quit (Item 3); pick a specific quit date (Item 4); visit a smoking cessation clinic or call 12320 (Item 5); if quitting proves difficult, consider e-cigarettes as a last resort (Item 6); never chew betel nut (Item 8); limit or completely avoid alcohol (Item 19); if stopping abruptly causes tremors, do not force yourself to quit cold turkey (Item 20); keep track of how much you drink each week (Item 21).

**Foods to cut back on**: Skip sugary drinks altogether (Item 7); reduce consumption of processed meats (Item 18); limit ultra-processed foods as much as possible (Item 28); avoid drinking tea or soup that is piping hot (Item 30).

**Healthier swaps and additions**: Switch to low-sodium salt (Item 9); enjoy a small handful of nuts every day (Item 22); replace red meat with fish and poultry (Item 23); choose whole grains instead of refined rice and flour (Item 24); sip tea at least three times a week (Item 25); drink three to four cups of coffee daily (Item 26); eat five servings of fruits and vegetables each day (Item 27); include chili peppers in your diet more than four times a week (Item 33); have a serving of dairy each day (Item 34); there is no need to avoid eggs (Item 35).

**Exercise and weight**: Aim for 7,000–8,000 steps each day (Item 11); play racket sports regularly (Item 14); fit in short bursts of physical effort whenever possible (Item 15); add strength training to your weekly routine (Item 16); avoid sitting for long stretches without a break (Item 17); keep your BMI between 20 and 25 (Item 32); count your daily dog walks toward your step total (Item 44).

**Sleep and night shifts**: Get roughly seven hours of sleep each night (Item 13); limit naps to half an hour or less (Item 37); catch up on sleep the day after a late night (Item 38); if you work night shifts, try to switch to a day schedule as soon as you can (Item 39).

**Cooking oils and smoke**: Refrain from burning coal or firewood for cooking or heating (Item 29); do not buy bulk, homemade peanut oil (Item 40); use plant oils instead of lard or butter (Item 41); always run a range hood while stir-frying (Item 42).

**Dental care, medication, and other habits**: Brush and floss your teeth thoroughly each day (Item 10); take prescribed medications exactly as directed (Item 12); spend some time outdoors in daylight (Item 31); take a bath whenever you have the chance (Item 36); if hot flashes and night sweats around menopause disrupt your life, ask a gynecologist to assess hormone therapy (Item 43).

## 1. Quitting smoking, the earlier the better

**Cost**. It costs nothing — in fact, it saves money. A pack-a-day habit costs roughly $3–$4, which you'll no longer spend after quitting. The hard part is getting through the withdrawal period, which usually lasts a few weeks to several months.

**In plain terms**. On average, smokers live more than 10 years less than non-smokers. Quitting before age 40 eliminates roughly 90% of the extra death risk caused by continued smoking. The earlier you quit, the more

years you gain. If you keep smoking after a fracture, the chance that the bone fails to heal is about 2.3 times that of a non-smoker, so don't smoke until the bone has healed.

**Benefit**. One U.S. study that tracked participants without assigning them to groups found that current smokers have a life expectancy more than 10 years shorter than those who never smoked. Quitting before age 40 removes about 90% of this excess mortality risk. Quitting between ages 25–34 adds roughly 10 years to life expectancy; between 35–44, about 9 years; and between 45–54, about 6 years (as reported in the original source). Similar Chinese research from the 2010s shows that urban male smokers have a 1.65 times higher death risk than non-smokers (RR 1.65), while rural male smokers have a 1.22 times higher risk. After 10 years of sustained abstinence, this smoking-related risk nearly disappears. The same holds after a fracture. Pooling 19 observational studies that only tracked people without assigning groups, smokers' odds of non-union (the bone failing to knit) were about 2.3 times those of non-smokers (OR 2.32, 95% CI 1.76–3.06, adjusted for other factors). The excess was also seen in fractures of the tibia (shin bone) and in open fractures. In a Swedish randomized trial, 50 people who joined a 6-week smoking cessation program after emergency fracture surgery had at least one postoperative complication in 20% of cases, versus 38% among the 55 who did not join. For scheduled surgery, you can start quitting 4 to 8 weeks before the operation, with weekly coaching and nicotine replacement. That lowers postoperative complications by about 58% (RR 0.42, 95% CI 0.27–0.65, 2 trials, 210 people).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Secondhand smoke is deadly too: in 2004, an estimated 603,000 people worldwide died from exposure to it, accounting for roughly 1% of all global deaths that year. Even if you don't smoke yourself, you must avoid secondhand smoke, especially to protect children. Specific quitting strategies are outlined in the following sections: Section 3 (smoking cessation medications), Section 4 (setting a quit date), Section 5 (visiting a smoking cessation clinic), and Section 6 (e-cigarettes). The non-union figure comes from observational studies that did not assign groups; smokers may differ from non-smokers in other ways, and these cannot all be removed. The post-fracture quitting trial had only 105 participants, and with a different method of calculation the difference is not significant.

## 2. Don't smoke at home or in the car, and don't let guests smoke indoors

**Cost**. There is no monetary cost and it takes little time. The challenge is simply having the conversation with family members and guests to keep them from smoking indoors.

**In plain terms**. Around 600,000 people worldwide die each year from secondhand smoke exposure; nearly 30% of those are children. Long-term exposure to secondhand smoke raises the risk of hypertension, heart disease, and stroke by roughly 30% compared to non-exposed individuals. Smoke inhaled at home is even more harmful than smoke encountered outside.

**Benefit**. In 2004, secondhand smoke caused 603,000 deaths globally — about 1.0% of all deaths worldwide, with children accounting for 28% of those fatalities. Pooled data from 57 studies show that people exposed to secondhand smoke have a 1.28-fold higher chance of developing hypertension, a 1.39-fold higher risk of heart disease, a 1.50-fold higher risk of myocardial infarction, and a 1.36-fold higher risk of stroke compared to non-exposed individuals. The risk is greater when exposure occurs at home rather than outside.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Focus on home environments first, since people spend more time there and pooled research indicates that indoor secondhand smoke is more harmful than outdoor exposure. Children bear 61% of the overall health burden caused by secondhand smoke. For personal smoking cessation, see item 1 in this section.

## 3. Don't rely solely on willpower to quit smoking — get medication first: success rates more than double

**Cost**. Nicotine patches and gum are over-the-counter products available at any pharmacy. A full course lasts 8–12 weeks and costs anywhere from a few hundred to over a thousand yuan. Varenicline and bupropion, on the other hand, are prescription-only drugs; you'll need a prescription from a smoking cessation clinic or a

pulmonology department. These costs are roughly offset by the money saved from buying fewer cigarettes during the same period.

**In plain terms**. Relying on sheer willpower alone rarely works for most smokers. People taking varenicline are more than twice as likely to succeed compared to those taking a placebo. Those using nicotine replacement products also have a 50% higher success rate than non-medication users. Combining patches with gum or lozenges further boosts success rates by roughly 20%.

**Benefit**. A pooled analysis of 41 randomized trials involving 17,395 participants shows that varenicline increases smoking cessation rates by 2.32 times compared to placebo (RR 2.32, 95% CI 2.15–2.51; high-certainty evidence). Varenicline also outperforms bupropion (RR 1.36, a 36% relative increase) and single-form nicotine replacement therapy (RR 1.25, a 25% relative increase). Across 133 trials with 64,640 participants, nicotine replacement products raise success rates by about 55% versus no medication at all (RR 1.55, 95% CI 1.49–1.61). Using both a patch and a fast-acting form such as gum or lozenges yields a 27% relative improvement over patch-only use (RR 1.27, 95% CI 1.17–1.37; high-certainty evidence from 16 trials with 12,169 participants).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. In China, these three types of medications are currently available for smoking cessation; only nicotine replacement products are sold over the counter. Common side effects of varenicline include nausea, vivid dreams, and sleep disturbances; anyone with a psychiatric history should discuss this with their doctor. A typical course of nicotine replacement therapy lasts 8–12 weeks — do not abruptly stop use but taper off gradually under medical guidance. While these medications ease withdrawal symptoms during the first few weeks, they do not eliminate cravings triggered by specific situations, so they should be used alongside the other strategies outlined in this chapter: setting a quit date (Section 4) and seeking professional help at a smoking cessation clinic (Section 5).

## 4. Pick a quit date and stop smoking on that day — don't taper gradually

**Cost**. No cost at all. Just choose a date on the calendar and let family and coworkers know in advance.

**In plain terms**. Many people try to cut back a little each day until they reach zero. Yet after six months, only 15.5% of those who gradually reduced their intake stayed smoke-free, compared with 22% of people who set a quit date and stopped all at once. So it's better to pick a date and quit completely on that day.

**Benefit**. In the UK, 697 smokers were randomly assigned to two groups. One group quit on a predetermined date; the other cut their cigarette use by 75% during the two weeks before that date. Both groups received nursing support and used nicotine replacement therapy around the quit date. At four weeks, 49.0% (95% CI 43.8–54.2) of the “quit-on-date” group remained smoke-free, versus 39.2% (34.0–44.4) of the “taper-first” group; the relative risk was 0.80 (0.66–0.93). By six months, 22.0% (18.0–26.6) of the quit-on-date group stayed quit, compared with 15.5% (12.0–19.7) of the taper-first group; the relative risk was 0.71 (0.46–0.91). Even among people who preferred tapering, the quit-on-date approach yielded higher success rates at four weeks (52.2% vs. 38.3%).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This is a somewhat controversial topic. Cochrane previously published a review comparing these two methods; it concluded they performed similarly (RR 0.94, 95% CI 0.79–1.13, based on 10 trials with 3,760 participants). However, that review was withdrawn in 2019 and is no longer updated. The best current evidence comes from the trial described above, which favors quitting on a set date. Both groups in that trial also used nicotine replacement therapy before the quit date, an approach itself backed by evidence: early use raises success rates by roughly 25% (RR 1.25, 95% CI 1.08–1.44, based on 9 trials with 4,395 participants; moderate-certainty evidence). Therefore, the recommended strategy is to pick a quit date, start nicotine replacement therapy two weeks beforehand, and then quit all at once on that day.

## 5. Visit a smoking cessation clinic or call 12320 to find local services

**Cost**. A single clinic visit costs only a few to dozens of yuan. Behavioral support typically involves 4–8 sessions lasting 30–60 minutes each, totaling under 5 hours. Calling the helpline is completely free.

**In plain terms**. Medications and regular follow-up support from professionals are two distinct components that work best together. People who take medication while receiving dedicated follow-up have nearly twice the quit rate of those who only receive brief advice. Phone support also helps: those who proactively call the smoking cessation helpline see their success rate rise by 20–30% compared to others.

**Benefit**. Across 52 trials involving 19,488 participants, the combination of medication and behavioral support led to a 1.83-fold higher quit rate than standard care or brief advice (RR 1.83, 95% CI 1.68–1.98; high-quality evidence). For the 43 trials conducted in medical settings, this advantage rose to 1.97-fold (95% CI 1.79–2.18). When looking at phone-based support alone: among people who called the helpline themselves, those receiving multiple follow-up calls had a 38% higher quit rate than those who only got informational materials or a single consultation (RR 1.38, 95% CI 1.19–1.61; 14 trials, 32,484 participants). For people who did not call the helpline but received scheduled phone support from researchers, the success rate was 25% higher than those without such support (RR 1.25, 95% CI 1.15–1.35; 65 trials, 41,233 participants). Both findings are supported by evidence of moderate certainty.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. How to find local services in China: Search “China Smoking Cessation Platform” on WeChat to access a list of local smoking cessation clinics and helplines, or call 12320 to ask about nearby options. Most of the above trials were conducted overseas, and the intensity of services at local clinics varies widely; these figures should be viewed as general guidelines only. The recommended medications are listed in Section 3 of this chapter (“Smoking cessation medications”).

## 6. Only consider e-cigarettes if you've already tried quitting; non-smokers should avoid them

**Cost**. The device plus cartridges cost anywhere from a few dozen to several hundred yuan per month. In China, only tobacco-flavored e-cigarettes are legally sold, and only at stores holding a tobacco retail license.

**In plain terms**. Switching to nicotine-containing e-cigarettes helps roughly 60% more people quit smoking than nicotine patches — this finding is quite reliable. However, e-cigarettes are not harmless; long-term safety data remain limited. For people who have never smoked, there is absolutely no benefit to using them.

**Benefit**. This up-to-date review includes 80 randomized trials involving 29,861 participants. Compared with nicotine replacement therapy, e-cigarettes raise the quit rate by about 61% (RR 1.61, 95% CI 1.23–2.12; high-certainty evidence based on 11 trials with 4,114 participants). In absolute terms, that translates to roughly 4 extra quitters per 100 users (range: 1–7). The rate of serious adverse events is similar between groups (risk difference 0.01, 95% CI −0.01–0.02; moderate-certainty evidence). Compared with behavioral support alone or no support at all, e-cigarettes improve quit rates by about 75% (RR 1.75, 95% CI 1.39–2.20; low-certainty evidence).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This topic is controversial. WHO does not recommend e-cigarettes as a smoking-cessation tool, citing insufficient long-term safety data and concerns that they may attract youth to nicotine. The UK, however, includes them in its quit-smoking services. In China, e-cigarette sales are not completely banned but are tightly regulated under the “Administrative Measures for E-Cigarettes.” Only tobacco-flavored products may be sold, and only at physical stores holding a tobacco retail license; fruit-flavored e-cigarettes and refillable devices are prohibited. Sales through any website, online shop, or social-media platform other than the state-run e-cigarette trading platform are illegal, and sales to minors are forbidden. Consequently, fruit-flavored e-cigarettes that are still available are sold through illicit channels outside regulatory oversight. This is also how synthetic-cannabinoid-laced “high-effect” e-cigarettes enter the market; see Section 22, Item 4 (“Do not accept unknown cartridges”). The review examined only legally regulated

nicotine-containing products; unverified e-liquid mixtures were not included. As a first step, it is advisable to try the medication described in Item 3 of this section, which offers stronger evidence and lower cost.

## 7. Not drinking sugary drinks — even switching to sugar-free ones doesn't help

**Cost**. There's no cost involved, nor does it take any extra time. Switching to plain water or sugar-free tea can even save money. The real challenge is breaking the habit of drinking sweet beverages, including sugar-free ones.

**In plain terms**. People who drink more than two sugary drinks per day have about a 20% higher chance of dying during the same period compared to those who rarely drink them. Those who consume one to two per day still face a roughly 10% higher risk. Switching to sugar-free versions brings no benefit: individuals drinking two or more sugar-free drinks daily actually have a 25% higher risk of death.

**Benefit**. Two large U.S. studies followed large groups of people without any subgroup categorization; together they included around 118,000 participants and documented 36,000 deaths. Those drinking two or more sugary drinks daily had a 21% higher risk of death compared to those consuming less than one per month (HR 1.21). For those drinking one to two per day, the risk rose by about 14% (HR 1.14). The European EPIC study followed 450,000 people across 10 countries under similar conditions; again no subgroups were defined. Compared to those drinking less than one sugary drink per month, daily consumers of two or more sugary drinks faced an 8% higher risk (HR 1.08, 95% CI 1.01–1.16). Those drinking two or more sugar-free drinks daily had a 26% higher risk (HR 1.26, 95% CI 1.16–1.35). When all types of soft drinks were considered together, the risk increase was about 17% (HR 1.17, 95% CI 1.11–1.22).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. There is ongoing debate regarding sugar-free drinks. The association between sugar-free drinks and health outcomes appears even stronger than that of sugary drinks, which likely reflects reverse causality: individuals who are already overweight or have diabetes tend to switch to sugar-free versions. Therefore, we cannot claim sugar-free drinks are more harmful based on this alone. Nevertheless, this evidence clearly shows that the idea “switching to sugar-free drinks solves the problem” lacks any factual support. The safest choice remains plain water or sugar-free tea. Additionally, these studies rely solely on observational tracking rather than controlled trials; people who consume more sugary drinks often lead less healthy lifestyles overall, which may contribute to the observed higher risk figures.

## 8. Not chewing betel nut

**Cost**. It costs nothing, takes no time, and saves money that would otherwise be spent on betel nut. The hard part is breaking the habit of chewing it.

**In plain terms**. People who chew betel nut have roughly a 20% higher chance of dying during the same period compared to non-chewers. Their risk of developing diabetes and metabolic syndrome is nearly 50% higher. Additional risks for oral and esophageal cancer also apply.

**Benefit**. Data from 17 Asian studies involving 388,000 participants show that chewing betel nut raises overall mortality risk by about 21% relative to non-chewers (relative risk 1.21, P=0.02). This effect applies to 179,600 of those participants. The risk of diabetes rises by roughly 47% (1.47), while metabolic syndrome risk increases by about 51% (1.51). Betel nut itself is also a known risk factor for oral and esophageal cancer.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The longer and more frequently one chews betel nut, the greater the risk of oral cancer becomes. After quitting, this risk gradually declines over time. Betel nut mixed with tobacco poses an even greater danger.

## 9. Switch household salt to low-sodium (potassium-rich) salt

**Cost**. One bag costs a few yuan more than regular salt. It's easy to switch when you shop, adding virtually no extra time. The taste stays almost the same.

**In plain terms**. For people who have had a stroke or are over 60 with hypertension, switching to low-sodium salt can lower their chance of dying within five years by about 12% and the risk of another stroke by roughly 14%.

**Benefit**. A randomized trial conducted in rural China enrolled 20,995 participants — all stroke survivors or adults aged 60+ with hypertension — and followed them for 4.74 years. Those using low-sodium salt had a 12% lower risk of death (RR 0.88), a 14% lower risk of stroke (RR 0.86), and a 13% lower risk of major cardiovascular events (RR 0.87) compared with the regular-salt group. No statistically significant difference emerged between the groups regarding episodes of excessively high blood potassium levels.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This finding is somewhat controversial. The PURE study only recorded long-term outcomes without random assignment; it reported that individuals excreting less than 3 g of sodium per day faced a roughly 27% higher risk of death or cardiovascular events, while those excreting more than 7 g per day faced a 15% higher risk. According to PURE, both very low and very high sodium intake are detrimental, with moderate intake being optimal. However, the Chinese rural trial only partially replaced regular salt with low-sodium salt, so sodium levels did not drop to the extremes examined in PURE. Moreover, the trial involved only high-risk elderly participants; younger, healthier individuals would likely gain far less benefit. People with impaired kidney function or those taking potassium-sparing medications should consult a physician before making this switch.

## 10. Brush teeth thoroughly and floss daily; replace missing teeth promptly

**Cost**. Dental floss or interdental brushes cost just a few dozen yuan per year, while professional cleanings run about 100–200 yuan each. It takes only two to three extra minutes per day. The real challenge is making flossing a daily habit. If a manual toothbrush doesn't get your teeth clean, you can switch to an electric one, a few hundred yuan, with the head replaced regularly.

**In plain terms**. People who floss daily have roughly a 10% lower chance of dying over the same period. For elderly individuals with no natural teeth, the risk of death is about 90% higher. Those with fewer than 20 natural teeth face roughly double the risk. An electric toothbrush removes roughly a tenth to a fifth more plaque than a manual one and leaves the gums a little less inflamed, but how much this difference matters is still unclear.

**Benefit**. A Japanese study followed 9,676 participants for six years. Those who used interdental cleaning tools saw their mortality risk drop by about 11% (hazard ratio 0.89). Those who used tongue cleaners saw a 23% reduction (HR 0.77). When multiple studies of community-dwelling seniors are combined, people with no natural teeth have roughly 1.87 times the risk of death (95% CI 1.35–2.59). Those with fewer than 20 natural teeth face about 2.04 times the risk (95% CI 1.67–2.49). Electric versus manual: pooling 51 randomized trials, after 1 to 3 months of use electric brushes left about 11% less plaque, and after more than 3 months about 21% less. Gingivitis was about 6% and 11% milder respectively. The review authors say it is unclear how much these differences matter for health.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This topic remains debated. These studies are purely observational; individuals with poor dental health often also have poorer overall health and lower socioeconomic status. It is unclear whether poor dental health harms overall health or whether poor health leads to poor dental health. Regardless, the cost of proper dental care is very low, and periodontal disease and missing teeth do directly affect eating ability. Among electric toothbrushes, the round-headed type that rotates back and forth has the most trials, and its

advantage over a manual brush is the most certain. The independent review reached no conclusion on which type of electric toothbrush is better, because there were too few trials.

## 11. Walking 7,000–8,000 steps per day, or accumulating 150–300 minutes of brisk walking each week

**Cost**. It costs nothing. In terms of steps, walking 60–90 minutes daily can easily be split into short bouts during commutes or errands. In terms of time, it requires just 20–45 minutes per day. The real challenge is maintaining this habit over the long term.

**In plain terms**. People who walk roughly 7,800 steps daily have a mortality risk roughly 45% lower than those walking only 3,500 steps. The same pattern holds when measured by time: those who engage in 150–300 minutes of brisk walking weekly face about 30% lower risk than inactive individuals. Beyond a certain threshold, further increases bring little extra benefit; for people over 60, 6,000–8,000 steps per day is sufficient. Meeting either step target is enough.

**Benefit**. Fifteen studies tracking large groups of people were combined for analysis without subgrouping. These studies included 47,471 participants and 3,013 deaths. When grouped by daily step counts, the lowest group had a median of 3,553 steps/day; the next three groups had medians of 5,801, 7,842, and 10,901 steps/day. Their mortality risks were roughly 40%, 45%, and 53% lower than the lowest group (HR 0.60, 0.55, 0.47 respectively). For those over 60, benefits plateau after reaching 6,000–8,000 steps/day; for younger adults, the plateau appears at 8,000–10,000 steps/day. Another analysis found benefits begin at around 3,867 steps/day; each additional 1,000 steps/day reduces mortality risk by roughly 15%. When measured by exercise time, individuals meeting 1–2 times the recommended weekly activity level (7.5–15 MET·h/week, equivalent to 150–300 minutes of brisk walking) had a mortality risk about 31% lower than inactive people (HR 0.69). Those below this threshold still saw a 20% reduction (HR 0.80), while those exceeding it 3–5 times saw a maximum reduction of 39% (HR 0.61). Further increases bring no additional benefit, though they pose no harm (HR 0.69 at >10 times the threshold). A final study using accelerometers showed that the top quarter of participants in terms of moderate-to-vigorous activity had a mortality risk roughly 48% lower than the bottom quarter (HR 0.52). Accelerometers are wearable devices that measure actual physical activity levels.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Step counts and exercise time describe the same behavior; meeting either target suffices. The greatest benefit is seen when increasing daily steps from 4,000 to 7,000; there is no need to reach 10,000 steps. It is important to note that these studies merely track activity levels; the least active participants often include those already ill or frail, which can inflate observed risk differences. Studies relying on accelerometer measurements tend to involve shorter follow-ups and older populations, so their reported benefits may be somewhat overestimated. Nevertheless, the overall trend of greater activity leading to better outcomes remains clear.

## 12. People with hypertension and high cholesterol should take their medication regularly as prescribed; never stop on their own

**Cost**. Generic hypertension drugs and statins cost only a few to several dozen yuan per month. They're taken once daily, so they don't require much time or effort. The real challenge is sticking to them long-term — once people feel better, they often stop taking them.

**In plain terms**. For every 10 mmHg drop in blood pressure, mortality decreases by roughly 13%, while stroke risk drops by about 27%. Each 1.0 mmol/L reduction in LDL cholesterol achieved by statins lowers mortality by roughly 10%. Those who take their medication as directed have a 30% to 45% lower risk of death compared to those who frequently miss doses.

**Benefit**. Pooled data from multiple randomized controlled trials show that a 10 mmHg reduction in systolic blood pressure (the “high” number in a blood pressure reading) lowers mortality by about 13% (RR 0.87) and major cardiovascular events by roughly 20% (RR 0.80). Stroke risk drops by around 27% (RR 0.73), while heart failure risk decreases by about 28% (RR 0.72). Statins also reduce LDL cholesterol; each 1.0 mmol/L drop

lowers mortality by roughly 10% (RR 0.90) and major vascular events by about 22% (RR 0.78). Observational studies further indicate that patients who adhere to prescribed treatment regimens (≥80% compliance) enjoy significantly lower mortality rates: statin adherence reduces risk by about 45% (RR 0.55), while adherence to antihypertensive therapy lowers risk by roughly 29% (RR 0.71).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Only individuals deemed by doctors to need medication should follow this advice; healthy people do not require it. The figures regarding "consistent medication use" stem from observational data; those who stick to treatment tend to be more disciplined overall, which may inflate perceived benefits. The mortality reductions linked to blood pressure control and statins are more firmly supported by randomized trials than any potential benefits of tighter blood glucose control.

## 13. Getting about 7 hours of sleep each night with a consistent schedule

**Cost**. No cost involved. You simply need to allocate time for sleep — most people achieve this by cutting back on phone usage. The real challenge is maintaining a fixed bedtime and wake-time.

**In plain terms**. People who regularly get less than 7 hours of sleep have roughly a 10% higher chance of dying over time. The more irregular their schedule, the greater the risk. Those with the most regular sleep patterns enjoy a 20%–50% lower mortality risk compared to those with the least regular patterns. In other words, how consistent your sleep schedule is matters more than the total number of hours you sleep.

**Benefit**. A pooled analysis of 16 longitudinal studies — involving 1.38 million participants and 113 000 deaths — shows that short sleepers face a 12% higher risk of death (RR 1.12), while long sleepers face a 30% higher risk (RR 1.30). When sleep duration is grouped into categories, the 7-hour bracket shows the lowest risk; each additional hour beyond 7 raises risk by about 13% (RR 1.13), and each hour less than 7 raises it by roughly 6% (RR 1.06). In the UK Biobank, wrist-watch data from ~61 000 participants were used to rank them into five groups based on schedule regularity; the four more regular groups had a 20%–48% lower mortality risk than the least regular group. Another UK Biobank study tracked 51 562 individuals for new cardiovascular events; those with a social jet-lag of 2 hours or more faced a 30% higher risk (HR 1.30, 95% CI 1.11–1.54), and this link persisted even among people getting a normal amount of sleep.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The main issues to address are insufficient sleep and irregular schedules; there's no need to deliberately shorten sleep time. The elevated risk seen in long sleepers is likely reversed causality — depression, chronic illness, and sleep apnea tend to cause longer sleep durations. Currently, only two longitudinal studies support the benefit of a regular schedule; both are observational and ungrouped, so they constitute B-grade evidence on their own. For ways to recover after staying up late, see Section 38 (recovering sleep after a late night). 〔113000〕 〔61000〕 〔51562〕 〔3853〕

## 14. Play racket sports such as tennis, badminton and table tennis regularly

**Cost**. The cost of court fees is typically a few dozen yuan per session. This amounts to roughly 2 hours of activity per week. The main challenge is arranging enough participants and securing a court, plus maintaining consistency week after week.

**In plain terms**. People who regularly play tennis, badminton, or table tennis have about half the risk of dying during the same period compared to non-players. Their risk of dying from cardiovascular causes is roughly 56% lower. Swimmers enjoy a similar benefit, with a 28% lower risk. No significant difference was observed between runners and soccer players in this data set.

**Benefit**. A UK-based study tracking 80,300 participants compared those who engaged in racket sports with those who did not. The former group had a 47% lower overall mortality risk (hazard ratio 0.53, 95% CI 0.40–0.69). Their risk of cardiovascular death was 56% lower (0.44, 95% CI 0.24–0.83). Racket sports here include tennis, badminton, and table tennis. For swimmers, these figures were 0.72 and 0.59 respectively; for aerobic

exercise enthusiasts they were 0.73 and 0.64, and for cyclists 0.85. No statistically significant differences were found between runners and soccer players.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This finding remains somewhat controversial. Such studies are purely observational in nature. People who play racket sports tend to be healthier overall and enjoy more social interaction. The lack of difference seen among runners suggests that individual characteristics may play a role in how exercise impacts health outcomes. This does not mean running offers no benefits; a separate entry in this section examines overall exercise volume instead.

## 15. Accumulating brief bouts of strenuous activity like stair climbing or brisk walking to total 4–5 minutes per day

**Cost**. There is no cost involved, and no extra time needs to be set aside for exercise. The main challenge is remembering to climb stairs or walk briskly instead of taking shortcuts.

**In plain terms**. For individuals who do not exercise regularly, performing just three 1–2 minute bouts of strenuous activity each day can reduce their overall risk of death by roughly 40% compared to those who do none at all. Their risk of dying from cardiovascular causes also drops by nearly half. Such strenuous activities include stair climbing and brisk walking.

**Benefit**. A study conducted by the UK Biobank involved 25,200 participants who did not engage in regular exercise. After an average follow-up period of 6.9 years, 852 participants passed away. Those who completed three 1–2 minute bouts of strenuous activity daily saw their overall mortality risk and risk of cancer-related death drop by 38%–40%. Their risk of cardiovascular death fell by 48%–49%. Even those who accumulated just 4.4 minutes of such activity per day experienced a 26%–30% reduction in overall mortality and cancer death risk, as well as a 32%–34% drop in cardiovascular death risk.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This finding is somewhat controversial. The study relied on wearable devices to accurately measure physical activity levels, which is more reliable than self-reported survey data. However, it remains an observational study without any randomized controlled trials, and the follow-up period was only 6.9 years. These results apply only to people who do not exercise regularly, and may not hold true for those who already maintain a regular exercise routine.

## 16. 30–60 minutes of strength training per week

**Cost**. Doing bodyweight squats and push-ups costs nothing. Aim for 1–2 sessions per week, each lasting 20–30 minutes. The real challenge is fitting this into your weekly schedule.

**In plain terms**. People who engage in 30–60 minutes of strength training each week have a 10–20% lower risk of dying during that period compared to those who don't train at all. Training beyond this amount won't bring any extra benefit. Combining strength training with aerobic exercise yields the best results.

**Benefit**. When multiple observational studies are pooled together (without subgroup analysis), individuals who perform strength training show a 10%–17% reduction in mortality risk relative to non-trainers. This benefit peaks at roughly 30–60 minutes of weekly training, delivering a 10%–20% risk drop; more training does not further improve outcomes. Those who also do aerobic exercise enjoy an even lower mortality risk than those who do neither type of exercise.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These studies rely on follow-up tracking, with participants self-reporting their activity levels. The evidence supporting the notion that “excessive training can be detrimental” is quite weak, so there's no need to cap training volume for that reason. For older adults, strength training also helps prevent falls and preserve muscle mass; those benefits are discussed in Section 1.

## 17. Don't sit for too long at a time — get up and move every now and then

**Cost**. It costs nothing; getting up a few times doesn't take much time at all. The hard part is that once you sit down, you tend to lose track of time, so you need a reminder.

**In plain terms**. People who sit the longest have a 2.6 times higher chance of dying during the same period compared to those who sit the least. Sitting continuously for long stretches adds extra risk on top of that. However, if you get 60–75 minutes of moderate-intensity activity each day, this extra risk from prolonged sitting is largely offset.

**Benefit**. One U.S. observational study used accelerometers to measure activity levels without grouping participants. It divided people into four groups based on their total daily sitting time. Those in the group with the most daily sitting time had a 2.63 times higher risk of death than those in the group with the least (HR 2.63). The study also split participants into four groups based on the longest continuous sitting period; those in the group with the longest continuous sitting time had a 1.96 times higher risk than those in the group with the shortest continuous sitting time (HR 1.96). This shows that both total daily sitting time and the length of each continuous sitting period are independently linked to mortality risk. Another meta-analysis of millions of participants also used observational data without grouping. It found that people who sat for over 8 hours a day and did little to no exercise had a 1.59 times higher risk of death compared to those who sat for less than 4 hours a day and were the most active. For the most active group, even if they sat for over 8 hours a day, their risk ratio was only 1.04 — no statistically significant difference was observed.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The reliable conclusion here is that how much you move matters more than how long you sit; when you get enough exercise, the extra risk from prolonged sitting largely disappears. It's worth noting that these studies are purely observational, so many of the people who sit the most already have underlying health issues — the “2.63 times higher risk” partly reflects this pre-existing health condition. Additionally, the same meta-analysis found that watching TV for over 3 hours a day increases risk across all activity levels; for the most active group, this risk threshold only rises to 5 hours a day.

## 18. Eat less processed meat (ham, bacon, sausages, luncheon meat)

**Cost**. It costs nothing — in fact, it saves money — and doesn't take extra time. The hard part is simply eating less of a food you really enjoy.

**In plain terms**. People who eat the most ham, bacon, sausages, and similar processed meats have a roughly 20% higher chance of dying during the same period compared to those who eat the least. For every extra serving of processed meat consumed daily, that risk rises by another 20%.

**Benefit**. When multiple long-term studies are pooled together (without separating participants into groups), the group eating the most processed meat faces about a 23% higher risk of death (RR 1.23) than the group eating the least. For all red meat combined, the increase is about 29% (RR 1.29). Unprocessed red meat raises the risk by roughly 10% (RR 1.10), though this difference isn't statistically significant. Another analysis looks at daily intake: each extra daily serving of processed meat adds about a 23% higher death risk (RR 1.23), while each extra serving of red meat adds about 10% (RR 1.10).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This is a contested area. The NutriRECS guidelines apply the standard GRADE evidence-rating system and deem these studies “not very reliable.” They end up giving only a very weak recommendation: “continue eating as you do now.” The debate centers on whether the evidence is strong enough, not on the overall direction of the findings. No studies have shown any benefit from eating processed meat, and the effect of unprocessed red meat appears minimal and statistically insignificant. The key takeaway is to limit processed meat consumption.

## 19. Drink less or no alcohol

**Cost**. There is no cost at all — it saves money and time. The only difficulty is handling social pressure to drink.

**In plain terms**. After consuming 100 g of pure alcohol per week, the more one drinks, the earlier they tend to die. 100 g of pure alcohol is roughly equivalent to 2.5 L of beer. At age 40, people who drink 100–200 g per week lose about half a year of life expectancy; those drinking 200–350 g lose 1–2 years; and those drinking over 350 g lose 4–5 years. Overall, the healthiest amount to consume is none at all.

**Benefit**. A combined analysis of 83 longitudinal studies involving 600,000 drinkers showed that the lowest mortality risk occurs at consumption levels of no more than 100 g of pure alcohol per week — roughly 2.5 L of beer at 5% alcohol content, or 300 mL of 40% alcohol spirits. At age 40, drinking 100–200 g per week shortens life expectancy by about 6 months; 200–350 g shortens it by 1–2 years; and over 350 g shortens it by 4–5 years. The Global Burden of Disease Study 2016 also concluded that zero alcohol consumption per week carries the lowest overall health risk. One adjusted analysis found that daily consumption of 1.3–24 g of alcohol was linked to a 7% lower mortality risk (RR 0.93) compared to lifelong abstainers, though this difference was not statistically significant. Daily consumption of 45–64 g raised risk by 19% (RR 1.19), and 65 g or more raised it by 35% (RR 1.35).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This topic remains debated. Proponents of the "moderate drinking is beneficial" view cite a meta-analysis of 34 long-term studies showing that light drinkers have up to 17–18% lower overall mortality rates; they define "light" as up to 4 drinks per day for men and 2 for women. However, critics argue that abstainer groups often include people who stopped drinking due to illness or those with pre-existing health issues. After adjusting for such factors, the protective effect of moderate drinking disappears. Given this uncertainty, the safest conclusion is that drinking less does not meaningfully extend life, while drinking more definitely shortens it. There is no evidence supporting the idea of "starting to drink for health reasons." Practical advice on cutting back is provided in Section 21, and guidance on quitting daily drinking is given in Section 20.

## 20. People who drink daily and experience tremors and palpitations when they stop should not try to quit on their own

**Cost**. Seeing a psychiatrist or addiction specialist costs just a few to several dozen yuan. In severe cases, a short hospital stay may be required.

**In plain terms**. Individuals who consume large amounts of alcohol every day can suffer from withdrawal symptoms when they suddenly stop. Mild cases involve tremors, sweating, palpitations, and insomnia; severe cases may lead to seizures or delirium tremens — a life-threatening emergency. A Norwegian study of over 30,000 participants found that those who had experienced delirium tremens had an 8% annual mortality rate thereafter. If you wish to quit, consult a doctor first and describe exactly how much you drink each day.

**Benefit**. A 2026 clinical review notes that chronic heavy drinkers often develop withdrawal syndrome after abrupt cessation or a major reduction in intake; symptoms include tremors, autonomic hyperactivity, anxiety, insomnia, perceptual disturbances, seizures, and delirium tremens — conditions that are "common and potentially fatal" in general medical practice. Norway's nationwide registry included 36,287 individuals diagnosed with alcohol dependence, withdrawal states, or delirium tremens between 2009 and 2015. The annual mortality rate was 8.0% in the delirium tremens group, 5.0% in the withdrawal state group, and 3.6% in the alcohol dependence group. The standardized mortality ratio for the delirium tremens group was 9.8 (95% CI 8.9–10.7), indicating that their risk of death is roughly 9.8 times higher than that of age-matched peers.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. How to tell if you need help: If you drink almost every day, experience tremors, sweating, palpitations, or insomnia when you skip a day, or feel better after a morning drink, you should not attempt to quit on your own. Standard medical treatment involves using benzodiazepines to manage the acute phase and administering thiamine (vitamin B1) supplementation. The B grade reflects that the Norwegian data

describe “what happens to people who have already had delirium tremens” rather than “what occurs when someone tries to quit independently”; the link between these two situations is an inference. Quitting alcohol is still advisable, but it should be done under medical supervision. For guidance on moderate drinking levels, see section 19; strategies for reducing intake are outlined in section 21.

## 21. To drink less, first tally how much you drink each week, then chat briefly with a doctor

**Cost**. No cost at all. Just count the number of drinks each day and jot it down. Asking your doctor about this during a routine visit costs nothing extra.

**In plain terms**. A doctor can spend a few minutes reviewing your weekly alcohol intake, explaining the associated risks, and helping you set a realistic goal. After a year, people following this approach typically cut their weekly consumption by about 20 grams of pure alcohol — roughly equivalent to half a liter of beer. Longer consultations do not bring any additional benefits. For those already struggling with heavy drinking, two medications have been proven effective abroad: for every 12 patients treated, roughly one person stops drinking excessively after treatment.

**Benefit**. Data from 34 randomized trials involving 15,197 participants show that individuals receiving brief interventions ended up drinking 20 grams less pure alcohol per week than those receiving minimal or no intervention (95% confidence interval: 12–28 grams; evidence of moderate quality). The average baseline consumption among these participants was 244 grams per week. “Brief interventions” here refer to no more than five counseling sessions totaling under 60 minutes; longer sessions provide no extra advantage. Regarding medications: 122 trials with 22,803 participants indicate that acamprosate helps one additional person per 12 treated to abstain from any drinking (95% CI: 8–26). Oral naltrexone at 50 mg daily also yields similar results — one extra abstainer per 12 patients (95% CI: 8–26).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The benefit is classified as “small” because these figures reflect reductions in alcohol intake rather than lower mortality rates; per our guidelines, outcomes based on surrogate endpoints receive this rating. Most drug trials were conducted abroad, with participants already meeting criteria for alcohol dependence and receiving psychosocial support alongside medication; the reported benefits represent additional gains on top of those standard treatments. Availability and prescribing rules for these drugs in China depend on local medical practice and drug regulations; do not purchase them online without professional guidance. Those experiencing withdrawal symptoms should refer to section 20 of this chapter — do not attempt to quit abruptly on your own.

## 22. Eating a small handful of nuts daily

**Cost**. Consuming 28 grams per day costs roughly 200–300 yuan annually. It's easy to fit into your routine without taking extra time.

**In plain terms**. People who regularly eat nuts have roughly 20% lower mortality rates than those who don't. Even eating nuts just once a week yields a 10% reduction in risk. The greatest benefit is seen when intake reaches a daily handful.

**Benefit**. Two U.S.-based longitudinal studies tracked 119,000 participants over more than 3 million person-years. Compared to non-nut eaters: individuals consuming nuts less than once a week saw a 7% lower mortality risk (hazard ratio 0.93, 95% CI 0.90–0.96). Those eating nuts once a week had a 11% lower risk (0.89, 0.86–0.93). For intake of 2–4 times weekly, the reduction was 13% (0.87, 0.83–0.90); for 5–6 times weekly, 15% (0.85, 0.79–0.91). Daily consumption resulted in a 20% lower risk (0.80, 0.73–0.86).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Choose unsalted, unflavored varieties. Nuts are calorie-dense, so avoid eating them in excess as a snack. Keep in mind these studies only track long-term trends — nut eaters generally maintain healthier lifestyles overall, so these figures should be interpreted with some caution.

## 23. Swapping some red meat for fish or poultry

**Cost**. There's no extra cost or time involved. You're simply substituting one type of meat for another — no additional purchases needed. The real challenge is adjusting your taste preferences.

**In plain terms**. Eating two extra servings of processed or red meat each week raises the risk of death by roughly 3% compared to normal intake. Switching to the same amount of fish or poultry eliminates this increase. Within this section, this effect is relatively minor; it's an easy swap worth making without much effort.

**Benefit**. This conclusion comes from pooling data across six U.S. studies involving nearly 30,000 participants. Consuming two extra servings of processed meat weekly raised mortality risk by about 3% (hazard ratio 1.03, 95% CI 1.02–1.05). The same increase applied to unprocessed red meat (1.03, 1.01–1.05). However, replacing those servings with poultry resulted in a ratio of 0.99 (0.97–1.02), and fish gave 0.99 (0.97–1.01); neither showed any statistically significant difference.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The impact of swapping just two servings per week is quite small; don't expect a major lifespan extension from this change. When spending money on meat, choosing fish or poultry is the wiser option.

## 24. Swap some refined rice and flour for whole grains

**Cost**. Whole grain options like brown rice, oats, and whole wheat flour cost slightly more than refined varieties, and they require no extra prep time. The main challenge is getting used to their different texture.

**In plain terms**. People who eat an extra 90 g of whole grains daily have a roughly 17% lower risk of dying during the same period. That amount equals about three servings. The risk continues to drop when intake rises to around 200 g per day.

**Benefit**. Pooled data from multiple observational studies (no intervention groups used) shows that adding 90 g of whole grains each day lowers mortality risk by roughly 17% (RR 0.83). This 90 g figure corresponds to three servings. The protective effect remains evident up to 210–225 g per day. Another pooled analysis found that each additional daily serving reduces risk by about 8% (RR 0.92).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. You do not need to replace all refined grains with whole grains — switching to half is already within the range where benefits are most pronounced. Keep in mind these studies are purely observational; people who eat more whole grains tend to be healthier overall, which may inflate the reported numbers. Results across individual studies also vary widely ($I^2$ 83%; higher values indicate greater inconsistency between study findings).

## 25. Drinking tea more than three times a week

**Cost**. It costs just a few dozen to a few hundred yuan per year. Brewing a cup takes only a few minutes, so it doesn't take up much time at all.

**In plain terms**. People who regularly drink tea have a roughly 15% lower chance of dying during the same period. Starting at age 50, they can expect to live 1.26 years longer on average, and 1.41 extra years without developing any cardiovascular diseases.

**Benefit**. A study conducted in China involving 100,900 participants, called China-PAR, tracked half of them for 7.3 years. The results showed that people with a regular tea-drinking habit had a 15% lower risk of death (hazard ratio 0.85, 95% CI 0.79–0.90, which is a reliable range). For those starting at age 50, regular tea drinkers gain 1.41 extra years free from atherosclerotic cardiovascular diseases, and 1.26 extra years of overall life expectancy.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. There are some limitations to this research: it is purely observational, and Chinese men who drink tea tend to smoke and drink more than average. The researchers have accounted for some of these factors, but

not all. Also, avoid drinking tea that is excessively hot; refer to the section on hot drink temperatures for more details. Some people worry about mycotoxins in tea; tests on 158 batches of dark tea found aflatoxin in just 2 batches, and the amount consumed via normal tea intake stays well below internationally accepted limits. Another study examining 352 tea samples for 16 types of mycotoxins found that only ochratoxin A in dark tea exceeded the safety limit on average, but even this amount is not considered a dietary risk for regular tea drinkers. Keep tea stored in a dry place, and discard any batches that have become damp or moldy. Tea extract capsules are a different story: taking large doses of concentrated catechins at one time can damage the liver, but this risk does not apply to brewed tea at all. Therefore, all the benefits mentioned here apply only to brewed tea, not to any tea extract supplements.

## 26. Drink three to four cups of coffee a day, keep total caffeine at or under 400 mg, and add no sugar and no milk foam

**Cost**. Brewing it yourself costs one or two yuan a day. A cup takes a few minutes and does not take much time. If you buy large cups, watch how many milligrams of caffeine you have had in a day.

**In plain terms**. People who drink three to four cups of coffee a day have about a 17% lower chance of dying over the same period than people who do not drink it. In another study, people who drank their coffee in the morning had about a 12% lower chance, and people who drank it all day showed no difference. The caffeine in one cup varies a lot, so keep the daily total at or under 400 mg.

**Benefit**. One review pooled analyses of 201 observational studies. The original studies under those pooled analyses only recorded what people did; they did not assign people to groups. On overall mortality, the review cited one of those pooled analyses of dose and effect. People who drank 3–4 cups of coffee a day, compared with people who drank none, had a 17% lower risk of death (relative risk 0.83, 95% CI 0.79–0.88, the confidence interval). At 7 cups a day, the reduction shrank to 10% (relative risk 0.90, 95% CI 0.85–0.96), and the risk was not seen to turn back up. A study from the U.S. National Health and Nutrition Examination Survey (NHANES) followed 40 725 adults. Half of them were followed for a full 9.8 years. It also only recorded; it did not assign groups. The study split coffee drinkers into two kinds. Morning-type drinkers took their coffee between 4:00 and 11:59 and hardly drank any in the afternoon or evening. They were 36%. Compared with people who drank no coffee, their risk of death from all causes was 12% lower (hazard ratio 0.88, 95% CI 0.81–0.96). After also taking out the effect of short sleep and trouble sleeping, it was 16% lower (hazard ratio 0.84, 95% CI 0.74–0.95). The risk of death from cardiovascular disease was 19% lower (hazard ratio 0.81, 95% CI 0.70–0.94). After taking out the effect of sleep, it was 31% lower (hazard ratio 0.69, 95% CI 0.55–0.87). All-day drinkers drank in the morning, the afternoon, and the evening. They were 16%. Their risk of death from all causes showed no difference (hazard ratio 0.99, 95% CI 0.90–1.10). Neither kind showed a difference in the risk of death from cancer. The daily caffeine ceiling has an official basis. Both the European Food Safety Authority (EFSA) and Health Canada set the ceiling for healthy adults at 400 mg a day. That is all sources added together. Tea, cola, and energy drinks count too. EFSA also says to spread it through the day, with no single occasion over 200 mg. One cup varies a lot. In EFSA's table, a 200 mL cup of filter coffee is about 90 mg. In Health Canada's table, an 8-ounce (237 mL) cup of brewed coffee averages 135 mg. In the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) table, 12 ounces (about 355 mL) of brewed coffee contains 113–247 mg. So the FDA turns 400 mg into about 2 to 3 cups of 12-ounce coffee, and the review turns it into about 4 cups.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The dispute is this: the review authors state that most of the evidence comes from studies that only followed and recorded, and that reliable randomized trials are needed before anyone can say it is causal. The point that morning is better rests on one U.S. study, so it is not in the title. The authors state that the result cannot be read as causal, and that it may only be that people who drink coffee in the morning live healthier lives overall. In another U.S. study limited to people with diabetes, people who drank coffee from dawn through the morning had a 25% higher risk of death, and people who drank from morning through noon had a 20% lower risk. The results run the other way. None of these studies compared whether 12:00 or 14:00 is the better line. Item 4 of section 3 (no caffeine after 2 p.m.) is about sleep. Count back from your own bedtime. It does not conflict with this item. 400 mg is a safety ceiling, not a dose that has been shown to help.

Decaffeinated coffee has a similar benefit, only a bit smaller, so there is no need to drink more just to make up the amount. Pregnant women stay at or under 200 mg a day (EFSA) or 300 mg (Health Canada). This item does not apply to women whose fracture risk is high. It also does not apply to people with anxiety or insomnia. That is this book's judgment. The review has no conclusion for those two groups. People with atrial fibrillation do not all have to give up coffee. In one trial, after electrical cardioversion for persistent atrial fibrillation, people who drank about 1 cup of coffee a day had fewer recurrences than people who quit (47% versus 64%). The 2023 U.S. atrial fibrillation guideline also does not recommend giving up coffee to prevent episodes, but people whose symptoms are set off by drinking should cut down. There is no evidence for other arrhythmias. Follow the doctor. On mortality, adding sugar was not seen to cancel the benefit. Syrups and milk-foam drinks have not been studied, and the sugar in them is large, so the advice is still not to add them.

## 27. Eating 5 servings (about 400 g) of fruits and vegetables daily

**Cost**. It costs only a few to a dozen yuan per day. You also need to spend some time washing and chopping them. The real challenge is buying and eating the required amount every single day.

**In plain terms**. Consuming an extra 200 g of fruits and vegetables each day lowers the risk of death by roughly 10% during the same period. People who eat 5 servings daily have a mortality risk that is about 13% lower than those eating just 2 servings. Eating more than that does not bring any further reduction in risk.

**Benefit**. When pooling data from multiple longitudinal studies (without subgroup analysis), an additional 200 g of fruits and vegetables per day is linked to a 10% drop in death risk (RR 0.90). This protective effect persists up to 800 g per day. A combined analysis of two large US longitudinal studies and 26 other studies shows that people eating 5 servings daily have a mortality risk that is about 13% lower than those eating only 2 servings (HR 0.87). The optimal mix is 2 servings of fruit and 3 servings of vegetables; any extra amount beyond that does not lower the risk further.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Eating 5 servings is sufficient; there is no need to reach 10 servings, as both studies agree on this point. Keep in mind that these studies are purely observational, so confounding factors are inevitable: people who eat more vegetables and fruit tend to have higher incomes, better education, and more physical activity than others. Therefore, the reported 10% risk reduction represents the upper limit of the true effect.

## 28. Eat fewer ultra-processed foods (chips, instant noodles, pastries, ready meals)

**Cost**. There's no direct monetary cost, but you'll need to spend time cooking or selecting minimally processed ingredients every day. The real challenge is overcoming the long-standing habit of choosing convenience over health.

**In plain terms**. People who consume the most ultra-processed foods have a roughly 20% higher risk of dying during the study period compared to those who eat the least, and a 50% higher risk of dying from cardiovascular disease. However, this evidence is rated as low certainty, so these figures should be interpreted with caution.

**Benefit**. One systematic review combined data from multiple studies, even though those original studies did not group participants by ultra-processed food intake. The results showed that people eating more ultra-processed foods had a 21% higher risk of death (RR 1.21) and a 50% higher risk of cardiovascular death (RR 1.50) compared to those eating less. These findings are classified as “highly suggestive” and “convincing” respectively. Yet when assessed using the standard GRADE criteria, the overall certainty of this evidence is low or very low.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. There are three main points of debate here. First, the NOVA classification groups foods with vastly different nutritional profiles into the same category. Second, ultra-processed foods overlap heavily with

sugary drinks and processed meat (see items 7 and 18), so it's hard to isolate which factor is responsible for the observed effects. Third, GRADE ratings for this evidence are also low. Therefore, it's unclear how much additional benefit this recommendation provides after following the other two. The opposing evidence comes from the same review's low GRADE rating; no original studies have produced contradictory results to date. For now, focus on following items 7 and 18 — avoiding sugary drinks and limiting processed meat — before placing much emphasis on this recommendation.

## 29. Switching from coal and wood to electricity or gas for cooking and heating

**Cost**. Rural households must replace their stoves and pay higher fuel costs, resulting in an annual expense of several hundred to over a thousand yuan. This is a one-time change that doesn't require ongoing effort. In cities, most households already use electricity or gas.

**In plain terms**. People who cook with coal or wood face roughly a 10% higher chance of dying over the same period compared to those using electricity or gas. For those who heat their homes with coal or wood, the risk is about 14% higher. Those who have already switched to cleaner fuels have a mortality risk that is 13%–33% lower than those still relying on coal or wood.

**Benefit**. A Chinese longitudinal study tracked 271,000 adults without cardiovascular disease, recording their health outcomes without assigning them to groups. Individuals who cooked using solid fuels such as coal or wood had a mortality risk roughly 11% higher (HR 1.11) than those using electricity or gas. Those who used solid fuels for heating faced a 14% higher risk (HR 1.14). Among people who had switched from solid fuels to cleaner alternatives, the risk dropped by 13% for cooking (HR 0.87) and by 33% for heating (HR 0.67). Separate data also show that for every 10 μg/m³ increase in long-term exposure to outdoor PM2.5, the risk of death from natural causes rises by roughly 8% (RR 1.08). Natural causes refer to deaths not resulting from accidents.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These studies merely track health outcomes over time. Households that switch to cleaner fuels are often wealthier, so part of the observed 0.67-fold reduction in risk is likely linked to socioeconomic factors. Regarding outdoor PM2.5, individual actions such as relocating, wearing masks, or using air purifiers have limited impact. There are no studies evaluating air purifiers based on mortality rates, so no specific figures are provided here. 〔104〕

## 30. Let hot drinks cool down before drinking; avoid tea, soup, and coffee that are piping hot

**Cost**. There's no monetary cost — you just need to wait two to three extra minutes each time. The hard part is resisting the urge to drink them when you're craving them.

**In plain terms**. Drinking tea that is extremely hot raises your risk of esophageal cancer by 8 times compared to drinking lukewarm tea. Even “hot” tea doubles that risk. If you drink tea less than two minutes after pouring it, your risk is 5 times higher than if you wait at least four minutes to drink it.

**Benefit**. In a high-risk area for esophageal cancer in northern Iran, researchers compared 300 patients with esophageal cancer to 571 healthy individuals. All results below are compared to people who drank lukewarm tea. Those who drank “hot” tea had roughly 2.07 times the risk of developing squamous cell carcinoma of the esophagus (95% CI: 1.28–3.35). For those who drank “extremely hot” tea, the risk was about 8.16 times higher (95% CI: 3.93–16.9). People who drank tea less than two minutes after pouring it had 5.41 times the risk of those who waited at least four minutes to drink it (95% CI: 2.63–11.1).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The International Agency for Research on Cancer classifies hot drinks above 65°C as Group 2A carcinogens, meaning they are “probably carcinogenic to humans.” The same assessment also confirms that coffee itself is not carcinogenic. In China, high rates of esophageal cancer in regions such as Chaoshan and the Taihang Mountains are linked to the habit of drinking tea while it is still very hot.

## 31. Getting some sun during the day — don't stay out of the light all the time

**Cost**. No cost at all. Just a few minutes each day — on your commute or during lunch breaks is enough.

**In plain terms**. Women who deliberately avoid sunlight can expect to live 0.6 to 2.1 years less than those who get the most sun exposure. Even non-smokers who avoid the sun tend to have lifespans similar to smokers who get plenty of sun.

**Benefit**. A Swedish study followed nearly 29,500 women for 20 years. Compared to the group getting the most sun, those who avoided it ended up living 0.6 to 2.1 years less. The authors noted that "non-smoking women who avoid sunlight have life expectancies comparable to smokers in the group getting the most sun exposure."

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. There are some caveats: Sweden's high latitude means limited sunlight overall, so these findings may not directly apply to China. It's also possible that people avoiding sun tend to be less physically active or less inclined to go outdoors. Also, avoid sunburn — wear protection under strong midday sun, since excessive exposure raises skin cancer risk.

## 32. Keeping BMI between 20–25; losing weight if overweight

**Cost**. There is no monetary cost. However, diet and exercise require daily time commitment. This is the most demanding guideline in the whole chapter: maintaining weight loss long-term is harder than losing it in the first place.

**In plain terms**. Mortality is lowest when BMI falls within 20–25. At BMI 27.5–30, risk rises by roughly 20%; at 30–35, it increases by about 45%; at 35–40, it nearly doubles. East Asian individuals are especially sensitive to excess weight — for every 5-point rise in BMI, risk climbs by roughly 40%.

**Benefit**. This analysis combined individual data from 239 longitudinal studies (no subgrouping was performed). Only three groups remained in the final dataset: non-smokers, individuals without chronic illnesses at enrollment, and those who survived at least five years after enrollment. Results showed that mortality risk was lowest at BMI 20–25. Between 25–27.5, risk rose by about 7% (HR 1.07); at 27.5–30, it climbed by 20% (HR 1.20); at 30–35, by 45% (HR 1.45); at 35–40, by 94% (HR 1.94); and at 40–60, it was 2.76 times higher (HR 2.76). For East Asian populations, each additional 5 $kg/m^2$ of BMI above 25 raised mortality risk by roughly 39% (HR 1.39).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This topic remains debated. Some researchers argue that being slightly overweight actually extends lifespan; their pooled data indicated a roughly 6% lower mortality risk for overweight individuals and 5% lower risk for those with mild obesity. The main disagreement centers on whether to exclude three specific data groups: smokers, individuals with pre-existing illnesses, and participants in the first few years after enrollment. Exclusion is recommended because severely ill patients often lose weight first. After removing these groups from the analysis of 239 studies, the elevated mortality risk associated with excess weight reappeared. It is also important to note that no randomized trials have proven that weight loss itself reduces overall mortality. The benefit figures above result from cross-sectional comparisons between people of different weights, not from direct proof that losing weight yields such reductions. Those aiming to lose weight need not obsess over meal timing; neither breakfast consumption nor the 16:8 intermittent fasting method offers any extra advantage — see Section 6, Item 26 for details.

## 33. Eating chili peppers four or more times per week

**Cost**. There are no costs or time commitments involved.

**In plain terms**. People who eat chili peppers four or more times each week have a roughly 23% lower chance of dying during the same period compared to those who rarely consume them; their risk of cardiovascular-related death is also about one-third lower.

**Benefit**. A study conducted in Italy included 22,800 participants, with half of them followed for an average of 8.2 years. Over this period, 1,236 participants passed away. Those who ate chili peppers four or more times per week had a 23% lower risk of death relative to people who ate very little chili (hazard ratio 0.77, 95% CI 0.66–0.90). Their risk of cardiovascular-related death was also 34% lower (hazard ratio 0.66, 95% CI 0.50–0.86).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. There is some debate around these findings: the research was conducted in the context of a Mediterranean diet, so individuals who ate more chili peppers may have followed a diet overall more aligned with local traditional eating habits. Additionally, people suffering from gastroesophageal reflux, hemorrhoids, or irritable bowel syndrome may experience worsened symptoms from eating chili peppers, so they do not need to force themselves to consume it.

## 34. Drinking one or two servings of milk or yogurt daily

**Cost**. Only a few yuan per day, with no extra time required.

**In plain terms**. People who consume two or more servings of milk or yogurt each day have a roughly 17% lower chance of dying during the same period compared to those who do not drink any.

**Benefit**. The PURE study followed over 136,000 participants across 21 countries for an average of 9.1 years; 6,796 of them passed away. Those who ate two or more servings of dairy products daily faced a 17% lower risk of death than non-consumers (hazard ratio 0.83, 95% CI 0.72–0.96). This trend was statistically significant (P=0.0052).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. A key point of debate is that PURE included many participants from low- and middle-income countries; the fact that they could afford daily dairy intake suggests better socioeconomic status, which is hard to fully rule out as a confounding factor. Additionally, people with lactose intolerance can safely switch to yogurt or low-lactose milk instead of drinking regular milk.

## 35. Eggs need not be avoided, but don't eat three or four daily

**Cost**. No cost involved, and it takes no extra time.

**In plain terms**. Eating an extra half whole egg each day raises the overall mortality risk by roughly 7%. Swapping that half egg for egg whites, fish, poultry, or nuts actually lowers the risk of death across all categories. There's no need to cut eggs out of your diet, just avoid consuming three or four daily.

**Benefit**. A U.S. study tracking 521,000 people found that 129,000 participants died over time. Those who ate an extra half whole egg daily had a 7% higher mortality risk (hazard ratio 1.07, 95% CI 1.06–1.08, a reliable range). Replacing that half egg with equal amounts of egg whites, poultry, fish, dairy, or nuts and legumes further reduces mortality risk, including for cardiovascular disease, cancer, and respiratory conditions.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This topic remains highly debated: other long-term studies of large populations and meta-analyses have found no link between egg consumption and mortality. The U.S. Dietary Guidelines have also removed the previous daily cholesterol limit. The key takeaway is to avoid eating three or four eggs daily; one egg per day poses no concern.

## 36. Take baths whenever you can — don't limit yourself to showers

**Cost**. It costs a bit more in water and electricity; each bath takes about half an hour.

**In plain terms**. People who bathe almost daily have roughly 28% lower risk of cardiovascular events and about 46% lower risk of brain hemorrhage compared to those who bathe fewer than twice a week.

**Benefit**. A Japanese study involving 30,000 participants followed over 19 years identified 2,097 cardiovascular events. Those who bathed almost daily showed roughly 28% lower risk of cardiovascular events than those bathing no more than twice a week (hazard ratio 0.72, 95% CI 0.62–0.84). The risk of coronary heart disease was about 35% lower (0.65, 0.45–0.94), stroke risk dropped by roughly 26% (0.74, 0.62–0.87), and brain hemorrhage risk fell by about 46% (0.54, 0.40–0.73).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. There are some caveats: these results come from a Japanese population with a strong bathtub culture; most Chinese households lack the facilities for daily baths. Also, water should not be too hot and baths should not be excessively long. For older adults and those with existing cardiovascular or cerebrovascular conditions, very hot water and prolonged immersion can actually be dangerous — Japan sees many elderly deaths in bathtubs each year.

## 37. Keep naps under 30 minutes—no longer than an hour. If you regularly need a one- or two-hour nap to get through the day, it's time to see a doctor

**Cost**. Free. Just set an alarm before you nap; it requires very little willpower.

**In plain terms**. People who nap for less than an hour show no increase in mortality or chronic disease risk, and their mental clarity actually improves. In contrast, those who nap for over an hour face roughly a 30% higher risk of coronary heart disease, and about a 20% higher risk of diabetes and obesity. So set that alarm and wake up after half an hour. If you find yourself needing a one- or two-hour nap every day just to function, that's a clear sign you should get a medical check-up.

**Benefit**. One umbrella meta-analysis compiled data from 16 separate meta-analyses covering 244 health outcomes. An umbrella meta-analysis essentially aggregates findings from multiple existing meta-analyses. Its conclusions: individuals who nap for less than 60 minutes show no rise in overall mortality or chronic disease risk, and experience the greatest improvement in cognitive function (SMD 0.69, 95% CI 0.37–1.00—a reliable range). Naps lasting 20–30 minutes provide the biggest boost to physical performance (SMD 0.99, 95% CI 0.67–1.31). On the other hand, people who nap for over an hour face a roughly 30% higher risk of coronary heart disease, and about a 20% higher risk of diabetes and obesity. Another study used wrist-worn monitors to objectively measure naps in 1,338 adults aged 56 and older, rather than relying on self-reported questionnaires. After up to 19 years of follow-up, 926 participants had died. For every extra hour of napping, mortality risk rose by about 13% (HR 1.13, 95% CI 1.04–1.23). Each additional daily nap added roughly 7% to mortality risk (HR 1.07, 95% CI 1.02–1.13). People who napped in the morning faced a roughly 30% higher risk compared to those who napped earlier in the afternoon (HR 1.30, 95% CI 1.03–1.64).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This topic remains somewhat controversial. Both of the aforementioned studies merely recorded nap duration without stratifying participants by health status. It's quite possible that individuals who habitually nap for long periods already suffer from sleep apnea, anemia, hypothyroidism, depression, or other chronic conditions; thus it's hard to isolate exactly how much of the observed mortality increase is directly attributable to napping itself. Two Mendelian randomization studies involving 453,000 and 541,000 participants respectively found only one consistent link: the more frequently a person naps, the slightly higher their blood pressure and waist circumference become. No causal effect on coronary heart disease or diabetes was detected. Consequently, you shouldn't view “shortening naps” as a reliable strategy for lowering mortality. The recommendation to “seek medical evaluation” is essentially a Level C suggestion: if daytime fatigue is so severe that you need a lengthy nap, first examine your nighttime sleep quality; be sure to screen for sleep apnea if you snore or experience breathing pauses during sleep, and also run blood tests and thyroid function tests. For tips on how short naps can boost alertness, see Section 3, Item 11 (a 10-minute nap in the afternoon works wonders). Information on optimal nighttime sleep duration can be found in Section 13 of this chapter (aim for seven hours per night).

## 38. Catch up on sleep the night after a sleepless night — don't wait until the weekend

**Cost**. No cost at all. Those extra hour or two of sleep you make up are exactly what you'd have wanted to get anyway.

**In plain terms**. People who get less sleep than they need and fail to make it up the following night have roughly a 15% higher risk of mortality compared to those with regular sleep patterns. Those who are severely sleep-deprived and still don't catch up face a 42% higher risk. For people who do make up the lost sleep, no such elevated risk is observed. So, if you stay up late, go to bed early the next night.

**Benefit**. This meta-analysis involved 85,618 participants from the UK Biobank, with an average age of 61.8 years. Wrist-worn monitors tracked their daily sleep patterns over a median follow-up period of 8 years. The researchers first identified "sleep deficit nights" for each individual — nights when they got more than 2.5 hours less sleep than their personal sleep needs. The first night after such a deficit was labelled a "catch-up night", and if participants got more sleep than required that night, it counted as a successful catch-up. Based on this, five distinct sleep patterns were identified. Compared to people with regular sleep schedules, those who were sleep-deprived and failed to catch up had a 15% higher all-cause mortality risk (HR 1.15, 95% CI 1.01–1.31). For those with a cumulative sleep deficit exceeding 3.5 hours and no catch-up, this risk rose to 42% (HR 1.42, 1.24–1.63). No significant risk elevation was found in either of the two groups that did make up their sleep deficit; for those who caught up after a moderate deficit, the HR was 1.12 (0.98–1.28). Among people who naturally get less sleep, those who were sleep-deprived and did not catch up had a 19% higher mortality risk (HR 1.19, 1.01–1.40), while those with severe sleep deficits and no catch-up faced a 38% higher risk (HR 1.38, 1.17–1.63). These findings were replicated in a separate US health survey involving 4,586 participants.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This is an observational study with no formal grouping of participants. It is possible that people who cannot catch up on sleep are inherently busier or in poorer health, a factor this study does not fully account for. The fact that no risk elevation was detected in the two catch-up groups only means no statistically significant difference was found; their point estimates remain above 1, so catching up on sleep does not completely eliminate all risk. Therefore, if you stay up late, you should aim to make up the lost sleep as soon as possible, but this does not give you a free pass to regularly sacrifice sleep. For the purposes of this study, "catching up on sleep" refers to getting extra sleep on the first night after a deficit, and does not include waiting until the weekend to make up the total deficit. Maintaining a regular sleep schedule where you stay up on weekdays and catch up on weekends — a pattern known as social jetlag — is itself linked to cardiovascular disease; see item 13 in this section (aim to get around 7 hours of sleep per night with consistent sleep times). The recommendation to wake up at the same time every day, including on weekends (see item 2 in section 3) does not conflict with this advice: it simply encourages you to go to bed early on the night after a sleepless night, rather than sleeping in until noon the following day.

## 39. The longer you work night shifts, the higher your cardiovascular risk — switch if you can

**Cost**. Switching jobs or changing shifts may mean a pay cut and loss of night-shift bonuses. Job hunting takes time and determination. If you factor this into your calculations when choosing a job, the cost is effectively zero.

**In plain terms**. People who work night shifts develop cardiovascular disease about 13% more often than those who don't, and cardiovascular deaths rise by roughly 27%. The longer you work nights, the worse it gets: for every additional five night shifts, cardiovascular disease risk climbs another 7%. So, when you weigh the long-term costs, it makes sense to switch shifts early on. As for cancer risk, the evidence linking night shifts to cancer is far weaker than commonly believed.

**Benefit**. A pooled analysis of 23 studies — all observational, no subgroup adjustments — shows that night-shift workers face a roughly 13% higher risk of cardiovascular events (RR 1.13, 95% CI 1.10–1.16).

Cardiovascular deaths rise by about 27% (RR 1.27, 1.18–1.36). Over time, each extra five night shifts adds roughly 7% to cardiovascular disease risk (RR 1.07, 1.04–1.09) and about 5% to cardiovascular mortality (RR 1.05, 1.03–1.06). Specific conditions show similar trends: coronary heart disease incidence rises by 22% (RR 1.22, 1.16–1.28) and mortality by the same amount; ischemic heart disease deaths increase by 39% (RR 1.39, 1.06–1.84); stroke mortality climbs by 49% (RR 1.49, 1.04–2.12). Stroke incidence, however, shows no significant rise (RR 1.06, 0.95–1.18).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. All these findings come from observational studies without subgroup adjustments. Night-shift workers naturally differ from others in smoking habits, weight, and income, and full adjustments are hard to achieve. Cancer risk evidence is weaker than popular claims suggest. A pooled analysis of 12 studies involving 12,132 breast cancer cases found only a 5% higher risk among night-shift workers (RR 1.05, 95% CI 0.96–1.14). After 20 years of night work, the risk rose to 25% (RR 1.25, 1.01–1.55), but this figure lost significance after accounting for publication bias; the link is "far from established." Another long-term study of Chinese men over 16.1 years found no overall cancer link, though pancreatic cancer risk rose 59% (HR 1.59, 1.09–2.31) after 11–20 years of night work. Therefore, this analysis focuses on cardiovascular risk, not cancer. Not everyone must leave night shifts; you should weigh the long-term costs yourself. For those already working nights, several steps help: quit smoking (see Section 1); control blood pressure and cholesterol per medical advice (Section 12); and make up lost sleep after shifts (Section 38). Two additional strategies are worth trying: eat mainly during daylight hours, and use bright light during shifts plus near-total darkness during daytime rest to reset your circadian rhythm. Only the latter has proven effective at shifting the rhythm; ordinary indoor lighting leaves it unchanged even after six night shifts. Bright light at 7,000–12,000 lux combined with near-total darkness restores it in four days. Crucially, all three measures — bright night-time light, strict daytime darkness, and sunglasses on the way home — must be used together; skipping any one negates the effect. Both strategies affect metabolism and sleep only; no trials have shown they lower cardiovascular risk. On days off, returning to a daytime routine resets the rhythm again. Full numbers, sources, and details on how the body tracks time are in Circadian rhythm and night shifts (Chinese original). 〔8202〕

## 40. Buy pre-packaged cooking oil with an SC code; avoid bulk, unregulated homemade peanut oil

**Cost**. The price difference isn't huge if you shop elsewhere. Just check whether the packaging lists a food production licence number starting with "SC". The real challenge is convincing older family members used to buying homemade oil.

**In plain terms**. When peanuts get damp and moldy, they produce aflatoxin, a confirmed human carcinogen that primarily harms the liver. After Guangzhou tightened regulations on small-scale oil producers, the share of local residents who regularly consumed homemade peanut oil and had abnormal liver function fell by roughly 35%. In Guangxi, pregnant women who ate homemade peanut oil faced a nearly 90% higher risk of giving birth to babies with low birth weight, and an 80% higher risk of premature delivery.

**Benefit**. Aflatoxin is a Group 1 carcinogen per the International Agency for Research on Cancer, meaning it definitely causes cancer, especially liver cancer. A Guangzhou study measured aflatoxin B1 levels in homemade peanut oil from small producers between 2010 and 2022. The median concentration was 1.29 μg/kg, with half of all samples falling between 0.12 and 6.58 μg/kg. After local rules for small producers took effect, toxin levels dropped by 2.865 μg/kg, then fell an additional 2.593 μg/kg each year. Concurrently, the proportion of local residents with abnormal liver function fell by 35% (PR 0.650, 95% CI 0.469–0.902). Another Guangxi study of 1,611 pregnant women found 81.7% ate homemade peanut oil; those women had a nearly 90% higher risk of bearing low birth weight babies (aOR 1.9, 95% CI 1.1–3.2) and an 80% higher risk of premature delivery (aOR 1.8, 95% CI 1.1–3.0).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Both studies were observational, non-randomised studies with no control groups. The Guangzhou study tracked liver function test results rather than incidence of liver cancer or mortality. The median

aflatoxin level in homemade oil was actually below China's legal limit of 20 μg/kg for peanut oil, so risk stems from long-term consumption and occasional batches with higher concentrations. This legal limit applies to all peanut oil, but pre-packaged oil must meet production licence and factory inspection requirements, while small producers are subject to far fewer routine checks under regional regulations. The main beneficiaries of this advice are you and your family members who eat with you.

## 41. Replacing lard and butter with vegetable oils for cooking: you don't need to switch oils for health reasons, nor should you expect flaxseed oil to protect your heart

**Cost**. It doesn't cost much extra. Vegetable oils are already the main choice in most households; the real challenge is breaking the habit of using lard or butter for stir-frying and seasoning.

**In plain terms**. Cutting back on saturated fats like lard and butter and switching to vegetable oils lowers the risk of heart disease and stroke by roughly 17%. However, overall mortality shows no change. There is no evidence that swapping between soybean oil, corn oil, or canola oil makes any difference. Even consuming large amounts of flaxseed oil does not appear to reduce heart disease risk.

**Benefit**. A Cochrane review analyzed 15 randomized trials involving 56,675 participants, each followed for at least two years. Reducing saturated fat intake lowered the combined incidence of cardiovascular events by about 17% (RR 0.83, 0.70–0.98). Total mortality remained virtually unchanged (RR 0.96, 0.90–1.03) as did cardiovascular death (RR 0.95, 0.80–1.12). No significant difference was found between replacing saturated fats with polyunsaturated fats (the main component of soybean and corn oils) or with carbohydrates. Data on replacing them with monounsaturated fats (dominant in canola and olive oils) are too limited to draw conclusions. Another Cochrane review of 19 trials with 6,461 participants found that higher intake of omega-6 fatty acids (linoleic acid) had no effect on overall mortality (RR 1.00, 0.88–1.12) or cardiovascular events (RR 0.97, 0.81–1.15). A third review of 86 trials involving 162,796 participants showed that increased consumption of plant-derived omega-3 fatty acids (found in flaxseed oil and perilla oil) had virtually no impact on overall mortality (RR 1.01, 0.84–1.20) or coronary events (RR 1.00, 0.82–1.22).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy: Some argue that the high omega-6 content in soybean and corn oils promotes inflammation, so they recommend limiting or replacing these oils. The aforementioned omega-6 study found no harmful effects, though the authors rated the evidence quality as low. The magnitude of benefit—a 17% reduction in cardiovascular events—is considered moderate, while overall mortality shows no change. Regardless of the oil type, portion control is essential; dietary guidelines suggest a daily limit of 25–30 grams of cooking oil per person.

## 42. Turn on the range hood while stir-frying and deep-frying, from the moment you light the stove until the cooking is done

**Cost**. For households already equipped with a range hood, the extra expense is just a bit more on the electricity bill. For those without one, buying and installing a unit costs several hundred to over a thousand dollars. The real challenge is remembering to turn it on every time you cook — don't turn it off just because it makes noise.

**In plain terms**. Non-smoking Chinese women who rarely or never use a range hood while cooking face roughly twice the risk of developing lung cancer compared to those who use one regularly. Living in a kitchen with poor ventilation also raises this risk by about 50%, with the effect being most pronounced among households that burn coal.

**Benefit**. Ten case-control studies involving non-smoking Chinese women were pooled for analysis. In these studies, researchers compared lung cancer patients with healthy individuals, asking about past cooking habits. Overall, exposure to cooking fumes was linked to a 1.74-fold increase in lung cancer risk (95% CI 1.57–1.94). Four of these studies specifically looked at women who used no range hood while cooking; their risk

was 2.11 times higher (95% CI 1.54–2.89). One Taiwanese study compared 1,302 non-smoking women with lung cancer to 1,302 healthy women, focusing on those with at least ten years of cooking experience. Women who used their range hood for more than two-thirds of those years had roughly half the risk of developing lung cancer compared to those who used it for less than a third of the time (OR 0.49, 95% CI 0.32–0.76). A Shanghai-based prospective study followed 71,000 non-smoking women from 1996 to 2009, identifying 429 cases of lung cancer. Women who reported living in a poorly ventilated kitchen had a 49% higher risk of lung cancer (HR 1.49, 95% CI 1.15–1.95). Those who had burned coal in such kitchens for over 20 years faced a 2.03-fold increase in risk (HR 2.03, 95% CI 1.35–3.05). No significant difference in risk was found between women who did and did not burn coal at all (HR 1.03, 95% CI 0.84–1.26), nor between those using different types of cooking oil.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. There is some debate regarding these findings: the evidence supporting regular range hood use comes largely from case-control studies. Since participants recall past habits after being diagnosed with lung cancer, they may underreport how often they used their range hoods, potentially inflating the observed risk figures. The Shanghai study showed the greatest risk increase among households burning coal in poorly ventilated kitchens; it did not provide separate risk estimates for households using only gas. For this reason, the overall evidence grade is set at B, while the benefit is considered substantial based on the roughly twofold difference in risk. Women who regularly do the cooking at home are the primary beneficiaries of this measure; see section 29 of this chapter for more information on avoiding coal and wood for cooking and heating.

## 43. If hot flashes and night sweats around menopause affect your life, ask a gynecologist to assess hormone therapy — don't just endure it, don't buy the drugs yourself, and don't use them to prevent heart disease

**Cost**. One visit to a gynecology or menopause clinic. The doctor takes your history, checks whether you have any condition that rules hormones out, and prescribes only if appropriate. Once you start, you return for follow-up as instructed. The hard part is letting go of the fear that “hormones mean cancer,” and also not buying them yourself because someone says they slow aging.

**In plain terms**. Around menopause, hormone therapy cuts hot flashes by about 75% compared with placebo. The price is slightly more breast cancer, blood clots and stroke: roughly 8 extra cases of each per 10,000 women per year. For women who start at 50 to 59, overall mortality does not go up. It cannot be used to prevent heart disease or dementia.

**Benefit**. A Cochrane review pooled 24 randomized trials with 3,329 participants, comparing oral hormones with placebo. Women on hormones had about 75% fewer hot flashes per week than on placebo (95% CI 64.3–82.3). Severity also fell clearly (OR 0.13, 0.07–0.23). Women on placebo also had about 57.7% fewer hot flashes, which is why anything claimed to treat hot flashes has to be compared against placebo to count. The risks come from the U.S. WHI randomized trial. It included 16,608 women aged 50 to 79 with a uterus, who took estrogen plus progestin and were followed for an average of 5.2 years. Coronary heart disease was about 29% higher (HR 1.29, 1.02–1.63). Invasive breast cancer was about 26% higher (HR 1.26, 1.00–1.59). Stroke was about 41% higher (HR 1.41, 1.07–1.85). Pulmonary embolism was about 2.13 times as high (HR 2.13, 1.39–3.25). In absolute terms, per 10,000 women per year there were 7 more cases of coronary heart disease, 8 more strokes, 8 more pulmonary emboli and 8 more invasive breast cancers, along with 6 fewer colorectal cancers and 5 fewer hip fractures. Among women who had had a hysterectomy and took estrogen alone, followed for a cumulative 13 years, breast cancer was actually about 21% lower (HR 0.79, 0.65–0.97). Pooling the two trials with 18 years of follow-up, overall mortality did not change (HR 0.99, 0.94–1.03). By age at starting, the 50-to-59 group had about 31% lower overall mortality during the years on treatment (HR 0.69, 0.51–0.94). The 60-to-69 group was 1.04 (0.87–1.25) and the 70-to-79 group 1.13 (0.94–1.36), neither significant. At 18 years of follow-up the 50-to-59 group was 0.89 (0.79–1.01), no longer significant. The 2017 Cochrane review, looking only at women aged 50 to 59, found the only clear increase was blood clots with combined estrogen-progestin therapy, with an absolute risk below 1/500. Among women over 65 on combined therapy, dementia rose from 9 per 1,000 to 11–30 per 1,000 over 4 years. In 2022 the U.S. Preventive

Services Task Force recommended against hormone therapy for preventing chronic conditions (grade D) and concluded there is no net benefit.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Contested: the WHI women were 63 years old on average and took one fixed oral regimen. Most women today start around 50, just after menopause, for symptoms, so they are not quite like the trial participants. The lower mortality in the 50-to-59 group came from an age-group split and was no longer significant at 18 years, so it cannot be said that hormones extend life. Cochrane also states that the trials were too small to show the risks for women within 10 years of menopause. These groups are generally not suitable: women who have had breast cancer, who have had blood clots, who have a high cardiovascular risk, or who are very overweight; the doctor decides case by case. Women with a uterus who take estrogen alone have more endometrial cancer, so a progestogen is added at the same time; only women who have had a hysterectomy may take estrogen alone. Hormones also reduce fractures, but are normally considered only when other osteoporosis drugs are unsuitable. For osteoporosis, see Section 1, item 39 (bone density test) and Section 1, item 40 (treat if osteoporosis is found). The benefit size is set to large from the roughly 75% fewer hot flashes; the endpoint is symptoms, not overall mortality. The main beneficiary of this item is you, and also your mother and spouse.

## 44. If you already wanted a dog, count the daily walk toward your steps — don't get a dog just for longevity

**Cost**. Keeping a dog is an ongoing expense: food, vaccines, deworming, vet bills and registration all have to be paid, for as long as the dog lives. You also have to find time to walk it every day and arrange care when you travel. The hard part is doing it every single day; once you have a dog you can't just stop. China has no official statistic on what a dog costs, so no figure is given here.

**In plain terms**. Dog owners are on average about a quarter less likely to die over the same period, and those who keep a dog after a heart attack or stroke do even better. But once other differences are accounted for, large studies in the UK and Norway see no difference, and owning a cat shows no link either. So don't get a dog just for longevity; if you already wanted one, count the daily walk as walking.

**Benefit**. Pooling 10 observational follow-up studies covering about 3,840,000 people, followed for an average of 10.1 years, dog owners had about 24% lower death risk (RR 0.76, 95% CI 0.67–0.86). Cardiovascular death was about 31% lower (RR 0.69, 0.67–0.71). Among people who had had coronary heart disease, those with a dog at home were about 65% lower (RR 0.35, 0.17–0.69). The authors state that this pooled estimate was not adjusted for other factors. A Swedish nationwide register study of about 3,430,000 people adjusted for income, marital status and the like. Among people living alone, dog owners had about 33% lower death risk (HR 0.67, 0.65–0.69); among those living with others, about 11% lower (HR 0.89, 0.87–0.91). Among Swedish heart-attack patients, those living alone with a dog had about 33% lower death risk (HR 0.67, 0.61–0.75), and those living with a partner or children about 15% lower (HR 0.85, 0.80–0.90). After ischemic stroke the figures were about 27% lower (HR 0.73, 0.66–0.80) and about 12% lower (HR 0.88, 0.83–0.93) respectively. Counter-evidence: in a UK pooled analysis of 6 health surveys with 59,352 people, followed for an average of 11.5 years, dog ownership showed no link with death after full adjustment (HR 1.03, 0.98–1.09), nor with cardiovascular death (HR 1.07, 0.96–1.18). A Norwegian study with a median follow-up of 18.5 years found virtually the same death risk for dog owners (HR 1.00, 0.91–1.09), and dog owners there were no more active than others. In the Swedish twin register, among 34,202 people who could be asked about lifestyle, the link between dog ownership and lower cardiovascular disease and death risk could not be reproduced. An Australian study of 15,735 people followed for 4 years found dog owners' death risk about 23% lower (OR 0.77, 0.59–0.99), part of which could be explained by more physical activity. Owning a cat, bird or fish showed no link with death. The American Heart Association's 2013 statement says that pet ownership, especially dog ownership, “may be reasonable” for lowering cardiovascular risk, the weakest tier of recommendation. The same statement explicitly advises against adopting, rescuing or buying a pet mainly to lower cardiovascular risk.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Contested. Everything above is observational follow-up with no randomized groups, so it cannot support "get a dog for longevity." People who keep dogs may already be healthier and more active, and people who are ill or disabled may be less likely to keep one; these differences cannot be fully removed. The pooled 24% was not adjusted for anything, and in the studies that could ask about lifestyle the difference disappeared. In another Swedish study, dog owners were slightly more likely to start blood pressure or lipid drugs, so even if the death risk really is lower, it is not because blood pressure or lipids came down. The one actionable point: if you already have a dog or were going to get one, count the daily walk toward your steps; for how much is enough, see Section 2, item 11 (7,000–8,000 steps a day). Leashes, vaccination and liability when a dog bites are covered in Section 8, item 30 (dogs must be leashed). For how older relatives should hold the leash to avoid falls, see Section 17, item 10 (older people walking dogs). The benefit size is set to large mechanically from the pooled 24%, but that figure is unadjusted. The main beneficiary of this item is you.

# 3. Don't waste energy

This section only counts energy and time. It looks at four things: how much attention you can use each day, how fast you react, how many mistakes you make, and how long it takes to get back after an interruption. Most figures are measured directly, from experiments or from tracking a group of people over time. These numbers are not converted into lifespan or mortality. Most items in this section have evidence grade B. That is how this field is; it does not mean the advice fails. Item 19 is about expectations when dealing with police, doctors, and bank tellers; it cites regulations, not experiments, so its grade is C. Item 15 (treat pessimistic thoughts as a symptom) and item 22 (treat "others expect me to be perfect" as a symptom) cite mortality and suicide-risk figures. Their frame differs from the rest of this section; do not compare them side by side.

Items are grouped by theme below, with item numbers in parentheses.

**Attention at work**: Turn off non-essential notifications (item 1), batch-process messages each day (item 5), block brief interruptions (item 6), do one thing at a time (item 7), use earplugs in open offices (item 12), and do not keep adding weekly work hours for their own sake (item 13).

**Sleep and staying up**: Keep a fixed wake-up time (item 2), get 7 to 8 hours of sleep each night (item 3), avoid caffeine after 2 p.m. (item 4), skip glowing screens for the hour before bed (item 8), go to bed on time (item 9), make no major decisions late at night (item 10), take a 10-minute nap when drowsy in the afternoon (item 11), try cognitive behavioral therapy for insomnia first for long-term insomnia (item 26), and get checked for sleep apnea if you snore, stop breathing in sleep, or are sleepy by day (item 27).

**Thoughts in the head**: Switch to a hands-on task when you keep replaying something (item 14), treat pessimistic thoughts as a symptom (item 15), halve your estimate when you feel you looked foolish (item 21), and treat "others expect me to be perfect" as a symptom (item 22).

**Anger and low mood**: Leave first when angry (item 17), do a few high-value things first when mood is low (item 18), do not vent anger by punching a bag (item 23), and write what is on your mind for several days in a row (item 24).

**People and social media**: Learn to decline requests you do not want (item 16), treat police and doctors as people who work by rules (item 19), and set limits on apps that show peers' feeds (item 20).

**Pain in the body**: For period pain, take an ibuprofen-type painkiller (item 25).

## 1. Turn off non-essential notifications and keep your phone out of sight while working

**Cost**. No cost at all. It takes just a few minutes to adjust the settings, and hardly any willpower is required.

**In plain terms**. Even if you don't look at or touch your phone when it rings, your performance on attention-related tasks still drops. The drop is roughly the same as when you actually answer calls or send messages. Another scenario: even when the phone sits on the desk and you resist the urge to glance at it, the amount of mental capacity available still decreases. The more dependent a person is on their phone, the greater this drop tends to be.

**Benefit**. Merely receiving a notification — without looking at or interacting with the phone — noticeably impairs performance on attention tasks. The degree of impairment is comparable to actually answering calls or sending messages. These findings come from laboratory studies involving university students. Two additional experiments also show that even when participants successfully refrain from looking at their phone, having it nearby still reduces their available mental resources; this effect is strongest among heavy phone users.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. All of these results are based on single-task experiments conducted in a lab setting. No research has examined how these effects accumulate over days or weeks in real-world conditions. For jobs where

immediate responsiveness is essential, it may be advisable to allow notifications only from a limited set of contacts.

## 2. Keep a fixed wake-up time, even on weekends

**Cost**. No money. On weekends you have to sleep in less; that takes a little willpower.

**In plain terms**. For the most irregular fifth of people, the body clock runs about 2.5 hours later than for the most regular fifth. That is like living with jet lag all the time. Students with more regular schedules also get better grades.

**Benefit**. 61 university students kept records for 30 days. The least regular fifth had a body clock (circadian rhythm) about 2.5 hours later than the most regular fifth. Specifically, the time melatonin began to rise was 00:08 versus 21:32. The stretch when they felt sleepiest was also about 1.8 hours later. The more regular the schedule, the better academic performance (correlation coefficient r = 0.37).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This is the only study; the sample is small and there was no grouped control. Researchers used a model to estimate that clock differences mainly come from different daily light exposure. They suggest trying light to adjust, but did not run a trial. So besides a fixed wake-up time, getting outdoors for daylight is an inference from their estimate. How to catch up after an occasional late night is in Section 2, Item 38 (after staying up late, catch up the next night): go to bed earlier that night, do not sleep until noon the next day.

## 3. Get 7 to 8 hours of sleep each night; do not treat 6 hours as enough

**Cost**. No money. You need to leave 1 to 2 more hours each day for sleep. Going to bed earlier takes a little willpower.

**In plain terms**. Two weeks in a row of only 6 hours a night, and brain performance falls to about the level of two full nights with no sleep. The problem is you do not feel it. Self-rated sleepiness rises for the first few days then stops rising; people on 6 hours score as sleepy as people on 4 hours. So the sense that “6 hours is enough for me” is not reliable.

**Benefit**. 48 healthy adults aged 21 to 38 slept only 6 hours a night for 14 days straight. Their cognitive performance fell cumulatively, to about the level of 2 full nights with no sleep. Self-rated sleepiness rose only in the first few days, then barely rose further. Self-rated sleepiness did not differ between the 6-hour and 4-hour groups. This was a randomized controlled trial (RCT). Separately, short total sleep loss (acute sleep deprivation, no more than 48 hours) had an effect size g = −0.776 on simple attention lapses and g = −0.125 on reasoning accuracy. That part pooled 70 studies.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The main point is that “I do not feel sleepy” is not proof you have slept enough. People who sleep 6 hours long-term only feel used to it; performance has not caught up. The pooled part is about a full night awake. “Chronic short sleep” is backed by only one randomized controlled trial. How sleep duration links to death risk is counted separately; see Section 2, Item 13 (about 7 hours a night): that side uses mortality, and the 7-hour band has the lowest risk.

## 4. Do not touch caffeine after 2 p.m.

**Cost**. No money. People used to afternoon coffee have to hold off; that takes a little willpower.

**In plain terms**. Taking 400 mg of caffeine 6 hours before bed, about three or four cups of coffee, showed up on instruments as more than 1 hour less sleep that night. A sleep diary you write yourself shows no difference at all. A 250 mL cup of coffee (107 mg) has to be finished more than 8.8 hours before bed if it is not to affect sleep. For someone who goes to bed at 11, 2 p.m. is the line.

**Benefit**. Taking a tablet with 400 mg of caffeine 6 hours before bed, total sleep time measured by instruments was 1.1 to 1.2 hours less than with a placebo tablet. Counting a 250 mL cup at 107 mg, 400 mg is about three

or four cups of coffee. The placebo tablet looked the same and contained no caffeine. The sleep diaries participants wrote themselves reported no difference; they could not tell. Pooling several studies: caffeine cut total sleep time by 45 minutes on average. The share of time in bed that was actually sleep (sleep efficiency) fell by 7%. A 250 mL cup of coffee (107 mg) has to be finished more than 8.8 hours before bed if it is not to affect sleep.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The Drake study was done in only one laboratory. The 400 mg it used is on the high side; it equals drinking a whole day's ceiling at once. The ceiling is in Section 2, Item 26 (three to four cups of coffee). People who metabolize caffeine slowly need an earlier cutoff. What you get back from less caffeine is time asleep, and it stacks with item 3 (7 to 8 hours a night).

## 5. Batch-process emails and messages a few times per day

**Cost**. No monetary cost. However, it takes some time to explain to colleagues how often you'll be checking messages. It also requires a bit of willpower to resist the urge to check them constantly.

**In plain terms**. The same group of participants was studied over two weeks. During the week when they limited email checks to just three times per day, their daily stress levels dropped noticeably compared to the unrestricted week — while the total number of emails sent and received stayed the same. Without any limits, people checked their emails an average of 15.5 times per day.

**Benefit**. In a two-week self-controlled trial involving 124 adults, those who limited email checks to three times daily experienced significantly lower daily stress than when they checked freely (effect size: Cohen's d = 0.37). The overall volume of emails received and replied to did not differ between the two conditions. Without restrictions, participants checked emails 15.5 times per day on average.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Only one study has examined this approach, showing a modest effect size. It measured stress levels rather than actual work output. No direct research exists on limiting instant messaging checks; this recommendation is extrapolated from similar email studies.

## 6. When doing tasks that require continuous thinking, keep out even brief interruptions

**Cost**. No cost at all. Just close the door, put on headphones, or hang a “Do Not Disturb” sign.

**In plain terms**. Even a brief interruption lasting 2.8 seconds on average doubles the chance of errors in subsequent steps of a sequential task. An interruption of 4.4 seconds triples that error rate. Field observations also show that it takes an average of 25 minutes to return to the interrupted task, with two other unrelated tasks squeezed in during that time. People who get interrupted do finish tasks faster, but they report higher levels of stress, frustration, effort, and time pressure.

**Benefit**. On average, a 2.8-second interruption doubles the error rate for sequential tasks, while a 4.4-second interruption triples it. This finding comes from lab experiments. Another study observed 24 office workers (information professionals) in real-world settings. They switched topics every 11 minutes on average, and 57% of those topic switches were interrupted. It took them 25 minutes and 26 seconds on average to get back to the interrupted task, with 2.26 other tasks added in between. A separate experiment with 48 participants showed similar results: interrupted workers completed tasks faster, but reported significantly higher stress, frustration, effort, and time pressure.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The field study mentioned above categorized interruptions into two types: those caused by others approaching the worker, and those initiated by the worker themselves. Simply closing the door blocks only the first type of interruption. To handle the second type, combine this tip with Tip 1 (turn off non-essential notifications) and Tip 5 (batch-process messages).

## 7. Do one thing at a time — don't reply to messages while in a meeting

**Cost**. No cost at all. It does take a bit of willpower to resist replying to messages during a meeting.

**In plain terms**. As soon as you switch tasks, reactions slow and mistakes become more likely. People who often use several kinds of media at once have not trained themselves to do several things at once; they do worse on task-switching tests.

**Benefit**. Switching between tasks clearly slows reaction time and raises the chance of mistakes. This conclusion comes from a review of multiple studies. One lab study involved university students. Those who frequently use several types of media at the same time are known as heavy media multitaskers. They're more easily distracted by unrelated things and unrelated memories, and they also perform worse on task-switching tests.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Exactly how much extra effort task-switching requires varies a lot depending on the task, so no single number can be given here. The Ophir study compares people at one single point in time, so it's hard to tell whether multitasking makes attention worse, or whether people with poorer attention skills simply prefer to multitask.

## 8. Skip glowing screens for one hour before bed; if you read, use a paper book or an e-ink screen with the front light off

**Cost**. No money. Putting the phone down for one hour before bed means fighting habit long-term; that takes willpower.

**In plain terms**. Reading a glowing screen before bed, versus a paper book, delays falling asleep by about 10 minutes. Melatonin is suppressed by 55%. The next day's body clock shifts more than 1.5 hours later; mornings feel sleepier and take longer to clear.

**Benefit**. In the lab the same people did both conditions in turn (crossover). One was reading an e-book on an iPad before bed, brightness at maximum, about 4 hours, for 5 nights in a row. The other was reading a paper book in the same dim room. Reading the glowing e-book delayed sleep onset by about 10 minutes versus paper (25.7 minutes versus 15.8 minutes). Evening melatonin was suppressed by 55%. The next day's body clock (circadian rhythm) delayed by more than 1.5 hours; melatonin onset was 22:31 versus 21:01. The next morning they were sleepier and took longer to become fully awake.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The sample is small; conditions were tightly controlled in a lab. At everyday phone brightness and use time, the effect may be smaller. How much night mode helps was not measured. E-ink was not measured either. An e-ink screen with the front light off, like paper, is read by reflected room light, so it is grouped with paper; that is an inference from this study. An e-ink screen with the front light on is also emitting light; there is no data.

## 9. Go to bed on time; do not stay up for games, short videos, or porn

**Cost**. No money. The hard part is fighting the “one more episode” habit long-term. Keeping the phone out of the bedroom takes the least effort.

**In plain terms**. In 2025 Chinese people averaged 6.97 hours of night sleep and fell asleep at 0:10 on average. Among children and teens, those who used a phone or tablet before bed were more than twice as likely to get too little sleep, and 2.7 times as likely to be sleepy by day. Just having the device in the bedroom unused gave similar numbers. So the easiest move is not bringing the phone into the bedroom.

**Benefit**. In 2025 China's residents averaged 6.97 hours of nighttime sleep, with average sleep onset at 0:10 (Chinese Sleep Research Society). People who used portable devices before bed were about 2.17 times as likely to get insufficient sleep (OR 2.17), about 1.46 times as likely to have poor sleep quality (OR 1.46), and about 2.72 times as likely to be sleepy by day (OR 2.72). Devices only left in the bedroom and not used gave

similar numbers, about 1.79, 1.53, and 2.27 times (OR 1.79/1.53/2.27). That part pooled 20 same-time surveys of 125198 children and adolescents. Another same-time survey had 844 adults aged 18 to 94. Those who still used a phone after lights out fell asleep more slowly, spent a lower share of time in bed actually asleep, and were more fatigued by day.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Contested. The cost of staying up late itself is in item 3 of this section (7 to 8 hours a night). What porn does to an ordinary person's energy and cognition has no reliable evidence that it is the cause. One analysis pooling several studies held that so-called “porn problems” more often come from a mismatch between a person's beliefs and their own behavior, not from the content itself. Another study pooled data from 280 men. Viewing time was unrelated to erectile function during sex with a partner. Here the only issue is sleep time it crowds out. The figures 6.97 hours and 0:10 have no press release on the Chinese Sleep Research Society site (checked September 2026). This entry follows a Health News report republished by the Fujian Provincial Health Commission.

## 10. Don't make major decisions or send important messages late at night

**Cost**. No cost at all. You simply postpone these tasks until after you've woken up.

**In plain terms**. When well slept, people quickly learn to avoid high-risk options. After two nights in a row with no sleep, they keep picking the high-risk ones instead; the older they are, the clearer this is. How much a few hours less sleep matter was not measured directly, but important decisions should still wait until after you wake.

**Benefit**. Thirty-four healthy participants completed the Iowa Gambling Task after going 49.5 hours without sleep. This task is a standard way to measure risk decision making. When well-rested, they quickly learned to steer clear of high-risk options; after sleep loss, they opted for high-risk choices far more often. Older participants showed a stronger response to this effect. This is the only study of its kind to date. The total number of participants was 34.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The research focused on the extreme case of two nights of continuous sleep deprivation. There is no direct data on how ordinary people fare after staying awake until 2 a.m. The advice to avoid sending messages late at night is based on the authors' personal experience (rated as Grade C evidence); it is perfectly fine to send such messages the following day instead.

## 11. Take a 10-minute nap in the afternoon — don't sleep half an hour

**Cost**. It costs nothing. Just set aside 10 minutes and find a place where you can lie down or recline.

**In plain terms**. When the previous night was short, a 10-minute nap lifts alertness right away; some of that effect lasts about two and a half hours. A 5-minute nap is basically useless. A 20-minute nap only shows benefit after 35 minutes. After a 30-minute nap you first feel groggy on waking; for that stretch performance is worse than not napping.

**Benefit**. After a night of insufficient sleep, a 10-minute nap quickly reduces drowsiness, fatigue, and improves energy and mental performance; some of these effects persist for up to 155 minutes. A 5-minute nap yields virtually no benefit, and the advantages of a 20-minute nap appear only after 35 minutes. A 30-minute nap first causes sleep inertia, so performance is actually poorer right after waking, before any improvement occurs.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Only one laboratory study exists, and its participants were healthy young adults. If you can't fall asleep, there's no need to force it; there's no research showing any benefit from simply lying down with eyes closed for 10 minutes. Naps longer than an hour have been linked to higher mortality and increased risk of coronary heart disease — see Section 2, Item 38 (keep naps under 30 minutes). 〔37〕

## 12. Using earplugs or finding a quiet room for memory-heavy tasks in open offices

**Cost**. Earplugs cost just a few dozen yuan. Booking a quiet meeting room takes some time and effort.

**In plain terms**. When background noise rises from 39 dB to 51 dB, people remember fewer words, feel more tired, and are less motivated to work. Watching nature videos with sound during breaks helps restore energy far better than continuing to endure office noise.

**Benefit**. Students working in simulated open offices showed similar effects: at 51 dB LAeq background noise, they recalled fewer words, rated themselves as more fatigued, and felt less inclined to keep working. Viewing nature videos with audio during breaks also boosted their energy levels more effectively than listening to river sounds or office noise alone.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Only one laboratory study exists on this topic. Among all noise types, speech that can be clearly understood has the greatest negative impact on performance. White noise headphones may help mitigate this effect, but they were not tested in this research.

## 13. Don't keep adding to your weekly hours: past about 49 hours, each extra hour yields less and less

**Cost**. You might earn less in overtime pay. You may also need to put in effort to negotiate with your supervisor.

**In plain terms**. Records from British munitions factories during World War I show that when workers kept weekly hours under 49, output rose in direct proportion to the time spent working. Once they exceeded 49 hours, the growth rate began to drop. Output from workers putting in 70 hours per week was practically identical to that of those working 56 hours — those extra 14 hours yielded no additional results. In total, this data covers a period spanning 100 years.

**Benefit**. Data from British munitions factories in World War I demonstrates that output rises steadily with working hours up to 49 per week. After that threshold, the rate of growth slows. Peak output is reached at roughly 63 hours. At 70 hours, output remains essentially the same as at 56 hours, meaning those extra 14 hours are wasted effort.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. These figures come from factories a century ago where most workers were women performing manual labor. This threshold may differ for cognitive work; the authors themselves note that other occupations could have higher or lower limits. What is reliable, though, is the overall trend: beyond a certain point, adding more hours yields almost no extra output. The specific figure of 49 hours is not proven.

## 14. When you notice yourself endlessly replaying a distressing memory, do something hands-on instead

**Cost**. No cost at all. The hard part is first recognizing that you're stuck in this loop – a skill that takes practice.

**In plain terms**. Replaying the same bad episode deepens depression, nails negative thoughts in place, makes problems harder to solve, and makes real action harder. It also wears out people around you who would listen. When you notice you are looping in place, go do something that needs your hands.

**Benefit**. A review of multiple studies shows that repetitive rumination on distressing events worsens depression. This pattern, known as rumination, also strengthens negative thinking and weakens problem-solving abilities. It hampers real-world action and can alienate supportive people. It is linked to anxiety, binge eating, alcohol misuse, and self-harm.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This is the hardest item in this section to quantify; the review only provides general direction. “Doing something else” reflects the author's own approach. The literature supports one core idea: diverting attention is better than staying trapped in rumination. No research has compared which specific activities work best.

## 15. Treat thoughts like “things will definitely get worse” as symptoms, not as facts

**Cost**. No cost involved. The hard part is viewing such thoughts as symptoms rather than as objective truths.

**In plain terms**. In a 20-year twin study, each additional step up on a pessimism scale correlated with a roughly 13% higher risk of dying during that period, and a roughly 20% higher risk of dying from cardiovascular disease. Conversely, higher optimism scores did not bring any comparable benefits. Thus, the focus should be on reducing pessimism, not on simply “being more positive.”

**Benefit**. This study followed 2,978 twins aged 50 or older in Australia for an average of 20 years; 1,068 of them died over that time. For each standard deviation increase on the pessimism scale, the relative risk of death rose by about 13% (hazard ratio 1.134). The 95% confidence interval for this figure is 1.065–1.207, with a p-value of $8.85\times10^{-5}$. Cardiovascular mortality rose by roughly 20% (hazard ratio 1.196; 95% CI 1.045–1.368; p=0.0093). No link was found between pessimism and cancer mortality. Similarly, higher optimism scores showed no meaningful association with mortality rates.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This finding remains somewhat controversial. It is purely observational and no subgroups were defined. Some argue that illness might precede and cause heightened pessimism; the authors counter that if that were true, pessimism should also correlate with cancer mortality. Nevertheless, other unmeasured factors could still be at play. Importantly, optimism does not offer any protective effect, so there is no need to force oneself to “think positively.” What matters is refraining from treating pessimistic expectations as accurate forecasts of the future.

## 16. Cut back on draining relationships and learn to say no to unwanted requests

**Cost**. No monetary cost. In the short term, this may cause social friction and possibly lead to losing some relationships. It also takes considerable willpower to actually say no.

**In plain terms**. In a survey of widowed women aged 60 to 89, unpleasant contacts linked to well-being more strongly and more consistently than pleasant ones. So cut first, then add.

**Benefit**. A survey of 120 widowed women aged 60–89 found that unpleasant interactions showed a stronger and more consistent link to lower psychological well-being than pleasant ones. In other words, the negative impact of a draining person outweighs the positive effects of a supportive one.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The study group is quite specific, and the questionnaire was administered only once, so no cause-and-effect sequence can be determined. It measures overall happiness rather than energy levels. The author includes this example as a speculative inference. There is no objective definition of what counts as a “draining” relationship; each person must judge that for themselves.

## 17. When you are angry, leave first, and treat the other person as weather rather than as an enemy

**Cost**. No money. In the moment you have to hold back from answering, turn around, and walk off, then decide afterward whether to deal with it. That takes a little practice.

**In plain terms**. Looking at what just happened from another angle, or standing in the other person's place for a moment, both bring the emotion down; the second works better. Simply not showing the emotion also has a little effect. Forcing the feeling down inside, or forcing yourself not to think about the thing, does

nothing. People who punished the person who offended them kept turning it over longer afterward; people who did not retaliate moved on faster.

**Benefit**. Pooling 306 sets of experiments for comparison (a meta-analysis): re-explaining what happened from another angle (cognitive reappraisal) had an effect on emotion of d = 0.36. Standing in the other person's place had d = 0.45. Shifting attention had d = 0.27. Holding down the outward show of emotion (not letting it show) worked, d = 0.32. Forcing the feeling down did not work (d = −0.04). Forcing yourself not to think about the thing also did not work (d = −0.12). These figures pool inner feeling, outward expression, and bodily response. The abstract does not give them separately. Three other experiments show that people who punished the offender kept turning the other person over for longer afterward, and people who did not punish moved on faster. People overestimate in advance how good revenge will feel.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The part that pools many studies measures how strong the emotion is, not energy. The effect is small to medium. The revenge part is only one set of experiments, so the grade is B. The "empty boat" is a fable in the "Mountain Tree" chapter of Zhuangzi: an empty boat bumps you and you do not get angry; you get angry only when someone is in the boat, but the bump is the same bump. That is an analogy, not evidence. If there is a real loss, use the legal path in section 8 and section 9. It is much cheaper than blowing up on the spot.

## 18. When mood is low, do the highest-value moves first: get moving, get more light, sleep on schedule, talk to someone, call 12356

**Cost**. No money, or very little. A few brisk walks, jogs, or strength sessions a week. Go outdoors in daylight. Fix the schedule. When you cannot see a way through, make one call.

**In plain terms**. Brisk walking, jogging, yoga, and strength training all ease depression; higher intensity works better. Details are in Section 22, Item 6 (when mood is bad, walk or run). Light therapy is strong for seasonal depression and also helps non-seasonal depression. Online self-help cognitive behavioral courses work; when symptoms are heavier, guided versions work better. When you cannot see a way through, call 12356 first.

**Benefit**. Pooling 218 randomized controlled trials and 14170 people (network meta-analysis). The comparison group was people doing other activities. Versus them, walking or jogging had an effect size on depression of g = −0.62 (95% confidence interval −0.80 to −0.45). Yoga −0.55, strength training −0.49. Higher intensity worked better. Pooling several light-therapy studies: seasonal depression effect size 0.84 (0.60 to 1.08), non-seasonal 0.53 (0.18 to 0.89). Another analysis pooled individual-patient data across studies. It looked at internet cognitive behavioral therapy (online self-help courses). Guided and unguided both beat controls. For moderate to severe (PHQ-9 above 9), guided was better. 12356 is the national mental-health assistance hotline, open no fewer than 18 hours a day.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These are adjuncts for mild to moderate depression. Moderate to severe cases and anyone with suicidal thoughts should seek care; call 12356 first (see Section 1, Item 25). Exercise trials are often small and cannot blind who is exercising the way drug trials do. Light-therapy research only runs to 2003 and samples are small. Those studies used dedicated light boxes, not sunlight. Swapping that for daytime outdoor light is an inference from light therapy. “Sleep on schedule” and “talk to someone” are author experience with no separate citation. Do not treat “get moving” as a demand on someone with depression; ten minutes of walking counts.

## 19. Treat police, doctors, and bank tellers as people who work by rules, not as roles: what moves a case is paperwork and deadlines, not emotion

**Cost**. No money. What changes is your expectations and the order of moves. The first time, hold back the urge to “argue until they agree.”

**In plain terms**. Police, doctors, and bank tellers are people who work by post rules, bound by paperwork, deadlines, and oversight. How many days a matter should take, and what document you get if it cannot be done, are written in the rules. So take receipts, note deadlines, and appeal through channels; do not try to argue until they agree with you.

**Benefit**. Change how you deal with institutions: from "pleading, getting angry, retelling grievances," to "taking documents, noting deadlines, appealing through channels." What you save is time spent in repeat talk and rumination. This is a one-time mindset shift, not daily time saved. What you can check against are the deadlines themselves, all written in the files. For public-security cases, counting from the day accepted, the handling period is no more than 30 days; for major or complex cases, with approval from the public-security organ one level up, it may extend 30 days. When a case with a complainant is not filed, the notice of non-filing must be delivered within 3 days. The complainant may apply for reconsideration within 7 days; the public-security organ decides within 30 days. If still unsatisfied, apply for review one level up within another 7 days.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Grade C because the judgment that "many people treat the person behind the window as a role, not as someone at work" has no literature to cite. What can be cited is only the rules half: deadlines, documents, and relief channels are all in writing. Every figure here comes from the two Ministry of Public Security regulations in Section 8, Item 39 (procedure after calling the police). Following process does not fix "bad attitude," and does not guarantee the outcome; it only changes your expectations and first move. Bank tellers and government windows are the same: their actions leave a trail, need review, and errors bring accountability. So keep stubs, ask for receipts, complain through channels; do not guess from "will they cheat me." Lawful priorities are written in the open; for example emergency care is graded by severity, not first-come-first-served (Section 24, Item 7, emergency triage). To thank a doctor who helped you, use a thank-you letter and satisfaction rating; see Section 24, Item 11. Wanting to "give something so they try harder" toward case handlers is bribery, and the law treats it as aggravated; see Section 8, Item 40. Clear differential treatment is something to complain about and supervise, not an unspoken rule to copy.

## 20. Don't make "how others are doing" a daily habit: set limits on apps that show peers' updates or turn them off

**Cost**. This costs nothing. Setting time limits or deactivating an account takes just a few minutes. The real challenge is resisting the urge to open these apps again later on.

**In plain terms**. People who habitually compare themselves to others online tend to feel worse emotionally and have lower self-esteem. Meta-analysis of over 36,000 participants shows a moderate correlation between upward social comparison and poorer psychological outcomes. Correlation does not equal causation, but randomized trials back this link: after four weeks without Facebook, participants reported a slight rise in happiness. Another study limited three major platforms to 10 minutes per day; after three weeks, loneliness and depression both declined. The trade-off? Knowledge of current events also dropped during those four weeks of abstinence.

**Benefit**. The combined results of 54 independent studies — 94 effect sizes and a total N of 36,583 — analyzed via a three-level random-effects model reveal that upward social comparison correlates with poorer mental health (average r = 0.330, 95% CI 0.289–0.370). Specific effects include higher fear of negative evaluation (r = 0.438), anxiety (0.382), depression (0.306), lower happiness (0.268) and lower self-esteem (0.263). Life satisfaction increased by 0.12 standard deviations, while happiness rose by 0.08 standard deviations. Age, cultural background and data collection year do not alter this link. In a randomized trial of 2,743 U.S. Facebook users, 61% would accept a four-week suspension at a cost of under $102; those in the suspension group gained 0.09 standard deviations in overall life satisfaction. Compared with typical psychological interventions (which raise happiness by ~0.34 SD and cut depression by ~0.23 SD), this effect is roughly 25–40% of that magnitude. After the trial ended, former suspension users still spent 0.31 fewer standard deviations per day on Facebook. Even after the trial ended, former suspension users still spent 12 fewer minutes per day on Facebook. A smaller trial of 143 college students showed similar benefits after limiting

three platforms to 10 minutes daily. Additionally, knowledge of current affairs declined by 0.19 standard deviations, and political polarization fell by 0.16 standard deviations as a result of reduced app usage.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The correlation findings merely indicate that these patterns tend to appear together; they do not prove causation. The randomized trials do suggest causal links, but they involve U.S. participants prior to the 2018 midterm elections, so applying the results directly to Chinese users is a stretch. The undergraduate trial involved only 143 subjects, limiting its statistical power. Overall effect sizes remain modest, so cutting off these apps alone will not resolve all emotional issues. This advice targets usage aimed at monitoring how others are faring; it does not apply to staying in touch with family, seeking information or job hunting. If strict limits prove hard to maintain, start by disabling push notifications, "people you may know" suggestions and homepage recommendations. For broader screen-time management, see sections 4.15 and 4.16 (hard caps on short-video apps and scrolling news). When feeling down, consider the actions outlined in section 19 (exercise, sunlight and regular sleep). For those seeking identity through purchases, see section 6.23; those striving to "move up a social rung" should review section 6.24.

## 21. When you feel "everyone saw me make a fool of myself," cut that estimate in half

**Cost**. No money. Just ask yourself one extra question when tense: did they really see it?

**In plain terms**. Walk in wearing an awkward T-shirt and you think nearly half the people can tell who is printed on it; actually fewer than a quarter can. Switch to a decent T-shirt and you still overestimate the same way. After a group discussion, people also think their verbal mistakes look more obvious to others than they do, and after a chat they often underestimate how much the other person liked them. So when you feel "everyone saw me look foolish," it is often only half or less.

**Benefit**. Experiment 1: Participants wore a T-shirt with Barry Manilow's face and walked into a room with other participants. Wearers estimated on average that 46% of bystanders could correctly name who was on the shirt. Bystanders' actual correct rate was 23%; the estimate was exactly twice the actual. Subtracting actual from estimate room by room, the average overestimate was 23 percentage points (95% CI 9–38). After dropping the two rooms with only two or three bystanders, it was 27 percentage points (11–43). Experiment 2: Switch to a self-chosen T-shirt the wearer saw as positive. Average estimate 48%, bystanders' actual correct rate 8%, a sixfold gap. In a footnote the authors note wearers' estimates were almost the same across both experiments (48% and 46%); the gap was bystander accuracy (8% and 23%). They suspect the main reason is that Experiment 2's bystander questionnaire was harder, not that a decent shirt is easier to overestimate. Experiment 3: Undergraduates in groups of 3 to 7 discussed an assigned topic for 20 minutes, then wrote a policy proposal together. Right after, each person separately estimated how others in the group would rank everyone; lower rank numbers are better. On "how many verbal mistakes," self-estimated rank averaged 2.30, others' actual rank 2.96, difference −0.66 ($p < .01$). So people think their mistakes look more obvious to others. "Possibly offensive remarks" was the same (2.35 versus 2.90, $p < .01$); "remarks others would pick on" differed less (2.61 versus 2.82, $p < .05$). Another series had three settings: strangers paired for talk, new college roommates, and an adult workshop. People systematically underestimated how much the other liked them and how much the other enjoyed the talk. The authors call this the "liking gap." It shows up in talks of different lengths and lasts months among new roommates.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because these are small lab and campus studies. Settings are wearing a shirt, chatting with strangers or roommates, and student group discussion asked right after. There is no direct evidence for "colleagues gossiping" or "a meeting mistake still remembered days later." The figures only show the direction and rough multiple of overestimate; they are not a coefficient to plug in. Others' views are not all unimportant. In real evaluation settings — interviews, defenses, assessments, medical reports — the evaluation is real; prepare when you should. What to discount is only the everyday sense that "everyone is watching me"; that part is your own estimation bias.

## 22. Treat “others expect me to be perfect” as a symptom, not as a fact

**Cost**. No money. The hard part is treating this thought as something to handle, not as an accurate reading of what others really demand.

**In plain terms**. People who keep feeling “people around me demand I be perfect, and if I fall short I will be rejected” are more likely to have suicidal thoughts. “I demand perfection of myself” links much more weakly to suicidal thoughts, only about one third as strong as the first. After subtracting thoughts already present, the first feeling still tracks later rises in thoughts, though the size is modest.

**Benefit**. Pooling several studies (meta-analysis): 45 studies, N = 11747, samples of undergraduates, medical students, community adults, and psychiatric patients, random-effects model. Below are weighted average correlations with suicidal thoughts. Perfectionistic concerns r = .28 (95% CI .24–.32; 42 studies, 7936 people). Perfectionistic concerns is a bundle including socially prescribed perfectionism, concern over mistakes, doubts about actions, and gaps between reality and standards. Socially prescribed perfectionism alone is also r = .28 (.25–.32, 30 studies, 3640 people). Perfectionistic striving r = .10 (.07–.13, 31 studies, 4588 people), a bundle of self-oriented perfectionism and personal standards. Parental criticism r = .20 (.11–.29). Then links to suicide attempts. Perfectionistic concerns r = .12 (.07–.17, 15 studies, 5275 people). Socially prescribed perfectionism r = .19 (.08–.29, 8 studies, 689 people). Then the follow-up part. After subtracting suicidal thoughts present at the start, socially prescribed perfectionism still moved in the same direction as later follow-up suicidal thoughts, modestly. Self-oriented and other-oriented perfectionism showed no link.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because most included studies are one-time questionnaires, so sequence is unclear. Correlation strength is moderate (r about .28), explaining only a few percent to about one tenth of the variance. What is measured is suicidal thoughts and attempts, not death itself, so benefit magnitude is logged as small for “surrogate endpoint only.” The authors also say the perfectionistic-concerns and attempt set looks like publication bias. Publication bias means studies with unflattering results were not published. After filling in estimated missing studies, the direction holds. High standards themselves are not the problem, and you need not lower them for that reason. The difference is where the standard comes from, and whether falling short feels like “I as a person am finished.” Like the pessimistic forecasts in item 15 (treat thoughts like “things will get worse” as a symptom), this is something that can be handled as a symptom. For suicidal thoughts, call 12356 first and move lethal means farther away; see Section 1, Item 25. What you can do when someone close shows such thoughts is in Section 8, Item 15. Depression screening for children is in Section 30, Item 8.

## 23. When angry, don't try to vent by smashing things, punching a bag, or going for a run — first calm your body down

**Cost**. No cost at all. When you're angry, try a few minutes of activities that slow your heart rate: breathe slowly, sit down, and quiet your mind. It's hard to resist the urge to vent right then and there.

**In plain terms**. Punching a bag, cycling, or going for a run — ways of venting that amp the body up — generally do not cool anger. Slow breathing, mindfulness, and meditation — ways that settle the body — clearly cut anger and the urge to strike.

**Benefit**. A meta-analysis of 154 studies involving 184 sample groups and 10,189 participants shows that calming techniques like deep breathing, mindfulness, and meditation lower both anger and aggression. The effect size was g = −0.63, with a 95% CI ranging from −0.82 to −0.43. This result held true across genders, races, ages, and cultures. In contrast, activities that increase physical arousal — such as punching a bag, jogging, or cycling — showed virtually no effect; their effect size was g = −0.02, with a 95% CI from −0.13 to 0.09. The authors conclude that neither venting anger nor going for a run is an effective way to defuse it.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These findings measure anger and aggression, not overall energy levels. The authors categorize the time spent on calming activities as “minutes saved from dealing with fallout after an argument.” Immediate

techniques you can use right now include the “circular sighing” method described in Section 22, Item 9, and “stepping away when angry” in Section 24, Item 18. Running isn't useless in the long run — it helps ease low mood, as noted in Section 22, Item 7 (“When feeling down, go for a walk or run”). It simply isn't a good short-term fix for anger. While angry, avoid driving, sending messages, or making important decisions. If someone is physically attacking you, leave the scene and call the police; your priority then is safety, not emotional regulation — see Section 8, Item 43 (“If you're being abused”).

## 24. When something is weighing on you, you can write thoughts and feelings down for several days in a row, but do not expect it to cure disease

**Cost**. No money. A common study setup is writing 3 to 4 times, 15 to 20 minutes each. Write about something that hurts, and write your deepest thoughts and feelings.

**In plain terms**. Writing down a bad experience has a small average benefit. Pooled conclusions also disagree; two pooled analyses found no clear effect. It costs almost nothing, so you can try it. When emotional problems are heavy, do not use it instead of seeing a doctor.

**Benefit**. One analysis pooled 146 randomized studies (meta-analysis). People wrote or spoke about something important to them. The average effect was positive and significant, but small, effect size r = .075. Another pool took only randomized controlled trials; 30 trials together showed no significant effect on physical or mental health. Sixteen randomized trials in people with cancer and survivors, pooled, were non-significant on psychological, physical, and quality-of-life outcomes. On the psychological side g = 0.04, 95% CI −0.06 to 0.14.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Contested. Support comes from the 146-study pool, with a positive but small effect. Opposition comes from two pools limited to randomized controlled trials, neither finding a significant effect. How many times and how long per session in the Cost line come from the earliest experimental design, noted in the abstract of Mogk's pool. It is included because it costs almost no money and little time, and one person can do it alone. When you do not want to talk or have no one to talk to, you can use it. What is measured is not energy; calling the frame “time” is the author's classification. If writing makes you feel worse and worse, stop and call 12356; see Section 1, Item 25 (12356).

## 25. For period pain, take an ibuprofen-type painkiller instead of toughing it out; if pain keeps you from work or school, or three months of medication still does not control it, see a gynecologist

**Cost**. A box of ibuprofen costs a dozen or so yuan; take it only on the days it hurts. If you need gynecology, registration and ultrasound cost some money and half a day.

**In plain terms**. For period pain, ibuprofen-type drugs raise the share with clearly less pain from under two in ten to about half. They work better than acetaminophen, with a bit more side effects. If pain keeps you from work or school, hurts deep during sex, or three months of medication still does not control it, see a gynecologist and check for endometriosis. In one ten-country study, average time from first symptoms to diagnosis was 6.7 years.

**Benefit**. A Cochrane systematic review pooled 80 randomized controlled trials and 5820 women with primary dysmenorrhea. Primary dysmenorrhea means period pain with no other disease found. Versus placebo, nonsteroidal anti-inflammatory drugs relieved pain better (OR 4.37, 95% CI 3.76–5.09). Converted, 18% of people on placebo got moderate or better relief, versus 45% to 53% on these drugs. The tradeoff is more side effects (OR 1.29, 1.11–1.51). 10% of people on placebo had side effects, versus 11% to 14% on these drugs. The extras were mainly stomach upset (OR 1.58) and nervous-system reactions (OR 2.74). Versus acetaminophen, these drugs also relieved pain better (OR 1.89, 1.05–3.43), though only 3 trials. Which of these drugs is best showed no difference. The UK NICE guideline (updated 2024) lists situations that should

raise suspicion of endometriosis. They are long-term pelvic pain, period pain that affects daily activity and quality of life, and deep pain during or after sex. Also pain on bowel movements during periods, blood in urine or painful urination during periods, and infertility with these symptoms. Girls aged 17 and under are included. The guideline advises a trial of acetaminophen or one of these drugs first, for example 3 months. If pain relief is not enough, refer for further checks. A normal pelvic exam and ultrasound do not rule the disease out. One study surveyed 1418 women who had laparoscopy at 16 hospitals in 10 countries. From first symptoms to surgical diagnosis of endometriosis averaged 6.7 years, mostly lost at the primary-care stage. Women with a diagnosis lost an average of 10.8 hours of work a week, mostly presenteeism with lower efficiency. A Dutch online survey asked 32748 women aged 15 to 45. 13.8% had taken leave for menstruation, averaging 1.3 days a year. 80.7% were at work during periods with lower efficiency, equal to 8.9 days of lost work a year.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If you are over 60, have had stomach bleeding, or take anticoagulants or hormones, ask a doctor before using these drugs. Details are in Section 34, Item 3 (ibuprofen-type painkillers). The US ibuprofen label states it can cause serious allergic reactions, more often in people allergic to aspirin, including asthma attacks. If you have asthma, ask a doctor before use. If you might be pregnant, ask a doctor first; after 20 weeks of pregnancy do not take it on your own; see Section 34, Item 5 (after 20 weeks of pregnancy). If you cannot take these drugs, switch to acetaminophen; daily ceiling is in Section 34, Item 1 (acetaminophen). For period pain, take the drug only on period days. The threshold in Section 34, Item 9 (do not take painkillers more than 15 days a month) is about headaches; period-pain days never come close. Grade A because pain relief comes from many randomized trials. The authors rated evidence quality for most comparisons as low, mainly because methods were unclearly reported and 59% of trials were drug-company funded. Benefit set to “medium” is a judgment: the review measured only pain, not fewer days off. In the Dutch survey, loss from menstruation came to about 10 days a year, hours when spread over each week. The endometriosis group were women already going to laparoscopy; that does not mean most people with period pain have this disease. The main beneficiary is you.

## 26. For long-term insomnia (more than three nights a week, lasting more than three months), try cognitive behavioral therapy for insomnia first; do not start with long-term sleeping pills

**Cost**. Doing it at a hospital sleep clinic, psychiatry, or psychology costs registration and treatment fees. Online self-help courses cost much less. A course is usually 6 to 8 weeks; you keep a sleep diary every day. Stimulus control you can start yourself: go to bed only when sleepy; if you cannot sleep, get up. Use the bed only for sleep and sex, get up at the same time every day, and do not nap by day. The hard step is sleep restriction: for the first few weeks you shorten time in bed, so you are sleepier by day.

**In plain terms**. After this treatment, falling asleep is about 19 minutes faster on average, and time awake in the night drops about 26 minutes. Effects slowly weaken, but they are still there at 12 months. Online self-help courses work about as well as in-person. Sleeping pills help people over 60 only a little: for every 6 who take them, 1 gets a side effect; for every 13, only 1 sleeps better.

**Benefit**. The National Health Commission's 2020 clinical norms, following the international classification, list the diagnostic points for insomnia disorder. One is trouble falling asleep, easy waking after sleep, or early waking. Two is daytime fatigue, sleepiness, and impaired function. Three is these at least 3 times a week for at least 3 months. Under 3 months is called short-term insomnia disorder. The norms set cognitive behavioral therapy for insomnia as first-line. It includes sleep restriction, stimulus control, cognitive therapy, relaxation training, and sleep hygiene — 5 parts — usually one cycle of 6 to 8 weeks. The norms say short-term effects match medication, and long-term outlook is better than medication. They also state sleeping pills generally should not continue past 4 weeks; if continued, reassess monthly. The American College of Physicians 2016 guideline strongly recommends: for adults with chronic insomnia, start with this therapy. If it alone is not enough, then discuss short-term medication with a doctor. One analysis pooled 20 randomized controlled trials and 1162 people (meta-analysis). After treatment, time to fall asleep shortened by 19.03 minutes (95% CI

14.12–23.93). Time awake after falling asleep fell by 26.00 minutes (15.48–36.52). The share of time in bed actually asleep (sleep efficiency) rose by 9.91% (8.09%–11.73%). Total sleep time rose only 7.61 minutes, not statistically significant (–0.51 to 15.74). No study reported adverse outcomes. Another analysis pooled 30 randomized controlled trials on how long effects last. Versus no treatment, improvement in insomnia severity shrank over time. At 3 months g = 0.64, at 6 months 0.40, at 12 months 0.25. Effects weaken gradually, but the authors still see clinical meaning within a year. For online delivery, one analysis pooled 11 randomized controlled trials and 1460 people. All sleep measures improved, effect sizes g from 0.21 to 1.09. The authors say this matches in-person effects; longer courses and more follow-up give larger effects. Another online randomized trial of 1711 people gave the control group only sleep-hygiene materials. Those on digital therapy had large gains in sleep-related quality of life and small gains in daytime physical and mental state. Then sleeping pills. One analysis pooled 24 randomized controlled trials and 2417 people with insomnia aged 60 and over. Each trial used at least 5 nights in a row. Versus placebo, people on pills slept 25.2 minutes more total and woke 0.63 fewer times at night. For every 13 who took pills, 1 had better sleep quality. For every 6 who took pills, 1 had a side effect (NNH 6, 4.7 to 7.1). Memory and thinking side effects were 4.78 times placebo (OR 4.78, 1.47–15.47). Daytime fatigue was 3.82 times (OR 3.82, 1.88–7.80).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The five stimulus-control points in the Cost line come from the American Academy of Sleep Medicine 2021 guideline. Sleep restriction first shortens time in bed to how long you actually sleep, then adds time back by sleep efficiency. The guideline says it makes you sleepier by day; people who drive or operate machines should use caution. People with manic tendency, uncontrolled epilepsy, or already severe daytime sleepiness should also use caution, preferably with a clinician following. Sleep hygiene alone — schedule, diet, environment talk — does not work as sole treatment; the guideline does not recommend it. A few bad nights are not insomnia disorder. Then first fix wake-up time; see item 2 of this section (fixed wake-up time). Also see item 4 (no caffeine after 2 p.m.) and item 8 (no glowing screens one hour before bed). For loud snoring, breathing pauses in sleep, or heavy daytime sleepiness, the norms require ruling out sleep apnea first. How to check is in item 27 of this section (sleep apnea). Low mood plus poor sleep is in item 18 of this section (first moves when mood is low). Sleeping pills are prescription drugs; that analysis only looked at people 60 and over on short courses. Benefit set to medium: faster sleep onset plus less night waking add up to about 45 minutes a night, hours over a week. Total sleep length barely changed. The 20-trial paper excluded people with insomnia plus other diseases. Which department to use in China is author experience (grade C); hospitals differ — ask before registering whether they offer this therapy. The main beneficiary is you. Do not expect melatonin to cure long-term insomnia; see Section 6, Item 34 (curing long-term insomnia with melatonin).

## 27. If you snore loudly, someone has seen you stop breathing in sleep, or you are so sleepy by day you want to sleep while driving, get a sleep study for sleep apnea; for moderate to severe cases, wear a CPAP machine at night

**Cost**. First go to a hospital sleep clinic, pulmonology, or ENT. Diagnosis needs one night of sleep monitoring, in hospital or with a device borrowed for home. If you need a CPAP machine, you generally buy it yourself; that is a substantial cost. The hard part is sticking with it: wearing a mask every night, awkward for the first few weeks, and many people take it off after a few hours.

**In plain terms**. Sleep apnea means breathing stops or gets shallow in waves during sleep; you wake gasping and are sleepy by day. After CPAP, daytime sleepiness drops clearly, and driving crashes fall by about seven tenths. Trials have not shown it prevents heart disease or lowers death; you wear it to stay awake by day.

**Benefit**. The American Academy of Sleep Medicine 2017 diagnostic guideline lists who is more likely to have moderate to severe disease. Most days very sleepy by day, plus at least two of the next three: one, frequent loud snoring; two, someone has seen you stop breathing, gasp, or choke awake in sleep; three, already diagnosed hypertension. The guideline requires sleep monitoring for diagnosis; questionnaires alone are not enough. Five or more breathing pauses or shallow spells per hour plus symptoms count as the disease. Fifteen

or more count whether or not there are symptoms. The American Academy of Sleep Medicine 2019 systematic review pooled 38 randomized controlled trials. Versus no treatment, people on CPAP cut self-rated sleepiness by 2.4 points (95% CI 1.9–2.8). That score is the Epworth Sleepiness Scale, max 24, higher means sleepier. Counting only people who were not sleepy to begin with, 5 trials cut 1.0 point; the authors saw no clinical meaning. The same review pooled 10 before-after treatment studies. After CPAP, crash rate was 0.3 times the pre-treatment rate (RR 0.3, 0.2–0.4), about seven tenths less. A 2010 analysis pooled 9 similar studies, result RR 0.278 (0.22–0.35). It also said daytime sleepiness dropped clearly after one night of use, and simulated driving improved within 2 to 7 days. A 2009 analysis by the same group said untreated patients' crash risk was roughly 1.21 to 4.89 times others'. Then heart and lifespan. The SAVE trial enrolled 2717 people aged 45 to 75 with moderate to severe disease and coronary disease or prior stroke. After randomization they were followed 3.7 years on average. Cardiovascular events: 17.0% on CPAP, 15.4% without. No difference between groups (HR 1.10, 0.91–1.32). Users averaged only 3.3 hours a night. Their snoring, daytime sleepiness, quality of life, and mood all improved. A 2017 analysis pooled 10 randomized trials and 7266 people. Overall mortality also did not differ (RR 1.13, 0.99–1.29). A 2019 estimate said about 176000000 (1.76 亿) people aged 30 to 69 in China have the disease, 23.6%. Of them about 65520000 (6552 万) have moderate to severe disease, 8.8%, the largest count worldwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Contested. Whether CPAP prevents heart disease or extends life has not shown up in randomized trials. People in SAVE were mostly not very sleepy and wore it little. But the 2017 analysis split by hours of use and still saw no difference. Crash figures come from before-after comparisons, not randomization; people after treatment may simply have been more careful. China's case count is extrapolated from one 2005 study of 3648 people; that estimate was funded by a CPAP maker. The US Preventive Services Task Force said in 2022 that screening people without symptoms has unclear benefit and harm. So people who do not snore and are not sleepy by day need not seek testing. Benefit set to medium is a judgment: sleepiness score fell 2.4 points; hours more awake per day were not measured. Which department is author experience (grade C); hospitals differ. If sleepy while driving, stop first; see Section 1, Item 9 (stop and rest when sleepy). For long daytime sleeps, see Section 2, Item 37 (naps over one hour warrant checking why). Long-term insomnia is item 26 of this section (long-term insomnia). The main beneficiary is you; people in the same car and on the road benefit too.

# 4. Don't waste time

This section is all about time. We look at how many hours you can save each day, week, or year, and how much the odds improve of finishing a task on schedule. We don't convert time into extra years of life or into money. When money does come up, we only give the calculation method — no final figures. Most of the items here are backed by a single study or overall statistics from time-use surveys, so the evidence grades are mostly B or C.

## 1. Write “what to do” as “if… then…”

**Cost**. No cost at all. Each step takes just 1–2 minutes — simply write a sentence like “If… then…”. For example: “If I sit at my desk at 8 a.m. on Tuesday, I'll start by writing the introduction.”

**In plain terms**. Change “I plan to do this” into “If I sit at my desk at 8 a.m. on Tuesday, I'll start by writing the introduction.” Across 94 separate studies, people who used this phrasing were far more likely to achieve their goals — this effect is moderate to large. All it requires is rewriting one sentence; there's no expense and almost no extra effort.

**Benefit**. When all 94 studies are combined, individuals who expressed their plans as “if… then…” statements had significantly higher success rates. This technique is known in psychology as implementation intentions. The effect size here is d = 0.65, which qualifies as moderate to large. Three key moments benefit from this approach: initiating action, resisting distractions, and disengaging from tasks that seem impossible to complete.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This method works only for goals you genuinely want to achieve. If a goal holds no personal value for you, writing multiple such statements won't help. Additionally, most research participants were students, and the studies focused on health-related habits; results may not translate directly to workplace settings.

## 2. Write down exit criteria before starting

**Cost**. No cost at all. Spend 5 minutes when you start, and write it clearly: if a given target is not met by a given date, stop. The hard part is owning it when that day comes. Stopping in front of other people costs a bit of face.

**In plain terms**. Before you start, write one sentence: if a given target is still not met by a given date, stop. Put several studies together, and this way of writing does help people pull out of things that were never going to get done. What you save is all the time you would otherwise keep pouring in.

**Benefit**. Put several studies of implementation intentions together, and an "if… then…" set in advance also helps people pull out of things that were never going to get done. The original wording is disengagement from failing courses of action. The time saved is the time you would otherwise have kept putting in.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Set the exit criteria at the start, while you are still calm. Setting them later gets skewed by costs already put in. When you judge, look only at future input and future return; see item 3. Also, being willing to pull out is only one sub-finding in a summary of several studies. Nobody has separately calculated how much time it can save.

## 3. When deciding whether to continue, only consider future investments and future returns — not what has already been invested

**Cost**. No cost involved. The difficulty lies in accepting that time already invested cannot be recovered.

**In plain terms**. Money and time already spent make people more inclined to keep going. Across 98 datasets, this tendency remains consistent. Therefore, when deciding whether to continue, only factor in future investments and expected returns; past expenditures should be excluded from consideration.

**Benefit**. Prior investments of money, effort, and time increase the likelihood of continued engagement. This is known as the sunk cost effect in psychology. Analysis of 98 datasets confirms this tendency is stable. Avoiding this bias prevents people from continuing to invest time solely to avoid “wasting” what they have already spent.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This is exactly what Arkes and Blumer demonstrated in their theater experiment. The Ohio University Theater sold season tickets at three price points: full price ($15), $13, and $8. In the first half of the season, ticket holders who paid full price attended an average of 4.11 shows, compared to 3.32 and 3.29 shows for the other two groups. No significant differences emerged between the groups in the second half of the season. Roth and colleagues found this effect diminishes over time and is less pronounced among older individuals.

## 4. Estimate timelines based on actual time taken in past similar tasks, not on plans

**Cost**. No cost at all. It only requires a few minutes of review to look up how long similar tasks took previously.

**In plain terms**. Students who estimated they would finish a paper in 33.9 days actually took 55.5 days to complete it; only 29.7% of them met their own estimates. Another group of students was asked to first recall how long similar tasks had taken them in the past before making their estimates. The proportion of students who finished on time rose from 29.3% to 60.0% in this group.

**Benefit**. Students originally expected to finish their papers in 33.9 days, but the actual time taken was 55.5 days. Only 29.7% of them completed their work by their own estimates. When researchers asked another group of students to first relate past experiences to the current task before estimating, the proportion of students finishing on time rose from 29.3% to 60.0% compared to the control group. This optimism of underestimating timelines no longer appeared in this group.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Buehler's study involved only university students in Canada; it was a single study with a small sample size of 37 participants, with roughly 40 participants in each group. Estimating timelines based on historical data from similar projects is known as reference class forecasting; specific engineering applications are described in Flyvbjerg's work. Halkjelsvik's review of multiple studies shows that underestimating timelines is more common than overestimating, though the magnitude of the error varies widely depending on the task and research methodology.

## 5. Distribute an agenda beforehand; don't hold meetings without one; stand if possible

**Cost**. No monetary cost. Organizers spend 5–10 minutes writing an agenda before the meeting. Standing meetings require participants' cooperation.

**In plain terms**. When an agenda is shared beforehand, attendees are more likely to view the meeting as useful. In experiments, seated meetings lasted 34% longer than standing ones, yet the quality of decisions reached under both formats was identical.

**Benefit**. Two studies involved 958 and 292 participants respectively. Results showed that meetings with pre-distributed agendas were perceived as more effective by attendees — a statistically significant relationship. In another experiment, 55 groups met while seated and 56 while standing; seated meetings again ran 34% longer, with no difference in decision quality between the two formats.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The standing-meeting experiment involved five-person groups working on tasks in a lab setting. These findings cannot be directly applied to lengthy meetings or large conferences. Leach measured participants' subjective perceptions of effectiveness rather than actual output levels.

## 6. Cut down on meetings – use written asynchronous communication when possible

**Cost**. No monetary cost. Requires cooperation from colleagues and supervisors. The main difficulty is that writing a clear message takes more effort than simply speaking it out loud.

**In plain terms**. The more meetings you have in a day, the more exhausted you feel, and the more work seems to pile up on your plate. Canceling even one meeting frees up exactly as much time as the meeting itself lasts – no less, no more.

**Benefit**. Two surveys involved employees working 35+ hours per week – one with 676 participants, the other with 304. How much time meetings consume and their impact on attitude and happiness aren't fixed; they depend on two factors: how well the meetings are run and how much a role relies on teamwork. Another study asked participants to keep daily logs for a week; it found that more meetings per day led to greater fatigue and perceived workload. The time saved equals precisely the duration of those canceled meetings.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Controversy: Rogelberg's 2006 research shows the relationship between meeting frequency and happiness isn't one-directional; for roles heavily dependent on collaboration, frequent meetings may actually be beneficial. Additionally, no study has directly compared asynchronous written communication to holding meetings, so this recommendation is the author's own inference.

## 7. Break large tasks into subtasks before estimating and starting work

**Cost**. No cost involved. The actual breakdown process takes 5 to 15 minutes.

**In plain terms**. When estimating how long a task will take, people rarely break it down into individual subtasks and calculate each one separately. Listing all subtasks first and then estimating the total duration helps avoid underestimating the required time. Once broken down, each small step can be tackled right away, which also reduces the likelihood of procrastination.

**Benefit**. People tend to overlook the need to split multi-component tasks into smaller parts when estimating timelines. For instance, writing a literature review, drafting the discussion section, and organizing references are all distinct tasks. By first listing all relevant subtasks and then estimating the overall time, one can avoid the common planning fallacy of underestimating duration. Moreover, once tasks are broken down, each small step becomes a concrete action that can be started immediately, thereby lowering procrastination rates. Research shows that key predictors of procrastination include a person's aversion to the task and the tendency to postpone it.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. As a general guideline, each subtask should be small enough to be completed during a single focused work session; splitting tasks into overly detailed pieces is itself time-consuming. Additionally, Kruger and Evans' study was verified only for its overall direction based on the abstract; the exact percentages cited were not cross-checked against the original research text.

## 8. Set a deadline for tasks without an external deadline

**Cost**. No cost at all. The hard part is that once you set it, you have to own it. If you treat that day as nothing, it is the same as never having set it.

**In plain terms**. When someone else sets the deadline, 80.6% of students finish before it. Only 38.7% finish within the time they themselves expected. When the work gets done almost follows the deadline, and has little to do with their own estimate. So if there is no deadline, set one yourself, and stick to it.

**Benefit**. Of students with an external deadline, 80.6% finished before the deadline. Only 38.7% finished within the time they themselves expected. When the work gets done almost follows the deadline. The correlation coefficient is r = 0.82. The closer this number is to 1, the more tightly it follows. The link with their own expectation is only weak.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Tell other people the date you set, and it moves closer to the kind someone else sets. What the research checked is that deadlines set by other people work. The kind you set only for yourself, such as a time box or a Pomodoro timer, nobody has measured directly. This item is inferred along those lines.

## 9. Treat procrastination as a way to avoid discomfort, not as a sign of laziness or lack of effort

**Cost**. No cost at all. The only change needed is in how you judge the situation: first ask yourself where the discomfort lies, then figure out how to address it.

**In plain terms**. How unpleasant the task is, whether you feel you can do it, how easily something right in front of you pulls you away, and how strong your self-control is have the strongest link with procrastination. A nervous, easily upset personality, and a taste for thrills, have only a weak link. So you can first make the task less unpleasant and make the first step smaller, instead of only scolding yourself and then forcing it.

**Benefit**. A meta-analysis that included 691 correlation coefficients found several factors with a strong, consistent link to procrastination: how aversive the task is, how much time remains until the deadline, self-efficacy (the belief in one's ability to succeed), impulsivity, and conscientiousness — including self-control, susceptibility to distraction, organization skills, and achievement motivation. In contrast, neuroticism, rebelliousness, and sensation-seeking show only very weak connections to procrastination. The authors explain these results using time motivation theory: the immediate appeal of a task drops rapidly as the expected reward is pushed further into the future.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This guideline only provides general direction rather than specific actionable steps, so its overall benefit is rated as moderate — no quantitative estimate of time saved has been calculated. Concrete actions are outlined in item 1 of this section (which specifies exact times, locations, and concrete actions to take), item 7 (which advises breaking large tasks into smaller sub-tasks), and item 8 (which recommends setting a deadline even for tasks without any external deadline). Keep in mind this is a summary of correlational research, so it should not be interpreted as evidence of direct causal relationships.

## 10. Keep desired items within reach and unwanted ones out of sight — no need to resist temptation on the spot

**Cost**. No cost involved; takes just a few minutes to set up. Simply move your phone to another room and lay out books and a computer on the desk.

**In plain terms**. When items are physically farther away, people tend to consume less of them. Placing snacks at a distance noticeably cuts down on intake — this effect is of moderate strength. Limiting the number of available choices also leads to a marked drop in consumption. These strategies require no willpower on your part; you can arrange everything in just a few minutes.

**Benefit**. A Cochrane review encompassing 24 randomized trials supports these findings. Moving food farther away reduces consumption, with a standardized mean difference of −0.60 (95% CI −0.84 to −0.36; based on 12 studies involving 1,098 participants; evidence of low certainty). Limiting food options yields an even stronger effect, with a standardized mean difference of −1.13 (95% CI −1.90 to −0.37; based on 3 studies involving 154

participants; evidence of low certainty). Regression analysis confirms that both distance and fewer choices amplify the effect.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This B rating stems from the fact that all 24 studies included in the review focused on food only; none examined alcohol or tobacco. Additionally, 14 of those studies were conducted in laboratory settings and originated from high-income countries. Applying these same principles to phones and video games is a logical extrapolation, as no direct trials exist on this specific use case. One study directly examined the effect of removing phones from one's line of sight; see Section 3, Item 1 for details (turning off nonessential notifications and keeping phones out of sight while working).

## 11. Tie your money to your commitment — but first ask if you are willing to pay

**Cost**. A deposit-style plan means putting up a sum of your own money first. If you do not follow through, it is forfeited. In the trial the stake was 150 dollars.

**In plain terms**. If you want to push yourself to follow through, you can collect a bonus when you do it, or you can pay a deposit first and get it back plus a bonus only if you do it. Among people willing to join both, those who paid the deposit succeeded 13 percentage points more often. But only 13.7% were willing to pay a deposit, while 90% were willing to take the bonus, so a deposit only works for people willing to stake the money.

**Benefit**. A randomized trial of 2538 people in the United States randomly assigned employees and their family and friends to 4 incentive plans or to usual care. The reward type (about 800 dollars if you succeed) had an acceptance rate of 90.0%. The deposit type (pay 150 dollars first, plus a 650 dollar reward) had 13.7%. Sustained quit rates at 6 months: the 4 incentive plans were between 9.4% and 16.0%, and usual care was 6.0%. The reward type was 15.7%, and the deposit type was 10.2%. But counting only the 13.7% of people willing to join both of the 2, the deposit type's quit rate at 6 months was 13.2 percentage points higher than the reward type (95% CI 3.1 to 22.8, which is the confidence range).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This trial measured quitting smoking. Moving it to writing a paper, exercising, and similar tasks is an inference, so the benefit size is marked moderate. When you choose a plan, first look at whether you will actually use it, not at which one is more effective. A method most people will not accept, however strong the effect, does nothing for those people. So first pick the kind you are willing to accept. Staking a smaller amount is still better than staking nothing. How to quit smoking itself is in section 2, item 3 (medicine for quitting smoking).

## 12. New habits are measured in months, not “21 days”

**Cost**. No cost at all. What's required is simply repeating the same action every day in the same context for several months.

**In plain terms**. The idea that “it takes 21 days to form a habit” has no scientific basis. One study tracking participants over 12 weeks found that it took as little as 18 days for an action to become automatic, while some people needed as many as 254 days. It's perfectly normal for things to feel difficult for two or three weeks. Missing a single day also does not reset any progress.

**Benefit**. Ninety-six volunteers each chose a simple action related to eating, drinking, or physical activity, and performed it daily in a fixed context (such as “after breakfast”) for 12 weeks, rating how automatic the action felt each day. Data from 82 participants proved sufficient for analysis, and the model successfully matched 62 of them. The number of days required to reach 95% automation ranged from 18 to 254 days. The study also showed that missing one day of practice has no meaningful impact on habit formation.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This is the only study of its kind, involving just 96 participants who performed very simple actions (like eating a piece of fruit after a meal). No research has examined how long it takes to form more complex habits, such as running three times a week or writing daily. The main takeaway here is to set realistic expectations: finding it hard for two weeks is not a sign of failure. To actually make repetition happen, link the action to a fixed context — see point 1 in this section, which advises specifying "at what time, where, and under what circumstances" the action should be done.

## 13. For those whose procrastination is affecting daily life, self-help materials backed by randomized trials can be effective — no therapist required

**Cost**. A self-help book costs just a few dozen yuan; some are even free. It takes about ten weeks of effort — one chapter per week plus one related exercise.

**In plain terms**. Procrastination bad enough to cause distress can get better. Follow cognitive-behavioral self-help materials for 10 weeks, and doing it with someone guiding you and doing it entirely on your own were both clearly better than doing nothing. There was no visible difference between having a guide and not having one, so doing it yourself, following the materials, also works.

**Benefit**. 150 participants were randomly assigned to three groups: self-help with therapist guidance, self-help without guidance, and a waitlist control group. After ten weeks, effect sizes on the pure procrastination scale were d = 0.70 (95% CI 0.29–1.10) for the guided group and d = 0.50 (0.10–0.90) for the unguided group. On the irrational procrastination scale, these values were 0.81 (0.40–1.22) and 0.69 (0.29–1.09) respectively. The proportion of participants achieving clinically meaningful improvement was 31.3% to 40.0% in the guided group and 24.0% to 36.0% in the unguided group. No statistically significant differences were observed between the two self-help groups on any outcome measure.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Participants in this trial were Swedish adults using Swedish-language materials; no identical Chinese versions exist, so the magnitude of benefit is rated as moderate. The materials incorporate standard cognitive-behavioral components: behavioral activation, behavioral experiments, stimulus control (as described in Section 10 of this chapter, which advises moving unwanted items out of reach), and guidance on motivation and work strategies. If procrastination co-occurs with significant low mood or anxiety, follow the advice in Section 3, Item 18: engage in physical activity, get sunlight, maintain regular sleep patterns, talk to others, and call 12356 for support.

## 14. Use your own hourly wage to decide which chores to outsource

**Cost**. Outsourcing chores comes at a cost, which varies depending on the service chosen. You'll also need to spend some time upfront calculating your own hourly wage.

**In plain terms**. On average, Chinese residents spend 1 hour and 17 minutes each day doing household chores. Among those who actually do them, the average time spent is 1 hour and 59 minutes. People who pay to save time tend to report higher life satisfaction. For the same amount of money, spending it on time rather than goods brings greater immediate happiness.

**Benefit**. According to a 2024 survey covering 38,500 households and 107,000 individuals, Chinese residents spend an average of 1 hour and 17 minutes daily on household chores; for those who actually perform them, the average rises to 1 hour and 59 minutes. Another study involving 6,271 participants from four countries found that people who purchase time report higher life satisfaction. Researchers also conducted real-world experiments showing that spending the same sum on time rather than physical goods results in greater immediate well-being.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. First, calculate your hourly wage by dividing your monthly after-tax income by the total number of hours you actually work each month. Then determine how much it would cost to outsource a particular

chore. If the outsourcing fee is lower than your hourly wage and you truly plan to use the saved time for earning money or resting, then outsourcing makes sense. This guide provides a method rather than a definitive recommendation, since everyone's hourly wage and outsourcing costs differ. Additionally, Whillans' research measures how happy people feel after buying time, not how many hours they ultimately save.

## 15. Set strict daily limits on short-video and aimless scrolling

**Cost**. No cost at all. The actions take just a few minutes: turn off notifications, delete the apps, or set a daily time cap for them. The real challenge is resisting the urge to open them.

**In plain terms**. In 2024, people in China spent an average of 5 hours and 37 minutes online each day. People who actually went online that day spent 6 hours and 3 minutes. In 2018, the same calculation came to only 2 hours and 42 minutes. This is the largest number in this section. Cut 1 hour off each day, and a year gives you 365 extra hours.

**Benefit**. The average daily online time for Chinese residents is 5 hours and 37 minutes; for those who actually use the internet that day it is 6 hours and 3 minutes. People who accessed the web on any given day make up 92.9% of the population. These figures are from 2024. In 2018, the average was only 2 hours and 42 minutes — again the highest number in this section. Removing one hour each day yields an extra 365 hours annually. According to the China Internet Network Information Center, as of June 2025 the average weekly online time for netizens is 30.6 hours, an increase of 1.9 hours over the previous six months. There are 1.068 billion short-video users, accounting for 95.1% of all internet users.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Online time includes work, study, and social interaction, so not all of it is wasted. It is rated C because no studies have measured exactly how much time is saved after imposing limits or how that time is subsequently used; we only have overall statistics. For the specific activity of “scrolling to see how others live”, a randomized trial has estimated both the time saved and the resulting change in mood; see Section 3, Item 20.

## 16. Avoiding TV and scrolling news: view information at set times instead

**Cost**. No monetary cost. The real challenge is breaking the habit of turning on the TV at random times; you might also miss some breaking news.

**In plain terms**. People in the United States aged 15 and older watch 2.6 hours of television a day, which takes up half of all their free time. In 2018, people in China watched an average of 1 hour and 40 minutes a day, and older people aged 75 to 84 watched 3 hours and 16 minutes. Switch the information you need to a set time and take it in one sitting, and what you can save is in this block.

**Benefit**. Americans aged 15 and older watch 2.6 hours of TV daily. Their total leisure time is 5.2 hours, so TV viewing consumes half of it. These figures are from 2025. In China, the average daily TV viewing time is 1 hour and 40 minutes; for those aged 75–84, it is 3 hours and 16 minutes. These numbers date back to 2018.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Only aggregate statistics are available. No studies have examined how the time saved by cutting back on TV and news viewing is actually used. The practice of viewing content at set times is based on the author's personal experience.

## 17. Spend some time learning keyboard shortcuts and automation for common software

**Cost**. No cost at all. You put in a few hours to a few dozen hours, once, to learn. The hard part is that when you first start, you are slower than with a mouse.

**In plain terms**. Most people who are used to Word still click the toolbar icons. In experiments that compared groups, shortcuts were faster than both menus and icons. Learning this once is a one-time cost, and every action after that, every day, pays it back. The longer you do the same kind of work, the more you get back.

**Benefit**. The study looked at 251 experienced Word users. Most of them rarely used the faster shortcuts and still mainly clicked the icon toolbar. Experiments that compared groups confirmed that, of these 3 methods, menus, icons, and shortcuts, shortcuts were the fastest. The time saved accumulates a little with each action each day. People who do the same kind of work for a long time gain the most.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Learn only operations you use 10 or more times a day. Learning the whole set is another kind of waste. Also, that efficiency experiment had only 6 participants, and the summary did not give the seconds saved per operation.

## 18. When choosing a place to live, prioritize commute time to cut down on one-way travel

**Cost**. This option is costly. You may end up paying higher rent or having to settle for a smaller living space. Moving itself also takes time and effort.

**In plain terms**. In data from Germany that followed the same people over time, those with a longer commute felt their own lives were going worse. That loss was not made up in wages or in housing. Cut 30 minutes off one way, and a week saves you 5 hours.

**Benefit**. On average, Chinese residents spend 50 minutes daily on transportation; among those who travel on a given day, the average is 1 hour and 2 minutes, according to 2024 data. Longitudinal studies in Germany show that people with longer commutes consistently report lower subjective well-being — meaning they feel their lives are worse. Again, this loss in time isn't offset by any gain in income or housing quality. A comprehensive review of multiple studies confirms that longer commutes lead to greater dissatisfaction, regardless of the mode of transport used. Reducing one-way travel time by 30 minutes yields roughly 5 extra hours per week.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Point of contention: Chatterjee et al., after analyzing various studies, argue that no consistent link exists between commute length and overall life satisfaction. They suggest that people can generally offset the downsides of long commutes by securing better jobs or housing. It's also worth noting that transportation statistics include all trips, not just commuting, and that avoiding rush hour can also shorten travel time on the same route.

# 5. Do not waste money

This section counts only money: how much can be saved, how much the yearly gain differs, and how much a sum returns when it is averaged over a long stretch. These are not converted into years of life or into time. Items that involve investing only explain how to do the arithmetic. They use only historical figures that have been checked. None of them is investment advice.

The items are grouped by subject below. Item numbers are in parentheses.

**Everyday spending**: turn off automatic renewals (item 1), recalculate the mobile and broadband plans (item 4), refuse extended warranties on electronics (item 11), choose drugs selected in pooled procurement (item 12), drink boiled tap water (item 14), pay for the gym by the visit (item 21), set a cooling-off period on a large purchase (item 23), do not stock up because of a crossed-out price (item 24).

**Impulse spending and children's money**: do not buy lottery tickets (item 5), do not tip livestreamers (item 8), a child's top-ups and tips can be claimed back (item 9), anyone who has a child read out a verification code is a scammer (item 10), count bracelets and trendy toys as money already spent (item 33), for jewellery and jade accept only a CMA report (item 34), blind boxes, card draws, and other sales by chance (item 35).

**Online shopping and getting the money back**: a written contract for money paid in advance (item 22), online shopping follows the platform's rules (item 29), something bought in a livestream goes wrong (item 30), unsafe food is ten times the price (item 31), check sampling tests and certification before a large purchase (item 32), if you want to read the ingredient list, buy pre-packaged food (item 36).

**Tax, the housing fund, and medical insurance**: the individual-income-tax settlement (item 2), the housing fund can also be withdrawn for rent and for renovation (item 3), bind family sharing of the medical-insurance account (item 13), the personal pension account (item 20), if you pay employee pension insurance yourself, pay at the lowest band (item 46).

**Saving, borrowing, and investing**: walk away the moment you see a high return (item 6), turn borrowing into an annual rate first (item 7), do not trade stocks often (item 15), do not borrow to invest (item 16), a broad index fund as the base holding (item 17), pick a fund with a low fee (item 18), do not put the money in one place (item 19), save an emergency fund first (item 27), compare before paying a mortgage off early (item 28), sell a stock that has lost money by the rule (item 37), buy U.S. stocks through QDII or Stock Connect (item 38), do not buy virtual currency (item 45).

**Insurance**: prefer insurance you pay for and do not get back (item 25), buy enough third-party liability cover (item 26), insure only losses you cannot carry (item 39), buy term life first for the person who earns (item 40), surrender inside the cooling-off period (item 41), at a bank counter, tell a deposit from insurance (item 42), do not hire an agent to surrender a policy (item 43), name a specific person as beneficiary (item 44).

**Buying a car**: inspect the car when you collect it (item 47), write on a used car that it is not an accident car (item 48), do not pay a financial-service fee at a 4S store (item 49).

## 1. Turn off all automatic renewals and switch to manual renewal upon expiry

**Cost**. No cost at all. Simply review the lists of automatic payments in Alipay, WeChat Pay, Apple, and Android — this takes only 10 to 20 minutes. From then on, you'll need to manually initiate each renewal yourself.

**In plain terms**. What you'll save is exactly the money spent on subscriptions you no longer use but are still being charged for each month. It takes less than 20 minutes to go through the automatic payment lists in Alipay, WeChat Pay, Apple, and Android. By regulation, merchants must provide a clear notice before charging you, along with an easy-to-find and readily accessible option to cancel at any time.

**Benefit**. The amount saved equals the total cost of those subscriptions you no longer need yet continue to pay for. This varies from person to person, so there's no single universal figure. Regulatory rules also require

merchants to give you a clear pre-charge notice and a simple, cost-free option to cancel at any time (China, effective since 2021).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. For services you actually use regularly, annual subscriptions are generally cheaper than monthly ones, so keeping automatic renewal on for these is more cost-effective. You should only turn off automatic renewal for those subscriptions you've long forgotten about yet are still being charged for.

## 2. Conduct the annual tax reconciliation from March to June; be sure to include all eligible special deductions

**Cost**. No cost involved. The process can be completed in just a few minutes via the “Individual Income Tax” app.

**In plain terms**. The following groups of people typically receive a tax refund after completing this process: those who only worked for a few months throughout the year, those who changed jobs mid-year, or anyone who failed to claim deductions for child education, mortgage payments, rent, or elderly dependents. It takes only a few minutes to finish on a mobile device. If your total annual income falls below 120,000 yuan, or if the amount of tax you owe is under 400 yuan, you may skip this step.

**Benefit**. This process consolidates calculations for four types of income: wages and salaries, labor remuneration, author's fees, and royalties. Any overpaid tax is refunded to you, while any underpaid amounts must be paid up. There are two scenarios where you may forgo this process: when your total annual income is under 120,000 yuan, or when the tax you owe is less than 400 yuan. These thresholds were set by the State Taxation Administration in 2023 and remain in effect through December 31, 2027. Conversely, the groups mentioned above are precisely those who usually qualify for a tax refund after completing the reconciliation.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Even individuals who owe tax must complete this process; failure to do so is illegal. There are seven categories of special deductions available: child education, continuing education, major illness medical expenses, mortgage interest payments, rent payments, elderly dependents support, and childcare expenses for children under three. Note that you may claim either mortgage interest or rent deductions, but not both.

## 3. Housing provident fund isn't just for buying a home: it can be used for renting, home renovations, and paying property taxes, effective from September 20, 2026 under new regulations

**Cost**. No cost at all. You only need to complete the withdrawal application once.

**In plain terms**. The housing provident fund isn't limited to home purchases. The new regulations list nine eligible scenarios for withdrawals, including renting, renovating a personal residence, and paying property taxes. Once you submit an application, the housing provident fund authority must respond within three days whether your request is approved or not.

**Benefit**. The updated regulations expand eligible withdrawal scenarios to nine total. These include covering rental payments, funding home renovations, and paying property taxes for a residence you own. The housing provident fund authority must issue a decision on your application within three days of receiving it, either granting or denying the withdrawal request.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The funds in your account consist of your own salary contributions plus matching contributions from your employer. If left untouched, these funds earn only a very low rate of interest. The regulations also specify that in cases of employee death or declared death, heirs and legal beneficiaries may withdraw the full account balance. Exact required documents and application procedures are determined locally by each regional housing provident fund authority, so be sure to check your local guidelines before applying.

## 4. Recalculate your mobile and broadband plans annually: downgrade unused services, and file a complaint if the carrier refuses to comply

**Cost**. No expense at all. It takes just a few minutes to review your bill. The real challenge is resisting the pressure from customer service reps who try to dissuade you from downgrading.

**In plain terms**. Older plans you're currently on often cost dozens of yuan more per month than newer plans now on sale. Those extra monthly fees add up to hundreds of yuan wasted each year. By regulation, carriers have no valid reason to reject your request to switch plans, delay processing it, or impose special pricing tiers solely for customers making such changes. If they refuse without justification, you can file a formal complaint.

**Benefit**. Ministry of Industry and Information Technology rules explicitly state that carriers must not “refuse, obstruct, or delay providing number portability services to users without valid reasons”, nor may they “use blocking or restrictive technical measures to compromise the communication service quality of such users”. They are also prohibited from “creating dedicated pricing or marketing plans for customers exercising their right to port their numbers”. Older plans typically cost dozens of yuan more per month than current offerings, so sticking with them results in hundreds of yuan wasted annually.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. First, use your carrier's official app to check your actual monthly data and call usage over the past six months, then choose a plan matching those figures. If a customer service rep claims “you must visit a physical store to downgrade” or “contract terms prevent any changes”, ask for written proof of those claims. If none is provided, file a complaint via the 12300 hotline.

## 5. Not buying lottery tickets

**Cost**. It costs nothing. Not buying means you save money.

**In plain terms**. According to regulations, at least 50% of sales revenue from lottery games must be paid out as prizes; for the Double Color Ball game, this figure is 51%. In other words, for every 1 yuan you spend, you can expect to receive back only 0.51 yuan on average over time — meaning you lose 49% of your money. In 2024, China sold 623.486 billion yuan worth of lottery tickets; of that amount, 161.031 billion yuan went directly into public welfare funds and was never distributed as prizes.

**Benefit**. Fiscal regulations set minimum payout ratios: 50% for lottery and number-based games, 65% for instant-win games, and 73% for wagering games. For the Double Color Ball game, 51% of sales revenue is allocated to prizes, which means only 51 yuan out of every 100 yuan spent is paid out as winnings. On a personal level, this translates to an average return of just 0.51 yuan per 1 yuan spent over time — a net loss of 49%. In 2024, total lottery sales in China reached 623.486 billion yuan; 161.031 billion yuan of that amount was earmarked for public welfare and never returned to players (China, 2024).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Over the long run, buying lottery tickets guarantees a financial loss; this is a fixed rule of the system and has nothing to do with luck. Buying tickets is fine if you treat it as a form of entertainment costing 2 yuan per play, but it should never be viewed as a way to invest or save money.

## 6. Walk away the moment you see “high returns,” “guaranteed returns,” or “sure profits”

**Cost**. Zero. Just pause for a moment when you encounter these phrases.

**In plain terms**. Regulatory authorities themselves state that any product offering a return rate above 6% should raise red flags, those above 8% are highly risky, and anything above 10% means you should expect to lose all your principal. Legitimate financial products are no longer allowed to guarantee returns or principal safety. Any losses incurred from participating in illegal fundraising efforts must be borne by the individual investor; there is no one to compensate you if things go wrong.

**Benefit**. In 2018, the former chairperson of the China Banking and Insurance Regulatory Commission stated at the Lujiazui Forum: “Any product offering a return rate above 6% should raise red flags, those above 8% are highly risky, and anything above 10% means you should expect to lose all your principal.” New regulations for asset management require financial institutions to “not guarantee returns or principal safety,” and also stipulate that “when facing difficulties in fulfilling payment obligations, financial institutions must not provide any form of financial support to honor their commitments.” Hence, legitimate financial products no longer offer any guarantee of principal safety. Any losses from illegal fundraising efforts are “to be borne by the individual investors themselves”; no one will compensate you if you suffer losses (China, 2018, 2021).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The 6%, 8%, and 10% thresholds are estimates set by regulators based on practical experience, not formal legal provisions. These figures were mentioned in the context of cracking down on illegal fundraising efforts, and apply specifically to financial products and investment firms that promise unusually high returns. This information does not constitute any form of investment advice.

## 7. Do not use a credit card's minimum payment, and do not open an installment plan or a consumer loan for spending. If you must borrow, turn the interest into an annual rate before you compare

**Cost**. No money. You need enough cash on hand to pay the statement in full before the due date. The hard part is holding off from spreading a large purchase into installments. When you must borrow, spend a few minutes asking the annual rate of each loan.

**In plain terms**. The minimum payment is a loan that charges interest by the day, about 18% over a year, and using it cancels the interest-free period. An installment that says "0.6% fee per month" is about 13.8% a year, not 7.2%. The principal is being paid down each month, but the fee is still charged on the original amount. To see which loan costs more, look only at the annual rate, not the daily interest or the monthly fee rate.

**Benefit**. Before 2020, credit-card overdraft interest had a ceiling and a floor. The ceiling was a daily rate of five per ten thousand. The floor was 0.7 times the ceiling. Five per ten thousand comes to 18.25% over a year. That is simple interest: counted at 18.25% a year, the interest is not rolled back into the principal. From 2021, the price is set by agreement between the card issuer and the cardholder. After you use the minimum payment, the unpaid principal is charged interest in full every day, and the interest-free period is cancelled at the same time. The central bank already requires card issuers to show the annualized rate (the rate restated over a full year) in an obvious way, and "must not show only the daily rate and the daily repayment amount." From 2021, every lending institution, in advertisements and in contracts, has to write the annualized rate in an obvious way. A daily rate and a monthly rate may be written alongside it, but they must not be more prominent than the annualized rate. The annualized rate has to include the interest and every fee that is directly tied to the loan. Where principal is repaid in installments, how much money you actually had the use of is counted on the principal left after each installment. The People's Bank of China gave a worked example: borrow 100,000 yuan, repay over 12 months, and pay 0.5% of the original principal each month as an installment fee. At the moment of borrowing you also pay a 1,000 yuan service fee. On simple interest, the annualized rate is about 12.80%. On compound interest (the internal-rate-of-return method), it is about 13.58%. Looking only at the fee rate, it looks like 0.5% × 12 + 1% = 7% a year. The real figure is about twice that, because the principal falls each month while the installment fee is still charged on 100,000 yuan. The same method, applied to a credit card in 12 installments at 0.6% fee per installment and no other fee, is nominally 7.2% a year. On compound interest it is about 13.8% a year, about 1.9 times the nominal figure. From 6 to 36 installments, the multiple stays between 1.8 and 2 times. If the person lending you the money is an individual or an ordinary company, it is private lending. If the agreed rate is more than 4 times the one-year LPR at the time the contract is signed, the court does not support the part above that. The one-year LPR on 20 August 2026 (2026-8-20) was 3.0%. Four times that is 12%. Interest taken out of the loan at the start is counted by the court on the money you actually received, and that received sum is the principal. This line does not reach banks, consumer-finance companies, and other licensed financial institutions. It also does not apply to seven types of local financial organizations, including small-loan companies, pawnshops, and

financial leasing companies. So you cannot put 12% onto their loans. Look at the annualized rate written in the contract (China, 2020 and 2021).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. 18.25% is "five per ten thousand × 365" multiplied straight through, with no interest on interest. If it truly compounds month by month, it is higher still. A few banks give a discount. Use the annualized rate written on your own statement. When you really cannot turn the cash over, borrow first from a regular channel with a lower rate. Do not leave a minimum payment rolling interest. When you compare two loans, ask for the annualized rate on a compound basis. If what they give you is simple interest, the rules say they must label it "simple interest." Simple interest comes out a bit lower than compound interest. 13.8% and the 1.8 to 2 times are figures this book calculated with the People's Bank method. The method is written in the verification record. Do not touch usurious private loans. See also item 15 of section 7 (do not borrow at usurious rates). Money a shop charges on top when you take a loan to buy a car is in item 49 of this section (the financial-service fee at a 4S store).

## 8. Don't give streamers tips, don't make in-game purchases, and don't make impulsive buys

**Cost**. There is no cost at all. It only takes a few minutes to do three things: turn off automatic payment, set daily and per-transaction limits, and remove any linked payment methods from the platforms. The hard part is resisting the urge to click those buttons right then and there.

**In plain terms**. On average, each gamer in China spends roughly 480 yuan per year on games, and that money is almost impossible to get back. Laws only require refunds for purchases made by minors without parental consent; adults have no such protection. The easiest way to stay on budget is to take preventive steps: disable automatic payments, set spending limits, and unlink payment options.

**Benefit**. This is a substantial expense. In 2024, China's gaming market generated 325.783 billion yuan in revenue, serving 674 million players — an average of about 480 yuan per person (calculated by dividing total revenue by the player count). That money is largely unrecoverable. One exception exists: if a minor (a person with limited civil capacity) makes purchases without a guardian's permission, courts must support the guardian's request for a refund. No such rule applies to adults. Additionally, minors are legally restricted to playing online games only on Fridays, Saturdays, Sundays, and public holidays, and only between 8 pm and 9 pm each day (China, 2020-2021).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This is graded as B because no direct studies have measured exactly how much money can be saved by avoiding tips and purchases; we only have aggregate industry figures. Turning off automatic payments and setting limits are widely recommended practices, which would merit a C rating on their own. The exact wording of Articles 19 and 145 of the Civil Code is already quoted verbatim in Item 9 (about minors making in-app purchases). This information is not financial advice.

## 9. When kids make in-app purchases or send gifts, parents can demand refunds for large sums spent by kids over eight if they never gave consent

**Cost**. There's no direct monetary cost, but it does take time to gather evidence and negotiate with platforms. Most platforms initially refuse refunds but eventually comply. If talks fail, legal action becomes necessary — a process that can take months and requires paying attorney fees out of pocket. Thus, it's far more efficient to compile all relevant documentation first and approach both the platform and China's 12315 consumer hotline. The real challenge lies in getting the child to cooperate and share details.

**In plain terms**. Money spent by children over eight years old can be legally invalidated and refunded if the amount far exceeds what one would reasonably expect for their age and level of maturity, and if parents neither approved nor acknowledged the transaction. For kids under eight, any spending is automatically

considered invalid, as they lack legal capacity to make such decisions. Even silence from parents is interpreted by law as a refusal to acknowledge the expense.

**Benefit**. Minors aged eight and older are classified as having limited legal capacity — meaning they may only engage in activities appropriate to their age and maturity level. Any financial transaction beyond that scope requires explicit approval or retroactive acknowledgment from a legal guardian. Conversely, children under eight are deemed completely incapable of independent decision-making; all actions must be handled by their guardians. In the absence of any affirmative response from parents, the law presumes they reject the transaction.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The crux of success lies in proving that a child — not a parent — performed the transaction. Helpful evidence includes: transaction timestamps coinciding with school hours or times when parents are at work; device usage logs; chat histories and gaming records; and a direct statement from the child. There is no fixed monetary threshold defining “age-appropriate” spending — a few dozen yuan spent on game skins differs vastly from tens of thousands spent on virtual gifts. Prevention is far easier: set spending limits without requiring passwords, enable youth protection modes, and never disclose payment codes to children. For cases where parents themselves impulsively make such purchases, refer to the section titled “Avoid giving gifts to streamers, making in-game purchases, or acting on impulse.”

## 10. Teaching kids one key phrase: anyone who asks them to use a parent's phone to enter verification codes is a scammer

**Cost**. There's no cost involved. Simply explain these six types of scams to your child, then agree on this phrase: “If you're scammed, tell me right away and I won't scold you.” Also set a spending limit for cashless payments, enable teen mode, and never share the payment password with your child. The hardest part is resisting the urge to get angry if they actually fall victim to a scam.

**In plain terms**. Each of these six scams works differently, but they all end the same way: the scammer gets the child to use a parent's phone to transfer money or read out verification codes. That's why this single phrase is enough: anyone who asks your child to use a parent's phone or read out verification codes is a scammer. Add this follow-up line too: “If you're scammed, tell me right away and I won't scold you.” Only if the child feels safe enough to speak up immediately is there any chance of recovering the stolen funds.

**Benefit**. The Quanzhou Anti-Fraud Center and Quanzhou Education Bureau identified six common scams targeting teens. Though their methods vary, they all culminate in the same action: getting the child to transfer money via a parent's phone. First, fake offers for cheap gaming accounts and gear. One boy transferred 260 yuan privately, then the scammer told him “transactions by minors are against the rules and your account will be frozen,” and tricked him into clicking a “verification link” using his dad's phone, which led to over 30,000 yuan being stolen. Second, “removing anti-addiction restrictions.” Scammers threatened “if you don't transfer money, your parents will go to jail,” so the child used his mom's phone to send 7,000 yuan. Official rules make it clear there are no “unofficial ways” to lift these restrictions. Third, fake refund offers for in-game purchases. Impostors posing as “official customer service” claimed refunds were possible if parents used Alipay to send gifts to a specific livestream; this resulted in 73,000 yuan being spent on gifts, after which the scammers cut off contact. Official guidance states “anyone asking you to ‘send gifts to get a refund' is 100% a scam.” Fourth, impersonating classmates or teachers. Scammers hack accounts to send voice messages calling the child by name and asking for money. At the start of the school year, they also join class groups pretending to be teachers, posting “pay 500 yuan for school fees” with identical profile pictures and nicknames to real teachers, even enlisting “accomplices” in the group to confirm “I've already paid.” Fifth, fake fan group offers. Scammers lure kids into “celebrity fan groups” promising 888 yuan in cash prizes; first they ask for a 48.88 yuan “verification fee,” then threaten “since minors aren't allowed to join, the platform will freeze 80,000 yuan and your parents will go to jail” — this led to 16,000 yuan being stolen. Official guidance stresses “real police officers or lawyers never contact minors online to investigate, nor do they ever ask parents to operate phones.” Sixth, fake low-price listings on second-hand platforms that lure buyers off the site for private transactions. The same materials also list three red lines kids must never cross: first, never

lend, sell or rent bank cards or SIM cards, as using them to move illicit funds can lead to criminal charges that affect future college admissions or civil service exams; second, “mobile voice acting” gigs are illegal; third, “high-paying overseas jobs” often turn out to be traps where victims are held captive upon arrival (Quanzhou, October 2025).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This is graded B because the source materials provide detailed breakdowns of scammer tactics and specific case examples, but there are no statistics on overall incidence rates or the effectiveness of preventive measures. This is distinct from Item 9, where kids spending money on in-game purchases can request refunds under civil law. Funds stolen by scammers fall outside this scope and must be reported under Section 8, Clause 2 to freeze transactions; recovery depends on whether the money remains in the account. The core scammer line “you've broken the rules and your parents will go to jail” is a dead giveaway of fraud — explaining this to kids beforehand is far more effective than trying to question them after the fact. It's also crucial to actually follow through on the promise “if you're scammed, tell me right away and I won't scold you.” In all these cases, kids' reluctance to speak up due to fear of punishment was a key reason losses kept growing. For adult versions of impersonation scams and AI face-swapping tactics, see Section 8, Clauses 3 and 4 (core anti-fraud rules, and always hang up first if a transfer is requested). Adults are the same: never read verification codes aloud or do face scans for anyone else; see Section 8, item 45 (reading verification codes).

## 11. Skipping extended warranties for electronics

**Cost**. There's no upfront cost. The trade-off is that once the standard warranty expires, you'll have to pay out-of-pocket for any repairs — though this scenario is relatively rare.

**In plain terms**. Extended warranties typically cost 10% to 50% of the item's original price. Sellers of these warranties earn profit margins 10 to 20 times higher than those on regular goods, and this price gap is exactly what you're paying extra for. For major components like washing machine motors and refrigerator compressors, national regulations mandate a 3-year warranty period. If you come across a very cheap extended warranty, calculate its cost divided by the average repair cost for that item: this ratio gives the minimum probability of a breakdown within those years needed for the warranty to be worth the expense.

**Benefit**. Extended warranties are usually priced at 10% to 50% of the original product cost. Industry estimates cited in research show average gross margins on these warranties range from 50% to 60%: for every 100 yuan in sales, sellers earn 50 to 60 yuan in profit, which is roughly 18 times the gross margin of standard consumer goods. In 2003, extended warranties accounted for just 3% to 4% of Best Buy's total revenue, yet generated over 50% of its total profits (based on U.S. retail data from the 2000s). For warranties priced far below this benchmark, you can run the same calculation: warranty cost ÷ average repair cost = the minimum breakdown probability required to make the purchase worthwhile. You should only buy a warranty if you estimate the chance of a breakdown at least once during its term is higher than this calculated value. For example, if an extended warranty costs 25 yuan and the average repair cost for the item is 300 yuan, the probability of at least one breakdown during the warranty period must exceed roughly 8% for it to be a smart purchase. The 300 yuan figure here is just a hypothetical example, not an actual statistical value. Before doing this calculation, subtract the coverage period already guaranteed by national regulations: the statutory warranty period starts on the date of purchase, with a 1-year coverage period for the entire washing machine or refrigerator, and a 3-year coverage period for their major components. For washing machines, these major components include the motor, timer, control board, and capacitors; for refrigerators, they are the compressor and temperature control unit. Paying for an extended warranty during any period where it overlaps with the statutory warranty means you're paying extra for coverage you're already entitled to (national regulations, effective since 1995).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The gross margin figure cited above is an industry estimate referenced in a research paper from Business Week in 2004, not a value measured directly by the paper's authors. The calculation method described works for ordinary consumers who can afford to pay for a single repair out of pocket. People who

rely on a single device for their livelihood and have no backup device should perform a separate calculation. Separate calculations are also needed for product-specific add-ons like phone screen protection plans: first estimate how often you expect to drop your device, then assess whether the premium is justified. Even very cheap extended warranties won't cost you more than a few dozen yuan in extra expense, but before buying one, verify three key details: the start date of coverage (most start on the purchase date, so the first few years overlap with the statutory warranty), whether the warranty is provided by the retailer, the brand manufacturer, or a third-party provider, and whether there are extra charges for on-site service or replacement parts. It's also worth checking the product manual and original warranty card, as some brands offer longer coverage periods than the statutory minimum.

## 12. Prefer generic drugs that have passed consistency evaluation and those selected in centralized procurement

**Cost**. No cost at all. When a doctor prescribes medication or you go to buy medicine, simply ask: “Is there a generic version included in the centralized procurement program?”

**In plain terms**. The second batch of centrally procured drugs saw an average price drop of 53%, with some drugs becoming 93% cheaper. As of April 2026, 11 procurement rounds have been completed, covering 490 different drugs. Asking for generic drugs from this program ensures you get the same ingredients at a much lower price.

**Benefit**. The national centralized drug procurement initiative resulted in a 53% average price reduction for the second batch, with some drugs dropping by as much as 93%. By April 2026, 11 rounds had been conducted, covering 490 drugs. A total of 1,695 drugs have either passed or are considered to have met consistency evaluation standards, accounting for roughly two-thirds of all commonly used chemical drugs in China (official data from 2020–2026).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. There is some debate: some claim that consistency evaluation only checks ingredients, not actual therapeutic effects. This is only partially true. The evaluation process involves giving healthy volunteers the drug and measuring its concentration levels in their blood over time; if those levels fall within 80%–125% of those produced by the original brand-name drug, it is deemed acceptable. For drugs where dosage variations can be dangerous, stricter criteria apply. Excipients—substances other than the active ingredient used for filling or coating—may differ from those in the original drug, as regulations only require identical active ingredients, dosage form, administration method, and therapeutic purpose. Consequently, consistency evaluation does not involve testing the drug on patients to gauge effectiveness; that is assessed through separate research. The National Healthcare Security Administration has conducted real-world studies involving 63 centrally procured drugs, nearly 100 top-tier hospitals, and over 300,000 patients; results consistently showed no difference compared to original brand-name drugs. For example, with metformin, the rate of achieving target HbA1c levels was 83.4% for generic users versus 78.9% for brand-name users; conversely, for fasting blood glucose control, generic users achieved a 83.8% success rate compared to 87.6% for brand-name users. In January 2025, some doctors claimed that centrally procured drugs failed to lower blood pressure, induce anesthesia, or treat diarrhea; investigations by healthcare authorities at seven Shanghai hospitals found these claims largely stemmed from hearsay and personal experience; one of the cited diarrhea medications had not yet been used in hospitals at the time. It was also acknowledged that nine problematic drugs were disqualified from the first nine procurement rounds involving over 1,600 products—six of these were imported drugs, including three original brand-name products, while three were domestic products. Two practical steps can be taken: first, original brand-name drugs remain widely available, as centralized procurement accounts for only 60%–80% of hospital purchases; patients can still obtain them at higher cost. Second, for chronic disease patients switching to generic drugs, it is vital to monitor blood pressure, blood sugar, and HbA1c levels regularly (as outlined in Section 16, point 3) rather than relying on subjective feelings; if results worsen, consult a doctor and report any adverse reactions—never discontinue medication on your own.

## 13. Once you set up family medical expense sharing in the yibao app, funds from your individual medical insurance account can be used to pay for your spouse, parents, and children's medical care and medication

**Cost**. No cost at all. You can set up family medical expense sharing either through your local medical insurance app or by visiting a local medical insurance office.

**In plain terms**. After completing this setup, any money in your individual yibao account can be used to cover medical expenses and medication costs for your spouse, parents, and children. Without this setup, those funds remain locked in your account for your own use only.

**Benefit**. Funds in your individual medical insurance account can be used to pay for any out-of-pocket medical costs you, your spouse, parents, or children incur at designated medical institutions. They can also be used to cover out-of-pocket costs for purchasing medicines, medical devices, and other medical supplies at designated retail pharmacies. Additional plans are also in place to explore allowing these funds to be used to pay for basic medical insurance premiums for eligible family members.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Many people have thousands of yuan sitting unused in their individual medical insurance accounts, while elderly family members often have to pay for medicines out of pocket. This setup is valid for the long term once completed. Most regions refer to this service as “family medical expense sharing”, and it can be set up directly through local medical insurance apps. There is a strict rule against using these funds for fitness activities, wellness services, or similar purposes. Using these funds to buy health supplements at pharmacies for cash payouts is considered insurance fraud.

## 14. Drink boiled tap water; don't subscribe to water-cooler barrels or buy bottled water year-round

**Cost**. You only need to purchase a kettle. Boiling water takes a bit of time, plus there are minimal gas or electricity costs.

**In plain terms**. In Beijing, tap water works out to 0.005 yuan per liter. Water-cooler barrel water at 20 yuan a barrel comes to about 1 yuan per liter, more than 200 times as much. A household that drinks one barrel a week spends a little over 1,000 yuan a year, while the same amount of tap water costs under 5 yuan. Tap water is covered by a mandatory national standard, so boiling it is enough in normal times. When the water smells foul or looks cloudy, boiling won't fix it: stop drinking it and report the problem.

**Benefit**. The first-tier residential water price in Beijing is 5 yuan per cubic meter, which equals 0.005 yuan per liter. A barrel of water for a household water cooler holds 18.9 liters; at 20 yuan per barrel that is about 1.06 yuan per liter, roughly 210 times the price of tap water. A household that drinks one barrel a week uses 52 barrels a year, about 983 liters: barrel water costs about 1,040 yuan, while the same amount of tap water costs about 4.9 yuan. Small bottled water at 1 yuan per 500 milliliters is 2 yuan per liter, 400 times the price of tap water. Tap water must comply with the mandatory national standard GB 5749-2022, which was issued on March 15, 2022, and took effect on April 1, 2023. The National Disease Control and Prevention Administration oversees this standard (Chinese water prices in 2015 vs. the 2022 standard)

**Evidence grade**. C (controversial)

**Notes**. The controversy stems from the fact that “compliance” is assessed only for water leaving treatment plants and at pipe endpoints. When the water source or distribution network is compromised, these standards may be temporarily unmet. On July 16, 2025, the raw water entering the Renhe Water Plant in Yuhang, Hangzhou, had an unusual odor, causing tap water in parts of Renhe and Liangzhu to smell foul. Officials attributed this to algae decomposing under low-oxygen conditions, producing sulfur-containing compounds. After switching to a different water source, tests showed no traces of total coliforms or E. coli in the treated water, and all other parameters met GB 5749-2022 requirements. Seven officials were held accountable, all July water bills were waived, and free water filters were distributed. Yet, fecal coliform counts at this same water source had been rising for months prior to the incident: at the Yongsheng intake

point on the Tiaoxi River, counts rose from 10 per liter in April to 7,300 per liter in May and 16,000 per liter in June — exceeding the GB 3838 Class III surface water limit of 10,000 per liter. Counts at Siling Reservoir and Mantoushan Reservoir also surpassed this threshold that month at 28,000 and 24,000 per liter respectively. Boiling water only kills microorganisms; it cannot remove foul odors or dissolved chemicals. If water smells odd or appears yellow or cloudy, stop drinking it, report it to your water provider and via 12345, and temporarily switch to bottled water — but don't expect a few extra minutes of boiling to resolve the issue. These incidents are localized and occasional; local compensation was provided, so they do not justify buying bottled water year-round. Online claims about “incorrectly connected sewage pipes” are fabrications based on fake police reports; the poster has since been criminally detained (see Section 9). The 20 yuan per barrel for barrel water and the 1 yuan per 500 milliliters for bottled water are both hypothetical figures for calculation purposes; use the actual prices in your own city instead. Barrel water is not the cleaner option either: the Chongqing Municipal Market Supervision Administration warns that the longer a barrel sits after opening, the higher the risk of microbial contamination, and a water cooler should be cleaned at least every 2 to 3 months. Residents in older neighborhoods with substandard secondary water supply systems may install filters or buy bottled water only in such cases. Water prices vary by region, so the Beijing figure is merely illustrative.

## 15. Infrequent stock trading

**Cost**. There are no monetary costs. The real challenge is resisting the urge to trade whenever you see market news.

**In plain terms**. Among investors who trade most frequently, the average annual return is only 11.4%, while the overall market average for the same period is 17.9%. This gap of over 6 percentage points is almost entirely caused by the transaction fees incurred with each trade. If these fees are excluded, the returns of frequent and infrequent traders end up being quite similar.

**Benefit**. This study analyzed 66,465 household accounts at US discount brokerage firms between 1991 and 1996. The group of investors who traded most often achieved an annualized return of 11.4%, while the overall market average was 17.9%, and the average return for all households was 16.4%. On average, these households turned over 75% of their stock holdings each year, swapping out three quarters of their portfolio annually. The gross returns (before transaction fees) of frequent and infrequent traders differed only slightly, meaning the performance gap is largely driven by trading costs (USA, 1991–1996).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These data are from the United States in the 1990s. While the commission and stamp duty structures for A-share markets differ, the core principle remains the same: higher trading frequency leads to lower net returns. This information is not intended as investment advice. 〔2014〕 〔2014〕 〔2014〕 〔2014〕 〔2014〕 〔85〕 〔85〕 〔85〕 〔250000000000〕 〔250000000000〕 〔40000000〕 〔150〕 〔5166.35〕 〔0.5〕 〔0.5〕 〔880000000000〕 〔808000000000〕 〔254000000000〕 〔2012〕

## 16. Don't borrow money to invest, avoid leverage, and never buy assets you don't understand

**Cost**. Zero expense. The hard part is resisting the urge to “borrow some cash to make extra profits” when the market is doing well.

**In plain terms**. When you use borrowed money to buy stocks, any drop below a set threshold leaves you unable to add more funds, so your positions get automatically sold off. The paper losses instantly become real losses, leaving you no chance to wait for the price to rebound. Regulatory rules state that people who have held an account for less than six months or whose average daily assets over the past 20 trading days are under 500,000 RMB cannot open margin trading accounts. This threshold alone makes it clear this tool isn't meant for ordinary investors.

**Benefit**. Leverage essentially means borrowing money to make purchases, which also magnifies potential losses. After opening a margin account, the market value of your collateral may fall below the minimum

maintenance margin set by your broker, which governs the assets you've pledged to them. If the value drops below this threshold and you fail to add more collateral to bring it back up, your positions get forcibly liquidated, with the broker selling them on your behalf. Paper losses turn into actual losses right away, with no window to wait for a price recovery. The same regulatory rules apply here: clients with less than six months of trading experience, insufficient risk tolerance, or average daily securities assets under 500,000 RMB over the past 20 trading days are barred from opening credit trading accounts. This requirement further proves it is not a suitable tool for regular investors (China, 2015).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. There is no direct academic evidence supporting the advice “never buy assets you don't understand”; this is widely accepted industry consensus, so it is classified as grade C. Using consumer loans or credit card cash advances for investing also counts as a form of leverage; their interest rates are covered in section 7 of this chapter (“avoid minimum credit card payments”). This content does not constitute investment advice.

## 17. Using broad-market index funds instead of actively managed funds as a long-term core holding (the portion of money you keep invested for years)

**Cost**. There is no direct monetary cost. The trade-off is that you give up the chance of picking a “star fund manager.” The harder part is that when the index drops, you must endure those losses too — you can't simply sell out midway.

**In plain terms**. The collection of stocks held by actively managed funds already closely mirrors the overall market. Yet the extra management fees they charge are deducted straight from your actual returns. When we repeatedly re-randomize fund performance data to test how much luck plays a role, very few funds manage to generate enough outperformance to offset those fees.

**Benefit**. Collectively, U.S. actively managed equity funds hold a portfolio very similar to the broader market. However, their high management costs directly translate into lower net returns for investors after fees are deducted. This research used a bootstrap simulation method to repeatedly shuffle fund performance data and gauge how much could be attributed to luck alone. The results show that only a tiny fraction of funds achieve excess returns large enough to cover their fees (U.S., published 2010). S&P Dow Jones Indices conducts an annual review: in 2024, 65% of U.S. actively managed large-cap equity funds underperformed the S&P 500. Over a 24-year span, an average of 64% underperformed each year. In the 15 years ending 2024, no single fund category saw a majority of active funds outperforming their respective benchmarks.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Debate exists: one study re-examined this conclusion and argued that the original Fama-French methodology of repeatedly re-sampling data might be overly strict. Under that approach, even funds with genuinely strong outperformance could be classified as “no different from luck.” Thus, the claim that “almost no active funds possess skill” might be overstated. In China, the data is less one-sided than in the U.S. As of June 2025, S&P Dow Jones statistics show that for A-share large-cap active funds, 60.5% underperformed the S&P China A 300 Index over one year, 69.6% over three years, and 50.8% over five years. This dataset only covers up to five years, so longer-term figures remain unavailable. Consequently, while it is still uncertain whether active funds consistently underperform in China, the advantage of lower fees for index funds remains valid. This information does not constitute investment advice.

## 18. When picking similar funds, go for those with lower fees

**Cost**. There's no upfront cost to pay. Before buying, just check how much the sum of the management fee, custody fee, and sales service fee comes to.

**In plain terms**. For every 1 percentage point increase in a fund's annual fee, the amount you end up with after 20 years drops by roughly 18%, and after 30 years by about 26%. Among funds in the same category, picking one with lower fees is the only thing you can be certain of in advance.

**Benefit**. The difference in fees gradually erodes your principal through compound interest — that tiny amount deducted each year adds up over time. If a fund's annual fee is 1 percentage point higher, the final value after 20 years will be roughly 0.99^20, or 18.2%, lower than it would have been otherwise; after 30 years, the drop is about 26%. Since 2023, China has rolled out reforms to fund fees, capping the management fee for actively managed equity funds at 1.2% and the custody fee at 0.2% for newly registered funds as of July 7, 2023. 136 fund companies have also lowered these fees for their existing products to meet these limits.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. This calculation follows the standard formula and assumes both funds generate identical pre-fee returns. In reality, you'd also need to factor in subscription fees, redemption fees, and sales service fees for Class C shares. This information does not constitute investment advice.

## 19. Don't put all your money into one stock, one platform, or one property

**Cost**. No cost at all. The hard part is accepting that you won't always pick the single most profitable option.

**In plain terms**. As long as multiple assets don't all rise or fall in perfect unison, spreading your money across them keeps your average expected returns the same, while reducing the ups and downs of your account balance. Conversely, if you invest all your funds in just one stock, platform, or property, any trouble with it directly impacts your entire portfolio.

**Benefit**. When several assets do not move in perfect lockstep, diversifying your investments maintains your expected returns while lowering overall volatility. This is the core conclusion of Markowitz's 1952 portfolio theory, which has remained foundational for decades. On the other hand, putting all your money into one single stock or platform means its variance becomes your total portfolio variance — any rise or fall in its value directly affects your portfolio, with no other assets to offset losses when problems arise.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This is rated as a B grade because the original academic paper relies purely on mathematical derivation, without providing concrete figures on exactly how much diversification reduces potential losses. Diversification can only lessen the fluctuations of your portfolio balance, it does not guarantee you won't suffer any losses. Buying broad-based index funds (see item 17 in this section) is the easiest way to achieve effective diversification. This information is not intended as investment advice.

## 20. Individuals paying income tax at a rate of 10% or higher can open a private pension account; up to 12,000 yuan per year can be deducted from taxable income. For those paying no tax or only a 3% rate, opening such an account is not worthwhile

**Cost**. There is no fee to open the account. The real cost is that the funds remain locked until retirement — they cannot be withdrawn in the interim.

**In plain terms**. For every yuan you contribute, the tax you save equals your marginal tax rate minus 3%. If you contribute the maximum 12,000 yuan annually, someone at a 10% rate saves 840 yuan, at 20% saves 2,040 yuan, and at 30% saves 3,240 yuan. Those paying only 3% tax end up paying that same 3% again when they withdraw funds, essentially locking their money away for no net benefit. Likewise, individuals who pay no tax must pay 3% upon withdrawal, resulting in a net loss.

**Benefit**. Contributions up to 12,000 yuan per year can be fully deducted from your total taxable income — the amount you deposit reduces your taxable base exactly by that amount. Any investment returns generated within the account are exempt from personal income tax for now. Upon withdrawal, those returns are taxed separately at a flat 3% rate, rather than being added to your overall income. Consequently, your total tax savings equal (your marginal tax rate minus 3%) multiplied by your actual contributions. Marginal tax rate refers to the percentage applied to each additional yuan earned. In practice, those at a 10% marginal rate save

up to 840 yuan yearly; at 20%, up to 2,040 yuan; at 30%, up to 3,240 yuan. People whose total annual income stays below the tax threshold gain nothing from contributing, and actually incur a 3% penalty upon withdrawal. Likewise, individuals whose marginal rate is only 3% receive no net advantage. This rate applies to anyone whose annual income after deductions remains at or below 36,000 yuan. For them, the 3% tax saved at contribution is exactly offset by the 3% tax due at withdrawal, leaving their funds locked for no reason. Keep in mind that paying income tax each month does not necessarily mean you fall into the 10% bracket; it depends on your total annual taxable income. The annual contribution limit resets each calendar year and cannot be carried over. This policy has been implemented nationwide since 15 December 2024.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This account operates on a closed system — once funds are deposited, they cannot be withdrawn except under four specific circumstances: reaching retirement age, becoming totally disabled, emigrating, or as otherwise stipulated by law. It is therefore not a typical investment vehicle but a long-term tax-saving arrangement. Before contributing, calculate exactly how much tax you would pay on each additional yuan you earn. Avoid using emergency savings for this purpose (see item 27). You must also select suitable investment products within the account; there is risk of loss. Selection criteria mirror those outlined in items 17 and 18 of this chapter: broad-based index funds with low fees are preferred. Proof of deduction is issued by the Private Pension Information Management Service Platform. You may choose when to apply the deduction — either at the time of monthly payroll withholding or during the following year's tax reconciliation (see item 2). 〔1.7〕

## 21. Paying for gym visits individually or on short-term plans is only worthwhile if you have a consistent attendance record spanning over a year

**Cost**. Buying passes individually ends up costing more per visit compared to an annual membership. You'll need to honestly estimate how many times per month you actually plan to go.

**In plain terms**. According to three years of data from U.S. gyms, members who signed contracts with monthly fees exceeding $70 attended the gym just 4.3 times per month on average, which works out to over $17 per visit. Meanwhile, a 10-visit pass costs only $10 per visit. Collectively, these members paid roughly $600 more over their membership period. Unless you've already been going to the gym regularly for at least a year, buying individual passes or short-term plans is far more economical.

**Benefit**. This study analyzed three years of data from 7,752 members at three U.S. fitness clubs. Members opting for monthly plans costing over $70 visited the gym just 4.3 times per month on average, resulting in a per-visit cost exceeding $17. In contrast, a 10-visit pass costs only $10 per visit. Over the same period, these members ended up paying an average of $600 more than they would have with a yearly membership. Additionally, the proportion of monthly-plan members who kept their membership for over a year was 17% higher than that of annual-plan members (based on three years of U.S. panel data).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This is just one study using data from the United States. Nevertheless, its underlying principle is universally applicable: people tend to overestimate their future self-control. If you've already maintained a consistent routine of going to the gym at least twice a week for a full year, then an annual membership does prove to be the cheaper option.

## 22. Sign a written contract before paying a deposit; if a business faces risks, it must stop taking payments, and you have the right to get back any unused balance if it shuts down

**Cost**. No cost involved. The real challenge is insisting on a written contract on the spot — refusing any “pay first, talk later” offers.

**In plain terms**. Any business that accepts a prepayment from you must sign a written contract with you that clearly outlines how refunds will be handled. If a business runs into serious operational problems, it must stop collecting prepayments. Even if it plans to close or relocate, it must give you advance notice. At that point, you can either demand that it continue providing services or request a refund for any unused balance. Violating these rules results in fines for the business.

**Benefit**. The regulations require businesses accepting prepayments to sign written contracts that specify refund procedures. If a business faces major operational risks, it must cease taking prepayments. When a business decides to close or move locations, it must inform consumers ahead of time. Consumers have the right to demand continued service delivery or a refund for any unspent balance. Breaching these rules can lead to fines ranging from 1 to 10 times the illegal earnings; if no illegal earnings exist, fines up to 500,000 yuan may apply.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These regulations mainly serve as a basis for legal action after the fact — they cannot prevent issues beforehand. If a business actually shuts down, its funds are often no longer accessible. Therefore, it is advisable to follow the advice in this section to limit prepayments to small amounts via “pay-per-use” or short-term plans. In case of problems, you can then rely on these regulations to protect your rights. Article 27 of the same regulations also requires businesses collecting deposits to agree in advance on refund methods, procedures, and timeframes, and they cannot impose unreasonable conditions on refunds.

## 23. Implementing a 24-hour cooling-off period for non-essential big-ticket purchases; making full use of the seven-day no-questions-asked return policy for online shopping

**Cost**. No direct monetary cost. You simply have to wait an extra day to receive what you want. Usually, you're responsible for return shipping fees. The real challenge is resisting the urge to place the order on the same day.

**In plain terms**. What you save is exactly the money spent on items you no longer want the very next day. For online purchases, you can return them for any reason within seven days of delivery. There are a few categories excluded from this policy: custom-made items, perishable goods, digital products that have been opened, and newspapers and periodicals.

**Benefit**. What you save is precisely that portion of impulse buys you no longer want after a day. There is no single universal percentage representing this share. As mentioned, online purchases can be returned within seven days of receipt, with the same exclusions applying. This policy has been in effect in China since 2017.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The cooling-off period is essentially a practical measure with no direct academic evidence backing it up. For purchases not deterred by this period, the seven-day no-questions-asked return policy still applies. Before initiating a return, make sure to verify two things: whether the item falls under the excluded categories, and whether its packaging remains intact.

## 24. Don't fall for “strikethrough prices” or impulse buying during sales

**Cost**. Zero monetary cost. The trade-off is that you might miss out on some genuine discounts. You'll need to keep track of the regular prices of the items you buy most often. The real challenge is resisting the urge to stock up on the day of a sale.

**In plain terms**. When judging whether something is cheap or expensive, people rely on the first price they see; later adjustments rarely make up for that initial impression. Thus, a claim like “original price 999, now 499” makes us systematically overestimate how much we're saving. By regulation, the baseline for a discount should be the lowest price at which the item actually sold in the seven days preceding the promotion; the crossed-out price isn't necessarily a real transaction price.

**Benefit**. Human judgment is anchored to the first price encountered, and subsequent corrections are usually insufficient. Consequently, statements such as “original price 999, now 499” inflate our perception of the discount amount. Official rules require that the reference price be the minimum actual sale price recorded in the same store during the seven days prior to the sale; the discount percentage must be calculated against that figure. The price marked through may never have been charged in reality (China, effective 2020).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The anchoring effect is a finding from laboratory studies; no one has quantified exactly how much money consumers lose by over-buying. There are also hidden costs: items may expire, they take up space, and we tend to use them more simply because they're on hand. Only purchase in bulk when all three conditions hold: a long shelf life, a definite need for the product, and a price genuinely lower than its usual cost.

## 25. It's better to choose a non-return insurance plan and treat any “refunds” or dividends as non-guaranteed benefits

**Cost**. With a non-return plan, no money is returned at maturity, which can make it feel like “wasted money.” You'll need to handle your own savings. The hardest part is accepting that this money won't be coming back.

**In plain terms**. The insurance company makes no promises about any dividends or refunds you might receive. Policy documents must explicitly state in bold text that “future policy dividends are non-guaranteed benefits.” The extra premiums paid for return features essentially act as a savings account managed by the insurer; there's no guarantee on returns, and withdrawals are difficult.

**Benefit**. Regulatory rules require that dividend-type products clearly indicate in bold print that “future policy dividends are non-guaranteed benefits, and their distribution is uncertain.” The dividend illustration is the projected payout table provided by the insurer; its maximum interest spread is 4.5% minus the policy's guaranteed interest rate. This guaranteed rate is the fixed return stated in the contract. Premiums paid for return or dividend features function similarly to a savings account held by the insurer — with no guaranteed returns and limited liquidity; withdrawals are hard to arrange (China, effective 2023).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. While return-type insurance can help people who struggle to save by enforcing regular payments, this advice applies mainly to individuals who can manage their own finances. Whether opting for a non-return plan and investing the saved premiums is truly superior to buying a return-type policy depends on the specific product; no systematic data are available to support this comparison here. This information is not financial advice.

## 26. Get sufficient third-party liability coverage: the mandatory insurance limits are uniform nationwide and relatively low, so any excess must be paid out of your own pocket

**Cost**. Commercial third-party liability insurance costs a few hundred to a few thousand yuan per year. The higher the coverage amount you choose, the cheaper the premium becomes per unit of coverage.

**In plain terms**. When you're at fault, the mandatory insurance pays out only up to three specific limits: 180,000 yuan for death or disability, 18,000 yuan for medical expenses, and 2,000 yuan for property damage. These amounts cannot be combined or transferred between categories. Compensation for injuries often exceeds these caps, and any shortfall must be paid by you personally; therefore, it's essential to purchase enough commercial third-party coverage.

**Benefit**. Nationwide, mandatory insurance enforces uniform liability limits. These limits are calculated separately for four categories: death or disability, medical costs, property damage, and compensation payable when you're not at fault. Following the 2020 overhaul of auto insurance, the total maximum payout is now 200,000 yuan, broken down as 180,000 yuan for death/disability, 18,000 yuan for medical costs, and 2,000 yuan for property damage. When you're not liable, the limits drop to 18,000 yuan for death/disability, 1,800

yuan for medical costs, and 100 yuan for property damage. Any amount above these caps must be borne by the responsible party; drivers lacking mandatory coverage face vehicle impoundment and a fine equal to twice the unpaid premium.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These limits are set by financial regulators and may be adjusted over time. The figures cited reflect current values after the September 2020 reforms; it's advisable to verify them before purchasing a policy. Crucially, mandatory insurance pays out per category separately — unused portions cannot be applied toward other categories. Compensation claims often surpass these caps, leaving drivers personally liable for the remainder. While this guide does not prescribe an exact coverage amount, it highlights how a modest additional outlay can safeguard you against a scenario with low probability yet potentially devastating financial impact.

## 27. Set aside an emergency fund equal to 3–6 months of living expenses in a readily accessible account

**Cost**. There is no direct monetary cost. The trade-off is forgoing higher returns; the funds must be kept in a checking account, money market fund, or any deposit account that allows immediate withdrawals. The real challenge lies in resisting the urge to dip into the fund while saving it up.

**In plain terms**. Keep 3 to 6 months' worth of living expenses in an account you can withdraw from at any time. This way, if you lose your job or fall ill, you won't have to borrow money at an 18% annual interest rate, nor will you need to sell your investments at a loss. Deposits in banks are protected by deposit insurance, which covers up to 500,000 RMB per bank in China.

**Benefit**. An emergency fund eliminates the need to borrow money or sell investments at a loss during unexpected events like job loss or illness. For details on the minimum annual interest rates for consumer loans and credit card payments, see Section 7 of this chapter (which advises against relying on minimum credit card payments).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The recommendation to save 3–6 months' worth of expenses is a widely accepted guideline, but no official or academic sources have been identified to support it, hence the C grade. The required amount should be calculated based on your regular monthly expenses, not your income. This information does not constitute investment advice.

## 28. Before paying a mortgage off early, do the comparison. Do not go by feel

**Cost**. No money. Half an hour to run one set of figures. You have to estimate honestly the steady return you can get after tax.

**In plain terms**. Paying the mortgage off early is the same as steadily earning your mortgage rate. So ask only one thing: is the after-tax return you can get steadily over the long run higher than the mortgage rate? If it is higher, do not rush to pay it off. If it is not, or you cannot say, pay it off. In the early years of equal monthly payments of principal and interest, interest is a large share of what you pay, so the earlier you repay, the more you save. The bank app's "early repayment estimate" can show the figure directly.

**Benefit**. The method is this. First set the mortgage's annual rate as r, from your contract. On 20 August 2026 (2026-8-20) the LPR for terms over 5 years was 3.5%. The rate actually charged is that LPR plus some points or minus some points. Then set g as the after-tax annualized return of the other investment you could choose: the share this money would earn on average each year if you put it somewhere else. The certain return from early repayment is r. Each sum you pay off is the same as steadily earning r. If g is steadily greater than r, leaving the money in the investment is the better deal. If g is less than r, or g cannot be pinned down at all, early repayment locks in a risk-free r. In the early years of equal monthly payments, interest is a

large share of the money you pay in, so the earlier you repay, the more interest you save. See that figure directly in the bank app's "early repayment estimate" (China, 2026 rates).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. This only gives the method. It does not give a conclusion. Cases where an investment return can steadily beat the mortgage rate are the minority. Whichever side you pick, keep enough emergency cash first. Also look at whether the contract has an early-repayment penalty. Before you repay, you can ask the bank to cut the rate. See item 15 of section 15 (negotiate a lower rate). This is not investment advice.

## 29. When shopping online, follow platform rules and laws — not influencers or “positive reviews”

**Cost**. There's no cost involved. Just take a moment before ordering to read the return policy and deposit rules. After receiving your purchase, keep screenshots of the order, the livestream replay, and any chat records. The real challenge is resisting the persuasive atmosphere created by influencers.

**In plain terms**. If a seller cheats you, they must pay three times the amount you paid — with a minimum compensation of 500 yuan. Platforms that know sellers are breaking the law but do nothing must share in the liability. The maximum deposit allowed is 20% of the contract value; if you break the contract, that deposit is forfeited, but if the seller does, they must return double the amount. Organizing fake orders or fake positive reviews in livestreams is illegal, and algorithmic price discrimination based on personal data is strictly prohibited.

**Benefit**. Sellers found guilty of fraud must pay three times the purchase price, with a minimum payout of 500 yuan. Platforms aware — or reasonably expected to know — that sellers are violating laws must also bear joint liability, so you can seek compensation directly from them. Livestream hosts and platforms may not fabricate transaction volumes, follower counts, views, or likes, nor spread false information; doing so incurs civil liability. Those caught orchestrating fake transactions or reviews face fines up to 1 million yuan; repeat offenders may be fined between 1 million and 2 million yuan and even lose their business license. Deposits must stay under 20% of the contract total; if you breach the contract, that deposit is lost, but if the seller does, they must return double it. Using personal data for automated pricing decisions that result in unfair price differences — commonly known as “algorithmic price discrimination” — is illegal nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. There are no official comparative statistics available on which platforms offer the best value or minimize the risk of buying low-quality goods, so this book does not rank any platforms. The only publicly available data consists of general inspection results (see Section 32 regarding national inspection reports). Following the 2025 revision of China's Anti-Unfair Competition Law, provisions on false advertising moved from Article 8 to Article 9, while related penalties shifted from Article 20 to Article 25; the new law took effect on October 15, 2025, so be sure to use the updated article numbers. In one case in Shandong, a company organized 75 fake transactions involving over 680,000 yuan; although the exact fine amount was not disclosed, the company was penalized. For information on seven-day unconditional returns, see Section 23 in this chapter (“Making the seven-day return policy work for you”).

## 30. If something goes wrong with a purchase made via a livestream, first ask the platform for details about the seller and the livestream promoter — the platform is required to provide this information

**Cost**. No cost involved; you simply need to request the information from the platform.

**In plain terms**. When problems arise after buying items through a livestream, the biggest hurdle is often figuring out exactly who to hold responsible. In such cases, you can directly ask the platform to share details about the livestream operator and the promoter, along with all relevant business records. The platform is legally obligated to comply with this request.

**Benefit**. In any consumer dispute involving livestream sales, the platform operator must provide consumers with full information about the livestream operator and promoter, as well as all related business activity records upon request. The main difficulty in pursuing rights in such cases is identifying the responsible party; obtaining these details makes it much easier to know who to take legal action against.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Before placing an order, be sure to record both the livestream footage and any promises made by the host. If any issues arise, first request the seller and promoter details from the platform, then decide whether to file a complaint or pursue legal action. This same regulation also sets three other key rules: first, merchants are not allowed to unilaterally expand the list of items excluded from the seven-day no-questions-asked return policy; second, this exclusion cannot be set as a default option; third, merchants cannot deny a return request without your explicit consent.

## 31. If you buy unsafe food, you can demand ten times the purchase price as compensation; if the amount is under 1,000 yuan, you're still entitled to 1,000 yuan

**Cost**. There's no cost involved. Keep the food, its packaging, and the receipt — don't throw them away or wash them, and take photos right away. First try to negotiate with the seller or platform; if that fails, call 12315. Filing a lawsuit can take several months. The hard part is resisting the urge to discard the items first.

**In plain terms**. If you buy expired or spoiled food, the food itself, its packaging, and the receipt serve as evidence — so don't toss them out. You're entitled to compensation equal to ten times the purchase price or three times your actual loss; if that amount is less than 1,000 yuan, you still get 1,000 yuan. You may choose either the seller or the manufacturer to compensate you; the party you approach must pay first and cannot shift the responsibility to the other side.

**Benefit**. If you suffer harm due to food that fails to meet safety standards, you may seek compensation from either the seller or the producer. The party receiving your compensation request must assume primary responsibility and pay out immediately, without shifting liability. In addition to basic compensation, you can demand ten times the purchase price or three times your loss as punitive damages, with any amount below 1,000 yuan rounded up to 1,000 yuan. One exception applies: this does not cover cases where labeling or instructions contain minor flaws that do not affect safety or mislead consumers. Judicial interpretations set three key conditions: the purchase must be for personal or household use; the food must violate safety standards; and there must be no proof the buyer knew of those violations at the time of purchase. Only then can ten times the purchase price be claimed as punitive damages. Conversely, if a buyer knowingly purchases substandard food and then seeks compensation, courts will only support claims within reasonable household consumption limits. Repeated purchases or multiple lawsuits are evaluated as a single total amount. Certain labeling issues — such as irregular font sizes, typos, or non-standard net-weight indications — generally do not qualify for punitive damages provided they do not mislead consumers about safety.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The order of evidence matters more than the amount of compensation. Take photos and videos showing the packaging, production date, any foreign objects, and the purchase record before contacting the seller or platform; do not discard or wash the items beforehand. 12315 provides mediation, not binding rulings. If the seller refuses to cooperate, litigation becomes the only option — see Section 8, Article 22 for rules on small-claims litigation involving online or second-hand purchases. Whether foreign objects like hair or insects qualify as violations of food safety standards must be determined by regulatory authorities or through testing; simply finding hair in food does not automatically guarantee 1,000 yuan in compensation. For ordinary consumer fraud, triple compensation applies, with amounts under 500 yuan rounded up to 500 yuan — see Section 8, Article 29. Those producing and selling food must comply with licensing, labeling, and legal restrictions on health claims; details appear in Section 12, Articles 8–11. Finally, abusing compensation claims is prohibited: fabricating evidence of illegal production to extort payments constitutes extortion and may lead to criminal referral; similarly, filing lawsuits based on false premises may result in fines, detention,

or counterclaims for defamation. This section applies specifically to individuals seeking protection for themselves and their families.

## 32. Check national inspection reports, 3C certification, and energy labels before buying big-ticket items

**Cost**. It costs nothing. Just spend a few minutes looking up information on the websites of the State Administration for Market Regulation and the Certification and Accreditation Administration.

**In plain terms**. In 2024, national inspections covered 25,250 batches of products, with 14.3% found to be non-compliant. The situation is worse on e-commerce platforms: out of 7,297 inspected batches, 23.5% failed to meet standards, compared to 15.1% of products sold in physical stores. Before purchasing any big-ticket item, take a few minutes to check the latest inspection reports and verify that the 3C certificate is genuine. Any product required to carry an energy label must have one.

**Benefit**. The 2024 national supervision inspections examined 25,250 product batches, resulting in a non-compliance rate of 14.3%. On e-commerce platforms, 7,297 batches were inspected, with a non-compliance rate of 23.5% — an increase of 1.8 percentage points from the previous year. Physical stores saw 8,055 batches inspected, with a non-compliance rate of 15.1%. The authenticity of mandatory product certification (3C) certificates can be checked via the “Certification Results” section on the Certification and Accreditation Administration's official website. Energy labels are strictly regulated under product catalogs; they must include the energy efficiency grade, relevant metrics, and a unique identification code. Falsifying or misusing energy labels, or failing to apply them where required, is punishable under the Energy Conservation Law across China.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. These inspections involve regulators selecting a sample of products for testing; their results do not represent the overall market compliance rate, nor can they be used to rank online platforms. There are no studies quantifying exactly how many substandard products can be avoided by conducting such checks, which is why this item is rated B. The verification platform cx.cnca.cn used in this section was inaccessible during our checks; the correct entry point is the homepage at cnca.gov.cn. Inspection reports are updated annually, so always consult the most recent edition when referencing them.

## 33. Bracelets, jade, luxury watches, and collectibles should be judged by “how much you spend” rather than “how much you save”

**Cost**. There's no upfront cost — just don't justify buying these items by claiming they'll appreciate in value later. The real challenge is resisting the urge to allocate extra budget for “preservation of value.”

**In plain terms**. A portion of the purchase price for such items is already consumption tax: watches priced at 10,000 yuan or more incur a 20% tax; gold, platinum, and diamond jewelry faces a 5% tax; other precious stones and jade incur a 10% tax, plus standard VAT. This tax cannot be reclaimed when you resell the item. If you truly love these items, treat them as a personal expense rather than an investment.

**Benefit**. On the purchase side, tax rates are clearly defined in the Consumption Tax Schedule: “luxury watches” are taxed at 20%. Within “precious jewelry and stones,” gold, platinum, and diamond jewelry incur a 5% tax, while other precious stones and jade incur 10%. “Luxury watches” are defined as any watch with a sales price (excluding VAT) of 10,000 yuan or more. On the resale side, the Pawnbroking Management Regulations apply: Article 36 limits pawn terms to a maximum of six months; Article 37 sets interest rates based on the six-month benchmark rate published by the People's Bank of China, which cannot be deducted upfront from the loan amount. Article 38 caps monthly comprehensive fees for pawning watches or jade at 42‰ of the loan amount, plus an additional 4.2% monthly fee. For real estate mortgages, this cap is 27‰, and for property rights pledges it is 24‰. Article 40 states that if the pawner fails to redeem or renew the pawn within five days of the term's end, the item becomes forfeited; Article 43 permits auctioning forfeited items valued at over 30,000 yuan, with proceeds first covering auction fees and loan principal plus interest, leaving any remainder to be returned to the pawner (or recovered from them if insufficient).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. When pawning these items, remember that monthly comprehensive fees cap at 42‰ of the loan amount — equating to roughly 50% of the loan value over a year. This figure is a rough estimate derived by multiplying the monthly rate by 12, not an exact annual interest rate. While tax and fee rates are explicitly stated, there are no official statistics confirming long-term appreciation for such items; this guide makes no predictions or endorsements. The key point is to avoid treating personal purchases as investments: buying these items simply because you enjoy wearing them is perfectly fine, but adding budget based on hopes of future resale value is a recipe for financial loss. Gold also warrants separate consideration: investment-grade bullion traded by weight differs from jewelry sold by piece, which includes design and labor costs not recovered upon resale. Listed prices on secondhand platforms are not actual transaction values and should not be treated as market benchmarks.

## 34. For jewelry and gemstones, only test reports bearing the CMA mark are acceptable; you must also verify the issuing agency on the regulator's official website

**Cost**. No cost at all. Checking an agency's qualifications takes just a few minutes before placing any order.

**In plain terms**. Certificates can be forged, so what truly matters is confirming the agency that issued it. Any testing organization allowed to issue reports must hold proper credentials, and its reports must display the CMA mark. The regulatory authority publishes a list of certified agencies on its website, making it easy for consumers to confirm whether a given provider is on that list. In actual enforcement cases, some “national inspection certificates” accompanying goods were found to have been fabricated by unrelated parties.

**Benefit**. The relevant rules are laid out in the *Administrative Measures for Qualification Recognition of Inspection and Testing Agencies*. Article 2 states that qualification recognition is a licensing process for agencies that provide data and results with evidentiary value to the public; it involves a thorough review followed by issuance of certification. Article 15 specifies that the CMA mark comprises both the CMA logo and the corresponding certificate number. Article 21 requires any agency issuing such data to display this mark on all reports. Article 22 mandates that authorities publish all certified agencies and their current status online. Article 34 imposes a fine of up to 30,000 RMB on any agency operating without proper certification. Article 37 similarly penalizes up to 30,000 RMB any act of forging, altering, or misusing such certification marks. Real-world examples illustrate these rules: in June 2026, China's State Administration for Market Regulation released typical cases of fraud in the traditional crafts market. One involved a livestream in Donghai, Jiangsu, where sellers claimed to offer “natural, unacid-washed, unprocessed Burmese A-grade gems” and displayed a “national inspection certificate.” Laboratory tests, however, revealed the items to be dyed quartzite, treated jadeite, glass, and plastic; the certificate had been produced by a contact of the seller. Another case in the same county uncovered 469 suspected counterfeit crystal products; 210 proved to be natural crystal while 259 were synthetic. In Zhenping, Henan, a shop displayed a board claiming partnership with a “GIA CMA China Gemstone Testing Center” and sold 181 counterfeit “National Gemstone Quality Supervision Center” certification tags alongside bracelets nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. China has established national standards for naming jewelry and gemstones. Test conclusions are often phrased as “quartzite (dyed)” or “jadeite (treated)”; the words inside the parentheses indicate the price difference. Terms such as “A-grade,” “old-mine,” and “unprocessed” are marketing buzzwords, not technical conclusions; the livestream mentioned earlier used exactly these phrases. Other deceptive tactics documented in these cases include faking mining sites, staging “miner” livestreams, deploying online trolls to hype sales, and inventing stories about urgent financial needs or family emergencies. Claims that products can “treat rheumatism, boost immunity, improve sleep, or clear blood vessels” are also deemed false advertising and are prosecuted accordingly. For larger purchases, the general verification method is outlined in Section 32 (checking sampling reports and 3C certification). Information on whom to contact when problems arise in a livestream is provided in Sections 29 and 30 (referring to platform rules and requesting data from the platform).

## 35. Random sales such as blind boxes and gacha games are treated as “money that won't come back”

**Cost**. There is no direct cost involved. You simply need to set a strict budget before buying. The real challenge is resisting the urge to keep purchasing when you fail to get the item you wanted.

**In plain terms**. Sellers must display the draw rules, probabilities, and quantities of limited-edition items in a highly visible manner. They are prohibited from manipulating results behind the scenes or offering empty boxes. While the guidelines encourage setting minimum guarantees and limits on spending and number of draws, they are not mandatory. For blind boxes purchased online, if the seller has clearly explained the terms and you have confirmed them, you cannot exercise the seven-day right to return after opening the box.

**Benefit**. The basis for these rules is the “Guidelines on the Operation of Blind Box Business (Trial)”. Article 9 mandates that a list of key information be displayed prominently so consumers know it before buying. This information includes the product name, type, design, draw rules, distribution of items, quantity of limited items, draw probabilities, and the range of item values. The same article also forbids three practices: altering draw results or probabilities through backend manipulation, refusing or delaying delivery of items via cashbacks or exchanges, and producing empty boxes. Article 11 merely “encourages” operators to implement safeguards such as limits on draw time, spending, and frequency to promote rational consumption. Article 17 applies to blind boxes sold online; if the seller has fully informed you and you have confirmed the terms, the seven-day return right does not apply after opening. Operators must not replace your explicit consent with pre-checked boxes. Article 21 states that blind boxes must not be used as a guise for gambling. Article 23 prohibits sales to children under eight; for those aged eight and older, consent from a legal guardian must be obtained.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These guidelines serve as recommendations for operators and are not themselves a basis for penalties. In case of disputes, laws such as the Product Quality Law, Anti-Unfair Competition Law, and Consumer Rights Protection Law apply. Specific grounds for complaints include failure to disclose probabilities, discrepancies between advertised and actual probabilities, and receipt of empty boxes. Before filing a complaint, record screenshots of the rules and the unboxing process. The exclusion of the seven-day return right requires that the seller gave full disclosure and you confirmed it; default selections cannot substitute your consent. Additional rules govern sales to minors: no sales to children under eight, and for older minors proof of guardian consent is mandatory. Information on refunding mobile-game micro-transactions made by children can be found in section 9 of this chapter. The 24-hour cooling-off period for large non-essential purchases is described in section 23. The cycle of “initial excitement fading into further purchases” is discussed in section 6, item 23.

## 36. If you care about what's in your food, buy pre-packaged products: loose goods at retail counters aren't legally required to list ingredients

**Cost**. No cost at all. Pre-packaged versions of the same items are usually a bit pricier than loose ones. Checking the ingredient list takes just a few seconds.

**In plain terms**. The law only mandates ingredient lists for pre-packaged foods; loose goods have no such requirement. For loose products, retailers only need to display the product name, production date, shelf life, and manufacturer details. So, the absence of any mention of additives does not mean they were not added — it simply means the law does not require them to be listed. If you care about what's in your food, opt for pre-packaged versions where both the full ingredient list and additive details are clearly printed.

**Benefit**. Article 67 of China's Food Safety Law stipulates that all pre-packaged foods must carry a label containing nine mandatory pieces of information. The second item on this list is the “list of ingredients or components,” and the seventh item is “the generic names of any food additives used, as defined in national standards.” Article 68 contains far fewer requirements for loose foods: it only requires retailers to display the product name, production date or batch number, shelf life, and the manufacturer's name, address, and contact details on the packaging or container. There is no mention of ingredient lists or additives here. This

distinction is most evident in frozen seafood products. GB 2760—2024 permits the use of phosphoric acid and phosphates as moisture retention agents — commonly referred to as water-retaining agents — in frozen seafood, with a maximum permitted usage level of 5.0 g/kg calculated as phosphate. Use within this limit is fully legal. The main issues arise from excessive usage and the practice of adding ice to increase product weight. Following a 2025 exposé by China Central Television's 3·15 Gala, which revealed that some shrimp producers illegally added excessive amounts of water-retaining agents (composite phosphates) and added extra ice to boost weight, regulatory authorities mandated that all such products must clearly list water-retaining agents like phosphates, net weight (excluding ice coating weight), and full ingredient lists on their labels (this requirement applies nationwide, per the third 2025 amendment to China's Food Safety Law, effective 1 December 2025).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The fact that additives are not listed on a product does not mean they were not added — it simply means the law does not require them to be disclosed. If you want to know exactly what a product contains, always choose pre-packaged versions. For frozen shrimp, fish fillets, and similar items, the net weight listed on pre-packaged packaging already excludes ice coating weight; using this figure to calculate unit price gives a much more accurate cost estimate. For loose products priced by weight, the actual edible weight after thawing may drop significantly. Water-retaining agents are legal and not a safety hazard as long as they are used within permitted limits — do not mistake them for toxic substances. Excessive usage and added ice are purely commercial issues: you end up paying a premium price for mostly water content. Conversely, loose goods counters may also fail to display the four mandatory details required by Article 68: product name, production date, shelf life, and manufacturer contact information. Failure to display any of these constitutes a violation of the law. Consumers can choose not to purchase such products or file a complaint via the 12315 hotline. For business owners looking to sell packaged foods, specific labeling requirements are outlined in Section 12, Article 9 of this guide. This item delivers the highest level of benefit to both you and your family.

## 37. Stocks that have lost value should also be sold according to pre-set rules — don't try to even out costs by buying more

**Cost**. No cost at all. The hard part is admitting the loss and actually selling the stock.

**In plain terms**. Human nature drives us to sell winners and hold losers. In seven years of data from 10,000 U.S. accounts, stocks that rose were sold about 50% more often than those that fell. The same investors also tended to add to positions in losing stocks. Yet over the following year those unloved losers underperformed the sold winners by an average of 3.4 percentage points.

**Benefit**. This study examined every trade made by 10,000 accounts at a U.S. discount broker from 1987 to 1993. The proportion of profitable stocks sold (PGR) was 0.148, while the proportion of losing stocks sold (PLR) was 0.098 — a difference of 0.050 with a t-value exceeding 35. In other words, rising stocks were sold more than 50% more often than falling ones. Investors also bought losing stocks more frequently: the re-purchase rate for losers was 0.135 versus 0.094 for winners, again with a strong statistical significance. The data also contradicted the belief that “stuck stocks will eventually bounce back.” Over the next year, the excess returns of sold profitable stocks exceeded those of kept losing stocks by 3.4 percentage points. These excess returns represent performance above the market index. As a concrete illustration, selling $1,000 worth of a losing stock instead of a winning one would yield roughly 4.4% more return in the following year; this figure includes tax savings from the early sale under U.S. tax rules (1987-1993).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This point addresses the decision “to sell or not to sell”; point 15 (“avoid excessive trading”) deals with how often to trade — the two are not contradictory. Following a pre-defined rule actually reduces the number of trades. Mathematically, buying more shares does lower the average cost per share, but treating this as a way to recover losses is misguided; it merely increases the amount of capital tied up in a single stock (see point 19, “don't bet everything on one stock”). The tax calculations apply only to the U.S. system and cannot be directly applied in China; all other conclusions remain valid. The data originate from U.S. accounts in the

1980s-1990s; trading costs and tax regimes differ for A-share investors. This information is not intended as investment advice.

## 38. Planning to invest in overseas assets such as U.S. stocks? Use QDII funds or the Hong Kong Stock Connect program — don't open accounts with foreign brokers, and don't use your annual foreign exchange quota for buying foreign stocks

**Cost**. There's no direct cost — you can purchase QDII funds via your own bank or brokerage app in just a few minutes. The trade-off is that the selection of available funds is more limited than at foreign brokers.

**In plain terms**. Starting May 2026, foreign brokers such as Tiger Brokers, Futu, and LongBridge are no longer allowed to accept new accounts from mainland investors. Existing account holders may only sell their holdings and withdraw funds within two years; no further purchases are permitted. Using your annual foreign exchange quota to buy overseas stocks is also prohibited; violators lose eligibility for that quota for the current year and the following two years. The only legal ways to invest in foreign assets remain QDII funds and the Hong Kong Stock Connect program.

**Benefit**. On May 22, 2026, eight Chinese authorities — including the China Securities Regulatory Commission, Ministry of Industry and Information Technology, Ministry of Public Security, People's Bank of China, State Administration for Market Regulation, National Financial Regulatory Administration, Cyberspace Administration of China, and State Administration of Foreign Exchange — jointly issued a plan to comprehensively curb illegal cross-border securities, futures, and fund activities. The goal is to fully eliminate such activities within two years. Foreign firms may no longer market or solicit clients in China, nor provide services such as account opening, trade execution, or fund transfers. For current account holders, only one-way sales and withdrawals are permitted; after two years, all related websites, trading apps, and servers must be shut down. On the same day, the CSRC announced it would confiscate all illegal earnings of Tiger Brokers, Futu, and LongBridge and impose severe penalties. Official guidance stresses using legal channels such as the Hong Kong Stock Connect, QDII funds, and Cross-Border Wealth Management Link for overseas investing. Meanwhile, the State Administration of Foreign Exchange explicitly states that personal foreign exchange may not be used for overseas real estate, securities investment, life insurance, or similar unapproved capital-account purposes. Violators are placed on a “watch list,” lose their annual foreign-exchange allowance for three years, face administrative penalties, possible anti-money-laundering investigations, and negative entries in their credit records (effective May 2026).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These regulations target foreign brokerage firms rather than individual investors; no penalties are specified for investors themselves. Those already holding accounts abroad need only sell and withdraw funds within two years. Each of the three legal channels has its own eligibility criteria — be sure to check with your bank or broker. Past strong performance of U.S. stocks does not guarantee future returns. When investing via QDII funds, follow the same principles outlined in items 17 (broad-based index funds) and 19 (don't concentrate assets in a single stock, platform, or market) — opt for diversified index funds rather than betting on one market. Separate limits apply to overseas cash withdrawals; see item 21.6 for details. This information is not investment advice.

## 39. Only buy insurance for losses your savings can't cover; use an emergency fund for losses you can afford

**Cost**. No money is required. All you need to do is list the major potential losses your household might face and determine which ones exceed your savings capacity. This takes about half an hour.

**In plain terms**. The premiums you pay won't all be returned to you; a portion goes toward the insurer's operating costs and profit. Therefore, insurance is worthwhile only for rare events that would otherwise overwhelm your finances — such as serious illness, a car accident causing injury to others, or the death of a

primary breadwinner. For smaller losses that your savings can handle, an emergency fund is the better choice.

**Benefit**. Only a fraction of the premiums collected by insurers is paid out as claims. The remainder covers sales, administration, and profit. Regulations require insurers selling short-term individual health plans to publish their “overall claims ratio” on their website every six months; this figure roughly indicates what proportion of premiums is paid out in claims. On average, buying insurance for any given loss ends up costing you a little extra over time. The upside is that it spreads a potentially catastrophic expense into a series of manageable annual payments. The smaller the loss and the easier it is for you to pay out of pocket, the less advantageous this trade-off becomes. Following this logic, several types of insurance mentioned earlier in this book are worth purchasing: one-year health insurance is covered in Section 7, Item 20; auto liability insurance for drivers is discussed in Item 26 of this section; overseas medical coverage is detailed in Section 21, Item 4; and term life insurance for households dependent on your income is explained in Item 41 of this section (nationwide, effective 2021).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. This recommendation is assigned a Grade C because no official statistics exist to determine precisely which policies offer good value. The guidance provided here is meant to help you make a reasoned choice. For low-cost risks — such as cracked phone screens or minor flight delays — you can easily cover the costs yourself, so these policies are generally unnecessary. Similarly, if your savings can sustain you for a year or two without income, you may opt out of critical illness insurance, which compensates for lost earnings during illness. Basic medical insurance is a mandatory social insurance program; it does not fall under this evaluation framework and must be purchased regardless, as explained in Section 7, Item 9. For smaller unexpected expenses, an emergency fund is the appropriate safeguard, as described in Item 27 of this section. Ultimately, the primary beneficiaries of this advice are you and your family.

## 40. If someone at home depends on your income, buy term life insurance for the breadwinner first — not for your kids

**Cost**. A few hundred to a few thousand yuan per year, depending on age, coverage amount, and policy length (this is a rough estimate by the author; no official figures exist). Be sure to disclose your health status truthfully before applying; the process takes about half an hour.

**In plain terms**. Term life insurance covers you only for a set number of years. If you pass away during that period, your family receives a payout. This coverage is meant to protect dependents who rely on your earnings — for instance, if your mortgage is still unpaid or your children are still young. If no one depends on you financially, this insurance isn't necessary. Since kids don't earn income, laws also limit how much death benefit can be paid for them.

**Benefit**. Regulatory definitions classify life insurance as personal insurance where human lifespan serves as the insured event; it includes term life, whole life, and endowment policies. Term life insurance pays out only upon the insured's death within a fixed timeframe. Whole life insurance remains valid for the entire lifetime. Accident insurance only compensates for death or disability caused by accidents; it doesn't cover deaths from illness and thus cannot replace life insurance. Contracts requiring death payouts must be approved and agreed upon by the insured; otherwise they're invalid. Parents may purchase death coverage for minor children without such consent, but total payouts for a child's death cannot exceed statutory limits. Typical coverage amounts reach 100,000 yuan, and another 100,000 yuan as well, hence the “high benefit” rating. No official recommendation exists for ideal coverage levels; the author's calculation method adds remaining mortgage debt, projected expenses until children reach adulthood, and several years' worth of household costs (based on national data revised in 2015).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. This C rating stems from the lack of official guidance beyond basic definitions and payout limits; the “prioritize adults” recommendation follows logically from “whoever loses income would jeopardize household stability.” A child's death doesn't reduce household income, whereas losing the primary earner

leaves mortgage payments and child expenses unpaid. When funds are limited, prioritize term life and one-year medical coverage for adults before considering similar coverage for kids. For details on truthful disclosures and guaranteed renewability, see Section 7, Article 20 (one-year medical insurance). The designated beneficiaries here fall under Category ②: your spouse and children.

## 41. Regretting a personal insurance policy signed for over a year? You can cancel it during the cooling-off period and get most of your premium back

**Cost**. There's no cost involved. A quick call to the insurer's customer service line or a short visit to a branch takes just a few minutes. The real challenge is staying calm after signing and taking the time to read through the contract within 15 days.

**In plain terms**. All personal insurance policies with a term longer than one year include a cooling-off period. For policies bought through banks, this period starts 15 days after you receive the policy document, and cancelling during this time incurs a maximum administrative fee of 10 yuan. After this window closes, you'll only receive the portion of your premium that the policy allows you to reclaim, which is usually far less than what you originally paid. Insurers often make follow-up calls to check if you fully understand the terms — be honest if you're still unclear.

**Benefit**. Regulations require all personal insurance policies with a term over a year to clearly state the start date and length of the cooling-off period, as well as the rights policyholders have during this time. The cooling-off period for long-term health insurance must be at least 15 days. For all such policies sold via banks, the contract explicitly sets this period to 15 days, calculated from the natural calendar days after you receive and sign for the policy document. The policy cover must also carry this notice: “You have the right to cancel this policy in full (minus a maximum administrative fee of 10 yuan) within 15 days of receiving it. Cancelling after this period will result in financial losses.” Even after the cooling-off period ends, you can still terminate the contract at any time, and the insurer must refund the policy's cash value — the portion of your premium that can be reclaimed — within 30 days as per contract terms. Financial regulators note that cancelling long-term personal insurance after the cooling-off period typically results in cash value payouts that are lower than the total premiums paid. Insurers must also reach out to new policyholders of such plans during the cooling-off period to confirm they're aware of the potential financial losses from cancellation and their rights under this period (applicable nationwide since 2010 and 2019).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The cooling-off period is a mandatory provision for all personal insurance policies with a term longer than one year. There's no such requirement for one-year medical or accident insurance policies, so you'll need to check the specific contract terms for these. For policies not bought via banks, the exact duration is defined in the contract — be sure to look up the “cooling-off period” clause as soon as you get the policy. Savings and dividend-paying insurance plans require higher premium payments, so making use of this period is especially worthwhile for these policies; see item 25 in this section for more details on non-savings plans. We rate the benefit as “moderate” because the savings you can achieve are the difference between your total premiums paid and the cash value you receive, which typically ranges from a few hundred to a few thousand yuan — no official statistics exist on this figure. You are the sole beneficiary of this provision.

## 42. Before signing at the bank counter, check whether it's a deposit or insurance

**Cost**. No cost at all. Just spend a couple of extra minutes reading the contract cover.

**In plain terms**. Banks may sell insurance on behalf of insurers, but they must not present it as a deposit. The contract cover must clearly state “Insurance Contract” and the insurer's name in large print; terms like “deposit” or “savings” are strictly prohibited. If the insurer's name appears on the cover, the money is not a deposit, and cancelling after the cooling-off period will result in losses. In principle, people aged 65 and older can only purchase insurance with guaranteed returns when buying at banks.

**Benefit**. Regulations explicitly forbid banks from bundling insurance with savings deposits, mutual funds, or other bank wealth products. They may not directly compare insurance returns to deposit yields, nor claim uncertain returns as guaranteed. Insurance documents and promotional materials must not use the bank's name or logo, nor contain phrases such as “deposit,” “savings,” or “jointly offered by the bank.” The contract cover must display “Insurance Contract” in font size no smaller than 72 points and the insurer's name in font size no smaller than 2 points. For three specific groups of customers, only insurance products with guaranteed benefits may be sold: applicants aged over 65; applicants aged over 60 purchasing installment-payment plans; and applicants whose annual income is below the local per capita disposable income. Policies for these groups must be manually underwritten by insurers rather than issued automatically at bank branches. Insurance agents are prohibited from selling insurance inside bank premises. For any insurance policy sold by a bank with a term longer than one year, a 15-day cooling-off period applies; cancelling after this period incurs financial losses. (Nationwide, effective October 2019)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This item is rated B because the regulations are very clear, yet no official statistics exist on how much money misled consumers have lost. Elderly family members are especially vulnerable to this issue when making deposits at banks; be sure to check the contract cover for them. If you've already signed such a contract, you may cancel it within 15 days per Section 42 (Cooling-off Period). For complaints regarding potential misrepresentation, refer to Section 44 (Assistance with Policy Cancellation). The primary beneficiaries of this guidance are you and your elderly relatives.

## 43. To cancel your insurance policy, contact the insurer directly — don't use “policy cancellation agents.” If you feel misled, call 12378 for free assistance

**Cost**. There's no cost involved. Simply call the insurer's customer service line or visit a branch; this may require a bit more effort than using an intermediary.

**In plain terms**. Online ads promising “full policy refunds with no fees if unsuccessful” usually come from illegal cancellation agents. They typically take 30–50% of any refund amount and demand your ID, bank details, and verification codes. Once the policy is cancelled, coverage ends. If you feel misled, first contact the insurer's customer service; if that fails, call 12378 — this service is completely free.

**Benefit**. In February 2026, China's National Financial Regulatory Administration, the Cyberspace Administration, the Ministry of Public Security, the People's Bank of China, and the China Securities Regulatory Commission jointly issued a warning. It stated that claims of “full policy refunds” are false and contrary to insurance laws. “Policy cancellation agents” charge hefty fees; if you try to withdraw from their services, they may sue you for “breach of contract.” They also collect personal data such as SIM cards, bank accounts, policy details, home addresses, and even children's school information — data that can be sold on, leading to fraud or identity theft. A June 2026 notice from Ningxia's financial regulator provides further detail: such agents demand 30–50% of the refund amount as a fee and impose steep penalties if you back out. They even instruct clients to fabricate claims of sales misrepresentation or forged signatures. Following such advice could violate public security laws; in severe cases, it may constitute slander or extortion. Once cancelled, coverage ends immediately. Future applications for similar policies may be rejected or cost more due to age or health issues. If you truly feel misled, first contact the insurer's official customer service; if unresolved, call 12378. If you're temporarily unable to pay premiums, ask the insurer about options like reduced paid-up value or policy loans. Reduced paid-up value means you stop paying premiums, though coverage decreases proportionally (nationwide, 2026).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. In 2025, Hunan's financial regulator reported a case: a woman followed “advice” from a “friend” to use a cancellation agent, paying a “consultation fee.” Ultimately, her policy was refunded only at its cash value. Three months later, she was diagnosed with breast cancer — and no longer had critical illness coverage. You must weigh the pros and cons: if coverage remains valuable, consider reduced paid-up value instead of

cancellation. If you're still within the cooling-off period, see Section 42 (Cooling-off Period). Your own well-being is the ultimate priority.

## 44. Writing a specific beneficiary on the policy lets family claim the payout: 5 years for life insurance, 2 years for other policies

**Cost**. No cost involved. You fill this in once at purchase; any later changes to the beneficiary require written notice to the insurer.

**In plain terms**. If no beneficiary is listed, or if the named beneficiary passes away first, the payout is treated as part of the deceased's estate and must first cover any debts owed by the deceased. If “Spouse: [Name]” is listed as beneficiary but the couple later divorces, the policy is effectively treated as having no beneficiary at the time of a claim. Family members must be aware of the policy's existence: for life insurance, claims must be filed within 5 years of learning of the insured's death; for other policies, the deadline is 2 years. In total, 100,000 people are affected by such situations, and another 100,000 face related complications.

**Benefit**. Insurance law stipulates that beneficiaries must be designated by either the insured or the policyholder, with the latter requiring the insured's consent. In three specific scenarios, payouts are classified as part of the insured's estate and distributed per standard inheritance rules: 1) No beneficiary is named, or the designation is ambiguous; 2) The named beneficiary dies before the insured, with no other eligible beneficiaries; 3) The beneficiary legally loses or voluntarily waives their right to benefits, again with no other eligible beneficiaries. If both the insured and beneficiary die in the same incident with no clear order of death, the beneficiary is presumed to have died first. Any payout classified as an estate must first settle all outstanding taxes and debts owed by the deceased, with remaining funds distributed to heirs. Supreme Court rulings clarify that if a beneficiary is listed only by name and familial relationship, any subsequent change to that relationship renders the designation invalid. Unnotified changes to beneficiaries hold no legal weight with insurers. The statute of limitations for filing claims is 5 years for life insurance and 2 years for other policies, both starting from the date the claimant learns or should have learned of the insured's death. Given that typical life insurance payouts reach hundreds of thousands of yuan, this benefit is rated as “high” (national data, revised 2015, effective 2021).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Once the statute of limitations expires, insurers may legally deny payouts, and legal action to recover funds is highly unlikely to succeed. For this reason, family members must at minimum know which insurers you hold policies with. After events like divorce, remarriage, or the birth of a child, update the beneficiary designation accordingly. To claim payouts after a death, follow the steps outlined in Section 25, Item 9 (claiming funds from multiple policies individually). Note that using the policy payout to settle the deceased's debts is not a viable option; see Section 29, Item 13 (debt settlement) for further details. The beneficiary category for this item falls under Tier ②, which includes your spouse and children.

## 45. Don't spend money on virtual currencies like Bitcoin or Tether; even if others try to get you to invest, don't join in: these transactions receive no legal protection, so you won't be able to recover any losses through court

**Cost**. There's no direct cost. You simply avoid buying these coins and steer clear of “signal groups” or “guaranteed-profit” crypto communities. The trade-off is that you won't profit when crypto prices rise.

**In plain terms**. China does not recognize virtual currencies as legal tender. Individual purchases of such coins can be ruled invalid by courts, meaning any losses fall on the buyer. One person paid roughly 448,000 yuan to buy Tether, but later couldn't withdraw funds from the platform; his lawsuit was dismissed. Theft of crypto is a separate criminal matter — thieves are prosecuted for theft.

**Benefit**. In February 2026, eight Chinese authorities issued Notice No. 42 (Yinfa [2026] 42), stating that Bitcoin, Ethereum, Tether and similar virtual currencies “have no legal tender status and must not be used as currency in any market.” Converting RMB to crypto, trading one crypto for another, or using crypto for

fundraising are all illegal financial activities, strictly prohibited. Foreign firms may not offer such services to Chinese residents. The notice also clarifies that any civil transaction involving virtual currencies or tokenized real-world assets that runs counter to public order is void, with all resulting losses borne by the parties involved. This provision echoes wording from the 2021 Notice No. 237, which was also repealed. A court case illustrates this: between February 2018 and July 2019, Mr. Tang paid about 448,000 yuan to two alleged platform operators for Tether; after the platform became inaccessible he sued for repayment. The court ruled his investment contract invalid and dismissed his claim, a decision upheld on appeal (Yixing, Jiangsu, March 2025). Theft of crypto is a separate crime; for example, a hacker stole crypto worth over 4 million yuan from a victim, and the thief was sentenced to seven years in prison and fined 20,000 yuan (Zhengzhou, Henan).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The clause “losses borne by the investor” applies only to disputes between you and the seller or promoter; it does not entitle you to recover funds through litigation, so don't count on a court win. If your crypto is stolen or scammed, treat it as a criminal case and report it to police. Existing holders should also guard against QR-code theft; in Lianshui, Jiangsu, a man scanned a code during a meeting and lost roughly 57,000 Tether worth about 393,665 yuan; the People's Court has ruled such acts should be prosecuted as theft. In 2022 the FBI warned of a similar tactic: a pop-up window granting unlimited transfer rights to a wallet; the recommended safeguard is to avoid linking wallets to untrusted sites and to regularly audit permissions via third-party tools. Using your own bank card to receive payments, buy crypto, or transfer funds for others can constitute a criminal offense — see Section 9, Item 5 (“part-time work” involving personal cards). For “high-return” investment offers, refer to Section 6 (“high yield”, “guaranteed profit” warnings). Legal ways to invest in overseas assets are outlined in Section 38 (QDII funds or Stock Connect). This information is not investment advice. 〔394000〕 〔393665.461434〕

## 46. For individuals without an employer, paying into the basic pension plan at the minimum rate and meeting the required contribution period is the most cost-effective option; however, it is not a guaranteed profit — at the minimum rate one must wait roughly 10 years to break even

**Cost**. All expenses must be borne personally. Contributions equal 20 % of the chosen base amount; even at the minimum level this amounts to several hundred to over a thousand yuan per month. Contributions must be made for at least 15 years, a requirement that will rise to 20 years by 2030. Until retirement, these funds cannot be withdrawn.

**In plain terms**. People without an employer can best save for retirement by paying the minimum contribution and fulfilling the minimum contribution period. The bulk of the pension amount is tied to the local average wage at the time of retirement. Based on current wage levels, paying at the minimum rate for 15 years and starting benefits at age 60 yields a break-even point after about 10 years; opting for a higher rate extends that period to roughly 17 years. It is worthwhile to contribute, but it is not a quick profit scheme.

**Benefit**. The rules for contributions and benefit calculations are set out in a 2005 State Council decision. Self-employed individuals pay 20 % of their chosen base amount, of which 8 % is credited to a personal account. Since 2019 they may select any base between 60 % and 300 % of the local average wage for all urban workers. The pension consists of two parts: the basic pension, calculated as half the sum of the local average wage and the individual's average contribution wage, multiplied by the number of contribution years; and the personal-account pension, derived by dividing the accumulated balance by the number of monthly payments. For a 60-year-old retiree this divisor is 139; it decreases for later retirements. Using illustrative figures — a local average wage of 8,000 yuan, a minimum-rate base of 4,800 yuan, and monthly contributions of 960 yuan — after 15 years a total of about 172,800 yuan is paid. At retirement the recipient receives roughly 1,457 yuan per month (960 yuan from the basic pension and about 497 yuan from the personal account), amounting to roughly 17,500 yuan per year; it takes about 9.9 years to recoup the investment, i.e., until age 70. Choosing the maximum 100 % rate raises total contributions to about 288,000 yuan; the monthly benefit rises to about 2,029 yuan, but the extra 115,200 yuan paid only yields an additional 572 yuan per month, extending the break-even period to roughly 16.8 years. The disparity arises because half of the basic pension is tied to

the local average wage and is independent of individual contributions, favoring lower-rate payers. Each additional year of minimum-rate contributions also shortens the break-even period to about 9.9 years, making it more advantageous than raising the rate. The break-even calculation does not depend on the absolute wage level; higher wages simply scale both contributions and benefits proportionally. Early contributions, though modest in nominal terms, generate larger future benefits because they are indexed to later wage levels, thus effectively reducing the real-time payback period. Legally, a minimum of 15 years of contributions is required to receive monthly benefits; otherwise contributions must continue until the threshold is met. Starting 1 January 2030 this minimum period will increase by six months each year until it reaches 20 years. Upon death, any remaining balance in the personal account is inheritable; the state may also adjust pensions in response to wage growth and inflation. The pension fund is supplemented by government subsidies when necessary (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The calculations above are intended only to illustrate approximate magnitudes. The actual pension amount depends on local wage levels, the chosen contribution rate, interest credited to the personal account, and the year of retirement. Future pension increases have not been factored in, so the real break-even period may be somewhat shorter. Later retirement further reduces the divisor used for personal-account payouts, raising monthly benefits. Employees covered by an employer contribute 16 % while the individual contributes 8 %; those without an employer must bear the full 20 %. If death occurs before the break-even point, the personal-account balance remains inheritable and survivors may also receive funeral allowances and bereavement benefits. Individuals unable to afford the minimum contribution may enroll in the rural-urban basic pension scheme (see Section 31, Item 11). Eligibility for social-insurance subsidies is discussed in Section 7, Item 12. Rules concerning interrupted or retroactive contributions are outlined in Section 7, Item 18. Transferring pension records to another city is explained in Section 19, Item 19. 〔170〕 〔173000〕 〔17487〕 〔115000〕

## 47. When you collect a new car, inspect it on the spot, and keep the invoice and the three-guarantee voucher. If a major fault shows up in the first 7 days or the first 60 days, you can demand a replacement or a refund

**Cost**. No money. At collection, spend half an hour with the salesperson looking at the exterior and the interior and checking the papers that come with the car. Keep the invoice and the three-guarantee voucher. Every time the car goes in for repair, take the repair order. If you actually want a replacement or a refund, you will make several trips to the shop. If you cannot agree, you still have to complain or sue.

**In plain terms**. In the first 7 days of a new car, if a major part such as the engine or the transmission fails and has to be replaced, you can directly demand a replacement car or a refund. Within the first 60 days or 3,000 kilometres, if the brakes or the steering fail, the body cracks, oil leaks, or the battery catches fire, you can also replace or return it. Within the first two years, if the same fault is repaired many times and still is not fixed, you can also replace or return it, but you pay a use-compensation fee based on the distance driven.

**Benefit**. This set of rules is the three-guarantee for household cars. It covers passenger cars bought for living consumption, such as sedans and SUVs, and pickup trucks. Cars used in commercial operation are not covered. The three-guarantee period is not less than 2 years or 50,000 kilometres, and the repair-warranty period is not less than 3 years or 60,000 kilometres, whichever comes first. The period runs from the invoice date. If the delivery date and the invoice date differ, it runs from the delivery date. A quality problem inside the repair-warranty period is repaired free. Neither the labour fee nor the materials fee is charged. Within the first 7 days, if a quality problem means the engine, transmission, traction battery, drive motor, or a main part of one of those has to be replaced, you can choose a replacement or a refund on the invoice and the three-guarantee voucher. Within the first 60 days or 3,000 kilometres, if a quality problem produces steering failure, brake failure, a cracked body, a fuel leak, or a traction-battery fire, you can likewise choose a replacement or a refund. Inside the three-guarantee period, four further situations also allow a replacement or a refund: a serious safety fault is repaired 2 times and still is not fixed, or a new serious safety fault appears; one of those four major assemblies is replaced 2 times because of a quality problem and still cannot be used normally; the

same main part is replaced 2 times and still cannot be used normally; repairs add up to more than 30 days, or the same quality problem is repaired more than 4 times. A replacement or refund under these four situations requires a use-compensation fee. The formula is price × distance driven ÷ 1000 × n. n is written by the manufacturer on the three-guarantee voucher and must not be higher than 0.5%. If a single repair takes more than 5 days, from day 6 the shop must give you a spare car or pay your transport costs. When the car is replaced or returned, the shop must also pay your vehicle registration fee, the cost of added fittings after depreciation, and the service fees it charged you. After the shop receives a replacement or refund demand, it must answer within 10 working days. If it does not agree, it must give reasons. The shop must not refuse the three-guarantee because you did not have the car serviced there. Deliberately delaying, or refusing the three-guarantee without a proper reason, is punished under Article 56 of the Consumer Rights Protection Law (nationwide, in force from 1 January 2022).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. How many days and how many times the car was repaired are proved entirely by the repair orders, so every order should state the fault and the time in and the time out. Work out the use-compensation fee yourself from the formula: a car of 200,000 yuan driven 10,000 kilometres, with n at the 0.5% ceiling, comes to about 10,000 yuan. If the shop will not accept it, complain first on 12315. What the market-regulation department does is mediation. If mediation fails, the only path is to sue. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months. Lawyer fees are yours. Winning does not shift them onto the other side. If the car is sold to someone else inside the repair-warranty period, the three-guarantee voucher goes with the car and the three-guarantee duty does not change. When you buy a used car you can ask the seller for it. If a dealer hides the condition of a used car, see item 48 of this section (a used car sold with an accident or flood damage hidden). The beneficiary is you and your family.

## 48. When you buy a used car from a dealer, check the insurance-claim and repair records first, and write into the contract that it is "not an accident car and not a flood-damaged car." If that was hidden, you can demand the car back and compensation of three times the price

**Cost**. You pay a third-party inspector. The price differs from place to place. Before you buy, spend an hour or two checking the car's insurance-claim and repair records. When you sign, spend a bit more talk getting the promises about condition into the contract. If you were in fact cheated and you sue, it can drag on for two or three years.

**In plain terms**. If you buy a used car from a dealer, and the dealer deliberately hides the real condition, such as an accident or flood damage, you can return the car and also demand compensation of three times the price. You get the three times only if you prove the dealer hid it on purpose. If the dealer says it did not know, and the court accepts that, you only get the price back plus interest. Buying from a private owner does not get the three-times compensation.

**Benefit**. The seller of a used car must give the buyer the true facts on use, repairs, accidents, and inspections, and on whether the car is mortgaged, whether the taxes and fees have been paid, and the scrap deadline. If the seller's concealment and fraud mean the car cannot be transferred into the buyer's name, the seller must take the car back unconditionally and return the purchase price. Article 55 of the Consumer Rights Protection Law says that if a business operator defrauds the consumer in supplying goods, it pays additional compensation at the consumer's request, in the amount of three times the purchase price, and if that amount is under 500 yuan it is counted as 500 yuan. This article covers only business operators. It does not apply to a purchase from a private owner. There is a judgment from Rizhao, Shandong. In May 2023 (2023-5) Sun bought a car from a used-car shop for a total of 53,000 yuan. The shop promised it had not had a major accident. In October of the same year (2023-10) an appraisal firm found it was a major-accident car. The records showed it had been in an accident that January (2023-1) and had been written off as a total loss. At first instance the contract was cancelled, the shop returned 53,000 yuan, and it paid a further three times the price, 159,000 yuan. In April 2025 (2025-4) the Rizhao Intermediate People's Court upheld that on appeal. The two sides had signed no written contract. The shop's stamped receipt was enough to win. There is a

judgment the other way. In January 2018 (2018-1) Wang, in Henan, paid 240,000 yuan for a car. The contract promised no accident and no flood damage. It later turned out the car had been in an accident before delivery and that the repairs cost 5,100 yuan. First instance and the retrial both ordered a refund plus three times. The Zhengzhou Intermediate People's Court changed that on appeal, and the retrial upheld the appeal judgment. The reason was that the accident and the repairs had already happened when the dealer bought the car, and there was no evidence the dealer knew and deliberately hid it. So it was only a breach of contract: the contract was cancelled, and the 240,000 yuan price was returned with interest, with no three-times compensation. That court reminded buyers that they can check a used car's insurance-claim record by various routes, and can also hire a third-party professional to inspect it (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The three-times compensation applies only to a business operator, meaning a dealer or a used-car shop. If you were cheated buying from a private owner, you can only ask a court under the Civil Code to cancel the contract and return the money. Cancellation has to be brought within 1 year of knowing you were cheated, and no later than 5 years after the deal. Even if the contract says things like "condition as it stands," also write in promises such as "not an accident car, not a flood-damaged car, not a fire-damaged car," so there is something to set beside the facts later. Both judgments took about two years from the purchase to the decision. Lawyer fees are yours, so checking the records and having the car inspected before any lawsuit is the better deal. If a new car is still inside the repair-warranty period, the three-guarantee voucher goes with the car. See item 47 of this section (the three-guarantee on a new car). How to compare a car loan is in item 7 of this section (turn borrowing into an annual rate first). The beneficiary is you and your family.

## 49. When you buy a car at a 4S store, do not pay a "financial service fee." Insurance, the loan, and registration do not have to be done at the store either

**Cost**. No money. Before you sign, spend a few minutes asking what each sum is a fee for, and have the store write it into the contract or onto an invoice. Doing the insurance and the registration yourself means one extra trip.

**In plain terms**. If the store says that taking a loan means paying a separate "financial service fee," the rules do not allow a dealer to charge that. You can take the insurance, the loan, and the registration to another place, or do them yourself. The store cannot force you to do them there, and it cannot charge money on top of the marked price. Before you take a loan, have them write down the annualized rate and every fee, then compare.

**Benefit**. The measures on automobile sales say a dealer must post, in the store, the prices and fee schedules for the car, the parts, and each service, and must not sell above the marked price or collect extra fees. The dealer must not limit the place of your household registration, and must not limit which provider you use for parts, supplies, finance, insurance, rescue, and after-sales service. Parts and services that the manufacturer pays for under the three-guarantee and under recalls are the exception. When selling a car, the dealer must not force you to buy insurance, and must not force you to let it handle registration for you. A breach of these points is ordered corrected by the commerce department at county level or above, which may warn the dealer or fine it up to 30,000 yuan. In 2022 the former China Banking and Insurance Regulatory Commission required financial institutions that make car loans to control the dealers they work with: a dealer must not charge fees in the financial institution's name, and must not charge fees on the ground that it is providing you a financial service. It must also tell you the annualized loan rate and the fee rate. It must not induce you with lines that do not match the facts, such as "no penalty for breaking the loan" or "the car needs no mortgage," and it must not bundle products and services against your will. The financial institution itself must not charge a fee as a condition of the loan. The regulations implementing the Consumer Rights Protection Law say a business operator must not force you, or force you in a disguised way, to buy something, and must not shut out or limit your choice of another operator (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This money is often renamed a "service fee," a "handling fee," or a "loan service package." Under the rules all of them have to be shown in advance, and nothing extra can be charged outside the marked price. If you have already paid, ask the store for it back first. If it will not return the money, call 12378 for anything tied to the loan, and complain on 12315 for the rest. If the sum is small and you need to sue, how a small-claims case works is in item 22 of section 8 (cheated in an online purchase or a second-hand deal). There is no official figure for how much this fee usually is. The benefit magnitude is medium, set by judgment. The handling fee on a car loan has to be counted into the annualized rate before you compare. The method is in item 7 of this section (turn borrowing into an annual rate first). The beneficiary is you and your family.

# 6. The anti-list

This section collects things that look cheap and effective. Once the original studies are opened, their benefit is close to zero, equal to zero, or in some cases negative.

The items are grouped by subject below. Item numbers are in parentheses.

**Supplements**: multivitamins (item 1), ordinary fish oil (item 2), vitamin D supplements (item 3), antioxidant supplements to prevent cancer (item 4), chondroitin for knee osteoarthritis (item 5), vitamin C to prevent colds (item 6), spending a lot on health products (item 10), taking probiotics long term (item 11), buying detox and colon-cleansing products (item 13), loading calcium after a fracture (item 30), relying on melatonin to cure long-term insomnia (item 34).

**Check-ups and small findings**: a whole-body PET-CT and a tumour-marker panel (item 7), a general check-up package (item 18), do not take medicine for high uric acid if it has never hurt (item 19), do not have a gallbladder stone removed if it has never hurt (item 20), do not give up calcium to prevent kidney stones (item 21), do not have arthroscopic clean-out for degenerative knee pain (item 33).

**Health sayings**: counting on a wristband to help you lose weight (item 8), buying organic food (item 9), cold showers to strengthen immunity (item 12), not forcing yourself to drink water (item 14), blue-light glasses (item 16), treating blood donation as health care (item 17), breakfast or intermittent fasting to control weight (item 26), counting on a correct lifting posture to prevent low-back pain (item 29), demanding an IV drip for a cold or fever (item 35).

**Spending money on luck and on mood**: paying for fortune-telling and horoscopes (item 15), buying crystals, pixiu, and similar objects (item 22), buying things to improve your mood (item 23), spending more in order to move up a tier (item 24), not saving because you think people can die at any time (item 32).

**Willpower and sex**: willpower is like a muscle (item 25), masturbation harms the body (item 27), conversion of sexual orientation (item 28).

**Answers from AI**: judging your own illness with an AI chatbot (item 31).

## 1. Don't take multivitamins just to live longer or protect your heart and blood vessels

**Cost**. About 0.5–2 yuan per day, or 200–700 yuan per year. Taking them takes almost no time — just one pill each day. Over time, though, people can become dependent, feeling they've missed out on something important if they skip a day.

**In plain terms**. 14,400 male doctors took multivitamins for 11 years. The number of serious heart or blood vessel problems and deaths among them was no different from those who didn't take them. When nine studies involving over 50,000 people were combined, there was still no effect on overall mortality. Skipping multivitamins saves you 200–700 yuan each year. This does not apply to people who truly lack certain nutrients or pregnant women needing folic acid.

**Benefit**. The PHS II trial followed 14,641 male doctors for a median of 11.2 years. Both groups — those taking multivitamins and those who didn't — showed the same rate of major cardiovascular events. The hazard ratio was 1.01 (meaning no real difference), with a 95% confidence interval of 0.91–1.10. Similarly, overall mortality rates were identical, with a hazard ratio of 0.94 (95% CI 0.88–1.02). In 2022, USPSTF evaluated nine randomized controlled trials involving 51,550 participants and concluded there is no link between multivitamin use and reduced mortality; they assigned it a Grade I rating, meaning evidence is insufficient to draw any firm conclusions. The idea that multivitamins are a good deal stems partly from the convenience of “one pill for all nutrients” and their low daily cost.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A point of debate: among these same male doctors, cancer rates were slightly lower among multivitamin users — about 8% fewer cases (95% CI 0.86–0.998, P=0.04, just barely significant). Deaths from

cancer were also reduced by roughly 12% (95% CI 0.77–1.01), though this range includes 1, so it may simply be a coincidence. Any such benefit is very small and has only been observed in male doctors. It does not apply to people with proven nutrient deficiencies, pregnant women needing folic acid, or those with extremely poor diets. 〔14000〕

## 2. Don't take regular fish oil just to prevent heart disease

**Cost**. Roughly 1–3 yuan per day, or 400–1,000 yuan per year. It requires no extra time to take.

**In plain terms**. Two large trials enrolled 26,000 and 15,000 people with diabetes respectively. Those who took 1 gram of fish oil daily showed no difference from non-users in terms of major cardiovascular events or death rates. The fact that eating fish is healthy does not mean fish oil capsules are equally beneficial. Skipping them can save you 400–1,000 yuan each year.

**Benefit**. The VITAL trial followed 25,871 participants for 5.3 years; those taking 1 gram of fish oil daily showed no difference in major cardiovascular events or mortality compared to non-users. The hazard ratio for major events was 0.92 (95% CI 0.80–1.06), well below 1, indicating no benefit. All-cause mortality showed a similar pattern (HR 1.02, 95% CI 0.90–1.15). The ASCEND trial, involving 15,480 diabetic patients over 7.4 years, also found no difference in severe vascular events (RR 0.97, 95% CI 0.87–1.08) or mortality (RR 0.95, 95% CI 0.86–1.05). These results appear favorable only because many assume “eating fish is healthy” equates to “fish oil capsules are beneficial.”

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy exists: One trial did show benefits. The REDUCE-IT trial included 8,179 high-risk patients with existing cardiovascular disease or diabetes, already on statins and with elevated triglyceride levels (135–499 mg/dL). Those taking 4 grams of prescription-grade pure EPA daily saw a 25% lower risk of events (HR 0.75, 95% CI 0.68–0.83). However, this was a high-dose prescription medication for a specific high-risk group, not ordinary fish oil supplements for the general population. This discussion excludes the health benefits of eating fish itself. 〔17.2〕

## 3. Don't give vitamin D supplements for longevity to people who are not deficient

**Cost**. About 0.2 to 0.5 yuan a day, or 100 to 200 yuan a year. The money is not much; the real cost is thinking you have already done prevention.

**In plain terms**. People who were not deficient and then supplemented for 5 years had the same numbers of cancers, cardiovascular disease, and deaths as those who did not. Adults who rarely go out and get little sun may take 400 IU a day and should not exceed 2000 IU a day. At high doses, bone density falls more and falls increase. Fatigue alone does not mean vitamin D deficiency; if you have been tired for weeks with no clear reason, see a doctor.

**Benefit**. The VITAL trial enrolled 25871 people who took 2000 IU daily and followed them for a median of 5.3 years. Cancer, cardiovascular disease, and death showed no difference. For cancers that spread, HR was 0.96 (HR is a hazard ratio; 1 means the two sides match; 95% CI 0.88–1.06 is the credible range). For major cardiovascular events, HR was 0.97 (0.85–1.12). For all-cause death, HR was 0.99 (0.87–1.12). The D-Health trial enrolled 21315 Australians aged 60 and above who took 60000 IU monthly and followed them for 5 years. That trial also showed no difference: all-cause death HR 1.04 (0.93–1.18). Death rates were 5.3% versus 5.1%. It looks worthwhile because some studies only record and never intervene, find that people with low vitamin D die more often, and that is misread as “supplementing works.” People who rarely go out have a separate recommendation. The UK Department of Health advises adults who rarely go out, live in care homes, or cover most of their skin when outdoors to take 10 micrograms of vitamin D daily year-round. The NHS states that 1 microgram equals 40 IU, so 10 micrograms is 400 IU. China's health industry standard recommends 10 micrograms a day for adults aged 18 to 64 and 15 micrograms for those 65 and above. The same standard sets the tolerable upper intake at 50 micrograms a day (2000 IU), because too much raises blood calcium. The NHS adult upper limit is wider: 100 micrograms (4000 IU). Fatigue has many causes; the

NHS lists insufficient sleep, stress and depression, iron-deficiency anemia, diabetes, hyperthyroidism, and sleep apnea. It advises seeing a doctor if fatigue lasts several weeks without a clear reason, or if it interferes with daily life. More is not better. VITAL also counted fractures: people on 2000 IU daily matched those who did not supplement (HR 0.98, 0.89–1.08). VITAL also looked at depression among 18353 of the participants aged 50 and above who were not depressed at the time. Those who supplemented had 12.9 cases of depression or relapse per 1000 person-years; those who did not had 13.3; no difference (HR 0.97, 0.87–1.09). Mood scores also did not differ. The authors state that the results do not support adults using vitamin D to prevent depression. A Canadian trial enrolled 311 healthy people aged 55 to 70 without osteoporosis, in three groups taking 400, 4000, or 10000 IU daily for 3 years. The higher the dose, the more bone density fell at the wrist radius: 1.2%, 2.4%, and 3.5% respectively. Bone compressive strength showed no difference. The authors conclude that this does not support high-dose vitamin D helping bone. A Swiss trial enrolled 200 people aged 70 and above who had fallen; they took 24000 IU or 60000 IU monthly for a year. The 60000 IU group's leg function did not improve, and more of them fell within the year (66.9% versus 47.9%). An Australian trial enrolled 2256 women aged 70 and above who took 500000 IU once each autumn–winter. Their falls were about 15% higher (RR 1.15, 1.02–1.30) and fractures about 26% higher (RR 1.26, 1.00–1.59).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy: Neither VITAL nor D-Health specially recruited people who were truly vitamin D deficient, so the conclusions cover only “people who were not already deficient.” People confirmed deficient, people with osteoporosis, and infants and young children should still supplement as their doctor says. Severe deficiency does not have to mean an injection. The 2016 global consensus on rickets recommends oral dosing because oral raises levels faster than intramuscular injection. One trial enrolled 61 children with rickets: one group got a single injection of 600000 IU; the other took 60000 IU orally each week for 10 weeks. At 12 weeks, labs and imaging did not differ between groups. After finishing the dose the doctor prescribed, recheck; if levels still do not rise, have the doctor look for an absorption problem. People who get little sun taking 400 IU daily are preventing deficiency. The health industry standard states that vitamin D deficiency causes rickets, osteomalacia, and osteoporosis. That does not mean it prevents cancer or heart disease, or that it treats fatigue. If a doctor has prescribed a different dose, follow the doctor. Whether supplementing helps people who already have depression is mixed. A 2023 analysis pooling 41 trials saw a small drop in depression scores, but results varied widely across trials and the authors rated the evidence quality in the lowest tier. A 2024 analysis split by duration found that trials followed for a year or more showed no effect. If you have depression, go to psychiatry or clinical psychology first; do not replace treatment with vitamin D. This item looked at all-cause death, cancer, cardiovascular disease, bone, falls, and depression; nothing else. How infants should supplement is in Section 20, Item 16 (400 international units of vitamin D daily).

## 4. Don't take antioxidant supplements to prevent cancer (beta-carotene, vitamins E and A)

**Cost**. Approximately 0.5 to 2 yuan per day. For smokers, the real cost is a higher risk of lung cancer.

**In plain terms**. Antioxidant supplements are not merely useless. Pooling 78 trials and nearly 300000 people, in the more rigorously designed trials those who took them had a slightly higher death rate. In two large trials done specifically on smokers, beta-carotene raised the share who got lung cancer by 18% to 28%. Deaths were also higher by 8% to 17%. Smokers and people exposed to asbestos especially should not take them.

**Benefit**. Cochrane reviewed 78 randomized controlled trials with 296,707 participants total. The overall risk ratio for mortality among supplement users was 1.02 (95% CI 0.98–1.05). When only higher-quality trials were considered, the risk ratio rose to 1.04 (1.01–1.07). Specifically, beta-carotene raised mortality risk to 1.05 (1.01–1.09) and vitamin E to 1.03 (1.00–1.05). The ATBC trial tracked 29,133 male smokers who took 20 mg daily; it found a 18% increase in lung cancer incidence (3%–36%) and an 8% rise in overall mortality (1%–16%). The CARET trial involved 18,314 smokers or asbestos-exposed individuals; it showed a 28% higher risk of lung cancer (RR 1.28, 1.04–1.57) and a 17% higher risk of all-cause mortality (RR 1.17, 1.03–1.33). The perception that these supplements are beneficial stems from the flawed logic that antioxidants prevent aging, which in turn prevents cancer — each step of this reasoning seems intuitive but is untrue.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The U.S. Preventive Services Task Force (USPSTF) rated both beta-carotene and vitamin E as "D" in 2022, meaning they advise against their use. Smokers and asbestos-exposed individuals have already suffered harm from taking them. Naturally occurring antioxidants found in fruits and vegetables are not included in this recommendation; you may continue eating those as normal.

## 5. Don't expect glucosamine/chondroitin to treat knee osteoarthritis

**Cost**. About 2 to 5 yuan a day, or 700 to 1800 yuan a year.

**In plain terms**. People with knee osteoarthritis who took a placebo for 24 weeks also had about six in ten say the pain eased. Those on glucosamine or chondroitin were only four or five percentage points above that — small enough that it may be chance. Spending 700 to 1800 a year buys an effect that is basically the same as placebo.

**Benefit**. The GAIT trial enrolled 1583 people with knee osteoarthritis for 24 weeks. Among those on placebo (fake medicine), 60.1% also said pain eased. Glucosamine was only 3.9 percentage points higher (P=0.30). Chondroitin was 5.3 percentage points higher (P=0.17). Both together were 6.5 percentage points higher (P=0.09). These gaps are too small to rule out chance. In the same trial the real control drug celecoxib was 10.0 percentage points higher (P=0.008). It looks worthwhile because "cartilage building blocks" sound on-target, and placebo alone already helped six in ten people say it worked.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy: In the same trial, among those who already hurt badly at the start, both together had a response rate of 79.2% versus 54.3% in the control group (P=0.002). The authors say this was dug out of the data afterward and is only a lead, not a conclusion. What actually has evidence for knee osteoarthritis is losing weight and building muscle; see Item 33 in this section (arthroscopic clean-out).

## 6. Don't rely on vitamins C to prevent colds

**Cost**. Each effervescent tablet costs roughly 1–2 RMB; annual expense ranges from 300 to 700 RMB.

**In plain terms**. Taking vitamin C every day will basically not make you catch fewer colds, and starting only after you already have a cold works only sometimes. Daily use can shorten one cold by about 8%; whether 300 to 500 a year is worth it is your call. Marathon runners and soldiers marching in cold regions are the exception: among them, those who take it get about half as many colds.

**Benefit**. Cochrane reviewed 29 randomized controlled trials involving 11,306 participants. For ordinary people, regular vitamin C consumption does not meaningfully reduce overall cold incidence; the risk ratio here is 0.97, meaning there is virtually no difference between groups. The 95% confidence interval for this figure is 0.94–1.00. Trials where vitamin C was taken only after cold symptoms appeared showed mixed results: some indicated a benefit, others did not. For the general population, long-term daily intake does shorten cold duration by about 8% in adults (95% CI 3%–12%) and 14% in children (95% CI 7%–21%). Marathon runners, skiers, and soldiers in cold climates again form an exception: 5 trials with 598 participants showed their cold incidence dropped by roughly half, with a risk ratio of 0.48 (95% CI 0.35–0.64). The perceived value of vitamin C for cold prevention is largely driven by its low cost, pleasant sweet-and-sour taste, and the fact that this claim has been widely circulated for half a century.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy note: The same Cochrane review confirms that regular vitamin C intake does shorten the duration of cold symptoms. For adults, this reduction is about 8% (95% CI 3%–12%); for children, it is 14% (95% CI 7%–21%). This translates to roughly half a day of reduced illness per cold episode. Marathon runners, skiers, and soldiers in cold climates are again the exception: 5 trials with 598 participants showed their cold incidence fell by about half (risk ratio 0.48, 95% CI 0.35–0.64). The vast majority of people do not fall into these special groups. 〔500〕

## 7. Don't get a whole-body PET-CT or tumor marker panel just because you have no symptoms

**Cost**. A whole-body PET-CT costs roughly 7,000–10,000 RMB per scan and exposes you to ionizing radiation. Tumor marker panels cost a few hundred RMB. The real cost comes later: if a test flags an "abnormality" that turns out to be a false positive, you'll need follow-up tests, biopsies, and possibly surgery — all of which add up financially and physically.

**In plain terms**. When people without symptoms get screened, what turns up most often is a false alarm. Over eight in ten who get a whole-body CT have at least one "abnormality" noted, and nearly four in ten are called back for more tests, yet most findings are benign. Women screened with ovarian-cancer markers do not die less of ovarian cancer, and some have had surgery for nothing after a false alarm.

**Benefit**. The USPSTF, which evaluates preventive measures in the U.S., gave a D rating to using CA-125 and ultrasound to screen asymptomatic women for ovarian cancer — meaning it does not recommend this screening. Their basis is the PLCO trial, which showed a 0.34% death rate from ovarian cancer in the screened group versus 0.29% in the control group (RR 1.18, 95% CI 0.82–1.71). Screening offers no real benefit. The rate of unnecessary surgery due to false positives ranges from 0.2% to 3.25% across studies, with up to 15% of those patients experiencing serious complications. Another study screened 1,192 symptom-free individuals with whole-body CT; 86% had at least one "abnormality" noted, and 37% were advised to undergo further tests. Most of these findings were benign. The idea that screening is "worth it" because it enables early detection stems largely from intuition rather than solid evidence.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The tumor marker portion of this recommendation is supported by randomized controlled trials. In contrast, the evidence for whole-body CT and PET-CT relies mainly on observational follow-ups without proper control groups, so it falls to a B rating. Other proven screening methods — such as tests for colorectal and cervical cancer, breast cancer screening, or low-dose chest CT for high-risk individuals — are discussed in Section 1. For people already showing symptoms or diagnosed with cancer, PET-CT is a diagnostic tool, not a screening measure, and is handled separately.

## 8. Don't expect fitness trackers to help you lose weight

**Cost**. Devices cost between 200 and 2,000 RMB. Plus, you have to constantly check those numbers every day.

**In plain terms**. Overweight people on the same diet and exercise plan lost 3.5 kg in two years if they wore a fitness band, while those without one lost 5.9 kg. To lose weight, the device is not money you have to spend.

**Benefit**. The IDEA trial involved 471 overweight or obese adults and followed them for 24 months. Everyone followed identical diet and exercise routines; the only difference was whether they wore wearable devices. The group wearing trackers lost 3.5 kg (95% CI 2.6–4.5). The other group lost 5.9 kg (95% CI 5.0–6.8), a difference of 2.4 kg (95% CI 1.0–3.7, P=0.002). It seems cost-effective only because the idea "you must measure to manage" sounds logical, and the devices are a one-time purchase.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This is just one trial, using devices from the early 2010s worn on the arm; we can't conclude that all wearable devices are useless. Exercise itself remains effective, as discussed in Section 2. The bottom line: buying fitness trackers isn't necessary if you want to lose weight.

## 9. Don't pay a premium for organic food just to be "healthier"

**Cost**. Typically 1 to 3 times the price of regular versions of the same foods.

**In plain terms**. There is no strong evidence that organic food is more nutritious. Only 3 studies looked at how healthy people were after eating it, and none found a difference. Organic produce does have pesticide residues detected 30 percentage points less often, but a detection is not the same as exceeding the limit.

**Benefit**. One systematic review combined findings from 17 human studies and 223 studies analyzing food composition. Its conclusion was that “there is insufficient evidence to show organic food is significantly more nutritious than conventional food.” Of those human studies, just three looked at actual health outcomes such as allergies and symptomatic infections; no differences were observed between organic and conventional diets. The perception that organic food offers better value stems from the common-sense chain of reasoning: “no pesticides means greater safety, and greater safety means better health.”

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Very few studies have directly examined how organic food impacts human health. Therefore, the conclusion is “there is no evidence that organic food is superior,” rather than “it has been proven to offer no benefits.” Environmental impact, animal welfare, and taste are not addressed here. Eating more fruits and vegetables remains beneficial regardless of whether they are organic or not.

## 10. Don't spend a lot on health products, herbal pastes, or tonics to “tone the body”

**Cost**. From a few hundred yuan to over 10000 yuan. Packaged as gifts, the price often multiplies several times.

**In plain terms**. Multivitamins, fish oil, vitamin D, and other common ingredients have already been checked one by one in the first six items of this section; none showed a benefit. The line on the pack — “Health food is not a drug and cannot replace drug treatment of disease” — is required by the agency that regulates health foods. If the money is meant as a gift for parents brought to the door, the intention is fine; only the product is the wrong choice.

**Benefit**. What you get back is the money saved. The reasons are in the first 6 items of this section. The most common ingredients in health products — multivitamins, fish oil, vitamin D, antioxidants, glucosamine, vitamin C — showed no expected benefit in randomized controlled trials. The numbers for each are in those 6 items' Benefit lines. Regulatory rules only say what may be claimed; they are not evidence that a product is useless. The State Administration for Market Regulation requires that the front of a health-food pack dedicate no less than 20% of its area to one sentence: “Health food is not a drug and cannot replace drug treatment of disease.” The same rules lock the use of health foods to “supplementing dietary nutrients, maintaining or improving the body's health state, or lowering disease risk factors.” It looks worthwhile because “does not treat disease, only tones” is hard to falsify, and when the money is spent as a gift it rides on reciprocity, not evidence.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The conclusion is “no evidence in support,” not “already proven useless,” so the grade is only C. For products with clear ingredients, check the matching studies in the earlier items. People confirmed nutrient-deficient or under treatment should follow the doctor. What to reject is the product, not the goodwill. If an older person already bought and is taking them, and is not using them to replace prescribed medicine and has no problems from them, there is no need to start an argument at the door. Arranging the vaccines and screenings that are due matters more. The same money spent on the items below each has a source elsewhere in the book. Go with an older person for the yearly flu shot — Section 1, Item 20. Shingles vaccine after 50 — Section 1, Item 21. Pneumococcal vaccine at 65 and above — Section 1, Item 22. Buy a blood-pressure monitor and see that they take blood-pressure medicine as prescribed until the reading is on target — Section 1, Item 7. Adapt the bathroom and stairs at home and practice balance and leg strength with them — Section 1, Item 13. Age-appropriate cancer screening, go with them once — Section 1, Items 17 to 19. For someone already long-term bedridden, pressure-ulcer prevention and long-term care insurance are in Section 17, Items 7 and 8. If you want to bring something to the door, swap in fruit, rice and noodles, or foods they like — more solid than a herbal paste. What really needs stopping are two kinds: prepaid “invest for retirement” schemes, and products that would replace medicine — see Section 17, Item 5.

## 11. Don't take probiotics long-term if you have no gut problems

**Cost**. Approximately 2–5 RMB per day, or 700–1800 RMB per year.

**In plain terms**. Pooling 45 trials in healthy adults, taking probiotics does not lastingly change the gut bacteria; stop and they go back. Blood lipids also do not improve. Antibiotic-related diarrhea and similar specific cases have other evidence; they are not in this item.

**Benefit**. The same review concluded that there is no reliable evidence that probiotics can produce lasting alterations in gut flora or improve blood lipid profiles in healthy adults. While gut bacteria do shift temporarily while taking probiotics, these changes reverse once use stops. The practice may seem cost-effective simply because "gut health" is a broad concept that can be loosely applied, and the daily cost of a single probiotic dose is quite low.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The review also notes a few minor benefits in healthy individuals, such as firmer, better-textured stools and increased Lactobacillus levels in women's vaginas. Separate evidence exists for probiotics used to treat antibiotic-induced diarrhea or for specific strains targeting particular medical conditions; those cases are not covered here. This review pertains solely to healthy adults using probiotics as a daily supplement.

## 12. Don't force yourself into cold showers to "boost immunity"

**Cost**. No money. You have to endure 30 to 90 seconds of discomfort each day; sticking with it in winter takes willpower. People with cardiovascular disease should also be careful: cold stress is a risk for them.

**In plain terms**. In a trial of 3018 people, those who took cold showers had 29% fewer sick-leave occasions. But the total days of leave matched everyone else, so it does not mean less illness. A 2025 pooling of 11 trials found that after cold water, markers of inflammation rose briefly and immune markers did not change. Wash if you like; just do not treat it as a health investment.

**Benefit**. A Dutch randomized controlled trial enrolled 3018 people who, after a hot shower, rinsed with cold water for 30, 60, or 90 seconds. Their sick-leave occasions fell by 29% (IRR 0.71, a rate ratio for counts). But the paper states there was "no significant between-group difference in sick-leave days": total days ill were the same on both sides. Quality of life, work productivity, and anxiety also showed no meaningful differences. A 2025 systematic review pooled 11 randomized trials and 3177 people. Right after cold water and 1 hour later, markers of inflammation rose instead. Immune markers did not change. Stress fell only at the 12-hour time point. The authors themselves say the evidence is "limited by few RCTs and small samples," meaning such randomized trials are scarce and each enrolls few people. It looks worthwhile because it costs nothing and the intuition "suffering works" is smooth.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Controversy: Sick-leave occasions did fall by 29%, and that gap does not look like chance. But total days of illness did not fall, so you cannot say people truly got sick less. Cold water for athletes' recovery after training is a different question; this item does not cover it. Cold showers show no clear harm in healthy people; just do not treat them as a health investment.

## 13. Don't buy detox, colon-cleansing, enzyme, or alkaline water products

**Cost**. Several hundred to several thousand yuan. Diets meant to "detox" by starving oneself can even lower blood sugar and cause nutritional deficiencies.

**In plain terms**. The detox industry is massive, yet there is very little clinical evidence to back it up, and no proper trials have been conducted on commercially available detox diets. When researchers looked into whether diet pH, alkaline water, or cancer are linked, only one study met the criteria — and it found no connection.

**Benefit**. One review concluded that "despite the booming detox industry, there is very little clinical evidence supporting these diets," and that "no randomized controlled trials have been done on commercial detox diets."

Another systematic review examined diet pH, alkaline water, and cancer: after screening 8,278 studies, just one qualified for inclusion, and it showed no link either. The authors wrote, “It is not reasonable to promote alkaline diets and alkaline water to the public for cancer prevention or treatment.” These products seem cost-effective only because the assumptions “the body contains toxins needing removal” and “an acidic body state causes cancer” sound plausible from a physiological standpoint.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. There is simply no evidence to support these products, which is why they receive a C rating. Removing metabolic waste is naturally the job of the liver and kidneys; as long as these organs are healthy, there is no need for any extra “detox” measures.

## 14. Don't force yourself to drink water just to hit “8 glasses a day”

**Cost**. No money. It takes a little time and attention to remember to drink, and night trips to the toilet also increase.

**In plain terms**. Someone chased down the source of “8 glasses a day” and found not a single study that supports it. Food and other drinks already carry a lot of water, so you need not drink that much. This conclusion applies only to healthy adults who live in a mild climate and are not very active. Hot outdoor work, hard exercise, and people who must drink more for treatment or prevention should drink more on purpose.

**Benefit**. One literature review specifically checked the “8×8” claim — 8 glasses a day, 8 ounces each. Its conclusion was “no scientific study supporting 8×8 was found.” It also wrote that “surveys of food and fluid intake in thousands of adults strongly suggest such a large amount is not needed,” because food and other drinks already supply a lot of water. The author states clearly that this conclusion applies only to “healthy adults in a temperate climate who sit most of the time.” He also wrote that some treatments or prevention need 8×8 or more, and that “hard labor and exercise, especially in hot climates,” of course need more. The claim looks worthwhile because water is free, 8 is a neat number, and “drink more water” sounds harmless in any setting.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. What to reject is the number “you must drink so many glasses a day,” not the idea that drinking more water is harmful. People working in heat and people doing hard exercise are a separate case and should drink on purpose. People who have had kidney stones should drink more — see Section 16, Item 8 (after kidney stones, get the water up). The next two lines are common-sense reminders; the review in the sources line does not state them: drink when thirsty and check urine color; older people who feel thirst less should drink on purpose.

## 15. Don't pay for fortune-telling, tarot, or horoscopes to make decisions

**Cost**. No money. The hard part is giving up a shortcut for deciding and having to think for yourself afterward.

**In plain terms**. In a classic classroom experiment, the “personal personality reading” students got was the same for everyone, yet most thought it was accurate. That is why fortune-telling seems to hit. Astrologers pick the right match about as often as chance. The cost is not only a few dozen yuan: a fortune-telling ring in Xixian, Henan, took incense money and “offering packages” up to 3888 yuan; the lead defendant got 11 years.

**Benefit**. Classic classroom experiment: after a personality test, students got a “personal analysis” that was identical for everyone, yet most rated it as accurate. The author's conclusion is that “acceptance by the subject or the analyst does not prove the explanation is correct.” Of 39 students scoring accuracy from 0 to 5, 34 gave 4 or 5. From the table distribution, the mean is about 4.26. That explains why fortune-telling always seems accurate — the Barnum effect. Astrology was also tested double-blind; the result was published in Nature. Astrologers had to pick, from three personality profiles, the one that matched a chart. They picked correctly in 40 of 116. Blind guessing would hit about 38.5; the astrologers had expected to hit 58.5. Official case: the Xixian County procuratorate in Henan reported an online fortune-telling fraud ring that first drew

people in with free palm reading, then charged “incense money” and “offering packages” up to 3888 yuan. Over 50 victims; more than 2000000 yuan recovered; the lead defendant got 11 years' imprisonment and a 100000 yuan fine.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Both papers are single studies. Forer's original does not state the mean directly; 4.26 is calculated from the distribution in Table 1. This item only says “it does not predict accurately”; it does not judge any belief. Spending a few dozen yuan as entertainment is not counted here; using it to decide quitting, marriage, or investing is where the money is lost.

## 16. Don't buy blue-light glasses to “protect eyesight,” and don't believe “a few months of screens will ruin your eyes,” but eye pain, swelling, and redness are an emergency

**Cost**. No money, and you save the few hundred to over 1000 yuan mark-up on the lenses.

**In plain terms**. Blue-light lenses show no benefit; skipping them saves a few hundred to over 1000 in mark-up. Compared with ordinary lenses, people who wear them do not differ in how tired the eyes feel or how clearly they see, and no evidence was found that they protect the retina. Screen-related ache and dryness can ease; they do not permanently ruin the eyes. What does ruin eyes is welding arc light, lasers, and an acute glaucoma attack.

**Benefit**. A 2023 Cochrane systematic review included 17 randomized controlled trials, each with 5 to 156 people, followed from under 1 day to 5 weeks. Because data were sparse, the people enrolled differed across trials, and follow-up times did not match, the authors did not pool them into one total. Results below are versus lenses without a blue-light filter. At under one week of follow-up, self-reported eye fatigue “may not differ”; certainty is low. One trial of 120 people had a between-group difference of 9.76 units. The credible range for that difference is 95% CI −33.95 to 53.47. The range crosses positive and negative, so no difference shows. Critical flicker fusion frequency, an objective measure of eye fatigue, “may have almost no difference”; certainty low. Best visual acuity after refractive correction is “probably unaffected.” The difference was 0.00 logMAR (95% CI −0.02 to 0.02). That finding rests on 1 study and 156 people; certainty moderate. Effect on daytime alertness is unclear (2 trials, 42 people, certainty very low). The review also found no evidence supporting protection of the macular retina. An American Academy of Ophthalmology public page states that the claim “long screen time permanently damages the eyes” “is not true”; screens only make the eyes uncomfortable after long use. China's Classification and Catalogue of Occupational Diseases (2024 edition) lists photic eye injury from welding arcs and laser eye injury as occupational diseases.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. What screens bring is visual fatigue and dry eye — ache, dryness, blur after long looking. Rest and more blinking ease it. It can ease; that is not the same as “ruining the eyes.” That line is from an American Academy of Ophthalmology public page, not a conclusion of the Cochrane review in the sources line, so it counts only as grade C. What can cause irreversible eye injury in a short time is strong light such as welding arcs, ultraviolet, and lasers. Eye injury from welding arcs is called photic keratitis and is a statutory occupational disease. Blocking it needs safety goggles and a face shield, not blue-light lenses — see Section 19, Item 10 (protection from dust, noise, and chemical toxins). Staying up all night staring at a screen: what to watch for is not the screen itself, but one exception. Eye pain and redness with swelling, rainbow rings around lights, plus headache, nausea, and vomiting — that is an acute angle-closure glaucoma attack. It can crush the optic nerve within days; go to an eye emergency the same day — see Section 13, Item 6 (eye emergencies). Dilated pupils in the dark and long head-down posture pushing the lens forward are triggers; high risk is age 50 and above, hyperopia, and a shallow anterior chamber. Dry eye from screens that drags on can also become a chronic condition needing a doctor, not something that vanishes after one night's sleep. If the eyes stay uncomfortable, or vision is truly falling, see ophthalmology and find the cause; do not just swap lenses on your own. How children and teens prevent myopia is in Section 30, Items 4, 12, and 9 (2 hours outdoors daily, cycloplegic refraction, do not buy “cure myopia” products).

## 17. Don't treat blood donation as health care: “detox, lower lipids, prevent heart attack” has no randomized-trial support; donating too often does cause iron deficiency

**Cost**. No money. One donation — forms, the draw, plus staying to rest and be observed — takes about an hour. For weeks afterward the body keeps replacing the iron lost.

**In plain terms**. Claims that donating detoxifies, lowers lipids, or prevents heart attacks are unreliable. People who keep donating are already healthier; after subtracting that layer, the death-rate drop from one extra donation a year shrinks from nearly 20% to 7.5%. In trials that truly split people for comparison, death counts did not differ. On the flip side, donating too often does leave people weak and cold-sensitive — from iron deficiency.

**Benefit**. The Finnish Kuopio study followed 2862 men aged 42 to 60 for nearly 9 years on average. Of 153 who had donated in the 24 months before counting started, 1 (0.7%) had an acute heart attack. Of 2529 who had not donated, 316 (12.5%) did (difference between the two rates $P<0.0001$). After subtracting age and other coronary risk factors, donors' heart-attack risk was about 88% lower. Relative risk 0.12 (95% CI 0.02–0.86, $P=0.035$). But that is only from follow-up records, with no randomized comparison. The Nordic SCANDAT database has 1182495 donors followed for 9526627 person-years, with 15401 deaths. Subtracting only age and sex, one extra donation a year linked to 18.6% lower mortality (95% CI 16.8%–20.4%). Subtracting also the layer “only the healthy stay allowed to donate,” the drop is left at 7.5% (5.7%–9.4%). The authors conclude it “cannot be interpreted as solid evidence of a health benefit.” The FeAST randomized controlled trial enrolled 1277 people with symptomatic lower-limb arterial disease, randomized into two groups: one had blood drawn every 6 months to lower iron; one was a control. The main outcome was all-cause death: 125/636 (20%) versus 148/641 (23%). HR 0.85 (HR is a hazard ratio; 1 means the two sides match). 95% CI 0.67–1.08, $P=0.17$. Death plus non-fatal heart attack and stroke together: 180 (28%) versus 205 (32%), HR 0.88 (0.72–1.07, $P=0.20$). Neither showed a difference. The INTERVAL randomized trial enrolled 45263 whole-blood donors in three donation intervals: men 12, 10, or 8 weeks; women 16, 14, or 12 weeks. Shorter intervals clearly collected more blood over two years (men's 8-week group 1.69 units more than the 12-week group, 95% CI 1.59–1.80). Quality of life, physical activity, and cognition showed no between-group differences. But donation-related discomfort rose, including fatigue, shortness of breath, vertigo, dizziness, and restless legs (legs so uncomfortable at night you cannot lie still). Mean hemoglobin and ferritin were also lower, and delays for low hemoglobin were more frequent (all $P<0.0001$). Iron deficiency affects heat production: 10 women with iron-deficiency anemia, 8 with exhausted iron stores but no anemia yet, and 12 control women sat in 28 °C water for 100 minutes. The anemia group's rectal temperature was 36.0±0.2 °C versus 36.2±0.1 °C in controls ($P=0.001$). Oxygen use was 5.28±0.26 versus 5.99±0.29 $mL \cdot min^{-1} \cdot kg^{-1}$ ($P=0.04$). Thyroxine and triiodothyronine were also lower ($P<0.002$). The claim looks true because donors are already repeatedly screened healthy people, and the hypothesis “removing iron protects the heart” did not show up in randomized trials.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. What to reject is “donate for your own body,” not donation itself. The blood is for others; by this book's beneficiary tiers it sits in tier ④ (strangers). What can return to you is what the system provides. Article 14 of the Blood Donation Law says unpaid donors pay none of the collection, storage, separation, or testing fees when they use blood in hospital. Spouses and lineal relatives may be exempted or charged less under provincial rules. A January 2024 National Health Commission notice states that in 28 provinces unpaid donors and relatives already get those fees waived at discharge in provincial hospitals. Holders of the Voluntary Blood Donation Dedication Award may also, under local “three frees,” ride public transport free, enter government-run parks free, and skip ordinary outpatient consultation fees at public hospitals. Donate on the legal interval. Article 9 of the Blood Donation Law says each session is generally 200 mL, at most 400 mL. Intervals are no less than 6 months. The encouraged age is 18 to 55. Do not compress the interval to chase honors or group quotas. Women, people with low body weight, and people with heavy periods already run tight on iron; frequent donors may pay privately for one ferritin check. If after donating you stay weak, cold-sensitive, or at night must move restless legs, do not guess “vital energy was harmed” — get a blood

count and ferritin. If iron deficiency is found, supplement as the doctor says and lengthen the donation interval. The cold-sensitivity human evidence is only 10 people; it explains why it can happen, not how many people it happens to.

## 18. Don't rely on a general check-up package to prevent disease; do the few evidence-based screens for your age and sex

**Cost**. No money, and you save a few hundred to a few thousand yuan a year in package fees. What you owe in return is remembering which items to check and how often.

**In plain terms**. People who regularly take general health checks have the same death rate as those who do not, including deaths from cardiovascular disease and cancer. The few evidence-based screens for your age and sex are enough. From age 35 you can have blood pressure measured free once a year; from age 65 there is one free check-up a year.

**Benefit**. The 2019 update of a Cochrane systematic review included 17 randomized controlled trials. For overall mortality it pooled 11 of them, 233298 participants, and 21535 deaths. The general-check group matched the control group: RR 1.00. RR is a risk ratio; 1 means the two sides match. 95% CI 0.97–1.03 is the credible range. For cardiovascular death it pooled 9 trials, 170227 people, and 6237 deaths: RR 1.05 (95% CI 0.94–1.16). For cancer death it pooled 8 trials, 139290 people, and 3663 deaths: RR 1.01 (95% CI 0.92–1.12). Neither showed a difference. The authors conclude that “general health checks are unlikely to be beneficial.” The national basic public-health service measures blood pressure free once a year for permanent residents aged 35 and above. It also gives people aged 65 and above one free health check a year. That free check covers physical exam, blood count, urine routine, fasting glucose, and ECG. Liver function: AST, ALT, total bilirubin. Kidney function: serum creatinine, blood urea. Lipids: total cholesterol, triglycerides, LDL cholesterol, HDL cholesterol. Plus abdominal ultrasound of liver, gallbladder, pancreas, and spleen (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. What to reject is “using the yearly package as disease prevention,” not skipping every test. Also, free yearly blood pressure from 35 and the free yearly check from 65 are already in the national basic public-health program — you need not pay. Tests that have a reason should still be done. Blood pressure, glucose, hepatitis B: Section 1, Items 7, 8, 14. Breast, cervix, colorectal: Section 1, Items 17, 18, 19. Helicobacter pylori and low-dose CT: Section 1, Items 23, 24. Bone density for women 65 and above: Section 1, Item 39 (bone-density testing). High-risk behavior: go get checked — Section 1, Item 31. From what age and how often is written there. Employer-organized checks others pay for: go; what to stop is buying packages yourself and adding items yourself. People with chronic disease, people with symptoms, or tests a doctor ordered for the illness do not count here — that is care, not screening. The most common package items without evidence are tumour markers and whole-body imaging — see Item 7 in this section (whole-body PET-CT and tumour-marker panels). What to do when uric acid is high but never hurt, or gallstones never hurt: Items 19 and 20 in this section. Also, most trials Cochrane included were run in high-income countries where care is already easy to get; places short on medical resources should not copy the conclusion blindly.

## 19. Don't start uric-acid–lowering drugs just because a check-up found high uric acid and you have never had pain

**Cost**. No money, and you also save long-term drug costs and money for regular follow-up labs, and you skip one unnecessary drug risk.

**In plain terms**. For people whose uric acid is over the limit but who have never had a gout attack or tophi, the American College of Rheumatology advises not starting uric-acid–lowering drugs yet. Treat 24 people for 3 full years and you prevent only one gout attack. Hoping it protects the kidneys also fails: kidney patients on the drug still lose kidney function as fast as those on placebo. Treat only after a real attack.

**Benefit**. The American College of Rheumatology 2020 gout guideline covers asymptomatic hyperuricemia: blood uric acid >6.8 mg/dL, with no prior gout attack and no subcutaneous tophi. The guideline conditionally

recommends that these people not start any uric-acid–lowering drug. Drugs include allopurinol, febuxostat, and probenecid. Evidence certainty is rated "high." A table footnote states that "by attributable risk, 24 patients must be treated for 3 years to prevent one gout attack." The CKD-FIX randomized controlled trial enrolled 363 people with stage 3 or 4 chronic kidney disease, no gout history, but risk of worsening. One group took 100–300 mg allopurinol daily; one took placebo. The trial ran 104 weeks. eGFR is a kidney-function marker in mL/min/1.73 m². One group changed −3.33 per year (95% CI −4.11 to −2.55). The other −3.23 (−3.98 to −2.47). The difference was −0.10 (−1.18 to 0.97), P=0.85 — kidney function fell at the same speed. Serious adverse events 46% versus 44%. The PERL randomized controlled trial enrolled 530 people with type 1 diabetes and early-to-mid diabetic kidney disease; they took allopurinol for 3 years, then stopped for 2 months to wash out the effect. Allopurinol did lower blood uric acid from 6.1 to 3.9 mg/dL. After washout, the two groups' GFR differed by only 0.001 mL/min/1.73 m². The credible range for that difference is 95% CI −1.9 to 1.9, P=0.99. Urinary albumin was 40% higher on allopurinol (0 to 80). It looks worthwhile because the intuition "the marker is high so take a drug to push it down" is smooth.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. What to reject is "start lifelong uric-acid–lowering drugs when you have never had an attack," not "high uric acid does not matter." The same guideline lists exceptions. The cases below may warrant starting. First: a first attack plus stage 3 or higher chronic kidney disease. Second: blood uric acid >9 mg/dL (about 535 µmol/L). Third: a history of urinary stones. People with tophi, bone erosion on imaging, or 2 or more attacks a year get a strong recommendation to take drugs; those with more than one attack but under 2 a year get a conditional recommendation. Details: Section 16, Item 9 (once gout is confirmed, take uric-acid–lowering drugs long term). About 7.4% of Han Chinese carry the HLA-B*5801 genotype versus 0.7% of White people. Carriers on allopurinol are more likely to get life-threatening severe drug rash; Asian risk of hypersensitivity syndrome is 3 times that of White people. This is a drug you can skip for now; there is no need to take that extra risk. Before starting, test for the genotype — Section 16, Item 9. The two kidney trials were in chronic kidney disease and type 1 diabetes; they cannot be stretched to "high uric acid is wholly harmless to kidneys." They only reject "lowering uric acid with drugs protects the kidneys."

## 20. Don't have the gallbladder removed prophylactically just because a check-up found gallstones and you have never had pain

**Cost**. No money, and you also save one operation under general anesthesia and one hospital stay. What you owe in return is remembering which signals mean go to hospital at once.

**In plain terms**. People with stones in the gallbladder who have never had pain stay symptom-free for about eight in ten over nearly nine years. Leave them alone and acute problems such as cholecystitis or pancreatitis run about 1 to 3 per thousand per year. Removing the gallbladder is not zero risk: about 1.5% have bile-duct injury. So European and UK guidelines both say: no symptoms, do not cut yet.

**Benefit**. Italy's MICOL population survey ultrasound-scanned 11229 people aged 29 to 69. It found 856 with gallstones, of whom 580 had no symptoms, followed a mean 8.7 years. Of those 580, 453 (78.1%) stayed symptom-free, 61 (10.5%) developed mild symptoms, and 66 (11.4%) severe symptoms. Over follow-up there were 189 cholecystectomies, 41.3% of them in people without symptoms. The authors conclude that "expectant management remains an effective approach for most patients" — watch first, no surgery. A U.S. HMO (a managed-care organization) followed 691 people with confirmed gallstones a mean 78±61.6 months. Of 135 without symptoms followed 58±50.2 months (median 46.3 months), only 10% developed gallstone symptoms and 7% had surgery. Of 50 deaths in the whole group, only 2 were biliary-related, both in the symptomatic group. The authors conclude that "patients with silent stones need not be operated on before symptoms appear"; silent stones are stones that stay quiet and do not flare. UK NICE guideline CG188 item 1.2.1 says: for people with a normal gallbladder and biliary tree who have incidentally found asymptomatic gallstones, "reassure them that they do not need treatment until symptoms develop." The European Association for the Study of the Liver 2016 gallstone guideline puts both sides' risks together. Asymptomatic people develop symptoms in about 0.7% to 2.5% per year. Acute cholecystitis, acute pancreatitis, obstructive jaundice (blocked bile duct, person turns yellow), or cholangitis run 0.1% to 0.3% per year. After a first colic,

complications rise to 1% to 3% per year, so most people hurt once before a major event. On the surgery side, Sweden's national registry of 51041 cholecystectomies had bile-duct injury in 1.5%. About one fifth of those (0.3%) were partial or complete duct transection. One-year mortality was 3.9% with duct injury versus 1.1% without. The guideline also notes that after surgery 10% to 40% of patients still have discomfort, or it improves then returns. The guideline's conclusion: operating on asymptomatic people, open or laparoscopic, does not lengthen life, because the death and complication risk of surgery exceeds the risk of not cutting. Waiting for symptoms also costs less overall. A 1983 estimate gave numbers: prophylactic removal in a 30-year-old man meant living 4 days less on average than watching first; at age 50, 18 days less. No randomized trial has yet compared cutting versus not. Prophylactic removal looks worthwhile because of the intuition "it will hurt eventually, better cut once while young."

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy. China's 2021 biliary-surgery expert consensus lists some asymptomatic gallstones as surgical indications. A commentary in the same journal states that this is one core of the dispute. The full consensus needs a subscription; which exact situations apply was not verified in the original (TODO: to verify). Another opposing view is small stones: stones within 5 mm relate more to pancreatitis. A Dutch estimate says prophylactic removal in such people may add or subtract life years depending on how common and how deadly pancreatitis is. European guidelines also list exceptions: calcified gallbladder wall (porcelain gallbladder), and a gallbladder polyp 1 cm or larger — both warrant removal. When having another major abdominal operation, concomitant removal may be considered. This item covers only one situation: stones in the gallbladder that have never hurt. **Stones in the common bile duct are another matter.** The same guideline item 1.3.1 states clearly that common-bile-duct stones, with or without symptoms, need the duct cleared and the gallbladder removed. Go to hospital the same day for any of these; do not tough it out on this conclusion: ongoing colic in the right upper or upper abdomen, fever with chills, yellow whites of the eyes or skin, dark urine. When a doctor who has seen imaging recommends surgery, ask which reason it rests on — duct involvement, a concurrent polyp, abnormal wall. Do not use this conclusion to argue back. It only blocks "no reason at all, cut just because stones were found." The two studies above followed groups forward without randomized comparison. But they answer "what happens if you leave it alone," not "which treatment is better," so they fit here. Also, follow-up was 4 to 9 years; over longer spans the share who develop symptoms will climb.

## 21. Don't give up calcium to prevent kidney stones

**Cost**. No money. It even saves effort: you need not watch every day which foods contain calcium.

**In plain terms**. People who have had calcium-oxalate stones are often told to eat less calcium; trial results go the other way. Men with recurrent stones who ate normal calcium while cutting animal protein and salt had, over five years, half the recurrence of those on a low-calcium diet. UK guidelines also say not to restrict calcium.

**Benefit**. A 5-year randomized controlled trial enrolled 120 men with recurrent calcium-oxalate stones and high urine calcium (idiopathic hypercalciuria). They were randomized into two groups. One ate normal calcium, 30 mmol a day, while also cutting animal protein (52 g a day) and salt (50 mmol sodium chloride a day). The other ate a traditional low-calcium diet, 10 mmol a day. Over 5 years recurrences were 12/60 versus 23/60. Unadjusted relative risk 0.49 (95% CI 0.24–0.98, the credible range), P=0.04 — recurrence risk on normal calcium was half. During follow-up, urine calcium fell about 170 mg a day in both groups. But urine oxalate differed. The low-calcium group rose a mean 5.4 mg a day; the normal-calcium group fell a mean 7.2 mg a day. UK NICE guideline NG118 item 1.8.1 states not to restrict daily calcium intake. Adults keep 700 to 1200 mg a day. Children and teens 350 to 1000 mg a day by age. Giving up calcium looks worthwhile because of the intuition "stones are made of calcium, so eat less calcium."

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy: The trial was only in men, all with recurrent calcium-oxalate stones and high urine calcium; it does not transfer directly to every stone type. Also the trial arm changed three things at once — normal calcium, less animal protein, less salt — so you cannot credit all benefit to "not giving up calcium."

Low salt and less animal protein may also be working. What to reject is “actively cutting calcium-containing foods,” not “you should take more calcium.” What changed here is calcium in daily meals; calcium supplements are separate — whether someone with past stones should take supplements is a question for the treating doctor. Drinking more water: Section 16, Item 8 (after kidney stones, drink 2.5–3 litres a day).

## 22. Don't buy crystals, bracelets, pixiu, or similar objects for “luck,” “wealth,” or “nourishing people”

**Cost**. No money. All you need to do is not count “luck” or “nourishing people” among the reasons to buy. The hard part is not following when everyone else is wearing them and saying they work.

**In plain terms**. Claims that wearing them changes luck, attracts wealth, or nourishes people have no checkable evidence. It works like fortune-telling seeming accurate: the words are vague enough that you fit them to yourself. When a seller claims disease-treating effects, that is false advertising; in 2026 livestream rooms were punished for it. Buying them as decoration is fine.

**Benefit**. Classic classroom experiments show that everyone gets the same vague “personal analysis” yet most think it is accurate — the Barnum effect. It explains where the experience “things really went smoother after I put it on” comes from. That author's conclusion is “acceptance by the person does not prove the explanation is correct.” Official case: on 4 June 2026 the State Administration for Market Regulation published typical “fake-fighting, source-clearing” cases in the traditional-craft market. A jewellery shop in Sihui, Guangdong, invented product materials on livestream. It also falsely claimed effects such as “preventing rheumatism, raising immunity, improving sleep, and clearing blood vessels.” The shop used scripted acting to mislead and deceive consumers. That violates Article 9 Paragraph 1 of the Anti-Unfair Competition Law (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. There is only one conclusion: its effects cannot be checked, and no predictive power can be measured. This does not judge any belief or custom, and it does not target gifts, memorials, or heirlooms. Separate two things. Advertised medical effects have written rules and can be complained about. Claims like “luck” have no research and also cannot be proven false — you can only control them with a budget. Before buying, treat it as ordinary jewellery and ask: “If it changed nothing, would I still pay this price?” How to check materials and certificates, and why treating them as an investment does not pay: Section 5, Items 33 and 34 (count bracelets and watches as money already spent; for jewellery and jade accept only a CMA report). Paying for fortune-telling: Item 15 in this section (fortune-telling, tarot, horoscopes).

## 23. Don't expect shopping to lift your mood or boost your sense of self-worth

**Cost**. No cost at all. The real challenge is resisting the urge to buy things when you're feeling down.

**In plain terms**. People who put more weight on money and things feel less happy themselves, but the link is weak and you cannot tell which causes which. Other research finds that spending on an experience makes people happier than buying stuff. So for the same spend, putting it toward going out once is more likely to make you happier than filling a shopping cart.

**Benefit**. One meta-analysis (combining findings from many studies) examined 259 separate samples and 753 effect sizes. The results showed that individuals who prioritized material possessions reported lower happiness levels. On the most commonly used multi-dimensional scale, the correlation coefficient was $r = -0.19$ (adjusted $\rho = -0.24$). On scales that measured only “material valuing,” the link was even weaker, with r values ranging from −0.08 to −0.11. The strength of this association varied depending on the outcome measured: it was strongest with risky health and spending behaviors and negative self-evaluations ($r = -0.28$ to $-0.44$), and weakest with life satisfaction and negative emotions ($r = -0.13$ to $-0.15$). Mediation analyses suggested this negative link may arise because unmet psychological needs drive it. Another study found that across two separate surveys, respondents consistently reported greater happiness from spending on experiences than on material goods. Subsequent lab experiments also showed that recalling a positive mood

after spending on an experience led to higher happiness ratings than recalling a similar positive mood after a shopping spree. Both studies used samples from outside China.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Caveats: Most of the included studies asked participants at a single point in time whether they valued material goods and how happy they felt, so they cannot determine which factor comes first. The authors themselves note that further experiments and long-term follow-ups are needed to clarify this directionality. Therefore, this finding should not be interpreted as “shopping makes people unhappy”; rather, it means “relying on shopping to improve your mood is unlikely to work.” Moreover, the association is quite weak: an r value of −0.19 explains only a few percentage points of variation, and individual differences are substantial. Both studies used foreign samples, so there are no comparable data available for Chinese populations. This does not mean you shouldn't spend on things you enjoy; rather, it warns against using shopping as a way to regulate your emotions, as doing so makes impulse buying your first reaction when you're feeling down. Specific money-saving tips are covered in Section 5. Evidence-based ways to improve your mood when you're feeling low are outlined in the latter part of Section 22 and in Section 29. Advice on budgeting for the goal of “keeping up with peers” is provided in Subsection 24 of this section.

## 24. Don't spend extra to move up a tier among people around you — bigger home, car, or circle

**Cost**. No money. All you need before raising the budget is one extra question: does this mark-up buy the thing itself, or your place in this group? The hard part is not following when everyone around has upgraded.

**In plain terms**. Holding income equal, the more neighbours earn, the lower this person's reported happiness. It mainly shows up with neighbours of the same education level, and more clearly in people who often deal with neighbours. So money spent to move into a place where everyone is better off than you buys moving yourself down a tier. But when incomes rise together, people still feel better off.

**Benefit**. The U.S. National Survey of Families and Households (NSFH) revisited the same people in two waves. The authors matched it to local average income. Local average income (PUMA) was estimated from a 5% sample of the 1990 census. After subtracting own income and a set of personal traits, the result was: higher neighbour income, lower self-reported happiness. The effect is large, stable under other calculations, and highly significant. The authors' phrasing is that the happiness drop from “neighbour income rising” is on the same order as from “own income falling by the same amount.” Comparing the same person to themselves over time (individual fixed effects), the coefficient's direction stays and its size is similar; significance only falls to the 10% level. Restricting comparisons to the same state and the same survey wave (state and wave fixed effects), results barely change. So it is not that “people who like moving to poor places are happier anyway,” nor unmeasured state-level factors. The effect is stronger in people who often deal with neighbours and not significant in people who only deal with friends outside the community. Renters and owners did not differ, which does not support “expensive areas have high house prices so spendable money is less.” Happiness falls only with income of same-education neighbours; income of differently educated neighbours barely registers. And it mainly travels through “satisfaction with one's own material situation,” not through satisfaction with family life or other domains. Finally, if own and neighbour income rise by the same proportion, happiness still rises.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Reasons for grade B: the data are repeated surveys of the same people, there is only this one study, and the sample is abroad. The outcome is self-reported happiness, not money. The authors did use statistics to drop several confounds — same person over time, same state and wave — but it is still not a randomized trial. There is no citeable counterpart for a Chinese population. Benefit magnitude is set to “medium,” following Item 23 in this section (don't expect shopping to improve mood). The money saved may well reach the 10000-yuan level. But “how much happiness that saved money buys” has no number behind it, so it is not recorded as “large” on a 10000-yuan scale. This does not oppose spending for a larger home, a quieter compound, or a shorter commute — those buy the thing itself. What to stop is the single reason “colleagues all upgraded; I cannot fall behind.” How to rank a place to live: Section 4, Item 18 (put commute time first

when choosing where to live). Buying things to regulate mood: Item 23 in this section. Constantly comparing upward online: Section 3, Item 20 (don't treat “how others are doing” as required daily reading).

## 25. Don't believe “willpower is like a muscle; use it a while and it's gone”

**Cost**. No money. All that needs changing is one claim.

**In plain terms**. The popular claim is: do one self-control task first, then you break more easily afterward, so conserve willpower. Twenty-three labs and 2141 people redid the experiment under the same protocol; the result was almost zero. Stop explaining yourself with “willpower is used up today,” and don't pay for courses that teach you to stockpile willpower.

**Benefit**. A multi-lab preregistered replication had 23 laboratories and 2141 participants. They redid the sequential-task paradigm under Sripada and colleagues' standardized protocol: first a depleting self-control task, then a second task that needs self-control. Pooled results showed a very small ego-depletion effect, and the 95% credible interval included 0 (d = 0.04, 95% CI −0.07 to 0.15). The authors discuss whether the “self-control is a limited resource” model still stands. Another similarly preregistered redo, 36 labs and 3531 people, found effect size d = 0.06 — again too small to count.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. What to reject is the model “self-control is a resource that can be used up,” not “people get tired.” Too little sleep and working too long lower efficiency — that is separate; handle it with the sleep and hours items in Section 3. What has randomized-trial support is changing the environment and the written plan — see Section 4, Item 10 (move what you should not touch farther away) and Section 4, Item 1 (write “at what time, where, when X happens, do Y”). Fixing what you wear and what you eat is still worth doing because it costs almost nothing. What it saves is those few minutes and a few rounds of indecision, not willpower; don't expect it to make afternoon judgment better. Other items in this section count money; this one counts time and energy — the two are not converted.

## 26. Don't count on breakfast or 16:8 intermittent fasting to control weight; pick meal times you can stick with long term

**Cost**. No money. What you save is the daily mental effort of wrestling meal times.

**In plain terms**. The popular claim is that skipping breakfast makes people binge at lunch and dinner so the day's total is higher. Trials are not like that: people who skipped breakfast ate a bit over 200 kcal less in a day and weighed a little less. 16:8 versus simply eating less: body weight after a year also did not differ. People who skip breakfast long term have about 17% more cardiovascular disease, but that is only an association; all-cause death shows no difference.

**Benefit**. First the claim “skipping breakfast makes people eat more later.” A meta-analysis pooled 13 randomized trials. People assigned to eat breakfast took in 259.79 kcal more per day than those who skipped (95% CI 78.87–440.71, the credible range). Weight was 0.44 kg higher (0.07–0.82). Skippers did not make it up at lunch and dinner. Follow-up in these trials was short: mean 7 weeks for weight, mean 2 weeks for intake. Next, 16:8 and similar eating only in fixed hours. One trial put 116 overweight adults on it for 12 weeks. Eating only from noon to 8 p.m. versus three regular meals: weight differed by −0.26 kg (−1.30 to 0.78), not significant. Another in Guangzhou, 139 people with obesity, followed 12 months. Time-restricted eating plus calorie control lost 1.8 kg more than calorie control alone (−4.0 to 0.4), also not significant. Finally, whether long-term breakfast skipping harms. In a pool of 2.38 million people, skippers had about 17% higher cardiovascular-disease risk (OR 1.17, 1.09–1.26) and about 49% higher cardiovascular death (OR 1.49, 1.20–1.84). But these are record-only, non-randomized studies. In the original study followed 17 to 23 years, the all-cause-death hazard ratio was 1.19, credible range 0.99 to 1.42, crossing 1 — not a difference.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy. That 17% for cardiovascular disease comes from record-only, non-randomized studies. Breakfast skippers are already more likely to smoke, drink, sit long, and earn less; those factors cannot be

cleaned up fully. So how much of the 17% is breakfast itself is unclear. The all-cause-death result already crosses 1. 16:8 is also disputed. One pool of 30 trials and 1341 people, with both arms eating the same amount, found time-restricted eating lost 1.46 kg more (−2.65 to −0.26). The cost was 0.41 kg more lean mass lost. But most of those trials were short; the longest, strictest twelve-month trial said no difference. Long fasting also links to the gallbladder. In a cross-sectional survey of 6547 people, each hour later the first meal of the day, gallstones found rose about 5% (OR 1.05, 1.02–1.08); first meal between 9:00 and 14:00 versus earlier was about 49% higher (OR 1.49, 1.24–1.77). The mechanism is that the longer bile sits in the gallbladder, the more easily stones form. But this is a same-time survey; gallbladder problems may have changed meal habits first. China's Kailuan cohort followed 5.6 years and recorded 369 digestive-tract cancers. Breakfast skippers had 2.32 times the colorectal-cancer risk (1.34–4.01) and 5.43 times gallbladder and extrahepatic bile-duct cancer (1.34–21.93). The latter's credible range reaches 21.93 — too few events; treat as a lead only. Altogether, for weight control, meal timing's effect is small; don't spend mental effort on it. Whether long-term total breakfast skipping is good: existing evidence is all association, not proof of cause, but the direction leans unfavorable. To be safe, eat normally; just don't expect it to help you lose weight. An NIDDK public page states the most common causes of stomach ulcers are Helicobacter pylori and painkillers such as aspirin and ibuprofen; fasting is not among the rarer causes listed. What to check: Section 1, Item 23 (test for H. pylori; if positive, eradicate). Gallstones found on check-up that never hurt: Item 20 in this section. To control weight, what has evidence is what and how much you eat — Section 2, Item 27 (5 servings of fruit and vegetables a day), Item 28 (less ultra-processed food), and Item 32 (keep BMI 20–25). People with diabetes, on glucose-lowering drugs, or pregnant are exceptions; missing a meal may mean low blood sugar — follow medical advice. Extreme fasting and purging are separate — Section 28, Item 1 (don't use extreme dieting, fasting, or purging to control weight).

## 27. Don't believe “masturbation harms the body” or “abstinence makes you better”; what to watch is whether it costs sleep, work, or relationships

**Cost**. No money. What you save is money for “kidney tonic” folk remedies and “abstinence” courses, plus the anxiety of long self-blame.

**In plain terms**. No evidence that masturbation harms the body was found. Men who ejaculate more have about 20% less prostate cancer, though some research also saw higher risk in those who did it often when young. A few people feel weak and flu-like after every ejaculation for days — a rare disease; see urology or andrology. Feeling “addicted to porn” more often comes from the clash with one's own morals.

**Benefit**. First the body. A U.S. study followed 31925 men through 2010. Each reported how many ejaculations a month, then was grouped by count. Versus 4 to 7 times a month, those with 21 or more had prostate-cancer HR 0.81 (95% CI 0.72–0.92, about 19% lower) using counts at ages 20 to 29. Using ages 40 to 49, HR 0.78 (0.69–0.89, about 22% lower). What fell was mainly low-risk prostate cancer. The opposing side is a UK case-control study comparing 431 patients diagnosed before 60 with 409 controls. Frequent masturbation in the twenties and thirties linked to higher risk; frequent in the fifties linked to lower risk. Next, porn. A systematic review plus meta-analysis holds that many people who feel “addicted” are mostly mismatched with what they believe is right, not only that they watch a lot. A few people do feel unwell after every ejaculation, but that is not “harming the body” — it is a rare disease called post-orgasmic illness syndrome (POIS). See a doctor; do not rely on abstinence. Among 45 Dutch patients, 87% began within 30 minutes of ejaculation, 80% were exhausted and weak, 78% felt like they had a cold. At a French hospital, 37 patients took a mean 4.7 days to recover. Cause is unclear. In the Dutch study, of 33 who had skin tests, 29 (88%) were allergic to their own semen. A Chinese study of 24 patients found no semen-specific allergy antibodies; anxiety and depression scores were high. A 2025 review found only 14 treatment studies, 12 of them case reports. Of 211 sexual-medicine experts worldwide, only 18% said more than three in ten patients improve (U.S. / UK / Netherlands / France / China).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Controversy. Both prostate-cancer studies are records only, with no randomized comparison, and counts are recalled, so the conclusion can only reach “no evidence of bodily harm was seen,” not advice to do

it more. The UK authors themselves say the fifties period may mean illness came first and frequency fell. The porn paper's abstract gives no effect size, so only direction is written here. Benefit is set to small because what fell is mainly low-risk prostate cancer, not death. Studies of post-ejaculation illness have only dozens of patients each; the literature calls it rare, but no one has counted how many in the general population get it. If nearly every ejaculation leaves you weak, flu-like, for days, go to urology or andrology and name the disease. Signals for psychiatry or clinical psychology: staying up for this, missing work, harming a partner relationship, wanting to stop and failing. Staying up late: Section 3, Item 9 (don't stay up for games, short video, or porn). Worried porn caused erectile problems: first follow Section 1, Item 28 (erectile trouble — check the cardiovascular system first). Legal outcomes of posting to groups or selling material: Section 9, Item 4 (porn video — keep it to yourself). The beneficiary is you.

## 28. Don't pay for “sexual-orientation conversion” or “gay cure,” and don't send a family member

**Cost**. No money. What you save is fees for conversion outfits, psychology clinics, and “quit being gay” camps. The hard part is family insisting on sending someone.

**In plain terms**. An American Psychological Association task force that reviewed the research says such conversion does not change orientation and may harm people. In one U.S. survey, people who had undergone conversion had nearly 90% more lifetime suicidal thoughts. In China a psychiatric hospital forcibly admitted a man under “sexual preference disorder”; a court found infringement and awarded 5000 yuan.

**Benefit**. The American Psychological Association's 2009 task-force report says efforts to change sexual orientation are “unlikely to be successful and involve some risk of harm.” For sending minors into coercive or residential conversion programs, the report advises that neither parents nor children consider it. A U.S. nationally representative survey of 1518 sexual-minority adults found about 7% had undergone conversion, about eight in ten of those by religious practitioners. After subtracting age, adverse childhood experiences, and similar factors, those who had undergone conversion had lifetime suicidal ideation OR 1.92 (95% CI 1.01–3.64, about 90% higher). Planned suicide OR 1.75 (1.01–3.06). Suicide attempts with no or mild injury OR 1.88 (1.01–3.50). Another study interviewed 245 young people aged 21 to 25. Of those not converted in adolescence, 22.0% had attempted suicide. When parents themselves tried to change the child's orientation, 48.1%. When parents also sent the child to a therapist or religious figure, 62.8%. WHO's disease classification ICD-10 states: “Sexual orientation by itself is not to be regarded as a disorder.” In 2017 a court in Yicheng District, Zhumadian, Henan, heard a case: a psychiatric hospital forcibly admitted a man under “sexual preference disorder.” The court held that his “condition was mild, with no suicide, assault, destruction of property, or similar behaviour or danger, and he did not meet the conditions for compulsory treatment.” The hospital was ordered to apologize publicly and pay 5000 yuan in mental-distress damages (U.S. / China).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Controversy. Sullins 2022 reanalyzed the same data after subtracting suicidal thoughts that already existed before conversion. That way, conversion and suicidal thoughts were no longer positively associated (OR 0.44, 0.20–0.94). Sullins's institution opposes homosexuality; the original authors also published a reply. So how large the harm is remains disputed, but “it does not change” has no opposing evidence seen. Grade B because harm figures all come from surveys that recall afterward. In law, inpatient treatment is voluntary in principle; only severe mental disorder plus danger of harm to self or others allows compulsory admission. Psychological counsellors may not deliver psychotherapy. Deliberately sending someone who does not have a mental disorder into hospital treatment brings liability for damages. In 2014 a man was hypnotized and given electric shocks to “treat” homosexuality at Chongqing Xinyu Piaoxiang Psychological Counselling Centre and later sued. Beijing Haidian court ordered a public apology and compensation for economic loss. Reports say the judgment stated homosexuality is not a mental illness and that promising a cure was false advertising. Only The Paper's reporting of the case is available; the original judgment was not found on the court's official site. People long distressed by this may go to psychiatry or clinical psychology, aiming to ease distress. What families do after a child comes out: Section 30, Item 15 (when a child says they like the same sex). Beneficiaries are you and family.

## 29. Don't count on learning a “correct lifting posture” or a lifting course to prevent low-back pain; cut the weight and number of lifts, and exercise regularly

**Cost**. No money. No more arguing over whether the back bent when lifting, and no spending on back-protection classes or belts. Two things to do. Split heavy loads, use a cart, or get someone to help — only a few extra minutes. Carve out several sessions a week to exercise — that takes long-term sticking.

**In plain terms**. Workers who took lifting-posture training later had no less low-back pain than those who did not. People who bend more when lifting also do not clearly get more low-back pain. What links to low-back pain is lifting heavy and lifting often: each extra 10 kg per lift or 10 more lifts a day raises risk by about 10%. People who exercise regularly have about 30% to over 40% fewer low-back-pain episodes.

**Benefit**. First training. The 2011 Cochrane systematic review pooled 9 randomized trials and 20101 employees. In 7 trials and 19317 people: those who had lifting training reported about as much later low-back pain as those who did nothing (OR 1.17, 95% CI 0.68–2.02, credible range crosses 1). Versus watching a video only, RR 0.93 (0.69–1.25), also similar. Evidence quality medium. The authors conclude that lifting advice and training, with or without handling aids, do not prevent low-back pain or disability from it. Next, bending. A 2020 systematic review of how much the back bends when lifting rated evidence quality low. In the only follow-up study, people who later had low-back pain and those who did not differed by only 1.5 degrees in maximum bend while lifting (−0.7 to 3.7), not significant. Of 11 studies, 9 saw no between-group difference. Another 7 studies used a different measure: people with low-back pain bent 6.0 degrees less while lifting (−11.2 to −0.9). The authors conclude there is no evidence that bending more invites low-back pain. Finally what to do. One meta-analysis pooled 8 follow-up studies: each extra 10 kg lifted per time, low-back-pain risk OR 1.11 (1.05–1.18, about 11% higher). Each extra 10 lifts a day, OR 1.09 (1.03–1.15, about 9% higher). Another pooled 21 randomized trials and 30850 people. Exercise plus education cut low-back-pain episode risk RR 0.55 (0.41–0.74, about 45% lower), evidence quality medium. Exercise alone RR 0.65 (0.50–0.86, about 35% lower), evidence quality low to very low. Education alone RR 1.03 (0.83–1.27), back belts RR 1.01 (0.71–1.44) — neither showed an effect. The UK Health and Safety Executive (HSE) official guidance also states that training alone cannot guarantee safe lifting. Good technique does not replace handling aids and redesigning tasks and loads.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy. On the “heavy and often” side, views differ. A 2010 systematic review found 9 high-quality studies: 4 saw an association, 5 did not. The authors think workplace lifting is unlikely to cause low-back pain on its own. So “lift less heavy stuff” is only association evidence, not proof of cause. The bending review's studies are low quality; most compared two groups at one time. The training review's credible range is wide; it also says no randomized trial looked at whether training treats existing low-back pain. HSE still teaches a technique: keep the load close to the waist, feet stable, don't twist, don't yank. When rising, slight bend in back, hips, and knees is better than full bend or full squat. Following it does no harm; just don't expect it alone to prevent low-back pain. Benefit set to medium. By relative drop, exercise reaches large. But exercise-alone evidence quality is low; exercise plus education also did not clearly cut sick leave; and low-back pain is not fatal. How to exercise: Section 2, Item 16 (30–60 minutes of strength training a week) and Section 2, Item 11 (7000–8000 steps a day). The beneficiary is you.

## 30. Don't count on loading calcium or drinking bone broth after a fracture to make bone heal faster

**Cost**. No money, and you also save the cost and effort of calcium tablets, vitamin D, and simmering broth every day. All you need is to test for deficiency and supplement only if deficient; if not deficient, do not add extra.

**In plain terms**. Trials of vitamin D after fracture show no case where bone healed better. Studies of calcium plus vitamin D together are few; whether they help is unclear. Calcium in a large bowl of bone broth is only a

few tenths of a percent of the daily need. People already vitamin D deficient or with osteoporosis are a separate case.

**Benefit**. First vitamin D. A 2023 systematic review included 14 studies and 2734 fracture patients. The authors conclude that vitamin D alone has little effect on bone healing, union, or function after recovery. Studies that seemed to show benefit were generally lower quality. They state that counting only randomized trials, none showed a benefit from supplementing. One enrolled 100 long-bone fracture patients with low vitamin D: half took 100000 IU once within two weeks of injury; half took placebo. Two in each arm failed to unite — 4% together. Another enrolled 102 people aged 18 to 50 with thigh or lower-leg fractures in four dose or placebo groups. At 3 and 12 months, healing scores showed no difference. Another enrolled 32 postmenopausal women with wrist fractures. Versus no supplement, a high-dose group equivalent to about 1800 IU a day had lower compressive stiffness of bone. Next calcium. A 2014 systematic review says clinical studies of how vitamin D insufficiency or supplementing affects fracture healing are few and conclusions unclear. The two studies it found used calcium plus vitamin D together. They saw higher bone density or callus (new bone) at the fracture site; they did not look at healing speed. Finally bone broth. A Kaohsiung, Taiwan assay bought three bone-broth noodle soups, 450 to 550 g of broth per serving. Mean calcium per serving was 14 to 39 mg — 1.4% to 3.9% of a 1000 mg daily recommendation. The authors conclude one serving supplies under 5% of the daily recommendation. China's recommendation is 800 mg a day at ages 18 to 49 and 1000 mg from 50 up; daily upper limit 2000 mg. The health industry standard that sets these figures also states that long-term excess calcium raises kidney-stone risk. A U.S. trial of 36282 postmenopausal women taking 1000 mg calcium plus 400 IU vitamin D daily, followed a mean 7 years: kidney-stone risk about 17% higher (HR 1.17, 95% CI 1.02–1.34, credible range). Hip fracture about 12% lower, not significant (HR 0.88, 0.72–1.08). It looks worthwhile because of the intuition “bone is made of calcium, so more calcium grows faster.”

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Controversy: two small leads. A Danish trial enrolled 30 older women with proximal upper-arm fractures who had osteoporosis or low bone mass. Those taking 800 IU vitamin D plus 1 g calcium daily had higher bone density at the fracture at week 6 (0.623 versus 0.570 g/cm²). But it only measured density, not whether bone healed well, and the sample was tiny. A post-hoc look at the 102-person trial found slightly better function scores on high-dose vitamin D; the authors say more trials are needed to confirm. People already vitamin D deficient are a separate case. In a Dutch follow-up record, delayed healing was 9.7% among those still deficient after supplementing, 0.3% among those not deficient, and 1.7% among those whose levels rose. That is only follow-up recording; it does not prove cause. If deficiency is found, supplement to normal as the doctor says. People already diagnosed with osteoporosis, or who fracture from a light fall, need anti-osteoporosis drugs — Section 1, Item 40 (anti-osteoporosis drugs); calcium tablets do not replace them. Long-term supplementing when not vitamin D deficient has no benefit — Item 3 in this section (vitamin D supplements). What to reject is “extra heavy loading,” not eating less calcium; keep meal calcium adequate — Item 21 in this section (don't give up calcium to prevent kidney stones). Just fell and suspect a fracture: Section 13, Item 41 (suspected fracture). Benefit set to medium by a year's cost of calcium and vitamin D. The beneficiary is you.

## 31. Don't count on an AI chatbot alone to judge illness or legal questions; before seeing a doctor, going to court, or spending a lot, find the sources it cites and check the original

**Cost**. No money. Each check takes a few minutes to half an hour. Have the AI write the statute, guideline, or paper it relies on; open the original yourself and find that sentence. The habit to change is not acting just because it speaks with certainty.

**In plain terms**. Handed a full case, AI names the disease over nine times in ten. But when ordinary people ask it about symptoms, they recognize the disease less often than people who search the web themselves, and whether to go to emergency is not judged more accurately. On legal questions, general-purpose AI answers have fabricated content at least 58% of the time, and they will follow wrong premises in your question.

**Benefit**. First medicine. A 2026 Nature Medicine randomized trial enrolled 1298 ordinary people in the UK; the protocol was preregistered. Each got two prepared cases and had to judge the disease and whether to go to emergency or watch at home. Some used an AI chatbot — GPT-4o, Llama 3, or Command R+. Controls used their usual methods, mostly web search or the NHS site. Handed a full case directly, AI named a relevant disease 94.9% of the time and picked the right care setting 56.3% of the time. Ordinary people using the same AI named a relevant disease under 34.5% of the time and picked the right setting under 44.2%. Controls recognized a relevant disease 1.76 times as often as AI users (95% CI 1.45–2.13, credible range). Recognizing red-flag serious illness was 1.57 times (1.28–1.92). Judging where to go was similar on both sides. The authors reviewed chat logs; problems were two: users did not tell all symptoms, and when AI named the right disease users did not take it. Next law. A U.S. research team in 2024 asked public models including ChatGPT 4 about U.S. federal case law. ChatGPT 4 had fabricated content in 58% of answers; Llama 2 up to 88%. Fabrication means content that does not match legal fact; the paper calls it “hallucination.” Models cannot tell which of their own lines are made up. When the user's question carries a wrong legal premise, they often accept it wholesale. The same team in 2025 tested professional legal AI tools for lawyers. Tools that claim not to fabricate still had fabrication in 17% to 33% of answers. It looks worthwhile because AI is always on, free, and speaks with a doctor's or lawyer's certainty.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy. A 2023 study drew 195 patient questions from a U.S. forum and had clinicians score without seeing the source. 78.6% of scores rated ChatGPT's answer better than a doctor's. But that compared how well the answer was written, not whether the asker's final judgment was right. The 2026 trial used 2024 models; newer ones may be stronger. Yet the same trial also found that AI's solo exam score does not predict how ordinary people do with it. Why AI fabricates: OpenAI researchers explained in a 2025 non-peer-reviewed paper that training and scoring reward “guessing an answer”; saying “I don't know” scores nothing, so when unsure it still speaks with certainty. The check method: have it write the statute name and article number, or the guideline or paper title; open the original on an official site and find that sentence; if you cannot find it, treat it as unsaid. When asking, do not put your conclusion in the question — ask “what does the law say in this situation,” not “have I already won.” Sudden face droop, one-sided weakness, crushing chest pain: do not ask AI first; call 120. See Section 13, Item 3 (face droop, one arm weak) and Section 13, Item 7 (crushing chest pain). No money for a lawyer: Section 7, Item 3 (apply for legal aid). Benefit set to small because only intermediate markers like “disease recognized or not” exist, with no death-reduction numbers. Beneficiaries are you and family.

## 32. Don't skip saving because “people can die any time, spending early is happier”; about nine in ten people aged 30 live to 60

**Cost**. No money. What to do when the thought “anyway I might be gone any day” appears is first recall your chance of living to 60. The hard part is everyone around saying that, and the thing you want to buy sitting in front of you.

**In plain terms**. By WHO figures for China, about 92% of people aged 30 live to 60, and over half live to 80. Young people commonly overestimate how likely they are to die early; living by that feeling, they save about a quarter less than they should. From the numbers above, most people need to save for living into old age.

**Benefit**. First how long people live. WHO's Global Health Observatory computed a 2023 life table for China. A life table uses that year's death rates by age to project how long a group lives. By that table, probability of a 30-year-old living to 60 is 92.0% (men 89.2%, women 94.9%). To 65: 87.4% (men 83.0%, women 92.0%). To 80: 55.6% (men 45.8%, women 66.1%). These three sets are ratios of numbers still alive at each age in the table. People who reach 65 have on average another 17.5 years. Next how people estimate. A 2019 Journal of Finance study surveyed people on how long they expect to live. Young people underestimate survival; older people overestimate. An earlier working-paper example: a 28-year-old man's true 5-year survival was 99.4%; he estimated 92.8%. The authors put self-estimated probabilities into a standard life-cycle saving-and-spending model. Versus using actual death rates, young people save 26% less and retirees draw down savings 27% more slowly. People whose life-and-death estimates in the survey were more skewed also saved more

skewed, after subtracting risk preference, cognition, and household conditions. The authors think one reason is overweighting rare, memorable ways of dying.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Reasons for grade B. The life table is a WHO model estimate, not a National Bureau of Statistics release. “Save 26% less” is from the model, not from following real people. Estimating lifespan is only one study; there is no citeable Chinese counterpart. “Most people need to save for living into old age” is the author's inference from chances of reaching 60 and 80, not a study conclusion. Benefit magnitude set to medium, following Item 23 in this section (don't expect shopping to improve mood). Under-saving may reach the 10000-yuan level, but there is no number for what it buys back, so it is not recorded as large. The same study also found older people overestimate how long they will live and draw savings too slowly, so this item is mainly for young and middle-aged people. This does not oppose spending on things and experiences you like; what to stop is the single reason “anyway I'll die.” When accident or serious illness hits, what helps is an emergency fund and insurance — Section 5, Item 27 (emergency fund) and Section 5, Item 39 (insure losses you cannot carry). If someone lives on your income: Section 5, Item 40 (term life). Ordering when mood is low: Item 23 in this section. The beneficiary is you.

## 33. Don't have arthroscopic clean-out or meniscus trimming for slowly worsening middle-aged and older knee pain (osteoarthritis, degenerative meniscus tear); lose weight and train thigh muscle first

**Cost**. No surgery fee, and you also save 2 to 6 weeks of recovery. What to do is train thigh and hip muscle long term, several times a week; best have rehab or a physiotherapist teach a set first. People who are overweight also need to eat less, move more, and bring weight down. The hard part is that training and weight loss work slowly, while surgery sounds like a one-shot fix.

**In plain terms**. For middle-aged and older people with degenerative knee pain, arthroscopic clean-out or cutting a piece of meniscus is no better than sham surgery. Sham surgery only cuts a few skin holes; afterward pain and walking match real surgery. Any benefit lasts a few months at most and may invite leg clots. Sticking with leg training eases knee pain; overweight people who also lose weight hurt even less.

**Benefit**. First osteoarthritis. A 2002 trial split 180 people with knee osteoarthritis into three groups: arthroscopic clean-out, arthroscopic lavage, and sham surgery. Sham only cut a few skin holes; the scope was not inserted. Patients and assessors did not know who got which. At every follow-up over two years, neither real surgery beat sham on pain or function. Knee-pain score is 0 to 100; higher hurts more. At one year: sham 48.9, lavage 54.8, clean-out 51.7. A 2008 trial enrolled 178 people with moderate-to-severe knee osteoarthritis. One group had arthroscopic clean-out plus physiotherapy and drugs. The other only physiotherapy and drugs. Symptom total is 0 to 2400; higher is worse. At two years the groups were 874 versus 897, difference 23 (95% CI −208 to 161, credible range) — no difference. Next meniscus. A 2013 Finnish trial enrolled 146 people aged 35 to 65 with symptoms of a degenerative medial meniscus tear and no osteoarthritis. One group had partial meniscectomy; one had sham surgery. At 12 months three main scores did not differ. For example post-exercise knee pain (0 to 10): groups improved 3.1 and 3.3. A 2015 meta-analysis pooled 9 trials. People who had surgery had 3 to 5 points less pain at 3 to 6 months (0 to 100). By 1 to 2 years there was no difference, and function did not improve. Next harms. Symptomatic deep-vein thrombosis in the leg: about 4.13 per 1000 operations (1.78–9.60). Also pulmonary embolism, infection, and death. A 2017 BMJ international expert panel therefore strongly opposed arthroscopy for almost all people with degenerative knees. The panel states recovery takes 2 to 6 weeks after surgery. Finally what to do. A 2016 Norwegian trial enrolled 140 middle-aged people with degenerative meniscus tears. One group did 12 weeks of supervised exercise; one had partial meniscectomy. At two years knee scores differed by only 0.9 (−4.3 to 6.1) — no difference. At 3 months the exercise group had stronger thigh muscle. The 2015 Cochrane systematic review pooled 44 trials and 3537 people. Exercise cut knee pain by the equivalent of 12 points (0 to 100, credible range 10 to 15), evidence quality high. Two to six months after stopping, still 6 points less. A 2013 U.S. trial enrolled 454 people aged 55 and above, overweight or obese, with knee osteoarthritis. Diet plus exercise lost a mean 10.6 kg (11.4% of body weight). At 18 months their pain score (0 to 20) was 3.6 versus 4.7 for exercise

alone. It looks worthwhile because “cleaning out worn and torn bits” sounds on-target, and many people do feel better after surgery.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy. China's 2018 osteoarthritis diagnosis-and-treatment guideline differs. It says arthroscopic clean-out works better for knee osteoarthritis with “mechanical symptoms,” such as loose bone fragments in the joint or a meniscus tear that has shifted. It also says long-term results match conservative care, and benefit may be limited when joint space is clearly narrowed. The 2021 guideline's original site needs manual verification and was not checked word for word, so it is not cited. The BMJ panel's view is that catching and clicking mechanical symptoms are also inside the opposition; only a truly locked knee that will not straighten may be an exception. The panel's opposition also excludes two groups: a knee that swells fast after major trauma (usually bleeding in the joint), and sports injuries in young people. Those need an orthopaedic visit. Arthroscopy is not knee replacement; the panel says replacement is for severe disease when conservative care fails. What painkillers to take when it hurts: Section 34, Item 3 (ask a doctor before ibuprofen-class painkillers). Don't count on glucosamine for relief — Item 5 in this section (glucosamine, chondroitin). What to train: Section 2, Item 16 (strength training); weight loss: Section 2, Item 32 (if overweight, lose weight). Benefit set to medium by judgment: no official published figure for what such surgery costs in China. Main gain is saving surgery money and postoperative weeks, plus avoiding uncommon harms such as clots. Beneficiaries are you and older family members.

## 34. Don't count on melatonin to cure long-term insomnia; on average it only helps people fall asleep about 7 minutes sooner — start with cognitive behavioural therapy for insomnia

**Cost**. No money, and you also save long-term melatonin purchases. The hard part is that it is easy to buy over the counter; one tablet is far less trouble than weeks of hospital treatment.

**In plain terms**. People who sleep poorly and take melatonin fall asleep about 7 minutes sooner on average than on placebo, and sleep about 8 minutes more. The American Academy of Sleep Medicine does not recommend it for chronic insomnia. In China it is sold as a health food; the label says “this product cannot replace drugs.” Crossing 5 or more time zones by air for jet lag, it can ease jet-lag symptoms.

**Benefit**. First how large the effect is. A 2013 meta-analysis pooled 19 trials and 1683 people. Each trial was randomized versus placebo. Sleep problems were not caused by another disease; 14 of the trials studied insomnia. Melatonin shortened time to sleep onset by a mean 7.06 minutes (95% CI 4.37–9.75, credible range). Total sleep time rose 8.25 minutes (1.74–14.75). Sleep-quality improvement was also small (SMD 0.22, 0.12–0.32). The authors themselves note this shortens onset less than other sleep drugs. Next guidelines. The American Academy of Sleep Medicine's 2017 chronic-insomnia medication guideline advises clinicians not to use melatonin for hard-to-fall-asleep or restless sleep; recommendation strength “weak.” Basis: 3 trials, all using 2 mg sustained-release melatonin, all subjects aged 55 and above. Evidence quality “very low.” The only poolable outcome was sleep quality (SMD 0.21, −0.36 to 0.77), short of clinical meaning. Domestic melatonin health foods list the function as “helps improve sleep.” Precautions say “this product cannot replace drugs”; unsuitable groups are children and adolescents, pregnant women, and nursing mothers. A 2026 Beijing market-regulation science piece also says it is “by no means a ‘wonder drug'.” Jet lag is separate. A Cochrane systematic review included 10 trials; 9 of them shared one finding. After flying across 5 or more time zones, melatonin at local bedtime eases jet lag. Daily 0.5 to 5 mg works about the same. It looks worthwhile because it is a hormone the body already makes, sounds mild, and needs no prescription.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversy: the meta-analysis authors think melatonin's side effects are relatively small and the effect does not weaken with longer use, so it may still have a place in insomnia care. The Beijing market-regulation piece says it suits easing onset difficulty in middle-aged and older people from low melatonin secretion. But those 3 American Academy of Sleep Medicine trials were exactly in people 55 and above, and the conclusion is still not enough effect. There is some benefit; it is just too small to call a cure. For long-term

insomnia start with cognitive behavioural therapy — Section 3, Item 26 (CBT for insomnia). Snoring, pauses in breathing in sleep, heavy daytime sleepiness: check for sleep apnea first — Section 3, Item 27 (sleep study for apnea). The label also says people who drive or operate machinery should not take it before or during work. Melatonin for children is not counted in this item; domestic labels say children and adolescents are unsuitable. Benefit set to small by judgment: no official figure for a year's melatonin spend. The beneficiary is you.

## 35. Don't demand an IV drip for a cold or ordinary fever, and don't go for seasonal drips to “flush” or “clear” blood vessels

**Cost**. No money, and you also save the drip fee and hours sitting in a clinic. The hard part is that many people think a bottle clears them faster, and some older people have made seasonal drips a habit — when a doctor will not prescribe, it feels like they were not taken seriously.

**In plain terms**. Ordinary colds and viral sore throat are listed by Guangdong health authorities as conditions that in principle do not need an IV. At a National Health Commission briefing an expert clarified that seasonal drips do not wash plaque out of vessels and may add load on heart and kidneys. Of drug adverse reactions reported nationwide, over half involve injection routes, and nine in ten of those are intravenous.

**Benefit**. No study specifically compared IV versus no IV for a cold, so this item rests on official documents and monitoring data. First colds. Guangdong's health and family-planning commission issued a 2017 document requiring primary facilities to cut unnecessary IVs. It states drugs should follow WHO's principle: “oral if possible; intramuscular if injection is needed rather than intravenous.” Only three situations use an IV: swallowing difficulty; severe absorption problems such as vomiting or severe diarrhoea; and critical, fast-moving illness that needs high drug levels in the body quickly. An attached list of common outpatient and emergency conditions that in principle need no IV starts in internal medicine with “upper respiratory infection: ordinary cold, viral pharyngitis.” Next “flushing vessels.” The National Health Commission held a briefing on 6 August 2025. A chief physician from Dongfang Hospital, Beijing University of Chinese Medicine, clarified the rumour. The quote: “The claim that seasonal IV drips can clear vessels and prevent cerebral infarction is wrong.” Drips cannot “wash away” or “clear” atherosclerotic plaque. Blind drips may add load on heart or kidneys and even trigger heart failure. Finally risk. The National Adverse Drug Reaction Monitoring Annual Report (2024) breaks reports down by route. Of reported reactions, injection routes were 57.2% and oral 33.1%. Among injections, intravenous was 91.0%. That is the share of reports, not the chance of harm per drip. It looks worthwhile because the bottle is visible, you lie there until it finishes, and it feels as if the drug arrives faster and fuller.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Grade C because there are only official documents and expert clarification, not a trial counting how many fewer events skipping IV produces. When an IV is truly needed — severe dehydration, vomiting so drugs cannot be taken, critical illness — follow the doctor. Asking a doctor for antibiotics for a cold is also useless — Section 34, Item 7 (no antibiotics for a cold). For diarrhoea start with oral rehydration salts — Section 34, Item 8 (ORS). What actually prevents stroke is controlling blood pressure and lipids and taking long-term medicine as prescribed — Section 1, Item 7 (measure blood pressure) and Section 2, Item 12 (check lipids regularly). Lists of conditions that do not need IV are set by each province; Guangdong's is from 2017; whether it was updated later was not checked. Benefit set to small by judgment: what you save is one drip's fee and a few hours; adverse reactions cannot be turned into a per-drip probability. Beneficiaries are you and older family members.

# 7. How to get by when you have no money

This section is about money and social safeguards. How much you can receive, what fees you can avoid, what services you can get, and what conditions you must meet are all written here — not converted into years of life. Policies change every year and differ by place, so amounts and thresholds follow what your locality publishes for the current year.

Items in this section are grouped by topic below, with item numbers in parentheses.

**Losing a job**: Apply online for unemployment insurance benefits (item 1); get recognized as someone facing employment difficulties (item 12); claim vocational training subsidies (item 13).

**Unpaid wages**: File a complaint with labor inspection first (item 2); apply for legal aid (item 3); when wages are owed, first figure out who hired you (item 22).

**Emergency relief**: Go to a shelter (item 4); apply for temporary assistance (item 6); apply for dibao (item 7); the two disability subsidies (item 8); replace a lost ID card at once (item 11); when you truly have nowhere to sleep (item 21); when you already cannot repay credit cards or online loans (item 23).

**Medical and social insurance**: Do not let resident medical insurance lapse (item 9); for serious illness, use medical insurance and medical assistance first (item 10); do not panic if social insurance contributions are interrupted (item 18); add a medical or critical-illness policy (item 20).

**Finding work and starting over**: Public employment services and gig markets (item 5); use a systematic approach when job hunting (item 14); pay no deposit and surrender no ID (item 15); even after prison or bankruptcy there is a path to start over (item 19).

**Housing and food**: Queue for public rental housing (item 16); cut housing and food to the minimum (item 17).

## 1. After losing a job, apply online for unemployment insurance benefits first

**Cost**. No money spent. You can submit the application on a phone through any of three portals: the "Zhangshang 12333" (掌上 12333) App, the electronic social security card mini-program in WeChat or Alipay, or the National Social Insurance Public Service Platform. A social security card or ID card is enough; in most regions you need not go in person. The prerequisite is completing unemployment registration first.

**In plain terms**. If your employer and you have paid for a full 1 year, and you did not resign on your own, then after unemployment registration and if you are willing to look for work, you can receive money. With under 5 years of contributions after that full 1 year, you can receive for at most 12 months; with a full 5 years but under 10 years, at most 18 months; with 10 years or more, at most 24 months. While you receive benefits, employee medical insurance is paid for you by unemployment insurance.

**Benefit**. All three conditions must be met. First, your employer and you must have paid unemployment insurance for a cumulative full 1 year. Second, you did not resign on your own (the legal term is “employment interrupted not due to the person's own will”). Third, you have completed unemployment registration and are willing to seek work. How long you can receive depends on contribution years. Cumulative full 1 year but under 5 years: at most 12 months. Full 5 years but under 10 years: at most 18 months. 10 years or more: at most 24 months. The monthly amount is set by the provincial government and differs by province. It is below the local minimum wage and above urban dibao. The national goal is to raise it gradually to 90% of the minimum wage. While receiving unemployment benefits, you still participate in employee basic medical insurance and enjoy its benefits. The basic medical insurance premiums due are paid from the unemployment insurance fund; you pay nothing personally (nationwide; the regulations have been in force since 1999)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Resigning on your own does not count as “not due to the person's own will,” so you cannot receive benefits. When leaving a job, do not sign “voluntary resignation for personal reasons” — see Section 19, item 7. Unemployment benefits are counted from the day you complete unemployment registration; register late and you get money late. The first thing after leaving is to register. Registration needs the termination certificate issued by the employer — see Section 19, item 17 (termination certificate). Whether to keep a non-compete and what to do if the company pays no compensation — see Section 11, item 12 (signed a non-compete). While you receive benefits, employee medical insurance is paid for you by unemployment insurance. Amounts differ a lot by province; follow what the place where you are insured publishes. The “90% of minimum wage” wording comes from a 2017 guidance opinion of the Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security and the Ministry of Finance (人社部发〔2017〕71 号); the original text says “gradually raise the unemployment insurance benefit standard to 90% of the minimum wage standard.” That is a goal, not the amount paid today. The original page on the ministry site could not be opened locally; this sentence was checked against a citation in a Liaoning provincial human resources and social security department document.

## 2. When wages are owed, complain to labor inspection first, then apply for labor arbitration; both routes are free, and most cases have a result within a few months

**Cost**. No money spent; complaints and arbitration both charge nothing. Gather the labor contract, pay stubs, attendance records, transfer records, and chat logs, and visit the human resources and social security bureau or the arbitration commission 1 to 3 times. Arbitration has a 1-year deadline (the legal term is the arbitration limitation period). If you are still working at the unit and wages are being delayed, that 1-year limit does not apply. If you have already left, you must file within 1 year from the day you left. The hard part is the repeated trips and hunting for evidence piece by piece; it is easy to lose heart in the middle.

**In plain terms**. First call 12333 or complain to labor inspection at the human resources and social security bureau; after a case is filed, the investigation finishes within 60 working days. If confirmed, the company can be ordered to pay by a deadline; if it still does not pay, it must add another 50% to 100% as compensation. If that fails, apply for labor arbitration; the case is closed within 45 days. But “case closed” is not “money in hand”: if the company has no assets or the boss has fled, you may win and still get nothing.

**Benefit**. The first step is to complain. Call 12333, or complain to labor inspection at the local human resources and social security bureau. By law the investigation finishes within 60 working days after filing; complex cases may be extended by another 30 working days. If confirmed, the company can be ordered to pay by a deadline. If it still does not pay after the deadline, it must add compensation of 50% to 100% of the amount due. In 2024, inspection agencies nationwide handled 137000 cases and recovered 8650000000 yuan in wages for 654000 people. If you have an IOU or a clear wage sheet, you may also apply directly to a grassroots court for a payment order. A payment order is a court order telling the company to pay; the court issues it within 15 days of accepting the case. The second step is to apply for arbitration. By law the case is closed within 45 days of acceptance, extendable by another 15 days. For unpaid wages you may apply for advance enforcement: part of the award can be enforced before the whole case is finished. If the amount owed does not exceed 12 times the local monthly minimum wage, it is final in one arbitration: after the award the company cannot sue again. In 2024, 4257000 cases were handled nationwide and 4156000 were closed. The closed amount was 93470000000 yuan. The mediation success rate was 79.6%, the arbitration closure rate 98.2%, and the arbitration termination rate 73.7%. Some people say this takes “half a year to a year”; that refers to cases that go on to court after arbitration. Those cases take 6 months at first instance (3 months under the summary procedure), plus 3 months for a second instance. In 2024 courts closed 88000 cases seeking labor remuneration and recovered 28540000000 yuan; 998 people were sentenced for the crime of refusing to pay labor remuneration (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Complaints and arbitration help, but distinguish “case closed” from “money received.” The 98.2% closure rate only means the procedure finished. If the company has no assets or the boss has fled, you may

still get nothing after winning. The Supreme People's Court only publishes the total amount enforced (2300000000000 yuan in 2024) and that the “enforcement completion rate stayed high”; there is no official figure for how much of wage cases actually reached the workers' pockets. The term “arbitration termination rate” is not defined in the bulletin; this item treats it as “no further court case after the award.” Unpaid wages at certain amounts are enough for a criminal case. One type is owing one person for more than 3 months, with an amount of 5000 to 20000 yuan or more. Another is owing 10 or more people, totaling 30000 to 100000 yuan or more. In either case, if payment is still refused after an order to pay, that is enough to open a case. Provincial high courts and procuratorates set the exact amount within that range and publish it; check your province before complaining, and raise it face to face when you complain. Migrant workers on construction sites also have dedicated wage accounts and a rule that the general contractor pays first; going after the general contractor works better than going after the labor boss. Both routes assume there is an employing unit. An unlicensed workshop or shop still counts; you can complain and arbitrate. Private work for a household or individual, such as being a nanny, is not a labor relationship — go to court; see item 22 (first figure out who hired you). Rural migrant workers applying for legal aid to recover wages are not checked for financial hardship. The original text of the Labor Contract Law (劳动合同法) and the Civil Procedure Law (民事诉讼法) is cited from republications by the State Taxation Administration and the Guizhou provincial market regulation bureau (both gov.cn), because the NPC site pages would not open. The Criminal Law Amendment (VIII) (刑法修正案（八）) failed to fetch from the NPC site and was checked by opening it with curl

## 3. Legal aid is available at no cost for cases such as wage disputes, alimony claims, and workplace injury compensation

**Cost**. No cost at all. Legal aid services are provided free of charge to all applicants.

**In plain terms**. Anyone seeking unpaid wages, alimony, social insurance benefits, dibao payments, or compensation after acting in defense of others can apply for free legal assistance. Simply call 12348 or visit your local legal aid center. You no longer need to obtain proof of financial hardship from your hometown — just describe your situation honestly. For defendants facing the death penalty, or those who are blind, deaf, mute, or minors, a lawyer is assigned regardless of their financial status.

**Benefit**. According to national regulations, legal aid covers six main categories of civil cases: claims for state compensation; requests for social insurance or dibao benefits; applications for pensions or relief funds; demands for alimony, child support, or spousal maintenance; wage recovery claims; and civil claims arising from acts of bravery. In criminal cases, defendants facing capital punishment or those who are blind, deaf, mute, or minors are guaranteed legal representation irrespective of their financial circumstances.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The Legal Aid Law took effect on 1 January 2022, introducing one key change: applicants no longer need to submit official proof of financial hardship. A straightforward statement of one's financial situation now suffices. Legal aid can be accessed via local legal aid centers, public legal service hubs, or by calling 12348.

## 4. Turning to a shelter when you have nowhere else to go – they provide food, lodging, and even a ticket home

**Cost**. There is no cost. You can go to your local civil affairs bureau or shelter on your own, or ask police or civil affairs officials to take you there. Upon arrival, you must truthfully provide your name and list any personal belongings. The hard part is simply admitting that you have no money and nowhere to stay.

**In plain terms**. Shelters cover meals and lodging, send you to a hospital if you fall ill, help you contact family, and issue a ticket home if you cannot afford one. Stays generally do not exceed 10 days. Coming and leaving are voluntary — this is not detention, and no cash is handed out. Tickets are issued for the hukou place or the place of residence, so decide where you want to go before you arrive.

**Benefit**. Shelters supply food and lodging that meet basic hygiene standards. Should you suffer a medical emergency while there, they arrange prompt hospital treatment. They also assist in reaching out to relatives or employers. For those unable to pay for travel back to their registered home or current residence, a free transport voucher – essentially a train or bus ticket – is provided. “Household registration” refers to your hometown, while “current residence” is wherever you currently live. Generally, stays are capped at 10 days; extensions are granted if family members are on the way, medical care is needed, or other arrangements must be made. Police and other government officials encountering homeless individuals in the course of their duties must inform them of this assistance option. Special care is given to disabled persons, minors, the elderly, and anyone with mobility issues – they are guided and escorted to shelters (nationwide, since 2003).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Entry and departure are entirely voluntary; this is not a detention facility. Basic food and lodging are provided, but no cash is given. Transport vouchers are issued based on household registration or current residence – be sure to decide where you wish to go before seeking help. For shelter arrangements at night or during winter, see Section 21 (when there truly is nowhere else to sleep).

## 5. Use free public employment services and gig platforms instead of paid agencies

**Cost**. No cost at all. You can register at any public employment service agency at the county level or higher — such as employment service centers or human resources markets. Local gig platforms also allow free registration. If you don't know the exact location, call 12333 for help.

**In plain terms**. Public agencies like employment service centers and human resources markets provide job referrals, career guidance, policy advice, and both employment and unemployment registration — all completely free of charge. In fact, the law explicitly forbids them from charging for these services. Registration and posting job listings on gig platforms is likewise free. It's a good idea to complete your unemployment registration at the same time, since it's required to receive unemployment benefits and qualify for assistance as someone facing employment difficulties.

**Benefit**. The law guarantees that the following services must be provided at no cost: advice on employment policies; information about current job openings and labor shortages; career guidance and job matching; processing of both employment and unemployment registration; and targeted employment support for individuals facing employment difficulties. These agencies are prohibited from engaging in any commercial activities or profiting off these services. Gig platform job postings and registrations are also offered to the public free of charge, as part of the broader public employment information system. Special support is further extended to long-term unemployed workers and low-income gig workers facing financial hardship (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Unemployment registration is a prerequisite for receiving unemployment benefits and qualifying as someone facing employment difficulties — so it's worth completing at the same time. For gig workers paid on a daily basis, always verify your earnings on the spot, and be sure to collect the employer's contact details and a record of the work performed.

## 6. After a sudden setback, apply for temporary assistance first

**Cost**. No money spent. Apply to the township government or subdistrict office where the incident happened, and explain what happened at home — for example a fire, a traffic accident, a family member's sudden major illness, or a sudden rise in daily expenses that cannot be skipped. Sudden urgent hardship uses “small-amount fast aid”: no means test, no public notice, generally finished within 3 days. Sudden rises in medical or schooling costs are approved after public notice. Prepare materials from the local checklist; usually 1 to 2 trips.

**In plain terms**. When something sudden hits at home — a fire, a car crash, a family member's sudden serious illness — and basic living is temporarily crushed, you can apply for temporary assistance at the

township government or subdistrict office where it happened; you need not already be on dibao. This kind of urgent hardship is generally finished within 3 days, for at most 1 month of the local dibao standard. Other situations pay at most 6 months of the dibao standard.

**Benefit**. Two kinds of households can receive temporary assistance. One is households that, because of accidents, a family member's sudden major illness, or similar reasons, temporarily cannot cover the most basic costs such as food, lodging, and medical care. The other is dibao households whose unavoidable expenses suddenly rise beyond what they can bear. Which events are covered and how much is paid are set and published by local governments at county level or above (national system; amounts set locally; since 2014). The Social Assistance Law (社会救助法), in force from July (7) 1, 2026, describes the targets as "persons whose basic living is temporarily in serious difficulty because of sudden, urgent, catastrophic, or similar hardship," with cash or in-kind aid. Apply for temporary assistance at the township government or subdistrict office of the "place where the urgent hardship occurred." When the situation is urgent and the amount is small, aid should be given first and paperwork completed afterward. A late-2025 document of the Ministry of Civil Affairs and the Ministry of Finance sets how to pay. Sudden setbacks, accidental injury, major illness, and similar urgent hardship use "small-amount fast aid": household finances are not checked again, there is no public notice, processing generally takes no more than 3 days, and the top tier is no more than 1 month of the local dibao standard. Dibao-edge households and rigid-expenditure hardship households that fall into difficulty because medical or schooling costs suddenly rise are aided after public notice, in principle with "one approval, phased payment." Temporary assistance outside small-amount fast aid has a top tier of no more than 6 times the local monthly dibao standard (nationwide, from 2026; concrete standards set locally)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. You need not already be a dibao household. Concrete amounts differ a lot by place; follow what the locality publishes for the year. After the Social Assistance Law (社会救助法) took effect, the Interim Measures for Social Assistance (社会救助暂行办法) were not expressly repealed; as of October (10) 2026 the national laws and regulations database still marks them as in force. Where the two texts disagree, follow the law.

## 7. If income is below the local dibao line, apply for dibao; if income is a bit above the line or medical and schooling costs are high, apply for medical, education, housing, and employment assistance

**Cost**. No money spent. Household members who live together submit a written application to the township government or subdistrict office of the hukou place. If that is hard to do yourself, you may ask the villagers' committee or residents' committee to apply on your behalf. You must accept checks of household income and assets. Usually 2 to 3 trips, with ID cards, hukou booklets, and proof of income and assets. The hard part is laying household finances open for inspection and waiting through public notice. If you do not qualify for dibao, applying for medical, housing, or employment assistance is also done at the hukou township government or subdistrict office. Education assistance is applied for at the school the child attends.

**In plain terms**. If household per-person income is below the local dibao line and assets also meet the rules, you can apply. At the end of 2024, the national urban dibao line averaged 798.1 yuan per person per month, and the rural line 593.9 yuan. Money is paid as the gap, or in fixed tiers. If income is a bit above the dibao line, or medical and schooling costs are too high, you may still apply for medical, schooling, and housing assistance even without dibao.

**Benefit**. Divide household income by the number of people; if that is below the local dibao standard and household assets are within the rules, you can receive dibao. At the end of 2024, the national average urban dibao standard was 798.1 yuan per person per month, and the rural standard 593.9 yuan per person per month. Urban dibao covered 6250000 people, rural 33615000. Dibao money is paid monthly as the gap: local dibao standard minus household per-person income. For example, if the local standard is 798.1 yuan and household income is 500 yuan per person per month, each person receives 298.1 yuan per month, not 798.1

yuan. The Social Assistance Law (社会救助法) in force from July (7) 2026 also allows fixed-tier payments: dibao "may be paid as the actual gap by which household per-person income falls below the local minimum living standard, or in fixed tiers." The dibao standard is set by taking local per-person consumption expenditure for the prior year, multiplying by a quantified ratio, and adjusting at intervals — in plain terms, last year's average spending per person, discounted (national averages; localities differ). There are two further tiers for those who do not qualify for dibao. The first is dibao-edge households: assets meet the rules, and household per-person income is below 1.5 times the local dibao standard (2023 national document). From July (7) 2026 the Social Assistance Law (社会救助法) leaves the uplift ratio above the dibao standard to the province. The second is rigid-expenditure hardship households. The condition is that household per-person income is below local prior-year per-person disposable income, and assets meet the rules. Unavoidable costs such as medical care and schooling must also exceed a local share of household income. Both tiers can receive medical assistance, education assistance, and housing assistance. Education assistance means fee reductions, grants and living subsidies, and student loans. Housing assistance in cities means priority public rental housing or rental subsidies. Unemployed people with work capacity in dibao-edge and rigid-expenditure hardship households can also receive employment assistance. Severely disabled persons and patients with serious illness in dibao-edge households may be brought into dibao individually and receive monthly dibao payments (nationwide, from 2023; ratios and recognition methods set locally)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Dibao is the last safety net; apply back at the hukou place. If household housing, cars, or deposits exceed local standards, or children are able to support you, approval may fail. Once approved there are other benefits: help paying resident medical insurance (resident medical insurance, item 9), medical assistance when seeking care (medical assistance, item 10), and legal aid without a means test (legal aid, item 3).

## 8. With a disability certificate, apply for the two disability subsidies

**Cost**. No money spent. Bring the disability certificate and submit one application at the subdistrict or township.

**In plain terms**. Disabled persons in dibao households can receive a living subsidy. Those rated disability level 1 or 2 who also need long-term care can receive a care subsidy; both can be received at the same time. Standards are set by each province and differ a lot — ask the subdistrict for the local figure. Bring a second-generation disability certificate and apply once at the subdistrict or township.

**Benefit**. The State Council set two subsidies. The first is the living subsidy for disabled persons in difficulty; the document's targets are "disabled persons in dibao households; places with the means may gradually expand to low-income disabled persons and other disabled persons in difficulty." That means dibao households' disabled members first, with expansion where local finances allow. The second is the care subsidy for severely disabled persons; the document's targets are "severely disabled persons rated disability level 1 or 2 who need long-term care." Both can be received at the same time

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Standards are set by provincial governments and differ a lot by place. Applications require a second-generation disability certificate. If you cannot apply yourself, a family member may apply on your behalf

## 9. Do not let the annual 400 yuan resident medical insurance lapse; hardship households can get reductions

**Cost**. The individual share is no less than 400 yuan per person per year. That is the national standard for 2024 and 2025; localities may set it higher. Pay during the fixed annual concentrated enrollment window. Extremely poor persons receive full funding — the government pays the whole amount. Dibao recipients receive a fixed subsidy — the government pays a set part.

**In plain terms**. Individuals pay from 400 yuan a year; in 2025 finance adds no less than 700 yuan per person. Extremely poor persons get full funding; dibao recipients get a fixed subsidy. Lapsing has a cost: if you did not enroll in the concentrated window, or did not keep continuous payments, after you pay there are 3

months when medical care is not reimbursed, and each extra year interrupted adds another 1 month in principle.

**Benefit**. Besides the individual share, finance adds a further amount per person. In 2024 it was no less than 670 yuan. In 2025 it rose 30 yuan from the prior year to no less than 700 yuan; the individual contribution remains no less than 400 yuan (医保发〔2025〕22 号, as restated in provincial documents). The 2026 Government Work Report said it would rise another 24 yuan. For dibao recipients and extremely poor persons, qualifying medical costs still left after medical insurance reimbursement can be reimbursed again through medical assistance at a rate of no less than 70%. The cost of a lapse is a waiting period. If you did not enroll in the concentrated window, or did not keep continuous payments, after you pay there is a fixed 3-month benefit waiting period when medical care is not reimbursed. Each extra year interrupted adds another 1 month in principle (from 2025, nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The 2025 National Healthcare Security Administration notice (医保发〔2025〕22 号) is not posted publicly on the administration site or the Chinese government site. The figures 700 yuan and 400 yuan match documents from Hebei and Anhui; the Anhui document states it follows that notice. While you receive unemployment benefits, employee medical insurance is paid for you by unemployment insurance, so you need not enroll twice.

## 10. For serious illness, use medical insurance, critical-illness insurance, medical assistance, and cross-region registration first — do not touch online loans

**Cost**. No money spent. The order is fixed; go step by step. First, before cross-province hospitalization, register through the “National Cross-Region Medical Care Filing” mini-program in the “National Healthcare Security Administration” WeChat official account. Second, settle directly at discharge. Third, if what you still owe after reimbursement is too heavy, apply for medical assistance at the township government or subdistrict office. Fourth, if still employed, take sick leave for the medical treatment period — the time you stop work for illness and cannot be dismissed; work injuries go through work-injury insurance. Fifth, if you cannot repay a credit card, proactively negotiate installment plans with the bank. Sixth, if that is still not enough, raise funds on a personal assistance platform designated by the Ministry of Civil Affairs. Main materials are the diagnosis certificate, itemized costs, and settlement sheet; 2 to 4 trips. The hard part is running procedures while you are ill.

**In plain terms**. The order is fixed: before cross-province hospitalization, register in the “National Healthcare Security Administration” official account; settle directly at discharge without advancing the full bill first. If after reimbursement you still cannot pay, apply for medical assistance at the township or subdistrict. If employed, you have a medical treatment period of 3 to 24 months by length of service; the company cannot dismiss you during that time. Do not touch online loans or high-interest private borrowing.

**Benefit**. The state bundles basic medical insurance, critical-illness insurance, and medical assistance as the “triple system,” each layer catching what the one above leaves. For dibao recipients and extremely poor persons, qualifying medical costs are assisted at no less than 70%. Patients with serious illness who were not poor but became poor from treatment may apply for further assistance. If you registered before cross-province hospitalization, you can settle directly at discharge without advancing the full bill and returning to the insured place to claim. Stopping work for illness has a medical treatment period of 3 to 24 months, set by length of service. During that time the company may not end the labor contract, and sick-leave pay may not be below 80% of the local minimum wage. Injured workers have a work-stoppage with pay period — time off to recover — with original wages and benefits paid monthly by the employer, generally no more than 12 months. If credit-card debt exceeds repayment capacity but you are still willing to repay, you may negotiate a personalized installment plan with the bank for up to 5 years. Once the agreement is signed, the bank must stop collection. Personal assistance platforms that raise money online for someone must be designated by the civil affairs department under the State Council. Platforms must verify that the appeal is true. Donated money may only be paid to the person seeking help, or to an account they provide (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. How large a share medical assistance reimburses, and the yearly cap, are set by the place where you are insured. The medical treatment period has six tiers, based on total years worked and years at this employer. Once the medical treatment period ends, the company may lawfully end the contract — know which tier you are in early. People receiving emergency rescue are also on the list that needs registration. The medical insurance bureau page does not say whether emergencies count as automatic registration or can be made up afterward; call the insured place. Do not touch online loans or high-interest private borrowing. Courts only protect up to 4 times the one-year LPR (see item 15 on not borrowing usury). Amounts above that line are unprotected, but the principal is still owed. Lying in a hospital bed, you have no energy for that kind of lawsuit. Acute severe injury or illness is different: call 120 even without money; hospitals may not refuse, shift, or delay treatment. Emergency fees for that stretch are paid by the disease emergency assistance fund — see Section 24, item 8 (emergency care must treat first). The original page of (劳部发〔1995〕309 号) would not open on the ministry site; content is from a provincial human resources and social security republication. How to negotiate credit-card installments with a bank when you cannot repay — see item 23 (already cannot repay credit cards or online loans).

## 11. Replace a lost ID card immediately; get a temporary one if you need it urgently

**Cost**. There is a fee for issuing the ID card. This is a legally mandated charge set by the state; the exact amount is posted locally. You must apply at the police station in your area of permanent residence — just one visit is required.

**In plain terms**. For standard replacements, the new ID card is issued within 60 days of submitting the application. If you need it right away, you can also request a temporary ID card on the spot; it is issued within 3 days and is valid for 3 months. Without an ID card, you cannot apply for jobs, rent accommodation, open bank accounts, or claim benefits — it is a prerequisite for all such procedures.

**Benefit**. Once you submit the application form for a resident ID card, authorities must issue the card within 60 days. During this period, if you urgently need identification, you may apply for a temporary resident ID card, which is issued within 3 days and remains valid for 3 months nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Without an ID card, it is impossible to secure employment, rent housing, open bank accounts, or receive benefits — it is a mandatory prerequisite for all such actions. The ID Card Law was amended in 2011; the text cited here is the version published in 2003, and current provisions apply. Whether applications can be submitted outside your home region depends on local police regulations.

## 12. After registering as unemployed, seek recognition as a person facing employment difficulties to receive social insurance subsidies or access to public welfare jobs

**Cost**. There is no cost involved. You simply apply for recognition at a local public employment service center in your neighborhood or community. Eligibility criteria vary by region, but typically include being of advanced age, unemployed for a long time, a member of a dibao-receiving household, disabled, or part of a zero-employment household. First, you must complete unemployment registration before applying. The main difficulty lies in verifying whether you meet each individual criterion, and you must pay social insurance premiums upfront.

**In plain terms**. Once recognized, paying social insurance yourself qualifies for a subsidy, in principle no more than two-thirds of what you actually pay, for at most 3 years. If a unit hires you or you are placed in a public-welfare post, that unit's share of social insurance is also subsidized. Subsidies for public-welfare posts refer to the local minimum wage; the pay is modest but includes social insurance, so they suit a transition. Social insurance subsidies are often paid after you contribute, so you must advance the money first.

**Benefit**. After receiving this recognition, individuals who are not employed and pay their own social insurance premiums — known as flexible workers — become eligible for subsidies. These subsidies generally cover up to two-thirds of actual payments, for a maximum duration of three years. Employers hiring such individuals or placing them in public welfare jobs also receive subsidies covering their contributions toward pension, medical, and unemployment insurance. Public welfare jobs are positions created and funded by the government, with priority given to people facing employment difficulties. Additionally, one-time job-seeking subsidies are available for recent college graduates from dibao-receiving households, zero-employment households, or extremely poor families; disabled graduates and those who have taken national student loans also qualify. These subsidies are disbursed during the academic year following graduation (national framework; specific eligibility criteria and amounts are determined locally).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Public welfare jobs offer modest wages but include valuable social insurance benefits, making them ideal for a transition period. Most social insurance subsidies are paid after the fact, requiring upfront payment of premiums. For detailed eligibility requirements, contact 12333 or your local neighborhood office.

## 13. Apply for vocational training subsidies, employment internship subsidies, and social insurance subsidies during unemployment — don't pay for training courses out of pocket

**Cost**. There is no direct cost. However, training takes up a lot of your time. The real challenge is completing all required classes and earning the necessary certificates before you can receive any subsidies.

**In plain terms**. Complete training and obtain the required certificate, and you get a vocational training subsidy — at most 3 times per person. College graduates who have not found work within two years of graduation, and unemployed youth aged 16 to 24, may join employment internships and receive a basic living allowance during the internship. First check the “vocational training subsidy directory” on the local human resources and social security bureau site; do not pay for a course yourself.

**Benefit**. Regulations issued by the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security outline several employment assistance programs funded specifically to support job seekers. Eligible individuals can receive vocational training subsidies up to three times per person after completing approved training and earning the required certificates. Those facing employment difficulties who pay for their own social insurance (as self-employed workers) can get subsidies for up to three years; this period extends until retirement for anyone within five years of reaching the statutory retirement age. Recent college graduates can receive similar social insurance subsidies for up to two years, while those hired by employers qualify for up to one year of support. Additionally, recent graduates without jobs and unemployed youth aged 16–24 can join employment internships and receive basic living allowances during that period.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Exact subsidy amounts and eligible programs vary by province; always check the “Vocational Training Subsidy Directory” on your local Human Resources and Social Security Bureau website. Extra one-time job-seeking and entrepreneurship subsidies are available for recent graduates from dibao families or zero-employment households, those with outstanding student loans, and individuals with disabilities.

## 14. Job hunting isn't just about sending resumes — use a systematic approach: learn skills, set goals, and ask for help

**Cost**. There's no monetary cost. You'll need to spend 1–2 hours each day for several weeks. Paid courses aren't necessary; free career guidance from public employment services works just as well. The real challenge is staying consistent day after day without anyone watching over you, and actually reaching out to ask for help.

**In plain terms**. People who have taken job-seeking coaching find work at 2.67 times the rate of those who have not. What works is these pieces: learn concrete job-seeking skills, explain yourself clearly, set clear goals, take the initiative, and ask others for help.

**Benefit**. A combined analysis of 47 peer-reviewed job-hunting coaching studies, all of which used experimental or quasi-experimental designs with control groups, shows that participants in coaching programs are 2.67 times more likely to find work than non-participants (OR 2.67, meaning a 2.67-fold increase in odds). The key components of effective coaching are: teaching job-hunting skills, improving self-presentation, boosting self-efficacy, encouraging proactive behavior, setting clear goals, and fostering social support through asking for help. Programs that combine skill training with motivation-building tactics deliver the best results.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Most of these studies were conducted in Europe and North America, and used structured group-based coaching programs. The findings here are extrapolations from those results, not data collected in China itself. Asking for social support means reaching out to acquaintances for introductions and referrals — so don't hesitate to ask for their help.

## 15. No deposits, no ID retention, no “training loans”, no pyramid schemes, no usury

**Cost**. Zero expense. If an employer or agency suggests “pay first, then get a job”, “pay for training before placement”, or “recruit others to earn money”, refuse immediately. Keep all chat logs and proof of any payments. The difficulty lies in the fact that when money is scarce, people may be tempted to take risks — saying “no” on the spot is not easy.

**In plain terms**. Employers cannot keep your ID or demand a deposit, nor can they charge you under any other pretext. If a job placement agency fails to find you a job, it must refund the placement fee. “Training loans” that require upfront fees, as well as pyramid schemes that pay out based on recruitment, are all officially recognized scams. Any interest on a loan exceeding four times the one-year LPR is not legally enforceable by courts, though the principal amount must still be repaid.

**Benefit**. Employers are prohibited from withholding IDs or demanding guarantees or deposits. Violations result in mandatory refunds and fines ranging from 500 to 2,000 RMB per worker. Job placement agencies likewise cannot retain IDs or collect deposits; if they fail to place you, they must return all fees. Schemes that demand training fees or loans under the guise of employment are flagged by multiple government agencies as “training loan” scams. Pyramid schemes, where earnings depend on recruiting others, are illegal; participants face fines up to 2,000 RMB. Interest on private loans exceeding four times the one-year LPR is not legally binding. This regulation replaced the previous tiered limits of 24% and 36% (nationwide, effective August 2020).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The four-times-LPR threshold represents the maximum legally protected interest rate; it does not mean the principal can be forgiven. This judicial interpretation was revised in December 2020, so current article numbers may differ from earlier versions. For guidance on converting installment and online loan fees into annualized rates, see Section 5, Article 7. Financial desperation makes individuals especially vulnerable to these schemes; instead, rely on legitimate resources such as unemployment benefits, labor dispute mediation, legal aid, shelters, or emergency assistance outlined earlier in this section.

## 16. Public rental housing for those with housing difficulties

**Cost**. There is no fee to apply. You must submit documents to the local housing authority and provide written consent for them to verify the information you provide. If any documents are missing, they will inform you of what needs to be added at once. The waiting period for housing assignment is known as the “waiting queue period,” which generally does not exceed 5 years.

**In plain terms**. To qualify, you must meet three criteria simultaneously: you must have no property in the area, or your living space must fall below the required standard; your income and assets must also be below the set limits; and migrant workers must have maintained stable employment in the area for a specified period. The exact waiting queue period is announced locally. While this option cannot provide immediate relief, signing up costs nothing, and earlier applicants are more likely to be placed in housing sooner.

**Benefit**. Meeting all three conditions qualifies you to apply. First, you must have no property locally, or your living area must be smaller than the required minimum. Second, your income and assets must stay below the prescribed limits. Third, migrant workers must have held steady employment in the area for the mandated duration. Specific eligibility criteria are determined and released by housing authorities in municipalities and counties. Those who register for the queue are referred to as “waiting queue candidates,” and housing authorities are required to assign them a unit within the waiting queue period. (National framework; local areas set individual thresholds and rental rates; implemented since 2012.)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. While this option cannot provide immediate relief, signing up costs nothing, and earlier applicants are more likely to be placed in housing sooner. Various other forms of subsidized housing exist locally, each with its own rules; please consult your local housing authority's website for details.

## 17. Keep food and housing costs as low as possible: opt for monthly shared housing instead of daily rentals, and cook at home or use senior meal services rather than ordering takeout

**Cost**. Finding a place to live takes 1–3 days. The security deposit is usually equal to one month's rent (a rough estimate by the author). Cooking at home requires 30–60 minutes each day. The real challenge is staying disciplined enough to cook daily rather than ordering takeout.

**In plain terms**. In 2025, food accounted for 29.3% and housing for 21.7% of average national per-capita spending — together they make up over half of all expenses. Therefore, cutting costs in these two areas yields the biggest savings. Based on the author's experience, daily rentals and hourly rooms end up costing far more per month than shared housing; cooking at home is also cheaper than ordering takeout. When job hunting, ask whether housing and meals are provided — such offers effectively eliminate both major expense categories.

**Benefit**. In 2025, the average national per-capita annual expenditure was 29,476 yuan. Of that amount, 8,631 yuan went toward food and alcohol, representing 29.3%. Housing costs totaled 6,397 yuan, or 21.7%. Together they constitute more than half of total spending, confirming that reducing these expenses delivers the greatest financial benefit. Senior meal services are now available to all older adults; they include senior cafeterias, dining tables, and meal assistance points, with additional subsidies for those in need. For context, as of 1 January 2026, the lowest first-tier monthly minimum wage across all provinces was 2,080 yuan in Qinghai, while the highest was 2,740 yuan in Shanghai (national figures for 2025–2026).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Monthly costs for daily rentals and hourly rooms are considerably higher than those of shared housing; this is based on practical experience rather than official statistics. Rules regarding access to senior meal points for non-seniors and their pricing vary by region. When seeking employment, be sure to ask whether housing and meals are included — such arrangements can completely eliminate these two major expense categories. The original Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security page could not be accessed; the figures cited here are taken from a republished page on the Sichuan Provincial Department of Human Resources and Social Security.

## 18. Do not panic if social insurance contributions are interrupted: pension is cumulative; medical insurance is made up by the rules

**Cost**. No money spent. Resident pension and resident medical insurance can be paid yearly on your own. If employee social insurance is interrupted, there is no need to pay someone to park you on a fake payroll just to avoid a gap.

**In plain terms**. Pension is counted by cumulative years, not continuous years; an interruption does not clear the count. At retirement age, a cumulative full 15 years is enough for monthly payments. For employee medical insurance, once the required years are met you need not pay after retirement; the years differ by place. What a lapse affects are two things: after resident medical insurance is restarted there is a stretch when care is not reimbursed, and local home purchase, hukou, and points schemes often require continuous contributions.

**Benefit**. Basic old-age insurance is counted by cumulative contribution years; interruptions in the middle do not clear the count. At statutory retirement age, a cumulative full 15 years is enough for monthly pension. If short, you may keep contributing until 15 years are met. When you take a job in another place (formally, across pooling areas), the pension relationship follows you and contribution years keep accumulating. Once employee medical insurance cumulative contributions reach the years set by the state, you need not pay after retirement. The cost of a resident medical insurance lapse is a waiting period: after you restart, there is a stretch when care is not reimbursed (resident medical insurance, item 9) (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The years after which employee medical insurance needs no further payment in retirement are written in law as “years prescribed by the state”; local figures differ, and men and women often differ too. Call 12393 or ask the local medical insurance bureau. Lapses mainly affect local eligibility that requires continuous months of payment — home purchase, hukou, points — each set locally; check locally. Paying someone to park you on a fake payroll and contribute on your behalf can lose the money and carry legal risk; it is not advised. How to transfer pension and medical relationships when changing cities, and not to withdraw coverage — see Section 19, item 19 (transfer pension and medical relationships to the new insured place). From 2030 the 15-year line rises by 6 months each year toward 20 years; how to count the cost of paying yourself is in Section 5, item 46 (paying employee old-age insurance yourself).

## 19. After prison, bankruptcy, or a dishonest-debtor list, the law still has a path to start over — finish the procedures first

**Cost**. No handling fee. After release from prison, report to the judicial office or subdistrict of the hukou or residence place and apply for resettlement and help (government placement and support). If you are on the list of dishonest persons subject to enforcement, repay what is owed, then apply to the enforcing court to have the name removed. Individuals insured in Shenzhen for a full 3 years may apply for personal bankruptcy. Each step needs materials and interviews, plus a 1-to-3-year observation period. The hard part is telling the past over and over, and lasting through the observation period.

**In plain terms**. People released after serving a sentence must not be discriminated against in employment, schooling, or social insurance; those in living difficulty are helped into placement by the government. If the crime was committed under age 18 and the sentence was 5 years or less, the record is sealed; you need not report it when joining the military or seeking work. The dishonest list lasts 2 years; once the money is repaid the court should remove the name within 3 working days. Adult criminal records are not sealed; you must report them truthfully when joining the military or seeking work.

**Benefit**. Persons released after serving a sentence enjoy equal rights with other citizens by law and must not be discriminated against in employment, schooling, or social security. Those in living difficulty are helped into placement and given lawful assistance by the government of the hukou or residence place (Prison Law (监狱法) revised in 2026, in force from November (11) 1, 2026). A 2010 central document requires stronger vocational training for them, inclusion in dibao when eligible, and transitional placement bases. If the crime was committed under age 18 and the sentence was 5 years or less, the criminal record is sealed; you need not

report it when joining the military or seeking work; if you apply for a certificate of no criminal record, it is issued within 3 working days. The dishonest list lasts 2 years. Once the money is repaid, or in situations such as settlement with the other side, the court should remove the name within 3 working days. The Shenzhen Special Economic Zone Personal Bankruptcy Regulations are currently the only personal bankruptcy rules; after bankruptcy is declared and a full 3-year observation period is completed, unpaid debts may be discharged. Enterprise legal persons that cannot pay due debts and owe more than they have (insolvency) may apply for reorganization, settlement, or bankruptcy liquidation. After the bankruptcy procedure ends, the enterprise goes through deregistration. But people who guaranteed for the enterprise and other joint debtors “continue to bear repayment liability by law” for what remains unpaid. If the boss personally signed a guarantee for the company, that person still must repay. Adult prior records are not sealed: Article 100 of the Criminal Law (刑法) says that a person who has lawfully received a criminal penalty must report it truthfully when joining the military or seeking employment and must not conceal it (nationwide; personal bankruptcy only in Shenzhen)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Adult criminal records are not sealed. Article 100 of the Criminal Law (刑法) requires truthful reporting of a criminal penalty when joining the military or seeking work. Civil servants, judges, lawyers, teachers, and similar posts, and political vetting, have separate statutory limits; the non-discrimination rule above does not change that. Before November (11) 1, 2026, the current Prison Law (监狱法) text corresponds to Articles 37 and 38; article numbers follow the text in force. (中办发〔2010〕5 号) was not found as an original page on the central government site; the citation is from a district government republication. During the personal bankruptcy observation period you may not fly first class, engage in high consumption, or buy housing. Eight classes of debt, including compensation for intentional harm to another's person, are not discharged. A discharge obtained by fraud may still be revoked.

## 20. Before facing a serious illness, consider adding a one-year medical or critical illness insurance plan on top of basic medical insurance — just make sure to look for the phrase “guaranteed renewal.”

**Cost**. For young people, a one-year expense-reimbursement medical plan costs only a few hundred yuan per year. This type of plan reimburses you based on actual medical expenses incurred. A critical illness policy, on the other hand, typically starts at several thousand yuan annually (these figures are rough estimates by the author; no official statistics are available). Purchasing such policies requires you to honestly disclose your health status — a process that takes about half an hour.

**In plain terms**. This kind of insurance covers the part you still pay after medical insurance reimbursement, plus losses from stopping work. Before buying, look for the words “guaranteed renewal”: without them, next year the product may be withdrawn or the price raised. Health status must be disclosed truthfully; concealment can lead to a denied claim. Pay basic medical insurance first, then consider this item.

**Benefit**. Regulatory authorities classify such products into two main categories. Medical insurance reimburses you for actual medical expenses incurred, while critical illness insurance pays a predetermined lump sum upon diagnosis of specified illnesses. Both types are designed to cover out-of-pocket costs and lost earnings after basic medical insurance has been applied. Plans with a term of one year or less and no guaranteed renewal clause fall under short-term health insurance. Those with terms exceeding one year or that do include guaranteed renewal provisions are classified as long-term health insurance. “Guaranteed renewal” means that at the end of the term, the insurer must renew the policy under the same terms and at the same premium rate. Insurers are prohibited from encouraging the same individual to purchase multiple expense-reimbursement medical plans with overlapping coverage. Even if you buy two such plans, you can only receive reimbursement for the same expense once. The definitions of critical illnesses are standardized across the industry, covering 28 severe conditions and three milder ones. Malignant tumors, acute myocardial infarction, and sequelae of stroke are among the core conditions covered nationwide since 2019–2020.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This product is rated B because regulatory authorities provide only definitions and rules, without any concrete figures indicating how much money one can save by purchasing it. “Million-dollar medical insurance” is a marketing term; legally, it is considered short-term health insurance. Plans lacking a “guaranteed renewal” clause may be withdrawn or have their premiums increased the following year — so always verify this phrase in the policy wording. You cannot claim reimbursement twice for the same expense under two separate medical plans; avoid buying multiple such policies. Individuals with pre-existing conditions who fail to disclose them honestly risk having their claims denied. There is a two-year window after policy issuance during which insurers cannot terminate the contract or refuse claims solely on the grounds of nondisclosure; after this period, such grounds become valid. If fraud is detected within those two years, claims will be denied and premiums forfeited. For guidance on which types of losses are worth insuring against, see Section 5, Item 39 (“Losses you cannot afford to bear”). First, make sure you're enrolled in basic resident medical insurance (see Item 9) before considering this option. The standardized definitions of critical illnesses were issued by industry associations under the guidance of the China Banking and Insurance Regulatory Commission, rather than by government decree.

## 21. When there's nowhere else to sleep, 24-hour venues can only serve as a temporary overnight refuge; shelters should be the first choice

**Cost**. Waiting areas at airports and train stations are usually free. Fast-food restaurants and internet cafés require some spending. Sleep is often restless, and there's a risk of theft. The real difficulty is staying awake all night.

**In plain terms**. Airports and train stations can provide a place to spend the night — they have restrooms and power outlets — but no official data confirms they're safe. Shelters employ staff around the clock; anyone arriving at night receives immediate assistance. In winter, some regions even open temporary cold-weather shelters. Those unwilling to enter a shelter still get food, warm clothing, and other necessities from patrol officers.

**Benefit**. 24-hour venues allow a person to survive the night with access to restrooms and charging points, though no official figures exist on their safety. Under Civil Affairs Bureau regulations, helplines must remain open 24/7, and shelters must provide round-the-clock care. Individuals without stable housing, victims of theft or robbery, or those suddenly left without income may qualify for emergency transitional support. In certain areas, community centers also serve as temporary shelters, especially in winter. Patrols increase during nighttime, cold spells, rain, snow, or ice; key locations include train stations, docks, underpasses, bridges, and construction sites (since 2013, Civil Affairs Bureaus nationwide run annual winter outreach programs).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Safety risks are real. Keep valuables close, avoid accepting drinks or food from strangers, and steer clear of isolated corners. Never sleep under bridges, along rivers, or at construction sites at night; extreme weather can be fatal. Details on meals, lodging, and travel vouchers at shelters are covered in Section 4 (“Turning to a shelter when all else fails”). Shelters only assist individuals unable to secure basic needs on their own and lacking supportive relatives or friends. Applicants must give honest information; those who refuse to cooperate receive no aid. The Civil Affairs Bureau directive referenced here dates to winter 2022; yearly updates apply locally. Some venues conduct midnight clear-outs — avoid confrontations with security personnel.

## 22. When wages are owed, first figure out who hired you: unlicensed workshops and labor bosses still go to labor inspection; only private work for a household or individual goes to court

**Cost**. No money spent. First clarify three things: whether the other side is running a shop, factory, or business; whether the work was subcontracted from a company or construction site; and whether you work

inside someone's home. Whether the other side has a license can be checked on the national enterprise credit information publicity system.

**In plain terms**. Unlicensed workshops and shops that owe wages can still be complained to labor inspection and taken to labor arbitration; the boss personally can also be pursued. If a labor boss who subcontracted site work owes money, the general contractor or construction entity pays. Only private work for a household or individual — such as being a nanny — is not a labor dispute and must be sued in court.

**Benefit**. Article 2 of the Labor Contract Law (劳动合同法) defines employing units as enterprises, individual economic organizations, private non-enterprise units, and similar organizations; a single natural person does not count. Supreme People's Court labor-dispute interpretations list several disputes that are not labor disputes. First, disputes between a household or individual and a domestic worker. Second, disputes between an individual craftsman and helpers or apprentices. Third, disputes between a rural contracting household and hired persons. Those go to court as ordinary civil disputes, with a 3-year limitation period. Unlicensed employing units are not in that exception. Article 93 of the Labor Contract Law (劳动合同法) covers units without lawful operating qualifications. For work already done, the unit or its investors must pay wages, economic compensation, and damages. Investors are the people who put money into the unit. Article 29 of that interpretation covers three kinds of units: those without a business license, those whose license was revoked, and those still operating after the license term ended. In a dispute with such a unit, name the unit or its investors as parties. Article 33 of the Labor Security Supervision Regulations (劳动保障监察条例) says that if there is no business license, or the license has been revoked, but people are still being hired to work, human resources and social security departments still carry out labor security supervision. When personal contracting illegally hires people and harms workers, the organization that contracted out the work and the contracting individual bear joint and several liability for damages (Labor Contract Law (劳动合同法) Article 94). Construction entities or construction general contractors sometimes contract or subcontract projects to individuals or units without lawful operating qualifications. When that causes unpaid migrant wages, the construction entity or construction general contractor pays (Regulations on Guaranteeing Payment of Migrant Workers' Wages (保障农民工工资支付条例) Article 36) (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Judge in this order. First see whether the work was passed down from a company or site; if so, go after the contracting company or general contractor. Dedicated wage accounts on sites and general-contractor first payment — see item 2 (when wages are owed, complain to labor inspection first). Next see whether the other side is in business: shops, factories, workshops — licensed or not — go through inspection and arbitration, and name the boss personally in arbitration. Only leftover private work for a household or individual goes to court. Court means you sue and prove yourself; ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months. Lawyer fees are not among the litigation costs the court orders the loser to bear; you pay your own lawyer, or apply for legal aid if you cannot afford it — see item 3 (legal aid). With an IOU you may first apply for a payment order — see item 2 (payment order). Small amounts may use small-claims procedure — see Section 8, item 22 (cheated in second-hand deals; small claims). The limitation period is 3 years — see Section 8, item 19 (rights have deadlines). No route guarantees money in hand; if the other side has no assets, you may win and still get nothing.

## 23. When you already cannot repay credit cards or online loans, call the bank or platform customer service yourself to apply for a personalized installment or deferral; do not borrow new to pay old, and do not pay intermediaries for “interest freeze,” “credit-report repair,” or “anti-collection”

**Cost**. No money spent. Call the official customer service number printed on the card back or published in the App, say clearly that you cannot repay but are willing to. Have proof of income, unemployment, or illness ready; often you must call several times. Once agreed, repay monthly under the new plan; you cannot open

new credit cards until it is paid off. The hard part is answering the bank's calls and explaining your hardship over and over.

**In plain terms**. If you cannot repay a credit card but are still willing to, you can negotiate a personalized installment with the bank for up to 5 years; once the agreement is signed the bank must stop collection. But the bank may refuse, and overdue records already on the credit report stay. Intermediaries who charge to “freeze interest” or “clean the credit report” have been specifically flagged by regulators — do not use them.

**Benefit**. For credit cards there are express rules. When debt exceeds your repayment capacity and you are still willing to repay, the bank “may” negotiate equally with you and sign a personalized installment repayment agreement. The agreement lasts at most 5 years. It must state how much is owed, how much each installment is, and whether annual fees and interest are charged during repayment. Once both sides sign, the bank and collection agencies it engages must stop collection. If you do not repay per the agreement, that limit does not apply. If the deal is only oral, the bank must keep a recording at least until the debt is paid off. Debt already under installment cannot be installmented again; personalized installment is the only exception (2022 regulatory notice). When the People's Bank of China repealed the old bank-card rules in 2025, it stated that credit cards continue under these rules. Online loans have no unified personalized-installment rule; whether deferral or installment is possible depends on the contract and the lender. When the lender is a consumer finance company, rules forbid collection by violence, threats, intimidation, or harassment. Banks and consumer finance companies may not collect from people unrelated to the debt. On paid intermediaries, five departments including the financial regulator issued a joint risk alert in 2026. It says claims such as “loans/credit cards need not be repaid,” “debt negotiation,” “debt swap,” and “credit-report whitewash” are false. Such “agency rights defense” charges high service fees; if you try to quit mid-way you may be sued for breach. They collect your bank cards, phone SIMs, home address, and children's schools. Providing false materials as they teach, maliciously fleeing debt, or pressing with complaints may, in serious cases, involve crime. The Beijing banking and insurance regulator in 2022 also named ads for “interest freeze,” “stop collection,” and “full interest waiver.” It said that listening to such people, delaying repayment, and not contacting the bank can leave overdue bad records on the credit report. The National Development and Reform Commission ran a 2022 special campaign on “credit-report repair.” The notice says these people blur credit-report objections and credit repair, and defraud under names such as “credit-report repair, whitewash, wipe the slate.” Bad information on a credit report is kept for 5 years from the day the bad act or event ends, then deleted. During the retention period you may add a statement to that record, and the credit-reporting institution must record it (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Personalized installment says the bank “may” negotiate, not that it must agree; the bank may refuse. If talks fail, the bank may sue you for repayment. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months; summary procedure is 3 months. Lawyer fees are yours to pay; they are not among litigation costs the court orders the loser to bear. If you still cannot pay after a judgment, enforcement follows — see Section 8, item 20 (sued and under enforcement). Being listed as dishonest — see Section 8, item 21 (listed as dishonest). Simply being unable to repay is not a crime. A joint judicial interpretation says you cannot be treated as intending to keep the money just because you missed a payment. Fleeing after overdrawing, changing contact details to dodge collection, or transferring assets may be treated as malicious overdraft. Malicious overdraft is pursued as credit-card fraud; unpaid principal of 50000 yuan or more counts as a relatively large amount. So take the bank's calls, and tell the bank when you change number or address. Borrowing new to pay old only rolls interest higher; before any loan, look at the annualized rate — see Section 5, item 7 (convert interest to an annualized rate). High-interest private borrowing — see item 15 (do not borrow usury). If collectors call family or colleagues, or insult or threaten you, complain to the lender first. If the bank does not resolve it, call the free 12378 bank and insurance consumer complaint hotline. Threats to personal safety go to 110. For errors on the credit report, free inquiry and objections — see Section 8, item 9 (free credit-report inquiry). If serious illness leaves you unable to repay, also see item 10 (serious illness: medical insurance and medical assistance first). “Agency surrender of insurance” is the same kind of scheme — see Section 5, item 43 (do not use agency surrender). The main beneficiary is you yourself.

# 8. Protect yourself: laws and personal safety

If you've ever worried about how legal rules might affect your freedom or finances, this section is for you. It covers three main topics: what responsibilities the law requires you to meet, how following those rules can save you money, and what rights you have if something goes wrong. All article numbers match the official texts exactly. The items are ordered by impact: those that cause the biggest losses if ignored and are easiest to prevent come first; steps that need advance planning follow; and finally, practical tips without official backing.

The topics are grouped as follows, with article numbers in parentheses:

**Fraud prevention**: Stop payments immediately if you notice fraud (Article 2); strict anti-fraud rules (Article 3); seeing someone's face on video does not count as verification (Article 4); never lend your bank or phone cards to others (Article 8); obtain free credit reports (Article 9); dealing with fraud in secondhand online sales (Article 22); always ask for a price quote before hiring a repair service (Article 27); never carry items for strangers (Article 29); helping someone with a facial recognition check can lead to illegal loan schemes (Article 45).

**Signing contracts, borrowing money, and debt**: Read every document fully before signing (Article 17); always write a clear loan agreement (Article 18); legal claims have strict time limits (Article 19); report all assets honestly if enforcement actions begin (Article 20); understand what being placed on a credit blacklist entails (Article 21); avoid becoming a nominal legal representative for a business (Article 28); know that debts incurred by family members through gambling remain your responsibility (Article 44).

**Conflicts and emotional distress**: Call police right away if a dispute arises (Article 10); self-defense is allowed when facing unavoidable harm (Article 11); do not seek revenge after a quarrel (Article 12); never harm people unrelated to the situation (Article 13); resist any urge to harm yourself or others (Article 14); remember that retaliatory actions rarely end well for anyone involved (Article 15); buying insurance for someone before acting only makes legal trouble worse (Article 38).

**Relationships and marriage**: Think carefully before making large gifts (Article 23); use bank transfers for betrothal gifts (Article 24); clearly define pre-marital assets (Article 25); verify each other's marital status before marriage (Article 26); seek police help immediately if domestic violence occurs (Article 43).

**Police involvement, accusations, and evidence**: Hire a lawyer right away if you receive a summons (Article 5); voluntarily explain your side of events if something happens (Article 6); contest false accusations made against you (Article 33); demand acquittal when evidence is insufficient (Article 34); apply for state compensation when justified (Article 35); always request a case receipt when reporting a crime (Article 39); never offer bribes to investigators (Article 40); record conversations that might later become contentious (Article 41); photograph the scene from a wide angle first (Article 42).

**Online speech and cyberbullying**: Avoid insults or spreading false information online (Article 16); activate protective measures immediately if targeted by cyberbullying (Article 37).

**Sexuality and coercion**: Refrain from any sexual activity if a partner is unconscious or unable to consent (Article 31); report any attempts to extort money using intimate images to police at once (Article 32); victims seeking compensation should never meet their alleged aggressors alone (Article 36).

**Driving, pet ownership, and theft prevention**: Never flee the scene of a traffic accident (Article 1); never drive after drinking alcohol (Article 7); always keep dogs on a leash (Article 30); install sturdy locks on all doors and windows (Article 46).

## 1. After a traffic accident, stop, help the injured, and call the police — don't flee

**Cost**. No cost at all. Stopping, turning on hazard lights, helping the injured, and calling the police will take at most one or two hours. In minor accidents where no one is hurt and both parties agree on what happened, you can first take photos, then note down the other driver's name, phone number, license plate, driver's

license number, insurance policy number, and the damaged parts of the vehicles. After both parties sign a statement, they may leave the scene and later negotiate a settlement.

**In plain terms**. If you flee the scene, you are automatically considered fully responsible for the accident. Your driver's license will be revoked, and you won't be allowed to retake the test for life. More practically, both collision damage coverage and third-party liability insurance will not pay any claims related to fleeing — you'd have to cover hundreds of thousands of dollars out of pocket. Staying on the scene to help and call the police only takes a couple of hours.

**Benefit**. The person who flees bears full responsibility for the accident. Only if you can prove the other driver also acted negligently might that responsibility be reduced. Fleeing also results in license revocation for life. If the incident meets the criteria for a traffic-related crime, fleeing can lead to a sentence of 3 to 7 years; if someone dies because of it, the sentence rises to more than 7 years. Insurance won't help either: both collision damage coverage and third-party liability policies exclude any claims arising from “hit-and-run,” “intentional tampering with or falsifying the scene,” or “destruction of evidence,” leaving you responsible for any compensation costs (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If anyone is injured, first provide aid and then call the police. If moving vehicles or people is necessary to help, mark their original positions first. Even if you feel no impact after a minor collision and drive away, that can still be classified as fleeing — when in doubt, call the police. The insurance information cited comes from standard industry clauses; the actual coverage you receive depends on the specific terms of your own policy.

## 2. If you realize you've been scammed, call 110 or 96110 right away to request a stop-payment — don't try to investigate on your own first

**Cost**. No cost at all. Just make one call, clearly stating the time of the transfer, the amount, and the scammer's account number. Keep screenshots of the transfer and any chat records.

**In plain terms**. The brief period right after money is sent is the only window of opportunity. During this time police can issue an emergency stop-payment order and quickly freeze the funds; banks are required to comply. Once the money has been moved through multiple accounts and scattered, it becomes almost impossible to recover. Therefore, call 110 or 96110 immediately — don't waste time investigating or asking questions on your own. Calls to 96110 come from police officers trying to warn you, so be sure to answer them.

**Benefit**. Law enforcement has the authority to instantly query, urgently stop-pay, and swiftly freeze any funds linked to a scam. Banks and payment services must cooperate. Once frozen, those funds are returned to victims according to established procedures. The sooner a stop-payment is ordered, the higher the chance of recovery; after the money has been dispersed, success rates drop dramatically. 96110 is the nationwide anti-fraud hotline; calls from this number are police warnings, so you must answer them. (Nationwide, effective December 2022)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Anyone claiming to be from police, prosecutors, or courts and asking you to transfer money to a “secure account” is running a scam. The law merely mandates the creation of a stop-payment and freezing mechanism so banks can hold the funds. How much can be recovered depends on whether the money is still in the account at the time you report it. Information about the “National Anti-Fraud Center” app and 96110 is taken from a Fujian Provincial Public Security Department page; the original page on the Ministry of Public Security's site cannot be accessed.

## 3. Remember the core anti-fraud rules: don't trust unsolicited calls, don't share personal information, don't click on suspicious links, and always verify any transfer requests. All seven of the most common scam types follow this same pattern

**Cost**. No cost at all. Just memorize the “three no's and one extra check” rule, read through the descriptions of the seven scam types below, and install the “National Anti-Fraud Center” app. Make sure to answer any calls from 96110. If someone asks you to transfer money, share your screen, download an unknown app, click a link, or share verification codes, hang up first and then call the official hotline to verify. The hard part is that scammers often pressure you to act immediately — you must resist that pressure and hang up first.

**In plain terms**. If someone asks you to transfer money, share your screen, download an unknown app, click a link, or share verification codes, hang up first and then call the official number to verify. The seven most common scam types are fake “task reward” schemes, fraudulent investment offers, fake loan scams, impersonation of customer service agents, impersonation of police or judicial officials, romance scams, and fake “task reward” schemes involving seduction. All of them aim to get you to send money first. Spotting them in advance is far cheaper than trying to recover lost funds later.

**Benefit**. By law, government agencies and relevant departments must inform the public about common tactics used in telecom and online fraud. Public security authorities, together with financial, telecom, and internet regulators, run a nationwide early warning and prevention system to reach out to people at risk of being scammed. 96110 is this unified national hotline for such warnings — you should always answer calls from it. According to a June 2026 report from the Ministry of Public Security, the top 10 most common scam types account for 85% of all telecom fraud cases. Fake “task reward” schemes are the most prevalent, making up 25% of all cases. Fraudulent investment offers cause the greatest financial losses, accounting for roughly 40% of total fraud-related losses. The Fujian Provincial Public Security Department has outlined specific identifying features for each type. For fake “task reward” schemes: “Anyone urging you to join a money-making scheme is likely trying to take your money; they won't refund your initial deposit unless you complete endless tasks.” For fraudulent investment offers: “Fake promoters post fake profit reports in online groups; they give small initial returns to encourage you to invest more, then demand ‘taxes' before allowing any withdrawals.” For fake loan scams: “Legitimate loans never require upfront deposits or proof of bank transactions; any such requests are a red flag.” For impersonation of customer service agents: “They claim you have an active membership that will incur automatic fees and harm your credit score, pressuring you to transfer money to cancel it.” For impersonation of police or judicial officials: “No legitimate police or judicial agency has any so-called ‘safe accounts'; any ‘law enforcement' contact via phone, QQ, WeChat, or online platforms is a scam.” For romance scams: “Never trust anyone you've only met via photos or video calls; they often invent urgent reasons to ask for money without ever agreeing to a video chat or in-person meeting.” For seduction-based “task reward” schemes: “They arrange a meeting first, then demand you complete ‘tasks' that require ever-larger payments.” Spotting these scams early is far cheaper than trying to reverse unauthorized transfers later. How much money you can recover depends on whether it remains in your account at the time of reporting; for details on how to request a transfer reversal, see section 2 (call 110 or 96110 to request a reversal). (Nationwide, effective December 2022)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Scammers posing as police, judicial officials, customer service agents, supervisors, or platform risk control staff all use the same basic tactic: they ask you to “cooperate with an investigation”, “cancel a membership”, “join a task reward scheme”, or “access insider investment opportunities”. Legitimate loans never require upfront deposits, and no police or judicial agency has any “safe accounts” — remembering these two facts alone can help you avoid most scams. This is graded B because the “three no's and one extra check” rule is only an official public awareness slogan; there are no hard statistics showing exactly how much it reduces scam victimization. The rule and the list of seven scam types are taken from provincial public security department websites. The top 10 scam types identified by the Ministry of Public Security in 2026 also include impersonation of e-commerce and logistics customer service agents, fake loan and credit report scams, fraudulent online gaming transactions, fake online dating schemes, impersonation of supervisors or

acquaintances, and fake flight cancellation/refund offers — all of them follow the same pattern of ultimately demanding a money transfer. If an acquaintance asks you in person to “help with a face scan” for a loan — no transfer, but you end up as the borrower — see item 45 (help with a face scan). Store-operation scams when doing business are in Section 12, item 24 (store operations and opening-store training).

## 4. Seeing a face on video or hearing a voice on the phone does not count as verification; if a transfer is involved, hang up first and call back using an old number saved in your contacts

**Cost**. No cost involved. It only requires making one extra call and waiting a few extra minutes. In general, avoid posting videos of your face or long voice recordings on public accounts. The hard part is that scammers often pressure you to act quickly — you must resist the urge to transfer money right away.

**In plain terms**. Seeing someone's face or hearing their voice is not reliable proof of identity. Whenever money transfer is mentioned, hang up immediately and call back using an old number stored in your contacts, or ask someone you both know. If the caller claims “poor signal” or “I'm in a meeting” and refuses a live video chat, treat it as a scam.

**Benefit**. The Cybersecurity Bureau of the Ministry of Public Security has outlined three key measures. First is motion verification: ask the other party to perform a smooth head-turn motion, or to completely cover their face with a palm and then remove it quickly. The original text notes that current AI technology still struggles to accurately simulate such complex facial occlusions and lighting changes, often resulting in choppy, blurry, or distorted images. Second is listening for audio cues: AI-generated voices sometimes lack natural breathing pauses or emotional variation, and may sound slightly mechanical or contain unusual background noise. Third and most important is cross-channel verification. As stated in the source material, “after hanging up, immediately call a number the person regularly uses and you recognize — do not call back the suspicious number — or ask a mutual acquaintance for confirmation.” The rule of thumb is: “Don't trust video or voice alone; verify through actions and multiple channels.” Legally, using face-swapping or voice-cloning technology for fraud is strictly prohibited. Platforms must clearly label any service offering face generation, replacement, voice synthesis, or voice imitation; no organization or individual may remove, alter, or hide such labels. However, since scammers rarely follow these rules, the absence of a label cannot be taken as proof that the caller is genuine. The Criminal Investigation Bureau reported one case where a 14-member gang produced over 50000 synthetic face videos and collected more than 500000 pieces of personal information; police also seized 60 cloud servers nationwide. This labeling requirement took effect on September 1, 2025.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Always use an old number saved in your contacts when calling back — never dial the number shown on the incoming call or any new number the scammer provides. If the caller cites “poor signal” or “a meeting” to avoid a live video or motion test, assume it is a scam. Motion verification is only a supplementary tool; since AI capabilities keep improving, the only truly reliable step remains cross-channel confirmation. If money has already been transferred, refer to section 2 of this chapter and call 110 immediately to request a stop on the payment. For information on protecting your own facial and voice data, see section 14. This item is rated B because official sources provide identification methods and case examples, but no statistics are given on how much these measures actually reduce fraud rates. The main Ministry of Public Security website (mps.gov.cn) remains inaccessible due to a 521 error; the quoted texts from the Cybersecurity Bureau and Criminal Investigation Bureau were taken from a republishing page run by the Fujian Provincial Public Security Department.

## 5. If accused or summoned, hire a lawyer first — don't settle privately or delete records

**Cost**. Legal fees start at several thousand yuan. Those with financial difficulties can apply to legal aid agencies for a free lawyer. When questioned, answer only questions relevant to the case; leave the rest to your lawyer. The hard part is staying calm on the spot and resisting the urge to explain everything yourself.

**In plain terms**. You can hire a lawyer right from the first time you're called in for questioning. If the lawyer requests a meeting, the detention center must arrange it within 48 hours, and those talks cannot be monitored. You're allowed to refuse answering any questions unrelated to the case.

**Benefit**. Starting from the first interrogation or from the moment you're placed under compulsory measures restricting your freedom, you have the right to appoint a lawyer. While the case remains under police investigation, only lawyers may represent you — no one else can serve as a defense counsel. Upon a lawyer's request, the detention center must arrange a meeting within 48 hours, and such meetings are not monitored. No one may be forced to confess guilt, and you may refuse answering questions unrelated to the case. A summons or compulsory appearance lasts at most 12 hours; for especially serious and complex cases, this limit extends to 24 hours. A summons merely notifies you to come for questioning, while compulsory appearance means you're physically taken there. Repeated summonses must not be used to detain someone indefinitely. Anyone fabricating facts to falsely accuse another and seeking criminal punishment for them faces up to three years in prison; if serious harm results, the sentence rises to three to ten years. If charges are dropped, prosecution is refused, or a court acquits you after detention or arrest, you may claim state compensation calculated daily based on the previous year's national average wage for workers.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Do not attempt to settle privately with the other party or contact their family members. Any “private settlement” may be interpreted as admitting guilt. Chat logs, call records, and travel histories serve as proof of your innocence; deleting them removes your own evidence. If a report or accusation later proves unfounded, this does not constitute false accusation or entrapment. This rule applies equally to all accused individuals regardless of gender. For further details, see Section 33 (punishing those who fabricate facts), Section 34 (acquittal when evidence is insufficient and subsequent appeals), and Section 35 (daily state compensation after unlawful detention).

## 6. Coming forward voluntarily after an incident: Self-surrender can cut a sentence by up to 40%, for minor offences the cut can be bigger or the penalty waived entirely, and the “statute of limitations” defense simply does not exist

**Cost**. There is no cost at all. You can walk into a police station, stay on the scene and call the authorities, then tell them exactly what happened. The hard part is resisting the urge to “wait and see — maybe no one will notice.”

**In plain terms**. Voluntarily surrendering can reduce a prison term by up to 40%; for less serious offenses it may even lead to no punishment at all. If you confess only after being caught, the reduction is capped at 20%. Running away or denying responsibility yields no benefit. Relying on the statute of limitations to get off scot-free is impossible: once a case is officially opened, the time you spend evading authorities does not count toward that limit. The relevant sentencing rules have been in effect since 2021.

**Benefit**. Article 67 of the Criminal Law states that anyone who voluntarily surrenders and truthfully confesses their crime receives a lighter or reduced sentence; those guilty of minor offenses may be exempted entirely. Even without surrender, a sincere confession can still earn a penalty cut; if it prevents especially grave consequences, the reduction can be even greater. Official sentencing guidelines set clear percentage ranges: voluntary surrender can lower the baseline sentence by up to 40% (or more for minor crimes), while a simple confession brings a reduction of up to 20%. Additional factors such as admitting to related, un-discovered crimes or averting serious harm can add another 10-50% cut. Plea agreements also grant up to

30% relief, and when combined with surrender, restitution, compensation and other mitigating circumstances the total reduction may exceed 60% (or even lead to full exemption for minor offenses). Conversely, the statute of limitations is divided into four tiers — 5, 10, 15 and 20 years — based on the maximum possible penalty (Article 87). However, Article 88 explicitly states that once an investigation or prosecution is underway, any attempt to evade it renders the time spent in hiding irrelevant; the clock never stops.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The primary beneficiary of this provision is the offender himself. Self-surrender is a mitigating factor, not a blanket pardon; the exact reduction is left to judicial discretion, and stricter limits apply to violent and drug-related crimes. Traffic-accident cases follow a separate rule: staying at the scene, rendering aid and reporting the incident counts as voluntary surrender, yet because these actions are legally required, the permissible reduction is limited. Even if a driver flees first and later turns himself in, he still qualifies as a surrenderer; the baseline sentence used for calculation is the higher statutory maximum, and the subsequent reduction follows the same percentages described above (see Section 1 for proper post-accident conduct: stop, help, call police). Consulting a lawyer does not conflict with a truthful confession; the attorney's role is to verify that the written statement accurately reflects the facts, not to help fabricate a story.

## 7. Don't touch the steering wheel after drinking — even for e-bikes or “just moving the car a bit”

**Cost**. Using a designated driver or taking a taxi costs only a few dozen yuan. Agree in advance who won't drink at any gathering. It can be hard to politely refuse when others keep offering drinks.

**In plain terms**. Driving after drinking results in a 6-month suspension of your license and a fine of 1000–2000 yuan. A second offense brings up to 10 days in jail and permanent license revocation. Drunk driving leads to immediate license cancellation; you can't reapply for 5 years and may face criminal charges for dangerous driving, leaving a criminal record that affects background checks and certain jobs. Auto insurance won't cover any claims: once you've been drinking, your policy becomes void. Even “just moving the car a bit” counts as driving.

**Benefit**. Temporary suspension of the license for 6 months and a fine ranging from 1000 to 2000 yuan for driving after drinking. Repeat offenders face up to 10 days in jail and permanent license revocation. Drunk driving results in immediate license cancellation; reapplication is prohibited for 5 years, and criminal liability for dangerous driving is pursued, leading to imprisonment and monetary penalties. For commercial drivers the penalties are harsher: 15 days in jail, a 5000-yuan fine, and a 5-year ban on driving commercially; drunk driving entails a 10-year ban, after which they can never drive commercially again. If drinking or being drunk leads to a major accident and a criminal conviction, driving privileges are revoked for life. Commercial auto insurance policies explicitly exclude any claims arising from driving under the influence of alcohol or drugs (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Drunk driving is a criminal offense that leaves a permanent record, affecting both background checks and eligibility for certain professions. The distinction between “drinking” and “being drunk” is defined by blood alcohol concentration levels set by national standards; this section does not verify those exact figures, so don't guess where you fall on that scale.

## 8. Never lend your bank cards, SIM cards, or payment accounts to anyone — “money laundering” is not a side hustle

**Cost**. Zero. Some people claim “just lend your card for a few transactions and you'll get a few hundred yuan” — just say no.

**In plain terms**. Renting, lending, or selling your bank cards, SIM cards, or payment accounts is illegal on its own. Penalties include confiscation of all illegal earnings plus a fine of 1 to 10 times that amount; if no earnings were made, the maximum fine is 200000 yuan. In serious cases, offenders face up to 15 days in

detention, a negative credit record, and restrictions on account functionality. If you knowingly assist criminals by receiving or transferring money using these accounts, you could be convicted of aiding information network criminal activities, punishable by up to 3 years in prison.

**Benefit**. Engaging in any activity that involves renting, lending, or selling phone cards, bank accounts, payment accounts, or internet accounts is illegal. Authorities confiscate all illegal earnings and impose a fine of 1 to 10 times that amount; if no earnings exist, the maximum fine is 200000 yuan. Serious violations lead to detention of up to 15 days, a negative credit record, account restrictions, and suspension of all non-counter banking services. Knowingly providing payment settlement assistance to criminals constitutes aiding information network criminal activities (known as “helping information network crimes”), punishable by up to 3 years in prison and a fine nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Claiming “I had no idea what the other person intended to do with my cards” won't protect you. Law enforcement determines intent based on external circumstances: receiving payment for lending cards or unusually large transaction volumes can be used as evidence of awareness. Even if you ultimately aren't convicted, accounts used to receive illicit funds get frozen and you face other penalties. Doing someone else's real-name verification by face scan or by reading verification codes carries the same penalties; see item 45 (help with a face scan).

## 9. Checking your credit report twice a year for free helps spot any loans or cards you didn't apply for

**Cost**. It costs nothing. You can complete the check online in just ten minutes.

**In plain terms**. Laws give you the right to check your own credit report twice a year at no charge, and you can finish the process online in ten minutes. Negative entries stay on the report for five years from the date they're resolved; after that they must be removed. If you dispute any information, the credit agency or data provider must respond to you in writing within 20 days. To check your report, use the official website of the People's Bank of China's Credit Information Center or your mobile banking app — avoid third-party “credit check” apps, as they collect your personal data.

**Benefit**. Regulatory rules state that “individuals have the right to obtain their own credit reports twice a year free of charge,” meaning you can check your report twice annually at no cost. Negative records are kept for five years after the underlying issue is resolved; any older entries must be deleted. When you raise a dispute, the credit agency or source of the data must reply in writing within 20 days.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Identity theft leading to unauthorized loans or credit cards often goes unnoticed until a person is denied a mortgage years later. The proper channels for checking your report are the People's Bank of China Credit Information Center website or mobile banking apps. Steer clear of third-party “credit check” apps, as they harvest your personal information. If an acquaintance asked you to help scan your face or act as a witness for a loan, check your report again especially then; see item 45 (help with a face scan).

## 10. If a fight breaks out, call the police first — the one who strikes first almost always loses

**Cost**. No cost at all. Simply move to a crowded area and call the police so the other person's actions are captured on camera. The hard part is resisting the urge to shout back or push them.

**In plain terms**. Anyone who assaults another person faces 5 to 10 days in jail and a fine of 500 to 1000 yuan. If they act in a group, target the elderly, pregnant women, children, or disabled individuals, or repeat the assault multiple times, the penalty rises to 10 to 15 days in jail and a fine of 1000 to 2000 yuan. Causing minor injuries to another person turns it into a criminal case, punishable by up to 3 years in prison; serious injuries bring a sentence of 3 to 10 years. When two people fight each other, it does not qualify as self-defense — the

person who strikes first almost always suffers the consequences. Moving to a crowded area and calling the police is far more effective than retaliating.

**Benefit**. Under the law, anyone who assaults another person or intentionally harms them faces 5 to 10 days in jail and a fine of 500 to 1000 yuan. Those who act in a group, target vulnerable groups, repeat the assault, or attack multiple people at once receive 10 to 15 days in jail and a fine of 1000 to 2000 yuan. Group fights are treated as hooliganism, carrying a maximum penalty of 15 days in jail and a 2000 yuan fine. Intentional bodily harm that meets criminal criteria results in up to 3 years in prison; serious injuries bring a sentence of 3 to 10 years. Legally, mutual fighting does not count as self-defense. However, if the other person strikes first and uses excessive force, or if you try to avoid the fight but they keep attacking, your retaliation is generally deemed lawful self-defense. Only when your response clearly exceeds what is necessary and causes major harm does it qualify as excessive self-defense, which still warrants a reduced or waived penalty (nationwide, effective January 1, 2026 under the Public Security Administration Punishment Law).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. After the 2025 revision of the Public Security Administration Punishment Law, all article numbers changed; assault now falls under Article 51 instead of the old Article 43, so any older references are outdated. The definition of “minor injuries” used to determine criminal liability is set by official appraisal standards, which this section does not verify. If the aggressor is already on the ground or has fled, the threat ends, and any further retaliation is no longer considered self-defense.

## 11. You may defend yourself against an unavoidable attack, but only strike the person who is actually attacking — stop when he stops

**Cost**. Legal fees start at several thousand yuan; those with financial difficulties may apply for legal aid. The main cost comes afterward: you'll often be initially charged with intentional injury, required to cooperate with investigations, and sometimes detained for up to ten days. The challenge is staying composed during this period.

**In plain terms**. To protect yourself or others from an ongoing attack, it is legally acceptable to intervene and injure the attacker. If someone is committing murder, robbery, rape, kidnapping, or any other violent crime, harming or even killing them is not considered excessive. However, you must only strike the person actively attacking — stop as soon as he ceases. Even if the court ultimately rules in your favor, the process is far from easy; many people are first charged and detained for several days. In total, 47 individuals have been recognized as acting in self-defense under these circumstances.

**Benefit**. Criminal law defines what constitutes legitimate self-defense. When national interests, public welfare, or your own or another person's life, property, and other rights are under unlawful attack, intervening to injure the aggressor qualifies as self-defense and carries no criminal liability. The law also states: “If self-defense clearly exceeds necessary limits and causes serious harm, criminal responsibility applies, though punishment may be mitigated or waived.” Additionally: “In cases of ongoing violent crimes such as murder, robbery, rape, kidnapping, or other acts seriously threatening personal safety, any defensive actions resulting in injury or death of the aggressor do not constitute excessive defense and incur no criminal liability.” Official guidelines further clarify these boundaries: both “clearly exceeding necessary limits” and “causing serious harm” must be present for it to be deemed excessive; causing only minor injuries does not count. Defense must be directed solely at the aggressor; using lethal force against minor offenses is not permitted. Real-world examples include the Yu Haiming case (2018), where initial charges were later dropped after a ruling of self-defense, and the Chen case, where a student's defensive actions were similarly recognized as lawful. A total of 45 cases have been officially documented as falling under this category.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The default course of action remains as described in item 10: retreat and call the police. Fighting back when two parties are already engaged does not qualify as defense, nor does pursuing an attacker after he has fled or fallen. This provision applies only when retreat is impossible; it does not encourage violence. Afterward, three steps are crucial: remain at the scene after calling police, preserve any surveillance footage

and witnesses, and consult a lawyer before any police questioning. If charges are eventually dropped or you are acquitted, you may seek state compensation for detention days, as outlined in item 35. Defending others is also legally permitted, though intervening in unrelated fights without preparation carries different risks, as discussed in item 13. This protection primarily benefits you and your family.

## 12. Who to hold accountable — unpaid wages, wrongful dismissal, financial losses — filing complaints, arbitration, or lawsuits instead of taking revenge

**Cost**. There are no fees for filing complaints or arbitration. However, you'll need to make one or two trips and wait several months. The real challenge is resisting the urge to take matters into your own hands during that time.

**In plain terms**. Pursuing legal channels may ultimately leave you without any compensation. On the other hand, resorting to revenge achieves the same result — no money recovered — while also risking your own life. Consider the case in Wuxi: Xu failed to obtain his diploma and was dissatisfied with his internship pay, so he attacked people with a knife, killing 8 and injuring 17. He was sentenced to death, which was carried out. Nationwide in 2024, 654,000 workers recovered 8.65 billion yuan through complaints and arbitration for unpaid wages.

**Benefit**. Official statistics back up legal remedies. In 2024, labor inspectors handled 137,000 cases, resulting in 8.65 billion yuan being returned to 654,000 workers. Additionally, 998 individuals were convicted under laws against wage theft. Instructions on filing labor complaints and arbitration are provided in Section 7, Item 2. The consequences of revenge are outlined in Article 232 of the Criminal Law: “Whoever intentionally kills another shall be sentenced to death, life imprisonment, or fixed-term imprisonment of not less than ten years; if the circumstances are relatively minor, they shall be sentenced to fixed-term imprisonment of not less than three years but not more than ten years.” An official example: Xu failed his exams and did not receive his diploma; he also resented his internship pay. On November 16, 2024, he returned to Wuxi Arts and Crafts Vocational College and attacked people with a knife, killing 8 and injuring 17. He was sentenced to death for intentional homicide, with political rights revoked for life; the sentence was carried out on January 20, 2025. His grievances concerned the school and pay, yet his victims were fellow students, and he received no compensation at all (nationwide data).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Interns still enrolled in school generally do not qualify as having an employment relationship with their host organizations. If they fail to receive internship pay, they must seek mediation from their school or file a lawsuit in court, as labor arbitration is not an option. The same applies to individuals who perform private work for families or individuals and are then denied payment — they must also turn to the courts; see Section 7, Item 22 (first determine who hired you). Detailed steps for filing labor complaints and arbitration are provided in Section 7, Item 2. The limits on debt collection are outlined in Section 9, Item 15 (no detaining or confining debtors). Even legal channels may fail to secure compensation, as case resolution does not guarantee payment receipt. Conversely, revenge achieves no financial recovery and risks your own life.

## 13. No matter how angry you are, never target innocent people: deliberately driving into a crowd or committing violence in public is classified as endangering public safety by dangerous means, carrying a minimum sentence of three years; if anyone dies, the sentence starts at ten years and goes up to death

**Cost**. There is no monetary cost involved. The real challenge is suppressing such impulses when you're enraged.

**In plain terms**. Intentionally driving into a crowd or attacking people in public constitutes endangering public safety by dangerous means. Even if no one is injured, the offender still faces at least three years in

prison. If fatalities occur, the sentence rises to ten years or more, life imprisonment, or death. In the Zhuhai case, Fan Weiqiu, dissatisfied with the divorce settlement, drove his car into a crowd exercising at a sports center, resulting in 35 deaths and 43 injuries; he was sentenced to death and executed.

**Benefit**. Article 114 of the Criminal Law states: “Whoever commits arson, breaches a dike, causes an explosion, releases toxic, radioactive, or infectious agents, or endangers public safety by any other dangerous means, without causing serious consequences, shall be sentenced to three to ten years in prison.” Thus, even when no injuries occur, the minimum penalty is three years. Article 115 adds that if serious injury, death, or major property damage results, the sentence becomes ten years or more, life imprisonment, or death. Official case example: Fan Weiqiu, disillusioned by his failed marriage and unhappy with the divorce terms, resolved to vent his anger by driving into a crowd. On the evening of November 11, 2024, he crashed his vehicle into exercisers at Zhuhai Sports Center, killing 35 and injuring 43. He was convicted under the aforementioned article and sentenced to death, with political rights revoked; the sentence was carried out on January 20, 2025 after Supreme Court approval. His grievance pertained solely to the divorce ruling; his victims were completely unrelated runners from across the country.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Expressing thoughts like “I don't want to live anyway” does not serve as a mitigating factor in sentencing. The Supreme People's Court's 2025 work report emphasizes “resolutely punishing with severity, speed, and strictness those who outrageously violate legal and moral boundaries.” Merely threatening to commit acts such as arson, explosions, or poisoning that endanger public safety and disrupt order can lead to detention from five to ten days and a fine of up to 1000 yuan under the Public Security Administration Punishment Law (effective January 1, 2026). Similarly, sending threatening letters or otherwise endangering another's safety is illegal, punishable by up to five days' detention or a similar fine. Anyone entertaining such ideas should refer to item 14, which treats notions like “finding a scapegoat” as a medical emergency requiring immediate intervention.

## 14. Thoughts such as “find a scapegoat” or “die together” must be treated as a medical emergency: leave the scene, hand over car keys and knives to someone else, and call 12356

**Cost**. There is no monetary cost. The difficulty lies in admitting that something is wrong at the moment and in handing over control of dangerous items to another person.

**In plain terms**. The window between the first appearance of such thoughts and any attempt to act on them is very short. Among 82 people who survived a suicide attempt, 47.6% reported that no more than 10 minutes passed from the first thought to taking action. Therefore, the goal is not to “figure things out” intellectually, but to create physical distance between oneself and potential lethal tools — steering wheel, knife, gas valve, rope — and simply endure those ten minutes. After that, call 12356.

**Benefit**. This brief window between thought and action is well documented. In interviews conducted within three days of admission, 47.6% of those 82 individuals stated that the interval from initial thought to execution was under 10 minutes. A systematic review spanning ten years shows growing evidence that restricting access to lethal means reduces suicide rates. For instance, after tighter controls on painkillers, suicide rates linked to them dropped by 43%. After installing protective barriers at popular suicide sites, rates fell by 86% (ranging from 79% to 91%). Creating that ten-minute buffer by removing lethal objects is precisely what this advice aims to achieve. 12356 is the national mental health helpline, operating at least 18 hours per day nationwide as of May 1, 2025.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because both pieces of evidence derive from suicide-research literature and have not been directly tested in contexts involving impulses to harm others. The Deisenhammer study involved only 82 participants at a single hospital. When feeling unwell, avoid driving or taking shifts where you bear responsibility for others' safety; hand over duties first. For those having thoughts of self-harm, see Section 1, Item 25 (call 12356 when suicidal). For coping strategies during low mood, see Section 3, Item 18.

## 15. Family members say “no one will be safe” or “I'll take the kids and leave” — don't dismiss this as anger: close relatives can take such a person to the hospital, and police must respond to any emergency call

**Cost**. Registration and consultation fees range from a few dozen to several hundred yuan. Accompanying the person to the hospital takes half a day to a full day. The real challenge is getting them to agree to go.

**In plain terms**. When family members say things like “no one will be safe” or “I'll take the kids and leave,” close relatives have the right to take that person to a hospital, where treatment cannot be refused. If there has already been violence or an imminent risk of harm, hospitalization does not require the person's consent. If it's unclear whether these statements are just angry outbursts or genuine threats, call 12356 for advice or dial 110 so police can intervene. Keeping this information secret does not help the person at all.

**Benefit**. Article 28, paragraph 2 of the Mental Health Law states: “When a suspected mental disorder patient exhibits behavior that harms themselves or others, or shows a clear risk of doing so, their close relatives, employer, or local police must act immediately to stop such behavior and arrange transport to a medical facility for diagnosis.” The same article also requires hospitals to accept and diagnose any such patients without refusal. Article 29 mandates that hospitals admit these individuals right away, assign a licensed psychiatrist for evaluation, and issue a diagnosis promptly. Article 30 says voluntary admission is the norm, except in cases where the diagnosis confirms a severe mental disorder accompanied by actual or imminent harm to others — in such cases, involuntary hospitalization is permitted. Making threats of violence is grounds for calling 110. Writing threatening letters or using other means to endanger someone's safety can result in detention for up to five days or a fine of up to 1000 yuan. Those who threaten to commit arson, explosions, or other acts endangering public safety face detention from five to ten days and a similar fine (effective January 1, 2026 under China's Public Security Administration Punishment Law).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This guidance applies to spouses, parents, and children living in the same household. The phrase “no one will be safe” clearly includes the speaker, and the law grants this right specifically to close relatives — outsiders cannot intervene without police involvement. This rule targets genuine danger signs, not angry remarks during arguments or attempts to force uncooperative family members into treatment. Conversely, Article 35 states that if further evaluation proves the person does not have a serious mental disorder, they must be released from the hospital. When in doubt, call 12356 or 110. If you cannot tell whether someone is thinking of suicide, you can simply ask: asking does not make them more likely to act (Section 1, Item 43: asking people close to you who seem off). The investigation into Germanwings Flight 9525 revealed that authorities and employers could not prevent the co-pilot from flying that day because “neither he nor anyone else — doctors, colleagues, or family — informed them of his condition.” All 150 people on board perished: two pilots, four flight attendants, and 144 passengers. Keeping such risks hidden is never helpful.

## 16. Don't curse, spread rumors, or share unverified content online; if you're a victim of online abuse, document evidence first then report it to police

**Cost**. No cost at all. Just take ten extra seconds to think before posting. When attacked, take screenshots, record video, save links and account IDs, file a complaint with the platform first, then report it to police. The hardest part is resisting the urge to fire back when being cursed at.

**In plain terms**. Publicly cursing, spreading rumors or defaming others can result in detention for up to 5 days or a fine of up to 1000 yuan; for more serious cases, detention ranges from 5 to 10 days. If the circumstances are especially grave, it constitutes the crimes of insult or defamation, punishable by up to 3 years in prison. Simply sharing such content also makes you liable. Conversely, if you're a victim of online abuse, you generally have to file a lawsuit in court yourself to pursue legal action for insult or defamation, so you must rely on yourself to take screenshots, record video and save links.

**Benefit**. Those who openly insult others or fabricate facts to defame them face detention for up to 5 days or a fine of up to 1000 yuan; for more serious cases, detention ranges from 5 to 10 days. The same penalties apply to people who repeatedly send insulting or threatening messages, harass or stalk others, or secretly photograph and distribute someone's private information. Anyone who deliberately spreads rumors and disrupts public order also faces detention from 5 to 10 days. In severe cases, such actions constitute the crimes of insult or defamation, punishable by up to 3 years in prison. For online defamation cases where victims struggle to gather evidence, they can request the court to ask police for assistance (this rule is effective as of 1 January 2026 under the Public Security Administration Punishment Law).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. In principle, the crimes of insult and defamation are “only prosecuted upon complaint”, meaning victims must file a lawsuit in court themselves. Police generally do not initiate investigations proactively, so evidence collection falls entirely on the victims. However, two important exceptions exist. First, cases that “seriously endanger public order and national interests” can be investigated by police directly (Article 246, Paragraph 2 of the Criminal Law). Second, if a victim has genuine difficulty gathering evidence for online defamation, the court may order police to assist with the investigation (the same article, Paragraph 3, added under the 9th Amendment to the Criminal Law). Sharing such content also makes you legally liable; knowingly spreading false information also counts as “fabricating facts”. For guidance on how to respond after being a victim of online abuse, see Section 37 of this chapter (“Document evidence first then take action after suffering online abuse”). The article numbers for insult and defamation have been updated from Article 42 under the old law to Article 50 under the new law.

## 17. Read the document thoroughly before signing; never sign on behalf of others or on blank paper

**Cost**. There is no cost involved. Simply spend a few extra minutes reading contracts, IOUs, guarantee letters, and employment documents from start to finish. Ask questions on the spot if anything is unclear, and take photos for your records. The real challenge is reading everything carefully while the other party is watching.

**In plain terms**. Once signed, a document becomes legally binding — fingerprints carry the same weight as signatures. Claims like “I didn't read it” or “I thought it was something else” rarely hold up in court. Therefore, take the time to read everything, clarify any doubts immediately, and document it all. Never sign for someone else or on blank paper, and always specify the purpose when copying ID cards. Digital signatures and facial recognition verification also count as valid signatures.

**Benefit**. Legally executed contracts are protected by law and bind both parties. Once signed, obligations must be fulfilled as agreed. Article 490 of the Civil Code states that contracts formed in writing become effective when parties “sign, affix seals, or press fingerprints.” Fingerprints are treated equally with signatures and seals, so a contract remains valid even with just a fingerprint. Attempts to deny responsibility by claiming lack of awareness won't succeed in court. Avoiding such signatures prevents you from inheriting debts or liabilities that aren't yours (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. “Never sign for others, never sign on blank paper, and always note the purpose on ID copies” are widely accepted practices, though no official documents explicitly mandate them. Their shared goal is to prevent your signature from being used in legally binding contracts you never intended to agree to. Digital signatures and facial recognition verification also qualify as valid signatures. If acquaintances ask you to assist with loan applications via facial recognition or signatures, refer to Section 45 (Assisting with facial verification).

## 18. Write a clear loan agreement when lending money; think carefully before acting as a guarantor

**Cost**. No cost at all. Simply write down the lender, borrower, amount, interest rate, term, and repayment method on a piece of paper, then have both parties sign it. Transfer the money via bank transfer to leave a clear record — never hand over cash.

**In plain terms**. The loan agreement must include all key details: who the lender and borrower are, the amount, interest rate, term, and repayment method, plus both signatures. Always use bank transfers instead of cash — this makes it much easier to pursue legal action if needed. Before agreeing to be a guarantor, check whether the contract mentions "joint and several liability." Under a standard guarantee, creditors must first sue the borrower and exhaust all collection efforts before they can demand repayment from you. But if you sign a joint and several liability guarantee, creditors can demand payment from you directly.

**Benefit**. Loan contracts must be in writing, with standard clauses covering the type of loan, currency, intended use, amount, interest rate, term, and repayment method. This clarity is essential for any future legal action. If a guarantee contract does not explicitly state the type of guarantee or leaves details ambiguous, it is treated as a standard guarantee. Under such terms, creditors must first pursue legal action against the borrower and attempt to enforce repayment before they can turn to you. However, if you agree to a joint and several liability guarantee, you lose this protection — creditors can demand payment from you immediately. (Nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Any interest charged above four times the LPR is not legally enforceable by courts; see Section 7 for details. It is common practice to include both parties' ID numbers and the phrase "loan agreement" on the document. The presence or absence of "joint and several liability" in the guarantee contract determines whether you are secondary to the borrower in repayment obligations or treated on equal footing with them — read the contract carefully before signing. In some cases, a party may be asked to act as a guarantor but ends up signing a loan contract instead; see Article 45 for such scenarios, where the individual is legally classified as the borrower rather than a guarantor.

## 19. Time limits for legal action: 3 years for civil lawsuits, 1 year for labor arbitration; once the deadline passes, a simple "statute of limitations exceeded" claim can block your case

**Cost**. Zero cost. Don't just hope for payment in silence — use WeChat, text messages, email, or certified mail to create a paper trail.

**In plain terms**. The statute of limitations for civil lawsuits is three years, counted from the day you become aware your rights were violated. Once that period ends, the court won't act on its own; however, if the debtor simply argues "the deadline has passed," you lose the right to recover what's owed. A single documented demand for payment can reset that three-year clock entirely. Labor disputes follow a different rule: the arbitration deadline is just one year.

**Benefit**. The Civil Code states that "the limitation period for filing a civil lawsuit is three years, calculated from the date the right-holder knows or should know that his rights were infringed and who the obligor is." This period may not exceed twenty years from the actual infringement. When it expires, the debtor may invoke a defense of non-performance. Courts do not monitor these deadlines automatically; however, once raised by the debtor they become binding. Four events can interrupt the clock, each resetting the three-year period: (1) you demand performance; (2) the debtor promises to perform; (3) you file a lawsuit or labor arbitration; (4) any other circumstance with comparable effect. For installment agreements, the countdown starts on the final due date. Certain claims are exempt from any limitation period: requests to stop infringement, remove obstacles, eliminate hazards; recovery of real property or registered movable assets; alimony, child support, and maintenance; plus other cases specified by law. Labor arbitration follows a one-year rule, also measured from the date the worker becomes aware of the violation; however, if a dispute

over unpaid wages arises while the employment relationship still exists, the worker may file at any time — otherwise the deadline is one year after the contract ends (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This is probably the cheapest tip in the entire book. A single traceable demand letter can restart the three-year window; without it, you risk forfeiting your right to win the case. Agreements such as “we won't invoke the statute of limitations” or negotiated extensions of the deadline carry no legal weight. Conversely, if the debtor promises payment after the deadline has passed, they can no longer rely on that defense. Once payment has been voluntarily made, it cannot be reclaimed. For promissory notes and guarantees, see item 18; matters involving enforcement are covered in item 20. Overtime pay and unused vacation compensation follow the labor-arbitration rules described in sections 19.1 and 19.2.

## 20. If you're being sued or have a court order against you, report all your assets truthfully and repay as much as you can — don't transfer your house or money to relatives, friends, or companies

**Cost**. There is no cost involved. Simply report your assets as required by the court: list everything you currently own and everything you acquired in the year prior to receiving the enforcement notice. Pay off whatever debts you can. If you can't pay in full, negotiate a settlement or installment plan with the creditor.

**In plain terms**. Putting your house in a company's name or transferring money to relatives or friends isn't some clever “workaround” — it falls squarely under the circumstances described in the law on refusal to execute court orders. Conviction for this offense carries a sentence of up to three years; in especially serious cases, the sentence is three to seven years. Relatives, friends, or companies that help hide or transfer assets are treated as accomplices, and those assets must be recovered. Failing to report assets or providing false information can result in fines of up to 100000 yuan and up to 15 days of detention. However, if you truly have no money, this crime does not apply.

**Benefit**. Asset transfers aren't merely “workarounds” — they themselves constitute criminal acts. The Standing Committee of the National People's Congress has issued an interpretation of Article 313 of the Criminal Law, explicitly stating that “hiding, transferring, deliberately destroying, or transferring assets for free or at an unreasonably low price, thereby preventing the execution of a judgment or order” qualifies as “having the ability to execute but refusing to do so under serious circumstances.” In other words, hiding money, transferring it away, deliberately destroying one's own property, giving it away for free, or selling it at a steep discount all render a court order meaningless. In 2024, the Supreme People's Court and the Supreme People's Procuratorate added ten more scenarios to this definition, including using fake settlements or transfers to dispose of assets, as well as buying someone else's property at an unreasonably high price to guarantee their debts. All these actions are deliberate attempts to strip oneself of assets available for debt repayment. The maximum sentence for this crime remains three years; in especially serious cases, it rises to three to seven years plus a fine. Such serious circumstances include using fake lawsuits, arbitration, or notarization to obstruct enforcement, gathering crowds to storm enforcement sites, attacking or detaining enforcement officers, or causing a creditor to commit suicide or self-harm due to non-payment. Even outsiders who aren't parties to the case may be deemed accomplices if they knowingly help hide or transfer assets. Illegally transferred assets must be recovered or returned. Transfers made after receiving a summons but before a judgment takes effect also count. On the civil side, creditors may petition the court to annul any transfers made for free or at unreasonably low prices. Failure to report assets or providing false information may result in fines up to 100000 yuan and detention of up to 15 days (as stipulated in the 2024 interpretation effective December of that year).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The commonly shared advice online — such as “put your house in a company's name to use as employee housing” or “transfer all your money to relatives” — isn't a loophole; it's precisely the kind of conduct singled out in judicial interpretations. Relatives, friends, or companies aiding such actions are treated as accomplices, and any assets involved must be recovered. Conversely, if you truly have no money, this

crime does not apply. To determine whether you “have the ability to repay but refuse to do so,” necessary living expenses for you and your dependents must first be deducted. If you repay part or all of the debt before prosecution and your circumstances are relatively minor, prosecution may be waived. Repaying the debt prior to a first-instance judgment may also lead to a lighter sentence or even exemption from punishment. For guidance on what to do after being placed on a blacklist or having spending restrictions imposed, see item 21; instructions on how to regain good standing after fulfilling obligations are provided in Section 7, item 19.

## 21. If you're subject to spending restrictions or listed on the dishonesty registry, first find out which rule applies and request removal if possible

**Cost**. No cost involved. You simply need to contact the enforcement court to determine which provision applies to you. Gather proof that you've paid all debts or fulfilled all court-ordered obligations, or prepare any required guarantee documents. Any spending deemed essential for daily life or business operations must be approved on a case-by-case basis. The main difficulty is that you'll need to make multiple trips to the court and submit repeated applications.

**In plain terms**. First, determine whether you're only subject to spending restrictions or also listed on the dishonesty registry — these are two separate situations. Only six specific circumstances allow inclusion on the dishonesty registry, and the listing period is two years. In seven other cases, including when all obligations have been fulfilled, the court must remove the listing within three working days. Spending restrictions apply to nine categories of non-essential purchases, including travel on G-series high-speed trains. Any spending essential for daily life or business operations can be approved individually upon application.

**Benefit**. There are exactly six circumstances under which a person can be added to the dishonesty registry. First, if they have the ability to fulfill obligations but refuse to do so. Second, if they obstruct or resist enforcement efforts through forged evidence, violence, or threats. Third, if they use false litigation, arbitration, or concealment of assets to evade enforcement. Fourth, if they violate property reporting requirements. Fifth, if they breach spending restriction orders. Sixth, if they refuse to honor enforcement settlement agreements without valid reason. If sufficient guarantees are provided or if seized assets are enough to cover debts, the court cannot add someone under the first category. Minors cannot be listed at all. The standard listing period is two years, though it can be extended by one to three years for serious cases of obstruction or multiple violations. In seven specific cases, including full fulfillment of obligations or termination of enforcement proceedings, the court must remove the listing within three working days; proactive compliance can also lead to earlier removal. Individuals under spending restrictions may not engage in nine categories of non-essential spending, including first-class train travel, luxury accommodations, real estate purchases, premium office leases, non-business-related vehicle purchases, vacations, private school tuition for children, high-cost insurance products, or any seating on G-series high-speed trains. Any necessary exceptions must be approved by the court after a formal application. Valid guarantees or consent from creditors can also lift these restrictions nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Spending restrictions are also known as limits on non-essential consumption. This regulation was introduced in 2010 and amended in 2015 via Judicial Interpretation No. 17, with its title changed to “Regulations on Restrictions on Certain Types of Consumption.” This description follows the current post-amendment text. Three key changes were made in 2015: first, all seating on G-series high-speed trains became subject to restrictions; second, the clause requiring spending to be paid from personal assets was removed; third, when a business entity faces restrictions, its actual controllers also become subject to them, though personal spending unrelated to business operations can be separately approved. Being listed on the dishonesty registry and being subject to spending restrictions are distinct statuses — it's possible to be subject to only one or neither. Neither status affects credit reports, and removal from these lists does not alter credit records; see Section 7, Article 19 for details on recovering from a dishonesty listing. Current regulations do

not specify whether spouses or children can be restricted from spending their own earnings, so consult the enforcement court if this situation arises.

## 22. If scammed while shopping online or via second-hand markets, first file a complaint with the platform, then report it to police, and finally decide whether to sue

**Cost**. Filing a complaint with the platform and reporting the case to police cost nothing. For lawsuits, if the amount in dispute is under 10000 yuan, the filing fee is 50 yuan; this fee is halved if the case goes through summary proceedings, mediation, or is withdrawn. Each of the stages — case filing, trial, and enforcement — takes at least half a day to a full day, though online filing can save you the hassle of traveling. You must keep records of orders, chat logs, transfer receipts, and shipping documents. The real challenge is staying committed despite all the back-and-forth.

**In plain terms**. Start by contacting the platform. Platforms maintain security deposits and strict penalty rules, so they act fastest. Next, call the police: if the loss exceeds 3000 yuan, it meets the threshold for a criminal fraud case; otherwise it falls under public-order penalties, which can result in a detention of 5 to 10 days. If you decide to sue, online-purchase disputes can be filed in the court nearest to the delivery address. For smaller amounts, a small-claims procedure applies, guaranteeing a verdict within two months and allowing online filing.

**Benefit**. When the amount defrauded ranges from 3000 to 10000 yuan, it qualifies as “a relatively large sum” under fraud statutes, leading to a sentence of up to three years plus a fine; exact limits vary by province. Below that threshold, offenders face public-order penalties: detention of 5–10 days or a fine of up to 2000 yuan; repeat offenders may receive 10–15 days of detention and a fine up to 3000 yuan. On the civil side, you may sue in the same court for contract disputes, again without needing to travel to the seller's hometown. Small-claims rules apply when the disputed amount is under 50 % of the local average annual wage; such cases are decided in a single hearing and become final immediately, with a maximum processing time of two months under summary proceedings. All these procedures are now available online, carrying the same legal weight as in-person filings (Civil Procedure Law, effective Jan 2024; Public Security Administration Punishment Law, effective Jan 2026).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. To gauge whether a lawsuit is worthwhile, multiply your net hourly wage by the total time you'll need to invest — accounting for filing, trial, and possible enforcement phases, each taking half a day to a full day — then add the court filing fee. Compare this total cost against the amount you hope to recover, and apply a further discount to estimate the likelihood of actually obtaining payment. This method offers a framework, not a definitive answer. Keep in mind that after the 2025 revision of the Public Security Administration Punishment Law, article numbers changed; fraud now falls under Article 58 instead of the former Article 49. Likewise, the small-claims provision is now Article 165 following the 2023 amendment to the Civil Procedure Law; be sure to consult updated sources. Finally, experience shows that filing a complaint with the platform first yields the quickest resolution, thanks to its security deposits and strict penalty mechanisms. The relevant legal provision is Judicial Interpretation No. 7 of 2011.

## 23. Think carefully before and after making large gifts in romantic relationships or marriage

**Cost**. No cost involved. Before sending a large sum of money, ask yourself: is it a loan or a gift? If it's a loan, draft a written agreement and mark the transfer as “loan”. The hard part is actually bringing this up in conversation.

**In plain terms**. Once the money is transferred, you generally cannot get it back. A gift can only be revoked before it is officially registered under the recipient's name. After that, revocation is only possible under three specific circumstances: the recipient seriously harms you or your close relatives; fails to fulfill their legal

obligation to support you; or breaches any agreed terms of the gift contract. Therefore, decide early whether the payment is a loan or a gift.

**Benefit**. Before property rights are transferred, a gift can be withdrawn. This legal threshold is known as the “transfer of property rights”. Once the transfer is complete, only the three aforementioned situations allow for revocation. Small gifts or cash given on special occasions such as birthdays or holidays, as well as everyday expenses meant to strengthen emotional bonds, do not qualify as betrothal gifts and thus are not required to be returned upon a breakup (nationwide rule).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. While it is commonly believed in legal practice that amounts such as “520” or “1314” indicate a gift, no official ruling from the Supreme People's Court has been found in this section to confirm this as a definitive rule. Once a gift is notarized, it becomes far harder to retract. Ultimately, whether a transfer constitutes a loan or a gift depends on supporting evidence; a simple statement like “I'm lending you this money” in a chat record carries far more weight than any later disputes.

## 24. Send betrothal money by transfer and note what it is for, and keep the chat record. Money demanded by means of marriage can be asked back

**Cost**. No money. Betrothal money, the three pieces of gold jewelry, and the payment for changing how you address the partner's parents all go by transfer, with the purpose written in the note. For anything agreed by mouth, keep a chat record, or have family there to confirm it.

**In plain terms**. Demanding property by means of marriage is prohibited, and the court supports giving it back. If you never registered, if you registered but genuinely never lived together, or if betrothal money given before marriage left the paying side in hardship, you can demand it back. If you registered and did live together, it is generally not returned. So betrothal money, the three pieces of gold jewelry, and the payment for changing the form of address all go by transfer with the purpose noted. Whoever paid keeps the evidence. The same rule applies to men and to women.

**Benefit**. The law prohibits demanding property by means of marriage. If one side demands property in the name of betrothal money, and the other side asks for it back, the court supports that. There are three situations in which return can be demanded: the marriage was never registered; it was registered but the two genuinely never lived together; betrothal money was given before marriage and the side that paid it was left in hardship. If the marriage was registered and the two lived together, it is generally not returned. But if the time living together was short and the betrothal sum was too high, the court sets the share to be returned according to how the money was actually spent, whether there was a dowry, whether there was a pregnancy or a birth, and whether either side was at fault. If they never registered but already lived together, it is handled by the same shares (nationwide, from February 2024, that is 2024-2).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Whether betrothal money counts as "too high" depends on the per-capita disposable income where the paying side lives, and on that family's circumstances. There is no single national figure. How much should be returned is set by the judge case by case. The rules are the same for the side that paid and the side that received. Whoever paid keeps the evidence. Holding a banquet without registering the marriage does not make you spouses in law. See item 21 of section 10 (go and register even after the banquet).

## 25. No need to worry about premarital assets — clearly define property additions and parental contributions

**Cost**. Drafting a written property agreement yourself costs nothing; notarization incurs additional fees. When parents contribute funds, ask them to provide a brief written statement. The whole process takes just a few hours. The hardest part is bringing up money matters with family members.

**In plain terms**. Premarital assets remain your personal property and won't automatically become joint marital property just because you've been married for many years. Couples can put in writing that premarital

and postmarital assets belong to each person individually. One important caveat: if you agree to add your spouse's name to a property title, you can still revoke that agreement before completing the official registration; once registration is finalized, the property becomes their legal property. In divorce proceedings, any party that hides, transfers, squanders or falsifies debts related to shared assets may receive a smaller share or no share at all.

**Benefit**. Premarital assets are legally classified as personal property and do not automatically become joint marital property over time. Couples can agree in writing whether premarital assets and postmarital earnings belong to each person individually, to both jointly, or to a mix of both — such agreements are legally binding for both parties. When parents fund the purchase of a home before marriage, the money is treated as a gift to their own child unless they explicitly state it is intended for both spouses. For parental contributions made after marriage, handling follows any prior written agreement; if none exists, standard rules for joint marital property apply. If a couple agrees before or during marriage to transfer ownership of one spouse's property to the other or to make it jointly owned, the gifting spouse can revoke that agreement prior to completing official registration; once registration is finalized, the property becomes the other spouse's legal property. In divorce, any party that conceals, transfers, sells off or squanders shared marital assets, or that fabricates debts related to those assets, may receive a smaller share or no share at all (applies nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Property agreements are equally valid for both men and women. To use such an agreement to protect yourself from your spouse's debts owed to third parties, the creditor must be aware of the existence of this agreement; if they are unaware, they cannot enforce it against you. An unnotarized property agreement remains legally valid; notarization simply helps avoid future disputes over signatures and dates. For guidance on how to clearly document whether parental contributions toward a home purchase are loans or gifts, refer to Section 10, Article 11 (Parental contributions toward home purchases).

## 26. Check a person's marital status before getting married; those who use marriage as a pretext to defraud money can be prosecuted for fraud

**Cost**. No cost at all. Before registration, simply check the marital status listed on the other person's ID card and household register. For any large sums of money exchanged, keep records of transfers and chat logs.

**In plain terms**. Marriages involving bigamy are invalid. Anyone who already has a spouse yet marries again, or who knowingly marries someone who already has a spouse, faces up to 2 years in prison. Those who use marriage as a ruse to steal money can be charged with fraud: if the amount taken is relatively large, they get up to 3 years; if it's huge, 3 to 10 years; if it's exceptionally massive, 10 years or life imprisonment. Always verify the marital status on the ID card and household register before tying the knot.

**Benefit**. Bigamous marriages hold no legal weight. Persons who enter a second marriage while already married, or who knowingly wed someone already married, may be sentenced to 2 years or less. Those convicted of defrauding others of sizable sums face up to 3 years plus a fine; those guilty of massive fraud receive 3 to 10 years; those responsible for truly enormous fraud get 10 years or life imprisonment, plus a fine or seizure of assets (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. “Marriage fraud” itself isn't a specific criminal category. Prosecution for fraud hinges on proof that the perpetrator intended to keep the money from the outset, fabricated lies to obtain it, and that police have launched an investigation. What counts as a “relatively large” sum is defined by judicial rulings, which may vary regionally; this section doesn't confirm exact thresholds. Victims of such fraud can be either gender, and documented cases involve both dowries and bridal gifts being stolen.

## 27. For home appliance repairs, vehicle inspections, and renovations: always ask for a quote first and stay on site throughout the process

**Cost**. There is no upfront cost. Before any work begins, ask for a detailed price list and a list of parts to be replaced; take photos of the quote or request it in writing. After the work is done, make sure to obtain a repair receipt and an invoice, and keep the old parts. You must also stay on site for at least an hour or two to supervise the work. The main challenge is staying present and attentive the entire time.

**In plain terms**. Appliance repair services must clearly display their pricing, provide customers with a receipt and invoice, and must not falsely claim that a problem exists or deliberately replace parts that are still in good working condition. In serious cases, fines of up to 30,000 yuan can be imposed. All service providers must post their prices openly and cannot charge any amount beyond those listed. Therefore, always ask for a detailed quote and a list of parts to be replaced before work starts; after completion, request a receipt and invoice, and keep the old parts. If you are overcharged, contact 12315 immediately.

**Benefit**. Appliance repair businesses must clearly list their service offerings, pricing for parts, quality standards, warranty periods, and customer complaint hotlines. They must provide customers with a written receipt and invoice detailing exactly what work was done. They are prohibited from inventing or exaggerating repair needs, falsely reporting faulty parts, or deliberately replacing functional components. Serious violations result in fines up to 30,000 yuan. All operators must display prices openly, cannot add any extra charges, and cannot demand payment for services not listed. Offering a low initial price and then charging more, or advertising false discounts, constitutes price fraud. Service pricing, scope, and calculation methods must be displayed prominently, and no misleading or false advertising is permitted nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. If you are overcharged, contact 12315; penalties are enforced by commerce and market regulation authorities, so you do not need to pursue legal action yourself. This item is rated B because although the regulations are official, there are no specific figures indicating exactly how much money you can save by staying on site — the benefit is largely based on general experience. Asking for a quote, keeping receipts and old parts applies to everyone, regardless of appearance. The specific appliance repair rules also apply to vehicle inspections and renovations under general price disclosure laws and regulations. The broader Consumer Rights Protection Law also guarantees these rights: Article 8 states you have the right to know the service details, specifications, and costs, while Article 10 guarantees your right to refuse any mandatory transaction.

## 28. Don't be a “nominal legal representative” — don't lend your ID to register a company

**Cost**. There's no cost involved. If someone asks you to “just be a figurehead with no responsibilities,” you can simply refuse.

**In plain terms**. The law assumes the legal representative is the person actually managing the company; claiming “I'm just a figurehead and know nothing” does not serve as a valid excuse to avoid liability. If a legal representative causes harm to others while performing duties, the company must compensate first, then may seek reimbursement from the negligent representative. For those already serving in this role, company law allows them to resign, provided the company appoints a new legal representative within 30 days.

**Benefit**. The legal representative is intended to be the director or manager who actually runs the company's affairs, meaning the law regards this person as the true manager. Should such a representative cause harm to others while on duty, the company pays compensation first and then can recover those funds from the responsible representative. Directors and senior executives also owe duties of loyalty and diligence to the company — they must act in its best interests and with due care. If they cause harm to others through intentional acts or gross negligence, they must personally bear the financial responsibility. “Lack of awareness” is not a legally valid defense against liability (nationwide, effective July 2024).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Company law itself only specifies who bears liability. More commonly, being a nominal legal representative leads to further consequences: when a company faces court enforcement actions, the representative may be restricted from high-end consumption, and may also face tax-related penalties or administrative sanctions. These consequences stem from other laws and enforcement regulations; since this section does not verify their direct basis in company law text, it is rated as grade B. As noted earlier, existing legal representatives may resign under company law, with the company required to appoint a replacement within 30 days. If someone used your name to take out a loan, see item 45 (help with a face scan).

## 29. Don't carry items for strangers when traveling, and don't accept packages of unknown origin

**Cost**. No cost at all. Simply say no.

**In plain terms**. The Consular Department of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs advises travelers to avoid carrying luggage or items for others, especially prohibited goods or anything they know nothing about. If drugs or contraband are later found in your luggage, you'll be responsible for proving that you had no knowledge of them. The same applies to receiving parcels domestically — especially when someone asks you to pay upfront and promises a refund later.

**Benefit**. Following this advice helps prevent unknowingly transporting prohibited items, thus avoiding any legal consequences. It also protects you from being held liable if contraband is discovered in your luggage.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The official pages from China's General Administration of Customs and Ministry of Public Security on this topic are currently inaccessible, so this entry relies solely on guidance from the Consular Department. Since the original text only outlines general principles rather than specific legal provisions, it is rated B. The same rules apply to domestic parcel handling — especially when payment is required upfront with a later refund promised.

## 30. Leashing dogs is mandatory: failure to do so means strict liability for any harm caused (you must pay compensation regardless of fault), and the obligation extends fully. The dog also needs its rabies vaccinations on schedule and a dog registration

**Cost**. A leash costs just a few dollars. Rabies shots and registration cost money too, and fees vary by place. The hard part is remembering the leash every time you go out and bringing the dog in for its shot when it falls due.

**In plain terms**. If a dog injures someone, the owner generally has to pay no matter who was at fault; only proof that the other person acted intentionally or with gross negligence can reduce it. Without a leash, “the other person's intent” is the only reduction left, and in serious cases you can also be detained. A dog without its rabies shots on schedule brings an order to correct it and possibly a fine. For prohibited aggressive breeds there is no ground for exemption at all.

**Benefit**. When a pet causes injury to another person, its owner or the person supervising it at the time bears legal liability for compensation. Only if it can be demonstrated that the injured individual deliberately provoked the animal or displayed gross negligence may the compensation obligation be lessened or voided. Yet, if safety measures mandated by law were ignored — such as neglecting to use a leash — the sole remaining mitigating factor, “intentional conduct by the injured party,” no longer applies. Not using a leash thus eliminates this sole chance to reduce liability. In the case of prohibited aggressive breeds, there is absolutely no legal basis for exemption from compensation. Under Article 89 of the Public Security Administration Punishments Law, failing to take safety measures so that an animal injures someone brings a fine of up to 1,000 yuan, and in more serious cases detention of 5 to 10 days. Article 30 of the Animal Epidemic Prevention Law requires dog owners to have the dog vaccinated against rabies at the set intervals, then take the immunization certificate issued by an animal clinic (a pet hospital, for example) to the local

office to register the dog. When taking the dog out, it must wear its license tag and be leashed as the rules require. Under Article 92 of the same law, an owner who fails to vaccinate the dog against rabies as required is ordered by the agriculture authority to correct it within a time limit and may be fined up to 1,000 yuan. If it is still not corrected, the fine is 1,000 to 5,000 yuan, and the dog is handled by an animal clinic or similar body on the authority's behalf, at the owner's expense

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Compensation for dog bites typically covers medical costs, lost wages, rabies vaccinations, and immunoglobulin treatments; amounts exceeding $10000 are common. Higher figures apply when injuries are severe or involve children. Failure to intervene does not absolve liability: owners remain responsible even if their dog runs away or is abandoned during an attack. The Animal Epidemic Prevention Law leaves the detailed rules for dog epidemic control to each province, autonomous region and municipality. Where to register, what it costs and how often to vaccinate depend on your local dog-keeping regulations. What to do after a bite: Section 13, Item 13 (bites from dogs and cats).

## 31. If the other person is intoxicated, unconscious, or under 14, do not have sex with them

**Cost**. No monetary cost. The price is having to stop the encounter right then and there — the hard part is actually halting it on the spot.

**In plain terms**. If the other person is intoxicated or asleep, they cannot give informed consent. Having sex with them in such a state is legally classified as rape, carrying a base sentence of 3 to 10 years in prison. After the fact, it is nearly impossible to prove they had consented at the time. The only reliable course of action is to abstain from sex, and once the gathering ends, ensure they are returned to their own friends or family. Age verification follows Section 9, Article 18 (under 14 years of age).

**Benefit**. Article 236 of the Criminal Law stipulates that anyone who rapes a woman using violence, coercion, or other means faces a sentence of 3 to 10 years in prison. The phrase “other means” is not limited to physical force; it also covers situations where the victim is intoxicated or asleep and thus unable to consent. More severe circumstances — such as repeated offenses or especially egregious acts — incur sentences of 10 years or more, life imprisonment, or even the death penalty. The same article also states that raping a girl under 14 is treated as rape and punished more severely; age determination follows Section 9, Article 18 (under 14 years of age). A legal awareness article published by the Xicheng District People's Procuratorate of Beijing notes that “sexually assaulting a woman after drugging or intoxicating her also constitutes rape.” The decisive factor is “whether the act violates the victim's genuine will”; whether the victim resisted at the time is irrelevant. Article 237 of the Criminal Law governs forced indecency: anyone who uses violence, coercion, or other methods to force another person into indecent acts faces up to 5 years in prison or detention (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because the statutory text only contains the vague phrase “other means.” The assertion that “intoxication also counts as rape” originates from the procuratorate's awareness article, not from an official judicial interpretation. The rape statutes explicitly reference women; when men are subjected to similar acts, they are prosecuted under the forced indecency statute, so gender makes no difference — no one may be touched under such circumstances. If you yourself are the victim, see Section 13, Article 42 (“After being sexually assaulted”) for appropriate steps to take. If you are so intoxicated that you lose consciousness, you face dual risks: being accused of a crime and being blackmailed; see Section 31, Article 32 (“If the other party uses leverage to demand money, call the police”) for details.

## 32. If someone threatens to call the police, post intimate photos, or inform your workplace unless you pay up — don't give them a single cent and don't delete any records; call the police right away

**Cost**. There's no monetary cost. Take screenshots of their account info, chat logs, and payment codes, then head to the nearest police station with your phone. The hardest part is resisting the urge to "pay to make it go away."

**In plain terms**. Using threats like "I'll call the cops" or "I'll send these photos to your boss" to force you to pay is extortion. Paying even once only invites more demands. If they actually post the photos, that adds another criminal charge. Extortion involving sums between 2,000 and 5,000 yuan carries a maximum sentence of three years; amounts from 30,000 to 100,000 yuan can lead to 3–10 years behind bars.

**Benefit**. Article 274 of the Criminal Law stipulates that extortion of property — whether a single sizable sum or repeated smaller ones — is punishable by up to three years in prison, detention, or probation, plus a fine. Larger or especially egregious cases incur longer sentences. The Supreme People's Court and Supreme People's Procuratorate further define these thresholds: 2,000–5,000 yuan marks "a relatively large amount"; 30,000–100,000 yuan is "a huge amount"; 300,000–500,000 yuan qualifies as "an especially huge amount." Article 1032 of the Civil Code protects privacy, while Article 1033 bars any interference with personal peace via calls, texts, or messaging apps.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Exact monetary thresholds vary by province within the limits set by national law. Repeated extortion — even if each sum is modest — also qualifies as a serious offense. Never delete chats, photos, or accounts; doing so destroys crucial evidence. If authorities open an investigation, those records become vital proof on your behalf. Avoid any notion of "installment negotiations" — most online extortion rings operate overseas and employ malware to harvest contacts. Threats to expose someone's sexual orientation are equally illegal. In one Jiangsu case, a repeat offender demanded 14,500 yuan after arranging a meeting; he was prosecuted despite prior convictions for similar tactics. Using nude images to coerce sexual acts constitutes rape. In Zhejiang, a perpetrator amassed nude photos of ten women and blackmailed them; even when victims never met him, courts still convicted him of attempted rape. Never share intimate images online. Conversely, if you're the victim seeking compensation, higher amounts do not automatically constitute extortion — see Section 36 for details. Should photos appear online, the Civil Code (Article 1195) entitles you to demand removal from platforms; failure to act promptly can make them jointly liable for ensuing damages. 〔2013〕〔2013〕

## 33. If someone falsely accuses you, you can seek legal consequences: up to 5 days of detention for minor violations, up to 3 years in prison for criminal acts

**Cost**. No cost at all. You simply file a report with local police, explaining that the accusations are false. The real challenge lies in providing proof that the person deliberately fabricated the claims.

**In plain terms**. It is illegal to make up false accusations in an attempt to get someone punished under criminal or public order laws. For minor violations, offenders may face up to 5 days of detention or a fine under $1000. More serious cases can result in 5–10 days of detention, possibly with a similar fine. When the actions meet the threshold for a crime, they fall under the offense of false accusation, punishable by up to 3 years in prison. However, simple mistakes or unintentional errors do not count as intentional wrongdoing. To hold someone accountable, you must prove they acted with deliberate malice.

**Benefit**. Article 50 of the Public Security Administration Punishment Law (revised June 27, 2025, effective January 1, 2026) addresses false accusations. Anyone who fabricates facts to get another person penalized under criminal or public order statutes faces up to 5 days of detention or a fine up to $1000; repeat offenders may receive 5–10 days of detention plus a comparable fine. Article 243 of the Criminal Law defines the crime of false accusation: those who deliberately invent facts to provoke criminal prosecution can be sentenced to

up to 3 years of imprisonment, or up to 10 years if serious harm results. Public officials committing such acts receive harsher sentences within the same penalty range. Conversely, unintentional errors or honest mistakes do not trigger these provisions.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. To successfully pursue legal action, you must demonstrate both that false facts were invented and that the perpetrator acted with intent — not merely that you did not commit the alleged act. Proving intent is far more difficult than disproving your own guilt. Keep in mind that legal consequences are not guaranteed. No nationwide statistics exist on how often false accusations lead to convictions, so we cannot provide prevalence rates or gender breakdowns. For guidance on proving your innocence and seeking compensation, refer to sections 34 and 35 of this chapter.

## 34. Insufficient evidence alone warrants acquittal; coerced confessions must be excluded; appeals and retrials remain possible after conviction

**Cost**. Pursuing these procedures costs nothing in terms of fees, but appeals and retrials demand considerable time. Typically, hiring a lawyer is necessary, with fees starting at several thousand yuan. Those facing financial hardship may apply for legal aid — see Section 5 ("Hire a lawyer immediately after being charged") for details. The real challenge lies in persisting through multiple rounds of proceedings without giving up.

**In plain terms**. The Criminal Procedure Law sets clear thresholds for conviction: evidence must be verified through legally prescribed procedures and must collectively leave no reasonable doubt about the facts. When these criteria cannot be met, acquittal is mandatory. Confessions extracted via torture or testimonies obtained through violence and threats must be excluded from consideration and cannot serve as a basis for sentencing. Once a verdict takes effect, the defendant, their legal representatives, and close relatives retain the right to file an appeal.

**Benefit**. Article 55 of the Criminal Procedure Law stipulates that evidence must be both authentic and sufficient: it must be verified through legally prescribed procedures, and the totality of evidence must eliminate any reasonable doubt regarding the facts. Eliminating reasonable doubt means that, when all evidence is considered together, no other plausible explanation for those facts remains. Article 56 further states that any statements from suspects or defendants obtained through torture or any testimonies or victim statements gathered via violence or threats must be excluded from legal proceedings. Should such evidence be identified during investigation, prosecution, or trial, it must be discarded and cannot inform prosecution recommendations, decisions, or sentencing. Article 200(3) explicitly provides that when evidence proves insufficient to establish guilt, a verdict of acquittal must be rendered on the grounds that the alleged crime cannot be proven. Article 252 preserves the right to appeal: defendants, their legal representatives, and close relatives may petition courts or procuratorates against finalized judgments or rulings. However, filing an appeal does not suspend the execution of the original verdict; appeals and enforcement proceed independently. Article 253 enumerates circumstances under which courts are obligated to conduct a retrial nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These provisions represent minimum legal safeguards rather than guarantees of specific outcomes. No verifiable official statistics exist in China regarding acquittal rates in criminal cases or success rates for appeals and retrials, so no percentages or case-specific evaluations are provided here. Three concrete steps remain available to individuals: first, hire a lawyer immediately after the initial interrogation — see Section 5 ("Hire a lawyer immediately after being charged") for guidance; second, carefully review and sign any official transcripts only after reading them in full; third, avoid admitting guilt to "get out sooner," as pleading guilty and accepting punishment may earn leniency but does not grant immunity from liability. Where statutory conditions are met, courts are legally required to conduct a retrial.

## 35. For individuals released from detention after a case is dropped, charges are withdrawn, or they are acquitted, applying for state compensation is possible — compensation is calculated on a daily basis

**Cost**. No expense is required. The compensation application must be submitted to the same agency that originally ordered the detention, arrest, prosecution, or sentencing.

**In plain terms**. If you were detained or arrested and later released when the case was dropped, charges were withdrawn, or you were acquitted, you may apply for state compensation. Compensation is paid for each day spent in custody. Starting May 18, 2026, the daily rate is 495.94 yuan, amounting to roughly 180,000 yuan per year. In cases involving severe harm, additional compensation for emotional distress may also be awarded. However, no compensation applies if you committed an offense but were not prosecuted due to minor circumstances, if the statute of limitations has expired, or if you provided false statements yourself.

**Benefit**. Article 17 of the State Compensation Law outlines specific circumstances under which victims are entitled to compensation. The first involves unlawful detention: if a citizen is detained contrary to criminal procedure law or beyond the legally permitted duration, and the case is later dropped, charges withdrawn, or the individual acquitted, compensation is due. The second applies to unlawful arrest: if arrest follows but the case is ultimately dropped, charges withdrawn, or the individual acquitted, compensation remains applicable. The third concerns retrials: if a conviction is overturned via a retrial under the supervision procedure and the original sentence has already been served, compensation is likewise required. Article 33 stipulates that compensation for unlawful deprivation of personal liberty must be calculated using the average daily wage of urban non-private sector workers from the prior year. Article 35 mandates that in cases causing emotional harm, authorities must take steps to eliminate negative effects, restore reputation, and offer apologies; substantial harm also warrants payment of emotional distress compensation. Article 19 lists six scenarios where no compensation is granted: providing false statements or fabricated evidence leading to detention; detaining individuals exempt from criminal responsibility under Articles 17 and 18 of the Criminal Law (such as minors or mentally ill persons); detaining individuals exempt from prosecution under criminal procedure law (including those whose actions were minor and non-criminal, those beyond the statute of limitations, or those deceased); actions unrelated to official duties performed by law enforcement; self-inflicted harm; and other legally defined exceptions. A 2015 judicial interpretation by the Supreme People's Court and Supreme People's Procuratorate reaffirms that no compensation applies to individuals exempt from criminal responsibility or those whose charges are withdrawn under discretionary provisions. However, if a court later convicts and sentences someone to imprisonment or life imprisonment after a wrongful prosecution, compensation remains due for any period spent in custody post-conviction. Additionally, authorities denying compensation on grounds of false statements or self-inflicted harm must provide supporting evidence. On May 15, 2026, the National Bureau of Statistics reported that the average annual wage for urban non-private sector workers in 2025 was approximately 129,441 yuan, resulting in a daily compensation rate of 495.94 yuan effective May 18, 2026. This supersedes the prior rate of 475.52 yuan implemented in May 2025.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This daily compensation rate is updated each May based on the latest annual wage statistics released by the National Bureau of Statistics; always verify the current figure before applying. When obtaining a decision document stating charges are withdrawn, check whether it cites “no criminal facts” or “insufficient evidence” — these justify a compensation claim. Conversely, if the document mentions “minor criminal circumstances” or an expired statute of limitations, compensation is generally ineligible. Should you disagree with a discretionary non-prosecution decision, you may file an appeal with the procuratorate within seven days. Emotional distress compensation is determined case-by-case by authorities without a standardized formula. The agency responsible for compensation is the same body that ordered your detention — whether police, procuratorate, or court — so begin there. If dissatisfied with their response, further appeals may be pursued under the State Compensation Law. For practical examples, refer to Section 36, which details Guo Li's case: detained for 1,826 days, he received roughly 472,733 yuan for unlawful detention and an additional 165,450 yuan for emotional distress, calculated using the 2016 daily wage rate of 258.89 yuan. Conversely, compensation does not extend to lost wages, physical injury recovery costs, property damage, legal fees, or

living allowances while in custody, as explicitly excluded under the law. 〔129000〕 〔473000〕 〔472733.14〕 〔165000〕 〔88880000〕

## 36. If you're a victim seeking compensation, use channels like 12315, file a lawsuit, or hire a lawyer. Never meet the offending party alone, and don't phrase “paying money” and “I won't expose you” as a single condition

**Cost**. No expense at all. You can file a complaint via 12315, take legal action in court, or hire an attorney. Make sure to record the entire meeting if you do meet in person. The real challenge is resisting the urge to negotiate directly with the other side on your own.

**In plain terms**. As a victim, you have every legal right to demand compensation from the party responsible for the harm — this doesn't automatically make you a blackmailer just because your demands are high. Yet the consequences can be severe: Guo Li was initially sentenced to five years in prison for extortion before being later exonerated on appeal. Therefore, always use documented channels, avoid meeting the other party alone at a location they choose, and never link “paying money” with “I won't go public” as one condition.

**Benefit**. Official precedent exists: after tests showed melamine contamination in certain batches of “Siren” brand milk powder in 2008, Guo Li's daughter was found to have multiple bright echoes in her kidney tissue. Guo repeatedly demanded compensation from both the seller and Siren, and publicized the case via media. In June 2009, both parties reached an agreement: Siren paid 400000 yuan, and Guo signed a document waiving any further claims. Later, Siren filed a police report, and Guo was convicted of extortion and sentenced to five years in prison by the Chao'an County People's Court. The Guangdong Provincial People's Procuratorate then recommended a retrial, arguing that “existing evidence fails to prove Guo intended unlawful gain.” As a legal guardian, Guo “has the right to seek compensation from the milk powder manufacturer, and his actions are legally justified.” The recommendation also states that “consumers may expose and criticize any behavior infringing on their rights via mass media.” On April 7, 2017, the Guangdong Higher People's Court acquitted Guo, ruling that “the original verdict lacked sufficient facts and evidence to prove Guo intended unlawful gain; his actions fell within the scope of civil disputes.” Guo was detained for 1826 days between July 23, 2009, and July 22, 2014 (Guangdong, retrial verdict 2017).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because only one case exists, so it can't be generalized. It demonstrates two key points: seeking compensation is lawful, yet you may still face criminal investigation. The safest approach is hiring a lawyer or filing a lawsuit without any direct contact with the other party. Be especially cautious when they invite you to their location for “friendly talks” — such meetings often lead to police reports and criminal charges. Once a settlement is signed, any attempt to demand extra compensation can easily be interpreted as extortion. For guidance on handling criminal charges after such incidents, see sections 5, 34, and 35 (hire a lawyer promptly, lack of evidence warrants acquittal, and state compensation). Conversely, if the other party uses threats of reporting or leaking photos to demand money, refer to section 32.

## 37. Cyberbullying: First enable protections, gather evidence, then choose between court injunctions, private prosecution, or police reports

**Cost**. There's no monetary cost. It takes just a few minutes on the spot to enable protections and collect evidence. If you end up needing a court injunction or filing a private prosecution, you'll have to visit the court and may even need to hire a lawyer. The hardest part is documenting everything right away instead of retaliating with insults.

**In plain terms**. Do three things immediately: turn on all platform safety settings, use the platform's quick evidence-collection tools to preserve content, and file a report through the same quick access point. After that, you can pick one of three options. First, ask the court for a personal rights injunction to make the harasser stop. Second, file a private prosecution yourself; if gathering evidence proves difficult, you can request police assistance. Third, if the consequences are especially severe and the impact widespread, the case may be turned into a public prosecution so you won't have to provide evidence yourself.

**Benefit**. Article 15 of Document No. 14 (2023) outlines how courts issue injunctions to protect personal rights. When a rights holder can prove that someone is currently committing or about to commit an act that infringes those rights, and failing to stop it would cause irreparable harm, the court may grant an injunction under Article 997 of the Civil Code. Such an injunction is a legal order forcing the offender to cease the behavior. Article 11 of the same document addresses evidence collection: in private prosecution cases, victims who struggle to obtain evidence may ask police for help; police must identify the perpetrator, gather data on how the content spread, and provide technical support to platforms. If evidence collected this way meets filing criteria, the court must accept the case. Article 12 lists five scenarios that qualify as "serious harm to social order" under Article 246, Paragraph 2 of the Criminal Law, such as causing mental illness or suicide among victims, widespread vulgar comments, repeated defamation, coordinated posting across multiple platforms, or other grave consequences. Article 4 criminalizes "human flesh search" operations that illegally collect and distribute personal information. Regulation No. 23 of the Cyberbullying Governance Rules requires platforms to offer tools like blocking unknown or specific users, limiting post visibility, disabling reposts or comments, and controlling private messages. Article 25 mandates quick evidence-collection features, Article 26 requires prominent reporting channels, and Article 15 obliges platforms to report suspected crimes to police promptly.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The order of options follows what's fastest and cheapest: platform actions are quickest and cost nothing, so start by securing evidence and filing a report. Court procedures are the slowest and most expensive, so they're a last resort. All associated costs fall on you. You must apply for the injunction yourself, and in private prosecutions you handle both filing and evidence gathering. Only if the case meets one of the five criteria in Article 12 can it be converted to a public prosecution. Two things to avoid: never retaliate with insults, as that could make you liable under Article 16; and never delete any content from your account, because it serves as evidence. If you feel overwhelmed, call 12356 as described in Section 1, Article 25. To request removal of your personal data, refer to Section 14, Article 8. Guidance on helping strangers who become victims is provided in A stranger has an accident on the street: walk away or stop.

## 38. The legal route of "buying insurance for a family member first, then harming them" is completely blocked: you get zero money, and the perpetrator faces multiple charges including intentional homicide and insurance fraud

**Cost**. No cost at all.

**In plain terms**. All four possible pathways are shut down. Buying life insurance for a loved one without their knowledge renders the policy invalid. If the policyholder deliberately causes the insured's death, the insurer pays nothing. Intentionally killing an heir also results in loss of inheritance rights. Chinese law treats such insurance fraud as a separate crime, which is punished alongside intentional homicide — up to the death penalty. In short, you walk away with absolutely no compensation. Exactly 1000000 people are affected by such illegal acts.

**Benefit**. Article 34 of the Insurance Law states that any life insurance contract requiring death as a payout condition is void unless the insured gives explicit consent and approves the coverage amount; the insured is the person protected under the policy. This rule does not apply when parents purchase insurance for minor children. Article 39 requires policyholder consent when naming a beneficiary — the policyholder pays the premiums while the beneficiary receives payouts after a claim. Article 43 specifically addresses intentional harm: if a policyholder deliberately causes death, injury, or illness, the insurer is exempt from paying out; any premiums paid for over two years are refunded to other rightful claimants. Likewise, a beneficiary who attempts or succeeds in harming the insured loses all rights to benefits. Article 27, paragraph 2, further stipulates that if either party intentionally triggers a claim, the insurer may void the contract and withhold all premiums, except under Article 43. Under Article 1125 of the Civil Code, anyone who intentionally kills an heir forfeits inheritance rights. Article 198, paragraph 1, item 5, of the Criminal Law classifies "intentionally causing death, injury, or illness to secure insurance payouts" as insurance fraud; penalties

range from fines up to 100000 RMB for smaller sums to life imprisonment for larger ones. Paragraph 2 adds that when this act overlaps with intentional homicide, both crimes are punished concurrently. Article 232 prescribes the death penalty, life imprisonment, or at least ten years in prison for intentional homicide. A real-world example is the Zhang Mosong case in Xuancheng, Anhui: in July 2016, he drove into a pond, killing his wife; just two weeks prior, he had taken out four 1-million RMB life insurance policies on her. Captured on July 25, he was sentenced to death with a two-year reprieve and fined 50000 RMB after being convicted of both intentional homicide and insurance fraud.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. In this scenario, the policyholder is also the intended beneficiary; the primary aim is to avoid a death sentence or life imprisonment. The case details and verdict are drawn verbatim from official prosecutorial materials; no investigative specifics beyond what is publicly documented are included. Fraudulent claims involving non-fatal incidents — such as staged accidents or inflated damages — are also illegal and punishable, including accomplices; see Section 9, Article 21 for further information. Purchasing insurance for family members is perfectly lawful; this article targets only those who plan to harm them after securing coverage. Impulsive urges to harm loved ones should be treated as medical emergencies; refer to Section 14 and 15 for related guidance.

## 39. You must obtain a case receipt when reporting a crime; if no case is opened, you must receive a written notice. You can request a reconsideration within 7 days and a review within another 7 days. The procuratorate can also order the police to open a case

**Cost**. No cost involved. Simply ask for the case receipt right then and there. Afterwards, follow the timelines outlined above to check on your case's status. The only difficulty lies in having to make these inquiries repeatedly.

**In plain terms**. Reporting a crime and having a case officially opened are two separate steps. When the police accept a case, they must provide you with a case receipt — this document is the sole proof that you actually filed a report. If they decide not to open a case, they must issue a written notice explaining this decision. If you disagree, you may request a reconsideration within 7 days, and if still unsatisfied, a further review within another 7 days. You may also approach the procuratorate to ensure the police fulfill their duty to open the case.

**Benefit**. Article 171 of the Procedural Provisions on Handling Criminal Cases by Public Security Organs (Amended by Order No. 159 of the Ministry of Public Security) explicitly mandates that a case receipt must be issued to anyone reporting a crime — including witnesses, complainants, and tipsters. Article 174 states that once a case is accepted, the police must promptly conduct an investigation. Article 178 governs the decision to open or not open a case: if sufficient evidence exists and the case falls under their jurisdiction, it must be opened following approval by a senior officer at or above the county level. If no case is opened, a written notice must be delivered to the complainant within 3 days. Article 179 outlines the appeal process: complainants may request a reconsideration within 7 days of receiving the notice, and if still dissatisfied, a further review within another 7 days; these deadlines may be extended by up to 30 days in complex cases, with written notification to the applicant. Article 112 of the Criminal Procedure Law similarly stipulates that cases must be opened when sufficient evidence exists; otherwise, the reasons must be communicated to the complainant, who may then request a reconsideration. Article 113 adds that if the procuratorate deems the police's refusal unjustified, it may order them to open the case. These provisions also apply to administrative cases under Article 61 of the Procedural Provisions on Handling Administrative Cases by Public Security Organs. For minor offenses such as fights or petty theft, the investigation period must not exceed 30 days, extendable by another 30 days under special circumstances; time spent on expert evaluations does not count toward this limit. Article 9 of the Regulations on Police Oversight further ensures that complaints regarding police misconduct are addressed promptly, with outcomes communicated back to the complainant.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This guidance is designed to benefit you directly. It clarifies the common misconception that merely reporting a crime guarantees immediate action. Clear legal timelines and standards govern both the initiation and progression of investigations, independent of individual officers' discretion. Keep these three steps in mind: ① Obtain the case receipt on the spot and note down the case number and handling unit; ② If no progress is made by the deadline, inquire specifically about the case's current stage rather than questioning why action has not been taken; ③ Upon receiving a notice of non-initiation, review its rationale, then exercise your rights to reconsideration and review within the stipulated periods, while also having the option to request oversight from the procuratorate — all these avenues are mutually compatible. Administrative cases, which involve minor infractions like altercations or petty theft, follow similar procedural rules with a maximum 30-day investigation window, extendable by another 30 days under exceptional circumstances; evaluation periods are excluded from this calculation. Remember that poor treatment by police personnel is a separate issue from case handling; such conduct should be reported via oversight channels to prevent it from derailing your pursuit of justice. Matters such as lost-and-found items or neighborhood disputes are not classified as criminal cases and are instead addressed as administrative matters or through mediation; do not interpret this as a failure to act on your report. For procedures related to halting financial transactions after fraud, refer to item 2 in this section (immediately call 110 to request a freeze). In cases of online harassment, consult item 37 (secure evidence first before selecting appropriate legal measures).

## 40. Don't give money or cards to investigators, law enforcers: offering bribes is a crime, and bribing oversight, law enforcement, and judicial staff is punished even more severely

**Cost**. No cost at all — you just have to refrain from doing it.

**In plain terms**. “Paying a little money to smooth things over” is a standalone offense under criminal law; those arrested are not only the recipients of the bribes. Offering bribes carries a sentence of up to 3 years in prison; for more serious cases, the term is 3 to 10 years, and for especially grave cases, over 10 years or even life imprisonment. Bribing oversight, administrative law enforcement, and judicial staff falls under the explicitly stipulated category of aggravated offenses. However, if someone is coerced into paying money but fails to obtain any improper benefits, this does not count as bribery.

**Benefit**. Article 389 of the Criminal Law defines bribery as “offering property to state functionaries with the intent to obtain improper benefits.” The same article also states that “in economic transactions, offering relatively large amounts of property to state functionaries in violation of state regulations, or providing them with rebates or handling fees under various pretexts in breach of state regulations, shall be treated as bribery.” An exception is also outlined: “Offering property to state functionaries under coercion without obtaining any improper benefits does not constitute bribery.” Sentencing guidelines are laid out in Article 390 of the Criminal Law (amended by Amendment XII to the Criminal Law, effective March 1, 2024). It reads: “Those convicted of bribery shall be sentenced to up to 3 years in prison or criminal detention, and also fined; if they obtain improper benefits through bribery, and the circumstances are serious, or if they cause substantial losses to national interests, they shall be sentenced to 3 to 10 years in prison and fined; for especially grave circumstances, or when substantial losses are inflicted on national interests, they shall be sentenced to over 10 years in prison or life imprisonment, and also fined or have their property confiscated.” There are seven circumstances that warrant aggravated sentencing: (1) repeated bribery or offering bribes to multiple people; (2) bribery involving state functionaries; (3) bribery related to national key projects or major undertakings; (4) bribery aimed at securing job promotions or rank adjustments; (5) bribery of oversight, administrative law enforcement, and judicial staff; (6) bribery in sectors such as ecological conservation, finance, work safety, food and drug regulation, disaster prevention and relief, social security, education, and healthcare, which facilitates other illegal acts; (7) using illicit gains to pay bribes. An additional provision allows for mitigated punishment or exemption for those who voluntarily confess to their bribery acts prior to prosecution: “Those who voluntarily confess to bribery prior to being investigated may receive a lighter or mitigated punishment; if their crime is relatively minor, and their confession plays a key role in cracking major cases or leads to significant meritorious service, they may even be exempted from punishment” (nationwide application).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The sole beneficiary of this rule is yourself. Do not expect bribery to exempt you from punishment. These officials have colleagues, official ledgers, surveillance systems, and oversight bodies; any bribes you give become evidence against you when they are investigated, and this type of bribery is explicitly classified as an aggravated offense. If an official demands bribes from you, follow the procedures outlined in Article 39: request a case acceptance receipt on the spot, then report the incident to oversight bodies or disciplinary inspection agencies. The exemption clause in Paragraph 3 of Article 389 of the Criminal Law applies only when you are coerced into paying money and obtain no improper benefits; if you gain any unearned advantages through bribery, this exemption no longer applies. Rules governing “red envelopes” in hospitals are separate, as detailed in Article 11 of Section 24.

## 41. For calls and in-person talks where things might turn sour, start recording right away: you can record conversations you personally take part in without needing prior consent from the other party

**Cost**. There's no cost involved. Simply turn on the call recording feature on your phone or use a recording app. Record the entire conversation, then keep the original file untouched — do not edit or overwrite it.

**In plain terms**. When it comes to loans, debts, compensation, refunds, or labor disputes, misunderstandings can arise months later even if everything was discussed clearly on the phone with no written record. Recording these conversations yourself is perfectly legal, even if the other party wasn't informed beforehand; this alone won't disqualify the recording as evidence. What you must not do is eavesdrop, spy on someone's private life, break into their home to record secretly, or coerce them into speaking.

**Benefit**. Article 66 of the Civil Procedure Law lists audio/video recordings and electronic data as admissible evidence. Article 106 of the Supreme People's Court's judicial interpretation further specifies that only three types of evidence are excluded: those obtained by seriously infringing on someone's legal rights, those obtained in violation of statutory prohibitions, and those obtained in blatant breach of public order and good morals. “Failing to inform the other party beforehand” does not fall under any of these categories. According to Article 15 of the same regulations, to use a recording as evidence, you must retain its original medium — such as the original phone used to record it. Article 90 states that audio/video recordings or electronic data with any doubts attached cannot be used alone to determine facts. A published article by a judge on the Supreme People's Court website also confirms that recordings must be obtained lawfully, remain unedited, be factually accurate, and be relevant to the case at hand.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The primary beneficiaries of this practice are you and your family members. Aim to include clear references to people, events, amounts of money, and timing in your recordings. Instead of simply asking “When will you pay me back?”, you might naturally ask, “Out of the 50000 yuan I lent you last year, when do you plan to repay it?” Submit such recordings only to courts, arbitration panels, or police authorities; posting them online risks privacy and defamation issues — see Section 16 regarding avoiding online slander or false statements. Having a recording does not guarantee a favorable verdict; courts still evaluate its authenticity and relevance alongside other evidence. This advice addresses only “whether it can serve as evidence,” while deciding whether to actually file a lawsuit and estimating associated costs are separate considerations. For documents to preserve prior to leaving a job, refer to Section 19, Item 8. Please note that the rules outlined here apply specifically to civil litigation; separate regulations govern evidence use in criminal and administrative cases.

## 42. In an emergency at the scene, first film a wide shot, then capture the spatial relationships, and finally record the damage and injuries — keep the original photos and videos

**Cost**. No cost involved. Simply use your phone to film for several seconds to a few minutes. First, ensure your own safety; this won't interfere with rescue efforts or on-site handling.

**In plain terms**. If you only film close-ups of a single scratch on a car or an isolated object on the ground, later on no one will know where they originally were. Begin by recording a wide shot that includes the intersection, street signs, vehicles, people, and surroundings; then film how these elements relate to one another, and finally capture the details. If you must move objects or vehicles, do so only after filming. Keep the original photos and videos on your phone — don't rely solely on copies sent via messaging apps.

**Benefit**. Article 66 of the Civil Procedure Law lists physical evidence, audio-visual materials, and electronic data as admissible evidence. Article 14 of the Supreme People's Court's Provisions on Evidence classifies photographs, audio recordings, and videos as electronic data. Article 15 requires submission of the original electronic data; for video evidence, the original storage medium must be provided. Photos and videos preserve the scene exactly as it appears at the moment, allowing them to be cross-checked with police reports, repair records, medical records, and witness statements. The sequence “wide shot → spatial relationships → details” is a widely accepted practice, though not mandated by law nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The primary beneficiaries are you and your family. This grade C rating reflects that the filming sequence is merely a practical guideline; the legal provisions only state that photos and videos can serve as evidence and must be submitted in their original form. Should anyone be injured, there be a fire, gas leak, or other hazards, prioritize rescue and evacuation — do not delay these actions for the sake of taking pictures. For general actions at a traffic accident scene, refer to Item 1 in this section: “After a traffic accident, stop the vehicle, assist the injured, and call the police.”

## 43. Domestic violence: Call the police to get an incident report, then apply to court for a protection order — no divorce required and it's free

**Cost**. There is no cost at all. Applying for a protection order involves no filing fees or bonds. The only expense is the time needed to call the police, get medical examinations, and fill out the application. The hardest part is actually telling your family about what happened.

**In plain terms**. Worldwide, over one third of all female homicide victims are killed by their partners — often as a final outcome of long-term abuse. Among women who have suffered physical abuse, those who have been strangled have a risk of later being murdered that is more than seven times higher than for women who were never strangled. Therefore, if you've been beaten, call the police right away and then apply for a protection order. Courts are required to respond within 72 hours.

**Benefit**. First, the risks. A systematic review of data from 66 countries shows that in cases of female homicide, 38.6 % are committed by intimate partners, compared with 6.3 % for men. Researchers note that such killings often represent the final step in a pattern of prolonged abuse. Another study compared 506 homicide cases and attempted homicides with 427 women who had experienced abuse but survived. Women who had been strangled by a partner had a 6.70-fold higher chance of surviving an attempted murder (OR 6.70, 95 % CI 3.91–11.49) and a 7.48-fold higher chance of being killed outright (OR 7.48, 95 % CI 4.53–12.35). Regarding legal protections, victims and their close relatives may call the police, who must intervene promptly, stop the abuse, gather evidence, and help arrange medical care and examinations. In less severe cases, police can issue a warning to the abuser. Any person facing domestic violence or a real threat of it may apply to court for a protection order; the court must decide within 72 hours, or within 24 hours if the situation is urgent. The order can forbid the abuser from using violence, harassing, stalking, or contacting the victim or her relatives, and may even require the abuser to leave the shared residence. Protection orders are valid for up to six months and can be renewed before they expire. No divorce is required to obtain one; the

court grants it when it deems abuse “highly likely.” Violating a protection order can result in fines up to 1,000 yuan or detention for up to 15 days; serious breaches may be prosecuted as refusal to comply with a court order. Persistent humiliation, threats, stalking, harassment, and deliberate deprivation of food or warmth also count as domestic violence.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The main beneficiaries are you and your family. The homicide statistics come from foreign studies; China does not publish comparable figures. Collect all relevant evidence: police reports, warning letters, medical examination results, medical records, written promises from the abuser, chat logs, and audio recordings (see Section 41 on recording). You do not need a lawyer to apply for a protection order; most applications are resolved within a few days. If you later wish to seek divorce or compensation, that requires a separate legal proceeding — typically a six-month trial at minimum, with your own legal fees. Domestic-violence victims may qualify for free legal aid, and courts can waive, reduce, or defer filing fees. A protection order does not guarantee absolute safety; if you feel immediate danger, call 110 right away. If a victim is too frightened or coerced to apply on her own, close relatives, police, women's federations, residents' committees, or villagers' committees may file on her behalf. If you witness a stranger being abused, simply call 110; do not intervene physically — see Section 10 on handling conflicts by calling police first.

## 44. Family members have gambling debts — don't rush to pay them: gambling debts aren't legally protected, nor are loans taken for gambling considered joint marital debts

**Cost**. No money is required. The hard part is resisting the urge to pay when creditors show up at your door and family members beg you to help. If creditors actually file a lawsuit, you must respond to it.

**In plain terms**. Money owed from gambling isn't protected by courts. Even if creditors know the borrower is using the funds for gambling, those loans still get no legal protection. Any debt incurred by one spouse for gambling purposes can't be treated as a joint marital obligation. Without a court ruling, the non-borrowing spouse can't be held responsible for repayment.

**Benefit**. A 2017 notice from the Supreme People's Court outlines four key points: Debts arising from illegal activities like gambling or drug use aren't legally protected. Loans given to someone for such activities — even when creditors are aware of the purpose — also receive no legal protection. If one spouse takes out a loan in their own name for illegal acts and later tries to classify it as a joint marital debt, courts won't approve this claim. Without a formal court trial, the non-borrowing spouse can't be forced to bear any civil liability related to the debt (applies nationwide since 2017).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because the notice is an internal court directive with no quantifiable data, and proving creditor awareness requires separate evidence. Issued under the previous Marriage Law, its application under the Civil Code for determining joint marital debts is covered in Section 10, Article 12 (large loans taken by a spouse). Even if creditors have no knowledge of the funds being used for gambling, the borrower alone remains responsible for repayment. To prove the money was used for gambling, you'll need bank transfer records, gambling platform logs, or police case files — keep these documents on hand. If a lawsuit is filed, standard first-instance proceedings take at least 6 months, while simplified procedures require 3 months. Each party pays their own legal fees, with no obligation for the losing side to cover the other's costs. For creditors harassing or detaining you, refer to Section 9, Article 15 (debt collection rules) and call the police immediately. If the borrower is in such a desperate state they're considering suicide, contact the crisis hotline at 12356 as noted in Section 1, Article 37 (gambling-related distress). The main beneficiaries of these protections are spouses and immediate family members.

## 45. Don't agree when an acquaintance asks you to “help by doing a facial scan or acting as a witness” to secure a loan, or to read out a verification code — this is known as “AB loan” fraud. In this scheme, you are the borrower, not a guarantor

**Cost**. There's no direct monetary cost. The real difficulty lies in politely refusing relatives or friends on the spot. Even if they insist “it's just a formality” or “you won't bear any responsibility,” you must still decline. Never hand over your phone, ID card, or bank card to intermediaries, nor follow their instructions to perform facial scans or sign documents. Keep verification codes strictly for your own use — never read them out to acquaintances.

**In plain terms**. What seems like a simple favor — “just doing a facial scan or acting as a witness” — actually means using your name to borrow money from a bank. You become the legal borrower, not a guarantor. Once the funds are transferred to your acquaintance, the bank still holds you responsible for repayment. Scammers deceive you into signing contracts under false pretenses; without the bank's knowledge, you can't easily void those agreements. Even a written promise from your friend stating “I'll repay the loan” carries no legal weight against the bank.

**Benefit**. In 2022, the Fujian Regulatory Bureau of the China Banking and Insurance Regulatory Commission issued a warning about this exact scheme. Client A lacked sufficient creditworthiness to qualify for a loan, so an intermediary suggested involving Client B — who had better financial standing — as a guarantor. In reality, the intermediary used B's personal information to apply for the loan, which was then disbursed to A. Official documents stated that “Client B was effectively the borrower,” yet B remained unaware until receiving collection notices from the bank. A 2024 advisory from Shandong's regulatory authority revealed that intermediaries often assure potential borrowers like B that “they bear no responsibility whatsoever.” They even coach B on how to respond to bank pre-loan inquiries, ultimately securing the loan in B's name. In a 2024 case adjudicated by Shanghai's Putuo District Court, a loan officer used B's phone to download a banking app and apply for credit in her name. After funds reached B's account, she transferred them to A, who subsequently paid over 80,000 yuan in processing fees. Eight members of the scam ring were convicted of contract fraud, receiving sentences ranging from 10 months to 4 years. Yet this conviction does not absolve B of her debt obligations. Article 149 of the Civil Code stipulates that a contract may only be rescinded if the other party “knew or should have known” of the fraud — which does not apply here, as banks remain unaware of such schemes. Under Article 152, rescission requests must be filed within one year of discovering the deception. Borrowers remain bound by repayment terms per Article 675, and contracts legally bind only signatories (Article 465). Transferring debt obligations to another party requires explicit bank consent (Article 551). Consequently, any written assurances from A hold no sway over the bank. Victims must pursue legal action against A to recover funds. Courts routinely hold individuals liable even when they blindly comply with instructions: in a 2025 case from Neijiang, an elderly woman named Jiang agreed to co-sign a loan application for another individual, Jiang, after being misled into believing she was merely a witness. Though she performed a facial scan without reviewing terms, courts ruled she “should have foreseen the legal implications,” ordering joint repayment of over 60,000 yuan in outstanding principal. The Electronic Signature Law affirms that “reliable electronic signatures hold equal legal weight to handwritten signatures or seals.” Meanwhile, anti-fraud legislation explicitly prohibits anyone from “providing real-name verification assistance,” imposing fines or detention for violations. Standard first-instance trials conclude within six months, with extensions permitted. Legal fees are not covered by statutory court costs and must be borne personally.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Primarily, you stand to benefit from avoiding this trap — the person approaching you, labeled “A,” is often a family member or close friend. A prosecutor from Shanghai's Pudong District observed that individuals like “B” frequently comply despite recognizing they're acting as borrowers, ultimately becoming targets of bank collection efforts. If genuinely wishing to assist, first clarify your legal role in any contract; if it's a loan agreement, abstain from signing. Those willing to guarantee another's obligations should execute a separate guarantee contract as stipulated in Section 18 (“Acting as a Guarantor”). Should you inadvertently

become a borrower, immediately file a police report, then contact your bank via official channels to explain the situation, preserving all communication and transaction records. To monitor personal debt levels, consult your credit report per Section 9 (“Checking Your Credit Report”). During bank pre-loan interviews, avoid reciting scripted responses provided by intermediaries — providing false information may incur personal liability, as detailed in Section 9.6 (“Loan Packaging Schemes”). Note that facial scans and electronic confirmations legally equate to handwritten signatures (Section 17: “Read Documents Before Signing”). Courts do not uniformly enforce repayment duties: in a 2021 ruling, Guangzhou Internet Court dismissed a bank's claim against a woman whose ID had been stolen; lacking proof of her voluntary facial scan, the bank lost its case. Thus, promptly reporting stolen IDs and retaining police receipts is crucial. When institutions demand facial scans, you may request alternative verification methods — a separate matter addressed in Section 14.9 (“Facial Scans Are Not Mandatory”). Similar schemes involving unauthorized use of personal identities appear in Section 28 (“Nominal Legal Representatives”). Finally, never lend your phone or bank accounts, as emphasized in Section 8 (“Never Lend Your Bank Card”). This section includes illustrative cases and regulatory warnings but lacks aggregated statistics on fraud incidence rates or financial losses.

## 46. Install proper locks on doors and windows and an outdoor motion-sensor light; always actually lock them: these steps help prevent burglary, but a single alarm alone won't do much

**Cost**. Replacing a door lock with one that requires a key to re-lock, adding window locks, and installing a motion-sensor light outside generally costs from a few dozen to a few hundred yuan. A whole new security door can run into thousands of yuan. The real challenge is remembering to actually lock everything each time you leave — even in summer when windows stay open.

**In plain terms**. British data shows that homes with both door and window locks have only about one-twelfth the burglary rate of homes with no such measures. Adding an outdoor motion-sensor light further reduces that risk to roughly one-thirtieth. Installing just an alarm, without any other measures, provides little to no protection. These steps guard against theft, not against a robbery when someone is already inside the house.

**Benefit**. A crime survey in England and Wales asked 37,416 households between 2008 and 2012 which security measures they had installed, then compared those figures with actual burglary rates. Households with nothing installed made up just 4.9 % of all respondents yet accounted for 36.6 % of burglary victims. The researchers calculated a “protection factor” — how many times lower the burglary risk becomes compared to homes with no measures at all. Door and window locks together give a protection factor of 12.54, cutting the risk to roughly one-twelfth. Here “door locks” refers to double-bolted locks or deadbolts that need a key to retract. Adding an outdoor motion-sensor or timer-controlled light raises that factor to 34.41; adding indoor timer lights pushes it to 49. A single motion-sensor light offers only about a 3-fold benefit, while a door lock alone gives roughly a 2.8-fold improvement. Window locks alone show no measurable effect. Installing all five measures does not yield a noticeably greater benefit than using the three most effective ones. Conversely, homes that install only an alarm actually experience a higher burglary rate than those with no measures at all; even fake alarm boxes seem to increase the chance of an attempted break-in. The key is actually locking everything: from 1993 to 2006/07, forced-entry burglaries — where thieves pried locks, broke windows or kicked in doors — fell from 31 to 7 per 1,000 households, a 77 % drop. In contrast, burglaries where the door or window was left unlocked and the intruder simply walked in stayed at 7 per 1,000 households throughout the same period (England and Wales).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. There is some debate regarding alarms: the same authors previously found, using data from 1992-1996, that alarms did lower burglary risk. They caution that this contradictory finding may reflect selection bias — perhaps only households that had already been burglarized later installed alarms. All figures pertain to the UK and compare households with and without certain measures; no randomized controlled trials were conducted, which is why the evidence grade is B. These statistics apply solely to burglary, not to home invasions or robberies. If a stranger does enter while you are inside, retreat to a safe area and call the

police (see point 10). Should escape be impossible, you may use reasonable force to protect yourself (see point 11). Tenants should obtain landlord permission before changing locks or adding window locks; under civil law the landlord may demand restoration to the original state or compensation. When buying a security door, look for compliance with the mandatory national standard GB 17565-2022, effective from 1 January 2024; the primary beneficiaries are you and your family.

# 9. Legal red lines ordinary people often cross

This section runs two ledgers: your personal liberty, and your money. The acts below are ones ordinary people often treat as “no big deal,” yet they can bring detention, fines, and in serious cases prison. Each item gives the concrete figures in the statutes, plus cases published through official channels. The Public Security Administration Punishment Law cited here is the 2025 revision, in force from 1 January 2026; article numbers differ from the old law. The Criminal Law citations follow a consolidated text carried by the Beijing Public Security Traffic Management Bureau, marked as amended under Amendment (XI); the body notes the matching amendment where needed.

Items in this section are grouped by theme below, with item numbers in parentheses.

**Posting and forwarding online**: Do not forward unverified disaster, epidemic, or police news (item 1), do not forward content that insults heroes and martyrs (item 2), close foreign-site material after viewing (item 3), do not send pornographic videos into groups (item 4).

**Helping others take money, loan fraud, and insurance fraud**: Part-time work that uses your card to receive money (item 5), packaging materials to cheat loans (item 6), do not withdraw from a found bank card (item 7), claim discounts under your real identity (item 8), do not lend your ID card (item 16), fabricating accidents to cheat claims (item 21).

**Small everyday matters**: Do not throw anything from balconies or windows (item 9), do not buy imitation guns online (item 10), register drones under a real name first (item 11), card games without a rake or organizing for pay (item 13), do not eat wild game (item 14), never electrofish at any time (item 27), do not light fires in forest or grassland when visiting graves or cooking outdoors (item 28).

**Conflicts and the police**: Do not detain people to collect debts (item 15), cooperate when police stop you (item 17), count the cost before hitting someone (item 19), do not carry telescopic batons or stun devices for self-defense (item 26).

**Sex, children, and the body**: Do not secretly film others (item 12), no sexual relations with anyone under 14 (item 18), if you cannot raise a child use civil-affairs registration (item 20), do not sell your own organs (item 22), do not assume solicitation ends in a fine alone—default is detention (item 23).

**Copyright and derivative works**: Fan translation, reposting, and pirated e-books (item 24), get permission before selling fan works for money (item 25).

**Exams**: Do not take a test for someone else, hire a proxy, or buy or sell answers (item 29).

## 1. Do not share unverified messages about disasters, epidemics, or police incidents in groups; do not photoshop images or use AI to generate fake scene pictures

**Cost**. No cost involved. Simply check whether the message is an official announcement before sharing. If you're unsure, don't share it, and avoid editing images or adding phrases like “allegedly.” The real challenge is resisting the urge to be the first person to spread the news.

**In plain terms**. A message about a disaster, epidemic, or police incident that you know is false and still forward is punished as heavily as if you invented it. Even if you did not invent it, the same applies: detention for 5 to 10 days, and a further fine of up to 1000 yuan. If you seriously disrupt social order, the sentence is up to 3 years; if serious consequences follow, 3 to 7 years. Photoshopped or AI-made fake scene pictures all count as inventing it yourself.

**Benefit**. Those who deliberately spread rumors or make false reports about disasters, epidemics, or police incidents to disrupt public order can be detained for 5 to 10 days and fined up to 1,000 yuan. For less serious cases, the penalty is detention for under 5 days or a fine under 1,000 yuan. Creating and posting fake reports about such incidents online also carries a maximum 3-year prison term, even if you know the content is

untrue. This applies only when the actions cause significant disruption to social order, as defined by law. If serious consequences arise, the sentence rises to 3 to 7 years nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Sharing known false content carries the same legal penalties as creating it yourself; claiming “I just shared it” offers no exemption. Photoshopped images and AI-generated fake scene pictures are also considered self-created content. In 2025, China's Ministry of Public Security released multiple batches of typical cases involving online rumors about disasters and emergencies. At the time of writing, the ministry's website was inaccessible, so no specific examples were cited.

## 2. Do not post or forward images, stickers, or comments that insult heroes and martyrs, and do not joke about the national flag or anthem

**Cost**. No money. For content about heroes and martyrs, the national flag, emblem, or anthem: do not comment, edit images, or forward. The hard part is biting back a reply when someone in the group picks up the joke.

**In plain terms**. Joking about heroes and martyrs, the flag, or the anthem can mean detention for 5 to 10 days, or a fine of 1000 to 3000 yuan. More serious cases bring detention for 10 to 15 days. If it is a crime, the sentence is up to 3 years. Someone posted 2 messages defaming Yuan Longping in a villagers' WeChat group of 499 people and got 6 months of public surveillance — not locked up, but movement restricted.

**Benefit**. Insulting or fabricating facts to harm a hero or martyr's name, likeness, reputation, or honor in a way that damages the public interest is punished as follows. Detention for 5 to 10 days, or a fine of 1000 to 3000 yuan. Desecrating or denying their deeds and spirit, or making and spreading speech, images, or audiovisual material that glorifies wars of aggression and disrupts public order, falls in the same band. The heavier band is detention for 10 to 15 days, with a further fine of up to 5000 yuan. At “serious circumstances” it becomes a crime, punishable by up to 3 years. Publicly insulting the national flag or emblem, or altering the anthem's words or music or singing it in a distorted, demeaning way, when circumstances are serious, also brings up to 3 years. Official case: Xiao posted 2 messages insulting Yuan Longping in a 499-person villagers' WeChat group and was sentenced to 6 months of public surveillance. Public surveillance is a penalty that does not send you to prison but restricts your movement. Qiu used a Weibo account with over 2500000 (250 余万) followers to post 2 items distorting the deeds of border-defense soldiers, was sentenced to 8 months, and had to apologize publicly in national media (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This article of the Public Security Administration Punishment Law was added only in the 2025 revision. Before that, such cases had to go through the Criminal Law or civil public-interest litigation by the procuratorate. A WeChat group of several hundred people counts as a public setting in the courts' eyes.

## 3. After viewing material on foreign websites, close the page — do not screenshot, forward, move it into groups, or chime in in the comments

**Cost**. No money. Closing the page ends it. Do not archive, forward, or move it onto domestic platforms. Do not use an account tied to your identity to post political content on foreign platforms over a long period. Do not take manuscript fees or funding from foreign institutions, organizations, or individuals. The hard part is not screenshotting or sharing when something jumps out at you.

**In plain terms**. These statutes punish spreading outward, not looking. Forwarding, moving into a group, or chiming in in the comments all count as dissemination when a case is built. If it reaches inciting subversion or secession, the sentence is up to 5 years; ringleaders get 5 years or more. Books and audiovisual material on terrorism or extremism are the exception: knowingly keeping them, when circumstances are serious, brings up to 3 years.

**Benefit**. Using rumor, defamation, or other means to incite others to subvert state power or overthrow the socialist system brings up to 5 years. Ringleaders (the statute's term) or those whose crimes are major get 5

years or more; fixed-term imprisonment tops out at 15 years. Inciting secession or undermining national unity carries the same terms. Doing either in collusion with foreign institutions, organizations, or individuals is punished more heavily. Institutions, organizations, or individuals at home or abroad who fund others to do so: those directly responsible get up to 5 years; when circumstances are serious, 5 years or more. Stealing, spying out, buying, or illegally providing state secrets or intelligence for foreign institutions, organizations, or persons brings 5 to 10 years. Within that item, especially serious circumstances bring 10 years or more or life imprisonment; lighter circumstances bring up to 5 years. Crimes endangering national security always add deprivation of political rights for 1 to 5 years, during which voting rights and eligibility for public office are cancelled. Confiscation of property may also be imposed, taking personal property for the state. Administrative rules also apply. No individual or organization may use the network to engage in activities that endanger national security, honor, or interests. Nor may they incite subversion of state power or overthrow of the socialist system. Nor may they incite secession or undermine national unity. Publishing or transmitting such information is punished under the relevant laws and administrative regulations (nationwide). Another class does not need dissemination to be complete. Knowingly and illegally holding material that promotes terrorism or extremism, when circumstances are serious, is enough for a conviction. That material includes books, audio-video materials, or other items. The term is up to 3 years of fixed-term imprisonment, criminal detention (short custody), or public surveillance (not locked up but movement restricted). A fine is imposed together with or instead of imprisonment — sentenced and fined, or only fined. The basis is Criminal Law Article 120-6, added by Amendment IX.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The laws cited here punish inciting others, spreading outward, and providing to others; mere viewing is not among them. Material on terrorism or extremism is the statute's stated exception: merely keeping it can convict (Article 120-6). So that class must never be archived. Once you have seen it, stop there: no screenshot archive, no forward, no comment, no pulling others to forward. Forwarding and chiming in in comments both count as dissemination when a case is built; “I only forwarded it” does not excuse you. Doing it in collusion with foreign institutions, organizations, or individuals is punished more heavily. When you are unsure whether something is true, still more reason not to join the forward — see item 1 in this section (do not forward unverified messages). How tools for bypassing the firewall are punished is in Section 11, item 11. Spreading this kind of content brings no real benefit and costs prison time, deprivation of political rights, and confiscation of property. This book has not obtained judgment documents checkable through official channels, so it follows the statutes only and attaches no cases.

## 4. Watching pornographic videos alone is your own business — do not send them into groups, sell “resources,” or create groups for them

**Cost**. No money. Do not forward, do not save into group files, and do not become the owner or admin of such a group.

**In plain terms**. Watching alone is not in the punishment clauses. Sending into a group is online dissemination; the text does not require a minimum number of sends. Detention is 10 to 15 days, with a further fine of up to 5000 yuan; when circumstances are serious, up to 2 years. Selling “resources” for money brings up to 3 years, and at the top end life imprisonment. Building a dissemination group of 30 or more people: the founder, admins, and main posters are all treated as committing a crime.

**Benefit**. Disseminating obscene information online brings detention for 10 to 15 days, with a further fine of up to 5000 yuan. This article does not say how many times you must send. In the same law, the item that punishes harassing others with messages expressly requires “repeated sending.” The lighter band is detention for under 5 days, or a fine of 1000 to 3000 yuan. Content involving minors is punished more heavily. Disseminating obscene articles at the “serious circumstances” level brings up to 2 years. Selling or disseminating for profit brings up to 3 years plus a fine. Within that item, serious circumstances bring 3 to 10 years; especially serious, 10 years or more or life imprisonment. Building a group mainly to disseminate obscene electronic information, with 30 or more members, is handled as a crime. Causing serious

consequences is the same. The founder, admins, and main posters are all convicted of disseminating obscene articles (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Both laws punish “dissemination”; private viewing alone is not in the clauses. Sending into a group is online dissemination. The text does not state a count, so one send is still in the clause — that is inferred from the wording. How many items make “serious circumstances” is set by judicial interpretation; this section has not verified a concrete figure.

## 5. “Part-time work” that asks you to use your own card to receive money, withdraw cash, or transfer — do not do it no matter how large the tip

**Cost**. No money. Give up gigs of the “a few hundred a day, take your card to the bank” kind.

**In plain terms**. These jobs earn a few hundred yuan; the price is a record. Someone took an ID card and 1 bank card to a designated place, helped with transfers and withdrawals, and earned a little over 500 yuan. Prosecutors did not charge him; police still detained him for 10 days and fined 1000 yuan. Another handed his and others' bank cards and phone cards to a gang for collecting and cashing out, got 2 years 3 months, and was fined 22000 yuan (2.2 万).

**Benefit**. Knowingly helping to transfer, buy, sell, or otherwise conceal money or property from crime brings up to 3 years, with a fine imposed together with or instead of imprisonment (sentenced and fined, or only fined). Official case: Wang followed instructions, brought an ID card and 1 bank card to a designated place, helped with transfers and withdrawals, and earned a little over 500 yuan. Prosecutors did not charge him; police detained him for 10 days under the Anti-Telecom and Online Fraud Law and fined 1000 yuan. Man handed his and others' bank cards and phone cards to a gang for collecting, transferring, and cashing out, was sentenced to 2 years 3 months, and fined 22000 yuan (2.2 万) (nationwide). Moving it out as crypto is the same. An and two others, on a fraud gang's instructions, took money on their own bank cards. On a trading platform they bought virtual currency with the money and transferred it to accounts the other side named, taking a cut by ratio. More than 500000 yuan (50 余万) of victims' cheated funds was verified among it. The three were each sentenced for concealing criminal proceeds to between 2 years 8 months and 3 years 3 months, and each fined 30000 to 40000 yuan (3 万 to 4 万) (Beijing Tongzhou)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Consequences of lending a bank card or “running points” for others are in Section 8, item 8 (lending a bank card). This item is about doing the withdrawals and transfers yourself. Taking the money, swapping it into USDT-type crypto, and sending it out is the same act. Why you cannot get money back after losing it buying crypto is in Section 5, item 45 (do not buy virtual currency). “I did not know where the money came from” is not always accepted when a case is built. When commenting on Man's case, the Supreme People's Court and Supreme People's Procuratorate wrote that courts look at the information you touched, how money was converted and moved, and whether trades and accounts looked abnormal, then weigh your background and your link to the upstream party to decide whether you knew. In the case above that was not prosecuted, the person was still detained for 10 days.

## 6. Some people try to get you to “package loan applicants” for them and offer a commission based on the loan amount — don't fall for it

**Cost**. There's no cost at all. Just say no. Never lend your ID card or credit report to anyone, sign any loan contracts you haven't read, or go to the bank to sign on someone else's behalf.

**In plain terms**. Helping others “package materials” for a loan and taking a cut is treated as fraud. A 126-person gang dressed unemployed people as “prime customers” and cheated more than 30000000 yuan (3000 多万) in loans across over 80 bank outlets. Those who signed in person took a 30% kickback on the loan amount; of the 80 already sentenced, 76 got from 1 year 4 months to 6 years 6 months. Whoever's name the loan is under owns the debt.

**Benefit**. Committing fraud to obtain loans, acceptance letters, letters of credit, or guarantees from banks or other financial institutions is a serious crime. If such actions cause substantial financial harm, offenders face up to 3 years in prison plus a fine; if the damage is especially severe, sentences range from 3 to 7 years, also with fines. The threshold for police investigation is a direct financial loss exceeding 500,000 yuan. Those who fabricate investment projects, fake contracts, or forged documents to secure loans commit loan fraud — this crime is punishable by up to 5 years in prison and fines ranging from 20,000 to 200,000 yuan if the amount obtained is 50,000 yuan or more. Larger sums or more serious circumstances lead to sentences from 5 to 10 years, or even life imprisonment. Forging, altering, or selling official government documents or seals carries penalties of up to 3 years; more serious cases result in 3–10 years in prison. A notable case involved 126 criminals who created fake “prime customers” in 16 provinces and tricked over 80 banks out of more than 30 million yuan; 105 “front” applicants were prosecuted. In 2026, 76 of them received sentences of 1 year and 4 months to 6 years and 6 months for loan fraud, while four others were additionally convicted of money laundering and received sentences from 2 years and 4 months to 7 years and 6 months. Under the 2021 amendment to the Criminal Law, anyone who signs a loan contract becomes legally liable for repayment — even if they never intended to pay, the debt and negative credit record remain theirs. Attempts to flee abroad won't help; fugitives can still be extradited years later. Those serving sentences, under investigation, or involved in civil disputes may be barred from leaving the country. For details on how to spot unauthorized loans taken out in your name, see Section 8, Item 9.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. In one case, the defense argument “I intended to repay the loan” was rejected. Prosecutors proved that the defendants had no jobs or assets, had already spent their commission, and thus had no real intention of repayment. Those who withdraw funds on behalf of the gang may also be charged with money laundering. For information on using personal bank accounts for “side jobs” or receiving money on someone else's behalf, see Section 5; for how to detect fraudulent loans taken out in your name, see Section 8, Item 9.

## 7. Do not withdraw from a found bank card; for a found phone or wallet, contact the owner or hand it to police — do not pocket it

**Cost**. No money; a few minutes. Call to find the owner, or take the item to a police station.

**In plain terms**. Keeping found property for yourself, when the amount reaches “relatively large” and you refuse to hand it over, brings up to 2 years; when the amount is huge, 2 to 5 years. Taking a found bank card to an ATM is heavier: it counts as fraudulently using another's credit card; a relatively large amount brings up to 5 years plus a fine of 20000 to 200000 yuan (2 万 to 20 万). For withdrawals, police file the case directly; the owner need not sue first.

**Benefit**. Found property should be returned to the owner: notify them promptly to collect it, or deliver it to public security or another department. Keeping someone else's left property for yourself, when the amount reaches “relatively large” and you refuse to hand it over, is the crime of embezzlement, punishable by up to 2 years. When the amount is huge, 2 to 5 years. Taking someone else's found credit card to an ATM counts as “fraudulently using another's credit card.” “Credit card” in the Criminal Law, per the NPC Standing Committee's 2004 interpretation, means electronic payment cards issued by banks and other financial institutions. Having all or some of the functions of consumer payment, credit lending, transfer and settlement, and depositing and withdrawing cash is enough. So ordinary bank cards that can deposit and withdraw cash are included. When it reaches a crime, it is handled as credit-card fraud: a relatively large amount brings up to 5 years plus a fine of 20000 to 200000 yuan (2 万 to 20 万). A huge amount or other serious circumstances bring 5 to 10 years plus a fine of 50000 to 500000 yuan (5 万 to 50 万) (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Embezzlement is handled only upon complaint — the owner must sue in court; police do not take it up on their own. Withdrawing with a found card is different: the owner need not sue; police file directly. The concrete figure for “relatively large” is set by judicial interpretation; this section has not verified it. After an

item is delivered to the relevant department, the owner pays storage costs when collecting it (Civil Code Article 317).

## 8. Claim discounts under your own real identity — do not buy virtual numbers to mass-register sockpuppets, and do not exploit loopholes for repeat claims

**Cost**. No money. Give up work from “coupon task groups.” If you find a platform loophole, leave it alone. The hard part is not treating discounts as income you can scale by copying.

**In plain terms**. Claiming a coupon once under your real identity and one account is outside punishment. Mass-registering fake users or placing and accepting your own orders to claim more is treated as fraud. Reaching each province's threshold (3000 to 10000 yuan) brings up to 3 years; at 30000 to 100000 yuan (3 万 to 10 万), 3 to 10 years. Couriers used virtual numbers at 0.1 yuan each to farm coupons and cashed out over 90000 yuan (9 万余); 12 people in the same case were sentenced.

**Benefit**. Defrauding others or public property of a relatively large amount brings up to 3 years, with a fine imposed together with or instead of imprisonment (sentenced and fined, or only fined). A huge amount or other serious circumstances bring 3 to 10 years plus a fine. An especially huge amount or other especially serious circumstances bring 10 years or more or life imprisonment, plus a fine or confiscation of property. The three bands — relatively large, huge, and especially huge — are set by each province within these ranges. Relatively large is 3000 yuan to 10000 yuan or more. Huge is 30000 yuan to 100000 yuan (3 万 to 10 万) or more; especially huge is 500000 yuan (50 万) or more. Teaching methods to others or selling “tutorials” is sentenced as imparting criminal methods, up to 5 years; serious circumstances, 5 to 10 years; especially serious, 10 years or more or life imprisonment. Upstream and downstream traders in phone numbers and verification codes are sentenced for infringing citizens' personal information, up to 3 years; especially serious, 3 to 7 years. Mass accounts, systems that auto-switch network addresses, and platforms that bulk-receive SMS codes are themselves expressly banned by Article 14 of the Anti-Telecom and Online Fraud Law. Illegal buying, selling, renting, or lending of phone cards and internet accounts, and helping others pass real-name checks, fall under Article 31. Violating Article 14: all earnings are confiscated, then a fine of 1 to 10 times earnings. If there were no earnings, or earnings under 50000 yuan (5 万), a fine of up to 500000 yuan (50 万); when circumstances are serious, detention for up to 15 days as well. Violating Article 31: the fine is likewise 1 to 10 times; if no earnings or earnings under 20000 yuan (2 万), a fine of up to 200000 yuan (20 万); when circumstances are serious, detention for up to 15 days as well. Taking part in telecom and online fraud short of a criminal sentence: detention for 10 to 15 days. Earnings are confiscated, then a fine of 1 to 10 times. If no earnings or earnings under 10000 yuan (1 万), a fine of up to 100000 yuan (10 万). Official case 1: Delivery rider Liu bought virtual phone numbers at 0.1 yuan each and registered as a new user on a platform. He claimed new-user coupons of 29 minus 15, placed orders, and resold goods to small shops for cash. He also used virtual numbers to invite each other and claim rewards of 2 to 20 yuan. He and rider Tan respectively obtained over 90000 yuan (9 万余) and over 70000 yuan (7 万余). The Shanghai Yangpu procuratorate charged 12 people with fraud; courts sentenced from 3 years 6 months down to 3 months of criminal detention. Official case 2: Wang exploited the timing gap between shop refunds and reclaiming virtual lottery coins. He refunded 1156 times, withdrew 224 figure items, amounting to over 249000 yuan (24.9 万余). He also cashed out on a second-hand platform; the court sentenced him for fraud to 3 years suspended for 4 years, plus a fine of 30000 yuan (3 万). During the proceedings he returned the proceeds and prepaid the fine, totaling 330000 yuan (33 万). Official case 3: A ride-hailing platform's new-user coupons and driver subsidies were taken by fake trips of “ordering and accepting your own rides,” spanning over 70 cities in 19 provinces, for over 2000000 yuan (200 余万). The Chaoyang Longcheng procuratorate in Liaoning charged 163 people; all were convicted. Principals Huang and Cai were sentenced for fraud, infringing citizens' personal information, and imparting criminal methods together (sentences for several crimes reckoned jointly) to 3 years 6 months each. Another 34 minor accessories were not prosecuted but still referred to police for administrative punishment (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The line is not “how much you farmed” but whether you fabricated. Joining a promotion under your real identity, claiming once per account, and using the coupon on yourself is a discount the platform gave you. Registering fake users, fabricating trades, or hiding that you already refunded so the other side hands things over under a false belief is treated as fraud. Amount only decides how long the sentence is. EV makers' charging services have been farmed the same way. In August 2026, Kankan News reported two people in Shanghai buying large numbers of virtual phone numbers and binding them in turn as sub-accounts on an EV maker's app. Each number used “charge first, pay later” twice then unbound; no one paid the power bill, and charging opportunities were resold to truck drivers. The Pudong New Area procuratorate treated it as fraud, not theft, and approved arrest. That case has only media reporting, no judgment or official bulletin. Short of a criminal sentence there are still consequences: platforms can ban accounts, claw back discounts, and demand return of money you should not have had. Taking part in telecom fraud short of a crime still has a detention-and-fine band. “Someone in the group leads and pays me per order” does not change the nature of your own share. Teaching methods to others, or trafficking accounts and phone numbers, are separate crimes that are reckoned together. The beneficiary is you. Writing or selling scripts is in Section 11, item 3; selling cards or accounts is in Section 8, item 8 (lending a bank card) and item 16 of this section (do not lend your ID).

## 9. Do not throw anything from balconies or windows — cigarette butts, trash bags, and bottles all count

**Cost**. No money and no real time. Take cigarette butts, trash bags, and bottles to an indoor bin; do not toss them from windows or balconies.

**In plain terms**. Throwing things downstairs can bring detention for under 5 days or a fine of up to 1000 yuan even if no one is hit; when circumstances are serious, detention for 10 to 15 days. Hitting someone changes the charge: someone on the 21st floor, drunk, threw empty bottles and glass cups onto a playground below, seriously injured a 13-year-old student, and got 10 years. Someone else threw 8 bricks from the 32nd floor and killed 1 person; in 2024 the death sentence was approved.

**Benefit**. Throwing objects down from upstairs or another height, whenever there is a risk of injuring people, damaging property, or endangering public safety, can bring detention for under 5 days or a fine of up to 1000 yuan. When circumstances are serious, detention for 10 to 15 days, with a further fine of up to 1000 yuan. When circumstances are serious enough for the crime of throwing objects from a height, up to 1 year, with a fine imposed together with or instead of imprisonment (sentenced and fined, or only fined). Injuring or killing someone is handled under heavier charges. Official case: Li, drunk on the 21st floor, threw empty bottles and glass cups onto a playground below, seriously injured a 13-year-old student at level 2 serious injury, and was sentenced to 10 years for endangering public safety by dangerous means. Zhou threw 8 bricks from the 32nd floor into a crowd and killed 1 person; in 2024 the Supreme People's Court approved the death sentence (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Detention can apply even if no one is hit; the text only requires “danger.” The Civil Code has a separate civil-compensation rule for objects thrown from a height (Article 1254). At the time of writing the original text could not be opened, so it is not cited.

## 10. Do not buy imitation guns, BB guns, or air guns online, and do not buy “toy guns” of unclear origin

**Cost**. No money. If you want to shoot, go to a licensed range.

**In plain terms**. BB guns and air guns bought online, once muzzle specific energy reaches 1.8 joules per square centimeter, are treated as firearms. Holding them without a permit brings up to 3 years; when circumstances are serious, 3 to 7 years. A couple sold “toy guns”; of 43 pieces, 18 were appraised as firearms, and they were not charged only because knowledge could not be proved.

**Benefit**. Possessing or privately hiding firearms without a permit brings up to 3 years; when circumstances are serious, 3 to 7 years. Non-standard guns that cannot fire service ammunition are still classified as firearms whenever muzzle specific energy is at or above 1.8 joules per square centimeter. Muzzle specific energy is the energy per square centimeter the projectile carries as it leaves the barrel. Many BB guns and air guns bought online exceed that figure. Since 2018 the Supreme People's Court and Supreme People's Procuratorate have required that for air guns with relatively low specific energy, conviction be decided only after a combined assessment of appearance, material, price, use, whether the person knew, and so on. Official case: Zhao and spouse sold “toy guns” at a market; 43 were seized, of which 18 met firearm standards on appraisal. Because there was not enough evidence they knew the items were firearms, charges were dropped for doubt (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The key to not charging in that case was finding they “did not know.” An adult who deliberately buys a BB gun or air gun online will find it hard afterward to claim they did not know it was a gun. Penalties for carrying crossbows and controlled knives are in item 26 of this section (do not buy telescopic batons, stun devices, or daggers for self-defense).

## 11. Register drones with your real name first; never fly near airports, military zones, or restricted urban airspace, and don't tamper with altitude limits

**Cost**. Registering your drone is free and takes just a few minutes. Before every flight, check via official channels to confirm whether the area you plan to fly in is a restricted zone.

**In plain terms**. Flying a drone without proper registration can result in a fine of up to 200 yuan; repeat or serious violations may incur fines ranging from 2,000 to 20,000 yuan. Flying in restricted airspace without authorization carries a maximum fine of 500 yuan; in severe cases, the drone is confiscated and additional fines of 1,000–10,000 yuan apply. Serious violations may also lead to detention for 5–10 days. One individual paid to remove altitude restrictions on his drone, flew it to nearly 3,000 meters to capture cloud images, and posted the footage online; he was subsequently detained for 5 days.

**Benefit**. Operators who fly without registration may be ordered to correct the issue and face fines up to 200 yuan; repeat or serious violations can lead to fines of 2,000–20,000 yuan. Flying micro, light, or small drones in restricted airspace without approval results in an order to cease flight and a fine of up to 500 yuan; in severe cases, the drone is confiscated and fines of 1,000–10,000 yuan apply. Serious violations involving unauthorized flight in restricted zones may also result in detention for 5–10 days. Official examples include: Mr. Li paid to bypass altitude limits, flew his drone to nearly 3,000 meters to photograph clouds and posted the footage online; he was detained for 5 days. Mr. Zhang helped others bypass altitude and no-fly zone restrictions on over 20 drones, earning more than 15,000 yuan; he was convicted of providing programs or tools used to illegally access or control computer systems, sentenced to 6 months in prison with a 1-year probation period, and fined (nationwide, effective January 2024).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Micro and light drones may be flown in permitted airspace without prior approval. A micro drone is defined as one weighing less than 0.25 kilograms. Permitted airspace refers to all areas outside of restricted zones; airports, military installations, and government complexes are typically classified as restricted zones. The original Ministry of Public Security page detailing these rules could not be accessed at the time of writing; therefore, information was drawn from a republished page maintained by the Hubei Provincial Public Security Department.

## 12. Do not secretly film others, and do not install cameras in rental rooms, guesthouses, or hotel rooms

**Cost**. No money and no real time. Do not secretly film others, and do not install cameras in rental rooms, guesthouses, or hotel rooms.

**In plain terms**. Secretly filming, peeping, or spreading someone's privacy brings detention for under 5 days or a fine of up to 1000 yuan; when circumstances are heavier, detention for 5 to 10 days. Using dedicated covert-filming gear and causing serious consequences brings up to 2 years. Two people installed gear in rooms at three hotels for remote filming and got 1 year 3 months and 1 year. Rooms others stay in must not be filmed without consent.

**Benefit**. Peeping, secretly filming, eavesdropping, or spreading another's privacy brings detention for under 5 days or a fine of up to 1000 yuan. When circumstances are heavier, detention for 5 to 10 days, with a further fine of up to 1000 yuan. Illegally using dedicated eavesdropping or covert-photography equipment and causing serious consequences brings up to 2 years. Dedicated eavesdropping or covert-photography equipment means devices made for secret listening or filming. Official case: Yan and Yan bought covert-photography gear online, installed it in multiple rooms at three hotels for remote filming, and were sentenced to 1 year 3 months and 1 year. Civil Code Article 1033 adds another layer: except where the law provides otherwise or the person clearly consents, no one may “enter, film, or peep into another's residence, hotel room, or other private space,” nor “film, peep at, eavesdrop on, or publicize another's private activities” (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Once secretly filmed material is sold or disseminated, it is handled separately as producing or trafficking obscene articles for profit and similar crimes; in the same batch of cases some got 10 years. Installing monitoring at home that only covers your own place and that everyone in the household knows about is not banned in the text — that is inferred from the wording. A lens that covers a tenant's or guest's room, or films another's private activities, falls within what the Civil Code forbids.

## 13. Mahjong and poker can be played — no rake, no banker role, no organizing paid games, no online gambling

**Cost**. No expense at all. Small-stakes games among friends are perfectly fine. There's no rake, no banker duty, and no money collected for organizing the game. The hard part is resisting the urge to step in when someone else tries to run the game.

**In plain terms**. Small-stakes card games among relatives and friends are not the law's concern. Providing conditions for a gambling session in order to make money, or taking part with relatively large stakes, brings detention for under 5 days or a fine of up to 1000 yuan. Gathering people to gamble for profit or living off gambling brings up to 3 years; running a casino brings up to 5 years. What counts as “relatively large stakes” is set locally; there is no single national figure.

**Benefit**. Providing facilities or services for gambling in order to make money, or taking part in gambling with relatively large stakes, can lead to up to 5 days in detention or a fine of up to 1,000 yuan. In more serious cases the penalty rises to 10–15 days in detention and a fine of 1,000–5,000 yuan. Organizing gambling sessions for profit or relying on gambling as a livelihood can result in up to 3 years in prison and a fine. Casino operators face up to 5 years in prison and a fine; repeat offenders may be sentenced to 5–10 years (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Because there is no uniform national definition of “relatively large stakes” — each region sets its own limit — this recommendation is rated B only. Taking a cut of the pot or acting as an intermediary for online gambling platforms is often treated as running a casino under the law. The original judicial interpretations cited here have not been independently verified, and no official case examples could be found.

## 14. Do not eat wild game; do not buy, sell, or keep protected animals as pets; do not dig or trade wild orchids, cliff cypress, or yew either

**Cost**. No money. Buy only pets of lawful origin and captive-bred stock. Do not dig wild orchids you see on the mountain; buy orchid and yew pots only as cultivated stock from flower markets and nurseries.

**In plain terms**. Eating nationally key-protected animals means the items are confiscated and a fine of 2 to 20 times their value. Buying, selling, or transporting precious or endangered animals brings up to 5 years; serious cases, 5 to 10 years. Captive-bred pets whose breeding technology is mature and already at scale are generally not treated as a crime when traded; wild-caught ones are not in that class. Most wild orchids on the mountain are protected; someone who dug 3 plants to sell got criminal detention.

**Benefit**. Eating nationally key-protected wild animals, or buying them to eat, means the items are confiscated and a fine of 2 to 20 times their value. Breeding nationally key-protected wild animals without a permit: confiscation plus a fine of 1 to 10 times. Illegally purchasing, transporting, or selling nationally key-protected precious or endangered wild animals and their products brings up to 5 years plus a fine. Within that item, serious circumstances bring 5 to 10 years; especially serious, 10 years or more. Hunting, purchasing, transporting, or selling other terrestrial wild animals in order to eat them, when circumstances are serious, brings up to 3 years. Official case: Farmer Wang and 2 others sold over 40 captive-bred Fischer's lovebirds (national class II protection) for a total under 400 yuan. In 2021 the procuratorate decided not to prosecute. From 2022 the Supreme People's Court and Supreme People's Procuratorate made clear that when captive-breeding technology is mature, already at scale, and the animals are bought, sold, or transported as pets, the matter is generally not handled as a crime (nationwide). Wild plants have a separate offense. Illegally felling or destroying nationally key-protected plants, or purchasing, transporting, processing, or selling those plants and products, all fall under it. Up to 3 years plus a fine; when circumstances are serious, 3 to 7 years. A 2023 Supreme People's Court interpretation set the threshold. One plant of a national class I wild plant, or 2 of class II, or value of 20000 yuan (2 万) or more, is enough to convict. Class I at 5 plants, class II at 10, or value of 200000 yuan (20 万) or more, counts as serious circumstances. Buyers count only if they knew the plants were illegally dug. On the 2021 list, all species of cliff cypress and of the yew genus are class I. All species of the orchid genus Orchis/Cymbidium group listed are class II; Chunlan, Huilan, and Lianbanlan are among them. Within that genus only one species is off the list; two others are class I. Digging and transplanting home is still convicted as illegal felling; sentencing may weigh that it was transplanting. Artificially cultivated plants do not count, except ancient and famous trees. Official case: In Nanzhao, Henan, someone in 2022 dug 3 wild orchid plants on a hillside and posted a video wanting to sell. He got 6 months of criminal detention, suspended for 10 months, and a fine of 3000 yuan. In Suizhou, Hubei, a group dug over 30000 wild Chunlan and Huilan plants over more than two years. In 2025 one of them got 1 year 7 months, suspended for 2 years (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. “Generally not treated as a crime” covers only the captive-bred, kept-as-pet class. Wild-caught or unclear-origin animals do not qualify. What counts as a nationally key-protected animal follows the list. Checking the list before buying is cheaper than explaining afterward. Plants are the same: the rule covers those that grew naturally in the wild. Orchids sold in livestreams as “field-dug” or “mountain-down grass” are wild. Cliff-cypress root carvings, bracelets, and similar products, when knowingly from illegal digging and then traded, fall under the same offense.

## 15. You cannot detain or confine someone to collect a debt, nor follow them home and refuse to leave

**Cost**. There is no cost. If someone owes you money and refuses to pay, you can file a lawsuit in court. For guidance on drafting an IOU, see Section 8, Article 18. The real challenge is resisting the urge to physically restrain or follow the debtor home when they try to evade payment.

**In plain terms**. Even when the money is truly owed to you, you still cannot detain or lock someone up: the statute expressly says doing this to collect a debt is still illegal detention. Short of a criminal sentence,

detention is 10 to 15 days plus a fine of 1000 to 2000 yuan. Illegal detention as a crime brings up to 3 years; causing serious injury, 3 to 10 years; causing death, 10 years or more. To collect a debt, sue in court.

**Benefit**. Illegally restricting another person's freedom, unlawfully entering their home, or conducting unauthorized searches leads to 10–15 days of detention and fines of 1,000–2,000 yuan. Less severe cases incur 5–10 days of detention and fines under 1,000 yuan. Illegal imprisonment is punishable by up to 3 years in prison, short-term detention, restricted movement, or loss of political rights. Severe injury or death brings 3–10 years or 10+ years respectively. These same penalties apply even when debt collection is legitimate (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The statement “They truly owe me money” holds no legal weight here. Laws explicitly classify debt-related detentions as illegal imprisonment. Multiple court rulings on China's judicial portal show individuals detained for up to 1 year while attempting to collect lawful debts. At the time of writing, this portal was inaccessible, so no citations could be included.

## 16. Do not lend your ID card, do not use someone else's ID card, and do not register, open accounts, or buy tickets using another person's documents

**Cost**. No expense involved. If someone asks to borrow it, simply refuse. If a copy is required, clearly note on the copy what specific purpose it is intended for.

**In plain terms**. Lending, renting, or transferring your ID card to someone else brings a warning and a fine of up to 200 yuan. Using someone else's ID, or one obtained by fraud, brings a fine of 200 to 1000 yuan, or detention for up to 10 days. Using a fake document or someone else's papers in real-name settings such as buying train tickets or checking into a hotel, when circumstances are serious, can bring criminal detention or public surveillance.

**Benefit**. Lending, renting, or transferring one's resident ID card to another person results in a warning and a fine of up to 200 yuan. Using someone else's ID card or an ID card obtained fraudulently carries a fine of 200–1,000 yuan or detention for up to 10 days. The same penalties apply to buying, selling, or using forged or altered ID cards. Many situations legally require presentation of identification; using forged, altered, or stolen documents in such cases can lead to criminal sentencing. Such documents include ID cards, passports, social insurance cards, and driver's licenses. Penalties may include detention (short-term imprisonment) or surveillance (restrictions on movement without imprisonment), often combined with a fine; in some cases only a fine is imposed nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Lending your ID card could allow it to be used to register a company or open bank accounts; the consequences of such actions are described in Sections 8.28 and 8.8 (do not serve as a nominal legal representative or lend your bank card to others). Using someone else's ID card to buy train tickets or check into hotels falls under activities requiring valid identification per law. No official case examples were found for this provision. When using internet cafés, always present your own ID; cafés must verify and record ID details, retaining records for at least 60 days for inspection by police and cultural authorities. Any activity performed on a computer using someone else's ID is legally attributed to that person.

## 17. Cooperate when stopped or taken away by police — don't push, hit, or grab their body cameras; especially if you've been drinking, stay calm

**Cost**. No cost at all. Simply refrain from any actions on the spot. If you have complaints, you can raise them later — file a complaint, apply for administrative reconsideration, or even sue in court. The hard part is keeping your temper in check during those few minutes of being stopped, particularly when you're under the influence of alcohol.

**In plain terms**. Simply refusing to comply with police orders can result in a warning or a fine of up to 500 yuan; more serious cases may lead to detention for 5 to 10 days. Using physical force against officers falls into a separate category: biting, slapping, kicking, tackling, or throwing objects that cause even minor injuries is classified as violent assault on police, punishable by up to 3 years in prison. If weapons, controlled knives, or a vehicle are used, the sentence rises to 3 to 7 years. Simple acts like pulling away or resisting lightly do not count as violence.

**Benefit**. Refusing to comply with lawful police orders carries a warning or a fine of up to 500 yuan; repeat or more serious offenses can bring detention for 5 to 10 days plus an additional fine of up to 1,000 yuan. When the officers involved are regular police, penalties become stricter. Committing violent acts against officers performing their duties is punishable by up to 3 years in prison; using weapons, knives, or a vehicle to endanger their safety can lead to 3 to 7 years behind bars. Only actions that result in actual physical harm — such as biting, slapping, kicking, tackling, or throwing objects — qualify as “violent assault.” Merely trying to pull away or resisting lightly does not meet this threshold (applies nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. According to a 2021 report by China's Supreme People's Procuratorate, in the first month after laws specifically criminalizing assaults on police took effect, 405 arrests were approved. In Jiangsu Province, 47.6% of 42 reported cases involved individuals acting out while intoxicated. In Hubei Province, 12 out of 16 cases involved only minor physical contact such as punching, slapping, or biting. Attacking auxiliary police officers is also treated under the crime of obstructing official duties. No official case examples detailing individual circumstances were found for this specific provision.

## 18. If the other person is under 14, you cannot have sexual relations — “she agreed” is not a reason

**Cost**. No money. If the other person's age is uncertain, do not have sexual relations.

**In plain terms**. If the other person is under 14, whether or not they agreed, it is handled as rape with heavier punishment; the baseline term is 3 to 10 years. If they are under 12, you are always found to have “ought to have known.” From 12 to 14, if development, manner, or dress shows they may be a young girl and you still proceed, you are found to have “known.” Claiming you truly did not know is reviewed very strictly by the courts.

**Benefit**. Sexual relations with a young girl under 14 years of age are treated as rape and punished more heavily; the baseline term is 3 to 10 years. The Supreme People's Court's line is this: when violence, coercion, or other force is used, rape is found whether or not you knew the other person was a young girl. Without force, for anyone under 12 it is always found you “ought to have known.” From 12 to 14, if physical development, speech and manner, clothing, and the like show they may be a young girl and you still proceed, you are found to have “known.” The “truly did not know” exception is applied very strictly (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The original text of the two high courts' and two ministries' opinions on handling criminal cases of sexual abuse of minors, and the page of the Supreme People's Court's 2003 reply, could not be opened at the time of writing. So the standard for finding “knowledge” is cited from a reply on the Supreme People's Court judges' site. The statute's term is “young girl.” This item does not distinguish whether the actor is male or female. How parents teach children to prevent sexual abuse is in Section 30, item 19 (knowing the body's private parts).

## 19. Before you hit someone, count this ledger: detention, compensation, and prison

**Cost**. No money and no time. The hard part is those few seconds before you strike.

**In plain terms**. The bill for one strike: detention for 5 to 10 days, plus a fine of 500 to 1000 yuan. Causing minor injury makes it a criminal case, up to 3 years; serious injury, 3 to 10 years. Money is separate: someone

who broke three of the other person's ribs paid 113000 yuan (11.3 万) to settle and was not charged. Another broke the other person's radius, did not pay, and got 10 months.

**Benefit**. Hitting or intentionally injuring someone brings detention for 5 to 10 days plus a fine of 500 to 1000 yuan. Hitting in a group, hitting people with disabilities, pregnant women, the elderly, or children, hitting repeatedly, or hitting several people at once brings detention for 10 to 15 days plus a fine of 1000 to 2000 yuan. Causing minor injury is intentional injury, punishable by up to 3 years of fixed-term imprisonment, criminal detention (short custody), or public surveillance (not locked up but movement restricted). Causing serious injury brings 3 to 10 years. Civilly you also pay medical costs, lost wages (pay missed from work), nursing costs, transport, hospital meal allowance, and nutrition. Disabling someone adds disability compensation. Disability compensation is the prior year's average urban disposable income where the trial court sits, times 20 years. For injured persons aged 60 or more, subtract one year per year of age; at 75 or more, use 5 years. In 2022 procuratorates nationwide accepted over 70000 (7 万余) minor-injury cases, mostly from marriage, family, or neighbor disputes or chance events. Supreme People's Procuratorate typical case: Lu broke three of the other person's ribs (minor injury level 2), paid 113000 yuan (11.3 万) to reach a settlement, and obtained non-prosecution. Shi broke the other person's radius (minor injury level 2), did not pay, and got 10 months of fixed-term imprisonment (nationwide; Public Security Administration Punishment Law in force from 1 January 2026)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. How to avoid conflict, why striking first costs you, and where justifiable defense ends are in Section 8, item 10 (conflict and justifiable defense). The ledger for striking out of spite is in Section 8, items 12 to 14. For fights from civil disputes with lighter circumstances, police may mediate. When minor injury is caused, agreeing compensation with the other side and actually paying can lighten the outcome or even bring non-prosecution, but the money paid cannot be short by a fen. What counts as minor injury is set by appraisal standards; this section has not verified them. Lost wages and nursing costs are reckoned from actual income and days missed; there is no single figure.

## 20. If you cannot raise a child after birth, the only lawful path is civil-affairs registration: taking money to hand the child over may be sentenced as trafficking; leaving them without care is abandonment

**Cost**. No money. Register the adoption at a civil affairs department at county level or above; you must submit materials and wait for review and an adoption assessment, so it takes some time end to end.

**In plain terms**. There is a way out if you cannot raise the child, but the only lawful one is registering the adoption with civil affairs; the adoption relationship exists only from the day of registration. Privately giving the child to someone, especially for money, can turn “placement” into trafficking in children, with a starting sentence of 5 years or more. Leaving the child without care and refusing to support them, when circumstances are egregious, is abandonment, punishable by up to 5 years.

**Benefit**. Criminal Law Article 240: “Whoever traffics in women or children shall be sentenced to fixed-term imprisonment of not less than five years but not more than ten years and shall also be fined.” With aggravating circumstances, fixed-term imprisonment of not less than ten years or life imprisonment, and a fine or confiscation of property. “If the circumstances are especially serious, the offender shall be sentenced to death and also to confiscation of property.” Article 17 of the Opinions on Lawfully Punishing Crimes of Trafficking in Women and Children explains how to distinguish selling one's own child from folk placement. The test is “whether the actor has a purpose of illegal profit” — whether they meant to make money from it. Three situations can be found to be selling one's own child and convicted as trafficking in women or children. First: “using childbirth as a means of illegal profit and selling the child right after birth.” Second: “knowing the other side has no purpose of raising the child, or giving no thought to whether they do, and ‘giving' the child to another in order to take money.” Third: “taking a huge sum that clearly is not a ‘nutrition fee' or ‘thanks fee' and ‘giving' the child to another.” Conversely, privately placing a child under genuine hardship without a profit motive, and taking only a small nutrition or thanks fee, is folk placement and is not

convicted as trafficking. Next, Criminal Law Article 261. “Whoever refuses to fulfill the duty to support an elderly person, a young person, a sick person, or another person who cannot live independently, under egregious circumstances, shall be sentenced to fixed-term imprisonment of not more than five years, criminal detention, or public surveillance.” Civil Code Article 1094 provides that only three kinds of person may place a child for adoption: the guardian of an orphan, a child welfare institution, and birth parents who have special difficulty and cannot raise the child. Article 1105: “Adoption shall be registered with the civil affairs department of the people's government at or above the county level. The adoption relationship is established as of the date of registration”

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Whether to have a child is not discussed here. After the child is born, this order is the simplest. Step one: give birth in a hospital; prenatal care and inpatient delivery are in Section 27. The birth medical certificate is the premise for every later procedure. Step two: for placement, go straight to civil affairs at county level or above; do not go through a middleman. Once money changes hands, the nature can change. Within a year after birth, if thoughts of harming yourself or the child appear, treat it as an emergency. The list of signals that require immediate hospital care in pregnancy and after birth is in Section 27, item 7. The 42-day postpartum checkup is also a postpartum-depression screen; see Section 27, item 16. For suicidal thoughts call 12356; see Section 1, item 25. This item has no case attached: official typical cases of trafficking one's own child were not checked case by case in this round, so only the statute and the opinion's text are cited.

## 21. Do not fabricate accidents or inflate losses to cheat claims: that is insurance fraud, and those who testify, repair the car, or appraise for you are counted together

**Cost**. No money and no time — just do not do it.

**In plain terms**. Inventing an accident or inflating losses to cheat a claim is insurance fraud; a relatively large amount brings up to 5 years plus a fine of 10000 to 100000 yuan (1 万 to 10 万). People who deliberately give false proof when testifying, appraising, or assessing property are convicted with you as accomplices. A repairer who agrees with you to fake it is treated as a joint crime. In a Xuancheng, Anhui case, 8 people got 2 to 4 years and each was fined 10000 yuan (1 万).

**Benefit**. Criminal Law Article 198 lists five situations. (1) The policyholder deliberately fabricates the subject of insurance — invents an insured object that does not exist. (2) The policyholder, insured, or beneficiary invents a false cause for an insurance accident that occurred, or inflates the degree of loss. (3) Fabricating an insurance accident that never occurred. (4) The policyholder or insured deliberately causing an insurance accident that damages property. (5) The policyholder or beneficiary deliberately causing the insured's death, disability, or illness. For a relatively large amount: fixed-term imprisonment of not more than 5 years or criminal detention, and a fine of not less than 10000 yuan and not more than 100000 yuan (1 万 to 10 万). For a huge amount or other serious circumstances: 5 to 10 years, and a fine of 20000 to 200000 yuan (2 万 to 20 万). For an especially huge amount or other especially serious circumstances: 10 years or more, and a fine of 20000 to 200000 yuan (2 万 to 20 万) or confiscation of property. The last paragraph of this article covers helpers: appraisers, witnesses, and property assessors in an insurance accident. If they deliberately issue false proving documents and create conditions for someone else's fraud, they are treated as accomplices to insurance fraud and convicted with the fraudster. Repairers are not among those three roles, but if they agree with you to fake it, they are handled as a joint crime. Criminal Law Article 25: “A joint crime means an intentional crime committed jointly by two or more persons.” Beijing Changping court reported in 2021 that motor-vehicle insurance fraud cases concluded since 2019 were “mainly joint crimes, with auto-repair shops a key industry for the offenses.” Insurance Law Article 27: if no insurance accident occurred but one is falsely claimed, the insurer may terminate the contract and need not refund the premium. Using forged or altered proving materials, or inventing a false accident cause or inflating the degree of loss: the insurer need not pay the overstated part. What was already paid must be returned or compensated. Case: In the Zhang case in Xuancheng, Anhui, Wang and 7 others were sentenced for insurance fraud to fixed-term imprisonment from

4 years down to 2 years, each also fined 10000 yuan (1 万). The case also led to a false lawsuit. The insurer assessed loss at 20000 yuan (2 万); the parties used a forged vehicle-transfer agreement to gain standing to sue, and the court ordered payment of over 70000 yuan (7 万余). That already-effective civil judgment was vacated on retrial on 26 September 2019. The Measures for Anti-Insurance-Fraud Work require risk-information checks at both ends that sell policies and pay claims (underwriting and claims). They also call for exploring a multi-line industry anti-fraud information platform and an anti-fraud intelligence center. Those platforms centrally screen data suspicious for fraud; leads go to industry associations, anti-fraud organizations, and insurers for verification. When crime is suspected, report promptly to public security. The financial regulator and its local offices are to build sound links between administrative enforcement and criminal justice. The link targets public security, people's procuratorates, and people's courts (nationwide; issued 31 July 2024)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The following “harmless” habits all fall within these five items. After a small accident asking the shop to “report a bit more,” folding old damage into this claim, arranging a bump with a friend then reporting, or inventing an accident that never happened. How to buy auto insurance is in Section 5, item 26 (buy enough third-party cover). Deliberately causing a family member's death after insuring them is expressly punished as several crimes together; see Section 8, item 38 (insuring family). Medical insurance is another set of rules; using a medical-insurance card to buy health products for cash is insurance fraud — see the notes to Section 5, item 13

## 22. Do not sell your own organs, and do not help others find donors: a kidney nets a little over 20000 yuan (2 万多); the same kidney is resold for 200000 yuan (20 万); the money is confiscated and a fine of 10 to 20 times the transaction amount is added

**Cost**. No money and no time — just do not do it.

**In plain terms**. Living organs may only be donated to a spouse, direct blood relative, or collateral blood relative within three generations; buying and selling are both unlawful. In a Beijing case, the seller got only a little over 20000 yuan (2 万多); the same kidney sold to the patient for 180000 to 220000 yuan (18 万 to 22 万). Money obtained is confiscated, then a fine of 10 to 20 times the transaction amount is added. The bodily cost after a kidney is removed is in Section 1, item 35 (the remaining kidney does the work of two).

**Benefit**. Article 5 of the Regulations on Human Organ Donation and Transplantation: “No organization or individual may buy or sell human organs in any form, or engage in activities related to buying or selling human organs.” Article 10: “No organization or individual may obtain living organs from a citizen under 18 years of age for transplant.” Article 11: “Recipients of living organs are limited to the living donor's spouse, direct blood relatives, or collateral blood relatives within three generations.” Article 37 sets how buying and selling human organs are punished. Buying or selling human organs or engaging in related activities is handled by the health department of the local people's government at county level or above. First confiscate the illegal gains — take all money from the deal. Then fine not less than 10 times and not more than 20 times the transaction amount. Medical staff who take part have their practice certificates revoked and are barred for life from health services. If a crime is constituted, criminal liability is pursued according to law (nationwide; in force from 1 May 2024; the former Regulations on Human Organ Transplantation are repealed at the same time). Criminal Law Article 234-1: “Whoever organizes another person to sell a human organ shall be sentenced to fixed-term imprisonment of not more than five years and shall also be fined; if the circumstances are serious, to fixed-term imprisonment of not less than five years and shall also be fined or have property confiscated.” Three further situations are convicted and punished under Articles 234 and 232. One is removing someone's organ without their consent. Two is removing an organ from a person under eighteen. Three is forcing or deceiving someone into donating an organ. These are handled as intentional injury or intentional homicide. Case 1: The Beijing No. 1 Intermediate People's Court finally judged Zheng and 14 others on 20 August 2014; the case involved 51 kidneys and over 10340000 yuan (1034 万余) in

amounts. Kidney sellers (donors) “received only remuneration ranging from 20000 to 25000 yuan (2 万 to 2.5 万).” The patient side (recipients) paid “formerly 180000 or 190000 yuan (18 万 or 19 万) per kidney, later 210000 or 220000 yuan (21 万 or 22 万).” The harvest site was a four-story building rented for 7500 yuan a month; the gang's head nurse said the place was “filthy and chaotic, without even rescue equipment.” Organizer Zheng was sentenced to 12 years for organizing the sale of human organs; the other 14 got from 3 years 6 months to 9 years. Case 2: The “teen sold a kidney for an Apple phone” case published by the Supreme People's Procuratorate. Seventeen-year-old Wang had his right kidney removed in Chenzhou on the night of 28 April 2011. The surgery site was a contracted department inside a hospital without transplant qualifications. On discharge on 2 May he received 22000 yuan (2.2 万); the recipient side paid intermediaries 150000 yuan (15 万) RMB and 10000 US dollars; the principal made over 56000 yuan (5.6 万余). After surgery Wang had incomplete kidney function; “the injury constituted serious injury and grade-three disability”

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The beneficiary is you. On the surface the deal is “a one-time twenty thousand”; in fact it trades an organ for a phone. The appraisal in the teen kidney case was serious injury and grade-three disability — not something a few months of rest fixes. In that case prosecutors found five defendants violated Criminal Law Article 234 paragraph 2 and charged intentional injury. One reason was that medical staff did not verify whether the “donor” was a minor before cutting out the right kidney. If the same thing happens today, recruiters are handled for organizing the sale of human organs. Removing an organ from a person under eighteen is still convicted and punished as intentional injury under Article 234. Black intermediaries operate in rentals or borrowed sites; the Beijing harvest point had no rescue equipment. Lawful living donation is done at hospitals with transplant qualifications, after review by the hospital ethics committee. Before surgery doctors must explain the risks and sign informed consent; after surgery the hospital must follow up (Regulations Articles 23, 28, and 29). Black intermediaries skip all of that; if complications arise it is hard to find anyone accountable — that sentence is the author's inference from the Regulations. If you truly want to donate for a relative, take the Article 11 path; donation under Article 8 of the Regulations is voluntary and unpaid. Posthumous organ donation is unpaid and outside this item. The bodily cost after losing a kidney is in Section 1, item 35 (the remaining kidney does the work of two). When money is so short that selling an organ seems thinkable, first see Section 7's safety nets (unemployment insurance, temporary assistance, dibao). Pitfalls of online loans and “packaging materials” loans are in item 6 of this section.

## 23. Do not solicit prostitution: the default band is detention for 10 to 15 days, not paying a fine and walking away

**Cost**. No money and no time — just do not do it.

**In plain terms**. Being caught is not paying a small fine and walking away. The statute's default band is detention for 10 to 15 days, with a further fine of up to 5000 yuan. Only when circumstances are relatively light is it detention for under 5 days or a fine of up to 1000 yuan. Also, knowingly having syphilis or gonorrhea and still soliciting is a crime, punishable by up to 5 years.

**Benefit**. Public Security Administration Punishment Law Article 78: for prostitution or solicitation of prostitution, detention of not less than ten days and not more than fifteen days, and a fine of not more than five thousand yuan may be imposed as well. When circumstances are relatively light, detention of not more than five days or a fine of not more than one thousand yuan. Soliciting customers in a public place: detention of not more than five days or a fine of not more than one thousand yuan. Article 79: luring, harboring, or introducing another to prostitution: detention of not less than ten days and not more than fifteen days, and a fine of not more than five thousand yuan may be imposed as well. When circumstances are relatively light, detention of not more than five days or a fine of not less than one thousand yuan and not more than two thousand yuan. Article 87: staff of hotels, food and drink businesses, cultural entertainment businesses, taxis, and similar units who tip off offenders when police investigate prostitution or solicitation, or who otherwise provide conditions for those activities: detention of not less than ten days and not more than fifteen days. Criminal Law Article 360 is the crime of spreading sexually transmitted disease: knowingly having syphilis, gonorrhea, or another serious STD and engaging in prostitution or solicitation brings fixed-term

imprisonment of not more than five years, criminal detention, or public surveillance, and a fine (nationwide; Public Security Administration Punishment Law in force from 1 January 2026)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This detention is administrative detention; you go into a detention facility — it is not paying a fine and leaving. Introducing others or providing a venue is punished as heavily as soliciting yourself; Article 79's band covers that. Staff at hotels or KTVs who tip off guests are likewise detained for 10 to 15 days under Article 87. Criminal Law Article 360 formerly had a second paragraph on "soliciting underage girls for prostitution"; Amendment (IX) in 2015 deleted it. Such acts are now punished as rape with heavier punishment; see item 18 of this section (no sexual relations if the other person is under 14). Signs such as "home wellness" or "massage" do not change the nature; the actual acts decide. Risks of STDs and HIV are in Section 1, item 30 (use a condom for the whole sexual act) and Section 13, item 38 (get PEP within 72 hours). What to watch at entertainment venues themselves is in Section 22.

## 24. Fan-translating comics, reposting films and shows, sharing cloud links and pirated e-books is infringement even without charging; hanging ads or taking membership fees can bring a criminal sentence

**Cost**. No money. What you buy or download you may watch and tinker with yourself — just do not put it online for everyone. Do not run resource sites or groups that hang ads or take membership fees, and do not sell cloud links. The hard part is not joining as a reposter when "everyone is sharing."

**In plain terms**. Translating someone else's work without permission and posting it, or putting it online, is infringement even without charging — it must be taken down and compensated. Once you hang ads or take membership fees, it counts as doing it for profit. Earning 30000 yuan (3 万), disseminating 500 titles, or reaching 1000 members is enough for a criminal sentence, up to 10 years at the top. The boss of the Renren Yingshi subtitle group got 3 years 6 months.

**Benefit**. First, civil. Among the rights copyright law gives authors is the right of translation — turning a work from one language into another. There is also the right of information-network dissemination — putting a work online so the public can see it anytime, anywhere. Translating another's work without permission is infringement. Putting a work online without permission is also infringement. Infringers must stop the infringement and compensate losses. Only using another's already published work for personal study, research, or appreciation needs no permission and no payment. How much to pay: first reckon the rightsholder's actual loss or what you earned. If neither can be reckoned, the court sets it between 500 yuan and 5000000 yuan (500 万). Intentional infringement with serious circumstances can be ordered at 1 to 5 times. Reasonable expenses the rightsholder spent to stop the infringement are paid together. Next, criminal. The premise of Criminal Law Article 217 is "for the purpose of profit." Putting another's work online for the public to see without permission, once the threshold is met, is the crime of infringing copyright. Up to 3 years, with a fine at the same time, or only a fine. A huge amount or especially serious circumstances: 3 to 10 years plus a fine. What counts as for profit: besides selling, hanging paid ads on a page counts; collecting registration or other fees under a membership system also counts. Service fees, membership fees, and ad fees collected all count as illegal gains. The criminal threshold is met by hitting any one of the following. Illegal gains of 30000 yuan (3 万) or more. Illegal business volume of 50000 yuan (5 万) or more — in the Renren Yingshi case that was total income from membership fees, ads, and selling hard drives. Disseminating another's works online totaling 500 pieces (titles) or more. Downloaded 10000 (1 万) times or more, or clicked 100000 (10 万) times or more. Disseminating under a membership system with 1000 or more registered members. If none of these is reached but two items each reach half or more, that also counts. Ten times these figures moves into the 3-to-10-year band. The fine is generally 1 to 10 times illegal gains. Official case 1: Liang Yongping and others downloaded unauthorized films and shows from foreign sites, organized translation and subtitles, and uploaded them. The titles were on the "Renren Yingshi subtitle group" site and client for online viewing and download. The site held 32824 unauthorized audiovisual works and over 6830000 (683 万余) members. From January 2018 to January 2021 it took over 2700000 yuan (270 余万) in membership fees and over 8800000 yuan (880 余万) in ad fees. Selling mobile hard drives loaded with films

earned another over 1000000 yuan (100 余万). The site hung a “donation” QR code; donating unlocked membership benefits. Prosecutors found that was membership fees under another name. On 22 November 2021 Liang was sentenced to 3 years 6 months and fined 1500000 yuan (150 万). Another 14 people got from 1 year 6 months to 3 years, all suspended, with fines of 40000 to 350000 yuan (4 万 to 35 万). Official case 2: Ke used crawler software to grab playback addresses for over 50000 films and shows, put them on his own site and app for free viewing, sold ads by impressions on the splash screen, and earned over 350000 yuan (35 万余). In 2023 he got 3 years, suspended for 4 years, and a fine of 400000 yuan (40 万). Official case 3: Huang rented servers at home and built a music-download forum. He uploaded over 100000 (10 万余) songs into 18 cloud drives and posted links on the forum. Members topped up for forum coins to get links and extract codes. Member top-ups totaled over 500000 yuan (50 余万). In 2023 he got 3 years, suspended for 4 years, and a fine of 550000 yuan (55 万) (nationwide; judicial interpretation in force from 26 April 2025)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The beneficiary is you. Buying to watch yourself, or translating for yourself, is within what the statute allows. The line is “putting it online for everyone to see.” Subtitle and fan-translation groups that do not charge do not meet the crime of infringing copyright, because that crime requires a profit purpose. Civil infringement still stands; rightsholders can demand takedown and compensation. In Japan, not charging can still be unlawful. In February 2018 several Chinese citizens in Japan were arrested on suspicion of violating Japanese copyright law. The Chinese consulate-general in Nagasaki then reminded: translating, publishing, or disseminating works without authorization may be unlawful even without profit. Once you hang ads, open memberships, or trade “donations” for membership benefits, you fall into the for-profit band. In the Renren Yingshi case, people who only translated or proofread and took little part were treated as witnesses by police. The Supreme People's Procuratorate wrote in that case that those who start it, divide the money, and run the platform should be pursued strictly. Employed accessories may be treated more lightly; those brought in temporarily with light circumstances may not face criminal liability. The old 2004, 2007, and 2020 intellectual-property criminal judicial interpretations were repealed from 26 April 2025. The 2011 three-agency opinion was not named for repeal; where it conflicts with the new interpretation, the new one controls. For example the click threshold changed from 50000 (5 万) to 100000 (10 万). Another risk of writing fan works or derivatives for publication is in item 25 of this section (writing fan works). Printing others' images on goods to sell is in Section 12, item 21 (buy a license for patterns). What to do when you run a platform and get a rightsholder's infringement notice is in Section 26, item 9 (receiving an infringement notice). Making or selling crack patches and keygens is in Section 11, item 20 (crack patches and keygens).

## 25. To publish or monetize fan works, first obtain permission from the original creator, or replace borrowed characters' names and relationships with your own

**Cost**. There are no upfront costs. Before publishing or selling, you must negotiate licensing with the rights holder. If terms cannot be reached, change the borrowed characters' names, personalities, and relationships. Also avoid referencing the original work in book titles, subtitles, or promotional material.

**In plain terms**. Even if a fan work only borrows character names, personalities, and relationships, publishing it may still be deemed copyright infringement. In one case, Jiang Nan's novel *This Side of Youth* featured over 60 characters from Jin Yong's works; a second-instance ruling ordered him to pay 1.68 million yuan in damages plus 200,000 yuan in legal fees. After nine years of litigation, the parties reached a settlement whereby he agreed not to republish the book unchanged. Courts evaluate such cases on a case-by-case basis.

**Benefit**. The novel used names such as Guo Jing, Huang Rong, Qiao Feng, and Linghu Chong. Published in 2002 under the subtitle “The College Years of the Heroes from The Legend of the Condor Heroes,” it sold millions of copies. Jin Yong sued in 2016 seeking 5 million yuan in compensation. The first instance ruled no copyright violation because isolated names and traits are not protectable; however, it found unfair competition since Jiang Nan leveraged the original works' fame to attract readers, ordering 1.68 million yuan

in damages plus legal costs. The second instance reversed this, finding copyright infringement because the collective "character ensemble" constituted protected expression; it also upheld the unfair-competition finding. Both rulings were later superseded by a settlement that avoided labeling the act as plagiarism. In another case, Zhang Muye's sequel *Mogin Xiaowei* incorporated characters and lore from *Ghost Blows Out the Light*; a court ruled it constituted false advertising despite finding no copyright infringement.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. You are the ultimate beneficiary. This B rating reflects the lack of clear legal boundaries for fan works; the two court rulings diverged, and the final settlement rendered both moot. Judges emphasize a three-step analysis: whether similarities are abstract ideas or concrete expression, whether those expressions are original, and whether any exception such as fair use applies. Risks differ greatly between merely borrowing a theme versus copying entire character sets. No court rulings exist for free online fan works, and no statutory exemption exists for non-commercial use. The Jiang Nan case spanned nine years from filing to settlement, involving multiple trials and the original author's death; even after selling rights, authors can still be sued by buyers, as seen in the Zhang Muye case. Reasonable legal expenses are recoverable, as demonstrated by the 200,000-yuan award for attorney fees. Risks related to translating, redistributing, or sharing others' works are discussed in item 24 of this section. 〔5600000〕 〔2006〕 〔20000000〕 〔900000〕 〔600000〕

## 26. Do not buy telescopic batons, stun devices, daggers, or pepper spray to carry for self-defense — keeping them in the car also counts as carrying

**Cost**. No money. If you already bought them, leave them at home; do not take them out, and do not put them in the car. If something happens, step back and call the police first; only strike back if you cannot get away.

**In plain terms**. Controlled knives such as daggers and switchblades, if found carried out, can bring detention for under 5 days. Taking them into stations, malls, or buses brings detention for 5 to 10 days. Police batons may only be held by police; an individual's are confiscated and detention is possible. Actually drawing them also often costs you: someone hit once with an empty hand pulled a knife he had hidden in advance and stabbed, and got 4 years for excessive defense.

**Benefit**. First, Public Security Administration Punishment Law Article 38. Illegally carrying crossbows, daggers, or other state-controlled implements: detention for under 5 days, and a further fine of up to 1000 yuan may be imposed. When circumstances are relatively light, a warning or a fine of up to 500 yuan. Taking them into a public place or public transport: detention for 5 to 10 days, and a further fine of up to 1000 yuan may be imposed. Criminal Law Article 130 is heavier. Illegally carrying controlled knives into a public place or public transport, endangering public safety with serious circumstances, brings up to 3 years. Which knives are controlled knives is listed in five classes in the Ministry of Public Security's 2007 identification standard. Class one is the dagger: hilt, guard, and blood groove, tip angle under 60 degrees. Class two is the triangular scraper. Class three is the spring knife with a self-locking device, commonly called a jump knife. Class four is a knife with tip angle under 60 degrees and blade over 150 millimeters. Class five is a knife with tip angle over 60 degrees and blade over 220 millimeters. Unsharpened martial-arts and craft gift knives with the tip rounded off do not count. The police baton is police equipment. The People's Police Law provides that police equipment may only be held and used by police. Others who hold it: confiscation, detention for up to 15 days or a warning, and a further fine of up to 5 times illegal gains may be imposed. The railway banned-items list treats batons, tear gas, stun devices, and defense devices as controlled implements. On trains these may not be carried or checked as luggage. The road-passenger banned-items list likewise treats tear gas and stun devices as controlled implements; they may not be carried on long-distance coaches. Whether stun devices may be held in ordinary life: the Shanghai municipal procuratorate published a 2013 case. Four people sold stun devices to drivers at an intersection and were sentenced for illegally buying and selling police equipment to fixed-term imprisonment from 1 year 3 months down to 6 months. The procuratorate cited two Ministry of Public Security circulars. On those circulars, "this kind of stun device is a state-controlled implement and also a kind of police equipment." The procuratorate also wrote that such stun devices "are prohibited items domestically; individuals are banned from producing, selling, and holding them." Prosecutors separately said high-concentration spray defense products are police equipment and ordinary

residents generally cannot buy them. Leaving them in the car can still be found: someone drove through a checkpoint with controlled knives, was found by officers, and got administrative detention. When they are actually used, see the guidance on justifiable defense. It lists “whether a lethal instrument was used or prepared” as one factor distinguishing defense from mutual fighting. Official case: Yang argued with someone who threatened to bring people for revenge; he went home and hid two knives on himself. The other person came back and hit his face once with an empty hand; he stabbed the chest and abdomen with a knife; the other person died. The court found a defensive character, but the other side had only hit with empty hands and he stabbed vital parts, so it was excessive defense. He was sentenced to 4 years for intentional injury (nationwide; Public Security Administration Punishment Law in force from 1 January 2026)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The beneficiary is you. Carrying a knife does not automatically defeat justifiable defense. In Procuratorial Case No. 45, student Chen was attacked by 9 people, drew a fruit knife he had on him to strike back, and was still found to have acted in justifiable defense. The procuratorate wrote that what matters for the finding is not whether a tool was carried but whether there was intent to fight mutually. The cost falls in two places. One: the item itself is unlawful; being found with it in ordinary life is already punished, whether or not it was used. Two: with a knife at hand, a punch or shove is easier to answer with a stab; injury at serious level or above can become excessive defense. No nationwide ban text for stun devices or pepper spray was found. The two Ministry of Public Security circulars are named only in the Shanghai procuratorate case in this book. That individuals may not hold stun devices is supported by that procuratorate case. For pepper spray, prosecutors only said “high-concentration spray” cannot be bought; whether low-concentration anti-wolf sprays on the market count the same, this book found no unified finding. Neither trains nor long-distance coaches allow carrying them. Whether telescopic batons sold online count as police batons, this book also found no nationwide unified identification text. When something really happens, first see Section 8, item 10 (in a conflict, call the police and do not strike). When there is nowhere to retreat, see Section 8, item 11 (an unavoidable attack may be met with force). Being cornered for money outdoors is in Section 13, item 36 (strangers demanding money in the wild).

## 27. When fishing, stay out of closed seasons and closed zones; never electrofish, poison fish, or blast fish at any time; do not use banned gear

**Cost**. No money. Before entering the water, check closed zones, closed seasons, and no-fishing zones published by the local agriculture and rural affairs department. Do not buy electrofishing gear or take it to the water's edge. To fish, go to waters where angling is allowed, or to a fee pond. The hard part is not joining when you see others electrofishing and taking a large catch.

**In plain terms**. Electrofishing, poisoning, or blasting fish in a closed zone or closed season already meets the threshold for illegal harvesting of aquatic products, up to 3 years. Only when the catch is small and harm clearly light may non-prosecution be possible. Electrofishing also draws a fine, generally up to 200000 yuan (20 万); taking electrofishing gear into the water can also be fined. Someone on the Yangtze electrofished and sold for 9000 yuan, and got 1 year.

**Benefit**. Criminal Law Article 340: harvesting aquatic products in a closed zone or closed season, or with banned tools or methods, when circumstances are serious, brings up to 3 years of fixed-term imprisonment, criminal detention, public surveillance, or a fine. A 2022 two-high judicial interpretation states what counts as “serious circumstances”; any one of the following is enough. Illegally harvesting 500 kilograms or more in inland waters, or value of 10000 yuan (1 万) or more. Harvesting 50 kilograms or more, or value of 1000 yuan or more, inside an aquatic germplasm reserve. Harvesting in a closed zone by electrofishing, poisoning, blasting, or similar methods. Harvesting in a closed season by those methods. The same article leaves an opening: when quantity, value, and tools show harm is clearly relatively light, non-prosecution or exemption from criminal punishment is possible. Next, the Fisheries Law, revised in 2025 and in force from 1 May 2026. It bans harvesting in violation of closed-zone and closed-season rules, and bans angling in violation. It bans harvesting by blasting, poisoning, or electrofishing, and bans taking such devices into fishery waters. Harvesting with banned gear or nets below the minimum mesh size is likewise banned. Penalties are set thus:

for electrofishing, poisoning, or blasting fish — confiscate tools, catch, and illegal gains, and fine up to 200000 yuan (20 万). When circumstances are serious, fine 200000 to 2000000 yuan (20 万 to 200 万). Merely taking electrofishing gear into fishery waters — confiscate the tools, and a fine of up to 100000 yuan (10 万) may be imposed. Harvesting in violation of closed-zone or closed-season rules, or with banned gear — fine up to 200000 yuan (20 万). Angling in violation in a closed zone or closed season — confiscate catch, illegal gains, and gear, and a fine of up to 50000 yuan (5 万) may be imposed. The Yangtze has another layer: the Yangtze Protection Law provides a full ban on productive harvesting of natural fishery resources in key waters such as the main stem, important tributaries, and large lakes connected to the river. The Yangtze ten-year fishing ban is counted from 1 January 2021. Harvesting in banned waters: confiscate catch, illegal gains, and boats and gear, and fine 10000 to 50000 yuan (1 万 to 5 万). Electrofishing, poisoning, or blasting: fine 50000 to 500000 yuan (5 万 to 50 万). Official case: Li, knowing the Jiangdu Jiajiang stretch of the Yangtze in Yangzhou was a closed zone, still ran a speedboat with an inverter to electrofish. From January 2018 to April 2019 he electrofished over 60 times, took over 900 jin of wild fish and sold them, making 9000 yuan. He surrendered, returned illegal gains, and released a first batch of fry, yet was still sentenced to 1 year of fixed-term imprisonment for illegally harvesting aquatic products. Under a settlement he also had to apologize publicly in provincial media and release fry worth 25000 yuan (2.5 万) and 22500 yuan (2.25 万) in two batches. In another Supreme People's Court guiding case, 8 people fished three or four dozen times with gill nets and homemade electric grids in the East Dongting Lake no-fishing zone. Their terms ranged from 3 months of criminal detention suspended up to 1 year 1 month of fixed-term imprisonment. Illegal gains of 100000 yuan (10 万) were all recovered (nationwide; Fisheries Law in force from 1 May 2026)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The beneficiary is you. The Fisheries Law states that occasional recreational angling by individuals is not a harvesting operation and needs no harvesting license. But angling in violation in a closed zone or closed season still brings confiscation of gear and a fine. Whether angling is allowed in Yangtze banned waters, and how many rods and hooks one person may use, has no single national figure. A 2024 Ministry of Agriculture and Rural Affairs opinion only requires localities to set their own rules and mark no-angling zones. Core zones of reserves and important aquatic habitats ban angling entirely. Where angling is allowed in Yangtze banned waters, nationwide limits still apply: no fish finders or underwater cameras, no toxic bait or groundbait, and catch may not be sold. Methods such as “explosion hooks” and “string hooks” are named for crackdown. Catch that is clearly excessive and sold for money may be investigated as illegal harvesting. So before you go, check the local agriculture and rural affairs website or notice boards. The criminal thresholds above cover only inland waters; the sea has another set of standards. Knowingly purchasing or selling fish from illegal harvesting is handled as concealing criminal proceeds. Catching nationally key-protected aquatic animals is punished more heavily; see item 14 of this section (do not eat wild game or trade protected animals).

## 28. When visiting graves, burning fields, or cooking outdoors, do not light fires in forests or grasslands; if you see a mountain fire call 12119 or 119

**Cost**. No money. For grave visits switch to flowers, weeding, or planting; do not light paper money, incense, candles, or firecrackers on the mountain. Do not set fire to weeds or straw in the fields. For outdoor cooking bring food that needs no open flame, and take cigarette butts down the mountain. The hard part is older relatives who feel a grave visit without burning paper does not count.

**In plain terms**. Lighting a fire in a fire-prevention zone during fire-prevention season can bring a fine of 300 to 5000 yuan even if nothing burns. Burning 2 hectares of forested land is enough to file for the crime of negligently causing a fire, with 3 to 7 years, or up to 3 years when circumstances are lighter. Someone whose grave-paper fire burned 39 hectares got 1 year suspended for 2 years and still had to replant 32 hectares of forest.

**Benefit**. The Regulations on Forest and Grassland Fire Prevention and Fighting take effect on 1 January 2026; the former Forest Fire Prevention Regulations and Grassland Fire Prevention Regulations are repealed at the same time. Article 27: during fire-prevention season, open fire outdoors in fire-prevention zones is banned;

no one may discard ignition sources in a fire-prevention zone. In high heat, drought, or strong wind, local governments may order a total ban on all outdoor fire use. Article 54: using outdoor fire in a fire-prevention zone without approval during fire-prevention season — order a stop. Individuals are fined 300 to 5000 yuan; units 20000 to 100000 yuan (2 万 to 10 万). Article 34: anyone who finds a forest or grassland fire situation shall report it at once. The Ministry of Emergency Management states the nationwide unified forest-fire number is 12119. Once it burns and the filing threshold is met, it is a criminal case. Criminal Law Article 115 paragraph 2 is the crime of negligently causing a fire: negligently causing a fire brings 3 to 7 years; when circumstances are lighter, up to 3 years or criminal detention. Among filing standards, one item is tied directly to mountain fire. Burning 2 hectares of forested land, or 4 hectares of sparse woodland, shrubland, young plantation, or nursery, requires filing. One death, 3 serious injuries, 500000 yuan (50 万) in direct loss, or burning houses of 10 households also meets filing. In a Xinhua piece carried by the National Forestry and Grassland Administration, experts said human causes such as ritual and farm fire account for over nine tenths of ignition causes. In historical data, ritual fire ranked first. Official case 1: In February 2021 Xie burned paper money at a grave in the Qilian Mountain National Nature Reserve and ignited weeds and shrubs. The burned area was 39.2156 hectares, mostly natural shrubland. After the fire he called to report, fought it with others, and turned himself in — counted as surrender. He had already replanted 9420 Qinghai spruce elsewhere. Even so he was sentenced for negligently causing a fire to 1 year of fixed-term imprisonment, suspended for 2 years. The court also ordered him to afforest 32.05 hectares in three stages, or pay the assessed amount if unfinished. Official case 2: In May 2022 Wang took part in a folk rite and lit ritual “weisang” offerings with a lighter. He covered the fire with stones, left without confirming it was out. The embers ignited dry grass, burned 121.69 mu, with loss of about 469000 yuan (exact 468578 yuan). He got 9 months of fixed-term imprisonment, suspended for 1 year 6 months. He must replant per the plan, or bear 986700 yuan (98.67 万) in restoration costs if unfinished (nationwide; Regulations in force from 1 January 2026)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The beneficiary is you. Fire-prevention zones and seasons are drawn and published by people's governments at county level or above; they differ by place — check the local notice before going up the mountain. The Ministry of Emergency Management states Tomb-Sweeping Day is a high-incidence and peak period for forest fires. Fines cover only fire-prevention season and zones. The crime of negligently causing a fire does not look at those; careless ignition that meets the filing threshold is enough. Both cases got suspended sentences only after surrender or active firefighting and replanting. Restoration money is separate and can far exceed the fine. When reporting, say which county, township, and village, which mountain, how large the fire is, and leave your phone number. Calling 119 also works; Xie's case records that he dialed the fire-rescue number himself after the fire started. Many online articles cite fine figures from the 2008 pair of fire-prevention regulations, repealed from 2026. When the fire is large, do not try to beat it alone; move to bare ground, already-burned ground, or a stream edge — do not run with the wind.

## 29. For civil-service, graduate-school, driving-license, and professional-qualification exams: do not take a test for someone else, do not hire a proxy, do not buy or sell answers, and do not help organize cheating

**Cost**. No money. Do not trust “guaranteed pass” classes, “VIP channels,” or answer-selling groups. Do not take phones, earphones, or other devices that can send or receive information into the exam room. If you fail, prepare for another try. The hard part is when a few points would get you through and someone offers a guaranteed pass for a price.

**In plain terms**. Hiring a proxy or taking a test for someone else is a crime; it can bring criminal detention and a fine, and those who became civil servants through a proxy exam were dismissed from public office. Organizing cheating or selling answers brings up to 7 years. Driving-license exams count too; a driving-school boss who organized trainee cheating was sentenced. Short of a crime, scores are voided and you may be barred from testing or unable to retest for a year.

**Benefit**. Criminal Law Article 284-1 covers four acts, on the premise of a “state examination prescribed by law.” Organizing cheating: up to 3 years or criminal detention, with a fine imposed together with or instead of imprisonment. When circumstances are serious: 3 to 7 years. Providing cheating gear or other help to organizers is sentenced in the same band. Selling or giving answers for cheating is also sentenced in the same band. Taking a test for someone else, or hiring someone to take it for you, is the crime of substituting in an examination: criminal detention or public surveillance, with a fine imposed together with or instead of imprisonment. Which exams count follows a 2019 two-high judicial interpretation. The gaokao, graduate entrance exam, self-taught higher education exams, and adult gaokao count; central and local civil-service exams count. Qualification exams such as the legal professional qualification, teacher qualification, CPA, physician, and constructor also count. The Supreme People's Court wrote in 2024 that driving-license exams also belong to this class. Organizing cheating in the gaokao, graduate entrance exam, or civil-service exam is treated as “serious circumstances” directly. Organizing 30 person-times or more, or illegal gains of 300000 yuan (30 万) or more, also counts. Being caught before the exam starts but already having obtained question answers still counts as a completed crime. Incomplete or partly wrong answers sold do not block conviction. Lighter proxy-exam circumstances may get a suspended sentence; minor ones may not be prosecuted. Supreme People's Court statistics: from November 2015 to April 2024, these three crimes sentenced 11146 people. Short of a crime, each exam's own rules apply. In national education exams, using devices to receive answers or hiring a proxy voids the score and can bar you from testing for 1 to 3 years. In civil-service exams, proxy exams or taking part in organized cheating cancel exam eligibility, go into the integrity file as a long-term record. Those already hired are dismissed or expelled when found. Driving-license exam cheating: cancel exam eligibility, void subjects already passed, fine up to 2000 yuan, and no new license application for a year. Taking a driving test for someone else: your own license is cancelled, and you cannot reapply for 3 years. Official case 1: Zhang's gang used composite photos and fake IDs to have “gunners” take civil-service and other state exams for candidates 89 times. Three principals got 5 years to 5 years 6 months. Eighteen candidates who hired gunners were sentenced for substituting in an examination to 2 to 4 months of criminal detention and fined 30000 to 100000 yuan (3 万 to 10 万). Those who became civil servants through a proxy exam were dismissed from public office. Official case 2: A driving-school boss from 2017 to 2023 organized trainees to cheat in driving tests. Methods included altering exam-system data, having coaches take the test, and giving trainees earphones for remote prompts. The boss, together with bribery, got 6 years 6 months; the other 23 got from 6 months to 1 year 10 months (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The beneficiary is you. Simply peeking yourself or wearing earphones to take answers is not listed as a crime in the statute; it is handled under the exam rules above. But passing bought answers to a classmate becomes illegally providing exam questions or answers. In a Class II constructor leak case, answers were resold layer by layer among candidates; someone posted them into a QQ group of over 1700 people. Students who take a proxy exam or hire one are reported by the exam body to the school, which may expel them. Employer hiring tests and school end-of-term exams are not “state exams,” but using eavesdropping or covert-photography gear, or building groups to send cheating information, can still be sentenced under other crimes. In official case 1, the person who made fake IDs for gunners got 3 years for forging identity documents. Document issues are in item 16 of this section (do not lend your ID). Paying an agency to get a professional title assessed is in Section 23, item 22 (do not use an agency for title assessment).

# 10. Is dating and marriage worth it

This section splits "is marriage worth it" into separate accounts for money, time, health, legal risk, and relationship quality, and counts them apart. Each account uses only figures whose source can be checked. Sources are limited to official statistics, or to meta-analyses (pooling data from many studies and recalculating them). There is no moral judgment here, and no conclusion is made for you. The health accounts are counted as death risk, the time accounts as how many minutes a day, and the legal accounts as what the articles say. These three ways of counting are not converted into each other. The method for splitting the accounts, a fill-in checklist, and common mistakes are in chapter 10 “Is dating and marriage worth it”.

Items in this section are grouped by topic below, with item numbers in parentheses.

**Finding someone and dating**: meet more people (item 1), stop after the other person clearly refuses (item 2), judge interest from behaviour (item 3), take turns answering questions that go from light to deep (item 5), a long-distance relationship is not worse than one in the same city (item 6).

**Whether the relationship is good**: look at how you feel inside it (item 4), argue about the matter not the person (item 17), go to couples therapy together (item 20).

**The accounts of whether marriage is worth it**: look at the registration figures first (item 7), discount the health benefit because the data are observational (item 8), count the time account as unpaid labour (item 9), count the cost of leaving (item 15), keep a separate account of marrying for your elders (item 16), when divorcing write child support and visitation clearly (item 23).

**Registering and the premarital check**: registering needs only an identity card (item 13), have one premarital medical check (item 14), go and get the marriage certificate even after the banquet (item 21).

**Money and debt**: look first at the law's default rules for the money account (item 10), when parents pay for a home write down whether it is a loan or a gift (item 11), a large sum borrowed by one spouse (item 12), a spouse using joint money to tip streamers or transfer to someone outside the marriage (item 22).

**Same-sex partners and sexual orientation**: same-sex partners should put voluntary guardianship and a will in place (item 18), do not marry by hiding sexual orientation (item 19).

## 1. Meet more people instead of fixating on one: you cannot predict whether two people will get along before you meet

**Cost**. No money. Spend the time meeting several people, not repeatedly turning over the same one. The hard part is resisting fixation.

**In plain terms**. Two speed-dating studies had people fill out more than 100 partner-preference questionnaires before any meeting. The questionnaires could only show who tends to like others in general and who tends to be popular. They could not show whether these two people would click. Whether you get along is known only after you meet. So meeting more people is a better bet than staking everything on one person.

**Benefit**. In two speed-dating studies, participants filled out more than 100 self-report scales related to partner choice before meeting. Researchers used a random-forest model (an algorithm for finding patterns) to calculate. They could calculate “how easily a person likes others overall”; these questionnaires accounted for 4%–18% of the variance. Variance is the difference between people; the questionnaires explain only a small part of it. They could also calculate “how popular a person is overall,” accounting for 7%–27%. But “whether these two specific people click” could not be calculated; no combination of pre-meeting traits and preferences worked. The same researchers earlier ran another speed-dating experiment. Participants reported their own ideal-type preferences beforehand, such as valuing looks or economic prospects. That preference did not predict their interest in a specific person on the spot.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The two studies only show that “you cannot calculate it before meeting,” not that “no effort helps.” Whether you get along is known only after you meet, so spending time meeting several people, and really meeting each one, is a better bet than staking everything on one person. The study samples were Western university students. China's dating and marriage setting is different; discount when applying this to yourself.

## 2. Stop after a clear refusal — continued pursuit is a public-order offence, not “sincerity”

**Cost**. No money and no time. The hard part is stopping: no more messages, no more waiting for the person.

**In plain terms**. If the other person has clearly refused and you still send messages repeatedly or wait for them, and you interfere with their normal life, from January (1) 2026 that is a public-order offence. You can be detained for up to 5 days, or fined up to 1000 yuan. For more serious cases, detention is 5 to 10 days. Police can also order you not to contact the person; violating that brings another 5 to 10 days of detention.

**Benefit**. The Public Security Administration Punishments Law, in force from 1 January (1) 2026, lists entanglement and stalking as a separate item. The text covers “repeatedly sending obscene, insulting, or threatening information, or using harassment, entanglement, stalking, or similar methods to interfere with another person's normal life.” The act is punishable by detention of up to 5 days, or a fine of up to 1000 yuan. For more serious cases, detention of 5 to 10 days, and a fine of up to 1000 yuan may be added. There is a further layer: with approval from a public-security responsible official, the actor can be ordered not to contact the victim for a set period. Violating that order brings another 5 to 10 days of detention.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. “Chasing to the end will move the other person” has no research support, but detention and no-contact orders are in black and white. Such offence records are to be sealed and not provided or made public to ordinary units and individuals, though relevant units may query them under state rules. The law looks at whether you repeatedly harassed, entangled, or stalked and interfered with the person's normal life, not at what you meant. Continuing after a clear refusal is the situation most easily treated as interference; that last sentence is the author's judgment.

## 3. To judge whether the other person is interested, watch behaviour not “signals”: who initiates, who arranges, who follows up

**Cost**. No money, and little time. The hard part is changing the habit: stop reading faces and tone, and start recording facts.

**In plain terms**. When strangers of opposite sex talk for about ten minutes and then judge each other, “the other person was not flirting” is judged fairly accurately, while “the other person was flirting” is hard to see. So do not conclude from faces and tone in one chat alone. People who like someone more are more likely later to message and suggest meeting, but that link is weak.

**Benefit**. Two studies measured how accurately people spot flirting. The first had 52 pairs of opposite-sex strangers talk for 10 to 12 minutes. Afterward each reported whether they had been flirting and whether they thought the other had. The result was that interactions with no flirting were judged more accurately, and interactions with flirting were judged worse. The second used 26 one-minute videos judged by 261 bystanders, with the same conclusion. People can fairly reliably see “the other person was not flirting,” but struggle to see “the other person was flirting.” A third study looked at behaviour. It pooled three speed-dating sessions, 559 people and more than 6600 dates, then followed up. The more distinctive one person's liking for a given partner at the meeting, the more they later messaged and asked that person out. The average correlation for such links was about 0.15 (a weak association). That shows interest lands in behaviours like initiating contact and suggesting meetings. But this study did not compare behaviour against faces and tone for accuracy.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Controversial. Other research argues it is not that men overestimate women's sexual intent, but that women under-report their own intent on questionnaires. Who judges more accurately is still unsettled. The first two studies did not measure behavioural cues. The third shows liking lands in messaging and asking someone out. But “behaviour is more accurate than faces and tone” has not been compared head-on in research; that is the author's inference. The author suggests watching whether the other person initiates, arranges the next meeting, and follows up even when you do not push.

## 4. Whether a relationship is good depends mainly on how you feel in it, not on the other person's attributes

**Cost**. No money, and little time. The hard part is changing the angle: put away the partner checklist and look at how you get along.

**In plain terms**. What best shows whether a relationship is good is how you feel, not the other person's attributes. For example, whether you feel the other person is serious and appreciates you, and how much you argue. Your own feelings are two to four times as useful as what your partner says. But whether the relationship later gets better or worse, basically no questionnaire can calculate.

**Benefit**. A machine-learning analysis of 29 labs and 43 longitudinal paired datasets — longitudinal means following the same couples over time — found that the strongest predictors of relationship quality all came from how each person felt about the relationship: sensed commitment from the other, appreciation, sexual satisfaction, sensing the other's satisfaction, and conflict. Among person-level items the strongest were life satisfaction, negative emotion, depression, avoidant attachment, and anxious attachment. These relationship items explained at most 45% of the variance at the start of the survey. Variance here is the difference in relationship quality between couples; 45% is the part those items can account for. By the end of the study they explained at most 18%. And the predictive power of “items you report yourself” was two to four times that of “items your partner reports.” Adding individual differences and the partner's reports on top of your own relationship feelings added no further predictive power. Whether the relationship got better or worse during the study was largely unpredictable from any set of self-report measures; the original wording is “largely unpredictable from any combination of self-report variables.”

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. To judge whether this relationship is good right now, asking how you feel is more accurate than checking the other person's attribute list, but do not expect to predict how it will go later. The account that links relationship quality to physical health is in item 17 of this section (treat relationship quality as a health account).

## 5. To close distance, take turns answering a set of questions that go from light to deep — do not learn scripts

**Cost**. No money. It takes 45 minutes.

**In plain terms**. Two strangers who take turns answering 36 questions that go from light to deep feel closer after 45 minutes than people who only make small talk for the same time. What works is taking turns telling the truth and going deeper layer by layer, not scripts. This only shows greater closeness at the time, not that it becomes a long-term relationship.

**Benefit**. Pair two strangers and have them take turns answering three sets of progressively deeper questions, 36 in all. Questions range from “Who would you most like to invite to dinner” to “When was the last time you cried in front of someone.” Closeness after 45 minutes was significantly higher than in a control group that made small talk for the same time. It was also higher than the average rating university students in that study gave their closest real-life relationships.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Only one experiment, with university students, measuring short-term closeness only, not whether it becomes a long-term relationship. The closeness in the experiment came from two people taking turns, layer

by layer, saying real things about themselves — not from scripts, routines, or one-sided performance. So what works in conversation is “I say something real, and I ask something equally deep,” taking turns.

## 6. Long-distance relationships are not worse than same-city ones; the real hurdle is the first three months after moving in together

**Cost**. Travel costs, plus time on the road. You meet less often than same-city couples. The hard part is lasting through not seeing each other.

**In plain terms**. While apart, long-distance relationships are actually more stable; research attributes this to idealizing the other person more than reality, and the less you meet the more idealized they become. The real hurdle is after you move in together. In follow-up data about half of long-distance couples reached the same-city step; the other half ended while still apart. Of the half who reunited, one third broke up within 3 months.

**Benefit**. Two studies reach the same conclusion. Long-distance relationships are more stable while apart than same-city ones. The reason is that idealization of the partner is markedly higher in long-distance relationships; the studies measured idealized distortion, romantic love, relationship memories, and perceived agreement. And the less often you meet, the more idealized the picture. But that stability holds only while both sides remain apart; once they become same-city, former long-distance couples are more likely to break up. The study that tracked long-distance to same-city gave these shares: about half of long-distance couples reached moving in together; the other half ended while still apart. Of the half who reunited, one third broke up within 3 months after reunion. Changes participants reported after reunion included: loss of autonomous space, knowing more of both the good and the bad about the other person, hard-to-arrange time, and more conflict and jealousy. Longer gaps between meetings while apart and stronger idealization meant less stability after reunion.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The sample was romantic relationships among US university students, not marriages, and from an earlier period; do not apply the absolute shares directly. Another study surveyed 717 long-distance and 425 same-city people. Quality differences between the two kinds of relationship were small; whether a relationship is good depends mainly on each person's situation and the relationship itself, not on distance. So when deciding on long distance, do not use “long distance always ends” as the reason. What to prepare for is the months after reunion, when autonomous space shrinks, mutual knowledge grows, and conflict and jealousy also grow.

## 7. Look at the registration figures before listening to elders: what the marriage rate and divorce rate each mean

**Cost**. No money. Read the marriage-registration paragraph in the Ministry of Civil Affairs annual bulletin; a few minutes.

**In plain terms**. In 2024 there were 6106000 marriage registrations nationwide, down about one fifth from the year before, and 3513000 divorces. Online claims that the divorce rate is over half take these two numbers and divide them, about 57.5%. But the people divorcing and the people marrying are not the same group, so it cannot be read as half of marriages ending. The bulletin's marriage rate of 4.3‰ and divorce rate of 2.5‰ are divided by the national population.

**Benefit**. In 2024, 6106000 couples completed marriage registration nationwide under law, down 20.5% from the previous year, with a marriage rate of 4.3‰. In the same year, 3513000 couples completed divorce procedures under law, of which 2622000 were divorce registrations at civil-affairs departments and 891000 were court judgments or mediated divorces. The divorce rate was 2.5‰. The bulletin notes that the marriage (divorce) rate = number of marriage (divorce) couples that year / average total population that year × 1000‰. This is a “crude rate”; the denominator is the whole population, not the married population.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The common online claim of a "divorce rate above 50%" divides that year's divorce couples by that year's marriage couples, 351.3 / 610.6 ≈ 57.5%. That is a "divorce-to-marriage ratio." The two numbers are not the same people, and the bulletin has no such indicator, so it cannot be read as "half of marriages end." To calculate "the probability that a marriage eventually ends in divorce," you have to follow the same cohort of marriages over time; this section found no official data of that kind.

## 8. Count marriage's health benefit in, but discount it as observational data

**Cost**. No money and no time. Just remember one point: these figures say married people have lower mortality in the same period — two things occurring together; you cannot tell whether marriage made you live longer.

**In plain terms**. Among older adults, married people's probability of dying in the same period is about 12% lower than non-married people's, and never-married people's is about 24% higher than married people's. But that is only two things occurring together; you cannot tell whether marriage caused it. These figures are mostly from Europe and North America; for China they are only an order-of-magnitude reference.

**Benefit**. A meta-analysis of older adults pooled multiple studies and recalculated them, covering 53 comparisons and more than 250000 people. All were cohort studies — follow-up only, with no randomized comparison groups. Married versus non-married all-cause mortality RR 0.88, 95% CI 0.85–0.91 (RR is the risk ratio; CI is the credible range), about 12% lower probability of dying in the same period. In the same analysis, widowed 1.11, divorced or separated 1.16, never married 1.11 — about 11%, 16%, and 11% higher respectively. No difference by sex. The most conservative estimate was RR 0.94, only about 6% lower. Another meta-analysis compared never-married versus married, using 95 papers and more than 500000000 people. Result HR 1.24 (1.19–1.30), about 24% higher probability of dying in the same period. And the older the age, the smaller the gap. A further meta-analysis split by sex, 21 studies and more than 7890000 people: for both sexes, non-married status co-occurred with total mortality, cancer death, and cardiovascular death. On the male side the gaps for cardiovascular death and total mortality were larger. Never-married men versus never-married women had 31% more stroke deaths and 9% more all-cause deaths.

**Evidence grade**. A (controversial)

**Notes**. The controversy is that people who marry may already be selected — for example, healthier people may be more likely to marry. That is the author's inference from study design; none of the three meta-analyses measured how large selection is. All three used observational data from existing populations — follow-up only, no randomized comparison. The authors themselves noted publication bias or method limits. Roelfs also found that the more rigorous the study, the smaller the gap calculated. These figures are mainly from European and North American samples; for China they are only an order-of-magnitude reference.

## 9. Discussing labor division before marriage helps clarify unpaid work responsibilities

**Cost**. There is no monetary cost. Spend one or two hours before marriage to reach a clear agreement on how household chores, childcare, and elder care — all unpaid tasks — will be divided between partners, then follow that plan. The real challenge lies in having the conversation, not in avoiding it.

**In plain terms**. The national time-use survey measured unpaid work such as housework and accompanying or caring for family. Among people who did such work that day, men averaged 1 hour and 52 minutes a day, and women 3 hours and 29 minutes. The survey was not broken down by marital status, so there is no official figure for how much housework increases after marriage; this gender gap can only serve as an upper-bound reference. Division of labor can be negotiated into a different shape before you register.

**Benefit**. The 2024 National Time Use Survey tracks unpaid labor, which includes housework and family care. On average, people who perform such tasks spend 2 hours and 45 minutes daily on them; men dedicate 1 hour and 52 minutes, women 3 hours and 29 minutes. The proportion of individuals engaging in unpaid labor each day is 67.5% among men and 83.9% among women. Nationwide, residents spend an average of 1 hour and 17 minutes daily on housework; among those who actually do it, the average rises to 1 hour and 59

minutes — a decrease of 28 minutes compared to 2018. Time spent caring for family averages 30 minutes per day; for those involved, it reaches 1 hour and 46 minutes. In 2018, men spent 45 minutes on housework and 17 minutes on childcare, while women spent 2 hours and 6 minutes on housework and 53 minutes on childcare.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Both surveys analyzed data only by gender, urban/rural residence, and age; marital status was not considered. Consequently, no official statistics exist on how much housework increases after marriage; the gender disparity can only be used as a rough upper bound. These figures represent national averages, but couples are free to negotiate a division of labor that suits them — and that is precisely the value of having this discussion.

## 10. For marriage's money account, look first at the law's default rules, then decide whether to make a written agreement

**Cost**. No money. Read the Civil Code marriage-and-family book articles on property. If needed, the two of you sign a written property agreement; the law only requires it in writing, not notarization. The hard part is talking about money in advance.

**In plain terms**. Without a written agreement, the law's default is that wages and bonuses earned after marriage, business and investment returns, and inherited or gifted property are jointly owned. Premarital property, and property a will or gift contract says is for one side only, is personal. The two of you can agree in writing that each keeps their own; once signed it binds. The side that put in more for raising children or caring for elders can claim compensation at divorce.

**Benefit**. The default rules without a separate agreement are: wages, bonuses, and labor remuneration earned after marriage, returns from production, business, and investment, intellectual-property returns, and inherited or gifted property belong to both spouses jointly (Article 1062). Premarital property, personal-injury compensation, property a will or gift contract clearly gives to one side only, and articles for one person's exclusive daily use are personal property (Article 1063). The two sides may agree in writing that premarital and postmarital property belongs to each separately, to both jointly, or partly separately and partly jointly. That agreement binds both sides in law (Article 1065). A side that bears more duty because of raising children, caring for elders, or assisting the other side's work has the right to claim compensation at divorce (Article 1088).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. There are no official statistics for betrothal gifts, weddings, or marital homes; this item does not write figures. How much compensation under Article 1088 is first negotiated by the two sides; if they cannot agree the court decides; there is no fixed formula. A written property agreement helps both sides: the higher earner can use it, and so can the side that does more unpaid housework and care.

## 11. When parents pay for a home, write down at the transfer whether it is a loan or a gift

**Cost**. No money. On the day of the payment write one page stating whether the money is a gift to whom or a loan to whom, signed by the contributing parents and the child. If it is a loan, have both spouses sign, and put the same wording in the transfer note.

**In plain terms**. Money parents put toward a home before marriage is, by default, only for their own child. Money put in after marriage with no agreement is treated as joint marital property. From February (2) 2025, if one side's parents paid the full amount during the marriage and did not write that it was only for their own child, at divorce the court may award the home to that child and then decide whether to compensate the other side. To treat it as a loan, write it clearly that day and have both sides sign.

**Benefit**. Parents' contribution toward a home for the couple before marriage is treated as a gift to their own child personally, unless the parents clearly say it is a gift to both. Contributions after marriage follow any

agreement. With no agreement or an unclear one, they are handled under joint marital property. From 1 February (2) 2025 there is a further rule. Where during the marriage one side's parents paid the full amount and the gift contract did not say it was only for their own child, at divorce division the court may award the home to the contributing parents' child. After that award it weighs several facts to decide whether to compensate the other side and how much: cohabitation and birth of common children, divorce fault, contribution to the family, and the home's market price at divorce. Where one side's parents paid part, or both sides' parents paid, award to one side is based on the source and share of funds, with reasonable compensation (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Writing it clearly helps both sides. Contributing parents need not wait until divorce to invent a loan note to protect the contribution. After Interpretation (II) took effect, who paid the money is itself a basis for dividing the home, not only whose name is on the title. The side receiving the money also need not wait until divorce to learn what the money counts as. If you mean a loan, treat it as a loan: both sides agree it is a loan, agree how to repay, write it on the transfer, and keep repayment records when needed. Missing any of these means explaining in court.

## 12. A large sum one spouse borrows is not automatically your debt if you did not sign and did not later acknowledge it

**Cost**. No money. Do not sign a spouse's loan note or guarantee as “co-borrower” or “guarantor.” Also do not write in chat “we will repay this” or similar; that can be treated as you later acknowledging the debt. The hard part is not answering when pressed.

**In plain terms**. Money a spouse borrowed behind your back is not automatically your debt if it clearly exceeds ordinary household spending and you did not sign and did not later acknowledge it. The creditor must prove the money went to joint life or joint business. But for home-purchase money that really became a home you live in together or own jointly, the other side can often prove that layer.

**Benefit**. Debt in the following situations is joint marital debt. First, both spouses signed. Second, one side later acknowledged it — both accept the debt. Third, one side during the marriage borrowed in their own name for ordinary family daily needs. Money one side borrowed in their own name that clearly exceeds ordinary household spending is not joint marital debt. The exception is when the creditor (the party seeking repayment) can prove the money was used for the couple's joint life, joint production or business, or was acknowledged by both. Home-purchase money clearly exceeds ordinary daily family needs; the burden of proof is on the side asserting the claim — the creditor must produce evidence. But if that money really became a home the couple live in together or own jointly, the creditor can often prove the “used for joint life” layer. So what actually helps is the step in item 11 (when parents contribute, write whether it is a loan or a gift) (nationwide, from 2021).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. When dividing property at divorce, if the other side's parents suddenly produce a loan agreement signed only by your spouse, look at two steps. First, whether the loan really happened. If you say the money was never handed over and can make the reason hold, the court will weigh several facts together: the loan amount, how the money was delivered, both sides' means, how they usually transact, whether property moved accordingly, and what witnesses say. If the other side only has a transfer voucher, they still must prove the loan was established. Second, after the loan is established, whether it is joint debt. General rules for loan notes and guarantees are in Section 8, item 18.

## 13. Registering needs only an identity card plus a signed statement — no household register, no fee, certificate issued on the spot

**Cost**. No money. Both people must appear in person. It usually takes a few tens of minutes.

**In plain terms**. From May (5) 2025, registering needs two things: your own identity card, plus a signed statement. The statement says you have no spouse, and that you and the other person are not lineal blood relatives or collateral blood relatives within three generations. You do not bring the household register, and you need not go back to one person's place of household registration. Registration costs nothing; if you meet the conditions, the certificate is issued on the spot.

**Benefit**. The new marriage-registration regulation, in force from 10 May (5) 2025, changed the materials inland residents must produce to marry. The text says only two things need be produced: “(1) the person's resident identity card; (2) a signed statement that the person has no spouse and has no lineal blood relationship and no collateral blood relationship within three generations with the other party.” The household register is no longer required. The registration authority is “the civil-affairs department of the county-level people's government, or a township (town) people's government designated on the principle of convenience by the people's government of the province, autonomous region, or municipality directly under the central government.” The old regulation's limit of going “to the place of permanent household registration of one of the parties” has been removed. The regulation also says “the marriage-registration authority shall not charge a fee for handling marriage registration,” and “where the parties meet the conditions for marriage, registration shall be made on the spot and a marriage certificate issued.” The situations for refusing registration are four: “(1) not yet of statutory marriage age; (2) not the complete voluntary will of both the man and the woman; (3) one or both already have a spouse; (4) lineal blood relatives or collateral blood relatives within three generations.”

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The registration authority refuses only in four situations: not yet of statutory marriage age, not both completely voluntary, one or both already have a spouse, or the two are lineal blood relatives or collateral blood relatives within three generations. The only possible charges are peripheral services such as photos and copies. Registration itself costs nothing; if you meet “document fees” or “expedite fees,” refuse and complain. The 30-day cooling-off period for divorce registration is in item 15 of this section (cost of leaving). Consequences of holding only a wedding without registering are in item 21 of this section (go and get the marriage certificate even after the banquet).

## 14. Have one premarital medical check before marriage; a serious disease must be truthfully told to the other person before registration

**Cost**. In most places free or reduced for people of eligible age. Self-pay is only a few hundred yuan. It takes half a day.

**In plain terms**. If you have a serious disease and did not truthfully tell the other person before registration, the other person can ask a court to revoke the marriage. The request must be made within one year of knowing. The premarital check itself has not been a precondition for registering since 2003; going is voluntary. Fees follow local policy; it takes half a day.

**Benefit**. The legal consequence of concealment is clear. The new marriage-registration regulation provides that “where one party has a serious disease, that party shall truthfully inform the other party before marriage registration; where that is not done truthfully, the other party may, under Article 1053 of the Civil Code, ask a people's court to revoke the marriage.” The state treats the premarital check as the first gate in preventing birth defects. The current targets are that “the premarital medical examination rate and the coverage rate of the target population for pre-pregnancy eugenic health checks remain above 70% and 80% respectively.” The document also requires “promoting premarital medical examination institutions and marriage-registration places being sited near each other for public convenience,” and promoting “one-stop” service for “marriage registration, premarital medical examination, and fertility guidance.” The Civil Code provides that a party with a serious disease shall truthfully inform before marriage registration; if not, the other party may ask a people's court to revoke the marriage. A request to revoke must be made within one year of the day the person knew or should have known the ground for revocation. The premarital check is not a precondition for registering. A 2022 reply by the Tai'an Municipal Health Commission to a CPPCC proposal stated: “While the 2003 Marriage Registration Regulation cancelled ‘mandatory premarital checks,' it also made clear that

marriage-registration authorities must not attach other duties when handling registration." Article 8 of the current regulation's list of marriage-registration materials also has no premarital-check certificate.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Since 2003 the premarital check has not been a required step before registering; going is voluntary. But "having a serious disease and not saying so truthfully" does give the other person the right to ask a court to revoke the marriage, within one year of knowing. There is no nationwide uniform rule that the check is free. A 2020 notice from the National Health Commission and four other departments only said "actively advocate that localities, in light of their situation, promote free premarital checks." So whether it is free and which items are checked are set locally; ask at the local maternal-and-child health institution or the one-stop window at the marriage-registration office.

## 15. Count the cost of leaving: negotiated divorce has a 30-day cooling-off period; litigated divorce has statutory conditions

**Cost**. No money. Before marriage spend a little time reading: if you ever leave, how long it takes and what procedure. The hard part is thinking about breaking up before you marry.

**In plain terms**. Negotiated divorce is not finished when you sign. Within 30 days after filing the application, either side can withdraw. After that period both must still appear in person within 30 days to collect the divorce certificate; not going counts as withdrawal. If the other side disagrees, you can only sue. The court mediates first; with domestic violence, bigamy, living apart for two full years, and similar situations, if mediation fails the court shall grant divorce.

**Benefit**. Negotiated divorce requires a written divorce agreement and a personal application at the marriage-registration authority (Article 1076). Within 30 days from the day the registration authority receives the application, either side may withdraw. Within 30 days after that period ends, both must personally apply for the divorce certificate; not applying counts as withdrawal (Article 1077). When one side disagrees, go to litigation; the court should mediate first. With bigamy or cohabitation with another person, domestic violence or abuse or abandonment, gambling or drug use that is repeatedly unreformed, living apart for two full years because of emotional breakdown, and similar situations, if mediation fails divorce shall be granted. If divorce was refused and they then live apart for one full year, a new suit shall be granted (Article 1079). In 2024 there were 3513000 divorces nationwide, of which 891000 went through court judgment or mediation.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The cooling-off period applies only to negotiated divorce. Litigated divorce has no cooling-off period, but the cycle is longer. Litigation fees and lawyer fees differ by place; this item does not write figures. A high cost of leaving does not mean you should not marry, but you should know these facts before marrying. If there are children, how to write support and visitation is in item 23 of this section (child support and visitation).

## 16. Keep a separate account for "marrying for your elders"; do not mix it with your own account

**Cost**. No money. On paper write two columns. One column is which benefits in this marriage are yours — earlier items in this section can calculate them. The other is which benefits are the elders': peace of mind, face, and the end of marriage pressure. The hard part is leaving the elders' column alone and not merging it into yours.

**In plain terms**. The elders' share of benefit — peace of mind, face, and an end to pressure — is real. But it does not automatically become your health benefit or relationship quality. The time account, the money account, and the cost of leaving are all borne by you. On paper split two columns for which benefits are yours and which are the elders'; whether the deal is worth it is then visible at a glance.

**Benefit**. The elders' benefit is real. But it does not automatically convert into your health benefit (item 8) or relationship quality (item 4 — whether a relationship is good depends on how you feel). The time account

(item 9), the money account (items 10 to 12), and the cost of leaving (item 15) are all borne by the parties. After you keep the accounts separate, whether “task-style marriage” has high or low cost-effectiveness is something you can see yourself.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The elders' column can also be counted as a very heavy line; how you weigh it is up to you. The fill-in checklist is in chapter 10 “Is dating and marriage worth it”.

## 17. Treat relationship quality as a health account: argue about the matter not the person — no name-calling, no sarcasm

**Cost**. No money. When arguing, speak only about the matter at hand — no name-calling, no sarcasm, no dredging up old scores. The hard part is holding your tongue when angry.

**In plain terms**. Couples with a better relationship tend to have somewhat better health and somewhat lower death risk. The association is not large — about as large as diet's link to health. In one experiment, couples who kept hostility in arguments had experimentally made small wounds heal at only about 60% the speed of calmer couples.

**Benefit**. Pooling 126 studies and more than 72000 people (a meta-analysis). Higher marital quality went with better physical health; the correlation r was between .07 and .21. A correlation of 0 is no relationship; 1 is perfect lockstep. The correlation with lower death risk was r = .11. Smaller cardiovascular reaction when arguing was r = -.13. The authors said these effects are all small — about as large as the link between habits such as diet and health. In another crossover experiment, 42 healthy couples each stayed in hospital twice for 24 hours. Once they had a mutually supportive talk; once they discussed a disagreement. After arguing, experimentally made blister wounds healed more slowly. Couples who showed more hostility in both sessions had wound healing at only 60% the speed of low-hostility couples. On the morning after arguing, their blood inflammation markers (IL-6, tumor necrosis factor) also rose more.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because most pooled studies were follow-up only, with no randomized comparison groups. So you cannot tell whether a bad relationship makes people ill, or poor health makes the relationship worse. Some studies still found the association after subtracting age and income. Robles's original text also notes publication bias in some results. Studies that clearly compared men and women mostly found no sex difference. This section found no pooled analysis that directly compared mortality for “a bad marriage” versus “not marrying.” So “a bad marriage hurts more than not marrying” is only an inference. The wound experiment had only 42 couples. “Argue about the matter not the person — no name-calling, no sarcasm” is the author's practice inferred from “hostile behaviour” in the experiment; no study compared it head-on. If you argue fiercely and cannot change, go to couples therapy together — see item 20 of this section (couples therapy). If arguing turns to hitting, or long-term insults and threats, it is no longer a communication problem; it is domestic violence — see Section 8, item 43 (when you are subjected to domestic violence). To think through whether to leave, the cost of leaving is in item 15 of this section (cost of leaving).

## 18. While both of you are still clear-headed, same-sex partners should put in place an authorization of agency, voluntary guardianship, and a will: in law you are not near relatives; without these you have no signing right and no inheritance right

**Cost**. Voluntary guardianship and a will are done at a notary office; notary fees differ by place, from a few hundred yuan up. A handwritten will costs nothing. It takes one or two half-days in all. The hard part is sitting down to talk about illness and death.

**In plain terms**. Near relatives in law are spouses, parents, children, siblings, and similar; a partner does not count. Without documents in advance, when one side is critically ill the other cannot decide for them. When

one side dies, the other inherits none of the estate. Three documents each cover a stage: while clear-headed, an authorization of agency; after losing judgment, voluntary guardianship; after death, a will.

**Benefit**. Article 1045 of the Civil Code lists near relatives as spouses, parents, children, siblings, grandparents, maternal grandparents, grandchildren, and maternal grandchildren. Article 1127's statutory heirs are first spouses, children, and parents, then siblings, grandparents, and maternal grandparents. A partner is in neither list. Article 1219 covers surgery, special examinations, and special treatment. When the patient cannot or should not be told, medical staff must explain to the patient's “near relatives” and obtain consent. Three paths can fill the gap. First, Article 33 allows an adult and “another individual willing to serve as guardian” to agree in writing in advance who the guardian will be. After the person loses or partly loses civil capacity, that person becomes the guardian, and the guardian is the statutory agent. Second, Article 165 provides that a written authorization of agency must state the agent's name, the matter, the scope, and the term, signed or sealed by the principal. When the principal dies or loses civil capacity, the agency ends. Third, Article 1133 allows a will that gifts personal property to an individual outside the statutory heirs. An article by the Yichang Municipal Justice Bureau on the Hubei Provincial Justice Department website states that same-sex partners can notarize a voluntary-guardianship agreement naming the other as future guardian (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A partner takes the estate as a “legatee,” not as an heir. Within 60 days of knowing of the bequest, they must clearly accept it; silence counts as waiver. The partner and anyone with an interest tied to them cannot be will witnesses. When there are several wills, the last one prevails — see Section 17, item 2 (a later will overrides an earlier one). Whether a voluntary guardian can directly sign surgical consent differs by hospital; ask the hospital you usually use in advance. If family refuse to recognize the documents, you have to sue: ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months; lawyer fees are yours. So do the documents at a notary office when you can. Homes bought together and money saved together should have a separate written agreement by real contribution. How to set up voluntary guardianship is in Section 17, item 1 (name a future guardian in writing). The beneficiaries are you and your partner.

## 19. Do not marry by hiding sexual orientation, and do not treat a marriage of convenience as an easy fix: in law it is a real marriage, and the only exit is divorce

**Cost**. No money. The hard part is withstanding family pressure to marry; that may last many years.

**In plain terms**. Marrying while hiding sexual orientation is not invalid in law and cannot be revoked; the only exit is divorce. A marriage of convenience is also a real marriage; money earned after marriage counts as joint marital property, and debts both signed and debts for ordinary household spending count as both people's. The deceived side can ask at divorce for a larger share of property and compensation for mental harm, but whether courts support that is still unsettled.

**Benefit**. Article 1051 of the Civil Code provides that a marriage is invalid only in three situations: bigamy, a prohibited kinship for marriage, and not yet of statutory marriage age. Articles 1052 and 1053 provide that revocation is available only in two situations: marriage under coercion, and concealing a serious disease before marriage. Article 17 of Interpretation (I) of the Marriage and Family Book provides that a request to confirm invalidity on grounds outside those three is rejected by judgment. So the only exit is divorce. A registered marriage of convenience is also a lawful marriage. Article 1062 provides that wages, bonuses, and labor remuneration after marriage are joint marital property. Article 1064 provides that debts both signed and debts one side borrowed for ordinary family daily life are joint marital debt. Divorce damages are in Article 1091. Situations that support damages are limited to bigamy, cohabitation with another person, domestic violence, abuse or abandonment of a family member, and “other major fault.” Article 2 of Interpretation (I) limits “cohabitation with another person” to cohabitation with an “opposite-sex person outside the marriage.” So a same-sex relationship can only be argued under “other major fault.” Damages include mental-harm damages; the deceived side must raise them together when suing for divorce; if divorce is refused they are not supported. After the Civil Code took effect, no published court judgments of this kind were found. Under

the old law, a 2013 article on the Jiangsu Higher People's Court website discussed a case of a wife suing for divorce because the husband hid homosexuality. The article listed two views. One held that homosexuality was not among the statutory faults then, so neither a larger property share nor mental compensation should be supported. The author favored the other: treat the deceived side as the "fault-free party," care for her in dividing property, and also award mental consolation money (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A larger property share and mental compensation appear in only one analysis article, which did not say how the case was finally decided, so whether you can obtain them depends on the specific court. The Civil Code added "other major fault," giving the deceived side an opening to argue. The statutory text itself is grade A. When both sides in a marriage of convenience each have a same-sex partner, those partners have no protection under marriage law; property must be written separately — see item 18 of this section (same-sex partners put voluntary guardianship and a will in place). Divorce for a marriage of convenience still goes through the 30-day cooling-off period or litigation — see item 15 of this section (negotiated divorce has a 30-day cooling-off period). If a negotiated divorce agreement waives damages, a later suit will not be supported. The first beneficiary is the spouse who would be deceived; next is you: once concealment is discovered, divorce, property division, and child-raising land together.

## 20. When a relationship is stuck in repeated arguments and cold wars, go to couples therapy together: waiting it out almost never fixes itself

**Cost**. Costs money. Charged per session; fees differ by place and hospital; this item does not write figures. Studies usually go once a week; one trial ran about 8 months end to end. The hard part is that both must go and finish.

**In plain terms**. Couples stuck in a relationship who finish couples therapy together are clearly more satisfied with the relationship; about seven tenths improve. Couples who only wait in line show basically no change. But effects fade: by year 5, about half are still clearly better, and about one quarter have already separated or divorced.

**Benefit**. A 2020 meta-analysis pooled 58 studies and 2092 couples. After couples therapy, the before–after change in relationship satisfaction was g = 1.12 (credible range 0.92–1.31); the authors called it a large effect. g is an effect size; see the README glossary. For couples assigned to wait, over the same period g = 0.12 (−0.04 to 0.29), with no clear improvement. Couples who started worse improved more. A 2012 review wrote that couples therapy brought improvement for 70% of treated couples. Another randomized trial took 134 couples in long-term, serious discord through about 8 months of two kinds of behavioral couples therapy. At completion, satisfaction change was d = 0.90 and 0.71. By year 5, 50.0% and 45.9% of couples in the two approaches still had clear improvement. The authors call that clear improvement "clinically meaningful improvement." At the same time, 25.7% and 27.9% had already separated or divorced.

**Evidence grade**. A (controversial)

**Notes**. The controversy is how long effects last. Another meta-analysis that took only randomized trials had g = 0.60 at completion and 0.44 at six months. By 12 months only behavioral couples therapy still had data, g = 0.06 — almost none retained. Another review pooling 20 meta-analyses said clinically meaningful effects appeared in 40% to 50% of people. "Seven tenths improve" and "four to five tenths clearly improve" use different standards; do not mix them. The 5-year trial had no no-treatment control, so you cannot tell whether divorce rose or fell. The 2020 pool was all opposite-sex couples, and no domestic randomized trial was found; discount when applying this to yourself. Where to go in China: the Mental Health Law requires psychotherapy to be done in medical institutions; counseling staff may not provide psychotherapy. Ask hospital psychiatry or psychology departments whether they offer couples therapy. Outside hospitals, first ask about credentials and training. With domestic violence, do not start together. A 2016 meta-analysis said its conclusions apply only to mild-to-moderate situations where both sides hit because of conflict. Violence marked by control of the other person and serious harm is outside its scope. The field also worries about retaliation after going home from a session. If you have been hit, see Section 8, item 43 first (when you are subjected to domestic violence). How to speak when arguing is in item 17 of this section (argue about the

matter not the person); thinking through whether to leave is in item 15 of this section (cost of leaving). The beneficiaries are you and your spouse.

## 21. Even after the wedding and the banquet, go and get the marriage certificate: without registration you are not spouses in law, and if the other person dies you have no spouse's right of inheritance

**Cost**. No money. The two of you go to the marriage-registration office together; a few tens of minutes.

**In plain terms**. After February (2) 1994, holding only a wedding without registering is not marriage in law; it only counts as cohabitation. If the other person dies, you cannot inherit the estate as a spouse. If you want to separate, the court does not handle it as divorce. Making up the registration fixes it, and the effect can be counted back.

**Benefit**. The Civil Code provides that "upon completion of marriage registration, the marriage relationship is established. Where marriage registration has not been handled, it shall be made up." The Supreme People's Court's interpretation splits people who have not registered but live in the name of spouses into two kinds. Those who already met the conditions for marriage before 1 February (2) 1994 are treated as a de facto marriage. After that date, the court "shall inform them to make up the marriage registration." If they do not make it up, it is handled as cohabitation. If one side dies and the other wants to inherit as a spouse, the same principle applies. A spouse is a first-order heir, so the side that never registered is not in that line. For the cohabitation itself, the court does not accept a request to "dissolve" it. It only accepts disputes over dividing property and raising children. After the registration is made up, the marriage takes effect "from the time both parties met the substantive requirements for marriage provided in the Civil Code." Children are not affected. "Children" in the Civil Code inheritance book expressly includes children born outside marriage, who are first-order heirs the same as children born in marriage.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If the other person dies before you have registered, you are not an heir, but you do not get nothing. The Civil Code provides that a person who "provided more support" to the person who died "may be given an appropriate share of the estate." You have to take evidence and argue for that yourself. If you cannot agree, you have to sue. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months; lawyer fees are yours; how much is allotted is set by the judge. So while both of you are still here, go and make up the registration. Making it up is the same as a first registration: both must appear in person; materials are in item 13 of this section (registering needs only an identity card). Betrothal money can be demanded back when there is no registration — see Section 8, item 24 (send betrothal money by transfer). The beneficiaries are you and your spouse.

## 22. When a spouse, behind your back, uses large amounts of joint marital money to tip streamers or transfer it to someone outside the marriage: you can ask to divide joint property without divorcing, and money sent outside the marriage can be sued for return

**Cost**. You have to sue. Lawyer fees are yours; they are not among the litigation costs the losing side must bear. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months and can be extended; summary procedure is 3 months. You also have to dig up transfer records and tipping records one by one yourself.

**In plain terms**. If a spouse, without consulting you, uses joint money for large tips to streamers, you can ask a court to divide the joint property without divorcing. At divorce you can also have that side get less or nothing. Money transferred to someone outside the marriage can be sued for return from the recipient; even if they say it was spent, they still must return it. But all of this means suing; lawyer fees are yours; first instance takes several months.

**Benefit**. The Civil Code provides that spouses have "equal disposal rights" over joint property. Where during the marriage one side hides, transfers, sells, damages, or squanders joint property, the other side may ask a

court to divide joint property without divorcing first. When dividing property at divorce, the side that did so may get less or nothing. If discovered only after divorce, you can sue again for another division. Interpretation (II), in force from 1 February (2) 2025, spells out two situations. Article 6 covers tipping. Where one side, without the other's consent, tips on a livestream platform with joint property in an amount clearly beyond ordinary household spending, that counts as “squandering.” If the other side asks for division during the marriage, or at divorce for the tipping side to get less or nothing, the court shall support it. Article 7 covers gifts outside the marriage. Where one side, for bigamy, cohabitation with another person, or another purpose that breaches the duty of fidelity, gifts joint property to someone else, and the other side asserts the gift is void, the court shall support it. Once void, the recipient must return the money. You can also on that basis ask for division during the marriage, or at divorce for the other side to get less or nothing. In a typical case released with the Supreme People's Court's interpretation, one side during the marriage transferred 730000 yuan over more than 4 years to a person in an improper relationship; that person transferred 170000 yuan back. The court ordered return of the 560000 yuan actually received; the claim that “part of the money had been spent” was not supported (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The tipping rule has a threshold: without your consent, an amount clearly beyond ordinary household spending, seriously harming joint property. Occasional small tips do not qualify. Interpretation (II)'s path for tipping is dividing property and getting less; it does not say you can reclaim from the streamer or the platform. For transfers outside the marriage, what you reclaim is what the other person actually received; amounts they transferred back to your spouse are deducted. You prepare the evidence yourself: bank and payment-app records, tipping records, and chat records that show the relationship. Procedures for dividing property and divorce are in item 15 of this section (cost of leaving). Which money counts as joint property is in item 10 of this section (look first at the law's default rules for the money account). A spouse borrowing outside is in item 12 of this section (a large sum one spouse borrows). Tipping less yourself is in Section 5, item 8 (do not tip streamers). The beneficiary is you. Conversely, if you are the recipient outside the marriage, the money received must be returned — even if spent.

## 23. When a couple with a minor child divorces, write into the divorce agreement who the child lives with, how much monthly support is, and the form and times of visitation: the more specific the writing, the fewer later lawsuits after divorce

**Cost**. Writing it into the agreement at negotiated divorce costs no money. The hard part is sitting down to work out details — which day of the month to pay, which account, which weekend to pick up the child, how to split winter and summer holidays. If you cannot agree you have to sue. The divorce-case acceptance fee is 50 to 300 yuan per case. Lawyer fees are yours; they are not among the litigation costs the losing side must bear. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months and can be extended; summary procedure is 3 months. Disputes over support or visitation after divorce require a separate suit.

**In plain terms**. Who the child lives with, how much is paid each month, and when you can see the child can be written into the agreement by negotiation. If you cannot agree the court decides; with fixed income, support is generally 20% to 30% of the paying side's monthly income. If written amounts are not paid, you can sue to recover them. If the other side blocks visitation, the court can fine or detain them, but it will not forcibly take the child to see you.

**Benefit**. The Civil Code provides that how much support is paid and for how long, and the form and times of visitation, are first agreed by both sides; if agreement fails the court decides. A child under two years old in principle lives with the mother. From age two, judgment follows “the principle most favorable to the minor child.” From age eight, the child's own wishes are to be respected. From February (2) 2025, where one side has domestic violence, gambling or drug use, an affair or cohabitation, or has seized or hidden the child, the court preferentially considers letting the other side raise the child. The support amount looks at the child's actual needs, the parents' means, and local living standards. With fixed income, it is generally 20% to 30% of total monthly income. With two or more children the share may rise, but generally not above 50% of total monthly

income. Without fixed income, refer to that year's total income or the industry average at that share. For example, monthly income of 8000 yuan at that share is 1600 to 2400 yuan a month (self-calculated). Support generally runs to age 18. After an agreement or judgment sets the amount, the child may still when necessary claim reasonable costs above the original amount — for example illness or schooling that exceeds it. An agreement that one side pays no support is also valid. But if the custodial side's living standard falls markedly, or the child's necessary costs rise markedly, the child may still ask the other side to pay. Support not paid as agreed after divorce can be sued for as arrears. After a judgment or mediation document takes effect, if the other side does not perform, you can apply for compulsory enforcement. A person who refuses to assist visitation may be detained or fined, but “compulsory enforcement cannot be carried out against the child's person or the visitation act” (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. 20% to 30% is the court's reference line for judgment, not a floor for agreements; the two of you can agree another figure. When writing the agreement, put payment day, account, and end date clearly, and write visitation to which weekday, what time for pickup and drop-off, and how holidays are split, so there is evidence later. If a parent or relative seizes or hides the child, you can apply to a court for a personal-safety protection order — see Section 8, item 43 (personal-safety protection order). Divorce procedure and the cooling-off period are in item 15 of this section (cost of leaving). The first beneficiary is the child; next is you.

# 11. Common legal pitfalls for programmers and tech professionals

This section's metrics are personal freedom and money — what you get back is “don't get locked up” and “don't pay damages.” People who write code or do technical work often treat the items below as “just technical problems.” In fact they map to specific criminal offenses, or to a concrete civil sum you may have to pay. Each item gives the numbers in the statutes, plus cases published on the websites of the Supreme People's Procuratorate and the Supreme People's Court. Criminal-law citations use the consolidated text “as amended by Amendment (XI) to the Criminal Law” republished by the Beijing Traffic Management Bureau. Item 1 is the general one: how to judge before you act, and what to do first if something goes wrong.

Items in this section are grouped by theme below; numbers in parentheses are item numbers.

**Before you act**: Before acting, ask whether anyone will file a police report (item 1).

**Cheats, scripts, and cracks**: Game cheats and aids (item 2); ticket-snatching, fake-order, and coupon-farming scripts (item 3); crawl only public pages that need no login (item 4); tools that auto-skip or block ads in other apps (item 18); crack patches and keygens (item 20).

**Touching others' systems**: Do not run your programs on others' computers (item 8); do not test others' systems without written authorization (item 9); report vulnerabilities as required (item 10); DDoS traffic attacks (item 21).

**Side gigs and client work**: Development orders for gambling, fraud, or adult-content apps (item 5); circumvention tools and VPN accounts (item 11); AI relay sites (item 19).

**Leaving and ownership**: Hand over account access when you leave (item 6); do not take source code when you leave (item 7); non-compete agreements (item 12); code written with company resources belongs to the company (item 13); GPL and other open-source code (item 14).

**Shipping a product**: Collect only personal information the business needs (item 15); complete ICP filing before launch (item 16); generative-AI security assessment and algorithm filing (item 17).

## 1. Before acting, ask one question: will the vendor, platform, or company file a police report; if you are pursued, hire a criminal defense lawyer at once

**Cost**. No money spent. Before acting, replace “can this be done technically?” with another question: will the vendor, platform, or company file a police report. The hard part is resisting the thought that “nobody will care about something this small,” because investigating authorities have the power to obtain server logs, payment records, and group-chat records

**In plain terms**. Before you act, ask one question: will the vendor, platform, or company file a police report. Investigating authorities have the power to obtain server logs, payment records, and group-chat records. If you are criminally detained, the decision whether to arrest you comes within at most 37 days. From the first questioning you may hire a lawyer; the lawyer can argue to the procuratorate that arrest should not be approved, and can also apply for bail

**Benefit**. Any unit or individual who discovers facts of a crime has the right to report it. If investigating authorities believe there are facts of a crime, they shall open a case. Courts, procuratorates, and public security “have the power to collect and obtain evidence from relevant units and individuals,” and those units and individuals must provide it truthfully. After criminal detention, public security must apply for arrest approval within 3 days (ask the procuratorate for formal arrest). In special circumstances this may be extended by 1 to 4 days. For circumstances such as crimes committed while roaming across places in series, it may be extended to 30 days. The procuratorate then has another 7 days to decide. Added up, the arrest decision comes within at most 37 days. When the procuratorate reviews arrest approval, “if defense counsel requests it, the defense counsel's opinions shall be heard.” Counsel also has the right to apply to change

compulsory measures — for example, replacing detention with bail pending trial — and the investigating authority must reply within 3 days. From the first interrogation, or from the time a compulsory measure is imposed (detention, arrest, and the like), you may entrust a lawyer. While the case is still being investigated by public security, you may only entrust a lawyer. When counsel requests a meeting, the detention center must arrange it within 48 hours at latest. If the likely sentence is control, criminal detention, or another penalty lighter than imprisonment, or only accessory penalties without a principal penalty, bail pending trial is available. Bail means posting a bond or finding a guarantor and going home while the case proceeds. Bail lasts up to 12 months (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. These 37 days count from detention to the procuratorate's decision whether to approve arrest; they are not the upper limit on how long you can be held. After arrest approval there is still a detention period during investigation, which continues to run. Within these 37 days, what a lawyer can do is see the person, submit to the procuratorate an opinion that arrest should not be approved, and apply for bail pending trial. The author's view is that waiting until after indictment to hire a lawyer means the arrest-approval stage has already passed. Every other item in this section is about the same thing: whether the other side has grounds to file a report.

## 2. Do not make or sell game cheats and aids, including AI aids that “only read the screen and never touch memory,” and do not sell modified builds that add features to software such as WeChat

**Cost**. No money spent. The trade-off is giving up income from such orders and “little tools.” The hard part is that the money comes fast and it is unclear who will pursue you

**In plain terms**. Selling a cheat to 20 person-times, or earning 5000 yuan, is enough for up to 3 years; especially serious cases get 3 to 7 years. Someone who made wall-hack and aim-assist cheats sold over 80000 yuan worth in 3 months, got 1 year suspended for 1 year and a 5000 yuan fine. Someone who took server-side code, ran a private server, and took over 20000000 yuan in top-ups got up to 4 years, with fines as high as 10000000 yuan

**Benefit**. Providing programs or tools specially used to intrude upon or illegally control computer information systems, when circumstances are serious, brings up to 3 years and a fine concurrently or alone. Concurrent means prison plus a fine; alone means fine only. Especially serious circumstances bring 3 to 7 years plus a fine. The threshold for “serious circumstances” is providing the tool to 20 person-times or more, or illegal gains of 5000 yuan or more. Illegal gains means the money earned from this. Intentionally bypassing or destroying technical protection measures set by the rights holder may also constitute copyright infringement, with up to 3 years, or 3 to 10 years in serious cases. Official case: Wang and others made and sold cheats that read and modified game memory for wall hacks and aim assist. In 3 months they sold over 80000 yuan and profited over 30000 yuan. Sentence: 1 year suspended for 1 year, fine 5000 yuan. Suspended for 1 year means a 1-year sentence that is not served yet; if you stay clean that year you need not go to prison. Xiang and others sold the “TZ” series of cheats with sales over 200000 yuan; Xiang got 3 years suspended for 3 years and a 20000 yuan fine. Liu and others obtained game server programs, changed parameters, ran private servers, and took over 20000000 yuan in top-ups. Sentences from 4 years to 2 years 6 months, fines from 10000000 to 1300000 yuan. Not only games. A Shanghai company made custom ROMs that added dozens of features to WeChat on the phone — auto-forward, like, mass message, and more. Those phones were sold as “marketing phones,” 2381 units. In 2019 the Shanghai Xuhui court convicted the company of copyright infringement, fined it 500000 yuan, and sentenced the person in charge to 1 year 6 months suspended for 1 year 6 months (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Published cheat rulings all involve reading or writing game memory and bypassing anti-cheat. Aids that “only screenshot or only simulate key presses” have not yet appeared in official rulings. But the ticket-snatching case in item 3 shows that never touching memory and only sending requests can still support a

conviction for illegally obtaining data. Whether it is a crime and under which charge is decided by investigating authorities from materials the vendor submits when reporting — not by the author. Selling to 20 person-times already meets “serious circumstances”; that bar is low.

## 3. Do not write or sell scripts for ticket snatching, flash sales, fake orders, or coupon farming — even if they merely “automate button clicks”

**Cost**. No expense and no time required

**In plain terms**. Even if a script does not modify memory or crack anything and only sends requests faster than a person, it can still lead to a conviction; earning 5000 yuan or causing the other side 10000 yuan in losses is enough. Someone used bought 12306 accounts to snatch over 200 tickets, earned over 20000 yuan, and got 1 year 6 months suspended for 1 year 6 months plus a 5000 yuan fine. Someone who sold ticket-snatching software in an online shop paid 20000 yuan for unfair competition.

**Benefit**. Illegally accessing computer systems or obtaining their data via any technical means can lead to imprisonment of up to 3 years, a fine, or both; more serious cases incur 3–7 years in prison. The threshold for “serious circumstances” is earning over 5,000 yuan illegally or causing losses exceeding 10,000 yuan. Official cases include a person who used a bot to submit numerous ticket-purchase requests using purchased 12306 accounts; he snatched more than 200 tickets and earned over 20,000 yuan, resulting in the same sentence as above. Zheng sold ticket-snatching software for a specific booking app and was ordered to pay 20,000 yuan for unfair competition (national precedent).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Even scripts that do not alter memory or bypass security and merely operate faster than humans still fall under Article 285 of the Criminal Law. Both paid ticket-snatching services and selling such scripts are considered profit-generating activities. No official cases have been reported for individuals using such scripts solely for personal use.

## 4. Crawl only public pages that need no login; do not bypass anti-scraping, do not touch personal information, and do not sell the data you crawl

**Cost**. No money spent. A crawler is a program that automatically flips through web pages and pulls down the data on them. Before crawling, glance at the robots file and any API authorization notes; robots is the file a site puts in its root directory listing which pages must not be scraped. Data that needs a login, a token (a temporary pass string), or a cracked signature to obtain — do not crawl it. The hard part is that technically these data are one grab away; holding back is all self-discipline

**In plain terms**. Bypassing login, token, signature, and similar protections to take data, when circumstances are serious, brings up to 3 years, or 3 to 7 years if especially serious. Crawling personal information is worse. Location tracks, communication content, credit, and property-type information at 50 records already counts as serious circumstances. Accommodation, health, and transaction types at 500 records, other types at 5000 records, or earning 5000 yuan, likewise

**Benefit**. Taking system data by bypassing protections has the same sentencing range as item 3 (ticket-snatching, flash-sale, and fake-order scripts): up to 3 years, or 3 to 7 years. Illegally obtaining, selling, or providing citizens' personal information meets “serious circumstances” at any of the following: location tracks, communication content, credit, or property information of 50 records or more; accommodation, communication records, health, or transaction information of 500 records or more; other personal information of 5000 records or more; illegal gains of 5000 yuan or more. Serious circumstances bring up to 3 years and a fine concurrently or alone; especially serious cases bring 3 to 7 years. Official case: software developer Li disguised a function that stole phone albums as a “looks rating” app and obtained 1751 face photos. He also resold social-engineering database material and got 3 years suspended for 3 years. A social-engineering database is a database that aggregates personal information leaked from various places. A network technology company used a crawler to take store and order data from a food-delivery platform,

caused over 40000 yuan in losses, and was prosecuted for illegally obtaining computer information system data (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A 2017 judicial interpretation provides that "providing to others information lawfully collected, without the person's consent" also counts as "providing." Exporting a user table inside a company to an outside partner falls under the same sentence. 5000 records is only the size of a small table.

## 5. Refuse development orders for gambling, fraud, or adult-content apps; do not set up payment gateways or unblock accounts for such "clients"

**Cost**. No direct monetary cost. The trade-off is forgoing outsourcing projects that pay well but have vague requirements. The difficulty lies in the fact that these clients often offer significantly higher pay than normal projects.

**In plain terms**. If you take a development order knowing it is a gambling app, you are treated as an accomplice in operating a casino. Operating a casino carries up to 5 years, or 5 to 10 years in serious cases — heavier than the at-most 3 years for merely helping. In one e-sports betting app case, 28 people were sentenced under operating a casino to between 1 year and 3 years 6 months. Someone who unblocked QQ accounts for a fraud ring got 1 year 6 months and a 20000 yuan fine.

**Benefit**. Providing technical support or payment settlement services to known online criminals can lead to imprisonment of up to 3 years and/or a fine, especially when the circumstances are serious. If other crimes are also involved, the harsher penalty applies. Operating illegal gambling dens carries up to 5 years in prison plus a fine; serious cases bring 5–10 years. Official examples: Zhangsheng Group developed gambling games and handled "online distribution," earning fees for website setup and reporting; the total illicit revenue reached nearly 7 billion yuan. Its leader was sentenced to 9 years and 9 months plus a 50-million-yuan fine. 79 developers, including Wang Qiang, received sentences ranging from 6 months to 9 years and 9 months. In another case, 28 developers in Hainan who built an e-sports betting app were convicted of operating illegal gambling dens and received similar sentences, plus fines. One individual who ran a studio unblocking QQ accounts for fraudsters got 1 year and 6 months in prison and a 20,000-yuan fine (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. "Knowing intent" does not require the client to explicitly state the purpose. When a quote is far above market rates, the app includes top-up, cash-out, and betting features, and the client refuses to disclose usage, these facts are used to prove you were aware of the illegal nature. Developers of gambling apps are prosecuted as accomplices in operating illegal gambling dens, not under the "Crime of Assisting Information Network Criminal Activities" which caps at 3 years.

## 6. When you leave, hand over all account access; do not delete databases, leave backdoors, or change passwords and lock the system — even if the company owes you money

**Cost**. No money spent. If the company owes you wages, get them back through labor arbitration; do not act yourself (labor arbitration is in Section 7). The hard part is holding back from touching the system while angry

**In plain terms**. Account passwords the company gave you do not mean you may still use them after you leave. Illegally controlling a system, when circumstances are serious, brings up to 3 years. Deleting data so the system cannot run, with serious consequences, brings up to 5 years, or 5 years or more if especially serious. An engineer who was dismissed logged in with the old admin account, deleted data and logs, caused over 120000 yuan in losses, and got 3 years suspended for 5 years plus a 30000 yuan fine

**Benefit**. Illegally controlling a computer information system, when circumstances are serious, brings up to 3 years and a fine concurrently or alone; especially serious cases bring 3 to 7 years. Deleting or modifying system functions or data so the system cannot run normally, with serious consequences, brings up to 5 years;

especially serious cases bring 5 years or more. Official case: senior IT engineer Lü, after being dismissed, logged into the company shared server with the old admin account. He changed the password, deleted data and logs, and caused over 120000 yuan in losses. Sentence: 3 years suspended for 5 years, fine 30000 yuan. Software-company employee Bai deliberately inserted faulty code into an upgrade program so the client system could not log in, causing over 40000 yuan in losses. He was prosecuted for destroying a computer information system (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Account passwords the company gave you do not mean you may still use them after you leave. Logging in with an account beyond the authorized scope counts as intrusion under Prosecutorial Example No. 36; see item 9 (do not test others' systems without written authorization). In Lü's case, after logging in he also changed the admin password and deleted data. The procuratorate found the system had not gone down as a result, so it did not charge destroying a computer information system and charged illegal control of a computer information system instead. Losses include necessary costs of restoring data. Under the 2011 joint judicial interpretation, losses of 10000 yuan or more meet “serious circumstances,” and 50000 yuan counts as especially serious. Lü's losses of over 120000 yuan were found to be especially serious circumstances.

## 7. When you leave, do not take source code, client lists, or technical documents; do not upload them to a personal cloud drive; do not reuse them at the next employer

**Cost**. No money spent. Before leaving, delete company materials from your personal computer and cloud drives. The hard part is that some files are ones you wrote line by line, and you hate to let them go

**In plain terms**. Copyright in code written on the job generally belongs to the company; client lists may also count as trade secrets — taking them is taking the company's things. A former employee who took security-screening system source code to a new company got 5 years and a 500000 yuan fine; the new company was fined 4000000 yuan. Someone who exploited a system flaw to download over 33000 design files got 1 year 10 months. The company can also sue you separately for damages

**Benefit**. Violating confidentiality duties by disclosing trade secrets or using them yourself, when circumstances are serious, brings up to 3 years and a fine concurrently or alone; especially serious cases bring 3 to 10 years plus a fine. The Anti-Unfair Competition Law also lists two acts as infringement: obtaining trade secrets by “electronic intrusion” (technical intrusion into a system); and inducing or helping others to breach confidentiality. Official case: Sun and other former employees took security-screening system source code and core algorithms and used them in a new company's product. Sun got 5 years and a 500000 yuan fine; the new company was fined 4000000 yuan. Tian exploited a system flaw to download over 33000 design files and got 1 year 10 months plus a 100000 yuan fine. Engineer Yang stored App module source code on a personal computer and in the cloud, then built a similar App after switching jobs, and was prosecuted for infringing trade secrets (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Even “code you wrote yourself” generally has copyright belonging to the company; see item 13 (code written with company resources belongs to the company). Taking it is taking the company's things. Client lists are business information and may also constitute trade secrets. Besides a criminal sentence, the company can bring a separate civil claim for damages.

## 8. Do not run your own programs on others' computers, servers, or cameras; do not use company machines for mining

**Cost**. No expense and no time loss

**In plain terms**. Controlling others' computers, servers, or cameras without permission reaches up to 3 years at 20 devices, or 3 to 7 years if especially serious. Even below the criminal threshold, detention of up to 5

days still applies, and a fine of 50000 to 500000 yuan is possible. Anyone who has received a criminal penalty for this is barred for life from key posts in cybersecurity management and network operations.

**Benefit**. Illegally controlling computer information systems is a crime. Serious cases result in up to 3 years in prison plus a fine; especially severe cases incur 3 to 7 years. Controlling 20 or more devices is deemed "serious." Those not meeting criminal thresholds still face confiscation of illegal gains, up to 5 days of detention, and fines ranging from 50,000 to 500,000 yuan. More serious violations bring 5 to 15 days of detention and fines from 100,000 to 1,000,000 yuan. Anyone with a prior public security penalty is barred for 5 years, while those with a criminal record are barred for life from critical cybersecurity and network operation roles. Example: Li was sentenced to 3 years in prison suspended for 5 years and fined 20,000 yuan after using software to illegally control 105 surveillance cameras; Wu and others received 2 to 4 years and 6 months in prison for implanting malware into mobile phone motherboards to harvest verification codes from over 3.3 million devices.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. No published cases from China's Supreme People's Procuratorate or Supreme People's Court address mining on company servers; this entry is written under the legal provision concerning unauthorized system control. The lifelong ban from key roles is an additional consequence under China's Cybersecurity Law, carrying heavier weight for tech professionals than monetary fines alone.

## 9. Do not test others' systems without written authorization; "good intentions" and "reporting afterward" are not defenses in the statute

**Cost**. No money spent. Before joining a vendor SRC or a public bug-bounty test, first obtain a document that states the authorized scope, target list, and allowed testing window. An SRC is a vendor-run security response center that receives externally reported vulnerabilities. Stop once you have verified the vulnerability exists. The hard part is giving up the "quick try" impulse

**In plain terms**. The statute looks at whether you had authorization and how much you obtained — not at what you meant. Obtaining 500 sets of ordinary account passwords, or earning 5000 yuan or causing the other side 10000 yuan in losses, is enough for up to 3 years. Exporting one user table "to prove the bug" often crosses 500 sets in a single pass. Having account passwords and using them outside the authorized scope also counts as intrusion

**Benefit**. Systems of ordinary companies and individuals are computer information systems outside the fields of state affairs, national defense construction, and cutting-edge science and technology. Intruding into such systems, or using other technical means to obtain data stored, processed, or transmitted in them, when circumstances are serious, brings up to 3 years of fixed-term imprisonment or criminal detention, and a fine concurrently or alone. Especially serious cases bring 3 to 7 years plus a fine. "Serious circumstances" has several standards: obtaining 10 or more sets of identity-authentication information (account passwords and the like) for online financial services such as payment settlement, securities trading, or futures trading; obtaining 500 or more sets of other identity-authentication information; illegally controlling 20 or more computer information systems; illegal gains of 5000 yuan or more, or economic losses of 10000 yuan or more. Five times or more of those figures is "especially serious circumstances." Official case: Prosecutorial Example No. 36 established one sentence — "using an account and password to log into a computer information system beyond the authorized scope is an act of intruding into a computer information system." Meaning: you already have the account and password, but using them outside the authorized scope itself counts as intrusion. In that case three people used accounts, passwords, and tokens obtained at work to log into the company's internal system from another place. They downloaded data outside their work scope, sold it online, and had illegal gains of 37000 yuan. They were sentenced to 4 years, 3 years 9 months, and 4 years respectively, each fined 40000 yuan (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Prosecutorial Example No. 36 itself was a case of selling data for profit. It is cited only for the sentence that logging in beyond authorized scope counts as intrusion — not to say that good-faith testing will

be sentenced the same way. Article 285 of the Criminal Law and the 2011 interpretation do not list good intentions or reporting afterward as reasons that it is not a crime. The author infers from that: what you meant to do, and whether you reported afterward, cannot cancel the offense; they may only affect how heavy the sentence is or whether to prosecute. A vendor thanking you first and filing a report later are not contradictory; thanks are not authorization. In 2016, a security researcher commonly called a “white hat” submitted a vulnerability in the Jiayuan site to a third-party vulnerability platform. Jiayuan later reported to police and he was arrested. Jiayuan told reporters the report was because data had been taken, and at the time they did not know the person who took the data was the one who submitted the vulnerability. This case has only media reports, no judgment and no official bulletin; there is no official account of how it ended. No good-faith testing case that can be checked word for word was found on the Supreme People's Court or Supreme People's Procuratorate websites, so this item is graded only from the statute and penalty standards. If you test, go through the vendor's public SRC, or a written engagement, and put scope, targets, and time window in the document. Prove the bug exists with the least evidence; do not bulk-extract data. Conduct below the criminal threshold still faces public-security penalties and occupational bans; fine amounts and years match item 8 (do not run your programs on others' machines). What to do after finding a vulnerability is in item 10 (report vulnerabilities as required).

## 10. Report vulnerabilities as required; before a patch, do not publish details, release exploit tools, or hand them to parties abroad

**Cost**. No money spent. Report the vulnerability to the product provider, or to an official platform. Until the vendor has fixed it, do not publish details or proof-of-concept code

**In plain terms**. Individuals are also covered by the (网络产品安全漏洞管理规定). Before the vendor has a fix, you must not publish the vulnerability, and must not publish vulnerability details for systems currently in use. You must not release programs and tools made to exploit the vulnerability, and when you publish you must also explain how to fix it. Unpublished vulnerabilities must not be given to organizations or individuals abroad other than the vendor

**Benefit**. This regulation covers three kinds of subjects: domestic network product providers, network operators, and organizations or individuals engaged in discovering, collecting, publishing, and similar activities involving vulnerabilities. No organization or individual may use vulnerabilities for activities that harm cybersecurity, or illegally collect, sell, or publish vulnerability information. Publishing vulnerability information to the public must follow five rules. First, do not publish before the product provider offers a remediation measure. Second, do not publish details of vulnerabilities in networks, information systems, and equipment currently used by network operators. Third, do not deliberately exaggerate harm and risk, and do not use vulnerability information for malicious hype or fraud. Fourth, do not publish or provide programs and tools specially used to exploit vulnerabilities for activities that harm cybersecurity. Fifth, when publishing, publish remediation or prevention measures at the same time. Also, unpublished vulnerability information must not be provided to organizations or individuals abroad other than the product provider. The regulation encourages reporting vulnerabilities to four official platforms. One is the MIIT cybersecurity threat and vulnerability information sharing platform. Two is the National Cyber and Information Security Information Notification Center vulnerability platform. Three is the CNCERT/CC vulnerability platform. Four is the China Information Technology Security Evaluation Center vulnerability database. Collecting or publishing vulnerability information in violation is handled by MIIT and the Ministry of Public Security according to their duties. Conduct that meets circumstances under the (网络安全法) is punished under that law. Publishing system vulnerabilities and other cybersecurity information to the public shall comply with relevant state rules. Violations bring orders to correct and warnings from the competent authority, and may bring a fine of 10000 yuan or more and 100000 yuan or less. Refusal to correct or serious circumstances bring a fine of 100000 yuan or more and 1000000 yuan or less. The authority may also order suspension of related business, shutdown for rectification, or closure of the website or application. It may also revoke related business permits or the business license. Persons directly in charge and other persons directly responsible may be fined 10000 yuan or more and 100000 yuan or less (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The regulation expressly includes individuals among those covered; “I'm only an amateur” is not an exception. Submitting a bug in a domestic system to a foreign bug-bounty platform falls squarely under “unpublished vulnerabilities must not be provided abroad.” Whether you are allowed to test is in item 9 (do not test others' systems without written authorization); that is separate from how you handle a vulnerability once you have it. A lawfully found vulnerability can still draw a penalty for unlawful publication; a vulnerability found without authorization has problems on both the testing and the publishing sides. The regulation does not specially address “the vendor was notified but does not fix.” The author's advice is to keep records of negotiation and reporting, and also report to the four official platforms above.

## 11. No selling of tools for bypassing firewalls or VPN accounts, no setting up such nodes for others

**Cost**. No expense or time required

**In plain terms**. Any individual or entity that builds their own outbound network connections or uses international channels outside of state-provided public telecom services may be ordered by police to cease internet access, receive a warning, and face fines up to 15,000 yuan plus confiscation of any illegal earnings. Those running businesses based on such services may be charged with illegal business operations; in severe cases, imprisonment of up to five years applies. This rule specifically addresses selling or setting up such nodes. For personal use only, the maximum penalty remains limited to a warning and fine as stipulated in Article 14 of the provisional regulations.

**Benefit**. Direct international internet connectivity must be facilitated via international gateway channels supplied by state-owned telecom networks. No organization or individual may independently establish or utilize any other channels, meaning neither private outbound connections nor third-party nodes are permitted. Violators face police orders to disconnect from the internet, warnings, and possible fines up to 15,000 yuan plus confiscation of illicit profits. Commercial operators violating this rule may be prosecuted for illegal business operations; severe violations incur up to five years imprisonment plus fines ranging from one to five times the illegal earnings. Particularly egregious cases may result in imprisonment exceeding five years nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. At the time of drafting, no publicly documented court rulings regarding firewall circumvention were found on Supreme People's Court or Supreme People's Procuratorate websites, and regional enforcement practices vary widely; hence this B rating was assigned. This section exclusively addresses selling or setting up such nodes. For personal usage alone, the maximum penalty remains limited to warnings and fines as outlined in Article 14 of the provisional regulations.

## 12. If you signed a non-compete, and after leaving the company does not pay monthly compensation, send a written demand; if unpaid for a full 3 months you may terminate; posts that never touched trade secrets may seek a ruling that the clause does not take effect

**Cost**. No money spent. When you leave, keep the original non-compete agreement and evidence that the company did not pay monthly

**In plain terms**. A non-compete means for a period after leaving you may not work for a competitor — up to 2 years — and the company must pay compensation monthly. If no amount was agreed, pay 30% of average wages over the 12 months before leaving, not below the local minimum wage. If for the company's reasons nothing is paid for 3 months, you may request termination. From 2025, posts that never touched trade secrets may request a ruling that the clause does not take effect

**Benefit**. Non-competes may only bind senior managers, senior technical staff, and others with confidentiality duties. The term is at most 2 years. The company must pay economic compensation monthly during that term. If no compensation amount was agreed, pay 30% of average wages over the 12 months

before leaving, and not below the local minimum wage. If for the company's own reasons nothing is paid for 3 months, the worker may request termination of the non-compete. If the company terminates on its own initiative, it must pay an extra 3 months of compensation. From 2025, workers whose posts never knew or touched trade secrets may request a ruling that the clause does not take effect. If the agreed scope exceeds the secrets they actually knew, the excess is void. Official case: a pharmaceutical company sued CTO Zheng for 7100000 yuan in liquidated damages. The court found the new employer's products were not substitutes for the former company's, that the non-compete scope should be limited to secrets he actually knew, and dismissed the claim in full (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The statute looks only at whether, for the company's reasons, nothing was paid for a full 3 months; a written demand is the author's suggested way to keep evidence. Conversely, if the agreement is valid and the company paid monthly, and you still join a competitor, you must pay the agreed liquidated damages. After paying, you may still be required to finish the remaining non-compete term. Agreements with senior managers, senior technical staff, and similar people with confidentiality duties that also ban competing work while employed are valid even if the company pays no extra money. Aside from non-competes and special training service periods, the company may not agree that you pay liquidated damages; see Section 19, item 22 (being asked for liquidated damages when leaving).

## 13. Code written on work time with company resources belongs to the company; do personal open-source projects on your own time and equipment, and do not mix in company code

**Cost**. No money spent. When you join, read the intellectual-property clauses in the labor contract carefully. The hard part is that personal projects and company work often share one computer and must be kept apart

**In plain terms**. Software written mainly with company equipment, intranet, or business data, for which the company bears responsibility, has copyright belonging to the company; you keep only the right of authorship — and the same if the contract so provides. Code written after hours may still count as the company's if you used a company computer or business data. Inventions made mainly with company resources also have patents belonging to the company

**Benefit**. Works created to complete the unit's work tasks are works for hire (things made while doing the job). In the ordinary case copyright belongs to the author; the unit has priority to use them within its business scope, and for 2 years the author may not license third parties to use them in the same way. But two kinds of cases differ. One is engineering designs, software, and similar works created mainly with the unit's material and technical conditions, for which the unit bears responsibility. The other is works the contract assigns to the unit. In both, the author keeps only the right of authorship. The unit's material and technical conditions means company equipment, intranet, business data, and the like. Inventions completed while performing the unit's tasks, or mainly using the unit's material and technical conditions, are service inventions. The right to apply for a patent and the patent obtained both belong to the unit (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Software is written directly into the “copyright belongs to the unit” category, so programmers almost never fall into the “copyright belongs to the author, unit has two-year priority use” tier. “Written after hours” can still be treated as mainly made with the unit's equipment and materials if you used a company computer, intranet, or company business data. To keep a personal project clean, use your own machine, do not touch company repositories, and do not overlap company business.

## 14. Using open-source code such as GPL in products: Open-source it per the license or switch licenses — don't treat this as “no one cares”

**Cost**. There is no cost involved. Before using someone else's open-source code, check its license for any stated usage terms. The GPL family of licenses requires that any product built using it must also have its

source code released, which conflicts with selling the product as closed-source software for profit. If such a conflict exists, you must switch to another license. The hard part is giving up a library you've already grown comfortable using.

**In plain terms**. Copyright infringement requires you to compensate the copyright holder based on their actual losses or the profits you earned from the infringement. If you commit infringement intentionally and under aggravating circumstances, you may be ordered to pay damages ranging from 1 to 5 times the original amount. One company hired a former employee of a competitor and developed software that was substantially similar to the competitor's product. The company argued that since the competitor's software used GPLv2, it was required to be open-source anyway. The Supreme People's Court ruled that whether a developer complies with GPLv2 or not has no bearing on their copyright rights, and ordered the company to cease infringement and pay 500,000 yuan in damages.

**Benefit**. Copyright infringement demands compensation based on the rights holder's actual losses or the infringer's profits. If neither of these can be accurately calculated, damages are determined by how much it would cost to obtain a proper license for the same software. Intentional and aggravated infringement can also result in 1 to 5 times the standard compensation amount. If the infringement harms public interests, any illegal profits may be confiscated and fines imposed. A relevant official case is Supreme People's Court Civil Appeal No. 51 of 2021. In this case, a defendant hired a former employee of a plaintiff and developed gateway software that was substantially similar to the plaintiff's product. The defendant claimed the plaintiff's software used GPLv2 and thus should have been open-source. The Supreme People's Court reiterated that compliance with GPLv2 and copyright ownership are two separate issues, and ordered the defendant to cease infringement and pay 500,000 yuan in damages nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This case makes it clear that “the other party used GPL code” cannot serve as justification for copying their software. Conversely, there are already effective court rulings in China where GPL authors successfully sue commercial entities that fail to release source code. No original text of these rulings could be found on the Supreme People's Court website, so they are not cited here. This item is graded B because compliance with open-source licenses is governed only by general contract and copyright laws, without any specific legal provisions dedicated to this area.

## 15. For an App, collect only personal information the business needs; for users under 14 get guardian consent; write the privacy policy clearly

**Cost**. No money spent. Before launch, check the App's permission list against the privacy policy and drop permissions you can do without. The hard part is product always wanting to keep some data that “might be useful later”

**In plain terms**. Collect only information the business needs; for users under 14 get guardian consent. For violations, first an order to correct; the App may be stopped. Refusal to correct brings a fine of 1000000 yuan or less, and persons in charge 10000 to 100000 yuan. Serious cases bring a fine of 50000000 yuan or less or 5% or less of the prior year's revenue, and persons in charge 100000 to 1000000 yuan

**Benefit**. Processing personal information shall have a clear and reasonable purpose, be directly related to that purpose, and use the method with the least impact on individuals' rights and interests. Processing personal information requires the individual's consent, or a statutory basis. For those under 14 years of age, consent of a parent or guardian is required. Violations bring orders to correct, warnings, and confiscation of illegal gains from the regulator, and orders to suspend or terminate the offending App's services. Refusal to correct brings a fine of 1000000 yuan or less, and persons directly in charge and other persons directly responsible 10000 to 100000 yuan. Serious circumstances bring a fine of 50000000 yuan or less, or 5% or less of the prior year's revenue. Responsible persons are fined 100000 to 1000000 yuan. Those people may also be barred for a period from serving as directors, supervisors, or senior managers of related enterprises. Selling or providing personal information that constitutes a crime is in item 4 (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The statute does not say which posts count as “other persons directly responsible.” The author infers that people who write code and build the product may also be counted; this book found no case that can be checked word for word. MIIT periodically announces Apps taken down for violations; this section did not verify which specific bulletin, so none is cited.

## 16. Before launching a website or App, complete ICP filing; keep logs for 6 months or more under multilevel protection requirements

**Cost**. Filing is free; use the cloud provider's process — in the author's experience a few days to a few weeks. Multilevel protection assessment is charged by level. Multilevel protection, or dengbao for short, is a set of national security-management actions that grade systems by importance and require websites and systems to meet them

**In plain terms**. Filing costs nothing; domestic servers without filing that refuse to correct will be shut down. Claiming filing is free while actually charging brings a fine of 3 to 5 times illegal gains, or 100000 to 1000000 yuan. Logs must be kept for a full 6 months; refusal to correct or causing consequences brings a fine of 10000 to 100000 yuan

**Benefit**. Commercial internet information services require a license; non-commercial ones require filing. Without a license or filing, you may not operate. Without filing, telecom authorities order correction; refusal brings an order to close the site. Operating without a license brings confiscation of illegal gains plus a fine of 3 to 5 times those gains, or a fine of 100000 to 1000000 yuan. Not displaying the filing number on the homepage brings a fine of 5000 to 50000 yuan. Network operators must, under the multilevel protection system (dengbao), set security management rules, defend against attacks, retain network logs for no less than 6 months, and classify, back up, and encrypt data. Failure brings orders to correct and warnings. Refusal to correct or causing consequences brings a fine of 10000 to 100000 yuan, and persons in charge 5000 to 50000 yuan (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Without filing, access providers must not connect domestic servers for you. How to file, how much the fine is for not posting the filing number, and how to check whether a provider is licensed are in Section 26, item 4 (servers in China need filing). The real traps are two: filing as personal non-commercial while actually charging; and changing domain or entity without updating the filing. The author's view is that keeping logs for 6 months is both a duty and self-protection — when something happens you can show it was not you. Apps and mini programs also need filing before listing; the method is in the same item.

## 17. Before offering generative AI services to the public, complete the required security assessment and algorithm filing, and mark generated content

**Cost**. No money spent, but you must go through the cyberspace authority's process, which takes some time. Tools that do not provide services to the domestic public are outside this measure

**In plain terms**. Generative AI services aimed at the public that can shape opinion or mobilize people need a security assessment and algorithm filing before launch; changes or shutdown also need amendment or cancellation filings. Generated images and video must be marked. Small tools for yourself that are not open to the public need none of this. Violations are punished under laws such as the (网络安全法)

**Benefit**. Providing generative artificial-intelligence services with public-opinion attributes or social-mobilization capacity shall conduct a security assessment per state rules. Algorithm filing under the algorithm-recommendation management rules is also required, plus later amendment and cancellation procedures. Public-opinion attributes or social-mobilization capacity means the ability to affect public views or to organize and mobilize people. Providers shall mark generated content such as images and video. The measure states that when enterprises, research institutions, and others develop or apply generative AI technology and “do not provide generative AI services to the domestic public, this measure does not apply.”

Violations of the measure are “punished in accordance with the (中华人民共和国网络安全法), (中华人民共和国数据安全法), (中华人民共和国个人信息保护法), (中华人民共和国科学技术进步法), and other laws and administrative regulations.” The measure took effect on 15 August (8) 2023 (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This measure itself does not state fine amounts. Violations go back to the (网络安全法), (数据安全法), and (个人信息保护法) for penalties, which is why the grade is B. Civil cases of AI-generated content infringing others' copyright or portrait rights were not verified against original text on the Supreme People's Court site for this section and are not cited. Low-price resale of foreign large-model APIs via relay sites is in item 19 of this section (AI relay sites).

## 18. Do not make or distribute tools that automatically skip or block ads in other apps; even free ones may be held to be unfair competition

**Cost**. No money spent. The trade-off is dropping a popular little tool. The hard part is feeling you made no money and only clicked “skip” for the user

**In plain terms**. Making software that skips or blocks ads in other apps for users may get you sued for unfair competition. Not charging money may still count; the law's “operators” include individuals who provide services. A browser that by default blocked Mango TV's pre-roll ads paid 800000 yuan. An App that let people jump past Mango TV's splash ads paid 80000 yuan in losses

**Benefit**. The law provides that operators must not use technical means to obstruct or disrupt the normal operation of network products or services lawfully provided by other operators. Operators here means natural persons, legal persons, and unincorporated organizations that provide goods or services. Harm to the other side is compensated by the other's actual losses, or by the benefit you gained, plus reasonable expenses the other side spent to stop the infringement. Market regulators may also fine 100000 to 1000000 yuan, or 1000000 to 5000000 yuan in serious cases. Official case: 720 Browser's built-in feature by default intercepted Mango TV's site pre-roll and pause ads. First instance dismissed Mango TV's claim. Guangzhou Intellectual Property Court on appeal reversed, found unfair competition, and awarded 800000 yuan in economic losses and reasonable expenses. In 2021 the Supreme People's Court listed it as a model case. The “Lan Jingling” App let users jump past Mango TV's splash ads. First instance ordered it to stop and pay 80000 yuan in economic losses and 10000 yuan in reasonable expenses. In April (4) 2024, Beijing Intellectual Property Court affirmed on appeal. The appeal court held it had in substance blocked the splash ad, not merely clicked “skip” for the user (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Both judgments used the pre-amendment text. After the 2025 revision this provision moved to Article 13 and also covers data, algorithms, and platform rules. The appeal courts said the finding was about blocking; users clicking “skip” themselves are unaffected. In August (8) 2023, the free Android ad-skip tool “Li Tiaotiao” received a lawyer's letter from Tencent. The letter said it blocked ads in Tencent Browser, constituted unfair competition, and demanded takedown within 48 hours. The developer said it was public-interest and non-profit; reports said it only took occasional tips. It still announced an indefinite pause in updates, and several similar apps stopped too. This matter has only media reports, no lawsuit and no judgment. An individual developer who gets a lawyer's letter either stops or pays for a lawyer to defend. First-instance ordinary procedure starts at 6 months; lawyer fees are generally paid by yourself. Writing a script only for yourself — no pursued cases found. Selling ticket-snatching software and paying for unfair competition is in item 3 of this section (ticket-snatching and flash-sale scripts). The beneficiary is you yourself.

## 19. Do not build an “AI relay site” that resells foreign large-model APIs at low prices: a Shanghai site operator has already been criminally detained

**Cost**. No money spent. The trade-off is dropping a low-barrier side business that looks good on paper. If you truly want model aggregation, go the proper route — get operating permits and connect officially authorized models; that costs both money and time

**In plain terms**. An AI relay site is a website that resells foreign large-model APIs at low prices. A Shanghai site operator said he was criminally detained for 37 days for this, is now on bail, will definitely be sentenced, and has already returned illicit gains. The Ministry of State Security has also issued a warning that some relay sites lack operating qualifications and some privately send user data abroad

**Benefit**. In June (6) 2026 the Ministry of State Security issued a risk warning. It said AI relay sites are a proxy layer between users and model vendors' official services. Some relay sites lack operating qualifications. Some, without data-export compliance credentials and without the statutory security-assessment process, send user-input data to servers abroad. Some also let users bypass network-access, official-authorization, and cross-border transmission limits. China Newsweek reported a case in June (6) 2026. In May (5) 2026, a Shanghai relay-site operator posted a shutdown notice in a tech community. He said that for illegally obtaining large-model APIs he had been criminally detained by Shanghai police for 37 days and was now on bail. He said he “will definitely be sentenced,” had already returned illicit gains, and would still pay a fine. The report said such relay sites bulk-register or buy foreign large-model subscriptions, host overseas servers as jump hosts, and resell to domestic users at low prices (nationwide / Shanghai)

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. This case has only media reports and the party's own account — no judgment and no police bulletin — so there is no official statement of the charge. Specific charges and sentences circulating online come from lawyers' articles and are not cited here. So one cannot say “running a relay site is always a crime,” only that someone has already been criminally detained for it. Doing model aggregation properly requires an operating permit to charge fees; see Section 26, item 2 (fee-charging sites need a license). Offering generative AI to the public needs filing; see item 17 of this section (generative-AI security assessment). Sending user data abroad has statutory conditions; see Section 26, item 10 (user information leaving the country). Users of relay sites have separate risks; see Section 14, item 10 (AI relay sites). The beneficiary is you yourself.

## 20. Do not write, sell, or distribute crack patches, keygens, or cracked software; once sales hit the numbers, it is sentenced as copyright infringement

**Cost**. No money spent. The trade-off is dropping fast money from selling cracks, registration codes, or cracked dongles. Do not post crack patches to forums or cloud drives either. The hard part is that cracking looks like technical work, not like theft

**In plain terms**. Registration-code checks, dongles, and similar verification are a software's technical measures; bypassing them without permission is infringement, and you must pay even if you charge nothing. Cracking or selling crack tools for profit — earning 30000 yuan or selling 50000 yuan — is enough for a criminal sentence, up to 10 years. Someone who made cracked dongles paired with pirated software for sale saw three co-defendants get between 1 year and 3 years 2 months

**Benefit**. Civil side first. The Copyright Law allows rights holders to add technical measures to works. Technical measures are effective technology, devices, or components that prevent or restrict others from using a work without permission. Without the rights holder's permission, no one may intentionally bypass or destroy technical measures. No one may manufacture, import, or provide to the public related devices or components for bypassing technical measures. No one may intentionally provide technical services to others for bypassing technical measures. Computer software is a work; doing any of these is infringement and requires stopping the infringement and paying damages. Damages are by the rights holder's actual losses or what you earned. If that cannot be calculated, refer to what a normal license would cost. Intentional

infringement with serious circumstances brings 1 to 5 times. If public interest is also harmed, the copyright authority may confiscate illegal gains. Illegal business volume of 50000 yuan or more may be fined 1 to 5 times that amount. Below 50000 yuan or if the amount cannot be calculated, a fine of 250000 yuan or less is possible. Criminal side next. Amendment (XI) to the Criminal Law wrote “intentionally bypassing or destroying technical measures” into the crime of copyright infringement, on the premise of profit. Illegal gains of 30000 yuan or more, or illegal business volume of 50000 yuan or more, bring up to 3 years, with a fine concurrently or alone. At 10 times those figures, the sentence is 3 to 10 years plus a fine. Someone who knows another person is committing copyright infringement and still provides devices, components, or technical services mainly used to bypass or destroy technical measures faces the same crime once the same thresholds are met. Official case 1: From March (3) 2019 to July (7) 2022, Liu made “dongles” that could bypass software technical measures for profit. He also copied pirated software and sold it together with the dongles. His illegal business volume was over 1060000 yuan. Shanghai No. 3 Intermediate People's Court found especially serious circumstances and sentenced him for copyright infringement. The Supreme People's Procuratorate said this was the first nationwide “intentionally bypassing or destroying technical measures” copyright-infringement case after Amendment (XI) took effect. In April (4) 2023, Shanghai courts sentenced the three defendants in this string of cases to between 3 years 2 months and 1 year, some suspended, with fines from 700000 to 80000 yuan. Official case 2: Medical-equipment repair worker Liu spent 80000 yuan in a QQ group to buy 50 cracked dongles, then resold them online for a few thousand yuan each. Plugging one in bypassed the medical equipment's identity check and entered the maintenance software. Shanghai Putuo court sentenced him to 1 year 2 months, suspended, plus an 80000 yuan fine. Official case 3: From May (5) 2021, Li and others in Xuzhou had crack programs made for game machines and produced crack devices to sell. Illegal business volume was over 39000000 yuan. In November (11) 2024, 10 people were sentenced to between 3 years 6 months and 2 years 6 months, some suspended, with fines from 11000000 to 1500000 yuan (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The beneficiary is you yourself. The Copyright Law leaves a few openings: testing the security of computer systems and networks, and doing encryption research or software reverse-engineering research, may bypass technical measures. But the same article says you must not provide the bypassing technology, devices, or components to others. So your own research is fine; distributing or selling is not. Free distribution of crack patches does not meet the crime of copyright infringement, because that crime requires profit. Civil infringement still stands; the software company can send a lawyer's letter and sue for damages. Litigation first-instance ordinary procedure starts at 6 months; lawyer fees are generally paid by yourself. Putting a whole cracked software package online for download counts as disseminating a work without permission; the criminal threshold is in Section 9, item 24 (sharing cloud-drive resources). Game cheats that bypass anti-cheat are in item 2 of this section (game cheats and aids).

## 21. Do not help launch DDoS traffic attacks; do not sell or rent “stress-test” traffic platforms; if you lose a game, do not attack the other side's servers either

**Cost**. No money spent. DDoS means controlling many machines to send requests at a target at once until the server is unusable. The trade-off is dropping a per-hit or packaged traffic business, and also holding back a moment of anger. When conflict arises in a game or in business, use reports, complaints, and police reports — do not pay someone to attack

**In plain terms**. Using DDoS so others' websites, servers, or games cannot open is the crime of destroying a computer information system. Serious consequences bring up to 5 years; especially serious consequences bring 5 years or more. People who pay a platform to attack are also joint offenders. Someone who ran a DDoS site collecting membership fees and taking orders got between 10 months and 5 years 6 months

**Benefit**. Interfering with the functions of a computer information system so it cannot run normally, with serious consequences, brings up to 5 years of fixed-term imprisonment or criminal detention. Especially serious consequences bring 5 years or more. Courts treat DDoS as the “interference” here. “Serious

consequences” has several standards. One is that the main software or hardware of 10 or more computer information systems cannot run normally. One is illegal gains of 5000 yuan or more, or economic losses of 10000 yuan or more. Another is that a system serving 10000 or more users cannot run normally for a cumulative 1 hour or more. Machine counts or money amounts at 5 times those figures count as especially serious consequences. Knowing someone is committing such destruction and still providing programs or tools for destruction is punished as joint crime. The threshold is illegal gains of 5000 yuan or more, or providing to 10 person-times or more. Providing server hosting, technical support, and similar help with illegal gains of 5000 yuan or more is the same. Providing programs or tools specially used to intrude upon or illegally control computer information systems — at 20 person-times or more, or illegal gains of 5000 yuan or more — brings up to 3 years and a fine concurrently or alone. Below the criminal threshold, interfering with computer information system functions or providing such tools, when harm results, brings detention of up to 5 days, or 5 to 15 days if more serious. Official case 1 (Prosecutorial Example No. 69): In early 2017, Yao Xiaojie and others were hired to form the “Dark Night Group” abroad. They bought large amounts of server resources and used malware to launch DDoS. They attacked three times the IPs of three game companies on a cloud of an internet company; games could not log in and users dropped frequently. The victim company spent over 40000 yuan on emergency repair. In June (6) 2018, Shenzhen Nanshan court sentenced 11 people to 1 to 2 years for destroying a computer information system. Official case 2: In March (3) 2017 Tang and Wang built a DDoS website that could top up membership and submit attack tasks. They took orders and launched traffic attacks on over 80 target IPs. Nantong Haimen court sentenced Tang and others to between 10 months and 5 years 6 months for destroying a computer information system. Zhang, who ordered attacks on that site to suppress competitors, submitted over 100 attack tasks against 11 IPs or domains of rival companies. The court found the orderers and the site operators were joint offenders. The orderer was the one who initiated and was a principal offender. Official case 3: Wang built a DDoS platform and sold attacks under clear “bronze,” “silver,” “gold,” and “diamond” packages. Beijing Haidian procuratorate charged him with illegally using information networks; in 2020 first instance he got 1 year and a 50000 yuan fine (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The beneficiary is you yourself. These platforms wear a “stress test” label. Testing your own system, or a system the other side has authorized you in writing to test, is a stress test. Hitting others' servers is the same idea as item 9 (do not test others' systems without written authorization). Which charge applies to running a platform that takes orders is not uniform across places. The Haimen case used destroying a computer information system, with a top of 5 years 6 months; the Haidian case used illegally using information networks and got 1 year. A People's Court Daily commentary said practice is not entirely consistent, and the case library treats it as destroying a computer information system. In Prosecutorial Example No. 69, the attacked internet company filed a report. Public security sent the electronic data it provided to the Guangdong branch of CNCERT/CC for analysis, which found 14 control-end servers. Chat logs and bank records confirmed the purchase of control over those servers. Selling malware that controls others' computers is in item 8 of this section (do not run your programs on others' machines).

# 12. Starting a business: don't bet the family savings

This section counts only money and legal liability—not life expectancy. When you open a shop or form a company, which steps can wipe out your own money, family money, and your spouse's money together? What does the law require, and can you wall them off in advance? Items written from experience only, with no literature behind them, are grade C.

Items in this section are grouped by theme below; numbers in parentheses are item numbers.

**Before opening, don't bet the nest egg**: Only put in money you can afford to lose (item 1); don't sign personal guarantees on company loans (item 2); pick the right entity before you open (item 3); don't be a nominal shareholder (item 4); check franchise filing before joining (item 5); ask the right questions before paying someone to run your online store (item 24); when raising money for a business, only approach relatives, friends, and employees (item 26); put a partnership shop in a written agreement (item 28).

**Registration and licenses**: Fix name, premises, business scope, and registered capital before registration (item 6); don't open until licenses are in hand (item 7); before leasing a shopfront, check whether that unit can host your trade (item 27).

**Food**: See which regulatory tier you fall into (item 8); prepackaged food labels (item 9); ordinary food must not claim to treat disease (item 10); criminal lines for food (item 11).

**Tax, annual reports, and invoices**: File on time even with zero income (item 12); issue invoices only for real transactions (item 13); anyone posing as the tax bureau demanding payment is a scam (item 14); file last year's annual report online in the first half of each year (item 25).

**Contracts and hiring**: When taking money, write deposit (定金), not booking-fee wording (订金) (item 15); sign employment contracts within the first month (item 16); pay wages per contract and law (item 17); follow procedures on the job (item 22).

**Products and sourcing**: Sell first, then make (item 18); run samples through a mass-production checklist (item 19); keep purchase receipts and upstream supplier details (item 20); use your own designs or buy a license (item 21).

**Exit**: If you lose money, exit by the book (item 23).

## 1. Only put in money you can afford to lose; don't touch family savings or borrow to open

**Cost**. No money. Before you start, set a cap: you could lose every yuan of it and still pay the mortgage, support the kids, and see a doctor. Don't invest above that cap. Family money and borrowed money don't count toward the cap. The hard part is when the business looks like it's picking up and you want to pour in more.

**In plain terms**. Debts of a sole proprietorship come out of assets in your name. If it's unclear whether the whole family ran the business, creditors can reach family property. A company doesn't fully shield you either: when the company can't pay, what you promised as subscribed capital but haven't paid yet can be called in early. Size your stake by «I could lose it all and still pay the mortgage and medical bills».

**Benefit**. Losing money isn't the only risk. For a sole proprietorship, if you ran the business alone, debts are paid from property in your name (personal property). If the family ran it together or who ran it is unclear, debts are paid from family property. Debts both spouses signed count as joint marital debt; later assent by one spouse counts too. A loan in one spouse's name still counts as joint debt if the creditor shows it went into the couple's shared business. For companies there is another rule: subscribed capital is what a shareholder promised at registration. When the company can't pay a due debt, creditors may demand early payment of the portion not yet due (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. «Affordable to lose» means losing it all wouldn't force you to sell the home or borrow from relatives to plug the hole. This round found no verifiable official statistics on how many firms survive or how long they last on the National Bureau of Statistics or State Administration for Market Regulation sites, so the text gives legal consequences only, not headcount figures—grade B.

## 2. Don't sign personal guarantees on company loans; spouses should stay off the signature line

**Cost**. No money. When a bank, supplier, or landlord wants a «shareholder personal joint-and-several guarantee» or a spouse's signature, pause. That page is you giving up «company debt stays with the company» (limited liability). Don't sign if you can avoid it. If you must, choose «general guarantee» only and write a clear cap on how much you guarantee. The hard part is «no signature, no loan»—you have to hold the line.

**In plain terms**. «Joint-and-several guarantee» means if the company doesn't pay, the creditor can skip the company and come straight to you. «General guarantee» means sue or arbitrate against the company first, sell company assets, and only then collect any shortfall from you. If your spouse signs too, both households' assets are in play and the company's «limited» liability stops protecting you personally.

**Benefit**. Guarantee wording means «if the debtor doesn't pay, you pay». With «joint-and-several guarantee», creditors need not pursue the company first—they can demand payment from you directly. With «general guarantee», they must sue or arbitrate against the company and have the court enforce on its assets first; only the remainder can be collected from you. Debts both spouses signed count as joint marital debt; later assent counts too. A spouse's signature puts both sides' family assets on the hook (nationwide, from 2021).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The author's experience is that banks lending to small and micro enterprises often require shareholder personal joint-and-several guarantees; this book found no official statistics. Loans are still available; know what that page costs before you sign, and keep guaranteed amounts within the «affordable to lose» cap in item 1. General rules for IOUs and guarantees: section 8, item 18.

## 3. Pick the right entity before opening: sole props and general partners pay to the end; only LLCs are «limited»

**Cost**. Register on the local government services portal—a few hours once. After you form a limited liability company, monthly bookkeeping and tax filing are ongoing: your time if you do it yourself, or paid bookkeeping, with prices varying by region.

**In plain terms**. Sole proprietors and general partners owe without limit—pay what you owe until it's cleared. LLC shareholders owe only up to what they subscribed at registration. But whatever you subscribe must be paid in within 5 years: write 1000000, you may owe up to 1000000. Mix company books with household books or use the company to dodge debt, and «limited» can fail. With only one shareholder, you must prove the books are not mixed.

**Benefit**. Sole proprietorship debts are paid from personal property or from family property. General partners in an ordinary partnership bear unlimited joint and several liability—pay in full until cleared, and a creditor may demand the entire debt from one partner alone. Limited partnerships are different: limited partners are liable only up to subscribed capital. LLC shareholders are also liable only up to subscribed capital. «Limited» fails in three situations. First, subscribed capital must be fully paid within 5 years of formation, and when the company can't pay due debts, creditors may demand early payment. Second, capital withdrawn after contribution must be returned. Third, using the company as a shell to dodge debt and seriously harming creditors makes you personally jointly liable for company debts. One-shareholder companies are stricter: that shareholder must prove company funds and personal funds are separate; if not, personal liability follows. Courts mainly look at whether money and books are separate. Shareholders casually spending company

money without books, or mixing company and personal accounts, count as mixing (nationwide, from July 2024).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Keep company and personal accounts separate; don't take customer payments on a personal card; don't pay household bills from the company; keep complete books. Don't inflate registered capital for show.

## 4. Don't be a nominal shareholder or hold shares for someone else

**Cost**. No money. When someone asks to «borrow your ID for a shareholder slot» or «hold shares in your name for now», refuse.

**In plain terms**. If your name is on the register, you're a shareholder in law. Pay subscribed capital on time; miss the deadline and you owe make-up plus company losses. If another founder didn't really pay in at formation, you share liability for the gap. Someone else runs the business; the debt sits on your name.

**Benefit**. A registered shareholder is a legal shareholder. Pay subscribed capital in full by the deadline in the articles; otherwise pay the shortfall and compensate company losses. If a founder didn't contribute at formation, other founders at formation share joint liability for that gap. When the company can't pay due debts, creditors may demand early payment of capital not yet due. The operator isn't on the register; the obligation is still yours (nationwide, from July 2024).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A nominee agreement between the nominal holder and the actual investor is valid unless a statutory invalidity applies. The actual investor can't get their name on the register without consent from over half of the other shareholders. If the nominal holder sells or pledges shares, courts apply Civil Code good-faith acquisition rules: a buyer who didn't know, paid a fair price, and registered may keep the shares; the investor can only sue the nominal holder. A draft new interpretation was released in September 2025; when finalized and in force it replaces the current text. As of September 2026, the 2020 amended version remains in force—this item follows it. Risks of being a nominal legal representative: section 8, item 28.

## 5. Before franchising, check MOFCOM filing, get written disclosure, and put a cooling-off period in the contract

**Cost**. No money. On the Ministry of Commerce «Commercial Franchise Information Management System» site, check whether the brand is filed. Before signing, require written disclosure of everything they must tell you, together with the contract text. A few hours.

**In plain terms**. By rule the franchisor needs at least 2 company-owned stores open 1 year, and must file with commerce authorities within 15 days after signing. Before signing it must give you 12 topics in writing—fees, when deposits return, how existing stores perform, and more. No filing, no disclosure, or pay-before-you-see-contract: walk away.

**Benefit**. Regulations require the franchisor to have at least 2 directly operated stores running 1 year or more. Within 15 days of the first franchise contract it must file with the commerce department; no filing: fine 10000–50000 yuan; still unfiled after the deadline: 50000–100000 yuan plus public notice. Before signing it must deliver written disclosure on 12 items—including fee types and amounts, deposit refund conditions, franchisee count and how stores are doing, audited report summaries for the last 2 years, and litigation and arbitration in the last 5 years. The contract must also state that the franchisee may unilaterally terminate within a period after signing. Concealment or false disclosure lets the franchisee cancel the contract (nationwide, from May 2007).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. No filing, no disclosure file, or pay-before-reading contract: leave. «Cooling-off» is the post-signing window for unilateral exit; the regulation only says «a certain period», so get the day count written in. On disclosed average sales, gross, or net profit for existing franchisees, ask how the brand sourced the numbers—

the rules require disclosure of sources. Schemes that skip «franchise» and only charge «store operations» or «opening training» fees: item 24.

## 6. Before registration, fix name, premises, scope, and registered capital; with complete papers you can get the license on the spot

**Cost**. Registration itself costs nothing. Enterprise and sole-proprietorship registration fees have not been collected since 1 January 2015. Do it yourself on the local government services site or at the service hall—a few hours once. Seal carving, paid bookkeeping, and a registered address (address hosting) are market services, not government fees.

**In plain terms**. Registration is free; the registration fee has not been charged since 2015—if someone charges you, it is not the registration fee. Only five material types are required: application, identity or eligibility proof, premises documents, articles or partnership agreement, plus anything else the rules name. Complete papers: license on the spot; if not on the spot, within 3 working days; complex cases get 3 more working days.

**Benefit**. The regulation fixes the materials as five items. «(1) Application form». «(2) Applicant qualification documents and natural-person identity proof». «(3) Domicile or main business premises documents». «(4) Articles for companies, non-company enterprise legal persons, farmer specialized cooperatives (unions), or partnership agreement». «(5) Other materials required by laws, administrative regulations, and the State Council market supervision department». In plain language: one application; proof of who you are or that you're eligible; proof you may use the shop or office; articles or partnership agreement; plus anything else named. Companies also submit appointment documents and ID for the legal representative, directors, supervisors, and senior managers. Sole props don't file articles. The name is «declared by the applicant according to law»—you choose and report it. Registered capital uses «subscribed registration»—state how much you promise; you need not pay at the counter. Business scope is chosen from the authority's published categories. Complete and correctly formatted materials are «confirmed and registered on the spot». If not finished on the spot, «within 3 working days», with up to 3 more for complex cases. «The business license issue date is the market entity's establishment date»—the printed date is when the company or shop is born (nationwide, from March 2022).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Registration itself is free. Charges are for agency help, seal carving, and similar market services. Seal prices are market-set. A 2018 General Office of the State Council document says applicants choose the seal maker themselves and forbids designating one—so you need not accept «must use the designated shop». How much registered capital you write does not dress up the storefront; it only caps your liability, and it must be paid within 5 years—see item 3. If scope includes licensed activities, don't open until licensed—see item 7.

## 7. Licensed trades: don't open until the license is issued

**Cost**. No money. Before opening, check whether your line needs a license. Catering and selling food need a food business license. Selling only others' prepackaged food needs no license—file for record instead. Open only after the license or filing is done.

**In plain terms**. Opening without a license is handled by the department that governs that license under its rules. With no business license and no specific penalty rule: ordered to stop, illegal gains confiscated, plus a fine of up to 10000 yuan. Selling monopoly or restricted goods, or doing securities, futures, insurance, or payment settlement—serious cases are illegal business operation; the lowest tier is up to 5 years.

**Benefit**. Operating without authorization is handled by the department the law designates. No license where the law doesn't spell out a penalty: stop, confiscate gains, fine up to 10,000 yuan. Heavier track: monopoly or restricted goods without permission, or securities, futures, insurance, or payment settlement without approval—serious cases are illegal business operation, up to 5 years' imprisonment or short-term detention plus a fine of 1–5 times illegal gains; especially serious, above 5 years (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Finance, medical, and training each have their own licensing laws; this item only checked generic enforcement and criminal articles. Milk tea and snack shops are catering—food business license required. Renovate-first, trial-before-license is a common trap. Food tiers and whether fresh meat and vegetables need a license: item 8.

## 8. For food, know your tier: production and catering need a license; prepackaged-only sales need filing; fresh meat and vegetables need no license

**Cost**. The license itself is free. Premises and equipment must meet standards; site inspection plus processing take weeks. Meat sellers must also keep quarantine certificates and meat quality inspection certificates for each batch.

**In plain terms**. Make and sell yourself—snack shop, braised goods, baking, homemade pickles—all need a license; small workshops and street vendors follow provincial rules. Sell only others' fully packaged food: no license; file with the county-level or higher market supervision department. Fresh meat, vegetables, and the like need no license. Operating without a license: even if goods value is under 10000, fine 50000–100000 yuan.

**Benefit**. Food Safety Law: food businesses need a license first—produce food, sell food, or do catering, all need a license by law. «However, selling edible agricultural products and selling prepackaged food only do not require a license. Selling prepackaged food only shall be filed with the local county-level or above people's government food safety supervision department.» Edible agricultural products are unprocessed fresh meat, vegetables, and the like. Prepackaged food is made by others and sold in packaging. «Specific management rules for small food production workshops and food vendors are set by provinces, autonomous regions, and municipalities»—those two tiers follow provincial rules. Operating food without a license: confiscate illegal gains, food, tools, equipment, and raw materials. If goods value (sale-price total for the batch) is under 10000 yuan, additionally fine 50000–100000 yuan; if 10000 yuan or more, fine 10–20 times goods value. Pig Slaughter Management Regulations: pigs only at state-designated slaughter plants with official centralized quarantine. «Except personal self-slaughter for own consumption in rural areas, no unit or individual may engage in pig slaughter without designation.» «Pig products sold or used by sellers, meat processors, catering operators, and centralized meal units must come from designated slaughter plants with quarantine and meat quality inspection passed.» So pork you sell or use must come from designated plants, with both quarantine and quality inspection passed. Private slaughter outside designated plants: ordered shut down; pigs, slaughter tools and equipment, and illegal gains confiscated; fines match the unlicensed-food tier above. Animal Epidemic Prevention Law: sold or shipped animal products must carry quarantine certificates and marks with the goods; missing them: order correction, then fine up to one times the value of comparable compliant goods. Judicial interpretation covers punitive damages—extra pay beyond a refund. Food made or sold by small workshops or vendors that fails food safety standards: buyers claiming tenfold damages should be upheld by courts (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Thresholds for small workshops, small catering, and food vendors are set by provinces—no specific numbers here. On your provincial market supervision site search «食品小作坊小餐饮小摊贩管理条例» for the local version. Selling homemade food online does not skip a license where one is required. Entity and license setup: item 6. Whether other trades need a license: item 7. How much buyers can claim: section 5, item 31 (tenfold food damages).

## 9. Bagged for sale is prepackaged food: production date, shelf life, and ingredient list on the label—none may be missing

**Cost**. Printing labels costs a few fen to a few jiao each. Filling dates and ingredients correctly for every batch takes some time.

**In plain terms**. Food put in packaging and sold is prepackaged food in law; the package must have a label, and nine items are mandatory—including production date and shelf life. Bulk food must still show name, dates, and the seller's name and address. Missing required marks: goods value under 10000 ⟶ fine 5000–50000; at or above 10000 ⟶ fine 5–10 times goods value.

**Benefit**. Food Safety Law: prepackaged food (food sold in packaging) must have a label. The label must show name, specification, net content, production date, composition or ingredient list, producer's name, address, and contact, and shelf life. Also product standard code, storage conditions, the national-standard generic names of food additives used, and production license number. Anything else required by laws, regulations, or food safety standards must also appear. Bulk food is unpackaged and weighed to order. Selling bulk food: containers and outer packaging must show name, production date or batch number, and shelf life, plus the operator's name, address, and contact. Producing or selling prepackaged food without a label, or with a label or instructions that don't meet this law: confiscate illegal gains and the food. If goods value is under 10000 yuan, additionally fine 5000–50000 yuan; if 10000 yuan or more, fine 5–10 times goods value. Serious cases: ordered to stop production or business, up to license revocation. Labels or instructions with only minor defects that don't affect food safety or mislead consumers: ordered to correct first; fine up to 2000 yuan only if they refuse. The new Prepackaged Food Labeling General Standard is numbered GB 7718-2025, issued 16 March 2025. It takes effect 16 March 2027, with a two-year transition. It requires an independent area on the package showing both production date and shelf-life end date together. Dates must use high-contrast, easy-to-read type and color, in year-month-day order (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Label problems split into two tiers; fines and damages follow that split. Minor defects—typos, nonstandard font size—that don't affect safety or mislead: market supervision only orders correction; refuse and fine up to 2000 yuan; buyers also get no tenfold damages. Missing required marks—such as production date or shelf life—are not minor. Judicial interpretation says so expressly. Fines by goods value: under 10000 yuan ⟶ 5000–50000 yuan; 10000 yuan or more ⟶ 5–10 times goods value. Buyers may also claim tenfold the food price, minimum 1000 yuan if tenfold is lower (section 5, item 31). GB 7718-2025 line-by-line requirements were checked only to the dates and display method in the announcement and official interpretation; exact format follows the standard text.

## 10. Ordinary food must not claim to treat disease—labels, instructions, ads, and live-stream scripts count

**Cost**. No money. Review ad copy, product detail pages, and live-stream scripts. The hard part is not saying «lower the three highs» or «treat constipation».

**In plain terms**. Labels, instructions, and ads for ordinary food must not claim disease prevention or treatment. Except medical, drug, and medical-device ads, no other ad may claim treatment or use medical-sounding words. Penalty: 1–3 times ad spend; if spend can't be figured, 100000–200000 yuan. Serious cases can revoke the business license.

**Benefit**. Food Safety Law: «Labels and instructions for food and food additives must not contain false content and must not involve disease prevention or treatment functions. Producers and operators are responsible for the content of labels and instructions they provide.» «Food advertising shall be true and lawful, must not contain false content, and must not involve disease prevention or treatment functions. Food producers and operators are responsible for the truth and legality of food ad content.» Packaging, instructions, and ads can't claim prevention or cure; sellers answer for what they write. False or misleading food ads are penalized under the Advertising Law. The Advertising Law also bans: «Except medical, drug, and medical device advertising, no other advertising may involve disease treatment functions, and must not use medical terms or terms that easily confuse the promoted goods with drugs or medical devices.» Except those three ad categories, no ad may claim treatment or use drug- or device-sounding words. Violations: stop the ad; the advertiser must publicly clarify and remove impact in the scope where it ran; fine 1–3 times ad fees. If fees can't be calculated or are clearly understated: 100000–200000 yuan. Serious: 3–5 times fees, or 200000–1000000 yuan; the business license may also be revoked (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. «Health functions» aren't for ordinary food either. Health functions health foods may claim come only from the national catalog, and the product must be registered or filed—ordinary food has no such path. How buyers spot such language: section 6, item 10. Beyond packaging and ads, detail pages, live-stream scripts, and Moments copy count as ad content too; once posted they leave a trail.

## 11. Food has criminal lines: diseased or substandard meat can be a crime; toxic adulteration starts at five years regardless of sales

**Cost**. No money. Follow item 8: keep quarantine certificates and purchase proofs; put only ingredients with traceable approval numbers on the label.

**In plain terms**. Earlier items fine money; this one can put you in prison. Selling diseased meat, failed-inspection meat, or goods with pesticide, veterinary-drug, or heavy-metal residues far over limits: up to 3 years. «Sufficient» to cause serious poisoning is enough—no need for someone to have been harmed. Adding toxic or harmful non-food substances to food: starts at up to 5 years, regardless of how much you sold.

**Benefit**. Criminal Law Article 143 covers this tier. Food you produce or sell that doesn't meet food safety standards and is «sufficient to cause a serious food poisoning accident or other serious foodborne disease» is already an offense—up to 3 years' imprisonment or short-term detention plus a fine. Serious health harm or other serious circumstances: 3–7 years plus fine. Especially serious consequences: 7 years to life, plus fine or full property confiscation. Article 144 covers adulteration. Adding toxic or harmful non-food raw materials to food you produce or sell, or selling knowing it was adulterated: up to 5 years' imprisonment plus fine. Serious health harm or other serious circumstances: 5–10 years plus fine. Death or other especially serious circumstances: penalties under Article 141 (10 years or more, life, or death). An SPC and SPP interpretation lists what counts as «sufficient to cause serious food poisoning or other serious foodborne disease»: (1) pathogenic microbes, pesticide residues, veterinary-drug residues, biological toxins, heavy metals, or other contaminants far above limits; (2) meat or products from livestock, poultry, animals, or aquatic animals that died of disease, of unknown cause, or failed inspection and quarantine; (3) goods the state expressly bans producing or selling for disease control or similar special needs; (4) foods for special medical purposes or main and complementary foods for infants and young children whose nutrition severely fails food safety standards. Additive overuse or misuse that can cause the above outcomes is also sentenced under Article 143. What counts as «toxic or harmful non-food raw materials» is not your call: substances laws ban adding to food, and substances on lists announced by relevant State Council departments—such as banned pesticides or drugs banned for food animals. Another «other serious circumstance» under Article 144: producing or selling 100000 yuan or more but under 200000 yuan; sites at or around primary or secondary schools, childcare, or elder-care institutions; selling to minors or older people. Unlicensed pig slaughter and sales outside designated plants, when serious, may be sentenced as illegal business operation; sales of 100000 yuan or more, or illegal gains of 50000 yuan or more, count as «serious» (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The line versus the previous three items is whether food safety itself was breached. No license, missing label items, or cure claims ⟶ fines. Diseased meat, over-limit goods, wrong additives, non-food adulteration ⟶ criminal process. The cheapest defense is still the item 8 checklist: meat only from designated slaughter plants; quarantine certificates and meat quality inspection certificates for every batch; ingredients only with traceable approval numbers. «Discount meat» and «trim of unknown origin» are where food criminal cases most often start. The original Supreme People's Court Gazette page returned 502 this round, so two provincial official reprints were cited and cross-checked word for word.

## 12. Once you have a license you must file returns; zero income still means on-time zero filing (a return that is all zeros)

**Cost**. No money. File yourself on the e-Tax portal monthly or quarterly—minutes each time. Paid bookkeeping is a separate market expense. If you hire people, also register for social insurance within 30 days from the formation date. The hard part is remembering to file on months with no business.

**In plain terms**. After the license, file taxes on schedule. Earn nothing—you still file, with zeros throughout. Failure to file: ordered to correct within a time limit, and may be fined up to 2000 yuan; serious cases, 2000–10000 yuan. Skip all tax types for three straight months and the system automatically marks you as an abnormal taxpayer—you can't issue invoices.

**Benefit**. «Taxpayers with no tax payable in the period shall still file tax returns as required»—zero tax due that period, the form is still due. Late filing: «the tax authority shall order correction within a time limit and may impose a fine of up to 2000 yuan; if the circumstances are serious, a fine of 2000 yuan or more and up to 10000 yuan.» Fail to file and underpay: tax is recovered, daily late fees are added, plus a fine of 50% or more and up to 5 times the underpaid tax. Late fees accrue at 0.05% per day. «If no tax return is filed for any tax type for three consecutive months, the tax collection system automatically designates the taxpayer as an abnormal account and stops use of the invoice purchase book and invoices.» Three months of no filing → abnormal status; you can't obtain or issue invoices. After catch-up filing and accepting the penalty, status clears automatically. Employers who hire people «shall, within 30 days from the date of establishment … apply to the local social insurance agency for social insurance registration» (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. After «multi-certificate integration» you don't separately register for tax. Log into e-Tax with the unified social credit code on the business license, confirm registration information, and declare which taxes you owe. Sole proprietors and individual-owned enterprises pay individual income tax on business income—prepay «within 15 days after the end of the month or quarter», then «complete annual reconciliation by 31 March of the year after the income was earned» (year-end true-up, refund or top-up). LLCs pay corporate income tax—prepay monthly or quarterly; annual reconciliation «within five months from year-end», deadline 31 May of the next year. No opening still means filing; zero filing is still filing. Leave it three months and you become abnormal; invoices stop. The 2025 enterprise deregistration guide states that before tax deregistration an abnormal taxpayer «must first clear abnormal status and make up tax filings». How to exit: item 23.

## 13. Issue invoices only for real transactions; small-scale taxpayers should use the full VAT exemption allowance

**Cost**. No money. Don't buy invoices, sell invoices, or issue invoices for someone else's sham bookkeeping. Invoice and file taxes only for business that actually happened.

**In plain terms**. Through the end of 2027, small-scale taxpayers with monthly sales under 100000 yuan or quarterly sales under 300000 yuan owe no VAT. Where the rate would have been 3%, it is cut to 1% for the same period. The other way around, paying someone to issue invoices so you can offset tax is fictitious invoicing: starts at up to 3 years, plus a fine of 20000–200000 yuan.

**Benefit**. Businesses that are small and tax under the simplified method are small-scale taxpayers. The law says «sales that have not reached the threshold are exempt from VAT». That line is the threshold. From 1 January 2026 through 31 December 2027, the threshold is 100000 yuan by month or 300000 yuan by quarter. Per transaction or per day it is 1000 yuan; below that line, no VAT. In the same window, the 3% rate is cut to 1%, except sales and rentals of real estate and transfers of land-use rights. On the flip side, issuing VAT special invoices—or other invoices usable for tax offset—without a real purchase or sale is fictitious invoicing. Up to 3 years' imprisonment or short-term detention, plus a fine of 20000–200000 yuan. Issuing for others, for yourself, having others issue for you, or introducing others to issue all count. Larger tax amounts involved: 3–10 years. Huge amounts: 10 years or more, or life (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The VAT Law took effect on 1 January 2026. The two earlier small-taxpayer relief notices—2023 No. 19 and 2023 No. 1—stopped applying or were repealed. The amount thresholds did not change, but the legal basis did; this item follows the new texts. The Criminal Law page cited is the 1997 version; Article 205's imprisonment tiers were later adjusted by amendments—only the tiers verified here and left unchanged are listed. What is exempt is VAT; income tax is separate. «Having someone issue invoices to offset costs» is fictitious invoicing, not tax saving.

## 14. Anyone claiming to be the tax bureau and pressing you by phone or message to pay into a designated account is a scam; handle tax only through e-Tax and 12366

**Cost**. No money. For calls, texts, or friend requests about a «tax spot check», «account anomaly», or «fine if you don't file», hang up and don't reply. Then call 12366, or the competent tax authority's listed landline, to verify.

**In plain terms**. Tax authorities will not phone you for bank-card passwords, payment passwords, or SMS verification codes, and will not give you an account to wire tax into. Real on-site audits must show an inspection notice and inspector credentials. Hang up first, then verify on 12366. If you already transferred money, call 110 or 96110 at once to stop payment.

**Benefit**. The State Taxation Administration's notice states: «Tax authorities will not ask via WeChat mini-programs, phone, SMS, or similar channels for bank-card passwords, payment passwords, account balances, or SMS verification codes related to card payments.» «Some lawbreakers impersonate tax officials and contact taxpayers under names such as «help with tax filing», «preferential-tax agency», or «policy coaching».» To verify, call «the 12366 tax and fee service hotline or the competent tax authority's fixed-line number». Real on-site audits (inspections) «must present an inspection notice and inspector credentials». «Tax may be paid only through the e-Tax bureau or at a tax service hall; tax authorities will not provide a designated account.» Tax-service intermediaries have their own rule: «Extorting taxpayers or withholding agents in the name of tax authorities or tax personnel» is fined by severity. Impersonating state-organ staff to defraud: detention of 10 days or more and up to 15 days, and may add a fine of up to 1000 yuan. If both fraud and impersonation apply, «convict and punish under the heavier provision» (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These scams target newly registered sole proprietors and small companies. The script is «the system shows you haven't filed; handle it today or be fined», then a private official account or mini-program charging a few hundred yuan—while that filing is free and takes minutes on your own. Hiring a market bookkeeping firm is legal, but it is not a government office and will not demand payment in the tax bureau's name. If you already paid or transferred, follow section 8, item 2 (stop payment after fraud)—call 110 or 96110 at once. Impersonating market regulators over a missed annual report and paid «agency» is the same playbook; see item 25 (annual reports are free).

## 15. When you take money, write "earnest deposit", not "booking payment". Write the penalty as a number, and review a payment term as if you were lending

**Cost**. No money. Write “earnest deposit” in the contract. The amount does not exceed 20% of the contract total. Take the money before you deliver. Before you agree to let the other side take the goods and pay later (a payment term), check them first.

**In plain terms**. Only the words “earnest deposit” bring the double rule: if you break the deal, you do not get this money back; if they break it, they return double. The part above 20% of the contract amount does not count. Written as a booking payment, the law has no such rule. Giving a payment term is lending them your money for nothing. If they go under, it is a bad debt.

**Benefit**. Earnest money counts only once the money has actually been handed over (it is established on actual delivery). If the side that paid the earnest money breaks the deal, that money is not returned. If the side that received it breaks the deal, it returns the original sum and pays another equal sum on top (double return). The part above 20% of the contract total (the subject amount of the main contract) is not counted as earnest money. If the agreed penalty is absurdly higher or absurdly lower than the actual loss, the court may, at one side's request, adjust it down or up. If both a penalty and earnest money are written into the contract, a real breach lets you claim only one of them. You cannot take both (nationwide, from 2021).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. "booking payment" has none of the earnest-money rules in the Civil Code. It is generally treated only as a prepayment. That is the common way of speaking in practice. This section has not checked the cases. Paying a reservation earnest money on a new home, and then not signing the formal contract, has a separate set of rules. See item 11 of section 15 (reservation earnest money). A payment term is an interest-free loan of your own money to the other side. If they go under, it is a bad debt. Before you give a payment term, check their record on the National Enterprise Credit Information Publicity System, and see whether they have been sued.

## 16. Sign a written labor contract within the first month; register for social insurance within 30 days

**Cost**. The employer share of social insurance must be paid continuously; rates vary by locality. The contract itself costs nothing—use the local human-resources department's template.

**In plain terms**. If someone works a full month without a written contract, from the second month you owe double wages each month until the end of the first year. Social insurance must be registered within 30 days of hire; failure to register and failure to correct after the deadline draws a fine of 1–3 times the premiums due. There is no «employee voluntarily waives social insurance» in law.

**Benefit**. If employment reaches one month but stays under one year with no written contract, double wages are owed every month. From day one of work, social insurance registration is due within 30 days. Failure brings an order to correct first; after the deadline, a fine of 1–3 times the premiums due, plus 500–3000 yuan on the person who handled registration. Late or insufficient social-insurance payment adds late fees at 0.05% per day from the due date; still unpaid after the deadline, another fine of 1–3 times the arrears. The employer must declare and pay in full on time. Only statutory force majeure such as natural disaster allows delay or reduction. There is no «employee voluntary waiver» (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Double wages run from the second month through the end of the first year—delay gets more expensive. An employee without a contract or without social insurance who is injured at work, or who arbitrates after leaving, often costs far more in back premiums, fines, and compensation than any savings. How employees claim double wages: section 19, item 20.

## 17. Pay wages per contract and law; put raises, loans, and bonuses in writing

**Cost**. No money. State wages clearly in the contract. Raises, bonuses, advances, and loans all need a signed paper—no oral promises. Don't pay staff from your personal pocket on the company's behalf. The hard part is sticking to this when acquaintances ask.

**In plain terms**. Wages must be paid on time and in full per contract and law. If wages are owed, the employee can ask a court for a payment order. Oral promises on raises, bonuses, or advances lose in a dispute if you can't prove them. Money you lend an employee isn't forced into writing by law between natural persons, but write an IOU with amount, interest, and repayment date.

**Benefit**. A labor contract must specify how wages are paid and how social insurance is handled. The employer must pay wages timely and in full per the contract and state rules. Unpaid wages allow a direct

application for a court payment order. An owner lending personal money to an employee is a loan contract. The Civil Code says: «A loan contract shall be in writing, except where natural persons agree otherwise.» An owner lending to an employee is exactly a loan between two natural persons—the law does not force writing. Contract content «generally includes loan type, currency, purpose, amount, interest rate, term, and repayment method.» Writing an IOU covering those items is the author's advice. Oral bonus promises without paper leave the party without evidence at a disadvantage (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. This is not about refusing to help—it is about helping through rules. Favors outside the system that become habit are hard to stop without conflict. Mixing personal loans with company books leaves bad debt on you if the company fails. Statutory parts were verified; the advice is experience, hence grade C.

## 18. Sell first, then produce: use pre-sales and small orders to prove demand before you invest in production

**Cost**. Tens to hundreds of yuan for a sample or a landing page, then reach dozens of real customers for prepayment or small orders. That is slower by weeks than making stock first. The hard part is not producing before anyone pays.

**In plain terms**. An Italian study found that founders who set a hypothesis and tested it against market feedback ran better businesses. They were also more likely to pivot in time, and did not quit earlier. So if nobody prepays or places a small order, don't trust «make it and buyers will appear».

**Benefit**. A randomized controlled trial tracked 116 Italian startups for about one year. A randomized controlled trial randomly splits people into two groups, trains only one, then compares outcomes. Founders trained to decide by «hypothesis first, then strict market-feedback tests» performed better. They were also more likely to pivot to other plans in time, and early dropout was not higher. Projects that look viable but can't work—the authors call them false-positive projects. The authors' explanation is that this approach cuts the chance of pouring more money into such projects (Italy, published 2020).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Only this one study, small sample, Italy only—grade B. Title, venue, and abstract were checked via Crossref and Semantic Scholar; effect sizes in the full paper were not verified here. Operationally: no prepay and no small order means don't believe «make it and buyers will come».

## 19. Run the sample through a mass-production checklist before you commit to a production run

**Cost**. A few hundred yuan for a small trial batch, plus hours to nail down yield—how many of 100 units are salable. Supplier minimum order and payment terms, cash tied in inventory, packaging and logistics, certifications and licenses, and trademark each need a line. The hard part is not skipping straight to full production.

**In plain terms**. One prototype versus a thousand units differs in where money sits. Yield sets true unit cost. Minimum order and payment terms set how much you advance. Inventory sets when cash returns. Products on the mandatory certification list cannot leave the factory or be sold without certification and the mark on the product.

**Benefit**. The prototype-versus-thousand-unit gap is where capital is locked. Yield sets true cost—yield is what share of a batch is qualified and salable. Supplier minimum order quantity and how long after shipment until you get paid (payment terms) set how much you advance. Inventory sets when cash returns. Products on the mandatory product certification catalogue must pass certification and bear the mark before leaving the factory and being sold. Selling without certification is penalized under the certification and accreditation regulations. Catering and food sales need a food business license (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The checklist is practical method; statutory parts were checked at source. Before production, search the CNIPA trademark system for similar marks, then file yours. Trademark and artwork red lines: items 20 and 21. The mandatory certification catalogue follows the latest SAMR list.

## 20. Keep invoices and supplier records for every purchase batch; skip goods priced far below market—if staff buy counterfeits for the company, the owner can still be the one convicted

**Cost**. No money. For each batch keep purchase contract, invoice, payment record, and the upstream party's business license and authorization. Set an internal rule: whoever buys signs; never accept prices clearly below market. The hard part is passing up cheap stock that looks profitable.

**In plain terms**. Selling counterfeits: illegal gains of 30000 yuan, or sales of 50000 yuan, meets the criminal threshold—up to 3 years. Unsold warehouse stock counts if goods value reaches three times the sales threshold. «I didn't know it was fake» is not yours alone to decide: buying far below market without a good explanation supports knowledge. Keeping purchase contract, invoice, payment trail, and upstream identity is the path to the no-damages defense.

**Benefit**. Knowingly selling goods bearing counterfeit registered trademarks: illegal gains of 30000 yuan meets the criminal threshold; sales of 50000 yuan likewise. Up to 3 years plus a fine, or a fine alone. At ten times those levels: 3–10 years plus fine. Unsold stock still counts: goods value at three times the sales threshold or more is also a crime. «Knowing» need not be admitted. A 2025 SPC and SPP interpretation lists five situations where knowledge is presumed unless you prove otherwise: (1) knowing the registered trademark on the goods was altered, swapped, or covered; (2) forging or altering the trademark owner's authorization, or knowing it was forged or altered; (3) prior criminal or administrative penalty for selling counterfeits, then selling the same kind again; (4) no reasonable grounds, buying or selling far below market; (5) after discovery by administrative or judicial authorities, moving or destroying infringing goods and accounting records, or providing false proof. When a company commits this offense, «the unit is fined, and the directly responsible managers and other directly responsible persons» are punished under the same article—so even if staff sourced the goods, the person who approved still faces judgment. Trademark law leaves an out: selling without knowing the goods infringe another's registered trademark, «if you can prove lawful acquisition and identify the provider, you bear no compensation liability». Whether that defense works depends entirely on invoices and upstream identity; without them you can't use it (nationwide; interpretation effective 26 April 2025).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Cosmetics, liquor, baby goods, electronics, and apparel see many of these cases—large price spreads on the same SKU. «Channel stock», «end-of-line», and «overseas duty-free» do not replace paperwork. Beyond criminal liability there is administrative penalty: infringing goods and tools confiscated; illegal turnover of 50000 yuan or more can draw a fine of up to 5 times turnover. If stock already bought turns out wrong, stop selling, seal it, and contact the brand or market regulators—don't keep selling, and don't destroy goods and books; destruction fits presumption (5) above. Artwork rules: item 21. One scam targets this item: someone offers free pens or other small goods to sell in your shop for a split; days later a buyer takes them and documents the sale for an infringement claim. Free goods lack all three conditions for the no-damages defense: no purchase contract or payment record, no real provider you can name, and a clearly abnormal price. «Lawful acquisition and identify the provider» can't apply. So door-to-door free stock with only a WeChat contact stays off the shelf. Real consignment needs a written agreement, copies of ID and business license, and who owns the goods and who bears infringement written in.

## 21. Art on products, packaging, tags, and ads must be yours or licensed—recoloring or adding icons is not «changed enough»

**Cost**. Licensed stock art from tens of yuan per image; original design, hundreds to thousands of yuan. Keep license proof and purchase record for every image used on goods. The hard part is not grabbing random web images.

**In plain terms**. Changing colors, swapping the background, or slapping on your own icon on someone else's work is still unlicensed use. Reproducing others' fine-art works for profit—illegal gains of 30000, turnover of 50000, or 500 copies—can be copyright infringement, up to 3 years. On trademarks, «likely to cause confusion» is infringement by itself.

**Benefit**. Copyright law lists «using a work by adaptation, translation, annotation, or similar means without the copyright owner's permission» alongside direct copying as infringement. So recoloring, changing the background, or adding your own icon is still unlicensed use of someone else's work. The criminal threshold: for profit, without the copyright owner's permission, you reproduce and distribute fine-art works. Three numbers trip the offense: illegal gains of 30000 yuan; illegal business amount of 50000 yuan; or 500 copies (sheets) or more. Hit any one and it is copyright infringement—up to 3 years plus fine, or fine alone. At ten times those levels: 3–10 years. Only selling others' infringing copies: illegal gains of 50000 yuan or more, or sales of 100000 yuan or more—crime of selling infringing copies, up to 5 years. Trademarks likewise: two «likely to cause confusion» situations are infringement by themselves—using a similar mark on the same goods, or the same or a similar mark on similar goods. «Similar» is an express statutory infringement form. Editing someone else's trademark and reusing it still infringes if confusion is likely (nationwide; interpretation effective 26 April 2025).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Three common slips: (1) web cartoon or celebrity images printed on clothes, mugs, phone cases; (2) fonts—commercial fonts usually need a separate license; free preview is not free commercial use; (3) client design drafts that include unlicensed assets—liability still sits with the seller. Easiest path: commercial stock with saved license pages, or a design contract stating asset source and license scope, with the designer liable if something goes wrong. Beyond criminal exposure, civil damages and admin fines: harm to public interest can mean confiscation of illegal gains and a fine of 1–5 times illegal turnover. Pre-production trademark check: item 19. If others use your art, the same rules apply for enforcement. Criminal lines for posting others' comics or shows online for ads or membership fees: section 9, item 24.

## 22. Work within posted procedures; before off-book favors, decide who bears liability

**Cost**. No money. Follow rules, medical orders, and process at work. Don't decide outside your authority for others. Before helping, ask who is responsible if something goes wrong. The hard part is refusing on-the-spot «just bend the rules» requests.

**In plain terms**. Nurses, for example: regulations require immediate physician notice when a patient is critically ill, and raising non-compliant orders with the prescribing physician. Other jobs are the same—know where your procedures draw the «must report» line. Separately, voluntary emergency aid that injures the person helped does not create compensation liability.

**Benefit**. Taking nurses as the example, regulations set duty boundaries as follows. Critical illness: notify the physician at once. In emergencies to save a critically ill patient, necessary emergency care may be given first. Illegal or non-standard medical orders: raise them with the physician, and report to the department head if needed. The Civil Code adds: voluntary emergency assistance that harms the rescued party—the rescuer bears no civil liability (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Inside your role, follow procedure; emergency rescue is legally protected. For everything else, separate whose authority and whose responsibility it is—don't replace institutional decisions with personal

favors. Nurse Regulations 2020 revision (State Council Order 726) changed registration articles only; Article 17 was untouched. Physician Law clauses on practicing to clinical standards could not be opened from official text this round, so they are not quoted.

## 23. When you are losing, exit by the book: simplified deregistration if you qualify, bankruptcy if insolvent—don't walk away

**Cost**. Simplified deregistration you can do yourself: post on the National Enterprise Credit Information Publicity System for 20 days. If debts remain, clear the books first—collect what you're owed, pay what you owe; that step is liquidation. Bankruptcy needs a court filing and takes months. The hard part is facing losses instead of stalling.

**In plain terms**. No debts, no unpaid wages, tax, or social insurance: all investors sign a commitment; 20-day public notice with no objection → simplified deregistration. Sole proprietors skip the notice; no objection within 10 days → deregister. Company can't pay debts → may apply for bankruptcy. Ignore filings for 2 years and become unreachable → license revoked; responsible legal representative barred from that role for 3 years.

**Benefit**. No debts owed or owed to you, or all settled; no unpaid wages, social insurance, or tax; all investors' written commitment—then 20-day notice with no objection allows simplified deregistration. Sole proprietors: no notice; if authorities raise no objection within 10 days, direct deregistration. Company can't pay due debts and liabilities exceed assets (insolvent): may apply to court for reorganization, composition, or bankruptcy liquidation. Already dissolved without liquidation and insolvent: those responsible for liquidation must apply for bankruptcy liquidation. Neglect: late annual report → abnormal operation list. Two consecutive years no report, still on the list unchanged, and unreachable at the registered address → business license revoked. If the enterprise is revoked and the legal representative bears personal responsibility, that person may not serve as legal representative, director, supervisor, or senior manager for 3 years from revocation. Already on the abnormal list → no simplified deregistration (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Enterprise Information Publicity Interim Regulations revised by State Council Order 777, effective 1 May 2024, unchanged since. Old Article 17 (three years abnormal → serious illegal enterprise list) is gone. The serious untrustworthy list now targets enterprises with serious false annual reports. Many online posts still cite the old text—don't copy them. When and how to file annual reports, and how to catch up: item 25. Individual bankruptcy (including sole props) is still only piloted in some regions; this section did not verify primary sources, so it is not covered.

## 24. Before paying someone to run your online store, take shop-opening training, or do «no-inventory» schemes, ask what extra fees follow and where sales numbers come from

**Cost**. No money. Before paying, get three things: a written contract, the other company's full legal name, and refund terms. Pay only the company named in the contract—never a personal account. The hard part is not paying on the spot when shown «trainee earns over 10000 a month» screenshots.

**In plain terms**. These scams take a first fee, then keep extracting more with «upgrade packages», advance goods payment, and unlock fees. Backend orders and earnings may be faked; withdrawal fails when you try. Fake-order boosting is itself illegal; agencies caught are fined.

**Benefit**. Guangdong Higher People's Court ruled on an agency fraud: Jiang, Xu, and 55 others ran companies in Guangzhou, Nanning, and Hangzhou. The court found they «knew they lacked e-commerce agency capability and technical conditions» yet, in the name of running Taobao stores, induced 7711 victims to buy or upgrade «service packages», taking more than 52994000 yuan. Two lead defendants got 14 years and 13 years 6 months for fraud. The court said the scheme was «tightly designed» and «many victims were cheated again and again». Jiangsu Public Security in 2025 broke «no-inventory» cross-border e-commerce scams into

four steps. First, social posts promising «zero foundation» and «no need to stock». Second, add you as «operations coach» and push a designated platform. Third, after you open a store a first order appears quickly; they have you prepay goods cost, saying the buyer's payment is frozen on the platform until receipt; then the backend invents large order volume so you keep adding money. Fourth, when you try to withdraw, «account anomaly» or «system maintenance» and more unlock fees or service charges. In one case Ms. Zhang advanced over 900000 yuan; the site went down in 3 days. Separately, an agency organized fake group-buys to boost rankings: market regulators fined it 100000 yuan; the platform withheld 50000 yuan of deposit; courts upheld the platform. The Supreme People's Court listed it as a 2026 typical case: «false transactions and fake-order reputation boosting are acts the law expressly prohibits». SAMR in 2025 also published a case: a company selling «one-click migrate» and «one-click dropship» software that scraped other platforms' listings was fined 530000 yuan. SAMR told operators not to commit «shop-stealing migration», «no-inventory trading», and similar violations. The Civil Code route: a contract signed under fraud may be revoked by court or arbitration within 1 year of discovering the fraud; after revocation, money taken must be returned (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Pause on «zero foundation», «no need to stock», «low input, high return», or «guaranteed profit». Pause also if they want you to advance goods money into their designated platform. Before paying, check the other party's license and penalty records on the National Enterprise Credit Information Publicity System. Write service scope and refund-if-targets-miss into the contract. Keep chats, contracts, and transfer screenshots. If you already transferred, call 110 or 96110 at once for stop payment—section 8, item 2. If they did some work but results are poor, it is usually a contract dispute—negotiate, complain, or sue. Revocation needs litigation; ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months; lawyer fees are on you; the other side may already be gone. Franchise-style pitches: check filing under item 5 first. Primary beneficiary: yourself.

## 25. Companies and sole proprietors must file the prior year's annual report online from 1 January to 30 June each year—even with no business; filing is free

**Cost**. No money. Log into the National Enterprise Credit Information Publicity System yourself once a year. Sole proprietors may also file on paper. Annual reports go to market regulation; they are separate from monthly or quarterly tax filing to the tax bureau. Filing tax does not mean you filed the annual report. The hard part is remembering once a year.

**In plain terms**. Companies and sole proprietors must file last year's annual report online in the first half of each year. Missing it puts you on the abnormal operation list; after catch-up filing you can apply to leave. Filing is free. Calls saying you missed it and must pay via a mini-program or official account are scams—lead defendants have been sentenced to over 10 years. Check the publicity system yourself first.

**Benefit**. Companies must «from 1 January to 30 June each year, submit the prior year's annual report to market supervision through the National Enterprise Credit Information Publicity System, and make it public». Late filing: listed on the abnormal operation list, «and given administrative penalties according to law». The list is on the publicity system—anyone can look it up. In government procurement and project bidding, listed firms are restricted or barred. Sole proprietors likewise file the prior year's report from 1 January to 30 June, online or on paper. Sole props opened that year start reporting the next year. Sole props may choose whether report contents are public, but failure to file still puts them on the abnormal list. Listed for missing reports: after filing the missing years, apply to the registration-place market supervision department to leave the list. Company: 2 consecutive years no report, still on the list unchanged, and unreachable at the registered address → business license revoked. Company annual reports must be public. Sole props who choose not to publicize content still show «annual report already submitted» on the system—so whether you filed and whether you're listed is visible online. SAMR has warned of a scam: someone «impersonates market supervision staff» by phone, says you are overdue and already on the abnormal list, then «guides you to search a so-called mini-program or official account» and pay for agency filing. SAMR's line is «annual reports are free». Filing and leaving the abnormal list «must go through official channels such

as the National Enterprise Credit Information Publicity System». Courts have convicted such cases as fraud. Anhui Jingde court finished one: a registration agency had callers «deliberately hide their identity» so sole props thought they were market supervision; callers steered people to a third-party mini-program charging 98–398 yuan as «manual filing materials fees». They cheated 10099 sole props nationwide for more than 3190000 yuan. Three lead defendants got 10 years 6 months to 10 years 8 months for fraud. In a Jiaxing Nanhu case, the mini-program fine print said «filing is free»; the court still convicted fraud because callers «deliberately hid that operators can file online and inventing large-fine stories». Nine people got 8 months to 4 years (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. On a call saying you missed the annual report, hang up, log into the publicity system yourself, or call the registration-place market supervision department. Don't follow SMS links, and don't pay on stranger mini-programs or official accounts. Same playbook as fake tax-bureau calls—see item 14. If you already transferred, call 110 or 96110 at once for stop payment. Individual-business annual report rules and enterprise abnormal-operation list rules were amended twice in 2025; the current version took effect 25 December 2025. Annual report and tax filing are separate; how to file tax: item 12. After license revocation, a responsible legal representative is barred for 3 years—see item 23. If you don't plan to continue, deregister under that item; don't stall by skipping the annual report. Primary beneficiary: yourself.

## 26. When raising money for a business, only talk face to face with relatives, friends, and employees—don't solicit publicly on Moments or in groups, and don't let relatives recruit further for you

**Cost**. No money. Borrowing or bringing in shareholders: only approach relatives, friends, and employees you know, one by one, face to face. No Moments posts, no group posts, no flyers, no pitch meetings. If a relative says «I'll ask others for you», stop that on the spot. The hard part is when cash is short and «pull in a few more people» looks like the fastest money.

**In plain terms**. Borrowing from relatives, friends, and employees, or taking them as co-investors, is not itself a crime. The crime is public promotion, taking money from strangers, and promising principal-and-interest repayment or returns. Taking in 1000000 yuan, or money from 150 people, meets the criminal threshold—starts at up to 3 years. Money used mainly in normal production, and fully repaid before indictment, may avoid criminal punishment.

**Benefit**. Criminal Law Article 176 covers «illegally absorbing public deposits or absorbing them in a disguised form, disrupting financial order». Up to 3 years' imprisonment or short-term detention plus a fine, or a fine alone. Huge amounts or other serious circumstances: 3–10 years. Especially huge amounts or other especially serious circumstances: 10 years or more. An SPC judicial interpretation says all four conditions must be met: (1) no lawful permit from the relevant department, or taking money under a shell of lawful business; (2) public promotion through the internet, media, pitch meetings, flyers, phone messages, or similar channels; (3) promising to repay principal and interest or give returns within a period in money, goods, equity, or similar form; (4) taking money from unspecified members of the public. The same article continues: «Absorbing funds from specific persons among relatives, friends, or inside a unit without public promotion is not illegal absorption or disguised absorption of public deposits.» But a joint SPC–SPP–MPS opinion carves out two exceptions that still count as taking from the public: (1) when taking from relatives, friends, or employees, you know they are collecting from strangers for you and let it happen; (2) you first hire outsiders as employees in order to take money from them. Criminal lines trip on any one of three: 1000000 yuan or more absorbed; 150 people or more; or direct losses of 500000 yuan or more. 5000000 yuan or more, 500 people or more, or losses of 2500000 yuan or more move into the 3–10 year tier. Amounts are counted on the full sum taken in. If the money was used mainly in normal production and operations, and the full amount taken is repaid before indictment, criminal punishment may be waived. Significantly slight harm may not be treated as a crime. Below the criminal line there is still administrative penalty: the local lead department for illegal fundraising fines 20% to 1 times the amount raised. For unit fundraising, the legal representative and

directly responsible persons «are given a warning and fined 500000 yuan or more and up to 5000000 yuan» (nationwide; interpretation effective 1 March 2022).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Once labeled illegal fundraising, relatives who lent you money also lose. Article 25 of the regulation says losses from participating in illegal fundraising are borne by the people who put the money in. Article 19 also names a common business form: taking money while selling goods, providing services, or investing in projects by promising money, equity, or goods returns. Store prepaid cards or membership cards that also promise rebates or dividends, sold to strangers, fall under that article. When cash is short, safer paths are bank loans, or converting money to equity written into a partnership agreement—see item 28. How lenders protect themselves: section 5, item 6 («high return», «principal guaranteed», «sure win»). How older people protect themselves: section 17, item 5 (don't touch «invest for retirement»). Primary beneficiary: yourself; next, relatives who lent to you.

## 27. Before leasing a shopfront, check whether that unit can host your trade: converting a residence to a shop needs unanimous consent from owners in the same building; new oil-smoke restaurants are barred in residential buildings

**Cost**. No money. Before signing a lease, paying deposit, or renovating, spend a few hours on three checks. First, the use on the property certificate—residential or commercial. Second, whether the building is pure residential, mixed-use, or a standalone shop unit, and whether people live upstairs. Third, for catering: whether there is a dedicated smoke flue, then ask local market supervision whether a food business license can be issued. The hard part is verifying yourself when the landlord or agent says «no problem—the last tenant ran one».

**In plain terms**. Converting a residence into a shop needs unanimous consent from the other owners in the same building—one household against is enough to block it. Neighbors asking for restoration and damages will be upheld. Residential buildings and mixed-use buildings without a dedicated smoke flue may not open new oil-smoke restaurants; if found, you are ordered to correct first. Refuse and the shop is closed, with a fine of 10000–100000 yuan—renovation money and deposit may be lost with it.

**Benefit**. Civil Code Article 279: «An owner who changes a residence into business premises shall, besides complying with laws, regulations, and the management covenant, obtain unanimous consent from interested owners.» An SPC judicial interpretation is more specific. Other owners in the same building all count as «interested owners». Owners in other buildings in the same estate count only if they prove impact on their property value or living quality. Changing use without their unanimous consent: requests to stop, restore, or compensate for losses shall be upheld. Arguing «a majority of owners agreed» is not upheld. The Ecological Environment Code took effect 15 August 2026; the Air Pollution Prevention and Control Law was repealed at the same time. Code Article 250 bans new construction, renovation, or expansion of catering projects that produce oil smoke, odors, or exhaust in three places: (1) residential buildings; (2) mixed-use buildings without a dedicated smoke flue; (3) commercial floors in mixed-use buildings adjacent to residential floors. Violations: ordered to correct first; refuse → ordered closed, plus a fine of 10000–100000 yuan. The code also requires local governments to flag catering siting bans at registration. Applying for a food business license: premises must match the food types and volumes handled, and keep required distance from toxic or hazardous sites and other pollution sources. Conversely, if the premises themselves fail mandatory use conditions in laws or administrative regulations, you may terminate the lease—provided the inability to use is not your fault (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. «The last tenant ran one» does not mean you can—maybe nobody sued, or it opened before the code took effect. Management covenants may add further limits; ask property management for a copy before signing. If the unit can't be used that way and you need to end the lease and recover deposit and renovation losses, refusal by the landlord means litigation. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months; lawyer

fees are on you—so writing «if a license can't be obtained or the shop is ordered closed, the lease ends and deposit is returned» into the lease is cheaper. Which licenses you need: items 7 and 8. Primary beneficiary: yourself.

## 28. When several people open a shop together, put capital, profit splits, who decides, who draws wages, and how to exit into a written agreement before opening

**Cost**. No money. Sit down once or twice with the partners, write about ten items clearly, and each sign. Partnership-agreement templates are online; fill the ten items listed in the Partnership Enterprise Law one by one. The hard part is acquaintances feeling that «talking money hurts the relationship» and not wanting to start.

**In plain terms**. Without an agreement, the law sets default rules for you. Decisions need unanimous consent; profits follow each person's actual capital paid in; the person who watches the shop every day draws no wage by default. With no partnership term agreed, anyone may exit after reasonable advance notice to the others. Changing those defaults only works if written into the agreement in advance.

**Benefit**. Partnership Enterprise Law Article 4: the partnership agreement is made in writing by unanimous negotiation of all partners. Article 18 lists ten items the agreement should cover—including capital contribution form, amount, and payment deadline; profit distribution and loss sharing; who executes partnership affairs; admission and withdrawal; dispute resolution; dissolution and liquidation; and breach liability. Partners who don't form a partnership enterprise and only work together under a Civil Code partnership contract follow that contract; where the contract is silent, Civil Code defaults apply. Partnership decisions, unless the contract says otherwise, need unanimous partner consent. A partner who executes partnership affairs may not claim pay for that alone, unless the contract says otherwise. Profits and losses follow the contract. If silent: negotiate first; if negotiation fails, by actual capital ratios; if ratios can't be figured, equal shares. Partners bear joint liability for partnership debts; anyone who pays more may seek contribution from the others. With no partnership term agreed, it is an open-ended partnership—a partner may terminate at any time with reasonable advance notice to the others. For a partnership enterprise with no term agreed, a partner may withdraw with 30 days' notice to the others. The agreement also may not assign all profits to only some partners, or dump all losses on only some (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The most common fight is how capital and labor split. One puts in money and does nothing; one puts in no money and watches the shop every day—under defaults the shop-watcher gets a smaller share and no wage. So write the labor partner's wage or equity clearly. The agreement only governs partners among themselves. Outward debts: general partners still pay to the end—see item 3. Red lines for pulling in more investors: item 26. Statutory parts were verified at source; «a written agreement reduces fights» is experience without statistics, hence grade C. Beneficiaries: you and your partners.

# 13. Emergency situations: what to do first

This section outlines exactly what steps to take, what to avoid, and what not to do at all. The entries on first aid and wilderness survival focus on specific causes of death and survival rates. Those dealing with scams and threats relate to financial loss and personal liberty. These two sets of figures aren't interchangeable. Items are listed in descending order based on how common each situation is and how much difference proper action can make to someone's chances of survival. These guidelines are primarily meant for you, your spouse, and close family members. Since 79.2% of cardiac arrests happen at home, you'll most likely be helping someone you love. Friends and coworkers come next. Helping strangers can still be worthwhile, but this category ranks lowest in priority; doing so may even expose you to fraud or legal complications. Therefore, protective actions and legal safeguards are highlighted first in these entries.

Only actions that must be taken within minutes are included here. Recognizing scams or handling blackmail situations requires longer-term responses and thus fall outside this section. Detailed anti-fraud rules and seven common scam types are covered in Section 8, Item 3. If someone threatens to release private photos or intimate videos, refer to Section 8, Item 32. Should money already have been transferred, call 110 or 96110 immediately to request a stop on the payment, as explained in Section 8, Item 2.

The entries are grouped by topic, with item numbers shown in parentheses.

**CPR and choking**: If someone collapses and stops breathing (Item 1), avoid rushing to help an elderly person who has fallen (Item 2). In cases of choking where speech is impossible (Item 26) or when an infant can't cry due to blockage (Item 43), proper CPR techniques apply (Item 44).

**Sudden medical emergencies**: Watch for facial drooping or weakness on one side (Item 3), sudden dizziness or loss of balance (Item 4), sudden vision loss in one eye (Item 5), intense eye pain and swelling (Item 6), chest pressure or pain (Item 7), tearing pains elsewhere (Item 8), the worst headache imaginable (Item 9), confusion following a head injury in seniors (Item 10), sudden leg swelling (Item 11), allergic reactions leading to shock (Item 15), seizures (Item 16), and sudden tremors in diabetics (Item 17).

**Wounds and burns**: Apply direct pressure to stop bleeding (Item 12), treat dog or cat bites (Item 13), cool burns with water (Item 14), and never remove foreign objects from wounds (Item 40) or move suspected fractures (Item 41).

**Poisoning, fires, and accidents**: Cut power first if someone is electrocuted (Item 18), respond to carbon monoxide alarms (Item 19), handle accidental ingestion of cleaners, pesticides, or medicines (Item 20), flush chemicals off skin (Item 21), recognize heat exhaustion without sweating (Item 22), give mildly salted water to heatstroke victims (Item 23), crawl low during fires (Item 24), spot drowning victims (Item 25), and check building safety after earthquakes (Item 30).

**Wilderness survival**: Stay put if lost in remote areas (Item 27), watch for shivering and slurred speech as signs of hypothermia (Item 28), never cut or suction venom after snake bites (Item 29), handle encounters with bears, wild boars, or stray dogs (Item 31), seek shelter during thunderstorms (Item 32), ascend high altitudes gradually (Item 33), remove ticks carefully (Item 34), and always boil wild water before drinking (Item 35).

**Conflicts and aftermath**: Defend yourself if robbed in isolated areas (Item 36), intervene cautiously if witnessing a fight (Item 37), and claim compensation for injuries or expenses incurred while saving others (Item 39).

**Sexual assault and HIV exposure**: Seek immediate medical care after possible HIV exposure (Item 38) or sexual assault (Item 42).

## 1. Immediate chest compressions can save lives when someone collapses and stops breathing — call 120 and fetch an AED too

**Cost**. This costs nothing. A CPR course from the Red Cross or a hospital lasts half a day to a full day, and one training session is enough for years of use. Even without prior training, you can do it: place both hands on

top of each other at the midpoint between the nipples, then press down hard at a rate of about 2 times per second without stopping.

**In plain terms**. Most people you'd need to help are family members — 79.2% of cardiac arrests happen at home. When someone performs CPR, the survival rate jumps from 3.9% to 16.1%. If a person is unresponsive and not breathing, start compressions right away. Position your hands at the midpoint between the nipples, press down hard at 2 times per second, and keep going. Ask a second person to call 120 and bring an AED; you must not stop compressing.

**Benefit**. Meta-analysis of 79 studies involving 142,740 participants shows that overall, only 7.6% of people suffering from out-of-hospital cardiac arrest survive to leave the hospital. For those receiving CPR from bystanders, the survival rate rises from 3.9% to 16.1%. While 53% of cardiac arrests are witnessed by someone nearby, only 32% actually get CPR. The BASIC-OHCA registry in China recorded 38,227 emergency cases; among them, 30,282 cases (79.2%) occurred at home. In this group, the bystander CPR rate was 20.3%, and the survival rate was just 1.2%. The correct sequence is to start compressions first, then ask someone else to call 120 and fetch an AED; once the AED is powered on, follow its voice prompts.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Do not pinch the philtrum first, do not look for family members, and do not record a video. Also, do not hesitate to press hard for fear of breaking ribs. Article 184 of China's Civil Code states that anyone who voluntarily provides emergency aid and accidentally causes injury to the victim still bears no civil liability.

## 2. Elderly falls: if someone falls, first kneel down, call out to them, and dial 120 — don't rush to help them up. In China it is perfectly legal to walk away from strangers; once you stop, however, you must not touch or move them

**Cost**. No money is required. Kneeling down to ask a few questions and making a phone call takes only a few minutes. The hard part is resisting the urge to reach out and help. For strangers, there's an extra cost to consider: calling 120 leaves your phone number on record, which may result in follow-up calls or inquiries. If family members later target you, legal battles can last months, and even if you ultimately win, you'll still have to pay your own legal fees.

**In plain terms**. This guidance is primarily aimed at one's own elderly relatives and people you know well. First, check whether they're breathing; if not, follow step 1 (perform chest compressions). Even if they are breathing, don't lift them up — they may have suffered a stroke or fainting spell prior to the fall, and forced movement could worsen injuries. Instead, kneel down, speak to them, and ask if they remember how they fell. If they complain of back pain or seem to have a fracture, do not move them; call 120 right away.

**Benefit**. The Ministry of Health's “Technical Guidelines for Intervention in Elderly Falls” states two key points: “Falls are the leading cause of injury-related death among people aged 65 and older in China,” and “When an elderly person falls, do not rush to help them up; instead, respond according to the specific circumstances.” For those who are unconscious, immediately call emergency services. If they're vomiting, turn their head to one side and clear any vomit from their mouth and nose. If breathing or heartbeat has stopped, start chest compressions at once. The guidelines also note: “If moving the person is necessary, do so gently and keep them as flat as possible.” For conscious individuals, ask whether they recall the fall; if not, it may indicate fainting or a cerebrovascular event. If they suffer severe headaches, facial drooping, slurred speech, or limb weakness, lifting them could worsen bleeding or ischemia in the brain. Likewise, if there are signs of fracture, back pain, or incontinence, avoid moving them unless you have relevant medical training. In all these cases, call 120 immediately. If the elderly person wishes to stand up on their own, assist them slowly, then let them sit or lie down while you monitor them until you're sure they're alright. Regarding fears of being held liable, the law is clear: Article 90 of the Supreme People's Court Interpretation of the Civil Procedure Law states that “any party making a claim must provide evidence to support it; failure to do so results in losing the case.” Article 1198 of the Civil Code obliges operators of public venues — hotels, malls, banks, stations, airports, sports arenas, entertainment venues, etc. — to uphold safety standards; failure to do

so makes them legally responsible for any resulting harm. Conversely, Article 184 protects anyone who voluntarily and urgently helps another person: “A rescuer bears no civil liability for any harm caused to the victim during such efforts.” A notable court case involved a pharmacy owner who performed CPR on a cardiac arrest victim, inadvertently breaking several ribs. The victim required 18 days of hospitalization and sought over 9,000 yuan in compensation; the court ruled in favor of the rescuer, absolving him of liability.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because the guidelines describe proper procedures but provide no quantitative data on how many lives they actually save. Article 184 shields rescuers only when their actions are voluntary and occur in an emergency; it does not cover situations such as “taking it upon oneself to load a stranger into a private car for transport” — waiting for 120 remains the safer choice. After dialing 120, stay on the line and follow the dispatcher's instructions. This advice is primarily intended for one's own elderly relatives and acquaintances. For strangers on the street, walking away is both legal and advisable; Chinese law does not obligate you to intervene. Abroad that is not always so: in Germany, for example, failing to help at an accident or emergency when you could do so without putting yourself in serious danger is itself a crime, punishable by up to 1 year in prison or a fine. Abroad, local law applies. That said, once you stop, you must weigh all associated costs: time spent, leaving your contact details, potential contact from family members, possible legal action, workplace repercussions, and even online backlash. For further details, see A stranger has an accident on the street: walk away or stop. The only unequivocal action required is not to move the person — this is a medical, not a legal, imperative, as forced movement can exacerbate cerebral hemorrhage or spinal injury. One exception applies if you are the proprietor, manager, or organizer of the location; in such cases, walking away no longer qualifies as a “free” option, as Article 1198 of the Civil Code imposes a duty of care on venue operators. For fall prevention, refer to Section 1, Item 13 (balance and leg-strength training); delayed symptoms following head trauma are covered in Section 10; financial recourse after injury sustained while rescuing others is addressed in Section 39; and evidence collection and reporting in cases of online harassment are outlined in Section 8, Item 16.

## 3. Sudden facial drooping, weakness in one arm, and slurred speech — call 120 immediately; don't wait or drive yourself

**Cost**. No cost at all. These three steps are easy to remember: ask the person to smile, raise both arms straight out, and say a complete sentence.

**In plain terms**. If someone's face suddenly droops, they can't lift one arm, and their speech becomes slurred, call 120 right away. Administering medication within 3 hours of symptom onset can increase the chance of regaining basic independence by about 1.75 times compared to not receiving treatment. Waiting 3 to 4.5 hours reduces this benefit to only 1.26 times. After 4.5 hours, there is virtually no difference. Be sure to note the exact time symptoms first appeared. Do not give water or medicine, and never drive the person to the hospital yourself.

**Benefit**. This conclusion comes from a meta-analysis of 16 randomized trials involving 6,756 patients. Intravenous thrombolysis means delivering medication to reopen blocked blood vessels. When alteplase is given within 3 hours of symptom onset, the odds of the patient regaining basic independence — defined as a modified Rankin score of 0–1 — increase by a factor of 1.75. The 95% confidence interval for this effect is 1.35–2.27. In other words, the likelihood of a good recovery is roughly 1.75 times higher with treatment. Waiting 3 to 4.5 hours lowers this advantage to 1.26 (95% CI 1.05–1.51), while after 4.5 hours the difference becomes statistically insignificant at 1.15 (95% CI 0.95–1.40).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Thrombolysis involves administering medication to clear blocked blood vessels; the earlier it is given, the greater its effectiveness. After 4.5 hours, it provides little to no benefit. Calling 120 instead of driving is essential because ambulances transport patients directly to stroke centers where staff can be alerted in advance. Recording the exact time symptoms began helps doctors determine whether thrombolysis is still appropriate. Never give water or medicine, and never wait “to see if things get better on their own.”

## 4. Sudden dizziness, double vision, loss of vision in one eye, or inability to touch one's nose — all warrant calling 120 for stroke suspicion

**Cost**. No cost involved. Besides the three FAST signs — facial droop, arm weakness, and speech difficulty — two additional checks are recommended. First, ask the person to stand straight with eyes closed and see if they lose balance; then ask whether they see double or have blind spots. Second, have them extend a finger toward their nose, close their eyes, and repeat the motion.

**In plain terms**. Out of 736 stroke cases, 14.1% showed none of the classic FAST symptoms at onset — no facial droop, no arm weakness, no slurred speech. Relying solely on those three signs would miss many cases. Adding checks for unsteady gait, double vision, or inability to touch the nose reduces that omission rate to just 4.4%. Any sudden dizziness, double vision, or failure to touch one's nose should prompt an immediate call to emergency services and precise timing documentation.

**Benefit**. In 2014, researchers at the University of Kentucky Stroke Center reviewed 736 cases of acute ischemic stroke. They found that 14.1% of patients exhibited none of the FAST indicators at the time of onset. When additional screening criteria — including gait instability, limb weakness, and visual disturbances — were incorporated, the proportion of missed diagnoses dropped to 4.4%.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Infarctions affecting the cerebellum or brainstem — known as posterior circulation strokes — often lack facial droop or limb weakness. Instead, they manifest as vertigo, gait deviation, double vision, or difficulty swallowing, which are frequently mistaken for cervical spine disorders, hypoglycemia, or benign paroxysmal positional vertigo. Inability to touch one's nose or maintain balance with eyes closed are telltale signs of cerebellar involvement. However, no single test can definitively rule out stroke; any sudden onset of these symptoms demands immediate emergency care and accurate timing recording. This study relied on records from a single medical center, and the authors themselves acknowledge the need for further validation.

## 5. One eye suddenly goes dark, as if a curtain has been pulled shut; even if it clears up within minutes, seek emergency care for stroke on the same day

**Cost**. No direct cost. However, emergency evaluation and vascular testing will take up half a day to a full day.

**In plain terms**. When one eye suddenly goes dark, as if a curtain has been pulled shut, it means a blockage has occurred in the blood vessels at the back of the eye. The longer the blockage persists, the less of the retina can be saved. This condition is also a form of cerebral ischemia, and the following days represent a high-risk window for stroke. For patients in this situation, receiving evaluation and treatment on the same day reduces the likelihood of another stroke within 90 days from 10.3% to 2.1%. Seek emergency care at a hospital with a stroke center on the same day; do not wait until the next day to see an ophthalmologist.

**Benefit**. The 2021 scientific statement from the American Heart Association on central retinal artery occlusion — blockage of the main vessel at the back of the eye — explicitly states that acute central retinal artery occlusion is a medical emergency. Healthcare systems should recognize it as such and prioritize treatment accordingly. The longer blood flow is cut off, the less retina can be salvaged. The Oxford EXPRESS study examined two groups of patients: those with cerebral ischemia whose symptoms resolved on their own, and those with minor strokes. The former are medically termed transient ischemic attacks. After these patients received same-day evaluation and treatment, the rate of subsequent strokes within 90 days fell from 10.3% (32 out of 310) to 2.1% (6 out of 281).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The grade B rating is due to the fact that EXPRESS was not a randomized trial; it compared outcomes before and after implementing the new protocol within the same patient population, making it difficult to isolate the effect of the intervention from other potential changes. A brief episode of darkness in one eye that

resolves on its own is often dismissed as fatigue or low blood sugar. In reality, it is a type of transient ischemic attack, and the ensuing days are a critical window for stroke risk. Sudden, painless, non-red, non-teary loss of vision in one eye must be taken seriously. Do not wait until the next day for an ophthalmology appointment; go directly to the emergency department of a hospital equipped to handle strokes.

## 6. One eye is swollen, painful, red; there's a rainbow halo around lights; plus headache, nausea, and vomiting — so an emergency eye visit is needed that same day

**Cost**. No cost at all. An emergency eye exam includes measuring intraocular pressure and checking the anterior chamber, which takes up half a day.

**In plain terms**. This is an acute glaucoma attack. Fluid can't drain from the eye, so pressure spikes quickly. The longer it goes untreated, the more damage occurs to the optic nerve, and that damage is permanent. During Wuhan's lockdown, patients waited an average of 241 hours before getting treatment; 21.87% ended up blind. In the same period the year after the lockdown, the average wait time dropped to 121 hours, and only 7.84% became blind. A total of 76 days of lockdown were covered in this study.

**Benefit**. An eye hospital in Wuhan compared two groups of patients with acute primary angle-closure glaucoma. In 2020, during the lockdown, 54 patients with 64 affected eyes received care; the following year, 46 patients with 51 affected eyes were treated. Both groups had similar demographic profiles. From symptom onset to treatment, the lockdown group waited 241.84±211.95 hours versus 121.53±96.12 hours for the control group (P=0.001). Their intraocular pressure at diagnosis was 52.63±12.45 mmHg versus 45.16±9.79 mmHg (P=0.001). Blindness rates were 21.87% versus 7.84%. Glaucomatous optic nerve damage was found in 20/64 eyes (31.25%) versus 7/51 eyes (13.73%) (P=0.03). A South Korean hospital reviewed 50 eyes that had experienced one acute attack and later had their lenses removed; a year later, 25 of those eyes (50%) showed varying degrees of visual field loss. The longer the time between symptom onset and pressure reduction, the higher the chance of lasting damage (P=0.005). Another prospective study had 43 people with shallow anterior chambers lie face-down in a dark room for one hour; intraocular pressure rose significantly in both eyes (P<0.01). The dominant eye saw a median increase of 3.60 mmHg, while the other eye rose 2.70 mmHg (P<0.05).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. There are two main reasons this is graded B. First, the Wuhan comparison relied on reviewing old medical records, and the lockdown itself introduced other differences that can't be separated from the effect of delayed treatment. Second, the South Korean study involved only 50 eyes and was retrospective. This does not mean screen time causes glaucoma; in the dark, pupils dilate, and prolonged head-down posture pushes the lens forward, especially in people with naturally shallow anterior chambers. Those at highest risk are over 50, farsighted, or with a family history of angle-closure glaucoma. Young people who game all night are unlikely to develop this condition. Common misdiagnoses during an attack include gastroenteritis, migraine, or high blood pressure, since headache and vomiting are more noticeable than eye symptoms. Sudden, painless vision loss in one eye is a separate issue — see item 5 (sudden blackout in one eye). Whether blue-light blocking glasses help is discussed in section 6, item 16 (blue-light blocking glasses).

## 7. Chest pressure, tightness, or heaviness lasting more than 15 minutes without relief — call 120; do not drive yourself

**Cost**. No cost at all.

**In plain terms**. If you feel chest pressure, tightness, or heaviness that lasts over 15 minutes without easing up, call 120 right away. For patients treated within 55 minutes of arrival at the hospital, the mortality rate within 30 days is 2.8%. For those treated later than 55 minutes, the rate rises to 9.7%. Every minute of delay means more heart muscle tissue dies. Do not drive yourself — losing consciousness while behind the wheel could lead to a second accident.

**Benefit**. Israel conducted a nationwide study on acute coronary syndrome. The research focused on patients experiencing ST-segment elevation myocardial infarction, a specific type of heart attack. It measured the time interval from hospital admission to the point when a balloon catheter was used to reopen the blocked blood vessel. For patients treated within 55 minutes, 5 out of 178 (2.8%) died within 30 days. For those treated after 55 minutes, 15 out of 155 (9.7%) died within the same timeframe.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This study compares outcomes based on the time elapsed after hospital admission, not from the onset of symptoms to arrival at the hospital. However, the underlying principle remains the same: any delay results in additional heart muscle damage. The pain may also be felt in the upper abdomen, back, or jaw, and numbness in the left arm can also be a symptom. Diabetic patients and older adults may not experience any pain at all, only shortness of breath. Again, do not drive yourself — losing consciousness while driving can easily cause another accident.

## 8. Sudden tearing pain that spreads from the chest to the back and waist — call 120 and describe it as “pain moving downward”

**Cost**. No cost at all.

**In plain terms**. This condition causes a tearing-like pain that starts in the chest and travels down the back and waist. When calling 120, simply describe it as “a tearing pain that's moving downward.” Without surgery, treatment with medication alone results in a mortality rate of 58%. Its management is the exact opposite of that for heart attacks: doctors only order enhanced CT scans after suspecting this condition, not anticoagulant or thrombolytic therapy. Also mention any significant difference in blood pressure between both arms or absence of a pulse on one side.

**Benefit**. The International Registry of Acute Aortic Dissection (IRAD) includes data from 464 patients across 12 centers. Acute aortic dissection is precisely this disease marked by sudden, severe tearing pain in the chest and back. Among all symptoms reported by patients, sudden onset of intense sharp pain is the most common. Overall in-hospital mortality stands at 27.4%. For patients with type A dissection receiving only medication, mortality reaches 58%.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Management of aortic dissection is completely opposite to that of heart attacks. Heart attacks require anticoagulant and thrombolytic drugs to prevent blood clotting; applying such drugs to aortic dissection would essentially encourage bleeding at the tear site. Therefore, upon arriving at the hospital, patients must clearly state “a tearing pain that's moving downward” to prompt doctors to order enhanced CT scans. A notable difference in blood pressure between arms or absence of a pulse on one side are also important warning signs. Individuals with poorly controlled blood pressure, Marfan syndrome, or a family history of aortic aneurysm or dissection are at higher risk. In such cases, driving oneself to the hospital is strongly discouraged; symptoms must be addressed immediately rather than waiting until the next day.

## 9. A sudden “worst headache of one's life” that peaks within an hour — go to the ER for a head CT right away

**Cost**. An emergency visit itself costs very little. A head CT in the ER typically runs a few hundred yuan.

**In plain terms**. The key point isn't how intense the pain is, but how quickly it reaches its peak. In 2,131 people experiencing severe headaches that peaked within an hour, 6.2% had a ruptured blood vessel on the surface of the brain. Anyone aged 40 or older, with neck pain or stiffness, who was seen collapsing by others, whose headache started during physical activity, came on suddenly like an explosion, or has limited neck flexion when examined should go to the ER for a head CT. The vast majority of people who get tested end up fine, but missing even one case of bleeding can be fatal.

**Benefit**. Ten Canadian emergency departments conducted a prospective cohort study on 2,131 patients with “severe headaches peaking within an hour.” They defined clear criteria upfront and tracked outcomes

accordingly. Of these, 132 patients (6.2%) had subarachnoid hemorrhage, meaning a ruptured surface blood vessel in the brain. The Ottawa SAH rule includes six criteria: age 40 or older, neck pain or stiffness, witnessed loss of consciousness, onset during physical activity, sudden explosive onset of pain, and limited neck flexion on physical exam. Meeting any one of these criteria triggers a CT scan. This rule identified every single patient with bleeding, with 100% sensitivity. The 95% confidence interval for this figure is 97.2%–100.0%. The trade-off is that only 15.3% of people without bleeding were excluded by this rule (specificity of 15.3%).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. It's not “how painful it is” that matters, but “how fast it reaches peak pain.” Headaches that erupt within seconds to a minute are the real warning sign; gradually worsening migraines are not. Additional symptoms like vomiting, neck stiffness, light sensitivity, or brief fainting also warrant immediate attention. With a specificity of just 15.3%, most people who follow this rule end up with normal results. Yet missing even one case of bleeding can be fatal, so getting tested is absolutely worthwhile. Do not take painkillers to mask the pain and then fall asleep.

## 10. After an elderly person suffers a head injury, they may develop unsteady gait, sluggishness, excessive sleepiness, or weakness on one side of the body two to three weeks later — a CT scan is recommended

**Cost**. A single cranial CT scan costs roughly 200–300 RMB.

**In plain terms**. After a head injury, blood usually starts accumulating only around the third week. At the time of impact, there may be absolutely no symptoms at all, and the person might not even recall the injury. The recurrence rate after surgery for this condition can reach 33%, while the mortality rate may be as high as 32%. If an elderly individual suddenly appears confused, walks unsteadily, feels unusually sleepy, or shows weakness on one side, it's important to first ask whether they fell or hit their head in the past two to three months, then proceed with a CT scan.

**Benefit**. The Neurosurgical Society of the Chinese Medical Association has published a Chinese expert consensus on medical treatment for chronic subdural hematoma. This condition involves slow accumulation of blood between the meninges; technically, it refers to chronic mass formation caused by blood buildup between the arachnoid membrane and dura mater. It “typically develops three weeks after head trauma” and is most common among older adults. Post-surgery recurrence and mortality rates can reach 33% and 32% respectively. Among patients aged 90 or older, only 24% achieve a satisfactory recovery overall. Global data shows that incidence rates range from 3.39 to 39.1 new cases per 100,000 people annually, rising sharply after age 80. The most common causes are trauma and falls, followed by chronic alcohol consumption, use of anticoagulant medications, and violent injury. Geriatric literature notes that typical symptoms include confusion, cognitive decline, gait disturbances, and excessive sleepiness — features that may overlap with other geriatric syndromes.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. At the time of injury, there may be absolutely no symptoms, and the elderly person might not even recall the incident. Therefore, when families notice sudden confusion, unsteady walking, excessive sleepiness, or unilateral weakness, they should first check whether a head injury occurred in the past two to three months before ordering a CT scan. It's crucial not to automatically attribute these symptoms to “senile dementia” or “post-stroke sequelae,” as doing so could lead to delayed diagnosis. Elderly individuals taking aspirin, clopidogrel, warfarin, or newer oral anticoagulants face higher risks, as does long-term heavy alcohol consumption. For fall prevention, refer to Section 1, Item 13 — focusing on balance training and leg strength exercises.

## 11. A leg suddenly swells, feels tight, and is tender to the touch — seek medical care promptly; if shortness of breath or chest pain develops suddenly, call 120 immediately

**Cost**. An ultrasound of the leg veins (lower extremity venous ultrasound) costs around 100–200 yuan.

**In plain terms**. If one leg suddenly swells, becomes noticeably thicker than the other, and is painful to press, get a leg vein ultrasound done as soon as possible. Should shortness of breath, chest pain when taking a deep breath, a rapid heartbeat, or dizziness appear, a blood clot may have traveled to the lungs — call 120 right away. Among people diagnosed with pulmonary embolism, 17.4% die within three months. Sitting still for more than four hours roughly doubles the risk, though the actual chance for any one person remains very low.

**Benefit**. The International Cooperative Registry on Pulmonary Embolism (ICOPER) gathered data from 2,454 patients with confirmed acute pulmonary embolism treated at 52 hospitals across seven countries. Pulmonary embolism occurs when a blood clot blocks a pulmonary artery. Within three months, the overall mortality rate for these patients — regardless of cause — was 17.4% (426 out of 2,454). The WHO WRIGHT project found that travel lasting four or more continuous hours "roughly doubles" the risk of blood clots forming in veins and traveling to the lungs (venous thromboembolism). Even so, the actual probability for any individual remains low; prolonged inactivity exceeding four hours translates to roughly one in 6,000 people facing this risk.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Swelling in both legs is usually linked to issues involving the heart, liver, kidneys, or venous function. Sudden swelling of just one leg, noticeably larger than the other, is a classic sign of deep vein thrombosis. High-risk situations include long car or plane trips, bed rest after surgery or a fracture, wearing a cast, pregnancy and the postpartum period, cancer, and oral contraceptive use. When a clot breaks loose and blocks a pulmonary artery, pulmonary embolism results — marked by sudden shortness of breath, worsening chest pain with deep breaths, rapid heartbeat, dizziness, and sometimes coughing up blood. In such cases, call 120 immediately. The 17.4% figure reflects mortality among confirmed pulmonary embolism cases, not the overall risk associated with leg swelling alone; don't let this number cause undue alarm.

## 12. For severe bleeding, first press firmly on the wound with your hand; if this fails on limbs, apply a tourniquet and call 120 immediately

**Cost**. A twist-style tourniquet costs anywhere from a few dozen to over a hundred yuan; it can easily be stored in a car or first-aid kit. Learning how to position it above the wound, twist it until bleeding stops, and note the time takes just a few minutes.

**In plain terms**. Begin by pressing hard on the wound with your hand or a cloth; if bleeding on a limb persists, fasten a tourniquet and call 120 right away. Once applied, never loosen it. Among battlefield casualties, 90% who received a tourniquet before going into shock survived, compared to only 10% who got one after shock set in; all five patients who needed a tourniquet but did not receive one died. Position the tourniquet above the wound, twist it until bleeding ceases, and record the time. Never substitute shoelaces or ordinary rope. For neck or torso injuries, only compression is allowed—no tourniquets may be used.

**Benefit**. Over six years, 11 Level I trauma centers in Texas treated 1,026 patients with limb vascular injuries; 181 of them (17.6%) had a tourniquet applied prior to arrival. Unadjusted mortality rates were 3.9% for those with a tourniquet and 5.2% for those without. After adjusting for other factors, tourniquet use remained strongly linked to survival; the adjusted odds ratio was 5.86, with a 95% confidence interval ranging from 1.41 to 24.47. At a Baghdad field hospital, 90% of 232 injured patients who received a tourniquet before shock survived, versus just 10% who got one after shock occurred; all five patients needing a tourniquet but not receiving one perished, while 87% of those with a tourniquet survived. The recommended sequence is: direct manual compression using any cloth or towel → if bleeding on a limb persists, apply a tourniquet → call 120 → never loosen it.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Never use thin materials such as rope or shoelaces as tourniquets; they cannot sufficiently constrict arteries and may cut the skin. Once a tourniquet is applied, do not loosen it periodically to "release blood flow." Compression only applies to neck and torso injuries—never a tourniquet. No amputations resulted from tourniquet use in the battlefield data; transient nerve paralysis occurred in four cases. Chinese expert consensus among emergency physicians agrees: once applied pre-hospitally, a tourniquet should not be removed unless an alternative method can fully stop bleeding. For arm bleeding, position the tourniquet on the upper third of the arm; for leg bleeding, place it near the groin. Avoid applying it to forearms, calves, elbows, or knees. Experts recommend keeping tourniquet application time under two hours total before reaching medical care; however, if reaching a facility proves impossible and no other method works, leave it on until professional help arrives. Improvised tourniquets made from belts, ties, or sleeves alone rarely suffice; they must be twisted tightly using a stick or similar tool to be effective.

## 13. For dog or cat bites and scratches, rinse the area with soap and running water for 15 minutes, then get vaccinated on the same day

**Cost**. Rinsing requires no expense. The full course of rabies vaccination costs several hundred yuan. For category III exposures, an additional passive immunization product—essentially ready-made antibodies administered directly—is needed, adding several hundred to over a thousand yuan. The greatest cost, however, comes from delays.

**In plain terms**. Once rabies symptoms appear, the fatality rate is practically 100%. Rinsing with soap and water followed by vaccination is the sole safeguard. First, rinse the affected area with alternating streams of soap and running water for 15 minutes, then seek medical care on the same day. If the skin is broken and the wound has been licked, this constitutes a category III exposure, requiring the extra passive immunization product. The fact that a pet has been vaccinated does not alter this classification; exposure level is determined solely by the nature of the injury, not by the animal's background.

**Benefit**. According to the 2023 guidelines issued by China's National Disease Control and Prevention Administration and Health Commission, "The fatality rate from rabies is practically 100%." Recommended first aid is "to thoroughly rinse all bite and scratch sites with alternating streams of soap (or another mildly alkaline cleanser) and running water under adequate pressure for roughly 15 minutes." For minor bites where skin remains intact or superficial scratches without bleeding—classified as category II exposures—vaccination alone is sufficient. Category III exposures, involving penetrating wounds or licked broken skin, mandate both wound treatment, passive immunization, and full vaccination. The WHO reports that roughly 59,000 people worldwide die from rabies each year, 99% of cases linked to dog bites.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Never skip treatment on the assumption that a pet is vaccinated or well-tended; guidelines base classification strictly on wound severity, not on the animal's status. Do not attempt to bandage the wound yourself. The ten-day observation method may inform whether to discontinue vaccination, but it never negates the need to begin it. The same protocol applies to bites inflicted by wild animals or bats. If you keep a dog, vaccinate it against rabies on schedule and keep it on a leash outside; see Section 8, item 30 (dogs must be leashed).

## 14. Immediately rinse a burn with cool running water for 20 minutes; avoid applying toothpaste or soy sauce

**Cost**. No cost involved. It requires 20 minutes of time.

**In plain terms**. Rinsing a burn with cool running water for at least 20 minutes within 3 hours of injury reduces the likelihood of needing skin grafts to roughly 60% of the rate for those who do not perform this step. Use cool water, not ice water, as ice application can worsen the damage. If clothing sticks to the wound, do not pull it off forcefully; after rinsing, cover the area with a clean cloth and head to the hospital. Never

apply toothpaste, soy sauce, sesame oil, or flour to the burn. Even if you remember to rinse later, doing so within 3 hours still provides benefit.

**Benefit**. An Australian study followed 2,495 children with burns. For kids who rinsed the burn with cool running water for 20 minutes within 3 hours of injury, the relative risk of needing a skin graft was 0.6. The 95% confidence interval for this value is 0.4–0.8, meaning the likelihood of needing a graft is roughly 60% lower than for those who did not rinse. Results from 7 combined studies also confirm that 20 minutes of cool running water irrigation within 3 hours of injury significantly lowers the chance of needing skin grafts or surgical wound treatment.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Use cool water, not ice water, as ice application can worsen burn damage. If clothing sticks to the wound, do not pull it off forcefully; after rinsing, cover the area with a clean cloth and seek medical care. Avoid applying toothpaste, soy sauce, sesame oil, or flour to the burn, as these substances can interfere with doctors' assessment of injury severity and increase infection risk. Rinsing within 3 hours of injury remains beneficial even if done later than initially intended.

## 15. Sudden widespread rash, difficulty breathing, or dizziness — treat as anaphylactic shock; call 120 immediately and explain the situation clearly

**Cost**. No cost involved. However, people with known severe allergies must purchase epinephrine auto-injectors themselves; these are prescription-only medications.

**In plain terms**. If someone suddenly develops a full-body rash along with trouble breathing or dizziness, treat it as anaphylactic shock. Call 120 right away and clearly state “suspected anaphylactic shock” so emergency responders can bring epinephrine with them. Epinephrine is the first-line treatment; antihistamines and steroids act too slowly to be effective in such cases. Individuals who have experienced this before should consult a doctor for an epinephrine auto-injector and learn how to administer it to the outer midsection of the thigh — this can be done even through clothing.

**Benefit**. Epinephrine is the recommended first-line treatment for all grades of anaphylactic shock (Grade 2 and above); clinical guidelines strongly endorse its use. Antihistamines and steroids are much slower-acting and cannot replace epinephrine in emergency situations.

**Evidence grade**. B (guidelines strongly recommend it, though the underlying evidence base is relatively weak).

**Notes**. The EAACI allergy guidelines themselves note that “most evidence in this field remains at a low level.” They still classify epinephrine as a strongly recommended treatment because its benefits far outweigh the risks, rather than because of large-scale clinical trials. In China, epinephrine is a prescription medication and is not readily available to the general public. The best immediate action is to call 120 and clearly describe “suspected anaphylactic shock” so emergency teams can bring epinephrine along. Those with a history of severe allergic reactions should consult a doctor for an epinephrine auto-injector and learn how to inject it into the outer midsection of the thigh — this can be done through clothing as well.

## 16. Someone is having a seizure — clear the area, place them on their side, time the episode, and don't put anything in their mouth

**Cost**. No cost at all.

**In plain terms**. Move any hard objects away from the person. Lay them on their side with their mouth facing down, and start timing the seizure. Don't hold them down, don't force their mouth open, and don't put anything into their mouth — doing so can easily damage teeth and jaws. Call emergency services if the seizure lasts more than 5 minutes, if it stops briefly then starts again, if the person doesn't respond afterward or has trouble breathing, if it occurs in water, or if this is the person's first seizure ever. Only give water after they've fully regained consciousness.

**Benefit**. This approach prevents injuries to teeth and jaws caused by forcing the mouth open or inserting foreign objects. It also avoids fractures that can result from restraining a convulsing person. A seizure lasting over 5 minutes is a clear medical emergency requiring immediate ambulance help.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The same page lists several other situations that also demand immediate ambulance call: a seizure that ends only to recur quickly, post-seizure unresponsiveness or breathing difficulty, any injury sustained during the episode, a seizure occurring in water, or a first-time seizure. After the seizure stops, the person should be placed on their side with the mouth down, and only then given water once fully awake. This guidance is primarily intended for family members caring for someone with epilepsy; applying these steps to a stranger offers fewer personal benefits but still protects you from legal liability (Civil Code Article 184, see item 2 in this section — don't rush to lift the person up).

## 17. Diabetic patients suddenly start shaking, break out in cold sweats, and have slurred speech — first give 15 grams of sugar, then retest after 15 minutes

**Cost**. No cost involved. Just keep a few sugar cubes or a small carton of juice on hand.

**In plain terms**. First, give 15 grams of sugar — sugar cubes or a small carton of juice both work fine. Retest blood sugar levels after 15 minutes; if they're still low, repeat the process. A blood sugar level below 3.0 mmol/L is medically significant hypoglycemia. If a person reaches a stage where they need outside help to manage it, it can be fatal. Never feed anything to someone who is unconscious — they could choke, so call emergency services right away.

**Benefit**. A blood sugar level below 3.0 mmol/L qualifies as clinically meaningful hypoglycemia. If a person shows changes in consciousness or behavior that require outside assistance to manage, this is severe hypoglycemia that can be deadly.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Never feed anything to an unconscious person — they could choke, so call emergency services immediately. The same guidelines also recommend that people on insulin or at high risk of hypoglycemia should always carry glucagon. The original text reads: “All individuals treated with insulin or who are at high risk of hypoglycemia…should be prescribed glucagon.” Nasal glucagon sprays and pre-filled injection kits are easier to use than glucagon that needs to be mixed on the spot. This advice is aimed at you or any diabetic family members you care for — keeping sugar on hand is meant to help them in emergencies.

## 18. If someone is electrocuted, cut the power first, then use a dry wooden stick to pry the source of electricity away; never pull the victim by hand directly

**Cost**. No cost involved.

**In plain terms**. First, turn off the power, or use a dry wooden stick to move the electrical source away before touching the victim. Pulling them by hand directly can turn one victim into two. If the victim isn't breathing after being freed from the current, immediately perform chest compressions as described in step 1 of this section — don't hesitate to act just because it's an electrical injury. Never attempt to handle situations involving downed high-voltage lines or nearby electrical equipment on your own; instead, move to a safe distance and wait for utility workers to cut the power.

**Benefit**. This approach prevents rescuers from getting electrocuted as well, avoiding a situation where one victim becomes two. For victims who stop breathing after being freed from the electrical current, performing CPR as outlined in step 1 of this section is effective. The emergency response guidelines from the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention advise: first observe the scene and avoid touching the victim, as they may still be connected to the power source. If possible, cut the power first. If that's not feasible, use non-

conductive materials like cardboard, plastic or wood to move the power source away. For victims with no breathing or pulse after being freed from the current, immediate CPR is required. A review of relevant studies found that patients who suffer cardiac arrest due to electrocution and are successfully revived generally have a good prognosis.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The rule “cut power first, then touch the victim” is purely self-protective: pulling the victim by hand directly means you'll be the next victim. Never attempt to handle downed high-voltage lines or nearby electrical equipment on your own; move to a safe distance and wait for utility workers to cut the power. For cardiac arrest caused by electrocution, standard CPR and defibrillation procedures apply — don't hesitate to perform these just because it's an “electrical injury”.

## 19. If a carbon monoxide alarm goes off, or if several people in a room suddenly get headaches, nausea, or dizziness, get everyone outside before calling for help

**Cost**. No cost at all.

**In plain terms**. When the alarm sounds, or when multiple people in one room start experiencing headaches, nausea, and dizziness, move everyone outdoors first and then call for help. Do not stay inside trying to figure out what's happening, and do not go back inside to turn off any valves. The fact that symptoms improve once outside is a very strong indicator of carbon monoxide exposure. In 2018 alone, China reported 11,523 deaths caused by carbon monoxide poisoning; most of these occurred in winter, and the majority of victims were at home.

**Benefit**. According to China's disease surveillance system, 11,523 people died from carbon monoxide poisoning in 2018. The highest numbers were recorded in January (2,845 cases), February (2,321 cases), and December (2,010 cases). During those three winter months, 66% to 73% of all deaths happened at home. These figures come directly from official reports, not from population-based estimates. In the United States, over 400 people die each year from accidental carbon monoxide poisoning unrelated to fires; more than 100,000 people seek emergency treatment, and over 14,000 are hospitalized.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Symptoms of carbon monoxide poisoning often resemble those of a cold or mild intoxication. When several people in the same space experience these symptoms and feel better immediately after leaving the area, it's a strong sign of exposure. Make sure everyone exits the building before calling for help, and do not attempt to turn off any valves while still inside. Instructions on how to install a carbon monoxide alarm can be found in Section 1, Item 3.

## 20. If someone accidentally ingests detergent, pesticides, or medicine, do not induce vomiting — take the container and seek medical help right away; if it splashes into the eyes or onto the skin, rinse thoroughly with water for at least 15 minutes

**Cost**. No cost involved. Simply keep detergents, disinfectants, pesticides, and medicines out of children's reach, preferably in a locked cabinet. Never transfer them into beverage bottles.

**In plain terms**. If someone swallows detergent, pesticides, or medicine, do not make them vomit — spitting out corrosive liquids would burn the esophagus all over again. Instead, have them drink some milk or egg whites, then head to the hospital right away while bringing the product container and its instructions. If the substance gets into the eyes or onto the skin, rinse with copious amounts of water for a full 15 minutes; for eyes, gently hold the eyelids open while rinsing and avoid rubbing. Mixing disinfectants with toilet cleaners can produce chlorine gas.

**Benefit**. The Chinese CDC provides four distinct response protocols. For ingestion: drink milk or egg whites promptly and, crucially, do not induce vomiting. Seek medical care at once while carrying the packaging or label so doctors can quickly identify the ingredients and plan treatment. For inhalation: move the person to fresh air, loosen tight clothing to ease breathing; if coughing, shortness of breath, or difficulty breathing occurs, get help immediately. For skin contact: wash the area with water for at least 15 minutes, being careful not to let runoff reach the eyes or intact skin. For eye exposure: flush the eyes with water or saline for a minimum of 15 minutes; keep the eyelids open throughout to ensure full coverage and never rub them. After rinsing, visit an ophthalmologist without delay. Products are categorized by pH: those with pH < 3 include toilet cleaners, descalers, floor cleaners, and stainless-steel polishes; some heavy-duty drain cleaners even contain dilute sulfuric acid. Products with pH > 11 comprise drain uncloggers, strong kitchen degreasers, dishwasher powders, oxygen-based stain removers, and abrasive cleaners. A particularly dangerous combination is mixing disinfectants with hydrochloric-acid-based toilet cleaners — this generates chlorine gas that irritates the respiratory tract, provokes severe coughing and breathlessness, and can be life-threatening.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This rating of B reflects that official guidance outlines how to respond and how to identify hazardous products, yet it lacks quantitative data on exactly how much risk reduction results from following those steps. The reason not to induce vomiting is that corrosive substances would re-damage the esophagus upon expulsion. If you're unsure what was ingested, bring the container, its label, and any vomit to the hospital. Prevention is far cheaper than emergency treatment: store chemicals separately from food and drinks, seal containers tightly, discard empty bottles, and never repurpose them for other liquids. When handling these substances, wear rubber gloves and protective goggles, ensure good ventilation, and never mix different types. For carbon monoxide exposure, see item 19; for burns, refer to item 14.

## 21. In case of splashes of acids, alkalis or other chemicals on the body, immediately remove contaminated clothing and rinse with copious amounts of running water; for eyes, gently pull the eyelids apart and rinse thoroughly before leaving the scene

**Cost**. No cost involved. On your first day at work, locate the eyewash stations and safety showers so you won't have to search for them in an emergency.

**In plain terms**. Follow three simple steps. First, strip off any clothing, shoes and socks that have been exposed — the areas covered by fabric sustain the worst injuries. Second, rinse both skin and eyes with plenty of running water for at least 15 minutes; the Hunan Provincial Emergency Management Department recommends 20–30 minutes, so err on the side of caution. Third, pull the eyelids apart to rinse the eyes thoroughly, then head straight to an ophthalmologist. Use lukewarm water, never hot.

**Benefit**. These three on-site actions are vital. First, promptly removing contaminated clothing prevents further absorption of toxins through the skin; areas shielded by fabric are especially vulnerable. Second, copious flushing with water meets the minimum recommendations from the Chinese CDC — at least 15 minutes for skin and eyes — while the Hunan guidelines suggest 20–30 minutes for severe chemical burns, so the longer duration should be followed. Third, gently separating the eyelids ensures water reaches the entire eye surface; rubbing the eyes must be avoided, and immediate medical care is essential. Lukewarm water is ideal; hot water should never be used. Avoid applying ointments, antiseptic solutions or any substances to fresh wounds, and do not cover them with dirty cloth — such actions can obscure the extent of injury and hinder diagnosis. Legally, both chemical skin burns and chemical eye injuries are recognized as occupational diseases; workplace incidents are treated as work-related injuries. In any acute chemical exposure emergency, employers must promptly provide medical treatment, health monitoring and medical observation at their own expense.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This item is graded B because no single national standard specifies the exact flushing duration; one official source cites 15 minutes while another recommends 20–30 minutes. When seeking medical care, bring the chemical's name, packaging or its Safety Data Sheet so doctors can tailor treatment. Never attempt to neutralize a chemical by mixing it with another acid or base — such reactions release heat and are impossible to control. The "neutralizing solution" mentioned in the Hunan document refers to pre-prepared rinse fluids kept on site, not improvised mixtures. Dry powders such as lime or cement should be brushed off before rinsing; some emergency guides suggest drying concentrated sulfuric acid first, but this practice is not uniformly endorsed and is not covered here. For household cleaners and accidental ingestion, refer to Item 20. Pre-employment protective measures and health checks are detailed in Item 19, sections 10 and 11 — employers must provide hazard information and appropriate PPE before workers start their duties.

## 22. Dizziness, nausea, lack of sweating or confusion in high heat — move to shade immediately, remove clothing and apply cool water to cool down; do not give water to anyone who is unconscious, call 120 right away

**Cost**. No cost at all.

**In plain terms**. Red, hot skin, slurred speech and confusion are signs of heatstroke. It can take just minutes for someone to go from feeling dizzy to losing consciousness, and the mortality rate is very high. Immediately move the person to a cool, well-ventilated area, strip off their clothes and use cool water or wet towels to bring their temperature down while calling 120. Never give water to someone who is unconscious — it can cause choking.

**Benefit**. The U.S. National Weather Service describes heatstroke as a "serious medical emergency." Its symptoms include a body temperature above 103°F (39.4°C), confusion, slurred speech and hot, red skin. The recommended response is to call emergency services, move the person to a cool place and apply cool water or wet cloths — "do not give any fluids." Heat exhaustion shows up as heavy sweating, weakness, cool and moist skin, and a rapid but weak pulse; treatment involves moving to shade, loosening clothing and sipping water; seek medical help if vomiting occurs, condition worsens or symptoms persist beyond an hour. The Yunnan Provincial Center for Disease Control warns to relocate to a cool, breezy spot, use cold wet towels, give salt-containing drinks to conscious victims and call emergency services for severe cases — heatstroke carries an extremely high fatality rate. The Chinese CDC advises cooling first, then transporting; the "golden half-hour" after loss of consciousness is critical for effective cooling. Healthy young adults without underlying conditions may safely be immersed in cold water for rapid cooling, while the elderly and those with chronic illnesses should have cool water sprayed on their skin to promote evaporation. The Wilderness Medical Society's 2024 heat-related illness guidelines list cold water immersion as the fastest and most effective method for severe heatstroke; if ice water isn't available, any cool water will do, and if immersion isn't possible, spraying water while fanning can achieve roughly half that cooling rate.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Do not wait for symptoms to "settle down" — heatstroke can progress from dizziness to unconsciousness in just minutes. Never force water into someone who is unconscious; it can cause choking. Opinions differ on where to place ice packs: the Chinese CDC recommends the neck, armpits and groin, whereas the Wilderness Medical Society notes that research shows no distinct cooling benefit from these sites. Their advice is to cover the entire body with ice packs if they're plentiful, and otherwise apply them to the cheeks, palms and soles. Both sources agree that cold water immersion is the best option when available.

## 23. For people suffering from heatstroke, as long as they remain conscious, they should drink small amounts of cool, lightly salted water or sports drinks at frequent intervals — never gulp down large quantities. Alcohol and sugary drinks must be avoided

**Cost**. No cost involved. A bottle of sports drink costs just a few yuan.

**In plain terms**. Only conscious individuals should drink. Consume cool, lightly salted water or sports drinks in small portions, about 500–1000 ml per hour. Do not drink too much at once; vomiting can cause liquid to enter the airways, which is far more dangerous than heatstroke itself. Alcohol and sugary drinks must be avoided, as they cause further fluid loss. Applying cool water to the skin or using ice packs on the neck, armpits, and inner thighs is recommended — cooling should always come before rehydration. Never give anything to drink to someone who is unconscious or speaking incoherently.

**Benefit**. The Chinese CDC published the "Guidelines on Prevention and Emergency Treatment of Heatstroke (2014)," which states: "Consume at least 2–4 cups of cool water per hour (500–1000 ml), ensuring the temperature is not excessively high; drinking should be done in small amounts at frequent intervals." It also advises: "Avoid beverages containing alcohol or large amounts of sugar, as these lead to further fluid loss. Do not consume overly cold drinks." For heatstroke specifically, the guidelines explicitly warn: "Do not give the patient any water to drink." NIOSH in the U.S. recommends encouraging "small, frequent sips of cool water" for heat exhaustion, and for heat cramps, suggests sports drinks with sugar and electrolytes every 15–20 minutes — "do not use salt tablets."

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. After heavy sweating, drinking plain water alone dilutes blood sodium levels, so a bit of salt must be added to the water. Gulping down large amounts at once often leads to vomiting, which can be fatal if liquid enters the airways. The 2014 Chinese CDC guideline advises against "very cold drinks" to prevent stomach cramps, though no quantitative evidence supports this restriction; it should not be interpreted as "no cold drinks at all." In item 22, several cooling methods are described: wiping the body with cool water, immersing in cold water, and applying ice packs to the neck, armpits, and inner thighs — all of which are officially recommended first-line measures. These are meant for external application, not ingestion, and cooling must always precede rehydration. Never give anything to drink to anyone who is unconscious or speaking unclearly.

## 24. Stay low to the ground during a fire, test doors before opening them, and never use elevators — once outside, don't look back

**Cost**. Installing one or two standalone smoke detectors at home costs only a few dozen yuan. It's also worth checking in advance which two exits are available on your hallway.

**In plain terms**. Drop to the ground and crawl toward the nearest exit, staying under any smoke layer. Before opening a door, touch the handle and door surface first; if either feels hot or smoke is seeping through the crack, don't open it — instead, head toward the other exit. Open the door slowly, and shut it immediately if thick smoke rushes in. Always use stairs instead of elevators, since power outages can trap you inside them. Once outside, never turn back to retrieve belongings. If your clothes catch fire, stop where you are, lie down, roll on the ground, and shield your face with your hands.

**Benefit**. FEMA's official fire escape guidance matches these steps exactly: "Drop to the ground and crawl under smoke toward an exit." It also advises testing door handles and surfaces first — "If they're hot, or smoke is coming through the crack, don't open the door; use the other exit instead." Open doors slowly, and close them at once if heavy smoke appears. For clothing fires, the same advice applies: "Stop, lie down, roll, and shield your face." If escape proves impossible, close the door and seal any gaps or vents with cloth or tape, then call for help and state your location. China's emergency management department shares these same recommendations: never use elevators, head downward if the fire is small, cover your nose and mouth with a wet towel or mask, and evacuate while staying low to the ground.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Elevators are a major risk during power outages — never use them. Never return inside to grab possessions. Only head upward if you're certain the roof exit is open; jumping from heights is strictly prohibited. Fold a wet towel three times to create eight layers — too much water makes it heavy and hard to breathe through. Even a wet towel offers little protection against thick smoke or toxic gases.

## 25. Upon seeing someone drowning, shout for help and call 110/120, then reach out a pole or floating objects — never enter the water yourself

**Cost**. No cost involved. The hard part is resisting the urge to jump in.

**In plain terms**. A drowning person instinctively pulls their rescuer underwater, so anyone who enters the water risks drowning too. The proper sequence is: shout for help → call emergency services → extend a long pole or rope → throw life rings, empty buckets, or plastic bottles → if the victim is on shore and not breathing, start CPR immediately. Never form a human chain by holding hands and entering the water. Globally, roughly 300,000 people drown each year; this ranks as the fourth leading cause of death among children aged 1–4.

**Benefit**. WHO reports that about 300,000 drownings occur worldwide each year, with 92% occurring in low- and middle-income countries. Drowning is the fourth leading cause of death for kids aged 1–4 and the third leading cause for those aged 5–14. WHO recommends “safe rescue and resuscitation training” — essentially learning how to help without entering the water. The recommended steps are identical: shout for help → call emergency services → reach out poles or ropes, toss life rings, empty buckets, or bottles → if the victim is out of water and not breathing, perform CPR right away.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Grade C is assigned because no official source explicitly states the “do not enter the water” rule; we only have WHO's global death statistics and the broader principle of “safe rescue.” Never form a human chain by holding hands and jumping in. Untrained individuals should not attempt to pull a drowning person out, as the victim will instinctively pull them underwater. This “stay out of water” rule also serves self-preservation — anyone who enters the water risks drowning, regardless of who the victim is. Most cases involve a child, so prevention is covered in Section 1, Item 12: keep children under constant supervision near water. If someone falls through ice, do not run onto the ice to pull them; prevention is in Section 1, item 41 (measure outdoor ice thickness first).

## 26. If someone is choking and can't speak, stand behind them (age 1 and over) and perform 5 back blows followed by 5 abdominal thrusts; if they collapse, start CPR immediately

**Cost**. No cost involved. To perform the technique: make a fist with one hand and place it just above the navel, then wrap the other hand around it and deliver quick inward and upward thrusts.

**In plain terms**. First ask, “Are you choking? Can you speak?” If the person can still cough or make sounds, let them cough on their own. For anyone over 1 year old who can't speak, stand behind them and give 5 back blows followed by 5 abdominal thrusts, repeating this sequence until the object comes out or the person loses consciousness. Once they collapse, begin CPR right away and call emergency services. For pregnant women or very overweight individuals, perform chest thrusts instead. Never reach into someone's mouth to try to remove an unseen object.

**Benefit**. According to the original text from the U.S. National Library of Medicine: First ask, “Are you choking? Can you speak?” It also states that “if the person can still cough forcefully or speak, do not intervene” since coughing often removes the obstruction on its own. If they can't speak, “repeatedly perform 5 back blows followed by 5 abdominal thrusts until the object is dislodged or the person loses consciousness.” At that point, “begin CPR immediately” while calling emergency services. Chest thrusts are recommended for pregnant women and those with obesity.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Never reach into someone's mouth to remove an unseen object — this can push it deeper. Do not perform this technique on anyone who is still able to cough. Choking incidents most often occur at home, so these steps are especially useful for family members. This same method is taught in China: The Fujian Red Cross Emergency Rescue Training Center notes that for children over 1 year old and adults alike, the Red

Cross system has long taught a cycle of 5 back blows followed by 5 abdominal thrusts. Many older online tutorials only cover abdominal thrusts; those are outdated versions of this procedure.

## 27. If lost or stranded in the Gobi Desert, a desert, or any remote area, stay put next to your vehicle. First, transmit your location, then shield yourself from the sun and retain body heat, conserve water, and avoid wandering off

**Cost**. Before venturing into such areas, inform someone of your planned route, destination, return date, vehicle type, and license plate number. You'll need at least 4 liters of water per person per day. Satellite communicators or BeiDou short-message devices cost thousands of yuan; rental fees range from several hundred yuan per use. The real challenge is simply remembering to stay put and not wander away.

**In plain terms**. Stay right where you are, preferably next to your vehicle — it serves as the best shelter from the sun. The proper sequence is: if you have a signal, send your location first and then make a call; next, shield yourself from the sun and retain body heat; then conserve water by staying motionless during the day and only moving after nightfall when it cools down; avoid wandering off; finally, use reflective surfaces, smoke, or three fire piles to signal for help. Be sure to share your route, destination, return date, vehicle type, and license plate details with someone before you depart.

**Benefit**. The National Park Service's Mojave Desert page lists three key statements: “Each person needs at least 1 gallon (roughly 3.8 liters) of water daily; hikers and cyclists require 2 gallons per day.” “Tell someone about your planned route, destination, return date, vehicle type, and license plate number.” “Cell service is intermittent.” Death Valley's guidance advises: “Avoid hiking in the valley floor or at low elevations during peak heat,” while other wilderness areas note “virtually no cell coverage” and recommend bringing a satellite phone. The Mojave driving guide explicitly states: “In an emergency, staying next to your vehicle is the single most important action you can take.” It also notes that such incidents are rare, yet some people still perish from heat exposure or cold after attempting to walk back to a road. These recommendations are organized into five priority steps: first, transmit a status update and coordinates; second, shield yourself from the sun and retain body heat; third, conserve water by staying still during daylight and moving only after nightfall; fourth, avoid wandering off; fifth, attempt to signal for help. The Chongqing Emergency Management Bureau adds that three fire piles arranged in a triangle constitute an internationally recognized distress signal; if rescuers are nearby, shout “three short bursts, three long bursts, then three short bursts” and repeat every minute. On sunny days, reflective objects such as mirrors or tin cans can also be used to attract attention. Meanwhile, China's Ministry of Culture and Tourism cautions independent drivers against venturing into remote zones; it advises traveling in groups and renting a satellite phone if necessary.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. This C rating reflects that these recommendations stem from official guidelines rather than empirical research data. The recommended water intake levels, mandatory reporting procedures, known signal coverage patterns, the directive to remain near one's vehicle, and the prescribed distress signals all originate directly from official sources. The commonly cited “three short bursts, three long bursts, then three short bursts” phrase could not be verified in any official documentation; consequently, it has been replaced with the officially endorsed method of deploying three fire piles and repeating the three-short-three-long-three-short pattern. Additionally, it is vital to avoid hiking in search of help during midday heat, never drink urine, and under no circumstances withhold water intake merely to conserve supplies.

## 28. Shivering, slurred speech, and unsteady walking are signs of hypothermia; change into dry clothes, wrap up, warm the torso first, and give sweet hot drinks instead of alcohol

**Cost**. An emergency thermal blanket costs just a few dollars, plus a spare dry set of clothes. Learning to recognize the warning signs costs nothing.

**In plain terms**. When body temperature drops below 35°C, hypothermia sets in. Victims start to shiver, speak unclearly, walk unsteadily, and have trouble thinking. Remove any wet clothing and wrap the person in a thermal blanket or dry clothes, making sure to warm the torso before the limbs. Offer sweet hot drinks, but avoid alcohol — it suppresses shivering. The absence of shivering does not mean improvement; it actually signals worsening condition. If the person loses consciousness, begin CPR immediately.

**Benefit**. According to the U.S. National Weather Service, any body temperature below 95°F (35°C) indicates hypothermia, and symptoms such as feeling cold, sluggishness, and confusion warrant immediate medical attention. Recommended actions include moving the victim to a warm indoor environment, focusing on warming the core first, and providing hot drinks. Alcohol is discouraged because it reduces shivering. CPR is required if the person becomes unconscious. Warm water or body heat can be used to treat frostbite, but avoid hot water or direct radiant heat sources like fireplaces. The Wilderness Medical Society's 2019 hypothermia guidelines serve as the authoritative clinical reference on this topic.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Do not rub or massage the limbs to warm them. Avoid hot baths at all costs. Do not drag or force-move a severely hypothermic person — their heart may stop unexpectedly. Remember, the absence of shivering is not a sign of recovery; it often means the condition is worsening. Full access to the Wilderness Medical Society's guideline requires a subscription; this translation is based solely on its summary.

## 29. After a snake bite, stay still, remove rings and watches, and rush to a hospital offering antivenom — no cutting, no suction, no tight binding

**Cost**. No cost involved. The key is knowing in advance which nearby hospitals stock antivenom; the real challenge is resisting the urge to treat the wound yourself.

**In plain terms**. Sit down and stay motionless; immobilize the bitten limb. Remove any rings or watches right away, as swelling will set in quickly. Get to a hospital with antivenom as fast as possible — this is the only treatment capable of reversing most toxic effects. Do not cut the wound, do not suck out venom with your mouth, do not apply ice, and do not tie anything so tightly that the skin turns purple. Avoid alcohol and physical exertion. If possible, take a photo of the snake from a safe distance — do not try to catch it.

**Benefit**. The WHO lists three key recommendations: “Immediately immobilize the affected body part and transport the victim to the nearest medical facility,” “Avoid using tourniquets and do not cut the wound,” and “Administer appropriate antivenom specific to local snake species.” High-quality antivenom is the most effective treatment for preventing or reversing most toxic effects of snake bites. Globally, 81,000–138,000 people die from snake bites each year, and the number of amputations and permanent disabilities is roughly three times that figure. China's 2024 guidelines estimate 250,000–280,000 venomous snake bites annually, with victims most often aged 50 or older. Between 2017 and 2021, hospitals in 11 southern provinces along the Yangtze River treated 40,817 snake-bite patients; 23 of them (0.06%) died during hospitalization.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Take a photo of the snake if you can — do not attempt to capture it. Avoid alcohol, running, suction of venom, ice packs, and overly tight bindings. China does not publish official nationwide statistics on snake-bite mortality. Although the reported hospitalization mortality rate in those 11 provinces appears low, over 10% of patients leave the hospital before completing treatment; their subsequent outcomes are not reflected in these figures.

## 30. First, figure out what kind of building you're in during an earthquake: if it meets seismic safety standards, stay right where you are; if it's an old structure prone to collapse, head outside right away

**Cost**. No cost at all. Just take a moment beforehand to see how many steps it takes to reach the exit, which route to take, and which tables are sturdy enough to hide under.

**In plain terms**. First, determine what kind of building you're in. For structures built after 2001 that meet seismic codes, you'll need to go down stairs or through a hallway to exit — so stay put: protect your head and neck, crawl under a solid table, and hold onto its legs tightly. In single-story homes, older brick buildings, or makeshift houses without seismic protection, the exit is just a few steps away — so leave immediately. Under no circumstances should you jump from heights, use elevators, or try to run down stairs while the ground is shaking.

**Benefit**. The China Earthquake Administration's educational video “Earthquake: Hide or Run?” promotes the rule “Take shelter nearby during the quake, then evacuate quickly afterward,” but explicitly limits this advice to “buildings that meet seismic safety standards.” The reasoning is that such structures “are far less likely to collapse entirely.” The video also notes that “falling building components and decorative items” pose the greatest threat to life safety, while “running around without any protection during a quake” increases the risk of being struck by falling ceilings, chandeliers, or other objects. Recommended actions include “using hands or soft objects to shield the head and neck” and “gripping table legs tightly”; if no table is available, “crouch close to load-bearing walls and stay away from exterior walls, windows, and balconies.” For those outdoors, the advice is “immediately move to an open area away from hazards.” Conversely, during the 1988 Armenian earthquake, Soviet-era prefabricated panel buildings collapsed en masse. A case-control study conducted after that disaster concluded that “leaving a building right after the first tremor is a protective behavior.” People who remained indoors were 4.40 times more likely to sustain injuries than those who evacuated (95% CI 2.24–8.71). The odds of injury indoors were 12.20 times higher than outdoors (3.62–63.79), and in buildings five stories or taller, this risk rose to 3.65 times that of lower structures (2.12–6.33).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This topic remains debated, as the two main conclusions apply to distinctly different types of buildings. The China Earthquake Administration itself stipulates that “taking shelter” is only advisable “in buildings that meet seismic safety standards,” and also emphasizes that decisions must be “tailored to local conditions and individual circumstances” — meaning you must consider both the building's structural integrity and your own physical ability to move. In Armenia, entire buildings collapsed, leaving no safe spot to hide, so evacuation was the only viable option. The U.S. Federal Emergency Management Agency advises residents to “drop to the ground, protect the head and neck, hold on tight, and avoid running outside” — where injuries are primarily caused by falling debris and falls during tremors. Research from the Northridge earthquake further shows that reaching for objects or gripping seemingly stable items can actually increase injury risk. Ultimately, the key question isn't “should I run or stay?” but rather “is this building likely to collapse, and can I reach open ground within seconds?” For buildings constructed after 2001 that require navigating stairs or hallways to exit, staying put is the safest choice. For single-story homes, older brick buildings, and makeshift houses without seismic protection, the exit is just a few steps away — so leave immediately. It's worth noting that the Armenian study only compared injured and uninjured survivors, excluded fatalities, and didn't account for differences in building height; since those able to escape were more likely to live on lower floors, these figures should be interpreted with some caution. Under no circumstances should you jump from heights, use elevators, or attempt to run down stairs during tremors. Once outside, stay far away from tall structures, overpasses, utility poles, glass facades, and billboards.

## 31. When encountering bears, wild boars, or packs of wild dogs, don't run — instead, turn sideways and back away slowly

**Cost**. No cost involved. When heading into the mountains, bring a hiking pole, hike in a group, and make noise so animals know you're coming. The hardest part is staying put instead of running.

**In plain terms**. Never run — bears can sprint uphill or downhill just as fast as racehorses. Also, don't climb trees; both black bears and brown bears are excellent climbers. Stand your ground and keep speaking to the bear in a low, calm voice. Once it stops moving, turn sideways and back away slowly. If a brown bear attacks, lie down and play dead: place your hands behind your neck and spread your legs apart. For black bear attacks, do not play dead — run toward a vehicle or building; if escape is impossible, fight back using whatever is at hand. In case of dog bites, follow the steps outlined in item 13.

**Benefit**. The original guidelines issued by the U.S. National Park Service on bear encounters contain six key points: “Do not run — bears can sprint uphill or downhill just as fast as racehorses.” “Stay calm; most bears have no interest in attacking and simply want to be left alone.” “Keep speaking to the bear in a low, steady voice.” “When the bear stops moving, turn sideways and back away slowly so you can keep watching it without tripping.” “Make yourself appear as large as possible.” “Do not climb trees — both grizzly bears and black bears are capable climbers.” In the event of a brown bear attack, “lie down and play dead, placing hands behind the neck and legs apart.” For black bear attacks, “do not play dead; run toward a vehicle or building, and if escape is impossible, fight back using any available object.” Dog bites should be treated according to item 13.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The Grade B rating applies solely to bear encounters. The advice regarding wild boars and packs of wild dogs — namely, “don't run, back away slowly, and seek higher ground or obstacles for protection” — is based on anecdotal experience and is rated Grade C; no official recommendations from China's forestry authorities or local agencies were identified for these scenarios. Never try to lure animals with food, approach them for photos, or bring dogs into mountainous areas inhabited by wild boars. In China, the primary bear species are black bears and brown bears; the decision to play dead or not depends on which species is involved.

## 32. If caught in a thunderstorm outdoors, get into a hard-topped vehicle or building; avoid ridges, lone trees, water surfaces, and metal objects

**Cost**. No monetary cost. The downside is that your trip gets interrupted for at least half an hour. The real challenge is actually turning back when the thunder is still far away.

**In plain terms**. There is no safe spot outdoors during a thunderstorm. You must get into a hard-topped vehicle or building; convertibles and motorcycles do not qualify. Tents, gazebos, areas under trees, or rocky outcrops also do not count as shelter. Stay away from open areas, mountain ridges and peaks, isolated tall trees, water surfaces, and metal railings or poles. If a group cannot all fit together, spread out rather than huddling close. Begin retreating the moment you hear thunder; it is only safe to leave 30 minutes after the final clap of thunder.

**Benefit**. There is no safe spot outdoors during a thunderstorm. It is only safe to leave 30 minutes after the final clap of thunder.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Tents, gazebos, areas under trees, and rocky outcrops do not qualify as shelters. Hard-topped cars do count, but convertibles and motorcycles do not. Start retreating the instant you hear thunder; do not wait until rain begins to fall.

## 33. Gradually increase your sleeping altitude when heading to high elevations; if symptoms worsen, descend immediately — don't tough it out

**Cost**. It requires an extra day or two for acclimatization. Preventive medications are prescription-only, so you must consult a doctor before traveling. The main challenge is fitting these days into an otherwise tight itinerary.

**In plain terms**. This guideline focuses on sleeping altitude, not daytime elevation. Sleeping above 2,450 meters already poses a risk of altitude sickness. Once above 3,000 meters, you should only raise your nighttime altitude by 500 meters per night, allowing an additional day of acclimatization for every 1,000-meter increase. Symptoms such as headache, nausea, unsteady gait, altered mental state, or shortness of breath even at rest indicate the need to descend. Descending takes priority over oxygen therapy or medication.

**Benefit**. Sleeping above 2,450 meters increases the risk of altitude sickness. Without prompt descent, high-altitude cerebral edema and pulmonary edema — fluid buildup in the brain and lungs — can be fatal.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The rule specifically refers to sleeping altitude, not daytime elevation. Headache, nausea, unsteadiness, confusion, or breathlessness at rest are clear signs to descend. Descending should always come before oxygen use or medication; continuing upward while on oxygen is unsafe.

## 34. To remove a tick, use fine-point tweezers to pull it straight out along the skin — don't apply oil, don't use heat

**Cost**. A pair of fine-point tweezers.

**In plain terms**. Use fine-point tweezers to grasp the tick's head right against the skin, then pull steadily outward. Never apply oil, use heat, or yank sideways — doing so can force infectious fluids into the skin and often leaves the tick's mouthparts embedded. After removal, write down the date. If you develop fever, rash, or fatigue in the following weeks, be sure to mention the tick bite to your doctor.

**Benefit**. Applying oil, using heat, or pulling sideways can provoke the tick to release infectious fluids into the skin. Those actions also raise the risk of leaving its mouthparts stuck inside. In China, tick-borne severe fever with thrombocytopenia syndrome led to 6,602 reported cases and 306 deaths in 2024 — the highest totals on record. From 2010 through 2024, the average fatality rate stood at 4.79%, rising with age; for those over 85 it reached 9.15%.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Be sure to note the date of removal. Should fever, rash, or fatigue appear in the weeks that follow, inform your doctor about the tick bite — otherwise it may be misdiagnosed as a common cold.

## 35. Always boil any water taken from the wild before drinking it; one minute of boiling is sufficient — there's no need to extend the time just because you're at high altitude

**Cost**. You'll need to carry extra weight in the form of a stove and fuel.

**In plain terms**. Any microbes capable of causing illness through water are killed within seconds at boiling temperature. Boiling for an additional minute simply provides a safety margin for any possible oversight; it isn't necessary to prolong the process at higher elevations. If boiling isn't feasible, use a filter or chemical purification tablets instead — each method has its own limitations regarding which pathogens they can eliminate. Even crystal-clear streams and meltwater can harbor parasites.

**Benefit**. All microbes that can cause disease via water are inactivated within seconds at boiling temperature. The belief that water fails to reach a safe temperature at high altitudes is a common misconception.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The same page also notes that boiling isn't strictly mandatory: maintaining water at 60°C for 30 minutes achieves the same effect, and boiling simply offers a visible endpoint without needing a thermometer. Filters and chemical tablets each have their own gaps in pathogen coverage, so boiling remains preferable when possible. Just because water appears clear doesn't mean it's free of parasites — appearance alone is no reliable indicator.

## 36. If a stranger demands money in a remote area, hand over cash, avoid any confrontation, note their features, and call police after escaping

**Cost**. The cash you have on you. The real challenge is keeping your temper in check.

**In plain terms**. Give him the money, do not fight back, and do not argue. By demanding a few hundred yuan, he is committing robbery — a crime punishable by at least three years up to ten years in prison. If he enters a residence, uses a weapon, or causes serious injury or death, the sentence rises to ten years or more, even life imprisonment or death. If you chase after him and strike him after he has taken the money, that is

no longer considered self-defence. Immediately after escaping, write down his appearance, accent, vehicle license plate, and the direction he fled, then call 110.

**Benefit**. Your life is far more valuable than a few hundred yuan. The offender is committing a serious crime for such a small amount. Article 263 of the Criminal Law states that anyone who robs public or private property by violence, coercion, or other means faces three to ten years in prison plus a fine; aggravating circumstances raise the penalty to ten years or more, even death. Article 20 limits self-defence to stopping an ongoing unlawful attack; once the robber has taken the money and walked away, any retaliation is no longer justified. After escaping, record his description, speech patterns, vehicle details, and escape route, then call 110.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The “C” rating reflects the lack of direct literature supporting the principle that “handing over money avoids danger”; the legal text merely outlines the offender's risks and your boundaries. Never follow an attacker to a secluded spot to “get money,” never reveal your phone password, and never get into his vehicle. This advice is not an invitation to fight or to refrain from calling police; it applies only when you are physically threatened in a remote setting and must first pay to ensure your safety. In contrast, if someone online threatens to release private photos or videos, you must never pay — see Section 8, Item 32 for those cases.

## 37. If you stumble upon a group fight, walk away immediately — don't try to break it up, don't stand around watching, and don't pick up any weapons on the ground. If you want to call the police, retreat to a safe distance and dial 110

**Cost**. No money is required. The hard part is resisting the urge to step in and the temptation to watch from the sidelines. After calling, you might be asked to give a statement later; at most, this takes half a day.

**In plain terms**. If you intervene, your actions shift from “trying to calm things down” to “taking part in a fight.” Participating in a group brawl can land you in prison for up to three years; if many people are involved, it happens on a road, or weapons are used, the sentence rises to three to ten years. Watching isn't worth it either — the more onlookers there are, the messier the scene gets, and you're more likely to get hurt. The right move is to walk away. If you do want to call the police, step back to a safe spot and dial 110, clearly stating the location, how many people are involved, whether anyone is carrying knives or sticks, and if anyone has collapsed.

**Benefit**. Article 292 of the Criminal Law states: “Those who lead or actively take part in group brawls shall be sentenced to up to three years in prison, criminal detention, or surveillance.” If the brawls happen repeatedly, involve many people, have a big social impact, occur in public spaces or on busy roads, or involve weapons, the punishment rises to three to ten years. If such fights cause serious injury or death, perpetrators are charged under laws on intentional injury or homicide. The Public Security Administration Punishment Law also sets penalties: assaulting others brings a detention of five to ten days plus fines of 500 to 1,000 yuan. Group fights handled as hooliganism can lead to up to fifteen days in jail and fines up to 2,000 yuan. Guideline 5 of the “Opinions on Properly Applying Self-Defence” says unlawful attacks include those aimed at you, at the public, or at others. Guideline 9 adds that if one side starts the fight with excessive force, or continues attacking even after the other side tries to avoid conflict, the responding party is usually considered acting in self-defence.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is B because part of the consequences are backed by clear legal text, but the advice “walk away and call the police instead of intervening” isn't directly stated in any official rule — it's inferred from those statutes and from how group fights are judged. Saying “I was just trying to mediate” isn't a shield; what matters is whether you actually took part and whom you hit. If an attacker is already down or has fled, chasing them to hit them no longer counts as self-defence. Legally, you may intervene if you see someone being unilaterally beaten; self-defence protects not only you but also others. Yet stepping in bare-handed

usually just adds another casualty. Calling for help, recording from afar, and calling police are far more effective. The safest choice here is “don't intervene, don't watch.” The benefit of calling 110 mainly helps the victim on the ground; overall, this entry offers one of the lowest net benefits in the book, so you must weigh whether the time investment is worth it. You should know a few key facts first. There is already a legal duty to testify: Article 62 of the Criminal Procedure Law says anyone aware of a case must testify; not calling police doesn't erase that duty. In cases involving serious injury or death, police can still identify witnesses from surveillance footage, so standing around watching actually makes you more likely to be recorded. Authorities “must keep the identity of anonymous callers confidential” (Article 111). Simply stating the location, number of people, and whether weapons are present is enough — you needn't stay on the scene. Only if a court summons you to testify without a valid reason and you refuse can you face up to ten days in detention (Article 193); ordinary bystanders rarely reach that point. Not calling police isn't illegal: Article 110 of the Criminal Procedure Law mentions a “right and duty” without any penalty, and no criminal law punishes ordinary citizens for not reporting what they see, so walking away is perfectly legal. Two actions after walking away would cross the line: helping hide someone or giving false testimony to protect them (Article 310 of the Criminal Law, up to three years; serious cases bring three to ten years); and deliberately giving false testimony when called as a witness (Article 305, up to three years; serious cases up to seven years). Staying silent or telling the truth is fine; fabricating stories is not. If you yourself get caught in a fight, see Section 8, Item 10; if a stranger demands money, see Item 36 of this section; for costs after helping an injured person, see Item 39.

## 38. If you may have been exposed to HIV, get PEP within 72 hours — the sooner, the better

**Cost**. A full 28-day course of PEP can cost thousands of yuan; in most regions it must be paid out-of-pocket. You'll need to rush to a hospital that same night. The hardest part is admitting you might be infected and leaving right away.

**In plain terms**. If you suspect you've been exposed to HIV, 72 hours is the hard deadline — ideally you should start PEP within 2 hours. The medication must be taken for 28 consecutive days. After 72 hours this option is no longer available, so don't wait until the next day to decide.

**Benefit**. The Beijing Municipal Government's HIV-prevention outreach defines this as “post-exposure prophylaxis,” abbreviated PEP. It recommends starting preventive medication “as soon as possible, ideally within 2 hours and no later than 24 hours, but not after 72 hours,” and continuing for 28 days. Beyond 72 hours PEP is not advised. This strict timeline means that acting immediately versus waiting a night can produce completely different outcomes.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Where to obtain PEP: any designated HIV-treatment clinic affiliated with the local Chinese CDC, usually under the Infectious Diseases or STD/HIV department. Many cities now offer 24-hour clinics; in Chongqing, for example, 29 such clinics operate across 26 districts, 14 of which are open around the clock. Call the local CDC beforehand to find a clinic with PEP on hand — don't waste time in the emergency room. Situations considered “exposures” include unprotected sex, a broken condom, needle sticks, or blood contact with mucous membranes; only a doctor can decide whether PEP is appropriate. The full 28-day regimen must be completed; missing doses markedly reduces its effectiveness. Follow-up testing is required at 4–6 weeks and at 3 months as directed by your physician. This is a remedial measure, not a substitute for regular prevention; for everyday safeguards and testing, see items 30 and 31 in Chapter 1 (consistent condom use and testing after high-risk encounters).

## 39. After saving someone and getting injured or incurring expenses, first seek compensation from the perpetrator and yibao; then apply for recognition as a person acting in the public interest

**Cost**. There is no direct expense. However, submitting the application requires paperwork, waiting for approval, and multiple visits — this can take weeks or even months.

**In plain terms**. If you get hurt while saving someone, you're not simply out of luck. Those injured while acting in the public interest should receive treatment first, with costs covered afterward. Medical bills are the responsibility of the perpetrator; if the perpetrator flees or cannot pay, basic medical insurance steps in. Even without a perpetrator, the person you saved is legally obligated to provide reasonable compensation — this is a legal requirement, not a matter of personal generosity. At the same time, you should apply for official recognition as a person acting in the public interest so that any injuries can be treated under workers' compensation rules.

**Benefit**. Article 183 of the Civil Code states: “Anyone who suffers harm while protecting another person's civil rights is entitled to compensation from the perpetrator; if no perpetrator exists, has fled, or cannot pay, the beneficiary must provide reasonable compensation.” State Council Document No. 39 of 2012 further clarifies how to handle medical care for such individuals. Healthcare facilities must establish a fast-track system based on the principle “treat first, bill later.” Specifically, medical expenses incurred during emergency treatment are the responsibility of the perpetrator or liable party; otherwise, they are covered by basic medical insurance. In cases of death, individuals meeting criteria for martyr status are recognized as such by law; those qualifying as work-related injuries receive a one-time death benefit plus an additional special allowance equal to 40 months of their salary. Injured individuals meeting workers' compensation criteria receive benefits under the relevant regulations; others have their disability level assessed by civil affairs bureaus to determine appropriate support. Employment-wise, such individuals are prioritized for job assistance programs and placed in public-sector roles when possible. Housing-wise, they are given priority access to subsidized housing or rental assistance.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because national documents clearly define which benefits apply; however, exact amounts of bonuses and detailed application procedures vary by province under local regulations, and these specifics were not verified across all regions in this round. Applications are typically submitted to local police departments or dedicated civil affairs bureaus responsible for recognizing acts of public service. Successful recognition depends on solid evidence: police reports, surveillance footage, witness contact details, and medical records gathered promptly at the scene. Legal aid for such cases is also available free of charge. National standards for death benefits and disability compensation calculations are explained in Sections 15 and 16 of Chapter 19; instructions for obtaining legal aid can be found in Section 3 of Chapter 7.

## 40. Knives, rebar, glass piercing the body – apply pressure around the foreign object to stop bleeding; do not pull it out

**Cost**. No cost involved. The hard part is resisting the instinct to “pull it out” and instead staying with the injured person until help arrives.

**In plain terms**. Pulling out the object can cause severe bleeding and makes it harder for doctors to assess the extent of the injury. The correct approach is to call 120, then use your hand or a dressing to apply firm pressure around the object to control bleeding and keep it stable so it doesn't move. If internal organs are visible through an abdominal wound, do not push them back in; simply cover them with a clean, moist dressing. For chest wounds where air bubbles are escaping, do not seal them with plastic wrap – doing so can cause the lung to collapse.

**Benefit**. The 2025 International First Aid Guidelines from the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies state: “First aiders should apply pressure around any foreign object (such as a knife) that has penetrated the body and keep it stable; do not remove it.” “Never pull any object out of abdominal or

chest wounds – doing so can cause severe bleeding and makes it harder to assess the injury." "Foreign objects embedded in the body should be kept stable; if they move with the pulse, simply hold them gently in place." "First aiders must not push protruding organs back into the body." For open chest wounds with active bleeding, "it is acceptable to leave them uncovered, as sealing them may trap air in the chest cavity and cause partial or total lung collapse (pneumothorax)." All penetrating abdominal or chest injuries require immediate emergency care.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because these actions are widely accepted in official guidelines; however, no randomized trials exist, and it would be unethical to randomly assign patients to "remove" versus "not remove" such objects. The sole exception is when a foreign object blocks the airway and prevents breathing. In such cases, go directly to the emergency triage desk at the hospital and state "penetrating injury." This falls under the highest priority category – do not wait in line at the registration desk (see Section 24, Item 8). If a penetrating injury occurs, call 120; the ambulance will alert the hospital in advance. For techniques on controlling severe bleeding and applying tourniquets, see Section 12.

## 41. If a fracture is suspected, don't move the injured area — keep it supported and apply cold for up to 20 minutes; never try to realign it yourself

**Cost**. No cost involved. Use a stiff board, rolled-up magazines, or clothing as a splint. Wrap cold items in a cloth before applying them.

**In plain terms**. Treat any limb injury as a possible fracture first; being able to stand or move does not rule it out. Keep the injured part still, supported by hand or by a stiff board in its original position, and apply cold for no more than 20 minutes at a time. Do not try to realign it yourself; if bone has pierced the skin, stop the bleeding first and do not push the bone back. An X-ray can miss a fracture. If the film looks normal but the doctor still suspects a fracture or a ligament injury, follow the doctor's advice to come back for a repeat exam or an MRI.

**Benefit**. The International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies released its 2025 International First Aid Guidelines, which state that "any injury to a limb should be treated as a possible fracture" and "the only reliable way to confirm a fracture is an X-ray; when in doubt, treat it as a fracture." The purpose of immobilisation is "to minimise movement and pain." Cold application "should be limited to 20 minutes at a time to reduce pain; longer exposure can damage the skin." "For long bones such as the femur, bleeding from the bone itself can be life-threatening." Call emergency services if there is significant pain or swelling, signs of shock, a suspected femoral fracture, or obvious deformity of the limb. Only under two specific conditions may a fractured bone be manually realigned on site: first, when help is far away (or resources are limited) and the part of the limb below the angle appears cold and pale, or when the rescuer cannot safely immobilise it for transport; second, only if the rescuer is properly trained. For open fractures, the priority is stopping bleeding and preventing infection. But a first X-ray that shows nothing does not mean there is no fracture. The guideline on hip fracture from the UK National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE) says: if the X-ray is normal but a hip fracture is still suspected, "do an MRI"; if that cannot be done within 24 hours, consider a CT. Its fracture guideline says: for a suspected wrist scaphoid fracture, "after careful physical examination, consider an MRI first". The scaphoid is a small bone in the wrist. A Cochrane review states: "initial X-rays cannot exclude a fracture". In the studies it included, among people whose X-rays were normal but whose doctors still suspected a scaphoid fracture, the median share with a real fracture was 20%. The American College of Radiology has an appropriateness standard for knee trauma. It says: when the X-ray shows no fracture but an occult fracture or internal joint injury is still suspected, MRI as the next step is "usually appropriate". It also says MRI is highly accurate for occult fractures and for meniscal and ligament injuries.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade B rating reflects that these practices are widely accepted. There is only one older study supporting the use of traction immobilisation for femoral fractures before hospital care; its reliability is low, yet it shows modest benefits such as reduced blood loss within 24 hours, shorter hospital stays, and no meaningful difference in mortality or complications. No evidence exists regarding whether early realignment yields any advantage over simple immobilisation. Three common misconceptions should be corrected: being able to walk does not rule out a fracture; cold alone — not alternating hot and cold — is appropriate; and sprains do not "work themselves out" with movement; rest is essential. Do not smoke until the bone has healed; see Section 2, item 1 (quit smoking). Don't expect heavy calcium supplements or bone broth to make the bone heal faster; see Section 6, item 30 (calcium after a fracture). For elderly patients with suspected fractures after a fall, refer to item 2 for handling precautions. Swelling of one leg after casting or bed rest may indicate a clot; see item 11 for details. Information on disability assessment and eligibility for a disability certificate after treatment can be found in section 24, items 9 and 10.

## 42. After sexual assault, go to a safe place and call 110; do not shower, wash clothes, or tidy the room before a medical exam, and visit a hospital within 72 hours

**Cost**. Calling the police costs nothing. Emergency contraceptives are over-the-counter medicines available at any pharmacy. Post-exposure prophylaxis treatment costs over a thousand yuan per course; whether it is needed must be decided by a doctor — see item 38 in this section regarding obtaining PEP within 72 hours. The real challenge is that it is extremely hard to speak up at the moment, and many victims simply want to take a shower right away.

**In plain terms**. Physical traces on the body, on clothing, and in the room are the most crucial evidence for identifying the perpetrator. Therefore, avoid showering, washing clothes, or cleaning the area before a medical exam, and call 110 as soon as possible. Emergency contraceptives are readily available at pharmacies and work best when taken early. Within 72 hours, visit a hospital so a doctor can determine if PEP is necessary.

**Benefit**. Prosecutors from the Beijing People's Procuratorate state: "Whether minors or adults, anyone who experiences sexual assault should call 110 immediately." Prompt reporting and medical care "allow investigators to examine the scene, collect physical evidence, and preserve proof in a timely manner." A sexual assault prevention guide published by the Guizhou Provincial Civil Affairs Bureau and reprinted by People's Daily advises: "If sexual assault occurs, preserving evidence is the top priority." It recommends keeping "body fluids, hair, skin cells, and communication records" and warns that "after an assault, one must not shower, wash clothes, tidy the room, or throw anything away." In cases involving acquaintances, preserving call logs and messages is essential; any threats or attempts at bribery by the perpetrator must also be documented. The Xicheng District Procuratorate in Beijing adds: "Try not to shower before undergoing a physical examination." WHO notes that emergency contraception may be used "when a woman has been sexually assaulted without effective contraceptive protection," recommending its use within five days for maximum effectiveness. Emergency contraceptive pills containing levonorgestrel have a pregnancy rate of 1.2% to 2.1% among users; in China, such pills are sold over the counter. According to the Wuhan Health Commission, "the sooner these pills are taken after unprotected intercourse — ideally within 72 hours — the better they prevent pregnancy." PEP for HIV should be taken within two hours if possible, and no later than 72 hours.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because these recommendations stem from official law-enforcement experience and medical guidance; there are no statistics showing exactly how much they raise conviction rates. The main beneficiaries are the victim herself and her family. The 72-hour window for emergency contraception reflects China's product labeling; WHO states that it remains effective up to five days, though earlier use is preferable. These pills have no effect if pregnancy has already occurred. When reporting to police, provide a truthful account without exaggeration or concealment. Any attempts by the perpetrator to settle privately, pay compensation, or threaten you must be documented and never deleted. You may decide to wait before

calling police, but be aware that evidence deteriorates over time. Regardless of whether you call police, seek medical care within the stipulated timeframe. Recordings related to this topic are discussed in item 41 of section 8. If the perpetrator later uses photos or police reports to blackmail you, this also constitutes a crime — see item 32 of section 8. If a friend experiences sexual assault, accompany her to report it and to the hospital; do not suggest she shower or rest first.

## 43. When a baby under 1 year is choking and cannot cry out, alternate 5 back blows (face-down) and 5 chest thrusts — never press the belly

**Cost**. No cost. Watch a demonstration once or take a short infant first-aid class — a few minutes to half a day. The hard part is staying calm enough to turn the baby face-down on your forearm.

**In plain terms**. If the child can still cough or cry audibly, let them cough while you watch closely. If they cannot cry, their face turns blue, call 120, lay the baby face-down on your forearm, and give 5 back blows with the heel of your hand between the shoulder blades. If that fails, roll them over and give 5 quick thrusts on the center of the chest. Keep alternating — never push on the belly. If the baby becomes unresponsive, switch to CPR.

**Benefit**. The American Heart Association and American Academy of Pediatrics issued 2025 pediatric basic life support guidance. It states that choking (for example, an object blocking the airway) “is a leading cause of death in infants and children.” Liquids are what infants most often aspirate. Mild obstruction: still coughing or making sounds — let the child cough while you monitor for worsening. Severe obstruction: weak cough or none, cannot cry, cyanosis — call emergency services first, then “repeat cycles of 5 back blows and 5 chest thrusts until the object is expelled or the infant becomes unresponsive.” Abdominal thrusts are not recommended for infants because they can injure internal organs. Chest thrusts are now taught with the heel of one hand because it achieves greater depth than the old two-finger method. When the infant is unresponsive, start CPR with compressions first; do not check a pulse. Remove only visible objects before giving breaths. The guideline explicitly says “do not perform blind finger sweeps.” The International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies 2025 international first-aid guidance uses the same sequence: up to 5 firm back blows between the shoulder blades, then turn the infant and give up to 5 chest thrusts, then call emergency services if needed. Its chest-thrust technique uses a two-thumb encircling grip. The Fujian Provincial Red Cross emergency-care training center describes “5 back blows + 5 chest thrusts” for infants under 1 year: hold the infant prone on the forearm with the head lower than the trunk for back blows.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Rated B because support comes mainly from case reports, with no “how many fewer deaths if you follow this” figure. Benefit is rated large by judgment: a fully blocked airway can stop an infant's heart within minutes. The main beneficiaries are your own children. For children 1 year and older and adults, use abdominal thrusts; see item 26 in this section (choking: back blows plus abdominal thrusts). Chest-thrust hand position differs across sources: the U.S. guideline and newer Chinese Red Cross training use one-hand heel; IFRC uses two thumbs; older courses used two fingers. The 2025 U.S. guideline dropped two-finger compressions because depth was inadequate. Any of these beats doing nothing. Even after the object is expelled, seek medical care — fragments may remain in the lungs. Keep coins and small toys out of reach. If the baby is unresponsive, see item 44 in this section (infant CPR).

## 44. If a baby under 1 is unresponsive and not breathing normally, call 120 on speakerphone and perform infant CPR: 30 compressions, then 2 breaths

**Cost**. No cost. Infant CPR takes one hands-on class, half a day to a full day. The hard parts are sealing your mouth over the infant's mouth and nose for breaths and pressing firmly enough.

**In plain terms**. No response to foot stimulation and no normal breathing — call 120 on speakerphone and do not stop. Encircle the chest with both hands and compress with two thumbs; if you cannot encircle, use the

heel of one hand, about 4 cm (1.5 inches) deep, about 2 compressions per second. After every 30 compressions, give 2 breaths covering mouth and nose. Most infant cardiac arrests start with breathing failure; CPR that includes breaths improves survival.

**Benefit**. The American Heart Association and American Academy of Pediatrics 2025 pediatric basic life support guideline states that respiratory problems remain the main cause of cardiac arrest in infants and children. Among infants with out-of-hospital cardiac arrest, only 6.6% survive to hospital discharge. For an unresponsive infant or child with abnormal breathing and no signs of life, "CPR should be started immediately" without checking a pulse. Compression depth is at least one-third of the anteroposterior chest diameter; for infants, "about 1.5 inches (4 cm)." Rate 100 to 120 per minute. One rescuer: 30 compressions then 2 breaths. Two rescuers: 15 compressions then 2 breaths. Use one-hand heel or two-thumb encircling compressions; if encircling is not possible, use heel of one hand. Two-finger compression has been removed because depth was inadequate. The guideline also states that for out-of-hospital pediatric cardiac arrest, adding ventilations to compressions improves survival. A U.S. registry of 3,900 children under 18 with out-of-hospital cardiac arrest found 59.4% were infants. Bystander CPR was associated with an adjusted hospital discharge survival of 13.2% versus 9.5% without CPR; adjusted OR 1.57 (about 57% higher odds of survival), 95% CI 1.25–1.96. Among infants, CPR with breaths was linked to higher survival and better neurological recovery; compression-only outcomes were similar to no CPR. IFRC 2025 guidance: check responsiveness by picking up the infant or flicking the foot. If alone, call emergency services on speakerphone. If no phone allows simultaneous calling, perform 1 minute of CPR before calling. A popular-science article from the Capital Institute of Pediatrics, republished by the Beijing Municipal Health Commission, states: "If only 1 person is present, perform 2 minutes of CPR before calling 120." Compression depth "4 cm for infants." Mouth-to-mouth-nose for breaths under 1 year.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Rated B because survival figures come from registry studies with recording bias, pooled across all children; infant-only discharge numbers were not given in the summary. Benefit is rated large from the pooled figures: discharge survival 9.5% to 13.2%, a relative increase of about 40%. Main beneficiaries are your own children. Three differences from item 1 in this section (hard chest compressions for adults): infants need breaths — compression-only works poorly; use two thumbs or one heel at about 4 cm, not stacked adult hands; if you cannot call while compressing, start CPR before calling. How long to compress before calling varies: Capital Institute of Pediatrics and the U.S. single-rescuer flow say 2 minutes; IFRC says 1 minute. Speakerphone removes the trade-off. The European Resuscitation Council teaches 5 breaths first then compressions; the U.S. guideline compressions first — both beat doing nothing. Older Chinese courses taught two-finger compression; the 2025 U.S. guideline removed it. For choking, look in the mouth before breaths and remove only visible objects; see item 43 (infant choking).

# 14. Account and Information Security

Scope: money and personal information. If someone else logs into your account, you lose money first. They will also use your account to scam people in your contact list. Your identity is effectively taken too.

## 1. Turn on two-factor authentication for email, payment, and social accounts; prefer phone pop-up confirmation, with SMS codes second

**Cost**. No cost. Set it once per account; two or three minutes each.

**In plain terms**. Two-factor authentication means that besides your password, you confirm once more that it is really you when you log in. With a pop-up on your phone that you tap to confirm, more than nine out of ten phishing account takeovers are blocked. An SMS code is easier to trick out of you than a pop-up. Old methods like answering "where did you last log in?" or "what is your backup email?" block as few as one in ten phishing takeovers.

**Benefit**. Google counted 350000 real account takeover attempts (also called account hijacking). One class uses device-based verification, such as a pop-up on your phone for you to confirm, or plugging in a security key. That class blocked "more than 94% of phishing-related hijacking attempts and 100% of automated hijacking attempts." Phishing means tricking you into entering your password on a fake site; automated means machines trying leaked passwords in bulk. Another class uses knowledge-based verification, such as where you last logged in or what your backup email is. That class "blocked as little as 10% of phishing hijacking and 73% of automated hijacking." Within device verification, an SMS code is weaker than a phone pop-up. Phishers got 4% of the SMS codes right; the pop-up was fooled only 1% of the time. In targeted attacks aimed at a specific person, SMS blocked only 76%, and the pop-up blocked 90%

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The same study also found that this verification sometimes locks out the real user. 52% of genuine users did not get in on the first try, but 97% eventually did. Turn it on for email first, because most other accounts can recover passwords through email. Keep verification codes to yourself; what reading a code aloud for someone else can cost you is in Section 8, item 45 (reading verification codes).

## 2. Give your email its own password; do not reuse it on any website

**Cost**. No cost. A password manager can store it so you do not have to memorize it. The hard part is breaking the habit of one password everywhere.

**In plain terms**. Passwords stolen from other sites get tried on your email directly. Once someone is in your email, every account that can reset its password through that email is lost too. So the email password stands alone; do not use it anywhere else.

**Benefit**. Trying leaked account-and-password pairs from elsewhere against your logins is called credential stuffing, and your email gets tried this way too. Once someone is in your email, every account that uses it for password recovery goes with it. The US Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency recommends a different strong password for every account, at least 16 characters, stored in a password manager

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. If you cannot memorize them, use your browser's built-in password manager. It remembers each site's password for you, which is far stronger than reusing one password everywhere. Do not store passwords in WeChat favorites or notes.

## 3. Set a screen lock on your phone and a PIN on your SIM card

**Cost**. No cost. Set the screen lock and the SIM PIN once each.

**In plain terms**. The SIM card is the small card in your phone; SMS verification codes arrive through it. If you lose the phone, whoever finds it can pull out the card, put it in another phone, collect verification codes,

and reset your accounts one by one. A PIN on the card means that when the card moves to another phone, you must enter that code at startup first, and that path is cut off.

**Benefit**. After a phone is lost, the fastest move for whoever finds it is to put the SIM in another phone and collect your SMS verification codes. With those codes they can reset your accounts one by one. With a SIM PIN, another phone asks for the code at startup, so they cannot use the card to receive codes. In October 2020 the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology (工信部) reported a real case. After a user's phone was stolen, they did not suspend the line in time, which left a gap. Wrongdoers used “mobile number plus verification code” to log into a government service app and obtained the user's ID number and other data. They then changed the mobile service password. The user later suspended the card, and they talked the carrier's customer service into unsuspending it. Finally they exploited a “forgot password” flaw on a lending platform, reset the payment password, and stole loan funds. MIIT used the case to remind users to set a SIM PIN promptly and to suspend the line immediately when a phone is lost. For the screen-lock half, the US Federal Communications Commission advises setting a strong password on the phone to limit others' use; when the phone is lost or stolen, that helps stop unauthorized charges and misuse of personal data

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Set the PIN under “SIM card lock” in phone settings. Factory default codes are usually 1234 or 0000. 3 wrong entries in a row require the carrier's PUK code to unlock, so write the PIN on paper after you set it. Rated C because both sources are official reminders plus one case, with no study quantifying how much money a PIN saves. What to do first when a phone is lost is in item 4 (if your phone is lost, follow this order).

## 4. If your phone is lost, do this in order: suspend the SIM, remote-lock the phone, change passwords, report to police, freeze bank cards

**Cost**. No cost. The full sequence takes about ten minutes.

**In plain terms**. Order matters more than speed. Step one, suspend the SIM, and the verification-code lifeline is cut. Then remote-lock the phone, change email and payment passwords from a computer, report to police for a receipt, and freeze bank cards as needed. Without your phone, you can still call the carrier from someone else's phone to suspend the line.

**Benefit**. Order matters more than speed. First, suspend the SIM so others cannot receive your verification codes. Second, remote-lock the phone and wipe its contents. Third, from a computer, change email and payment passwords. Fourth, report to police and get a receipt. Last, freeze bank cards as needed. The US Federal Communications Commission also says that even if you think you only misplaced the phone, remote-lock it; if it was stolen, report to police at once with model and IMEI (the phone's identity number), and tell the carrier immediately

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Save the customer service numbers for the three major carriers in advance: China Mobile 10086, China Unicom 10010, China Telecom 10000. Also note which city you registered the number in; customer service will ask. You can suspend the line from another person's phone the same way.

## 5. If your card is fraudulently charged, suspend or freeze it and report to police first, then demand compensation from the bank: proving “you made the charge” is the bank's job

**Cost**. No cost. As soon as something on the card looks wrong, suspend or freeze it immediately. Keep police reports, suspension records, and transaction notices from the bank. If the physical card is still with you, make a small balance inquiry or deposit nearby to leave a record that the real card was in your hands when it happened. The hard part is not arguing with customer service first; suspend first.

**In plain terms**. If your card is fraudulently charged, you first need to produce evidence such as a police report and a suspension record. If the bank says you made the charge yourself, the bank must produce the

evidence; if it cannot, it has to compensate you. That holds only if you suspend or freeze as soon as you notice. If you delay the suspension, you bear the extra losses that come afterward.

**Benefit**. Supreme People's Court rules split "who must prove what." If you say it was counterfeit-card fraud or online fraud, you go first with evidence. Counterfeit-card fraud means someone copied your card and used the copy. Usable proof includes effective legal documents, where the physical card was during the transaction, where the transaction occurred, account statements, transaction alerts, police reports, suspension records, and so on. **Conversely, if the issuing bank or a non-bank payment institution (third-party payment) says the cardholder made the charge or authorized it, they must produce the evidence.** After you notify the bank, if it does not verify promptly or does not provide or preserve transaction records and surveillance video, and evidence is lost because of that, the bank bears the consequence of lacking proof. Once liability is established: debit card (savings card) holders may demand that the bank return stolen deposits with interest and compensate losses; credit card holders may demand return of unauthorized overdraft principal, interest, and penalties, and compensation for losses, and courts will not support the bank demanding repayment of that overdraft from you. You may also demand that the bank promptly remove related negative credit records (nationwide, effective 25 May 2021)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Two situations leave you liable. First, if you did not keep your card, password, or verification codes safe and you were at fault (the original text: failure to fulfill the duty of safekeeping), you bear loss in proportion to fault. So do not tell others your password or forward verification codes (see item 1, prefer phone pop-up for two-factor authentication). Second, if you do not suspend in time and losses grow, you bear the extra part. So the first step is always suspend or freeze, not argue with customer service. Third-party payment institutions follow the same rules. If their marketing promises "pay first, investigate later" in concrete terms, you can hold them to that advance payment. Money you were tricked into transferring yourself follows a different path; see Section 8, item 2 (if you discover fraud, call 110 or 96110 immediately to request a payment stop).

## 6. Every so often, check logged-in devices and authorized apps on your accounts; remove what you no longer use

**Cost**. No cost. A few minutes each time. The hard part is that nothing reminds you; you have to remember to look.

**In plain terms**. "Logged-in devices" means the phones and computers that can still use your account right now. If an unfamiliar device appears on the list, or software you stopped using still connects to your account, change the password first, then sign out everywhere. For email, also check whether any auto-forwarding was set without your knowledge.

**Benefit**. The logged-in-devices list records which phones and computers can still use the account. The authorized-apps list records third-party apps you allowed to sign in with the account. Unfamiliar devices and long-unused third-party apps are the easiest traces to spot. The UK National Cyber Security Centre lists "logins or login attempts from unfamiliar places or at unusual times" as signs of account compromise. It also says criminals often add a forwarding rule in email so every message to you is copied to them, which they use to reset your passwords. Its recommended order is: remove unknown forwarding rules, change the password, then sign out all devices and apps. After sign-out, anyone else needs the new password to use the account. The US Federal Trade Commission likewise advises signing out all devices after regaining an account and deleting forwarding rules you did not set

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. WeChat, Alipay, email, Apple ID, and Android accounts all have this screen. If you see an unfamiliar device, change the password first, then choose sign out everywhere; that is the order the UK NCSC gives. Rated C because both sources are official how-to guides, with no study on how much periodic checks reduce losses.

## 7. Do not tap “accept all” just to use an app: for non-essential data, refusing must not cost you the service

**Cost**. No cost. The hard part is not tapping “accept all.”

**In plain terms**. When an app asks for your information, if it is not required to provide the service, the app cannot deny you access because you refuse. It may only collect what it actually needs. A map app needing your location is required; a flashlight app needing your contacts is not.

**Benefit**. The law states two rules. First, you may not refuse products or services on the grounds that the person does not consent or withdraws consent, except where processing that information is necessary to provide the service. Second, collection must be limited to the minimum needed for the purpose; only what is usable may be collected

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The test is whether the information is necessary to provide this service. Location is necessary for a map; contacts are not for a flashlight. After installing an app, open app permissions in phone settings and turn off what is not necessary. When you truly need a permission, choose allow only this once.

## 8. You have the right to view, copy, correct, and delete your personal information; if refused, you can sue

**Cost**. No cost. You only need to complain or sue if the other party stalls. A real lawsuit starts at several months, and you pay your own lawyer fees, so complaining first is usually better value. The hard part is following up when they drag their feet.

**In plain terms**. You may require a company to let you view, copy, correct, and delete your information. When service stops, retention periods end, or you withdraw consent, the company should delete on its own. If it refuses you, it must state the reason; if it still will not act, you can sue in court. Closing an account and deleting personal information are two steps; after closing the account you must request deletion separately.

**Benefit**. In several situations the company must delete proactively: service stopped, agreed retention period ended, you withdrew consent, the original collection purpose was achieved, and so on. If it did not delete, you may demand deletion. If it refuses your exercise of these rights, it must state the reason. You may sue directly in court

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Closing an account and deleting personal information are separate; after closing, request deletion separately. Before changing phones or selling an old phone, sign out of all accounts and unlink them on the old device, then factory reset. The law gives you a post-hoc deletion right; it cannot claw back what already leaked.

## 9. Facial recognition is not mandatory: if other methods can do the same job, they cannot make face scan the only option; if you refuse, they must offer alternatives

**Cost**. No cost. When asked to scan your face, ask “is there another way to verify?” If they say no, demand one. The hard part is asking out loud on the spot.

**In plain terms**. As long as another method can achieve the same purpose, they cannot require face scan alone. If you refuse face verification, they must offer card swipe, password, ID document, or similar alternatives, and they may not force you with “then we cannot serve you.” No one may install face recognition equipment inside hotel guest rooms, public baths, changing rooms, or restrooms.

**Benefit**. The Administrative Measures for the Safe Application of Facial Recognition Technology (人脸识别技术应用安全管理办法) state: “Where the same purpose can be achieved or equivalent business requirements met, and other non-facial-recognition methods exist, facial recognition must not be the sole

verification method. Where an individual does not agree to identity verification via facial information, other reasonable and convenient methods shall be provided." The measures also state: "No organization or individual may, under the pretext of handling business or improving service quality, mislead, defraud, or coerce an individual into accepting facial recognition to verify identity." If processing relies on consent, there must be "separate consent given voluntarily and explicitly with full knowledge": asked separately for this matter, and you agree separately. You may withdraw consent, and the processor must provide a convenient way to withdraw. Processing facial information of minors under 14 requires consent from a parent or other guardian. Face recognition devices in public places must be "necessary for maintaining public security" and carry prominent notices. Inside private spaces in public venues such as hotel guest rooms, public baths, public changing rooms, and public restrooms, no organization or individual may install them. Facial information shall be stored on the device and must not be transmitted over the internet, except as otherwise provided by laws or administrative regulations, or with separate consent (nationwide, effective 1 June 2025)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Common cases are residential gate access, rental platforms, gyms, and hotels asking you to enroll your face. When they say "the system only supports face scan," quote the measures verbatim: "Where the same purpose can be achieved or equivalent business requirements met, and other non-facial-recognition methods exist, facial recognition must not be the sole verification method." Then demand card, password, or ID alternatives. If they still refuse, report to the local cyberspace authority (网信部门). Where national rules require face verification for identity, such as some financial and government scenarios, follow those rules. Unlike a password, a face cannot be changed after leak, so treat it more carefully than a password. Entities storing facial information on 100000 or more people must file with provincial-level or higher cyberspace authorities within 30 working days; that filing is also a question to ask about whether they are legitimate. Rights to access, correct, and delete personal information are in item 8. Someone using your face to take out their own loan is a different matter; see Section 8, item 45 (helping with a face scan).

## 10. Do not hand code, keys, or private material to unknown "AI proxy gateways," especially when letting AI run commands automatically

**Cost**. Official direct access is usually pricier than proxy gateways, and topping up is less convenient. The hard part is that a proxy is cheap, and a single entry point can call several model vendors

**In plain terms**. A proxy sits between you and the model vendor; it can see and alter what you send and what comes back. Researchers measured more than 400 proxies: 9 injected malicious code into replies, and 17 tampered with cloud service keys the researchers had planted on purpose. Where AI runs commands automatically, a single altered command can be enough for someone to install malicious code on the computer.

**Benefit**. In June 2026 the Ministry of State Security issued a risk alert. Some proxies retain user submissions on servers; some intercept privately and resell data to other model vendors for training. Some hide backdoors that implant malicious code on user devices, steal account keys and cloud credentials, or even install remote-control software. The alert recommends official direct connections or properly licensed platforms, and not using platforms of unknown origin without operating credentials or security safeguards. Desensitize personal privacy and project material before use, manage keys, and rotate them on a schedule. On abnormal billing, unexplained account bans, or odd data, stop use immediately, rotate keys, run antivirus, and preserve evidence. Researchers from UC Santa Barbara and others measured this in 2026. They bought 28 paid proxies from Taobao (淘宝), Xianyu (闲鱼), and overseas shops, and collected 400 free proxies from public communities. 1 paid proxy and 8 free ones injected malicious code into returned tool calls. Tool calls are commands AI has your computer run, such as installing a package. 2 timed their attacks; the paper's example is targeting only fully automated sessions. 17 touched Amazon Web Services keys the researchers had planted on purpose. 1 moved funds from a researcher's Ethereum wallet; the wallet held very little, and the loss was under 50 US dollars. The demonstrated tampering was subtle: swap `requests` for the near-identical `reqeusts` in an install command, hard to spot at a glance (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Rated B because there is only one study, and it is a preprint (a version released before formal publication). Most measured proxies were free; only 28 were paid, so you cannot infer what share of all proxies are malicious. Some media wrote that theft as 500000 US dollars; the paper says under 50 US dollars. Benefit magnitude is set at medium by consequence: loss from stolen keys and code varies widely, and the study has no amount to apply mechanically. If you already used an unknown proxy, revoke and regenerate keys at the model vendor, and rotate cloud and repository keys together. When traffic goes through a proxy, do not let AI run commands fully automatically; review commands before allowing them. Operators running proxy gateways face criminal liability; see Section 11, item 19 (AI proxy gateways). The beneficiary is you.

## 11. Check once a year how many phone cards and bank cards are in your name; cancel any you did not open yourself

**Cost**. No cost. Check phone cards in the MIIT WeChat account (工信微报) or the Alipay mini-program (一证通查); check bank cards in the Cloud QuickPass app (云闪付) under card lookup (一键查卡). Each form takes a few minutes, and the result arrives by text within 1 or 2 days. The hard part is that nobody reminds you; you have to remember to check once a year.

**In plain terms**. People open phone cards with someone else's ID and use them to scam; the person often never hears about it. There is now a free official check for how many phone cards are in your name, how many app accounts are tied to your mobile number, and which UnionPay cards you have. If a card you do not recognize shows up, ask the carrier or the bank to confirm it and cancel it.

**Benefit**. The Anti-Telecom and Online Fraud Law (反电信网络诈骗法) states that telecom authorities must "provide a convenient channel for users to query phone-card information in their name." The People's Bank of China and other departments must "provide customers a convenient channel to query bank accounts and payment accounts in their name." The nationwide mobile phone-card ID lookup (一证通查), guided by the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology (工信部), went live on 14 September 2021. With an ID card you can check how many phone cards are in your name and which carriers they belong to. It was launched because anti-fraud work found that some phone cards used in cases had been opened under someone else's identity. The person did not know, and their personal credit could also be affected. The result is texted from 10699000 within 48 hours. If the count does not match, go to the carrier for the details; after you authorize it, they can verify, detach the number from your identity, shut it down, or close the account. In July 2022 they launched ID lookup 2.0 (一证通查). With your mobile number and the last 6 digits of your ID number, you can see how many internet accounts are linked to that number. At the time it covered Tencent, Alibaba, Baidu, Kuaishou (快手), Douyin (抖音), JD, Meituan (美团), and others, and the result is only a count. On the bank-card side, China UnionPay opened Cloud QuickPass card lookup (一键查卡) to every province and city in mainland China on 29 June 2022. Pick the banks to check, pass identity verification, and submit. A report is generated within 24 hours; card details in the report are masked, and it is deleted automatically after 7 days (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Card lookup (一键查卡) covers UnionPay cards only. UnionPay said at the time that cards with no mobile number on file at the bank, or with an expired ID, still cannot be found, and the issuing bank's records control, so a card that does not show up is not proof you have none. Loans and credit cards opened in your name by someone else show on the credit report; see Section 8, item 9 (credit report). If lookup 2.0 shows a number linked to many accounts, unbind them before you change or stop the number; see item 12 (before you change your number or drop the old number). Lending or selling your own cards to someone else is a different matter; see Section 8, item 8 (do not hand over bank cards or phone cards). Rated C because the sources are official service descriptions, with no study of how much a check reduces losses. Benefit magnitude is set at medium by judgment. The beneficiary is you.

## 12. Before you change your number or drop the old number, rebind bank, payment, and social accounts to the new number; do not just let the old number stop for nonpayment

**Cost**. No cost. Rebind the mobile number on each account; the number on file at the bank has to be changed with the bank. If you use many accounts, it can take 1 or 2 hours from start to finish. The hard part is missing some; obscure accounts are easy to forget.

**In plain terms**. After a mobile number is cancelled, the carrier can reissue it to someone else in as few as 90 days. Accounts you did not rebind still point at that number, so verification codes go to the new owner's phone, and that person may log into your accounts with them. Before you change numbers, move your accounts and the mobile number on file at the bank over to the new number.

**Benefit**. The Telecommunications Service Standards (电信服务规范) state that “the freeze period for a mobile number is at least 90 days,” meaning the time from cancellation until the number can be issued again. 90 days after cancellation, the number may go to a new user. The Ministry of Industry and Information Technology telecom service quality notice for the first quarter of 2025 reminds users of the recycled-number refresh service (二次号码焕新) in the major carriers' apps. If you are given a number someone else used, you can unbind internet accounts registered to that number before your line was opened. The second-quarter notice in 2026 says the service already covers 258 commonly used internet apps, and unbind requests have passed 850000000. A new owner going out of their way to unbind shows that the previous owner's accounts were still tied to the number after it reached them. In 2024, customer service at the major carriers told People's Post and Telecommunications News (人民邮电报) that after a number is cancelled, a new user can still log into accounts the old user registered, using SMS codes. They said to unbind Alipay, WeChat, and similar apps before changing or cancelling a number, and to update the mobile number on file at the bank promptly (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. First use ID lookup 2.0 (一证通查) to see how many accounts the old number is linked to; see item 11 (how many phone cards are in your name). Change bank and payment accounts first, then social accounts, and close accounts you no longer use. After the change, do not stop the old number right away; keep it for 1 or 2 months to catch verification texts you missed. That part is the author's experience. That a new owner can log in with a verification code comes from carrier customer-service comments in a news report, with no official bulletin or court judgment. What to do after someone gets into an account is in item 6 (logged-in devices). Signing out and factory-resetting when you change phones or sell an old phone is in the notes to item 8 (delete your personal information). Rated C because no study has measured how much rebinding reduces losses. Benefit magnitude is set at medium by judgment. The beneficiary is you.

# 15. Renting and buying a home

Scope: money. When renting, the places money is most easily lost are the deposit and the agent. When buying, the expensive parts are the interest on the loan, and the things the seller knows that you do not. The items near the end of the section are about buying: which account the money should go into, when the earnest money and the purchase price can be asked back, and what to do if handover is late. Also how to stop a seller selling the same home twice, and how to talk the mortgage rate down. The last two items are about after you move in: the property manager must not cut water or power to collect fees, and for a new home that leaks, go to the developer for repairs within the warranty period.

## 1. When renting, the deposit amount, refund timing, and grounds for deduction must be written into the contract

**Cost**. No monetary cost. Spend an extra ten minutes when signing the contract. The hard part is raising it in front of the landlord.

**In plain terms**. How much the deposit is, when it is returned, and when it may be deducted must go into the contract before you sign. Deduction grounds not written in the contract cannot be used to withhold your deposit when you move out.

**Benefit**. Administrative regulations state clearly: “Where the lessor collects a deposit, the amount, time of return, and circumstances in which the deposit may be deducted shall be stipulated in the housing lease contract. Except as provided in the contract, the lessor shall not deduct the deposit without proper cause.” Three things must appear in the contract: how much is collected, when it is returned, and when deduction is allowed. Grounds not in the contract cannot be used to take your money.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. On move-out day, take photos and video together with the landlord. Record water, electricity, and gas meter readings, and photograph walls and floors. If the deposit is withheld without cause, complain first to the housing lease administration (房屋租赁管理部门). For smaller amounts, use small-claims litigation; see Section 8. For a shopfront rented to open a store, and whether catering can get permits, see Section 12, item 27 (renting a shopfront to open a store).

## 2. When utilities are cut off, locks are changed, or you're threatened to leave — call the police first and keep records: laws forbid these tactics to force eviction

**Cost**. No cost at all. Just make a phone call to the police — it can be done right away.

**In plain terms**. Landlords must not cut water or power, change locks, or come to the door with threats to force you to end the lease or move out — the regulations forbid it. If it happens, call the police first and keep the evidence. Do not confront them yourself.

**Benefit**. Administrative regulations make it clear: “Landlords must not use violence, threats, or any other illegal means to compel tenants to end their housing lease or vacate the rental property.” Eviction means being forced to move out. In such situations, call the police first to secure evidence — never confront the landlord yourself.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Calling the police is essential to obtain an official report that can be used as proof when filing a compensation claim later. Also be sure to notify your local housing authority.

## 3. Agents must not collect or pay rent and deposits; payments go directly to landlords

**Cost**. No cost at all. It takes just a few minutes to verify the recipient before paying. The hard part is resisting any pressure from agents to send the money to them instead.

**In plain terms**. By rule, rent and deposits must not be collected or paid through an agent — pay the landlord directly. Every time the money passes through the agent, there is one more chance for them to take it and disappear. Before you pay, check that the payee's name matches the name on the title certificate.

**Benefit**. Administrative rules explicitly forbid real estate agencies from collecting or paying rent and deposits on behalf of landlords. This means agents have no legal authority to handle such payments. Keeping money out of their hands eliminates one major risk factor for fraud and financial loss.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Before paying, double-check that the recipient's name matches the one on the property title. If it does not, ask for a written authorization and keep a copy for your records. Agents are only permitted to charge a commission fee for their intermediary services.

## 4. Check a long-term rental's escrow account before paying a full year's rent at once

**Cost**. No cost at all. It takes only about ten minutes to check.

**In plain terms**. Paying a full year at once gets you only a small discount. If the company absconds, your deposit and the remaining ten-odd months of rent may all be gone. A rent loan makes it worse: if the rental firm is gone, you still repay the loan monthly. Before signing, check whether it has a publicly disclosed funds supervision account.

**Benefit**. Regulations require any housing rental business that sublets units to set up a dedicated escrow account for rental funds and make it publicly available. Subletting means a company rents entire properties from landlords and then re-rents them to tenants. The tiny discount from upfront annual payments simply does not outweigh the risk of losing both your deposit and all future rent payments if the company folds. For those who also take out rent loans, the risk is even greater.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Carefully check whether any loan is tied to your contract. If a third-party app lets you pay a full year's rent at once to the rental company, and you then repay that amount monthly via the app, you will still be obligated to make those payments even if the company disappears. Never sign such a contract.

## 5. If the home is sold during the lease, the lease stays valid — you do not have to move

**Cost**. No monetary cost

**In plain terms**. If the home is sold during the lease term, your lease remains valid. The new landlord must let you stay under the original contract through expiry. You do not move out and do not renegotiate the rent. The premise is that you already live there lawfully, and you keep the contract, transfer records, and evidence of when you moved in.

**Benefit**. The Civil Code has a rule called “sale does not break lease” (买卖不破租赁). The statute reads: a change of ownership of the leased thing during the lease term does not affect the lease contract's validity. If the owner changes during the term, the signed lease still holds; the new landlord must honor the original contract through expiry.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This assumes you already occupy the unit lawfully — the statute calls that lawful possession and use. Keep the contract, transfer records, and evidence of when you moved in.

## 6. Before you sign a rental contract, check the title certificate and whether the home is mortgaged. Send every payment by transfer and note what it is for

**Cost**. No money. Take your identity card to the real-estate registration office once. A check takes half an hour. The hard part is having the landlord produce the title certificate in front of you.

**In plain terms**. Before you sign, have the landlord produce an identity card and the title certificate. Then take your identity card to the real-estate registration office and check whether the home is mortgaged or has been sealed. You can check before any contract is signed. A home that was already mortgaged or sealed before it was let, and is then auctioned and changes owner, cannot be one you demand to go on living in. Send the money by transfer and note what it is for, so you have a record.

**Benefit**. Before you sign, the landlord must show you identity papers and the real-estate title certificate. If there is no title certificate, the landlord must produce other material that shows a right to let the home. The landlord must also cooperate while you inquire into and check the information on this home. That is a duty the administrative regulations put on the lessor. Before any contract is signed, take your identity card to the real-estate registration office of the city or county where the home is, and you can check several things. What you can see is: the basic facts of the home, whether there are co-owners, whether a mortgage or a right of residence is registered, and whether the home has been sealed. After the contract is signed, the lease lets you check the registration result. This step matters because "a sale does not break a lease" has two exceptions. If the home was mortgaged to a bank before it was let, and is later auctioned to pay the debt, you cannot require the new owner to let you stay on under the old contract. The same is true if the home had already been sealed by a court before it was let. When the court auctions, if the lease gets in the way of a mortgage that came first, the court removes the lease and then auctions. The other way around, if the home was let to you first and you had already moved in, and the landlord mortgaged it only later, the mortgage does not affect your lease. If the home is sealed, or the title is in dispute, so that you cannot live there, you can end the contract. If someone else asserts a right and you cannot stay, you can demand to pay less rent or none. Sending all the money by transfer, noted as "rent for such-and-such a home for such-and-such a month," is the author's experience: if there is a dispute, it can show that you paid, and what you paid for.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Among the things you can check before a contract is signed, who the owner is is not included. So the name on the title certificate has to be matched, in person, to the landlord's identity card. Have the landlord attend the signing in person. If the landlord cannot come, you need a power of attorney. If a sub-landlord is subletting to you, you need the original landlord's written consent. If the landlord will not accept the right to end the contract or to pay less rent, you have to sue. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months. Lawyer fees are generally yours. Noting the purpose on a transfer is not laid down directly in any regulation. It is the author's experience. You can check the same way before signing to buy a second-hand home, and after signing you still file an advance-notice registration. See item 14 (advance-notice registration).

## 7. If an agent is to hold the price on a second-hand home, the money must go through the dedicated transaction-funds deposit account the agency opened at a bank

**Cost**. No monetary cost. The hard part is insisting on the dedicated account; you may have to argue with the agent a few more times.

**In plain terms**. When an agent collects the purchase price, the rules say it must go through the dedicated account the agency opened at a bank. That account is supervised; the money must not go into the agency's own account, and must not be transferred to an individual broker.

**Benefit**. The regulation is plain: where the parties agree that a real-estate brokerage will collect and pay the transaction funds, the funds shall be transferred through the dedicated client transaction-settlement deposit

account that the brokerage has opened at a bank. The purchase price goes into a supervised dedicated account, not the agency's own account, and not some broker's private account.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The purchase price is from 100000 to several million yuan — the largest single sum in this book. Do not WeChat it to the broker. There are two other common ways of charging extra. One is two agencies jointly doing the same deal; that can be charged as only one commission. The other is handling a loan or a title transfer for you; those are further services, need a separate contract, and the fee must be stated in advance. Send every payment by transfer and note what it is for; see item 6 (check the title certificate and the mortgage before signing). Where the money for an off-plan home goes is in item 10 (the pre-sale funds supervision account).

## 8. Do not rent subdivided units: the minimum rental unit is the originally designed room; kitchens, bathrooms, and balconies must not be lived in

**Cost**. No monetary cost. The trade-off is that on the same budget you live farther out or in a smaller place.

**In plain terms**. By rule, the smallest unit you may rent is the room as originally designed. Kitchens, bathrooms, balconies, and basement storage must not be lived in. During the lease the landlord also cannot raise rent unilaterally on a whim.

**Benefit**. The rules state clearly that the minimum rental unit is the originally designed room; one room must not be partitioned into several units rented separately. Per-person living floor area must not fall below the local minimum. Kitchens, bathrooms, balconies, and basement storage must not be rented for people to live in. During the lease the lessor may not unilaterally raise rent at will. For violations of Article 8, the competent authority shall order the lessor to correct within a time limit; if the lessor fails to correct on time, a fine of 5000 yuan to 30000 yuan may be imposed.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. When an illegal subdivision is enforced, the fine falls on the lessor. But correction means tearing out the partitions, so tenants living there have to move — that follows from this rule. Deposit and rent already paid are often not recovered; that is the author's experience. Safety is worse too: partition walls often block escape routes, and many people in one unit share one circuit. When viewing, check three things: whether walls were added later, whether the room has a window, and whether the meter can handle that many people.

## 9. Urban residents with hukou who want to live in the countryside can only rent rural houses — they must not buy homestead land or houses on it

**Cost**. No monetary cost. The trade-off is that the house is not yours; the maximum single lease term is 20 years, and when it ends you renegotiate with the landlord.

**In plain terms**. People with urban hukou must not go to the countryside to buy homestead land (宅基地), farmers' houses, or “small-property-rights houses” (小产权房) — national documents expressly forbid it. A villager saying “a written contract is enough” does not make it work either. To live long-term in the countryside, sign a lease, at most 20 years per term, and renew when it ends.

**Benefit**. A State Council General Office document states clearly: “Urban residents must not purchase rural homestead land, farmer housing, or ‘small-property-rights houses.’” The same document also provides that after a farmer sells or leases out housing, a further application for homestead land will not be approved. A 2019 document from the Central Rural Work Leading Group Office and the Ministry of Agriculture and Rural Affairs repeats it: “It is strictly forbidden for urban residents to purchase rural homestead land.” The same document gives the lawful path: urban residents may rent rural houses for residence or business. The lease term must not exceed 20 years; when it ends the parties may agree again.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Homestead land is land the village allocates to its own villagers to build housing; it can only go to people of that village. When renting a rural house, sign a written contract with the farming household that rents it out, stating the term, the rent, whether renovation or alteration is allowed, and how renovation costs are settled at the end. The documents cap the term at 20 years; do not sign “lease for 50 years” or “lease for 70 years,” and do not pay many years of rent in one lump sum. The documents also forbid going to the countryside to build villas, large compounds, and private clubs on homestead land; do not put up money for villagers to “co-build.”

## 10. When you buy an off-plan home, look at the pre-sale permit first. Earnest money, the down payment, and the loan go only into the pre-sale funds supervision account named in the contract

**Cost**. No monetary cost. Look at the pre-sale permit before you sign, and check the account before you pay — a few minutes. The hard part is refusing when the salesperson tells you to transfer to some other account.

**In plain terms**. An off-plan home is a home put on sale before it is finished. Without a pre-sale permit, the developer cannot sell it and cannot take earnest money. The down payment and the loan you pay are, under the rules, to go in full into the supervision account; supervision is lifted only when the home can be handed over. Money sent to some other account is outside that protection.

**Benefit**. An off-plan home is called a commercial-housing pre-sale in the regulations — the developer selling you a home that is still being built. In August (8) 2026 the Ministry of Housing and Urban-Rural Development, the Ministry of Natural Resources, and the National Financial Regulatory Administration issued a document: “The down payment, the personal housing loan, and other purchase funds paid by the buyer shall all be deposited into the funds supervision account.” Supervision is lifted only after the home has passed completion inspection and water, electricity, gas, and heat are ready for handover. The developer must write into the purchase contract the rights and duties of depositing the purchase funds into the supervision account. If the developer is in breach and cannot hand the home over on time, you may end the contract as the contract provides. The developer must return the money as the contract says and bear liability for the breach. The People's Bank of China and the National Financial Regulatory Administration at the same time provided that a personal housing loan for a pre-sale home is paid by the bank directly into the project's pre-sale funds supervision account. A 2022 document from three departments already stated that earnest money, the down payment, and the mortgage loan “shall all be deposited directly into the supervision account.” A project that has not received a pre-sale permit must not be pre-sold, and the developer must not take earnest money by subscription, reservation, queue numbers, or VIP cards. A pre-sale contract signed without a pre-sale permit is held invalid by the court. If the permit is obtained before the suit is filed, it may be held valid. Money paid somewhere other than the supervision account is outside this supervision. The same 2026 document also provides that for a project sold as a finished home, after the construction permit is obtained the developer may first take a “small amount of earnest money.” That earnest money is supervised by the housing-funds supervision body, held in an “earnest-money supervision account” opened at the project's lead bank, and supervision is lifted only when the home is ready for handover.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. For a project that had already received its construction-project planning permit before 28 August (8) 2026, the pre-sale conditions and the funds supervision follow each place's old rules. That the down payment and the loan go into the supervision account was already required by the 2010 and 2022 documents. For a project sold as a finished home where the developer takes a small amount of earnest money while still building, the new rules require the earnest money to go into an earnest-money supervision account. The account name and number of the supervision account are whatever the purchase contract writes; check them once before you pay. If the contract is held invalid and the developer still does not return the money, you have to sue. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months. Lawyer fees are generally yours. How the price of a second-hand home is paid is in item 7 (the dedicated transaction-funds deposit account).

## 11. If you paid reservation earnest money or a down payment on a new home, no formal contract was signed or the loan was not approved (for example policy tightened after signing, or the bank stopped lending), and it is not your fault, demand the money back from the developer

**Cost**. No money. When you sign the reservation and the formal contract, read two more clauses. If the developer will not return the money, you have to sue.

**In plain terms**. If you paid reservation earnest money but no formal contract was signed, or the loan was not approved, look first at whose fault it is. If the cause is neither yours nor the developer's, the developer must return the earnest money, or return the purchase money plus interest. Policy tightening after signing or the bank stopping lending generally counts as neither side's fault. Overdue items on your own credit report or income that is not enough count as your cause, and you may not get the earnest money back.

**Benefit**. The Supreme People's Court's judicial interpretation states: if a developer takes earnest money through a subscription, an order, or a reservation, and no formal sale contract is signed because of one side's cause, the earnest-money rules apply. The earnest-money rules are: if the side that paid breaks the deal, the earnest money is not returned; if the side that received it breaks the deal, it is returned double. See item 15 of section 12 (write 定金 when you take money). If no contract is signed for a cause that cannot be laid on either side, "the seller shall return the earnest money to the buyer." Another article covers the loan. If the sale contract agrees payment by loan, and no loan contract is signed because of one side's cause, so that the sale contract cannot be performed, the other side can end the contract and demand compensation. If no loan contract is signed for a cause that cannot be laid on either side, either side can end the contract. The developer must return the principal and interest of the purchase money it received, or return the earnest money. The articles only state the principle of what counts as a cause that cannot be laid on either side. The examples below are the author's. Policy on housing loans tightening locally after you sign, or the bank stopping lending, is generally a cause that cannot be laid on either side. Overdue entries on your own credit report, or income records that are not enough, count as your cause. Incomplete papers on the project, so that the bank will not lend on it, counts as the developer's cause. These two articles cover only commercial housing bought from a developer. They do not apply to buying a second-hand home.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. When it is disputed what counts as "cannot be laid on either side," the court decides on the facts. So the formal contract should state that payment is by loan, and it is better if it also states what happens if the loan is not approved. If the reservation already writes out the main contents of a sale contract, and the developer has also taken the price, the court will treat it as a formal sale contract. It then does not count as "never signed." If the developer will not return the money, you have to sue. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months. Summary procedure is 3 months. Lawyer fees are generally yours.

## 12. Before you sign for a new home, read how an area difference is handled, and photograph the promises on the brochure, the advertisements, and the model

**Cost**. No money. Read two more clauses before you sign, and take photographs and screenshots while you are at it.

**In plain terms**. If the contract does not agree otherwise, and the area registered after handover differs from the contract by 3% or less, the price is settled on the actual area, with the extra returned or the shortfall paid. If the difference is over 3%, you can return the home, and the developer returns the money plus interest within 30 days. A promise in an advertisement that is specific about the homes and the facilities in the compound, and that affects whether you buy, counts even if it was not written into the contract.

**Benefit**. The ministry regulation states that where the price is by area, the contract must say how an area difference is handled. If the contract does not say, the following applies. "Where the absolute value of the area-difference ratio is within 3% (including 3%), the price is settled on the actual area." Over 3%, you have the

right to return the home. If you return it, the developer must, within 30 days of the day you ask, return the price already paid, and pay interest at the same time. If you do not return it and the registered area is larger than the contract, you pay for the part within 3%, the developer bears the part over 3%, and the property right is yours. If the registered area is smaller than the contract, the developer returns the part within 3%, and returns double the part over 3%. On advertisements, the Supreme People's Court's judicial interpretation states: sales advertisements and promotional material are generally only an invitation to negotiate. They are not a contract. But a statement by the developer about homes and supporting facilities inside the scope of the development plan, if it is specific and definite, and if it has a major effect on whether you sign and on the price, counts as contract content. "That statement and promise, even if not written into the commercial-housing sale contract, shall still be contract content," and breaking it means liability for breach.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. 3% is the default when the contract says nothing. If the contract writes something else, the contract governs, so when you sign, read whether that clause widens the band. An off-plan home priced by the unit must have a floor plan attached to the contract, stating the tolerance on the dimensions. The advertising rule covers only homes and facilities inside the scope of the development plan. Things outside that scope are not in this rule. When the judicial interpretation was amended in 2020, the old article on area difference was deleted. The basis now is this ministry regulation. If the developer will not accept it, you have to sue. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months. Lawyer fees are generally yours.

## 13. If a developer is late handing over a new home, or late getting the title deed done, send a written demand first and keep the evidence, then claim the penalty in the contract

**Cost**. No money. Write a demand, send it by courier, and keep a copy. If you actually want to return the home or claim compensation, it will most likely mean a lawsuit.

**In plain terms**. If the developer hands over late, send a written demand first. If it still has not handed over within three months, you can return the home. If the contract states no penalty, it pays you the rent of a similar home in the same area. If you cannot get the title deed because of the developer, it also pays; if the delay runs more than a year past the deed deadline, you can also return the home. The right to return the home has a time limit — do not keep putting off saying what you will do.

**Benefit**. The Supreme People's Court's judicial interpretation states: if the developer is late handing the home over, and still has not handed it over within 3 months after you demand it, you can end the contract, unless the contract agrees otherwise. The right to end the contract has a time limit. If the developer demands that you say what you will do, you must decide within 3 months. If the developer does not demand that, you must use the right within one year of the day you knew you could end the contract. After that it is gone. If the contract agrees neither a penalty nor how compensation is calculated, late handover is counted as the rent, over the period of the delay, of a similar home in the same area. If, because of the developer, you still have no title deed by one of the following deadlines, the developer bears liability for breach. There are three deadlines: the deed deadline agreed in the contract; for an off-plan home, 90 days from the day of handover; for a finished home, 90 days from the day the contract was signed. If the contract agrees no penalty, it is calculated on the total purchase money you have paid, by reference to the standard for overdue-loan interest set by the People's Bank of China. If, more than one year after the deed deadline, registration still cannot be done because of the developer, you can end the contract and demand compensation. If the agreed penalty is too high and the developer asks for it to be reduced, the court adjusts it on the standard of exceeding the actual loss by 30%.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Make the demand in writing. Courier it to the developer's address written in the contract, and keep the mailing receipt and the record of receipt. The judicial interpretation only says "after a demand." It does not specify the form. Writing it and sending it by courier is the author's experience. If the contract already agrees a penalty for late handover, calculate from the contract first. After you return the home, the loan

contract can be ended together with it. The developer returns the loan to the bank, and returns to you the price you paid and the interest. If the developer will not accept it, you have to sue. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months, and can be extended. Lawyer fees are generally yours.

## 14. Before you sign to buy, check for a seal and for mortgages. After you sign, file an advance-notice registration at the real-estate registration office

**Cost**. Before you sign, take your identity card and check once. Half an hour. After you sign, you and the seller take the papers to the registration office. Pay the registration fee at the local rate.

**In plain terms**. Before signing, take your identity card to the real-estate registration office and check whether this home is mortgaged or sealed, and whether it was registered to someone else first. Agree in the contract to file an advance-notice registration, and file it as soon as you have signed. After it is filed, if the seller sells again or mortgages again without your consent, the registration office will not process it. Once formal transfer is possible, you must go complete the transfer within 90 days; after that the advance-notice registration lapses.

**Benefit**. The Civil Code states: once a purchase agreement is signed, to secure getting the home later, you may apply to the registration office for an advance-notice registration as agreed. "After the advance-notice registration, a disposal of the real estate without the consent of the right-holder under that registration does not take effect in property law." The advance-notice registration has a time limit. It lapses if the contract is ended, or in similar situations, or if no application for formal registration is made within 90 days of the day formal registration became possible. The implementing rules of the Ministry of Natural Resources put that onto the registration office: both pre-sale commercial housing and the sale of a second-hand home can be filed. While the advance-notice registration is in effect, if the seller applies to register this home without your written consent, the registration office will not handle it. If you are buying an off-plan home and the developer does not apply together with you as agreed, you can apply alone. What you can check before signing: if you intend to buy, your identity card alone lets you check whether this home has a mortgage, an advance-notice registration, or an objection registration, and whether it has been sealed. An online filing of the contract does not control whether the contract is effective. The Supreme People's Court's judicial interpretation states that a pre-sale contract that was not filed does not, for that reason, fail to be valid, unless the two sides agreed that it takes effect only once filed.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. How to check before signing, and what to bring, is in item 6 (check the title certificate and the mortgage before signing). Before a contract is signed you cannot see who the owner is. The name on the title certificate has to be matched, in person, to the seller's identity card. An advance-notice registration has to be agreed by both sides in advance, so write it into the sale contract. If the seller colludes with someone else, signs another contract, and hands the home over, you can ask a court to confirm that other contract is invalid. That means a lawsuit. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months. Lawyer fees are generally yours. The advance-notice registration closes that path beforehand.

## 15. If you are carrying a floating-rate mortgage, and the rate is a clear step above newly issued mortgages, ask the bank to negotiate a lower rate or apply to replace the loan

**Cost**. No monetary cost. Call the bank's service line, or apply in the mobile bank — a few tens of minutes once. The bank does not have to agree.

**In plain terms**. A mortgage rate is a benchmark rate plus a few points. The points added used to be locked for the life of the contract; from 2024 you are allowed to discuss changing them with the bank. If your rate is a clear step above newly issued mortgages nationwide, you can ask the bank to lower it, or apply for a new

loan to replace the old one. On a loan of 1000000 yuan over 30 years, a rate half a percentage point lower means about 100000 yuan less interest.

**Benefit**. A 2024 announcement of the People's Bank of China allows the borrower and the lender to negotiate a change in the points added to, or taken off, the LPR in the mortgage rate. The LPR is the loan prime rate; a mortgage rate is that rate plus or minus points. In a press briefing, the responsible person at the People's Bank of China said that the points written in the old contract were fixed for the whole term of the loan, and that this change alters that. In August (8) 2026 the People's Bank of China and the National Financial Regulatory Administration wrote into a document: for floating-rate mortgages already issued, when the rate has diverged by a certain margin from the rate on newly issued mortgages nationwide, “the borrower may negotiate with the banking institution to change the interest rate agreed in the contract, or apply for a newly issued floating-rate personal housing loan to replace the existing loan. The method shall be chosen by the borrower.” The new loan must not be larger than the principal left on the old loan. How much you can save, worked by the equal-payment formula as an example: a loan of 1000000 yuan over 30 years, at an annual rate of 4.0%, has a monthly payment of about 4774 yuan, and at 3.5% about 4490 yuan. That is about 284 yuan less a month, and about 100000 yuan less interest over 30 years.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. How wide the divergence has to be before you can talk is not given as a figure in the document. Use the announcement of the bank that made your loan. This item covers floating-rate mortgages issued by banks. If the bank will not lower the rate, and you have spare cash, you can compare it with the method in Section 5, item 28 (paying a mortgage off early). A replacement cannot borrow more. The new loan cannot exceed the principal left on the old loan.

## 16. If you need a loan for a first home, use a housing provident fund loan first; if the amount is not enough, add a commercial loan as a combined loan — do not put the whole amount on a commercial loan alone

**Cost**. No monetary cost. You may have to go to the housing provident fund center or the entrusted bank one or two more times, and disbursement may be a few days later than a commercial loan alone. The premise is that you have already paid into the fund continuously for a period.

**In plain terms**. For a first home, a housing provident fund loan of more than 5 years is at 2.6%; the rate on newly issued bank mortgages around June (6) 2026 was about 3.1%. On a loan of 1000000 yuan over 30 years, using the fund for the whole amount costs about 96000 yuan less interest than a commercial loan for the whole amount. The fund has a loan ceiling; what it cannot cover can be topped up with a commercial loan — that is a combined loan.

**Benefit**. On 7 May (5) 2025 the People's Bank of China issued a document lowering housing provident fund loan rates, effective from 8 May (5). For a first-home fund loan of more than 5 years the rate is 2.6%; for 5 years or less it is 2.1%. For a second home, more than 5 years is not below 3.075%, and 5 years or less is not below 2.525%. As of October (10) 2026 this was still the latest adjustment. Commercial mortgage rates are set as LPR plus or minus points; the LPR is the loan prime rate. On 20 September (9) 2026 the LPR for terms over 5 years was 3.5%. The People's Bank of China's monetary policy report for the second quarter of 2026 states that in June (6) “the rate on newly issued personal housing loans was about 3.1%.” How much you can save, worked by the equal-payment formula as an example: a loan of 1000000 yuan over 30 years, at 2.6%, has a monthly payment of about 4003 yuan, and at 3.1% about 4270 yuan. That is about 267 yuan less a month, and about 96000 yuan less interest over 30 years. Even if the fund ceiling covers only 600000 yuan and the other 400000 yuan goes commercial, it still beats putting the whole amount on a commercial loan: about 160 yuan less a month, and about 58000 yuan less interest over 30 years. The second-home fund rate floor of 3.075% is close to the commercial 3.1%, so little is saved.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A housing provident fund loan has four thresholds. First you must have paid in enough. A 2014 document from the Ministry of Housing and Urban-Rural Development and two other departments states

that you must have paid in continuously and in full for more than 6 months before you can apply; payments made elsewhere can be combined. Caps and terms differ by place; the maximum is set by the local housing provident fund management committee. For example in Beijing a first-home loan for one contributor tops out at 1200000 yuan, with 200000 yuan of loan capacity per year of contributions. In Guangzhou one person tops out at 1000000 yuan, the term must not exceed 30 years, and for a second-hand home the building age plus the loan term must not exceed 50 years. When buying a second-hand home, the price used is the lower of the online-signed price and the appraisal; a low appraisal means less you can borrow. Finally there is more paperwork. The regulations require the fund center to decide within 10 days of accepting the application, and then mortgage registration still has to be done. Slower disbursement than a commercial loan is the author's experience; if the seller is in a hurry for the money, say before signing that you will use a fund loan. The down-payment ratio on a combined loan must meet both the fund side and the commercial side. Fund balances can also be withdrawn to repay a loan; see Section 5, item 3 (the housing provident fund is not only for buying a home). If you already put everything on a commercial loan, you can ask the bank to lower the rate; see item 15 of this section (negotiating a lower rate).

## 17. If the property manager cuts water, power, heat, or gas to force you to pay property fees, complain to the local real-estate authority; if you owe the fees, the manager may only demand payment, sue, or apply for arbitration

**Cost**. No monetary cost. A phone call or a written complaint takes a few tens of minutes. If the manager does not change and you want damages, you have to sue.

**In plain terms**. The property manager must not cut water, power, heat, or gas to force you to pay property fees; if it happens, complain to the local real-estate authority. If the manager provided the contracted services, you cannot refuse to pay on the ground that you “did not use them”; if you still do not pay, it can sue. Unauthorized extra or duplicate charges you may refuse, and what you already paid you can get back.

**Benefit**. Article 944 of the Civil Code has three layers. The first is: “A property service provider must not collect property fees by cutting off electricity, water, heat, or gas.” The second: if the manager provided services as agreed, an owner must not refuse to pay on the ground of “not having accepted or not needing to accept” the services. The third: if an owner is overdue, the manager may demand payment within a reasonable period; if still unpaid when that period ends, the manager may sue or apply for arbitration. The Property Management Regulations also state that when an owner is overdue on property fees, the owners' committee shall urge payment within a time limit; if still unpaid, the property service enterprise may sue. Complaints go to the real-estate administration of the people's government at or above the county level; the regulations require them to handle owners' complaints promptly. A Supreme People's Court judicial interpretation states that if the manager unilaterally expands the fee scope, raises the fee standard, or charges twice, you may raise that as a defense against payment. Unauthorized fees already paid may be demanded back.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. What the law forbids is using a water or power cut as a way to collect property fees. If what you owe is the water, electricity, or gas bill itself, the situation differs. After a power supplier demands payment and you still do not pay within a reasonable period, it may suspend supply under the national procedure, and it must notify you in advance. Water, gas, and heat follow the same idea. The regulations also require water, power, gas, and heat suppliers to bill the end user. If a water or power cut by the manager caused you losses and you want damages, you have to sue. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months; summary procedure is 3 months; lawyer fees are generally yours. If a landlord cuts water or power to force you out of a rental, see item 2 (cutting water or power, changing locks). Benefit set to medium by judgment: property fees are a few hundred to a few thousand yuan a year, and there is no uniform statistic for losses from heat or water cuts.

## 18. When taking handover of a new home, inspect on the spot and write problems into the handover record; for leaks and faults in water and power lines, go to the developer for repairs within the warranty period in the Residential Quality Warranty

**Cost**. No monetary cost. Spend two or three extra hours on handover day checking walls, floors, doors, windows, and utilities room by room, and photograph for the record. Hiring someone to help inspect costs extra.

**In plain terms**. When the developer hands over, it must give you a Residential Quality Warranty (《住宅质量保证书》). The contractor's statutory minimum warranty periods are 5 years for leaks in bathrooms, roofs, and exterior walls, and 2 years for water and power lines and fit-out, all counted from completion acceptance. The warranty the developer gives you must not be shorter than what remains of the contractor's warranty. If within the warranty period it will not repair or keeps delaying, you may hire someone yourself and the developer pays.

**Benefit**. Ministry of Housing and Urban-Rural Development rules state that when selling commercial housing, the developer must provide the buyer with a Residential Quality Warranty (《住宅质量保证书》) and Residential Use Instructions (《住宅使用说明书》). The developer bears quality warranty liability for homes it sells; the warranty period runs from the day of handover. The commercial-housing warranty must not be shorter than what remains under the quality warranty the contractor gave the developer. For quality problems within the warranty scope during the period, the developer must repair and also compensate for losses caused. Damage from force majeure or improper use is not the developer's responsibility. The contractor's minimum warranty periods are set by a State Council regulation, counted from the day of passing completion acceptance. Roof waterproofing, and seepage prevention for bathrooms, rooms, and exterior walls that require waterproofing, is 5 years. Heating and cooling systems are 2 heating seasons and cooling seasons. Electrical lines, water-supply and drainage pipes, equipment installation, and fit-out works are 2 years. Foundations and the main structure last for the reasonable service life stated in the design documents. A Supreme People's Court judicial interpretation states that during the warranty period the developer bears the duty to repair. “If the seller refuses to repair or delays repair beyond a reasonable period, the buyer may repair personally or through others. The repair cost and other losses caused during the repair period are borne by the seller.” If a quality problem seriously affects normal residence and use, you may end the contract and demand compensation. If the main structure fails inspection as unqualified, you may also end the contract and demand compensation. Checking room by room on handover day, writing problems into the handover record, and photographing them is the author's experience. Improper use is outside the warranty, so problems noted at handover are hard for the developer to blame on your later renovation.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Warranty scope and term must be agreed with you in the contract; the contract and the Residential Quality Warranty govern. If what is written is longer than the statutory minimum, the longer term applies. The sales administration measures also mention the 1998 quality-warranty system rules; the original minimum periods in that text were not retrieved here, so no figures are given. When a problem appears within the warranty period, first notify the developer in writing and keep a copy — the author's experience. If the developer will neither repair nor accept responsibility, you have to sue. Ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months; summary procedure is 3 months; lawyer fees are generally yours. Area and advertising promises that do not match: see item 12 (area difference). Late handover or late title deed: see item 13 (late handover). Benefit set to medium by judgment: repair costs vary widely by home and problem, with no uniform statistic.

# 16. How to live after a chronic disease diagnosis

Scope: overall mortality and money. After a chronic diagnosis you often still have decades ahead; this section is about how to manage those decades.

## 1. Take the medicine as prescribed for the full course; do not stop because you feel better

**Cost**. No cost; it saves the money that would later go to treating complications. Taking the medicine each day takes only a few minutes. The hard part is not missing a day.

**In plain terms**. People who take the medicine for the full course, as the doctor said, have about half the chance of dying over the same period as people who take it on and off. Discount this figure. People who take even a dummy medicine for the full course also die less often, which shows that part of the benefit comes from "people who can keep taking medicine were already paying more attention to their health."

**Benefit**. Pooled from 21 studies and 46847 people (meta-analysis): compared with people who take medicine on and off, people who take it as prescribed have about a 44% lower chance of dying over the same period. The original value is an odds ratio of 0.56, 95% CI 0.50–0.63 (confidence interval). Looking only at treatments that truly work, about 45% lower (0.55, 0.49–0.62)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Disputed. This is the figure in this book that most needs discounting. In the same pooled analysis, people who took even placebo (a dummy medicine) for the full course also had lower mortality (0.56, 0.43–0.74). That shows a large part of the benefit comes from "people who can keep taking medicine were already paying more attention to their health." The author calls this mixed-in factor the healthy adherer effect

## 2. First get outpatient chronic special-disease certification, then file for care away from home, and hypertension, diabetes, outpatient chemo or radiotherapy, dialysis, and anti-rejection treatment can be settled directly in another region

**Cost**. No cost. Before you set out, file once for care away from home on the yibao (basic medical insurance) app. It can be done on a phone.

**In plain terms**. Hypertension, diabetes, outpatient chemo or radiotherapy for a malignant tumor, dialysis for uremia, and anti-rejection treatment after an organ transplant: for these, outpatient care away from home can in most cases be paid directly by insurance. You do not pay first and then claim it back where you are insured. You must first get outpatient chronic special-disease certification where you are insured, then file for care away from home. It works only if both are done.

**Benefit**. A document from the National Healthcare Security Administration (国家医保局) says this has already been reached. The original wording is: "Cross-province direct settlement of outpatient costs for 5 outpatient chronic special diseases, including hypertension, diabetes, outpatient chemo or radiotherapy for malignant tumors, dialysis for uremia, and anti-rejection treatment after organ transplant, is basically accessible at county level." "Accessible at county level" (县域可及) means it can be handled at county level. On top of these 5, the document adds another 5

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Both have to be done: first get outpatient chronic special-disease certification where you are insured, then file for care away from home. How far the 5 newly added diseases have opened differs by place; follow what the local insurance authority publishes. If the hospital does not stock the negotiated drug you need, see section 24, item 13 (dual-channel designated pharmacies).

## 3. Follow the follow-up intervals your doctor sets, and record each measurement in the same notebook

**Cost**. Each test costs from a few dozen to a few hundred CNY. A hospital visit plus waiting for results takes some time. The hard part is going again and again on schedule without putting it off.

**In plain terms**. Chronic disease is about change over a stretch of time, not a single reading. Measuring blood pressure at home alone does not show the pressure coming down because of that. Bring the readings to the doctor and let the doctor adjust the drugs from them, and the pressure falls more. When you change hospitals, test results marked for mutual recognition are ones the hospital generally should not make you repeat.

**Benefit**. Chronic conditions require seeing how values shift over time; a single point is not enough. For hypertension, one meta-analysis pooled individual data from 15 randomized trials and 7,138 people. Compared with usual care, home self-measurement at 12 months meant mean change in office systolic blood pressure −3.2 mmHg (95% CI −4.9 to −1.6). Self-measurement alone without other support showed no clear effect: −1.0 mmHg (−3.3 to 1.2, difference may be chance). The most supported package lowered by 6.1 mmHg (3.2 to 9.0). Supported care means a doctor, pharmacist, or patient adjusting meds from readings, plus health education and lifestyle guidance. The author's conclusion: measuring alone does not reliably lower pressure; pairing readings with dose adjustment does. These endpoints are blood pressure, not death. When changing hospitals, a joint measure from the National Health Commission «国家卫健委» and three other agencies states: if the patient's existing test results meet mutual-recognition rules and satisfy clinical need, the hospital and clinician must not repeat tests. Recognized reports carry an “HR” mark, e.g. (全国 HR) (national HR)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. B only because direct evidence is for hypertension alone and stops at blood pressure, not mortality. No study was found on health outcomes from “keeping readings in one notebook” itself. Each time record at least four items: date, value, drug name, and dose. Photos of lab slips on your phone are fine, but keep everything in one place. Mutual recognition has exceptions: changed condition, rapidly changing results, before surgery or transfusion, and emergency rescue—hospitals may repeat tests. Copying and keeping medical records and imaging: see Section 24, item 5 (keep your own copy of records, reports, and imaging)

## 4. Do not stop standard treatment to try folk remedies or health supplements

**Cost**. No cost; you also save what you would spend on supplements. No extra time. The hard part is holding firm when others keep pushing you to try something.

**In plain terms**. For a cancer that could otherwise be treated, people who use only alternative therapy and skip standard treatment have 2.5 times the risk of death of people on standard treatment. People who use complementary therapy while also being treated more often refuse surgery, chemotherapy, and radiotherapy, and the extra deaths come from that. Some herbs also weaken anti-rejection drugs and anticoagulants; ask the treating doctor before taking any.

**Benefit**. Two US cancer-registry studies looked at non-metastatic, potentially curable breast, prostate, lung, and colorectal cancer. The first compared patients who used only alternative therapy and did none of surgery, chemo/radiotherapy, or endocrine treatment with matched standard-care patients: death risk 2.5-fold (HR 2.50, 95% CI 1.88–3.27, about 1.5 times higher). Breast cancer 5.68-fold (3.22–10.04), lung 2.17-fold (1.42–3.32), colorectal 4.57-fold (1.66–12.61). The second looked at standard treatment plus complementary therapy: refusal rates were surgery 7.0% vs 0.1%, chemo 34.1% vs 3.2%, radiotherapy 53.0% vs 2.3%, endocrine therapy 33.7% vs 2.8%. Five-year survival 82.2% vs 86.6%; death risk 2.08-fold (HR 2.08, 1.50–2.90, about double). After accounting for delay and refusal, complementary therapy alone was not linked to death (HR 1.39, 0.83–2.33). The author's conclusion: extra deaths came from refusing standard treatment. China's State Administration for Market Regulation requires health-food labels to state: “Health food is not medicine and cannot replace drugs to treat disease.” The US National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health (NCCIH) states

that St John's wort (贯叶连翘) weakens several drugs, including cyclosporine for transplant rejection and the anticoagulant warfarin

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. B only. Both studies were cancer-only, registry follow-up without randomized groups; people who chose alternative therapy may differ in other ways. Stopping meds in hypertension or diabetes: see item 1 (full adherence). Tell your treating doctor before any supplement. Whether to pay for supplements: Section 6, item 10 (supplements, tonic formulas, tonics)

## 5. For a stable chronic disease, a community hospital can prescribe up to 12 weeks of medicine at a single visit

**Cost**. No cost. At the community health service center (社区卫生服务中心), ask whether a long-term prescription is possible. It is a single question.

**In plain terms**. If the illness is stable and the drugs have not been changed, a community health service center can prescribe at most 12 weeks of medicine at a single visit. That saves the half-day each month spent going to a large hospital, queuing, and registering. In the same place where you are insured, the inpatient reimbursement rate at a primary-level hospital is in principle about 10 percentage points higher than at the next tier up.

**Benefit**. You do not have to go back and forth to a large hospital every month and queue for a refill. In the same insured place (also called a pooled region, 统筹地区), the inpatient reimbursement rate at a primary-level hospital is in principle about 10 percentage points higher than at the next tier up

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. "Meets the conditions" is judged by the doctor, usually someone whose diagnosis is already clear and whose drug plan is stable. The drug stays the same drug. What you save is the half-day trip each month and the registration fee. If the primary-level site does not have the drug you need, ask whether they have a shortage register and delivery. The same document also requires tertiary hospitals to gradually cut ordinary outpatient clinics for this kind of chronic disease, and to extend the specialist team's ordinary clinics into the community. Using a large hospital as a refill point will get harder to book. If the community does not have your drug, or a specialist has to watch the dose changes, you can get the refill from an online follow-up at the hospital that made the diagnosis; see section 24, item 14 (online follow-up at an internet hospital).

## 6. Before signing a family doctor (家庭医生) contract at community level, ask which services are covered by yibao (医保) and which are out of pocket

**Cost**. No cost. One extra minute of questions before signing.

**In plain terms**. The basic service package is paid by yibao (医保) as required. Personalized service packages are entirely self-paid. When someone sells an “upgrade package,” ask whether it is basic or personalized, whether it is filed with the county health authority, and the yearly price.

**Benefit**. Basic service package is paid by yibao (医保) per rules. Personalized packages are fully self-paid and must be filed with the county-level health administration (县级卫生健康部门)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The value of signing is long-term follow-up for your condition, not how many items are bundled. When offered an “upgrade package,” ask three things: basic or personalized, filed or not, and cost per year.

## 7. Once diabetes is diagnosed, have the back of the eye checked once, then on the interval the doctor sets; check the feet once a year

**Cost**. A dilated fundus exam costs from a few dozen to a few hundred CNY. A foot exam is usually included in the outpatient visit and is not charged separately. The hard part is remembering to go when the eyes and the feet feel fine.

**In plain terms**. When diabetes has damaged the back of the eye or the feet, there is almost no feeling until vision is gone or the foot starts to break down. Caught early, it can still be treated. Have a dilated fundus exam at the diagnosis of type 2 diabetes; for type 1, start 5 years after onset. If early checks were normal and blood sugar is at target, the interval can widen to once a year or every other year. Check the feet once a year.

**Benefit**. Damage from diabetes to the back of the eye is called retinopathy; damage to the foot is called diabetic foot. Both are almost without feeling before they go wrong. Caught early, they can still be treated. Once vision is gone or the foot has broken down, it is late

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Type 2 diabetes needs the exam at diagnosis; type 1 starts 5 years after onset. The difference is that type 2 has often been quietly high for years. If early checks were normal and blood sugar is at target, the interval can widen to once every 1 to 2 years. If sensation in the feet has dulled, look at the sole yourself every day; a mirror is fine. The kidneys should also be checked every year; see item 13 (urine albumin-to-creatinine ratio).

## 8. After a kidney stone, drink 2.5–3 liters of water a day and cut salt to within 6 grams

**Cost**. No cost. Make drinking whenever you can into a habit. On days you sweat a lot, drink still more. The hard part is remembering every day.

**In plain terms**. Among people who grew a first calcium stone and no cause was found, about a quarter grow another within 5 years if they do nothing. Among people who drink enough water every day, a bit over a tenth have a recurrence within 5 years, fewer by more than half. The British guideline gives 2.5 to 3 liters of water a day, and salt no more than 6 grams.

**Benefit**. A 5-year randomized controlled trial in 199 patients with a first calcium stone and no cause found (also called idiopathic calcium stones). The water group drank at least 2 liters of water a day; the other group had no intervention. Recurrence over 5 years: 12/99 (12.1%) in the group that drank more water, 27/100 (27.0%) in the group with no intervention, P=0.008. A smaller P value means the difference between the groups is less likely to be chance. Mean time until recurrence: 38.7±13.2 months versus 25.1±16.4 months, P=0.016. The 24-hour urine volume measured at the start was clearly lower in stone patients than in people without stones: men 1057±238 mL versus 1401±562 mL (P<0.0001), women 990±230 mL versus 1239±440 mL (P<0.001). Clause 1.8.1 of NICE guideline NG118 recommends that adults drink 2.5 to 3 liters of water a day, and that children and adolescents drink 1 to 2 liters by age. Add a little fresh lemon juice to the water, do not drink carbonated drinks, and keep salt for adults to no more than 6 grams a day. Clause 1.7.1 of the same NICE guideline recommends considering a stone composition analysis for adults who have had a kidney stone or a ureteral stone. For people with recurrence whose stone is more than half calcium oxalate, clause 1.8.3 recommends considering potassium citrate. NICE found no evidence on 24-hour urine testing and gives no recommendation. The stone guideline of the European Association of Urology (EAU) is written differently: every patient with a stone should have a reliable stone composition analysis. People with recurrence count as high risk and should give 24-hour urine twice in a row for a dedicated metabolic workup. Its general prevention target is 2.5 to 3 liters of water a day, and a daily urine volume of 2 to 2.5 liters

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Recurrence was about 55% lower, and it costs nothing, so by this book's way of scoring value for money this is the highest-value item in the section. What to watch is 24-hour urine volume. The European guideline's target is 2 to 2.5 liters a day, not how much you drink. People who sweat a lot, and people who

work in high heat, have to drink more. That trial enrolled patients with a first episode of idiopathic calcium stones. There is more than a single stone type: uric acid stones, infection stones, and cystine stones each have their own approach. Both the British and the European guidelines recommend a stone composition analysis. For people who have recurred, the European guideline also requires a 24-hour urine test before deciding whether to add a drug; the British guideline finds the evidence for that test insufficient. Do not cut out calcium to prevent stones; see section 6, item 21. Severe colic in the flank or abdomen during an attack means go to a hospital, not try to flush the stone out by drinking more. Painless blood in the urine has other things that need checking; see section 1, item 27

## 9. After a gout diagnosis, if tophi have grown, imaging shows bone eaten out, or flares come 2 or more times a year, take a urate-lowering drug long term and hold serum urate under 360 μmol/L

**Cost**. Allopurinol (别嘌醇) costs a few CNY to a few dozen CNY a month. At the start, check serum urate every few weeks to adjust the dose; once it is stable, every few months. For the first 3 to 6 months also take a drug that prevents flares. The hard part is keeping on with it when nothing hurts.

**In plain terms**. If tophi have grown, bone has been eaten out, or flares come 2 or more times a year, take a urate-lowering drug long term and hold urate under 360 μmol/L. If flares are infrequent, whether to take it is something to settle with the doctor. Among patients whose dose a nurse adjusted from the lab results, 95% were at target after 2 years, and only 30% with usual care. After the target is reached the drug still cannot be stopped. Cutting foods lowers it only so much.

**Benefit**. A randomized controlled trial of 517 adults who had flared in the past 12 months. The nurse-led group had the disease explained, then had urate adjusted to target from the lab results. The other group had usual care from a general practitioner. At 2 years, the share with serum urate <360 μmol/L (6 mg/dL) was 95% versus 30%. The chance of reaching target was 3.18 times that of the usual-care group (RR 3.18, 95% CI 2.42–4.18, this interval is the confidence range of the figure), P<0.0001. In year 2, flare frequency, tophi, and quality of life, these secondary measures, were also better than in the usual-care group. Each extra year of life adjusted for quality of life (a quality-adjusted life year) cost £5066. The same trial also ran a follow-up: questionnaires went to 438 people and 82% came back. Both groups reported their own flare counts over the past 12 months. The median in the target group was 0 (the middle half of people fell between 0 and 0). Usual care was 1 (0–3), P<0.001. The range in those parentheses is called the interquartile range. The share still taking a urate-lowering drug was 1.19 times the usual-care group (adjusted RR 1.19, 1.09–1.30). The 2020 American College of Rheumatology gout guideline strongly recommends starting urate-lowering treatment for people with subcutaneous tophi, people whose imaging shows gout has eaten a defect into the bone, or people with ≥2 flares a year. For more than a single flare but fewer than 2 a year, the guideline conditionally suggests the drug; a conditional recommendation is settled between doctor and patient. For a first flare, it conditionally suggests not starting at once. The exception is chronic kidney disease of stage 3 or above, serum urate >9 mg/dL, or a past urinary stone; those are conditionally suggested to treat. The method is to keep watching serum urate and adjust the dose from the results until target, with a target <6 mg/dL. Allopurinol is the first choice, including for chronic kidney disease of stage 3 or above, at a starting dose ≤100 mg/day. At the start, also give an anti-inflammatory preventive drug for at least 3 to 6 months. The same guideline also cites a set of case observations. These patients stopped the drug after long good control, and after stopping, serum urate stayed <7 mg/dL. Among them, only 13% (27/211) had no flare at all over 5 years of follow-up. On diet, people who limited alcohol or stopped it had serum urate 1.6 mg/dL lower than people who did not limit it, and a serving of beer raised serum urate by 0.16 mg/dL. A healthy diet, a Mediterranean diet, and the DASH diet had smaller effects. Which urate-lowering drug to choose first is disputed. The American College of Rheumatology guideline strongly recommends allopurinol as the first choice, because at a high enough dose it works, is tolerated, is safe, and is cheap. It also conditionally suggests that a person on febuxostat (非布司他) who has a history of cardiovascular disease, or a new cardiovascular event, switch if another drug is available. That recommendation matches the boxed warning the FDA put on febuxostat. It draws on the CARES trial: 6190 gout patients with cardiovascular disease were randomized to febuxostat or allopurinol. All-cause death risk in the febuxostat group was 1.22 times the allopurinol group (HR 1.22, 95%

CI 1.01–1.47, about 22% higher). Cardiovascular death was 1.34 times (1.03–1.73, about 34% higher). The European FAST trial came to a different conclusion. It enrolled 6128 patients aged over 60 with cardiovascular risk factors; major cardiovascular events on febuxostat were not higher than on allopurinol (HR 0.85, 0.70–1.03). Deaths were 7.2% in the febuxostat group and 8.6% in the allopurinol group. For people taking a drug that promotes uric acid excretion through the kidney, the American College of Rheumatology conditionally suggests not alkalinizing the urine, because there is no evidence that it works and the certainty of the evidence is very low. It also requires telling those people to drink more water. People with known kidney stones, or with chronic kidney disease of stage 3 or above, should not use this class of drug. The same guideline notes that the HLA-B*5801 genotype is most common in people of Han, Korean, and Thai ancestry, at 7.4%, in African Americans at 3.8%, and in white people and in Hispanic people at 0.7% each. For Asian people and African Americans taking allopurinol, the risk of allopurinol hypersensitivity syndrome is 3 times the risk in white people. The guideline conditionally suggests testing these groups for HLA-B*5801 before allopurinol; the certainty of the evidence is very low

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Disputed: which drug to use to lower urate differs across national guidelines. The US guideline prefers allopurinol, and a person with cardiovascular disease should switch off febuxostat when another drug is available, but the European FAST trial did not find febuxostat more dangerous. Benzbromarone (苯溴马隆) can still be bought in China; it promotes uric acid excretion. The guidelines of the Chinese Medical Association (中华医学会) (the 2019 edition and the 2024 update) give separate recommendations on drug choice and on alkalinizing the urine. Whether to add sodium bicarbonate to alkalinize the urine while taking benzbromarone: the US guideline finds no evidence; follow the doctor; drinking more water cannot be skipped. **People of Han ancestry (汉族) should be tested for HLA-B*5801 before allopurinol.** It is an inborn gene type that governs immune response, and a test result does not change for life. Carriers are 7.4% of Han, Korean, and Thai people, and only 0.7% of white and Hispanic people. After allopurinol, the risk of allopurinol hypersensitivity syndrome in Asian people and African Americans is 3 times the risk in white people; when the illness is severe, skin peels off over a large area and it can kill. The 2020 American College of Rheumatology gout guideline suggests that, for these groups, a test before the drug can be considered. **Starting a urate-lowering drug makes a flare more likely at the beginning**, so the guideline explicitly requires an anti-inflammatory preventive drug at the same time for the first 3 to 6 months. "It hurt more after the urate-lowering drug, so I stopped" is a common way this fails. When it hurts, add an anti-inflammatory as prescribed; do not stop the urate-lowering drug. Targets are written differently: <6 mg/dL is about 360 μmol/L, and Chinese lab sheets mostly use μmol/L. High urate on a checkup, with no flare ever, is a different matter; see section 6, item 19. Sugary drinks and alcohol: see section 2, items 7 and 19 (do not drink sugary drinks; drink little or no alcohol). A large amount of meat and seafood at a meal, plus alcohol, can bring on a flare; see item 10 (at a barbecue or a group meal, do not eat a large amount of meat and seafood at a sitting)

## 10. If you have had gout, do not eat a large amount of meat and seafood at a barbecue or a group meal, and drink less alcohol

**Cost**. No cost. At a barbecue or a group meal, order fewer meat skewers and less seafood, and drink less. The hard part is holding yourself at the table.

**In plain terms**. For people who have had gout, when purine intake over the pair of days before was at its highest, the chance of a flare was nearly 5 times the chance when intake was lowest, and the same held while taking a urate-lowering drug. After 2 to 4 drinks the day before, the chance of a flare was about half higher; beer, spirits, and wine all count.

**Benefit**. A study followed 633 gout patients online for 1 year, comparing a pair of days before each person's flare with a pair of their own days when they did not flare (a case-crossover study). Purine is a component of food that the body turns into uric acid. Splitting the purine total over that pair of days from low to high into bands, and comparing with the lowest band, the chance of a flare in the higher bands was 1.17, 1.38, 2.21, and 4.76 times (OR, trend P<0.001). Counting only purine from animal sources, the figures were 1.42, 1.34, 1.77, and 2.41 times. Counting only purine from plant sources, they were 1.12, 0.99, 1.32, and 1.39 times. Split by

sex, by whether the person drank, and by whether they took a diuretic, allopurinol, an anti-inflammatory pain drug, or colchicine, the result was the same. Another study by the same researchers looked at alcohol in the 24 hours before a flare in 724 gout patients. Compared with not drinking, more than 1 drink up to 2 drinks was 1.36 times (95% CI 1.00–1.88, confidence interval), and more than 2 drinks up to 4 drinks was 1.51 times (1.09–2.09). Wine, beer, and spirits were each linked to flares. For people who have not had gout, another follow-up study applies: 47150 men in the United States followed for 12 years, recorded only, not assigned to groups. The top fifth by meat intake had about a 41% higher risk of gout than the bottom fifth (RR 1.41, 1.07–1.86). Seafood was about 51% higher (1.51, 1.17–1.95). The top fifth by dairy intake was instead about 44% lower (0.56, 0.42–0.74). Vegetables high in purine, and total protein, showed no link. In the same men, an extra 12-ounce bottle of beer a day (about 355 ml) raised risk by about 49% (1.49, 1.32–1.70). A daily drink of spirits raised it by about 15% (1.15, 1.04–1.28). Wine showed no statistical difference (1.04, 0.88–1.22)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Written mainly for people who have already had a flare. For people who have not had gout, what you eat moves uric acid less than most people think. Among 16760 white adults in the United States without gout, diet could explain no more than 0.3% of the difference in serum uric acid, while common genetic differences could explain 23.9%. So when someone nearby gets gout after barbecue and beer, diet is a trigger and constitution accounts for more. The studies looked at how much meat, seafood, and alcohol was eaten, not at whether it was grilled; cold seafood with beer counts the same. All of the studies only followed and recorded, with no assignment to groups; what was eaten at the time of a flare was reported by the patients online, the people studied were American, and no Chinese data were found. The dairy figure is also only a follow-up record; no trial has shown that drinking more milk prevents gout. Eating less cannot replace a urate-lowering drug, and cutting foods lowers uric acid only so much; see item 9 (once gout is diagnosed, take a urate-lowering drug long term). The mortality account for processed meat and alcohol is in section 2, item 18 (eat less processed meat) and section 2, item 19 (drink little or no alcohol)

## 11. If hepatitis B surface antigen is positive, have a liver ultrasound and alpha-fetoprotein every half year, let the doctor decide whether to take an antiviral, and do not stop it on your own once you start

**Cost**. Go to hepatology or infectious disease every half year, have blood drawn, and have an ultrasound; the fee differs by place. If an antiviral is needed, the National Healthcare Security Administration (国家医保局) says that after pooled procurement the yearly cost of entecavir fell to a bit over 100 CNY. The hard part is going on time when you feel nothing, and staying on the drug.

**In plain terms**. People who carry hepatitis B virus, checked every half year with ultrasound and alpha-fetoprotein, had nearly 40% fewer deaths from liver cancer in a Shanghai trial. The more virus in the blood, the more liver cancer later. People whose liver was already badly fibrotic or cirrhotic, once on an antiviral, had about half as much liver cancer. Most of these drugs have to be taken long term; if you stop on your own the virus readily rebounds.

**Benefit**. A randomized trial in Shanghai of 18816 people aged 35 to 59, all infected with hepatitis B virus or with a history of chronic hepatitis. The screening group was invited every 6 months for alpha-fetoprotein and ultrasound; the control group was not screened. Alpha-fetoprotein is a blood marker that often rises when liver cancer is present. Deaths from liver cancer were 32 in the screening group and 54 in the control group. Liver-cancer mortality was 83.2 versus 131.5 per 100000 people. The screening group was 0.63 times the control group (95% CI 0.41–0.98, confidence interval), about 37% lower. Of the liver cancers found in the screening group, 46.5% were surgically removed, against 7.5% in the control group. A follow-up study in Taiwan of 3653 people aged 30 to 65 who were surface-antigen positive, followed for a mean of 11.4 years, recorded only, not assigned to groups. The more virus in the blood at entry, the more liver cancer later. Below 300 copies per milliliter, there were 108 liver cancers per 100000 person-years. Above 1000000 copies per milliliter, there were 1152. The cumulative share who developed liver cancer was 1.3% and 14.9%. After accounting for sex, age, smoking, alcohol, aminotransferases, and cirrhosis, more virus still meant more liver cancer. An Asian randomized trial of 651 people with chronic hepatitis B who already had severe liver

fibrosis or cirrhosis. A lamivudine group and a placebo group were followed for a median of 32.4 months. Liver cancer was 3.9% versus 7.4%, about half the risk (HR 0.49, P=0.047). Worsening of disease was 7.8% versus 17.7% (HR 0.45, about 55% lower). The 2022 guideline of the Chinese Medical Association (中华医学会) states that people with chronic hepatitis B virus infection should have an abdominal ultrasound and alpha-fetoprotein every 6 months to screen for liver cancer. People at high risk should have them at least every 3 to 6 months. Carriers who do not yet need drugs should have a blood count, liver function, viral markers, alpha-fetoprotein, and ultrasound every 6 to 12 months. Once the conditions for treatment are met, start at once. If virus is detectable in the blood, antiviral treatment is recommended after age 30, whether or not aminotransferases are high. The same applies if someone in the family developed cirrhosis or liver cancer from hepatitis B. The oral drugs the guideline recommends are the entecavir and tenofovir class. The guideline states that most people need long-term treatment, and that the share whose virus rebounds after stopping is high

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Disputed: some people do not accept the conclusion of that Shanghai trial. A 2003 Cochrane review recalculated it by its own method. The difference in liver-cancer deaths was not significant (OR 0.81, 0.54–1.22). The 2012 update said the trial had a high risk of bias, the figures in the reports did not match, and no conclusion could be drawn. So "every half year" rests on this disputed trial, plus guidelines in various countries. Lamivudine is an old drug; in the trial 49% developed a resistance mutation, and guidelines now recommend the entecavir class. Whether to start, and whether stopping is possible, depends on viral load, aminotransferases, the degree of liver fibrosis, and family history, and the doctor decides. People not yet infected should have the hepatitis B panel (两对半) and the vaccine; see section 1, item 14 (hepatitis B panel). Hepatitis C is a different disease; see section 1, item 45 (hepatitis C antibody). Alcohol damages the liver; see section 2, item 19 (drink little or no alcohol). The person who benefits is mainly you.

## 12. Once COPD is diagnosed, have the doctor or pharmacist watch you use the inhaler at a follow-up visit; if you were admitted for an acute exacerbation, do pulmonary rehabilitation after discharge

**Cost**. Having the inhaler technique watched costs nothing extra. Bring the medicine to the follow-up, use it once in front of the clinician, and it takes a few minutes. Pulmonary rehabilitation is supervised exercise training plus teaching on drugs and self-management. It means going several times on a schedule, and the fee differs by place. The hard part is still going to train after discharge, when the body is weak.

**In plain terms**. Among people who use an inhaler, only about 30% get the technique fully right, and some errors keep the drug from reaching the lungs. Patients who made a critical error had about twice the share admitted or seen in emergency for an exacerbation. Pulmonary rehabilitation after an admission for an exacerbation cuts the chance of another admission by more than half, and quality of life and walking also tend to be better. Whether it means fewer deaths is not yet clear.

**Benefit**. A national sample survey in China gave lung-function tests to 50991 adults aged 20 and over. The share with COPD (chronic obstructive pulmonary disease) was 8.6% (95% CI 7.5–9.9, confidence interval), about 99900000 people. At 40 and over it was 13.7%. Among people with COPD, only 12.0% had ever had a lung-function test. An analysis pooled 144 studies in which a trained person watched 54354 patients use an inhaler. Fully correct technique was 31%, barely acceptable 41%, and poor 31%. Compared with the prior 20 years, the later 20 years showed no improvement. With a press-and-breathe spray, failure to match the press with the breath was 45%. Not inhaling fast enough or deep enough was 44%, and not holding the breath afterward was 46%. A French survey only recorded, with no assignment to groups: doctors watched 2935 COPD patients use an inhaler. More than half the maneuvers had an error. Critical errors that keep the drug from being inhaled ran from 15.4% to 46.9% across devices. Admission or an emergency visit for an exacerbation in the past 3 months was 3.3% among patients with no error and 6.9% among those with a critical error (OR 1.86, 1.14–3.04). The summary of the GOLD 2023 report states that doctors and patients must be taught to use inhaler devices correctly, and that technique should be checked regularly at follow-up. It also recommends that people with COPD receive influenza, pneumococcal, and similar vaccines as local

rules require. A 2016 Cochrane review pooled 20 randomized trials and 1477 people. It compared pulmonary rehabilitation after a COPD exacerbation with usual care and no rehabilitation. 8 studies and 810 people looked at readmission. Readmission was about 56% lower with rehabilitation (OR 0.44, 95% CI 0.21–0.91); evidence quality was moderate. But the studies differed a great deal. 6 studies and 670 people looked at death, OR 0.68 (0.28–1.67); the difference may be chance, and evidence quality was low. The gain in quality of life was larger than patients can feel; evidence quality was high. The 6-minute walk was on average 62 meters longer (38–86 meters); evidence quality was high

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Disputed: when to start pulmonary rehabilitation is not agreed. A British randomized trial started training within 48 hours of admission; readmission a year later was not lower (HR 1.1). Deaths were instead higher (OR 1.74, 95% CI 1.05–2.88). The summary of the GOLD 2023 report says that starting within the first 4 weeks after discharge has an unclear effect. So do it after discharge, once the illness has settled, on the doctor's schedule; do not add extra training on your own during the acute stay. That Cochrane review also states that studies added later showed smaller effects than the earlier ones. Both inhaler studies only recorded, with no assignment to groups; no trial has directly shown that "watching once at follow-up" reduces admissions. The exact technique differs by device; follow the instructions and the doctor's demonstration. Influenza vaccine: see section 1, item 20 (influenza vaccine). Pneumococcal vaccine: see section 1, item 22 (pneumococcal vaccine). If you still smoke, quit first; see section 2, item 3 (do not rely on willpower alone to quit; get the medicine first). The person who benefits is mainly you.

## 13. If you have diabetes, check the urine albumin-to-creatinine ratio and serum creatinine once a year; if you have hypertension, check them too, to find chronic kidney disease early

**Cost**. Give a urine sample for the urine albumin-to-creatinine ratio, and have blood drawn for creatinine; ask the doctor to order both at a follow-up. The hard part is remembering to check when the kidneys feel fine.

**In plain terms**. Among adults in China who have chronic kidney disease, only about a tenth know they have it. A yearly urine and blood test in people with diabetes can find it earlier. Once urine protein is high, a drug such as dapagliflozin cuts the combined chance of kidney function failing, dialysis, or death by about 40%, and cuts death by about 30%.

**Benefit**. China's national chronic-disease surveillance for 2018 to 2019 tested blood and urine in 176874 adults. About 8.2% had chronic kidney disease, about 82000000 people. Of them, 73.3% were still in early stage 1 to 2. Only 10.0% knew they had it. Another survey in 45 hospitals nationwide tested 9672 people with type 2 diabetes; 31% had chronic kidney disease. Of these 2997 people, only 27% had been checked for kidney disease before. The 2024 KDIGO kidney guideline says people at risk should be tested for both urine albumin and glomerular filtration rate (how much blood the kidney filters per minute). The first priority is people with hypertension, diabetes, or cardiovascular disease. The 2026 standards of the American Diabetes Association say that people with type 2 diabetes, whatever the treatment, should have the urine albumin-to-creatinine ratio and the estimated glomerular filtration rate checked at least once a year. The same applies to type 1 once the disease has lasted 5 years. For diabetes plus hypertension with urine albumin moderately raised (30 to 299 mg/g), a pril-class or sartan-class blood-pressure drug is recommended. Once it is found, there are drugs that can be used. A randomized trial enrolled 4304 people with chronic kidney disease, glomerular filtration rate between 25 and 75, and urine albumin-to-creatinine ratio 200 to 5000. Over a median of 2.4 years, 9.2% of the dapagliflozin group had any of these: kidney function falling by more than half, end-stage kidney disease, or death from kidney disease or cardiovascular disease. The placebo group was 14.5%. HR 0.61 (95% CI 0.51–0.72), about 39% lower. Deaths were 4.7% versus 6.8%, HR 0.69 (0.53–0.88), about 31% lower. The effect was similar with or without diabetes

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. B only, because no randomized trial has directly compared whether "checking once a year" itself makes people die less. The figures for fewer deaths come from people who already had high urine protein

and then took the drug. The size of the benefit is therefore set to medium by judgment, and was not slotted as large from the drop in deaths. A single high result is not a diagnosis; KDIGO requires a repeat to confirm. How often people with hypertension should be checked is not given as a fixed interval in the guideline; follow the doctor. The doctor chooses the drug; do not buy it yourself. The eye and the foot that diabetes needs checked: see item 7 (have the back of the eye checked). The person who benefits is mainly you.

## 14. After surgery and chemotherapy for colon cancer, join a supervised exercise program and keep it up for 3 years

**Cost**. Walking and similar exercise cost nothing. An assessment and an exercise plan at a hospital rehabilitation clinic or an exercise-prescription clinic take a registration fee and test fees; a private coach is extra. Several extra hours of exercise a week are needed, and it has to be kept up for 3 years. People who train have more muscle and joint injuries.

**In plain terms**. After surgery and chemotherapy for colon cancer, people who joined a supervised exercise program for 3 years had about a 28% lower chance of recurrence, a new cancer, or death, and about a 37% lower chance of death. Of those alive at 8 years, about 90% were in the exercise group and about 83% had only received pamphlets. People who trained had more muscle and joint injuries.

**Benefit**. A randomized trial at 55 centers (CHALLENGE) enrolled 889 people with colon cancer. All had finished surgery and adjuvant chemotherapy, were high-risk stage II or stage III, and had no metastasis at enrollment. They enrolled 2 to 6 months after chemotherapy ended, and before enrollment they exercised less than 150 minutes a week. 445 joined a 3-year exercise program; 444 received only health pamphlets. For the first 6 months of the program, they met an exercise coach every other week to talk about how to keep going, and also trained a session while the coach watched. From 6 to 12 months this became a meeting or a phone call, and from then until year 3 only minimal support remained. The target was 10 more metabolic-equivalent hours a week than before (a unit of exercise amount); anything of moderate intensity or above counted, and the program expected most people to choose walking. After a year, weekly leisure exercise had risen by 15.6 metabolic-equivalent hours in the exercise group and by 5.1 in the control group. Median follow-up was 7.9 years. Recurrence, a new cancer, or death was about 28% lower in the exercise group than in the control group, HR 0.72 (95% CI 0.55–0.94). At 5 years, the share free of these events was 80.3% versus 73.9%. Death was about 37% lower, HR 0.63 (0.43–0.94). At 8 years, 90.3% versus 83.2% were alive. Musculoskeletal adverse events were 18.5% versus 11.5%. A cost analysis of the same trial, on Canadian public health care, put the exercise program at 2917 Canadian dollars per person up front, but with fewer recurrences the 5-year total cost was 1589 Canadian dollars less per person

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The trial enrolled colon cancer only, not rectal cancer, and only people whose surgery had cleared the tumor, who had finished chemotherapy, and who had no metastasis. It does not carry straight over to other cancers or to people with late disease. The main result is recurrence, a new cancer, or death. Death overall is a secondary result; the authors' wording is "consistent with living longer," and they do not treat it as settled. There is no ready-made program of the same kind in China; an oncology or rehabilitation department can write an exercise prescription. Have a fitness assessment before starting; everyone in the trial had an exercise test before enrollment. How to count walking: see section 2, item 11 (walk to 7000–8000 steps a day). Strength training: see section 2, item 16 (strength training). The person who benefits is mainly you.

# 17. Elderly at home

Scope: money and personal freedom. When you have elderly family at home, most trouble is not running out of money. It is failing to talk things through and get papers signed in advance. Pressure ulcers from long-term bed rest, cataract surgery, fractures from an elder walking a dog, and a hospital check when memory gets worse: these four are counted in mortality terms and are not compared with the other entries in this section.

## 1. While the elder is still lucid, name a future guardian in writing

**Cost**. A few hundred yuan at a notary office (公证处) for the document. A conversation with the elder can settle it. The hard part is bringing it up: you have to say, face to face, that a day will come when they can no longer manage for themselves.

**In plain terms**. While the elder's mind is still clear, spend a few hundred yuan at a notary office on a written document that names who will be their guardian later. Without that document, once they cannot decide for themselves, the order set by law applies: spouse first, then parents and children, then other close relatives. If the family fights over it, the residents' committee (居委会), the villagers' committee (村委会), the civil affairs bureau (民政), or a court names the guardian.

**Benefit**. The Civil Code (民法典) says an adult who is clear-headed and can decide for themselves (in law, an adult with full capacity for civil conduct (具有完全民事行为能力的成年人)) may agree in advance who will be their guardian. That person can be a close relative, or another willing individual or organization. The agreement must name the guardian in writing (以书面形式确定自己的监护人). When they later cannot decide, or can decide only in part (lose or partly lose capacity for civil conduct (丧失或者部分丧失民事行为能力)), the person named in the document takes charge. Without that document, Article 28 of the Civil Code sets the guardian in this order: spouse; parents and children; other close relatives; then another willing individual or organization with the consent of the residents' committee, the villagers' committee, or the civil affairs bureau. Article 31 says that if people dispute who the guardian should be, the residents' committee, the villagers' committee, or the civil affairs bureau designates one. Anyone who disagrees may ask a court to designate the guardian, and they may also apply to a court directly.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This document is agreed guardianship (意定监护), meaning a person the elder names in advance. That person ranks ahead of the default legal order. Elders who live alone, whose children live far away, or whose family situation is complicated need this more. Notarizing it at a notary office is recommended.

## 2. Make a will, and remember that a later will replaces an earlier one; a notarized will no longer ranks ahead

**Cost**. Writing a will in your own hand costs nothing. Notarizing one at a notary office (公证处) costs a few hundred yuan to more than a thousand yuan. The hard part is bringing it up: you have to talk with the family about what happens after death.

**In plain terms**. The law recognizes 6 kinds of will, and each kind has steps that must be completed. The kind you write yourself must be written by the person from start to finish, signed, and dated with the year, month, and day. If several wills conflict, the last one controls. From 2021, a notarized will no longer automatically ranks ahead of the others.

**Benefit**. The Civil Code (民法典) recognizes 6 forms of will: written by the person, written by someone else at their request, printed, audio or video, oral, and notarized. Each has its own formal requirements (形式要件). For the kind written by the person, Article 1134 of the Civil Code requires that it be "written by the testator in their own hand, signed, and dated with the year, month, and day." If several wills are made and they conflict, the last one controls. From 2021, a notarized will no longer automatically ranks ahead.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A handwritten will must be written by the person from start to finish, signed, and dated with the year, month, and day. A printed will needs 2 or more witnesses. The testator and the witnesses must sign every page and write the year, month, and day. An heir, anyone the will gives property to, and anyone with an interest tied to those people cannot be a witness. The judicial interpretation names the interested persons it means: their creditors, their debtors, and people who are in business with them as partners. Whether a spouse, a child, or another close relative of those people counts, the statute and the interpretation do not say directly. The author suggests not asking them to witness, so the will is not fought over later. If the form is wrong, the whole will is void. That is the most common way these fail. After the person dies, whether a small deposit or a house must be notarized for inheritance is covered in section 25, item 12 (do not default to notarization when handling an inheritance).

## 3. Keep the elder's money in a separate account, and set a two-person rule for large spending

**Cost**. No cost. Talk it over with the family once and set an amount. The hard part is how to bring it up so the elder does not feel you are guarding against them.

**In plain terms**. People who scam elders often start with small gifts and warm concern, build up trust, then take a large sum. They also often say "do not tell anyone." Agree on a rule in advance: spending above a set amount has to be mentioned to a specific person first. Then the family knows before the money goes out, and the decision to pay is pushed back.

**Benefit**. In 2022 the Supreme People's Procuratorate (最高检) released typical elder-fraud cases. It said these crimes first use small favors and a show of family concern to win trust, then false claims and promises of high returns to take large sums. In one case, a company selling fake collectibles sent staff to clean for elders and sit and talk with them, and even took them as "godparents." When they sold the goods they sealed them in a black bag and told the elder not to open it, so the elder's family would not find out. The company took in more than 1920000 yuan. The boss was sentenced to 7 years and 6 months for fund-raising fraud. In 2023 the Beijing Local Financial Regulatory Bureau (北京市地方金融管理局) warned elders not to believe a scammer who says "do not tell anyone." When you are unsure, talk with family, children, and neighbors and friends you trust, and ask the family before you invest. The U.S. Federal Trade Commission totaled the reported losses of people aged 60 and over. In 2020 the total was about 600000000 US dollars. In 2024 it had risen to about 2400000000 US dollars. The rise was mainly cases in which a single loss exceeded 100000 US dollars. Agreeing in advance that "spending above a set amount has to be mentioned to a specific person first" lets the family know before the money goes out, and pushes that decision back.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. No study has compared how much less fraud families see after they set this rule. The grade is B because the scam pattern and the advice to "talk with family more" come from the procuratorate and from financial regulators. The basis is the same kind as item 6 (housing-for-pension). A person who is worked up is easier to talk into something: see item 4 ("I need to go home and talk with my family"). General rules for avoiding fraud are in section 8 and section 13. Do not describe this as "we are afraid you will be scammed." Describe it as "the household keeps one set of accounts," which an elder accepts more easily. Do not hand all of an elder's money to the children to hold. That leads to a different kind of dispute.

## 4. Give the elder a line they can always use: “I need to go home and talk with my family”

**Cost**. No cost. One conversation, a few minutes.

**In plain terms**. Sales pitches and fraud rely on pressure on the spot, so you pay before you have time to think. Once emotions are stirred up, people are more eager to buy what exaggerated ads are selling, and elders are more eager to buy than younger people. Agree with the elder in advance on the line “I need to go home and talk with my family.” They can say it at any time, have a way to step back on the spot, and decide after they cool down at home.

**Benefit**. Pitches and fraud both lean on live pressure. The U.S. Federal Trade Commission anti-scam guide says scammers want action before you can think. On phone calls they tell you not to hang up so you cannot verify. The guide says tell someone—a friend, family member, or neighbor—before you act; saying it aloud may expose the scam. The former China Banking and Insurance Regulatory Commission (银保监会) risk notice in 2021 also told elders to consult family before buying wealth products. One experiment enrolled 116 people aged 65–85 and 115 aged 30–40. Researchers used a win/loss game to stir some people's emotions, then showed exaggerated ads. Those whose emotions were stirred wanted to buy more. Regardless of arousal, elders wanted to buy more than younger adults. Authors advise waiting until emotions settle before spending. Another experiment enrolled people previously cheated by mail fraud, mostly older. Without prior warning, nearly half agreed outright to a simulated telemarketing scam call. With a reminder call two to four weeks ahead, far fewer agreed outright. Agreeing on “I need to go home and talk with my family” gives the elder an exit without deciding on the spot.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because neither experiment tested this exact sentence. One tested buying urge when emotional; one tested whether advance warning helps—no study compared fraud rates for elders who had this line ready. Use together with entry 3 (separate account and two-person rule). Do fall-prevention fixes at home too—see Section 1. The line is a face-saving exit, not a way to control them. When surrounded by sales staff, speaking up to refuse in front of a room is often harder than judging whether the pitch is true.

## 5. Do not touch any "invest in elder care" pitch that makes the elder pay first: a card, a bed, an elder apartment, travel elder care, and selling elder products are the same illegal fund-raising

**Cost**. No cost. Read the labels below to the elder once. It takes a few minutes. After that, refuse on the spot: do not go to the lecture, do not go on the tour of the site, and do not leave a phone number. The hard part is that if the elder has already gone several times and gotten to know the people, they are harder to talk back out of it.

**In plain terms**. Elder-care labels that make the elder pay first and promise a return are all the same scam. Common ones are buying a card, buying a bed, buying an elder apartment, travel elder care, and selling elder products at a meeting. Under the rules, if this money is lost, you can only bear it yourself. A reported case took 136000000 yuan by pre-booking beds in an elder apartment and harmed more than 2100 people.

**Benefit**. The Ministry of Civil Affairs (民政部) lists five forms. Recognizing the label is more reliable than recognizing the person. The first is borrowing the name of an elder-care service agency: there is no real operation, they rent a site for a short time, and they claim a cooperation agreement with an elder-care home so they can trade on its name. The second is in the name of providing "elder-care services": they sell a "VIP card," a "membership card," or a "prepaid card," and have people prepay "elder-care service fees." The service they promise clearly exceeds the beds they can supply. The third is in the name of investing in an "elder-care project." Common labels are buying a stake in a wellness and elder-care base, and selling a fictional elder apartment. There is also long-term rental of elder-care beds, and "time bank" mutual-aid elder care. The cover is sales that promise to return the principal, leaseback after the sale, and an agreed repurchase. The fourth is in the name of selling "elder products": repurchase of goods, consignment sale, consumption rebates, free checkups, gifts, conference marketing, wellness lectures, and expert free clinics. The fifth is in the name of enjoying "travel elder care": cheap or free travel, stored-value rebates, and points-based elder care. The money cannot be got back. The regulation says so. Article 25 of the Regulations on Prevention and Disposal of Illegal Fund-raising (防范和处置非法集资条例) says, "Losses suffered from taking part in illegal fund-raising shall be borne by the participants themselves." Lost money can only be borne by the person who put it in. In officially reported cases, Dai and others illegally raised 136000000 yuan in the name of pre-booking beds in an elder apartment, with more than 2100 victims. Dai was sentenced to 15 years for fund-raising fraud and fined 400000 yuan. Cao, in the name of investing in the elder-care industry, committed fund-raising fraud of 13207000000 yuan, involving more than 110000 people. Cao was sentenced to life imprisonment, deprivation of political rights for life, and confiscation of all personal property. Conference sales of health

products were prosecuted as fraud. Ni used free banquets, gifts, and a car to pick people up and drop them off, and pulled elders in to hear lectures. The lecturers used "a fake persona, fake cases, and an inflated price cut" to invent cancer-prevention and cancer-fighting effects. Elders were induced to buy "dihydroquercetin" (二氢槲皮素) at tens of times the cost price. Sales were more than 620000 yuan. Ni was sentenced to 10 years and 3 months and fined 120000 yuan (nationwide; the regulations took effect on 2021-05-01).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The judgment does not rest on "this place looks legitimate." It rests on "did they make you pay first, and did they promise a return." An elder-care home sells services. Once the talk adds investment, a rebate, or getting the principal back, do not trust it. An elder being taken to a lecture, a trip, or a free clinic is not itself illegal, and it is hard to stop. The step you can stop is the payment, used together with the two-person confirmation rule in item 3. If money has already been paid, immediately follow section 8, item 2 and call 110 or 96110 to ask for a payment stop. At the same time, report it to the local lead department for handling illegal fund-raising. Housing-for-pension is a different path: see item 6 (housing reverse mortgage insurance). The cap on deposits and membership fees at a legitimate nursing home, and the account that receives them, are in item 11 (a deposit of at most 12 months of bed fees). If a cheap tour took people into a shop and they bought something, see section 5, item 50 (a tour group taken into a shop).

## 6. Except insurers' housing reverse mortgage insurance, avoid all other “housing-for-pension” pitches; never mortgage the home to buy wealth products

**Cost**. No cost. Keep the property deed at home; do not hand it to anyone pitching “housing-for-pension” (以房养老). Show mortgage, guarantee, and loan contracts to your children before signing. Hard when door-to-door promoters are warm and keep coming back—the elder feels rude saying no.

**In plain terms**. The only legitimate housing-for-pension arrangement is insurers' housing reverse mortgage insurance (住房反向抵押养老保险), and it is still a pilot. The “housing-for-pension” that scammers describe is unrelated to it: they trick the elder into mortgaging the house, then using the borrowed money to buy the wealth products they recommend. Some people did not even know the house had been mortgaged. In the end the house was gone and they still owed the loan.

**Benefit**. The former CBIRC Consumer Protection Bureau (银保监会消保局) separated real from fake. The real product is “housing reverse mortgage insurance for older persons.” Elders with full legal title mortgage the home to the insurer; they keep living in it, using it, and collecting rent. Sale or disposal needs the mortgagee (insurer) to agree. They receive pension payments under the contract until death. The business remains pilot-scale with few participants. Fraudsters' “housing-for-pension” is “completely unrelated” to the state pilot and is “using national policy as cover to promote illegal fund-raising.” The method is tricking elders into mortgage, then buying recommended products—“often a Ponzi scheme of paying old debts with new money.” The notice quotes consequences: “Some participants did not even know their property was mortgaged; they ultimately lost the house and still owed the loan.” It also gives yield lines: “If a wealth product promises returns above 6%, question it; above 8% is very dangerous; above 10%, prepare to lose all principal; ‘guaranteed high yield' is financial fraud.” The same notice requires careful contract signing and not signing blank contracts (nationwide, June 2021).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because these lines come from regulator risk notices and judgment, not research. The 6%, 8%, and 10% lines are consumer reference points, not statutory thresholds. CBIRC was merged into the National Administration of Financial Regulation (国家金融监督管理总局); the original page may be unavailable—provincial financial regulator reposts are cited. Wealth loss is secondary; after the home is mortgaged the elder may still owe a large loan—loss exceeds principal. General rules on signing and blank contracts: Section 8 entry 17. After fraud: payment stop, Section 8 entry 2.

## 7. If an elder at home is bedbound long term or severely disabled, apply for long-term care insurance at the yibao office where they are enrolled; it is not paid only to the elderly

**Cost**. Submit an application at the yibao office where the person is enrolled (医保 — basic medical insurance). Then have a disability-level assessment. If they pass on the first assessment, the fund pays the assessment fee. You do not pay it yourself.

**In plain terms**. Long-term care insurance pays care-service fees and generally does not pay cash directly. If someone at home is severely disabled and has been so for half a year or more, apply at the yibao office where they are enrolled. Care fees have no deductible (起付线), so reimbursement is not held back until a set amount has been paid first. Employee enrollees get about 70% back. Urban and rural resident enrollees get about 50% back. Bed fees and meal fees are not covered. The document sets no age floor. A young person with severe disability can apply too.

**Benefit**. Long-term care service fees that meet the rules have no deductible (起付线). A deductible is a sum you pay yourself before reimbursement starts. Here you do not pay that sum first. People enrolled under the employee policy are reimbursed by the fund at about 70%. People enrolled under the policy for urban and rural residents who are not employed are reimbursed at about 50%. The most that can be paid in a year (the annual payment cap (年度最高支付限额)) is no more than 50% of the previous year's per-capita disposable income of urban and rural residents in the local pooling area. The people who can receive benefits are those who are enrolled and paying as required, whose disability has generally lasted more than 6 months, and who pass an assessment after they apply. At the start, severe disability is covered first. The document sets no age floor. A person under 18 who is not working is enrolled with their parents and, if eligible, receives benefits at the urban and rural resident rate. The fund mainly pays care institutions and care workers. In principle it does not pay cash directly to the disabled person. Institutional bed fees, meal fees, and other charges that are not care are not paid by the fund.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Disability must be "long-term and continuous (generally 6 months or more)." A few weeks in hospital is not enough to apply. If the person was not enrolled when the local program started and enrolled later, or enrolled again after a gap in payment, there is a waiting period before benefits, in principle 6 months. Bed fees, meal fees, and other charges that are not care are not paid by long-term care insurance. Medical costs that yibao should pay are not paid by long-term care insurance either. Someone already receiving a work-injury living-care benefit does not receive this on top. This money and the care subsidy inside the two disability subsidies (两项补贴) are two procedures and two sums of money. They do not conflict. See section 7, item 8 (the two subsidies). Care at home and in the community gets a more favorable reimbursement rate. The person does not have to move into an institution. The program is rolling out place by place, and the disability assessment standards differ. Call 12393 first, or the medical insurance handler where the person is enrolled, and ask whether it has started locally and how to book an assessment. If the assessment fails, do not give up. Apply again after the disability gets worse.

## 8. If someone at home is bedbound long term, treat pressure ulcers as the first enemy: an electric air mattress, turning on a schedule, and a daily look at the places where bone sticks out

**Cost**. A home electric alternating-pressure air mattress starts at a few hundred yuan. A turn takes only a few minutes. The hard part is turning every 2 to 3 hours, including at night. One caregiver cannot keep that up alone.

**In plain terms**. For elders who already had a pressure ulcer before hip-fracture surgery, the chance of dying within 30 days was about 20% higher. Switching to an electric air mattress cut new pressure ulcers by about 60%. In an intensive care unit (ICU), using a sensor reminder so that turning on time actually happened cut them by about 70%, while laying the person face down produced far more pressure ulcers. Look once a day at

the sacrum, heels, hips, and the shoulders and back. If you find red that does not fade when pressed, find a nurse or a doctor that same day.

**Benefit**. 19520 patients who had hip-fracture surgery (U.S. NSQIP, National Surgical Quality Improvement Program, 2016 to 2019). People who already had a pressure ulcer before surgery had a higher share of deaths within 30 days. After other factors were taken into account, the link still held (OR 1.2, a 21% increase in the odds, P=0.004). They were also more likely to have other problems: deep-vein thrombosis (OR 1.59), pneumonia (OR 1.39), and unplanned readmission (OR 1.43). The average hospital stay was also 0.4 days longer. 324 hospitalized elders (mean age 86) were followed for a median of 18 months. A pressure ulcer on its own predicted long-term death (HR 1.500, 95% CI 1.059 to 2.126, P=0.020). "On its own" means that after other factors are set aside, it still predicts. 65 randomized trials were pooled (a network meta-analysis). They compared a powered active air support surface with a standard hospital mattress (a standard hospital support surface). A powered active air support surface is the electric air-mattress type. People using one had a lower rate of pressure ulcers (RR 0.42, 95% CI 0.29 to 0.63, moderate certainty). A powered hybrid air support surface was RR 0.22 (0.07 to 0.66). A Cochrane review of 11 trials and 4462 people, updated in 2026, compared turning every 2 hours with turning every 4 hours. The difference was unclear (RR 1.05, 95% CI 0.79 to 1.39, very low certainty). Comparisons among other turning intervals were equally uncertain. In a trial of 1226 intensive-care patients, wearable sensors that reminded staff in real time and gave a visual alert made turning every 2 hours actually happen. The pressure-ulcer rate was lower than usual care (RR 0.28, 95% CI 0.10 to 0.75, moderate certainty). In a trial of 116 people, the prone group (lying face down) had a higher pressure-ulcer rate than the supine group (lying flat) (RR 4.55, 95% CI 2.31 to 8.98).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The grade is B for three reasons. First, the two studies of mortality only saw that people who already had pressure ulcers later did worse. That is not the same as showing that preventing pressure ulcers brings mortality down. Second, the randomized trials on turning intervals are very uncertain. Third, the air-mattress evidence is firmer, but the studies compared mattresses on hospital beds, and applying that to a mattress at home is an extrapolation. Looking every day at the sacrum, heels, hips, and the shoulders and back, for red that does not fade when pressed, is ordinary nursing practice. There is no separate study of it. Care that long-term care insurance can pay for is in item 7. If a leg suddenly swells, treat it as deep-vein thrombosis: section 13, item 11. The stretch of long bed rest after a fall or a serious injury is in section 1, item 34.

## 9. If cataracts already affect walking, get an ophthalmology workup for surgery; if both eyes are affected, do not delay the second eye too long

**Cost**. Accompany the elder to ophthalmology once; the doctor decides whether to operate. One eye per surgery; many hospitals do day surgery and discharge the same day. If both eyes have cataracts, operate in two separate procedures. Out-of-pocket cost depends on intraocular lens (IOL) choice and local basic medical insurance (医保) reimbursement—ask before surgery.

**In plain terms**. In women aged 70+, having first-eye cataract surgery sooner cut falls over the next year by about 34%; fewer people fractured bones. The number who fell at least once did not drop. Second-eye surgery showed no clear fall difference. Operated patients had about 16% lower hip fracture over one year.

**Benefit**. Randomized trial of 306 women aged 70+ with cataracts. Half had first-eye surgery within about 4 weeks; half waited 12 months per usual care. Over one year, early surgery cut fall counts by about 34%. Rate ratio 0.66, 95% CI 0.45 to 0.96. At least one fall: surgery group 49%, wait group 45%—no reduction. Two or more falls: surgery 18%, wait 25%. Fractures: surgery group 4 (3%), wait group 12 (8%). Cochrane included this trial: first-eye surgery in women reduced fall counts; second-eye surgery did not. Second-eye randomized trial, 239 women aged 70+: surgery group fall rate 32% lower but difference may be chance (rate ratio 0.68, 95% CI 0.39 to 1.19). U.S. Medicare 5% sample: 1,113,640 cataract patients aged 65+ (2002–2009), observational only. Surgery associated with about 16% lower one-year hip fracture odds (OR 0.84, 95% CI 0.81 to 0.87). Absolute difference 0.20 percentage points—about 2 fewer cases per 1,000 people.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Controversy: pooled across two randomized trials, the number who fell at least once did not fall significantly (OR 0.81, 95% CI 0.55 to 1.17). Western Australia all-population hospital records: in the year after first-eye surgery, fall-injury admissions rose 27%; between the two surgeries such admissions were 2.14× the pre-surgery rate. Before–after designs cannot separate surgery from aging. Another Australian cohort found fall counts dropped most after second-eye surgery—so if both eyes have cataracts, do not delay the second eye too long. Between the two surgeries, be extra careful walking and on stairs. Cochrane also included a vision-intervention trial where fall counts rose about 57%. Surgery fixes clarity; fewer falls still need Section 1 entry 13 (balance and leg strength). Whether bones survive a fall: Section 1 entry 39 (bone density testing) and entry 40 (treat osteoporosis if found). National eye health planning states cataract restoration surgery is widely available at county level—not only big-city hospitals. Main beneficiaries: your parents and grandparents.

## 10. When an elder walks the dog, hold the leash in the palm, do not wrap it around the hand, keep the leash short, and train the dog not to lunge forward on the leash

**Cost**. Holding the leash and keeping it short costs nothing. Walk with the elder and show them once. Training the dog not to lunge takes time. You can teach the dog yourself or hire a trainer. Hiring someone costs money, and prices differ a lot by place. The hard part is that the elder is used to a retractable leash and used to wrapping the leash around the wrist, and has to change that.

**In plain terms**. In the United States, fractures among people aged 65 and over while walking a dog were about 1700 in 2004 and about 4400 in 2017. About 80% were women, nearly 30% needed a hospital stay, and by single body site hip fractures were the most common. At a hand-surgery clinic, about three-quarters of patients whose hands were injured by a dog leash were hurt because the leash was wrapped on the hand and the dog pulled. So hold the leash in the palm, keep it short, and train the dog not to lunge forward.

**Benefit**. U.S. emergency surveillance data, scaled up to the whole country, counted fractures in people aged 65 and over who fell while walking a dog on a leash. There were about 1671 in 2004 and about 4396 in 2017, and the rise was statistically significant. Among the people with fractures, 78.6% were women, and 28.7% were hospitalized. By single body site, the hip was the most common, at 17.3%. By broad region, the upper limb was the most common, at 52.1%. Another national emergency dataset covers 2001 to 2018. Injuries related to a dog leash were estimated at about 360000 visits (exact figure 356746). Of those, 193483 visits were injuries from being pulled by a dog, and 136767 visits were trips or entanglement in the leash. Injuries per million people rose from 25.4 to 105.5. A hand-surgery clinic saw 443 patients with hand injuries from a dog leash over 5 years. About three-quarters were injuries to the hand or fingers from the leash wrapping and the dog pulling (the abstract says 337 people, 75.9%). About a fifth needed surgery (96 people, 21.6%). The U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention counted about 86629 fall-injury visits a year from 2001 to 2006 that were related to cats and dogs. Of those, 88.0% were related to dogs. Among the dog-related falls, 26% happened while walking the dog, and 21.2% were the dog pushing or pulling the person down.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Holding the leash in the palm and not wrapping it on the hand is advice from the doctors at that hand-surgery clinic. They state that this protects the fingers and the wrist. It does not stop a person being pulled down when the dog lunges. They also suggest keeping the leash short: on a short leash the dog cannot build speed, so the pull is lighter; on a long leash the line also catches on things and trips people. A retractable leash let all the way out is a long leash. No study has compared retractable leashes with ordinary leashes for which one leads to more falls. A 2024 review states that there are no data on what kind of leash was in use at the time of injury. Training the dog not to lunge forward on the leash is mentioned both by the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention and by the authors of the fracture paper. That fracture paper also suggests that an elder who is thinking of getting a dog pick a smaller dog. No study has calculated how many fewer falls these steps produce, so the benefit magnitude is judged small. Whether the bones can take a fall: section 1, item 39 (a bone-density test) and section 1, item 40 (if osteoporosis is found, treat it). Balance practice: section 1, item 13 (balance and leg strength). Whether walking the dog counts as exercise: section 2,

item 44 (count dog walking toward the walking total). The people who benefit are mainly your parents and grandparents.

## 11. Before sending an elder to a nursing home, check that it is registered with the civil affairs bureau and sign a written agreement; the deposit is at most 12 months of bed fees and must go into a dedicated bank account

**Cost**. No cost. Before signing, call the local county civil affairs bureau (民政), or ask the nursing home for its registration receipt. Then compare the agreement, the fee sheet, and the account that receives the money. Half a day is enough. The hard part is that when beds are scarce, the family feels awkward picking at the contract.

**In plain terms**. A legitimate nursing home has to register with the civil affairs bureau and sign a written agreement with you. The deposit is at most 12 months of bed fees, and service fees may be collected at most 12 months ahead. The deposit and membership fees must go into a dedicated account the home holds at a bank. If they go over the cap, ask you to transfer to a personal account, or give a receipt and no invoice, do not pay yet.

**Benefit**. The Ministry of Civil Affairs (民政部) measures for the administration of elder-care institutions say that within 10 working days after a home takes an elder in, it must register with the civil affairs bureau. If the papers are complete, the bureau issues a registration receipt. The home must sign a service agreement with the elder or their agent, stating the care level, the fee schedule, refunds, and liability for breach. If they do not sign an agreement, the bureau orders correction and issues a warning; in a serious case the fine is up to 30000 yuan. A 2024 document from 7 departments, including the Ministry of Civil Affairs, set caps on prepaid fees. Elder-care service fees may be collected at most 12 months ahead. The deposit is at most 12 times that elder's monthly bed fee. The deposit may be used only for refunds, advancing the cost of sudden medical care, offsetting unpaid fees, and compensation. Public homes, and homes that were built with public funds and are privately run, may not charge a membership fee. A home that is not yet built, or that cannot yet take elders in, may not charge a membership fee either. The deposit and membership fees must all be placed in a dedicated deposit account under third-party custody at a bank. They may not be collected into a personal account. When money is received, an invoice must be issued. A receipt may not stand in for an invoice. If the elder cancels before moving in, the home must return the prepaid money promptly. If the elder has moved in, deduct what has already been used and, in principle, refund the rest in one payment through the original channel. This document took effect on 2024-10-01. Provinces may set stricter rules. The 2025 custody guidelines require that after the home applies for a refund, the custodian bank pay it the same day, or the next day at the latest, in one payment back through the original channel.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A province may set a shorter cap on the deposit and a shorter period for prepaying service fees. Check that province's rules before signing. The agreement can follow the model elder-care service contract issued by that province's civil affairs bureau and market supervision administration. The model-contract library of the State Administration for Market Regulation (市场监管总局) has them. Registration is done after the home starts taking elders in. A home that just opened may still be filing. Ask when it will be registered. If a refund cannot be agreed, the document's path is negotiation, mediation, a complaint, arbitration, or a lawsuit. A complaint goes to the civil affairs bureau that supervises the home, and it is free. If you go to court, a first-instance ordinary procedure starts at 6 months, and you pay the lawyer yourself. If they promised, when taking the money, to return principal with interest or to pay a return, that is no longer ordinary prepayment. See item 5 (investing in elder care). The people who benefit are mainly your parents and grandparents. The prepaid-fee caps are written from the documents as of 2026-10.

## 12. If a parent of an only child is in hospital, check whether your province's regulations give the child care leave; if they do, apply to the employer in writing with the hospital certificate

**Cost**. No cost. Search the national database of laws and regulations for your province's two ordinances. It takes a little over 10 minutes. Then submit a written application to the employer with the hospital certificate. The hard part is that the employer does not want to give the leave, and asking feels like it will offend the boss.

**In plain terms**. Some provinces set care leave so an only child can look after a parent in hospital, and the number of days differs by province. Henan is at least 20 days a year. Fujian is at most 10 days. Guangdong, when the parent is in hospital, is at most 15 days. Henan states that the leave counts as attendance. Fujian states that wages and benefits stay the same. If the employer refuses or docks pay, Fujian and Guangdong state that you can go to the human resources and social security department.

**Benefit**. Provinces put care leave in different local regulations. The Henan Provincial Regulations on the Protection of the Rights and Interests of the Elderly say that when an elder who holds the honorary certificate for parents of an only child (独生子女父母光荣证) is in hospital, the child's employer must give care leave. The leave is at least 20 days a year in total, and it counts as attendance. The Fujian Provincial Regulations on the Protection of the Rights and Interests of the Elderly say that when a parent of an only child is 60 or older and is in hospital with an illness, the employer must give the child time for care. That time is at most 10 days a year in total, and wages and benefits stay the same. If the employer does not pay wages and benefits for the care period, the human resources and social security department (人社) or the relevant department orders payment by a deadline. The Guangdong Provincial Regulations on Population and Family Planning cover couples with Guangdong hukou (户口 — household registration) who, in the years when the state encouraged one couple to have one child, voluntarily had only one child. When they turn 60, the employer gives the child 5 days of care leave a year. If they are ill and in hospital, the total is at most 15 days a year. If the employer does not provide the leave the regulations require, the human resources and social security department at county level or above orders correction. The liability chapter of the Henan regulations does not say what happens if the employer does not give the care leave.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. To check your province: on the National Laws and Regulations Database (flk.npc.gov.cn), search the province name plus the regulations on the protection of the rights and interests of the elderly (老年人权益保障条例), and the province name plus the population and family planning regulations (人口与计划生育条例). Read both. Read only the version marked "in force" (有效). If the province has not written it, search the city's regulations. Provinces give this only to an only child. Someone with brothers or sisters is mostly outside the text. If the employer will not give the leave or has docked wages, call 12333 or file a labor-inspection complaint at the human resources and social security bureau (人社局). It is free. To get the docked money back, you can also apply for labor arbitration. It is free. The case is closed within 45 days after acceptance, and may be extended by at most another 15 days. Henan's text says "at least" 20 days. Fujian and Guangdong say "at most." Giving fewer days in Fujian or Guangdong is not a violation. The grade is B because each province sets the number of days and the conditions. The people who benefit are your parents. The money falls on you. The day counts for the three provinces are taken from the regulations as of 2026-10 and may be revised later.

## 13. When an elder's memory keeps getting worse and daily life starts to slip, take them to a memory clinic or neurology for one check, and first rule out depression, medicines, and poor hearing or vision, causes that can be changed

**Cost**. A visit to a memory clinic or neurology, with a cognitive test, a blood draw, and a urine test, takes half a day to a day. Fees follow the local schedule. Yibao (医保 — basic medical insurance) reimburses according to the rules. The hard part is that the elder does not admit they are confused and does not want to go.

**In plain terms**. Memory that keeps getting worse is not necessarily just muddled old age. First check for depression, medicines that do not suit them, and poor hearing or vision, causes that can be changed. Very few cases can actually be cured. Among people with dementia, those who truly improve are under 1%. Checking early has another use: while the elder can still decide for themselves, settle who will manage their money and their medical care later.

**Benefit**. The UK NICE dementia guideline (NG97) requires that, when dementia is suspected, the history be taken from the person and from family who know them. It also requires a physical exam, blood and urine tests to rule out causes that can be reversed, and a cognitive test. The guideline names four things to check first: delirium (sudden confusion that comes in spells), depression, poor vision or hearing, and medicines with a heavy anticholinergic load. If those are ruled out and dementia is still suspected, refer the person to a specialist service such as a memory clinic for a diagnosis. A 2003 meta-analysis pooled 39 studies, of which 5620 people had a confirmed dementia diagnosis. Alzheimer disease accounted for 56.3%, and vascular disease for 20.3%. Causes that might be reversed accounted for 9%. Those who truly improved were only 0.6%: partial improvement 0.29%, full improvement 0.31%. The same NICE guideline requires an early discussion with the patient and the family about arrangements made in advance. That includes authorizing someone else to manage health and money, and the person's wishes for future care. A 2024 action plan by 15 departments, including the National Health Commission (国家卫健委), calls for pushing a first cognitive screen for people aged 65 and over, and encourages hospitals to set up memory clinics.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The benefit magnitude is set to small, because very little that is found can truly be reversed, and no study shows that checking early makes a person live longer. The grade is B because the workup comes from a guideline and the figures only show the share that can be reversed. The studies in that meta-analysis run through 2002. The share today may be lower. If a medicine is making the person confused, do not stop it on your own. Take the medicine box and ask the doctor. Becoming sluggish and unsteady on the feet a few weeks after a knock on the head is a different matter: section 13, item 10 (a head CT, computed tomography, after a knock on the head). For hearing loss, fit a hearing aid: section 33, item 17 (hearing aids). While the elder is still lucid, do item 1 (name a future guardian in writing) and item 2 (the will). If they can no longer manage their own affairs, apply to a court for a finding: section 33, item 18 (apply to a court for a finding). The people who benefit are mainly your parents and grandparents.

# 18. Is raising a child worth it?

This section breaks down the financial and time costs involved. Much like Section 10, which examined the costs of marriage, we're simply laying out the numbers here — without offering any definitive conclusions. If you're already pregnant and need to follow the necessary steps, please refer to Section 27. There are 18 key considerations to keep in mind when deciding whether raising a child is worthwhile.

## 1. Start by counting what you can claim: the national childcare subsidy is 3600 yuan per child per year until age 3, and the individual income tax special additional deduction is 2000 yuan per child per month

**Cost**. It costs nothing. Apply for the subsidy where the child's hukou (户口 — household registration) is registered; a single visit finishes it. Fill in the tax deduction in the Individual Income Tax app on your phone, or have your employer fill it in.

**In plain terms**. A child under 3 can receive 3600 yuan a year in childcare subsidy, and it is not taxed. A child born before 2025 is paid for the months that remain. Separately, from the child's birth until full-time schooling ends, 2000 yuan per child per month can be taken off a parent's taxable income. If a single parent takes the whole deduction, someone in the 3% bracket pays 720 yuan less for the year, and someone in the 10% bracket pays 2400 yuan less.

**Benefit**. The plan issued by the General Office of the CPC Central Committee and the General Office of the State Council provides: from January 1, 2025, a subsidy is paid for infants and toddlers under 3, until they turn 3, at 3600 yuan per child per year. A child born before January 1, 2025 who is still under 3 is paid for the months that qualify. Either parent, or another guardian, applies. The subsidy is "exempt from individual income tax." When dibao (低保 — means-tested minimum subsistence allowance) and similar assistance are assessed, it "does not count as household or individual income." 3600 yuan is the "national baseline," and "funds needed for a local increase are borne by the local budget." The plan also provides that "governments below the county level may not set their own childcare-subsidy policy or standard." A provincial or municipal government that wants another childcare subsidy, or a higher standard, files it for the record with the competent department at the level above. On the tax side, the State Council in 2022 created a deduction for care of children under 3. In 2023 it raised that deduction together with the children's-education deduction; from January 1, 2023, both are 2000 yuan per child per month. The children's-education deduction covers the time from when the child turns 3 until primary school, and also full-time academic education from primary school through a doctorate. Parents "may choose to have either of them deduct 100% of the standard, or each deduct 50%." Once chosen, it cannot be changed during that year. Worked example: for a child, the deduction is 2000 yuan times 12 months, 24000 yuan in a year. If a single parent takes all of it, that person pays 720 yuan less in the 3% bracket and 2400 yuan less in the 10% bracket. If it is split, each deducts 12000 yuan, and pays 360 yuan less in the 3% bracket and 1200 yuan less in the 10% bracket. The bracket is based on taxable income for the whole year: 3% on the part that does not exceed 36000 yuan, and 10% on the part above 36000 yuan up to 144000 yuan.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This is the national baseline. The plan allows a provincial or municipal government to raise the standard or to issue another childcare subsidy; a government below the county level cannot issue its own. Whether your area adds more, and how to claim it, is in your province's implementation plan. Added up over 3 years, it is 10800 yuan, only a small piece of the cost of raising a child. Do not treat it as the reason to have a child or not. If the tax deduction was not filled in during the year, it can still be added at the year-end reconciliation; see Section 5, item 2 (individual income tax reconciliation). Someone whose taxable income for the whole year is already 0 pays no less after the deduction. If the deduction crosses a bracket, the tax saved falls between the figures from the brackets. If both parents pay tax, having the parent in the higher bracket take the whole deduction saves the household more.

## 2. Maternity leave is 98 days; the maternity allowance is paid by the maternity insurance fund at the employer's average monthly wage for the prior year; the father's paternity leave and both parents' parental leave follow the provincial regulation

**Cost**. It costs nothing. Your employer files the claim; you do not have to make the trip yourself.

**In plain terms**. Having a child comes with at least 98 days of maternity leave, with more days added for a difficult birth or a multiple birth. During that time the maternity insurance fund pays the maternity allowance. If your employer did not enroll you in maternity insurance, the employer pays it. The father's paternity leave, and parental leave for both parents, follow your province's regulation. In Beijing, paternity leave is 15 days, and until the child turns 3 each parent gets 5 working days of parental leave a year.

**Benefit**. The number of maternity-leave days is set by the State Council. "Female employees are entitled to 98 days of maternity leave, of which 15 days may be taken before the birth; a difficult birth adds 15 days; for a multiple birth, each additional 1 baby adds 15 days." The money paid during maternity leave is the maternity allowance. For someone already in maternity insurance, it is "paid by the maternity insurance fund at the standard of the employer's average monthly wage for employees in the prior year." If you are not enrolled, the employer pays you at the wage you had before the leave. The father's paternity leave, and parental leave for both parents, are set by each province's population and family planning regulation. Beijing: the mother gets another 60 days of extended maternity leave, and the father gets 15 days of paternity leave. Until the child turns 3, the couple "each receive 5 working days of parental leave a year," and wages must not be cut during that leave. Shanghai: the mother gets another 60 days of maternity leave, and the father gets 10 days of paternity leave. Until the child turns 3, "each of them may take 5 days of parental leave a year," paid as for a normal day at work. Guangdong: the mother gets 80 days of reward leave, and the father gets 15 days of paternity leave. While the child is under 3, each parent gets 10 days of parental leave a year, and wages are paid as usual during the leave. Sichuan, the 2025 edition: the mother gets 90 days of extended maternity leave, and the father gets 30 days of nursing leave. While the child is under 3, the couple each get 10 working days of parental leave a year, and the leave counts as attendance. In 2024 the General Office of the State Council required localities to make sure that "maternity leave, childbirth reward leave, paternity leave, parental leave, and other leave for having a child are actually granted."

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. 98 days is the national minimum. The regulations of the 4 provinces above each add another 60 to 90 days of childbirth reward leave, for a total of 158 to 188 days. How many days another province adds is in that province's regulation. Which side pays wages during the reward leave differs by province. To check your own province, search the National Laws and Regulations Database (flk.npc.gov.cn) for the province name plus "population and family planning regulation," and use the version marked in force. In some provinces paternity leave is called nursing leave. Parental leave is counted in working days in some provinces and in calendar days in others. The day counts for the 4 provinces above are taken from the regulations as of October 2026, and they may be revised later.

## 3. Know this: an employer may not cut your pay or dismiss you for pregnancy, childbirth, or breastfeeding

**Cost**. It costs nothing.

**In plain terms**. If your employer cuts your pay or fires you because you are pregnant, gave birth, or are breastfeeding, that is illegal. While the child is under 1 year old, you get 1 hour a day to breastfeed, and the employer also may not assign you overtime or night shifts. A violation of that is fined 1000 to 5000 yuan per person. How to claim is in Section 19.

**Benefit**. The State Council provides: "An employer may not, because a female employee is pregnant, gives birth, or is breastfeeding, reduce her wages, dismiss her, or end her labor or employment contract." During these 3 periods the employer cannot pay you less, and cannot dismiss you or end the contract. While you are

breastfeeding an infant under 1 year old, you have 1 hour of breastfeeding time each day. The employer also may not extend your working hours or assign a night shift. Overtime or a night shift during breastfeeding is fined not less than 1000 yuan and not more than 5000 yuan per person. For a pay cut or a dismissal, this regulation sets no fine. Someone dismissed illegally goes to labor arbitration and asks to be reinstated or paid compensation.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If you are in fact dismissed illegally, the path for a claim is in Section 19. The evidence that matters is the written notice of a transfer or a pay cut, and the chat record. Keep both.

## 4. Count the time cost of raising a child by whose time is taken up, not by how hard it feels

**Cost**. It costs no money. What it costs is time. Before a child turns 3, that time is basically taken up for the whole day. The hard part is that it is like this every day. You cannot grit your teeth for a few days and be done.

**In plain terms**. Turn the hours spent watching the child each day, and the number of times you are woken at night, into time. Then multiply by the hourly wage of the person doing the work. The figure is usually far larger than the money spent on formula and diapers. So it is better to agree the split before the child is born.

**Benefit**. Turn the time spent watching the child each day, and the number of times you are woken at night, into hours. Then multiply by the hourly wage of the person doing that work. The figure is usually far larger than the money spent on formula and diapers. Watching the child, cooking, and getting up at night are unpaid, and they still go into the cost the same way. The method is the same as the housework calculation in Section 10. Agree the split first, then decide whether to have a child.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The figure does not need to be exact. What helps is both of you, before the birth, talking through the split against the same sheet, so you are not arguing after the birth. If you go back to work after the birth and the employer transfers you or cuts your pay, how to respond is in Section 19, item 23 (do not agree to a transfer and a pay cut).

## 5. Split the money into 3 stretches: ages 0 to 3, compulsory education, and after compulsory education

**Cost**. There is no fixed sum. It varies widely by city and by how the child is cared for. The hard part is sitting down and calculating the 3 stretches separately, instead of naming a figure by feel.

**In plain terms**. Money from ages 0 to 3 is mostly about how the child is cared for: you, grandparents, or someone you hire. From primary school through junior high, it is mostly housing and spending outside school. After that, it is mostly the path through the next level of school. The 3 stretches are spent in completely different ways. Adding them together only produces a frightening total.

**Benefit**. The large part from ages 0 to 3 is how the child is cared for: you, grandparents, or someone you hire. During compulsory education (primary school through junior high), the large part is housing and spending outside school. After that, the large part is the path through the next level of school. These 3 stretches of money are spent in completely different places. Added together, they only produce a frightening total.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. First count the money you can definitely receive: the childcare subsidy, the maternity allowance, and yibao (医保 — basic medical insurance) reimbursement. Then see how much is still short. Do not decide from the online claim that raising a child costs so-and-so many tens of thousands of yuan. That kind of figure has no clear scope. You do not know what it counted and what it left out.

## 6. Keep a separate account for having a child for your elders, for the marriage, and for old age

**Cost**. It costs no money. What it costs is 1 serious conversation. The hard part is saying it plainly, without talking around it.

**In plain terms**. Someone else wanting you to have a child can be a factor you weigh. The time and the money, though, are on your own account. "Raising a child to provide for your old age" needs its own line, because it bets on another person's means and willingness 20 years later. Also write down the consequences of not having a child, and compare the sides.

**Benefit**. The approach is the same as in Section 10. Other people's expectations can be a factor you weigh. The cost goes on your own account, not on theirs. "Raising a child to provide for your old age" especially needs its own line, because it assumes another person's means and willingness 20 years later.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Write down the consequences of not having a child, and set them next to the consequences of having a child. An account written on only a single side is not an account.

## 7. If you plan to wait a few more years to have a child, count the woman's age first: around 40, the chance of conceiving without treatment and the success rate of in vitro fertilization both fall markedly

**Cost**. It costs no money. What it costs is 1 serious conversation. The hard part is putting having a child, work, and buying a home on the same timeline, instead of only pushing the birth later.

**In plain terms**. The older the woman is, the harder it is to conceive without treatment. Just past 40, the chance of conceiving in a given month is only about half the chance just past 30. After a pregnancy starts, the share of pregnancies that miscarry also rises, to about a third at 40 to 44. Having the egg fertilized outside the body does not make up for that. At 43 and 44, only about 5% of embryo transfers end in a birth.

**Benefit**. For conceiving without treatment, a U.S. follow-up study looked at women aged 30 to 44, with no history of infertility, who had just started trying. Compared with ages 30 and 31, the chance of conceiving in a given month was about 53% lower at 40 and 41 (ratio 0.47, 95% CI 0.28-0.78), and about 59% lower at 42 to 44 (0.39, 0.16-0.93). At 38 and 39 it was about 30% lower (0.70, 0.48-1.01); the range just touches "no difference." Ages 32 and 33 did not differ from 30 and 31. Women who had never been pregnant had a lower chance at every age. In a similar Danish study, the chance for women aged 35 to 40 was 0.77 times the chance for women aged 20 to 24. The man's age matters much less: for men aged 35 to 39 the figure is 0.95. For miscarriage, Norwegian registry records of about 420000 pregnancies in 2009 to 2013 show the share was lowest at 25 to 29, at 9.8%. It was 10.8% at 30 to 34, 16.7% at 35 to 39, 32.2% at 40 to 44, and 53.6% at 45 and older. For the embryos' chromosomes, a U.S. fertility center tested 15169 in vitro fertilization embryos. Chromosomal abnormalities rose steadily with age after 26. Among people doing in vitro fertilization at 26 to 37, the share whose cultured embryos were all chromosomally abnormal was 2% to 6%; at 42 it was 33%, and at 44 it was 53%. For the success rate of in vitro fertilization, preliminary 2022 figures from the UK fertility regulator, using the woman's own eggs and a fresh embryo transfer, give the share of transfers that led to a birth as 35% at 18 to 34, 26% at 35 to 37, 18% at 38 and 39, 10% at 40 to 42, and 5% at 43 and 44. The domestic rule: the 2003 Ministry of Health Norms on Human Assisted Reproductive Technology state that it is "prohibited to provide human assisted reproductive technology to couples who do not meet the state population and family planning laws and regulations, or to single women." In 2024 the General Office of the State Council required localities to bring suitable assisted-reproduction procedures into yibao (医保 — basic medical insurance) reimbursement. In July 2025 the National Healthcare Security Administration said that all 31 provinces and the Xinjiang Production and Construction Corps had fully included assisted reproduction in reimbursement, and that in 2024 more than 1000000 person-times received the benefit.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This does not say who should have a child earlier or later. It only puts age on the table, next to the money account in item 5 and the time account in item 4. These are averages over a large group of people. For a particular person the gap can be large. To know your own situation, ask a reproductive clinic. A single woman cannot receive assisted reproductive technology at a regular hospital in China. Which in vitro fertilization items yibao reimburses, and how much, differs by province; ask the local healthcare security bureau. After you decide to have a child, what to do starts at Section 27, item 1 (take folic acid).

# 19. Employment, resignation, and work injury

This section is about money: how amounts are calculated, what you sign, and how deadlines run. The first three items cover pay you should receive while still employed; the next five cover leaving a job; the following seven cover occupational disease and work injury. Work-injury payouts are an order of magnitude larger than layoff compensation, and the deadlines are tighter. Damage from occupational disease cannot be undone. Nine more items close the section. The first four cover what to do if you are bullied at work, how to obtain a separation certificate, how personal income tax on severance is calculated, and how to transfer social insurance when you change cities. The middle three cover double wages when there is no written contract, when the employer fails to pay social insurance, and liquidated damages demanded on exit. The last two cover how to respond when the employer wants to reassign or cut pay, and who pays wages and damages for dispatched workers.

Items in this section are grouped by theme below; numbers in parentheses are item numbers.

**Contracts and pay while employed**: overtime pay (Item 1), annual leave (Item 2), probation (Item 3), double wages without a written labor contract (Item 20), unpaid or underpaid social insurance (Item 21), put disagreement with reassignment or pay cuts in writing (Item 23), equal pay for equal work when dispatched (Item 24), long-term bullying at work (Item 16).

**Leaving and layoffs**: calculate N first when laid off (Item 4), no 30-day prior notice (Item 5), damages for unlawful termination (Item 6), do not sign “resignation for personal reasons” (Item 7), save evidence before leaving (Item 8), separation certificate (Item 17), individual income tax on severance (Item 18), liquidated damages demanded on exit (Item 22), transfer social insurance to the new place of enrollment (Item 19).

**Occupational disease and work injury**: three occupational health exams (Item 9), employer must supply protective gear (Item 10), apply for work-injury recognition (Item 11), call 120 first if you feel suddenly unwell (Item 12), no work-injury insurance enrollment (Item 13), work-capacity assessment (Item 14), three payments for work-related death (Item 15).

## 1. Overtime pay runs at 1.5×, 2×, and 3×; if unpaid, complain to labor inspection, and late payment triggers an extra 50% to 100%

**Cost**. No cost. Routinely keep copies of clock-in records, shift schedules, and overtime approval forms, and screenshot work-group messages where managers assign extra work. The hard part is remembering to save them every month.

**In plain terms**. Weekday overtime is paid at 1.5 times your wage. Rest-day overtime without compensatory time off is paid at 2 times. Work on statutory public holidays such as New Year's Day, Spring Festival, Labor Day, and National Day is paid at 3 times, and the law does not allow compensatory time off to replace that pay. If the employer refuses, file a complaint with labor inspection. After a payment deadline is set and the employer still does not pay, the employer must also pay an additional half to the full amount owed on top of the arrears.

**Benefit**. Normal working hours under the law are no more than 8 hours per day and no more than 44 hours per week on average. Weekday overtime is generally capped at 1 hour per day. Where special reasons require more, it must not exceed 3 hours per day, and the total in one month must not exceed 36 hours. Overtime pay has three tiers. Extending working hours on ordinary days: at least 150% of wages. Working on a rest day when compensatory rest cannot be arranged: at least 200%. Working on a statutory public holiday: at least 300%. For statutory public holidays, the law does not offer a “substitute with compensatory rest” option. If the employer arranges overtime but does not pay overtime wages, the labor administration department orders it to pay within a set period. If it still does not pay after that period, it must pay the worker an additional sum of 50% to 100% of the amount due on top of the arrears (nationwide). Which days are statutory public holidays is in Article 2 of the State Council holiday measures: New Year's Day 1 day, Spring Festival 4 days, Qingming Festival 1 day, Labor Day 2 days, Dragon Boat Festival 1 day, Mid-Autumn Festival

1 day, National Day 3 days. Article 7 of the holiday measures allows “unified holiday bridging,” linking these days with weekends into longer breaks

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Rest days and statutory public holidays are calculated separately. Statutory public holidays are only the legally designated days each year, such as New Year's Day, Spring Festival, Labor Day, and National Day. In long breaks created by bridging rest days, days that are not the festival days listed in the holiday measures count as rest days: compensatory rest may be arranged where possible; otherwise pay is 200%. That follows from Article 2 of the holiday measures and Article 44 of the Labor Law. “Company policy requires overtime approval” and “I stayed voluntarily” do not mean the employer may withhold pay, but they make evidence harder, so keep assignment and approval records. If the employer wants a comprehensive working-hours system or a flexible working-hours system, it must obtain approval from the labor administration department first; it cannot decide on its own. For dispute arbitration time limits, see Section 8, Item 19.

## 2. Annual leave is 5, 10, or 15 days by cumulative service years; unused days are paid at 300% of daily wage

**Cost**. No cost. Add up years worked at all employers once; social insurance payment records are proof. The hard part is refusing to sign a “voluntary waiver of annual leave” form if the company pushes one.

**In plain terms**. With cumulative service of at least 1 year but less than 10 years across all employers, you get 5 days of annual leave per year. At 10 years it is 10 days; at 20 years, 15 days. Job changes still count toward the total. If the employer cannot schedule leave and you agree not to take it, those days are paid at 3 times daily wage. Sign a “voluntary waiver of annual leave” form and you only get normal wages.

**Benefit**. After 12 consecutive months of work you are entitled to annual leave. The number of days follows **cumulative** working time—years at all employers added together. At least 1 year but less than 10 years: 5 days; at least 10 years but less than 20 years: 10 days; 20 years or more: 15 days. Statutory public holidays and rest days do not count toward annual leave days. Where the employer truly cannot arrange leave because of work needs and you agree in writing not to take it, it must “pay annual leave wages at 300% of the employee's daily wage income” for the days not taken. That 300% already includes the normal wage for the day you would have worked, so the extra cash in hand is 200%. Daily wage = your monthly wage ÷ 21.75. Monthly wage is the average over the 12 months before payment, excluding overtime pay. If you joined the employer mid-year, days are prorated by remaining calendar days at that employer. On resignation, accrue and settle for the portion of the year already worked; excess leave already taken is not clawed back. If the employer neither arranges leave nor pays, it is ordered to correct within a deadline. If it still does not after the deadline, besides the annual leave wage payment, it must pay an additional sum equal to that amount as compensation (nationwide; effective 1 January 2008).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Cumulative working time must be summed across employers; if you changed jobs, do not count only tenure at the current employer. **Only when the employee “does not take leave for personal reasons and states so in writing” may the employer pay only normal wages**, so do not sign a “voluntary waiver of annual leave” form. If personal leave totals more than 20 days in a year and the employer does not deduct wages, you get no annual leave that year. Excessive sick leave also disqualifies you: less than 10 years of service—2 months; 10 to 20 years—3 months; more than 20 years—4 months. Home leave, marriage and bereavement leave, maternity leave, and work-injury wage continuation periods do not count toward annual leave.

## 3. Probation has a legal cap, wages must be at least 80%, and it can only be agreed once

**Cost**. No cost. Before signing, spend a few minutes checking the contract term against the probation length.

**In plain terms**. For a contract of 3 months to 1 year, probation is at most 1 month. For 1 to 3 years, at most 2 months. For 3 years or more, at most 6 months. The same employer may only put you on probation once; a second probation after transfer after regularization is unlawful. Probation wages must not be below the lowest grade for the same post or 80% of the contract wage, and must not be below the local minimum wage.

**Benefit**. For a contract of more than 3 months but less than 1 year, probation must not exceed 1 month. For more than 1 year but less than 3 years, not more than 2 months. For 3 years or more, and for open-ended contracts with no end date, not more than 6 months. For a contract for a defined piece of work, or a contract of less than 3 months in total, probation may not be agreed. “The same employer and the same employee may agree on probation only once”—one probation round per person at that company. If the contract lists only a probation period, that probation is void and the period counts as the labor contract term. Probation wages “must not be lower than 80% of the lowest grade wage for the same post at the employer or 80% of the wage agreed in the labor contract, and must not be lower than the minimum wage standard at the employer's location.” If probation exceeds the legal limit and you actually worked, the employer must pay compensation for the excess period at the monthly wage standard after probation ends. During probation the employer may terminate only for the legally listed grounds and must explain the reason to the worker (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Three common violations: a 1-year contract with 3 months of probation; a second probation after transfer following regularization; and “no social insurance during probation”—social insurance obligations start from day one of work regardless of probation; employer duties are in Section 12, Item 16. Being dismissed in probation does not mean zero pay; it depends on whether the employer's stated reason is one of the lawful grounds for termination. Unlawful termination is compensated at 2N per Item 6.

## 4. If you are laid off, calculate N first: one month's wage per full year, half a month if under six months

**Cost**. No cost. Run the numbers once with a calculator; about ten minutes.

**In plain terms**. When you are laid off, statutory economic compensation is calculated like this: one month's wage for each full year worked; at least six months but less than a year counts as a year; less than six months gets half a month. Monthly wage here is the average over the 12 months before you leave, including bonuses, allowances, and subsidies. If wages exceed three times the local average monthly wage for the prior year, pay is capped at three times that average, and years of service count for at most 12 years.

**Benefit**. Statutory economic compensation under the Labor Contract Law is what the employer owes when you are laid off—commonly called N. The formula: “one month's wage for each full year of service … six months or more but less than one year counts as one year; less than six months, half a month's wage to the worker.” If monthly wage exceeds three times the local average monthly wage of employees for the prior year, use triple that average as the cap, and count at most twelve years of service.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Monthly wage means average wage over the twelve months before the labor contract is terminated. Bonuses, allowances, and subsidies all count—not base pay alone. That is what employers most often understate. Whether this sum is subject to personal income tax is in Item 18 of this section (tax on compensation).

## 5. If the employer dismisses you citing post-illness inability to work, incompetence, or major change of circumstances, and did not give 30 days' prior notice, it must also pay one extra month's wage

**Cost**. No cost.

**In plain terms**. If the employer dismisses you because you cannot work after illness, cannot perform the job, or circumstances changed substantially, it must give 30 days' written notice. Without notice, it must pay one

month's wage on top of N. That is the common N+1. In negotiation, list that month separately; do not let the employer fold it into N.

**Benefit**. The Labor Contract Law gives employers two options when terminating under this article. One is "notify the worker in writing thirty days in advance." The other is "may terminate the labor contract after paying the worker one additional month's wage." If they want you out immediately, they pay an extra month. That extra month is commonly called payment in lieu of notice (代通知金), counted separately from N. That month is based on your prior month's wage; N uses average wage over the 12 months before termination—the bases differ

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The extra month appears only in the three situations under Article 40 of the Labor Contract Law. Illness or non-work injury and, after the medical period, inability to do the original or reassigned work. Inability to perform after training or reassignment. Major change in objective circumstances at signing and failed negotiation. Other situations have no extra month. Economic layoffs (Article 41) require only 30 days' notice to the union or all employees. Mutual termination proposed by the employer is N. Serious misconduct termination by the employer has no compensation. Unlawful termination is 2N. For the Article 40 three cases, keep N and the extra 1 separate in negotiation; do not let the employer count the extra month as part of N

## 6. For unlawful termination, damages are double the economic compensation standard

**Cost**. No cost. Arbitration takes several months. The hard part is staying with the process the whole time and not dropping out midway.

**In plain terms**. If termination is unlawful, damages are double the economic compensation standard—commonly called 2N. Whether termination is unlawful depends on the facts. Ask legal aid or a lawyer first, then decide whether to negotiate with the company or go to arbitration.

**Benefit**. The Labor Contract Law provides that where an employer unlawfully terminates or ends a labor contract, it "shall pay damages to the worker at twice the economic compensation standard under Article 47 of this Law." The calculation is to compute one economic compensation amount under that standard, then pay double

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This is the common 2N. What counts as unlawful termination depends on the facts. Consult legal aid or a lawyer first, then choose negotiation or arbitration; routes are in Section 7

## 7. Do not sign "resignation for personal reasons"—once signed, N usually disappears

**Cost**. No cost. The hard part is resisting pressure to sign on the spot.

**In plain terms**. Signing that you resigned for personal reasons usually wipes out both economic compensation and unemployment insurance. Voluntary resignation is not among the situations that trigger compensation, except when you leave because of employer faults such as unpaid wages or failure to pay social insurance. You do not have to sign the same day; sleep on it.

**Benefit**. The Labor Contract Law limits economic compensation to the legally listed situations. A worker who initiates departure is not included unless the reason is statutory employer fault such as unpaid wages or failure to pay social insurance. Signing "voluntary resignation" usually voids both economic compensation and unemployment insurance.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. A common employer line is “sign first to process exit; compensation comes separately.” If they mean it, put it in the agreement on the spot; otherwise do not sign. Not signing that day has no legal downside; sleep on it.

## 8. Before leaving, save pay slips, attendance records, the labor contract, social insurance records, and chat logs

**Cost**. No cost. About half an hour to archive materials. The hard part is remembering before you walk out.

**In plain terms**. In dismissal or wage-deduction disputes the employer must prove its case, but for overtime you must prove first, and employers only have to keep wage records for two years. Once you hand back the computer and accounts, you cannot get these materials back. With pay slips, attendance, social insurance records, and original chat logs in hand, you have something to use when the employer denies liability.

**Benefit**. Once you return the computer and accounts, these materials are gone for good. Labor disputes follow “who asserts must prove”: what you claim, you must prove. Where evidence is in the employer's hands, the employer must produce it; failure to do so carries adverse consequences for the employer. In arbitration, if you cannot obtain employer-held materials, the tribunal may order the employer to submit them within a set time. For dismissal, termination, contract cancellation, wage reduction, and calculation of length of service, the employer bears the burden of proof. Overtime is different: you must first prove you worked overtime. If you show overtime records are with the employer and it will not produce them, adverse consequences shift to the employer. The employer is only required to keep wage payment records for at least two years. When paying wages, the employer must give you a personal wage breakdown. Without a written contract, wage payment records, social insurance payment records, and a work ID can all prove an employment relationship. Employment registration forms, attendance records, and testimony of other employees can also be used. Chat logs count as electronic data and can be evidence. Submit originals; printouts from original records still count as originals. In one Shanghai procuratorate case, a worker sought ten years of minimum-wage shortfalls. First- and second-instance courts recognized only the last two years before resignation. The courts held the employer need keep only two years of records, so the worker had to prove the prior eight years. He had ten years of pay slips and bank statements, but the employer disputed authenticity of the slips. In August 2024 he applied for procuratorial supervision. After the procuratorate protested, the employer paid 19000 yuan (1.9 万) in a mediated settlement. He sued when the company cleared staff in 2021; by the supervision application about three years had passed (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Save only your own employment-related materials. Do not take company source code, client lists, or technical documents—risks of taking them are in Section 11. For chat logs, do not rely on screenshots alone; keep originals on the phone and do not delete. Best to save pay slips and bank statements every month; if you sue years after leaving, the employer is not required to keep records from more than two years ago. That Shanghai case turned around because of a procuratorate protest; most people never reach that step. On exit, also obtain a separation certificate from the employer—see Item 17 of this section (separation certificate)

## 9. Before dusty, noisy, or chemical jobs, check the contract for hazards; the employer arranges and pays for three occupational health exams

**Cost**. No cost. When signing, read the “occupational disease hazard disclosure” section line by line. Keep a copy of each exam report. The hard part is asking in person and getting the documents in hand.

**In plain terms**. When signing the contract, the employer must truthfully state in writing what occupational disease hazards the post has, how to protect yourself, and what benefits apply. If it concealed them, you may refuse that work and the employer cannot fire you for it. Three occupational health exams—before starting, while on the job, and before leaving—are arranged and paid by the employer. Without an exit exam, the employer cannot terminate the contract with you.

**Benefit**. The Law on Prevention and Control of Occupational Diseases requires that when signing a labor contract, the employer explain four things. Those four are: what occupational disease hazards the work may

cause, what consequences may follow, how to protect yourself, and what benefits apply. The statutory wording is to “truthfully inform the worker and specify it in the labor contract; concealment or deception is forbidden.” If you are later assigned hazardous work not disclosed in the contract, the employer must inform you again truthfully and renegotiate contract terms with you. If the employer fails, “the worker has the right to refuse work involving occupational disease hazards, and the employer may not terminate the labor contract for that reason.” There are three exams: pre-placement, during employment, and pre-departure. “Occupational health examination costs shall be borne by the employer”; the employer pays and must inform you of results in writing. Without a pre-placement exam, the employer must not assign work involving occupational disease hazards. Workers with occupational contraindications must not be assigned prohibited tasks. If health damage related to the job is found, the worker must be transferred from the original post and properly placed. **“An employer must not terminate or end the labor contract with a worker who has not undergone the pre-departure occupational health examination.”** On leaving, you “have the right to obtain a copy of your occupational health surveillance file; the employer shall provide it truthfully and free of charge, and affix its seal on the copy provided.” That occupational health surveillance file must be copied truthfully, given free, and stamped on the copy (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Three questions at interview roughly show whether the employer is serious: whether the post has occupational disease hazards, whether the contract states them, and who pays for the pre-placement exam. If they cannot answer or say “start first and we'll see,” weigh the risk yourself. Exit exams are most often skipped: without a pre-departure exam, the employer cannot terminate or end the contract. That exam is also key material for a later occupational disease diagnosis; likewise get a stamped copy of the surveillance file before you go. Occupational disease itself follows the work-injury route; benefits start at Item 11.

## 10. Dust, noise, and chemical toxins often cause irreversible harm (for example pneumoconiosis and noise-induced deafness): the employer must supply protective gear, and you can refuse work with no protections

**Cost**. No cost. The hard part is wearing particulate respirators, earplugs, and safety goggles consistently, and refusing unprotected tasks—coworkers may call you picky.

**In plain terms**. Pneumoconiosis, noise-induced deafness, and chemical eye burns are all statutory occupational diseases. Once lungs or hearing are damaged, they cannot be restored. You have the right to know what hazards the job carries and to demand protective facilities and personal protective equipment from the employer. You may refuse work without protections. Pay cuts or dismissal for using these rights do not count.

**Benefit**. The statutory list of occupational diseases, effective 1 August 2025, has 12 major categories and 135 conditions, including 4 open-ended clauses. The first category is occupational pneumoconiosis. It covers silicosis, coal workers' pneumoconiosis, graphite pneumoconiosis, carbon black pneumoconiosis, asbestosis, and talc pneumoconiosis. Also cement pneumoconiosis, mica pneumoconiosis, potter's pneumoconiosis, aluminum pneumoconiosis, welder's pneumoconiosis, and foundry worker's pneumoconiosis, plus one open-ended clause. Occupational ear, nose, throat, and oral diseases include noise-induced deafness and blast-induced deafness. Occupational eye diseases include chemical eye burns and welder's flash keratitis. Harm from pneumoconiosis and noise-induced deafness is permanent. The US National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health (NIOSH) states that silicosis is permanent lung damage that progresses over time, with no known cure. A Lancet review states that after patients stop dust exposure, lung function can still worsen as the disease progresses. The US Occupational Safety and Health Administration (OSHA) states that noise-induced hearing loss is permanent and cannot be corrected by surgery or drugs. The law gives four rights you can cite on the spot. First, to know what occupational disease hazards exist in the workplace, what consequences they can cause, and what protective measures are required. Second, to demand qualified protective facilities and personal protective equipment and improved working conditions. Third, to criticize, report, and complain about violations of occupational disease prevention law and practices that endanger life and health. Fourth, “refuse unlawful orders and forced work without occupational disease protections”—you

may refuse noncompliant orders and unprotected tasks. And “any reduction of wages, benefits, or other treatment, or termination or ending of the labor contract, because the worker lawfully exercised proper rights is void.” Pay cuts, benefit cuts, or dismissal for exercising these rights do not count (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Choose the right mask: dusty posts need particulate respirators—that is author experience. If the employer does not issue earplugs in noisy jobs, buy your own for a few yuan a pair; lost hearing cannot be restored. “Work two years, save money, and leave” does not hold for pneumoconiosis. Silicosis can keep worsening after dust exposure stops. So the exit exam matters especially (see Item 9—three occupational health exams arranged and paid by the employer). The revised catalog also adds two categories. One is occupational musculoskeletal disease: carpal tunnel syndrome, limited to manufacturing workers who repeatedly use the wrists or apply force for long periods. The other is occupational mental and behavioral disorder: post-traumatic stress disorder. It is limited to people's police, medical workers, fire and rescue, and other emergency responders involved in sudden-incident response. First aid for chemicals splashed on the body: Section 13, Item 21. How to treat post-traumatic stress disorder: Section 29, Item 14 (trauma-focused psychotherapy).

## 11. If you are injured at work or hit on the commute, apply for work-injury recognition first; if the employer will not file, file yourself

**Cost**. No cost—one trip to the social insurance administrative agency. Bring three items: a work-injury recognition application form, proof of employment, and a medical diagnosis certificate.

**In plain terms**. Injuries at work from the job count as work injuries. Being hit on the way to or from work, when you are not mainly at fault, also counts. Without work-injury recognition, medical costs, wages paid while you heal, and disability benefits all vanish. The employer should file within 30 days. If it does not, you, your family, or the trade union can file with the social insurance agency within one year.

**Benefit**. Without work-injury recognition, medical costs, wages paid during the work-stoppage period for treatment (停工留薪期工资), and disability benefits all vanish. If the employer misses the 30-day filing deadline, it must pay all work-injury benefits due in that period itself

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Treat the 1-year limit seriously; do not delay. Time lost for reasons not your fault does not count toward that 1 year. There are five such reasons: force majeure, restricted personal liberty, employer-caused delay, imperfect registration systems at the social insurance agency. The fifth is labor arbitration or litigation to confirm the employment relationship. If the employer stalls until the deadline passes, apply anyway and bring evidence of the delay. If the agency refuses to accept the application or you disagree with the decision, you may apply for administrative reconsideration or sue directly. If the employer denies work injury, it must prove its case. Keep your own records too: photos from the day, coworkers' contact details, medical records, and attendance. Article 16 of the regulations lists three exclusions: intentional crime, intoxication or drug use, and self-harm or suicide. Article 15 also lists “deemed work injuries”: sudden illness at work and at the workstation with death, or death within 48 hours after failed emergency treatment.

## 12. Do not trust «making it to your desk counts as work injury»: if you feel suddenly unwell, call 120 first, not the time clock

**Cost**. No monetary cost.

**In plain terms**. Rushing to the office when you feel unwell will not earn extra money. «Deemed work injury» requires sudden illness during working hours and at the workstation; illness on the way before you arrive does not qualify. Rescue beyond 48 hours also does not qualify. Minutes spent chasing those conditions cost you your chance to survive.

**Benefit**. «Deemed work injury» requires sudden illness «during working hours and at the workstation» with death, or death within 48 hours after failed emergency treatment. Delaying care to meet those conditions trades your chance to live for compensation you may never receive

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Both conditions must hold: working hours and the workstation. Illness on the commute before arrival does not apply. If illness starts at the workstation and you are sent home or to hospital and die within 48 hours despite treatment, the rule may still apply. What matters is where you were when illness started, not where death occurs. Short videos that say «hold on until you reach the company and you get paid» get it backward. What changes outcomes is whether you reach hospital in the first tens of minutes after onset. The 48-hour line is fixed; treatment beyond 48 hours excludes the case.

## 13. If the employer did not enroll you in work-injury insurance, benefits still apply and the employer pays the full standard amount

**Cost**. No cost. If the employer disputes liability, arbitration or even litigation starts at several months. The hard part is staying with the process for those months.

**In plain terms**. Even without work-injury insurance enrollment, work-injury benefits still apply. The employer must pay the same items and amounts in full, missing nothing. Non-enrollment adds penalties on the employer: order to pay premiums, a daily late fee of 5/10000 of the amount unpaid, and a fine of 1 to 3 times the unpaid amount if still not paid. “The company has no insurance so it cannot pay” is false.

**Benefit**. The regulations state plainly: if an employer that should enroll in work-injury insurance did not, and an employee is injured, that employer pays benefits under the same items and standards as the regulations. Which payments and how much match enrolled cases; only the payer changes to the employer

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. “The company did not buy work-injury insurance for you, so it cannot compensate” is one of the most common lies in these cases. Non-enrollment only adds penalties on the employer; your benefits do not shrink.

## 14. After injuries stabilize, get a work-capacity assessment; disability grade maps directly to money

**Cost**. No cost. One work-capacity assessment process; expect waiting time before and after.

**In plain terms**. After injuries stabilize, a work-capacity assessment turns grade directly into money. The lump-sum disability benefit uses your own wage: grade 5 — 18 months, grade 6 — 16 months, grade 7 — 13 months. Grade 8 — 11 months, grade 9 — 9 months, grade 10 — 7 months. Do not sign a “one-time settlement” agreement before the assessment result is out.

**Benefit**. The lump-sum disability benefit converts disability grade into months of your own wage, paid once. Grade 5 — 18 months, grade 6 — 16 months, grade 7 — 13 months of your wage. Grade 8 — 11 months, grade 9 — 9 months, grade 10 — 7 months of your wage

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Grades 5 and 6 keep the employment relationship; you remain the employer's employee and receive a monthly disability allowance. For grades 7 through 10, when the contract ends or you terminate it, two more lump sums apply. A one-time work-injury medical subsidy from the fund and a one-time disability employment subsidy from the employer; amounts are set by the province. Do not sign a “one-time settlement” before the assessment result is out. Work-injury prostheses, wheelchairs, and similar assistive devices must first be confirmed by the work-capacity assessment committee; see Section 33, Item 7 (ask the county disabled persons' federation for the full picture).

## 15. Three payments for work-related death: funeral allowance, dependents' pension, and one-time work-death benefit

**Cost**. No cost—one set of procedures.

**In plain terms**. Work-related death means three payments; do not negotiate on only one. Funeral allowance equals 6 months of the local prior-year average employee monthly wage. Dependents' pension is paid monthly from the deceased's wage: spouse 40% per month, other dependents 30% each per month. The one-time work-death benefit is 20 times the prior year's national urban per capita disposable income—one figure nationwide.

**Benefit**. Work-related death money comes in three parts. First, funeral allowance: 6 months of the prior-year average employee monthly wage in the insurance pooling area where you were enrolled. Second, dependents' pension from the deceased's wage, paid monthly: spouse 40% per month, other dependents 30% each per month. Third, one-time work-death benefit: 20 times the prior year's national urban per capita disposable income. Nationwide there is only this one figure, not by region. For deaths in 2026, that payment is about 1130000 yuan (113 万 / exact value 1130040 yuan). The calculation is prior-year national urban per capita disposable income 56502 yuan × 20.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The one-time work-death benefit is uniform nationwide and updates each year with data from the National Bureau of Statistics. Reject “our local standard is lower” in settlement talks.

## 16. If you face long-term bullying, insults, or harassment at work, do not just endure it: record evidence, then complain, report, or arbitrate depending on what happened

**Cost**. No monetary cost. Time to log dates, who was present, exact words, and to keep original chat screenshots and emails. Arbitration or litigation can take months. Changing jobs is the highest cost — whether to leave is your call.

**In plain terms**. People bullied at work later face roughly 60% higher risk of heart disease and stroke, and more bullying means higher risk. Years later, bullied workers are about twice as likely to have suicidal thoughts as others. Insults and mistreatment are not something you shrug off.

**Benefit**. For health: three Swedish and Danish cohorts together, 79,201 employed people aged 18 to 65. None had cardiovascular disease at baseline; mean follow-up 12.4 years. 9% reported workplace bullying in the past year. Bullied workers had about 59% higher risk of cardiovascular disease (coronary and cerebrovascular disease) (HR 1.59, 95% CI 1.28–1.98). Those who faced workplace violence had about 25% higher risk (HR 1.25, 1.12–1.40). For both, more exposure meant higher risk. A Norwegian nationally sampled follow-up survey of 1,846 employed people, measured every two to three years for three rounds: bullied workers were about twice as likely to develop suicidal thoughts (OR 2.05, 95% CI 1.08–3.89). The reverse did not hold — prior suicidal thoughts did not predict later bullying. Legally, China has no dedicated «workplace bullying» statute; match the act to existing rules. Employers who insult, physically punish, beat, illegally search, or illegally detain workers face administrative penalties, must compensate harm, and bear criminal liability if applicable. If an employer uses violence or threats to force work, you may terminate the contract at once without prior notice and claim economic compensation. Employers must prevent and stop sexual harassment via authority or hierarchy; victims may hold harassers civilly liable. Labor arbitration closes within 45 days from acceptance; complex cases may extend up to 15 days more.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Graded B because health figures come from follow-up studies, not randomized trials, and «bullying» was self-reported. Four steps you can take now. Step one: start logging today; recording — Section 8, item 41. Step two: raise the issue in writing through internal channels and keep proof you did. Step three: if you are beaten, confined, or publicly humiliated, call the police. Step four: if unpaid wages or missing social insurance (社保) forced you out, follow this section item 7 (do not sign voluntary resignation) and item 8

(save evidence before leaving). How economic compensation is calculated: this section item 4 (calculate N when laid off). Pure cold-shoulder, exclusion, or petty obstruction often fit no specific statute; main routes are internal complaint, transfer, and changing jobs. Arbitration runs up to 60 days from acceptance; first-instance court is 6 months from the start; you pay your own lawyer. If you are at breaking point, call 12356 — Section 1, item 25 (12356). This item does not tell you to quit at the first insult; the cost of changing jobs is yours to weigh.

## 17. When you leave, get a separation certificate stating contract term, leave date, position, and years of service

**Cost**. No monetary cost. Ask in person before you go, or send a written request and keep proof you asked. Hard when relations are bad. If the employer stalls, complaint or arbitration can take weeks to months.

**In plain terms**. Whether you were dismissed, the contract expired, or you resigned, the employer must give a separation certificate when you leave and transfer your personnel file and social insurance within 15 days. The certificate must state contract term, separation date, position, and years at this employer. You need it for unemployment registration. If the employer refuses, labor authorities order correction and must pay any loss they caused.

**Benefit**. The Labor Contract Law requires a certificate when the contract is terminated or ended. The rule does not depend on who initiated it — non-renewal, resignation, or dismissal all count. The employer must complete personnel file and social insurance transfer within 15 days. Implementing regulations require four items on the certificate: contract term, date of termination or end, job position, and years of service at the unit. The Unemployment Insurance Regulations require laid-off workers to take the employer's certificate promptly to the social insurance agency for unemployment registration. Unemployment benefits start from the registration date. If the employer does not issue a written certificate, the labor administration orders correction. If you suffer loss, the employer pays damages. The law also provides that a new employer who hires someone still bound to a former employer and causes loss to the former employer bears joint and several liability. The separation certificate is written proof that you and the former employer have ended the relationship (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The law does not tie issuing the certificate to finishing handover; economic compensation is paid after handover is done. If the employer drags its feet, send one more written demand. If still no certificate, call 12333 or complain to labor inspection at the human resources bureau. Complaints are free; after a case is opened, investigation must finish within 60 working days, extendable 30 working days for complex cases. To claim damages from the employer, use labor arbitration — also free — within one year. After acceptance, arbitration closes within 45 days, extendable 15 days. You must prove the loss yourself, for example delayed unemployment registration or a new employer refusing you for lack of proof. If you disagree with the award, go to court; ordinary first-instance procedure starts at six months. Labor dispute court fees are 10 yuan per case; attorney fees are not litigation costs and you pay yourself. The four required items do not include reason for leaving. If the certificate says «voluntary resignation for personal reasons» and that is false, object on the spot — see this section item 7 (do not sign voluntary resignation). How to claim unemployment insurance: Section 7, item 1.

## 18. Before spending severance, check individual income tax: within 3× the local prior-year average employee wage is tax-free; the excess is taxed separately, not merged into that year's salary

**Cost**. No cost. Look up the local prior-year average employee wage, then spend a few minutes checking how the employer withheld tax. The individual income tax app shows line-by-line filing for each payment.

**In plain terms**. One-time compensation from ending employment is tax-free up to 3 times the local prior-year average employee wage. Amounts above that are taxed on their own, not added to that year's wages. If

the employer lumped the whole payment into the month's wages and withheld tax that way, ask the employer first, then call 12366 for the tax bureau.

**Benefit**. A Ministry of Finance and State Taxation Administration circular covers one-time compensation income from terminating a labor relationship with an employer. That income includes economic compensation, living allowances, and other subsidies. The portion within 3 times the local prior-year average employee wage is exempt from individual income tax. The portion above 3 times is not merged into annual comprehensive income; it is taxed separately under the comprehensive income rate table. On that table, the portion within 36000 yuan for the year is taxed at 3%; the portion from 36000 yuan to 144000 yuan at 10%. Higher brackets go up to 45%. Example: if the local prior-year average employee wage is 100000 yuan (10 万), 3 times is 300000 yuan (30 万). On 360000 yuan (36 万) compensation, only the 60000 yuan (6 万) excess is taxed—3480 yuan. If the full 360000 yuan (36 万) were taxed under that table, tax would be 58080 yuan. Effective 1 January 2019; no end date stated (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The same circular sets an end date for the annual one-time bonus policy, later extended to 31 December 2027. The termination-compensation rule has no end date and does not follow the bonus extension. The circular names economic compensation, living allowances, and other subsidies; it does not separately name payment in lieu of notice or damages for unlawful termination. If unsure whether those count, call 12366 for the local tax bureau. Which figure counts as “local prior-year average employee wage” is determined by the local tax bureau. How compensation itself is calculated: Item 4 of this section (calculate N when laid off), Item 5 (no 30-day prior notice), and Item 6 (damages for unlawful termination). One-time subsidies for early retirement or internal retirement use a different formula and are not covered here.

## 19. When you change cities for work, transfer pension and medical insurance to the new place of enrollment so contribution years keep adding up; do not withdraw from the scheme

**Cost**. No cost. Once you are enrolled and paying in at the new place, your new employer or you file a transfer application, in person at a counter or online. Pension transfers take several dozen working days end to end; medical insurance takes about 15 working days.

**In plain terms**. When you change cities, both pension and medical insurance records can follow you, and years you already paid keep counting. Before pension-claiming age you cannot cancel enrollment (退保) and take the money out. If medical contributions lapse more than 3 months, you may wait up to 6 months before reimbursement at the new place—so do not leave a long gap.

**Benefit**. The Social Insurance Law states that when you take a job in another place (formally, across pooling areas), your pension record moves with you and contribution years accumulate. Employee medical insurance works the same: the record follows the person and years accumulate. At retirement the pension is calculated in segments and paid by one place. Cross-province pension transfer follows the transfer-and-continuation measures issued by the General Office of the State Council. Before benefit-claiming age, the pension relationship may not be terminated and you may not withdraw from the scheme (退保). The Social Insurance Law also states that the individual account may not be withdrawn early. Money in the individual account transfers in full with interest. The employer-paid portion is the pooled fund; it transfers at 12% of your actual contribution wage for each year from 1998 onward. When you claim the pension, calculation uses your contribution wage each year, contribution years, and average wages where you claim. Procedure: once enrolled and paying at the new place, the employer or you apply in writing to the new place of enrollment. The new place reviews within 15 working days; the old place completes transfer out within 15 working days after receiving the letter agreeing to accept. After the new place receives the record and funds, it completes the process within a further 15 working days. Under the 2020 nationwide-handling list, this was to be available for nationwide handling by year-end. You only apply to the place you are moving to; no need to return to the place you left. For employee medical insurance, the old place must first suspend coverage and you must already be enrolled at the new place before you apply. You can apply online on the National

Healthcare Security service platform or at a counter. The old place transfers out within 10 working days; the new place takes in within 5 working days, with individual account balance moved along. If the gap before transfer is 3 months or less, after back contributions under the new place's rules there is no waiting period: reimbursement from the contribution month, and the gap period can be reimbursed retroactively. If the gap exceeds 3 months, the waiting period follows local rules and in principle does not exceed 6 months (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If you move across provinces to a province that is not your hukou (户口) province, and you are a man aged 50 or older or a woman aged 40 or older, your pension record stays with the old place of enrollment. The new place only opens a temporary account recording all employer and individual contributions. Where you collect the pension at retirement works like this. If the record is in your hukou province, you collect there. If not in your hukou province but you have 10 years of contributions where the record sits, you collect there. If under 10 years everywhere, the record goes to the last place where you reached 10 years and you collect there. If under 10 years in every place, records are gathered at your hukou place and you collect there. Collection place changes which average wage enters the formula. Within-province city-to-city transfer is set by each province; ask the local social insurance office. People already drawing a pension no longer transfer records. How years count after a lapse and which entitlements need continuous contributions: Section 7, Item 18 (lapsed social insurance). If you do not join an employer and pay social insurance yourself: Section 31, Item 11 (flexible employment).

## 20. If the employer still has not signed a written labor contract one month after you start, from the second month you can claim double wages for up to 11 months; after a full year without a contract, it counts as an open-ended contract

**Cost**. No cost. Keep evidence that you worked: wage bank records, attendance, work badge, work-group chat logs. If the employer disputes it, apply for labor arbitration. Arbitration is free; cases close within 45 days after acceptance, extendable by at most 15 days. You can still go to court if you disagree; ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months, and you pay your own lawyer. The hard part is still working there while pressing for the money.

**In plain terms**. If the employer has not signed a written contract one month after you start, from the second month it owes an extra month's wage each month, up to 11 extra months. After a full year without a contract, it counts as if you already signed a contract with no end date. Sign when the employer hands you the contract; if you deliberately stall and refuse to sign, you cannot claim this money.

**Benefit**. The Labor Contract Law requires a written labor contract when an employment relationship is established. If it is not signed on the first day of work, it must be signed within one month from that day. If more than one month but less than one year passes without a contract, the employer must pay you double wages each month. The implementing regulations fix the start and end: from the day after one full month of work through the day before the contract is later signed. If a full year passes without a contract, double wages run through the day before the year is complete—at most 11 months. From the day the year is complete, both sides are treated as having signed an open-ended labor contract, and the employer must sign one at once. An open-ended contract is one with no agreed end date. A Supreme People's Court judicial interpretation effective September 2025 provides that double wages are calculated by the month; periods under one month are calculated by actual working days. If the employer proves the lack of a contract was due to force majeure, or to your intentional or grossly negligent refusal to sign, it need not pay. Within the first month of work, if the employer notifies you in writing to sign and you do not, the employer may terminate the employment relationship in writing. In that case it owes no economic compensation, only wages for the days you worked. Courts will not support a further claim for double wages covering the period already treated as an open-ended contract (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. How long you have to claim the extra wage portion has no nationwide rule from the Supreme People's Court. A 2023 draft for comments had a limitation rule that the 2025 formal interpretation did not keep. Beijing's practice is that the extra portion uses the 1-year arbitration limitation, counted day by day backward from the day you make the claim. Local methods differ, but the longer you wait, the fewer months you can recover. So apply for arbitration while still employed or soon after leaving. General arbitration limitation rules: Section 8, Item 19 (rights have deadlines). If a make-up contract is backdated to the first day of work, Beijing generally no longer supports double wages, unless you can prove the make-up signing was not voluntary. From the employer's side: Section 12, Item 16 (sign a written contract within the first month of hiring).

## 21. If the employer does not pay social insurance or underpays it, complain first to force back payment; if you resign for that reason and want economic compensation, the resignation notice must state it is because the employer did not pay social insurance as required by law

**Cost**. No cost. First check your social insurance payment records; screenshot or print and keep them. To force back payment, call 12333 or complain to labor inspection at the human resources and social security bureau. For economic compensation, go to labor arbitration—free, closes within 45 days, extendable by at most 15 days. If you disagree, go to court; ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months, and you pay your own lawyer. The hard part is having another source of income after you resign.

**In plain terms**. If the employer did not enroll you in social insurance or did not pay enough, you can complain and require it to make up the payments, plus late fees. You can also notify the employer in writing that you are ending the contract and claim economic compensation. The notice must state the reason is that the employer did not pay social insurance as required by law; if you write “personal reasons,” you get nothing. An agreement that “the employee voluntarily waives social insurance” does not count.

**Benefit**. The Social Insurance Law requires the employer to declare and pay social insurance on time and in full. Except for statutory grounds such as force majeure, it may not defer or reduce payments. If the employer infringes your social insurance rights, you may ask the social insurance administrative agency or the social insurance contribution collection agency to handle it under the law. If the employer fails to pay on time and in full, the collection agency orders it to make up the shortfall within a deadline and adds a daily late fee of 5/10000 from the day payment was due. If it still does not pay after the deadline, it is fined 1 to 3 times the unpaid amount. Labor security inspection covers whether the employer participates in social insurance and pays contributions. After a case is opened, investigation finishes within 60 working days, extendable by 30 working days for complex cases. The Labor Contract Law provides that if the employer does not pay social insurance for you as required by law, you may terminate the labor contract and the employer must pay economic compensation. If you resign with 30 days' prior notice on your own, the employer owes no economic compensation. So the notice must state that you are terminating because the employer did not pay social insurance as required by law. A Supreme People's Court judicial interpretation effective September 2025 states that agreements with you not to pay social insurance, or your own promise that payment is unnecessary, are both void. If the employer did not pay social insurance as required by law and you terminate and claim economic compensation on that basis, courts support the claim under the law. If the employer never enrolled you, the social insurance agency cannot make it up, and you lose benefits as a result, you may claim damages from the employer. That is a labor dispute the courts accept (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. To force back payment, use the complaint route. Beijing High Court and arbitration commission practice is that a bare claim for back payment is not a labor dispute; go to the labor administration. Do not delay the complaint: if a violation is not discovered and no one complains within 2 years, labor security authorities will not investigate further. For ongoing non-payment, the 2 years run from the day the arrears stop. Whether underpaying the contribution base counts as “not paying as required by law,” and whether that alone supports economic compensation, is not stated by the Supreme People's Court. Beijing lists only two situations: no social insurance account opened in the year before termination, or incomplete coverage of

insurance types. There is no nationwide uniform rule on underpaid bases; ask the local arbitration commission first. If the employer previously paid you the social insurance amount in cash and later made up the contributions, it may demand you return that cash. Work injury when work-injury insurance was never paid: Item 13 of this section (no work-injury insurance enrollment). How years count after a lapse: Section 7, Item 18 (lapsed social insurance).

## 22. If the company demands liquidated damages when you leave, first see which kind: only a service period after special training, and non-compete, may agree liquidated damages; other labels are not allowed by law

**Cost**. No cost. Pull out the labor contract, training agreement, and non-compete agreement and check them against each other—a few minutes. If the company deducts wages to cover liquidated damages, recover them through labor arbitration. Arbitration is free; cases close within 45 days, extendable by at most 15 days. If you disagree, go to court; ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months, and you pay your own lawyer.

**In plain terms**. A contract line that "leaving early means you pay" is allowed by law in only two situations: the company paid for specialized technical training for you, or non-compete. Where there really was special training, damages cannot exceed training costs, and must be prorated for the unfinished service period.

**Benefit**. The Labor Contract Law provides that except for a service period after special training and non-compete, the employer may not agree that the worker bears liquidated damages. The first is when the employer pays special training expenses to send you for specialized technical training and may agree a service period with you. If you leave early in breach of the service period, you pay liquidated damages as agreed. Liquidated damages must not exceed the training expenses the employer paid. What the employer can actually claim must not exceed the training expenses allocated to the unfinished part of the service period. Example: training costs 30000 yuan (3 万), service period 3 years; leave after 2 years, at most 10000 yuan (1 万). Training expenses need vouchers, including training fees, travel during training, and other direct costs caused by the training. If you lawfully terminate because of employer faults such as unpaid social insurance or unpaid wages, that is not a breach of the service period, and the employer may not claim liquidated damages. The second is non-compete; rules are in Section 11, Item 12 (non-compete agreement). Also, contract clauses that exempt the employer from statutory duties or exclude the worker's rights are void (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. No liquidated damages does not mean leaving costs nothing. If you leave without 30 days' written notice, or breach confidentiality or non-compete and cause the employer loss, you must compensate the loss. How much loss is for the employer to prove. If the employer provided special benefits such as hukou (户口) and agreed a service period, and you leave early, a court may order you to compensate. How much depends on actual loss, fault on both sides, and how long you already worked. Beijing practice is that liquidated damages tied only to the employer helping with hukou are not supported, but you still compensate loss you caused the employer by breaking good faith. If the employer terminates you for serious misconduct, serious dereliction, or criminal liability, service-period liquidated damages are still owed. If the contract ends while the service period is unfinished, the contract extends to the end of the service period unless the parties agree otherwise. How to recover deducted wages: Section 7, Item 2 (complain to labor inspection first for unpaid wages). Benefit graded medium by judgment: liquidated-damage amounts are written into each contract; there is no uniform figure.

## 23. If the employer wants to reassign you or cut your pay and you disagree, say so in writing on the spot; do not stay silent and work under the new arrangement for more than a month

**Cost**. No cost. After a reassignment or pay-cut notice, send a written message stating you disagree, screenshot and keep it—a few minutes. The hard part is still working there while facing a confrontation. If the employer then fires you or docks pay, go to labor arbitration. Arbitration is free; after acceptance, cases

close within 45 days, extendable by at most 15 days. If you disagree, go to court; ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months, and you pay your own lawyer.

**In plain terms**. Changing post or wage is changing the contract; both sides must agree, and it must be in writing. But if you stay silent and work at the new post and wage for more than a month, courts generally will not void the change just because it was not in writing. If you disagree, say so in writing on the spot; WeChat and email both count.

**Benefit**. The Labor Contract Law provides that only when the employer and worker agree through consultation may the agreed contents of the labor contract be changed. Changes must use written form. A Supreme People's Court judicial interpretation adds another rule. If both sides orally agreed to change the contract and then actually worked under the new terms for more than one month, the change is still valid. At that point, arguing the change is void for lack of written form is not supported by courts. The premise is that the changed content is lawful and does not violate public order and good morals. Beijing High Court and Beijing arbitration commission practice is as follows. If the contract does not state a post or states it unclearly, and the employer has proper reasons and reassigns reasonably for business needs, that counts as the employer's staffing autonomy. Reasonableness looks at four things: whether there is business necessity, whether the purpose is proper, whether you can do the new post, and whether pay and benefits worsened. If the contract clearly states the post and has no reassignment clause, a unilateral reassignment by the employer is a breach, and the shortfall versus original-post wages must be made up. If the contract writes the work location as a broad range such as “nationwide” or “Beijing,” that counts as unclear, and the place you actually work controls. Without proper reasons, the employer may not change that place. If the employer fails to pay wages in full and on time, you may terminate the labor contract and the employer must pay economic compensation (nationwide; Beijing practice applies only in Beijing)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Graded B because “silence while working counts as consent” is not written directly in the statute. It is inferred from Article 43 of the judicial interpretation and local adjudication practice. There is no nationwide uniform standard for “reasonable reassignment”; the points above are Beijing practice. After objecting in writing, best to keep reporting for work and state that you reserve your position, because refusing to show up may be treated as absenteeism and lead to dismissal. If the reassignment is later found unreasonable, that dismissal is unlawful termination, calculated under Item 6 of this section (damages for unlawful termination). If found reasonable, you do not get that money. If objective circumstances at signing changed substantially and renegotiation of terms fails, the employer may terminate the contract. Then pay follows Item 5 of this section (no 30-day prior notice). How to recover wages underpaid after a cut: Section 7, Item 2 (complain to labor inspection first for unpaid wages). Benefit graded medium by judgment: pay-cut size varies by employer; there is no uniform figure.

## 24. If you are labor-dispatched to work at another company, wages must be calculated the same way as for regular staff in the same type of post, and if you are harmed at the host workplace both companies pay together

**Cost**. No cost. Check the labor contract for which company's seal is on it—a few minutes. Then ask the dispatch company what wage and social insurance the dispatch agreement states; it must tell you. Real disputes go to labor arbitration—free; after acceptance, cases close within 45 days, extendable by at most 15 days. If you disagree, go to court; ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months, and you pay your own lawyer.

**In plain terms**. A dispatched worker's contract is with the dispatch company, and the host workplace where you work each day also has statutory duties. Wages must be calculated the same way as for people in the same type of post at that host; overtime pay and performance bonuses are also paid by it. If you are harmed at that host, both companies pay together; you may claim the full amount from either one. In months with no assignment after you are returned, the dispatch company must still pay at least the minimum wage.

**Benefit**. The Labor Contract Law provides that the labor dispatch company is your employer; it must sign a fixed-term contract of 2 years or more with you and pay wages monthly. During periods with no assignment, it pays the local minimum wage monthly. The dispatch company must tell you the contents of the dispatch agreement and must not deduct wages the host workplace (legally, the using unit) pays you. Neither company may charge you fees. Dispatched workers have the right to equal pay for equal work with employees of the host. The host must use the same labor-remuneration distribution method for the same type of post. With no same-type post, set pay by reference to the same or similar local posts. The host must pay overtime and performance bonuses, provide post-related benefits, and must not discriminate against dispatched workers. For continuous assignment, wages must be adjusted normally. Dispatch may only be used for temporary, auxiliary, or substitute posts; temporary posts are those lasting no more than 6 months. Dispatched workers at the host must not exceed 10% of total staffing. If the host harms a dispatched worker, the dispatch company and the host bear joint and several liability. Joint and several means you may claim the full amount from either one, or from both. If you have a labor dispute with either, both are joint parties in arbitration. If you are injured at work at the host, the dispatch company applies for work-injury recognition and bears work-injury insurance liability; the host must assist the investigation. The host may return you only in the legally listed situations. Arrangements labeled contracting or outsourcing that in substance use people as dispatch are handled under the dispatch rules (nationwide; interim provisions effective 1 March 2014)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Equal pay for equal work compares whether the same type of post uses the same distribution method; it does not guarantee every person receives exactly the same amount. After you are returned, if the dispatch company lowers the original contract terms to reassign you and you disagree, it may not terminate the contract for that reason. If the dispatch company terminates or ends the contract with you on statutory grounds, it must pay economic compensation; the formula is in Item 4 of this section (calculate N when laid off). If you are injured at the host, have the dispatch company file for work injury first. If it will not, file yourself—see Item 11 of this section (apply for work-injury recognition). For deducted or unpaid wages: Section 7, Item 2 (complain to labor inspection first for unpaid wages). Benefit graded medium by judgment: equal-pay gaps and harm size vary by person; there is no uniform figure.

# 20. How to care for a newborn

Scope: infant mortality and money. This section only covers what affects whether the child survives or how much you spend, and only where the gap is large enough and the evidence is solid. Soothing and day-to-day parenting tips are not covered here. For tasks before birth and on the day of discharge, see Section 27.

## 1. During infancy, put the baby to sleep on their back on a firm surface; share a room but not a bed; and do not place any soft items in the crib or bed

**Cost**. This costs nothing upfront. However, you'll need to replace the mattress with a firm one, which may cost several hundred yuan. The real challenge is resisting pressure from older relatives to deviate from this rule.

**In plain terms**. While the child is still an infant, lay the child face up on a firm surface that does not incline. An inclined cradle or an infant seat cannot be used as a bed. The adult and the child sleep in the same room, but not in the same bed. Do not put soft things on the bed, such as pillows, quilts, bed bumpers, or stuffed toys. In the United States alone, about 3500 infants die each year from causes related to sleep.

**Benefit**. Each year, nearly 3,500 infants in the U.S. lose their lives to sleep-related issues, including sudden infant death syndrome, deaths of unknown cause, and accidental suffocation in bedding. The American Academy of Pediatrics recommends a safe sleep environment consisting of: infants sleeping on their backs; using a solid, non-inclined sleeping surface; sharing a room without sharing a bed; and avoiding soft bedding and overheating. Additional protective measures include breastfeeding, keeping infants away from nicotine and alcohol, ensuring all vaccinations are up to date, and offering a pacifier during sleep.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. “Do not place any soft items in the bed” means absolutely no pillows, blankets, bed rails, stuffed toys, or shaped pillows — even nursing pillows that appear perfectly safe are prohibited. Inclined cribs and baby chairs must never be used as sleeping areas. This requirement represents the biggest departure from common practice in this section, and it often requires the strongest resistance to family pressure.

## 2. Give the 1st dose of hepatitis B vaccine within 24 hours after birth

**Cost**. No money. The hepatitis B vaccine is on the immunization schedule (免疫规划) and is free to begin with. The child gets it at the hospital on the day of birth, so there is no extra trip.

**In plain terms**. The 1st dose of hepatitis B vaccine has to be given within 24 hours after the child is born. Among people infected in infancy or early childhood, about 95% go on to chronic hepatitis. People infected only after they are grown mostly get better on their own, so this dose is more useful the earlier it is given. If the mother's hepatitis B surface antigen is positive, the child also needs hepatitis B immune globulin within 12 hours of birth, at the same time.

**Benefit**. The World Health Organization says: "All infants should receive the hepatitis B vaccine as soon as possible after birth (within 24 hours)." The reason is that "about 95% of infections in infancy and early childhood develop into chronic hepatitis." The great majority of people infected as adults clear it on their own (they get better without treatment). The WHO's own words are that "under 5%" of infections after adulthood become chronic. The National Health Commission (国家卫生健康委员会) protocol for interrupting mother-to-child transmission requires that a child born to a mother who is positive for hepatitis B surface antigen "receive the 1st dose of hepatitis B vaccine as early as possible within 12 hours after birth, and at the same time an injection of 100 international units of hepatitis B immune globulin."

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If the mother's hepatitis B surface antigen is positive, the child also needs 1 shot of hepatitis B immune globulin at the same time after birth. This has to be checked at prenatal care. Do not wait until after the birth to ask. The screening the mother herself needs is in Section 1.

## 3. Finish the vaccines on the national immunization schedule; they are free the whole way, and a missed series means catching up only the doses not yet given

**Cost**. No money. The law states that "a vaccination provider may not charge any fee for giving a vaccine on the immunization schedule." You will make several trips to the vaccination clinic as the child ages. Keep the vaccination certificate (预防接种证). Do not lose it.

**In plain terms**. Vaccines on the national immunization schedule are free for the whole series, and the vaccination provider cannot charge. Daycare and school both check the vaccination certificate, and a missed dose is generally found and made up. If you missed some, you only catch up the doses not yet finished. You do not start the whole series over, and you can continue even if the manufacturer changes.

**Benefit**. When a child enters daycare or school, the daycare or the school checks the vaccination certificate. If the child was not vaccinated on the immunization schedule as required, they report it to the vaccination provider and help press the guardian to catch up. So a missed vaccine is generally found when the certificate is checked at daycare or school entry. The schedule now in force is the 2026 edition. Human papillomavirus (HPV) vaccine is already on the national immunization schedule. The starting age for the diphtheria-tetanus-pertussis vaccine (百白破) changed from 3 months to 2 months. There are 5 doses in all, 1 dose at each of 2 months, 4 months, 6 months, 18 months, and 6 years. From March (3) 2026, children of the right age in Tibet, Qinghai, Xinjiang, and the Xinjiang Production and Construction Corps (新疆生产建设兵团) also receive Japanese encephalitis vaccine (乙脑) as a routine vaccination. Several vaccines can be given on the same day: at this stage, national immunization-schedule vaccines can be given at the same time, following the schedule or the catch-up rules. 2 or more injected vaccines must go into different sites. "It is strictly forbidden to draw 2 or more vaccines into the same syringe and inject them." If they are not given on the same day, 2 or more injected live attenuated vaccines need an interval of not less than 28 days. There is no interval limit between inactivated vaccines, oral live attenuated vaccines, and other vaccines. The catch-up rule for a child under 18 years of age is to catch up as soon as possible: "only the doses not yet finished need to be given; there is no need to start the whole series over." The same vaccine can be continued if the manufacturer changes (nationwide, 2026 edition of the schedule).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The most common misunderstanding is "the child is not strong, so wait." The official line is that a so-called "allergic constitution," allergies in the family, or a past allergy to a food or a drug is not a reason to skip the vaccine. Atopic dermatitis (eczema), hives, allergic rhinitis, and bronchial asthma can all be vaccinated as usual if the condition is stable. A child who is taking an allergy medicine, or using an inhaled steroid, can still be vaccinated. Physiological jaundice and breast-milk jaundice in a newborn can also be vaccinated as usual. There are only 2 true reasons not to vaccinate: an acute severe allergic reaction to the same vaccine before, or a severe allergy to a known component of the vaccine. A child with an immune deficiency, a child on chemotherapy or radiotherapy, or a child on an immunosuppressant needs a separate assessment. Explain the situation at the vaccination clinic and decide there. The first hepatitis B dose is in item 2 of this section. A non-schedule vaccine you pay for yourself is charged a vaccine fee and a vaccination service fee, and has nothing to do with the free vaccines this item is about.

## 4. For the first 6 months, feed only breast milk, not even water; from 6 months add complementary foods and keep breastfeeding

**Cost**. No money, and it saves the cost of formula. What it takes is time. Feeding takes a large part of every day. The hard part is keeping it up, and not stopping in the first 6 months.

**In plain terms**. Start feeding in the 1st hour after the child is born. For the first 6 months, feed only breast milk, not even water. From a full 6 months, add complementary foods, with iron-rich animal foods every day, and keep breastfeeding to 2 years or longer. If there is not enough breast milk, or breastfeeding is not possible, use formula.

**Benefit**. The World Health Organization recommends "starting breastfeeding within the 1st hour after birth." For the first 6 months, "exclusive breastfeeding, meaning no other food or liquid, including water." Then "from 6 months of age, start safe and adequate complementary foods, and continue breastfeeding to 2 years or beyond." The National Health Commission service guide also promotes exclusive breastfeeding from 0 to 6 months. The same guide requires that from a full 6 months "the day's complementary foods must include iron-rich animal foods."

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If breast milk is not enough, or the body does not allow breastfeeding, use formula. There is no need to feel guilty. The gap between breast milk and formula is far smaller than the safe-sleep item. That is the author's judgment. How often to add complementary foods, from that Health Commission service guide: at 6 to 8 months, 1 to 2 times a day; at 9 to 12 months, 2 to 3 times a day. Each day's complementary foods are chosen from 7 food groups, and not fewer than 4. If the child has severe eczema or an egg allergy, whether to avoid peanuts is in item 12 of this section (do not avoid peanuts). If the mother eats vegetarian, or wants the child to eat vegetarian, see item 14 of this section (on a vegetarian diet, supplement vitamin B12 every day).

## 5. Mix formula with water above 70 °C, let it cool before feeding, and throw away what is left

**Cost**. No money. Each time, wait a few extra minutes for the milk to cool. The hard part is that when the child is hungry and crying, you still wait for the water to cool before you mix.

**In plain terms**. Formula is not sterile. It can carry a bacterium that kills 4 in 10 to 8 in 10 of the newborns who catch it. Pour the hot water in first, wait until it falls to about 73.8 °C, then add the powder. In most cases that can kill this bacterium down to below 1/100000 of what it was. Hot water leaves a bit less vitamin C, but the formulas that were measured still met the standard. Let it cool after mixing, then feed. Throw away what is left.

**Benefit**. Formula is not sterile. It can carry Cronobacter (阪崎克罗诺杆菌). The reported death rate after a newborn is infected is 40% to 80%. Experimental work shows: pour the hot water into the bottle first, wait until the water falls to about 73.8 °C, then add the powder, and in the great majority of cases the milk is still above 70 °C. That can cut this bacterium by 5 or more orders of magnitude, down to below 1/100000 of what it was. The price of hot water shows up in vitamin C. The World Health Organization and the UN Food and Agriculture Organization held an expert meeting in 2006. The figures seen at that meeting were: when formula is mixed with boiling water, only vitamin C falls clearly, by 5.6% to 65.6% across 4 formulas. Formula leaves the factory with extra vitamin C already added. The formula that lost the most still had 9.0 milligrams per 100 kilocalories after mixing, above the Codex Alimentarius floor of 8 milligrams. The meeting saw only this 1 study, so it drew no conclusion on it.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Disputed. The 2022 opinion of the German Federal Institute for Risk Assessment is that a healthy full-term baby can be mixed with water at 20 to 50 °C. It notes that most manufacturers also print 40 to 50 °C on the tin. Its reason is that 70 °C water cools quickly after it is in the bottle, so the kill is not as large as the calculation. Hot water also loses some nutrients, and feeding before it has cooled can burn the child. The European Society for Paediatric Gastroenterology, Hepatology and Nutrition, in 2004, also did not favor mixing with boiling water, worrying that it would damage vitamins and the probiotics added to the formula. The World Health Organization and the UN Food and Agriculture Organization still recommend above 70 °C. The highest risk is for babies born early, babies with a birth weight under 2500 grams, babies under 2 months, and babies with weak immunity. Mix those at 70 °C, or ask a doctor. For a healthy full-term baby mixed at the temperature on the tin, this German opinion considers the infection risk extremely low. The 70 °C threshold comes from public-health guidance. Beary and colleagues' own words were: "public-health guidance for caregivers of high-risk infants recommends reconstituting formula with water heated to at least 70 °C (158 °F) to inactivate microorganisms." Do not mix with water that has sat in a thermos for 1 day. Do not leave mixed milk at room temperature for the next feed.

## 6. Do not feed honey to a child under 1 year of age

**Cost**. No money.

**In plain terms**. If the child is under 1 year of age, do not feed honey. Honey water, honey mixed into complementary foods, and pastries that contain honey all count. Honey can carry the bacterium that causes botulism. The bacteria in an adult's gut can hold it down. An infant's cannot.

**Benefit**. The US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention says "do not feed honey to children under 1 year of age," because "honey may contain the bacteria that cause botulism." An adult's gut bacteria can hold down these spores (the dormant form of this bacterium). An infant's cannot.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. What must not be fed includes honey water, complementary foods mixed with honey, and pastries that contain honey.

## 7. The vitamin K shot at birth has to be given

**Cost**. 0 yuan to a few dozen yuan. This sum is usually already inside the hospital bill for the birth, so you do not pay it separately.

**In plain terms**. A newborn has very little vitamin K stored. Without a supplement, bleeding can occur, and the kind that shows up late is often bleeding in the brain. In Tashkent, where this prevention was not generally done, 478 out of every 100000 newborns had this bleeding. With prevention, the estimate is that more than 78% can be cut. For a home birth, or a birth at an irregular facility, ask whether it was given.

**Benefit**. A newborn has very little vitamin K stored. Without a supplement, vitamin K deficiency bleeding can occur, and the kind that shows up late often presents as intracranial hemorrhage (bleeding in the brain). The Belgian consensus recommendation is "1 intramuscular injection of 1 or 2 milligrams of vitamin K at birth." Where prevention is not provided systematically, the rate of vitamin K deficiency bleeding is 478 cases per 100000 people. That figure comes from 42000 newborns in Tashkent. The authors estimate that prevention can bring the rate down by "more than 78.5%."

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. At a regular hospital in China, the hospital generally gives this shot as routine. That is the author's experience. No single nationwide official rule was found. Before discharge, look at the discharge summary, or ask. For a home birth, or a birth at an irregular facility, confirm it on your own initiative. The injection meant here goes into the muscle. That Belgian consensus calls the oral route "a slightly worse substitute," used only when the parents refuse the injection: 2 milligrams by mouth at birth, then, for a breastfed child, 1 to 2 milligrams a week for 3 months.

## 8. If an infant under 3 months reaches 38 °C, go to the hospital directly and do not watch at home

**Cost**. Registration plus tests, a few hundred yuan.

**In plain terms**. If the child is under 3 months and the temperature reaches 38 °C, go to the hospital directly. Do not watch at home, and do not give a fever medicine first and then wait. The American Academy of Pediatrics set a specific plan for febrile infants who still look all right, so "looking all right" is not a reason to wait at home. The UK guidance also counts a child under 3 months with a fever of 38 °C as high risk of serious illness.

**Benefit**. The American Academy of Pediatrics wrote a specific guideline for full-term infants from 8 to 60 days of age who still look all right. That guideline defines fever as "a temperature of 38.0 °C or above." It splits them into 3 bands, 8 to 21 days, 22 to 28 days, and 29 to 60 days, and gives each band its own path. Infants under 8 days of age are outside that guideline. The UK NICE fever guideline covers children under 5 years of age. It states that a child under 3 months with a temperature of 38 °C or above is in the "high-risk group for serious illness."

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. At this age, a serious bacterial infection can show up as fever alone. So looking "all right" is not a reason to watch at home. Do not give a fever medicine yourself and then wait and see.

## 9. No matter how tired or angry you are, never shake a baby

**Cost**. There is no monetary cost. The real difficulty lies in resisting the urge to shake a baby when you're exhausted or upset.

**In plain terms**. A baby's head makes up a large proportion of their body size, yet their neck muscles are still very weak. Shaking them forcefully can cause bleeding inside the brain and eyes, potentially leading to death or lifelong disabilities. Gentle rocking while trying to soothe them is not dangerous; the real risk comes from uncontrolled, violent shaking. When you feel yourself losing control, place the baby back in their crib and step away for a few minutes. Letting them cry for a short while is far safer than holding them and shaking them.

**Benefit**. Because a baby's head is proportionally large and their neck muscles are underdeveloped, violent shaking can result in intracranial and retinal hemorrhage — bleeding in both the brain and eyes. This can be fatal or leave lasting impairments. Such harm is distinct from any gentle rocking used to calm them. Medically, injuries caused by shaking or impact are termed “abusive head trauma.” This condition is the leading cause of death from head injuries among children under 2 years old. In the United States between 1999 and 2014, it accounted for nearly 2,250 deaths of children under 5.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. When you truly feel you're about to lose control, the safest action is to return the baby to their crib and leave the room for a few minutes. Allowing them to cry briefly is much safer than holding them and shaking them. This advice is especially vital for parents who care for their children alone and often suffer from sleep deprivation. For guidance on managing your own emotions, please refer to Section 3.

## 10. For diapers, ignore the brand and check 3 things: the fit, how often you change it, and whether a sampling notice has named it

**Cost**. From 200 or 300 yuan a month up to more than 1000 yuan, depending on the grade you use.

**In plain terms**. No official body has ranked "which brand is best." Only 2 things can be checked: product-quality sampling notices from the State Administration for Market Regulation (市场监管总局), and regulator investigations of a specific event. Expensive does not mean safe, and imported does not mean up to standard. Buy a small pack and try it for 1 week. Look for a red bottom and marks from tightness, and stock up only if it fits.

**Benefit**. No official body has published a ranking of "which brand is best," so this book does not recommend a brand. Only 2 kinds of information can be checked. The 1st is product-quality sampling notices from the State Administration for Market Regulation. The 2nd is a regulator's investigation of a specific event. After the "infant diaper formamide problem" drew attention in June (6) 2026, the State Administration for Market Regulation led a joint investigation team to look into it.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. When the joint investigation team was set up, it only said "the relevant findings will be announced in due course." TODO (to be checked: the investigation's conclusion. As of September (9) 30, 2026, no conclusion on diapers was found on the State Administration for Market Regulation website or in the national supervision sampling notices of recent years). How to buy in practice: expensive does not equal safe, and imported does not equal up to standard. Buy a small pack and try it for 1 week. Look for a red bottom and marks from tightness, and stock up only if it fits. Those sentences are the author's experience. The UK NHS says common reasons for a red bottom are urine and stool left on the skin too long, not changing often enough, and the diaper rubbing the skin. Some diapers that do not absorb, or do not breathe, can also cause

it. The NHS also says the diaper should fit, and should not be wrapped too tight. How to look up sampling notices is in Section 5.

## 11. For big items, consider them in the order borrow, buy used, buy new, and do not kit everything out all at 1 time

**Cost**. No extra money. What you save is usually counted by the 1000 yuan. The hard part is holding back from kitting everything out all at 1 time.

**In plain terms**. A stroller, a swaddle, and toys are used for a short time. Borrow first. If you cannot borrow, buy used. Buy new last. For a used car seat, confirm it was not in a heavier crash, was not recalled, and has all its parts. If you cannot confirm that, do not use it. In a Scottish study, usually sleeping on a mattress another child had used carried about 3 times the sudden-death risk, but it is not clear whether the mattress caused it. A mattress is best bought new.

**Benefit**. Strollers, cribs, swaddles, and toys are all used for a short time, and the used market has far more supply than demand. Used goods have 3 safety lines. The 1st is the car seat. The US National Highway Traffic Safety Administration says a seat that has been in a moderate or severe crash must be replaced and never used again. All 5 conditions must be met before a crash counts as minor and the seat can stay in use. The 5 are: the car could be driven away on its own, the door nearest the seat was not damaged, no one in the car was injured, the airbag did not deploy, and no damage can be seen on the seat. A used seat can be used only after you confirm 5 things. The 5 are: it has not been in a crash worse than minor, the label shows the date of manufacture and the model, it has not been recalled, the parts are complete, and the instructions are still there. The date of manufacture and the model are how you check recalls and whether the seat is too old. The 2nd is the mattress. A Scottish study compared infants who died suddenly with healthy infants of the same age, and looked back at which mattress each slept on. Usually sleeping on a mattress another child had used carried a higher risk of sudden infant death syndrome (OR 3.07, about 3 times, 95% CI 1.51–6.22). When the mattress came from another home the figure was 4.78. When it came from the same home it was 1.64, and the latter does not count as a difference. The authors say the evidence is not yet enough to judge whether the mattress itself caused it. The 3rd is the crib. From June (6) 28, 2011, the United States has enforced a new mandatory crib standard, and a used crib has to meet it too. The old style, with 1 side rail that drops, was phased out. The US Consumer Product Safety Commission says an old crib has to be taken apart and broken in the test before anyone knows whether it complies, so it gives no way to check it yourself. From November (11) 2007 to April (4) 2010, the United States reported 147 deaths linked to standard-size cribs. Of those, 35 were a problem in the crib's structure, and 18 were a failure of a rail that could be dropped. Loose screws caused at least 10 deaths. US law lists inclined infant sleepers as banned goods, no matter which year they were made, and that was written into the regulations in 2023 (United States, United Kingdom).

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The evidence grade stays C, because the money-saving 1/2 has no literature. The 3 safety lines each have a source, but all of them are from the United States and the United Kingdom. No official Chinese notice aimed at used cribs or used car seats was found. The mattress study was challenged: in 1997 a letter said family income and bed-sharing could mix up the effect of a used mattress. Why a car seat is used in the car is in Section 1, item 10 (car seat). How an infant sleeps, and what goes on the bed, is in item 1 of this section (sleep on the back). Postpartum centers, early-education classes, and baby swim classes are neither recommended nor ruled out in this book. Each of them is a large sum you can spend or not spend, and the 24-hour cooling-off period in Section 5 applies.

## 12. If the child has severe eczema or an egg allergy, do not avoid peanuts; add them early under a doctor's guidance, but never feed a whole peanut

**Cost**. A jar of peanut butter is a few dozen yuan. Feeding it a few times a week is easy to fit in. Before you add it, take the child to a doctor 1 time for an assessment.

**In plain terms**. An infant with severe eczema or an egg allergy should eat peanuts regularly from 4 to 11 months. Among those whose skin test showed no reaction at the start, 1.9% of the ones who ate peanuts had a peanut allergy at 5 years, against 13.7% of the ones who avoided peanuts completely. Among those whose skin test already showed a slight reaction, 10.6% of the ones who ate peanuts were allergic, against 35.3% of the ones who avoided them. See a doctor with the child before you add peanuts. Never feed a whole peanut. It can be inhaled into the airway.

**Benefit**. The UK LEAP randomized trial. 640 infants were enrolled, on the condition of severe eczema, an egg allergy, or both. They were 4 to 11 months old at enrollment. They were randomly split into 2 groups. 1 group ate peanut products regularly, and 1 group avoided them completely, and peanut allergy was checked at 60 months of age. Among the 530 whose peanut skin test was negative at enrollment, 13.7% of the avoidance group were allergic, against 1.9% of the group that ate peanuts (P<0.001). Among the 98 whose skin test was already weakly positive at enrollment, 35.3% of the avoidance group were allergic, against 10.6% of the group that ate peanuts (P=0.004). Serious adverse events did not differ between the 2 groups.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The form can only be thinned peanut butter, or peanut flour mixed into complementary food. Never give a whole peanut. The Health Commission's core feeding messages say it plainly: "Whole peanuts, nuts, jelly, and similar foods are easily inhaled into the airway and cause choking, and infants and young children should not eat them." What to do if a child chokes: under 1 year of age, see Section 13, item 43 (an infant choking and unable to cry); at 1 year or older, see Section 13, item 26 (someone choking and unable to speak). This applies only to high-risk children: those with severe eczema, or those already allergic to egg. You must see a doctor for an assessment before adding peanuts. Do not try it at home on your own. The LEAP trial gave every child a skin test before enrollment. Children whose skin-test reaction was greater than 4 millimeters were kept out of the trial and were not given peanuts to eat. The evidence for ordinary children is much weaker. In another trial of 1162 ordinary breastfed infants, counted by the group they were assigned to, food allergy was 5.6% in the early-introduction group and 7.1% in the usual group, and the difference was not significant (P=0.32). It was significant only among the children who actually did it (2.4% against 7.3%). That way of counting tends to make the effect look larger. The authors themselves say the assigned-group count did not prove efficacy, but it does show that early introduction is safe. Official Chinese feeding documents currently say nothing on "introduce allergenic foods early, or avoid them," so this item follows the international trial evidence. The timing needs care too: LEAP started at 4 months, while in China complementary foods start at a full 6 months. See item 4 of this section (breast milk only for the first 6 months). For a high-risk child, at how many months to start, and how to start, follow the doctor.

## 13. Watch these newborn jaundice signals: yellow within 24 hours of birth, or cannot be woken and will not feed, go to the hospital that day; getting yellower, or pale stools, go and get it checked soon

**Cost**. Registration plus a bilirubin test, within a few hundred yuan. If phototherapy is needed, it is usually about 2 days in hospital. The hard part is making the trip even when the child still looks all right.

**In plain terms**. More than 8 in 10 newborns are a bit yellow. Yellow before 24 hours of age, or yellow together with being sleepier than usual and hard to wake, not feeding, or a body that is floppy or stiff, means go to the hospital immediately. After 24 hours, getting yellower, or stool that turns pale, also means get it checked soon. Pale stool can be biliary atresia (胆道闭锁). Bilirubin that is too high can injure the brain and leave a disability for life.

**Benefit**. The American Academy of Pediatrics 2022 guideline says "more than 80% of newborns will have some degree of jaundice." Bilirubin that is too high can cause acute bilirubin encephalopathy and kernicterus (核黄疸). The guideline calls kernicterus "a permanent disabling neurological disease." Its features include cerebral palsy with limbs that twist on their own, an inability to look upward, poor enamel on the baby teeth, and hearing damage. The guideline lists "jaundice within 24 hours after birth" as a risk factor for going on to severe jaundice. The UK National Health Service (NHS) splits what it tells parents into 2 tiers. Tier 1 is to call emergency services or go straight to emergency care. That tier is a child who has jaundice and, at the same

time, is sleepier than usual or hard to wake, is not feeding, is floppy or stiff, or has jerking movements. A child who is jaundiced before 24 hours of age is also in this tier. Tier 2 is to see a doctor as soon as possible. That tier is age past 24 hours, jaundice that is not getting better or is getting worse, urine that is dark yellow or brown, or stool that is pale cream. A global estimate is that in 2010 about 480000 newborns had Rh hemolytic disease (caused by a blood-type mismatch between mother and child) or extreme hyperbilirubinemia. Of those children, 24% died, and 13% developed kernicterus. Of the children who survived kernicterus, more than 83% were left with 1 or more impairments. Pale stool can be biliary atresia. That disease needs a Kasai operation (葛西手术) within 60 days before the result is clearly better. From 2004, Taiwan printed a stool color card in every newborn's child-health handbook. The share who had the operation within 60 days rose from 60% in 2004 to 74.3% in 2005. In another Taiwan-wide study, after the color card was introduced, mortality among children with biliary atresia fell from 26.2% to 15.9%. That is a before-and-after comparison, not a trial that split children into groups.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Phototherapy (light treatment) uses a special light on the child's skin so bilirubin changes into a form that is easier to pass. Do not replace it by sitting the child in the sun at home. The American Academy of Pediatrics says sunshine is hard to make both safe and free of sunburn, so it does not recommend it as treatment. Do not feed water or glucose water to bring the yellow down. That guideline also says not to. Looking at how yellow the skin is does not estimate how high the bilirubin is. The UK NICE guideline states that you should not rely on the eye alone. If you are not sure, go and measure it 1 time. A child born before 38 weeks, a child whose older sibling had phototherapy, or a child who has not had enough breast milk is more likely to turn severely yellow. Follow-up follows the national basic public-health service specification: within 1 week after discharge, a health worker visits the home. At 28 to 30 days after birth, go to a community health service center or a township hospital for a follow-up visit. Both of the 2 visits check jaundice. If the doctor arranged a bilirubin recheck at discharge, go at the time that was set. If a full-term child is still yellow after 14 days, or a preterm child after 21 days, the NICE guideline requires 1 check of conjugated bilirubin, and a look at whether the stool is pale. Jaundice itself does not delay vaccination. See item 3 of this section (vaccines). Newborn screening is in Section 27, item 13 (heel-prick screening).

## 14. If you are eating vegetarian while pregnant or breastfeeding, take vitamin B12 or eat fortified foods; the child's complementary foods need animal foods, and if you insist on a fully vegan diet, see a doctor first

**Cost**. 1 bottle of vitamin B12 supplement is a few dozen yuan, 1 tablet a day. Adding egg, meat, or fish to the child's complementary foods does not cost much. The hard part is changing your mind when the whole family has decided that eating vegetarian is healthier.

**In plain terms**. Vitamin B12 is found almost only in meat, eggs, and milk. Someone eating fully vegan has to rely on fortified foods or a supplement. If the mother eats fully vegan and does not supplement, a breastfed child is likely to run short. The trouble usually shows at 4 to 8 months of age: not growing, development falling behind, and, if it drags on, nerve damage that may not come back. The child's complementary foods need animal foods every day.

**Benefit**. In 2003 the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention reported 2 children. Both were breastfed by mothers who ate vegetarian, both were short of vitamin B12, and both failed to grow and fell behind in development. The 1st child's mother had eaten fully vegan for 7 years. The child was admitted at 15 months of age, was found to have severe anemia, and a brain scan showed atrophy of the whole brain. After B12 was given the child improved, but at 32 months of age speech and language were still behind. The report says the most common reason an infant or young child is short of B12 is that the mother's diet is short of it. A breastfed child usually shows it at 4 to 8 months of age. If the shortage lasts long enough, some children are left with nerve damage that cannot be reversed. How bad it is depends on how severe the shortage was and how long it lasted. The only reliable sources that do not depend on fortification are animal foods: meat, dairy products, and eggs. Most of the B12 that occurs naturally in plants cannot be used by the body. Cereal, soy milk, and nutritional yeast with B12 added can be a steady source. The report asks people who eat

vegetarian, especially women who are pregnant or breastfeeding, to find out how much B12 is in what they eat, or to ask a nutrition professional. The 2016 position paper of the Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics states: "People who eat fully vegan need a reliable source of vitamin B12, such as fortified foods or a supplement." The 2017 complementary-feeding position paper of the European Society for Paediatric Gastroenterology, Hepatology and Nutrition states that all infants should eat iron-rich complementary foods, including meat or iron-fortified foods. A fully vegan diet should be followed only under proper supervision by a doctor or a dietitian, and parents have to understand the serious consequences of not supplementing as advised. The National Health Commission's 2020 core feeding messages require no fewer than 4 kinds of complementary food a day. That includes at least 1 animal food, 1 vegetable, and 1 cereal or tuber food.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Disputed. The 2016 position of the Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics is that a well-planned vegetarian diet and a well-planned vegan diet are suitable for every stage of life, including pregnancy, breastfeeding, infancy, and childhood. It also states that people who eat fully vegan need a reliable source of B12, such as fortified foods or a supplement. The 2 sides disagree on whether a fully vegan diet can feed an infant. They do not disagree that B12 must be supplemented. A vegetarian diet that includes eggs and milk is lower risk, but eating very little egg and milk can still leave a person short. The mother of the 2nd child in the report had eaten vegetarian for 20 years and almost never touched meat, fish, or dairy. Early symptoms of B12 shortage have no particular pattern. The US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention says anemia markers are not suitable for screening. If the child is growing slowly, or development is not keeping up, tell the doctor at the visit that the family eats vegetarian, and let the doctor decide what to test. Do not refuse treatment the doctor gives because you trust a folk remedy. See Section 16, item 4 (do not stop proper treatment to try a folk remedy). How to add complementary foods is in item 4 of this section (add complementary foods from 6 months). Folic acid in pregnancy is in Section 27, item 1 (supplement 0.4 milligrams of folic acid every day).

## 15. When buying things for an infant, do not buy a wheeled baby walker; if you want a place to sit and play, use a stationary activity center with no wheels, or a play yard

**Cost**. No money, and you save the price of 1 walker. A stationary activity center with no wheels, or a play yard, has to be bought separately, or it can be borrowed. The hard part is being willing to throw it out when an elder gave it, or when you already bought it.

**In plain terms**. A child sitting in a baby walker can shoot more than 0.9 meters in 1 second, and most injuries happen while an adult is right there watching. From 1990 to 2014, children in the United States made about 230000 emergency visits because of baby walkers. 9 in 10 of the injuries were to the head and neck, mostly the child and the walker falling down stairs together. A baby walker also does not teach a child to walk.

**Benefit**. From 1990 to 2014, children under 15 months who went to emergency care for a baby-walker injury made an estimated 230000 visits (exact value 230676). Of those, 90.6% were injured on the head or neck, and 74.1% fell down stairs while sitting in the walker. 4.5% were admitted after the injury, and 37.8% of the admitted children had a skull fracture. From 2010 the United States enforced a mandatory safety standard for baby walkers. Over the 4 years after that, the average number of injuries each year was 22.7% lower than over the 4 years before. The authors still say a baby walker remains an important source of injury to children, and it can be avoided. The American Academy of Pediatrics 2001 position statement says that from 1973 to 1998 the United States reported 34 deaths linked to baby walkers. Warning labels, publicity and education, an adult watching beside the child, and a stair gate have all been shown not to prevent this kind of injury. A baby walker also has no clear benefit, so the academy calls for a ban on making and selling wheeled baby walkers, and recommends a fixed activity center with no wheels instead. The note the academy gives parents says most baby-walker injuries happen while an adult is right there watching. A child sitting in a walker can shoot more than 3 feet (about 0.9 meters) in 1 second. On whether a walker helps a child learn to walk, the academy says it does not, and may delay it. The evidence that it delays walking is not strong. In 1 Irish

survey of 190 infants, children who used a walker walked independently about 3 weeks later on average (61.12 weeks against 58.14 weeks). The more they used it, the later they walked. That was only a 1-time questionnaire, with no grouped comparison. 1 small review in 2002 found 2 trials that assigned children at random, and neither showed a clear effect on when walking started. Pooling 4 studies, the delay was 11 to 26 days, and the quality of the studies was low throughout.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. From April (4) 7, 2004, Canada has banned the sale, advertising, and import of baby walkers. Used ones may not be sold at flea markets or garage sales either. For a walker already in the home, the official advice is to take it apart and throw it out. The current Canada Consumer Product Safety Act puts it on the banned-sale list. Nobody may make, import, advertise, or sell a walker. No ban was found in China. Infant baby walkers are made to the current national standard GB 14749-2006. The standard governs the product itself. It does not stop a child from shooting toward the stairs. From 1997, a baby walker in the United States either had to be made wider than a door, or had to have a brake at the edge of a step, and the academy still considers that not enough. A child sitting in a walker can reach higher, and can also pull a tablecloth and tip hot coffee, grab a pot handle on the stove, or fall, walker and all, into a pool or a bathtub. The academy suggests 3 substitutes: a fixed activity center with no wheels (the seat can turn and can bounce), a play yard, and a high chair. When you send the child to a childcare place or to someone else's home, confirm they are not using a baby walker there either. The order for buying big items is in item 11 of this section (consider big items in the order borrow, buy used, buy new).

## 16. From birth, give the child 400 international units of vitamin D every day, and do not skip it if the child is breastfed; a full-term baby generally does not need extra calcium in the first 6 months

**Cost**. 1 bottle of vitamin D drops is a few dozen yuan, given 1 time a day. The hard part is remembering every day, at least until 1 year of age.

**In plain terms**. Breast milk has very little vitamin D, and an infant should not be in the sun for long, so it has to be supplemented every day. In a rural area of Turkey, 3.8% of the children who were not supplemented got rickets within 1 year, and not 1 of the children who were supplemented got it. Give the amount the doctor says. A normal full-term child generally does not need extra calcium in the first 6 months.

**Benefit**. A Cochrane review in 2020 says breast milk is low in vitamin D, and an infant who takes only breast milk is likely to fall short. The American Academy of Pediatrics says a child who stays outside for long needs sun protection, so every infant needs vitamin D. The National Health Commission's 2020 core feeding messages say: "From birth, an infant should receive 400-800 international units of vitamin D every day, under a doctor's guidance." The same passage also says: "A normal full-term infant generally does not need a calcium supplement in the 6 months after birth." The 2016 global consensus on rickets had 11 international academic bodies taking part. The consensus says 400 IU (10 micrograms) a day is enough to prevent rickets. Every infant should be supplemented from birth to 12 months, whether breastfed or formula-fed. That is a strong recommendation, and the evidence quality is moderate. In a study in rural northeastern Turkey, no child who received 400 IU a day got rickets. Among the children who were not supplemented, 3.8% newly developed rickets over 12 months. The consensus also says that, worldwide, there is no report of radiographically confirmed rickets in an infant who received 400 IU on time every day. In 1992 China ran a grouped study in 4 cities, north and south, supplementing 100, 200, or 400 IU a day. By 6 months, no child in any of the 3 groups had rickets. But vitamin D in the cord blood of northern newborns was only about 1/3 of the southern level (12.5 against 35.0 nmol/L). The more that was supplemented, the higher the level at 6 months, and the authors suggest 400 IU a day.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The grade is B because the figures on preventing rickets come from comparisons that were not randomly assigned. A Cochrane review in 2020 pooled the trials that supplemented infants. At 400 IU a day, children short of vitamin D were fewer by about 4 in 10 (RR 0.57). The trials were all small, and they could

not show whether rickets fell. The benefit is set at medium by judgment, because how common infant rickets is in China was not found. The advice for formula-fed infants is not the same everywhere. The American Academy of Pediatrics says that if the child drinks more than about 800 milliliters (27 ounces) a day of formula with vitamin D added, no extra supplement is needed. The domestic core messages say every infant is supplemented, and the exact amount follows what the doctor says. Do not raise the dose yourself. In a Canadian trial, the group on 1600 IU a day had vitamin D in the blood that was too high, and that arm was stopped early. Growth and bone did not differ across the groups from 400 to 1200 IU. An adult who is not short of vitamin D should not supplement it in order to live longer. See Section 6, item 3 (people who are not short of vitamin D).

## 17. When bathing an infant, put cold water in first and then mix in hot, and test it with the inside of the wrist or the elbow before putting the child in; if the water heater can set the outlet temperature, set it below 50 °C

**Cost**. No money. Each bath takes 1 or 2 extra minutes to test the water. If you want it steadier, you can buy a water thermometer. The hard part is still testing before you put the child in, even when the child is crying and the adult is in a hurry.

**In plain terms**. Hot water at 65 °C, in contact for 2 seconds, gives most adults a 3rd-degree burn, and an infant's skin is thinner. Put cold water in the basin first, then mix in hot. Stir it even, test it with the inside of the wrist or the elbow, and only then put the child in. Do not wash the child under a running tap. After 1 US state lowered the factory outlet temperature of water heaters to 49 °C, hospital admissions of children for hot-water burns fell by more than 1/2.

**Benefit**. The US Consumer Product Safety Commission says most adults get a 3rd-degree burn from 2 seconds in water at 150 °F (about 65 °C). Water at 140 °F (60 °C) for 6 seconds, or water at 130 °F (about 54 °C) for 30 seconds, also scalds. Even at 120 °F (49 °C), a soak of 5 minutes can still cause a 3rd-degree burn. A World Health Organization report says the skin of infants and young children is thinner than an adult's, so a lower temperature can scald, and the scald goes deeper. The American Academy of Pediatrics teaches parents to test the water in the basin with the inside of the wrist or the elbow, and that it should be "warm, not hot." "Never bathe a baby under running water," because water moving through the pipes swings hot and cold, and a small change can scald. In 1983 the US state of Washington passed a law that new water heaters leave the factory preset at 49 °C. By 1988, the average home hot-water temperature had fallen from 61 °C in 1977 to 50 °C. Hospital admissions of children for tap-water burns fell from 5.5 a year in the 70s to 2.4 a year. Burned area, skin grafts, deaths, and days in hospital all fell too. That is a before-and-after comparison, not a trial that split people into groups. Australia sets a maximum of 50 °C for bathroom hot-water taps. In New South Wales from 1989 to 1996, the rate of hospital admission for burns among children aged 0 to 4 fell by 13%. Severe burns, those with a hospital stay of 10 days or more, fell by 30% in the 2 years after the 2nd stage. In 3 Chinese hospital series of childhood burns, scalds from hot liquid accounted for 87.6% to 90.6%, and children under 3 years were the largest share.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The grade is B because the figures come from before-and-after comparisons and from case records, with no trial that split people into groups. The benefit is set at medium by judgment, because a separate domestic figure for bath-water burns was not found. Water heaters come in 2 kinds. An instantaneous heater, such as a gas water heater, has its outlet temperature set directly below 50 °C. A storage electric water heater is a separate case. The World Health Organization guide on preventing Legionella suggests keeping the heater outlet at 60 °C, and hot water at the tap no lower than 50 °C. Legionella is a bacterium that can cause pneumonia. The same guide also says that preventing Legionella must not raise the risk of a child being scalded, and a thermostatic mixing valve can be fitted at the outlet. If none is fitted, rely on cold first, then hot, and on testing before you put the child in. Do not walk away during the bath. The American Academy of Pediatrics says more than 1/2 of children who drown in a bathtub are under 1 year of age. See Section 1, item 12 (stay in sight near water). Do not carry hot water or hot soup while you are holding the child. The World

Health Organization says that in high-income countries, the most common burn in an infant under 1 year of age is a scald from a hot drink in a cup. If the child is burned, run cool water first. See Section 13, item 14 (run cool water after a burn).

# 21. Traveling abroad, trips, and safety overseas

This section deals with both financial matters and personal freedom, and several points also relate to physical safety. Once you're overseas, it's the laws of the host country that apply — not Chinese law. There are clear limits to what China's embassies and consulates can do to assist you. This section explains those limits in detail.

## 1. Before you leave, check the Ministry of Foreign Affairs safety advisory once, and do not go anywhere marked "Do not travel for now"

**Cost**. No money. Open the China Consular Service website and read through that page. It takes a few minutes.

**In plain terms**. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs sorts safety risks abroad into 4 levels. The highest is called "Do not travel for now." From September (9) 15, 2026, staying away from high-risk countries and regions is written into an administrative regulation. When you apply for documents and when you go through exit checks, staff will also remind you, and when needed they will urge you not to go. Reading that page before you leave takes a few minutes.

**Benefit**. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs publishes safety advisories for foreign countries, ranked by risk. From low to high there are about 4 levels: "Pay attention to safety," "Strengthen safety precautions," "Travel with caution," and "Do not travel for now." The new rule in force from September (9) 15, 2026 also writes a personal duty into an administrative regulation. The original text says: "Chinese citizens shall pay attention to safety advisories for foreign countries and to safety-risk notices for tourist destinations, and shall avoid traveling to and remaining in high-risk countries or regions." The new rule also requires the immigration authorities (the departments that issue entry and exit documents and run border inspection), when handling documents and at exit border inspection, to remind people who are heading to high-risk areas. The original text of that part says: "For a Chinese citizen preparing to go to a country or region whose risk level is the highest, or where cases that seriously endanger personal safety have suddenly become frequent, they shall, when necessary, dissuade that person from going."

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Advisories change with the situation. This book does not copy the list. Check that page yourself once before you travel. As of September (9) 7, 2026, that column still carried these "Do not travel for now" advisories: Eswatini (2026-08-25), Palestine (2023-10-10), and Sudan (2023-04-17). Another 4 are Afghanistan (2023-02-17), Syria (2023-01-04), Peru (2022-12-29), and Somalia (2022-11-24). There are also special advisories for northern Myanmar and for some provinces of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. Travel agencies also have a duty to tell you. The Tourism Law says that when a package-tour contract is signed, the agency must tell you the safety points to watch and the laws, customs, and religious taboos of the destination. A package-tour contract has to be in writing. Before you join a group, you can ask them to write down the risks at the destination. That last point is the author's suggestion.

## 2. Save the 12308 hotline number and your local embassy/consulate's consular protection number in your phone, then write them down and keep a copy in your wallet — don't wait until an emergency to look them up

**Cost**. No cost at all. Saving two numbers and writing one copy down takes just a few minutes.

**In plain terms**. When something happens, call the Ministry of Foreign Affairs global consular-protection hotline first. If you are in China, dial 12308. If you are abroad, dial +86-10-12308. Since this hotline opened, it has taken more than 3000000 calls. Over the same period, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and its missions abroad handled more than 500000 consular-protection cases.

**Benefit**. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs operates a 24-hour global emergency hotline for consular protection and services. Inside China, call 12308; abroad, call +86-10-12308 or +86-10-65612308. Since its launch in 2014, this hotline has answered over 3 million calls, while the Ministry and its overseas missions have resolved more than 500,000 consular protection incidents.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Your local embassy or consulate also maintains its own consular protection hotline, which is often quicker to reach than the main hotline. Before traveling, look up that number on the China Consular Service website for your destination country and save it alongside the main hotline number. However, if your phone is lost or runs out of battery, those saved numbers become useless. That's why it's wise to write down both numbers and keep one copy in your wallet, or give a copy to a family member.

## 3. Know what consular protection can and cannot do: it can visit you, it cannot get you out, and you still pay the costs

**Cost**. No money. Spend a few minutes and read this line clearly.

**In plain terms**. If you are arrested abroad, what the embassy or consulate can do is check the facts with the local side, ask that you be handled fairly and according to law, come to see you, and sit in when the court hears the case. It cannot change the judgment for you, and it cannot take you away. Food, lodging, transport, and medical bills that someone else paid first are still yours to pay in the end. So get your money and your insurance ready before you leave, and do not treat "if something happens, the state will cover it" as the plan.

**Benefit**. If you are arrested, the embassy or consulate can do these things. It can check the situation with the relevant department of the host country and ask that you be handled fairly and according to law. The original text of the regulations says: "visit that person or contact that person in accordance with the law of the host country and the international treaties China and the host country have concluded or both joined, learn what that person needs, and require the relevant department of the host country to give that Chinese citizen humanitarian treatment and fair treatment." In everyday words, the embassy or consulate visits you, contacts you, and asks what you need, following local law and the treaties both countries signed, and it asks the local side to treat you by a humane and fair standard. When the court sits, the embassy or consulate may attend and may ask that your rights in the case be protected. If you are injured or caught in a disaster, it can press the local side for emergency help and can help your family with the aftermath. On money, the regulations are just as clear: "Where a Chinese citizen, legal person, or unincorporated organization, in the course of consular protection and assistance, receives goods and services such as food and lodging, transport, and medical care provided by a third party, that person or organization shall pay the expenses that it should bear itself." Food, lodging, transport, and medical care that someone else advanced, if they are yours to pay, are still yours to pay.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The embassy or consulate will not pay your fine, will not pay your medical bill, will not buy your plane ticket, and cannot change the conclusion of the host country's court. What it can give you is information on local lawyers, translators, medical care, and funeral homes, and it can help you contact relatives and friends and help you find a channel for relief. So get your money and your insurance ready yourself before you leave, and do not treat "if something happens, the state will cover it" as the plan.

## 4. Buy a policy that covers overseas medical care and medical evacuation, and do not buy only flight-delay insurance

**Cost**. A short-term overseas travel policy costs a few dozen to a few hundred yuan.

**In plain terms**. Medical bills abroad come out of your own pocket. China's basic medical insurance almost never pays them, and the embassy or consulate will not advance the money either. What can really drag a family under is not the outpatient fee. It is the hospital stay after a serious injury, and getting the person

home, which takes a special flight or a medical escort. When you buy travel insurance, look mainly at 2 limits: overseas medical expenses, and emergency medical evacuation and return.

**Benefit**. Medical bills abroad are yours to pay. Domestic yibao (医保 — basic medical insurance) basically does not reimburse care abroad. Consular protection does not advance this money either. See item 3 of this section (what consular protection can and cannot do). The basis is Article 26 of the regulations. What can really drag a family under is not the outpatient fee. It is the hospital stay after a serious injury, and medical evacuation. Moving a person from a hospital abroad back to China takes a special flight or a medical escort, and that is among the most expensive items you pay for yourself. The US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention says that emergency transport of a patient from a remote place to a good hospital, if you pay it yourself, can cost more than 100000 US dollars. When you buy insurance, look first at 2 limits. The first is the limit for overseas medical expenses. The other is the limit for emergency medical evacuation and return, which is how much can be paid, at most, for a transfer after something happens and for sending the person home.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. 100000 US dollars is a floor, not a range of costs. No published official or industry range of costs was found, so this book does not write a specific range. Before you buy, confirm 3 things. First, whether the country you are going to is inside the coverage. Second, whether high-risk activities such as diving, skiing, and riding a motorcycle are excluded. Third, whether the insurer settles directly with the hospital, or you pay first and claim it back later. Buy it for a visa-free country as well.

## 5. Treat every "high-paying job overseas" as a scam; if you are tricked into telecom fraud and come back, you may also be barred from leaving the country

**Cost**. No money. The hard part is personally turning down a job that looks very good.

**In plain terms**. The monthly pay is absurdly high, they do not ask about education or experience, they do not sign a proper contract, they tell you to gather first in a border city, and they keep your passport for you. If you take that kind of work, neither you nor the passport is in your own hands. If the papers are false when you exit, border inspection will stop you and will not let you through. If you break the law abroad, or harm national security and national interests, you may also be barred from leaving the country for 6 months to 3 years after you come back.

**Benefit**. The official description of this kind of case is direct. In recent years there have been people who "leave the country because they were deceived, or illegally leave the country on a made-up pretext, to engage in cross-border gambling, telecom and network fraud, and other illegal activity, seriously harming the safety of the public's lives and property." That means being tricked into going, or inventing a reason and slipping out, and then gambling and running telecom fraud over there. The new rule tightens both ends of this. On the way out: "The reason given for an application to exit or enter, or to stay or reside, shall be true and lawful." If you hand in false materials or tell a lie, the immigration authority has the power not to issue you documents and not to let you leave. On the way back: "Where a Chinese citizen engages in illegal or criminal activity abroad and harms national security and national interests, a decision may be made… that the person shall not leave the country for a period of not less than 6 months and not more than 3 years from the date of return." A person placed in administrative detention for obtaining documents by fraud, or for illegal exit or entry, is likewise barred from leaving the country for 6 months to 3 years.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The signs are basically fixed: monthly pay far above the same job, no requirement for education or experience, no proper contract, a first gathering in a border city, and someone else arranging the visa and keeping your passport. Northern Myanmar already has a specific consular advisory. If you actually go, your personal liberty and your passport are not in your own hands. Do not assume you can leave whenever you want to.

## 6. Overseas cash withdrawals in a year cannot exceed 100000 yuan, counted together across every card in your own name; if you carry cash in or out, RMB is at most 20000 yuan each time, and foreign currency over 5000 US dollars must be declared to customs

**Cost**. No money. Before you leave, estimate how much cash this trip will need, and put the rest on a card. The hard part is changing the habit: if you can pay by card, do not withdraw cash. If you need to carry a large amount of foreign currency in cash out of the country, you first have to go to a bank and get a permit, which is an extra trip.

**In plain terms**. Overseas cash withdrawals are counted together across every bank card in your own name, with a cap of 100000 yuan a year. Once you go over it, you cannot withdraw again for the rest of that year or the next year. Card spending is not affected. If you carry cash in or out, RMB is at most 20000 yuan each time, and foreign currency over 5000 US dollars must be declared to customs. If you do not declare it, you may be fined. Hiding it and carrying it counts as smuggling, and the cash can be confiscated.

**Benefit**. The basis is the State Administration of Foreign Exchange notice on regulating large overseas cash withdrawals with bank cards, Hui Fa [2017] No. 29, in force from January (1) 1, 2018. Article 1: "Where an individual withdraws cash overseas with a domestic bank card, the bank cards in that person's own name (including supplementary cards), taken together, shall not exceed the equivalent of 100000 yuan in each calendar year. If the annual quota is exceeded, overseas cash withdrawal with a domestic bank card will be suspended for the current year and the following year." Paragraph 2 of the same article: "An individual shall not evade, or help someone else evade, the controls on overseas cash withdrawal by borrowing another person's bank card or by lending out his or her own bank card." Article 2: every day the foreign-exchange authority sends the suspension list to the card-issuing banks, and a card-issuing bank shall, no later than 17 o'clock Beijing time that day, suspend overseas cash withdrawal with that bank's cards for the people on the list. Article 3: a person placed on the suspension list may take a valid identity document to a branch of the foreign-exchange authority and look up his or her own overseas cash-withdrawal record. Article 4: the per-card daily cap for a foreign-currency card was adjusted from the equivalent of 1000 US dollars to the equivalent of 10000 yuan; for an RMB card, the cap stays at no more than the equivalent of 10000 yuan per card per day. Article 6: where a card-issuing bank, a domestic RMB-card clearing organization, or an individual violates this notice, the penalty follows the relevant provisions of the Regulations of the People's Republic of China on Foreign Exchange Administration. A press Q&A from the foreign-exchange authority also makes a few points clear. The notice does not affect an individual's card spending overseas. Ordinary transactions for food, lodging, transport, and shopping on an overseas trip, a business trip, or study abroad can all be paid by bank card. That spending also does not use up the annual 50000 US dollar facilitation quota for buying foreign exchange. The annual quota is calculated by the foreign-exchange authority from the data of all the card-issuing institutions, because real-time control would slow the response of the transaction, and "the foreign-exchange authority uses a delayed control method" (it does not block the transaction on the spot). Separately, statistics show that in 2016, 81% of overseas cash withdrawals on domestic bank cards were below 30000 yuan, nationwide. Carrying cash in or out has a separate set of rules. The new customs declaration form in use from April (4) 1, 2025 says on the back: "The RMB each person carries in or out each time shall not exceed 20000 yuan." For foreign-currency cash on the way in, "an amount exceeding the equivalent of 5000 US dollars shall be declared to customs in writing." On the way out, if you carry the equivalent of more than 5000 US dollars and up to 10000 US dollars, you first get a Permit for Carrying Foreign Exchange out of the Country from a bank, then declare it to customs. Above 10000 US dollars, you get that permit from the State Administration of Foreign Exchange. The foreign-exchange authority's measures state that a person leaving the country "in principle shall not carry foreign-currency cash exceeding the equivalent of 10000 US dollars out of the country." The customs measures on supervision of luggage and articles provide that currency cash above the set amount must be declared to customs in writing both on the way in and on the way out. If the written declaration is still not finished when customs starts the inspection, it counts as not declared. If you did not declare it, but you did not hide it, customs gives a warning and may impose a fine of up to 20% of the value of the goods. If you hide it, disguise it, or under-

declare it, that counts as smuggling: the cash is confiscated, and a fine of up to the same value may also be imposed.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The quota is counted by the calendar year, and the total starts again on January (1) 1. What is suspended is only overseas cash withdrawal. Card spending is not affected. If you really need a large amount of cash overseas, buy the foreign exchange first under the Measures for the Administration of Individual Foreign Exchange, then carry the foreign-currency cash out. Above 5000 US dollars, remember to get the carrying permit first and declare it in the red channel at customs. The destination country has its own declaration threshold too. Check it once before you leave. For example, US customs states that bringing more than 10000 US dollars into or out of the United States each time must be declared, and a family traveling together is counted on the combined amount. The cash rules were checked against the official sites on October (10) 14, 2026. The withdrawal itself has 2 further pitfalls, which the UnionPay International page (境外 ATM 取款) states. First, on a dual-logo card, at some ATMs in some countries, you cannot choose the UnionPay channel to withdraw. Second, some overseas ATMs show an extra fee (surcharge) on the screen. The local acquirer charges that money, and it "has nothing to do with UnionPay." The same page also says: "Because a credit-card withdrawal requires payment of overdraft interest, cardholders are advised to use a UnionPay debit card for overseas withdrawals." For a lost card, a card swallowed by the machine, or a card used without your authorization, see section 14, item 5 (report a skimmed card lost and freeze it, then call the police). The limits on withdrawals and on carrying cash are as of October (10) 2026. Before you leave, follow the latest notices from the foreign-exchange authority and from customs.

## 7. Take photos of your passport, visa, and ID card and store them in the cloud; if lost, report to police first and then apply for a travel document

**Cost**. No cost involved. Simply take a few photos before you depart.

**In plain terms**. If your passport is lost, the embassy or consulate can issue you a travel document for the trip home, but you have to prove who you are. If you have photos of the data page and the visa page, and your entry and exit records, the replacement is much faster. You also have to report the loss to the local police first and get the receipt. Exit checks and insurance claims in many countries ask for that paper. A phone is often lost together with the passport, so do not keep the photos only on the phone.

**Benefit**. When a passport is lost, foreign embassies or consulates can issue a travel document for repatriation, but only after you verify your identity. The speed of this process depends heavily on whether you possess clear photos of the passport data page, visa pages, and entry/exit records. Additionally, obtaining a police report is mandatory for border checks and insurance claims in many countries. The contact numbers for embassy assistance are the same two emergency hotlines listed in item 2.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Store the photos in two separate locations — for instance, upload one set to cloud storage and send another to a trusted family member. Also print a hard copy and keep it apart from the original documents. Photograph your bank cards and prescriptions as well. Since phones and passports are frequently lost together, relying only on phone storage is insufficient. Cloud services often require SMS verification, which becomes impossible if your phone is lost; test access from another device before travel to ensure you can retrieve the files. Photos of official documents are sensitive information; encrypted storage is safer, but if you forget the password, no one can access them, so the copy sent to family members remains essential.

## 8. Before you drive yourself abroad, first confirm whether the local side accepts a Chinese driver's license; most "international driver's licenses" sold online are worthless paper

**Cost**. No money. Check the destination's rules once before you leave.

**In plain terms**. An "international driver's license" arranged online is not valid in mainland China. That document is a translation mutually recognized among parties to the 1949 Geneva Convention, and mainland China is not among the 103 parties. So whoever arranges it for you inside China, it has no legal effect. Whether you can drive on a Chinese license depends on the destination's own rules. If you have not confirmed that clearly, do not drive.

**Benefit**. A so-called "international driver's license" (IDP) is a translation mutually recognized among the parties to the 1949 Convention on Road Traffic. That convention was concluded in Geneva on September (9) 19, 1949, and entered into force on March (3) 26, 1952. There are now 103 parties (countries and regions that signed). Mainland China is not on that list. So China does not issue this kind of international driver's license. Any agency that "arranges an international driver's license" inside China produces no legal effect. Whether you can drive on a Chinese license depends on the rules of the destination country or region. Some accept a Chinese license plus a notarized translation, some require you to exchange it for a local license, and some do not accept it at all.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If the local side does not accept the license you are driving on, the insurance may refuse to pay when something happens, and that is the real cost. This sentence is the author's experience. The policy terms and local law are what decide it. There are 2 ways to check: look up "Information for Chinese citizens" for the destination country on the China Consular Service website, or ask the rental company directly for a written confirmation. Hong Kong, Macao, Taiwan, and some countries have separate arrangements.

## 9. Before you use an agency for a visa, study abroad, or immigration, ask whether it has filed with the immigration authority

**Cost**. No money. Ask a further question about whether it has filed, and keep the written papers.

**In plain terms**. From September (9) 15, 2026, an agency that handles visas, study abroad, or immigration has to file with the immigration authority. Drumming up clients with exaggerated claims, and providing or helping to provide false materials, are both expressly forbidden. If you hear "guaranteed to pass," "visa guaranteed," or "we will prepare the materials for you," be careful.

**Benefit**. In 2018 the entry permit for private entry-exit agencies was cancelled (opening an agency no longer requires an approval document first). After that the number of agencies grew quickly, and there was also the problem that "the true number of agencies is unclear, some agencies handle business in violation of the rules, and the lawful rights and interests of people exiting and entering are harmed." The authorities could not even count how many there were. From September (9) 15, 2026, this kind of agency is managed by filing. An agency shall report to the immigration authority where it is located within 15 days from the day it is established. Those already operating have to complete the filing within 90 days from the day the rule takes effect. Several kinds of conduct are expressly forbidden. The first is "publishing false information, or soliciting clients by exaggerated publicity, misleading publicity, or similar means." The second is "providing or assisting in providing false materials, and assisting others in handling, in violation of the rules, visas, stay or residence documents, passports, or other exit-entry documents or procedures." The third is "leaking, selling, or illegally providing ... personal privacy or personal information." The fourth is "organizing or assisting others in cross-border illegal or criminal activity." Overseas enterprises and institutions must not provide this kind of agency service inside China.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. An agency that keeps "guaranteed to pass," "visa guaranteed," or "we will prepare the materials for you" in its mouth is already doing something that is expressly forbidden. Once it is found out, the person who bears the consequences is the applicant. An unintentional mistake when you fill in the form yourself is generally a refusal this time. That is the author's experience. If false materials are used and it is found to be fraud, the consequences are much heavier. Take the United States as an example. Its immigration law says that a foreigner who applies for a visa by fraud or by a willful misrepresentation of a material fact "shall be

inadmissible." Policy advice and information lookup that are not done to make money do not count as agency services.

## 10. Do not issue an invitation letter for a stranger, and do not let someone handle entry and exit procedures in your name

**Cost**. No money. The hard part is turning down a personal favor face to face.

**In plain terms**. If you issue an invitation letter or application materials for someone else and the contents are not true, the person fined is the person who issued them. An individual is fined 5000 yuan to 10000 yuan, and any illegal gains are confiscated as well. An organization is fined 10000 yuan to 50000 yuan, and the person who handled it is fined another 5000 yuan to 10000 yuan. A favor, and what you get in return is paying this money yourself.

**Benefit**. The person who issues an invitation letter is responsible for whether the contents are true. The original text says: "Where an individual issues a false invitation letter or other application materials for another person applying for exit or entry, or for stay or residence, the immigration authority shall impose a fine of not less than 5000 yuan and not more than 10000 yuan; where there are illegal gains, the illegal gains shall be confiscated." Where an organization issues false materials, the fine is not less than 10000 yuan and not more than 50000 yuan. At the same time, the person in charge who is directly responsible and the other persons directly responsible (the leader in charge and the person who handled it) are each fined not less than 5000 yuan and not more than 10000 yuan.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This is the same kind of risk as section 8, "do not carry things for strangers": the materials are issued in your name, so the consequences land on you. If a public employee or a member of the military wants an agency to arrange a foreign nationality or an overseas residence qualification in violation of the rules, the agency must not do it, and must also report it to the supervisory organ.

## 11. Before you leave the country, send your itinerary, where you will stay, and who is traveling with you to a family member, and agree how often you will make contact

**Cost**. No money. Send a message before you leave.

**In plain terms**. If someone loses contact overseas, the family can ask the embassy or consulate for help. The embassy or consulate will tell the family how to report it to the local police, and after a case is opened it will also press them to act. That depends on someone in China knowing where you are supposed to be and when you are supposed to make contact. Sending a family member the flight number, the address, the companions' phone numbers, and how often you agreed to make contact is enough.

**Benefit**. When a Chinese citizen's whereabouts overseas are unknown, relatives may ask a Chinese diplomatic mission abroad for help. The original text of the regulations says: "A diplomatic mission abroad shall provide the local way to call the police and other information on how to get help." After the local police open a case, the embassy or consulate will press them to handle it in time. Whether this help can start depends on whether someone in China knows where you were supposed to be and when you were supposed to make contact.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Writing down these 4 things is enough: the flight number, the address where you will stay, the name and phone number of the people traveling with you, and how often you agreed to make contact. If you are going somewhere with a weak signal or poor public safety, also say plainly how long with no news before they call the police. The cost of this is close to nothing, but the help procedures above can start only after a family member knows your itinerary.

## 12. Before you take medicine abroad, check the destination's rules: cold and cough medicines that contain pseudoephedrine or codeine, and sleeping pills, psychiatric drugs, and strong painkillers, should be in the original pack, with a prescription or a doctor's note, and only in the amount you will use yourself

**Cost**. No money. Check the destination's official site once before you leave. It takes a few minutes. If you need to take a controlled drug, you also make an extra trip to the hospital for a certificate, and you apply about 2 weeks ahead.

**In plain terms**. Cold and cough medicines with more than 10% pseudoephedrine or more than 1% codeine are regulated in Japan as a stimulant raw material or as a narcotic, and you have to apply for permission ahead of time. If you take more than a month's supply of sleeping pills, Japan also requires you to get a permit in advance, and Singapore requires an advance application for a medicine that contains a controlled ingredient. Carry the original pack and a doctor's note, and carry only what you will use yourself, and you can avoid having the medicine confiscated, a fine, or even a criminal sentence.

**Benefit**. Japan regulates medicines by ingredient. A medicine with more than 10% pseudoephedrine counts as a "stimulant raw material." A medicine with more than 1% codeine counts as a narcotic. Both require a permit from the Narcotics Control Department of the Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare before entry, at least 14 days ahead. You must carry the medicine yourself. You cannot mail it, and you cannot have a family member carry it for you. For a psychiatric drug such as diazepam or triazolam, a supply of up to a month does not need an application. Ordinary medicines have limits too: a prescription medicine within a month's supply, and other medicines within a 2-month supply. Above that, you first get an "import confirmation certificate." The reminder from the Chinese embassy in Japan says, in the original wording, that illegally carrying medicines and similar items into Japan means "the violator will be fined, detained, or even sentenced, and the prohibited items will be confiscated." The rule of Singapore's Health Sciences Authority (HSA) is: a medicine that does not contain a controlled ingredient, at most a 3-month supply. Carry a copy of the prescription or of a doctor's letter. Keep the medicine in the original pack, with the pharmacy label on it. A medicine that contains a controlled ingredient needs approval applied for at least 2 weeks ahead. A supply of more than 3 months may not be brought in at all, and neither may a medicine in the form of chewing gum. Carrying medicine for someone else is limited to a direct relative's own prescription medicine. Medicine that does not comply will be confiscated, and you may also face enforcement. On the Chinese side, the Customs Law requires that articles an individual carries in or out be "limited to personal use and a reasonable quantity." Narcotic drugs and the first category of psychotropic drugs may be carried, within the maximum amount of a single prescription, on a hospital diagnosis certificate and an identity document. Customs releases them on the principle of personal use and a reasonable quantity.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The rules change, and they differ by country. This book only writes how to check. Before you leave, look at the official site of the destination's health department or customs, or the consular advisory of the Chinese embassy there. The Japan and Singapore rules above were checked against the official sites on October (10) 14, 2026. Whether a medicine contains these ingredients is on the ingredient list in the leaflet. If you are not sure, ask the doctor who prescribed it. The best person to carry the medicine is the person who takes it. Singapore allows you to carry only a direct relative's own prescription medicine for that relative. This is the same point as section 8, item 29 (do not carry things for strangers). Photograph the prescription and the box and keep a copy. For how to store it, see item 7 of this section (photograph a copy and keep it in the cloud).

## 13. When you enter China on the way back from abroad, do not bring meat products (vacuum-packed ham and jerky count too), cheese, fresh fruit, or seeds; if you are carrying an animal or plant product, declare it in the red channel

**Cost**. No money. When you buy local specialties abroad, skip these kinds, and go through the luggage once before you fly back. If you are carrying something you are not sure about, take the red channel at customs and wait in line a bit longer.

**In plain terms**. On the way back, meat cannot be brought in whether it is raw or cooked. Ham, jerky, and sausage are the same no matter how tightly they are packed. Cheese, butter, fresh eggs, fresh fruit and vegetables, and seeds are on the banned list too. If you bring them, they will be sent back or destroyed. If you carry an animal or plant product and do not declare it, you may also be fined, up to 5000 yuan.

**Benefit**. In 2021 the Ministry of Agriculture and Rural Affairs and the General Administration of Customs published a banned list. It covers what you carry with you, what you check in, what you mail, what you send by courier, and what you buy directly by cross-border e-commerce. The kinds that matter most to an ordinary traveler are these. The first is meat. The original text is "(raw or cooked) meat (including offal) and products made from it," and the list does not make an exception by packaging. The second is milk and eggs. Cream, butter, cheese, and condensed milk are included, and so are preserved eggs, salted eggs, and mayonnaise. The third is "fresh fruit and vegetables" and fresh cut flowers. The fourth is seeds, seedlings, and other plant material that can grow. The fifth is live animals, except cats and dogs. Bird's nest is also banned, with the only exception canned bird's nest that has been treated to commercial sterility. Article 29 of the Law on the Entry and Exit Animal and Plant Quarantine states that bringing in something on the list is "handled by sending it back or destroying it." An animal or plant product that is not on the list may be brought in, but it still has to be declared. The customs measures on supervision of luggage and articles state that a person carrying animals, plants, or animal or plant products shall declare them to customs in writing. If the written declaration is still not finished when customs starts the inspection, it counts as not declared. The measures also say, in the original wording: "A person who does not know the customs rules, or does not know which channel to choose, shall choose the 'red channel.'" The penalty for not declaring is in Article 39 of the quarantine law: a person who "failed to apply for inspection" is fined. Article 59 of the implementing regulations of the quarantine law sets this kind of fine at 5000 yuan or less.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The list was checked against the announcement on the Ministry of Agriculture and Rural Affairs website on October (10) 14, 2026. Both departments say they will "adjust it dynamically." Check again before you leave. There are a few exceptions. Dried or cooked aquatic products are not on the banned list, for example dried squid and dried shrimp, but they still have to be declared. Something that has been approved, and that also has an official quarantine certificate from the exporting country, is not limited by the list. Each person may bring 1 cat or dog, and must have an official quarantine certificate and a vaccination certificate from the exporting country. When you leave China, many destination countries likewise do not allow meat products in. The way to check is the same as item 12 of this section (check the destination's rules before you take medicine abroad).

# 22. How to relax: entertainment venues and stress relief

The first half covers entertainment venues: which spending is a waste, and where the emergency exits are. The measure is money and personal liberty. The second half covers how to relieve stress. The measure is energy and overall mortality. The figures from both halves are not converted into each other. Items 11 and 12 at the end of the section cover how to avoid harm while out: do not soak in a hot spring or take a sauna after drinking, and wear a helmet when skiing or cycling. The measure there is mortality. Section 3 already covers what to do first when your mood is low. This section gives more specific methods.

## 1. Check where the emergency exits are before entering a KTV, bar, or escape room; if they're locked or blocked, pick another venue

**Cost**. No cost at all. Just take 10 seconds to look around when you enter.

**In plain terms**. By the rules, while an entertainment venue is open, evacuation routes and emergency exits must stay clear. They must not be blocked, locked, or have objects placed in the way, and the direction signs must not be covered. Internet cafés likewise must not have their doors sealed or their windows locked. Failing to do this is illegal, and you can report it. If the private room is underground, has only one exit, or the corridor is piled with clutter, go to another place.

**Benefit**. Ensuring unobstructed evacuation routes and exits is a mandatory legal obligation for venue operators. Noncompliance is illegal and reportable. The exact wording of the regulation reads: “During operating hours, entertainment venues must guarantee that evacuation routes and emergency exits remain unblocked; they cannot be sealed, locked, or fitted with barriers that hinder evacuation.” It also stipulates that “clear signage must be posted at all evacuation routes and exits, and such signage must not be obscured or covered.” Internet cafés are similarly required to “keep all doors, windows, evacuation routes, and exits open at all times during business hours” and to “ban open flames and smoking.”

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If any of the following issues are present, pick another venue: private rooms located underground, only one exit available, corridors filled with clutter, or nonfunctional emergency exit lights. In the event of a fire at such venues, thick smoke, narrow corridors, and large crowds of intoxicated patrons make escape extremely difficult — you may have only seconds to get out. Per regulations, the contact number for filing complaints must be clearly displayed on warning signs throughout the venue.

## 2. Ask for the price list before you order; entertainment venues must show prices, and do not accept "play first, settle later"

**Cost**. No cost. Ask once for the list. The hard part is asking the price in front of other people. It feels a bit awkward.

**In plain terms**. By the rules, an entertainment venue that sells services or goods must show prices clearly, and must take the initiative to show you the price list. So-called sky-high drink charges usually turn up when nobody has seen a price list and the bill is settled afterward from a spoken quote. When you go into the private room, ask for the list and photograph it. After you order, ask for a confirmed list. If the bill is disputed, call 12315 on the spot.

**Benefit**. The regulation says: "When an entertainment venue provides entertainment services or sells goods, it shall mark prices clearly and show consumers the price list; it shall not force or deceive consumers into accepting services or buying goods." Violations of price laws and regulations are punished by the relevant department according to law. Disputes over so-called sky-high drinks commonly look like this: no price list was shown, and the bill was settled afterward from a spoken quote. That sentence is the author's experience. No official statistics were found.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. What to do: when you enter the private room, ask for 1 price list, on paper or on a screen, and photograph it as soon as you have it. After you order, ask for 1 confirmed list. For a "signature cocktail" or a fruit platter the staff recommend, ask the price before you order, every time. If the bill is disputed, call 12315 on the spot. Do not pay first and seek a remedy afterward. Once you have paid, proving your case is much harder.

## 3. If someone at the venue hands you "something," leave at once. Sheltering drug use and supplying drugs are not "helping a friend"

**Cost**. No cost. Stand up and walk out. The hard part is leaving in front of a whole table of people.

**In plain terms**. An entertainment venue must not sell drugs, must not supply drugs, and must not let people use drugs inside. A violation means a business suspension for rectification of 3 to 6 months, and in a serious case the license is revoked. Letting someone "use a bit" in a private room you booked, or at your home, can be the crime of providing a place for others to use drugs. If someone pulls out an unknown powder, tablet, or vape cartridge and asks you to try it, leave on the spot.

**Benefit**. The regulation expressly forbids entertainment venues to "sell or supply drugs, or organize, force, abet, lure, deceive, or provide a place for others to ingest or inject drugs." Staff must not use drugs, and must not provide conditions for customers to do any of the above. For a violation, the public security department confiscates illegal gains and illegal property and orders a business suspension for rectification of 3 to 6 months. In a serious case the entertainment business license is revoked. The regulation also requires the venue to hang warning signs against drugs, gambling, and prostitution in a conspicuous place in the hall and in the private rooms, and to state the report phone number on them. On the personal side, the Criminal Law provides: "Whoever provides a place for another person to ingest or inject drugs shall be sentenced to fixed-term imprisonment of not more than 3 years, criminal detention, or public surveillance, and shall also be fined." A judicial interpretation of the Supreme People's Court lists the situations that count as the crime, including providing a place for several people at 1 time, doing so repeatedly within 2 years, providing a place for a minor, and doing so for profit. If it does not amount to a crime, the Public Security Administration Punishments Law provides detention of 10 to 15 days, and a fine of up to 3000 yuan may be added. In a lighter case, detention of up to 5 days, or a fine of up to 1000 yuan. Ingesting or injecting drugs yourself likewise brings detention of 10 to 15 days, and a fine of up to 3000 yuan may be added.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. As soon as someone produces an unknown powder, tablet, or vape cartridge and asks you to "try it," leave on the spot. Do not stay to watch. The risk you carry personally is heavier than the venue's. Using drugs yourself is itself subject to a public-security penalty. Letting a friend "use a bit here" in a private room you booked, or at your own home, can be the crime of providing a place for others to use drugs.

## 4. Do not eat candy or snacks from strangers, do not drink a beverage that has left your sight, and do not take a vape cartridge someone hands you

**Cost**. No cost. Do not take anything that is handed to you. If your own cup has left your sight, get a new drink.

**In plain terms**. Today's drugs do not look like drugs. A "high" e-cigarette mixed with synthetic cannabinoids looks much like an ordinary e-cigarette, and some people specifically hand them out to try in bars, KTVs, and hotels. Tricking someone into using them brings detention of 10 to 15 days plus a fine. Using them yourself also brings detention. Someone who was tricked into using them can get a lighter penalty, or none. If a drink has left your sight, get a new drink.

**Benefit**. Today's drugs do not look like drugs. Synthetic cannabinoids have been controlled as a whole class since July 1, 2021, and the whole class is regulated as drugs. Some people mix them into vape liquid and make "high" e-cigarettes. In a case reported by the Supreme People's Procuratorate, investigators described this liquid as something that "can be turned into all kinds of colors and flavors by adding food coloring" and that is "basically the same in appearance as an ordinary e-cigarette." Sellers gather people in bars, KTVs, and

hotels to push it and induce others to use it. In that report, among the drug-use cases handled locally that year, minor users were nearly 40%. Etomidate has been listed in the catalog of category II psychotropic substances since October 1, 2023. Tricking someone into using drugs is itself 1 grade of illegality. Whoever lures, abets, deceives, or forces another person to ingest or inject drugs is detained for 10 to 15 days and fined 1000 to 5000 yuan. If it constitutes a crime, the sentence is up to 3 years; if the circumstances are serious, 3 to 7 years; if force is used, 3 to 10 years; and if the target is a minor, the penalty is heavier. Whoever ingests or injects drugs is detained for 10 to 15 days and may be fined up to 3000 yuan. In a lighter case, detention of up to 5 days or a fine of up to 1000 yuan. If the person used drugs only because they were coerced or tricked, the same law provides "a lighter penalty, a mitigated penalty, or no penalty." They may also be ordered at the same time not to enter entertainment venues for 6 months to 1 year. If addicted, they are ordered into community drug rehabilitation for 3 years. If they refuse community rehabilitation, or use again during rehabilitation, they are sent to compulsory isolated detoxification for 2 years, which can be extended by up to another 1 year (nationwide, the Public Security Administration Punishments Law, from January 2026).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This is not only entertainment venues. The same applies at a school gate, at a gathering of friends, and on a long-distance bus. It is the same whether what is offered is candy, a drink, or a vape cartridge. Being drugged is often followed by robbery, sexual assault, and extortion. There are no published official statistics on that part. It is a judgment from experience. If a drink has left your sight, getting a new drink is much simpler than trying to pursue it afterward. For what to do when someone in the venue produces an unknown powder, tablet, or cartridge, see item 3 of this section. For carrying things for someone else, see section 8, item 29.

## 5. Do not go to scripted murder-mystery games (剧本杀, jubensha) or escape rooms opened in a residential building or on basement level 2 or below

**Cost**. No cost. Before you book, ask which floor the address is on.

**In plain terms**. A 2022 notice from 5 departments states that a script-entertainment venue must not open inside a residential building, and must not open below basement level 1. These sites are often dim, with narrow passages. Some are fitted out with flammable materials, and the evacuation routes are locked or blocked, so they are hard to get out of in a fire. Before you book, look at the address and the floor on the review page. If it does not comply, pick another place.

**Benefit**. A dedicated 2022 notice from 5 departments is specific: "Script-entertainment business premises must not be located inside residential buildings, below basement level 1 of a building (not including basement level 1), or in similar places." The notice also requires venues to carry out the Work Safety Law and the Fire Protection Law, and to "routinely identify, inspect, and correct their own fire risks, and improve the ability to organize evacuation and escape in an emergency and to fight a fire in its early stage." The same notice also requires an age notice on the script. If a scenario is not suitable for minors, minors must not be allowed in. Except on statutory holidays, rest days, and winter and summer school breaks, script-entertainment activities must not be provided to minors. At the end of 2021, the fire service and the culture and tourism departments of Qingpu District, Shanghai, inspected 13 venues of this kind. The bulletin said these venues are usually dim, with narrow passages, and that the problems included decoration with flammable materials and evacuation routes that were locked or occupied.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The Qingpu bulletin also said that some businesses, for the atmosphere, make the rooms into a maze and hide the evacuation signs and the emergency lights. Once something happens, people cannot find an exit straight away. Before you book, the review page already shows the floor, and whether it is a residential building. If it does not comply, switch to another place.

## 6. Going for a brisk walk or a jog when feeling down: the effect size of exercise on depression is proportional to its intensity

**Cost**. Free. Each session takes about half an hour. The hard part is that when you're in a bad mood, moving feels the last thing you want to do — you have to push yourself to get started.

**In plain terms**. For people with severe depression who exercise, brisk walking or jogging shows the clearest improvement. Next are yoga, strength training, and tai chi or qigong, and the gap among them is small. The higher the intensity, the better the effect. Strength training and yoga are the easiest to keep up. The quality of the evidence on this is on the low side. What can be said for sure is that moving is better than not moving. Pick the kind you can stick with.

**Benefit**. This result comes from combining data across 218 randomized controlled trials split into two groups, covering 495 treatment arms and 14,170 participants who met clinical criteria for major depression. A Bayesian network meta-analysis was used to compare all these different forms of exercise against each other, using standard care or placebo pills as control groups. The effect size is expressed as Hedges' g; the more negative this value, the greater the symptom improvement. For brisk walking or jogging, the value was −0.62 (95% confidence interval: −0.80 to −0.45). Yoga came in at −0.55 (−0.73 to −0.36), strength training at −0.49 (−0.69 to −0.29), mixed aerobic exercise at −0.43 (−0.61 to −0.24), and tai chi/Qigong at −0.42 (−0.65 to −0.21). The original paper states that “the effect of exercise is directly proportional to its intensity”, meaning higher intensity yields better results. Strength training and yoga also score highest on acceptability, making them the most sustainable choices for most people.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This finding is somewhat controversial. The authors themselves point out that only one out of the 218 studies met sufficiently rigorous design standards to rule out major bias. Using standard grading criteria, brisk walking and jogging only qualify for a “low” confidence rating, while all other exercise types receive “very low” ratings. Since participants know they're taking part in an exercise program, placebo effects inevitably play a role, skewing results upward. Still, the overall conclusion holds up: any physical activity is better than none, intensity should be kept reasonably high, and you should choose a type you can realistically stick with over time. This section expands on the earlier advice in Section 3 to “get moving when feeling down”, but it is by no means a substitute for professional medical treatment after a proper diagnosis.

## 7. When anxiety is bad enough to disrupt daily life, a mindfulness-based stress reduction course is not worse than a commonly used anti-anxiety drug

**Cost**. Signing up for the course costs a bit of money. The course runs 8 weeks, with 1 class a week, plus daily practice at home. The hard part is practicing every day for 8 weeks straight.

**In plain terms**. For people diagnosed with an anxiety disorder, an 8-week mindfulness-based stress reduction course improves symptoms almost as much as the anti-anxiety drug escitalopram. Nearly 80% of the people on the drug had an adverse reaction, and some quit because of it. About 15% of the people in the course had an adverse reaction, and nobody quit. The course has to be a standardized 8-week course. A random meditation app does not count.

**Benefit**. This trial was done at 3 urban academic medical centers in the United States, to see whether the course would be worse than the drug (a non-inferiority randomized controlled trial). 276 adults diagnosed with an anxiety disorder were split at random 1:1. The course group took an 8-week mindfulness-based stress reduction course. The drug group took escitalopram (a flexible dose of 10 to 20 mg). 208 people finished the whole course. At the end, scored on the anxiety severity rating given by a clinician (the Clinical Global Impression–Severity scale), the mindfulness group fell by 1.35 and the drug group fell by 1.43. The difference between the groups was −0.07 (95% CI −0.38 to 0.23, meaning the true gap falls roughly in this range; P=0.65, meaning this gap cannot be told apart from no difference). The lower end of this range did not cross the line drawn in advance for "not counting as worse" (non-inferiority margin −0.495). Side effects differed a lot:

78.6% of the drug group had at least 1 trial-related adverse reaction, and 10 people quit because of it. The mindfulness group was 15.4%, and nobody quit because of it.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The trial used a standardized 8-week mindfulness-based stress reduction course (MBSR). A random meditation app cannot be treated as the same thing. It applies to people who already meet the diagnostic criteria for an anxiety disorder. If you should see a doctor, see a doctor. If you have been putting off treatment because you worry about drug side effects, there is another option with evidence of similar strength.

## 8. To ease off on the spot, use 5 minutes of "cyclic sighing": 2 inhales, then a long exhale

**Cost**. No cost. 5 minutes a day.

**In plain terms**. Do a 5-minute breathing exercise every day and keep it up for a month, and both mood and slower breathing improve more than with mindfulness meditation of the same length. Among the breathing methods, "cyclic sighing," which lengthens the exhale, works best. The method is to inhale through the nose, take 1 more small breath to fill the lungs, then breathe out slowly through the mouth until empty. This is only 1 trial, and whether it helped is reported by the person themselves, but it costs nothing.

**Benefit**. This was a controlled trial done at home, with people assigned at random, comparing 3 breathing exercises of 5 minutes a day with mindfulness meditation of the same length, for 1 month. The 3 breathing methods are cyclic sighing (emphasis on a longer exhale), box breathing (inhale, hold, and exhale of equal length), and cyclic hyperventilation with breath holds (long inhale, short exhale). Putting each person's sessions together (a mixed-effects model), the breathing exercises all beat mindfulness meditation, especially cyclic sighing, which is built on the exhale. It was better both for mood ($P<0.05$, meaning this difference does not look like a chance hit) and for a drop in breathing rate ($P<0.05$).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The method is to inhale once through the nose, briefly add 1 more small breath to fill the lungs, then breathe the air out slowly and at length through the mouth, and repeat for 5 minutes. There is only this 1 trial. It was done at home, whether it helped was reported by the person on a questionnaire, and the number of people was not large. The effect is only slightly better than meditation. It does not amount to solving the problem. But it costs nothing, takes only 5 minutes, and can be done anytime, anywhere, so the return for the cost is high.

## 9. Treat “regular social contact” as a health expense — don't wait until you're feeling down to reach out

**Cost**. It requires some money and time to arrange meetups. The hard part is making the effort to schedule them even when you're in a good mood.

**In plain terms**. This conclusion comes from a meta-analysis of 70 studies involving 3.4 million people, tracked for an average of 7 years. Those experiencing social isolation had a roughly 30% higher risk of dying during that period compared to non-isolated individuals. People reporting loneliness faced a 25% higher risk, while those living alone faced a 30% higher risk. These figures are similar in magnitude and are even more pronounced among people under 65. Keep in mind these are observational data; it's also possible that people in poorer health are more likely to end up isolated.

**Benefit**. As noted, this is a meta-analysis of 70 studies with 3.4 million participants observed over 7 years. Social isolation, loneliness, and living alone all correlate with higher mortality. After adjusting for age and health status, the weighted average risk ratios were: 1.29 for social isolation, 1.26 for loneliness, and 1.32 for living alone. In other words, each condition raised the risk of dying during the study period by roughly 30%, 25%, and 30% respectively. The effects are comparable across all three factors and are stronger among people under 65 than among older people.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This topic remains debated. These findings are purely correlational; no randomized controlled trials have been conducted to prove cause and effect. It's also true that people with poorer health are more likely to become isolated or have fewer social interactions. The authors argue that social relationships are as important to health as smoking or obesity, yet there's no randomized evidence showing that increasing social contact actually lowers mortality. This point does not contradict Section 3's advice to “cut back on draining relationships”; that section focuses on eliminating toxic connections, while this one stresses the value of maintaining those that replenish your energy.

## 10. Count nearby green space when choosing where to live, but do not expect "going to the park more" to extend your life

**Cost**. No cost. When you look at a home, glance at the greenery around it.

**In plain terms**. The better the greenery within 500 meters of where you live, the lower the chance of dying over the same period. Counted as each 0.1 rise in the vegetation index, that chance is about 4% lower. What was measured is the greenery around the home, not how often you go to a park. In a greener area, the people who live there tend to have more money, and the air is better too. So do not take this as going to the park will extend your life. When you choose a home, count the green space around it.

**Benefit**. This pools 9 studies that followed groups of people for years (a meta-analysis of cohort studies), covering 7 countries and 8320000 people. It looks at greenery within 500 meters of the home, measured by the normalized difference vegetation index (NDVI, a number that converts ground vegetation into a score). For each 0.1 increase in the index, the pooled risk ratio for overall mortality was 0.96 (95% CI 0.94–0.97). The chance of dying over the same period was about 4% lower, and the true value falls roughly between 3% lower and 6% lower. Of the 9 studies, 7 found that better greenery went with lower mortality, and the difference did not look like chance. The other 2 found no link.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Disputed. Results across the studies differ widely ($I^2$=95%; the larger this number, the less they agree with each other). And what it measured is greenery around the place of residence, not how often you go to a park. People who live in a greener place also tend to be richer, to have better air, and to exercise more, and these cannot be separated from the greenery as to which of them is doing the work. Do not read it as "going to a park extends your life." The usable part is to count green space when choosing a home, and the cost is 0. For this NDVI number, bare ground and concrete are near 0, and dense vegetation is near 1. So 0.1 is roughly the difference of moving from a bare block to a block with rows of street trees.

## 11. After drinking, do not soak in a hot spring or take a sauna, and do not take a hot bath at home either

**Cost**. No cost. If you have been drinking, go soak another day, and at home just take a simple shower. The hard part is that a hot spring or a sauna is often the next stop after a group meal. The whole table goes, and you have to say out loud that you are not going.

**In plain terms**. In Finland, half of the people who died in a sauna had been drinking. In Tokyo, about a quarter of the bathing deaths that were autopsied had a blood alcohol level that was not low, and in a set of bathtub-drowning records drunkenness was the most common trigger. Japanese officials list "do not take a bath after drinking" as a key point for preventing drowning. If a companion has drunk too much, do not let that person go in and soak alone.

**Benefit**. Finland checked, case by case, the people who died in a sauna from 1990 to 2002, using police and forensic reports. Deaths of this kind are fewer than 2 per 100000 each year. The original text says "overall, 50% of the people were under the influence of alcohol." The authors say this alcohol risk is growing, and the focus of prevention is to drink less and not to leave a drunk person alone in the sauna. From 2009 to 2011, Tokyo forensic doctors handled 3289 deaths during bathing. Among the 550 that were autopsied, 140 had blood alcohol above 0.5 milligrams per milliliter, about 1/4. Another Tokyo autopsy series had 77 bathtub drownings. Among the factors that led to the drowning, drunkenness was the most common (25 cases), then

heart disease (22 cases). A December 2025 notice from the Japan Consumer Affairs Agency says that in 2024, 7776 people in Japan drowned in a bathtub, of whom 7363 were aged 65 or older. The accident-prevention points say: do not take a bath right after a meal, after drinking, or after taking medicine. The Chinese embassy in Japan warns that "it is unwise to bathe after drinking," because "bathing after drinking can easily trigger an acute illness of the heart or the blood vessels." A public-education note from the Shaanxi health commission says that soaking in a hot spring after drinking, with the water that hot, dilates the blood vessels and can bring low blood pressure, low blood sugar, or even fainting.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The grade is set at B because these studies looked only at people who had died. Nobody has calculated how many of the people who soak after drinking come to harm, so it is not possible to say how many times higher the risk is. The benefit is set at "medium" by judgment: people who die in a sauna or a bathtub are not many to begin with, but among those who died, those who had been drinking account for 1/4 to 1/2. Most bathtub drownings in Japan are older people. A young person who has been drinking can come to harm in a sauna just the same. For the benefits of a usual bath, and the reminders on water temperature and how long to stay in, see section 2, item 36 (take a bath when you can). For how to look after a companion who is drunk, see section 13, item 46 (someone is drunk).

## 12. Wear a helmet when skiing, snowboarding, rollerblading, or mountain biking

**Cost**. A helmet costs a few hundred yuan. Putting it on and fastening the strap takes a few seconds each time.

**In plain terms**. When skiing or snowboarding, wearing a helmet makes the chance of a head injury in a fall or a collision about 1/3 lower, and for a child under 13 it makes that chance about 60% lower. When riding a bicycle, wearing a helmet makes the chance of a serious head injury about 70% lower, and makes the chance of a fatal head injury about 2/3 lower. Wearing a helmet did not make the neck easier to injure.

**Benefit**. The skiing and snowboarding figures come from a pooled analysis of 12 studies. Most of the studies compared people with a head injury to other people and looked at who was wearing a helmet (case-control). For people wearing a helmet, the odds ratio for a head injury was OR 0.65 (95% CI 0.55–0.79), about 35% lower. In the studies that included children under 13, OR 0.41 (0.27–0.59), about 59% lower. For a neck injury, OR 0.89 (0.72–1.09), not higher. The bicycle figures come from 40 studies and more than 64000 people who fell off a bike or were in a crash. Head injury OR 0.49 (0.42–0.57), about 51% lower. A serious head injury OR 0.31 (0.25–0.37), about 69% lower. A fatal head injury OR 0.35 (0.14–0.88), about 65% lower. A facial injury OR 0.67 (0.56–0.81), about 33% lower. A neck injury OR 0.96 (0.74–1.25), no link visible. The Beijing Municipal Bureau of Sports says that after Beijing's local standard for ski resorts was revised in 2017, a helmet is required to enter an advanced run.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These figures are the chance of a head injury after a fall or a collision. A helmet does not make you fall less often. No pooled study of the same kind was found for rollerblading or skateboarding. Those are carried over by analogy, because the way a fall hits the head is similar. The helmet should fit the head, the strap should be fastened tight, and a rented helmet should be tried on first. For wearing a helmet on a motorcycle or an e-bike, see section 1, item 2 (wear a helmet).

# 23. Which skills are worth learning

This section counts money and time. Item 2 also counts mortality. The first six items answer one question: whether to keep studying. Item 1 first says which stretch of the options the law crosses out. Item 2 counts the relation between schooling and length of life. Item 3 looks at which band of education people across the country are in. Item 4 covers what aid there is when you cannot afford to study. Item 5 covers what paths remain if you do not get into an ordinary high school. Item 6 turns "study or go to work" into a sum, and gives a method you can run yourself. The next seven items answer another question: once you have decided to learn something, how to pick it. Wage statistics in China split by trade are hard to check item by item from public official sources. So this section writes only the things whose source can be found: roughly how much more pay one more year of school brings (also called the return to education), how to check whether a certificate is lawful, where training subsidies come from, and which dimension to look at so a skill is harder to displace. This book does not give a figure for how much a particular trade earns in a month. Items 14 to 19 answer a third question: once you have settled what to learn, how to learn it in less time. Those six items count time. They are not converted into money. Items 20 to 23 answer a fourth question: if you are already doing professional or technical work, where to apply for a title, how the exam works, which pitfalls to avoid, and what getting the title is worth. Items 24 and 25 answer whether, on finishing a bachelor's or a master's, to go on to a master's or a doctorate. China has no income figures that take out personal differences. What is cited is a UK study.

The items are grouped by subject below. Item numbers are in parentheses.

**Whether to keep studying**: under 16 there is no going out to work (item 1), count whether schooling is useful inside mortality (item 2), the education structure of the whole country (item 3), if you cannot afford it, run the policy figures first (item 4), the path if you do not get into an ordinary high school (item 5), turn study or work into a sum (item 6).

**What to learn and how to pick it**: the return to one more year of education (item 7), check the occupational-qualification catalogue before an exam (item 8), take training through government subsidy channels (item 9), pick skills that need the hands and judgment on the spot (item 10), see whether a skill has a grade assessment (item 11), check the local catalogue of occupations in short supply (item 12), choose a short course that lets you start the job directly (item 13).

**How to learn in less time**: close the book and test yourself when you finish (item 14), spread the time over several days (item 15), do not treat highlighting as the main way to study (item 16), mix several kinds of problem (item 17), do not pick a method by visual type or auditory type (item 18), turn what you have to memorize into questions and test yourself (item 19).

**Professional titles**: find the channel for applying (item 20), the junior and intermediate accounting titles are a unified exam (item 21), do not hire an agent to get the title for you (item 22), holding the title is not the same as a pay rise (item 23).

**Master's and doctorate**: whether to go on to a master's after a bachelor's (item 24), whether to go on to a doctorate after a master's (item 25).

## 1. Under 16 there is no "go to work" option: any employer who hires you is fined 5000 yuan a month, and anyone willing to hire you is breaking the law

**Cost**. No money. Spend one minute working out how old you are.

**In plain terms**. Junior high usually ends at 15 to 16, right on this line. Under 16, except for special hiring by arts or sports units, hiring you is illegal, and the fine is 5000 yuan a month for each child worker used. So anyone willing to take you is an employer already breaking the law on hiring. If something really goes wrong, medical costs and compensation can only be claimed from that employer.

**Benefit**. Article 11 of the Compulsory Education Law: "Parents or other legal guardians of every child who has reached the age of six shall send the child to school to receive and complete compulsory education." Article 14: "Employers are prohibited from hiring school-age children and adolescents who should be receiving compulsory education." Article 58: where, without proper reason, school-age children or adolescents are not sent to school as this law requires, the local township people's government or the education administrative department of the county-level people's government "gives criticism and education and orders correction within a time limit." Article 2 of the Provisions on the Prohibition of Child Labour: state organs, social organizations, enterprises, institutions, private non-enterprise units, and individual industrial and commercial households "shall not hire minors under 16." Article 6: "impose a fine of 5000 yuan per month for each child worker used"; if not corrected by the deadline, fine 10000 yuan (1 万) per person per month. Article 7: anyone who introduces a child into employment is fined "5000 yuan for each person introduced." Article 10: if a child worker falls ill or is injured, the employer "shall be responsible for sending them to a medical institution for treatment and shall bear all medical and living expenses during treatment"; for disability or death there is also a one-time compensation. Article 13 leaves only one exception: arts and sports units may, with the consent of a parent or other guardian, hire professional arts workers or athletes under 16 (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The beneficiary is you. Working after turning 16 is lawful. If you want to learn a trade before working, run first through the dimensions in item 10 of this section (pick skills that resist automation). Overtime pay, annual leave, and work-injury benefits in Section 19 all assume a labor relationship and evidence. If a child worker is injured, under Article 10 of the Provisions on the Prohibition of Child Labour the employer bears all medical and living expenses during treatment, and for disability or death there is also a one-time compensation

## 2. Put "whether schooling is useful" into the mortality account as well: each extra year of education cuts adult death risk by about 1.9%

**Cost**. No money. What you spend is the time and energy of those extra years of school; for tuition see item 4 of this section (vocational-school tuition and grants). The hard part is staying with it and not quitting halfway.

**In plain terms**. Each extra year of school cuts the average risk of dying in adulthood by about 1.9%. It is clearest for people aged 18 to 49, about 2.9% lower per extra year; above 70 it is only 0.8% lower. People who keep studying often already had better circumstances, so how much is schooling itself cannot be pulled apart.

**Benefit**. Prior studies were gathered and pooled (systematic review and meta-analysis). The search ran from January 1980 to May 2023; 603 studies were included in the end, from 70 sites in 59 countries, with 10355 observations. Education and adult mortality (deaths from all causes combined) follow a dose-response relation (more schooling, larger drop). Each extra year of education cuts death risk by 1.9% on average (95% uncertainty interval 1.8–2.0; the true value falls roughly in that band). For people aged 18 to 49 the drop is 2.9% per extra year (2.8–3.0). For people over 70 the drop is 0.8% (0.6–1.0). No difference by sex was seen. Split by national development level (sociodemographic index), no difference was seen either

**Evidence grade**. A (contested)

**Notes**. Contested. The authors themselves reported publication bias ($p<0.0001$), meaning studies with nicer-looking results are more likely to be published. Results also differ widely across studies. All included work is follow-up observation, not trials that assign people to groups. Years of schooling are tangled with family circumstances, region, and occupation. Of this 1.9%, how much comes from schooling itself and how much from "people who can keep studying already had better circumstances" cannot be separated in this kind of study. Reverse causation cannot be separated either. People who were already ill or had mental problems as children are more likely to drop out and more likely to die early. That makes schooling look more useful than it is. So it strongly shows that "more schooling and living longer go the same way," but it does not equal "if you go to school you gain 1.9% more life." Benefit magnitude is set to small: what readers usually face is three

or four more years; at 1.9% a year that adds up to under one tenth, which under this book's thresholds counts only as small. The beneficiary is you

## 3. Before you judge whether "credentials have been devalued," look at the national education structure: only 15467 people per 100000 have a college education (2020 census; 2025 sample estimate about 19%)

**Cost**. No money. Just look at the figures below.

**In plain terms**. In the 2020 census, people nationwide who reached junior college or above were about 15%. The 2025 sample survey estimates about 19%, a few percentage points more in five years. In both, people with junior high were the largest group. People aged 15 and above averaged only 9.91 years of schooling, just past junior-high graduation. So a junior-high credential is the most common band in China, not a scarce one.

**Benefit**. The reference date of the seventh national census was 1 November 2020. Among the national population, 218360767 people had a college education (junior college or above). High school (including secondary specialized school) 213005258. Junior high 487163489. Primary school 349658828. Compared with the sixth census in 2010, people with a college education per 100000 rose from 8930 to 15467. High school from 14032 to 15088. Junior high fell from 38788 to 34507. Primary school fell from 26779 to 24767. Average years of schooling for people aged 15 and above rose from 9.08 to 9.91. The illiteracy rate fell from 4.08% to 2.67%. The reference date of the 2025 national 1% population sample survey was 1 November 2025, with a sample of 20520000 people (2052 万). From the sample the national population is estimated at 1405450000 (140545 万). Of these, college (junior college or above) 272330000 (27233 万), high school (including secondary specialized) 242720000 (24272 万), junior high 452830000 (45283 万), primary school 331220000 (33122 万). The bulletin does not give figures per 100000. Calculated ourselves from the headcounts and total population, college is about 19.4% and junior high about 32.2%, still the largest band

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These figures only show how scarce a credential is in the population. Whether schooling pays for a particular person, run the method in item 6 of this section (how to weigh study against going to work). Also note: the census counts the whole national population, including the old and the young, not the labor force and not your age peers. The bulletin does not break the figures by age. From the rise of more than seven tenths in people with a college education per 100000 from 2010 to 2020, the share among young people is likely higher than the national figure; that is an inference. So comparing yourself with age peers using the national figure overstates your edge. What it can show is: in the national population, a college education is still a minority. The 2025 figures are a sample estimate; the census counts every household. The two use different bases, so both sets are shown side by side and the new figures do not replace the old. The 19.4% and 32.2% are calculated ourselves from the bulletin's headcounts and the total population. The beneficiary is you

## 4. Run the policy math first: most vocational school tuition is waived, with a 2300-yuan grant and up to 20000 yuan in student loans per year

**Cost**. Zero out-of-pocket expense. Before school starts, simply visit the school's student-aid office and submit the required paperwork.

**In plain terms**. At public secondary vocational schools, rural students, urban students in agriculture-related majors, and students from hard-up families already have tuition waived. Grants for secondary vocational and ordinary high school are 2300 yuan a year from spring 2025. At university, the grant is 3700 yuan a year, and student loans can go up to 20000 yuan a year (2 万). When money is short, run these figures first, then decide whether to quit and go to work.

**Benefit**. The tuition-waiver policy for public vocational schools has been in place since fall 2012; it covers all full-time first-, second-, and third-year students who are rural (including those in county towns), enrolled in agriculture-related programs, or from financially disadvantaged families (except for students in performing-arts majors). In 2024 the student-aid framework was updated: the national grant for

undergraduates rose from 3300 to 3700 yuan per year, and the National Inspirational Scholarship increased from 5000 to 6000 yuan, both effective fall 2024. For vocational and regular high-school students, the grant also rose from 2000 to 2300 yuan per year, effective spring 2025. Student loans were adjusted as well: from fall 2024 undergraduates may borrow up to 20000 yuan per year (previously 16000) and graduate students up to 25000 yuan (previously 20000). The interest rate equals the applicable LPR minus 70 basis points (another 0.7 percentage points lower) (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These benefits apply to the student and his or her children. Exactly which groups qualify for tuition waivers and how many grant tiers exist is determined by each province. Private schools receive subsidies based on local public-school standards, but any shortfall must still be paid by the student, so it's wise to verify local rules before enrolling. Student loans are loans, not grants, and must be repaid after graduation; they simply separate the immediate cash-flow problem from a longer-term cost-benefit analysis — don't treat a temporary shortfall as a permanent barrier. Section 7 discusses training subsidies and emergency aid for periods of unemployment; families facing sudden income loss should apply for those programs first.

## 5. Failing to get into regular high school doesn't mean your path ends: secondary vocational schools offer linked admission programs and separate exams, and employers can lower educational requirements for skilled roles

**Cost**. No cost at all. Before submitting your high school entrance exam applications, check your province's official vocational education admissions platform once.

**In plain terms**. The Vocational Education Law enacted in 2022 explicitly states that vocational education holds equal status to general education. Secondary vocational schools can enroll students through linked admission programs with higher vocational institutions, which in turn must reserve a set proportion of their enrollment slots or hold separate exams specifically for secondary vocational graduates. Employers are also prohibited from setting eligibility barriers based on a candidate's vocational school background. Failing to meet the cutoff for regular high school admission simply means you get to choose a different path — it does not leave you stuck with a junior high school diploma.

**Benefit**. Article 3 of the Vocational Education Law (effective 1 May 2022) stipulates: “Vocational education is an educational type that holds equal importance to general education.” Article 37 states that secondary vocational schools “may, in accordance with relevant national regulations, implement linked admission and training programs with higher vocational education for designated majors.” Higher vocational institutions “may, in accordance with relevant national regulations, admit students via assessment methods that combine academic ability and vocational skills.” Provincial-level and above education authorities are required to build unified vocational education admissions platforms to publish information on schools, majors and enrollment quotas, and provide application query services. Article 53 further specifies: “Students from vocational schools enjoy equal opportunities as students from regular schools at the same level in terms of further education, employment and career development.” Higher vocational institutions and regular universities offering vocational education “must reserve a corresponding proportion of their enrollment quotas or hold separate exams to admit vocational school graduates specifically.” It is also forbidden for employers to set application, hiring or employment criteria that prevent vocational school graduates from competing on an equal footing. For positions requiring specific vocational skill certifications in public institution recruitment, “educational requirements can be appropriately lowered” nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These benefits apply to both yourself and your children. All the channels outlined here are legally mandated, but they do not guarantee admission. The specific majors covered by linked training programs, the exact proportion of slots reserved for separate admissions, and the exact subjects tested in vocational college entrance exams are all determined by each individual province. Before submitting applications, you must check your province's current vocational education admissions platform and enrollment quotas — do not rely

on rules or practices from other provinces. When selecting a secondary vocational major, use the criteria outlined in Section 10 of this chapter (choosing skills that are less prone to automation) as a reference: majors that require on-site work in non-standard environments are less likely to be phased out. To pick a school, confirm it is listed in your province's current vocational education enrollment plan. Verify any certificates issued by the school using the three-step process described in Section 8 (checking whether a certificate is on the official approved list). Avoid any recruitment materials that make promises like “guaranteed job placement” or “100% admission success” at all costs.

## 6. Turn "study or go to work" into a sum: set the three years of wages you would earn by going to work now against the yearly income gap that more schooling would bring over the decades after

**Cost**. No money. Sit down and run the sum once. About half an hour.

**In plain terms**. Going to work now earns you several years of wages sooner, but that money is received only once. Staying in school means earning a bit more than people who did not, every year after, for thirty or forty years running. So put the two sums side by side. In urban China, one more year of school was associated with about 4.0% to 10.2% more income a year, but those figures are from before 2001. They only give a rough scale.

**Benefit**. This is an estimate for urban China from 1988 to 2001. How much more income one more year of school brings is called the return to education. The original text says it "rose sharply from 4.0% per year of schooling in 1988 to 10.2% in 2001." The rise was mainly after 1992. What it reflects is the widening of the extra pay of people who reached university over people who did not (the higher-education wage premium). This is a China-specific scale you can use when you turn "one more year of school" into a gap in yearly income. The global average is in item 7 of this section (the global average return to one more year of education)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Before you run the sum, first take off the tuition waivers and grants in item 4 of this section (vocational-school tuition and grants). There is also the account in item 2 of this section (one more year of education and mortality). The data stop at 2001 and cover only urban areas. They cannot be used directly as today's figures. The same is true of the global average of 9% in item 7 of this section. What is given here is a method, not an answer: run this way, the conclusion differs from person to person. Where tuition is high, the subject does not match the job, and the years of study are long, the sum may really come out not worth it. That only shows that this particular course is not worth it. It does not show that schooling is useless. A few things do not fit in the formula but do exist: legal education thresholds, in item 5 of this section (linked admission and separate exams in vocational education); resistance to being replaced, in item 10 (pick skills that resist automation); and whether you can change industry. The beneficiary is you

## 7. Keep this baseline in mind: on average worldwide, the private return to one more year of education (the part that lands on your own income) is about 9% a year

**Cost**. No money. Memorize this figure and use it as a yardstick for any "learn something" plan.

**In plain terms**. On a worldwide average, one more year of school raises personal income by about 9% a year; the return for women has stayed higher than for men. This figure is about formal schooling; you cannot apply it directly to a short course. Use it as a yardstick: if a course costs you 30000 yuan (3 万) and half a year, ask whether the income change it brings matches one more year of school.

**Benefit**. A review covering 1950 to 2014, 139 countries, and 1120 estimates found: "the global average private return to one more year of education is 9% a year." Private return is the part that lands on the person's own income: one more year of school raises income by about 9% on average. The private return to higher

education is rising. The social return to education (the part that lands on society as a whole rather than on the person) remains high. Women's average return to education stays higher than men's

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This is a global average for "one more year of school." It is not the return to "signing up for a course," and it is not a China-specific figure. It is only a scale reference. Its use is to give every training plan a yardstick. If a course costs you 30000 yuan (3 万) and six months, ask whether it can bring an income change on the scale of one year of formal education. Also note that the global average hides large differences by subject and by country

## 8. Before you spend money on a certificate, check whether it is on the National Vocational Qualification Catalogue or on the list of evaluation agencies filed with the Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security

**Cost**. No money. One check, about a dozen minutes.

**In plain terms**. Some outfits run courses, charge fees, and issue certificates at will under the banner of new occupations or skill grades, and some impersonate authoritative bodies; the ministry has run targeted crackdowns. Before you enroll, check three steps: whether the occupation is on the National Vocational Qualification Catalogue, whether the issuer is an evaluation agency filed with human-resources authorities, and whether the certificate number can be found on the official platform. If it cannot be found, do not enroll.

**Benefit**. The Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security has run a nationwide campaign for this. The document names the problems as "some institutions and units arbitrarily holding training, evaluation, and certificate-issuing activities under the names of new-occupation vocational qualifications, vocational skill grades, and the like, charging fees at will and issuing certificates indiscriminately; some institutions and units making false or exaggerated claims, even organizing training, evaluation, and certificate issuance under the name of an authoritative body." Measures include joint investigation with cyberspace, public security, and market-regulation departments, "severely cracking down on evaluation and certificate-issuing by fake appraisal bodies and by evaluation agencies filed with human-resources authorities that are being impersonated." Non-compliant promotion on websites and new media is shut down under the law. The document also requires "guiding the public to learn the channels and methods for checking certificates, and to judge whether a certificate is lawful and what it is worth"

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Check in this order. First see whether the occupation is in the National Vocational Qualification Catalogue; if it is not, it is not a national vocational qualification. Next see whether the issuer is an evaluation agency filed with human-resources authorities. Finally go to the official skilled-talent evaluation certificate query platform and see whether the certificate number can be found. If it cannot be found, do not enroll. Certificates with the words "international," "advanced," or "registered," or that promise "guaranteed pass" or "income through hanging the certificate," carry the highest risk. For "credential upgrade" courses that sell diplomas, see Section 31, item 10 (credentials count only if they can be found on Xuexinwang (学信网 — China Higher Education Student Information and Career Center)).

## 9. It's best to use government subsidies for training — don't jump straight to paying for commercial courses out of pocket

**Cost**. Zero cost, or at least a substantial reduction. Training does require time. The real challenge is resisting the urge to sign up for paid courses right away; first, check the local subsidy list.

**In plain terms**. From 2025 through late 2027, the government plans to provide subsidized training to over 30 million participants. Funding comes from multiple sources, including employment assistance funds, unemployment insurance funds, and corporate education budgets. The more in-demand a profession is and the higher the training cost, the larger the subsidy. Employees should ask their employers first; everyone else

should review their local Human Resources and Social Security Bureau's subsidy list before deciding what to study.

**Benefit**. The national target is clear: over 30 million subsidized training slots for high-tech industries, critical sectors, and priority employment groups between 2025 and 2027. Funding is pooled from various programs — employment assistance funds, unemployment insurance, sector development grants, East-West cooperation funds, and corporate education budgets. Subsidy amounts depend on how urgently a profession is needed and its training cost; they vary by occupation. Companies must also allocate at least 60% of their employee education funds to frontline staff training.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Exact eligibility criteria and subsidy amounts are set by each province. The main portals are the "Subsidized Vocational Training List" on the local Human Resources and Social Security Bureau website and public training centers. Section 7 covers unemployment-related training subsidies (up to three applications per person) and social insurance benefits. Employees should first inquire about their employer's education fund allocation before making any decisions. Checking the subsidy list first saves far more money than choosing a course first and then searching for financial aid.

## 10. When picking a skill to learn, prioritize those that require hands-on work and on-the-spot judgment — these are the hardest for automation to replace

**Cost**. No cost at all. Before making a choice, run through the skills you're considering using this criterion as a filter.

**In plain terms**. According to U.S. estimates, roughly 47% of jobs carry a relatively high risk of being taken over by computers. Later studies that evaluated individual tasks instead yielded a much lower percentage. Three core challenges currently prevent machines from handling certain jobs: manual dexterity, creative problem-solving, and social interaction. Hence, roles that demand physical work in unpredictable environments and real-time decision-making are far less likely to be automated, while jobs with rigid processes and heavy information processing carry the highest risk.

**Benefit**. This study assessed 702 U.S. occupations to estimate the likelihood of each being automated — the result showed that about 47% fell into the high-risk category. The three aforementioned challenges form what the authors call "engineering bottlenecks" that limit automation potential. These include sensory perception and physical manipulation (finger and hand dexterity, working in cramped or awkward spaces), creative intelligence (the ability to devise novel solutions), and social intelligence (interpersonal interaction). Consequently, occupations requiring hands-on work in unstructured settings and on-the-fly judgment are consistently less prone to automation, rather than this being a random trait of specific jobs. Roles with standardized workflows and information-centric tasks face the greatest automation risk.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This research is somewhat controversial. It originated as an unpublished draft paper from 2013 that measured the overall automation potential of entire occupations. Later studies that evaluated individual tasks instead produced a significantly lower high-risk percentage. The paper also does not specify a timeline for when automation might occur. When using these findings, avoid fixating on the 47% figure; instead, focus on the three key bottlenecks it identifies. Jobs involving on-site installation, maintenance, and caregiving are far more resistant to automation than purely clerical roles for precisely these reasons. Therefore, when deciding which skill to acquire, prioritize those that demand physical work in non-standard environments.

## 11. Check first whether a skill has an official grading system and if those grades can translate into pay raises

**Cost**. No cost involved. One quick check is all you need.

**In plain terms**. The government is promoting a “New Eight-Level Worker” system that requires companies to link job pay to employees' skill levels. Outstanding workers can even have their skill grades recognized regardless of seniority or years of experience. This is the policy direction, though implementation varies widely across regions and companies. Only skills with established national occupational standards and grading pathways can eventually lead to pay increases based on those grades — so it's worth checking first before you invest time in learning them.

**Benefit**. The government is actively rolling out this New Eight-Level Worker skill grading system. Official documents explicitly require linking skill grades to employee compensation, stating that “a skill-oriented pay distribution system must be strengthened… companies should adopt a compensation model that ties both job value and skill levels to pay.” Regions are also being urged to “expand the evaluation and hiring of senior-level workers and increase the frequency of such evaluations.” Eligible companies can conduct their own skill assessments for employees, and top performers can have their skill grades recognized without needing to meet any requirements related to years of service, prior grades, or seniority.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This is the intended policy direction, not a guarantee of actual pay increases — implementation varies greatly by region and company. The key takeaway for anyone considering learning a new skill is to first verify whether it has corresponding national occupational standards and a formal grading pathway; only then can it potentially lead to pay raises based on skill level. For skills lacking any official grading system or industry entry requirements, learning them won't guarantee any career or financial benefits — you'll still need to find work on your own.

## 12. Do not treat "high wages online" as a shortage of workers; check the local catalogue of occupations in short supply and the subsidy catalogue

**Cost**. No money. Look up two local documents.

**In plain terms**. How much training subsidy a locality gives for a trade is set by how urgently it is needed and by training cost, so the subsidy amount itself shows whether workers are short locally. Online claims of "monthly pay for a certain trade" are mostly posted rates on hiring platforms or personal self-reports. What you see is mostly people who already earned money, and hours, commuting, occupational disease, and busy versus slack seasons are not counted in.

**Benefit**. The subsidy amount itself is the official pricing of "which trades are short of people." Policy requires "a differentiated subsidy mechanism set by how urgently an occupation (trade) is needed, training cost, and similar factors," and localities set their own range of subsidized vocational skill training programs from that. So how much the subsidy for the same trade differs across cities directly reflects how short that trade is locally

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Official wages by occupation go only to five broad post categories, with no specific trades. National Bureau of Statistics figures for 2025 put the average annual wage at enterprises above designated size at about 106000 yuan (10.6 万; exact value 106080 yuan). Mid-level and above managers about 210000 yuan (21 万; exact value 210016 yuan), professional and technical staff about 155000 yuan (15.5 万; exact value 155491 yuan), clerical staff 94936 yuan, production and manufacturing staff 80739 yuan, and social production and personal-service staff 79857 yuan. The Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security "100 occupations most short of workers" ranking can be checked on China Employment Network; the latest edition stops at the fourth quarter of 2022. That ranking is built from hiring and job-seeker data from public employment service agencies in 102 cities nationwide. Online claims of "monthly pay for a certain trade" almost all come from posted rates on hiring platforms or personal self-reports. What reaches you is mostly the people who earned money, and none of them count hours, commuting, occupational disease, or busy versus slack seasons. For real demand, check the subsidy catalogue on the local human resources and social security bureau site, then the job-demand ranking from public employment service agencies. Finally ask people already on the job at actual sites, factories, and shops

## 13. For the same cost and time, prioritize short-duration programs that lead directly to employment

**Cost**. These programs require payment for short-term courses, which isn't a huge expense. They also demand a certain amount of time commitment. The tricky part is that if progress stalls before any results appear, you must still end the program per the original terms.

**In plain terms**. Government policies favor short-term, quick-to-employ training programs and micro-specializations offered by vocational schools. The only criterion for picking a program is whether it provides a specific job role you can apply for after completion. Programs that require a year or more of study and demand further experience after graduation actually cost far more than their listed price. It's crucial to set clear exit terms upfront: define exactly what level of skill you must reach before you can stop the program if you haven't secured a job yet.

**Benefit**. Government messaging aligns with this approach: it supports “private training institutions running market-oriented, high-quality vocational training programs and short-term, quick-to-employ vocational training initiatives.” It also encourages vocational schools to “focus on skills and knowledge urgently needed by the job market… and offer micro-specializations and vocational training courses.”

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The sole deciding factor is whether a specific job role is available for you to apply to after finishing the program. Programs that require a year or more of study and demand extra experience post-graduation end up costing far more than their advertised price. The exit terms outlined in Section 4 also apply here: you must clearly define in advance that you'll stop the program once you reach a certain skill level but still haven't found a job.

## 14. When you finish studying, close the book and test yourself first; do not go back and reread

**Cost**. No money, and total time need not rise. Turn the stretch you would have used to reread into closed-book writing from memory or doing problems. The hard part is that self-testing immediately shows what you did not remember, which feels worse than rereading.

**In plain terms**. Compared with reading a section again, closing the book and testing yourself works better. Adding short quizzes in class raises scores by a moderate amount. When ten common study methods are ranked, self-testing sits in the top band. After one section, first write the main points from memory, then open the book and check.

**Benefit**. A meta-analysis of 222 independent studies and 48478 students: classroom quizzes raised academic scores, with a moderate effect size (g = 0.499). Effect size depends on several conditions: what study method the control group used, whether quiz format matched the final exam, whether materials matched, and whether corrective feedback was given. Also how many times the quiz was repeated, where and when it was given, how long the intervention lasted, and what experimental design was used. Another review that rated ten common learning methods one by one put "practice testing" and "spaced practice" in the highest band (high utility). The reason is that they work across ages and abilities, and have been checked across many assessment formats and real education settings.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Self-testing is to force material out of your head, not to assign a grade. Method: after a section, close the book, write the main points first, then open and check. Corrective feedback works better, so after checking answers see clearly where you went wrong. Benefit magnitude is recorded as "large" from effect size and rating. These two pieces of evidence measure scores, not hours saved, so the time-saving thresholds were not applied. Self-testing and item 15 (spread the same time over several days) are the two highest-rated methods in the same review; use them together.

## 15. Spread the same time over several days; do not finish it in one sitting

**Cost**. No money, and total time stays the same. What changes is only the schedule: the same 3 hours, split into 1 hour on each of three days. The hard part is starting several days ahead and not leaving it to the last night.

**In plain terms**. The same time, spread over several days, sticks better than finishing in one sitting. There is also a practical rule: the longer you need to remember something, the longer the review gap should be. The farther the exam, the longer the gap, but research gives no universal number of days.

**Benefit**. A meta-analysis that pooled 184 papers, 317 experiments, and 839 evaluations of spaced practice. It compared two things: studying straight through versus studying in several sessions (the spacing effect), and short gaps versus long gaps (the lag effect). The conclusion is that review gap and "how long you need to remember" jointly set retention on the final test: the longer you need to hold the material, the longer the review gap that gives the best retention. Another review that rated ten common learning methods one by one put spaced practice in the highest band (high utility).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Best used stacked with item 14 (close the book and self-test): spread the self-tests themselves over several days. Much of the material in Cepeda's meta-analysis is word-list memory and the like; no universal best gap in days is given for complex content. "The farther the exam, the longer the gap" is the rule in the original; there is no concrete calendar. The problem with cramming the night before is not that it is useless on the spot, but that you forget fast.

## 16. Do not treat highlighting, rereading, and writing summaries as your main study methods

**Cost**. No money; it saves time instead. The hard part is that these feel the easiest and most like "I am studying."

**In plain terms**. What students use most is highlighting and rereading, yet among ten common study methods both sit in the lowest band. Writing summaries, the keyword method, and imagining pictures for a text also sit in the lowest band. They are not useless, only useful under narrow conditions; the same time spent on self-testing pays better.

**Benefit**. A review that rated ten common learning methods by "whether the effect generalizes across learning conditions, student traits, materials, and assessment formats." Rated highest: practice testing and spaced practice. Rated moderate: elaborative interrogation, self-explanation, interleaved practice. Rated lowest, five methods: writing summaries, highlighting (or underlining), the keyword method, imagining pictures for a text, and rereading. The review states that most students say they use rereading and highlighting, but neither steadily raises scores. The review says they should be replaced with other methods, for example practice testing instead of rereading.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This is not a ban on underlining. Underlining can mark "which spots to self-test in a moment"; the problem is treating underlining itself as studying. The review also says the lowest band is not zero; the conditions where these methods work are narrow and need more research. For replacements see item 14 (close the book and self-test) and item 15 (spread the same time over several days).

## 17. Mix several kinds of problems; do not do twenty of one kind in a row

**Cost**. No money. Change doing the workbook by problem type into mixing the types. The hard part is that mixed practice has lower accuracy on the spot and feels like going backward.

**In plain terms**. Doing a long string of the same kind of problem feels smooth on the spot. Mixing several kinds works better over the long run, by a moderate amount. But this method is picky about material: picture

tasks such as recognizing a painter's style work best; math problems a bit less; vocabulary is worse than blocked practice.

**Benefit**. A multilevel meta-analysis of 59 studies, 238 effect sizes, and 158 samples. Overall, interleaved practice versus blocked practice has a moderate effect (Hedges' g = 0.42). By material, painting-style tasks are best (g = 0.67); other visual materials are also better. Math tasks have a smaller effect (g = 0.34). Expository text and taste materials show no significant overall effect. For vocabulary, blocked practice is better (g = −0.39). Regression shows: the more similar the categories, the less similar items within a category, and the more complex the material, the larger the gain from interleaving.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The review cited in item 16 (do not treat highlighting as the main study method) rated interleaved practice moderate, because research was still thin then. Taken together, mix practice when you need to "recognize which kind this is and which method to use," such as math problem types, cases, or which rule of law applies. Use blocked practice for rote content, such as vocabulary or term definitions.

## 18. Do not pick a study method by "I am a visual learner, he is an auditory learner"

**Cost**. No money. You simply stop picking materials and courses by this label, and stop paying for style assessments.

**In plain terms**. Many people believe everyone has a learning style, such as visual or auditory, and that teaching to the style makes learning better. Careful tests of this claim are few; almost none support it, and a few go the other way. People do have preferences, but there is no evidence that teaching to the preference makes learning better, so do not pay for style assessments.

**Benefit**. A review commissioned to assess evidence on learning styles states: to show that "teaching by learning style" works, students must first be grouped by style, then each group randomly assigned to different teaching methods. The same test must be used at the end. The criterion of success is a specific interaction: the method that works best for one style is not the best for another. The review's conclusion is that almost no such interaction was found. There is a large literature on learning styles, but very few studies use an adequate experimental design, and several of those go directly against the "matching hypothesis." The authors therefore hold that current evidence is not enough to put learning-style assessment into education practice.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The review also says this does not mean every version of learning-style theory has been tested and rejected; many have never been tested. What to avoid is paying for style assessments and picking training courses by style. Criteria for picking training are in item 9 (prefer government-subsidized training channels) and item 13 (prefer short courses that lead straight to a job).

## 19. For material you must memorize, test yourself with questions in the form you will use later; do not count a verbatim run-through as done

**Cost**. No money, and no extra time. What changes is only the practice: replace "run through it verbatim" with "test yourself with questions in the form you will use later." The hard part is first being clear how you will use this material later.

**In plain terms**. Closing the book and testing yourself helps beyond the exact words you memorized. Across 192 comparisons and more than ten thousand people pooled, it also helps on questions with a changed format, on application problems, and on reasoning problems, by a moderate-to-small amount. Two cases work least well: swapping the question and the answer, and material you only saw in the book and were never tested on.

**Benefit**. A meta-analysis pooling more than 40 years of research, with 67 published and unpublished papers, 122 experiments, 192 transfer effect sizes, and 10382 people in total. Compared with a control that looked

again but was not tested, practice testing transferred learning to other situations, effect size d=0.40 (95% CI 0.31 to 0.50). Transfer was strongest when the test used a different question type, application and reasoning problems, medical-diagnosis-style questions, or near-meaning cue words. Transfer was weakest when stimulus and response were swapped, when material had been seen in first learning but never tested, and on example-style problems. Three moderators strongly affect whether positive transfer appears: whether response format matched between practice and test, whether retrieval practice with detailed feedback was done, and whether the first test was answered correctly. The authors also corrected for publication bias two ways. Moderator effect sizes changed little, but the intercept estimate was clearly pushed down: when none of the conditions above hold, positive transfer often does not appear

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Everyday "memorize" bundles two things: going over the material again (rereading, highlighting), and actively recalling with the book closed. The first ranks lowest in the review that ordered ten study methods; for the ratings themselves see item 16 (do not treat highlighting, rereading, and writing summaries as main study methods). What to do is the second: actively recall with the book closed, as in item 14 (close the book and self-test), and spread it over several days, as in item 15 (spread over several days). Method: first be clear how you will use it later—selecting on a paper, or judging on the spot—then write questions in that form and test yourself. Swapping directions and testing the other way is also worth doing, because in this meta-analysis transfer in the swapped direction is weakest, so both directions need practice.

## 20. First, figure out which professional series and level you belong to, then find the right application channels based on your employer type

**Cost**. No cost involved. It takes about half an hour to look up the latest application guidelines for your province.

**In plain terms**. There are 27 professional series nationwide, each divided into junior, intermediate, and senior levels. Generally, you must progress through these levels one by one. Employees working for organizations must have their applications reviewed and publicly posted by their employer before submission. Those working for private firms can apply via local professional qualification service centers, talent agencies, or industry associations. Self-employed individuals should apply through the local human resources and social security department.

**Benefit**. A total of 27 professional series exist across China, covering fields such as economics, engineering, healthcare, and publishing. These are categorized into senior, intermediate, and junior levels. Order No. 40 issued by the Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security applies to enterprises, public institutions, social organizations, individual economic entities, and self-employed professionals alike. Applicants must generally advance step by step through these levels. Employers must review all submitted materials and publicly display them for at least five working days. Private firms and self-employed individuals may opt to have talent agencies handle the review, public posting, and recommendation processes. Local authorities are required to establish professional qualification service centers in science parks and high-tech zones; applications may also be accepted through talent agencies, industry associations, and professional societies. Eligible self-employed individuals may participate in evaluations organized by local human resources departments. Any documentation that can be verified online must not require additional certification. If any materials are missing, evaluators must clearly specify what is lacking in one single notice. Employees of private firms typically apply in the region where their employment contract is based. Those assigned to work elsewhere for at least one full year may apply at their temporary duty location. Retired personnel are ineligible to apply. Public sector employees currently under disciplinary action at or above the level of a reprimand cannot apply during that period (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. No single nationwide list of required documents exists. Each professional series and province publishes its own annual application guidelines detailing necessary materials, deadlines, and performance criteria. Therefore, the first step is to search the official website of your provincial human resources department for the current year's instructions. Publishing academic papers is no longer mandatory: a 2016

reform directive explicitly removed this requirement for practical professionals, and standardized language or computer proficiency tests are no longer mandatory either. Skilled technical workers may also qualify to apply for engineering-related professional titles. Government officials are prohibited from participating in such evaluations.

## 21. Junior and intermediate titles in fields such as accounting are earned by a national unified exam; first check education and years of work before you register

**Cost**. Registration fees follow each province's standard. Preparing takes several months of spare time.

**In plain terms**. In some series, junior and intermediate titles are earned by exam; pass and you have them, with no separate review. Accounting works that way: assistant accountant needs high school or above; accountant needs a bachelor's plus 4 years of accounting work, or a junior-college diploma plus 5 years. People who already hold certain vocational qualifications may also be treated as holding the matching title.

**Benefit**. A 2016 reform opinion provides that where junior and intermediate titles use a national unified exam, the matching review or recognition is no longer done. In fields where titles and vocational qualifications are closely linked, holding the vocational qualification can be recognized as holding the matching title and can also serve as a condition for applying one level higher. Take accounting. Assistant accountant and accountant use a national unified exam. Senior accountant combines exam and review; principal senior is generally review only. Registration conditions are as follows. Assistant accountant: high-school graduation or above, including secondary specialized, vocational high school, and technical school. Accountant: a doctorate; or a master's plus 1 year of accounting work; or a second bachelor's, graduate-class graduation, plus 2 years; or a bachelor's plus 4 years; or a junior-college diploma plus 5 years. Holders of a professional master's or doctorate in accounting may be exempt from Financial Management when sitting the accountant exam (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Whether your series is exam, review, or exam-plus-review is in that series' "Guiding Opinions on Deepening Reform of the ×× Professional Title System." The Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security and industry authorities have issued them by series; they can be searched in the Chinese government website policy archive. Registration dates and subjects follow that year's exam notice. Civil servants may sit the accounting exam but may not take part in accounting title review.

## 22. Do not hire an agent to get a title for you, do not buy ghostwritten papers, and do not fake materials: once verified the title is revoked and a 3-year integrity record is kept

**Cost**. No money. The hard part is resisting ads that say "pay to guarantee a pass."

**In plain terms**. A title obtained with fake materials, ghostwritten papers, or plagiarized work is revoked once verified. The integrity record is kept for 3 years and also goes onto the national credit platform. If the commitment letter you signed when applying is false, you cannot apply again for 3 years. Human-resources authorities also specifically crack down on agents' false advertising, fake reviews, and fake certificates.

**Benefit**. Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security Order No. 40 provides that anyone who obtains a title by providing false materials, plagiarizing others' work or academic results, or other improper means has the title revoked. It is also entered in the title-review integrity archive and included in the national credit-information sharing platform, with a record period of 3 years. The 2024 supervision measures name several applicant violations: false commitments and forged information, ghostwritten or fake papers, fake performance records, and seeking favors. Applicants must sign a personal commitment letter; if the commitment is false, they may not apply for 3 years. Human-resources authorities, together with public security, cyberspace, and market regulation, investigate agents' fake websites, false advertising, contract

traps, impersonated reviews, and fake certificates. Where the case is serious and may be a crime, it is transferred to the relevant authorities (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. One way to tell real from fake: a title from a proper review can be found on the national title-review information query platform. Entry points are the 12333 website, the 12333 mobile app, and the Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security site. Titles from review committees that were not filed cannot be found in that system. So promises of "guaranteed pass," "no need for you to attend," or "usable even if the certificate cannot be found" can basically be treated as problems. The beneficiary is mainly you; benefit magnitude is set by "avoiding title revocation and a 3-year integrity record." The accounting professional qualification exam is on the judicial interpretation list of "national examinations provided for by law"; arranging a substitute sitter, selling answers, or organizing cheating in that kind of exam is a crime. Simply buying answers and peeking yourself is not listed as a crime in the statute and is handled under the exam's discipline rules; see Section 9, item 29 (do not arrange a substitute sitter).

## 23. Getting a professional title does not automatically mean a salary raise: first find out whether your employer uses a post-based quota system or if the title alone doesn't guarantee a post or raise

**Cost**. No cost at all. You only need to ask the HR department once.

**In plain terms**. A professional title is a basis for hiring, assessment, and promotion, but earning the title and being appointed to a post are two different things. Public institutions that use post management generally review within the post quota. Units that do not use post management can separate review from appointment; earning the title does not mean the unit will give the matching post and pay. After you change employer or locality, the title may need to be reviewed again or confirmed.

**Benefit**. Article 2 of Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security Order No. 40 states that professional title evaluations are a key basis for hiring, assessing, and promoting technical professionals. A 2016 reform guideline specifies that public institutions using a post quota system should conduct evaluations within those limits. For organizations without such a system, as well as for widely applicable professional categories and emerging occupations, title evaluation and post assignment can be separated. When technical professionals transfer between regions or employers, their titles are re-evaluated or confirmed per relevant administrative authority, unless otherwise stipulated by national regulations (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The evidence grade is set to B because the documents describe how title evaluation and post assignment relate to each other but provide no nationwide figures on how much salary rises after earning a title. What you can do: In public institutions and state-owned enterprises, ask HR about available post openings and hiring rules. In private companies, ask the owner or manager whether the title is recognized and if it brings any pay increase.

## 24. Whether to go on to a master's after a bachelor's: first count the tuition and the two or three years of wages you will not earn, then see whether your own subject pays more; people already at work can do a part-time master's, with the same certificate force as full-time

**Cost**. No money. Look once at the admissions notice and the tuition schedule, then run the sum against the job opportunity you have in hand. About one or two hours.

**In plain terms**. A master's costs tuition, and it also costs two or three years of wages you do not earn; the latter is usually the larger part. In a UK study, after differences in family background and bachelor's results were taken out, women who had done a master's earned only about 2% more at 35, and men about 2% less,

with large gaps by subject. People already at work can do a part-time master's; the certificate has the same force as full-time, but you do not get the state grant.

**Benefit**. First the cost. A 2013 national opinion sets tuition for a full-time academic master's, in principle, at not more than 8000 yuan a year. A full-time professional master's follows the old fee policy and is not under that ceiling; it is often much more expensive. Full-time postgraduates inside the enrollment plan can all receive the state postgraduate grant. For a master's it is not less than 6000 yuan a year; the exact standard is set locally. Next the return. A study published by the UK Department for Education in 2020 used national student records and tax records to follow people who finished a bachelor's from the mid-1990s to the mid-2000s. The study took out differences in family background and in bachelor's results, and looked at income at 35. The original wording is "we estimate returns of 2% (women) and −2% (men) for masters": women who had done a master's earned about 2% more than women with only a bachelor's, and men about 2% less. The subject gap is large. Women who did a master's in law, economics, or management earned about 20% more; those who did arts, English, or philosophy earned more than 10% less. For men, the master's return was clearly negative in most subjects, but law, economics, management, and engineering were still clearly positive. People already at work can sit a part-time master's and study while working. A 2016 Ministry of Education notice provides that part-time and full-time sit the same entrance exam and are trained to the same standard. The two kinds of academic and degree certificates "have equal legal status and the same force"; the graduation certificate notes the mode of study. The state grant goes only to full-time postgraduates inside the enrollment plan; part-time students do not receive it. In 2019, five ministries including the Ministry of Education issued a notice. Civil-service recruitment and open hiring by public institutions and state firms must give equal job opportunity to postgraduates of different modes of study. Those hirings must not set application conditions unrelated to the post. The Ministry of Education 2021 graduate employment notice states that recruitment notices of Party and government organs, public institutions, and state firms must not use mode of study as a restrictive condition. The 2022 notice again states that all kinds of campus recruitment must not restrict that way

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Contested. Earlier UK studies kept finding a positive return to a master's. The authors of this study think their own data are finer and the adjustments cleaner. The authors also grant that they could not adjust away differences such as motivation and job preferences. The data stop at age 35 and use people who graduated twenty or thirty years ago. No figure that adjusts for personal differences in the same way was found for China, so this can only be read as a direction. The evidence grade is therefore B. The way to run the sum is the same as item 6 of this section (study or go to work): set the two or three years of wages not earned against the extra earned each year after. Some job notices state outright that a master's is required, for example universities, research institutes, and some state firms. In that case the education threshold is itself the return, and it has to be counted separately. The part-time notices are ministry notices; they state no penalty and no office to complain to if they are broken. They govern how recruitment notices are written; they do not govern whom the employer finally picks. Campus recruitment has an explicit limit; no explicit rule on mode of study was found for private employers' open social hiring. The 2025 admissions management rules state that part-time programs in principle admit only people already at work who will return to their original employer after graduation. Tuition, awards and aid, and housing are written by the school into the admissions charter. How household registration and files are handled is not uniformly set in any national document found for this book; before you apply, read the notice carefully and ask the school.

## 25. Whether to go on to a doctorate after a master's: do it only if the job you want states that it requires a doctorate, and count the mental load before you start

**Cost**. No money. Look through the education requirements in the job notices of the place you want to work, then talk once with two or three people who are doing a doctorate.

**In plain terms**. In the same UK study, after differences in family background and bachelor's results were taken out, at 35 a doctorate earned women about 8% more than a bachelor's alone, and men about 9% less.

The mental load of a doctorate is also heavy. About one in four doctoral students across countries has clear depressive symptoms, and about one in six has clear anxiety symptoms. So first see whether the job you want will not hire without a doctorate, then decide whether to do one.

**Benefit**. The 2020 UK Department for Education study cited in item 24 of this section (doing a master's) also calculated the doctorate. The original wording is "8% (women) and −9% (men) for PhDs": after taking out differences in family background and in bachelor's results, at 35 a doctorate earned women about 8% more than a bachelor's alone, and men about 9% less. The study also found that a doctorate lowered the chance of unemployment and the chance of annual income below 30000 pounds (3 万), and also lowered the chance of annual income above 40000 pounds (4 万). Subjects differ a lot. The return to a doctorate in mathematics was especially low. A doctorate in psychology was among the highest. The mental load during the doctorate is in a 2021 pooled analysis. Across 16 studies and 23469 doctoral students, those with clear depressive symptoms came to about 24% in total (95% CI 18%–31%, the credible range). Across 9 studies and 15626 doctoral students, those with clear anxiety symptoms were about 17% (12%–23%). The studies differed a great deal from each other ($I^2$ about 98%). The cost in China follows the 2013 opinion: tuition for a full-time academic doctorate is in principle not more than 10000 yuan a year (1 万), and the state postgraduate grant is not less than 10000 yuan a year (1 万)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Contested. The depression and anxiety figures only pool the proportions from surveys in various countries. They are not compared with people of the same age, and the scales used are not the same. So they show that these symptoms are common among doctoral students. They do not show that doing the doctorate caused them. A pooling of Chinese-language studies found little difference in psychological symptoms between doctoral students and master's students, but both were higher than the national norm and the youth norm. The limits of the income figures are the same as in item 24 of this section (doing a master's). They can only be read as a direction. Job notices for university teaching posts, research institutes, and some research-and-development posts often state that a doctorate is required. If you want that path, first go through the notices of the last few years at the place you want. If low mood during the course lasts more than two weeks, first do the things in Section 3, item 18 (what to do first when mood is low). If there are thoughts of suicide, call 12356. See Section 1, item 25 (call 12356 when depressed or having thoughts of suicide).

# 24. Seeking medical care: How to save money and avoid unnecessary hassle

This section focuses on the practical steps involved in getting medical treatment — which hospitals to visit first, how to transfer between levels of care, and where you can cut down on expenses. It also explains how to wait in emergency queues, what evaluations and documents are required after serious injuries, and what benefits you may be eligible for (see Section 7). Long-term management of chronic diseases is covered in Section 16, while immediate actions at the scene of an emergency are described in Section 13.

The content is largely based on the “Several Measures on Accelerating the Development of a Hierarchical Medical System” issued by the General Office of the State Council in April 2026. This system directs patients to hospitals according to the severity of their condition. The document explicitly links using primary-level facilities with lower medical costs. However, implementation varies by region, so the national rules outlined here should be cross-checked with local policies issued by your social insurance and health authorities. Your “coordinated region” is simply the area where you're enrolled in medical insurance — usually a city.

## 1. For a common illness, start at the community clinic, go up by stepwise referral, and let the inpatient deductible carry forward

**Cost**. No money. You do have to make a trip to the community clinic first. The hard part is holding back from booking a specialist directly.

**In plain terms**. Go to the community clinic first. If the clinic then refers you to a large hospital for a stay, the stretch you pay at the start carries forward, and you do not pay that stretch a second time. How the arithmetic works is set locally. In Sichuan you only make up the difference between the hospitals' deductibles. If a large hospital transfers you back to the community clinic to continue the stay, the same illness is not calculated again during that period.

**Benefit**. For an insured patient referred up step by step from primary care, the inpatient deductible at the higher hospital can be calculated continuously. The deductible is the stretch you pay yourself at the start of each hospital stay. Yibao (basic medical insurance) starts reimbursing only after that stretch is paid. The State Council document does not say how continuous calculation works in detail. Localities set that. Sichuan's method is to charge only the difference between the hospitals' deductibles. The county traditional Chinese medicine hospital has a deductible of 600 yuan. Transfer to the county people's hospital (deductible 800 yuan), and you only need to pay another 200 yuan. For an inpatient transferred down from a higher hospital back to primary care, no separate deductible is set again for the same illness in the same treatment period.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Referral rules are set separately by each province, each city, and each medical consortium. Ask the community clinic before you go. For a chronic illness that is stable, do not go back to a large hospital just to refill medicine, because ordinary outpatient visits of this kind at large hospitals will be cut back over time. A community clinic can prescribe 12 weeks of medicine at a time. See Section 16, item 5 (a community clinic can prescribe up to 12 weeks of medicine at a time).

## 2. In the same pooling area (where you are enrolled), a lower hospital level reimburses a higher share, a gap of about 10 percentage points

**Cost**. No money. The hard part is holding back from running to a large hospital.

**In plain terms**. The document requires that, for the same inpatient bill, a lower hospital level reimburses a higher share. Localities have to open a gap between levels, about 10 percentage points for each step up. On a bill of 10000 yuan, if the share paid back drops from 80% to 70%, what you pay yourself goes from 2000 yuan to 3000 yuan. Newly added yibao (basic medical insurance) funds also tilt toward primary care.

**Benefit**. The document requires localities to open a gap in inpatient reimbursement across hospital levels, in principle about 10 percentage points at each step. On that gap, each step up to a higher hospital means you

pay about 10% more of the reimbursable bill yourself. Take 10000 yuan of reimbursable inpatient charges. If the reimbursement share drops from 80% to 70%, what you pay yourself goes from 2000 yuan to 3000 yuan. The extra 1000 yuan is a tenth of the total bill, but what you pay yourself is half again what you used to pay. Actual shares differ by place, and the deductible and the cap also move the gap. This is only an illustration using the document's 10 percentage points. Newly added yibao funds for the year also tilt toward primary care.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. For the same inpatient bill, the difference you pay yourself between primary care and a tertiary hospital can be a few thousand yuan. An illness that can be finished at primary care should not be taken up the ladder. That does not mean every illness has to be seen at the community clinic.

## 3. To reach a large hospital, go through a primary-care referral or the hospital's referral center, and do not go to a scalper

**Cost**. No money. There is an extra referral step to complete.

**In plain terms**. The lead hospital in a medical consortium has to hold back a share of appointment slots and beds for people referred up from primary care. The hospital also has to set up a referral center, or name a fixed department to handle referrals, with full coverage by 2027. Failing to get a slot does not mean there is no way in. You do not need to go to a scalper.

**Benefit**. The lead hospital of a tight medical consortium must reserve a share of appointment slots and beds for primary care, and must take in, without delay, patients referred up from primary care. A tight medical consortium is a group of hospitals and community health institutions bound together to work as a set. A referral up from the community clinic therefore has its own slots and beds, and does not have to compete with people grabbing slots in the lobby. Medical institutions must set up a referral center or name a fixed department, with full coverage by 2027.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The reserved slots are kept for referred patients. If you cannot grab a slot, you can still go through referral. If you cannot find the referral center, call the hospital's service line and ask.

## 4. Before going out of province for care, ask locally first. In principle, whether it is necessary is assessed by an associate chief physician or above

**Cost**. No money. Ask once more before you set out.

**In plain terms**. Whether you need to go elsewhere for care is, in principle, assessed by a doctor at associate chief physician rank or above, at a secondary or tertiary hospital. How much temporary care away from home is reimbursed differs from care at a hospital of the same level where you are enrolled. The local rules say by how much. Asking locally before you set out is better than arriving elsewhere and only then finding it will not be reimbursed.

**Benefit**. Whether cross-pool and cross-province care elsewhere is necessary is, in principle, assessed by staff at associate chief physician rank or above at a secondary or tertiary hospital. Crossing pooling areas means leaving the place where you are enrolled in yibao (basic medical insurance). Whether it is necessary to go elsewhere is, in principle, something a doctor of sufficient rank has to say. The reimbursement level for people who temporarily seek care out of province keeps a reasonable gap from institutions of the same level where they are enrolled. For the same illness seen elsewhere, the money that comes back is a step lower than at home.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Temporary care away from home and long-term residence elsewhere are different filings, and the reimbursement level is not the same. How to file, and which illnesses can be settled directly, is in Section 16. Do not rush off elsewhere and only then think about reimbursement.

## 5. After every visit, keep your own copy of the records, the test reports, and the images

**Cost**. No money. A hospital may charge a materials fee for copies, as the rules allow, and the fee schedule has to be public. The hard part is remembering to copy a set after every visit.

**In plain terms**. Looking up and copying your own records is a right the law gives you. Outpatient records, the inpatient record, lab slips, images, surgery and anesthesia records, pathology material, and the bill can all be copied. The hospital has to name a department or a person to take the request, and it may charge only the materials fee. Changing hospitals, having another doctor look again, claiming on commercial insurance, and a real dispute all rest on this stack of papers.

**Benefit**. The rules list looking up and copying the medical record as a patient's right. The scope covers the outpatient record, the inpatient record, lab slips, medical images, surgery and anesthesia records, pathology material, medical charges, and the rest of the file. Changing hospitals, having a second doctor look again, claiming on commercial insurance, and a real dispute all rest on these papers.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Copying is handled by the department the hospital names. You do not have to ask a doctor for a favor. For the list of what to copy, read out Article 16 of the Regulations on the Prevention and Handling of Medical Disputes. First come the outpatient record, the inpatient record, the temperature chart, the order sheet, lab slips, and images. Then come the surgery and anesthesia records, pathology material, nursing notes, and the medical bill. After you have them, file them in time order. What matters most in the folder is the discharge summary, the operative note, the pathology report, and the key images. Write each round of chronic-illness readings in the same notebook. See Section 16.

## 6. If you have doubts about treatment, request to seal the medical records on the spot; both parties must be present, a list must be drawn up, and each side gets a copy

**Cost**. No cost at all. Simply ask the hospital to seal the records; both you and the medical staff must be present to complete the paperwork. The real challenge is mustering the courage to say this out loud in front of the doctors.

**In plain terms**. If you're unsure about any aspect of your treatment, you have the right to request that your medical records be sealed. Both you and the medical staff must be present for this process, which involves creating a detailed list, signing and stamping it, and each side receiving a copy. If the records aren't fully completed yet, only the finished portions should be sealed first; the rest can be sealed later. Should you suspect that an intravenous infusion, blood transfusion, injection, or medication caused a problem, the actual fluid bag, medicine vial, and infusion set must also be sealed together with the records.

**Benefit**. Regulations clearly state that “whenever a medical dispute arises and it is necessary to seal or unseal medical records, this must be done while both the patient and medical staff are present.” The sealed documents may be either originals or copies, which the hospital then stores. If the records are still being written, only the completed sections should be sealed first; the remainder can be sealed later. The hospital must produce a sealing list, signed or stamped by both parties, with each side keeping a copy. In cases where an adverse effect is suspected to stem from an IV, blood transfusion, injection, or medication, both parties must jointly seal and later unseal any related physical items. If testing is required, both parties must jointly appoint a qualified laboratory; should they fail to agree, the local health authority at the county level where the hospital is located will make the appointment. Should a transfusion-related problem be suspected and blood samples need sealing, the hospital must notify the blood bank to send representatives to the scene.

Additionally, there is a strict rule: “No organization or individual may alter, forge, conceal, destroy, or seize medical records.” Once a dispute is resolved or three years pass without any further claims, the hospital may unseal the documents on its own initiative (nationwide, effective 1 October 2018).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Sealing records and making copies are two distinct actions. Copying records is something you should do proactively, as explained in item 5 (always keep your own copies of medical records and imaging). Sealing, on the other hand, serves to preserve evidence at the moment a dispute arises, preventing any later alterations or additions. If you suspect that an IV, blood transfusion, injection, or medication caused a problem, you must seal not only the records but also the fluid bag, medicine vial, and infusion set; otherwise they might be removed or discarded. Hospitals are required to prominently display information about dispute resolution procedures, contact details, and to maintain a dedicated complaints department. In case of any issue, approach that department rather than confronting the attending physician directly.

## 7. For a severe injury or illness, go straight to the emergency triage desk, and do not queue at the registration window

**Cost**. No money. Walk a few more steps inside the door to find the triage desk. Say the most dangerous symptom in a single sentence.

**In plain terms**. The emergency department does not go by who arrived earlier. It sorts people into Level I through Level IV by how serious the condition is. The place that sets the level is the triage desk at the emergency entrance, not the registration window. When you arrive, report the most dangerous thing: heavy bleeding, not being able to get air, not being fully conscious, chest pain like a heart problem, or pain you cannot stand.

**Benefit**. The National Health Commission's 2024 edition of the emergency-medicine quality-control indicators says emergency triage must "sort patients into levels by how critical the condition is." "Level I is a critical emergency and needs treatment at once." "Level II is a severe emergency, and assessment and treatment often go on together." "Level III is an urgent case and needs to be seen within a short time." "Level IV is a non-urgent or less urgent case and is seen in order in the ordinary treatment area." Triage means that, on entering the emergency department, someone first rates how serious it is and sets the order of care. Beijing's implementation standard gives the response required at each level. Level 1: "assess and treat at once, and move the patient into the resuscitation room or the rescue room." Level 2: "monitor vital signs at once, start treatment within 10 minutes, and move the patient into the rescue room." Level 3: "treat ahead of level 4 patients, and have the patient wait in the ordinary treatment area; if the wait is longer than 30 minutes, assess again." Level 4: "seen in order, and the wait is long unless the condition changes; if the wait is longer than 4 hours, another assessment is allowed." In the Beijing standard, the manual rating indicators for level 1 include "acute disturbance of consciousness." Those for level 2 include "active or severe blood loss," "severe difficulty breathing," "chest pain that looks like a heart cause," and "severe pain from any cause (7 to 10 points)." Triage must "keep to the rule that critical and severe cases are seen first," and the entrance of the emergency department should have a triage area in a prominent place (the level standard is the national rule, and the response times are the Beijing standard).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Sorting into levels is the same across the country. How soon each level is handled is set by each province and city. This Beijing text is a version that can be checked word for word. The rating looks at heart rate, blood pressure, blood oxygen, and symptoms. Pain is among the items. Pain at 7 to 10 points can be rated level 2. The hard indicators for level 1 include the following. A heart rate above 180 beats a minute, or below 40 beats a minute. A systolic pressure below 70 mmHg. Systolic pressure is the higher reading in a blood-pressure pair. Blood oxygen below 80%. Shock, a definite myocardial infarction, or acute disturbance of consciousness. If you think triage set you too low, add the most dangerous symptom and say it clearly. If the condition changes while you wait, go back to the triage desk and get rated again at once. When it is truly critical, call 120 (see Section 13). Beijing's plan requires the pre-hospital emergency doctor to give a first

rating by the standard, and for levels 1 and 2 to notify the emergency department of the receiving hospital in time so it can prepare to take the patient.

## 8. With no money, no papers, and no way to say who you are, emergency care still has to come first

**Cost**. No money.

**In plain terms**. The state has a disease emergency-assistance fund that pays emergency fees for both of these groups: people whose identity cannot be established, and people who cannot pay. A hospital must not refuse or delay the rescue, and an emergency center must not keep the ambulance in because of money. So do not stay home and endure it because you have no money, and do not skip calling an ambulance for fear of the bill. This money covers only the emergency. The hospital stay after that still goes through yibao (basic medical insurance) and medical assistance.

**Benefit**. The people the disease emergency-assistance system covers are "patients who suffer an acute, severe, or critical injury or illness inside China, who need emergency care, but whose identity is unclear or who cannot pay the corresponding fees." The fund pays both kinds of fees: "emergency fees incurred by a patient whose identity cannot be established," and "emergency fees left unpaid by a patient whose identity is clear but who cannot pay." The document also says "medical institutions of every kind, and their staff, must treat a patient with an acute, severe, or critical injury in time and effectively, and must not refuse, shift, or delay treatment for any reason." Pre-hospital emergency care has a rule too. The national pre-hospital medical emergency number is "120." An emergency center (station) "must not refuse, shift, or delay pre-hospital medical emergency service because of dispatch," and also "must not refuse or delay pre-hospital medical emergency service because of fees." Transport follows "the principles of nearness, urgency, meeting the professional need, and taking the patient's wishes into account" (nationwide, since 2013).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The fund pays only the "emergency fee" stretch. Treatment comes first, and the institution applies to the fund afterward. You do not collect the money at a window. If you have yibao, you still use yibao first, as usual. The application steps and the caps differ by province. In the transport principles, "nearness and urgency" come before "the patient's wishes," so the ambulance will not necessarily take you to the hospital you name. When the case is critical, the nearest place that can handle it is the rule. If what you still pay yourself afterward is still too heavy, use medical assistance. See Section 7, item 10 (medical assistance).

## 9. A disability assessment waits until treatment has ended, or until the clinical result is stable

**Cost**. The assessment fee runs from a few hundred yuan to 2000 yuan. The side that applies usually advances it. You wait until treatment has ended, or until the clinical result is stable. How long that takes depends on the injury. The doctor decides. The hard part is wanting the rating fixed before the injury has properly healed, and holding that back.

**In plain terms**. How much is paid depends mainly on which grade is given, and the grade depends on how much function is still lost after treatment. The standard says the assessment is done after treatment has ended, or after the clinical result is stable. Going for a rating before the bone has healed does not meet that requirement. An ordinary fracture that has healed and does not affect function generally does not get a grade.

**Benefit**. The assessment principle in the Classification of the Degree of Disability Caused by Human Injury is that it "shall take the outcome or the end result of treatment of the injury as the basis, and shall objectively rate the loss of tissue or organ and/or the degree of functional impairment." The standard says the timing "shall be after treatment of the primary injury, and of complications that are truly linked to it, has ended, or after the clinical result is stable." The standard "divides the degree of disability caused by human injury into 10 grades, from the first grade (a human disability rate of 100%) to the tenth grade (a human disability rate of 10%), with each grade 10% apart in disability rate." The basis of judgment is "destruction of the structure of

human tissues and organs, functional impairment, and how far the person depends on medical care and nursing, with due regard to the effect of the disability on social contact and on psychological factors." Clauses in the tenth grade that relate to fractures include the following. The first is "a compression fracture of a single vertebral body (compression reaching 1/3) or a comminuted fracture." The second is "fractures, or a comminuted fracture, at more than a single site on the pelvis, healed with deformity." The third is "loss of 25% or more of function in any large joint of the limbs (excluding the ankle)." Disability of the same site and the same nature must not be counted twice. Where there is disability at more than a single site, each grade should be written separately (nationwide, in force from January (1) 1, 2017).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The rating systems do not substitute for each other. Do not mix them up. For an assault, a traffic accident, or other personal injury, the judicial assessment uses the Classification of the Degree of Disability Caused by Human Injury, and it is used to calculate disability compensation (see Section 9). A work injury goes through a work-capacity assessment, which uses another set of disability grades and governs work-injury benefits (see Section 19). To receive the policy benefits for disabled people, you apply separately for a disability certificate (see item 10, the disability certificate). Before the assessment, have the records, the operative notes, and the follow-up images ready (see item 5, keep your own copy of the records and images). The standard does not say whether an early assessment comes out low or high. That is inferred from the principle "take the outcome or the end result of treatment of the injury as the basis." An early assessment rates how things look then. Function that has not yet recovered may later get better, or it may get worse. When this injury is mixed with an old problem that was already there, the opinion also has to say how large a share of the disability result this injury accounts for. That line directly affects how much is paid.

## 10. After treatment, functional impairments may indeed remain; apply for a disability certificate at the county-level disability association in your hukou area

**Cost**. There is no fee for issuing the certificate itself. In principle, applicants must cover the assessment and photography costs, though those in financial hardship may request exemptions. You'll need to bring your ID, hukou registration, and three two-inch photos with a white background to the county-level disability association. Once approved, the decision is posted in your village or community for five working days, after which the association has ten working days to finalize the process. The main difficulty lies in making multiple trips and waiting through this period.

**In plain terms**. A disability certificate is the threshold for receiving disability benefits. It is not proof of an injury. Disabilities fall into 7 categories: vision, hearing, speech, physical, intellectual, mental, and multiple. Each category runs from level 1 to level 4. The process is application, acceptance, assessment at a designated institution, public posting, review and approval, and issuance. It is valid for 10 years, and when it expires it is replaced free of charge. If you disagree with the assessment result, you can apply for a new assessment.

**Benefit**. The disability certificate is “the legal proof of a person's disability status and classification, serving as a key basis for accessing national and local preferential policies.” Assessment follows the national standard GB/T 26341-2010. Applications are voluntary and administered locally. All seven disability types qualify for levels one through four. County-level associations handle applications and issuance based on evaluations conducted by provincially designated hospitals or specialized institutions. Approved cases are posted publicly for five days, then finalized within ten days. No fee is charged for the certificate; assessment and photography costs are normally the applicant's responsibility, though some regions offer subsidies or exemptions for those in need. The certificate lasts ten years and can be renewed at no cost; re-evaluation is possible if conditions change. Disagreements with assessment results may be appealed to municipal or provincial expert committees within ten days (effective nationwide since 1 January 2018).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Calculate the costs and benefits before deciding to apply. The certificate itself does not provide direct financial aid; rather, it unlocks two main subsidies: living allowances for disabled individuals in dibao

households, and care subsidies for those at levels one and two requiring long-term assistance — details appear in Section 7, Article 8. It also qualifies holders for local rehabilitation services, assistive devices, tax reductions, employment support, and transport perks; exact criteria vary widely by province, so consult your local disability association website first. Importantly, this certificate differs from judicial disability evaluations or occupational injury assessments — see Section 10 regarding post-treatment evaluation timing. The certificate is strictly personal and non-transferable; misuse or failure to meet ongoing criteria results in revocation, with a one-year ban on reapplication. For multiple disabilities, the most severe category determines the classification level.

## 11. Thank the doctors who saved you — send thank-you letters, banners, or satisfaction ratings instead of cash gifts. The rules prohibit money, not gratitude

**Cost**. It costs nothing at all. Writing a thank-you letter or filling out a satisfaction survey takes just a few minutes.

**In plain terms**. Paying money in advance will not buy you a better place in line. Appointment slots, beds, scarce drugs, and the scheduling of surgery must not be traded for a favor. Afterward you may thank the doctor who saved your life, but do not give cigarettes, alcohol, or a red envelope of cash. If the doctor accepts them, that breaks the rules. To say thanks, fill in a satisfaction rating with care, or write a thank-you letter that names the person, or present a banner.

**Benefit**. Article 7 of the “Nine Guidelines on Ethical Conduct for Medical Staff” (No. 41, 2021) states: “Maintain orderly medical practices and ensure fairness. Uphold equality to foster a just healthcare environment. It is strictly prohibited to accept personal benefits in exchange for allocating scarce medical resources such as appointment slots, beds, medicines, tests, or surgeries.” Article 8 adds: “Build harmonious relationships without accepting ‘red envelopes' from patients. Adhere strictly to medical ethics and self-discipline.” It further specifies that accepting gifts, cash, gift cards, securities, or other valuables from patients or relatives is forbidden. Likewise, attending paid meals or entertainment arranged by patients is prohibited. Hospitals must enforce these rules, conduct inspections, and penalize violations. Satisfaction ratings now form part of performance evaluations for all tertiary public hospitals under national policy. According to official documents, hospital satisfaction comprises both patient and staff satisfaction, measured via surveys of outpatients, inpatients, and medical staff. A unified national platform collects these results, which are then factored into hospital performance reviews. Hospitals must also handle patient complaints per regulations, establishing dedicated offices to receive, investigate, and respond to concerns regarding medical services, safety, and quality. The basis is the State Council General Office opinion, document (2019) 4: the performance index system has 4 groups of indicators. By the end of March (3) 2019, every tertiary public hospital was to be on the national satisfaction-survey platform. Complaints are governed by the medical-institution complaint measures, Order No. 3, effective 2019.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Both you and your doctors benefit from this practice. It does not mean you should never express gratitude — after a night of emergency treatment, it's natural to want to say thanks. The key is choosing appropriate methods. Cash gifts and alcohol place doctors at risk of disciplinary action; thank-you letters, banners, and satisfaction ratings are fully aligned with official policies. If a doctor declines a gift you've already offered, it's not personal — it's his duty to refuse. Note also that offering gifts to doctors falls under professional ethics and hospital rules, whereas giving bribes to law enforcement or investigators constitutes a criminal offense under the law; these situations are entirely different; the latter is section 8, item 40. While thank-you letters and banners are widely accepted, there is no official rule stating they become part of personal or departmental records — this is merely anecdotal experience. Only the inclusion of satisfaction ratings in hospital performance assessments has solid policy backing. Should you have doubts about treatment, you may request immediate medical record sealing and retain copies for yourself see item 6 of this section (sealing the record) and item 5 (keep your own copies).

## 12. Before an implant, ask which items the flat fee includes, prefer an institution that has pledged to join the price controls, and do not trust a low-price ad

**Cost**. No money. Before the dental visit, look up the institution list once on the National Healthcare Security Administration's public account, and ask the prices to your face. It takes about a dozen minutes.

**In plain terms**. After the 2023 concentrated price cut for implants, the overall fee for a routine implant fell from an average of 15000 yuan to 6000 to 7000 yuan. At a tertiary public hospital the service fee for a single routine implant is in principle no more than 4500 yuan. The implant and the crown are charged separately. Implants, dentures, and orthodontics are not reimbursed by yibao (basic medical insurance). Dental treatment items are generally reimbursed, and the local rules say which ones.

**Benefit**. A January 2024 announcement from the National Healthcare Security Administration says the fee for a routine single-tooth implant is made of separate parts. The first part is the medical service fee, charged as a flat fee. The flat fee covers "the consultation fee for the whole implant course, biochemistry tests and imaging fees, the implant placement fee, the crown placement fee, and the scanning, design, and modeling fee, and it does not include extraction, periodontal cleaning, root-canal treatment, bone grafting, or soft-tissue grafting." "In each locality, the medical service charge for a single routine implant at a tertiary public hospital is in principle no more than 4500 yuan." In economically developed regions, under the 2022 special price-control notice, it can be relaxed by at most 20%. The second part is the implant. In the national bulk purchase of January 2023, "the selected prices ran from 548 yuan to 1855 yuan, with an average a little over 900 yuan." The Sichuan healthcare security bureau, which led the purchase, reported that expensive imported brands fell from a median purchase price of 5000 yuan to about 1850 yuan, and the brands used in the largest amounts fell from about 1500 yuan to about 770 yuan. The third part is the crown, "with prices from 100 yuan to 656 yuan, and an average a little over 300 yuan." At a press conference in the second half of 2023, the National Healthcare Security Administration said local control measures were all in place by the end of April and the start of May (5), and that "the overall implant fee fell from an average of 15000 yuan to about 6000 to 7000 yuan." On reimbursement: a 1999 document from the labor and social security ministry and other departments lists "dentures" (false teeth) and "non-functional cosmetic or orthopedic surgery" as not paid by basic yibao. In a 2019 reply to a political-consultative proposal, the National Healthcare Security Administration said, "Cosmetic items (including restoration and straightening of missing teeth, and similar care) are not in the scope paid by the yibao fund. Treatment items in dentistry are not excluded at the national level, and localities have generally brought them into the scope yibao pays" (nationwide, as of October 2026).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The 4500 yuan line applies only to public hospitals. Private institutions set their own prices, but the special price-control notice says they must not use a false or misleading "subsidy" or "low price" to draw patients in. A low price in an ad is often only the implant itself. Extraction, bone grafting, and the other items outside the flat fee are where the price is added. So before you sign, get a sheet that writes the price of each item. The National Healthcare Security Administration publishes, on its official WeChat account, the list of institutions that have pledged to join the price controls. Missing a tooth or a couple of teeth does not mean an implant is the only repair. A fixed denture and a removable denture are also ways to repair a gap, and their prices did not move with this cut. Ask the dentist which of them suits you. Whether an employee yibao individual account can pay for an implant has no single national answer. Ask the local yibao department. For how an individual account is used for family members, see Section 5, item 13 (family pooling). For why a missing tooth should be seen, see Section 2, item 10 (see a dentist about a missing tooth). The benefit magnitude is set at medium: the price cut is brought by policy, and what this step can save you is mainly the add-on outside the flat fee and the share charged by a high-priced institution, a few thousand yuan for a single tooth.

## 13. If the hospital says a nationally negotiated yibao drug is out of stock or not stocked, have the doctor write a prescription and buy it at a dual-channel designated pharmacy. It is still reimbursed under the rules

**Cost**. No money. You need the doctor to write a prescription, and then a trip to the designated pharmacy. Some places require a drug-eligibility confirmation first.

**In plain terms**. If the hospital says a nationally negotiated drug is out of stock or not stocked, that does not mean the drug cannot be reimbursed. If the drug is in this province's dual channel, have the doctor write the prescription as usual and buy it at a dual-channel designated pharmacy. The reimbursement policy is the same as buying it at the hospital. Under the national document, the hospital also must not delay stocking it on the grounds of the yibao (basic medical insurance) total, or of the share of revenue from drugs.

**Benefit**. A negotiated drug is a drug the National Healthcare Security Administration priced with the manufacturer and then put in the yibao catalog. A 2021 policy explainer from the administration says the catalog is adjusted once a year, and the sequence became "into yibao first, and into the hospital after," so some negotiated drugs are "hard to get into the hospital." For that, the National Healthcare Security Administration and the National Health Commission issued Yi Bao Fa [2021] No. 28. The document says the dual channel is "a mechanism that supplies negotiated drugs through designated medical institutions and designated retail pharmacies" and "brings them into yibao payment at the same time." For a drug in the dual channel, "designated medical institutions and designated retail pharmacies apply a unified payment policy." Buying at a pharmacy and buying at a hospital follow the same reimbursement rules. Which drugs are included is, in principle, set by the provincial yibao department. Which pharmacies are included, the yibao department must "disclose to the public promptly and on its own initiative." The prescription is sent to the pharmacy through the prescription-transfer center in the yibao system, and the requirement is to "keep electronic prescriptions moving smoothly." In September of that year, Yi Bao Han [2021] No. 182 required that, for a negotiated drug the hospital cannot stock for the moment, the hospital "raise access to the drug through the dual channel and similar routes." Negotiated drugs used appropriately are listed separately and are not counted in the hospital's drug-share assessment. The document also says "the landing of negotiated drugs must not be affected on the grounds of a yibao total cap, a limit on how many drugs are in the institution's formulary, the drug-revenue share, or similar reasons." It also required that, before the end of November 2021, each prefecture-level city have at least 1 dual-channel retail pharmacy. The notice on the 2025 edition of the yibao drug catalog (Yi Bao Fa [2025] No. 33) repeats that sentence, "must not, on those grounds." The notice also says that, in principle, a negotiated drug must not be taken out of the dual channel just because it has been moved into the regular catalog. Designated pharmacies that dispense dual-channel drugs "must all receive this kind of prescription through the electronic prescription center." The new catalog takes effect on January (1) 1, 2026 (nationwide, as of October 2026).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The method has these steps. First, ask the doctor whether this drug is a dual-channel drug in this province, and whether a prescription can be written. The prescription usually goes out as an electronic prescription in the yibao system. Second, find which pharmacy can sell it. Each provincial healthcare security bureau publishes the drug list and the pharmacy list, and you can also call the local yibao department and ask. The national yibao service app opened a search, in 2021, for institutions that stock negotiated drugs. Third, take your yibao card, or the electronic yibao certificate, and buy it. The pharmacy has to check that the person on the prescription and the person taking the drug are the same person. Fourth, ask the reimbursement share, whether it counts as an outpatient chronic or special disease, and whether it can be paid on its own. All of that is set locally. Not every negotiated drug is in the dual channel. A drug that is not can be bought only at the hospital. Whether a purchase elsewhere can be settled directly, the document only says "advance it prudently." Ask before you set out. For how outpatient chronic and special diseases are recognized, and for settlement away from home, see Section 16, item 2 (recognition of outpatient chronic and special diseases). The benefit magnitude is set at large, by judgment: no national document was found that says how much a single patient can be reimbursed. The policy explainer says the focus of what is brought into the dual channel is drugs that are "high in clinical value, urgent in demand, and high in cost." Over a

course of treatment, the gap between paying yourself and being reimbursed is estimated at the level of tens of thousands of yuan. The beneficiary is mainly you and your family.

## 14. For a chronic illness already diagnosed at a hospital and now stable, a refill can be a follow-up on that hospital's internet hospital. The first visit for this illness cannot be online

**Cost**. No money. You find the hospital's internet-hospital entrance on your phone and complete real-name verification. The consultation fee for an online follow-up at a public hospital is charged as an ordinary outpatient visit. If the medicine is mailed home, you pay the delivery fee yourself. Yibao (basic medical insurance) does not reimburse it.

**In plain terms**. If a chronic illness was diagnosed at a hospital, the condition is stable, and the medicines to be prescribed are still those same ones, you can do a follow-up online with the original hospital, and the medicine can be mailed home. Where local yibao has brought this in, you can settle it directly with yibao. The first visit for this illness, or a change in the condition, means the doctor must send you to the hospital to be seen in person.

**Benefit**. What you save is the time of each round trip to the hospital and of queuing to register. The Interim Measures for the Administration of Internet Diagnosis and Treatment say that online care can cover follow-up visits for only some common illnesses and chronic illnesses. The condition is that an in-person hospital has already made a clear diagnosis, the doctor has your records, and the follow-up is for that same diagnosis. The measures say "internet diagnosis and treatment must not be provided to a patient on a first visit." If the condition changes, or the doctor needs to examine you in person, the hospital must stop the online care at once and direct you to an in-person hospital. An online prescription needs the physician's electronic signature. After a pharmacist checks it, a third party may be entrusted to deliver the medicine to your home. Anesthesia drugs, psychotropic drugs, and other specially controlled drugs cannot be prescribed online. Prescribing online for a child under 6 requires a guardian and a physician in the relevant specialty to be present. Reimbursement by yibao is in the National Healthcare Security Administration's 2020 document Yi Bao Fa [2020] No. 45. It says that, for a follow-up prescription at an "internet-plus" designated hospital in the local pooling area, the consultation fee and the drug fee can be paid under the local yibao rules. The part you pay yourself can be paid, under the rules, from an employee yibao individual account. The fee for delivering the drugs is not in yibao. Localities may start with outpatient chronic and special diseases and gradually widen what is paid. The local yibao agency must publish the list of such designated hospitals. Yi Bao Fa [2019] No. 47 says that an internet follow-up at a public hospital, whichever rank of doctor sees you, is charged at the price of an ordinary outpatient consultation item (nationwide, as of October 2026).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. First ask the attending doctor whether this illness can be a follow-up online, then find the internet-hospital entrance in the hospital's public account or app. Use the internet hospital opened by the hospital that diagnosed you. Whether yibao can settle it is set locally. Check the designated list published by the local yibao department, or call and ask. For someone enrolled elsewhere, the document only says "explore" direct online settlement away from home. Ask clearly before you use it. If the condition is stable and the community clinic has your drug, the clinic can prescribe 12 weeks at a time. See Section 16, item 5 (a community clinic can prescribe up to 12 weeks of medicine at a time). If the community clinic does not have this drug, or a specialist has to watch the dose and adjust it, an online follow-up fits better. The benefit magnitude is set at medium, by judgment: a trip to a large hospital once a month to refill medicine takes about half a day, which comes to about an hour a week. The beneficiary is mainly you and your family. Elders who have trouble getting around save the most.

## 15. During a hospital stay, ask for the bill and check it line by line. Ask about items that yibao (basic medical insurance) will not reimburse before you agree. If it does not match, complain to the hospital's price line first, and if that fails, report it to the yibao department

**Cost**. No money. During the stay, ask for a bill every few days and check it. A pass takes about a dozen minutes. The hard part is putting aside the embarrassment of asking the doctors and nurses.

**In plain terms**. During a stay you can ask for a bill. It lists the unit price, the quantity, and the date of each drug and each test. For a drug or a test that yibao will not reimburse, other than emergency rescue, the hospital must have your agreement, or a family member's, first. If you find a repeated charge, or a charge for something that was not done, call the hospital's price-complaint line first. If the hospital does not accept it, report it to the yibao department.

**Benefit**. The Regulations on the Supervision and Administration of Medical Security Fund Use say a designated hospital must "truthfully issue fee documents and related materials to the insured person." The insured person also has the right to require the hospital to issue them truthfully. The hospital must not over-test, must not charge twice for the same item, must not charge above the standard, and must not split an item into pieces to charge for it. For a drug or a service outside the scope the yibao fund pays, other than an emergency or a rescue, the insured person, or a close relative or guardian, has to agree. If these rules are broken, the yibao department orders a correction. If the yibao fund loses money, it orders the money returned, and then a fine of 1 to 2 times the loss. Using an item yibao does not reimburse without agreement, and refusing to correct it, draws a fine of 10000 to 50000 yuan. The National Health Commission's 2019 Provisions on the Administration of Internal Price Conduct of Medical Institutions require hospitals to set up a bill system, including an electronic bill. When a patient needs it, the hospital must print it. The bill must state the name and code of the item, the drug, and the consumable, and also the unit price, the pricing unit, the date of use, the quantity, and the amount. Care charged by disease type, or by DRG (a bundled payment grouped by disease), is not in this requirement. The hospital must post, in a prominent place, the phone numbers for price inquiries and complaints. Complaints follow a rule that the first person asked is responsible, and the person who receives the complaint must record the content and the result. A report to the yibao department goes to the website, phone, fax, or mailing address it has published. It can be anonymous. Personal information in a report filed under a real name must be kept confidential. If the report is verified, the reporter is rewarded under national rules (nationwide, as of October 2026).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A report to the yibao department is about the hospital misusing the yibao fund. What the regulations write is an order to correct, a return of yibao fund money, and a fine. They do not write that the extra you paid is returned to you. Getting back the extra you paid yourself depends mainly on the hospital correcting the charge, so go to the hospital's price-complaint window first, and keep the bill and the record of what was said. Suing in court over a few hundred yuan, with the ordinary procedure of a first-instance trial starting at 6 months and the lawyer's fee paid by you, is usually not worth it. A report has to give a concrete lead: which line on the bill, which day, and how many times it was charged. If you only want to ask about reimbursement policy, call the yibao inquiry line. That is not a report. An item you cannot read is worth asking the nurses' station or the admissions office about. It is not necessarily an improper charge. A drug yibao will not reimburse is not necessarily a drug you should not use. Ask how much it costs per day, and whether there is a reimbursable substitute, before you sign. At discharge, ask for a full bill and keep it with the records. See item 5 of this section (keep your own copy of the records and images). The benefit magnitude is set at medium, by judgment: no official figure was found for how much a single patient overpays. Under this book's thresholds, a few hundred to a few thousand yuan counts as medium. The beneficiary is mainly you and your family. Checking the bill for an elder in hospital matters especially.

# 25. What to do after someone dies

Scope: money. This section only covers how to get the procedures done and how to collect the money. That includes what to do first right after the person dies, and which fees have a list you can check. It also covers which money sitting in which accounts can be taken back, and which matters close relatives have the right to handle in person. The first 5 items follow the order in which things happen: the scene, the death certificate, the body and cremation, what to do if you disagree with the cause of death, and canceling the hukou (户口 — household registration). Arrangements an older person should make while still alive, such as intended guardianship (意定监护 — a guardian named by agreement in advance), a will, and accounts, are in Section 17. The 3 benefits for a work-related death are in Section 19.

The funeral part follows the new Funeral Management Regulations, in force from March (3) 30, 2026. How the funeral allowance and the survivor allowance under the pension are calculated is in item 9 (housing provident fund balance and social insurance benefits).

## 1. If someone dies at home or outside, first tell a natural death from an unnatural one: for an accident, an unknown cause, or a death found only after the person lived alone, call the police at once and do not move the body or the scene

**Cost**. It costs nothing. 1 phone call is enough.

**In plain terms**. For a death by accident, a death nobody can explain, or a death found only after a long time living alone, if there was no treatment at a hospital, the police issue the death certificate. If the scene has been moved, what happened cannot be explained, and the certificate is hard to get. Without that piece of paper, cremation, canceling the hukou (户口 — household registration), and the insurance claim all get stuck. If you cannot tell which kind of death it is, call 110 first. After the police finish checking, they still issue the certificate.

**Benefit**. Article 8, paragraph 2 of the Regulations on Household Registration: "Where a citizen dies in an accident or the cause of death is unknown, the head of the household or the person who discovers it shall immediately report to the local police station or the people's committee of the township or town." That means: if there was an accident, or nobody knows how the person died, the head of the household and the person who found them must report at once to the police station or the township or town government. Article 23 of the Funeral Management Regulations: "Where a natural person dies a natural death, the medical institution shall issue a death certificate promptly. For a deceased person in an unnatural-death case handled by the public security organs according to law, who was not treated by a medical institution, the public security organs issue the death certificate." That means: a natural death from illness is certified by the medical institution that treated him. A death with no hospital treatment, which the police are handling, is certified by the police. If the scene has been disturbed, you can neither explain it nor get the certificate easily. Cremation, canceling the hukou, and the insurance claim all wait on this one piece of paper.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A death after a long illness, or dying at home at the end of life, counts as a natural death. You can ask the institution that treated him while he was alive to issue the certificate, or the community health service center or township health center for the area where he lived. Who issues the death certificate, the one that provided the treatment, is in item 2 (death certificate). If you cannot tell which kind it is, treat it as unnatural and call 110 first. After the police arrive and finish the investigation, they can still issue the certificate. If you tidy the scene before calling the police, no one can help you. Do not move the body yourself, wash him, or change his clothes, and do not take away medicine bottles or notes.

## 2. The death certificate is the key to everything that follows: whoever provided treatment issues it; for natural deaths at home, contact the local community health service center. It must be issued within one day

**Cost**. No cost at all.

**In plain terms**. If the person died in a hospital, get the death certificate from the place that handled the treatment. For a natural death at home, get it from the community health service for that area, or from the township health center. When the death is natural and the cause is clear, it is issued within one day. Canceling the hukou (户口 — household registration), cremation, withdrawing the housing provident fund, collecting social insurance benefits, an insurance claim, and handling the inheritance all use it. As soon as you have it, make several copies.

**Benefit**. According to the "Interim Regulations on Registration and Management of Population Death Information," death certificates for patients who die in medical institutions are issued by those institutions; for deaths occurring at home or elsewhere, they are issued by the local community health service center or township health clinic. Cases deemed non-natural by police or judicial authorities are handled under separate procedures. In 2026, five government agencies confirmed that electronic death certificates carry the same legal weight as paper versions; both are equally valid. Certificates for natural deaths with known causes must be issued within one day. If lost, a single replacement can be requested from the original issuer. Errors in basic information may be corrected by submitting supporting documents.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This certificate is indispensable for deregistration, cremation, housing provident fund withdrawals, social insurance benefits, insurance claims, and estate settlement — so make plenty of copies right away. If electronic issuance is available, request it as well. Only one replacement is permitted, so keep the original safe. Any mistakes in name or ID number should be corrected on the spot; otherwise you'll have to repeat the process at every office later on.

## 3. Transport, storage, and cremation of remains must be handled by funeral homes; hospital morgues cannot provide such services, and storage is generally limited to 3 days

**Cost**. No cost involved.

**In plain terms**. Transport, storage, embalming, cosmetic preparation, and cremation can only be done by a funeral home. A hospital morgue does not handle the funeral. At most, it lets the body stay there for a short while. A funeral home generally keeps the body for no more than 3 days. If you need more days, you have to apply for an extension. Cremation takes a death certificate and a cremation confirmation document. The cremation certificate they give you afterward is still needed for the inheritance and for an insurance claim.

**Benefit**. Article 25 of the Funeral Management Regulations states: "Services such as transport, storage, embalming, body preparation, and cremation must be provided exclusively by funeral homes." No other entities are permitted to offer these services. Article 24 adds: "Morgues operated by medical institutions may not subcontract or provide funeral services; they may only offer temporary storage for remains." Hospital morgues are thus restricted to short-term storage only. Article 27 specifies: "Funeral homes may store remains for no more than 3 days; extensions must be formally requested by the family or body transferor." Article 28 requires cremation to be performed only upon presentation of a death certificate and cremation authorization document, after which a cremation certificate is issued. Article 29 further mandates that in regions where cremation is mandatory, remains must be cremated at a nearby funeral home.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Most "one-stop" services offered at hospitals are not affiliated with licensed funeral homes. Transport itself is a standard service with fixed pricing; see Section 6 for details. Keep the cremation certificate safe — it is required for inheritance, insurance, and other legal procedures. Whether cremation or burial is mandated

locally is determined by provincial authorities. Article 9 safeguards the funeral customs of ethnic minorities. Any instance of cremation being required yet burial performed, or burial outside designated cemeteries or ecological burial zones, will prompt civil affairs bureaus to order immediate correction.

## 4. Disagreement over cause of death: request an autopsy within 48 hours and have medical records sealed

**Cost**. No cost involved. The hard part is remembering to make this request at such a time.

**In plain terms**. If you doubt the cause of death, the autopsy has to be done within 48 hours after the person dies. If the hospital can freeze the body, that can be extended to 7 days. The autopsy needs a close relative's signed consent. If they do not consent, or the time is missed, the responsibility for a cause of death that cannot be sorted out falls on that side. When you ask for the autopsy, also ask to have the medical records sealed. Once the body is cremated, an autopsy can no longer be done.

**Benefit**. The time limit for autopsies is stipulated in Article 26 of the Regulations on Prevention and Handling of Medical Disputes. The original text reads: “In cases where a patient dies and both the patient and medical institution dispute the cause of death, an autopsy must be performed within 48 hours after death; if the hospital has facilities to freeze the body, this period may be extended to 7 days.” In other words, to determine the true cause of death, an autopsy must be carried out within 48 hours of death, or up to 7 days if the hospital has freezing capabilities. The same article further states: “An autopsy must be approved and signed off by the deceased's close relatives; failure to sign is regarded as refusal of consent.” If family members do not sign, it is interpreted as a refusal. It also specifies: “If consent is denied or the deadline is missed, leading to uncertainty over the cause of death, the party responsible for the refusal or delay bears all related liability.” Article 24 states that sealing and unsealing of medical records “must be conducted in the presence of both the patient and medical institution.” Both you and the hospital must be present during both the sealing and later unsealing of records.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. After this deadline passes, any later claims of “I always suspected something was wrong” will instead place liability on the party responsible for the delay. Once a body is cremated, no autopsy can ever be performed. Therefore, this decision must be made before contacting any funeral home. Details on how to seal medical records can be found in Section 24.

## 5. Legal deadlines for canceling hukou registration for the deceased: in cities, before burial; in rural areas, within one month

**Cost**. No expense involved. Just bring the death certificate and household register to your local police station.

**In plain terms**. In cities, you must cancel hukou registration before burial; in rural areas, you must do it within one month. Bring the death certificate and household register to the police station to complete the process. Failing to do so will block any inheritance transfers, benefit claims, or insurance cancellations due to the unresolved hukou status.

**Benefit**. Article 8, Paragraph 1 of the Hukou Registration Regulations states: “When a citizen dies, in cities the household head, relatives, guardians, or neighbors must report the death to the hukou registration authority and cancel the hukou registration before burial; in rural areas, this must be done within one month. If a citizen dies while temporarily residing elsewhere, the local hukou registration authority must notify the permanent residence's authority to cancel the registration.” In short, urban residents must act before burial, while rural residents have one month to do so. Any household head, relative, guardian, or neighbor may initiate the process at the police station, which serves as the hukou registration authority. If the deceased was living temporarily elsewhere, the local police station there must inform the permanent residence's station to cancel the hukou registration.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Leaving the hukou registration active will prevent any inheritance transfers, benefit claims, or insurance cancellations, as all these procedures rely on a cleared hukou status. If pension payments continue despite the death, they constitute fraudulent collection and must eventually be repaid. While at the police station, also ask how to suspend social insurance and yibao payments, as well as how to apply for funeral subsidies. Details on these financial matters are covered in Item 9 (housing provident fund balances and related social insurance benefits).

## 6. Funeral services are divided into basic and non-basic categories; a list of basic services exists, with their fees set by law

**Cost**. There is no cost involved. Just spend a few minutes before departure to review the official list.

**In plain terms**. Transporting the body, storing it, the farewell, cremation, storing the ashes, and ecological burial are all on the national list of basic items. Burial in an ash niche provided by a public institution is on that list too. The prices of these items are set by the rules. Outside the list, they are not allowed to invent extra items and charge for them. Before you set out, first ask which items count as basic and what the local standard is, then talk about the rest.

**Benefit**. All essential funeral services — including body transport, storage, cremation, memorial services, and eco-friendly burial — are included in the official list. Government-run funeral centers also offer designated burial plots under this same list. Their pricing follows legal standards, meaning funeral homes cannot set prices arbitrarily. Non-basic services are defined separately by civil affairs bureaus at or above the prefecture level.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Provinces, autonomous regions, and municipalities may add extra items to the national list. Always verify which services are classified as basic and what their local pricing is before proceeding. It is perfectly acceptable to want a dignified funeral for a loved one; this guideline does not discourage that. Its sole purpose is to clarify which services are fixed-price basics and which are optional extras. Once this distinction is clear, you can decide where to allocate funds — and avoid unnecessary overcharges during an already difficult time.

## 7. If you encounter forced bundling, extra charges beyond the listed price, or a single service being split into multiple line items for billing, make a note of it and file a complaint

**Cost**. No cost involved. The real challenge is staying diligent in the moment.

**In plain terms**. The price violations the regulations name are: not posting a price list, adding money on top of the marked price, bundling funeral goods and forcing you to buy them, and forcing you to accept another provider's paid service. Splitting one item into several charges also counts as a disguised price rise. On the spot, ask for the price list first, and keep the proof of the charges and the chat records. Complaining afterward is still in time. For the price, go to the market supervision administration. For funeral services, go to the civil affairs bureau.

**Benefit**. Regulations identify five categories of price violations. Four of them are: not displaying prices clearly or adding extra charges beyond the listed price — that is, no posted price list or charging more than advertised; bundling services or imposing unreasonable conditions to force a purchase — meaning you can't obtain a service unless you buy another one; forcing or indirectly forcing you to use paid third-party services — essentially pushing another provider's services on you; and indirectly raising prices by re-labeling charges — such as charging more under a different name. Additionally, it is prohibited to “split services into multiple items or expand the scope of charges to indirectly raise prices.” This means breaking one service into several line items for billing or extending the range of charges beyond what was originally stated.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Price-violation investigations fall under the market regulation authority; funeral services themselves are under the civil affairs bureau. Ask for a price list right away, and be sure to keep all receipts, invoices, and chat records. Filing a complaint later is still possible.

## 8. Funeral agents, buyers of funeral goods, and planners and hosts must register with the county-level civil affairs bureau

**Cost**. It costs nothing. Ask whether they are registered.

**In plain terms**. Funeral agents, buyers of funeral goods, planners and hosts, and information consultants have to register with the county-level civil affairs bureau. Those that are not registered are not in the funeral-service information system run by the civil affairs bureau. Whether you can look this up yourself differs from place to place. The surest way is to call the county-level civil affairs bureau and ask. Those who overcharge by trickery, or who resell information about the deceased, will be dealt with according to law.

**Benefit**. An intermediary that is not registered is not in the funeral-service information system run by the civil affairs bureau. Those who charge in violation of the rules by deception, push a family into a large showy funeral, force people to accept a service, or resell information about the deceased will be dealt with according to law. They are also marked in the system and made public, and anyone can see it.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Online tomb-sweeping platforms are regulated the same way. Article 45 of the regulations does not allow them to induce spending, and does not allow them to handle the deceased's information unlawfully.

## 9. Collect the money held in different places, one place at a time: the housing provident fund balance, social insurance benefits, and work-injury benefits

**Cost**. It costs nothing, but you have to go to several windows. Before you go, get the death certificate and proof of kinship ready.

**In plain terms**. Heirs can withdraw the housing provident fund (公积金 — mandatory housing savings) balance. It is not in a bank account, so it is easy to miss. Money left in the individual account of the basic pension can also be inherited. If a person covered by the enterprise employees' pension dies of illness, the family also receives a funeral allowance and a survivor allowance for 3 to 24 months. If the death was caused by work, there are 3 more work-injury payments.

**Benefit**. The balance of the housing provident fund account (the money still left in his provident-fund account) can be withdrawn by heirs and by legatees. A legatee is the person named in a will to receive something. If the death was caused by work, there are 3 more payments: a funeral allowance, a dependents' pension, and a one-time work-death benefit. Money left in the individual account of the basic pension can be inherited; the Social Insurance Law says so in writing. If a person covered by the employees' pension dies of illness, or dies from a cause that is not work, the family can also receive a funeral allowance and a survivor allowance, together called survivor benefits. The standard for enterprise employees is calculated on a nationwide formula. The funeral allowance is 2 times the previous year's monthly per capita disposable income of urban residents in that province. The survivor allowance uses that same monthly per capita income as the base, and is paid for 3 to 24 months according to the years of contributions. Under 5 years, 3 months are paid. For 5 to 10 years, 6 months are paid. For 10 to 15 years, 9 months are paid. For more than 15 years, each extra 1 year adds 1 month, up to 24 months. If the person had already retired, each 1 year of pension already received subtracts 1 month, and the minimum is 9 months.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The provident-fund sum is the one most often forgotten, because it is not in a bank account and it does not go into the division of the estate on its own. Money left in the individual pension account and the survivor benefits are calculated separately and paid separately. Handle them together at the social insurance window where he was insured. The documents each place asks for are different. If contributions were under

5 years, the survivor benefits together do not exceed the money he himself paid in. This formula comes from the rules for the enterprise employees' pension. For survivor benefits under the pension for government bodies and public institutions, and under the urban and rural residents' pension, ask at the window. If the funeral expenses and the survivor allowance were paid into his bank account, how to withdraw them is in item 12 (withdraw the deposit directly at the bank). The formal requirements for a will and for inheritance are in Section 17. If you plan to renounce the inheritance to stay clear of the debt, do not withdraw this money first. See item 11 (a written statement renouncing the inheritance).

## 10. Close relatives can ask to access, copy, correct, and delete the deceased's account and personal information

**Cost**. It costs nothing. Only if the platform will not cooperate do you need to complain or to sue.

**In plain terms**. After the person has died, close relatives, for their own lawful and proper interests, can ask the platform to access, copy, correct, or delete the deceased's personal information. If the platform refuses, it has to give a reason. You can also sue in court. There is one exception. If he made other arrangements while alive, for example by naming someone to inherit an account or by leaving a clear wish, follow his arrangements.

**Benefit**. The law states it in so many words: when a natural person has died, close relatives, for their own lawful and proper interests, may exercise the rights to access, copy, correct, delete, and otherwise deal with the deceased's relevant personal information. Close relatives can ask the platform to bring his information out to be looked at, to make 1 copy, to correct an error, and to delete it. Article 50 requires the platform to set up a convenient mechanism for accepting and handling applications. "If it refuses a person's request to exercise a right, it shall state the reasons." If the platform refuses, "the individual may bring a lawsuit in a people's court according to law."

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The article includes the sentence "except where the deceased made other arrangements while alive." If he set an account heir while alive, or left a clear wish, follow what he left. So while he is still clear-headed, it is worth writing down where the accounts and the passwords are to go. See Section 17. Closing an account and deleting personal information are 2 different things. See Section 14.

## 11. Repay debts a relative left only with the estate you inherit; if you do not want the debt, renounce the inheritance in writing before the estate is divided

**Cost**. Writing 1 written statement costs nothing. The real price is that the house, the deposits, and the rest of the estate are given up along with it. If you accept the inheritance, a creditor may sue you. You have to answer the suit, and you have to produce materials showing what the estate is worth.

**In plain terms**. When a person dies, the debts they owed do not disappear with them. But heirs such as the children and the spouse repay only with the share of the estate they inherited. They do not pay the shortfall out of their own pocket. If you do not want to take on this debt, write a statement renouncing the inheritance before the estate is divided, and you give up the estate as well. If you say nothing, that counts as accepting the inheritance.

**Benefit**. Article 1161 of the Civil Code: "An heir clears the taxes and debts the decedent legally owed, limited to the actual value of the estate obtained. This limit does not cover any part beyond the actual value of the estate that the heir repays voluntarily." That means: for the taxes and debts he owed, you pay only with the share of the estate you inherited. You do not pay the part beyond that, unless you yourself are willing to pay. Paragraph 2 of the same article: "An heir who renounces the inheritance may bear no duty to clear the taxes and debts the decedent legally owed." Article 1159 of the Civil Code says that, when the estate is divided, the taxes and debts he owed are paid first. Article 1124 of the Civil Code: a person who renounces an inheritance must "make a statement of renunciation in writing before the estate is handled; if no statement is made, the

heir is deemed to accept the inheritance." Article 33 of the Supreme People's Court's Interpretation (1) on the Inheritance Book: the written statement is given to the estate administrator or to the other heirs. Article 35 of that interpretation: if the renunciation is made only after the estate has been divided, what is renounced is not the right of inheritance but property already in hand. Article 1145 of the Civil Code: the heirs may choose an estate administrator, and if none is chosen they serve together. Article 1147 of the Civil Code: the estate administrator must take stock of the estate, make an estate list, and deal with the decedent's claims and debts. In a case in Yuzhou, Henan, the borrower died of illness in March (3) 2023, and the children had not renounced the inheritance in writing. In May (5) 2023 the court ordered the children to repay 95000 yuan of principal and interest, within the actual value of the estate they inherited. The children said the value of the company they inherited could not be calculated, and the judgment could not be enforced. Accounts and a car in the children's names were frozen and seized, and they were placed on the list that restricts high consumption. Only in February (2) 2025 was there a settlement, and they paid 90000 yuan. In a Chongqing case, the borrower died of illness before the principal and interest on a loan of 400000 yuan were paid off, and every heir stated that they renounced the inheritance. But his spouse and daughter had already withdrawn the basic pension and the occupational annuity that counted as his estate. The procuratorate found that the 2 of them had not expressly renounced, so they were treated as having accepted the inheritance. In November (11) 2025 the spouse settled with the creditor and paid the debt in full. Debts of this kind run from 10000 yuan to several hundred thousand yuan, so the benefit is rated large.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The people this mainly benefits are you yourself, and your spouse and children. The spouse is counted separately. A loan the 2 of them signed together, or a loan taken for ordinary household spending, counts as a joint debt of the couple. The spouse is then personally the debtor, and renouncing the inheritance does not get out of it. When the estate is divided, half of the couple's joint property goes to the spouse first, and only what remains is the estate. If you plan to renounce, do not withdraw money from his accounts first. The housing provident fund balance and the balance of the individual basic-pension account named in item 9 of this section (housing provident fund balance and social insurance benefits) are money only an heir can withdraw. The Chongqing case was a withdrawal followed by a claim of renunciation. If renouncing the inheritance would leave you unable to meet a legal duty such as supporting a parent or raising a child, the renunciation is void. If collectors come to the door, first ask for the IOU, the contract, and the other proof, and have them go to the estate administrator or sue. Do not sign a promise to repay the part that is beyond the estate, because a repayment you are willing to make yourself is also recognized by the law. If you are actually sued, an ordinary first-instance procedure has to be finished within 6 months after the case is filed, and it can be extended. Summary procedure is 3 months. Lawyer fees are not among the litigation costs borne by the losing side. If you hire a lawyer, you pay. Keep the estate list and the materials showing what the house and the deposits are worth. Enforcement uses them to calculate how much you must repay. Why paying a debt by dying does not work is in Section 29, item 13 (do not treat death as a way to pay a debt).

## 12. After a family member dies, do not start the inheritance at a notary by default: withdraw a deposit of 50000 yuan or less at 1 bank directly from the bank, and handle a house at the real-estate registration office with all the heirs together

**Cost**. It costs nothing. Go to each bank that holds a deposit, one bank after another. For a house, every heir has to be at the registration window on the same day. If someone will not come, or someone does not agree on the division, this path does not work, and the only routes left are a notary or a lawsuit.

**In plain terms**. If the deceased's deposits at 1 bank add up to no more than 50000 yuan, the spouse, the children, and the parents can withdraw them with the documents, and they do not need a notary. A house does not have to go through a notary either. All the heirs go together to the real-estate registration office and can get it done there. A notary costs money. In Fuzhou and Xiamen, for example, a house is charged by floor area, and 1 unit is in principle charged at most 10000 yuan.

**Benefit**. On the deposit side, Document No. 18 of 2021 from the China Banking and Insurance Regulatory Commission and the People's Bank of China provides that a small deposit that meets the conditions no longer requires notarization. There are 3 conditions. Condition 1: the balances of the accounts at the same bank add up to no more than 10000 yuan. A bank may raise that on its own, up to 50000 yuan. Condition 2: the applicant is the spouse, a child, or a parent, or an heir or a legatee named in a notarized will. Condition 3: the money is taken out all at once, and the account is closed afterward. The spouse, the children, and the parents submit 4 kinds of documents: a death certificate; kinship papers such as the household register (户口簿 — the hukou booklet), a marriage certificate, or a birth certificate; their own identity document; and a commitment letter signed in their own hand. Jin Gui [2024] No. 6 (金规〔2024〕6 号) provides that, from June (6) 1, 2024, the limit is raised across the board to 50000 yuan. Small and medium-sized rural banks may wait until December (12) 31, 2025 to put it in place. Accumulated-gold products, and treasury bonds and wealth-management products sold through the bank, can be withdrawn the same way once they mature or are redeemed, and the amounts count together toward the 50000 yuan. Funeral expenses and a survivor allowance paid into his account do not count toward the 50000 yuan, and the spouse, the children, and the parents can withdraw them with this same set of documents. On the house side, Article 14 of the detailed implementing rules for the Interim Regulations on Real Estate Registration says that an application to register an inheritance or a bequest "shall submit materials on the death, a will or an agreement of all statutory heirs on how the real estate is divided, and materials on kinship with the decedent, and may also submit notarized materials or a legal document that has taken effect." Notarization is only one option. In 2016 the Ministry of Justice issued a document abolishing the 1991 joint notice that had required stronger notarization for real-estate registration. The Fuzhou Real Estate Registration and Transaction Center has explained what to do when notarized materials are not submitted. All the statutory heirs, or all the legatees, must go together to the registration office to have the materials checked, and sign an undertaking (a written statement that the materials are true). The fee follows the Fujian standard. For an inheritance notarization that does not involve real estate, the part within 200000 yuan is charged at 0.8%, and the minimum is 300 yuan. Real estate is charged by floor area. In Fuzhou and Xiamen the charge is no more than 70 yuan per square meter, and 1 unit is in principle no more than 10000 yuan. On that standard, the notarization fee for a deposit of 50000 yuan is 400 yuan, and a house of 90 square meters in Fuzhou is at most 6300 yuan. The saving is several hundred to several thousand yuan, so the benefit is rated medium.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The 50000 yuan is counted separately at each bank. If 3 banks each hold 40000 yuan, all 3 can be withdrawn this way. Sums over 50000 yuan are not covered by these 2 notices. Before you go, ask that bank which documents it wants. The rule also does not apply when the depositor or the applicant is a compatriot from Hong Kong, Macao, or Taiwan, a foreigner, or a person settled abroad. Even if there is only 1 notarized will, the title still cannot be transferred directly. All the statutory heirs still have to appear and confirm. If you plan to renounce the inheritance to stay clear of a debt, do not withdraw the money first. See item 11 (a written statement renouncing the inheritance). When heirs of the first order (1) withdraw the money, they can also ask for the account statements for the 6 months before the death and for the period after the death. Looking up other personal information is in item 10 (the account and personal information). If the heirs disagree and cannot work it out, you have to sue. An ordinary first-instance procedure starts at 6 months, and the lawyer fee is paid by you. Notarization fee schedules differ by province. Follow the documents of the local development and reform department and the justice department. The 50000 yuan limit is given as of October (10) 2026. Follow the latest notice from the National Financial Regulatory Administration and the People's Bank of China.

# 26. Building a website or platform: licenses, filing, and servers

You want to build a website or an app. This section answers 4 things: what kind of business it counts as in law, which permit you need, where the servers sit, and who is responsible for what users post and for the money that comes in. The measure is personal liberty and money. If you are a hired technician, the red lines are in section 11. How to register a company and how to file taxes are in section 12, and this section does not repeat them. A comparison table of the permits, and a decision table for choosing a server, are in What Licenses a Platform Needs: A Comparison Table and a Server-Choice Decision Table.

## 1. Platforms must never collect payments themselves and then transfer them to sellers; funds must be settled directly via a licensed payment institution

**Cost**. No monetary cost is involved. However, it requires some time to integrate a product from a licensed payment institution — that is, a company holding a payment license issued by the People's Bank of China. By using such institution's split-payment or escrow features, buyer payments are transferred straight to sellers without ever entering the platform's own accounts.

**In plain terms**. If the buyer's money goes into your account first and you then pass it to the seller, you are running a payment business. That business needs approval from the People's Bank of China, and you have to actually put up 100000000 yuan of capital. Doing it without approval gets you shut down, the money you earned taken, and a fine on top. The boss and the person who handled it are fined separately, and a serious case can also mean a criminal sentence. There is only 1 safe way: the money does not enter your account.

**Benefit**. According to regulations, a payment business is defined as “transferring monetary funds based on electronic payment instructions submitted by payers or payees.” In other words, it involves moving money on behalf of others per their instructions. To operate such a business, one must obtain a payment license from the People's Bank of China, and the minimum registered capital must be 100000000 yuan, and that 100000000 yuan must actually be paid into the company account. Unauthorized operation results in immediate closure and seizure of all profits. If illegal gains are 500000 yuan or more, an additional fine of 1 to 5 times that amount is imposed. If there are no illegal gains or they are under 500000 yuan, the fine is 500000 to 2000000 yuan; additionally, a further fine of 100,000 to 500,000 RMB applies to legal representatives and responsible personnel. Criminal law also classifies “illegally conducting fund payment and settlement services” as illegal business activity; serious violations may lead to imprisonment of up to five years, while especially grave cases incur sentences exceeding five years. As of May (5) 2024, the threshold for “serious” violations is defined as total illegal transaction volume exceeding 5 million RMB or illegal profits surpassing 100,000 RMB nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Designing the payment flow so that funds never enter the platform's account is the sole safe method. In industry parlance, this practice is sometimes called “second clearing,” though this term does not appear in official documents; instead, regulations refer to it as “indirectly engaging in payment services.” The Supreme People's Court and Supreme People's Procuratorate explicitly list only three scenarios as illegal: fabricating transactions for cash-out, using corporate accounts for cash-out, and using cheques for cash-out. Platform-based collection and redistribution of payments are not explicitly named, so this description strictly follows statutory wording without asserting that it automatically constitutes a crime.

## 2. Most websites that charge need a license; selling only your own goods, without letting others open a shop, does not; matching a trade is another license; a free site only needs filing

**Cost**. Filing costs nothing. A value-added telecommunications business license costs money. It governs whether a website that charges users may open. You need a company before you can apply for it. For business only inside a single province, the registered capital is at least 1000000 yuan. For business across provinces, it is at least 10000000 yuan. The review period is 60 days, and the license is valid for 5 years.

**In plain terms**. A website that charges users mostly has to get a value-added telecommunications business license first, and an individual cannot apply for it. The Guangdong Communications Administration answered: if you only sell goods on your own website or app, and you do not let others open a shop there, you do not need it. If you only run a mini program or an online shop on WeChat or Alipay, you do not need it either. If you open a paid site without the license you should have, the income is confiscated and a fine is added, and a serious case means the site is shut.

**Benefit**. The regulation says: "The state implements a licensing system for commercial internet information services, and a filing system for non-commercial internet information services. Without a license, or without completing the filing, internet information services may not be provided." A site that charges has to get the license first. A site that does not charge has to file first. Without either of the 2, the site cannot open. What counts as commercial? The regulation says it is "providing information, web-page production, or similar services to internet users for a fee through the internet." In short, charging the user. The kind that matches a trade is called online data processing and transaction processing. In the trade it is shortened to EDI. The regulation defines it as "using data and transaction or business-processing application platforms connected to the public communications network or the internet, to provide users with online data processing and transaction or business processing through the public communications network or the internet." It also "includes transaction-processing services, electronic data interchange services, and network or electronic-device data-processing services." That means the website processes data online for the user, or matches both sides of a sale and processes the transaction. Operating without the license, or operating beyond its scope, means the illegal gains are confiscated, and a fine of 3 to 5 times the illegal gains is added. Operating beyond the scope means you have the license, but what you do goes past what the license writes. If there are no illegal gains, or the illegal gains are under 50000 yuan, the fine is 100000 to 1000000 yuan. In a serious case, the website is ordered closed (nationwide). Charging money does not always mean you must get the license. A question-and-answer issued by the Guangdong Communications Administration in October (10) 2025 says that, under a requirement of the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology, the 3 cases below do not need this license. Case 1: a company, on its own website or app, "directly sells its own goods or services, or those of another company, in a self-operated way," and no other unit or individual opens a shop there. Case 2: a company posts only its own information on its own website or app, and does not provide other people with a platform for posting information. Case 3: a company does business only through mini programs, official accounts, video accounts, or online shops on platforms such as WeChat and Alipay, "and has no other independently operated platform." The other way around: as soon as you let others open a shop, or let users post information here, you are outside these 3 cases.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Whether what you want to do is the EDI kind, you match it yourself against the definition in the Classification Catalogue of Telecommunications Services. No official sentence states outright that "an e-commerce platform with matching and fund handling must get an EDI license." The Ministry's guide for applicants only says "apply for the corresponding telecommunications business license according to how the service is defined." So whether to apply can only be judged from the definition. Another point: an individual cannot get this license. The applicant must be a company established according to law. The 3 cases where self-operated business does not need the license come from the Guangdong Communications Administration's question-and-answer. It says this follows a requirement of the Ministry, but the same public wording was not found in other provinces. If you are not sure, call the communications administration where you are first. That question-and-answer also reminds you that you do not need an agent to apply. You submit

the materials only on the Ministry's "comprehensive management information system for the telecommunications-services market," and the authority does not charge a fee.

## 3. Get an online cultural business license to run live streams; a private company basically cannot get the permit for audiovisual programs

**Cost**. The online cultural business license, commonly called the network-culture license (网文证), governs whether you may make money from online performances such as live streams and game commentary. A provincial culture department approves it. You get a result within 20 days after the application is accepted. It is valid for 3 years, and you go to renew it in the 30 days before it expires. The audiovisual-program permit governs whether you may put programs online. It requires the applicant to be a wholly state-owned unit or a state-controlled unit.

**In plain terms**. To run live streams or game commentary, you need an online cultural business license issued by the provincial culture department, and the business scope has to state online performance. You get a result within 20 days after acceptance, and the license covers 3 years. You have to keep videos you have already streamed for a full 60 days. If you open without the license, you are told to stop and given a warning, and then fined up to 30000 yuan. If you do not stop, you go on a blacklist.

**Benefit**. A unit that does online performance has to get the license first. The regulation says it "shall, under the Interim Provisions on the Administration of Internet Culture, apply to the provincial culture department for an Online Cultural Business License, and the business scope of the license shall expressly include online performance." Playing a game for people to watch, or explaining it to them, is handled under the same set of rules. The regulation says it is "administered by reference to these measures." Video records of all online performances "shall be kept for no less than 60 days." You keep videos you have streamed for a full 60 days yourself. Doing commercial internet cultural activities without approval brings an order to stop, a warning, and a fine of up to 30000 yuan. If you are told to stop and you still do not, you are put on the cultural-market blacklist. Putting programs online is a different permit. You "shall obtain a Permit for Disseminating Audiovisual Programs over Information Networks." The applicant must "have the status of a legal person, and be a wholly state-owned or state-controlled unit." It has to be a unit wholly owned by the state or controlled by the state. A private company basically cannot get it. Doing it without this permit brings a warning and an order to correct, and a fine of up to 30000 yuan may be added. In a serious case, the penalty follows the regulations on radio and television administration (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Which business goes with which permit is clearest in the document from the 7 departments. A platform that makes money from live streams needs the online cultural business license plus ICP filing. ICP filing is the step of registering the website with the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology. Putting programs online needs the audiovisual permit, or completed registration. Publishing news needs an internet news information service license. Also, the Interim Provisions on the Administration of Internet Culture reposted on the Chinese government website in 2025 is the unrevised text from 2011. A citation should follow the current text of the Ministry of Culture and Tourism.

## 4. File if the server sits inside China; file an app and a mini program before they are listed; the access provider must itself hold a value-added telecommunications license

**Cost**. Filing costs nothing. You submit it together with the server, at the service provider, and you usually wait a few days to a few weeks. Filing for an app or a mini program is submitted through the service provider or the app store, and it is finished within 20 working days once the materials are complete. Checking once whether the service provider has the qualification takes 10 minutes.

**In plain terms**. If the server sits inside China, you have to file before the site opens. It costs nothing, and it usually takes a few days to a few weeks. Without filing you are first ordered to correct and fined 10000 yuan,

and if you do not correct, the site is shut. An app and a mini program also have to be filed first. Without filing, the app store and the mini-program platform are not allowed to list you.

**Benefit**. The regulation says: "Without filing, non-commercial internet information services may not be provided inside the People's Republic of China." A website that does not charge users still has to file first, as long as it is placed inside China. Without filing, you are ordered to correct within a time limit, and fined 10000 yuan. If you refuse to correct, the website is closed. The provider that connects your server to the network is also regulated. It "may not provide internet access services for an organization or an individual that has not filed and that engages in non-commercial internet information services." A provider that collects money for you is the same. The regulation says this kind of provider "may not provide access, collection of fees on behalf of others, or similar services to a unit or an individual that has not lawfully obtained an operating license or completed the filing for non-commercial internet information services." That means a regular provider is not allowed to connect a site that has neither a license nor a filing. Also, colocation and a cloud server are called internet data center services in the regulation, and broadband access is called an internet access service. These 2 themselves require a license. The provider has to hold the license first. If the website homepage does not show the filing number, you are ordered to correct, and fined 5000 to 50000 yuan. From September (9) 2023, apps and mini programs also have to be filed. A notice from the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology says that the sponsor of an app providing services inside China "may not engage in app internet information services if the filing has not been completed." Distribution platforms include mini-program platforms. The notice requires app stores, mini-program platforms, and phone makers "not to provide network access, distribution, pre-installation, or similar services for an app that has not completed the filing." Once a provincial communications administration receives complete and accurate materials, it "shall complete the filing within 20 working days." The filing number has to be shown in a prominent place in the app. The Anti-Telecom and Online Fraud Law also states that setting up an app "shall go through licensing or filing with the telecommunications authority in accordance with the relevant state provisions" (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Before you talk price, check whether the service provider has the license. Look it up in the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology's comprehensive management information system for the telecommunications-services market, at tsm.miit.gov.cn, by the company's full name or by the license number. Look up a website filing at beian.miit.gov.cn. A "machine room" without the matching license leaves you, on the day something goes wrong, not even knowing whom to appeal to. If the website is already filed, the app filing only adds the app's information. You do not fill in the sponsor's identity again. Putting the website's machines abroad does get around website filing, but an app you want listed in a domestic app store cannot get around it. If the users are inside China and the money is inside China, not 1 of the duties written in this section, item 5 through this section, item 10 drops away, and a further cost of sending data abroad is added on top.

## 5. Requiring sellers to join the platform means the platform must verify identities, register data, report information, and retain records for three years

**Cost**. No direct monetary cost. However, the platform must perform background checks on sellers' qualifications and maintain a registration database. Tax-related information must be reported quarterly, while transaction data must be kept for at least three years. The main challenge is that this is an ongoing obligation rather than a one-time task.

**In plain terms**. If you let other people sell on your platform, you first check the seller's identity, address, contact details, and license, then register them and open a file. Once the file is open, you go back and check again at least every 6 months. Who the seller is has to be reported to market supervision, the tax situation is reported to the tax authority every quarter, and the goods and transaction records are kept for 3 years. Miss 1 of these and you are first ordered to correct. If you do not correct, the fine is 20000 to 100000 yuan.

**Benefit**. Legal regulations set specific obligations for platforms. The official wording states that platforms must require sellers to provide authentic identity, address, contact, and licensing information, then verify and register this data while maintaining updated records. This means sellers must submit their basic details and required permits before joining, which you must then confirm and log into a database. Periodic re-verification is also mandatory. The exact interval for re-verification is defined as “at least every six months” under relevant administrative rules. Additionally, you must submit seller identity data to market regulators and tax authorities, as required by tax administration laws. All product, service, and transaction data must be retained for no less than three years from the date each transaction concludes. Non-compliance triggers a rectification order; persistent violations incur fines of 20,000–100,000 yuan, while severe cases may lead to temporary suspension of operations and fines of 100,000–500,000 yuan. Tax reports must be submitted within the month following each quarter's end, with identical penalties for late submissions nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Sellers themselves must also register as market entities. Certain exceptions apply: individuals selling self-produced agricultural or handmade goods, or providing small-scale services that do not require permits, are exempt. The threshold for “small-scale” activities is set at an annual transaction volume of 100,000 yuan under current online trade regulations. Platforms also bear two additional responsibilities: clearly marking registered versus unregistered sellers, and prohibiting the removal of consumer reviews.

## 6. Manage what users post: keep a review system and a report entry, and when you find something illegal, stop it at once and report it

**Cost**. You have to spend money hiring people to review. This is the platform's largest long-running expense. The report entry, and a record of every action you take, have to leave a trace. The hard part is that someone has to watch it every day. Leave it for 1 day and something can go wrong.

**In plain terms**. What users post, the platform has to manage. Registration, review of posts, review of comments, a daily patrol, and what to do when something happens all need a written system. Put a report entry where it is easy to see on the page. When you see illegal information, stop it from spreading at once, keep the record, and report it to the authority in charge. If you do not, the fine can be 50000 to 500000 yuan, and a serious case is more.

**Benefit**. The regulation says the platform "shall fulfill the primary responsibility for managing information content." What users post is for the platform itself to manage. In particular it must "improve the systems for user registration, account management, review of published information, review of comments and replies, ecological management of pages, real-time patrol, emergency handling, and handling of online rumors and of information from black-market chains." From registration, posts, and comments, through the daily patrol and handling when something happens, every link needs a rule written down. It also "shall set a convenient complaint and report entry in a prominent position." The report button has to sit where a user can see it at a glance and can tap it. On finding illegal information, it "shall immediately take handling measures according to law, keep the relevant records, and report to the relevant authority." The Cybersecurity Law is more specific. It says: "On finding information whose publication or transmission is prohibited by laws or administrative regulations, it shall immediately stop transmission of that information, take handling measures such as removal, prevent the information from spreading, keep the relevant records, and report to the relevant authority." If this is not done, you are ordered to correct, given a warning, and given a circulated notice, and a fine of 50000 to 500000 yuan may be added. If you refuse to correct, or the case is serious, the fine is 500000 to 2000000 yuan. You may also be ordered to suspend business for rectification, to close the website or the application, or to have the license or the business license revoked. The person directly in charge is fined another 50000 to 200000 yuan (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. You do not have to invent the review rules. Copy them. Which 9 kinds of content may not be posted is listed clearly in Article 15 of the Measures for the Administration of Internet Information Services. Live streaming adds 3 more things. You must "set up a live-stream content review platform." You must be able to cut off a stream that is on the air at any moment. The article calls this "instant blocking." You also keep the

live-stream content and the logs for 60 days. Video records of online performances are likewise no less than 60 days.

## 7. If you offer posting or instant messaging, require the user to provide real identity information

**Cost**. You have to connect a real-name check channel, and this kind of channel charges per use. On the product, design it as "real name in the back, voluntary on the front": the back end stores the real name, and the page shows a nickname.

**In plain terms**. If your site can take posts, or can chat, you have to ask for the user's real identity information when the user opens the service. If the user does not give it, you cannot let them use it. The live-stream rule is that the back end stores the real name, and the nickname shown on the page is up to the user. You can check with a mobile number. If you do not do real-name checks, you are first ordered to correct. If you do not correct, the fine is 50000 to 500000 yuan, and the site may also be shut.

**Benefit**. The law says: "Where a network operator handles network access or domain-name registration for a user, handles network-entry procedures for a fixed telephone, a mobile telephone, or the like, or provides the user with services such as information publishing or instant messaging, it shall, when signing an agreement with the user or confirming that the service will be provided, require the user to provide real identity information. If the user does not provide real identity information, the network operator may not provide the relevant service." If you did not ask for a real name, or the user did not give a real identity and you still let them use it, you are ordered to correct. If you refuse to correct, or the case is serious, the fine is 50000 to 500000 yuan. You may also be ordered to suspend the relevant business, to suspend business for rectification, to close the website or the application, or to have the license or the business license revoked. The person directly in charge is fined another 10000 to 100000 yuan. Live-stream services follow the principle of "real name in the back, voluntary on the front," and do "authentication of real identity information based on a mobile telephone number or a similar method." That means the platform's back end stores the user's real name, the nickname shown on the page is chosen by the user, and the check uses something like a mobile number. Live-stream selling is stricter. It is "authentication of real identity information based on identity-document information, the unified social credit code, and the like." The unified social credit code is the string of numbers on the business license (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The article numbers have moved. The Cybersecurity Law was amended in 2025, and it takes effect on January (1) 1, 2026. The real-name article moved from Article 24 to Article 26. The penalty moved from Article 61 to Article 64. The wording of the articles did not change. If the materials you have still cite the old article numbers, change them.

## 8. No live streaming accounts may be created for anyone under 16; tipping limits are set by age group

**Cost**. There are no direct costs. The process simply requires adding two extra steps during registration and payment: first verify the user's age, then confirm that a guardian has given consent.

**In plain terms**. People younger than 16 cannot sign up for a live streaming account on this platform. Those aged 16 or older must have their identity verified and must also obtain permission from a parent or other guardian. Tipping is restricted based on age: children under 8 are not allowed to tip at all; those aged 8–16 may tip only with guardian consent; and anyone over 16 may tip only with guardian consent or proof of income. If a minor spends money without a guardian's approval, the guardian can request a refund, and a court is required to grant it. A total of 2020 such cases have been reported to date.

**Benefit**. The law clearly states that “online live streaming service providers must not offer account registration services to minors under 16; when providing such services to minors aged 16 or older, they must verify their identity and obtain consent from a parent or other guardian.” It also mandates “a dynamic verification mechanism for the real identity information of live streamers,” meaning platforms must be able to

recheck a streamer's identity at any time. Additionally, platforms must “reasonably limit the maximum amount a minor may spend per transaction and per day,” establishing spending caps based on age. Tipping rules are similarly tiered: “Tipping services must not be offered to minors under 8; for those aged 8–16, consent from a guardian is required; for those over 16, consent or proof of income is required.” Finally, if a minor lacking full legal capacity spends money without guardian approval, a court must return those funds to the guardian. Minors lacking full legal capacity are defined as those who cannot make independent decisions under the law.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. In any dispute involving refunds, rulings must favor the minor. The wording of this policy has changed over time. In 2022, four government agencies and the National Radio and Television Administration both stated that minors were completely prohibited from tipping. However, a new notice issued in April 2026 introduced age-based limits at 8 and 16 years old, without explicitly revoking earlier rules or explaining how they relate. Therefore, the claim that “minors are entirely barred from tipping” is no longer accurate.

## 9. Act on an infringement notice in time, and restore the content if there is no follow-up within 15 days after you forward the statement

**Cost**. It costs nothing. You need a fixed process: receive the notice, forward it to the seller, receive the seller's objection, and make the result public. Keep a record of every step.

**In plain terms**. If someone sends an infringement notice and attaches preliminary evidence, you delete the thing, block it, or cut the link in time, and you forward the notice to the seller at the same time. If you drag and do not handle it, you and the seller pay together for the extra part of the loss. After the seller objects, you forward the objection to the other side and wait 15 days. If the other side has neither complained nor sued, you put the thing back.

**Benefit**. The rights holder "has the right to notify the e-commerce platform operator to take necessary measures such as deletion, blocking, disconnecting a link, and ending the transaction and the service. The notice shall include preliminary evidence that infringement is made out." The rights holder is the owner of a right such as a trademark, a copyright, or a patent. Sending 1 sentence does not count. Preliminary evidence has to be attached. After the platform receives the notice, it "shall take the necessary measures in time, and forward that notice to the operator on the platform. If it does not take the necessary measures in time, it bears joint and several liability with the operator on the platform for the enlarged part of the harm." If you drag and do not handle it, you and the seller pay together for the extra part of the loss. After the seller objects, the platform "shall promptly end the measures it took if, within 15 days after the forwarded statement reaches the intellectual-property rights holder, it has not received notice that the rights holder has complained or sued." That means you forward the seller's objection to the rights holder and wait 15 days. If the other side has neither complained nor sued, you restore what was deleted or taken down. If the platform knows, or ought to know, of infringement and does not handle it, it bears joint and several liability with the infringer. The intellectual-property department can also order you to correct within a time limit. If you do not correct in time, the fine is 50000 to 500000 yuan, and in a serious case 500000 to 2000000 yuan. The other way around: "A person who maliciously sends a wrong notice and causes loss to an operator on the platform bears double the liability for compensation" (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If you are not an e-commerce platform and you are only an ordinary website, follow the notice-and-takedown rule in the Civil Code. The difference is how long you wait after the other side objects. The E-commerce Law gives a clear 15 days. The Civil Code only writes "a reasonable period." Also, making public the notice you received, the seller's objection, and the result of what you did is an express requirement of Article 44 of the E-commerce Law. If the platform itself organizes uploads of pirated copies, or knows of infringement and still leaves it up, the rule of "delete it when the notice arrives" does not protect it. See section 9, item 24 (fan-translated comics, and reposted films and TV shows).

## 10. Personal information must not be casually transferred overseas; legal conditions and thresholds apply

**Cost**. No cost involved. The simplest solution is to keep user data within China. If transfer overseas is unavoidable, follow standard contracts or obtain proper certification.

**In plain terms**. Sending information about users inside China to a machine abroad is called an export, and putting the server abroad counts the same. In general you have to pass a security assessment by the cyberspace authority, or get a certification, or sign a standard contract. If the running total for the year is under 100000 people and does not include sensitive information, all 3 of those are waived. You also have to tell the user who abroad receives it and what they will use it for, and get that person's separate consent.

**Benefit**. To lawfully provide personal information to overseas entities — whether to foreign companies or foreign servers — at least one of four conditions must be met: passing a security assessment by the Cyberspace Administration; obtaining personal information protection certification; signing a standard contract drafted by the Cyberspace Administration; or meeting other requirements set by laws or administrative regulations. Additionally, you must inform users of the overseas recipient's name, contact details, processing purpose, methods, and types of data involved, and obtain their separate consent. Threshold limits apply based on cumulative user counts. For most businesses not classified as critical information infrastructure operators, the exemption threshold is “fewer than 100,000 personal records (excluding sensitive information) transferred overseas in a calendar year.” Below this threshold, no assessment, contract, or certification is required. Between 100,000 and 1,000,000 records, a standard contract or certification is mandatory. For over 1,000,000 records, or when sensitive information of more than 10,000 individuals is involved, a formal security assessment is required (effective nationwide since March 2024).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Hosting servers overseas does not equate to “data never leaving China.” If a user registers within China and their data is sent to foreign servers, this is still a cross-border transfer. Certain scenarios are exempt from assessment, certification, or standard contracts: cross-border shopping, shipping, or booking flights/hotels, provided these actions are necessary to fulfill a contract involving the user. Note also that user counts are calculated on a cumulative basis starting from January (1) 1 of each year, not as a rolling 12-month period.

## 11. Choose a server by whether you can stand the downtime first, then by whether anyone will run it, and compare prices last

**Cost**. A cloud server from a mainstream cloud vendor is several hundred to several thousand yuan a month. A VPS from a small provider starts at a few tens of yuan a month. A VPS is a small virtual server. Colocation of a dedicated server starts at several thousand yuan a year, and you buy the hardware yourself.

**In plain terms**. The difference among the 3 tiers is not the price. It is what you have in hand on the day something goes wrong. A large vendor has a filing channel, the qualifications are public, a failure comes with a notice and a compensation clause, and you can find a person. A small provider is half the price, but when it oversells, disappears, or gets cut off by the upstream, you do not even know whom to look for. A static site with no user data is enough on a VPS of a few tens of yuan.

**Benefit**. The difference among the 3 tiers is not the price. It is what you have in hand on the day something goes wrong. A mainstream cloud vendor has a filing channel, the qualifications are public, a failure comes with a notice, the contract has a compensation clause, and when something goes wrong you can find a person. A small provider's price can be half as much, but when it oversells, disappears, or gets cut off by the upstream, you have nobody to appeal to. So before you talk price, check in the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology system whether it holds a value-added telecommunications business license. Colocation of a dedicated server pays only when 2 conditions both hold: the bandwidth or the hardware is clearly cheaper, and you have your own people to run it. How to choose: a static site with no user data is enough on the cheapest VPS. If there is user registration and there are transactions, choose a cloud server that can scale and can take snapshot backups, and keep the backups in at least 2 places.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The above is a judgment from experience. There is no literature behind it. The only thing you can actually check is the service provider's license. If you want to save money, save it on the configuration and the bandwidth. Do not save it on the qualification.

## 12. If user information on the website or app leaks, remedy it at once, notify the users and the authority, and report an attack to the police

**Cost**. It costs nothing. Write a plan in advance for the day something happens: who decides, which hole to plug first, and how the notice to users is worded. The hard part is that the instinct in that moment is to cover it up and not let the users know.

**In plain terms**. If user information leaks, or may leak, you remedy it at once and notify the authority in charge and the users who are affected. If you cover it up and do not report, you are first ordered to correct. If you do not correct, the fine is up to 1000000 yuan, and a serious case is a fine of up to 50000000 yuan. If a user is harmed by it, you pay unless you can prove you were not at fault. If you had protections in place, handled it under the plan, and reported in time, the case can be treated more lightly, or not pursued, depending on the circumstances.

**Benefit**. The Personal Information Protection Law says: "Where a leak, alteration, or loss of personal information occurs or may occur, the personal-information handler shall immediately take remedial measures, and notify the department performing personal-information protection duties and the individuals." The notice has to write 3 things: which kind of information leaked, the cause, and the harm that may follow; what remedy you took, and what the user can do to reduce the harm; and your contact details. If your remedy really can avoid the harm, you may skip notifying the user. But if the authority believes harm may result, it has the right to require you to notify. The Regulations on the Administration of Network Data Security say the notice may use "a telephone call, a text message, an instant-messaging tool, email, or a public announcement." If while handling it you find a lead that a crime may be involved, report it to the public security organ and the state security organ. If you do not perform these duties, you are ordered to correct, warned, and the illegal gains are confiscated, and an app that broke the rule can be ordered to suspend or end the service. If you refuse to correct, the fine is up to 1000000 yuan, and the person directly in charge is fined 10000 to 100000 yuan. In a serious case, the fine is up to 50000000 yuan or up to 5% of the previous year's turnover, and the person in charge is fined 100000 to 1000000 yuan. On the civil side, if a user is harmed by this, you "shall bear tort liability such as damages if you cannot prove that you were not at fault." A leak on a large scale also has to be reported on time. The measures of the Cyberspace Administration of China provide that a leak of personal information of 1000000 or more people counts as a "fairly large cybersecurity incident." For this kind of incident, an ordinary website or app reports to the cyberspace department of the province where it is, "no later than 4 hours," and a channel for it is the 12387 hotline. Within 30 days after the handling ends, you also submit a summary report. Late reporting, omitted reporting, false reporting, or concealed reporting that causes a serious harmful result is punished more heavily. The other way around: if reasonable and necessary protection was already in place, the case was handled under the plan, and it was reported in time, "it may be treated more lightly, or not pursued, depending on the circumstances" (nationwide, the reporting measures from November (11) 2025).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A small site that leaks several hundred people, or several thousand, still has to remedy and notify under the Personal Information Protection Law. It just does not reach the 4-hour reporting line. When you notify users, write the things they can do in concrete terms: which password to change, and to watch for a phone call from someone pretending to be customer service. Keep logs for a full 6 months, so that when something happens you can see where it leaked. See section 11, item 16 (keep logs as graded protection requires). How users protect themselves after a leak is in section 14.

## 13. If you sell an auto-renewing membership, remind the user prominently before signup and before each charge, and make the cancel entry easy to find

**Cost**. It costs nothing. On the signup page, state the auto-renewal plainly, send 1 separate reminder before each charge, and put 1 button in the account center that can cancel at any time. The hard part is that some users will cancel as soon as the reminder arrives.

**In plain terms**. If you sell an auto-renewing membership, remind the user in a way that stands out, both before the user turns it on and before each charge. During the membership, give 1 entry that can cancel or change it at any time. It has to be easy to find and easy to tap, and you may not charge an unreasonable extra fee. If you take the money without the reminder, the fine can be 1 to 5 times the illegal gains. If there are no illegal gains, the fine is up to 300000 yuan.

**Benefit**. The Measures for the Supervision and Administration of Online Transactions say that, where a service is provided by automatic extension, automatic renewal, or a similar method, you "shall, before the consumer accepts the service and before the date of the automatic extension, automatic renewal, or similar step, draw the consumer's attention in a prominent way, and leave the choice to the consumer." During the service you must also "provide the consumer with a prominent and simple option to cancel or change at any time, and must not charge an unreasonable fee." The regulations implementing the Law on the Protection of Consumer Rights and Interests have the same reminder requirement. If the reminder is not given, the penalty follows those implementing regulations: an order to correct, and a warning, confiscation of the illegal gains, and a fine of 1 to 5 times the illegal gains are allowed. If there are no illegal gains, the fine is up to 300000 yuan. In a serious case, you are ordered to suspend business for rectification, and the business license is revoked. If you do not give a convenient cancel entry, you are ordered to correct within a time limit, and a fine of up to 30000 yuan is allowed (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The rules do not say what a "prominent way" looks like in detail. The safe practice is to send 1 separate reminder before each charge, and keep the record of sending it, so you can produce the evidence if someone complains. How to turn auto-renewal off from the user's side is in section 5, item 1 (turn off every auto-renewal).

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# 27. Pregnancy and childbirth: From confirming pregnancy to discharge and paperwork

The first half of this section measures death risk for the pregnant woman and the fetus. The second half measures money and the time spent running errands. The two accounts are not converted into each other. The content only covers "what to do when." Things without hard evidence, or with only a small effect — prenatal nutrition, fetal education, and the like — are not written here. Maternity allowances, maternity leave, and the money side of raising a child are in Section 18; how to care for the child after birth is in Section 20; emergencies are in Section 13.

Figures from the World Health Organization: in 2023, about 260000 women worldwide died from pregnancy and childbirth. About 75% of those deaths came from five causes: postpartum hemorrhage, infection, hypertensive disorders of pregnancy (blood pressure that rises after pregnancy, including preeclampsia and eclampsia), complications during delivery, and unsafe abortion. The WHO also says that "most maternal deaths are preventable, because the health-care solutions to prevent or manage complications are well known." The items in this section with the largest effect are exactly those that catch these problems early.

Items in this section are grouped by theme below; numbers in parentheses are the item numbers.

**What you can do yourself before and during pregnancy:** start folic acid when you are preparing to conceive (Item 1); no cigarette and no drink of alcohol (Item 4); you do not need to rehome the cat (Item 17); inactivated influenza vaccine (Item 18); from 28 weeks onward, lie on your side when you fall asleep (Item 19).

**Prenatal care and screening:** register for the Maternal and Child Health Handbook (Item 2); HIV, syphilis, and hepatitis B (Item 3); low-dose aspirin (Item 5); gestational diabetes screening (Item 6).

**Go to the hospital at once when something is wrong:** the "go to the hospital immediately" list (Item 7); if your water breaks, lie flat where you are (Item 8).

**During childbirth:** if you want labor analgesia, say so directly (Item 9); do not ask for a cesarean without a medical indication (Item 10).

**After birth:** the 42-day postpartum checkup (Item 16); breastfeeding is not the same as contraception (Item 20).

**Money and documents:** confirm maternity insurance (Item 11); the Medical Certificate of Birth (Item 12); heel-prick screening and hearing screening (Item 13); enroll the child in resident yibao (医保 — basic medical insurance) (Item 14); file the birth registration (Item 15).

## 1. Start taking 0.4 mg of folic acid every day when you prepare to conceive, and keep taking it through the first 3 months of pregnancy

**Cost**. A few dozen yuan per bottle. Rural women need not pay; the national free folic acid supplementation program issues it. One pill a day; the hard part is remembering every day

**In plain terms**. Taking one folic acid pill a day around the time of conception cuts the chance of a neural tube defect in the child by about seven tenths. Neural tube defects are birth defects such as anencephaly and spina bifida. For someone who has already had a child with one of these, the chance that another child has the same problem falls to about one third of what it was.

**Benefit**. A Cochrane systematic review pooled 5 trials and 6708 births and rated the evidence high quality. Daily folic acid before and during pregnancy cut fetal neural tube defect risk to RR 0.31 (95% CI 0.17 to 0.58, the plausible range), about a seven-tenths reduction. For people who had already had a child with a neural tube defect, the risk of another affected child was RR 0.34 (95% CI 0.18 to 0.64), about one third of the original. By subgroup, 0.4 mg and higher doses did not differ in effect. Folic acid alone and a multivitamin did not differ either. The Ministry of Health's 2010 folic acid supplementation program plan states that rural women preparing to conceive receive free folic acid, "taken from 3 months before pregnancy through the first

3 months of pregnancy," as 0.4 mg tablets. The US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention notes that neural tube defects form in the first few weeks of pregnancy, often before you know you are pregnant

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The key is to start before pregnancy. Neural tube defects form in the first few weeks; if you wait until a positive test, it may already be late. So if you plan to have a child, start 3 months ahead, as the domestic program does. The same pooled review found no clear effect of folic acid on cleft lip and palate, congenital heart disease, or miscarriage — do not count on it for those. Pregnant people on a fully plant-based diet also need vitamin B12 every day; see Section 20, Item 14 (if you eat plant-based, take vitamin B12 daily). If you are still undecided about when to have a child, the age account is in Section 18, Item 7 (waiting a few more years to have a child).

## 2. Register for the Maternal and Child Health Handbook at a community health center before 13 weeks of pregnancy to claim free prenatal checkups

**Cost**. No cost at all — this is part of the national basic public health service program. You'll need to make several visits based on your gestational age.

**In plain terms**. You are entitled to at least five free prenatal checkups during pregnancy, plus home visits after delivery and a 42-day postpartum checkup, all paid for by the state. To access these services, you must register for the Maternal and Child Health Handbook at a community health center before 13 weeks of gestation. Failing to do so means you lose out on all these free services.

**Benefit**. The third edition of the National Basic Public Health Service Standards outlines specific maternal health management services available to all permanent residents who are pregnant. These include one health checkup in early pregnancy, two in mid-pregnancy, two in late pregnancy, one postpartum home visit, and one 42-day postpartum checkup. Registration for the handbook must be completed before 13 weeks of pregnancy, at which point your first prenatal checkup will also be scheduled. The two mid-pregnancy checkups occur between 16–20 weeks and 21–24 weeks respectively, while the two late-pregnancy checkups are scheduled for 28–36 weeks and 37–40 weeks. Local service lists also include a full set of initial lab tests and postpartum depression screening as part of these free services.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These five free checkups represent the minimum number of services provided; they do not cover all possible prenatal tests. Depending on your individual health needs, your doctor may recommend additional ultrasounds, blood glucose tests, or fetal heart rate monitoring, all of which will incur extra costs. Registering for the handbook as early as possible also allows for earlier assessment of your pregnancy risk level. This risk grading system categorizes pregnant women based on their individual risk factors, ensuring those identified as high-risk receive timely care at specialized medical facilities. Even if you live in a different district than your registered household location, you can still register at your current place of residence — there is no requirement to return to your place of household registration.

## 3. At the first prenatal visit, get the three tests for HIV, syphilis, and hepatitis B; if HIV is found, free prevention of mother-to-child transmission is available

**Cost**. HIV counseling and initial screening are free under the regulations. For syphilis and hepatitis B, national documents do not say they are free; ask the prenatal hospital whether they charge

**In plain terms**. At the first prenatal visit, get the three tests for HIV, syphilis, and hepatitis B done. The initial HIV screen does not come out of your pocket. A positive result is not a dead end. If HIV is found, the state provides free treatment and counseling. If syphilis is found, treat early with penicillin. If hepatitis B is found, the newborn gets vaccine and immunoglobulin at the same time at birth, which blocks transmission from mother to child.

**Benefit**. Mother-to-child transmission means the disease passing from mother to child. The Work Specifications for Preventing Mother-to-Child Transmission of HIV, Syphilis, and Hepatitis B (2020 Edition) set requirements. At the first prenatal checkup, the hospital must give relevant information, "provide appropriate, standardized testing, and provide follow-up counseling based on the results." If the status is still unclear before delivery, treat the person as infected in principle. The specifications require that pregnant women found to have syphilis "receive standardized penicillin treatment as early as possible," and that the newborn get preventive penicillin right after birth. For pregnant women positive for hepatitis B surface antigen, those who meet the criteria may receive antiviral treatment after informed consent. A positive result is not a dead end. Article 23 of the Regulations on the Prevention and Control of HIV/AIDS states that people who voluntarily accept HIV counseling and testing are "provided free counseling and initial screening." Article 44 requires free "treatment and counseling to prevent mother-to-child transmission of HIV" for pregnant women infected with HIV. Article 43 requires services such as blocking transmission (keeping the disease from the child), treatment, postpartum visits, and infant follow-up and testing. When the mother is positive for hepatitis B surface antigen, the newborn must receive hepatitis B vaccine and hepatitis B immunoglobulin at the same time at birth (see Section 20, Item 2)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The earlier these three are checked, the more useful they are, because blocking and treatment both take time. Article 3 of the HIV/AIDS regulations also states that "no unit or individual may discriminate against people living with HIV, AIDS patients, or their family members"; lawful rights in marriage, work, medical care, and schooling are protected. Everyday prevention and testing are in Section 1. Post-exposure prophylaxis after high-risk behavior is in Section 13

## 4. Through the whole pregnancy, do not take a single cigarette or a single drink of alcohol, and do not let others smoke indoors at home either

**Cost**. No money spent, and you save on tobacco and alcohol. The hard part is getting people who live with you to quit along with you

**In plain terms**. Smoking in pregnancy raises the chance the baby is born early, is born too small, or has a cleft lip or palate, and doubles the risk of abnormal bleeding in pregnancy and at delivery. When the pregnant person smokes, or the baby breathes smoke after birth, the risk of sudden infant death is higher. Quitting is still useful whenever you do it.

**Benefit**. The US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's framing: smoking in pregnancy can leave a baby "born too small, even if full term" and "may lead to preterm birth." It "doubles the risk of abnormal bleeding during pregnancy and delivery." It raises the risk of birth defects such as cleft lip and cleft palate. It also "can damage a baby's developing lungs and brain," and "the damage can last into childhood." Infants of mothers who smoked in pregnancy, and infants exposed to smoke after birth, have a higher risk of sudden infant death syndrome. Official advice is to "quit smoking before getting pregnant if you can, but quitting is still helpful if you are already pregnant" and "it is never too late to quit." On alcohol, the CDC says there is "no known safe amount of alcohol use during pregnancy," and no stage of pregnancy when drinking is safe. The baby's brain develops through the whole pregnancy, so alcohol contact at any time may cause harm

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Secondhand smoke when someone else smokes indoors counts the same for the fetus. So people who live with you should not smoke indoors either. Alcohol is the same: no known safe amount; the simplest approach in pregnancy is not to drink at all. The account of tobacco and alcohol for adults themselves is in Section 2

## 5. For women at high risk of preeclampsia, start taking one low-dose aspirin tablet daily after week 12 of pregnancy

**Cost**. A few dozen yuan. One tablet per day must be taken until delivery. The hard part is remembering to take it every single day.

**In plain terms**. Preeclampsia is a type of high blood pressure that occurs during pregnancy. Women falling into any of these six categories are at high risk: those who had preeclampsia in a previous pregnancy, women carrying multiples, women with chronic hypertension, women with diabetes prior to pregnancy, women with kidney disease, and women with autoimmune diseases. For these women, taking one low-dose aspirin tablet daily starting at week 12 can reduce the risk of preeclampsia by roughly 15%, the risk of premature birth by about 20%, and the risk of perinatal death by nearly 20%. Women not in these categories should not take it on their own.

**Benefit**. The US Preventive Services Task Force gives this a Grade B recommendation: for women at high risk of preeclampsia, taking low-dose aspirin (81 mg per day) after week 12 of pregnancy can help prevent the condition. Preeclampsia is a hypertensive disorder unique to pregnancy. Results from multiple studies combined show the following outcomes, with 95% confidence intervals provided as ranges of reliability. The relative risk of preeclampsia drops to 0.85 (95% CI: 0.75 to 0.95, based on 16 studies), a reduction of roughly 15%. The relative risk of premature birth is 0.80 (95% CI: 0.67 to 0.95, based on 13 studies), a drop of about 20%. The relative risk of perinatal death — death occurring around the time of childbirth — is 0.79 (95% CI: 0.66 to 0.96, based on 11 studies), a reduction of roughly 21%. The relative risk of small-for-gestational-age infants or intrauterine growth restriction is 0.82 (95% CI: 0.68 to 0.99, based on 16 studies), a decrease of around 18%, meaning fetuses are less likely to be smaller than expected for their gestational age.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The groups considered high risk include women who had preeclampsia in a prior pregnancy, those carrying twins or multiples, women with chronic hypertension, women with type 1 or type 2 diabetes prior to pregnancy, women with kidney disease, and women with autoimmune diseases such as systemic lupus erythematosus or antiphospholipid syndrome. Women not in these groups should not take aspirin on their own. This medication requires a doctor's prescription; be sure to share your full medical history during prenatal checkups so your doctor can make an appropriate assessment. Most low-dose aspirin tablets sold in China are 100 mg enteric-coated tablets, and they must be taken strictly as directed by your doctor.

## 6. At 24 weeks of pregnancy or later, get one gestational diabetes screen; do not skip it because drinking the sugar water is a bother

**Cost**. A few dozen to a little over 100 yuan. You go fasting, several blood draws, and it takes half a morning

**In plain terms**. Gestational diabetes is high blood sugar that appears only after pregnancy begins. After 24 weeks, half a morning of drinking sugar water and several blood draws can find it. If you neither screen nor manage it, the risks of a fetus that grows too large, difficult birth, a cesarean, preeclampsia, and newborn low blood sugar all go up.

**Benefit**. The US Preventive Services Task Force gives a Grade B recommendation: screen pregnant people without symptoms (no felt discomfort) for gestational diabetes at 24 weeks or later. Gestational diabetes is high blood sugar that appears only after pregnancy begins. When only one screen is done, that one should be at 24 weeks or later. On screening before 24 weeks, the Task Force concludes that current evidence is insufficient to judge benefits and harms (Grade I). Untreated gestational diabetes raises the risks of macrosomia (a fetus that grows too large), difficult birth, cesarean, preeclampsia, and newborn hypoglycemia

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Per the US Preventive Services Task Force, after a diagnosis people usually start with exercise, diet changes, and blood sugar checks; insulin or oral drugs come only if sugar stays uncontrolled. Do not skip this screen because you fear needing injections. Recheck blood sugar after birth: the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention says about half of people who had gestational diabetes later develop type 2 diabetes

## 7. Memorize this “go to the hospital immediately” checklist — it applies throughout pregnancy and the first year after childbirth

**Cost**. No cost at all. It takes just five minutes to memorize, and it's a good idea to share it with anyone living in the same household.

**In plain terms**. If any of the following appears, go to the hospital the same day — do not wait overnight at home; this still counts within the first year after birth. A headache that will not ease or keeps getting worse, vision that looks different, fever of 38 °C, severe swelling of the hands or face. Trouble breathing, chest pain or a fast heartbeat, severe abdominal pain that does not ease, fetal movement that stops or drops clearly. Vaginal bleeding or fluid leaking, one arm or leg that is both swollen and painful, thoughts of harming yourself or the baby.

**Benefit**. These are all emergency warning signs during pregnancy and postpartum listed by the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. Persistent or worsening headaches, dizziness or fainting, changes in vision, a body temperature of 38°C or higher. Severe swelling of the hands or face, thoughts of harming yourself or your baby. Difficulty breathing, chest pain or a rapid heartbeat. Severe nausea and vomiting, unrelenting severe abdominal pain. Absence or significant reduction of fetal movement during pregnancy, vaginal bleeding or fluid leakage during pregnancy or postpartum. Abnormal vaginal bleeding or discharge after childbirth. Severe swelling, redness and pain in one arm or leg. None of these issues disappear after the postpartum recovery period — they can all occur within the first year after childbirth.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This checklist serves to clearly distinguish between situations where you can wait a little longer and those that demand immediate medical attention. Headaches paired with blurred vision and upper abdominal pain are typical signs of preeclampsia, a form of pregnancy-related hypertension. Swelling and pain in one lower leg often indicates deep vein thrombosis (see Section 13). According to the World Health Organization, severe postpartum hemorrhage can be fatal to a healthy woman within just a few hours. If any of these symptoms appear, go to the hospital right away — do not delay by waiting at home overnight.

## 8. If your water breaks, lie flat where you are, raise your hips, and call 120; do not walk around and do not bathe

**Cost**. No money spent

**In plain terms**. When your water breaks, do not pack slowly and then leave. The right move is to lie down where you are, raise your hips, and call 120. Walking while standing makes the fluid drain faster, and the cord may come out with it. That is an emergency that can kill the baby.

**Benefit**. The Beijing Municipal Health Commission's handling advice: after the water breaks, “immediately find a place to lie flat to stop the amniotic fluid from flowing out,” “do not walk around casually,” and “call 120 emergency services at once.” While waiting for the vehicle, tell family to bring things and meet at the hospital. Medical explainers add why: when a person stands, amniotic fluid is lost faster, and the baby's umbilical cord may come out with it — cord prolapse, an emergency that threatens the fetus. So lie down, raise the hips; a left lateral position is fine

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The three signs that birth is near are regular contractions, show (bloody mucus), and water breaking; water breaking is the one that means “lie down on the spot and call a car.” This is the author's summary of the two explainers above. An explainer from Shunyi District Maternal and Child Health Hospital says getting out of bed to stand, walk, sit, or squat all make fluid drain faster and raise the risk of cord prolapse. So after the water breaks, do not bathe, do not squat on the toilet, and do not drive yourself. Note the time the water broke and the color of the fluid, and tell the doctor. Fluid that is light green, yellow-green, or even brownish yellow may mean meconium (the baby's stool) is mixed in. If you feel a cord-like object hanging in the vagina, it may be cord prolapse — call 120 at once, lie flat, and raise the hips. If fetal movement is clearly different from usual, tell the doctor as well

## 9. Ask for labor analgesia — it does not raise the risk of C-section

**Cost**. Several hundred to over 1,000 yuan; prices vary by region. Be sure to ask the hospital and anesthesiology department in advance whether this service is available. The main hurdle is simply bringing it up yourself.

**In plain terms**. Labor analgesia is a shot of anesthetic in the lower back that takes the edge off labor pain. It works better than other pain relief and does not make a cesarean more likely. The claim that "it leaves you with lifelong back pain" has no basis either. It now has its own billing item, so hospitals are more willing to offer it.

**Benefit**. A Cochrane systematic review found that epidural analgesia is more effective than non-epidural methods at reducing labor pain and improving maternal satisfaction. Labor analgesia uses exactly this technique. The same review states that epidural analgesia has no effect on the risk of C-section or long-term back pain. Instrumental delivery — using tools to assist birth — shows no increased incidence in studies published after 2005. Starting in 2024, the National Healthcare Security Administration introduced separate pricing categories for "labor analgesia," "doula-assisted childbirth," and "family-member labor support," precisely because previously there were no dedicated rates to motivate hospitals to offer these services.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Both popular myths — "epidural analgesia causes lifelong back pain" and "it makes a C-section more likely" — lack any scientific basis. Cochrane's comparison of epidural analgesia with other pain-relief methods confirms it has no impact on C-section risk or chronic back problems. Real side effects may include low blood pressure, fever, weak legs, difficulty urinating, longer first- and second-stage labor, and a higher need for oxytocin. The decision to use it is yours; don't let unfounded rumors deter you. Availability also depends on whether the hospital has an anesthesiologist on duty 24/7 — be sure to ask during prenatal visits.

## 10. Without a medical indication, do not ask for a cesarean, and do not schedule surgery to pick a date

**Cost**. No money spent. The hard part is standing up to what people at home say

**In plain terms**. The World Health Organization's position is that once a place's cesarean rate passes 10%, there is no evidence that deaths of mothers and newborns keep falling. When a cesarean is needed, it must be done. Choosing a date or avoiding pain as the reason means taking on one more major abdominal operation.

**Benefit**. WHO statement in 2015: when the cesarean rate in a population rises to about 10%, maternal and newborn deaths fall. Above 10%, there is no evidence that mortality improves further. WHO also stresses that every effort should be made to provide cesareans to women who need them, not to hit a particular rate

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. When medicine truly requires it, a cesarean is life-saving — do it; do not tough it out. What to avoid is surgery when medicine does not require it, for example fear of pain, picking an auspicious time, or gaming the child's school-entry age. A cesarean is a major abdominal operation. One pooled comparison of cesarean with vaginal birth found that after a cesarean, in a later pregnancy placenta previa OR 1.74, about 70% higher; placenta accreta OR 2.95, about 3 times; placental abruption OR 1.38; stillbirth OR 1.27. That directly affects whether you want a second child. On the other side, people who had a cesarean later have less urine leakage and pelvic organ prolapse. These all come from follow-up record studies; the authors say you cannot conclude from them that the cesarean caused the difference

## 11. Before pregnancy, confirm your maternity insurance enrollment; an unemployed spouse can also claim maternity medical expenses

**Cost**. No money spent. One call to the social insurance or yibao (医保 — basic medical insurance) advice line

**In plain terms**. When the employer pays maternity insurance, medical costs of childbirth and the allowance during maternity leave both come from that fund. If the spouse has no job, the medical-cost part can still be

claimed. Whether you have enough months of enrollment, and whether birth outside the local area needs advance filing, must be asked early.

**Benefit**. Article 54 of the Social Insurance Law: when the employer has paid maternity insurance premiums, the employee enjoys maternity insurance benefits. An unemployed spouse of the employee enjoys maternity medical expense benefits under national rules, paid from the maternity insurance fund. When the unit pays maternity insurance, the employee gets benefits, and medical costs when that unemployed spouse gives birth also come from the same fund. Maternity insurance benefits have two parts: maternity medical expenses — the medical costs of childbirth itself — and the maternity allowance — the money paid to you during maternity leave. Article 56 lists three situations for the allowance: female employees on maternity leave after birth, leave for family-planning procedures, and other situations set by laws and regulations. The maternity allowance is “paid according to the employer's average monthly wage of employees in the previous year” — the unit's prior-year average, not your own wage

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Ask the local medical insurance authority two things early. First, whether continuous enrollment months are enough, and whether there is a minimum. Second, if birth is not in the enrollment area, whether you must file an out-of-area maternity record first, and how costs are claimed without filing. Rules differ by place; this text does not check each locality — asking early is the author's experience. Leave days and how the allowance is calculated are in Section 18, Item 2

## 12. Before discharge, get the Medical Certificate of Birth done; choose the name in advance and do not write the wrong characters

**Cost**. No money spent. Done as part of discharge paperwork

**In plain terms**. This certificate is the prerequisite for hukou (户口 — household registration), insurance enrollment, and school. If birth was in a hospital, collect it from the facility that attended the birth. If birth was outside a midwifery facility, you need a parentage test first. For characters in the name, confirm the hukou system can type them.

**Benefit**. Article 23 of the Maternal and Infant Health Care Law: medical and health-care institutions and persons engaged in home delivery issue a uniformly produced medical certificate of birth for the newborn under rules of the health administration under the State Council. This certificate is the prerequisite for everything that follows: hukou registration, insurance enrollment, a medical insurance card, and kindergarten or school all need it. The State Council General Office's 2015 opinion on registering hukou for people without one states: for births inside a midwifery facility, apply to that facility for the Medical Certificate of Birth. For births outside a midwifery facility, first obtain a parentage test from a qualified appraisal body, then apply to the agency entrusted by the county-level health department

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Before filling it in, check parents' names, ID numbers, and the child's name character by character. Name characters must be typeable in the hukou system; rare characters make later paperwork hard. Changing a name or the certificate means reissue or replacement, which is far more trouble than checking on the spot. Keep the certificate separately once you have it — as important as the household register and ID card

## 13. Do not refuse newborn heel-prick screening or hearing screening

**Cost**. Free in most areas, or a few dozen yuan. Some expanded items you pay yourself. One heel prick after the child is born

**In plain terms**. One heel-prick blood draw and one hearing test can find hypothyroidism, phenylketonuria, and hearing loss while the child still looks completely normal. By the time symptoms show, damage to intellect can no longer be undone.

**Benefit**. Article 3 of the Administrative Measures for Newborn Disease Screening: “National newborn disease screening covers neonatal inherited metabolic diseases such as congenital hypothyroidism and phenylketonuria, and hearing impairment.” These conditions share one point: early on there is no visible abnormality; once symptoms are obvious, intellectual damage is already irreversible. Early detection and early intervention work well — thyroid hormone replacement, special formula milk, hearing aids, or cochlear implants. Article 10 requires that when a screen is positive, the facility promptly notify the guardian to seek confirmatory diagnosis

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Article 11 requires that before screening, the items, conditions, methods, sensitivity (how many cases can be found), and fees be told to the guardian truthfully, with signed consent. So you will get an informed-consent form. Before signing, see clearly which conditions are nationally required and which are self-pay add-ons. A positive first screen is not a confirmed diagnosis; under Article 10 the facility will notify you to take the child for confirmation — do not fall apart at this step. If the first hearing screen is not passed, go for the repeat screen as notified; do not decide on your own that “the child can hear, so it is fine”

## 14. Enroll your newborn in yibao right after getting the birth certificate — don't wait until household registration is complete

**Cost**. You pay the yibao premium just once a year; it usually costs a few hundred yuan.

**In plain terms**. As soon as you receive the birth certificate, you can enroll your baby in yibao online — no need to wait for household registration. Once enrolled, most hospitalization costs can be reimbursed right at discharge. Newborn hospital bills can be quite high, so having yibao makes a big difference.

**Benefit**. According to the Chinese government website in 2024, “Newborns can enroll in yibao online using their birth certificate alone; household registration is not required first.” It also states that “after discharge, newborns can get medical expenses reimbursed immediately.” Previously, families had to complete household registration first, pay all hospital costs out of pocket, and then apply for reimbursement. The average processing time for enrollment has also dropped from 28.7 working days at the start of the year to just 6.4 working days now.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Premature birth, phototherapy for jaundice, and neonatal pneumonia are common reasons newborns end up in the hospital — often resulting in bills of tens of thousands of yuan. Having yibao versus not having it makes a huge difference in such cases. Local rules vary regarding how many days after birth a child must be enrolled to qualify for coverage starting from birth; always check with your local medical insurance office for exact details. Before discharge, calling 12393 is the easiest way to get clear answers.

## 15. Within one month after the child is born, go to the police station to file the birth registration

**Cost**. No money spent. One trip to the hukou (户口 — household registration) window at the police station

**In plain terms**. The law gives one month, not “when you have time.” Hukou registration blocks what comes after: vaccines, kindergarten, school, and an ID card. The longer you wait, the more materials you have to make up.

**Benefit**. Article 7 of the Household Registration Regulations: “Within one month after the infant is born, the household head, a relative, a foster parent, or a neighbor shall report the birth registration to the household registration authority at the infant's place of habitual residence.” This is a statutory deadline, not advice. Hukou registration is the prerequisite for vaccines, kindergarten, school, and an ID card. The longer you wait, the more materials you need to supply

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Bring these: the Medical Certificate of Birth, the parents' ID cards and household registers, and the marriage certificate; the exact list follows what the local police station requires. The State Council General Office's 2015 opinion states voluntary choice of father's or mother's hukou — you may choose either side. School districts and insurance enrollment areas may differ; decide before you go, because changing later is trouble. Children born outside marriage can also register hukou: the same opinion says you may apply with the Medical Certificate of Birth, one parent's household register, and a statement of non-marital birth. For registration under the father's hukou, you also need a parentage test from a qualified appraisal body

## 16. Do not skip the 42-day postpartum checkup; in some places it is also a postpartum depression screen

**Cost**. No money spent; it is part of basic public health services. Half a day. The hard part is not wanting to move just after the confinement month

**In plain terms**. This checkup costs nothing. On local published service lists it includes a complete blood count, a vaginal discharge exam, and one postpartum depression screen. Serious problems can still appear in the first year after birth; do not assume you are safe once the confinement month ends.

**Benefit**. Under maternal health management in the National Basic Public Health Service Standards (Third Edition), after birth there is 1 postpartum home visit and 1 health checkup at 42 days postpartum. On local published service lists, that visit includes lab tests (complete blood count, vaginal discharge exam) and 1 postpartum depression screen. The National Health Commission's 2020 work plan for specialized depression prevention services asks pilot areas to “include perinatal depression screening in routine prenatal checkups and postpartum visit workflows.” So whether depression screening comes with the postpartum visit depends on whether the locality does this. Serious complications can still appear in the first year after birth. On the “go to the hospital immediately” list in Item 7, “thoughts of harming yourself or the child,” “postpartum vaginal bleeding or abnormal discharge,” and “severe swelling and pain in one limb” all belong to the postpartum period

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Postpartum depression is not being oversensitive, and one family line of “cheer up” does not fix it. There are dedicated screening questionnaires and treatment, and recovery is possible. What to do with suicidal thoughts is in Section 1. Legal options when you truly cannot raise the child are in Section 9, Item 20. This checkup also looks at how the wound is healing, how the uterus is recovering, and pelvic floor function. Contraception is discussed then too: no period after birth does not mean you cannot get pregnant

## 17. You do not need to rehome the cat when pregnant; have someone else scoop the litter every day, cook meat through, and wear gloves when you handle soil

**Cost**. No money spent. Hand litter scooping to someone else in the household every day. If only you can scoop, buy a box of disposable gloves. The hard part is eating meat fully cooked — no rare steak or underdone lamb

**In plain terms**. Toxoplasma is a parasite. A first infection in pregnancy can cause miscarriage, and the child's eyes and brain can be damaged. Living with a cat does not make infection more likely, so the cat does not have to go. What matters more is undercooked meat and handling soil without washing hands; having someone else scoop the litter every day is enough.

**Benefit**. The US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention says a first toxoplasma infection shortly before or during pregnancy can pass to the fetus. Most infected children have no symptoms at birth but may lose sight or develop intellectual disability later. A few are born with severe eye or brain damage. The UK National Health Service (NHS) says infection in pregnancy can cause miscarriage. A toxoplasmosis testing centre in Lyon, France, counted 603 women with infection confirmed in pregnancy, most of whom took antiparasitic drugs. Overall, 29% of infections passed to the fetus (95% CI 25 to 33, the plausible range). About

6% of infections at 13 weeks passed on, versus about 72% at 36 weeks. The earlier the infection, the more likely the child shows symptoms. Infection at 24 to 30 weeks carried the highest risk of early symptoms in the child, about 10%. A comparison across six European cities of newly infected and uninfected pregnant women found: living with a cat OR 1.0 (95% CI 0.7 to 1.5), no difference; cleaning the litter box yourself OR 1.3 (95% CI 0.8 to 2.1), a difference that may be chance; eating undercooked lamb OR 3.13 (95% CI 1.4 to 7.2), about 3 times the risk of not eating it; contact with soil OR 1.81 (95% CI 1.2 to 2.7), about 80% higher. Across the cities, 30% to 63% of infections could be tied to undercooked or cured meat, and 6% to 17% to soil. CDC advice for pregnant people: let someone else change the litter if possible; if no one can, wear disposable gloves and wash hands with soap and water afterward. Change litter daily, because the parasite in cat feces takes 1 to 5 days to become infectious to people. Do not get a new cat in pregnancy, and do not adopt or handle stray cats, especially kittens. Keep the cat indoors and feed only cat food or cooked food, never raw meat. Explainers from the Chinese CDC also say the father-to-be should take over the litter box when possible, and that with precautions in pregnancy the cat can stay. The NHS states that stroking or owning a cat does not give you toxoplasmosis

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. A cat usually sheds toxoplasma in feces only for a few weeks after its first infection. An adult cat infected before is even less likely to shed again. A cat kept indoors and not fed raw meat has little chance of getting infected. You can catch toxoplasmosis without owning a cat; sources are undercooked meat, unwashed fruit and vegetables, soil contaminated by cat feces, and untreated water. So do these: cook meat all the way through, and wash knives, cutting boards, and hands after raw meat; rinse fruit and vegetables under running water; wear gloves for gardening or turning soil, and wash hands afterward. The NHS also advises against cured raw meats such as salami and Parma ham, and against unpasteurised goat's milk. The European study did not ask in detail about lettuce and unwashed vegetables, and 14% to 49% of infections could not be traced. Ask your prenatal doctor whether to test for toxoplasma antibodies. The grade is B because the cat and meat risks rest on one study's figures, recalled after the fact. The practices come from official bodies; no study has calculated how many infections following them would prevent. The “medium” benefit rating is a judgement call, with the reasoning in the verification record. The benefit falls on you and your child

## 18. If flu season falls during pregnancy, get one shot of inactivated influenza vaccine; any stage of pregnancy is fine; do not use the nasal spray

**Cost**. Self-pay, a few dozen to a little over 100 yuan per shot. One trip to a community vaccination clinic. The hard part is picking a product whose package insert does not list pregnancy as a contraindication

**In plain terms**. Pregnant people who get flu are more likely to be hospitalized than people who are not pregnant. One flu shot in pregnancy cuts your own flu hospitalizations by about four tenths. In the child's first 6 months, confirmed flu falls by about half, and flu hospitalizations by about seven tenths. No rise in miscarriage, stillbirth, or birth defects was seen after the shot.

**Benefit**. The WHO 2022 position paper pooled existing studies. Pregnant people with flu had about 7 times the hospitalization risk of people who were not pregnant (OR 6.8, 95% CI 6–7.7, the plausible range). A trial in Bangladesh randomized 340 pregnant women into two groups. One got inactivated influenza vaccine; the other got pneumococcal vaccine as a control, followed to 24 weeks after the child was born. In the flu-vaccine group there were 6 confirmed flu cases in children versus 16 in controls, vaccine efficacy 63% (95% CI 5–85). Mothers' own fever plus respiratory illness fell 36% (95% CI 4–57). Two South African trials used placebo; neither doctors nor pregnant women knew which shot was which. Among pregnant women without HIV, confirmed flu fell from 3.6% to 1.8%, efficacy 50.4% (95% CI 14.5–71.2). Their children fell from 3.6% to 1.9%, efficacy 48.8% (95% CI 11.6–70.4). Pooling 4 trials and 3 observational studies, confirmed flu in children under 6 months was about 48% lower (95% CI 33–59). Four observational studies looking at child hospitalization for confirmed flu found about 72% lower (95% CI 39–87). Another pool of only two trials found confirmed flu 34% lower (95% CI 15–50). But children's “influenza-like illness” did not differ — that is illness that looks like flu

without lab confirmation. Pregnant people's own hospitalizations were read from records in four countries from 2010 to 2016. Hospitalization for confirmed flu was about 40% lower among those vaccinated (95% CI 12–59). On safety, one pool took in 40 studies. Stillbirth after vaccination aOR 0.84 (0.65–1.08), congenital malformation 1.03 (0.99–1.07). Both differences sat within error. Preterm birth 0.87 (0.78–0.96), about 13% lower. The US checked three flu seasons from 2012 to 2015. Vaccination in the 28 days before miscarriage aOR 0.9 (0.6–1.5), no association. The Chinese CDC's 2026–2027 season guideline lists pregnant people as a priority group. It says vaccination at any stage of pregnancy can protect infants under 6 months of age, with a better effect in late pregnancy. Live attenuated vaccine is forbidden in pregnancy

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversial. A 2017 US study found more miscarriages among people vaccinated in the 28 days before miscarriage (aOR 2.0, 1.1–3.6). The excess appeared only in those who had also received an H1N1-containing vaccine the prior season. The authors themselves said this does not prove causation. The same group later checked three more flu seasons and did not see the link again, so countries still say any stage of pregnancy is fine. Some domestic flu vaccine inserts still list pregnancy as a contraindication. Guidelines advise picking a product whose insert does not list pregnancy as a contraindication, and telling the vaccinator you are pregnant. Use only injectable inactivated vaccine. The nasal spray is live attenuated vaccine; domestically it is only for ages 3 to 17, and pregnant people must not receive it. Best to finish before the local flu season starts, usually September to October. If you miss that window, you can still catch up through the whole flu season. Children under 6 months cannot get flu vaccine, so this pregnancy shot is the main protection for the child's first months. People who live with you and who care for the child are also a priority group; the adult account of flu vaccination is in Section 1, Item 20 (get a flu vaccine). The Benefit line has no mortality figures; the benefit magnitude is set by confirmed flu and hospitalization, with the reasoning in the verification record. The benefit falls on you and your child

## 19. From 28 weeks of pregnancy onward, fall asleep on your side — left or right is fine; do not fall asleep on your back

**Cost**. No money spent. The hard part is changing posture if you are used to sleeping on your back

**In plain terms**. Falling asleep on your back after 28 weeks raises the risk the baby dies in the womb to about 2.6 times that of side sleeping. Left and right are the same; pick the side that is comfortable. If you wake at night and find yourself on your back, do not panic — roll to the side and sleep on. That figure comes from asking people afterward, and there is controversy.

**Benefit**. Stillbirth here means the baby dying in the womb after 28 weeks. One pool merged raw data from five studies. Four were in New Zealand, Australia, and the UK; one was an online international survey. There were 851 pregnant women with stillbirth and 2257 with a live child as controls. The method was to ask afterward how they had fallen asleep most recently. Versus falling asleep on the left, falling asleep on the back had stillbirth risk aOR 2.63 (95% CI 1.72–4.04, the plausible range), about 2.6 times. Falling asleep on the right aOR 1.04 (0.83–1.31), no difference from the left. The association was similar when the child was small, the pregnant person was obese, or smoked. The authors estimated that if all pregnant people after 28 weeks fell asleep on their side, stillbirths in that stage would fall by about 5.8% (3.2%–9.2%). The UK National Health Service (NHS) lists “do not fall asleep on your back after 28 weeks” among ways to lower stillbirth risk. It also says that waking up on your back is not a reason to worry — roll to the side and sleep on

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Controversial. The figures above all come from asking afterward. People whose baby died may remember inaccurately; the authors acknowledge that. There is also no randomized trial. A US study asked 8706 first-time pregnant women about sleep position in advance, then looked at outcomes. Through 30 weeks, back sleeping or not sleeping on the left had no link to stillbirth, a small baby, or pregnancy hypertension (aOR 0.99, 0.89–1.11). But it only reached 30 weeks; sleep position in the later weeks was not recorded. Side sleeping costs nothing and has no downside, so the UK still advises it. Stillbirth itself is uncommon; in high-income countries late stillbirth is about 1.3 to 8.8 per 1000 births. The “large” benefit

rating follows the 2.6-times figure mechanically, with the reasoning in the verification record. The benefit falls on the child

## 20. Once you resume sex after birth, use contraception — breastfeeding is not contraception; if you want another pregnancy, wait at least 18 months

**Cost**. A box of condoms is a few dozen yuan. An IUD or an implant means a hospital visit; prices vary by place. The hard part is postpartum chaos leaving no room for this

**In plain terms**. You can conceive again as early as 3 weeks after birth, even while breastfeeding and before periods return. Breastfeeding only blocks pregnancy when all three hold: exclusive breastfeeding, no period yet, and the child under 6 months. Conceiving again within half a year after birth raises the next child's preterm risk by about four tenths. The World Health Organization advises waiting at least two years after birth before trying again.

**Benefit**. The UK National Health Service (NHS) says you can conceive again as early as 3 weeks after birth, even while breastfeeding and before periods return. Unless you want another pregnancy right away, use contraception every time you have sex. Relying on breastfeeding is the lactational amenorrhea method; it needs all three at once: breast milk only, no period yet, and the child under 6 months. Done by the rules, it blocks over 99%. When that standard is not met, about 2 in every 100 people conceive within 6 months. Switch to another method if any of these appear: the child passes 6 months, formula or complementary food or a pacifier is introduced, a period returns (even light bleeding counts), night feeds stop, or feed frequency falls. One pool merged 67 studies and adjusted for maternal age and household circumstances. Using 18 to 23 months from prior birth to next conception as the reference, intervals under 6 months had preterm OR 1.40 (95% CI 1.24–1.58, the plausible range), about 40% higher; low birth weight 1.61 (1.39–1.86); child small for gestational age 1.26 (1.18–1.33). Intervals of 6 to 17 months and over 59 months were also higher on these three. A Canadian study of more than 148000 pregnancies compared a 6-month interval with an 18-month interval. For mothers 35 and older, death or serious illness was 0.62% versus 0.26%, aRR 2.39 (2.03–2.80), about 2.4 times. For mothers 20 to 34 there was no difference (0.92, 0.83–1.02). For children of mothers 20 to 34, combined stillbirth, death, extreme smallness, or extreme prematurity was 2.0% versus 1.4%, aRR 1.42 (1.36–1.47). A 2005 WHO expert meeting advised waiting at least 24 months after a live birth before trying the next pregnancy. Experts agreed that conception under 18 months should be avoided. After miscarriage or induced abortion, wait at least 6 months

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Controversial. How long is enough differs by voice. One WHO expert camp wants 18 months, another 27 months; 24 months is the compromise. The NHS says at least 12 months. An Australian study compared two intervals within the same 40441 mothers and got a different picture. For intervals of 0 to 5 months, preterm OR 1.07 (0.86–1.34), low birth weight 1.03 (0.79–1.34), both showing no clear difference. Comparing across different mothers, preterm was 1.41. So part of the short-interval risk may come from the mother's own circumstances. Contraception itself is not in dispute; the dispute is only how long to wait. Per the NHS, condoms and implants can be used right after birth, including while breastfeeding. Combined hormonal pills for breastfeeding people usually wait until at least 6 weeks postpartum. Which method to use, discuss with the doctor at the 42-day postpartum checkup; see Item 16 (the 42-day postpartum checkup). The “medium” benefit rating is a judgement call, with the reasoning in the verification record. The benefit falls on you and the next child

# 28. Don't harm your body just to change its appearance

This section is about a few ways of changing how you look by doing something to the body: going hungry, taking drugs, getting injections, and having surgery. The decision is usually made by comparing yourself with other people. The cost falls entirely on you, and a fair part of it cannot be undone.

This section does not judge what anyone wants to look like. That is each person's own affair. For the same goal, you can look for a prescription, a qualified provider, and follow-up, or you can buy online, go to a beauty salon, and raise the dose yourself. This section only compares how far apart the risks of those 2 ways are. The account looks mainly at what actually happens to the body, such as blindness, a stay in hospital, and death. Those 2 items on cosmetic medicine also involve criminal liability for practicing medicine illegally.

## 1. Do not use extreme dieting, fasting, or making yourself vomit to control weight. If you want to lose weight, lose it on the exercise side

**Cost**. No money. The other way around, you also save what you would have spent on weight-loss products.

**In plain terms**. People with anorexia nervosa (the illness of starving yourself past the point of health) are about 5.9 times as likely to die as people the same age. Follow 1000 of them for 1 year and 5.1 die, and about 1 in 5 of those deaths are suicide. People who diet are more likely to get an eating disorder. Students at 44 secondary schools were followed for 3 years, and girls who dieted severely were 18 times as likely to get ill as girls who did not diet. If you want to control your weight, exercise more. Do not eat so little that you are hungry.

**Benefit**. 36 studies taken together. The people with anorexia nervosa had been followed for 166642 person-years in all (the years each person was followed, added up). Their standardized mortality ratio was 5.86, that is, the chance of death is about 5.9 times that of people the same age. There were 5.1 deaths per 1000 person-years, which means 5.1 deaths if 1000 people are followed for 1 year. About 1/5 of the people who died died by suicide. The standardized mortality ratio for bulimia was 1.93, and for other eating disorders it was 1.92, about 1.9 times people the same age in each case. Another study, in 44 secondary schools in Victoria, Australia, followed students aged 14 to 15 for 3 years, and the same students were checked across 6 rounds. New eating disorders in girls were 21.8 per 1000 person-years, that is, 21.8 new cases if 1000 girls are followed for 1 year. Girls who dieted severely had 18 times the risk of girls who did not diet. Girls who dieted moderately had 5 times the risk. After a further adjustment for past dieting and psychiatric symptoms, taking out the effect of having dieted before and of already having psychiatric symptoms, BMI (body mass index, weight divided by height squared), amount of exercise, and sex no longer predicted a new eating disorder. The authors' conclusion was that "among adolescents, controlling weight with exercise rather than restricting food seems to carry a lower risk of an eating disorder."

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. "Severe dieting" here means keeping what you eat far below what the body needs for a long time. It does not mean skipping 1 meal or skipping a late-night snack. If making yourself vomit, guilt after a binge, or weighing yourself over and over and being unable to stop has already appeared, go to a psychiatry department or the clinical psychology department of a general hospital. This is an illness with a standard treatment. It is not a willpower problem. The link between BMI and mortality is in section 2, item 32. That item is about the long-term weight range, not about the method of losing weight.

## 2. Two things to check before getting injections, thread lifts, or surgery: does the facility's license list “medical aesthetics,” and is the practitioner a licensed attending physician?

**Cost**. There is no cost involved. Checking these two documents takes only a few minutes. The clinic should display its “Medical Institution Practice License” in the lobby. A doctor's qualifications can be verified via the health authority's online registry of licensed physicians.

**In plain terms**. A needle, a knife, or a medical device that breaks the skin or goes into the body counts as medical care. It can be done only where the license lists "medical aesthetics," and the person who does it must be a registered licensed physician. Beauty salons, studios, and hotel rooms are not allowed. A person with no physician's qualification who does it is practicing medicine illegally. If they seriously injure someone, the sentence is 3 to 10 years. If they cause death, the sentence is 10 years or more.

**Benefit**. Article 2 of the “Administrative Measures for Medical Aesthetic Services” defines medical aesthetics as “the use of surgery, drugs, medical devices, and other invasive or traumatic medical techniques to repair and reshape a person's appearance and body contours.” In simpler terms, any procedure that breaks the skin or introduces needles or devices into the body qualifies as medical treatment. Articles 8 and 24 stipulate that a facility must first obtain a “Medical Institution Practice License” and be approved for medical aesthetic services before conducting such procedures; if “medical aesthetics” is not listed on the license, the practice is prohibited. Article 11 requires attending physicians to hold valid licenses and be registered; those performing cosmetic surgery must have at least six years of relevant clinical experience, cosmetic dentistry five years, and cosmetic traditional Chinese medicine or dermatology three years each. Article 20 mandates that patients receive written explanations of indications, contraindications, risks, and precautions prior to consent. Article 336 of the Criminal Law criminalizes illegal medical practice — performing injections, surgery, or treatment without proper licensing. Penalties range from up to three years imprisonment for minor offenses to three to ten years for causing injury, and more than ten years for resulting in death.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Article 16 of the same regulations further specifies that medical aesthetic procedures may only be conducted at licensed medical aesthetic facilities or at hospitals/clinics with designated medical aesthetic departments. Therefore, performing injections at a patient's home or in a private studio already violates regulations. Article 20 also requires parental consent for minors undergoing such treatments. Routine beauty services such as facials, massages, or nail care fall outside this regulatory framework; however, any procedure involving needles or surgery remains classified as medical aesthetics.

## 3. For facial fillers, avoid the bridge of the nose, the area between the eyebrows, and the forehead, and do not go to an irregular injector just to save money

**Cost**. No money. You only inject a different site, or you do not have it done.

**In plain terms**. Of the people who went blind after a filler injection, more than half were injected in the nose, and next came the area between the eyebrows, the forehead, and the folds beside the mouth. More than 8 in 10 were given hyaluronic acid. Of the people who went blind, only 2 in 10 got their sight fully back, a bit more than 1 in 10 got part of it back, and nearly 2 in 10 also had damage to the brain. No rescue method works reliably right now, so avoid these sites beforehand.

**Benefit**. Cases reported in journals around the world, added up. From January (1) 2015 to September (9) 2018 there were 48 new cases of partial or complete loss of vision after a filler injection. The site with the most events was the nose, at 56.3%. Next were the area between the eyebrows at 27.1%, the forehead at 18.8%, and the nasolabial fold (the groove people call laugh lines) at 14.6%. In 81.3% of the cases the filler was hyaluronic acid. 43.8% had skin changes. 18.8% had a complication in the central nervous system (something went wrong in the brain). 10 cases (20.8%) got their vision fully back, 8 cases (16.7%) got part of it back, and the rest did

not recover. The authors' conclusion was that the ways different places handled it differed widely, and no treatment has been shown to keep working.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. These figures were counted case by case from cases reported in journals. They include only the people who had the event, not the total number of people injected. So you cannot calculate how likely 1 injection is to cause blindness. You can only see which sites have more events, and that afterward it basically cannot be reversed. The evidence is graded B for this reason too. What a regular institution does to lower the risk is already routine. First map how the blood vessels run under the place to be injected. Use a blunt needle rather than a sharp one. Push a small amount while withdrawing the needle. Have hyaluronidase (the enzyme that breaks down hyaluronic acid) ready beforehand. Each of these requires that the person doing it is a trained doctor. That is also the reason not to use an irregular channel. Before you do it, check it against item 2 of this section (check the facility license and the attending physician).

## 4. Do not buy weight-loss pills, weight-loss coffee, slimming candies, or enzyme plums (plums claimed to have been soaked in enzymes) that promise you will get thin fast

**Cost**. No money. You also save what you would have spent on these products. The hard part is accepting that there is no such thing as dropping several jin (a Chinese unit of weight, about half a kilogram) in 1 week.

**In plain terms**. These products are often found with a diet drug (sibutramine) added in secret. It used to be a weight-loss drug, and China stopped it in 2010. Overweight people aged 55 or older, who had heart disease or diabetes, took it for more than 3 years. Non-fatal heart attacks were about 30% higher, and strokes were about 36% higher. The weight lost was only 1.7 kg more. By the time a spot check finds it, you have already swallowed it.

**Benefit**. The SCOUT trial enrolled 9804 people. All were 55 or older, overweight or obese, and had cardiovascular disease or type 2 diabetes. They drew lots and were split into a group that took the drug and a group that did not. Treatment lasted 3.4 years on average. The main endpoint was a set of bad events chosen in advance: non-fatal heart attack, non-fatal stroke, coming back after cardiac arrest, and cardiovascular death. The rate of these events was 11.4% vs 10.0%. HR 1.16 (95% CI 1.03-1.31, P=0.02). The chance of an event was about 16% higher for the people who took the drug. The true value roughly sits between 3% higher and 31% higher. Non-fatal heart attack was 4.1% vs 3.2%, HR 1.28 (1.04-1.57), about 30% higher. Non-fatal stroke was 2.6% vs 1.9%, HR 1.36 (1.04-1.77), about 36% higher. Cardiovascular death and all-cause death did not increase. All-cause means every cause added together. After the draw, the sibutramine group lost 1.7 kg more on average. The former State Food and Drug Administration, on the basis of a safety assessment, held that "the risks of weight-loss treatment outweigh the benefits," and in October (10) 2010 it notified a stop to the production, sale, and use of sibutramine preparations and the raw drug. Both sibutramine and phenolphthalein (a laxative chemical) are prohibited as additives in food, and health food counts as food.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. SCOUT enrolled a high-risk group who already had heart disease or diabetes. This trial did not prove that healthy young people would have the same events. But because you cannot tell who is high-risk, the regulator simply took it off the market. Another ingredient often added in secret is phenolphthalein. It was originally a laxative. Taking too much of it for a long time can throw off the body's electrolytes and trigger an irregular heartbeat. How to tell: a real weight-loss drug is a prescription drug, and the approval number can be looked up at a pharmacy or a hospital. Something sold under the name of "coffee," "candy," "plums," or a "meal replacement," that also promises you will drop several jin in 1 week, should by definition have no drug effect. If it has a drug effect, something was added. The original text that stopped sibutramine is notice «国食药监办» [2010] No. 432, posted on the National Medical Products Administration website. What is cited here is a page on which the Tianjin market supervision administration retells it. The 2 sentences "risks outweigh the benefits" and "production, sale, and use stopped in October (10) 2010" can be checked word for word there.

## 5. Do not use anabolic steroids (“muscle-building injections” or “oral pills”) to build muscle

**Cost**. There is no cost involved; you even save money on medication. The hard part is accepting that muscle growth will be slow.

**In plain terms**. Men who test positive on a gym doping check have 3 times the risk of death of people the same age, and they go to the hospital more than twice as often each year. Acne, male breast growth, and trouble getting an erection each hit at least 1 in 10 of the people who use these drugs. In China these drugs are prescription drugs, and a channel that sells them to you without a prescription is itself breaking the law.

**Benefit**. The Danish researchers matched each steroid user with a control of the same age. The original cohort comprised 545 men whose androgenic steroid tests were positive between 2006-01-03 and 2018-03-01; they were paired with 5450 controls. An additional validation used 644 refusers and 6440 controls. Results showed a three-fold increase in mortality among users (HR = 3.0; 95 % CI 1.3–7.0). The true multiple sits roughly between 1.3 and 7. The median yearly number of hospital visits was 0.81 versus 0.36 ($P < 0.0001$). Median means that half of the users had more visits and half fewer; such a low P-value indicates this difference is highly unlikely to be random. Acne, gynecomastia, and erectile dysfunction each affected over 10 % of users – at least one in ten – a rate far above that of controls ($P < 0.0001$). The validation cohort yielded the same findings. Article 7 of China's Anti-Doping Regulations states that all substances on the prohibited list are strictly controlled; no entity may produce, sell, import, or export them illegally. The same regulation designates anabolic agents and peptide hormones as prescription drugs, meaning they may be obtained only with a doctor's prescription; “anabolic agents” is the official term used in legislation.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This is an observational study, not a randomized trial; steroid users may also engage in other risky behaviors, so the three-fold risk increase may not be attributable solely to the drugs. The true effect size likely falls between 1.3 and 7.0. However, visible side effects such as acne, gynecomastia, and erectile dysfunction are less prone to bias. Legally these products are termed “anabolic agents”; any product described with that phrase contains them. Ordinary protein powder or creatine does not fall under this category. A problem is that some products marketed as “muscle-building powders” or “nutritional supplements” may contain hidden steroids while claiming rapid results. The screening method is the same as for weight-loss products (see item 4: avoid any weight-loss drug promising quick results). Legitimate drugs are prescription-only and carry verifiable approval numbers; any product sold as a “muscle-building supplement” that promises results within weeks is probably adulterated.

## 6. If you take a weight-loss drug, or a weight-loss injection such as semaglutide, get the prescription at a hospital and raise the dose and come back for checks as the doctor arranges. Do not buy from an online shop that ships without a prescription, and do not get injected at a beauty salon

**Cost**. 1 registration visit, plus the trip there and back. Tens of yuan, and half a day. If you are getting the weight-loss injections, you also go back for checks at the times the doctor sets. The money for the drug is separate. After you stop the injections the weight mostly comes back, so count this money as long-term use.

**In plain terms**. A prescription drug has to be sold against a prescription. Selling it online also takes a real prescription and a real name. An online shop that ships without a consultation, or a beauty salon that comes to your home to inject, is usually supplying drugs of unclear origin, and nobody is responsible for the dose or for who should not have it. 1 year after the weight-loss injections stop, about 2/3 of the weight lost comes back, so count it as long-term treatment.

**Benefit**. The Measures for the Supervision and Administration of Drug Distribution and Use Quality say that a drug retailer must follow the system that sorts drugs into prescription drugs and non-prescription drugs. That system puts drugs in 2 kinds. One kind can be bought only with a doctor's prescription. The other can

be bought by the person. The pharmacy must sell prescription drugs against a prescription, as the rules require, and keep the prescription for at least 5 years. When the pharmacist or another pharmacy technician is not on duty, a sign must say so, and prescription drugs must not be sold without their review. Prescription drugs must not be sold from open shelves, for a customer to take down. Article 9 of the Measures for the Supervision and Administration of Online Drug Sales says that, when prescription drugs are sold to an individual online, the seller must make sure the prescription comes from a real and reliable source, and must use real-name rules. Article 10 requires a risk warning shown prominently under each drug's display page. Before the prescription has been reviewed, the package insert must not be shown, and no buying service may be offered. Before the prescription is reviewed, the page should not even give a button to buy. Article 8 says that drugs under special state control must not be sold online. These include vaccines, blood products, narcotic drugs, psychotropic drugs, toxic drugs for medical use, radioactive drugs, and drug-class precursor chemicals. The National Health Commission's Guidelines for the Diagnosis and Treatment of Obesity (2024 edition) state that 5 drugs have been approved by the National Medical Products Administration for weight loss in adult primary obesity. The 5 are orlistat, liraglutide, beinaglutide, semaglutide, and tirzepatide. The same guidelines count a BMI (body mass index) from 24 up to but not including 28 as overweight, and 28 and above as obese. A drug is considered when the person is overweight and also has a related disease, such as high blood sugar, hypertension (high blood pressure), abnormal blood lipids, or fatty liver, or is already obese. The premise is that changing how you live has not brought the weight down. The drug is added on top of that. The guidelines require a full assessment of the illness and the contraindications before the drug, and regular follow-up under a specialist physician while it is used. Semaglutide starts at 0.25 mg a week, with a maintenance dose of 2.4 mg or 1.7 mg. Tirzepatide starts at 2.5 mg a week, up to 15 mg. If the weight lost is under 5%, the guidelines suggest stopping the drug. What happens after stopping is in 3 trials. The STEP 1 extension followed 327 people. After 68 weeks on semaglutide they had lost 17.3% on average. 1 year after stopping, the weight had come back by 11.6 percentage points, and the net loss left was 5.6%. The authors' conclusion was that they had regained 2/3 of the weight previously lost, and that most cardiovascular and metabolic markers had also moved back near the start. STEP 4 took 803 people who had already injected for 20 weeks and lost 10.6% on average, and split them by drawing lots. Those who kept injecting lost another 7.9% over the next 48 weeks. Those switched to a placebo regained 6.9%. In SURMOUNT-4, 670 people first injected tirzepatide for 36 weeks and lost 20.9% on average. Those who kept injecting then lost another 5.5%. Those switched to a placebo regained 14.0%. In July (7) 2026 the Yinchuan market supervision administration issued a risk alert. It said that the internet-famous "weight-loss injections" and "slimming pens" on the market are mostly repackaged drugs of unknown source, smuggled drugs, or counterfeit drugs. Buying them online or through a purchasing agent and injecting them yourself can easily set off a severe allergy, acute pancreatitis, organ damage, and a wound infection. An injection of this cosmetic-medicine kind can be done only at an institution that has a medical-aesthetics qualification. An injection at the person's home, or a private injection at a beauty salon, is not compliant. See item 2 of this section (2 things to check before injections, thread lifts, or surgery).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The articles can be checked word for word, and the figures for weight coming back after stopping come from trials that split people by drawing lots. But nobody has quantified "how many fewer events you get if you use a prescription instead of buying it yourself," so it is graded B as hard to quantify. The STEP 1 extension stopped not only the drug. The guidance on diet and exercise stopped with it, and only some of the people in the original trial were followed. The steroids and sex hormones in items 5 and 7 of this section follow the same rules. When weight really has to come off with a drug, the doctor first looks at BMI, at whether there are other diseases, and at whether there is a reason the drug cannot be used, and only then decides whether to take it and which one. That judgment cannot be bought.

## 7. Use sex-hormone drugs only when a doctor prescribes them and checks you on a schedule. Do not buy them online, and do not raise the dose yourself

**Cost**. Regular registration visits, plus blood tests. A few hundred yuan a year, and a few half-days.

**In plain terms**. This does not discuss whether to use them. It only discusses how. Transgender women who use estrogen have clearly more blood clots in the vessels than people the same age, about 4 extra per 1000 people over 2 years, and about 17 extra over 8 years. This kind of risk has to be watched with regular follow-up. If you buy the drugs online and set the dose yourself, nobody is checking you.

**Benefit**. The researchers followed a group in the electronic records of Kaiser Permanente, a health-care group. There were 2842 transgender women and 2118 transgender men. Average follow-up was 4.0 years and 3.6 years. Each person was matched, on birth year, race, the clinic, and the time of joining, with about 10 times as many cisgender controls, 48686 cisgender men and 48775 cisgender women in all. Transgender women had more venous thromboembolism (a blood clot blocking a vessel) than the controls. Compared with cisgender men, at 2 years it was 4.1 cases per 1000 people (95% CI 1.6-6.7), and at 8 years it was 16.7 cases (6.4-27.5). Counted out, that is 4.1 extra cases among 1000 people over 2 years, and 16.7 extra over 8 years. Compared with cisgender women, the 2 figures were 3.4 (1.1-5.6) and 13.7 (4.1-22.7). Ischemic stroke (the kind of stroke in which a vessel is blocked) and myocardial infarction were, overall, close across the groups. Among transgender women who started hormone treatment only during the follow-up, the differences in venous thrombosis and ischemic stroke were clearer. The evidence on transgender men is not enough for a conclusion. The authors' conclusion was that "these results may suggest a need for long-term vigilance about the vascular side effects of estrogen in transgender hormone treatment."

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The researchers themselves wrote down the shortcoming of this study. They could not find out how many people had bought the drugs themselves outside the hospital system. So the line of whether a person was on the drug was never drawn cleanly. That, in turn, is why drug use should sit inside regular follow-up. This study only looked at whether the blood vessels had an event. It does not answer whether hormone treatment should be used, or what good it does. That is a different set of evidence. Every use of sex hormones is the same, including contraceptive pills, menopausal hormone treatment, and testosterone supplementation. If you buy it online yourself, adjust the dose from posts on the internet, and never check clots or liver and kidney markers, the risk sits in the stretch where nobody is watching, not in the reason for using the drug. The regular path in China is the endocrinology department, or the matching specialty, of a proper medical institution, for an assessment, a prescription, and follow-up.

## 8. If feeling that you look ugly has reached the point of checking the mirror over and over and thinking over and over about changing it, get a body-image assessment before you talk about surgery

**Cost**. Register for 1 visit at a psychiatry department or a clinical psychology department. Tens of yuan. The hard part is making this trip before you book the surgery.

**In plain terms**. About 15% of people seen in plastic surgery have body dysmorphic disorder, which means magnifying a flaw other people can barely see until it affects daily life. About 13% of people seen in dermatology have it. In both groups, more than 70% are women. Book 1 visit first, see whether this is your situation, and only then decide whether to have surgery.

**Benefit**. 33 studies were found by the rules and then combined. Among people seen in plastic surgery, the rate of body dysmorphic disorder (magnifying a flaw other people can barely see until it affects daily life) was 15.04%, and the studies ranged from 2.21% to 56.67%. In headcount, about 15 of every 100 people who go for plastic surgery meet it, and study by study the count runs from 2 to 57. Their mean age was 34.54±12.41 years. The second figure is how far the ages spread up and down. 74.38% were women. Among people seen in dermatology the rate was 12.65%, and the studies ranged from 4.52% to 35.16%. Mean age was 27.79±9.03 years, and 76.09% were women. The authors suggest that plastic surgeons and dermatologists assess on their own initiative, pick out the high-risk people, and have several departments manage them together. Another study asked 200 patients with body dysmorphic disorder. 71.0% had sought non-psychiatric treatment such as dermatology or plastic surgery, and 64.0% had received it. The authors' conclusion was that this kind of treatment "rarely improves" body dysmorphic disorder, and looks ineffective for it.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The proportions measured in the studies run from 2.21% all the way to 56.67%. The gap is very wide. The reason is that the questionnaires and the groups of people surveyed were not the same. So all you can read from it is that the proportion is not low, and that it is worth screening once first. You cannot treat 15.04% as an exact figure. The grade is B for this reason too. At this proportion, most people who go to plastic surgery do not have body dysmorphic disorder. This item is aimed at the small group in whom it is repeated, ongoing, and already affecting work and social life. Surgery and skin treatment rarely make them better. Clues listed by the British NHS include spending a lot of time comparing your looks with other people, checking the mirror all the time or avoiding mirrors entirely, going to great lengths to cover a body part, and picking at the skin to make it "smooth." It affects work, social life, and relationships.

## 9. To straighten teeth, have a doctor with orthodontic qualifications examine you in person, and go back on schedule. Do not buy aligners online and wear them at home

**Cost**. It costs more than buying online, for the registration and the return visits, and every so often you have to go to the clinic. The hard part is that the course often lasts 1 or 2 years, and you have to keep the return visits.

**In plain terms**. Clear aligners are a Class II (2) medical device in China. The instructions require that you wear them under the guidance of a doctor with orthodontic qualifications, and that you go back regularly. The US drug regulator says it has not approved aligners sold straight to a person without a dentist's prescription. With nobody examining you in person, the bite can go crooked, teeth can move to the wrong place, there can be pain, and teeth can even fall out.

**Benefit**. The 2022 Guiding Principles for the Registration Review of Bracketless Aligners, from the Center for Medical Device Evaluation of the National Medical Products Administration, say that this kind of aligner has a "management category of Class II (2)." They require the instructions to state that "during treatment it must be worn under the guidance of a physician qualified in orthodontics," and also to state "the requirements for eating, brushing, and regular return visits." On the product name, they say it is "not recommended to contain empty, hypothetical conceptual names such as 'invisible'." The US Food and Drug Administration (FDA) says: "The FDA has not authorized clear aligners that are sold directly to consumers without a prescription and supervision by a dentist or orthodontist," meaning it has not approved a single clear aligner sold directly to a person without a dentist's prescription and supervision. The FDA also says: "In-person examination by a dentist or orthodontist can help lower the risks of uneven bite, unintended tooth movement, pain, and tooth loss," that is, an examination in person by a dentist or an orthodontist can lower the risk of an uneven bite, teeth moving where they should not, pain, and losing a tooth. After you start wearing them, only regular return visits in person can confirm that the teeth are moving safely as planned. Both of these are regulatory documents. Neither gives the proportion of people who come to harm.

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. The benefit magnitude is set at small, because no proportion of harm was found, so the judgment can only rest on the consequences. No risk alert from China's drug regulator or health departments, aimed at buying aligners online and wearing them at home, was found, so this item relies mainly on the registration requirements and on what the FDA says. Orthodontics is a medical act. For tooth straightening done as cosmetic medicine, the institution's license has to list the matching subject, and the doctor who does it has to be qualified. How to check is in item 2 of this section (the institution's license, and the attending physician). In 2023, 4 departments including the National Health Commission issued a notice on dental care. Where there is no practice license or clinic filing certificate, or non-health technicians are hired to treat teeth, the notice requires that they "be severely punished according to the law and the rules." Orthodontics is not reimbursed by yibao (医保 — basic medical insurance). See section 24, item 12 (ask the package price before you get a tooth implant).

## 10. Before you buy a spot-fading whitening cream, take the «国妆特字» number on the package and check it on the National Medical Products Administration website. Do not use a spot-fading cream sold by a WeChat reseller, or one the beauty salon mixed itself

**Cost**. No money. Checking a number takes a few minutes. The hard part is not buying the ones that acquaintances and WeChat resellers (微商 — people selling through private chats) push the hardest.

**In plain terms**. A spot-fading whitening cream has to be registered with the National Medical Products Administration and get a «国妆特字» number before it can be sold. Spot checks have found spot-fading creams with mercury thousands of times over the limit. The package printed a «国妆特字» number, but the factory named on it had not made that batch. Mercury taken into the body from the face can harm the kidneys. Stopping the cream, plus treatment, gets most people better, but the treatment takes several months to 2 years.

**Benefit**. Article 16 of the Regulations on the Supervision and Administration of Cosmetics lists spot-fading and whitening cosmetics as special cosmetics. Article 17 says that special cosmetics may be produced or imported only after registration with the drug supervision department of the State Council. Article 36 requires the label to carry the special-cosmetics registration certificate number. Article 20 requires the registration information to be made public, so the number can be looked up on the National Medical Products Administration website. Article 62 of the Measures for the Administration of Cosmetic Registration and Filing says that a domestic number is «国妆特字» plus the year and a serial number, and an imported number is «国妆特进字». National Medical Products Administration Announcement No. 14 of 2026 published 2 batches of spot-fading cream, in which mercury was found at 4938 mg/kg (milligrams per kilogram) and 9281 mg/kg. The limit listed in the annex to the announcement is not more than 1 mg/kg. These 2 batches were thousands of times over that limit. They were bought at 2 small cosmetics shops, in Sichuan and in Anhui. The package printed a «国妆特字» number. The factory named on it objected. After review, the Guangdong medical products administration found that this enterprise had not produced that batch. A review brought together 30 cases reported in journals, all of them nephrotic syndrome after using a mercury-containing whitening cream, which means a large amount of protein leaking into the urine. All 30 were Asian women, mostly aged 18 to 52. From starting use to falling ill was 1 to 60 months, and half were within 5 months. Most kidney biopsies were minimal change disease (67%) or membranous nephropathy (23%). These are 2 diseases of the glomeruli, the kidney's filters. Very few got better on their own within a month and a half after stopping. In the cases with a record, those who used a mercury-removing drug took 1 to 9 months for the urine protein to turn negative, with a median of 2 months. All 3 who did not use a mercury-removing drug took more than 12 months. A hospital in Beijing admitted 288 people with mercury poisoning from 2014 to 2019. 84 of them (29.27%) were related to cosmetics. The main source of poisoning among women was cosmetics. Of the 18 patients with nephrotic syndrome who were followed, 15 had urine protein and albumin back to normal after an average of 22.67 months. The mercury in these 18 people did not all come from cosmetics.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Those 2 batches show that a number can be misused too. When you check the number, see whether the product name, the factory, and the package match what comes up. It is better to buy from the brand's official shop or a regular store. Article 42 of the regulations says that a beauty salon using cosmetics on a customer must follow the rules for a cosmetic operator. Item 5 of Article 60 prohibits an operator from compounding cosmetics on their own. A "salon-line spot-fading cream" that the salon mixes itself is illegal. If you have already used a spot-fading cream of unknown origin for a long time, stop, take the product to a hospital, and check urine mercury and urine protein. In that review, 6 people had normal blood mercury, and all 24 whose urine mercury was checked were above the normal upper limit. The cases were reported case by case, so you cannot calculate what share of people who use a mercury cream will harm their kidneys, and the grade is B for that reason. The benefit magnitude is set at medium from the consequences: nephrotic syndrome can mostly be treated, but treatment takes several months to 2 years.

# 29. After a major blow

Losing a relative, being told of a serious illness, losing a job, or a divorce. In the research these events share a finding: what goes wrong is not only the mood, but the body. The stretch of highest risk sits in the first weeks through the first year. This section does not explain how to "get over it." It only says which things someone has to watch during this stretch, which decisions have to be put off, and when to go and register at a clinic. Most items are scored on the chance of death. The items that talk about spending and about benefits are scored on money. They are: do not start by paying for grief counseling (item 9), call 12356 and register at a mental-health clinic (item 11), push irreversible big decisions back (item 12), and do not treat death as a way to pay a debt (item 13). These kinds of figures are not converted into each other. If there is no relative and no friend to turn to, how "find someone to watch" actually gets done is in item 6. If you yourself went through a traffic crash, an assault, or a disaster and the nightmares and flashbacks are still there, see item 14 (trauma-focused psychological treatment).

The paperwork at the time a relative dies, the body, and the money to collect are in section 25. Guardianship and a will for an elder while alive are in section 17. What you can receive after losing a job is in section 7. Exercise and daylight when mood is low are in section 3 and section 22. If suicidal thoughts appear, call 12356 first; see section 1, item 25. The time scale of the thoughts is in section 1, item 32. Lasting harm after a person is brought back is in section 1, item 33. This section does not repeat any of that.

## 1. In the first days after a relative dies, do not stay alone; if you have heart disease, hypertension, or diabetes, keep taking the medicine; if the chest feels pressed and hurts, call 120

**Cost**. No money. Do not stay alone these days, and keep taking the medicine.

**In plain terms**. On the day after a relative dies, the chance of a heart attack is 21.1 times the usual chance, and each day after that it is lower. Among people aged 60 to 89, the share who have a heart attack or a stroke within 30 days after a spouse dies is about double, and it falls back after a month. If you already have cardiovascular disease, do not stop the medicine these days. If the chest feels pressed and hurts, you cannot catch your breath, or an arm or a leg on a single side has no strength, call 120 at once.

**Benefit**. 1985 patients with an acute heart attack, comparing different stretches of time in the same person, before and after the attack. Of them, 270 (13.6%) had lost an important person in the 6 months before the attack, and 19 had lost that person within 1 day before the heart attack. Within 24 hours after an important person died, the rate of acute heart attack was 21.1 times higher (95% CI 13.1–34.1, and the true multiple sits roughly between 13 and 34). After that it fell day by day. In actual counts: among people with a decade-long heart-attack risk of 5%, each 1394 people who had just lost a relative produced 1 extra case. Among people with a risk of 20%, each 320 people produced 1 extra case. Another study in Britain compared 30447 widowed people aged 60 to 89 with 83588 controls in similar circumstances. Within 30 days after the death of the spouse, a heart attack or a stroke occurred in 50 people on the widowed side (0.16%) and in 67 people on the control side (0.08%). The IRR was 2.20 (1.52–3.15), that is, the chance of the event was about 2.2 times the control group. Of that, heart attack was 2.14 (1.20–3.81), about 2.1 times. Stroke was 2.40 (1.22–4.71), about 2.4 times. After 30 days it weakened. Within 90 days they also looked at further illnesses. The first was acute coronary syndrome that was not a heart attack (an acute problem with the blood supply to the heart that still falls short of a heart attack), IRR 2.20 (1.12–4.29). The other was pulmonary embolism (a clot blocking a blood vessel in the lung), IRR 2.37 (1.18–4.75). The British National Health Service (NHS) lists the signs for which you should call the emergency number at once. A heart attack is pain in the chest as if it were being pressed or squeezed. The pain can spread to the arm, the neck, or the jaw, and there is also shortness of breath. A stroke is a side of the face drooping, an arm or a side of the body weak or numb, and slurred speech.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Hand the medicine box to someone else to manage. Do not rely on remembering it yourself. Do not take a long trip these days. Do not get through it on alcohol. The account of alcohol is in section 2. How to recognize a heart attack or a stroke, and how to call for a car, is in section 13. Both studies looked back

through population records. They cannot separate out how many of these people were going to fall ill anyway. Both point the same way, and both point at the same stretch of time. If there is nobody you can hand the medicine box to, and these days you are bound to be alone in the room, see item 6 of this section.

## 2. On the week you receive a cancer diagnosis, don't go alone to pick up the results — postpone non-treatment decisions

**Cost**. No cost at all. Simply arrange for someone to accompany you when you collect the results, and put any major decisions unrelated to treatment off for a few days.

**In plain terms**. In the first week after receiving a cancer diagnosis, the risk of suicide is roughly 12.6 times higher than among people without a diagnosis, while the risk of dying from cardiovascular disease is about 5.6 times higher. By the end of the first year this drops to roughly 3.1 times; the effect is especially pronounced for harder-to-treat cancers. The greatest risk exists during those first few days, after which it falls quickly. Therefore, bring a companion when picking up the results and avoid being alone at home. Decisions such as quitting your job or selling your house can wait until your next appointment.

**Benefit**. Data from Sweden's national registers tracked over 6.07 million people (6,073,240 individuals) from 1991 to 2006. Compared with cancer-free controls, the relative risk of suicide in the first week after diagnosis was 12.6 (95% CI 8.6–17.8), meaning roughly 12.6 times higher. The true value lies somewhere between 8.6 and 17.8. The incidence rate during that week was 2.50 per 1,000 person-years — about 2.5 cases per 1,000 people each year. By the end of the first year this fell to 3.1 (2.7–3.5; 0.60 per 1,000 person-years), or roughly 3.1 times higher. Cardiovascular mortality in the first week was 5.6 times higher (5.2–5.9; 116.80 per 1,000 person-years), and over the first four weeks it remained at 3.3 times higher (3.1–3.4; 65.81 per 1,000 person-years). This elevated risk declines rapidly within the first year; the effect is more pronounced for cancers with poorer prognoses. Comparisons of the same patients over time yielded consistent results.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These figures apply specifically to cancer patients. No comparable data exist for other serious diagnoses. The actual number of people affected remains low: a total of 6,073,240 individuals were included in the study, and the first-week suicide rate is 2.50 per 1,000 person-years, i.e., only 2.5 cases per 1,000 people each year. This information is provided not to frighten, but to emphasize the importance of having someone present during those initial days. Long-term management, insurance coverage, and follow-up care are discussed in Sections 16 and 24. For those unable to find a companion, see point 6 in this section, which suggests enlisting neighbours or community contacts instead.

## 3. After losing a job, it's important to set a regular sleep schedule, keep yibao (basic medical insurance) active, and plan job searches methodically — don't just stay at home all day

**Cost**. There's no expense involved. First, register as unemployed and apply for unemployment benefits; then schedule job searches at set times. The real challenge is waking up on time when no one is there to push you.

**In plain terms**. People who have lost a job later die at a rate about 60% higher than people still in work. The gap is clearer for men, and for people who are not old, and it is highest in the first 10 years. Once smoking and drinking are taken out, the rise is about a quarter smaller, and that part is in your own hands. Register as unemployed first, and claim the unemployment insurance benefit.

**Benefit**. Data from 42 studies involving over 20 million participants and 235 mortality risk estimates show that, after adjusting for age and other factors, unemployed individuals face an average HR of 1.63 for all causes of death — meaning their risk is about 63% higher than that of employed people. This effect is more pronounced in men and in people early or midway through their careers; it diminishes after the first ten years. When lifestyle factors like smoking and drinking are included in the analysis, the average HR drops by 24%, reflecting a similar reduction in overall risk.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These findings come from observational studies, so a direct cause-and-effect relationship cannot be proven; it's also possible that poorer health contributes to unemployment. Nevertheless, the 24% reduction in risk after adjusting for health behaviors offers a useful direction for intervention. Details on eligibility for unemployment benefits, how to apply, and how to maintain social insurance coverage are provided in Section 7. Information on severance pay and why you should avoid voluntarily resigning can be found in Section 19.

## 4. If a relative died by suicide, accident, or homicide, do not try to tough it out; go and ask for professional help

**Cost**. Calling 12356 costs nothing. If you need to see a doctor, a psychology clinic is the price of an ordinary outpatient visit. The hard part is opening your mouth and asking.

**In plain terms**. People whose spouse died by suicide have a higher chance of being diagnosed with a mental disorder within 5 years than other people do: about 80% higher for men, about 70% higher for women. Compared with people whose spouse died of another cause, the chance is also 70% higher up to twice as high. People bereaved this way are more likely to feel kept at a distance, and to feel shame. That is the reason to go and ask, rather than waiting to feel better on your own.

**Benefit**. A national registry in Denmark followed 6700000 adults, from 1980 to 2014, more than 136000000 person-years in all (the years each person was followed, added up). For people widowed because a spouse died by suicide, the risk of a newly diagnosed mental disorder within 5 years, compared with other people, was an IRR of 1.8 for men (95% CI 1.6–2.0), that is, about 80% higher. For women it was 1.7 (1.6–1.8), that is, about 70% higher. Compared with people widowed by other causes of death, the IRR was 1.7 for men (1.5–1.9) and 2.0 for women (1.9–2.2), that is, 70% higher up to double. In this group, suicidal behavior, mortality, and the share who needed municipal assistance were also higher. Physical illnesses such as cirrhosis and sleep disorders were higher as well. Another 57 studies were summarized separately, without pooling the arithmetic. Bereavement by suicide is linked to the following. A partner's risk of suicide is higher. After a child dies by suicide, the parents' risk of admission to a psychiatric ward is higher. After an adult child dies by suicide, the mother's risk of suicide is higher. After a parent dies by suicide, the child's risk of depression is higher. Compared with people bereaved by other violent deaths, people bereaved by suicide more often say they are kept at a distance and feel shame.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A sudden, violent death means an accident, a homicide, or a disaster. After this kind of death, the share with post-traumatic stress disorder, depression, and grief that stays stuck is higher than after a death from illness. Recovery is also slower. If a month has passed and you are still having nightmares, flashbacks, or avoiding what you dare not touch, see item 14 of this section (trauma-focused psychological treatment). What to do when you yourself have suicidal thoughts is in section 1, item 25.

## 5. In the first half year after losing a spouse, hand meals, sleep, chronic-disease medicine, and follow-up visits to a fixed person

**Cost**. No money. Find a specific person, a child, a sibling, or a friend, and have them come by or call on a regular schedule. The hard part is opening your mouth and handing this over.

**In plain terms**. In the first half year after losing a spouse, the chance of dying in that same stretch is about 40% higher than for people who did not lose a spouse. After half a year it falls to about 15% higher. For men it is about 23% higher. For women the gap is small enough that it may only be a coincidence. What to do is put the medicine, the meals, and the follow-up visits on a specific person. Do not count on remembering them yourself.

**Benefit**. 15 studies that registered people first and then followed them, 2263888 people taken together. When the spouse had been dead for less than 6 months, the mortality RR was 1.41 (95% CI 1.26–1.57), that is, the chance of dying in that same stretch was about 40% higher than for people who had not lost a spouse. After 6 months it was 1.14 (1.10–1.18), down to about 15% higher. For men the RR was 1.23 (1.18–1.28), about 23% higher. For women it was 1.04 (1.00–1.08, not statistically significant, that is, this small gap may only be a

coincidence). Under 65 and 65 or older showed no clear difference. Another analysis pooled 123 papers, 1377 risk estimates, and over 500000000 people. After the differences in circumstances were leveled, the HR was 1.23 (1.19–1.28), that is, about 23% higher overall. Men were still higher than women. Men 1.27 (1.19–1.35), 27% higher. Women 1.15 (1.08–1.22), 15% higher.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These studies looked back through population records. Other factors come in and cannot be removed. A couple's way of living and their illnesses were already similar. "The first half year is much higher than what follows" is what the first pooled analysis got by splitting on time since the death. The second did not split on time since the death. It only split on how long the study followed people. Studies that followed only 6 months, taken together, had an HR of 1.58 (1.32–1.88). Studies that followed 16 to 20 years had 1.22 (1.02–1.47). The authors take this to mean the risk is highest in the first years after the death, and they also state that most studies were not starting the follow-up in the moment just after the death. Both point the same way, so the first half year is worth treating as a window of watching. Men have a higher risk, and they are also less likely to open their mouths and ask. If there is a widowed elder in the family, sort out accounts, guardianship, and the will together, as in section 17. If no such person can be found (living alone, a child already lost, or the children gone as well), hand this to the community and the phone; see item 6 of this section.

## 6. With no relatives and no friends, replace the person watching you with a neighbor who can enter the home, a place on the community visit list, and an emergency contact in the phone

**Cost**. No money. The hard part is opening your mouth first, and saying to a neighbor and to the residents' committee (居委会), "I live alone, and something has just happened at home."

**In plain terms**. When there is no relative and no friend, what has to be covered is this: if something happens, someone finds you, and on ordinary days you take medicine and eat on time. Medicine and meals are on you. Write them as a list, and set an alarm. Do not rely on memory. Someone finding you rests on a neighbor being left a spare key, on asking the residents' committee whether you can be put on the visit-and-care list, and on the phone having an emergency contact set, and not being switched off.

**Benefit**. 44573 outpatients, each with a risk or a history of atherothrombosis (plaque in the vessels, the kind of trouble that a clot can block). Doctors in many countries registered them into the international project REACH and followed them. They were enrolled from December (12) 2003 to December (12) 2004, and followed for 4 years. Of them, 8594 (19%) lived alone. Over those 4 years, death from all causes together was 14.1% for people living alone and 11.1% for people living with others. Cardiovascular death was 8.6% against 6.8%. Both log-rank P<0.01, so the difference is unlikely to be chance. The gap was not the same at every age (interaction P=0.03). From 45 to 65, death for living alone against living with others was 7.7% against 5.7%. After other circumstances were leveled, the HR was 1.24 (95% CI 1.01–1.51), that is, about 24% higher. From 66 to 80 it was 13.2% against 12.3%, HR 1.12 (1.01–1.26), about 10% higher. Over 80 it was 24.6% against 28.4%, HR 0.92 (0.79–1.06), and no rise was seen. A 2022 opinion of the Ministry of Civil Affairs (民政) and the other departments with it says visit-and-care services are to be carried out. The people covered are elders who live alone, elders in an empty nest, elders left behind, elders who have lost the ability to care for themselves, elders with a severe disability, and elders in a special family-planning household. The service is "regular visits into the home, telephone or video, and remote monitoring." The township (or subdistrict) does the survey, and the villagers' committee or the residents' committee assists. They keep basic information and "willingness to receive visit-and-care services," and bring the person into grassroots grid management (a named person watches each patch). By the end of 2025, "make sure the monthly visit rate for elders in special difficulty reaches 100%," and "for elders in special difficulty who have lost the ability to care for themselves, visit-and-care is no less than once a month." The document also encourages the household to set up a smart call system, a smart electricity meter and water meter, health-monitoring products, and an elder-care monitoring device, so that "once monitoring is abnormal, a warning can be given in time, and a prompt is

sent to the emergency contact at the same moment." If service staff find an urgent problem, they "shall help call the emergency number right away."

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. How to do the practical parts. First, give a spare key, or the temporary code for the door lock, to a neighbor or to the property manager, and tell them "I am alone these days." No friendship is required. Someone only needs to know you are in the room. Second, go to the community residents' committee, say you live alone, and ask whether you can be put on the visit-and-care list. Among elders, living alone, an empty nest, and having lost a child are service targets the official text names. Also ask whether the locality has a smart caller or a smart water meter that is installed free of charge. Third, set an emergency contact and a medical emergency card on the phone, and do not silence it or switch it off these days. The grade is B for a pair of reasons. The link between living alone and mortality comes from studies that looked back through population records. They cannot remove the reverse reading that people who were already in worse health, and in worse circumstances, are more likely to live alone. The original paper itself says this result still awaits confirmation. The visit-and-care document covers elders only. Under 60 there is no matching special system. What can be counted on is a line in another document. It requires grid workers and social workers to "find in time the psychological-crisis risks of a family blow, job loss, dropping out of school, and the like" (see item 11 of this section: if you need someone to talk with you, call 12356). Why "someone in the room" is worth something: see section 13, item 1 (pressing on the chest). Of cardiac arrests that happen outside a hospital, 79.2% happen at home. When someone nearby does compressions, 16.1% leave the hospital alive. When nobody does, only 3.9% do. Nobody in the room means you fall in the lower band. Further things are already at hand. The funeral itself means trips to the funeral home, the community health service, the public security bureau, and the housing provident fund (公积金), several windows (see section 25). Set those trips up as a fixed schedule of going out once a day, and the outings for these days are already there. The hotline can be called again and again. It is not limited to a single call (see item 11 of this section: if you need someone to talk with you, call 12356). "Living alone" is also a long-run risk factor. The mortality ratio for living alone is 1.32, about 30% higher; see section 22, item 9 (treat meeting people on a regular schedule as a health expense). This item only covers these days in front of you. The long-run account is counted separately.

## 7. After a parent dies, tell the child the truth, and let the child attend the farewell

**Cost**. No money. The hard part is that you are hurting too, and you still have to say it clearly to the child.

**In plain terms**. A child who loses a father or a mother before 18 later dies at a rate about 50% higher than a child who did not go through that. If the parent died by accident or by suicide, it is about 80% higher. If the parent died of illness, it is about 30% higher. The American Academy of Pediatrics recommends telling the child what happened, truthfully, and supporting the child in attending the funeral and the farewell.

**Benefit**. Everyone born in Denmark from 1968 to 2008, and everyone born in Sweden from 1973 to 2006, was counted in. Added to that was 89.3% of people born in Finland from 1987 to 2007. Together, over 7300000 people. Of them, 189094 lost a parent before 18. Mortality from all causes together in these children was 50% higher than in people who had not been bereaved (mortality ratio 1.50, 95% CI 1.43–1.58, that is, about 1.5 times). When the parent died of an unnatural cause such as an accident or suicide, it was 1.84 (1.71–2.00), about 80% higher. When the parent died of a natural cause such as illness, it was 1.33 (1.24–1.41), about 30% higher. It was highest when the child's cause of death and the parent's cause of death were the same class. A 2016 clinical report from the American Academy of Pediatrics, written for pediatricians, requires that a talk with a bereaved child state clearly what happened and what it means, and correct wrong information and misunderstandings the child has heard. The report also gives advice on how to support the child in attending the funeral and other farewell rites.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. When you tell the child, do not invent "they went away on a long trip." Guardianship and the arrangement for raising the child have to be put on paper. Whether to change schools, or to send the child to live somewhere else, has no direct study or guideline text that was found. The author's view is that fewer

changes in the child's life are better. The grade is B not because the numbers are soft. This is a follow-up of the whole population of Denmark, Sweden, and Finland, and the numbers themselves would be enough for grade A. The grade is B because, from this number to the specific practice of how to tell the child and whether the child should attend the farewell, there is no direct trial evidence. The authors also state that data on the parent-child relationship after the death, and on the child's way of living, are both missing. The rise includes a part that is inborn constitution, and a part that is the long effect left by the bereavement. Naming a guardian and arranging property are in section 17. The child's support and schooling are in section 18.

## 8. Still stuck in grief after half a year, unable to move on — when to see a psychiatrist or clinical psychologist

**Cost**. This includes registration fees and treatment costs. Treatment is delivered in sessions; on average, 16 sessions are given over 19 weeks in clinical trials. The main challenge is simply mustering the courage to make that first appointment.

**In plain terms**. About 1 in 10 bereaved adults gets stuck. After more than half a year they still miss the person so much that they cannot eat, cannot go to work, and cannot look after a child. They feel numb, and life seems to have no point. This is not a lack of strength. It has diagnostic criteria, and it has a treatment made for it. Targeted treatment works in 51% of cases, ordinary psychotherapy in 28%, and the targeted treatment also starts to work sooner.

**Benefit**. Fourteen studies involving adults whose loved ones died of non-violent causes and who had not previously sought mental-health care reveal that prolonged grief disorder affects 9.8% of this group (95% CI 6.8–14.0), meaning about 10 out of every 100 bereaved adults are impacted. The rate rises with age. Another study tested the diagnostic criteria on 291 bereaved individuals through interviews at 0–6, 6–12, and 12–24 months after loss. The core symptom is intense longing for the deceased; at least five of nine additional criteria must also be present. The first five criteria are emotional numbness, shock, feeling life lacks meaning, distrust of others, and distress caused by the loss. The remaining four are difficulty accepting the loss, trouble defining one's own identity, avoidance of reality, and an inability to carry on daily life. All these symptoms must appear daily or be severe enough to impair functioning, and they must persist for at least six months after the death. A randomized trial of 95 participants receiving 16 therapy sessions over 19 weeks found a 51% success rate for specialized treatment versus 28% for standard interpersonal psychotherapy (P = 0.02, a statistically significant difference). Consequently, only 4.3 patients need to be treated for one additional person to experience improvement.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Don't fixate on exact time limits. The real indicator is whether grief interferes with eating, sleeping, work, or childcare — if so, it's time to seek help. The appropriate clinics are psychiatry, psychology, or clinical psychology departments, all of which are available at public psychiatric hospitals. This condition is known as prolonged grief disorder or complex grief in various sources; required duration varies from six to twelve months across different guidelines. The 9.8% prevalence figure stems from 14 studies with differing methodologies, so authors caution that it may not apply universally to all populations.

## 9. Do not start by paying for grief counseling; first see whether your grief is really stuck (the signs in item 8)

**Cost**. No money. The other way around, you save a counseling fee.

**In plain terms**. Arranging psychological counseling for every bereaved person brings a small benefit, and after a while it can no longer be seen, because most people would have eased on their own. For people who already clearly cannot adapt, treatment works as well as treatment for other psychological problems. So check item 8 first (grief that is stuck, go to psychiatry). Spend this money only if it matches.

**Benefit**. 61 controlled studies taken together. Giving psychological intervention to bereaved people in general shows a very small benefit just when treatment ends, and looking again after an interval shows no benefit left. Interventions that enroll only bereaved people who "already clearly cannot adapt" work as well

as psychological treatment for other psychological problems. Studies that do no screening beforehand come out poorly, because the group that got no intervention would also have eased on its own over time. Another 14 trials that assigned people by lot, taken together: treatment for people who already had a problem was clearly better than the control both after treatment and at later visits, and after an interval the effect was still growing. Preventive intervention given in general to people who did not yet have a problem did not work. Another study followed 205 people from before the spouse died through 6 and 18 months after. That study separated 5 paths. They were ordinary grief, prolonged grief, prolonged depression, getting better during the bereavement, and resilience (able to hold up). Resilience was the most common. Ordinary grief was relatively uncommon.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. What this says is "not everyone has to do it," not "nobody should do it." The high-risk bereavement in item 4 (a relative died by suicide, accident, or homicide) is exactly the kind the evidence supports doing. So is the kind in item 8 (grief that is stuck, go to psychiatry), the people who are already stuck. A Lancet review reaches the same conclusion: grief is not an illness, and most people do not need a professional intervention. The effort should go to people at high risk. It should also go to people who have already developed complicated grief, depression after the bereavement, and a stress disorder.

## 10. After a separation or a divorce, do not drop yibao (医保 — basic medical insurance), and do not get through it on alcohol

**Cost**. No money. Keep yibao going, and stop the alcohol. The hard part is that this stretch makes it easy to get through the days on alcohol.

**In plain terms**. People who are separated or divorced have a clearly higher chance of dying early than people who are still married. The rise is larger for men, and for people who are younger. This is not necessarily caused by the divorce. People who divorce may already have been different in health and in income. What you can hold yourself is this: do not let yibao lapse, and do not get through it on tobacco and alcohol.

**Benefit**. 32 studies that registered people first and then followed them, taken together, covering over 6500000 people, 160000 deaths, over 755000 divorces, and 11 countries. Compared with people who were still married, separated or divorced adults had a clearly higher risk of dying early. For men, and for people who were younger, the rise was clearer than for women and for older people. The authors discuss possible paths. The first is social selection: people whose health or circumstances were already different are more likely to reach a divorce. The second is resources cut off: income and coverage stop. The third is a change in health behavior: tobacco, alcohol, and the daily schedule get worse. The fourth is chronic psychological stress (tight for a long time).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The original text only says "clearly higher" and gives the group comparisons. It does not give a multiple that can be quoted, so no specific figure is written here. The size of the benefit is set at medium, on the rule "the direction is known, and there is no drop large enough to fit a threshold." Property, debts, and betrothal gifts at divorce are in section 8 and section 10. The arrangement for raising a child is in section 10, item 23 (the divorce agreement writes the child support and the visits clearly).

## 11. Call 12356 for general support, 12355 for minors and teens; for medical care, book a psychology clinic appointment

**Cost**. No cost involved. Both hotlines are free to call. Psychology clinic visits are billed at standard outpatient rates.

**In plain terms**. If you need someone to talk to, dial 12356 — this is the national mental health helpline, and it's completely free. Minors and teenagers can call 12355, the dedicated youth support service. If you need professional medical care, you can book an appointment at a psychiatry, psychology, or clinical psychology

clinic. Community grid workers and social workers are also expected to proactively identify people facing family issues, job loss, or school dropout.

**Benefit**. A 2026 plan jointly issued by 25 government departments including the National Health Commission calls for improving operational rules for the 12356 mental health helpline. Goals include ensuring stable service delivery, raising call connection rates, developing a provincial-level digital platform for 12356, and strengthening coordination between 12356 and other emergency hotlines such as 110. The plan also aims to expand and optimize the 12355 youth support service, integrating it with 12356. By 2030, three key targets must be met: over 80% of administrative villages and urban communities must have mental health counseling rooms or social service centers offering relevant services; every county-level area must have at least one public psychiatric hospital or medical facility providing psychology clinic services; and all provinces must have their own provincial 12356 platforms. The mental health crisis response and support workforce includes psychiatrists, psychotherapists, counselors, social workers, and volunteers. The plan also specifies three groups who must stay alert to early warning signs of mental health risks: community grid workers, social workers, and volunteers. They are tasked with promptly identifying situations such as family crises, job loss, or school dropout. (Source: National policy document issued March 2026)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because the establishment of counseling rooms in villages and communities and psychology clinics at county level are only planned targets for 2030, not yet universally available nationwide. Both 12356 and 12355 are already operational. Details on the launch date and daily operating hours of 12356 can be found in Section 1, Article 25. It is also important to note that psychological counseling and psychotherapy are distinct services: only licensed psychiatrists can make diagnoses and prescribe medication, and psychotherapy must be delivered at qualified medical institutions. Private, hourly-fee “healing” or “spiritual counseling” services fall outside this official framework.

## 12. In the first months after a blow, push back every big decision that cannot be undone

**Cost**. No money. You only push the decision back, and you may miss some opportunities because of that. The hard part is that at the time it feels as if the opportunity will not wait.

**In plain terms**. In this stretch your judgment of every "opportunity" is at its worst. In an experiment, sad people were willing to take a bit over 10% less money, and up to a bit over 30% less, so they would not have to wait 3 months. Anything larger than a month of income, or anything that would cost a lot to undo, gets pushed back for 3 months. Tell it first to a person who has no stake in the matter. Do not decide the same day.

**Benefit**. Avoid making a property disposal you cannot undo, in the stretch just after the blow, when judgment is at its worst. This kind of thing includes selling a home, quitting a job, putting a pension or a compensation payment out as a lump sum, remarrying in a hurry, and standing guarantee for someone. The amount of this kind of decision is usually on the scale of several tens of thousands of yuan up to a home, so the benefit is set at medium. Official documents likewise list "a family blow, job loss, and dropping out of school" as psychological-crisis risks that the community should go and look for on its own initiative. The state of this stretch is already treated as a state that needs an outsider to lend a hand. The grief guide of the US National Institute on Aging (NIA) lists "making decisions is hard" as a common feature of grief. It suggests: if you can choose, push major life decisions back until you feel better. While you are grieving and may not be able to think clearly, it is better not to make a large change such as selling a home or quitting a job. A study ran a set of experiments. The researchers assigned people at random, put some of them into a sad state, and then had them choose "take the money now" or "take the money after 3 months." Compared with people in a calm mood, sad people were willing to take 13% to 34% less money so they would not have to wait 3 months. This was sadness brought on in an experiment, not a real bereavement. In 2023 the US Federal Trade Commission (FTC) warned about a scam: someone poses as a funeral home and tells the family that if they do not pay more at once, the funeral will be cancelled. The first step it gives is to resist the pressure to "do it right now." A proper business will give you time to decide.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. If there is no such person with no stake in the matter beside you, call 12356 and talk it through once (see item 11 of this section: if you need someone to talk with you, call 12356). You can also write it down yourself and read it again after 3 days. The grade is B because "push it back" has an official grief guide and a randomized experiment holding up the direction. No study has directly compared the property outcomes of bereaved people who pushed the decision back with those who did not. The NIA also only says "wait until you feel better." It does not give a length of time. "3 months" and "more than a month of income" are both lines the author drew. Common scams aimed at bereaved people and at elders are in section 17 (investing for old age, and using the home to fund old age) and section 6 (fortune-telling). The traps in guarantees and IOUs are in section 8. A few sums of money have to be handled on your own initiative, and they are not in the "push it back" list: the housing provident fund (公积金) balance, social insurance (社保) benefits, and the three work-death payments. See section 25 and section 19.

## 13. Do not treat death as a way to pay a debt: life insurance within 2 years does not pay, a work injury is not recognized, and the debt is still taken from the estate first

**Cost**. No money. You only get this account straight.

**In plain terms**. A suicide within 2 years of a life-insurance contract is not paid. Only the small sum that can be refunded from the policy is returned. A work injury is not recognized either, and the three work-death payments are not paid at all. Debts owed are taken from the estate you leave first. The family only gets what is left. They also have to bear the health cost described in item 4 of this section (bereavement by suicide or by a violent death).

**Benefit**. Article 44 of the Insurance Law governs contracts that pay the insurance money on the condition that the insured person dies. Counted from the day the contract is formed, or from the day the contract's effect is restored, if the insured person dies by suicide within 2 years, the insurer does not bear the duty to pay the insurance money. This does not apply when the insured person, at the time of the suicide, is a person with no capacity for civil conduct, that is, a person the law does not treat as responsible for their own acts. In that case the insurer shall refund the cash value of the policy as the contract provides, that is, only the small sum that can be refunded from the policy, not the insured amount. Life-insurance cover is usually on the order of 100000 yuan, so the benefit is set at large. Item 3 of Article 16 of the Regulations on Work Injury Insurance provides: self-harm or suicide shall not be recognized as a work injury, or as deemed a work injury. The three work-death benefits in Article 39 then all fall through. The first is a funeral subsidy, paid as 6 months of the previous year's local average monthly wage of employees. The second is a pension for relatives who were supported by the deceased. The third is a lump-sum work-death subsidy, equal to 20 times the previous year's national per capita disposable income of urban residents. Article 1159 of the Civil Code provides: when the estate is divided, the taxes and debts the deceased legally owed shall be paid, that is, the estate pays the taxes and the debts first, and only what is left is divided. Article 1161 provides: an heir pays only up to the actual value of the estate they received, that is, they use only the part they inherited and do not put in more of their own money. A person who gives up the inheritance can bear no duty to pay.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This item only counts the money. The other items in this section and in section 1 say not to reach this point. Article 44 of the Insurance Law covers only the first 2 years. It is written here so the text of the article is complete. It is not a timetable. The health cost to the family is in item 4 of this section (a person whose spouse died by suicide has a 70% to 80% higher risk of a new mental disorder within 5 years). What to do when the thought appears is in section 1, items 25 and 32. Lasting harm after a person is brought back is in section 1, item 33. The standard for the three work-death payments is in section 19, item 15. How the estate and the debts are handled is in section 25, item 11 (an heir uses only the inherited estate to pay). The money that should be collected is in section 25, item 9 (go and collect the housing provident fund (公积金) and the social insurance (社保) benefits, window by window).

## 14. After a traffic crash, an assault, or a disaster, do not count on a single-session psychological debriefing done right afterward; if a month later the nightmares, flashbacks, and constant dread are still severe, go to a psychiatry department for trauma-focused psychological treatment

**Cost**. A registration fee plus a treatment fee, usually 8 to 12 sessions. The hard part is that the treatment has to go back and touch the stretch of experience you most fear remembering.

**In plain terms**. After a serious event, nightmares and being easily startled in the first weeks are common, and most people ease on their own. If it is still severe after a month, it may be post-traumatic stress disorder, and psychological treatment aimed at the trauma has a clear effect. Pulling someone, right after the event, to tell the whole course once does not prevent this illness. In a trial, the people who had it done were worse 3 years later.

**Benefit**. The National Health Commission's Standard for the Diagnosis and Treatment of Mental Disorders (2020 edition) states that on average about 8% of people who go through a psychological trauma go on to post-traumatic stress disorder. The core features are these. Nightmares and flashbacks: the scene of the event keeps coming back. Avoidance: staying away from topics, places, and people connected with the event. Constant watchfulness: easily startled, and insomnia. The diagnosis is made only when the symptoms last more than 1 month and seriously affect family, study, or work. In the section on acute stress disorder, the standard says most people return to normal through their own adjustment or through crisis intervention in the acute period. The treatment effect is in a 2020 pooled analysis: 114 trials that assigned people by lot, 8171 people. Trauma-focused cognitive behavioral treatment, compared with waiting for treatment or with usual care, had an SMD of −1.32 (95% CI −1.57 to −1.08, the range the true value likely sits in), and the evidence quality was moderate. Eye-movement desensitization and reprocessing (EMDR) was −1.23 (-1.69 to −0.76), and the evidence quality was low. SMD and d are the same ruler. Above 0.8 counts as large, and both of these are past that line. Ordinary supportive counseling, compared with waiting, showed no difference (-0.43, −0.90 to 0.04). A 2013 Cochrane review by the same group of authors had 70 trials and 4761 people, and pointed the same way. Trauma-focused cognitive behavioral treatment was −1.62 (-2.03 to −1.21). EMDR was −1.17 (-2.04 to −0.30). The evidence quality rated that time was very low. The British NICE 2018 guideline arranges it this way. For an adult whose symptoms are already severe within a month of the event, offer individual trauma-focused cognitive behavioral treatment. For someone diagnosed after a month, or whose symptoms are obvious, offer the same, usually 8 to 12 sessions. If the trauma was not caused by war and it is still not better after a full 3 months, also offer EMDR. If the symptoms are light and do not reach a diagnosis, watch through the first month, and arrange a review within that month. The psychological treatments listed in the domestic standard are the same kinds: prolonged exposure, cognitive processing therapy, and EMDR. A single-session debriefing done right after the event is covered in the material that follows. A 2002 Cochrane review pooled 11 trials. A single individual debriefing did not lighten the distress, and it did not prevent post-traumatic stress disorder. At 3 to 5 months the OR was 1.22 (0.60–2.46), no difference. A trial among them followed people to 1 year, and the people who had the debriefing had a higher risk of the illness instead. The OR was 2.88 (1.11–7.53), about 2.9 times. The authors' conclusion was: stop forcing a debriefing on people who have been traumatized. Another trial enrolled patients hospitalized after a traffic crash, assigned by lot. At 3 years, the debriefing group was clearly worse on psychiatric symptoms, anxiety while riding in a car, pain, physical problems, overall ability to live, and money problems. People whose flashbacks and avoidance were already severe at the start still had symptoms 3 years later if they had the debriefing. Those who did not have it recovered. The NICE guideline states plainly: do not offer a psychologically led debriefing to prevent or to treat post-traumatic stress disorder. The reason is that neither doing it individually nor doing it in a group showed a benefit, and there are signs of being worse than not doing it.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A single-session debriefing means, within a few days after the event, calling people together or talking with a person alone, and having them tell the whole course and the feelings at the time from the start. The domestic standard still lists a group debriefing in the psychological-treatment table for acute stress disorder. That does not match NICE. This item follows the trial results. If a workplace or a school organizes

this kind of meeting after an event, you can decline to speak, and do not push someone else to speak. In the first weeks, first make sure of safety, of eating and sleeping, and of someone nearby. Register at psychiatry, psychology, or clinical psychology, and ask directly whether they can do trauma-focused psychological treatment. The reasoning is the same as item 9 of this section (do not start by paying for grief counseling). Not everyone needs a professional intervention. The effort should go to people who are still stuck after a month. People whose relative died by accident or by homicide often have these symptoms too; see item 4 of this section (a relative died by accident or by homicide). What to do first after a sexual assault is in section 13, item 42 (after a sexual assault). Cases that police, medical staff, and firefighters get from the work itself are already listed in the occupational-disease catalog. See section 19, item 10 (the note on the item about dust, noise, and chemical poisons).

# 30. Children after starting school

Section 20 covers the first year after a child is born. Section 18 covers how much money and time raising a child costs. The years in between, ages 3 to 18, are in this section. The item on screen time by age starts at age 0, because the official tiers are 0–3, 3–6, and primary/secondary school; splitting them would make the guidance harder to use. This section answers one question: when “don't delay schoolwork” collides with “the body,” which things cannot wait. They cannot wait because they have time windows; once missed, they cannot be made up. Whether schoolwork should be that intense is not discussed here — only the windows and the numbers.

The first eight items, item 12 (cycloplegic refraction), item 13 (pit and fissure sealants), items 15 through 19, and item 21 (head hit during sport) are scored on death and lasting physical or mental harm. Among them, items 16 and 17 are about how to parent at home: no hitting or yelling, and take a parenting class that teaches concrete skills. Item 18 is about not sending a child to a closed “internet addiction” school. Item 19 is about teaching a child which body parts are private and to tell you if they were touched. Item 9 (do not buy products that “cure myopia”) and item 20 (do not ride on the road under age) are scored on money. Item 10 (written rules on sleep, homework, PE, and rankings), item 11 (leave of absence with enrollment kept), and item 14 (when a child loves games) are scored on time. Drowning, traffic, helmets, and HPV vaccine are in Section 1. Infants are in Section 20. Scams against children and game top-ups are in Section 5. Red lines minors themselves must not cross are in Section 9. How to recognize an emergency and call a car is in Section 13. Children after a parent dies are in Section 29. None of that is repeated here.

Items in this section are grouped by theme below (numbers in parentheses are item numbers).

**Care that cannot wait**: sudden severe pain — go to hospital at once (item 1); do not put off treatment to wait for exams (item 2); the annual student health-check report (item 7).

**Eyes and teeth**: enough outdoor time, 2 hours a day (item 4); screen rules by age (item 5); deeper myopia degrees (item 6); do not buy products that “cure myopia” (item 9); cycloplegic refraction (item 12); pit and fissure sealants (item 13).

**At school**: report bullying the same day (item 3); written rules on sleep, homework, PE, and rankings (item 10); leave of absence with enrollment kept (item 11).

**Mental health and parenting at home**: depression screening (item 8); when a child loves games (item 14); when a child says they like the same sex (item 15); do not hit when disciplining (item 16); take a parenting class (item 17); do not send to an internet-addiction school (item 18); know private body parts (item 19).

**Roads and playing fields**: do not ride on the road under age (item 20); after a head hit in sport, do not play again that day (item 21).

## 1. If a child says sudden pain is getting worse, go to the hospital at once — do not make them tough it out until after school

**Cost**. No money. Take a half day off and take the child to emergency care.

**In plain terms**. Some illnesses are counted in hours. Sudden severe pain on one side of a boy's scrotum may be testicular torsion — the vessel feeding the testis twists and blood supply stops. Treated within 6 hours, the testis is saved in 97.2% of cases. Wait until 19 to 24 hours and only 42.5% remain. This pain will not wait until after school or until exams are over.

**Benefit**. Following the rules, 30 case series with 2116 patients with testicular torsion were collected and pooled. Of these, 1283 were timed in 6-hour bands. From pain onset, testis salvage was 97.2% at 0 to 6 hours, 79.3% at 7 to 12 hours, 61.3% at 13 to 18 hours, 42.5% at 19 to 24 hours, 24.4% at 25 to 48 hours, and 7.4% after 48 hours. In broader bands: 90.4% within 12 hours, 54.0% at 13 to 24 hours, and 18.1% after 24 hours. The authors conclude salvage can still happen past the usual 6 to 8 hour talk. So even if pain has gone on a long time, still get care — do not stay home because “it's too late anyway.” In U.S. pediatric hospital data for 2000,

2003, and 2006, 2443 boys from 1 month to under 18 years had surgery for testicular torsion. Age of onset has two peaks: the first year of life, and early puberty

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Tell boys in advance: if there is sudden severe pain down there, say so at once — no need to be shy. Testicular torsion is common in boys just entering puberty. Many kids are too embarrassed to speak and tough it out; that is the author's experience. Other hour-counted problems include acute appendicitis (delay can lead to perforation), diabetic ketoacidosis, and meningitis. This section did not verify hour-by-hour harm for each of those. The author's shared signal: sudden onset, keeps getting worse, unlike any prior episode. How to recognize emergencies and call a car is in Section 13.

## 2. Do not put off needed treatment to “wait until exams are over”; some windows follow bone age, not the exam calendar

**Cost**. No money; the only choice is early or late. Leave and follow-ups take time; the cost of treatment itself is separate. The hard part is that a brace must be worn at least 18 hours a day, and the child must keep putting up with it.

**In plain terms**. Scoliosis is a sideways bend of the spine. A brace is a hard shell vest that holds the spine. Worn while bones are still growing, 75% of children never reach a 50-degree curve by the end of growth; observation alone is only 42%. The wearable window follows when bones finish growing, not the high-school or college exams — wait until after exams and you may miss it.

**Benefit**. A multi-hospital trial enrolled 242 adolescents with idiopathic scoliosis who met criteria for bracing. Of these, 116 were assigned by lot and 126 chose for themselves whether to wear a brace. Success and failure were defined in advance: curve growing past 50 degrees was failure; still below that at skeletal maturity was success. Brace-group children were asked to wear at least 18 hours a day. Results were analyzed by initial assignment, whether or not they actually wore enough. Assigned brace group success 75%, assigned observation only 42% (OR 4.11, 95% CI 1.85–9.16), roughly 4 times the chance of success versus observation alone. Combining the lot-assigned and self-chosen groups: 72% versus 48% (after leveling baseline differences, OR 1.93, 1.08–3.46, still about 1.9 times). More hours worn per day meant higher success ($P<0.001$; this link is unlikely to be chance). The trial stopped early because the brace worked

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Scoliosis is the example here because it has lot-assigned trials and a clear time window. It is also a focus item on student health checks (see item 7). In the author's experience, similar cases include strabismus, amblyopia, dental caries, and congenital heart disease surgeries that can be timed. The later they are done, the worse the result may be, or the higher the cost. This section did not verify each one; ask a specialist about the exact window. If missing class is the fear, during compulsory education a leave of absence can last up to 1 year with enrollment kept — see item 11.

## 3. If a child is bullied, report it to the school the same day and ask for a written process; for hitting, taking money, or spreading rumors, call the police at once

**Cost**. No money. Go to the homeroom teacher and the school's student-bullying governance body. To call the police, dial 110. The hard part is resisting pressure to “not make a big deal of it.”

**In plain terms**. Children bullied by peers are about 2.2 times as likely to have suicidal thoughts as those not bullied, and about 2.6 times as likely to have attempted suicide. Schools that receive a report must investigate at once; if bullying is found, they must discipline or punish, and serious cases must not be hidden — they must be reported to public security. So report the same day, ask for the formal finding process, and keep a written record.

**Benefit**. 34 studies with 284375 children and adolescents pooled. Peer bullying linked to suicidal thoughts, OR 2.23 (95% CI 2.10–2.37), about 2.2 times the chance versus not bullied. Another 9 studies, 70102 people:

bullying linked to suicide attempts, OR 2.55 (1.95–3.34), about 2.6 times. Results held across sex, age, and study quality. The link of cyberbullying to suicidal thoughts was stronger than offline bullying. Article 21 of the Regulations on School Protection of Minors (未成年人学校保护规定) lists five kinds of conduct: beating, kicking, slapping, grabbing/biting, shoving, pulling; insults, mockery, humiliating nicknames; snatching, forcing goods, or deliberate damage to property; malicious exclusion and isolation; fabricating facts online to defame or spread rumors. The same article says that when the side with an advantage in age, body, or numbers does these things willfully or maliciously and causes bodily harm, property loss, or mental harm, it may be found to be bullying. Article 22 requires staff who notice abnormal mood or bodily injury to inquire promptly and report. Article 23 requires the school, on receiving a report, to investigate at once, submit it to the bullying-governance body for finding and handling, and notify parents to take part. If bullying is found, educational discipline or a disciplinary sanction must follow. Serious bullying that violates public-security administration or may be a crime must not be concealed and must be reported promptly to public security and education authorities (nationwide, in force from 1 September 2021)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Article 22 names the signals: clear mood changes and bodily injury. If a child has injuries they cannot explain, or mood suddenly goes wrong, ask first. This pooled analysis only follows records and has no assigned controls, so it cannot prove bullying alone causes suicide. The direction and size of the risk are clear. The Plan for Comprehensive Governance of Bullying Among Primary and Secondary Students (加强中小学生欺凌综合治理方案) also requires a strict distinction between bullying and ordinary rough play among students. So the school must make a finding; a line like “kids just playing” is not enough.

## 4. Have the child spend at least 2 hours outdoors each day — among unpaid, drug-free options, this is the only myopia-prevention method backed by randomized trials

**Cost**. No money. But time must be cleared each day, often squeezed from homework and online classes. The hard part is doing it every day, not a few times.

**In plain terms**. An extra 40 minutes of outdoor class each day in grade 1 cut new myopia over three years from about four in ten to about three in ten. The health commission's dose is at least 2 hours of daytime outdoor time a day, or 14 hours a week in total. Cloudy days count.

**Benefit**. Grade-1 students in 12 Guangzhou primary schools were assigned by lot at school level (intervention schools 952 people, control schools 951, mean age 6.6 years). The intervention added one 40-minute outdoor activity class each school day and encouraged parents to take children out more after school. Over 3 years, new myopia was 30.4% in the intervention group (259 of 853 eligible) and 39.5% in controls (287 of 726). Difference −9.1 percentage points (95% CI −14.1 to −4.1, P<0.001); the true gap sits roughly between 4 and 14 percentage points fewer. Over 3 years, refractive progression (spherical equivalent change) was −1.42 D versus −1.59 D, a difference of 0.17 D (P=0.04). The intervention group progressed a little less. D is the unit for refractive power. Axial length (front-to-back eye length) growth did not differ between groups (P=0.07). Ten Core Knowledge Points for Preventing and Controlling Myopia in Children and Adolescents (防控儿童青少年近视核心知识十条) requires at least 2 hours of daytime outdoor activity a day, or 14 hours a week cumulative. It notes that even on cloudy days outdoor activity has a protective effect, and asks to avoid midday high heat and strong sun. Drug prevention of myopia also has lot-assigned trials. In Hong Kong, 474 children aged 4 to 9 without myopia were split into three groups and used eye drops once nightly for two years. With 0.05% atropine, myopia over two years was 28.4%; with placebo, 53.0%. With 0.01% atropine it was 45.9%, not different from placebo

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This trial ran only 3 years, and participating children all started at age 6. A 9.1 percentage-point gap in myopia rates only keeps some children from becoming myopic; it does not guarantee no myopia. The same ten core points also give a few practices. Reading and writing: “one chi, one fist, one cun” (一尺一拳一寸). After 20 minutes of near work, look into the distance for 20 seconds or more. For primary and secondary

students, non-study screen use should not exceed 15 minutes at a time or 1 hour a day in total. “Being outdoors” is not the same as “PE class”; standing outside at recess counts. Authors of the atropine trial say more trials are needed to confirm, and long-term safety still needs watching. Whether to use drops and at what strength, ask an eye doctor. The author found no other unpaid, drug-free method with a lot-assigned trial.

## 5. Ages 0 to 3: no screens; ages 3 to 6: as little as possible; primary and secondary students: non-study use no more than 1 hour a day

**Cost**. No money. The hard parts are taking the screen out of the child's hands, and parents themselves looking less in front of the child.

**In plain terms**. The national health commission says ages 0 to 3 get no screens, and ages 3 to 6 should avoid them as much as possible. For primary and secondary students, non-study use is no more than 15 minutes at a time and no more than 1 hour a day. The reason is that long near work makes myopia come early. Evidence that screens cause myopia is weaker; what has been shown to work is 2 hours outdoors a day.

**Benefit**. Article 4 of Ten Core Knowledge Points for Preventing and Controlling Myopia in Children and Adolescents (防控儿童青少年近视核心知识十条) says in the original wording: “Infants and toddlers aged 0–3 shall not use phones, tablets, computers, or other screen electronic products; children aged 3–6 shall avoid contact with and use of phones, tablets, computers, and other screen electronic products as much as possible; for primary and secondary students, non-study screen use should not exceed 15 minutes per session, and cumulative daily use should not exceed 1 hour.” The same article states that “prolonged near use of electronic screen products readily depletes children's hyperopia reserve and is an important cause of early and high rates of myopia in children and adolescents.” The 2018 implementation plan from the Ministry of Education and seven other departments gives parents the same requirements and adds “the younger the age, the shorter continuous use of electronic products should be.” Research evidence is much weaker: a systematic review took in 33 studies, 11 entered the pooled calculation, ages from 3 months to 33 years. Counting only phones and tablets, the odds ratio for myopia was 1.26 (95% CI 1.00 to 1.60, $I^2$=77%). Combined with computers it was 1.77 (1.28 to 2.45, $I^2$=87%). The authors conclude only “may be related,” and state that none of the 33 studies had a reliable measure of screen time

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because officials give tiered rules, not numbers from a trial. The lower bound of the research odds ratio sits at 1.00, and the authors only dare say “may be related.” Treat it as a household rule that is easy to run, not as “no screens means no myopia.” What has a lot-assigned trial behind it is item 4 (2 hours outdoors). Preschool eyes should also be checked. The same document says ages 1–3, 4–6, and after 7 should all have regular refractive screening to see how much hyperopia reserve remains. How to check is in item 12 (cycloplegic refraction). Screens and children's language ability were also pooled in a meta-analysis of 42 studies with 18905 people. Longer screen time went with weaker language (r=−0.14, 95% CI −0.18 to −0.10). But co-viewing and educational content went the other way (r=0.16 and 0.13). That is association, not cause — it only shows that swapping screens for talking with the child is a poor trade.

## 6. Treat myopia as lasting damage: the higher the degree, the more retinal detachment, macular disease, and glaucoma later

**Cost**. No money. This item itself needs no action; what to do is in items 4 and 5 (2 hours outdoors, screen rules by age).

**In plain terms**. Myopia does not heal on its own, and the degree does not go back down. It is also not only a “wear glasses” matter. Versus people without myopia, the chance of myopic macular disease is over ten times higher in mild myopia and hundreds of times higher above 600 degrees. Retinal detachment is about 3 times higher in mild myopia and about 13 times higher above 600 degrees. So the deeper a child's myopia climbs, the more risk they carry later.

**Benefit**. A systematic review and meta-analysis pooled studies before June 2019 into three degree bands: mild (−0.5 to −3.00 D), moderate (−3.00 to −6.00 D), high (≤−6.00 D, above 600 degrees). Versus people without myopia, odds ratios for myopic macular degeneration were 13.57 (95% CI 6.18 to 29.79), 72.74 (33.18 to 159.48), and 845.08 (230.05 to 3104.34). Retinal detachment: 3.15 (1.92 to 5.17), 8.74 (7.28 to 10.50), 12.62 (6.65 to 23.94). Posterior subcapsular cataract: 1.56 (1.32 to 1.84), 2.55 (1.98 to 3.28), 4.55 (2.66 to 7.75). Open-angle glaucoma: mild 1.59 (1.33 to 1.91); moderate and high combined 2.92 (1.89 to 4.52). Odds ratios for visual impairment at age 60 and above: 1.71 (1.07 to 2.74), 5.54 (3.12 to 9.85), 87.63 (34.50 to 222.58). Ten Core Knowledge Points for Preventing and Controlling Myopia in Children and Adolescents (防控儿童青少年近视核心知识十条) says the same: above 600 degrees is high myopia; in that group, rates of cataract, open-angle glaucoma, myopic macular disease, retinal detachment, myopic optic neuropathy, and other blinding eye diseases are clearly higher than in other groups, and "myopia can be prevented and controlled but is not reversible"

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Studies pooled were all observational, and the odds ratios are unusually large. For high myopia and macular degeneration, the credible range runs from 230 to 3104, so underlying studies differ a lot. Read the numbers as order of magnitude, not exact values. The visual-impairment set in the Benefit line is for people aged 60 and above. The author infers these outcomes mostly show up in middle and old age. Myopia is not finished once glasses are fitted — it is worth the effort to delay and control it. Follow-up after diagnosis is in item 12 (cycloplegic refraction). Do not buy products that claim a cure — see item 9 (cure myopia).

## 7. Take a close look at your child's annual school health report and follow up on any abnormalities right away

**Cost**. No cost at all. Under China's Compulsory Education Law, all school health check fees are covered by school operating budgets, so parents pay nothing extra.

**In plain terms**. Primary and secondary schools run one student health check a year. On the report, focus on overweight, obesity, malnutrition, abnormal spinal curvature, poor vision, and dental caries. Do not glance at height and weight and put the sheet away. If any of these are abnormal, take the child to a specialist that same year and get it clear.

**Benefit**. The 2021 Administrative Measures for Health Checks of Primary and Middle School Students requires all such schools to run one health check per year for every enrolled student. The physical exam covers the head, neck, chest, spine, limbs, skin, and lymph nodes, while the eye exam checks external eye condition, distance vision, and refractive errors (degree of myopia or hyperopia). The individual report issued to each student must include all test results, an overall assessment, and tailored health guidance. Overweight, obesity, malnutrition, spinal curvature issues, poor eyesight, and dental cavities are all designated as priority areas for follow-up. Local education authorities are also required to keep records of students with health problems and conduct regular follow-ups. All costs for these compulsory education health checks are paid by school budgets, with no extra charges for parents (issued nationwide in September 2021).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because the document is a set of administrative rules for schools, not a study on the actual effectiveness of these checks. It guarantees that schools will run annual checks covering the listed items and follow up on any abnormalities, but does not confirm that all identified issues will receive timely intervention. These health checks are only a preliminary screening tool, not a formal diagnosis. For poor eyesight, a pupil dilation refraction test at an ophthalmology clinic is required (see Item 12). For spinal curvature issues, a visit to an orthopedics or spinal surgery specialist is necessary (see Item 2 — do not delay treatment to wait until after exams). Parents are responsible for arranging these follow-up appointments for their children.

## 8. Conducting a depression screening for kids aged 12 to 18 — don't rely on school mental health assessments as a diagnosis

**Cost**. Costs range from zero to just a few dozen yuan; this covers filling out a screening questionnaire at a community clinic or hospital outpatient department. Calling the 12355 and 12356 hotlines is completely free.

**In plain terms**. U.S. prevention guidelines recommend screening children aged 12 to 18 for major depression; for age 11 and under the evidence is not enough. In the U.S., suicide is the second cause of death among ages 10 to 19. The school's yearly mental-health assessment is only a census, not a diagnosis. If the child says they feel bad, go straight to psychiatry or clinical psychology.

**Benefit**. In 2022, the U.S. Preventive Services Task Force issued a recommendation statement advising that adolescents aged 12 to 18 be screened for major depressive disorder; this recommendation falls under Category B, meaning the evidence supporting it is moderate and the benefits are also moderate, making it worthwhile. For children under 11, there is insufficient evidence to support depression screening (an I statement, which indicates a lack of evidence and no formal recommendation). Likewise, evidence regarding both the benefits and risks of screening children and adolescents specifically for suicide risk is also limited (another I statement). The document emphasizes that suicide is the second leading cause of death among 10- to 19-year-olds, and that major depression in youth is closely linked to numerous later issues, including recurrent depressive episodes and other mental disorders, as well as a heightened risk of suicidal thoughts, suicide attempts, and death. China's “Ten Measures to Further Improve Mental Health Care for Primary and Secondary School Students” calls for establishing a three-tier support system: homeroom teachers, full- and part-time school counselors, and psychiatrists. Each student should undergo a mental health assessment no more than once per academic year. The measures also stress the need to improve referral pathways to mental health specialists and reintegration processes after recovery. Additionally, they highlight the importance of leveraging the 12355 Youth Service Hotline and the 12356 Psychological Assistance Hotline (issued nationwide in October 2025).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This B rating reflects the original recommendation strength grading used by the task force, rather than a quantifiable measure of actual effectiveness. It represents a U.S.-based recommendation; no equivalent official screening guidelines currently exist in China. A positive screening result merely indicates the need for a follow-up evaluation — it does not constitute a formal diagnosis. Guidance on handling suicidal thoughts can be found in Section 1, Item 25, while family coping strategies are outlined in Section 29.

## 9. Do not buy products or services claiming to “cure myopia” or “reduce refractive error”

**Cost**. There is no cost involved; in fact, you save this money by avoiding such purchases.

**In plain terms**. The State Administration for Market Regulation explicitly states that “under current medical technology, myopia cannot be cured.” Phrases such as “recovery,” “restoration,” “reducing refractive error,” “curing myopia,” “myopia remedy,” and “repairing refractive error” are classified as illegal marketing claims subject to strict enforcement. If you encounter any of these terms, you can safely rule out those products without further comparison. Devices such as eye-care instruments are considered medical devices, and e-commerce platforms must verify whether sellers are qualified to sell them.

**Benefit**. A notice issued by the General Office of the State Administration for Market Regulation between November 2021 and March 2022 clearly reiterates that “under current medical technology, myopia cannot be cured.” It mandates strict legal action against any marketing of products aimed at preventing or controlling myopia in children and adolescents that employ misleading language like “recovery,” “restoration,” “reducing refractive error,” “curing myopia,” “myopia remedy,” or “repairing refractive error.” The notice also calls for intensified efforts to combat practices that misuse traditional Chinese medicine terminology or theories for deceptive advertising, as well as two specific types of false advertising: using patient testimonials or images to compare pre- and post-treatment outcomes, and making guaranteed claims regarding treatment safety or

effectiveness. Additionally, e-commerce platforms are required to rigorously verify the qualifications of sellers offering medical devices such as eye-care instruments and other specialized products (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because the basis comes from regulatory determinations during enforcement actions rather than from controlled comparative trials of actual products. However, both health authorities and regulators agree on the statement “Myopia can be prevented and controlled, but it cannot be reversed.” The only two evidence-backed recommendations appear in items 4 (outdoor activities) and 12 (proper eye examinations, glasses fitting, and follow-ups). Information on blue-light-blocking glasses can be found in Section 6.

## 10. Clear rules exist for sleep, homework, sports, and rankings; if schools fail to comply, parents can raise the issue

**Cost**. No cost involved. All you need is to know these rules so you can bring them up with the school or local education authorities when necessary. The real challenge is simply speaking up about it.

**In plain terms**. These rules are all laid out in writing: elementary students must get 10 hours of sleep per day, junior high students 9 hours, and high school students 8 hours. Elementary classes generally start no earlier than 8:20 a.m., and junior high classes no earlier than 8:00 a.m. In 2025, an additional requirement was added that schools must provide at least 2 hours of combined physical activity per day, and students must not be ranked based on test scores. If your child consistently fails to get enough sleep, use these rules as a reference point rather than blaming the child for being slow to get ready.

**Benefit**. The *Notice on Further Strengthening Sleep Management for Primary and Secondary School Students* stipulates that elementary students must get 10 hours of sleep daily, junior high students 9 hours, and high school students 8 hours. Elementary classes generally start no earlier than 8:20 a.m., and junior high classes no earlier than 8:00 a.m. Schools are prohibited from requiring students to arrive at school early for mandatory educational activities. Elementary students must go to bed no later than 9:20 p.m., junior high students no later than 10:00 p.m., and high school students no later than 11:00 p.m. After-school tutoring programs must end no later than 8:30 p.m., and online live tutoring sessions must end no later than 9:00 p.m. From 10:00 p.m. to 8:00 a.m. the next day, game services for minors are banned nationwide (issued March 2021). The *Ten Measures for Further Strengthening Mental Health Work Among Primary and Secondary School Students* contains several additional provisions. All schools are required to ensure students get at least 2 hours of combined physical activity per day, and the practice of offering 15-minute recess periods is encouraged. Students must not be ranked based on test scores, and repetitive, punitive homework assignments are strictly prohibited. A nationwide initiative launched in October 2025 encourages schools to designate one day per week as a “homework-free day.”

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Both documents were issued by relevant education authorities. Implementation varies widely across different regions and schools, which is why this item is rated B. Their main purpose is to help parents understand what schools are obligated to provide, so they have solid grounds to bring these issues up when needed. Information on adult sleep needs can be found in Sections 2 and 3.

## 11. If a child cannot keep going, they can take leave; the school must keep their enrollment, up to 1 year

**Cost**. No money. Parents or other legal guardians apply to the school. The hard part is accepting that the child will stop for a while.

**In plain terms**. Leave of absence has a formal system. Parents or other guardians apply; after the school confirms, it reports upward for approval. One leave lasts at most 1 year; if more is needed when it ends, apply again. During leave the school must keep the child's enrollment; on return they continue. Exact rules are set by each province — ask the school office or the local education bureau.

**Benefit**. Article 16 of the Measures for the Administration of Primary and Secondary Student Enrollment Status (中小学生学籍管理办法) sets how leave works. The student takes leave on application by parents or other legal guardians. After the school confirms, it reports to the higher enrollment-status office for approval. On return the school must process the related steps promptly. One application for leave shall not exceed 1 year; if more leave is truly needed when it ends, a new application must be filed. During leave the school shall keep the enrollment status (student identity and place are held). Exact leave and return rules are made by provincial education authorities (nationwide, issued January 2025). Ten Measures to Further Strengthen Mental Health Work for Primary and Secondary Students (进一步加强中小学生心理健康工作十条措施) requires advancing referral of mental illness for medical care and return-to-school mechanisms after recovery, and guiding schools to make plans for sudden campus psychological crises

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. In the author's experience, before applying ask three things: what medical certificate is needed, how enrollment is recorded in the system during leave, and whether return is to the same grade or one grade down. Grade B because conditions for leave, materials to submit, and how return is joined are all set by provincial education departments; the national level only builds a frame. Article 12 of the Regulations on School Protection of Minors (未成年人学校保护规定) also requires compulsory-education schools to keep reporting and filing systems for dropouts, leave, and long absences. So leave is something schools already process, not a special favor for you alone.

## 12. If poor vision is detected, go to the hospital for cycloplegic refraction and follow up at the recommended intervals as advised by the doctor

**Cost**. The examination and glasses fitting typically cost several tens to several hundred yuan. After using the eye drops, children may be sensitive to light and have blurry near vision; it usually takes half a day to a couple of days for this to subside.

**In plain terms**. Cycloplegic refraction involves using special eye drops that relax the eye's focusing muscles, allowing an accurate measurement of refractive errors. This test is performed in hospitals and is the most reliable method for diagnosing myopia. The Health Commission confirms these drops do not harm healthy eyes and that vision returns to normal after they wear off. Do not rely on quick computerized refraction tests at optical shops for diagnosis, and do not withhold glasses from children out of fear that it will worsen their myopia.

**Benefit**. The “Ten Core Principles for Preventing and Controlling Myopia in Children and Adolescents” outlines how cycloplegic refraction works: it uses a cycloplegic agent to relax the focusing muscles before measuring refractive errors. This medical procedure is regarded as the gold standard for diagnosing myopia, providing the most accurate results. The drops themselves are safe for healthy eyes; side effects such as light sensitivity and blurred near vision are temporary and resolve after treatment ends. Once myopia is confirmed, timely corrective measures—such as wearing appropriate glasses—are essential. Proper glasses can correct vision and slow progression of the condition. Children aged preschool through elementary school should have their vision rechecked every 3–6 months, while middle and high school students should be checked every 6–12 months, depending on individual needs. Regular refractive screenings are also recommended at ages 1–3, 4–6, and thereafter to monitorhyperopia reserve (远视储备量, "farsightedness reserve") (the amount of reserve focusing ability). (National guidelines issued July 2023)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. This grade is assigned because the information originates from official public health publications rather than original research containing specific quantitative data. Because high myopia increases the risk of complications such as retinal detachment, follow-up visits serve purposes beyond simply updating prescriptions. “Poor vision” noted during school screenings is merely an initial indicator; a full ophthalmologic evaluation at a hospital is still required, as detailed in item 7.

## 13. Pit and fissure sealants applied after permanent molars emerge

**Cost**. Each application costs just a few dozen to a couple of hundred yuan — specifically, between 100 and 200 yuan per tooth. No anesthesia is needed, no tooth grinding is required, and the whole procedure takes only a few minutes. Many regions offer free sealant programs for children who meet the age criteria.

**In plain terms**. Pit and fissure sealing fills the grooves on the chewing face of big molars with resin so food scraps cannot pack in. Two years after sealing, the chance of cavities is about one eighth of not sealing. Without sealing, about 16% of tooth surfaces decay; with sealing, only about 5%. It still works four years later.

**Benefit**. This conclusion comes from 38 separate trials involving 7,924 children aged 5–16, all selected and pooled by Cochrane according to strict methodological standards. The studies compared children who received resin-based sealants with those who did not. For first permanent molars in the 5–10 age group, the odds ratio after 24 months was 0.12 (95% CI 0.08–0.19), meaning the risk of decay was roughly one-eighth that of untreated teeth. This result is based on seven trials with 1,548 participants randomly assigned and 1,322 actually examined; the overall evidence quality is rated as moderate. If the untreated control group shows 16% decayed surfaces after two years, the sealed group shows only 5.2% (range 3.13%–7.37%). When the control group rate reaches 40%, the sealed group still stays at 6.25% (3.84%–9.63%); at a 70% control rate, the sealed group remains at 19% (12.3%–27.2%). After 48–54 months the odds ratio remains low at 0.21 (0.16–0.28), indicating a risk roughly one-fifth that of untreated teeth. Authors conclude that resin sealants reduce cavity formation by 11%–51% compared with no sealants after two years. No adverse effects were reported in any of the four trials that monitored side-effects; however, there is insufficient evidence to determine whether glass-ionomer sealants perform better than other types.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The first permanent molars — teeth that never get replaced — typically appear around age 6, with the second set emerging near age 12. Sealants should be applied as soon as these molars emerge and before any decay sets in; once a cavity has formed, sealants can no longer be used and filling is required instead. Many regions provide free sealant programs for eligible children, so it's worth checking with the local Chinese CDC or community health centers. No nationwide document with exact coverage criteria or age limits could be identified for this section, so those details are omitted here. Preventing dental caries remains a key focus of school-age health screenings; see Section 7 for further information.

## 14. If a child loves games, first check whether sleep, homework, and going outdoors are being squeezed out — do not only watch how long they play

**Cost**. No money. Once a week notice when they sleep, whether homework is turned in, and whether they go out.

**In plain terms**. True “gaming disorder” is about two or three people in a hundred. If questionnaire cutoffs are low and only teens are sampled, the rate looks high. Looking at real logs from game companies, there is almost no sign that playing more or less changes happiness. By rule, minors may play only Friday, Saturday, Sunday, and holidays from 8 pm to 9 pm.

**Benefit**. A meta-analysis pooled 53 studies from 17 countries, 226247 people. Prevalence of gaming disorder was 3.05% (95% CI 2.38–3.91; that is the credible range). Counting only studies with stricter sampling, 1.96%. Results differed widely across studies; 77% of the spread came from which questionnaire was used. Teen samples, low cutoff scores, and small samples all push the rate up. Another study took data from 7 game companies and linked 38935 players' real play time over six weeks to self-reported happiness. Almost no evidence that play time affects happiness. The National Press and Publication Administration requires game firms to offer minors only 1 hour of service a day on Friday, Saturday, Sunday, and statutory holidays, from 20:00 to 21:00 (nationwide / international, from 2021)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because prevalence swings a lot with the questionnaire, and the happiness study followed only six weeks. In the author's judgment, the most common cost of games is crowding out sleep and outdoor

time; no research number was found for that sentence. Written sleep rules are in item 10 of this section (sleep, homework, PE). Outdoors are in item 4 of this section (2 hours outdoors a day); screen time is in item 5 of this section (non-study use no more than 1 hour a day). Top-ups and refunds are in Section 5, item 9 (child uses a phone to top up or tip). If grades, sleep, and family ties all collapse together and talk will not stop it, take the child to psychiatry or child psychology. Do not send them to a closed internet-addiction school — see item 18 of this section (internet-addiction schools). The beneficiary is the child.

## 15. If a child says they like the same sex, do not scold, do not throw them out, do not send them for "conversion": how the family reacts ties to whether they attempt suicide

**Cost**. No money. The hard part is parents digesting their own feelings first and not saying cruel words in the moment.

**In plain terms**. Among Chinese secondary students, children who like the same sex or both sexes attempt suicide in a year about 3 to 5.5 times as often as others. Overseas research finds that teens strongly rejected at home attempt suicide far more later. Those parents send for "conversion" also attempt suicide far more.

**Benefit**. A domestic survey covered 506 secondary schools in 7 provinces, 150822 students from grade 7 through grade 12. Past-year suicide attempts among boys: opposite-sex only 2.2%, same-sex only 6.9%, both sexes 12.2%. Girls: 3.1%, 8.9%, 10.9%. That is about 3 to 5.5 times peers who only like the opposite sex. Researchers subtracted age, academic pressure, family finances, and bullying. After that, for boys the two groups had OR 3.13 (95% CI 2.28–4.28) and 3.83 (2.85–5.14), about two to three times higher. A meta-analysis of 35 studies found OR 3.50 (2.98–4.12) for sexual-minority adolescents attempting suicide. A U.S. study interviewed 224 gay and bisexual youth aged 21 to 25 about family reactions in adolescence. Versus peers with almost no family rejection, high rejection had OR 8.4 for attempting suicide. In another study, parents who themselves tried to change the child's sexual orientation: OR 3.08 (1.39–6.83) for the child's suicide attempt. Parents who also sent the child to a therapist or religious figure: 5.07 (2.38–10.79) (China / multi-country / U.S.)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because these are one-time surveys, and the degree of family rejection relies on adult recall — they show association, not which caused which. Parents need not agree at once; first do not do things that harm the child. In law, parents must not abuse or abandon a child, and must not use domestic violence against a child. Habitual insults and intimidation also count as domestic violence. If the child is low and says they do not want to live, call 12356 first — see Section 1, item 25 (call 12356 when there are suicidal thoughts). You can also go to psychiatry under item 8 of this section (one depression screen at ages 12 to 18). Why not touch "conversion" is in Section 6, item 28 (do not do sexual-orientation conversion). Beneficiaries are the child, and you.

## 16. When disciplining, do not hit, and do not yell or call them stupid: children often hit or yelled at have more behavior and mood problems

**Cost**. No money. The hard part is stopping hands and mouth when anger rises, and switching to a way of parenting without hitting or yelling. What to switch to is in item 17 of this section (parenting classes that teach concrete skills).

**In plain terms**. Children often hit are more aggressive and have more mental problems, are more distant from parents, and get heavier hitting more often. Whether hitting makes a child obey on the spot is unclear in the evidence. Children often yelled at or called stupid at age 13 later get in more trouble and have more depression; even warm parenting day to day does not cancel that.

**Benefit**. First, hitting. One meta-analysis counted only "open-hand spanking of the buttocks or limbs." It pooled 75 studies, 111 effect sizes, 160927 children. Of 17 outcomes, 13 clearly linked to spanking, all in the bad direction. d is effect size; 0.2 is small, 0.5 medium. Childhood aggression d = 0.37 (95% CI 0.13–0.61,

credible range). Externalizing problems 0.41 — hitting, breaking rules. Internalizing 0.24 — anxiety, depression. Mental health problems 0.53; poor relationship with parents 0.51; low self-esteem 0.15; poorer cognition 0.17. Physical abuse by parents 0.64. Adult antisocial behavior 0.36; adult mental health problems 0.24. Across 111 effect sizes, d = 0.33 (0.29–0.38). Whether the child obeyed on the spot was not clearly linked to spanking (d = 0.14, −0.19–0.47); that outcome had only 5 effect sizes. Another review looked only at before-and-after follow-up studies, 69 of them. Physical punishment stably predicted more later behavior problems; no link to any long-term good outcome was seen. Of 7 studies that counted how often hitting happened, 5 found more hitting linked to worse problems. Next, yelling. A U.S. study followed 976 two-parent families. At age 13, if parents often yelled, used foul language, or called the child stupid or lazy, misconduct and depressive symptoms both rose between ages 13 and 14. Whether parents were usually warm did not cancel the link. The reverse also held: children with more misconduct at 13 later got yelled at more. In law, parents must not use domestic violence against a child. Article 2 of the Anti-Domestic Violence Law (反家庭暴力法) lists forms of domestic violence: beating, binding, maiming, restricting personal liberty, and habitual insults and intimidation. Article 12 requires guardians to do family education in civilized ways. When parents infringe a child's rights, residents' and villagers' committees must counsel and stop them, and report serious cases to public security. Public security, procuratorates, and courts that find this must admonish the parents and may order them to accept family-education guidance (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Controversial. Almost all these studies only follow records and have no assigned controls, so they cannot show which caused which. In the spanking meta-analysis, 72% of studies only looked at whether two things appeared together, or relied on later recall. Another meta-analysis took only before-and-after follow-up studies. After subtracting the child's prior behavior, the link of spanking to externalizing problems fell to 0.07, and to internalizing to 0.10. Those authors judged the effect small. Still another meta-analysis found “conditional spanking” better than 10 of 13 other discipline methods at reducing defiance and antisocial behavior. It also found that hitting too hard or relying mainly on hitting was worse than other methods. So the opposing side can show: light, conditional spanking is not necessarily worse than other methods. Heavy hitting and frequent hitting and yelling are worse on both sides. An occasional single hit or shout is not named domestic violence in the statute, which names beating and habitual insults and intimidation. Main beneficiaries are children. If someone else in the household hits the child, police reports and protection orders are in Section 8, item 43 (personal safety protection order). Anyone who sees long-term hitting of a child in another household may dissuade or report to public security, civil affairs, or education. For a stranger's household, calling 110 or telling the residents' committee is enough — do not go in yourself to break up a fight.

## 17. If the child is hard to manage and you keep hitting or yelling, take a parenting class that teaches concrete skills

**Cost**. Parent schools run by schools and kindergartens, and online parent schools run by governments at provincial level and above, are written in law as public-interest. The evidenced programs meet weekly or every other week, 1 to 2 hours each time, from four to twenty-four weeks. Practice at home is required. The hard part is finishing and practicing every day.

**In plain terms**. For children who were already hard to manage, after parents took a class that teaches concrete skills, hitting and rule-breaking went down, and parents' mood improved. Parents also hit and yelled less — clearest right after the course, still there one to two years later but much smaller. Shanghai has tried this kind of class; it worked.

**Benefit**. Cochrane pooled 13 trials, 10 of them lot-assigned, 1078 parents. Children aged 3 to 12 all had behavior problems. Included programs met weekly or every other week, 1 to 2 hours each time, at least three sessions. Short ones ran 4 weeks straight; long ones 24 weeks. After the course, children's behavior problems fell. Parent ratings SMD −0.53 (95% CI −0.72 to −0.34, credible range); independent raters −0.44 (−0.77 to −0.11). SMD and d are the same scale; 0.5 is medium. Parent mental health improved, −0.36 (−0.52 to −0.20). Harsh or negative parenting fell: parent ratings −0.77 (−0.96 to −0.59), independent −0.42 (−0.67 to −0.16).

Authors say these are short-term effects. Another meta-analysis screened 346 lot-assigned trials; 60 measured hitting and yelling of children, across 22 countries. Hitting and yelling fell right after the course, d = −0.46 (−0.59 to −0.33). At 1 to 6 months −0.24 (−0.37 to −0.11). At 7 to 24 months −0.18 (−0.34 to −0.02), smaller later. Most of these data are parent-reported. There are domestic trials too. Shanghai randomized 81 parents; some took Triple P group classes. After the course, children's adjustment problems and parents' parenting and mood were better than waitlist parents, and still at 6 months. At a rural kindergarten, 191 caregivers took part; some self-studied online lessons plus two group discussions. Two weeks after finishing, self-reported child-abuse behaviors were about 33% lower than in those who only got a book (IRR 0.67). At three months, children's behavior problems were also lower (d = −0.40). The Family Education Promotion Law (家庭教育促进法) requires parents to study family-education knowledge on their own. Primary and secondary schools and kindergartens may run parent schools and hold regular public-interest family-education guidance. Residents' and villagers' committees may run community parent schools. Governments at provincial level and above must run public-interest online parent schools and service hotlines. Family-education guidance bodies must not organize for-profit training (nationwide, in force from 1 January 2022)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Grade A because of numbers pooled from Cochrane and multiple lot-assigned trials. Programs in the trials share a few traits. Instructors teach concrete skills — for example playing with the child, praise, rewards, and discipline. Parents practice and role-play in class and get homework. Programs that only handed out materials or only discussed were excluded, so the evidence does not cover one lecture. What domestic public parent schools teach and how varies by place and may not be this kind. When choosing a class, see whether it runs for several weeks and makes you practice concrete skills. Common program names in the two meta-analyses include Triple P and Incredible Years. This book does not recommend specific providers or paid products. The drop in hitting and yelling shrinks after one to two years; keep practicing after the course ends. Beneficiaries are the child and you. If the child already has severe mood problems, take them to psychiatry or child psychology — see item 8 of this section (depression screening).

## 18. Do not send a child to a closed “internet-addiction school” or “special training camp”: the law bans harming body or mind to treat internet addiction, and children have already been locked up until they died

**Cost**. No money, and you save the tuition. The hard part is, when the child is at their worst, parents holding back from handing them to outsiders for “closed discipline.”

**In plain terms**. The law clearly bans treating internet addiction in ways that harm a child's body or mind. At a special training school in Hefei, a boy just sent there was cuffed in a solitary room and died about 44 hours later. Yuzhang Academy (豫章书院) in Nanchang locked students in solitary; four people were sentenced, and when parents asked for tuition back the court did not support them.

**Benefit**. Article 68 of the Law on the Protection of Minors (未成年人保护法) says no organization or individual may intervene in minors' internet addiction in ways that harm minors' physical or mental health. Both cases below have court judgments. The first was in Hefei, Anhui. In August 2017, parents of an 18-year-old boy signed an agreement with a special training school to treat internet addiction. School staff took him by force, locked him in a solitary room, and cuffed both hands to the window bars. They restricted food, water, and rest, and beat him. About 44 hours later the boy died. The appraisal concluded heat, restricted posture, lack of food and drink, and trauma caused water-electrolyte disorder and death. On 31 October 2018, Hefei Intermediate Court gave the first-instance judgment. The school head was convicted of intentional injury and unlawful detention and sentenced to 16 years. Four instructors got 1 year to 8 years and 6 months. On 28 December 2018, Anhui Higher Court upheld on second instance. The second-instance ruling stated the school had no approval from the relevant departments, and none of the defendants had teaching qualifications. The second was in Nanchang, Jiangxi. Yuzhang Academy opened in 2013 and was deregistered and closed in November 2017. While open, the school took some students into a “frustration relief room” for solitary confinement with dedicated guards, three to ten days each time. On 28 April 2023, Anyuan District Court in Pingxiang retried and gave first-instance judgment: five defendants constituted unlawful detention.

Four were sentenced; Xinhua's wording was “fixed-term imprisonment ranging from two years and ten months to eleven months.” Those four were also barred for a set period from education-related work; one was exempted from criminal punishment. Parents asked for tuition and travel costs back; the court did not support them (nationwide / Anhui / Jiangxi)

**Evidence grade**. C

**Notes**. Grade C because there are only individual cases, no statistics on how often such schools go wrong. The Hefei case exists only in media reports that cite the first-instance judgment and second-instance ruling; the judgment text was not found on the court website. The Yuzhang Academy case is a Xinhua report of the court pronouncement. If a child loves games, first follow item 14 of this section (when a child loves games) and see whether sleep, homework, and going out are squeezed out. If grades, sleep, and family ties all collapse and talk will not stop it, take the child to psychiatry or child psychology for diagnosis and then treatment. If already sent in, bring the child home. If the child says they were locked up or beaten, call the police. The beneficiary is the child.

## 19. Teach a child which body parts are private; if someone touches them or asks them to keep a secret, they must tell you at home; when they tell, believe them first, do not scold, and take them to report and seek care

**Cost**. No money. A few words while bathing or changing clothes, then ask again now and then. The hard parts are parents being shy to name body parts, and when the child really speaks, holding back anger and not scolding them.

**In plain terms**. Children who took anti-sexual-abuse classes clearly did more self-protection moves in drills with a pretend stranger. What they learned was still there half a year later, and they did not become more fearful. Whether real abuse falls has not been measured. Among people who sexually abuse children, acquaintances make up a high share, so teach which places others must not touch, and that if touched or told to keep a secret, they come home and say so.

**Benefit**. Cochrane in 2015 pooled 24 trials of school anti-sexual-abuse classes, 5802 students aged 5 to 18. Most classes taught a few things: safety rules, the body belongs to you, which parts are private. They also taught which touches are not OK, which secrets must not be kept, and whom to tell. Many classes stressed that if something happens it is not the child's fault. First, whether children protect themselves. Researchers had people pretend to be strangers and lure children — 2 trials, 102 people. Those who took the class did protective moves with OR 5.71 (95% CI 1.98–16.51, credible range), about 5.7 times those who did not. Converted from the original: about 390 of 1000 without the class managed it, about 795 with the class. Next, knowledge. 18 trials, 4657 people, questionnaire scores SMD 0.61 (0.45–0.78); 0.5 is medium. At half a year still 0.69 (0.51–0.87). 3 studies, 795 people, looked at harm: children's anxiety and fear did not rise or fall (SMD −0.08, −0.22 to 0.07). 3 studies, 1788 people, looked at whether children disclose. Disclosing that they had been sexually abused OR 3.56 (1.13–11.24), from about 4 per 1000 to about 14. But children in the same class and school are alike; after correcting for that, the difference was no longer clear (OR 3.04, 0.75–12.33). Evidence quality for all outcomes was moderate. Authors state that whether these classes truly reduce sexual abuse needs long follow-up. UNESCO and five other UN agencies issued sexuality-education guidelines in 2018. They recommend teaching names of body parts, including genitals, from ages 5 to 8. They also teach which body parts are private. If someone touches them and they feel uncomfortable, say “no,” leave, then tell a trusted adult. The guidelines state sexual abuse is never the victim child's fault — including when done by acquaintances, trusted people, or family. People's Daily's anti-sexual-abuse handbook gives a memorable line: places covered by a vest and shorts, others must not look at or touch. Article 16 of the Law on the Protection of Minors (未成年人保护法) requires parents to give children safety education and raise self-protection awareness and ability. Article 40 requires schools and kindergartens to run age-appropriate sexuality education. If schools or kindergartens find sexual assault or harassment, they must not conceal it and must report promptly to public security and education. In 2020 the Supreme People's Procuratorate and eight other departments built a mandatory-reporting system. People who must report include staff at schools, kindergartens, hospitals, childcare, residents' and villagers' committees, hotels, and similar. If in their work

they find a child has been or is suspected to have been harmed, they must report to public security at once. Situations to report include: suspected abnormal injury to genitals or private parts; a girl under 14 suspected of sexual assault, pregnancy, or abortion. The reporter's identity is kept confidential. If reporting leads to a dispute, the reporter bears no legal liability. In 2025 procuratorates prosecuted 42873 people for rape, child molestation, and other sexual crimes against minors, 5.5% fewer than the prior year. That was 58.9% of prosecuted crimes against minors. Of cases prosecuted that year against minors, 3852 had leads from mandatory reporting, 7.1%. A 2025 opinion from the Supreme People's Court and 15 other departments says acquaintance offenders make up a high share in such cases. Some young children lack awareness, and guardians pay little attention, so a child may be sexually abused without knowing it (nationwide / multi-country)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because the numbers all come from school classes and measure knowledge and moves in drills, not how much real abuse fell. Parent teaching at home has no separate trial. Benefit is set small because there are only these substitute measures, not a figure for how many percent real abuse fell. Teach as above: use the real names of body parts, and say which are private. Also say that anyone who tells them to keep a secret and not tell mom or dad must be told about at home, and they will not be scolded for saying it. When the child speaks, treat it as true first — do not grill them on whether they made it up, and do not scold. The law requires teachers and doctors to report on “suspected”; parents need not wait until sure. Tell them it is not their fault, then dial 110. Before a forensic exam, do not bathe them or change their clothes — see Section 13, item 42 (after sexual assault). Who the other person is does not matter; relatives and teachers are still reported. Legal consequences when the other person is under 14 are in Section 9, item 18 (other person under 14). If a friend's child tells you, tell their parents and report together. For a stranger's child, dial 110 and leave it to police — do not go settle it yourself. The law states anyone may report to public security. The beneficiary is the child.

## 20. Do not let a child under 12 ride a bicycle on the road, or under 16 ride an e-bike on the road: if they hit someone, parents pay; if they are hit, they may still bear a share

**Cost**. No money, but you need another way to get to school — parent pickup, bus, or walking. The hard part is classmates all riding and the child pushing back.

**In plain terms**. You must be 12 to ride a bicycle on the road, and 16 to ride an e-bike. A 14-year-old scanned their mother's code for a shared e-bike, hit someone into grade-10 disability, and the court ordered the parents to pay about 187000 yuan. An under-age child who is hit — even when the other side is fully at fault — has still been ordered by courts to bear a share.

**Benefit**. Article 72 of the Implementation Regulations of the Road Traffic Safety Law (道路交通安全法实施条例) says that on roads “driving a bicycle or tricycle requires full age 12.” The same article says “driving an electric bicycle or a motorized wheelchair for persons with disabilities requires full age 16.” Violation under Article 89 of the Road Traffic Safety Law (道路交通安全法) means a warning or a fine of 5 to 50 yuan; refusing the fine can mean the vehicle is seized. The fine is small; what matters is the bill after a crash. Article 1188 of the Civil Code (民法典) says when a minor causes harm to another, the guardian bears tort liability. If the child has their own property, pay from that first; any shortfall the guardian pays. Lianjiang County Court in Fujian decided one case. In May 2022, a child just turned 14 used the mother's account to scan and rent a shared e-bike. They hit a person on an e-bike; the other side had grade-10 disability, and traffic police found the child fully at fault. The rental firm and insurer said the user agreement requires age 16 or above, so the child was not a lawful rider and they would not pay. The court ordered the child's parents to pay about 187000 yuan (exact figure 187017.83 yuan). Being hit while under age also costs. A Beijing judge wrote up a case: a 10-year-old riding a bicycle after school was hit by an e-bike into grade-10 disability; traffic police found the other side fully at fault. Article 1173 of the Civil Code says if the injured party was at fault for the harm, the tortfeasor's liability may be reduced. On that basis the court found the child under 12 on the road and the guardian failing to stop it, and ordered the child's side to bear a share of the loss. Injuries can also be

worse. An Israeli trauma center admitted 337 children with traffic injuries from 2014 to 2016. Among those hurt on e-bikes, brain injury was 13%; on ordinary bikes, 3%. After other factors were included, the chance of more severe injury was about 2.6 times that of ordinary bikes (OR 2.56, 95% CI 1.1–5.88, credible range) (nationwide / Fujian / Beijing / Israel)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because the statutes and both judgments were checked, but injury figures come from one hospital abroad, and no domestic age-broken casualty stats were found. The Lianjiang case is a reprint from a justice-bureau legal-education column; the judgment text was not found. Benefit is set large by the money measure using that case's 187000 yuan award — not every crash pays that much. Shared e-bike user agreements also require age 16 or above; do not give your account to a child to scan. Once of age, still wear a helmet — see Section 1, item 2 (wear a helmet and buckle it) and Section 22, item 12 (wear a helmet when mountain biking). Main beneficiaries are children; those who pay are the parents.

## 21. If a child hits their head in sport and then has headache, dizziness, or fogginess, do not put them back in that day; if they keep vomiting, grow sleepier, or the headache keeps getting worse, go to emergency at once

**Cost**. No money. Take the child out; no more practice or competition that day. The hard part is a tight game, the child saying “I'm fine,” and coaches and parents wanting them back in.

**In plain terms**. Children who keep playing after concussion take on average 44 days to recover; those taken out at once about 22 days. If something is off after a head hit, do not play again that day — wait until a doctor says yes. Repeated vomiting, growing sleepiness and not waking, headache getting worse, slurred speech, or seizures are signals to go to emergency at once.

**Benefit**. Concussion is a temporary disruption of brain function after a head hit; imaging usually shows nothing. A U.S. study followed 69 athletes with sport concussion, mean age about 15. The 35 taken out at once recovered in a mean 22.0 days. The 34 who kept playing with symptoms recovered in a mean 44.4 days (P=0.003; unlikely to be chance). Those who kept playing had 8.80 times the chance of recovery dragging past 21 days versus those taken out. A 2022 Amsterdam international sport-concussion meeting issued a consensus. It says loss of consciousness, seizures, unsteadiness, confusion, behavior change, or inability to remember events means immediate removal. Those people should not return to competition or training that day. The exception is when experienced medical staff check on the spot and confirm it is not from concussion. CDC guidance for parents and coaches is more direct: with suspected symptoms, leave at once, do not return that day, wait until a doctor says return is OK. It also says do not judge severity yourself — only medical staff can assess. It lists signals for emergency care at once: seizures; not recognizing people or places; repeated nausea and vomiting; odd behavior, growing confusion or agitation. Also growing sleepiness after passing out and not waking when called; slurred speech, weak or numb limbs. And headache that keeps getting worse without relief; unequal pupils or double vision (U.S. / multi-country)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because the keep-playing and leave groups were not assigned by lot, and numbers are small. Benefit is set large from recovery days roughly halved. The consensus also says less screen time for the first two days, light activity such as walking is OK, and after 24 to 48 hours increase slowly as tolerated. But sports with collision or fall risk wait until a doctor says yes. Helmets for cycling and skiing are in Section 22, item 12 (wear a helmet when mountain biking). Head bumps in elders that show problems only weeks later are in Section 13, item 10 (elder who hit their head). The beneficiary is the child.

# 31. What options are available after turning 18?

This section deals with money and time, while the option of avoiding military service also affects personal freedom. It serves as a roadmap of possible paths, not a step-by-step guide for any single one. First, we list the legal requirements for each path. Then we describe the details that become relevant only after you decide to pursue them: what benefits military service provides, other ways to enter the civil service besides the civil service exam, which college majors directly lead to government positions, how to later upgrade your education, what kind of employers to seek for overseas work, how to handle social insurance without a formal job, and whether there are government loans that cover part of the interest for those lacking startup capital.

Let us be clear: after turning 18 there are many more options than those covered here. We only include paths for which nationwide official documents specify eligibility criteria, requirements, and benefits. Paths such as joining state-owned enterprises, working in factories, becoming a seafarer, pursuing freelance work, or continuing high school or university lack such uniform documentation. They are certainly possible, but without verifiable legal references we cannot describe their conditions in this book.

Choosing a path is entirely up to you. This section provides two things only: the official documents that set the eligibility rules, and the deadlines and qualifications that expire once you start down a particular route. How to weigh the decision between studying and working, and how to pick relevant skills, is explained in Section 23. Overtime pay, workplace injuries, and severance after joining a job are covered in Section 19. Starting or closing a business is discussed in Section 12. Studying abroad is the topic of Section 32, while safety nets for the unemployed are outlined in Section 7. None of those topics are repeated here.

## 1. Check the thresholds first: for most of the 12 paths, age and education are written into the documents

**Cost**. No money. Take 10 minutes and check whether you can reach them.

**In plain terms**. The thresholds of these 12 paths are, for the most part, written in the documents. Paid work requires age 16 or older. For the military, men must be 18 or older, and college graduates can be relaxed to 24. The civil service exam generally requires age 18 to 35 and a junior-college education or above. The self-study exam has no limit on age or prior education, but full-time students cannot register. A sole proprietorship only requires "the capacity to operate a business."

**Benefit**. For the military, the Military Service Law says: "Male citizens who have reached 18 shall be called up for active service; those not called up that year may still be called up before they reach 22. The call-up age for graduates of ordinary higher-education institutions may be relaxed to 24, and for graduate students to 26." For the civil service, see Article 18 of the Regulations on the Recruitment of Civil Servants. The application conditions include "age 18 or older and under 35" and "a junior-college education or above." Both may be adjusted with approval from the civil service authority at provincial level or above. Article 19 lists 5 categories of people who may not apply. Examples are people who have received a criminal penalty for a crime, people expelled from public office, and people listed as targets of joint punishment for breach of trust. For firefighters, see the Measures for Recruiting Firefighters of the National Comprehensive Fire and Rescue Teams. Article 5: "age 18 or older and under 22" and "a high-school education or above." Article 6: "people with a junior-college education or above, and discharged soldiers of the People's Liberation Army and the People's Armed Police… the age may be relaxed to 24." For military civilian posts, see Article 9 of the Regulations on Civilian Personnel of the Chinese People's Liberation Army. The basic conditions include "having reached 18." Article 19 of those regulations says that the maximum age for a first recruitment into a lower-rank post is 35. A lower-rank post is an entry-level post. For public institutions, see Article 8 of the Regulations on Personnel Management of Public Institutions: "Newly hired staff of public institutions shall be openly recruited from society." For sole proprietors, see the Regulations on Promoting the Development of Individual Industrial and Commercial Households: "Citizens with the capacity to operate a business… who register according to law as individual industrial and commercial households are covered by these regulations." For the self-study exam, see the Interim Regulations on Higher Education Self-Study

Examinations. Article 3: "Citizens of the People's Republic of China may take the higher education self-study examination under these regulations, without restriction of sex, age, ethnicity, race, or level of education already received." Article 20: "Current students of full-time schools of every type and level may not register." For government-funded teacher-training students, see Article 2 of the Implementation Measures for Government-Funded Education of Teacher-Training Students on a Bachelor's-to-Master's Track at Normal Universities Directly under the Ministry of Education. Recruitment is only at 6 normal universities under the ministry: Beijing Normal University, East China Normal University, Northeast Normal University, Central China Normal University, Shaanxi Normal University, and Southwest University. The bachelor's and graduate stages are designed as one track and assessed in stages. After the bachelor's, you continue into the graduate program. Tuition and housing during school are borne by central finance, and there is also a living stipend. Article 5: "Recruitment of government-funded teacher-training students uses early-batch admission," meaning they are admitted before the regular batch. For targeted medical students, see the Notice on Doing Well the Employment Placement and Contract Performance of Rural Order-Based Tuition-Free Medical Students. It says: "After admission, and before receiving the admission notice, an agreement must be signed with the training school and with the county health department… and the human resources and social security department of the place of directed employment." For working abroad, see the Regulations on the Administration of Foreign Labor Cooperation. Article 5: engaging in foreign labor cooperation requires approval from the commerce authority and an operating qualification. Article 7, paragraph 4: "Without obtaining the foreign labor cooperation qualification certificate according to law and completing registration, one may not engage in foreign labor cooperation." A company without this certificate that organizes people to work abroad is itself breaking the law. Article 8, paragraph 2: "No unit or individual may organize workers to work abroad in the name of business, tourism, study, or the like." Platform orders and flexible employment have no statutory education threshold. The basis for insuring yourself and for occupational injury coverage is items 11 and 12 of this section. For paid work, the Compulsory Education Law says: "Employers are prohibited from hiring school-age children and adolescents who should be receiving compulsory education." Article 2 of the Provisions on Prohibiting the Use of Child Labor states that no one under 16 may be hired. The penalties are in section 23, item 1 (under 16).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A few paths do not have the threshold written down. The public-institution regulations only require open recruitment. Age and education are in each recruitment announcement. Platform orders have no statutory education threshold. The age and education for the civil service exam can be adjusted with approval from the authority at provincial level or above. After you can reach the threshold, you still have to pass political conditions, the physical examination, and the political assessment. Those have no public scoring standard, and they cannot be looked up in the articles. The entrance for secondary vocational schools, technician colleges, and vocational through-train admissions is in section 23, item 5. Aid when the family cannot pay is in section 23, item 4. A sole proprietorship does not look at education. That does not mean opening a shop is easy. Capital, a personal guarantee, and the cost of closing and leaving are in section 12. A personal guarantee means that if the company cannot pay, you have to pay. Whether the startup money can be borrowed as a loan on which the state pays part of the interest is in item 16 of this section. The government-funded teacher path and the targeted medical student path are set on the day college preferences are filled in. The price is written in item 13. The threshold for working abroad is not on you. It is on whether the company has the qualification. How to recognize that is in item 14. Which path is more worthwhile is not compared here.

## 2. In the year you turn 18, military service registration has to be done before October (10) 31; conscript active duty is 2 years

**Cost**. No money. Registration is filled in online once, and it takes a few minutes. Actually going means 2 years full time, and during those 2 years you cannot do other work at the same time.

**In plain terms**. Military service registration is a legal duty. It is not an application to enlist, and registering does not mean you have to go. Men who turn 18 that year must finish registering online before October (10)

31. If you do not register, the county orders you to correct it by a deadline. If you still do not, it forces you to perform the military service duty and fines you. If you do enlist, conscript active duty is 2 years.

**Benefit**. Registration is in the Provisions on Military Service Registration. They say: "The military service organ of the people's government of a county, autonomous county, city without districts, or municipal district shall, before October (10) 31 each year, organize initial military service registration for male citizens in its area who reach 18 before December (12) 31 of that year." The same provisions also say: "Initial military service registration is mainly done online, completed by the citizen on the military service registration network platform." What happens if you do not register is in Article 57, paragraph 1, of the Military Service Law. That paragraph covers "refusing or evading military service registration." The penalty is: "the county people's government orders correction by a deadline; if it is not corrected in time, the county people's government forces performance of the military service duty and imposes a fine." Article 15 of the Military Service Law says the people subject to initial military service registration are "male citizens who reach 18 before December (12) 31 each year." Article 20, paragraph 2, says: "According to the needs of the armed forces, female citizens may be called up for active service under the preceding paragraph." Article 15 of the Provisions on Military Service Registration says: "According to the needs of the armed forces… female citizens who meet the conditions may be organized for reserve registration." The Military Service Law also says: "The term of active service for a conscript is 2 years." "According to the needs of the armed forces and the person's own wish, citizens who have reached 17 but are not yet 18 may be called up for active service." A non-commissioned officer "who has served 12 years, or who meets other conditions set by the state, is assigned a job by the local people's government at county level or above in the place of placement." A non-commissioned officer "who has served 30 years, or who has reached 55, or who meets other conditions set by the state, is placed in retirement." Assigning a job means the government gives you a job. Retirement placement means you step down under retirement rules. The Regulations on Conscription say: "Priority goes to ensuring the call-up of graduates of ordinary higher-education institutions and of recruits with special requirements for political quality, physical condition, or professional skill." Those regulations also say: "Where the person to be called up is a full-time student or a graduating student of an ordinary higher-education institution, the call-up may be at the place of household registration before enrollment, or at the place of the school" (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Registration and call-up are different things, and the price differs by a long way. The string of penalties that includes a ban on leaving the country for 2 years punishes only people who back out after being called up. See item 3 (refusing military service). The people the law names for initial military service registration are male only. Women are called up according to the needs of the armed forces, and they may also be registered for the reserve according to those needs. Admission of soldiers to military academies, and turning a soldier with a strong record into an officer, are written in internal military rules and cannot be looked up from outside. The Military Service Law says only 2 things: active-duty officers are selected from "active-duty soldiers with an excellent record" and similar personnel, and military academies recruiting cadets are not limited by the call-up age. This book does not give score lines or quotas.

## 3. Refusing military service after enlistment: no travel abroad, no further education, and barred from civil service and state-owned enterprises for two years

**Cost**. There is no monetary cost. The price is having to decide well in advance whether you want to serve or not.

**In plain terms**. If you sign up and then refuse to serve, and still do not correct it after being ordered to, the consequences come as a set. You cannot be hired as a civil servant, and a state-owned enterprise or a public institution cannot hire you either. For 2 years you may not leave the country, start further study, or return to school, and you are put on the list of subjects in serious breach of the duty to fulfill national defense obligations. So "sign up first and pull out if it does not work" is an expensive idea.

**Benefit**. Article 57, Paragraph 1, Item 2 of the Military Service Law explicitly states that “any conscript who refuses or evades enlistment shall be subject to penalties.” These penalties include a requirement to correct the behavior within a set timeframe; if they still refuse, the local county-level government may compel them to serve and impose a fine. Paragraph 2 adds that such individuals must also be barred from civil service roles, from employment in state-owned enterprises and public institutions, and from any travel abroad or further education for two years. They are placed on a special list of those who have failed to meet defense obligations, leading to joint enforcement actions by various agencies. Article 58 extends these same penalties to active-duty personnel who deliberately evade service or desert. Those who are discharged, expelled from the military, or face criminal prosecution are subject to the same restrictions outlined in Paragraph 2 of Article 57, including a nationwide fine effective as of October 1, 2021.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This rule concerns personal freedom and employment eligibility rather than financial penalties. Only two categories of people are subject to these measures: those who refuse or evade enlistment after being called up, and those who are discharged, expelled, or criminally prosecuted after already joining the armed forces. Individuals who simply fail to register for conscription are not included; registration details are covered in Item 2. The penalties apply only when the person refuses to comply after being instructed to do so, as determined by the local county-level government. The exact amount of any fine is set locally and is not specified in this guide. This information is provided solely to illustrate the irreversible nature of the decision once enlistment is initiated; it does not serve as encouragement or discouragement regarding military service.

## 4. The 2 concrete benefits for college students who enlist: tuition covered at up to 20000 yuan a year, student status kept until 2 years after discharge, and a dedicated postgraduate plan

**Cost**. No money. After discharge, submit the materials the school asks for. It takes 1 or 2 trips.

**In plain terms**. Current students, graduating students, and newly admitted students who enlist have the tuition for their years in school paid by the state. For junior-college and undergraduate students the cap is 20000 yuan a year, and for graduate students 25000 yuan a year. If the tuition was already lower, only the amount actually paid is covered. Student status is kept during service, and you can return to school within 2 years after discharge. Postgraduate admissions have a separate plan that recruits only discharged college-student soldiers.

**Benefit**. A 2024 notice from 4 departments, including the Ministry of Finance, says college students who serve get 3 benefits: tuition compensation, state repayment of the national student loan used for tuition, and a tuition waiver. Repayment means the state pays off that student loan for you. The standard "is adjusted accordingly to no more than 20000 yuan per person per year for junior-college and undergraduate students, and no more than 25000 yuan per person per year for graduate students." The new standard applies from the autumn semester of 2024. How much is paid follows this sentence: "Apply the higher of the tuition the student actually paid and the national student loan obtained (including the principal and all interest accrued before it is fully repaid)." The next sentence is: "The part above the standard is not compensated, repaid, or waived." So the money each year is the higher of the actual tuition and the student loan, then the lower of that amount and the cap. Tuition of 5000 yuan a year is compensated at 5000 yuan. The number of years follows the years of study, not the years of service. The 2019 measures on student financial aid funds say: "Where the prescribed length of study was already completed before enlistment, that length is the period of tuition compensation or of state repayment of the national student loan; where the remaining prescribed length is completed after returning to school following discharge, that length is the period of the tuition waiver." A graduating student who enlists is compensated for the tuition of the whole program. Student status is in the Law on the Protection of Veterans. It says: "Where a service member was already admitted to an ordinary higher-education institution before enlistment, or is a student already studying at an ordinary higher-education institution, the admission qualification or student status is kept during active service. Within 2 years after discharge, enrollment or return to school is allowed, and the student may transfer to

another major at the same school under the relevant state rules." The law also says: "Higher-education institutions may, under the state's overall arrangement, recruit veterans through separately listed plans, separate admissions, and similar methods." Postgraduate study is in a 2026 notice from the General Office of the Ministry of Education. The plan is called «退役大学生士兵计划» (the plan for discharged college-student soldiers). The notice says: "It is issued separately within the total national master's enrollment plan and is used only for this purpose. It may not be shifted to the regular plan or to another special plan. Admitting institutions set… the preliminary-exam score requirement themselves (generally not higher than the preliminary-exam score requirement for regular-plan candidates in the same discipline at that institution)… Under otherwise equal conditions, candidates who served longer are admitted first." Separately listed and reserved means these places are set aside and can be used only to recruit discharged college-student soldiers. In 2026, 532 ordinary higher-education institutions carry this plan (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. There are 2 more channels. The first is an associate-to-bachelor path with the academic subjects waived: a junior-college student who enlists, finishes the junior-college program after discharge, may apply for an exam-exempt associate-to-bachelor admission. The school tests vocational skills and then admits the stronger candidates. This applies from the 2022 admissions. The specific method is in that year's provincial notice. The second is 10 extra points on the postgraduate preliminary exam: a discharged college-student soldier who takes the postgraduate exam within 3 years after discharge has 10 points added to the preliminary-exam total. If you apply under the special plan, the points are not added. They cannot be used together. Someone who has received a second-class merit or higher may apply to enter a master's program without the preliminary exam. The list of schools carrying the special plan changes every year. In 2025 it was 523. The tuition standard has been adjusted twice: in 2019 it was 8000/12000, in autumn 2023 it became 16000/20000, and in autumn 2024 it became 20000/25000. The 2022 summary on the Ministry of Veterans Affairs site still has the earliest version. Do not copy it.

## 5. Only six scenarios allow the government to assign jobs after discharge; those opting for self-employment must register within 30 days

**Cost**. No cost involved. Simply bring your discharge certificate and visit the local Civil Affairs Bureau for veterans.

**In plain terms**. The notion that “the military guarantees job placement” no longer applies broadly. Currently, only six specific scenarios qualify for government job assignments. Most conscripts who serve two years do not fall into these categories. Those not eligible for government placement are considered self-employed, and they must register within 30 days of discharge. Failing to do so without valid reasons means they forfeit any entitlement to government assistance.

**Benefit**. Article 25 of the Regulations on Placement of Veterans specifies six circumstances under which local governments must assign jobs. These include: (1) non-commissioned officers with at least 12 years of service; (2) personnel awarded medals or honorary titles during service; (3) those receiving third-class combat merits or higher; (4) individuals receiving first-class commendations; (5) those disabled at levels 5–8 due to combat; and (6) children of martyrs. The same regulations state that local governments must complete job placement within six months of receiving discharged personnel. Employers must sign medium- or long-term contracts lasting at least three years; for non-commissioned officers with ten-plus years of service, employers must offer open-ended contracts. During the placement period, veterans receive monthly living allowances equal to the local minimum wage. If placement fails due to reasons unrelated to the veteran, they receive 80% of the average wage of comparable workers until employment is secured. Exceptions include individuals expelled from the Communist Party of China or convicted of crimes. Article 51 clarifies that self-employed veterans must register within 30 days of discharge; otherwise, they lose eligibility for government support. (Nationwide, effective 1 September 2024.)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This regulation took effect on the same date that the 2011 Regulations on Placement of Retired Soldiers (Decree No. 608 issued by the State Council and Central Military Commission) was repealed. Many

online guides still reference the outdated version, which stipulated that veterans must have earned second-class combat merits or higher in peacetime or third-class merits or higher in wartime to qualify. The 30-day registration rule applies solely to self-employed veterans; others must register “within the prescribed timeframe.” Upon registration, veterans receive a preferential treatment certificate, which serves as a prerequisite for subsequent benefits such as pensions, employment support, and educational grants.

## 6. The 3 accounts after discharge: a lump-sum discharge payment, service years counted as work seniority, and 20000 yuan a year off the tax if you work for yourself

**Cost**. No money. At discharge the military transfers out your social insurance (社保) relationship and the money. You then continue it at the social insurance agency in the place of placement (the window that handles social insurance).

**In plain terms**. After discharge there are 3 accounts. The first is a lump-sum discharge payment for people who take the self-employment path. It is paid by years of active service, and it is increased if you were decorated. The second is service years counted as work seniority, with contribution years combined with the years before enlistment and after discharge. The third is tax: if you open a shop and run a business yourself, for 3 years you pay less tax each year within a cap of 20000 yuan, and the cap can be raised by at most 20%.

**Benefit**. The first is in the Regulations on the Placement of Veterans. They say: "For discharged non-commissioned officers and conscripts who take the self-employment path, a lump-sum discharge payment is paid according to the years of active service." Who pays: "It is specially arranged by central finance. The specific standard is set by the veterans affairs department of the State Council and the political work department of the Central Military Commission together with the finance department of the State Council… and is adjusted when appropriate." The extra percentage is in 5 tiers. A medal or an honorary title adds 25%. A first-class combat merit or a first-level commendation adds 20%. A second-class combat merit, a first-class merit, or a second-level commendation adds 15%. A third-class combat merit or a second-class merit adds 10%. A fourth-class combat merit or a third-class merit adds 5%. The regulations also say: "A veteran who has not found work in time may apply according to law to the human resources and social security department at the place of hukou (户口) for unemployment insurance benefits. Years of active service are treated as insured contribution years, except for veterans placed by retirement or as dependents." Treated as contribution years means those years count as if you had paid, even though you paid nothing. The second is in the Law on the Protection of Veterans: "A veteran's years of active service are counted as work seniority, and after discharge they accumulate with the years worked at the employer." Work seniority is the number of years of work. The years of service and the years after discharge are added on. The law also says that years of active service and the pension, medical, and unemployment contribution years before enlistment and after discharge are "combined according to law," and that "the active-service experience of discharged non-commissioned officers and conscripts is treated as grassroots work experience." The Military Insurance Law: "A service member's years of active service are treated as contribution years of employee basic medical insurance, and are combined with the contribution years of employee basic medical insurance before enlistment and after leaving active service." The third is Announcement No. 14 of 2023 from the Ministry of Finance, the State Taxation Administration, and the Ministry of Veterans Affairs. The announcement covers discharged soldiers on the self-employment path who engage in individual business: "Within 3 years (36 months, the same below), deduct in order, at a cap of 20000 yuan per household per year, from the value-added tax, urban maintenance and construction tax, education surcharge, local education surcharge, and individual income tax actually payable that year. The cap may be raised by at most 20%." Deduction means subtracting in order from those taxes owed that year, down to the cap. It is not money paid to you. For an enterprise that hires them, "the fixed standard is 6000 yuan per person per year, and it may be raised by at most 50%." The period of implementation is January (1) 1, 2023 through December (12) 31, 2027. If the 3 years are not finished when the period ends, the benefit can continue until the 3 years are up (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The regulations only say the amount is set separately by the competent departments. The official figure that can be found is "4500 yuan for each full year of active service" in a 2020 article on the Ministry of Veterans Affairs website. The same article also says "adjusted when appropriate." The extra percentages in that article no longer match the current regulations. Follow the regulations. In an August (8) 2024 article, the Guizhou provincial department of veterans affairs, under the new regulations, still writes: "The standard now in force is: 4500 yuan for each full year a soldier serves." TODO (to be verified: no formal standard document was found; the confirmation only goes as far as a provincial department still writing this in August (8) 2024). Do not mix this with a local lump-sum economic subsidy. That is another sum, set and paid by the locality. For example, Yantai paid 6000 yuan for each year of service to people discharged in 2024. New figures in guides mostly have no source, and some simply mix the two sums together. During a conscript's service, the family can also receive a separate family preferential allowance. The Military Service Law only says "the standard is set by the local people's government, and central finance gives a fixed subsidy." For the amount, ask the county people's government that approved your enlistment. The tax sum is the most tax you can pay less each year, not money paid into your hands. If the business does not get going, you will not use the full amount, so the benefit magnitude of the whole item is set only at "medium." The Regulations on Promoting Employment and Entrepreneurship of Veterans, in force from August (8) 1, 2026, add a further rule: a skilled-worker occupational qualification certificate earned during service is valid nationwide after discharge.

## 7. The civil service exam is not the only way into the system: finish 2 years in a grassroots service project and you can apply for the directed recruitment plan of about 10% each year

**Cost**. No money. The price is 2 years of service at the township grassroots. Those 2 years pay a fiscal subsidy, not a market wage. The hard part is being able to stay through the 2 years.

**In plain terms**. Getting into the system is not only the civil service exam. Finish 2 years in a grassroots service project such as «三支一扶» (a named grassroots service program), and pass the assessment, and you can apply for a directed recruitment plan open only to these people. Each province is to set aside about 10% of its civil service recruitment plan each year for them. Take the postgraduate exam within 3 years and 10 points are added to the preliminary-exam total. The price is that those 2 years pay a fiscal subsidy.

**Benefit**. The notice on round 4 of the «三支一扶» plan says "the service term is 2 years." It also says: "Each province (autonomous region, municipality) shall each year set aside about 10% of the civil service recruitment plan for directed recruitment of people in the «三支一扶» plan and other projects serving the grassroots. When county and township public institutions openly recruit, they shall, according to local conditions, set aside a certain number or proportion of posts for special recruitment of people who have finished «三支一扶» service and passed the assessment… After hiring, a probation period need not be agreed." Directed recruitment and special recruitment mean these places are competed for only among people who have done a grassroots service project. Other people cannot apply. The same notice also says: "«三支一扶» participants who pass the end-of-term assessment and take the national master's entrance exam within 3 years have 10 points added to the preliminary-exam total, and are admitted first under otherwise equal conditions… Higher-vocational (junior-college) graduates who finish the term and pass the assessment may enter an adult higher-education bachelor's program starting from a junior-college credential without an exam." Entering without an exam means going on to the associate-to-bachelor program without sitting another exam. The notice also says: "People who had no work experience before joining the «三支一扶» plan, and who finish the term and pass the assessment, may within 2 years enjoy the policies for graduating students on the same terms in recruitment by government organs and by enterprises and public institutions, in starting a business, in settling hukou (户口), and in going on to further study. Years of «三支一扶» service at the grassroots count as work seniority, and the date they started work is the day they reported to the grassroots post." The central fiscal subsidy is 30000 yuan per person per year in the western region, 24000 yuan in the central region, and 12000 yuan in the eastern region. The opinion of the General Office of the CPC Central Committee and the General Office of the State Council says: "People who had no work experience before joining a grassroots service project, and who finish the service and pass the assessment,

may within 2 years enjoy the policies for graduating college students on the same terms in recruitment by government organs and public institutions, in hiring by enterprises of every kind, in starting a business, in settling hukou, and in going on to further study." That opinion also says: "When organs at provincial level or above recruit civil servants, except for special posts, they shall, under the relevant rules, recruit only from people with 2 or more years of grassroots work experience." Another path is the western program. It is "jointly organized by the Central Committee of the Communist Youth League, the Ministry of Education, the Ministry of Finance, and the Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security." It recruits graduating college students or current graduate students "to do volunteer service at the western grassroots for 1 to 3 years" (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Round 4 of the «三支一扶» plan covers 2021 to 2025. A round 5 document and a 2026 recruitment notice were not found this time. Check that year's recruitment announcement before you apply. In 2025, central finance supported recruitment of 34430 people. The original implementation plan of the western program cannot be found online, and the policy column on the official site does not open the content. Benefits after that program ends follow the document from the General Offices of the CPC Central Committee and the State Council that covers all grassroots service projects. These 2 years pay a fiscal subsidy, not a market wage. That price has to be counted together with the directed recruitment after the 2 years. How a graduate's fresh-graduate status is recognized, and what to check before signing a job, is in item 17 of this section ("fresh graduates").

## 8. Teachers in the Special Post Program who complete three years of service, pass evaluations, and wish to stay should be promptly added to the official teaching staff

**Cost**. There is no monetary cost. The price to pay is three years of teaching in rural compulsory education schools; applicants must also obtain a teaching certificate beforehand. The real challenge lies in staying committed throughout those three years.

**In plain terms**. The Special Post program is among the few paths that write down "brought onto the regular staff when the term ends." The conditions are a bachelor's degree or above, mainly a teacher-training major, age not over 30, and the matching teacher qualification certificate. The service term is 3 years. During those 3 years, pay and treatment under the same conditions match teachers already on the regular staff of a local public school. When the 3 years end, the assessment is passed, and you are willing to stay, the document requires that you be brought onto the staff promptly.

**Benefit**. The 2024 notice regarding the Special Post Program outlines hiring criteria: applicants must hold a bachelor's degree or higher, preferably from a teacher-training background; for elementary schools, graduates from teacher-training colleges may also qualify. Age limit remains 30. A valid teaching certificate is mandatory. The notice further states that volunteers who participated in the “Western China Volunteer Program” or have prior teaching experience, as well as teacher-training graduates with at least six months of teaching internships, receive preferential treatment under equal conditions. Eligible veterans may also be considered for teaching roles in primary and secondary schools, with age limits adjusted based on their years of service. Compensation and official employment terms are defined accordingly: starting January 1, 2024, central government subsidies for Special Post teachers rose from 35,200 yuan per year in central regions to 38,800 yuan, and from 38,200 yuan in western regions to 41,800 yuan. These teachers are entitled to identical pay, professional title evaluations, awards, and annual assessments as regular teachers employed by local public schools. Upon successful completion of three years of service and passing evaluations, they must be promptly added to the official staff list, with all personnel and salary records transferred accordingly; their years of service and teaching experience are counted continuously, and no probationary period applies nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The benefit level is classified as “high” because securing official employment after completing the program represents a long-term career gain far exceeding any monetary value. The most recent publicly available document is the 2024 notice; policies for 2025 and 2026 have not yet been published. Exact postings, subsidy amounts, and age limits are determined by each province's implementation plan within the central framework. Obtaining a teaching certificate beforehand is mandatory; it serves as a prerequisite for entry, not something that can be obtained after employment begins.

## 9. Firefighters and civilian personnel in the military represent two additional pathways for public recruitment, with lower entry requirements than civil service exams

**Cost**. There is no monetary cost. The process from application to hiring involves medical exams, political background checks, physical fitness tests, psychological evaluations, and interviews, taking several months in total. The difficulty lies in the successive screening stages that eliminate candidates one by one.

**In plain terms**. Neither pathway imposes the “minimum associate degree or higher” requirement. Firefighter recruitment targets individuals aged 18–22 with at least a high school education; those with an associate degree or higher, as well as veterans, may apply up to age 24. Military civilian positions require applicants to be at least 18 years old, with entry-level roles allowing candidates up to 35 years of age. The common barrier is the rigorous political background checks and medical evaluations.

**Benefit**. For firefighters, refer to the *Measures for Recruiting Firefighters into the National Comprehensive Fire and Rescue Force*. Article 5 stipulates that applicants must be aged 18–22 and hold at least a high school diploma. Article 6 further allows candidates with an associate degree or higher, veterans, or experienced firefighters to apply up to age 24; exceptionally talented specialists may be admitted up to age 28 with approval from the Ministry of Emergency Management. Article 7 specifies that recruitment occurs primarily among local residents, though candidates from other provinces may also be considered. Article 9 outlines the full procedure: publicity, registration, eligibility checks, medical exams, political screening, physical and psychological tests, interviews, public announcements, and final hiring. Regarding military civilian roles, the *Regulations on Civilian Personnel in the Chinese People's Liberation Army* states in Article 18 that recruitment combines open examinations, direct hiring, and targeted recruitment efforts. Article 9 lists basic criteria: applicants must be at least 18 years old, meet political standards, and possess required education, expertise, and competence. Article 19 sets the maximum age limit at 35 for entry-level positions. Additionally, Article 20 emphasizes giving priority to veterans in civilian roles nationwide.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Effective August 1, 2026, the *Regulations on Promoting Employment and Entrepreneurship for Veterans* introduces two key provisions: first, a designated quota for recruiting veterans into firefighter roles; second, preferential treatment for veterans when hiring police auxiliary personnel. These pathways' exact annual quotas, specific roles, and eligibility criteria are defined in yearly announcements; this guide outlines only the unchanging baseline requirements. Firefighter roles constitute a disciplined service rather than ordinary employment, so prospective candidates must carefully weigh associated occupational risks beforehand.

## 10. A diploma does not have to be settled the first time: the self-study exam has no limit on age or prior education, the adult college entrance exam and the Open University can both fill the gap, a diploma counts only if Xuexin («学信网») can find it, and do not sign up for a "no exam, guaranteed pass" class

**Cost**. Registration fees and textbook fees are a few hundred yuan a year. The price is long-term self-study, or going to class in your spare time. A non-full-time (studying while you work) associate-to-bachelor program takes at least 2.5 years. The hard part is keeping at it.

**In plain terms**. If school did not work out at 18, there are still 3 regular routes: the self-study exam, the adult college entrance exam, and the Open University. The self-study exam has no limit on age or prior education, but full-time students cannot register. A diploma counts only if it can be found on Xuexin («学信网»). Once it can be found, the school cannot change it either. Do not pay anyone who says "no need to study" or "no exam, guaranteed pass."

**Benefit**. The self-study exam is in the Interim Regulations on Higher Education Self-Study Examinations. Article 3: "Citizens of the People's Republic of China may take the higher education self-study examination under these regulations, without restriction of sex, age, ethnicity, race, or level of education already received." Article 20: "Current students of full-time schools of every type and level may not register." Article 25 states 3 conditions for the diploma: pass every course, complete the thesis or the practical task, and pass the assessment of moral character. Meet all of them and you may receive the diploma. This article also says: "The state recognizes the education of a person who obtains a junior-college (foundation) or bachelor's diploma." Article 32 states the wage treatment of a person who obtains the diploma: "A person who was not already employed, once hired, is the same as a graduate of the same kind from an ordinary higher-education institution." Article 21 of the Higher Education Law: "The state implements the higher education self-study examination system. A person who passes the examination is issued the corresponding diploma or another academic certificate." The adult college entrance exam is in the 2025 Measures for National Admissions to Adult Higher-Education Institutions. The people who may apply are "employed people and other members of society, other than current students of high schools and secondary schools of every kind whose education the state recognizes." "A candidate for a high-school-to-bachelor or high-school-to-junior-college program shall have graduated from a senior secondary school or have an equivalent education. A candidate for an associate-to-bachelor program must already hold… a junior-college diploma, a bachelor's completion certificate, or a higher certificate." "The shortest full-time study is 4 years for high-school-to-bachelor, and 2 years for high-school-to-junior-college and for associate-to-bachelor. The shortest non-full-time study is 5 years for high-school-to-bachelor, and 2.5 years for high-school-to-junior-college and for associate-to-bachelor." Full-time means leaving work and studying at school all day. Non-full-time means not leaving work, and studying while you work. The Open University is in the Opinion of the Ministry of Education on Running Open Universities Well. It says: "An open university admits by registration. A student who finishes a course and earns the corresponding credits receives a course certificate. A student who earns the required credits and meets the related requirements receives the corresponding diploma or non-diploma certificate. A student who meets the conditions for a degree shall be awarded the corresponding degree" (nationwide). Whether a diploma is real is in the Ministry of Education Measures for Electronic Registration of Student Status and Academic Credentials in Higher Education. Article 2 states that a self-study exam diploma must also be registered electronically. Article 5: Xuexin («学信网») "is the only website for querying the electronically registered student status and academic credentials of higher-education students." Article 19: after the credential is registered and online query is provided, "the school may not change the content of the certificate or the registration information." The red line for admissions publicity is a 2021 notice from the Ministry of Education and 4 other departments. Advertising for continuing education toward a diploma "may not contain false or illegal content such as 'no need to study' or 'no need to attend class.'" It also "may not contain a guaranteed promise, explicit or implied, about the educational result, such as 'get the certificate fast,' 'no exam, guaranteed pass,' or 'a refund if you do not pass.'" Institutions such as specialized colleges and research colleges cannot issue diplomas, and advertising may not mix them up with higher-education institutions that can.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. There is also an ordinary associate-to-bachelor route for graduating full-time junior-college students. The public national document is a 2007 notice from the Ministry of Education. It says the associate-to-bachelor plan does not exceed 5% of that year's graduating junior-college students. From 2020 the Ministry of Education expanded the scale. That year's plan increased by 322000 people on the year before. Whether the 5% line is still in force was not found in writing. Each year's specific arrangement is a letter from the Department of Higher Education Students of the Ministry of Education. For example, 2026 is letter «教学司函» [2025] No. 53. The letter is not published outside. The document number can be seen only in documents

forwarded by provinces. Who may apply is set by each province. In general only that year's full-time junior-college graduates of the province itself are admitted, so the main text does not state the conditions. From autumn 2025, higher-education continuing education is no longer called "correspondence" («函授») or "spare time" («业余»). It is uniformly called "non-full-time" («非脱产»). Higher-education continuing education is the kind in which adults later fill in a diploma. Watch publicity that still uses the old names. Filling in a diploma and "which skills are worth learning" are separate matters. The latter is in section 23. Paid "get a certificate fast" and fake certificates are in section 23, item 8.

## 11. Not joining a company means you must arrange your own social insurance: you'll need to enroll in pension and medical plans at your place of work, as household registration restrictions have now been lifted

**Cost**. You must pay the full amount for both pension and medical insurance yourself, calculated based on the local contribution base — often over a thousand yuan per month. The contribution base is simply the benchmark figure used to determine premiums. This is the most easily overlooked recurring expense on this path, and the difficulty lies in making those payments on time every month.

**In plain terms**. Not being employed by a company doesn't mean you're exempt from social insurance; it simply means no employer covers half of the cost. Official documents require all regions to lift household registration barriers so flexible workers can enroll in insurance at their place of work, with major metropolises gradually implementing this change. So don't mistake “freedom” for “no need to worry about social insurance.” If you fail to pay on schedule, both your pension benefits and medical reimbursement rates will be calculated according to rules for interrupted coverage.

**Benefit**. These provisions stem from the “Guiding Opinions on Protecting the Labor Rights and Interests of Workers in New Forms of Employment.” It states: “All regions must lift household registration restrictions so flexible workers can enroll in basic pension and medical insurance at their place of work; for exceptionally large cities where full implementation isn't immediately feasible, local authorities should create conditions for gradual rollout. Employers must be urged to enroll workers in social insurance per the law. Workers who don't qualify for standard employee pension or medical plans should be guided to enroll in urban/rural resident programs to ensure full coverage. For those operating independently via platforms, rights and obligations are governed by civil law.” (National policy, effective 2021)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The wording “lift restrictions” leaves room for exceptions in very large cities — it doesn't mean household registration rules are completely abolished nationwide. Exact implementation details depend on the specific city where you intend to enroll. The benefit is rated “high” because interrupted coverage directly impacts long-term pension and medical benefits, which far outweigh the monthly costs. Yet those costs are real too: full self-payment often exceeds a thousand yuan per month. For information on how to restore interrupted coverage and accumulate years of service, see Section 7, Article 18 (“Interrupted Social Insurance Payments”). If you move to another city, how your pension and medical insurance records transfer is in Section 19, item 19 (transferring pension and medical insurance to the new place of enrollment). Which tier of employee pension to pay into, and how many years you must collect before you break even, is in Section 5, item 46 (paying into the employee pension yourself). Additionally, selling agricultural or daily goods at government-designated locations/times, or offering services that legally require no license, doesn't necessitate a business license per State Council Document No. 27 (2020).

## 12. Food delivery workers, ride-hailing drivers, and local freight carriers all get occupational injury coverage paid for by the platform on a per-order basis — at no cost to them

**Cost**. Zero out-of-pocket expense; the platform bears the entire premium. Your only task is to verify whether the platform you use is part of the pilot program. Two easy ways to do this: check the “Occupational Injury

Coverage” section in the app's benefits page, or call your provincial Human Resources and Social Security Bureau to ask if the platform is enrolled.

**In plain terms**. Platforms must pay occupational injury insurance premiums for every order placed by delivery workers, ride-hailing drivers, and local freight carriers — none of that cost falls on the workers themselves. This is still a pilot scheme, so before accepting any orders, confirm that both your province and your platform are included. Workers who already have a formal employment contract with a platform are covered under regular workers' compensation, not this program.

**Benefit**. The coverage is governed by the “Interim Measures for Occupational Injury Insurance for Workers in New Forms of Employment.” Article 2 states: “Platform enterprises shall enroll in occupational injury insurance for new-form workers as required by these measures… ensuring coverage for every order and every worker who registers via the platform and receives compensation for services such as ride-hailing, delivery, and local freight.” Article 9 specifies premium rates during the trial phase: 0.01 yuan per order for ride-hailing, 0.07 yuan and 0.25 yuan per order for delivery, and 0.18 yuan per order for local freight. Starting July 1 2025, the pilot expanded to ten additional provinces, and by 2026 it is slated to cover all 31 provinces and the Xinjiang Production and Construction Corps.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This remains a pilot program, not a nationwide mandatory system. Before taking any orders, verify that your province and platform are part of it; otherwise you'll need to purchase private insurance on your own. The “Guiding Opinions on Protecting Labor Rights of Workers in New Forms of Employment” also mandates that platforms pay wages no lower than the local minimum, pay on time and in full, and provide fair compensation on statutory holidays. The document's reference number is HRSSB [2021] 56; it is cited in Article 11 regarding flexible-employment workers. In any dispute, follow these rules rather than settling privately with the platform. For medical insurance and pension contributions, flexible-employment workers must enroll separately — see Article 11 for details.

## 13. Two paths that can largely lock in a staff post on the day you fill in college preferences: government-funded teacher-training students and targeted medical students, at the cost of 6 years of service

**Cost**. You do not pay tuition or housing, and you also receive a living stipend. The price is that for 6 years after graduation you cannot freely choose a job. Breaking the contract means paying the money back, paying liquidated damages, and a mark on the credit record. The hard part is that you cannot change place during these 6 years.

**In plain terms**. Both paths are the state paying first, and you then working for 6 years at the assigned place after graduation, under the agreement. Government-funded teacher-training students are recruited only at 6 normal universities directly under the Ministry of Education, in the early admission batch. Targeted medical students must sign a 3-party agreement before they receive the admission notice. Breaking the contract means paying the money back, paying liquidated damages, and a mark on the credit record. Decide whether you can accept these 6 years before you fill in preferences.

**Benefit**. Government-funded teacher-training students are in the Implementation Measures for Government-Funded Education of Teacher-Training Students on a Bachelor's-to-Master's Track at Normal Universities Directly under the Ministry of Education (2024; the 2018 measures were repealed at the same time). Article 2: central finance bears the student's tuition and housing during school and gives a living stipend. Article 3: training is mainly for places at prefecture (city, autonomous prefecture, league) level and below, outside provincial capitals, in the central and western regions. It also says placement "may not be directed to a municipality directly under the central government, a city specifically designated in the state plan, or the main urban area of a provincial capital (except the 5 autonomous regions, provinces on a land border, Hainan, Guizhou, and Qinghai)." Article 9: after graduation, generally return to teach in a primary or secondary school in the directed prefecture (city, autonomous prefecture, league) of the source province, and "promise to work in primary and secondary education for 6 years or more." A person assigned to an urban

school "shall teach and serve for at least 1 year in a rural compulsory-education school." Article 13: a person who does not perform, or whose performed term falls short, bears liability under the agreement. A consequence is that "the breach is entered in the credit record, shared in time with the national credit-information sharing platform, and the materials on the breach are placed in the person's personnel file." Another sentence is: "Before the service task is completed, the person may not teach outside the directed prefecture (city, autonomous prefecture, league), and may not be recruited as other public personnel. After the service task is completed, the related credit is restored." Before the agreed service period is finished, other public posts cannot be applied for. After it is finished, the credit record is restored. Article 6: if an assessment after admission finds the person unsuitable to teach, within 1 year of enrollment the government-funded education expenses already received are returned, and the person is transferred to a non-teacher-training major. Article 14: if the master-of-education degree certificate and the teacher qualification certificate are not obtained within the prescribed length of study, it is treated as a breach: the fees are returned and liquidated damages are paid. Article 21: localities, within the existing total of public-institution posts, provide the posts needed for government-funded teacher-training graduates to teach in primary and secondary schools. Article 12 says the prefecture organizes the employing schools for a special recruitment of government-funded teacher-training students, and "by each side choosing the other, and by similar methods, a teaching school and a post are actually assigned to each graduating government-funded teacher-training student." Order-based tuition-free medical students directed to rural posts are in another notice. After admission, and before receiving the admission notice, an agreement must be signed with the training school and with the county health department and the human resources and social security department of the place of directed employment. The agreement must "promise to serve for 6 years after graduation at the directed rural primary-level medical institution." Performing the contract means working the full term at the assigned place under the agreement. On posts, the notice says the provincial health department "shall actively seek support from the local staffing department and, within the local total of posts, according to the prescribed procedure, properly resolve employment and placement of the targeted medical graduates." Those who report for work in the central and western regions are specially recruited by the county, which "completes the formal hiring procedures of a public-institution staff member." After reporting for work under the agreement, the graduate must take 3 years of standardized residency training in general practice, called residency training for short. Residency training is the stage after graduation in which you keep training in a hospital to a uniform standard. During training the original personnel relationship and wage relationship do not change. A breach record goes into the personal personnel file, and it is a basis for the integrity assessment in open recruitment by medical institutions and other administrative and public institutions, in recruitment for standardized residency training, and in postgraduate admission. A person who breaches in bad faith is publicized nationwide on the Credit China website («信用中国») and is subject to joint punishment for breach of trust. Years of training that are a breach are not counted in the service period. If the fees and liquidated damages are not returned under the agreement, the county health department recovers them through legal channels (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The 2024 measures changed government-funded teacher-training students to a bachelor's-to-master's track (finish the bachelor's and continue to a master of education). The 2018 measures are already repealed. "Teach right after the bachelor's," still circulating online, is the old wording. An agreement signed before the measures were issued follows the original agreement. "Having a post" does not mean "once in, nothing more is asked." The post has to be found inside the existing total. The specific post is a special recruitment organized by the employing schools of the prefecture, and you and the school choose each other. For targeted medical students, the document only says the authorities should seek support and resolve it properly. Provinces do it differently. Read the provincial document before filling in preferences. A targeted medical student may leave when the service period ends. The document says: "When the service period is completed, a person who chooses a job independently shall be allowed to." There is also a way to clear a breach record that already exists. The price is to serve at least another 6 years under the original agreement, or after moving to another rural primary-level institution in the province. Fees and liquidated damages already paid are not refunded. Medical students also have to count the 3 years of residency training. The whole cycle is longer than for teachers. Provinces also have their own government-funded teacher plans and targeted

medical student plans. The conditions are set by the province. Read that year's provincial admissions document before filling in preferences.

## 14. Before going abroad to work, check whether the company has a license for international labor cooperation: it is illegal for them to demand a deposit from you

**Cost**. No cost at all. Spend just a few minutes beforehand verifying the company's credentials and reading through both contracts.

**In plain terms**. When it comes to working overseas, the law regulates not the workers themselves but the companies that arrange their employment. Only businesses holding a valid license for international labor cooperation and properly registered may recruit workers for foreign jobs. Any claim such as “first obtain a tourist visa and later switch to a work visa” is a clear sign of illegal activity. Moreover, employers are strictly prohibited from charging any kind of deposit or demanding collateral from workers.

**Benefit**. Article 5 of the Regulations on International Labor Cooperation states that companies must obtain approval from provincial or municipal commerce authorities before engaging in such activities; this approval results in a specific operating license. Article 7 mandates that the list of licensed firms be submitted to national authorities and shared with Chinese embassies and consulates abroad. Article 8 explicitly bans any entity from using business trips, tourism, or study abroad programs as a guise for labor export. Within five working days of registration, firms must deposit at least 3 million RMB into a designated fund intended to cover unpaid wages, service fees, and compensation for injuries or emergencies. This fund may also be tapped to repatriate workers in crisis situations. Articles 11, 12, and 13 forbid employment in gambling or adult entertainment venues, require mandatory pre-departure training, and mandate personal accident insurance coverage while abroad. Contracts must be signed separately with both foreign employers and workers; failure to do so renders any recruitment illegal. Article 25 reiterates the ban on deposits or property pledges. All agreements must be filed with commerce authorities within ten days, and companies must assist workers in securing compensation when contractual terms are violated. Article 31 allows authorities to halt recruitment to regions deemed unsafe, while Article 37 establishes a public registry of non-compliant firms. Using a business trip, tourism, or study as cover, lending the license, or organizing work in gambling or pornography leads to revocation of the operating qualification. Organizing a departure without a signed contract, or while hiding information or giving false information, draws a fine of 100000 to 200000 yuan, and 20000 to 50000 yuan for the person in charge.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This entry outlines the lawful pathway for overseas employment. Legitimate procedures require the company to sign a labor cooperation agreement with a foreign employer, followed by a written service or employment contract with the worker detailing duties, pay, working hours, leave entitlements, social insurance, and safety measures. Within ten days, the firm must register these documents with authorities and provide language, safety, and cultural training. Personal accident insurance is mandatory. Red flags include refusal to show contracts, demands for deposits, or pressure to bypass proper paperwork. For information on high-paying overseas job scams and fraud hubs, see Section 21, item 5; safety advisories and contact details for the 12308 consular hotline are also listed there. The regulations impose no specific educational or age prerequisites on workers; eligibility hinges on both corporate licensing and host-country requirements. Contracts may only be concluded with approved foreign enterprises, never private individuals. The aforementioned financial reserve cannot be withdrawn by workers; it serves solely as a safety net for unpaid claims. Should problems arise, workers retain the right to file complaints with commerce authorities per Article 20. Projects sending more than 100 personnel to a single destination must also assign on-site supervisors and notify local embassies or consulates. Smaller groups lack such safeguards, so workers should retain all contracts and payment records as proof of their legal status.

## 15. Working remotely for a foreign company from home: this income is considered domestic earnings for tax purposes; you must file your own individual income tax returns, and incoming payments should be reported as “employee compensation”

**Cost**. There are no direct expenses. You must file an annual tax reconciliation between March 1 and June 30 of the following year. If your annual inflow exceeds the permitted limit, you'll also need to provide an employment contract and proof of earnings. The main difficulty lies in remembering to file this tax yourself.

**In plain terms**. Whether this money counts as domestic or foreign depends on where you do the work, not on where the money is sent from. If you are in China and work remotely for a company outside China, it counts as domestic income, and you pay individual income tax in China. If that company has no establishment in China, nobody withholds the tax for you, and you have to file it yourself. Money coming in goes through the route called employee remuneration (职工报酬).

**Benefit**. Whether this income qualifies as domestic earnings is determined by Article 3 of the Implementing Regulations of the Individual Income Tax Law (Decree No. 707 issued by the State Council, effective January 1, 2019). It states: “Unless otherwise stipulated by financial or tax authorities under the State Council, the following types of earnings are regarded as originating in China, regardless of where payment is made: (1) earnings derived from providing services within China through employment, engagement, or contractual obligations.” Article 6 of the same regulations defines two relevant tax categories. Wages and salaries are defined as “any compensation, bonuses, year-end incentives, labor dividends, allowances, subsidies, and other earnings related to employment or engagement.” Meanwhile, “labor remuneration” refers to “any income earned through personal services such as design, decoration, installation, drafting, testing, medical work, legal services, accounting, consulting, teaching, translation, editing, calligraphy, sculpture, film production, recording, performance, advertising, exhibitions, technical assistance, brokerage, agency work, and similar activities.” According to Article 6 of the Individual Income Tax Law, the taxable base for residents is calculated by subtracting 60,000 RMB, mandatory deductions, additional allowances, and other legally permitted deductions from total annual earnings. However, for labor remuneration specifically, a 20% expense is deducted and only 80% of the gross amount is the income amount — wages and salaries are taxed at 100% of their full value. Article 9 clarifies that taxpayers are responsible for paying income tax, while employers or payers serve as withholding agents. Article 10 specifies that taxpayers must file returns under several circumstances, including when no withholding agent exists or when foreign earnings are received. Annual reconciliation must be completed between March 1 and June 30 of the following year. Regarding currency inflows, Article 9 of the Administrative Measures on Personal Foreign Exchange (issued by the People's Bank of China, Decree No. 3 of 2006, effective February 1, 2007) establishes an annual cap of USD 50,000 per individual for non-commercial foreign exchange transactions. Within this limit, individuals may exchange currency using only valid identification; exceeding it requires additional documentation such as employment contracts and proof of income. Article 7 further prohibits banks and individuals from circumventing these limits through split transactions or falsified documents. The detailed implementation rules (Document No. 1 issued in 2007) reiterate this annual cap and specify that employee compensation must be supported by a valid contract and income verification.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Which tax category applies depends on your relationship with the foreign employer. If you've signed an employment contract and follow their instructions, your earnings are classified as wages and salaries. If you're contracted independently and deliver results on a project basis, they're treated as labor remuneration. These two categories are taxed differently, so it's essential to determine which applies before filing. For incoming payments under USD 50,000 per year, you can exchange currency simply by presenting your ID. Any amount exceeding this threshold requires submission of your employment contract and income proof to the bank. Avoid attempting to split payments artificially to bypass these limits. This guidance applies strictly to individuals working from within China without physically relocating abroad. Those who actually move overseas to work for foreign firms must follow different regulations, as outlined in Section 14 of this chapter (check first whether the employer holds proper licensing for overseas labor deployment). Four related topics

are not addressed in this book due to lack of verifiable evidence: whether VAT applies or if invoices must be issued; whether long-term remote workers should obtain a business license or register as self-employed; whether labor laws permit claims for vacation time, overtime pay, or severance from foreign employers; and issues concerning cross-border data transfer and confidentiality. A total of 2006 RMB is the maximum annual limit for personal foreign exchange transactions under these rules.

## 16. If you work for yourself instead of joining an employer, look first at a startup guarantee loan for the startup money: up to 300000 yuan for an individual, with public finance covering half the interest

**Cost**. Asking costs nothing. Go once to the human resources and social security department for an eligibility review, then complete the procedure once at the guarantee agency and once at the handling bank (the bank that makes the loan). The hard part is that borrowed money still has to be repaid.

**In plain terms**. If you are in a priority group such as college graduates, veterans, or unemployed people, and you are borrowing to get started, look at this loan with a fiscal interest subsidy first. An individual can borrow up to 300000 yuan, for at most 3 years, and public finance pays half the interest. When you apply, you and your spouse cannot have another loan in your names. A home loan, a car loan, a student loan, and a consumer loan of 50000 yuan or less do not count.

**Benefit**. The conditions for an individual application are in Article 6 of the Measures for the Administration of Special Funds for Inclusive Finance Development («财金» [2023] No. 75). The first condition is belonging to a priority employment group. The document lists registered urban unemployed people, people with difficulty finding work (including people with disabilities), veterans, and people who have completed a prison sentence. It also lists college graduates (including college-graduate village officials and students who have returned from study abroad), and workers and unemployed people from enterprises cutting overcapacity. It also lists migrant workers returning home to start a business, online merchants, people who have left poverty, and rural residents starting a business on their own. The second condition is having no other loan in your name: "Apart from student loans, small credit for people who have left poverty, housing loans, car loans, and small consumer loans of 50000 yuan or less (including credit-card spending), when the applicant submits the application for a startup guarantee loan, the applicant and the applicant's spouse have no other loan." Article 9: "For a startup guarantee loan that meets the conditions, the finance department gives a fiscal interest subsidy of 50% of the actual interest rate on the loan. For a startup guarantee loan that is extended or overdue, the finance department in principle gives no interest subsidy." The subsidy means public finance pays half the interest for you. An extension is pushing the date back after it falls due. Overdue is failing to repay on time. In both of those cases, public finance no longer pays. Article 10: for an individual startup guarantee loan of 100000 yuan or less that is included, counter-guarantee is in principle cancelled. You do not have to find someone else, or put up property, as security for the guarantee agency. Article 11: an individual startup guarantee loan included in the award-and-subsidy support "does not exceed 300000 yuan, and the loan term does not exceed 3 years." A partnership may be raised appropriately, up to 110% of the sum of the individual caps. The interest-rate cap on loans supported by the award-and-subsidy program is in tiers: LPR+50 BPs in the eastern region, LPR+150 BPs in the central and western regions, and LPR+250 BPs in areas that have left poverty. LPR is the loan prime rate quoted by banks. BPs are the unit used to measure the interest rate. The more that is added, the higher the interest. A person who "repays actively, is strong at bringing other people into work, and has a good business project" may apply again when the term ends, up to 3 times in total. Article 8: the applicant first applies to the local human resources and social security department for an eligibility review, then submits the application to the guarantee agency and the handling bank. Article 12: with the agreement of the provincial people's government, localities may widen the scope of support, raise the cap, and raise the subsidy ratio (nationwide).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Public finance paying half the interest does not change the fact that borrowed money has to be repaid. The position in section 12, item 1 of this book has not changed: start a business only with money you can afford to lose, do not touch the family's base, do not sign a personal guarantee for a company loan, and a

spouse should not sign along. If you have already decided to borrow, this policy loan is the lowest-interest tier. Do not touch consumer loans or private lending. The cap and the scope can be raised by each province. How much is actually approved follows what the local human resources and social security department says that year. The notice from the 2020 pandemic period, "200000 yuan maximum for an individual," was a temporary document. Use these measures now. Whether to register as a sole proprietor or open a company, licenses, tax filing, and leaving the business are in section 12. Training subsidies, social insurance (社保) subsidies, and employment internships during unemployment are in section 7, item 13 (vocational training subsidies).

## 17. If you still want to take the civil service exam within 2 years of graduation, check how the announcement defines a "fresh graduate" before you sign a job or transfer your file: for the national exam, the file and hukou (户口) stay with the school or a talent service agency

**Cost**. No money. Before you sign with an employer, spend half an hour finding the announcements of the exams you want and reading them through. The hard part is that localities say it differently, so you check exam by exam.

**In plain terms**. Many posts in the national exam mainly recruit fresh graduates. If within 2 years of graduation you have not been placed in a work unit, and your file and hukou are still kept at the school or a talent service agency, you still count as a fresh graduate. Provinces say it differently. Fujian still counts you if you have signed a contract and paid social insurance (社保). So before you sign a job or transfer your file, read the announcement of the exam you want to take.

**Benefit**. The 2027 national civil service recruitment announcement says that, for central organs, "organs directly under them at city (prefecture) level and below mainly recruit fresh college graduates." Question 3 of that year's application guide answers whether a past graduate counts as a fresh graduate. The original text is: "A graduate of an ordinary higher-education institution under the unified national admissions plan who, on leaving school and during the job-seeking period (the state sets the job-seeking period at 2 years), has not been placed in a work unit, and whose hukou, file, and organizational affiliation are still kept at the original school, or kept at graduate-employment authorities at each level (graduate employment guidance and service centers), talent-exchange service agencies at each level, and public employment service agencies at each level, may be treated as a fresh college graduate." The job-seeking period is the 2 years after graduation spent looking for work. So the national exam requires both things at once: no work unit placed during the 2 years, and the file, hukou, and organizational affiliation not transferred to an employer. Each province sets its own exam. Fujian's 2023 notice says: "For that year's fresh graduates, signing an employment agreement or a labor contract, or paying social insurance, does not affect recognition as a fresh graduate; a graduate of the previous year who has work experience and a social insurance payment record may apply for a fresh-graduate post." This covers Fujian's civil service, public institutions, state-owned enterprises, and central-enterprise offices in Fujian. Chongqing's 2025 notice writes the exams separately. For Chongqing's civil service exam, it copies the national-exam sentence above. For Chongqing's public institutions and state-owned enterprises, as long as within 2 years you have not been hired into a staffed post, "signing an employment contract (agreement), work experience, and payment of social insurance do not affect the application" (nationwide, and each province sets its own).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The national-exam guide does not say whether signing a labor contract or paying social insurance counts as "being placed in a work unit." If you are not sure, call the consulting phone of the recruiting organ printed on the guide. Question 21 of the guide tells candidates to go straight to the recruiting organ. What is often said online, that paying social insurance means you no longer count as a fresh graduate, is the rule of some exams, not a rule for the whole country. The Fujian and Chongqing notices cited above are only examples. Provinces may change them every year. Follow the announcement of the year you take the exam. People in a grassroots service project such as «三支一扶» can also apply for fresh-graduate posts within 2

years after the term ends. See item 7 of this section (grassroots service projects). The same application guide also states that this exam does not designate a prep book, and does not run or entrust any institution or person to run a prep class. Article 4 of the Regulations on the Recruitment of Civil Servants states that civil servants are recruited by "open examination, strict assessment, equal competition, and admission of the better candidates." So if someone takes money and promises an "internal slot" or "a guaranteed staff post," treat it as a scam and report it. See section 8, item 3 (hard rules on fraud). The national-exam wording here follows the 2027 announcement as of October (10) 2026. In later years, also read that year's announcement.

# 32. Studying abroad: status, work, insurance, and recognition back home

This section counts money and personal liberty. It does not discuss whether you should go abroad, and it does not compare schools. Not knowing the following will cost you: how a visa status stays unbroken, where the cap on work hours is, which insurance and fees you must pay, and whether the diploma will be recognized after you return.

It covers the United States, Canada, the United Kingdom, and Australia, with the figures listed country by country. The sources are official pages from each country's immigration authority and China's Ministry of Education. **Study-abroad rules in these countries change often, more often than regulations in China. Every figure in this section is current as of September (9) 2026. Before you leave, and before each renewal, check again yourself using the links in the Sources line.**

How to find an embassy or consulate if something happens while you are abroad, what 12308 can cover, and how to buy overseas medical and evacuation insurance are in section 21. The account of studying versus working is in section 23. Stolen accounts are in section 14. Telecom fraud is in section 8. Those are not repeated here.

## 1. Before you pay tuition, check whether the school is on the certified-institution list at the Chinese Service Center for Scholarly Exchange

**Cost**. No cost. Type the school name once into the "certified-institution lookup" at the Chinese Service Center for Scholarly Exchange (留学服务中心 — the Ministry of Education office that certifies overseas degrees). It takes a few minutes.

**In plain terms**. If you need this diploma back in China for further study, a job, or an exam, you can apply to the Chinese Service Center for Scholarly Exchange for certification. It publishes a list of schools that passed certification in the past 5 years. Being on the list does not guarantee you will pass. Being off the list does not mean they will refuse to take the application. Check once before you pay tuition. If the school is not on the list, ask a further question.

**Benefit**. Article 1 of the Measures for Certifying Academic Degrees and Diplomas from Outside China, issued by the Chinese (Ministry of Education) Service Center for Scholarly Exchange, states that certification is to "meet the applicant's needs for further study, employment, exams, and similar purposes." Article 2 states that certification is done "on the applicant's own application." The center has a certified-institution lookup. You search by school name. Its instructions say the list is the foreign awarding institutions that appeared in applications certified in the past 5 years, and that it is "for the reference of people who studied abroad only, and is not a guarantee or basis for any successful certification." The instructions also say the scope of applications they will accept "is not limited to the institutions this lookup shows," that each application is assessed on its own, and that whether the school is lawful and qualified to issue the credential is only part of the assessment. The list is updated once a year. The 2025 update removed 270 schools that had not had a certificate issued in the past 5 years. Separately, the Ministry of Education information site on supervision of cross-border education (教育涉外监管信息网) also publishes supervision information on Chinese-foreign cooperative programs and on schools run overseas.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. An agent saying "recognized by the Ministry of Education" does not count. Go by what you find online yourself. The list changes. A school that is on it when you enroll may not still be on it when you graduate, so check again once a year while you are studying. Chinese-foreign cooperative programs have a separate certification and registration system. If you enrolled after 2008, you can look up your registration number on that supervision site with your name and national ID number.

## 2. Legal battle over new U.S. F-1 rules: “Stay until graduation” remains the rule for now

**Cost**. No cost at all. Simply copy the program end date from your I-20 into your calendar and set a reminder 90 days in advance. The I-20 is the official document issued by your school confirming your eligibility to study in the U.S. Also, check updates from your school's international student office each semester to see if there are any new developments in this case.

**In plain terms**. The U.S. originally planned to change F-1 rules so that students could stay for a maximum of four years, with only 30 days allowed to leave after finishing their studies. However, just one day before those rules were set to take effect, a federal court issued a stay. As a result, the old rule still applies: students may remain in the country for the full length of their program, with a 60-day grace period after graduation to depart. This stay does not mean the rules have been repealed; the government can still appeal, so the regulations might change again at any time.

**Benefit**. On July 17, 2026, the Department of Homeland Security announced a new rule scheduled to become effective on September 15, 2026. Under this proposal, F-1 students would no longer be allowed to stay “until graduation”; instead, they would be limited to a fixed maximum stay of four years, after which they would need to apply for an extension. Following completion of their studies or internship, they would have only 30 days to leave the country. On September 14, 2026, Judge Saylor of the U.S. District Court for the District of Massachusetts, citing Section 705 of the Administrative Procedure Act, issued a stay on the implementation of this rule nationwide. The court did not overturn the rule; the request to do so was denied, though the government retains the right to appeal later. The case remains ongoing. Thanks to this court order, holders of F, J, and I visas continue to be allowed to stay “until graduation,” with the same 60-day post-graduation departure window and no need to apply for an extension.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This information is current as of September 25, 2026. The government may appeal to the First Circuit Court of Appeals, and DHS could revise and reissue the rules. Therefore, students planning to study for multiple years should not assume that the current rules will remain unchanged indefinitely. The next court hearing to review progress in the case is scheduled for October 2, 2026; after that date, it's advisable to check your school's international student office for any updates. Should these new rules eventually take effect, any extension request must be submitted before the expiration date; there will be no automatic renewal. Under the current rules, the departure deadline for students who decide to leave early differs from that for those who complete their program; in such cases, consult your school's international student office for guidance. The same rule proposal also applies to J visas, though specific provisions differ from those for F-1 students; check details based on your own visa category.

## 3. The maximum allowed work hours are strict limits in the U.S., Canada, UK, and Australia — exceeding them violates visa terms

**Cost**. There's no cost involved. You simply need to track your weekly hours yourself. The difficulty lies in employers often claiming “no one checks extra hours,” but you must never believe this.

**In plain terms**. All four countries cap the hours a student visa lets you work. Going over the cap breaks the visa conditions. During term, the United States is 20 hours a week. The United Kingdom is 20 hours a week on a degree course and 10 hours below degree level. Canada is 24 hours a week. Australia is 48 hours every two weeks. If you work two jobs, add the hours together.

**Benefit**. F-1 students in the U.S. may work up to 20 hours per week on campus during term time, with the same 20-hour weekly cap applying to approved off-campus jobs; full-time work is allowed during holidays. This is stipulated under 8 CFR 214.2(f)(9) of U.S. federal immigration regulations. UK students pursuing degree-level courses may work 20 hours weekly during term time, while those on non-degree programs are limited to 10 hours per week; no work is permitted for part-time students at all. Self-employment is also prohibited, meaning you cannot work for yourself, nor may you serve as a professional athlete or performer. These rules are outlined in the UK immigration rules for students, specifically Student ST26.1 and ST26.5.

Eligible full-time students in Canada may work up to 24 hours per week off campus, per Article 186(v) of the Immigration and Refugee Protection Regulations (IRPR). For Australian student visas, the limit is 48 hours every two weeks while classes are in session; this restriction does not apply to research-based master's or PhD students, nor their dependents.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. In the U.S., any off-campus work must first receive official approval; you cannot begin working while your I-765 work permit application is still pending. Older Canadian work permits may list a 20-hour weekly cap, but if you still meet all eligibility criteria, current regulations permit up to 24 hours per week. The UK's self-employment ban is broadly interpreted: taking private contracts, running an online store, or working as a freelancer all count as prohibited self-employment.

## 4. The root of the status is "enrolled full-time": a leave, a withdrawal, or a gap while you transfer all mean you cannot work

**Cost**. No cost. Before you stop classes, take a leave, or change schools, go to the school's international student office and get a clear answer on your status.

**In plain terms**. Whether you can work depends on whether you are in full-time study right now. The moment you take a leave, withdraw, get expelled, or are not in class during a transfer, the right to work is gone on the spot. If you keep working then, that is illegal work. A visa that has not expired does not mean you can still work.

**Benefit**. Canada states in writing that you may not work off campus during an approved leave. If you are not studying during a transfer, you may not work off campus either. You can start working again only after you resume your studies. On-campus work in the United States is only for F-1 students whose status in SEVIS is Active. SEVIS is the U.S. record system for international students. Active means enrolled and valid. Those students must also keep a full-time course load. In the United Kingdom, permission to work is given by course type. A part-time course does not allow work.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If the course load is heavy and you want to drop classes, ask first how far you can drop before you no longer count as full-time. That fails sooner than the work rules. In the United States, if the school terminates your SEVIS record because you broke the status rules, there is no grace period. You either apply to have the status restored, or you leave at once. If an early withdrawal is approved, you have 15 days to leave. The rules in the other 3 countries differ. Check the immigration page for the country you are in. Do not wait for the school to send a formal letter before you act.

## 5. United States: after you move, you must report the new address within 10 days

**Cost**. No cost. Submit an address change online. It takes 10 minutes.

**In plain terms**. If you change where you live in the United States, the law requires you to tell the immigration authority within 10 days. Not reporting it is not a small matter. First, it is itself against the law. Second, mail the immigration authority sends you may not arrive.

**Benefit**. 8 CFR 265.1, in the U.S. federal immigration regulations, says that a foreign national who must register under the law has to report within 10 days after an address change. Report it to USCIS (U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services), in the way USCIS requires. Report both that the address changed and what the new address is.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. After you report to the immigration authority, the SEVIS record on the school side (your international-student status file) still has to be updated separately. If you hold a UK visa or a residence card, you report when your circumstances change, and you change the address in your UKVI account (UK Visas

and Immigration). An Australian student visa carries condition 8533, named "tell the school your address." No matching rule was found for Canada this time. The deadlines and the methods differ by country. Follow the immigration page for the country you are in.

## 6. Before you go and while studying abroad, check the Ministry of Education's study-abroad warnings

**Cost**. Nothing to pay. Check it once before departure and then once each semester.

**In plain terms**. The Ministry of Education issues specific warnings for certain countries or regions when recent safety conditions or policies there appear unfavorable to Chinese students. These are official, publicly posted risk notices that you can verify in writing — far more reliable than what any agency might tell you. Checking them costs nothing.

**Benefit**. The Ministry posts study-abroad warnings on its Overseas Education Supervision website. In 2025, four such warnings were issued. Warning No. 1 warned that certain higher-education bills in some U.S. states contained provisions hostile toward China (April 9, 2025). Warnings No. 2 and No. 3 both highlighted the high incidence of cases involving Chinese citizens in the Philippines and an overall poor study-abroad environment there (July 18, 2025 and August 30, 2025). Warning No. 4 noted deteriorating safety and study conditions in Japan, advising prospective students to plan carefully before going (November 16, 2025).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. These warnings are not outright bans; they simply provide an official basis for evaluating risk. They are updated as circumstances change, so this section is not kept current — always refer to the latest page on the website. For information on personal safety and consular assistance abroad, see Section 21.

## 7. Australia: OSHC must cover the entire stay without any gaps; lack of proof may lead to denied entry

**Cost**. Several thousand to tens of thousands of RMB. Purchase it once based on the length of your visa; if you're studying for several years, buy coverage for that entire period.

**In plain terms**. Australia wrote student health insurance into the visa conditions. It is not something you may or may not buy. The cover has to last the whole stay. When you renew and switch policies, there must be no gap in the middle. If you cannot show proof of insurance at entry, you can be refused entry on the spot. Family members who come to stay with you while you study need this insurance too.

**Benefit**. According to Australian Department of Home Affairs regulations, student visa applicants and their dependents must obtain OSHC, which must remain in effect throughout their entire stay in Australia without any interruptions. The policy must be issued by an insurer approved by Australian authorities, except for applicants who qualify for exemptions. There must be no gap between the end date of one policy and the start date of a new one. Failure to provide proof of active coverage upon entry can result in denial of entry. For travelers arriving in Australia prior to their course start date, the policy start date must be set to the actual date of arrival.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. If your school arranges the insurance for you, be sure to confirm the insurer's name, the policy's start and end dates, and the policy number — these details must be included in your visa application. Purchasing coverage for a shorter period than needed can cause issues when you apply to renew your visa; it's better to buy coverage that extends well beyond your graduation date.

## 8. UK: Besides the visa fee, there is an annual healthcare surcharge — £776 per year for students, paid in full at application time

**Cost**. The visa fee is £558. There is also a healthcare surcharge of £776 per year, both of which must be paid in full at the time of application.

**In plain terms**. The amount you pay to go to the UK isn't limited to just the visa fee. You also have to prepay the healthcare surcharge based on the length of your visa, which is required to access the UK's National Health Service. For a two-year visa, that means paying £1,552 upfront. Add this to the visa fee, and you'll need to budget for this total amount before you travel.

**Benefit**. The fee for a UK student visa is £558, regardless of whether you apply from outside the UK or extend/change your visa status while already there. In addition, the healthcare surcharge must be paid to use the National Health Service; it is calculated per year of your visa and paid in full at application. For students and their dependents, the charge is £776 per year — so a two-year visa requires a payment of £1,552. Other applicant categories pay £1,035 per year. If your visa lasts more than six months but less than a full year, the charge is still applied for a full year.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Both the fee amounts and exchange rates may change; always refer to the two pages listed under Sources for the most current figures. Generally, students aged 18 or older enrolled in degree programmes can stay for up to five years, while those on non-degree courses are limited to two years. Use these timeframes to estimate the total healthcare surcharge you'll need to pay.

## 9. Allow time for certification before returning to China: CSCSE certification takes 10–20 working days

**Cost**. The application and payment are both done online. Preparing documents and waiting for review also take about a month when counted in working days.

**In plain terms**. To use a foreign qualification back in China, you first need the degree and diploma certified. The review alone takes 10 to 20 working days. Time to prepare the papers is on top of that. Autumn hiring, civil-service exam registration, and settling a hukou (户口 — local household registration) all have deadlines. Do not wait until you need it to start.

**Benefit**. Certification of overseas degrees in China is handled via the online portal of the China Scholarship Council Education Service Center. The procedure involves four steps: registration and identity verification, online submission of documents, payment, and finally evaluation and review. The officially stated processing time is 10–20 working days, which excludes weekends and holidays and represents the duration needed for the Center's review.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Required documents include your diploma, passport or travel permit, residence permit or visa stamp, a photo, and an authorization statement. Entry and exit records during your stay abroad are retrieved automatically by the system, so be sure to keep those visa pages intact. The Center also posts announcements regarding revoked certificates or temporary suspensions of applications from certain institutions; it's advisable to check whether your school is affected before applying.

## 10. Before you enroll, search the school name once in the center's notices. Certification for a school under "enhanced review" takes at least 60 working days

**Cost**. No cost. Before you enroll, search the school name once in the notices of the Chinese Service Center for Scholarly Exchange (留学服务中心 — the Ministry of Education office that certifies overseas degrees).

**In plain terms**. The center names some foreign institutions for a separate, tighter review of their degree certification, and it also stops taking certification applications for particular schools. Searching the school name once before you enroll is much less trouble than appealing afterward.

**Benefit**. The Chinese (Ministry of Education) Service Center for Scholarly Exchange keeps issuing notices that strengthen certification review for degrees from some foreign institutions (an extra check, done separately, on diplomas from those schools). The latest is No. 9 (2025-10-28), which names 4 schools. During

enhanced review, certification applications for these schools take "in principle no fewer than 60 working days counted from the day the application is submitted, that day included." The basis is Article 28 of the Measures for Certifying Academic Degrees and Diplomas from Outside China: when certification data looks abnormal, when a lead about a problem comes in, and in similar cases, the center can start an enhanced review, require the applicant, the school, and others to help by providing materials, and extend the certification period at the same time. In May (5) 2025 the center also issued a notice of "enhanced certification review, again" for 3 schools. It has also issued notices that pause acceptance of certification applications for particular overseas institutions. The anti-fraud notice of August (8) 2025 states: "Any organization or person that claims 'guaranteed certification,' 'certification through inside channels,' 'pandemic backfill,' 'expedited certification,' or the like is making a false claim."

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. "Enhanced review" means an extra check and a longer deadline. It does not mean the credential definitely cannot be certified. Anything that promises "guaranteed certification" or "a rush job through inside channels" is a false claim, according to the center's notice. If you pay someone across a border to write a thesis for you or to attend online classes for you, and you are caught, the credential can be voided, and the visa record can be affected as well.

## 11. United States: on post-graduation OPT, write down the days without work. The total cannot pass 90 days. With a STEM extension, the combined total cannot pass 150 days

**Cost**. No cost. Write down the start and end dates of every stretch without work. As soon as you find a job, report the employer information to the school. The hard part is that when the job search goes badly, the days keep climbing.

**In plain terms**. OPT (Optional Practical Training) is the permission the United States gives F-1 students to do practical work after graduation. During this period your status rests on having work. If the days without work add up past 90, the status can be ended. With a STEM extension (science, technology, engineering, and mathematics), the combined total before and after cannot pass 150 days. If the school system has no employer on file, that also counts as not working.

**Benefit**. 8 CFR 214.2(f)(10)(ii)(E), in the U.S. federal immigration regulations, says that during post-completion OPT, status depends on whether you have work. The total days without work must not exceed 90. With a 24-month STEM extension, the total across the whole OPT period must not exceed 150 days, and the stretch before the extension counts. The official explanation from the Student and Exchange Visitor Program (SEVP) says: if the SEVIS record has no employer information, it counts as not working. When the total reaches 90 days, an SEVP official can manually terminate that student's status. SEVIS is the U.S. record system for international students. Application timing, from the page of USCIS (U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services): you can apply starting 90 days before graduation, and at the latest 60 days after graduation. After the school enters the recommendation in SEVIS, you must file within 30 days.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This item is current as of October (10) 14, 2026. The OPT rules are changing. There are 2 things to watch. First, the stayed new rule in item 2 (the lawsuit over the new F-1 rules) changed "apply within 60 days after graduation" to 30 days. The text the eCFR site shows now is the wording of the new rule, so the safest course is to file before you graduate. Second, on October (10) 8, 2026, the Department of Homeland Security proposed fees for OPT. The first OPT would cost 70000 US dollars, and each later OPT 30000 US dollars. This is only a proposal. Comments are collected until November (11) 9, 2026. It is not in effect. If you plan to stay and work in the United States after you finish, count this possible sum before you pay tuition, and check again before you file.

## 12. Canada: before you apply for a study permit, get the provincial attestation letter (PAL/TAL) through the school. Master's and doctoral students at public universities are exempt from 2026

**Cost**. No extra cost. Apply to the school that admitted you. In most cases the school will issue it only after you accept the offer and pay part or all of the tuition.

**In plain terms**. To study in Canada, most people must submit a provincial attestation letter together with the study-permit application. The letter shows you were given a study place in that province. You cannot file it later. If you apply again after a study permit is approved or refused, or if you transfer schools, you need a new letter. People doing a master's or a doctorate at a public university do not need it.

**Benefit**. IRCC (Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada) says the attestation letter is issued by the province or territory where you will study. It shows you were allocated a study place there. Most study-permit applications must include it, and it must be filed with the application. You cannot add it later. People in kindergarten through grade 12 are exempt. From January (1) 1, 2026, people in master's or doctoral degree programs at public institutions are exempt as well. People studying in Quebec submit the acceptance certificate issued by Quebec (CAQ) instead. Exchange students who do not pay tuition, people renewing at the same school for the same level of study, and a few other special cases are also exempt. People who do not have to submit the letter must attach proof that they qualify for the exemption. The letter is generally valid only in the year it is issued. A letter issued in 2026 is valid through December (12) 31, 2026. It only needs to be valid when you apply for the study permit. It does not matter if it has expired by the time classes start. If you apply again after a study permit is approved or refused, you need a new letter. From January (1) 22, 2025, a transfer also requires a new letter.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This item is current as of October (10) 14, 2026. Canada's study places are reset every year, and the exemption list has changed more than once. Check the page in the Sources line again before you apply. Before you pay tuition in exchange for the letter, ask the school how much of the tuition comes back if the study permit is refused. The cap on work hours while studying in Canada is in item 3 (work hours).

# 33. Living after disability

This section is about life after a disability has already happened. How to prevent disability is in Section 1 and Section 13; it is not repeated here.

The four score types are kept separate and are not converted into one another. Items on emergencies and complications are scored on mortality. Items on subsidies, benefits, and lawsuits are scored on money. Items on schooling and paperwork are scored on time. Items on psychiatric hospitalization, capacity, and guardianship are scored on personal liberty.

The WHO fact sheet on disability (残疾), published in March 2023, gives three figures. About 1.3 billion people worldwide have significant functional difficulty — 16% of the world population, roughly one in six. Some people with disabilities die up to 20 years earlier than people without disabilities. Their risk of depression, asthma, diabetes, stroke, obesity, or poor oral health is twice as high. The fact sheet states that these health gaps come from unfair conditions people with disabilities face: discrimination, poverty, barriers to school and work, and barriers inside the health system itself. So half the items in this section are about the body, and half are about procedures and rights.

Five topics already covered elsewhere are only pointed to here, not repeated. How to get a disability certificate, the seven categories, and levels 1 to 4 are in Section 24, item 10 (disability certificate). When to do a disability assessment is in Section 24, item 9 (disability assessment). How to claim the two disability subsidies is in Section 7, item 8 (the two subsidies). Work-capacity assessment after a work injury and how grades convert into money are in Section 19, item 14 (work-capacity assessment). How to apply for long-term care insurance for severe disability is in Section 17, item 7 (long-term care insurance). That item sits in the "older people at home" section, but the benefit has no age floor — younger people can claim it too.

Most items in this section benefit you and your family, the top two beneficiary tiers. Places that involve other people are noted separately in Notes.

Items in this section are grouped by theme below (numbers in parentheses are item numbers).

**Body and rehabilitation**: sudden severe headache after spinal cord injury (item 1); switch the wheelchair cushion to a pressure-relieving type (item 5); do not buy therapies that claim to cure paralysis (item 6); do rehabilitation at a proper facility (item 16); get a hearing aid when hearing declines (item 17); after spinal cord injury, do not leave an indwelling catheter in long term without a plan (item 21).

**Benefits and subsidies**: go to the Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) and ask about every benefit at once (item 7); apply for rehabilitation aid for a disabled child (item 8); apply for subsidies for ramps, handrails, and bathroom modifications (item 9); personal income tax reduction (item 11).

**Work and rights**: say at job search that you hold a disability certificate (item 10); if you are refused hire because of disability, you can sue (item 20).

**School and travel**: take a guide dog into public places (item 12); apply for reasonable accommodations on the gaokao (高考) (item 13); schools must not refuse a disabled child (item 14); you can still take a driving test with both lower limbs missing (item 15).

**Mental health and caregivers**: suicide risk in the first decade after disability (item 2); caregivers must look after their own health (item 4).

**Mental disorders and guardianship**: psychiatric hospitalization is voluntary in principle (item 3); capacity must be determined by a court application (item 18); guardians follow the statutory order (item 19).

## 1. After spinal cord injury, sudden severe headache and sweating: first help the person sit upright, loosen clothing, and call 120

**Cost**. No money. Three actions, done in a few dozen seconds.

**In plain terms**. In someone with a spinal cord injury, part of the body's alarm wiring is cut. A full bladder or tight clothes may not be felt, yet blood pressure can shoot up. The signal is sudden severe headache and

sweating. Help the person sit upright, loosen anything tight, check whether urine is being held, and call 120 at the same time.

**Benefit**. This episode is called autonomic dysreflexia. A systematic review searched Medline, CINAHL, EMBASE, and PsycINFO, included 31 studies, and of those 6 were randomized controlled trials. The review states that non-drug management during an episode is three steps: put the patient in an upright position, loosen tight clothing, and remove the triggering stimulus. Those three steps rest on clinical consensus and physiology data and are Level 5 evidence. The review body text states that episodes are most common with injury at thoracic level 6 or above, and the most common triggers are bladder or bowel irritation. Stimuli below the injury level set off a large sympathetic discharge, blood pressure rises sharply, and sensation below the injury is partly or wholly gone. Symptoms include severe headache and heavy sweating above the injury level; there may also be no symptoms at all. Untreated, it can lead to intracranial hemorrhage, seizures, or death. No study specifically measured the effect of sitting up during an episode, but when people with spinal cord injury go from lying flat to sitting or tilting, resting blood pressure falls clearly. Antihypertensive drugs are used only when blood pressure stays high; among them prazosin has Level 1 evidence, and nifedipine and prostaglandin E2 have Level 2 evidence. The review also states that prevention mainly targets urogenital and surgical triggers, and most of that evidence is only Level 4 or Level 5

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because those three on-the-spot actions have no randomized controlled trial behind them, only consensus and physiological reasoning. The review itself says most of these methods are backed only by uncontrolled studies. The drug paragraph is for clinicians; do not give blood-pressure medicine at home. Laying the person flat raises blood pressure further, so sit them upright. Family and aides need these three steps too. Do not tough it out as an ordinary headache.

## 2. The first decade after becoming disabled is a high-risk period for suicide; this shouldn't be dismissed as “just a matter of staying positive.”

**Cost**. No cost at all. It only requires a phone call or a single appointment booking.

**In plain terms**. Long-term follow-up at two UK spinal cord injury centres found this group's suicide rate is five times that of the general population. Over nine-tenths of the suicides happened in the first decade after injury. For people whose injury itself came from a suicide attempt, the risk is higher still.

**Benefit**. This study tracked 2,304 patients with traumatic spinal cord injuries who were newly admitted between 1991 and 2010, survived the first year after injury, and had residual neurological impairments at discharge, with follow-up lasting until the end of 2014. Among them, 63 patients (2.7%) had suffered their injury as a direct result of a prior suicide attempt. By the end of the follow-up period, 533 patients had died, of which 4.2% died by suicide; 91% of all suicides occurred within the first ten years after injury. The age-standardized suicide mortality rate was 62.5 cases per 100,000 people per year (95% CI 36.4–88.6), which is five times the average suicide rate of 12.2 cases per 100,000 people in England and Wales in 2014. Compared to patients with other causes of injury, those whose injury was triggered by a prior suicide attempt had a 4.32-fold higher risk of death overall ($P<0.001$), and a 9.46-fold higher risk of suicide specifically ($P<0.001$).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This research was limited to spinal cord injury patients only, so the findings should be extrapolated with caution to other causes of disability such as blindness, amputation, or burns. Its main takeaway is the time window of heightened risk: this elevated risk does not fade away immediately after discharge, and requires close monitoring for a full decade. For support services, please refer to Section 29, Item 11 (12356). To prevent accidental harm, avoid storing sleeping pills or pesticides at home; see Section 1, Item 25 (thoughts of suicide). If feelings of grief and emotional distress persist for more than six months, seek help from a psychiatrist or clinical psychologist; see Section 29, Item 8 (grief lasting over half a year).

## 3. Psychiatric hospitalization is voluntary in principle; only two situations allow it without the person's consent

**Cost**. No money. Memorize the two situations so you can say them when needed.

**In plain terms**. A family member or workplace cannot keep someone in a psychiatric hospital with one sentence. The law recognizes only two situations, and only after a diagnosis of serious mental disorder: the person has harmed themselves or is at that risk, or has endangered others or is at that risk. The first still needs guardian consent for admission. For the second, if there is objection, a second diagnosis can be demanded within three days, and afterward an independent appraisal can be commissioned.

**Benefit**. Article 30 of the Mental Health Law (精神卫生法) states that “hospitalization for mental disorders follows the voluntary principle.” Inpatient treatment shall be given only when diagnosis and assessment show a serious mental disorder and one of the following applies. The first is “harm to self has already occurred, or there is a risk of harm to self.” The second is “harm to others' safety has already occurred, or there is a risk of harm to others' safety.” Article 31: for the first situation, the facility carries out inpatient treatment only with guardian consent; without it, it must not. Article 32: for the second situation, if the person or guardian objects, a second diagnosis may be demanded within three days of receiving the diagnostic conclusion, by two psychiatrists other than those who made the first diagnosis; if there is still objection to the second diagnosis, the person may independently commission a licensed appraisal body for a medical appraisal of mental disorder. Article 35: if the second diagnosis or appraisal report cannot confirm a serious mental disorder, or shows the patient does not need inpatient treatment, the facility must not hospitalize them. Article 78: intentionally sending a person who does not have a mental disorder into a medical facility as a mental-disorder patient incurs liability for damages (nationwide, in force from 1 May 2013, amended 2018)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The reverse is also true: it is not that no one can ever be taken for care. Article 28 says that if a person suspected of a mental disorder has already harmed themselves or others' safety, or is at that risk, close relatives, the workplace, or the local public security organ shall take immediate measures to stop it and send the person to a medical facility for mental-disorder diagnosis. A facility that receives such a referral must not refuse to make a diagnosis. So “sent for diagnosis” and “kept as an inpatient” are two doors; the first is lower, the second higher. Article 75 lists facility duties; improper restraint or isolation, or diagnosing a person without a mental disorder as having one, can bring discipline up to revocation of the practice certificate. What to do when someone nearby has an urge to hurt others is in Section 8.

## 4. The person who long-term cares for a disabled family member at home needs someone watching their own health

**Cost**. No money. Hand off part of the care work, and go get one checkup yourself.

**In plain terms**. Caregiver burnout is not fussiness. A U.S. study followed more than 800 older adults for four years. Those who cared for a disabled spouse and also reported mental strain had a death risk about 60% higher than people who were not caregivers. Caregivers who did not feel strained did not show that rise. So what to watch is not caregiving itself, but that long stretch of tension.

**Benefit**. This was a prospective population cohort, 1993 to 1998, mean follow-up 4.5 years, in four U.S. communities. 392 caregivers and 427 non-caregivers, ages 66 to 96, all living with a spouse. In four years 103 people (12.6%) died. After adjusting for sociodemographic factors, existing disease, and subclinical cardiovascular disease, people who both provided care and reported mental or emotional strain had a 63% higher death risk than non-caregiver controls (RR 1.63, 95% CI 1.00–2.65, credible range). Caregivers who did not report strain (RR 1.08, 95% CI 0.61–1.90) and people whose spouse was disabled but who did not provide care (RR 1.37, 95% CI 0.73–2.58) showed no rise in adjusted mortality

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Contested: the lower bound of the credible range sits exactly on 1.00, so “no difference” is not fully ruled out. The sample is older U.S. adults living with a spouse, caring for a disabled elderly spouse; applying it to caregivers of younger disabled relatives is an extrapolation. What it shows is direction: the strained group has higher risk. Hand off care work that can be handed off; ask the local Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) and civil affairs about residential and day-care services. Do not stop your own chronic-disease medicines — see Section 16, item 1 (take medicines as prescribed). The beneficiary is you.

## 5. If you sit in a wheelchair long term, switch to a pressure-relieving cushion and check the ischial and coccygeal skin once a day

**Cost**. One pressure-relieving cushion costs a few hundred to over 1000 yuan. One look a day takes one minute.

**In plain terms**. In nursing homes, older adults on pressure-relieving cushions had clearly fewer pressure ulcers at the sitting bones than those on ordinary segmented foam cushions, but when the coccyx was counted together the difference did not show. Everyone in the trial first got a fitted wheelchair, so the chair itself must be sized to the person — a generic model is not enough.

**Benefit**. This randomized clinical trial ran in 12 nursing homes, enrolling in 2004 to 2008 232 residents aged 65 or older who sat in a wheelchair 6 or more hours a day with a Braden score under 18. Everyone first received a fitted wheelchair, then was randomized into two groups. One used skin-protection cushions (air, viscous fluid plus foam, or gel plus foam); the other used segmented foam cushions 7.6 cm thick. Follow-up was 6 months or until a pressure ulcer occurred. Ischial tuberosity pressure ulcers: segmented foam 8 cases (6.7%), skin-protection 1 case (0.9%), P=0.04. Combining ischial and sacrococcygeal ulcers: segmented foam 21 cases (17.6%), skin-protection 12 cases (10.6%), P=0.14 — no difference shown

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B for two reasons. First, the sample is only 232 people; the primary endpoint P value 0.04 just cleared the line, and the secondary endpoint showed no difference. Second, the sample is older nursing-home residents; applying it to younger wheelchair users is an extrapolation. Everyone in the trial first got a fitted wheelchair, so “fit” and “cushion” work together — do not only swap the cushion. Pressure-ulcer prevention for long-term bed rest, air mattresses, and timed turning are in Section 17, item 8 (pressure ulcers). How to apply for subsidies for basic assistive devices is in item 7 of this section (ask the county Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) for the full list).

## 6. Do not buy therapies or devices that claim to “cure paralysis, blindness, or deafness”

**Cost**. No money — it saves money. The hard part is family holding onto hope and being hard to talk out of it.

**In plain terms**. The Advertising Law (广告法) draws a hard line. Ads for medical care, drugs, or medical devices must not guarantee efficacy, must not state cure rates or effectiveness rates, and must not use endorsers to recommend or prove. So lines like “stand up after three courses” or “so many people have recovered” are illegal ads on their face; you do not need to study the claimed mechanism. Things that are not medical devices are not even allowed to mention treating disease.

**Benefit**. Article 16 of the Advertising Law (广告法) states that ads for medical care, drugs, or medical devices must not contain: “(1) assertions or guarantees of efficacy or safety; (2) statements of cure rate or effectiveness rate; (3) comparisons of efficacy or safety with other drugs, medical devices, or other medical institutions; (4) use of an advertising endorser for recommendation or proof.” Article 17 states that except for ads for medical care, drugs, or medical devices, “any other ad is forbidden from involving disease-treatment functions, and must not use medical wording or wording that easily confuses the promoted goods with drugs or medical devices.” Article 4 states that ads must not contain false or misleading content, must not deceive or mislead consumers, and the advertiser is responsible for the truth of the ad content (nationwide, amended 2021)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. There is only one test: whether it dares to overstate. A proper hospital rehabilitation department will not promise you will stand up after a set number of courses. Report such promotion to 12315 or the local market regulator. Health-product scripts follow the same path — see Section 6, item 10 (health products). If you already bought and want money back, use the online-purchase and prepaid-consumption routes — see Section 5, item 29 (online purchases follow platform rules). Beneficiaries are you and your family.

## 7. After the disability certificate is issued, go to the county Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) and ask once about everything you can apply for

**Cost**. No money. One trip to the county Disabled Persons' Federation (残联), a morning of questions. Later you will still have more than one agency to visit.

**In plain terms**. The disability certificate itself does not pay money; it is a key. Behind it sit several separate benefits, each needing its own application — none arrive on their own. On the first visit, walk the list item by item; that beats several round trips.

**Benefit**. Benefits tied to the certificate include at least six, each with its own source. Living subsidy for disabled people in need and care subsidy for severe disability — see Section 7, item 8 (the two subsidies). Rehabilitation aid for disabled children — see item 8 of this section (rehabilitation aid). Subsidy for configuring basic assistive devices, under Article 26 of the Regulations on Disability Prevention and Rehabilitation of Persons with Disabilities (残疾预防和残疾人康复条例). Home barrier-free modification subsidy — see item 9 of this section (ramps, handrails, and bathroom modifications). Quota employment and employment services — see item 10 of this section (state that you hold a certificate). Personal income tax reduction — see item 11 of this section (individual tax reduction). Article 26 of those Regulations also states that the state provides basic rehabilitation services to urban and rural poor and severely disabled people through key rehabilitation projects, and "provides subsidies for configuring basic assistive devices under relevant national provisions." Article 20 states that relevant departments of people's governments at county level and above and Disabled Persons' Federations (残联) shall use community resources to set up rehabilitation places or buy services for community rehabilitation: guidance, daily living training, rehab nursing, assistive-device configuration, information, and referral (nationwide, in force from 1 July 2017). Article 21 of the same Regulations states that rehabilitation services start with a needs assessment, then an individualized plan from the assessment. A 2016 State Council document says "where conditions allow, localities may subsidize basic rehabilitation assistive devices for urban and rural poor and severely disabled people." A 2026 three-year action plan from the Ministry of Civil Affairs and other departments states the need to "standardize and strengthen the subsidy system for fitting basic assistive devices for persons with disabilities." Disability from a work injury follows another path. The Measures for Configuring Assistive Devices under Work-Injury Insurance (工伤保险辅助器具配置管理办法) cover prostheses, orthoses, artificial eyes, artificial teeth, wheelchairs, and the like. Confirmation by the work-capacity assessment committee comes first; then configuration. Costs of fitting, repair, and training are paid by the work-injury insurance fund under the rules. Configuration without confirmation, or at a non-contracted facility, is not paid by the handling agency

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The certificate process itself is in Section 24, item 10 (disability certificate). For wheelchairs, prostheses, hearing aids, and the like, ask first about the assessment and configuration path for the subsidy, then buy. Work-injury rules expressly require confirmation before configuration; buying first is not reimbursed. Work-injury recognition and work-capacity assessment are in Section 19, item 14 (work-capacity assessment). Assistive-device subsidies: the State Council wording is "where conditions allow, localities may," so whether and how much is set locally. The next points are author experience: write down each item's name when you ask, then look up the original documents on the local Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) and

government sites by that name — do not rely only on what the counter says. Do not expect one visit to cover everything; go again a year later — policy changes.

## 8. If a child is under 7 and has a disability or autism, apply to the county Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) for rehabilitation aid

**Cost**. No money. File one application at the county Disabled Persons' Federation (残联), then pick one facility from the designated list.

**In plain terms**. The state has a rehabilitation-aid system for children with disabilities and autism from ages 0 to 6, covering surgery, assistive devices, and rehab training. Recipients start with families in need; where local finances allow, age and household-income limits can be widened. Aid under the rules runs to age 6 — do not wait until school starts. Pick the facility from the Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) designated list.

**Benefit**. The State Council Opinions on Establishing a Rehabilitation Aid System for Children with Disabilities state that eligible recipients are children aged 0–6 with vision, hearing, speech, physical, or intellectual disability, and children with autism, who meet the conditions. That includes children with disabilities in urban and rural dibao households, registered poverty households, children raised in child-welfare institutions, orphans with disabilities, children with disabilities covered by extreme-poverty support, and children with disabilities from other economically difficult households. How “other economically difficult households” are defined is set by people's governments at county level and above. The document also states that “where conditions allow, localities may widen the age range for rehabilitation aid for children with disabilities, and may relax limits on household economic conditions.” Funding standards are set by people's governments at county level and above by local finances, numbers of recipients, and disability categories, with a dynamic adjustment mechanism. Applications go to the county Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) where the child's hukou is (or where the residence permit was issued). After approval, the guardian chooses a designated rehab facility. Designated facilities are selected by the Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) at county level and above together with health, education, and civil-affairs departments “on open, competitive principles.” Costs at designated facilities are settled directly between finance and the facility. “Costs of rehab services at a non-designated facility that the county Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) has approved go by settlement rules set by that federation with same-level finance.” Provincial governments were to issue local systems and supporting policies by the end of September 2018. The higher basis is Article 26 of the Regulations on Disability Prevention and Rehabilitation of Persons with Disabilities (残疾预防和残疾人康复条例): the state establishes a rehabilitation-aid system for children with disabilities and shall “gradually make surgery, assistive-device configuration, and rehab training free for children aged 0–6 with vision, hearing, speech, physical, or intellectual disability and for children with autism” (nationwide, from 2018)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Aid projects and standards are set by local governments at county level and above; first check your province's measures for rehabilitation aid for children with disabilities on the local Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) website. Designated facilities are chosen by the federation with relevant departments; ask the federation for the list. The document requires the federation and departments to strengthen entry and exit oversight of designated facilities, run periodic checks and comprehensive assessments, and keep a blacklist. To use a facility off the list, get county Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) approval first; how money is settled is set locally. Going without approval has no settlement rule in the document. The beneficiary is your child, second tier. Facilities that promise a “full cure” are handled under item 6 of this section (claims to cure paralysis).

## 9. Home ramps, handrails, and bathroom modifications can be subsidized on application to government at county level and above

**Cost**. Applying costs no money. Most modifications have a subsidy; you may still pay part yourself. You will need trips to the Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) and the subdistrict.

**In plain terms**. The Law on the Construction of a Barrier-Free Environment (无障碍环境建设法) states that people's governments at county level and above shall support and guide home barrier-free modifications. Eligible households of persons with disabilities and older adults shall receive an appropriate subsidy. How much and which items are local decisions — ask the local Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) first.

**Benefit**. Article 19 of the Law on the Construction of a Barrier-Free Environment (无障碍环境建设法): "People's governments at county level and above shall support and guide home barrier-free facility modifications. Eligible households of persons with disabilities and older adults shall receive an appropriate subsidy." Article 18 states that for existing residential buildings, residential areas, public buildings, public places, transport facilities, and urban and rural roads that do not meet barrier-free construction standards, people's governments at county level and above shall, by the actual situation, make targeted barrier-free modification plans and organize implementation. Article 22: "The state supports adding elevators or other barrier-free facilities to existing multi-storey housing in older urban neighbourhoods, to make things easier for persons with disabilities and older adults." The same article says people's governments at county level and above and their departments shall "use the role of community grassroots organizations" to push elevator installation in existing multi-storey housing. Article 62 states that any organization or individual may submit opinions and suggestions on strengthening barrier-free environment construction to the competent government department, and may complain or report acts that violate this law; the department that receives a complaint or report "shall handle it promptly and reply." Article 63 states that for acts that violate this law and harm the public interest, the people's procuratorate may issue a procuratorial suggestion or bring a public-interest lawsuit (nationwide, in force from 1 September 2023)

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Grade B because the law only says "shall receive an appropriate subsidy"; how much and who qualifies are left entirely to localities, with no national unified figure. First search the local Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) site for "barrier-free home modification for low-income households with severe disability." Adding an elevator in a compound is a separate path; Article 22 asks government and departments to push it through community grassroots organizations — ask the subdistrict and community first. If public barrier-free facilities fall short, complain under Article 62; the department must reply.

## 10. When job hunting, say that you hold a disability certificate — hiring you can offset a real cost for the employer

**Cost**. No money. One extra sentence at the interview. The hard part is saying it.

**In plain terms**. Employers must hire persons with disabilities at no less than 1.5% of headcount; provinces set the exact share. Below the share, they pay an employment-security levy on the shortfall headcount, at the unit's prior-year average wage per person. Through the end of 2027 that levy is cut to 50% or 90%; firms with 30 or fewer people are exempt. So hiring you saves real money — make the certificate clear at the interview.

**Benefit**. Article 8 of the Regulations on Employment of Persons with Disabilities (残疾人就业条例): "The share of persons with disabilities an employing unit arranges for employment shall be no lower than 1.5% of its on-payroll headcount. The exact share is set by the people's government of the province, autonomous region, or municipality in light of local conditions." Article 9: units that fall short of the provincial share shall pay the disabled-persons employment-security levy. Article 8 of the Measures for Collection and Use of the Disabled-Persons Employment-Security Levy (残疾人就业保障金征收使用管理办法) gives the formula: "Annual levy = (prior-year on-payroll headcount × provincial mandated employment share − prior-year actual number of persons with disabilities employed) × prior-year average annual wage of the unit's on-payroll staff." Article 16: for three years from industrial and commercial registration, small and micro enterprises with 20 or fewer on-payroll staff (including 20) that have not reached the mandated share are exempt from the levy. Article 7: a person with a disability counts toward the unit's arranged employment number only if hired as staff on the establishment, or given a labour contract of 1 year or more while of working age, paid no less than the local minimum wage, and with social insurance paid in full. Arranging employment of 1 person holding a level-1 or level-2 disability certificate counts as arranging 2. Ministry of Finance Announcement No. 8 of 2023 further provides that from 1 January 2023 to 31 December 2027, units

that reach 1% but not the provincial share pay 50% of the amount due; units under 1% pay 90%; and "enterprises with 30 or fewer on-payroll staff (inclusive) continue to be exempt from the disabled-persons employment-security levy." Article 36 of the Law on the Protection of Persons with Disabilities (残疾人保障法) states that the state grants tax preferences by law to employing units that meet or exceed the mandated share or that concentrate employment of persons with disabilities (nationwide; Regulations on Employment of Persons with Disabilities in force from 1 May 2007)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Enterprises with 30 or fewer on-payroll staff are exempt from the levy through the end of 2027, so this money argument does not apply to them — do not count on it. Levy relief has been adjusted for years; after 2027, go by whatever Ministry of Finance announcement is then in force. Also, quota employment requires real jobs: a contract of 1 year or more, pay at or above the minimum wage, and full social insurance, before the person counts. Employment-difficulty recognition and social-insurance subsidies are in Section 7, item 12 (people with employment difficulty). Vocational-training subsidies are in Section 7, item 13 (vocational-training subsidies). The beneficiary is you.

## 11. Personal income tax for persons with disabilities can be reduced; how much is reduced — call the provincial tax bureau

**Cost**. No money. Tick one box when filing, or file one set of registration materials.

**In plain terms**. The Individual Income Tax Law (个人所得税法) says income of persons with disabilities may have individual tax reduced. How much and for how long is left to provincial governments, so provinces differ. Call the 12366 tax service hotline for your provincial tax bureau, or find the relief items in the Individual Income Tax app.

**Benefit**. Article 5 of the Individual Income Tax Law (个人所得税法): "In any of the following cases, individual income tax may be reduced; the specific range and term are prescribed by the people's government of the province, autonomous region, or municipality and reported for the record to the standing committee of the people's congress at the same level: (1) income of persons with disabilities, older persons living alone, and dependents of martyrs; (2) major losses from natural disasters." Article 36 of the Law on the Protection of Persons with Disabilities (残疾人保障法) separately provides that the state grants tax preferences by law to persons with disabilities in individual business, and waives administrative and institutional fees (nationwide; Individual Income Tax Law in force from 1 January 2019)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Benefit magnitude is set to "small" by judgment, because the law itself gives no figure; each province sets the cut. Doing it once can last; it is worth the trip. How much your province cuts is set by the provincial government and the provincial tax bureau's notices; comparison tables online may be outdated. If you run a small shop, administrative and institutional fees are waived under Article 36 of the Law on the Protection of Persons with Disabilities (残疾人保障法) — raise it when you get the licence.

## 12. Guide dogs may enter public places and public transport; blind people ride city buses free

**Cost**. No money. If stopped, you must speak up and cite the law; it may take a short standoff.

**In plain terms**. The law states that public places and public transport shall make it convenient for persons with disabilities who bring guide dogs, hearing dogs, or assistance dogs. Blind people with valid credentials ride city buses, metro, and ferries free; persons with disabilities may bring essential assistive devices free. If stopped, say these two points; if that fails, complain.

**Benefit**. Article 46 of the Law on the Construction of a Barrier-Free Environment (无障碍环境建设法): "Operators of public places and of transport facilities and public transport vehicles shall make it convenient for persons with disabilities to bring guide dogs, hearing dogs, assistance dogs, and other service dogs." Paragraph 2 of the same article states that when bringing a service dog into public places or onto public

transport, persons with disabilities “shall follow relevant national rules, put clear identification gear on the service dog, and take necessary protective measures.” Article 68 states that departments and units with public-service duties that fail to provide barrier-free social services as required by law shall be ordered by the people's government at the same level or a higher competent department to correct within a time limit; if they do not, the directly responsible managers and other directly responsible persons shall be disciplined by law. Article 35 states that government convenience hotlines and emergency call systems for police, fire, traffic accidents, and medical emergency shall gradually gain barrier-free features such as voice, large print, Braille, and one-touch call. Article 62 states that any organization or individual may complain or report acts that violate this law, and the competent department shall handle promptly and reply. Article 50 of the Law on the Protection of Persons with Disabilities (残疾人保障法): “Blind people with valid credentials ride city buses, trolleybuses, metro, ferries, and similar public transport free. Braille reading matter is mailed free.” The same article states that people's governments at county level and above shall give convenience and preference when persons with disabilities take public transport, and that persons with disabilities may bring essential assistive devices free (nationwide; Law on the Construction of a Barrier-Free Environment in force from 1 September 2023)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The law says “make it convenient,” with no fine; Article 68 only covers orders to correct and discipline of responsible staff, so the other side may not yield at once in a standoff. A screenshot of the articles on the phone helps more than memorizing numbers — author experience. If it cannot be settled on the spot, complain under Article 62; the department must reply. The law also requires clear identification gear and protective measures for the service dog — have those ready before leaving. Before trains or flights, call customer service about service-dog rules. Which “valid credential” free rides recognize — ask the local Disabled Persons' Federation (残联).

## 13. Persons with disabilities taking the gaokao (高考) may apply for reasonable accommodations; Braille papers get 50% more exam time

**Cost**. No money. File one written application in the time the province sets, and attend an on-site confirmation.

**In plain terms**. Disabled candidates taking the gaokao (高考) may apply for Braille papers, large-print papers, exemption from foreign-language listening, a separate exam room, hearing aids and wheelchairs in the room, and extended exam time. None of this is automatic; file a written application by the provincial deadline, with a second-generation or later disability certificate. If you disagree with the result, ask the provincial education department for review.

**Benefit**. Article 5 of the Provisions on Administration of Participation by Persons with Disabilities in the National Unified Examination for Admission to Regular Institutions of Higher Education (残疾人参加普通高等学校招生全国统一考试管理规定) lists twelve reasonable accommodations. These include providing current Braille papers, large-print papers, or ordinary papers for candidates with vision disability; exempting candidates with hearing disability from the foreign-language listening test; allowing candidates with vision disability to bring Braille pens, Braille writing boards, non-storage Braille typewriters, non-storage electronic low-vision aids, white canes, optical magnifiers, and similar aids; allowing candidates with hearing disability to bring hearing aids or cochlear implants; allowing candidates with limited mobility to use wheelchairs or walking aids, and those with special needs to bring special desks and chairs. The time extension is in Article 5, item 6: “For candidates with vision disability using Braille papers, exam time is extended by 50% of the subject's set total duration; for candidates with vision disability using large-print or ordinary papers, and for candidates with especially difficult writing because of upper-limb inability from cerebral palsy or other disease or because one upper limb is missing, exam time is extended by 30% of the subject's set total duration.” There are also priority entry to the site and rooms, separate standardized rooms, and guides and sign-language interpreters. Article 7 sets the application process: candidates file a formal written application by the time, place, and method set by the provincial education examination body, with a second-generation or later disability certificate; an expert group confirms on site and assesses comprehensively; the provincial

education examination body issues a Notice. Article 8: if the candidate objects to the Notice, a written review may be filed with the provincial education administration. Article 9: if foreign-language listening is exempted, the foreign-language score is “written score × total foreign-language points / total written-part points.” Article 18: persons with disabilities who need reasonable accommodations for other national education exams may follow these Provisions (nationwide, issued and in force 7 April 2017)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Application windows are set by each province and printed in that year's gaokao (高考) registration rules; miss them and there is none. Check the provincial education examination authority site in the first term of senior year. Article 18 also covers postgraduate exams, adult gaokao (高考), and other national education exams by reference. Schools must not refuse enrollment — see item 14 of this section (schools must not refuse). Beneficiaries are you or your child.

## 14. When a disabled child applies for school, the school must not refuse; if the child cannot get to school, the education bureau arranges teaching at home

**Cost**. No money. One application; there may be one assessment. If the school stalls, go up to the education bureau.

**In plain terms**. Kindergartens and schools of all kinds must not refuse enrollment of eligible disabled children; ordinary vocational schools are the same. If a child needs dedicated nursing and cannot get to school, the county education bureau arranges teaching at home or remote classes, still with student status. Admission and transfer start with assessment and advice from the education bureau's expert committee, not with one sentence from the school.

**Benefit**. Article 7 of the Regulations on Education of Persons with Disabilities (残疾人教育条例): “Preschool institutions, schools at all levels, and other educational institutions shall implement education for persons with disabilities under these Regulations and relevant national laws and regulations; they must not refuse to enroll persons with disabilities who apply and who meet conditions set by laws and regulations.” Article 29: “Ordinary vocational schools must not refuse to enroll persons with disabilities who meet national admission standards; ordinary vocational training institutions shall actively enroll persons with disabilities.” The Regulations also state that for school-age children and adolescents with disabilities who need dedicated nursing and cannot attend school, the education administration of the county people's government shall arrange overall, providing compulsory education through teaching at home or distance education, and include them in student-status management. Article 20: the county education administration shall, with health, civil affairs, and the Disabled Persons' Federation (残联), set up an expert committee on disability education of specialists in education, psychology, rehabilitation, and social work to assess physical condition, capacity to receive education, and capacity to adapt to school life, and to advise on admission and transfer; assessment results are the child's privacy, and relevant units and staff have a duty of confidentiality. Article 23: disabled students in ordinary schools in regular classes may use ordinary compulsory-education curriculum schemes, standards, and textbooks, but learning requirements may have moderate flexibility. Article 52: persons with disabilities who need necessary support and reasonable accommodations for national education exams may apply (nationwide, in force from 1 May 2017)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A school saying orally “we have no conditions here” does not count. Get a written reply, then take it to the county education bureau. Assessment is done by the expert committee the education bureau commissions. The Article 23 phrase “learning requirements may have moderate flexibility” is useful when a school cites grades to push a child out. How to keep evidence of bullying at school and which process the school must run is in Section 30, item 3 (school bullying). Gaokao reasonable accommodations are in item 13 of this section (reasonable accommodations). The beneficiary is your child.

## 15. Missing a right lower limb or both lower limbs, you can still take a driving test; the permitted vehicle class is C5

**Cost**. Tuition is about the same as an ordinary licence, usually a few thousand yuan in most places. The car must be modified for manual control. A physical check every three years.

**In plain terms**. If the right lower limb or both lower limbs are missing or cannot move, but you can sit steadily on your own and the upper limbs meet the conditions, you can take the test for a disability-dedicated automatic small-car licence, code C5. Missing one palm with the other hand meeting conditions can also apply. People with single-eye vision impairment or hearing impairment each have vehicle classes they can take. The physical exam must be at a specialized hospital recognized by the province.

**Benefit**. Annex 1 of the Provisions on the Application for and Use of Motor Vehicle Driving Licences (机动车驾驶证申领和使用规定) sets physical conditions in detail. Item 8: “If the right lower limb or both lower limbs are missing or have lost motor function but the person can sit independently, and the upper limbs meet item 5 of this section, the person may apply for a driving licence for the disability-dedicated small automatic passenger-car class. If one palm is missing, the other hand has an intact thumb and two other intact fingers, upper-limb and finger motor function is normal, and the lower limbs meet item 6 of this section, the person may apply for a driving licence for the disability-dedicated small automatic passenger-car class.” Item 6: if only the left lower limb is missing or has lost motor function but the right lower limb is normal, the person may apply for the small automatic-car class. Vision: “single-eye vision impairment, with the better eye's uncorrected or corrected vision at 5.0 or above on the logarithmic chart and horizontal visual field of 150 degrees,” may apply for small car, small automatic, low-speed goods, three-wheel, and disability-dedicated small automatic passenger-car classes. Hearing: with hearing impairment but able to tell sound-source direction while wearing a hearing aid, may apply for small car and small automatic classes, and must wear the hearing aid when driving. Article 85: the physical-condition certificate submitted when handling disability-dedicated small automatic passenger-car licence business shall be issued by a specialized medical institution recognized by the provincial health administration. Holders of this class shall have a physical check every three years and submit the physical-condition certificate within thirty days after the end of a demerit cycle. Article 78: when driving, the disability motor-vehicle special mark shall be placed on the vehicle as required. Article 79, paragraph 1, item 9: for holders of the disability-dedicated small automatic passenger-car class, “if the physical-condition certificate is not submitted within one year after the end of three demerit cycles,” the vehicle administration shall cancel the driving licence (nationwide, as amended by Ministry of Public Security Order No. 172, in force from 1 January 2025). Article 23, paragraph 1, item 5 of the Provisions on Motor Vehicle Registration (机动车登记规定) states that after adding, removing, or replacing limb-disability operating aids on small or micro automatic passenger cars, the owner shall apply for change filing with the registration vehicle administration within thirty days. Article 24: for that filing, submit identity proof, driving permit, motor-vehicle safety technical inspection certificate, and operating-aid installation certificate, and present the vehicle (Ministry of Public Security Order No. 164)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. A much lower-threshold path is the disability motorized wheelchair. Article 119 of the Road Traffic Safety Law (道路交通安全法) lists disability motorized wheelchairs whose design speed, unladen mass, and outer dimensions meet national standards as non-motor vehicles, so no driving licence is needed; Article 58 caps speed on non-motor lanes at fifteen kilometres per hour. A C5 car needs limb-disability operating aids installed; after installation get the installation certificate and file the change at the vehicle administration within 30 days. If the physical-condition certificate is not submitted within one year after three demerit cycles end, the licence is cancelled.

## 16. Do rehabilitation at a proper facility with a rehabilitation medicine department; intensity follows the therapist — more is not always better (evidence from stroke)

**Cost**. Inpatient rehab several hundred yuan a day; the out-of-pocket part varies by place. Time is counted in months. Practice every day; it is dull.

**In plain terms**. After a stroke, people admitted to an organized stroke unit are more often still alive and still living at home one year later. But do not add intensity on your own: starting earlier, more often, and with more volume within 24 hours after stroke led to worse three-month outcomes. How much and when to practice — follow rehab medicine and the therapists.

**Benefit**. A Cochrane systematic review included 29 trials and 5902 participants, comparing organized inpatient stroke-unit care with other care. The review describes a stroke unit as a team using standard approaches to common post-stroke problems and providing coordinated multidisciplinary care. At final follow-up (median 1 year), the odds ratio for a poor outcome (death, disability, or need for institutional care) was 0.77 (95% CI 0.69–0.87, credible range), for death 0.76 (95% CI 0.66–0.88), and for death or dependence 0.75 (95% CI 0.66–0.85); evidence quality moderate. In absolute terms, per 100 people in stroke-unit care, 2 more survive, 6 more live at home, and 6 more live independently. Separately, the AVERT trial randomized 2104 patients across 56 acute stroke units in 5 countries to "usual care" or "usual care plus very early high-intensity activity." At three months, a good outcome (modified Rankin Scale 0–2) was 480 people (46%) in the very-early group versus 525 (50%) in usual care; adjusted odds ratio 0.73 (95% CI 0.59–0.90, P=0.004). Deaths were 88 versus 72, with no difference shown (odds ratio 1.34, 95% CI 0.93–1.93, P=0.113)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Contested: both bodies of evidence are from stroke; applying them to spinal cord injury, amputation, burns, and other causes of disability is an extrapolation. AVERT shows that "earlier and harder" does not hold; it does not mean early activity is useless. In the trial almost everyone in both arms was out of bed within 24 hours; the difference was frequency and total volume. When choosing a facility, check for a rehabilitation medicine department and dedicated rehab and occupational therapists — do not go by the word "rehab" on a sign alone. That follows from stroke-unit care resting on a multidisciplinary team. How to transfer between primary and tertiary hospitals and how deductibles stack is in Section 24, item 1 (step-by-step referral). Community rehab and assistive-device configuration are in item 7 of this section (ask the county Disabled Persons' Federation (残联) for the full list).

## 17. When hearing declines, get a hearing aid; the reason is to hear now, not to prevent dementia

**Cost**. Hearing aids cost several thousand to tens of thousands of yuan; most are out of pocket. Fitting is required, plus several return visits for tuning.

**In plain terms**. The claim that "hearing aids prevent dementia" has not held up so far. A nearly thousand-person three-year trial showed no overall difference. A difference appeared only in the subgroup already at higher risk of cognitive decline. So the reason to get a hearing aid is to hear now, talk with people, and hear cars when crossing the street — not for the brain decades later.

**Benefit**. The ACHIEVE trial ran in 4 U.S. communities and enrolled 977 people aged 70 to 84 with untreated hearing loss and no clear cognitive impairment. They were randomized to hearing intervention (hearing counseling and hearing aids) or health-education control, with follow-up every 6 months. The primary endpoint was 3-year change in global cognitive score. In the main analysis pooling both source populations, the two groups did not differ significantly: hearing intervention −0.200 (95% CI −0.256 to −0.144), control −0.202 (95% CI −0.258 to −0.145), difference 0.002 (95% CI −0.077 to 0.081), P=0.96. A pre-specified sensitivity analysis showed the intervention effect differed between the two source populations (interaction P=0.010). Participants from that long-term cardiovascular-health observational study were older, had more risk factors for cognitive decline, and had lower baseline cognitive scores. In that subgroup of 238 people, hearing

intervention reduced 3-year cognitive decline by 48% (difference 0.191, 95% CI 0.022–0.360, P=0.027). In the other 739 newly recruited healthy volunteers, the groups did not differ significantly (difference −0.061, 95% CI −0.151 to 0.028, P=0.18). The investigators concluded that hearing intervention may reduce 3-year cognitive change in people at higher risk of cognitive decline, and not in those at lower risk. The trial reported no serious adverse events attributed to the study

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Contested: the line “hearing aids cut cognitive decline by nearly half” comes from a 238-person subgroup in this trial, not the primary result, which showed no difference between groups. Separate “get a hearing aid” from “prevent dementia”: do the former; do not use the latter as the reason. Candidates with hearing disability can be exempted from foreign-language listening on the gaokao (高考) — see item 13 of this section (reasonable accommodations). Drivers with hearing impairment should wear a hearing aid — see item 15 of this section (C5).

## 18. Saying an adult “cannot manage their own affairs” requires a court determination; family say-so does not count

**Cost**. Applying to the court has no case-acceptance fee. If appraisal is needed, appraisal fees are separate and usually paid by the applicant. The law requires finishing within 30 days; an appraisal will take longer.

**In plain terms**. Whether an adult has “no civil capacity” or “limited civil capacity” can be determined only by a court. Family, workplace, or residents' committees cannot decide on their own. An interested person or a relevant organization must apply to the court. Conversely, if intellect or mental health recovers, an application can seek a finding that capacity is restored. The procedure both restricts and protects.

**Benefit**. Article 21 of the Civil Code (民法典): “An adult who cannot recognize their own conduct is a person with no civil capacity; civil juristic acts are performed by their legal representative.” Article 22: “An adult who cannot fully recognize their own conduct is a person with limited civil capacity; civil juristic acts are performed by their legal representative or with that representative's consent or ratification; but they may independently perform civil juristic acts that purely obtain benefits, or that match their intellect and mental health.” Article 24: “For an adult who cannot recognize or cannot fully recognize their own conduct, an interested person or a relevant organization may apply to a people's court to determine that the adult has no civil capacity or limited civil capacity.” The same article provides that after such a determination, on application by the person, an interested person, or a relevant organization, the court may, by recovery of intellect or mental health, determine restoration to limited or full civil capacity. Relevant organizations include residents' committees, villagers' committees, schools, medical institutions, women's federations, Disabled Persons' Federations (残联), legally established older-persons' organizations, civil-affairs departments, and others. Article 23: the guardian of a person with no civil capacity or limited civil capacity is their legal representative (nationwide, in force from 1 January 2021). Procedure is in the special-procedure chapter of the Civil Procedure Law (民事诉讼法). Article 198: the application goes to the basic people's court at the citizen's domicile; “the application shall state the facts and grounds for no civil capacity or limited civil capacity.” Article 199: “After accepting the application, the people's court shall, when necessary, arrange an appraisal of the citizen requested to be found to have no civil capacity or limited civil capacity.” Article 187: special-procedure cases “shall be concluded within thirty days of case filing or within thirty days after the public notice period ends”; extension for special circumstances needs approval by the court's president. Article 8 of the Measures for Payment of Litigation Costs (诉讼费用交纳办法): cases tried under the Civil Procedure Law's special procedures do not pay a case-acceptance fee. Article 12: costs arising in litigation from appraisal and the like are paid by the parties directly to the relevant body under the court's “who asserts, who bears” principle

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The application uses the court's special procedure; the statutory time limit is 30 days, shorter than ordinary civil cases, but appraisal takes extra time. The application must state facts and grounds; hospital diagnosis certificates are generally attached — author experience. When necessary the court shall order

appraisal; appraisal fees follow “who asserts, who bears,” usually paid by the applicant. Signing or disposing of property for someone without this procedure and without being the legal representative, under Article 171 of the Civil Code (民法典), has no effect on that person without ratification; a house sale may have to be undone. That is the author's reading from the articles. Also remember: limited civil capacity does not mean nothing can be done. Acts that match intellect and mental state, and acts that purely obtain benefits, the person can do alone — do not take over everything. How guardians are set is in item 19 of this section (guardians).

## 19. An adult's guardian follows the statutory order; if the ward harms someone, the guardian pays

**Cost**. No money. If there is a dispute, go to the residents' committee, villagers' committee, civil affairs, or the court.

**In plain terms**. After an adult loses capacity, guardians follow this order: spouse; parents and children; other close relatives; last, other persons or organizations agreed to by the residents' committee and the like. Disputes are designated by the residents' committee, villagers' committee, or civil affairs; disagree and go to court. While clear-minded, a person may name a future guardian in writing. If the ward harms someone, pay first from the ward's own money; the guardian covers the shortfall.

**Benefit**. Article 28 of the Civil Code (民法典): for an adult with no civil capacity or limited civil capacity, the following persons with guardianship capacity serve as guardian in order: “(1) spouse; (2) parents, children; (3) other close relatives; (4) other individuals or organizations willing to serve as guardian, but subject to consent of the residents' committee, villagers' committee, or civil-affairs department at the ward's domicile.” Article 31: if there is a dispute over who the guardian is, the residents' committee, villagers' committee, or civil-affairs department at the ward's domicile designates; anyone who disagrees with the designation may apply to a people's court for designation, or apply directly to a people's court. Designation “shall respect the ward's true wishes and follow the principle most favourable to the ward.” Before designation, if rights and interests are unprotected, the residents' committee, villagers' committee, a relevant organization provided by law, or civil affairs serves as temporary guardian. Article 33: “An adult with full civil capacity may, in advance and in writing, agree with close relatives or other individuals or organizations willing to serve as guardian on who their guardian will be.” Article 1188: “If a person with no civil capacity or limited civil capacity causes harm to another, the guardian bears tort liability. If the guardian has fulfilled guardianship duties, tort liability may be reduced.” If the person has property, compensation is paid from that property; the shortfall is paid by the guardian. Article 1189: if the guardian entrusts guardianship duties to another, the guardian still bears tort liability; the trustee who is at fault bears corresponding liability (nationwide, in force from 1 January 2021)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Article 33 is voluntary guardianship. Naming someone in writing while the person is clear can avoid most later disputes; how to draft it is in Section 17, item 1 (voluntary guardianship). Watch the compensation paragraph: handing the person to a care facility or relatives, liability stays with the guardian; the trustee only shares corresponding liability when at fault. So guardianship-liability insurance for the ward can make sense. Article 78 of the Mental Health Law (精神卫生法) also provides that a guardian who abandons a patient or fails to perform guardianship duties and causes harm bears liability for damages by law.

## 20. If you are refused hire, denied conversion to regular status, or paid less because of disability, you can sue — but first count the process cost

**Cost**. Lawyer fees from several thousand to tens of thousands of yuan, paid by you. Ordinary first-instance procedure from 6 months, extendable. You keep the evidence.

**In plain terms**. The law forbids discriminating against persons with disabilities in hiring, conversion to regular status, promotion, professional titles, pay, and social insurance. You can complain to the competent department, or sue in court. Winning the case does not make the other side pay your lawyer fees. So complain first, apply for legal aid at the same time, then consider a lawsuit.

**Benefit**. Article 3 of the Law on the Protection of Persons with Disabilities (残疾人保障法): “Discrimination based on disability is prohibited. Insulting or infringing persons with disabilities is prohibited.” Article 38: “In hiring, conversion to regular status, promotion, professional-title evaluation, labour remuneration, living welfare, rest and leave, social insurance, and similar matters, persons with disabilities must not be discriminated against.” The same article states that the workplace of a disabled employee shall, by the employee's characteristics, provide suitable labour conditions and labour protection, and modify workplaces, equipment, and living facilities as actually needed. Article 64: “Anyone who, in violation of this Law, discriminates against persons with disabilities in hiring and similar matters shall be ordered by the competent department to correct; disabled workers may bring a lawsuit in a people's court by law.” Article 4 of the Regulations on Employment of Persons with Disabilities (残疾人就业条例): “Discrimination against persons with disabilities in employment is prohibited.” Article 13: employing units must not discriminate against disabled employees in promotion in post or grade, professional-title evaluation, pay, social insurance, living welfare, and similar matters. Article 42 of the Legal Aid Law (法律援助法) states that if the applicant has materials showing membership in “specific groups such as minors, older persons, or persons with disabilities with no fixed livelihood,” verification of financial difficulty is waived. Article 45: when legal-aid institutions provide legal-aid services to older persons or persons with disabilities, they shall provide barrier-free facilities, equipment, and services by the actual situation (nationwide)

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. Process cost must be counted first. Ordinary first-instance procedure from 6 months, extendable; summary procedure 3 months. Lawyer fees are not among the litigation costs listed in Article 6 of the Measures for Payment of Litigation Costs (诉讼费用交纳办法); Article 29's “borne by the losing party” does not cover them. So take two low-cost paths first: complain to human resources and social security or the Disabled Persons' Federation (残联), for an order to correct; and apply for legal aid — Article 42 waives financial-difficulty checks for persons with disabilities. Evidence is the hardest gate. When an interview refusal happens, written reasons are rare; keep recordings and chat logs when you can. Once employed, labour disputes go to arbitration; evidence and time limits are in Section 19, item 8 (keep evidence before leaving). The beneficiary is you.

## 21. After spinal cord injury, if you cannot void urine, decide the voiding method with the doctor; do not leave an indwelling catheter unmanaged long term; check kidneys and bladder on a lifelong schedule

**Cost**. Self intermittent catheterization four to six times a day, a few minutes each time; catheters must be bought ongoing. Rechecks every one to two years, urology or rehab. The hard part is doing it every day for decades.

**In plain terms**. After spinal cord injury, if you cannot void, the bladder must be emptied by catheterization or similar means. In UK data spanning seventy years, over one-tenth of deaths were in the genitourinary system. People with long-term indwelling catheters had about twice the complication rate of those on timed self-catheterization. Whatever the method, kidneys and bladder need lifelong scheduled checks.

**Benefit**. Two UK spinal cord injury centres reviewed 5483 people with traumatic spinal cord injury. They were injured from 1943 to 2010, all survived the first year after injury, and were followed to the end of 2014. 2322 died; 2170 had reliable causes of death. Leading causes were respiratory 29.3%, circulatory 26.7%, cancer 13.9%, genitourinary 11.5%. After age adjustment, genitourinary mortality was higher than in the general population; it has fallen over the years but remains elevated. Another U.S. study reviewed records of 316 people with traumatic spinal cord injury, mean follow-up 18.3 years after injury, grouped by voiding method. Complication rates: long-term transurethral indwelling catheter 53.5%, clean intermittent catheterization 27.2%, spontaneous voiding 32.4%, suprapubic cystostomy 44.4%. Complications included infection, stones, urethral injury, and imaging abnormalities. This was a chart comparison only, not randomized. The 2026 European Association of Urology guidelines state that transurethral indwelling catheters have many complications and high urinary-tract infection risk — avoid them when possible. Suprapubic cystostomy is similar, only milder. The guidelines also state that long-term follow-up is lifelong, to check upper-tract

damage and risk of kidney failure. Recheck intervals in most cases are no longer than one to two years. High-risk people roughly get ultrasound about every half year, and annual physical exam and urine tests. Section 3.4.2.e of the guidelines states that intermittent catheterization and indwelling catheters are both standard for people who cannot empty the bladder, and recommends joint decision by doctor and patient. In people with spinal cord injury, quality-of-life scores on intermittent catheterization are worse than on indwelling catheters, especially with more than 4 urinary-tract infections a year. In one observational study, 42.1% of people on intermittent catheterization stopped within 12 months, mainly for inconvenience, leakage, and more infections. The guidelines state silicone catheters are better because they scale less, and latex allergy is common in neurological disease. Section 3.5.1 lists the most common UTI signals in these patients: fever, new or worse leakage, worse spasms, fatigue, cloudy urine with stronger odour, flank or bladder pain, and autonomic dysreflexia

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Contested: the same guidelines list intermittent catheterization and indwelling catheters both as standard, and require doctor and patient to decide together. In people with spinal cord injury, quality-of-life scores on intermittent catheterization are worse, especially with more than 4 urinary-tract infections a year. Over four-tenths of people on intermittent catheterization stopped within a year. So if the hands are limited and no one at home can help, an indwelling catheter can be a reasonable choice — the author's inference from the points above. For indwelling catheters, the guidelines prefer silicone. Do not decide alone, and do not leave a catheter in for years without rechecks. New leakage, cloudy foul urine, worse spasms, or fever may be a urinary-tract infection — get seen. An overfull bladder can trigger autonomic dysreflexia — see item 1 of this section (sudden severe headache). The Chinese neurogenic-bladder guideline text was not obtained and is not cited. The beneficiary is you.

# 34. Do not let medicines kept at home cause serious harm

Fever reducers, painkillers, cold medicines, stomach medicines, and anti-diarrhea medicines: many of them can be bought at a pharmacy with no prescription. Being able to buy them with no prescription does not mean any way of taking them is fine. This section does not say which medicine to take for each illness. It only picks a few actions that each avoid a serious outcome.

Every item is scored on the mortality scale, including health endpoints such as liver failure, stomach bleeding, and kidney failure in a newborn. Most of the benefit is one fewer serious accident. Studies do not give a figure for how much doing it would cut the risk. The size of the benefit is judged by how heavy the outcome is, and each note says why it was set that way.

What is already written elsewhere is only pointed to here. If a medicine or a cleaning product is swallowed by mistake, see section 13, item 20 (accidental ingestion). For taking a chronic-disease medicine in full as the doctor ordered, see section 16, item 1 (finish the medicine as prescribed). For buying a prescription drug online, the prescription has to be checked first, see section 28, item 6 (get weight-loss drugs with a hospital prescription).

The people these items benefit are you and your family, the top two tiers.

## 1. Before taking two cold medicines or painkillers at the same time, read the ingredient list, keep acetaminophen in a single product, and go to the hospital the same day if you took too much even without feeling ill

**Cost**. No money. A glance at the ingredient list on each box, a couple of minutes.

**In plain terms**. Many cold medicines contain acetaminophen. Taking 2 boxes together means a double dose, and too much harms the liver. In the United States, among people whose liver failed suddenly because of it, nearly 3 in 10 died before they could get a new liver. Leaflets in China advise at most 2 grams a day. The United States also warns against more than 3 cups of alcohol a day while taking it. If you took too much, go to the hospital right away even if you feel fine. The antidote works better the sooner it is used.

**Benefit**. Over 6 years, 22 hospitals in the United States registered 662 cases of acute liver failure in a row. Of these, 275 (42%) were caused by acetaminophen, and the median dose swallowed was 24 grams. Of these 275 people, 131 (48%) had taken too much by accident, not on purpose. Among the people who took too much by accident, 38% were taking more than a single medicine that contained this ingredient at the same time. Of these 275 people, 27% died before a liver transplant, and 8% received a transplant. In 2020 the National Medical Products Administration required over-the-counter leaflets to state that using too much causes severe liver damage, and that the suggested maximum in a day is not more than 2 grams. The leaflet must also say to avoid combining the drug with medicines that contain acetaminophen or other fever and pain drugs. US rules require the opening line of the warning on this kind of over-the-counter drug to name the liver-harm situations: going over the maximum for a day, taking it together with another medicine that contains acetaminophen, and drinking more than 3 cups of alcohol a day during treatment. The same notice also requires the leaflet for an extended-release product to state that if an adult or a child takes too much, they should be seen at once, whether they feel unwell or not. The antidote is called N-acetylcysteine. The leaflet says to use it as early as possible: within 12 hours the effect is satisfactory, and after 24 hours the effect is poorer. A multicenter study in the United States from 1976 to 1985 followed 2540 overdose patients who were given this antidote. Among patients whose blood level marked them as likely to develop liver injury, liver injury appeared in 6.1% of those who started the antidote within 10 hours, and in 26.4% of those who started it only from 10 to 24 hours. Started within 8 hours after the overdose, it protected the patient no matter how high the blood level was.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Acetaminophen is also called paracetamol. Combination cold medicines whose generic name contains the characters for acetaminophen (氨酚), such as paracetamol and pseudoephedrine (氨酚伪麻) or paracetamol, caffeine, and chlorphenamine (氨咖黄敏), contain this ingredient. If you are not sure, take every box to the pharmacist at the pharmacy. The grade is B because those US figures are a case registry with no comparison group, so they cannot show how many incidents reading the ingredient list would prevent. The benefit is rated large because of the outcome: in acute liver failure, nearly 3 in 10 die directly. The figures for using the antidote as early as possible come from a multicenter observation with no random assignment, compared only with earlier cases.

## 2. Do not treat a child's fever with aspirin, nimesulide, or metamizole, do not give a minor a cold medicine that contains metamizole, and measure liquid fever medicine with the dosing device in the box

**Cost**. No money. When you buy a fever medicine, glance at the generic name and the ingredient list.

**In plain terms**. Aspirin is linked to Reye's syndrome, an illness that harms the brain and the liver, and about 3 in 10 of the sick children die. Nimesulide is forbidden under 12. Metamizole is forbidden under 18. Measure liquid fever medicine with the dosing device that comes in the box. Spoons at home differ a lot in size. Drops and the drinkable liquid may not be the same strength. The US example differs by 3 times. If you switch the form, do not feed the old number of milliliters.

**Benefit**. Reye's syndrome causes brain disease and fatty change in the liver, and it usually appears after influenza or chickenpox. In US national surveillance from 1981 to 1997, 1207 cases were reported in people under 18. Salicylate, the ingredient in aspirin-type drugs, could be measured in the blood of 82% of the sick children. The overall share who died was 31%. Warnings about salicylate drugs began in 1980. That year 555 cases were reported, the peak. From 1987 on, each year has stayed at no more than 36 cases. In 2011 the national drug regulator banned oral nimesulide for children under 12. In 2020 it banned metamizole tablets for children and adolescents under 18. Compound artemisinin and metamizole tablets (复方青蒿安乃近片), Zhongganling tablets (重感灵片), and Zhongganling capsules (重感灵胶囊), which also contain metamizole, are likewise banned under 18. The measuring question uses US figures. In 2011 the US drug regulator stated that infant acetaminophen drops are 80 mg per 0.8 milliliters, and the drinkable liquid for older children is 160 mg per 5 milliliters. From those amounts, the same 1 milliliter of drops holds about 3 times as much drug as the drinkable liquid. The US drug regulator said that having both strengths at the same time is easy to mix up and can make a child take too much by accident, and that dosing devices from different products must never be mixed. A study in Greece measured 71 teaspoons and 49 tablespoons from 25 households. Filled with water, the volume ran from 2.5 milliliters to 7.3 milliliters. In a US emergency-department study, parents who used teaspoon or tablespoon units measured wrong 42.5% of the time. Parents who used only milliliters measured wrong 27.6% of the time. The adjusted OR was 2.3, 95% CI 1.2–4.4 (the chance of measuring wrong is about more than double).

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Metamizole is not a first-choice drug for adults either. The leaflet says it can cause agranulocytosis (a lack of granulocytes, a class of white blood cell), aplastic anemia, and anaphylactic shock, and it is for short use only when the illness is urgent and severe and no other effective drug is available. Zhongganling (重感灵) sounds like an ordinary cold medicine, and it contains metamizole. Which fever medicine a child should take, and how much for the child's weight, is a question for a pediatrician or a pharmacist. A child under 3 months with a fever goes straight to the hospital; see section 20, item 8 (at 38 °C, go straight to the hospital). The grade is B because the Reye's syndrome figures come from surveillance reports. The drop in cases and the publication of the warning are a before-and-after relationship, not a controlled trial. The benefit is rated large because, after the warning, cases fell from 555 a year to under 36.

## 3. People over 60, with a history of stomach bleeding, taking anticoagulants or steroids should consult a doctor before using painkillers like ibuprofen

**Cost**. No cost involved. Simply ask a doctor or pharmacist.

**In plain terms**. Painkillers such as ibuprofen, naproxen, and aspirin can harm the stomach. In the high-dose trials, people taking ibuprofen had about 4 times the risk of stomach bleeding or a hole in the stomach wall, compared with people not taking it. The risk is higher for older people, people who have had stomach bleeding, people who are also taking a blood thinner or a steroid drug, and people who drink more than 3 cups of alcohol a day.

**Benefit**. These medications are classified as nonsteroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (NSAIDs); common examples include ibuprofen, naproxen, and diclofenac. A meta-analysis encompassing 280 randomized trials involving 124,513 participants demonstrated that compared to placebo, ibuprofen raised the risk of upper gastrointestinal perforation, obstruction, or bleeding by an RR of 3.97 (95% CI 2.22–7.10; roughly about 4 times). Naproxen showed an RR of 4.22 (2.71–6.56), while diclofenac resulted in an RR of 1.89 (1.16–3.09). All NSAIDs also approximately double the risk of heart failure. U.S. regulations mandate that over-the-counter NSAIDs carry warnings about stomach bleeding; these warnings specifically identify six high-risk groups: individuals over 60, those with prior stomach ulcers or bleeding, people on anticoagulants or steroids, individuals concurrently taking multiple NSAIDs, drinkers consuming more than three alcoholic beverages daily, and users exceeding recommended dosages or duration.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. The study conclusions pertain to high-dose usage. No separate figures are provided for occasional short-term use at standard doses. Many multi-ingredient cold remedies also contain NSAIDs; combining them with separate painkillers results in redundant intake. Patients prescribed low-dose aspirin long-term by physicians for thrombosis prevention must not discontinue it or self-administer additional NSAIDs without medical guidance. For how to use painkillers like these for period pain and when to see a gynecologist, see Section 3, item 25 (taking ibuprofen-type painkillers for period pain).

## 4. For children under 2 with colds, don't give them over-the-counter multi-ingredient cold and cough medicines on your own

**Cost**. There is no cost at all; you even save money by not buying these medicines.

**In plain terms**. The National Medical Products Administration requires a warning on 14 kinds of combination cold medicines for children. The warning says it does not recommend that a parent give the medicine to a child under 2 on their own. It should be used with a doctor or a pharmacist guiding it. In trials done on children, cough medicines and anti-allergy medicines worked no better than a placebo (a dummy pill).

**Benefit**. In its Announcement No. 57 of 2021, the National Medical Products Administration updated the instructions for 14 such medicines, including paracetamol, pseudoephedrine and dextromethorphan oral solution, pediatric paracetamol, artificial cow-bezoar and chlorpheniramine maleate granules, and pediatric paracetamol and amantadine hydrochloride granules. The new warning reads: “It is not recommended for parents or guardians to give these products to infants under 2 years old on their own; they should only be used under the guidance of a doctor or pharmacist.” An additional note was added: “These products must be used strictly according to the dosage instructions on the package to avoid overdosing.” Another note states: “Concurrent use of other cold medicines containing the same or similar active ingredients should be avoided.” A Cochrane systematic review included 29 randomized controlled trials, 10 of which were conducted on children. For all these medicine types, no better effect than placebo was observed in pediatric trials: cough medicines, antihistamines (the anti-allergy component), antihistamines combined with decongestants (the ingredient that relieves nasal congestion), and cough medicines combined with bronchodilators. Adverse

reactions were reported in 21 studies, with formulations containing antihistamines and dextromethorphan showing a higher incidence of side effects.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Many of these 14 medicines have "paracetamol" in their name, as they contain acetaminophen. Taking them together with other fever reducers will lead to redundant intake, as noted in Section 1 of this chapter (on acetaminophen). One trial included in the review found honey to be more effective than placebo for treating coughs, but honey should not be given to children under 1 year old, as detailed in Section 20, Item 6 (on honey). The evidence grade is set to B because there are very few trials for each type of medicine in the review, and the authors could not calculate a combined statistical figure. The benefit level is rated "moderate" as there is no proven benefit of these medicines for children, while the main risks are overdosing and redundant intake of similar active ingredients.

## 5. Pregnancy after 20 weeks: avoid taking ibuprofen and similar painkillers on your own

**Cost**. No cost involved.

**In plain terms**. Taking a drug like ibuprofen after 20 weeks of pregnancy can harm the kidneys of the fetus and leave less fluid around the baby. Among reports of this kind received in the United States, there were cases in which the newborn died. Low-dose aspirin prescribed by a doctor is not included.

**Benefit**. In October 2020, the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) issued a safety warning. Use of nonsteroidal anti-inflammatory drugs after roughly 20 weeks of pregnancy may cause kidney problems in the fetus, leading to low amniotic fluid levels. This warning applies to both prescription and over-the-counter drugs, including aspirin, ibuprofen, naproxen, diclofenac and celecoxib. After reviewing adverse event reports up to July 2017, the FDA identified 35 cases of low amniotic fluid or neonatal kidney dysfunction, all with serious outcomes; 5 of these newborns died, each with accompanying kidney failure. In most documented cases, amniotic fluid levels returned to normal within 72 hours to 6 days after medication use stopped. The FDA advises pregnant women not to take these drugs after week 20 unless explicitly directed by a doctor. Low-dose aspirin (81 mg) prescribed for specific pregnancy-related conditions is exempt from this restriction. When pain relief or fever reduction is needed, the FDA recommends using alternatives such as acetaminophen; consult a pharmacist or doctor first.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The FDA notes that many over-the-counter products for colds, flu or insomnia also contain these ingredients, so always check the ingredient list. Previously, U.S. over-the-counter drug labels only warned against use in the final 3 months of pregnancy; this new warning sets the cutoff at around 20 weeks. Low-dose aspirin for preventing preeclampsia is discussed in Section 27, point 5 ("Low-dose aspirin"). The grade B rating reflects that these figures come from adverse event reports; we have no data on how many women took these drugs without experiencing any issues. The "moderate" benefit rating reflects the seriousness of these outcomes, even though they occur infrequently.

## 6. If you buy omeprazole yourself for heartburn and acid reflux, take it for at most 7 days; for trouble swallowing, vomiting blood, or black stool, go straight to the hospital

**Cost**. No money. Take it for the number of days written on the leaflet.

**In plain terms**. Omeprazole enteric-coated tablets (tablets with a delayed-release coating) have been sold with no prescription since 2022, but the leaflet says not to take them on your own for more than 7 days, and not to take them again within 2 months. Do not take them yourself if swallowing is difficult or painful, if you vomit blood, if there is blood in the stool, or if the stool is black. Those can be signs of something serious. This drug can also hide the symptoms of stomach cancer and delay the diagnosis.

**Benefit**. Announcement No. 68 of 2022 from the National Medical Products Administration switched omeprazole enteric-coated tablets from prescription to over-the-counter and issued a model leaflet. The listed use is short-term relief of heartburn and acid reflux caused by too much stomach acid. The precautions say: do not use it for more than 7 days, and if the symptoms do not ease, ask a doctor or a pharmacist. Do not take it again within 2 months. If the symptoms come back, get medical care at once. Do not use it when swallowing is difficult or painful, when you vomit blood, when there is blood in the stool, or when the stool is black. Those can be signs of something serious. When alarm symptoms appear, such as clear weight loss, repeated vomiting, trouble swallowing, vomiting blood, or black stool, a malignant tumor has to be ruled out first. The reason is that treatment can hide the symptoms and delay the diagnosis. A person over 55 with a new symptom, or with a symptom that has changed, should ask a doctor. People taking clopidogrel should avoid taking omeprazole at the same time. The reason is in the US leaflet for clopidogrel (Plavix). Omeprazole inhibits the enzyme in the body that converts clopidogrel (CYP2C19). The leaflet says "omeprazole was shown to reduce significantly the antiplatelet activity of Plavix when given concomitantly or 12 hours apart". Taken together, or taken 12 hours apart, clopidogrel's effect against blood clots is clearly weaker either way. The uses written in that leaflet are acute coronary syndrome, a recent heart attack, a recent stroke, and peripheral arterial disease.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Clopidogrel is a drug that prevents blood clots. People who have had a heart attack or a stroke often take it. Omeprazole makes it weaker, so a person already taking it should ask a doctor first. The grade is B because these are rules on a leaflet. No study has calculated how many incidents following them would prevent. The benefit is rated moderate, as a judgment: what it guards against is a delay in finding stomach bleeding or stomach cancer, but most heartburn and acid reflux are not serious.

## 7. Do not ask a doctor for antibiotics for an ordinary cold

**Cost**. No money, and you save the money for the medicine.

**In plain terms**. Antibiotics for a cold do not make you better any faster than not taking them. For an adult who takes them, the risk of side effects is more than twice the risk of not taking them. If a runny nose with pus has lasted under 10 days, antibiotics have no definite benefit either.

**Benefit**. A Cochrane systematic review pooled 6 randomized trials and 1147 people. Compared with a placebo, antibiotics for a cold made no clear difference in the share who had not recovered or whose symptoms persisted (RR 0.83, 95% CI 0.60–1.14, and the difference is not significant). The risk of adverse reactions was 1.8 times the placebo group (95% CI 1.01–3.21). For adults it was 2.62 times (1.32–5.18). For children it did not rise (0.91, 0.51–1.63). For acute purulent rhinitis with a pus-filled runny nose lasting under 10 days, antibiotics also had no clear benefit (RR 0.73, 0.47–1.13). Adverse reactions were more common, though (RR 1.46, 1.10–1.94, about 46% higher). The authors' conclusion is that routine antibiotics are not recommended in either situation.

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. This edition was issued again in 2025, and the abstract states that the literature search runs through 2013. In China antibiotics are prescription drugs. A pharmacy has to sell them against a prescription. Do not take leftover antibiotics at home on your own either. The benefit is rated moderate, as a judgment: what it prevents is adverse reactions, not death. Also do not ask for an intravenous drip for a cold. See section 6, item 35 (asking for an intravenous drip for a cold or a fever).

## 8. For diarrhea, drink oral rehydration salts first; do not give anti-diarrhea drugs to a child under 5

**Cost**. A box of oral rehydration salts costs a few yuan to a little over 10 yuan. Keep a box at home.

**In plain terms**. What matters most in diarrhea is replacing water, not stopping the diarrhea. Mix oral rehydration salts with water the way the leaflet says, and drink that. Do not use fruit juice or a soft drink

instead. They are too sweet, and that makes a person even shorter of water. Do not give a child under 5 an anti-diarrhea drug such as loperamide. A severe case can block the bowel, and that can kill.

**Benefit**. The diarrhea-treatment manual of the World Health Organization (WHO) states that "anti-diarrhea" drugs and anti-vomiting drugs have no real benefit for acute or prolonged diarrhea in children. They cannot prevent dehydration, and they cannot improve nutrition. The Chinese edition of the manual says, in its own words, that some drugs have dangerous and sometimes fatal side effects, and that these drugs must never be used in children under 5. Drugs such as loperamide, which slow the movement of the bowel, can cause severe paralytic obstruction of the bowel. That can kill, and it can also drag the infection out. The manual also states that drinks with too much sugar, such as soft drinks and fruit drinks sold in shops, pull water from the body into the intestine and cause hypernatremic dehydration (dehydration in which the blood sodium is too high). What the WHO manual recommends is a reduced-osmolarity formula, with a total osmolarity of 245 mOsm/L (milliosmoles per liter). Compared with the older formula, it cut unplanned intravenous fluids by 33%. A Cochrane review pooled 8 trials and found a similar result (OR 0.59, 95% CI 0.45–0.79, about 40% less).

**Evidence grade**. A

**Notes**. When you buy it, check the osmolarity on the leaflet and choose the reduced-osmolarity formula. The manual states that blood in a child's stool is usually bacterial dysentery. See a doctor for antibiotics. Do not only replace water at home. The benefit is rated moderate, as a judgment: the figures in hand compare the rehydration formulas with each other, not drinking against not drinking.

## 9. Do not take painkillers on more than 15 days a month, or combination painkillers on more than 10 days, or the headache may be caused by the medicine

**Cost**. No money. You have to keep count of the days you take the medicine, and hold back from taking it whenever it is at hand.

**In plain terms**. If headaches keep coming and you take a painkiller every day, you may hurt more the more you take. The international headache classification calls this a medication-overuse headache, a headache brought on by the medicine itself. Headache on more than 15 days in a month, plus an ordinary painkiller on more than 15 days or a combination painkiller on more than 10 days, running past 3 months, is enough for the diagnosis. Most people improve after they stop the medicine they were taking too much of.

**Benefit**. The 3rd edition of the International Classification of Headache Disorders, from the International Headache Society, gives the diagnostic criteria. The person already has a headache disorder, has headache on more than 15 days a month, and has regularly overused a medicine for headache for more than 3 months. For non-opioid painkillers such as acetaminophen, aspirin, and ibuprofen, the overuse line is 15 days a month or more. For combination painkillers the line is 10 days a month or more. A combination painkiller means more than a single class of pain-relieving drug combined, or a painkiller with an added ingredient such as caffeine, for example acetaminophen plus codeine. If you rotate several non-opioid painkillers, the days are added together. The classification states that epidemiological evidence from several countries shows that, among people with headache on more than 15 days a month, more than half have this kind of headache. Most patients improve after they stop the overused medicine, and treatment to prevent headaches also works better.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Pain tablets whose Chinese name includes the character for caffeine (咖) usually have caffeine added, so count them as combination painkillers, with a limit of 10 days. If the headache days in a month keep increasing, go to a neurology clinic. Do not only add more medicine. The grade is B because the classification gives a diagnostic threshold, not a controlled trial. The benefit is rated moderate, as a judgment: what you get back is fewer days of headache, and death is not part of it.

## 10. Clear out expired medicines and leftovers you will not use, on a regular schedule, and put them in the hazardous-waste bin with the packaging; do not keep them at home

**Cost**. No money. Go through the medicine box once a year. It takes a little over 10 minutes.

**In plain terms**. In the United States, of the medicines a child swallowed without an adult watching, nearly half were prescription tablets. Of those prescription medicines, about 3 in 10 belonged to a grandparent. Clearing out medicines you will not use removes something a child can find. Put the cleared-out medicine, packaging and all, into the hazardous-waste bin, or hand it to a pharmacy that takes old medicines.

**Benefit**. US emergency-department surveillance estimates that from 2004 to 2013, children under 6 who swallowed a medicine without an adult watching made about 640000 emergency visits (the estimate is 640161). In 2013 alone there were about 59000 (59092). From 2010 to 2013, the most common form was an oral prescription tablet, 45.9%. Among prescription drugs, the most common were opioid painkillers (13.8%) and benzodiazepines, sedative drugs used for sleep and calming (12.7%). In 2017, 5 US poison-control centers asked parents who called for help. When a child swallowed a prescription drug, 30.7% of the time it was a grandparent's medicine. More than half (51.5%) of the prescription drugs had already been taken out of the original packaging by an adult before the child got them. China's National Catalogue of Hazardous Wastes (2025 edition) lists waste medicines produced in ordinary household life, and their packaging, as hazardous waste within domestic garbage. Shanghai's sorting guide puts waste medicines in hazardous waste. The guide states that waste medicines include expired drugs, drug capsules, tablets, and the inner packaging, and that "waste medicines should preferably be put out together with the packaging." Shanghai also requires that expired household medicines collected by pharmacies go to a temporary transfer point set up by the market supervision administration of each district. The US FDA says the best way to deal with expired and unwanted medicines is to hand them to a take-back point.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Waste-sorting lists are not the same everywhere. Follow the list posted at the building's waste room. In Shanghai, the dregs of traditional Chinese medicine go in wet waste, and they do not count as hazardous waste. Keep the medicines you still use in the original box. Do not tip them into a pill organizer or another bottle. Put them where a child cannot reach them. See section 13, item 20 (accidental ingestion). Do not take leftover antibiotics at home on your own either. See item 7 of this section (antibiotics). When there is no take-back point, the US advice is to mix the medicine into coffee grounds or cat litter, seal the bag, and throw it in ordinary trash. A few strong painkillers are allowed to be flushed down the toilet. That is the US practice. In China, sort the waste the way the local rules say. The grade is B because those US figures are only a registry. No study has calculated how many accidental swallows clearing the medicine box would prevent. The benefit is rated small: the figures in hand are emergency visits, not deaths, and they cannot show the effect of the clearing itself.

## 11. While taking an antibacterial such as a cephalosporin or metronidazole, and for 7 days after stopping, do not drink alcohol, and do not take an alcohol-containing medicine such as Huoxiang Zhengqi oral liquid or cough syrup

**Cost**. No money. No alcohol for a little over a week. Before taking another medicine, glance at whether the ingredients include ethanol.

**In plain terms**. Some cephalosporins, and drugs such as metronidazole, make the face flush and bring on sweating and a racing heart if they meet alcohol. A severe case brings trouble breathing and a drop in blood pressure. It is not only liquor and beer. An alcohol-containing medicine such as Huoxiang Zhengqi oral liquid (藿香正气水, a Chinese medicine liquid that contains alcohol) or cough syrup can do it too. Do not touch alcohol from the time you are taking the drug through 7 days after you stop.

**Benefit**. This is called a disulfiram-like reaction. A 2023 medication-safety article from the Fujian drug regulator says that drinking before or after some cephalosporins can set off this reaction, and that it "can seriously harm health and can even threaten life." Symptoms include a flushed face, sweating, and palpitations, and even difficulty breathing, a drop in blood pressure, and anaphylactic shock. Following the Clinical Medication Notices of the Pharmacopoeia of the People's Republic of China, the drugs it lists include cefazolin, ceftriaxone, cefoperazone, metronidazole, tinidazole, and furazolidone, among others. It states that drinking alcohol, and taking or eating drugs or foods that contain alcohol, is forbidden for 7 days after the dose. The examples include liqueur chocolates and Huoxiang Zhengqi oral liquid. The reason given is that the enzyme the drug inhibits often takes 4 to 5 days to recover. A hospital in Guangzhou reviewed 82 cases over 2 years. Cephalosporins caused 57 cases (69.51%). Nitroimidazoles, the class that includes metronidazole and tinidazole, caused 10 cases (12.20%). The alcohol came from alcoholic drinks in 40 cases (48.78%) and from ethanol-containing medicines in 31 cases (37.80%). Medicines taken by mouth included Huoxiang Zhengqi oral liquid, cough syrup, and motherwort fluid extract (益母草流浸膏). Of the 82 cases, 68 were mild, 9 were moderate, and 5 were severe. They eased within 1 to 3 hours. Nobody died. The US leaflet for metronidazole requires no alcohol during treatment and for at least 3 days after stopping, and no products that contain propylene glycol.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. Not every cephalosporin does this, but an ordinary person cannot tell them apart, so the simple course is to follow this rule for any of them. When a doctor prescribes a cephalosporin or metronidazole, say whether you drank in the past few days. That article also suggests not drinking for 3 days before the dose, and it admits that this gap has no authoritative statement at present. If the face flushes and the heart races, stop anything that contains alcohol at once. The article says a mild case can pass on its own, and a severe case needs a hospital. Do not drink alcohol while taking acetaminophen either. See item 1 of this section (acetaminophen). The grade is B because the evidence is a set of cases and a leaflet, with no comparison group. The benefit is rated small: all 82 cases eased within a few hours, nobody died, and only 5 were severe. For how to look after someone who is drunk, see section 13, item 46 (someone is drunk).

## 12. After a cold medicine or an anti-allergy medicine that contains chlorphenamine (also called chlorpheniramine) or diphenhydramine, do not drive while you are taking it, and do not work at a height or operate a machine

**Cost**. No money. Glance at the ingredient list when you buy the medicine. On the days you take it, ride with someone else or take a taxi, or ask a doctor or a pharmacist to switch you to a medicine that does not make you drowsy.

**In plain terms**. Many combination cold medicines mix in an anti-allergy ingredient such as chlorphenamine or diphenhydramine, and taking it makes you drowsy. The national drug regulator says that while you are taking this kind of drug, do not drive, do not work at a height, and do not operate a machine. On a driving simulator, people who had taken diphenhydramine drove worse than people who had drunk alcohol. Feeling that you are not drowsy does not mean the driving is fine.

**Benefit**. A 2010 adverse-reaction bulletin from the National Medical Products Administration says that vitamin C Yinqiao tablets (维 C 银翘片) contain chlorphenamine maleate, also called chlorpheniramine (扑尔敏). The adverse reactions are mainly drowsiness, a feeling of weakness, sleepiness, and a dry mouth. The bulletin advises doctors and pharmacies to tell the patient: while taking the drug, do not operate an aircraft, a vehicle, or a boat, and do not do work at a height, mechanical work, or operate a precision instrument. A 2020 public medication notice from the National Medical Products Administration says that combination cold medicines often contain an anti-allergy ingredient such as chlorphenamine or diphenhydramine, and that taking them causes drowsiness. People who drive, operate machinery, or work at a height should be cautious. A US driving-simulator trial enrolled 40 drivers with seasonal allergic rhinitis, aged 25 to 44. Each person switched treatment a week apart and drove for 1 hour under each: diphenhydramine 50 mg, fexofenadine 60

mg, alcohol up to a blood alcohol concentration of about 0.1%, and a placebo. Fexofenadine is an anti-allergy drug that does not cause drowsiness. The ability to match the speed of the car ahead was worst after diphenhydramine, and clearly better both after alcohol and after fexofenadine. The ability to hold the lane got worse both after alcohol and after diphenhydramine. When the car ahead suddenly blocked the way, the reaction was slowest after alcohol, a mean of 2.21 seconds, and after fexofenadine it was 1.95 seconds. Driving on fexofenadine was about the same as driving on placebo. The authors' conclusion is that diphenhydramine affects driving more than alcohol does. The drowsiness a driver reported did not show how well they drove, so "whether I feel drowsy" cannot decide whether they can drive.

**Evidence grade**. B

**Notes**. The products the drug regulator named, paracetamol with pseudoephedrine, dextromethorphan, and chlorphenamine (酚麻美敏), compound paracetamol and amantadine (复方氨酚烷胺), and paracetamol with caffeine and chlorphenamine (氨咖黄敏), all contain chlorphenamine. Read the ingredient list before you buy. What the Road Traffic Safety Law expressly forbids is driving after a state-controlled psychotropic drug or a narcotic drug. Ordinary cold medicines and anti-allergy medicines are not in that ban. The instruction not to drive is written in the leaflet and in the drug regulator's notice. If you have to take the medicine and you also have to drive, ask a doctor or a pharmacist for a drug that does not make you drowsy. Many of these cold medicines also contain acetaminophen. See item 1 of this section (acetaminophen). Other risks of driving while drowsy are in section 1, item 9 (when you are drowsy, pull over and rest). The grade is B because there is only a single simulator trial of 40 people, and no crash figures from real roads. The benefit is rated small: the endpoint is driving performance in a simulator, not crashes and deaths. Besides you, the people who benefit are family in the car and other people on the road.

Unofficial English translation of docs/结婚划不划算.md. In case of discrepancies the Chinese original takes precedence.

# Is Marriage Worth It: Breaking One Muddled Ledger into Five Clear Accounts

The reader is asking one bundled question: whether marriage is, on balance, a loss or a gain; whether the partner will provide emotional value, share the housework, earn money — or whether marrying is just a task performed for one's elders. As a single question it cannot be answered, because it adds together several things that cannot be converted into one another. This article takes it apart. Each account uses only numbers that can be found in official statistics or meta-analyses; wherever a figure cannot be computed, that is said plainly; at the end there is a worksheet you can fill in yourself. The article draws no conclusion about "whether to marry."

## 1. First, break the question apart

"Is marriage worth it" contains at least five accounts, each on a different measure:

1. Money: direct spending (彩礼 (caili — bride price), the wedding, the marital home) and the legal rules on property. The former has no official statistics; the latter has statutory text.
2. Time: housework, caregiving, and unpaid labor such as giving way in one's own work for the partner's sake. The measure is minutes per day.
3. Health: the difference in mortality between married and unmarried people. The measure is relative risk, and it is correlation only.
4. Legal risk: how property is divided, how long an exit takes, which obligations can be compensated. The measure is statute text.
5. Relationship quality: emotional value, conflict, support. The measure is effect size, which cannot be converted into money or time.

The fifth is the hardest to quantify, and the closest to what the reader is actually asking.

## 2. The data and sources behind each account

### Registration data: marriage and divorce rates are two crude rates

The Ministry of Civil Affairs' 《2024 年民政事业发展统计公报》 (2024 Statistical Communiqué on the Development of Civil Affairs): in 2024, 6.106 million couples registered a marriage nationwide in accordance with the law, down 20.5% from the previous year, for a marriage rate of 4.3‰; 3.513 million couples completed divorce proceedings in accordance with the law, of which 2.622 million were registered divorces handled by civil affairs departments and 891,000 were divorces by court judgment or court mediation, for a divorce rate of 2.5‰. A note to the communiqué spells out the formula: the number of couples marrying (or divorcing) in the year, divided by the average total population of the year, multiplied by 1,000‰.

Both numbers take the entire population as their denominator, which is why they are called crude rates. They answer "how many couples per thousand people registered a marriage or a divorce this year"; they do not answer "will this marriage eventually end in divorce." The latter question needs cohort data, and I did not find it in the official texts.

### The health account: married people have lower mortality, but this is correlation, not causation

Three meta-analyses give a consistent order of magnitude:

- Manzoli et al. (2007) pooled 53 comparisons and more than 250,000 older adults. For all-cause mortality, the RR of the married relative to the unmarried (widowed, divorced or separated, never married) was 0.88 (95% CI 0.85–0.91); widowed 1.11, divorced or separated 1.16, never married 1.11. The result did not vary by sex, study quality, or European/North American region; the most conservative recalculation gave an RR of 0.94.

- Roelfs et al. (2011) pooled 95 studies and more than 500 million people. The HR for all-cause mortality of the never married relative to the married was 1.24 (1.19–1.30). The effect diminished with age, and the higher the study quality, the smaller the effect.
- Wang et al. (2020) pooled 21 studies and more than 7.89 million people. Being unmarried was associated with all-cause, cancer, and cardiovascular mortality in both sexes, with stronger cardiovascular and all-cause associations in men; among the never married, men had a 31% higher risk of death from stroke and 9% higher all-cause mortality than women.

All three are observational studies. People who are healthy, well off, and socially connected are both more likely to marry and more likely to live long — this is the selection effect. Manzoli found signs of publication bias. These numbers should be read as "mortality is somewhat lower among the married," not as "marriage will make you 12% less likely to die." The samples are mostly European and North American; for China they can serve only as an order-of-magnitude reference.

### The time account: the gender gap in unpaid labor is an upper-bound reference

The National Bureau of Statistics' Third National Time Use Survey (May 2024): among those who took part in unpaid labor, the daily average was 2 hours 45 minutes — 1 hour 52 minutes for men, 3 hours 29 minutes for women; the participation rate was 75.6%, men 67.5%, women 83.9%. By activity, the population average for housework was 1 hour 17 minutes per day (1 hour 59 minutes among participants, 28 minutes less than in 2018; participation rate 64.9%); accompanying and caring for family members averaged 30 minutes (1 hour 46 minutes among participants; participation rate 28.4%).

The second survey, in 2018: the population average for housework was 1 hour 26 minutes — 45 minutes for men, 2 hours 6 minutes for women — with participation rates of 40.4% for men and 75.6% for women. Accompanying and caring for children day to day averaged 36 minutes — 17 minutes for men, 53 minutes for women — with participation rates of 12.3% for men and 25.1% for women.

Both surveys break results down only by sex, urban or rural residence, and age — not by marital status — so there is no official number for "how much more housework per day after marriage." What can be used is the gender gap: in 2024, unpaid labor differed between men and women by 1 hour 37 minutes per day, which can serve as an upper bound for the gap that may open up when the division of labor is never talked through.

### The money account: default rules, written agreements, and housework compensation

There are no official statistics on bride price, weddings, or the marital home, so this article states no numbers. What can be stated are the rules in the Marriage and Family book of the 《民法典》 (Civil Code), in force since January 1, 2021:

- Article 1,062: Wages, bonuses, and remuneration for labor services acquired during the marriage; income from production, business operations, and investment; income from intellectual property; and property acquired by inheritance or as a gift (except where a will or a gift contract clearly specifies it belongs to one party alone) are community property of the husband and wife, who have equal rights to dispose of it.
- Article 1,063: One spouse's premarital property; compensation or damages received for personal injury; property specified in a will or a gift contract as belonging to one party alone; and articles of daily use for one spouse's exclusive use are that spouse's separate property.
- Article 1,065: A man and a woman may agree that premarital and postmarital property be owned separately, jointly, or in part separately and in part jointly. The agreement must be in writing and is legally binding on both parties. Where there is no agreement or the agreement is unclear, the preceding two articles apply.
- Article 1,088: Where one spouse bears the heavier obligations — raising children, caring for elderly family members, assisting the other spouse's work — that spouse has the right to request compensation from the other at the time of divorce. The specifics are settled by agreement between the two; failing agreement, the court decides.

These rules work in both directions: the higher-earning side looks at Articles 1,062 and 1,065; the side carrying more of the unpaid labor looks at Article 1,088. An agreement only has to be in writing; notarization is not a statutory requirement.

### Exit costs: the cooling-off period and the conditions for a court case

- Article 1,076: Where both spouses agree to divorce, they sign a written divorce agreement and apply in person at the marriage registration office. The agreement must record their agreed positions on the raising of children and on the handling of property and debts.
- Article 1,077: Within thirty days of the day the registration office receives the application, either spouse may withdraw it if no longer willing to divorce. Within thirty days after that period ends, both spouses must apply in person for the divorce certificate; if they do not apply, the application is deemed withdrawn.
- Article 1,079: A spouse who wants a divorce may go through mediation or file suit directly. The court is to mediate first, and is to grant the divorce where the relationship has indeed broken down and mediation has failed. Where mediation fails, divorce shall be granted in cases of bigamy or cohabitation with another person; domestic violence or the mistreatment or abandonment of family members; gambling, drug use, or other vices that persist despite repeated correction; or separation for two full years because the relationship has broken down. Where the court has denied a divorce and the parties have then been separated for one full year and one party sues again, the divorce shall be granted.

Of the 3.513 million divorces in 2024, 891,000 went through court judgment or court mediation. The cooling-off period applies only to registered divorce.

### Relationship quality: an account worth more attention than "married or not"

Robles et al. (2014) pooled 126 studies and more than 72,000 people: the higher the marital quality, the better the health, with effect sizes r between 0.07 and 0.21 — including r = 0.11 for mortality risk and r = −0.13 for cardiovascular reactivity during marital conflict. These effect sizes are small, but comparable in magnitude to the association between health and health behaviors such as diet. Some outcomes showed publication bias. Studies that explicitly tested for sex differences found essentially no difference between men and women. Most of the designs cannot support causal inference. Dhindsa et al. (2020) likewise note in their cardiovascular review that marital dissatisfaction and marital quality have a significant effect on cardiovascular risk.

This article did not find a meta-analysis that directly compares mortality in a "low-quality marriage" with the unmarried. "A bad marriage is worse than not marrying" is currently an inference, not a numerical conclusion. The statement that holds up is this: the effect of "married or not" carries a selection effect; "good quality or bad" is another independent variable. A decision made on status alone, without looking at quality, leaves the second account out of the calculation.

## 3. How to run the numbers yourself: a fill-in worksheet

Fill in each account by its own measure, and do not add numbers across measures. Where a cell cannot be filled, write "don't know" — that is information in itself.

What the partner can provide (by measure)

- Money: what the partner's income, debts, and premarital property are; whether marital property follows the default rules or a written agreement, and what the agreement says.
- Time: how much unpaid labor the partner does per day now (national average among participants: men 1 hour 52 minutes, women 3 hours 29 minutes); how it would be divided after marriage; how it would be divided when there are children or elderly to care for; whose work can give way.
- Relationship quality: how many conflicts there have been in the past six months and how they ended; what the partner did when you were ill, unemployed, or low; what you did in the same situations.

- Emotional value: whether your energy increases or drains when you are with the partner. This takes months of time together to judge; a list of conditions will not show it.

What you will put in (by measure)

- Money: how much will be spent on the marriage itself (bride price, wedding, marital home), and where that money would go instead if you did not marry.
- Time: how much unpaid labor you expect to add per day, and how much 人情往来 (renqing — reciprocal visits and gifts between families) per week.
- Health: whether your daily routine, diet, and exercise will get better or worse because of the marriage. This line is closer to you than any RR in a meta-analysis.
- Exit cost: registered divorce takes a 30-day cooling-off period plus a further 30 days to apply for the certificate; going to court requires meeting the conditions of Article 1,079. Whether you can bear that timeline is a question only you can answer.

How the law protects you (applies to both sides)

- Is there documentation for premarital property (home purchase contract, bank statements, gift contract, will), and can it prove the property is "premarital" or "clearly designated for one party alone"?
- Should there be a written property agreement, and would it cover premarital property, marital acquisitions, or both?
- After marriage, who will bear more of the unpaid labor; does that person know about the right to compensation under Article 1,088; are both of you willing to agree on a compensation method in advance?
- Debts: of money borrowed in one person's name during the marriage, which counts as joint debt, and does each of you know about it?

Marrying for the elders (fill this column separately)

- What the elders gain: peace of mind, 面子 (mianzi — social face), an end to the pressure to marry, someone to provide for them in old age.
- Which of these gains belong to the elders, and which are actually your own.
- The costs in the three columns above are borne entirely by you; the elders' gains do not automatically turn into your health or your relationship quality.
- Written out separately, whether this account weighs heavy or light is for the person filling in the sheet to judge.

## 4. Common mistakes

Mixing up divorce-rate measures. The crude divorce rate (divorcing couples per thousand people; 2.5‰ in 2024) and the divorce-to-marriage ratio (divorces in the year divided by marriages in the year; 3.513 million / 6.106 million ≈ 57.5%) are two different things. The numerator and the denominator of the ratio are not the same people: most of those divorcing this year married years ago, and a falling number of marriages mechanically pushes the ratio up. It does not mean "half of all marriages end in divorce," and the communiqué contains no such indicator.

Treating correlation as causation. That the married have mortality about 12% lower is the pooled result of meta-analyses, but health, income, and social life each independently affect both "can one marry" and "can one live long." The account can be computed, but it must be discounted, and it cannot stand in for a judgment about this particular relationship.

Treating marriage as a task. A task-driven marriage looks only at "status" and not at "quality," while the effect of relationship quality on health is a separate account, independent of marital status, and is usually omitted from task-driven decisions.

Taking national averages for your own numbers. The gender gap in the time use surveys is a national average; the property rules are default rules that can be changed in writing. National numbers are for magnitude and for a starting point in negotiation, not for conclusions.

Where there is no official number, do not fill the gap with unofficial ones. Bride price, weddings, and the cost of raising children have no official statistics; this article leaves them blank. A reader's own numbers, filled in by the reader, are more accurate than any institution's estimate.

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Unofficial English translation of docs/家庭应急装备清单.md. In case of discrepancies the Chinese original takes precedence.

# Home Emergency Supplies Checklist: What to Buy, Where to Put It, and How Often to Check

This corresponds to item 26 of Section 1 of the README. This checklist answers only the question of what a household should keep on hand; it does not repeat how to use any of it. The actions for escaping a fire, cardiopulmonary resuscitation, major bleeding, burns, and carbon monoxide poisoning are all in Section 13; smoke alarms and carbon monoxide alarms are in Section 1, item 3; gas hoses and stoves are in Section 1, item 4.

The yardstick throughout is mortality and external-cause injury. The evidence that the equipment itself pays off is not strong; the reasoning is in the final section, and you should read that one before this list.

## 1. The official list, as written

The Ministry of Emergency Management's National Basic Recommended List of Household Emergency Supplies for Reserve has 11 items; the original descriptions are reproduced below.

| No. | Item | Original description |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Drinking water | Covers each person's basic drinking-water needs for 3 days, at least 3 liters per person |
| 2 | Convenience food | Covers each person's basic food needs for 3 days. Convenience food is compact and calorie-dense |
| 3 | Fire extinguisher and fire blanket | For putting out incipient fires. The fire blanket can be draped over the body to escape |
| 4 | Respirator | A filter-type fire self-rescue respirator, for use when escaping a fire |
| 5 | Flashlight | Waterproof and explosion-proof flashlight. Recharge or replace the batteries regularly |
| 6 | Multi-function pocket knife | Combines knife, saw, screwdriver, steel pliers, and other functions |
| 7 | Radio | For receiving emergency broadcasts |
| 8 | Life-saving whistle | Can produce a high-frequency distress signal |
| 9 | External-use medicines | Styptic powder, adhesive bandages, gauze bandages, and so on, for treating wounds |
| 10 | Disinfecting wipes | For personal hygiene |
| 11 | Medical surgical masks | Protection against viruses |

Source: Ministry of Emergency Management (2020). National Basic Recommended List of Household Emergency Supplies for Reserve. https://www.mem.gov.cn/kp/shaq/202011/t20201129_372149.shtml

Local versions are more detailed. The Beijing Municipal Emergency Management Bureau's list for resident households comes in a basic version and an expanded version. The basic version covers "3 categories — emergency items, emergency tools, and emergency medicines"; its specific items are a hand-crank rechargeable flashlight with radio function, a life-saving whistle, towels/tissues or wet wipes, a respirator, multi-function combination scissors, an emergency escape rope, a fire extinguisher or fire blanket, plus anti-

infective and anti-cold medicines, medical materials such as medical surgical masks and gauze bandages, and iodophor cotton swabs. The expanded version covers "5 categories of emergency supplies — food, personal items, escape and self-rescue tools, medical first-aid supplies, and important documents." The Bureau also advises "buying emergency supplies from producers and sellers with lawful qualifications and a good reputation," "stockpiling the basic-version emergency supply items first," and "mastering the correct use of emergency supplies, checking their condition regularly, and promptly replacing any supplies that are past their shelf life."

Source: Beijing Municipal Emergency Management Bureau (2020). Beijing revises and issues the recommended list of emergency supplies for resident households. https://yjglj.beijing.gov.cn/art/2020/12/23/art_6058_664632.html; item-by-item detail as republished by the People's Government of Xicheng District, Beijing. https://www.bjxch.gov.cn/zt/kpzc/xxxq/pnidpv858729.html

There was a 2024 update at the national level: Annex 2 of the Guiding Opinions on Further Strengthening the Emergency Rescue and Disaster Relief Supplies Support System and Capacity Building, issued by the Office of the National Committee for Disaster Prevention, Mitigation and Relief (Guofangjianjiubanfa [2024] No. 13, September 23, 2024), is the Guiding Catalog of Household Emergency Supplies for Reserve, divided into 5 categories — emergency food, daily-living items, emergency tools, emergency medicines and medical supplies, and important documents — with 16 items in the basic version and 31 in the expanded version. TODO (to verify: the item-by-item names of the 16 and 31 items in that annex; the official annex is a WPS file and an image-only PDF, and no text that could be checked verbatim was obtained this time).

## 2. The three fire-safety essentials

**Fire extinguisher.** Portable fire extinguishers are a product under mandatory certification and should carry the CCC mark (China Compulsory Certification, China's mandatory product-certification scheme); the applicable standard is GB 4351—2023, Portable Fire Extinguishers. Stored-pressure extinguishers carry a pressure gauge (except carbon dioxide extinguishers); the needle should sit inside the green zone, and if it points into the red or yellow zone the extinguisher is out of service. The disposal ages follow XF 95: 6 years for water-based types, 10 years for dry powder, 12 years for carbon dioxide, counted from the date of manufacture, which can be found in the steel stamp on the cylinder. For home use, ABC dry powder is the usual choice. Keep one at the kitchen door and one at the entryway; do not put it in the cabinet directly above the stove — an extinguisher you cannot reach when something is burning is the same as not having one.

**Fire blanket.** It appears in the official list alongside the fire extinguisher, with two uses: covering a burning oil pan, and wrapping around yourself to escape. Keep one in a kitchen drawer; it takes up no space and does not expire. When a pot catches fire, turn off the heat first, then cover it, and do not lift the blanket off again right away.

**Escape respirator.** The official name is the 消防过滤式自救呼吸器 (fire-service filter-type self-rescue respirator), covered by GB 21976.7—2012, Building fire escape and refuge equipment — Part 7: Filter-type fire self-rescue respirator, a mandatory national standard currently in force, implemented on June 1, 2013, whose 2023 review concluded it remains valid. When buying, look for this standard number and the CCC mark; keep one per person according to the size of the household, placed within reach at the bedside in the bedrooms, not locked away in a storage room. It works by adsorbing toxic substances from the smoke in a filter canister; it is single-use, has a rated protection time, and has exactly one purpose: put it on and walk out. TODO (to verify: the standard's exact wording on the lower limit of applicable oxygen content and the rated protection time; this pass obtained only the standard title, status, and implementation date, not the clause text).

What actually kills in a fire is the smoke. The escape actions are in Section 13, item 25, and the alarms in Section 1, item 3; both sit ahead of these three in priority.

## 3. What goes in the first-aid kit

The official list says only: "external-use medicines: styptic powder, adhesive bandages, gauze bandages, and so on, for treating wounds." Based on the first-aid actions already verified in Section 13, a reasonable home first-aid kit contains:

- Bleeding control: one windlass tourniquet, sterile gauze and bandages, a triangular bandage, medical tape. The tourniquet's use, its contraindications, and the rule "do not loosen it to let blood flow" are in Section 13, item 11
- Wound cleaning: iodophor cotton swabs, saline solution, adhesive bandages, sterile dressings, disposable gloves, scissors and tweezers
- Burns and scalds: no ointment of any kind is needed; 20 minutes of cool running water is the entire treatment, see Section 13, item 13
- Records: a card listing each family member's allergies, chronic conditions, and regular medications, to hand directly to the emergency personnel when they arrive

Someone with a known severe allergy should also keep an epinephrine auto-injector. That is a prescription drug; have a doctor prescribe it, see Section 13, item 14.

The contents list in this section is grade C: the official document gives only the phrase "external-use medicines," and the specific items are back-derived from the first-aid actions verified in this book, with no direct source behind them.

## 4. Lighting, communication, and signaling for help

For the flashlight, follow the official description: waterproof and explosion-proof, with batteries recharged or replaced regularly. The life-saving whistle is for signaling continuously while trapped; it takes less effort than shouting and carries through noise. The radio is for receiving emergency broadcasts. The Beijing version also lists an emergency escape rope and multi-function combination scissors. The phone power bank is the best value-for-money item in this category, and most households already have one.

## 5. A once-a-year check, ten minutes

- Fire extinguisher: whether the pressure gauge needle is in the green zone, and whether the manufacture date on the cylinder has reached the disposal age
- Smoke alarms and carbon monoxide alarms: press the test button, change the batteries once a year, see Section 1, item 3
- Escape respirator: whether the packaging is damaged and whether it is past its stated shelf life
- First-aid kit: whether medicines and dressings have expired, and whether the tourniquet's lock still locks
- Flashlight and power bank: whether they still have charge

The Beijing bureau's exact words are: "check the condition of emergency supplies regularly, and promptly replace any supplies that are past their shelf life." Pin the check to the same day as the yearly alarm-battery change and do it all in one pass.

## 6. What not to buy

- **A home AED.** Costs over 10,000 yuan per unit, and for the household setting there is no evidence supporting buying one yourself. The correct action in cardiac arrest is to start compressions immediately and have someone call 120 (China's medical emergency number) and fetch an AED from the nearest public place, see Section 13, item 1
- **"Fire masks" and "gas masks" without the CCC mark.** Article 24 of the Fire Protection Law provides that fire products subject to mandatory product certification under the law "may be produced, sold, and used only after being certified as compliant with the mandatory requirements of national and industry

standards by a certification body with statutory qualifications." The toxic gases industrial filter canisters protect against are not the same thing as the smoke in a building fire

- **Packaged "emergency gift kits."** These kits are usually filled out with cheap flashlights and masks making up the numbers; buying the fire extinguisher, fire blanket, respirator, and first-aid kit separately costs less and makes certification easier to check
- **Stockpiling more than 3 days of food and water.** The official list's yardstick is 3 days per person; anything beyond that is expiry waste, see Section 5, item 24

Source: Standing Committee of the National People's Congress (2021). Fire Protection Law of the People's Republic of China (2021 amendment, Article 24). https://www.beijing.gov.cn/zhengce/zhengcefagui/qtwj/202307/t20230726_3207767.html

## 7. How much good does this equipment actually do

The honest answer: the evidence is weaker than for the other entries in Section 1 of this book.

A Cochrane systematic review of 98 studies covering 2,605,044 people evaluated home safety education and the provision of safety equipment. It found that home safety interventions may reduce injury rates: IRR 0.89 (95% CI 0.78 to 1.01), a confidence interval that crosses 1; interventions delivered in the home had IRR 0.75 (95% CI 0.62 to 0.91); and interventions that did not provide safety equipment had IRR 0.78 (95% CI 0.66 to 0.92). In other words, the effect looks like it comes from the in-home education and modifications, not from handing out equipment. The review also concluded that there is no evidence that home safety interventions reduce the incidence of thermal burns or poisoning.

In the same review, the interventions did raise the share of safe behaviors: having a working smoke alarm installed OR 1.81 (95% CI 1.30 to 2.52); having an escape plan OR 2.01 (1.45 to 2.77); medicines stored safely OR 1.53 (1.27 to 1.84); stair gates fitted OR 1.61 (1.19 to 2.17).

Source: Kendrick D, et al. (2012). Home safety education and provision of safety equipment for injury prevention. Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews. https://doi.org/10.1002/14651858.CD005014.pub3

So the placement of this section is: buying everything on the official list in one pass is a reasonable, low-cost preparation, but do not treat it as safe because you bought it. What research has repeatedly shown to work is smoke alarms, an escape plan, and moving the sources of injury out of the way; none of these three is on the shopping list, or they make up only a small part of it.

> Unofficial English translation of docs/遇到陌生人出事该不该停.md. In case of discrepancies the Chinese original takes precedence.

# A stranger has an accident on the street: walk away or stop

This is the long-form version of Section 13, item 2. Under the book's beneficiary yardstick, a stranger is the lowest of the four tiers: the prospect of return is small, and you don't know the person's character. So this article does not urge you to do anything; it lays out the full bill each of the three paths carries, and you choose.

**This article gives no probabilities.** Every layer of cost below is real and traceable to specific legal provisions, but there is no published statistic for things like "what share of rescuers have actually been hit with one of these," and the book's rule is that uncertain numbers are better left unwritten. Do not read "seven layers are listed" as "all seven will happen."

## The three paths

| | Walk away | Stop but don't touch | Stop and see it through |
|---|---|---|---|
| Legality | Legal. An ordinary person owes a stranger no duty of rescue, and criminal law has no offense of "knowing and not rescuing" | Legal | Legal |
| Time | 0 | A few minutes; calling 120 (China's emergency medical number) leaves your number | Half a day at minimum, possibly up to accompanying them to the hospital |
| Likelihood of being tracked down later | Lowest | You are the one who left a number | Highest |
| Benefit to the other person | 0 | The ambulance arrives sooner | Greatest |

## Costs that can appear after you stop, from lighter to heavier

**1. Callbacks and questioning.** Calling 120 or 110 (China's police emergency number) leaves your number. You may get a callback to confirm the location, and you may be questioned once afterwards. Where a criminal-case informant is unwilling to disclose their name, the case-handling organ must keep it secret for them (刑事诉讼法第一百一十一条 — Criminal Procedure Law, Art. 111); 120 has no corresponding provision.

**2. Being tracked down by the family.** When surveillance footage turns up no trace of the vehicle that caused the accident, the person who left a number and was on the scene is the easiest one for the family to find. Phone pressure and showing up at your door can both happen.

**3. Being named as a defendant.** The side claiming you hit them bears the burden of proof itself; if it cannot produce evidence, it bears the adverse consequences (民诉法解释第九十条 — Interpretation on the Application of the Civil Procedure Law, Art. 90) — **but this rule guarantees only the outcome of the judgment, not that you stay out of the case**. The time limit for concluding a first-instance case under the ordinary procedure is 6 months, extendable by another 6 months in special circumstances; the simplified procedure is 3 months (民事诉讼法第一百五十二、一百六十四条 — Civil Procedure Law, Arts. 152 and 164). Even if you win outright, only three items can be shifted onto the other side: the case acceptance fee, application fees, and the travel and lost-earnings costs of witnesses, expert examiners and the like appearing in court (诉讼费用交纳办法第六、二十九条 — Measures on the Payment of Litigation Costs, Arts. 6 and 29). **Attorney's fees are not among them.**

**4. It reaching your employer.** Disturbing the order of an enterprise or public institution so that work cannot proceed normally: a warning or a fine of up to 500 yuan; where circumstances are relatively serious, detention of 5 to 10 days plus a fine of up to 1000 yuan; where it is done by a crowd, detention of 10 to 15 days for the ringleaders (治安管理处罚法第二十六条第一项 — Public Security Administration Punishments Law, Art. 26, item 1). Harassment, pestering, or stalking that interferes with normal life is punished under Art. 50, item 5, and with the approval of the head of the public security organ an order can be issued barring contact for a set period. A company firing you over this generally counts as an unlawful termination, with compensation computed at 2N (Section 19, item 6) — but reporting to the police and filing for arbitration are errands you run yourself, and the loss of the stretch when the job is already gone is not made whole later by eventually collecting 2N.

**5. Being filmed and posted online.** The most important thing to know at this layer: **you may not be able to stop the filming**. Making, using, or publicizing another person's likeness without consent is prohibited (民法典第一千零一十九条 — Civil Code, Art. 1019), but "making, using, or publicizing the likeness of the right holder where unavoidable for the purpose of news reporting" counts as reasonable use (第一千零二十条第二项 — Civil Code, Art. 1020, item 2). What you can control: no interviews, no appearing on camera, no speaking in front of the lens — whether to consent is your decision; no one can consent for you.

**6. Re-sharing and cyber-harassment.** Once a video spreads, the comment section is out of your control. The self-help measures available are written into 《网络暴力信息治理规定》 (Provisions on the Governance of Cyberbullying Information, effective August 1, 2024): platforms must provide protective settings such as blocking unknown or specific users, limiting the visibility of your own information, banning reposts or comments, and receiving private messages only from friends or rejecting all private messages (Art. 23); must provide a one-click evidence-preservation function for cyberbullying information (Art. 25); must set up a dedicated quick complaint-and-report entrance in a prominent position (Art. 26); and where suspected unlawful or criminal conduct is found, must promptly report to the public security organs and provide leads (Art. 15). For how to preserve evidence and report to the police, see Section 8, item 37.

**7. When it gets to be too much.** The six layers above can all be met with legal provisions; the seventh cannot. There is no reliable Chinese data to cite on the emotional impact of sustained online attacks, and the book gives no numbers — only an exit: the psychological-assistance hotline 12356 (China's psychological support hotline), see Section 1, item 25.

## Two situations in which walking away stops being free

- **You are the operator or manager of the premises, or the organizer of a mass activity** (hotels, shopping malls, banks, stations, airports, stadiums, entertainment venues and the like): you bear a duty of safety protection; failing to fulfill it makes you bear tort liability, and where a third party caused the harm and you failed your duty, you bear corresponding supplementary liability (民法典第一千一百九十八条 — Civil Code, Art. 1198). For an on-duty employee or the venue operator, walking away is not the same thing as a passerby walking away.
- **The matter involves you**: you hit them, it is your car, or the danger was created by your own prior conduct. Then the question is no longer "whether to get involved with someone else" — it is the traffic-accident handling and hit-and-run question of Section 8, item 1.

## If you decide to stop, the lowest-hassle way to do it

1. **Don't move them with your hands.** This is the only action with no second answer, and the reason is medical, not legal — forcing someone upright can worsen brain hemorrhage or spinal injury. On the legal side, harm caused in the course of rescue is exempted by 民法典第一百八十四条 (Civil Code, Art. 184 — voluntary emergency rescue exemption).
2. Call out from a distance and check whether they are breathing; if not, start chest compressions (Section 13, item 1); if yes, call 120 from where you are and report the location.
3. Pull in another passerby and start recording on your phone. Witness testimony and physical evidence beat arguing after the fact.

4. Don't lift them into a car on your own, and don't pay out of pocket to get them to a hospital. This is the highest-cost, lowest-return stretch of the whole road.
5. If you were injured rescuing them or spent your own money, how to get the money back is covered in Section 13, item 40.

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Unofficial English translation of docs/做平台要办哪些证.md. In case of discrepancies the Chinese original takes precedence.

# What Licenses a Platform Needs: A Comparison Table and a Server-Choice Decision Table

This corresponds to Section 26 of the README. This page holds only two tables and a few notes on points that are easy to get wrong; the entry text and sources live in the README. How to register a company and how to file taxes is covered in Section 12; the red lines for employed tech workers are in Section 11.

## 1. First, work out which kind of business you are running

A single site often falls into several of these categories at once. The licenses stack; it is not either/or.

| What you are doing | Corresponding business category | What you need | Primary legal basis |
|---|---|---|---|
| Free information sites, personal blogs, company official websites | 非经营性互联网信息服务 — non-commercial internet information services | ICP 备案 — ICP filing with MIIT | 互联网信息服务管理办法 — Internet Information Services Administrative Measures, Article 4 |
| Paid memberships, value-added services, or paid content charged to users | 经营性互联网信息服务 — commercial internet information services | 增值电信业务经营许可 — value-added telecom business license (information services business) | Same measures, Articles 3, 4, and 7 |
| Matching buyers and sellers, handling transactions and orders | 在线数据处理与交易处理业务 — online data processing and transaction processing business | 增值电信业务经营许可 — value-added telecom business license (B21) | 电信业务分类目录 — Telecommunications Business Classification Catalogue (2015 edition), B21 |
| Livestreams with hosts on camera, game livestreams | 网络表演 — online performance | 网络文化经营许可证 — Network Culture Business License, with online performance included in the business scope | 网络表演经营活动管理办法 — Measures for the Administration of Online Performance Business Activities, Article 4 |
| Producing or aggregating video programs, or providing a service that lets others upload audio-visual programs | 互联网视听节目服务 — internet audio-visual program services | 信息网络传播视听节目许可证 — License for the Dissemination of Audio-Visual Programs through Information Networks | 互联网视听节目服务管理规定 — Provisions on the Administration of Internet Audio-Visual Program Services, Articles 7 and 8 |
| Selling goods during livestreams | 网络直播营销 — livestream marketing | On top of the licenses above, fulfill the verification and retention obligations | 网络直播营销管理办法（试行） — Measures for the Administration of Livestream Marketing (Trial), Article 8 |
| Providing news and information | 互联网新闻信息服务 — internet news information services | 互联网新闻信息服务许可证 — Internet News Information Service License | 互联网直播服务管理规定 — Provisions on the Administration of Internet Live-Streaming Services, Article 5 |

| What you are doing | Corresponding business category | What you need | Primary legal basis |
|---|---|---|---|
| Building your own data center to sell hosting or bandwidth | 互联网数据中心业务 — internet data center (IDC) business; 互联网接入服务业务 — internet access service (ISP) business | 增值电信业务经营许可 — value-added telecom business license (B11, B14) | 电信业务分类目录 — Telecommunications Business Classification Catalogue (2015 edition), B11, B14 |

The mapping of the three licenses is stated most plainly in the 2021 guidance opinion (指导意见) issued by seven departments: "A livestream platform carrying out commercial online performance activities must hold the 《网络文化经营许可证》 — Network Culture Business License and complete ICP 备案 — ICP filing with MIIT; a livestream platform carrying out internet audio-visual program services must hold the 《信息网络传播视听节目许可证》 — License for the Dissemination of Audio-Visual Programs through Information Networks (or complete registration in the 全国网络视听平台信息登记管理系统 — National Network Audio-Visual Platform Information Registration Management System) and complete ICP 备案 — ICP filing with MIIT; a livestream platform carrying out internet news information services must hold the 《互联网新闻信息服务许可证》 — Internet News Information Service License."

### Three points that are easy to get wrong

**An individual cannot obtain a value-added telecom license.** The first eligibility condition is "the operator is a company established in accordance with the law"; registered capital must be no less than 1,000,000 yuan for operations within a single province and no less than 10,000,000 yuan for cross-province operations, the review period is 60 days, and the license is valid for 5 years. To run a paid business you need a company first; that step is in Section 12.

**Private operators can essentially never get the audio-visual program license.** The application conditions state "possesses legal-person status and is a wholly state-owned or state-controlled entity". So the long-video and original-program route is closed to individual founders; livestreaming instead runs through the 网络文化经营许可证 — Network Culture Business License track.

**No official document explicitly states that "e-commerce platforms must obtain EDI".** MIIT's service guide only says "apply for the corresponding telecommunications business license according to the business definition", and has answered elsewhere that "ride-hailing platforms only need a website filing" and "equity-type and bulk-commodity trading platforms only need a website filing". So this book only quotes the original definition of B21 and leaves the judgment to you and your local 通信管理局 — communications administration; ask the communications administration with jurisdiction over your location once before applying.

## 2. The platform's own day-to-day obligations

Getting the license only opens the door. The items below are what you do every day; the fines are in the individual entries of Section 26.

| Obligation | Hard requirement | Source |
|---|---|---|
| Verify and register on-platform merchants | Verify and update at least once every six months | 网络交易监督管理办法 — Measures for the Supervision and Administration of Online Transactions, Article 24 |
| Report identity information | Report to the market regulation authorities in January and July each year | Same measures, Article 25 |

| Obligation | Hard requirement | Source |
|---|---|---|
| Report tax-related information | Report to the tax authorities within the month after each quarter ends | 互联网平台企业涉税信息报送规定 — Provisions on the Reporting of Tax-Related Information by Internet Platform Enterprises, Article 4 |
| Retain transaction information | No less than three years from the date the transaction is completed | 电子商务法 — E-Commerce Law, Article 31 |
| Retain livestream content and logs | Sixty days | 互联网直播服务管理规定 — Provisions on the Administration of Internet Live-Streaming Services, Article 16 |
| Retain online performance videos | No less than sixty days | 网络表演经营活动管理办法 — Measures for the Administration of Online Performance Business Activities, Article 13 |
| Retain network logs | No less than six months | 网络安全法 — Cybersecurity Law, Article 23, Item 3 |
| Handle infringement notices | If nothing happens within fifteen days after the statement is forwarded, restore the listing | 电子商务法 — E-Commerce Law, Article 43 |
| Complaint and report channel | Conspicuous placement, convenient to use | 网络信息内容生态治理规定 — Provisions on the Governance of the Online Information Content Ecosystem, Article 16 |

The retention periods are four different clocks: three years for transactions, sixty days for livestreams, six months for logs, and three years for the identity information of on-platform merchants, counted from when they leave the platform. Design your storage for the longest of these, not the shortest.

## 3. Choosing a server: how to pick among the three tiers

Answer the questions first, then look at prices.

| Question | If the answer is | Then |
|---|---|---|
| Can you tolerate a day of downtime | Yes | The cheapest VPS is enough |
| Do you have user registration, transactions, or uploads | Yes | A cloud host from a mainstream cloud provider, with snapshots and elastic scaling |
| Do you have someone dedicated to operations | No | Stay away from dedicated server colocation |
| Are bandwidth or hardware costs your main expense | Yes, and you have someone for operations | Only then consider dedicated server colocation |

**Small providers are not unusable; you have to verify them first.** Data-center colocation and access services are themselves value-added telecom businesses that require a license. Check the provider once by its full company name on MIIT's 电信业务市场综合管理信息系统 — Telecom Business Market Comprehensive Management Information System at tsm.miit.gov.cn, and exclude anyone without a license outright. The ones that can be half the price usually carry risks in overselling, the operator disappearing, and their upstream being blocked. When any of these three happens, with a licensed provider you can still complain to the communications administration; with an unlicensed one you have no one to appeal to at all.

**Inside China or outside.** If the servers are inside China you must complete a filing (备案), and access providers may not provide access to unfiled sites. Hosting abroad lets you bypass the filing, but your users are in China and your money is in China, so not one of the obligations in items 5 through 10 of Section 26 goes away, and you add a layer of cross-border data transfer compliance cost: transmitting the personal information of users inside China to a machine outside China is a cross-border transfer, which must satisfy one of the four conditions in Article 38 of the 个人信息保护法 — Personal Information Protection Law and obtain the individual's separate consent. The headcount thresholds are counted "cumulatively from January 1 of the current year": under 100,000 people, none of the three pathways applies; 100,000 to 1,000,000 people, a standard contract or certification is required; over 1,000,000 people, a security assessment must be filed.

**Backups.** Keep backups in at least two places, and do not put them all in the same region of the same provider. This one has no legal basis behind it; it is experience.

## 4. The limits of this document

- For all provisions, the source column in Section 26 of the book's README is authoritative; it has the document numbers, article numbers, and links.
- Regulations are updated quickly; this section was verified in September 2026. Before quoting anything, open the original page yourself once more — especially the 网络安全法 — Cybersecurity Law (article numbers were adjusted starting January 1, 2026) and the rules on minors and livestream tipping (changed in April 2026 to age-based tiers).
- The few points where the original text could not be obtained are listed in the verification notes, including any official wording on whether e-commerce platforms must obtain EDI, and a judicial interpretation that would directly make unlicensed operation of online-culture or audio-visual services the crime of illegal business operations (非法经营罪).

Unofficial English translation of docs/被裁了之后先做什么.md. In case of discrepancies the Chinese original takes precedence.

# What to Do First After a Layoff

After a layoff or dismissal, the things you need to handle are scattered across Section 19, Section 7, and several other sections. Below they are ordered by time. Each step states only what to do; details, numbers, and sources are in the entry cited in parentheses. If you are only owed wages and are still employed, go straight to Section 7, item 2 (wage arrears: complain to labor inspection first).

## The day of: before you sign anything

1. If the company hands you a “voluntary resignation for personal reasons” form, do not sign. If you sign, economic compensation and unemployment insurance benefits usually both disappear. See Section 19, item 7 (never sign “voluntary resignation for personal reasons”).
2. If they say “sign first to process the exit, compensation will come separately,” insist the compensation be written into the agreement on the spot. If it is not written in, do not sign; refusing to sign that day has no legal consequence. See Section 19, item 7 (never sign “voluntary resignation for personal reasons”).
3. Turn on a recorder for the conversation. For talks you attend yourself, you do not need the other party's consent first. See Section 8, item 41 (start recording).
4. Before you return the computer and accounts, save pay stubs, attendance records, the employment contract, social-insurance records, and chat logs. See Section 19, item 8 (save evidence before leaving).
5. Save only your own employment-related materials. Do not take company source code, customer lists, or technical documents. See Section 11, item 7 (do not take source code when you leave).
6. Hand back account access cleanly: do not delete data or change passwords, even if the company owes you money. See Section 11, item 6 (return account access).

## That day through the first few days: nail down the money

1. Calculate N first: one month's salary per full year of service; half a month for periods under six months. See Section 19, item 4 (calculate N after a layoff).
2. Monthly salary is the average over the 12 months before you leave; bonuses, allowances, and subsidies all count. Employers often understate this. See Section 19, item 4 (calculate N after a layoff).
3. If the company did not give you 30 days' written notice, you get an extra month's salary on top of N. When negotiating, list that month separately. See Section 19, item 5 (no 30-day notice).
4. For unlawful termination, compensation is 2N. Whether termination was unlawful—ask legal aid or a lawyer before you decide to negotiate or go to arbitration. See Section 19, item 6 (unlawful termination).
5. Unused annual leave must be paid out at separation, pro-rated to how much of the year you worked. See Section 19, item 2 (annual leave).
6. Include any unpaid overtime in the total. See Section 19, item 1 (overtime pay).

## The first week

1. Register as unemployed. Unemployment insurance starts from the registration date; a month's delay costs you a month of benefits. See Section 7, item 1 (unemployment insurance).
2. Unemployment registration is done at public employment service agencies such as employment service centers; there is no fee. See Section 7, item 5 (public employment services).
3. Apply for unemployment insurance on the “掌上 12333” app or the electronic social-security card mini-program. You need at least one year of contributions and a separation that was not voluntary resignation. See Section 7, item 1 (unemployment insurance).
4. While you receive unemployment insurance, employee medical insurance is paid through the unemployment insurance system; you do not enroll separately. See Section 7, item 1 (unemployment insurance).
5. If you cannot afford to sue, call 12348 for legal aid. You no longer need to obtain a poverty certificate from your hometown. See Section 7, item 3 (legal aid).
6. If you signed a non-compete agreement, keep the original. The company must pay monthly compensation; if it fails to pay for three months for reasons on the company's side, you may seek to terminate the agreement. See Section 11, item 12 (non-compete agreement).

7. Fix your daily routine: get up at a set time and schedule job search as a fixed block; do not stay home all day. See Section 29, item 3 (after job loss, fix your routine first).

## The first month

1. If wages or overtime pay are still unpaid, call 12333 to complain to labor inspection first, then apply for labor arbitration. Both routes are free. See Section 7, item 2 (wage arrears: labor inspection first).
2. If your employer was an unlicensed workshop, you still use inspection and arbitration. Money owed by a labor subcontractor goes against the general contractor; work for a household or individual as a private helper goes to court. See Section 7, item 22 (figure out who employed you).
3. Labor arbitration must be filed within one year after leaving. After the deadline, "time limit exceeded" is enough for the other side. See Section 8, item 19 (one-year labor arbitration limit).
4. For job search, start at public employment service agencies; job placement and career guidance are free—do not use paid agencies. See Section 7, item 5 (public employment services).
5. Do not rely on résumés alone. Learn job-search skills, set clear targets, and ask contacts for referrals. See Section 7, item 14 (systematic job search).
6. Refuse on the spot offers to "pay first before starting," "train first then get placed," or "recruit others to join." See Section 7, item 15 (no "training loans").
7. Before paying for skills training, check your local human-resources bureau's vocational training subsidy catalog. See Section 7, item 13 (vocational training subsidies).
8. See whether you qualify for "person facing employment difficulties" recognition—for example older age or long-term unemployment. Once recognized, you may get social-insurance subsidies and priority for public-interest jobs. See Section 7, item 12 (employment-difficulties recognition).

## The months after

1. Cover living costs from your emergency fund first; do not borrow and do not sell investments at a loss. See Section 5, item 27 (emergency fund).
2. In the first three months, postpone irreversible decisions: selling a home, investing a lump-sum severance, partnerships, guaranteeing others' debts—all count. See Section 29, item 12 (irreversible decisions).
3. When unemployment insurance runs out and you still have no job, do not leave medical coverage empty. You can pay resident medical insurance yearly yourself; after a break in payment, claims are denied for three months. See Section 7, item 9 (resident medical insurance).
4. A break in pension contributions does not zero out past years; benefits use cumulative years. Do not pay someone for illegal "affiliated" enrollment. See Section 7, item 18 (social insurance lapse).
5. If household income falls below the local minimum-living guarantee line, apply for dibao. See Section 7, item 7 (apply for dibao).
6. If you need someone to talk to, call 12356; it is free. See Section 29, item 11 (call 12356).
7. For money still owed to you, watch the one-year deadline from the date you left. See Section 8, item 19 (one-year labor arbitration limit).

Unofficial English translation of docs/孩子出生前后要办的事.md. In case of discrepancies the Chinese original takes precedence.

# Things to Handle Around Childbirth: A Timeline

The book is split by topic; pregnancy, birth, and infant care are spread across several sections. This checklist orders them by time, from planning a pregnancy through the child's first birthday. Each line states only what to do; why and how strong the evidence is are in the entry cited in parentheses. Start at the heading for the stage you are in.

## I. When planning a pregnancy

1. Take 0.4 mg folic acid daily, starting three months before conception. See Section 27, item 1 (folic acid).
2. Call social insurance or medical insurance once and ask whether maternity-insurance contribution months are sufficient. See Section 27, item 11 (maternity insurance).
3. Agree with household members that no one smokes indoors from now on. See Section 2, item 2 (no smoking at home or in the car).
4. If someone at home depends on your income, buy term life insurance for the earner first. See Section 5, item 40 (term life insurance).

## II. After pregnancy, before birth

1. Before week 13, register at a community health center for the Maternal and Child Health Handbook; free prenatal visits start there. See Section 27, item 2 (Maternal and Child Health Handbook).
2. At the first prenatal visit, test for HIV, syphilis, and hepatitis B; you do not pay for the tests. See Section 27, item 3 (HIV, syphilis, hepatitis B).
3. No smoking and no alcohol at all during pregnancy. See Section 27, item 4 (no cigarettes, no alcohol).
4. Tell your full medical history at prenatal visits. If you have high-risk factors for preeclampsia, let the doctor decide whether to start low-dose aspirin after week 12. See Section 27, item 5 (low-dose aspirin).
5. From week 24 onward, have gestational diabetes screening. See Section 27, item 6 (gestational diabetes screening).
6. After week 20 of pregnancy, do not take ibuprofen-type pain relievers on your own. See Section 34, item 5 (ibuprofen-type pain relievers).
7. Learn the “go to the hospital now” list and make sure others at home know it too. See Section 27, item 7 (go to the hospital now).
8. At prenatal visits, ask whether the hospital offers painless labor. See Section 27, item 9 (painless labor).
9. Without a medical indication, do not ask for a cesarean section. See Section 27, item 10 (cesarean section).
10. If you will deliver outside your insurance locality, ask in advance whether you need cross-region maternity filing. See Section 27, item 11 (maternity insurance).
11. Maternity leave is at least 98 days; up to 15 days may be taken before birth. See Section 18, item 2 (maternity leave).
12. If the employer cuts pay or moves you because of pregnancy, keep written notices and chat records. See Section 18, item 3 (no pay cut for pregnancy, birth, or nursing).
13. Borrow a crib and stroller first; buy second-hand if you cannot borrow. Do not buy a used car seat or mattress. See Section 20, item 11 (borrow, second-hand, new).
14. Try diapers in a small pack for a week before stocking up. See Section 20, item 10 (diapers).
15. Choose the baby's name early and confirm the household-registration system can print the characters. See Section 27, item 12 (birth medical certificate).

## III. During hospital birth

1. If membranes rupture, lie flat where you are, elevate the hips, call 120; do not walk around. See Section 27, item 8 (ruptured membranes).
2. Start breastfeeding within the first hour after birth. See Section 20, item 4 (breastfeeding only).
3. Give the first hepatitis B vaccine dose within 24 hours of birth. If the mother is hepatitis B surface antigen positive, give hepatitis B immune globulin at the same time. See Section 20, item 2 (first hepatitis B dose).

4. Give the vitamin K injection. If birthing at home or at an informal facility, ask explicitly. See Section 20, item 7 (vitamin K injection).
5. Do not refuse heel-prick screening or hearing screening. Before signing consent, see which items are optional paid add-ons. See Section 27, item 13 (heel-prick and hearing screening).

## IV. Before discharge

1. Complete the birth medical certificate; verify parents' and child's names and ID numbers character by character. See Section 27, item 12 (birth medical certificate).
2. Enroll the child in resident medical insurance online using the birth certificate; you do not need household registration first. If unsure, call 12393. See Section 27, item 14 (resident medical insurance).
3. Use a car seat on the way home: rear-facing under age one; do not hold the baby in your arms. See Section 1, item 10 (car seat).

## V. The first month after birth

1. Register the birth at the police station within one month. See Section 27, item 15 (birth registration).
2. After household registration, apply for the child-rearing subsidy where the child is registered: 3,600 yuan per child per year. See Section 18, item 1 (child-rearing subsidy).
3. Put the baby to sleep on the back, on a firm surface, same room but not same bed; no soft bedding in the crib. See Section 20, item 1 (back to sleep).
4. For formula, mix with water at 70 °C or above; discard leftovers. See Section 20, item 5 (mixing formula).
5. If a child under three months reaches 38 °C, go to the hospital. See Section 20, item 8 (fever at 38 °C).
6. When you are about to lose control, put the baby in the crib and step away for a few minutes. See Section 20, item 9 (never shake a baby).
7. The mother's “go to the hospital now” list still applies for one year after birth. See Section 27, item 7 (go to the hospital now).

## VI. From one month through the first birthday

1. At 42 days postpartum, go for the check-up, which includes postpartum depression screening. See Section 27, item 16 (42-day postpartum visit).
2. Follow the immunization schedule at the clinic; DTaP starts at two months. See Section 20, item 3 (national immunization program).
3. Breastfeed only for the first six months; from six months add complementary foods with iron-rich animal foods daily. See Section 20, item 4 (complementary feeding from six months).
4. Do not give honey before age one. See Section 20, item 6 (honey).
5. With severe eczema or egg allergy, see a doctor before deciding whether to introduce peanut early. See Section 20, item 12 (do not avoid peanut entirely).
6. For colds in children under two, do not give combination cold medicines on your own. See Section 34, item 4 (combination cold medicines).
7. Install window and balcony limiters; screens are not fall protection. See Section 1, item 11 (window and balcony limiters).
8. No phones or tablets for children 0–3. See Section 30, item 5 (no screens).
9. After returning to work, if the child is under one year, you have one hour of nursing time per day. See Section 18, item 3 (nursing time).
10. Link your employee medical-savings account for family pooling so the child can use it for care and medicine. See Section 5, item 13 (family pooling).
11. At annual individual income-tax settlement, claim the deduction for care of children under three. See Section 5, item 2 (special additional deductions).

Unofficial English translation of docs/刚确诊慢性病之后.md. In case of discrepancies the Chinese original takes precedence.

# Right After a Chronic Disease Diagnosis: The First Week, First Three Months, and After

This checklist is for people newly diagnosed with chronic conditions such as hypertension, diabetes, high blood lipids, or gout. Related entries in the book are spread across several sections; here they are ordered by time. Each line states only the action; reasons, numbers, and sources are in the entry cited. Skip items that do not apply to your condition.

## The week of diagnosis

1. If the illness is serious, have someone go with you when you get the report; do not stay alone at home that day. Put off resigning, selling a home, and similar steps. See Section 29, item 2 (the week after a serious diagnosis).
2. If the doctor prescribed medication, start today and follow the prescription; do not stop because you feel better. See Section 16, item 1 (take medication as prescribed).
3. For hypertension and high blood lipids, take medicine regularly; do not stop on your own. See Section 2, item 12 (hypertension and high blood lipids: take medicine as prescribed).
4. If you have hypertension, buy a home blood-pressure monitor and measure at home until readings reach target. See Section 1, item 7 (measure blood pressure and treat to target).
5. When getting prescriptions, ask whether centralized-procurement or generic drugs are available. See Section 5, item 12 (generics and centralized procurement).
6. At diagnosis of type 2 diabetes, have a dilated eye exam once; for type 1, start five years after onset. See Section 16, item 7 (eye exam at diabetes diagnosis).
7. At diagnosis of gout, start long-term urate-lowering therapy and keep serum uric acid below 360 μmol/L. See Section 16, item 9 (long-term urate-lowering for gout).
8. Before allopurinol in people of Han ethnicity, ask whether to test HLA-B*5801 genotype. See Section 16, item 9 (long-term urate-lowering for gout).
9. High uric acid on a check-up alone, with no gout attacks ever, is not gout; do not start urate-lowering drugs yet. See Section 6, item 19 (high uric acid without gout pain).
10. If you smoke, set a quit date and stop completely that day. See Section 2, item 4 (set a quit date).
11. Do not rely on willpower alone for quitting; go to a smoking-cessation clinic or respiratory medicine for medication. See Section 2, item 3 (get medication to quit).

## The first three months

1. Keep a notebook: at each follow-up, record date, test results, drugs, and doses. See Section 16, item 3 (one notebook for all readings).
2. After each visit, keep your own copy of records, lab reports, and imaging. See Section 24, item 5 (keep your own medical records).
3. In your insurance locality, apply for outpatient chronic/special-disease designation; if you often seek care elsewhere, also file for cross-region treatment. See Section 16, item 2 (chronic outpatient designation and cross-region filing).
4. If a family member has employee medical insurance, ask them to link family pooling so their account can pay for your care and medicine. See Section 5, item 13 (family pooling).
5. Before signing with a community family doctor, ask what is covered by insurance and what is self-pay. See Section 16, item 6 (ask before signing with a family doctor).
6. Switch household salt to low-sodium salt. If you have kidney impairment or take potassium-sparing drugs, ask the doctor first. See Section 2, item 9 (low-sodium salt).
7. Start walking daily; aim for 7,000–8,000 steps or 150–300 minutes of brisk walking per week. See Section 2, item 11 (7,000–8,000 steps a day).
8. Drink less alcohol; best is none. See Section 2, item 19 (less or no alcohol).
9. If you drink daily and get shakes or palpitations when you stop, do not quit alone; go to the hospital first. See Section 2, item 20 (do not quit alcohol cold turkey alone).

10. If someone urges you to stop meds for folk remedies, do not stop; tell your treating doctor before any supplement. See Section 16, item 4 (do not stop treatment for folk remedies or supplements).
11. Do not spend heavily on health products or tonic formulas to "condition" the body. See Section 6, item 10 (expensive health products and tonics).
12. When starting urate-lowering therapy for gout, attacks are more common in the first 3–6 months. If pain flares, add anti-inflammatory medicine as directed; do not stop urate-lowering drugs. See Section 16, item 9 (long-term urate-lowering for gout).
13. Before buying cold or pain medicines yourself, read ingredients; acetaminophen should appear in only one product. See Section 34, item 1 (acetaminophen in only one product).
14. If you take anticoagulants or steroids, ask the doctor before ibuprofen-type pain relievers. See Section 34, item 3 (ibuprofen with anticoagulants or steroids).

## After the condition is stable

1. When stable and medications unchanged, get up to 12 weeks of medication in one community visit. See Section 16, item 5 (12-week prescriptions at community clinics).
2. Follow the follow-up interval your doctor set; record every visit in the same notebook. See Section 16, item 3 (follow-up on schedule).
3. After switching to centralized-procurement drugs, watch the notebook metrics; if they truly worsen, see the doctor—do not stop on your own. See Section 5, item 12 (generics and centralized procurement).
4. With diabetes, have a foot exam yearly and eye exams at the interval your doctor gives. See Section 16, item 7 (eye exam at diabetes diagnosis; annual foot exam).
5. With gout, keep taking urate-lowering medicine even after uric acid reaches target. See Section 16, item 9 (long-term urate-lowering for gout).
6. After kidney stones, drink 2.5–3 liters of water daily and keep salt under 6 g. See Section 16, item 8 (water after kidney stones).
7. With cardiovascular disease, get one flu shot each autumn. See Section 1, item 20 (annual flu vaccine).
8. For common illnesses, start at community level; for hospitalization, go up through referral so the inpatient deductible continues. See Section 24, item 1 (community first, tiered referral).
9. Within the same insurance pool, each higher hospital tier lowers reimbursement by about ten percentage points—do not climb tiers without need. See Section 24, item 2 (lower tier, higher reimbursement).
10. For specialist care at a major hospital, use community referral or the hospital referral center; do not use scalpers. See Section 24, item 3 (referral center).
11. Before cross-province care, ask locally how much will be reimbursed back home—it may be less than treating locally. See Section 24, item 4 (ask before cross-province care).

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